

스마트폰 너머의

프랜차이즈 사업가에게 물어보기

마신님

Information

Table of Contents URL: <https://www.lightnovelworld.co/novel/the-evil-god-beyond-the-smartphone-05122224>

The Evil God Beyond the Smartphone

스마트폰 너머의 악신님

Author: [Shadow Star](#)
RANK 381

4.6
219
Chapters
662K
Views
3.04K
Bookmarked
Completed
Status

Categories

- [Adventure](#)
- [Fantasy](#)
- [Mystery](#)

The Evil God Beyond the Smartphone novel is a popular light novel covering Adventure, Fantasy, and Mystery genres. Written by the Author Shadow Star. 219 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

I was playing a boring game where you don't level up no matter what you do, there's no event happening and it was even FREE on *** store. I had an argument on relationship stuff, was angry and decided to destroy the village in a game, then a notification pop-up...

-Your karma has increased by 10.

-You are now at level 2.

Graphics of the game changed. Acquired magic. Saved a village girl that was chased by bandits. Gained a cultist.

It seems the events are starting to take place. Lets see what happens...

Show More

Tags

- [Army Building](#)
- [Dark](#)
- [Evil Gods](#)
- [Evil Organizations](#)
- [Evil Protagonist](#)
- [Evil Religions](#)
- [Fanaticism](#)
- [Fantasy World](#)
- [Game Elements](#)
- [God Protagonist](#)
- [Godly Powers](#)
- [Gods](#)
- [Knights](#)
- [Level System](#)
- [Magic](#)
- [Male Protagonist](#)
- [Multiple POV](#)
- [Past Trauma](#)
- [Saints](#)
- [Special Abilities](#)
- [Wars](#)
- [Witches](#)

[Show More](#)

User Comments

Write Comment

Please read and apply the rules before posting a comment.

By sharing your comment, you agree to all the relevant terms.

You must be logged in to post a comment.

Comments on the novel chapters for the last week.

(12 hours ago)

: 1 comment on Chapter 138: The Contract of Regression (1)

(12 hours ago)

: 1 comment on Chapter 137: Fall of a Hero (6)

(12 hours ago)

: 1 comment on Chapter 133: Fall of the Hero (2)

(23 hours ago)

: 1 comment on Chapter 118: The Price of Slaughter (5)

(23 hours ago)

: 1 comment on Chapter 117: The Price of Slaughter (4)

- 1
Regismagni01
Reader
9d

Such an unexpected twist,wonderful

[Reply](#)

0 0

- 1
tribluation
Reader
1mo

it's like nebula civilization based on the summary, I'm already interested.

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 1
ReadsGoldAndShit
Reader

1mo

I did not expect such a good story from such a title. At first glance it looks like a typical powertrip novel, but it goes a lot deeper from chapter 100 when things are revealed. You will be confused, because the translation is bad and you will have to decipher what's going on sometimes, but the payoff is amazing. for sure read this novel!! You probably won't read something like this ever again

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 7
Seolw
Reader
2mo

This is a literal masterpiece. Comment section convinced me to give it a shot and oh boy I'm glad I did

Edited: 2mo

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 1
You_cant_see_me
Reader
2mo

Just finished reading it, this would have been way high up in the rankings if the transition was a bit better. Was a short but great read, there were good moments and also some dark ones, the twists and turns were a bit unexpected but had enough foreshadowing. Ending was a bit rushed but the side stories make up for it completely. If you're an old reader this one really is unique compared to the rest you've read till now so you'll enjoy it. And as for new readers it's a pretty simple but enjoyable first read, nothing overly complex ah but

you'll surely be a bit p*ss*d off at whose gender is what 😊

Ps:ESTASIA BEST GIRL(wanted to cheer for Eutenia till the end but Estasia at the last quarter won my support!)

[Reply](#)

3 0

- 1
Sirigaz
Reader
2mo

Es Esperw, I just wanted to read the full name, but does this look good?! The protagonist basically entered an isekai playing a god where evil = xp and has to create a cult? Wonderful...

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 1
Dominatrix
Reader
2mo

One of the most Wholesome_Completed_Novel. (I believe it should atleast be in top 20 completed novels)

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 1
EllaYoung
Reader
2mo

Finished reading this for the 2nd time. This one is indeed a hidden gem. The MC's character development is good. It's not like other novel that has sh*t ton of chapter (like in thousand) and will give you

sh*ty ending. This one doesn't have much ch but the author put all the seasonings in 200+ chap. The first time i finished reading this novel i feel complete, calm, no cliff hangers, no ending like the others like (author: i will leave it to your imagination what happen to them sh*t). Actually the reason why i read this again is because the last novel o read is sh*t (don't want drop name). So im healing my readers mind from that last novel by reading this one. Overall rating is still 9/10. (why not 10/10?) Because of the repeated chaps)

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 1

Reaper456

Reader

6mo

This novel was good, even when sometimes it's confusing to read especially when some of the chapters have repeated sentences. The prologue was ok and i liked that there's side stories where you can read what the apostles do after winning the war. And the MC's Character development was so good. This novel was worth the time reading compare to those Chinese system novels that has 1k to 4k. This in my opinion is a hidden gem

[Reply](#)

9 0

- 4

Your_Lord_Escanor

[Reaper456](#)

Reader

3mo

I'm reading because of your comment 🙏

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 1
_Snow
Reader
6mo

is it just me or the guy in the cover looks like griffith???

[Reply](#)

3 0

- 1
TheAngelOfTime
_Snow
Reader
6mo

It's the girl. The girl running from the bandits and MC's very first believer

Edited: 6mo

[Reply](#)

7 0

Load More Comments

Chapter 1

< 1 : Prologue >

The trigger was a mobile game.

I don't remember the exact genre, but I think it was introduced as an idle game.

The game itself was nothing special.

There were tiny figures of people walking around, and all I did was watch their movements.

They had finely crafted AI, or so it seemed, as each character moved diligently and did their own tasks.

Sometimes they would do something unusual, breaking the rules.

It felt like raising ants in a transparent gel.

I also remembered the tiny sea monkeys I used to keep in an aquarium.

Sometimes I would touch the people with my finger, and their health would decrease while a -1 appeared above their heads.

If I tapped them more than a dozen times, the character would disappear, but my finger would hurt so I stopped.

The magic resource at the bottom of the screen kept decreasing, so I couldn't endlessly tap the passing people.

Besides, it was healing to just watch the characters do their thing.

I spent about two or three hours a day watching the characters like that.

Until I came home drunk after a frustrating day.

“Why do they treat me like that——.”

One day, I came home intoxicated by alcohol because of human relationship problems.

I turned on the mobile game as usual, without any thought.

At first, I just wanted to look at the screen mindlessly.

But then, I got annoyed and looked for a target to vent my anger in the game.

What I found was a village in a secluded place.

I ignored the pain in my finger and tapped the screen until all the villagers disappeared.

I kept moving my finger busily until all my magic was consumed.

When I had recovered and spent all my magic again,

I had completely annihilated one village and found a message on my smartphone screen.

-Your karma has increased by 10.

-You have reached level 2.

It was the moment when I learned about a new feature of the game that I didn't know.

Chapter 2: Karma System (1)

< 2 : Karma System (1) >

The next day.

When I woke up from the alcohol, what I faced was the game screen that had reached level 2.

My level had increased by one.

It would have been nothing if it was a normal game.

Going from level 1 to level 2 was something that happened in the beginner stage.

But in this game, level had a different meaning.

There was no experience point to begin with, and level was meaningless in this game.

It was surprising that there was a hidden way to level up in this game that didn't even have a proper tutorial or guide.

It was natural that I was interested in the result of leveling up.

-<Observer's Eye (Lv.1)> grows.

-<Observer's Eye (Lv.2)> has been achieved.

You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

The first thing that changed was the skill called <Observer's Eye>.

It wasn't a skill that I could use at will.

It was a passive skill that applied automatically.

And after learning this skill, the graphics of the game that I saw changed.

It wasn't a drastic difference, but the shape of the characters that I saw changed.

Before <Observer's Eye> evolved, I could only recognize their human shape.

But after this skill evolved, more details appeared on the characters' appearance.

At least I could tell their gender and hair color.

“And this is... dialogue?”

Another change that came with the graphics change.

It was that I could understand the dialogue between characters.

Speech bubbles appeared above their heads, and the dialogue content was displayed as icons.

Of course, it was barely enough to understand their interaction purpose, not a real dialogue.

But it was amazing enough to create AI that acted like humans, let alone more details.

I decided to compromise with what I saw.

“Anyway. It's free, what more can I ask for.”

After answering myself, I checked out other skills that had appeared on my account.

There were several more skills besides <Observer's Eye> on my account that had leveled up.

You have acquired <Karma's Judgment (Lv.MAX)>.

-All actions that affect life and death will generate karma.

-Karma that is excessively biased in one direction has a high possibility of triggering <Causality Adjustment>.

It meant that the actions I took that affected the game characters would come back to me as experience points.

It seemed that killing characters like yesterday would increase my level.

There was also a warning about <Causality Adjustment> below, but it didn't explain what it was in detail.

Of course, if I attacked the characters recklessly like yesterday, my finger would only hurt.

It would be better to find an efficient way to hunt quickly if possible.

“What is this next skill... What is this?”

I scrolled down and checked the skill that was next to <Karma's Judgment>.

And I saw something unbelievable.

There was something clearly strange among the list of skills.

It was not a skill name that belonged to the skill window.

-You have acquired <Paid Currency Shop (Lv.MAX)>.

-You can now use paid currency to purchase items from the shop.

The skill name, <Paid Currency Shop>.

It was a skill that allowed me to use the cash shop.

No, it was too embarrassing to call it a skill.

After all, paid currency is something that you buy with real money.

But you have to learn a skill to buy it?

It was an absurd skill.

“Why did they put this in the skill?”

I grabbed the back of my neck as soon as I saw <Paid Currency Shop>.

I had heard a lot of stories about how games nowadays were crazy about scams, but this was crossing the line too much.

You can spend money when you level up!

Who wouldn't think that's ridiculous?

I take back what I said about the developer being amazing for making this a free game.

This developer was a writer who was crazy about money.

And a person who was crazy in an innovative way.

“...”

I stared intently at the shop button in one corner of the screen.

Hmm.

I don't feel like spending money on this game.

I already had a big expense from drinking too much yesterday because of the third round of promotions.

And they want me to spend money on this trash game?

I can't do that sober. Well, anyway.

“Shall I just take a look at the contents?”

-That's what I thought for a moment.

My eyes didn't leave the shop button.

No matter what, I was curious about what they were selling in <Paid Currency Shop>.

It was a game that could be played without spending money.

Then what kind of things did this shoddy game sell for money?

I stretched out my hand hesitantly and clicked the shop button quietly.

Click.

The shop page opened in front of me with a familiar touch sensation.

-Welcome to <Paid Currency Shop>.

-<Paid Currency Shop> sells various items that can help you play the game smoothly.

It said various items, but there was only one thing for sale.

The revenue structure was the famous 10-pull gacha.

They didn't even give a free pull for the first time.

The shop page didn't even tell me what kind of items were in the gacha.

Only a black cow customer would buy it without knowing anything.

And the price was 49,900 won for 10 pulls.

It was a fairly vicious price for a non-mainstream mobile game gacha.

“50,000 won for 10 pulls? Who would pull that?”

With that money, I could do at least 10 pulls in a major mobile game, or even dozens of pulls in a user-friendly game.

It was an amount that normal people wouldn't press the pull button.

Really.

I was normal and I didn't even dare to try it.

Only someone who had too much money would try it.

As if it read my mind, the game showed me a new guide message on the screen.

-You can get various items that can help you play the game by using 10 pulls.

“Are you crazy? Why would I pull that?”

I wasn't a black cow who spent money on this kind of game, even though I wasn't stingy with mobile games either.

I'd rather spend 100,000 won more on another game than this one.

With that thought, I tried to close the shop window when

I felt something wrong with my finger that was operating the screen

“...Oh, I pressed it wrong.”

Instead of going out, I accidentally pressed the 10-pull button

Of course, it wouldn't have been a big deal if it was a normal game

There would be a payment confirmation window in the middle, and I could cancel it there and it wouldn't be charged.

But this game wasn't a normal game.

As soon as I pressed the button, it went straight to the 10-pull screen.

“Hey, why don't you ask me if I want to pay?”

Even if it was a shoddy game, it would at least confirm the payment.

But this game ignored even that minimum rule and showed me the 10-pull screen.

Shhhhh.

Ten items appeared in front of me in sequence.

There was no effect to indicate the grade.

Either they were all trash items, or there was no grade distinction for items in the first place.

My eyes quickly scanned the list of items that appeared.

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Crude Dagger].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Magic Book: Lightning].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Torn Cloak].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

They all looked like garbage just by reading them.

Most of them were duplicates.

I realized as soon as I saw the items that they were things that should never be bought.

No, I already knew that to some extent, but I felt it painfully with my own body.

I denied the reality as soon as I saw the item list.

“I didn’t choose a payment method, so it didn’t go through, right?”

Ding.

A message arrived as soon as I finished speaking.

It was a message from the card company informing me of a payment of 49,900 won.

And it wasn’t even a credit payment, but a cash payment that came out.

I thought that since it was a shoddy game, the payment wouldn’t work properly, but this part was sharp and came out quickly.

It was a game that blatantly screwed over the user.

“No, what is this... Why did it really go out?”

The more I played, the more I fell into a maze.

I had no choice but to cross my arms and think about the money that had already gone out of my card.

Should I delete the game and get a refund?

Or should I keep playing the game with the thought that I was bitten by a dog?

I made up my mind after thinking about it.

“Hmm... Okay.”

I had fun playing it until now.

I decided to think of the 50,000 won as the purchase cost for the game.

There should be consumers like me who can make more diverse games.

Of course, I should stop this kind of payment model, though.

I quickly finished my decision and closed the shop and returned to the main screen.

And I looked at the items I got from the 10 pulls.

-[Rusty Iron Sword].

This was garbage.

There was no interaction other than throwing it on the ground.

It seemed that only the characters could move in the first place.

I checked the next item.

-[Hard Black Bread]

-[Crude Dagger]

-[Torn Cloak]

These were also the same as [Rusty Iron Sword].

There was no choice but to throw them away.

In other words, it was just sprinkling them on the characters.

I paid 50,000 won for these things.

It was something that I couldn't help but be disappointed.

-[Magic Book: Lightning]

Only this last remaining item, [Magic Book: Lightning], was different from the others.

It was the only one that had a direct interaction button with me.

When I pressed [Magic Book: Lightning] in my inventory, a selection window popped up above the inventory screen.

The new message that appeared was about learning magic.

-Do you want to learn <Lightning> skill?

-The magic book will disappear when you learn it.

-Yes / No

There was only one choice, of course.

I pressed 'Yes' without any hesitation.

Ding.

With a pleasant notification sound, the magic book disappeared from my inventory.

-You have learned <Lightning (Lv.MAX)>.

-You can now use lightning magic by consuming magic power.

At the same time, lightning magic appeared in the skill window.

The lightning magic button was different from other skills in that I could press it.

I immediately pressed the lightning magic button.

Then, with a small target mark and my magic power decreasing by almost 10%,

A bolt of lightning fell from the sky as soon as I touched a point on the screen.

A high-level magic that shoots lightning, lightning.

It was the moment when I learned an active skill for the first time in this game.

Chapter 3: Karma System (2)

< 3 : Karma System (2) >

After getting the skill, what I had to do was obvious.

I immediately looked for a target that I could attack nearby.

Despite the fact that there were some characters around, when I looked again, they were nowhere to be seen.

Maybe it was because of the rugged terrain of the mountain range, but it was not easy to find the characters in the tiles of similar colors.

The only thing I found was a rabbit that was grazing on the grass.

Unlike humans, its small graphic was standing still in its place.

It was the first time I tried to attack something that was not a character.

“Maybe... I can attack that too.”

I prepared the lightning magic when I found the rabbit.

Press.

I activated the target by pressing the button, and then placed the target on top of the rabbit.

Then I cast the magic by touching the target again.

Crack!

A short lightning struck above the rabbit's head.

-You used <Lightning>.

With the message that I used magic, a number -15 popped up above the rabbit's head.

The rabbit that was attacked fell down with a skull in its speech bubble.

The tiles around where the lightning fell were also charred black.

The rabbit that fell down did not get up again.

I knocked down the rabbit with one shot of <Lightning> magic.

“The damage is 15.”

The damage I inflicted on the rabbit with one lightning magic was 15.

Considering that I had to touch it once with my finger to inflict 1 damage, it was 15 times stronger than the basic attack.

Of course, I couldn't spam it indefinitely because of the high magic consumption.

But it seemed certain that my fingers would hurt less.

I tried out the lightning magic and felt sorry for myself, so I looked around.

“...”

I confirmed that <Lightning> magic could knock down a rabbit in one shot.

But I didn't think I could send a character away in one shot either.

I felt like trying it on a character as a target once.

I started looking for a suitable target by moving the screen.

The mountain beyond the mountain.

The small stream beyond that.

And then the dense forest that appeared again behind it.

I couldn't see any characters even after looking for a long time.

It seemed like the characters I found earlier were the last ones.

I kept flipping through the screen and looked for traces of characters carefully.

Then I felt something suddenly and put down my smartphone.

“...My stomach hurts. I should eat ramen while doing this.”

A sudden stomachache while playing the game.

It was the alcohol I drank yesterday that showed its presence.

Feeling a heavy sensation from my stomach, I decided to sober up with ramen reluctantly.

I left my smartphone alone and moved to boil ramen.

I came back to my smartphone after bringing a pot of boiling ramen.

“How can there be no one until I finish a bowl of ramen?”

I muttered to myself as I looked at the empty pot.

It was natural, because I still couldn't find any traces of people.

Not even animals, let alone people's traces.

Maybe it was because <Eye of Observation> was still low level, I thought.

If this was going to happen, maybe it would have been better to leave some characters alive instead of wiping out the village.

At least the location of the village would be fixed, right?

With regret, I kept flipping through the screen and then saw the end of the long mountain range slowly coming into view.

As if trying to reflect the real mountain range, this mountain range was unnecessarily long and wide.

Swipe. Swipe.

As I moved my finger busily to flip through the screen, I finally found what I wanted.

At the end of the mountain range where I arrived after a long time flipping through screens.

I saw a group of characters moving around there.

“One woman. And five men.”

What I saw at the end of the mountain range were six characters moving busily.

One woman running ahead of them all,

And five men following her closely behind them.

The men who were chasing after her had blood-stained knives in their hands.

It looked like a result of an interaction between characters.

A crying face speech bubble popped up above the woman’s head who was moving ahead.

“Is she being chased?”

They didn't look like they were traveling together no matter how you looked at them.

It seemed like she was being chased by bandits or thieves who were nearby.

They were faithful to their roles as AI's, even doing robbery faithfully.

I watched their movements with an interested face.

The woman who was leading them ran while crying, and soon found a dead end and sat down.

Even after sitting down, the speech bubble above her head did not disappear.

When the woman who was running ahead stopped, the thieves who were chasing her also stopped nearby and started to surround her.

-(Skull)

The figure who looked like the leader of the thieves raised a skull speech bubble above his head.

It was the same emoticon that was output when the rabbit died.

But the thief who raised the speech bubble didn't look like he was dead.

It looked like they were having a conversation with each other.

And judging by the situation, the meaning of the conversation seemed to be that they would kill the other person.

“Wow, they even threaten each other?”

They were AI's, but they even threatened each other.

The more I looked at it, the more I thought it was a game that well represented human nature.

It might be a bit disappointing in terms of graphics or payment structure, but AI was one thing that I didn't regret praising.

The thief who was threatening the woman in front of him soon raised his blood-stained knife and walked forward.

The bush tile on the ground split as the distance between the two narrowed.

When the distance between them narrowed to leave only one tile left.

I placed the target of the magic I had prepared on top of the thief.

-You used <Lightning>.

Crash!

The lightning struck and the thief who was moving stopped.

15 damage.

The same amount of damage as when I attacked the rabbit was output.

A spinning star-shaped speech bubble appeared above the thief's head.

A stationary character.

And the content of the speech bubble.

No matter how you looked at it, it looked like he was stunned.

It seemed that <Lightning> magic could interfere with his actions to some extent, even if it couldn't kill him in one shot.

I clicked the button again and used magic.

-You used <Lightning>.

-You used <Lightning>.

Crack! Crash!

I attacked the thief who was standing still with two more lightning strikes.

15 damage.

And then 15 damage again.

The thief who was hit by two more shocks fell down with a skull in his speech bubble.

The shock that knocked down the rabbit in one shot.

No matter how tough he was, he couldn't withstand being hit by lightning three times.

-Your karma increased by 1.

The new message was about the increase of karma.

It was the same format as when I wiped out the village.

I knocked down the thief and gained experience.

I didn't get any karma when I knocked down the rabbit, but I got karma when I knocked down the thief.

This fact meant something simple.

I could only get karma by knocking down characters.

The screen in front of me where the characters were gathered was nothing but a hunting ground full of experience.

"...You're all dead."

I snapped my fingers and looked at the screen.

It was time for hunting.

With her ash-gray hair fluttering in the wind, the girl ran away as fast as she could.

Behind her, there were muscular men with weapons chasing after her.

The weapons they were holding were stained with blood.

It was blood that they had spilled by cutting down the villagers who had blocked their way to protect her.

She felt the presence of the thieves behind her and bit her lip.

‘How did this happen...’

Eutania was a daughter of a baron who lived on the outskirts of the empire.

Her family was not a great one to boast about to others, even though they were nobles.

Her house was not wealthy, but the fact that they had a happy family was something to be proud of to others.

The village where Eutania lived was also a peaceful and quiet place.

A vast wheat field stretching out in one corner of the village.

And the fragrant grass scent that tickled the noses of the villagers.

Everyone was living a relaxed life in the village that Eutania loved.

Until the knights from ‘Cloud’ who came down with orders from the system came to visit.

‘Baron Highlost. You are arrested for treason against the royal family.’

Her father was taken away by the knights who came from the system.

Baron Highlost was arrested for political reasons.

Eutania kept insisting on her father's innocence, but no one listened to her story.

There were not many people who would listen to a young lady who ruled a rural village in the countryside.

Rather, only rude marriage proposals from nobles who preyed on her alone came in.

As more letters with unpleasant contents piled up, Eutania's heart was filled with distrust and hatred for humans.

'I can't ruin the village that my father loved.'

Still, she took over her father's empty seat and worked hard for the village.

Eutania had been following Baron Highlost since she was young and peeked at his work over his shoulder.

She knew better than anyone else about the village's affairs.

The villagers also trusted and followed Eutania, who had been a sincere lady for a long time.

Maybe someday another knight would be assigned to this small village, but she thought she had to protect the place where her father would return while she was there.

At least until this morning, she had that thought.

Until the thieves who came to the village slaughtered the villagers and chased after her.

"Haa, haa..."

Eutania's breath became rough as she ran towards the front.

She saw tears in her eyes as she crossed over the mountain.

It hurts. And it's painful.

It was a day when she missed her father who was locked up somewhere.

Still, she couldn't stop her footsteps because she remembered the faces of those who sacrificed themselves for her.

But no matter how many sacrifices she carried, it was impossible to run away forever?

What faced Eutania who ran ahead and looked ahead was a cliff that stretched out as if it had been cut off.

She couldn't run away any further on this road.

She saw a cliff in front of her and sat down on the ground.

“Ah, ah...”

Tears flowed from Eutania's eyes as she sat down.

She failed.

She failed to save her father, to protect the place where her father would return.

And in the end, she even failed to escape from the enemy of the village.

She hated herself for not being able to do anything right.

Now she had no more strength to move.

She missed her father.

She also missed the villagers who had become cold corpses and could no longer see.

“Dad... Mrs. Ena...”

Now she was alone.

She hated people.

She even hated someone coming near her.

But there was no end to those who chased after Eutania,

Thud. Thud.

She felt someone approaching from behind as she sat down and cried.

“Is this the end of your escape?”

“...”

“What a waste, poor noble lady?”

Eutania looked at the man in front of her with tearful eyes.

The face of a man with a knife mark on his face came into her sight.

The leader of the bandits who had mercilessly killed the villagers.

That was who the man was.

Chapter 4: Karma System (3)

< 4 : Karma System (3) >

“Looks like you have nowhere to run, huh?”

“Uh...”

Eutania bit her lip and looked up at the man in front of her.

She had no one to support her, and no one to protect.

This world was strangely unfair.

Her father had sacrificed his life for the weak, but he was imprisoned.

But the thief in front of her killed people mercilessly, and he was still roaming around freely.

“So, do you want to die here, or be sold as a slave?”

“...”

“Don’t you think it’s better to live as a slave, even if you suffer a bit?”

Hehehe.

The thief let out a disgusting laugh.

She didn’t want to hear his unpleasant voice anymore.

Instead of her father’s gentle voice, she had to listen to that arrogant voice.

She couldn’t help but think that the world was an unfair place.

And the moment she realized that fact, Eutania wished for something in her heart.

She wished that this world would just perish.

“If you can’t decide, I’ll decide for you.”

The thief finished his words and approached Eutania.

Thud, thud.

The sound of footsteps breaking through the bushes reached Eutania’s ears.

There was no place to escape anymore.

She had no choice but to accept her fate at this moment.

Eutania gave up everything and closed her eyes tightly.

As the thief got closer to her and reached out his hand towards her,

Crash—!

A thunderous sound echoed as lightning struck down.

“Aaaargh...!”

“Ah...?”

Eutania lifted her head and checked the scene in front of her with a deafening thunderclap.

There was an astonishing sight in front of her eyes, who had been denying reality until then.

The thief who was hit by the sharp lightning was rolling on the ground.

The damage from the lightning was so severe that the thief was foaming at the mouth with his eyes rolled back.

Eutania was startled by the sudden lightning strike, but it was only for a moment.

Soon, two more lightning bolts fell down.

“Ugh...”

Crash! Crackle!

The world flashed in an instant.

The thief who was hit by the lightning fell to the ground and didn't move anymore.

The lightning had cut off his breath.

Eutania saw that and looked up at the sky with horror.

The sky where the thunder sounded had no trace of a dark cloud.

The lightning she saw was not ordinary lightning.

“Boss? Did he really die?”

“There's no cloud in the sky. How did this happen...”

The thieves around him also showed signs of trembling with fear at the sight of their dead leader.

The lightning that fell from the clear sky had killed their boss.

They had never seen such a phenomenon before, even though they had been robbing for years.

One of them seemed to have figured out the situation quickly, pointing at the corpse of their boss that was turning into ashes and shouted.

“Magic! It must be magic!”

“Magic... magic?”

“Then is that girl a mage?”

The thieves’ eyes all turned to Eutania.

Mage.

They were objects of fear and awe for those who didn’t know magic.

Everyone knew the old story of how a village disappeared by an evil witch.

The thieves’ eyes were filled with fear as they looked at Eutania.

But this was also unknown to Eutania, who received their fearful glances.

‘Someone must have used magic. Then, who used magic?’

Eutania turned her head and looked around slowly.

A cliff cut off sharply.

A dense forest.

She couldn’t see any human figures on either side.

There was no one near her who could be suspected of being a mage.

Of course, while she was doing that, the fear in the thieves’ hearts grew bigger and bigger, and soon some people started running away with their weapons clanging.

“It’s a mage! Run!”

“Why is there a mage in this backwater place...!”

The thieves turned their backs on Eutania and ran towards the bottom of the mountain, screaming.

But the lightning that struck from the sky was not satisfied with one sacrifice.

Crash! Crackle!

Lightning struck again and swallowed up the fleeing thieves.

With a loud noise, the lightning mercilessly judged the scared thieves.

“Cough...!”

“Aah! P-please spare me...”

Every time the sky flashed, new screams came out of the thieves’ mouths.

The thieves died one by one from the continuous lightning strikes.

Some of them were lucky enough to avoid the lightning, but it was futile in front of the lightning that fell one after another.

All of the thieves met their end by the lightning, except for two exceptions.

And the last remaining thieves died painfully on the ground with bruises all over their bodies.

They died more brutally than the previous thieves.

Eutania got up from her seat with a blank expression as she saw the thieves being cleaned up in an instant.

“What is this...”

The enemy was a skilled thief.

They had been robbing for a long time, and they easily slaughtered the villagers.

But even those thieves couldn’t resist the lightning that struck one after another and fell down.

Eutania's eyes looked at the ashes of the thieves that scattered.

The unknown magic had taken away even the remains of the enemies.

It was as if all life had been taken to where it should have been.

She could only think of one kind of being that could do such a thing.

The omnipotent being who watched over her from the distant sky.

In other words, the ones called gods.

"I was... not alone."

Thud.

As she looked up at the sky, Eutania felt a sting on her head.

It was a similar feeling to when her father had given her a honeycomb when she was young.

It hurt where she was hit.

Tears trickled from her eyes.

But Eutania smiled faintly at the corners of her mouth.

She realized that she was not alone now.

"Thank you."

Eutania folded her hands and bowed to the sky in gratitude.

The sky was clear and bright without a single cloud.

There was no second honeycomb coming to Eutania from there.

"Ah, there's only one left."

I suppressed the yawn that was about to come out of my mouth in the morning and looked at the screen of my smartphone.

There were various messages popping up at the bottom of the screen where I had turned on the game.

They were new messages that came up as I attacked the gathered thieves.

Of course, most of them were messages about using magic and gaining karma by knocking down characters.

-You used <Lightning>.

-You used <Lightning>.

-Your karma increased by 1.

-You used <Lightning>.

-Your karma increased by 1.

-Your karma increased by 1.

I used the <Lightning> magic to knock down the thief characters who were clustered together.

<Lightning> was a powerful skill that inflicted 15 damage with just one use.

It didn't take long to take down the thieves who were not many in number.

However, even a powerful skill had its drawback of consuming mana.

At the end, I ran out of mana and had to move my fingers quickly to knock down the thief.

My fingers hurt from moving them almost a hundred times.

But I gained 5 karma, so it wasn't a completely useless thing.

“Well, it’s over once I get rid of this one.”

I moved my eyes to the last remaining character.

A female character with ash-colored hair was standing up and looking around in the middle of the screen.

She was the character who was sitting on the ground and showing a crying emoticon until a moment ago.

Maybe it was because I had killed all the thieves who were near her.

She was now standing up and crying.

I didn’t know what had happened between her and the thieves.

But I had led the thieves who were chasing her to hell, so she could now face her end peacefully.

“Go with them.”

As I touched the head of the remaining character.

The speech bubble above her head changed.

I looked closely at the speech bubble that was blinking above her head.

Various emoticons were displayed alternately there.

-(Sadness)

-(Joy)

-(Gratitude)

-(Sadness)

-(Joy)

She cried and smiled, thanked and cried again.

I was puzzled by the emoticon pattern that I had never seen before.

The pattern that the characters who had been clicked by me showed was usually constant.

They either showed a question mark above their head suddenly.

Or they just showed a crying emoticon right away.

But this character was showing a strange behavior of crying and smiling.

“Is there a problem with the AI intelligence?”

My finger that was about to click on her hesitated for some reason.

A character who expressed gratitude after being attacked.

She was the most peculiar one among the characters I had encountered so far.

It would be nice to kill her and get karma, but I didn't know when I would meet such a character again.

It wouldn't be bad to play while watching this character for a while.

If I changed my mind later, I could just use <Lightning>.

As I put my finger away and watched the screen, the character who had been showing speech bubbles started to move.

And at the same time, a new message popped up at the bottom of the screen.

-[Eutania Highlost] acquired <Fanatic> trait.

-Your karma increased by 1.

I looked at the screen with a curious face at the new message that popped up.

Even though I didn't kill the character, my karma increased by 1.

There was also a message saying that she acquired <Fanatic> trait.

Eutania Highlost.

I didn't know whose name it was exactly.

But there was one character that I could guess.

"Eutania Highlost... Is that her name?"

The only character left on the screen came into my sight.

A female character with ash-colored hair who started to climb up the mountain slowly.

She must have been Eutania.

She acquired <Fanatic> trait and gave me extra karma.

I could get karma without killing characters.

It was information that I learned for the first time through Eutania.

"But hunting is still faster."

Of course, it was only 1 karma after all.

I didn't know which character would get <Fanatic> trait, so I couldn't keep doing this.

It was still more efficient to hunt characters.

So I moved the screen right away to find the next prey.

Chapter 5: Awe and Fear (1)

< 5 : Awe and Fear (1) >

What do people need to live?

If I asked this question to anyone, most of them would give me similar answers.

They would say that people need the basics to live.

Food. Clothing. And a safe place to stay.

There are many things that are necessary to guarantee a minimum level of life.

And that seemed to be no exception for the character that was reflected in front of my eyes.

The first character who awakened the <Fanatic> trait, Eutenia Hyroste.

She had been constantly displaying a food emoticon above her head since a while ago.

“They said it was an idle game, but now it’s like they left the feeding to me.”

The catchphrase that I saw when I first encountered this game was that it was an idle game that anyone could play.

Idle game.

It meant that most things could be done without much effort.

But looking at the character in front of me, leaving her alone didn't seem like the best option.

It had been three days in game time.

Eutenia had been stuck in the cave without eating anything and starving.

The physics of this game were not much different from reality.

If she didn't eat for a long time, she would surely die.

In that sense, leaving her alone seemed like a bad idea.

"I can't just leave her to starve to death. It's not like I don't care about her."

She was just one character.

What difference would it make if one character disappeared?

But still, I felt a bit reluctant to let her go.

She was the first <Fanatic> character I got.

It wouldn't be too bad to take care of one character and raise her well.

I moved my finger and pressed the inventory button on the corner of the screen.

Ding.

A light notification sound and the items registered in the inventory appeared in my sight.

-[Rusty Iron Sword] x 3

-[Hard Black Bread] x 4

-[Torn Cloak] x 1

-[Crude Dagger] x 1

The items in the inventory were all obtained through the 10 consecutive draws.

It was impossible to obtain items other than through the draws in the store.

That's why the contents of the inventory were not much different from a few days ago.

I dragged one of the [Hard Black Bread].

As I clicked and moved the graphic that looked like bread, the bread followed my finger out of the inventory.

Thud.

The bread that came out of the inventory fell right in front of Eutenia.

As soon as I put down the [Hard Black Bread], Eutenia's eyes went straight to it.

-(Question)

The first reaction that Eutenia showed when she faced the bread was a question mark above her head.

From her perspective, it was sudden that bread appeared.

It was natural for an AI to have doubts if it was normal.

But soon she seemed to have made a judgment about the situation, and she picked up the bread on the floor.

Eutenia's speech bubble changed quickly as she lifted up the bread.

-(Thankful)

-(Moved)

-(Thankful)

-(Moved)

The graphic of the bread was barely distinguishable from the character as she lifted it up.

Eutenia started to eat the bread slowly, expressing her gratitude.

Eutenia's graphic was small, and the bread's graphic was even smaller.

It was hard to feel more than just understanding that she was eating from looking at the screen.

But as I saw the bread disappearing little by little, it was clear that Eutenia was eating it.

“Is this how it feels to feed a pet?”

I felt a warm feeling as I watched Eutenia eat.

I remembered when I fed my fish when I was young.

When I put in food, the fish would swarm around and nibble at it with their mouths open and closed.

Maybe because of the poor graphics, I couldn't feel more emotion than that.

I rested my chin on my hand and kept watching Eutenia eat.

About 20 minutes after I put down the bread.

Eutenia finished eating all of it and got up from her seat.

-(Satiated)

-(Moved)

-(Thankful)

After finishing her meal, Eutenia thanked me again with a prayer gesture.

I thought she was a bit crazy AI, but she seemed to be very good at expressing gratitude.

Maybe I could show her some more mercy if she reacted like this.

I opened my inventory and took out some other items.

[Crude Dagger]. [Torn Cloak].

They were both items that were useful for living in the cave.

As I dropped the dagger and cloak on the floor, Eutenia blinked her eyes and watched them.

“Take these as gifts from me, who generously gave you the results of the 10 consecutive draws.”

They were useless items for me.

I couldn't use any of them except for the magic book.

But for Eutenia in front of me, they were valuable items.

As I gave Eutenia the items, she showed another intense reaction and prayed again.

-(Moved)

-(Thankful)

-(Moved)

-(Thankful)

Even if I lent money to someone in need, I wouldn't see such a reaction.

I was satisfied with Eutenia's reaction and closed my inventory.

I didn't think she would stay here forever.

But they were useful items for living in the mountains.

If I wanted to see a different reaction later, I would have to kick her out of the mountain by touching her or something.

Anyway, it was fun to see Eutenia's reaction to the items I got from the draw.

Except for the fact that they came out of the draw.

“Evil bastards. This is how you plan to take my money.”

I recalled the items I got from the last draw.

Bread that I could feed to the character.

A weapon that I could give to the character.

And magic that I could use myself.

Except for the unreasonable price and probability, it was a tempting composition that made me want to press it more often.

I realized this temptation after I got used to the game a bit.

I resisted the urge to press the draw button right away with my twitching finger.

It was all for their own wallets.

Eutania Highlost.

The ash-haired girl looked up at the sky with dry lips.

She had been holed up in the mountain for three days now, feeling empty about the ruined village and hateful towards the world.

A nameless god had saved her from the brink of death, but that didn't mean that Eutenia's life had a happy ending.

Family. Clan. Relationships.

Everything that supported her had already collapsed.

Now, the only things left were the god who watched over her, and Eutenia herself, who had become a lonely outcast.

And even that was only prolonging her life thanks to the nameless god who saved her.

If it weren't for the nameless god who struck lightning at the last moment, she would have taken her own life long ago.

“Sigh...”

Eutenia let out a sigh as she looked at the cave shrouded in darkness.

The cave was damp and dark, with no one else in it.

Gurgle.

Her stomach screamed after not eating anything for three days.

She was cold. And hungry.

She had never experienced such hunger for so long.

At least, not as far as she could remember.

She was used to facing a plentiful table every day, so this experience was unfamiliar to her.

But she couldn't hope for a lavish table all of a sudden either, so all Eutenia could do was to space out to forget her hunger.

“...”

Eutenia's eyes scanned the empty cave.

Moss. Damp floor. Humid air.

There was nothing else but Eutenia.

Her eyes moved again.

Moss. And damp floor.

Thud.

Moss. Floor. Hard black bread.

Life returned to Eutenia's eyes, which had been moving listlessly.

“Bread fell down.”

What fell on the floor was unmistakably bread.

It looked hard as if it had been there for a long time, but it was still edible bread.

Eutenia picked up the bread that had fallen on the floor and looked up at the ceiling.

It was impossible for bread to sprout on moss in the middle of a cave.

It wasn't that she missed it rolling on the floor either, so it must have fallen from the sky, Eutenia thought.

But all she could see from the ceiling were rough stones.

“It must have been sent by you.”

A smile bloomed on Eutenia's lips as she lifted up the bread.

It wasn't the last time that he sent lightning down.

The nameless god had been caring for Eutenia's affairs all along.

He even prepared bread for her to eat, knowing that she was hungry.

Eutenia brought the bread to her mouth and bit it slightly.

Crunch. Crunch.

Her teeth bounced off the bread without penetrating it easily.

The old bread was harder than she thought.

“Do I have to lick it slowly?”

She had no choice but to soak the bread enough to bite it off.

Lick. Eutenia's tongue brushed over the surface of the bread.

It was hard bread that she wouldn't have bothered to look at normally.

But in this hungry situation, it was a delicious feeling just to touch it with her tongue slightly.

Eutenia slowly melted the hard bread and put it in her mouth.

She wasn't in a situation where she could swallow it quickly, so there was no risk of choking or vomiting.

‘It would have been nice if I had some milk.’

She felt a bit regretful that she didn't have any milk to soak the hard bread in.

But there was nothing better than eating bread in this hungry situation.

Besides, the bread she had now was a gift of mercy from heaven.

She thought it would be a sin to complain more than this.

“Mm, hmm...”

It had been quite some time since Eutenia started eating bread.

The large piece of black bread had mostly disappeared into Eutenia’s stomach.

Now, all that remained in her hand was one last piece of bread.

Eutenia put the last piece of bread in her mouth and looked at the sky with satisfaction.

She felt good after filling her stomach for the first time in a while.

She clasped her hands and thanked the sky briefly.

“Thank you for the meal. I appreciate it.”

She didn’t know which god was watching over her, but he had helped her several times already.

Eutenia was ready to serve and follow him no matter what god he was.

He was the last milestone left in Eutenia’s life.

It would be foolish not to follow the only path left for her.

Even if he was a god full of sinister rumors.

As Eutenia prayed to the sky with excitement, she heard something falling from above.

“Huh...?”

Thud. Thump.

In front of Eutenia, a shabby cloak and a crudely made dagger fell down.

A light dagger that anyone could use.

And a warm cloak that could cover her body.

Her god was not only concerned about her meal, but also her life in the mountain.

Eutenia picked up the dagger with tears in her eyes.

“What words should I use to thank you? Really, it’s a hard thing to do.”

They say that after hardship comes sweet reward.

She thought that all the trials she had gone through were for this moment.

Devotion to a nameless god.

That was the path that the ash-haired girl chose for herself.

Chapter 6: Awe and Fear (2)

< 6 : Awe and Fear (2) >

——The Executor ‘Cloud’.

Under the great empire’s emperor, the investigators of Cloud had jurisdiction over the entire empire, and they all boasted of their outstanding military prowess.

In the deep darkness of the empire, there were all kinds of vicious criminals lurking.

The investigators of Cloud who had to face them had to have a high level of military prowess.

It was no exception for Rick Swail, a third-class investigator of Cloud who was patrolling a small village on the outskirts of the empire.

Rick Swail.

The sharp-eyed investigator scanned the empty village.

A fireplace that still had warmth.

Food scraps rolling on the floor.

A wet cloth hanging on the window.

The whole village showed signs of life.

It meant that people had been living there until recently.

However, contrary to the appearance of the village, there was not a single person in sight.

Rick looked at the guide who had brought him to the village and asked.

“So this happened overnight?”

“Yes, sir! The entire village disappeared in one day.”

“Is there any possibility that they moved somewhere as a group?”

“No way. My friend Jack is... he has a bad leg.”

The guide who accompanied Rick was someone who had a friend in this village.

He had a friend who had difficulty moving because of his bad leg.

If he said so, it was unlikely that they had moved somewhere.

Rick walked towards the village and said.

“I can feel the signs of life... but I don’t see anyone.”

Rick felt uneasy as he walked around the village and opened each door one by one.

Creak.

The old wooden doors made of wood opened easily without any resistance.

But he couldn’t find any people in any of the buildings he entered.

There were traces of people, but the actual subjects were nowhere to be found.

If the villagers hadn’t moved as a group, it meant that the entire population had evaporated in one day.

“Any guesses?”

“Uh, I heard rumors that there were bandits around here! Maybe they did it?”

“Bandits...”

Rick scanned the village again.

If there was a fight, there would have been traces of it.

But he couldn't find any bloodstains or anything like that in the village.

The only strange thing was that there were black scorch marks all over the village.

It was a peculiar mark that didn't seem to be caused by fire.

“If there were bandits, there would have been signs of resistance.”

“Then...”

“It looks like there's a mage nearby.”

The ability to erase a whole village without leaving any traces.

And the black scorch marks that appeared all over the village.

Combining all these things, Rick Swail could only come to one conclusion.

There was a mage nearby.

And not just any mage, but a powerful one who could leave no traces behind.

“A mage...!”

The guide looked horrified when he heard Rick's words.

The existence of mages was not uncommon in the empire.

There were also mages among the investigators of Cloud who used magic.

But people had long been afraid of evil mages.

There were also those who abused magic on the wanted list of Cloud, so it was understandable that the guide was scared.

“Don’t make too much noise. He might still be hiding nearby.”

“O-okay.”

“By the way, you said there were bandits around here?”

“I don’t know much about it, but I heard rumors that sometimes gangs of thieves roam around.”

Rick frowned as he heard about the bandits.

“Isn’t it too dangerous for you to go alone?”

“There’s a shortcut I know around here. If I go through there, I won’t run into any thieves.”

“I see. Then you should go back now. I’ll investigate by myself from now on.”

Rick dismissed the guide with his words.

An unknown mage and a gang of bandits.

He didn’t know which one was more dangerous.

And the guide who had brought Rick to the village weighed more on the former.

He bowed his head and left after a brief farewell to Rick.

Rick looked up at the sky blankly in the desolate village where he was left alone.

“I got myself into a tricky situation this time.”

-Your karma increased by 1 point.

-Your karma increased by 1 point.

-You reached level 3.

Two more days passed since I gave Eutania a dagger and a cloak as gifts.

During that time, I found five more villages and destroyed three of them.

One of them was filled with bandits who were chasing Utania.

Of course, they met their end by my <Lightning> magic just like the previous bandits I encountered.

I gained nearly 30 karma points by destroying three villages.

Karma 30.

It was enough to level up again.

Naturally, I reached level 3 with the karma I gained this time.

“Level 3... my magic power increased a lot.”

The biggest change that happened when I reached level 3 was the increase in magic power.

My magic power increased by twice as much as before when I leveled up.

If I could use <Lightning> 10 times with my previous magic power, now I could use it 20 times in a row.

It was definitely a drastic increase in ability.

If I assumed that my magic power increased by twice every time I leveled up, then by the time I reached level 10, I would be able to use it more than 1000 times in a row.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.2)> has grown.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.3)> has been achieved. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

The next change was in <Eye of the Observer>.

The level of <Eye of the Observer> skill increased, and I was able to face a sharper graphic than before.

If the character I saw before was a dot graphic, now it was a cute 3D graphic level.

It was a game that evolved its graphics as the level increased.

No matter how I thought about it, it was a strange structure.

And the appearance of Eutenia, who I faced with the new graphics, was more adorable than I expected.

“It feels like I’m really raising a character like this.”

The ash-haired tiny character was nibbling on the black bread in her hand.

She looked like a squirrel eating an acorn.

She was still eating while showing various speech bubbles above her head.

Judging by the fact that the content did not change, the 3rd level <Eye of the Observer> did not affect the speech bubbles.

I watched Eutenia for a while and then turned my eyes to see the next change.

-Warning: Karma that is excessively biased in one direction has a high possibility of causing <Causality Adjustment>.

The next message was a warning sent by the <Karma's Judgment> skill.

It said that if karma was biased in one direction, <Causality Adjustment> could occur.

But I didn't know what to do to make karma balanced.

And I couldn't just stop leveling up in a game that I paid 50,000 won for.

I decided to ignore the message.

"I don't know what this is, so pass. And next is... this is here again."

I scrolled down and looked at the message with a bitter smile.

The next skill that evolved had a very familiar name.

It was because it was a skill from the store that occupied the spot.

-<Paid Currency Store (Lv.MAX)> skill has been expanded.

-You have acquired <Paid Currency Store (Lv.MAX + 1)>.

-You can now use paid currency to purchase items from the store.

The <Paid Currency Store> skill had evolved.

And what was more peculiar was that the level notation of the <Paid Currency Store> skill was strange.

Skill level MAX + 1?

If the level is MAX, then it should end there. How can there be a level MAX + 1?

Anyway, it was absurd that the store evolved as the level increased.

It was a game that became more and more ridiculous as I saw it.

And I was a user who played that game.

I marveled at myself who enjoyed such a game, and moved my finger to the back button.

“Who would buy this? I’ll never buy it.”

I would never come back to this store again.

That’s what I thought as I pressed the back button.

At that moment, I felt something strange and looked at my finger.

My finger that was heading towards the back button moved in a weird direction.

“What, what is this... Wait, why is this happening!”

There was a strong force somewhere on the screen that pulled my finger in.

My finger moved without my will.

I tried to shake off the force on my finger, but the unknown force was stronger than I thought.

In an instant, my finger moved to the 10 times draw button.

Click.

That’s how my finger pressed the 10 times draw button.

“Sigh...”

The screen flashed and the draw page started to appear.

I looked at the items that came out one by one with a blank face.

Ding dong.

The text message from the card company that popped up at the top of the screen was extra.

Chapter 7: Awe and Fear (3)

< 7 : Awe and Fear (3) >

Payment amount, 69,900 won.

It was a level that could be burdensome to use as a dining cost if the first digit exceeded 5, but I ended up spending 70,000 won on one draw.

It would be a lie if my blood pressure didn't rise.

I looked at the draw screen with a blank expression.

“Did I really press this with my finger?”

My finger suddenly ran to the draw button.

Even though I had such a memory, it was not easy to believe the surreal memory.

Maybe I pressed it and was mistaken.

I wondered for a moment if I wanted to draw 10 times so badly that I distorted my memory.

I weighed the reliability between reality and memory, and quickly compromised with reality.

“Ah, I don't know. I guess I wanted to draw that much.”

Compared to the games that cost a lot of money, I hadn't spent that much yet.

It's not like I skipped meals because of the draw.

It feels like I'm reminded of the old days.

Now it's nothing but a romance of my past childhood.

I finished my quick regret and turned my eyes to the draw screen to check the contents.

Items of various colors were displayed on the screen.

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Stylish Tunic].

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Steel Shield].

-You have acquired [Sponge Cake].

-You have acquired [Magic Book: Barrier].

-You have acquired [Torn Tunic].

-You have acquired [Iron Sword].

The guide that said 'better' draw seemed to be true, as the items that came out of the draw were mostly different from before.

The biggest difference was that there were no broken items unlike before.

I started to look at the items that came out of the draw one by one.

The first thing to look at was food.

[Baguette]. And [Sponge Cake].

Neither of them were items that I could use.

Eutenia would like them if I gave them to her.

“Come to think of it, she’s eating more expensive than me.”

If you divide the 10 times draw cost of 69,900 won by 10, it would be about 7,000 won each.

I took out the [Sponge Cake] from my inventory and handed it to Eutenia.

Maybe it was because a different food popped out instead of the [Hard Black Bread] she had been eating for days.

Eutenia, who was curious, took a piece of the [Sponge Cake] and put it in her mouth.

She showed a more intense reaction than before after eating the cake.

-(Thankful)

-(Tears)

-(Moved)

-(Thankful) (Thankful) (Thankful) (Thankful)

It was a 7,000 won worth of food.

If she didn’t show such a reaction, I would have been disappointed.

I also threw the [Stylish Tunic] that was in my inventory on the floor while I was at it.

It seemed better than what she was wearing now.

She would look neater than now with a [Torn Cloak] wrapped around her if she changed her clothes.

Eutenia picked up the [Stylish Tunic] and thanked me again and accepted the gift.

I watched Eutenia for a while as she ate the cake and was moved, then moved my eyes back to the inventory to check the next item.

“It’s not rusty this time.”

[Iron Sword] and [Steel Shield].

They were quite different from the [Rusty Iron Sword] that came out before.

They could be used if given to a suitable character.

But it was awkward to give them to Eutenia right now.

She didn’t seem like someone who could wield a sword anyway.

If I ever raise a character that needs them, I’ll give them these items then.

“And lastly... today’s only harvest.”

The only magic book that came out of the 10 times draw.

I looked closely at the magic book I got new.

[Magic Book: Barrier].

Barrier was a magic that was used to protect people.

It didn’t seem like a good magic to acquire karma.

I would have learned it in an instant if it was an attack magic, but it was hard to learn because it had a different purpose.

What should I do with this?

I thought of one question as I looked at the magic book.

“Can’t the character learn this and use magic?”

If I acquire a magic book, the magic book disappears from my inventory.

But it’s different if I give it to Eutenia.

As long as she doesn’t eat the magic book, the magic book won’t disappear.

I don’t know if I can get the magic book back, but it’s worth a try.

I dragged the magic book I was holding in front of Eutenia.

Thud.

As the magic book suddenly fell in front of her, Eutenia, who was eating the cake, looked up at the sky.

-(Question)

-(Thankful)

That’s how I dumped all the products of the 10 times draw to Eutenia.

It was an act of giving to her who had the <Fanatic> trait, thinking that she was on my side.

Some kind of result will come out soon.

I don’t know if the result is good or bad.

I wanted to see Eutenia’s appearance who learned magic if possible.

“It would be fun if she learned magic.”

Magic books are also items that can be given to characters.

I didn't think it was possible without any reason.

The game's interaction itself was more elaborate than I thought.

There must be some preparation for magic as well.

At least I believed that.

Thud.

I turned off the screen of my smartphone by pressing the button, after giving Eutenia the magic book.

I did everything I could.

Now it was time to wait until my mana came back up.

“Ah. My 70,000 won.”

Sigh.

I looked at my wallet that was rolling on the bed with a dry mouth.

My empty wallet looked pitiful today.

I guess I'll have to settle for ramen for dinner tonight.

Damn developers.

I cursed at someone who might be somewhere, and threw myself on the soft bed.

Eutenia had been living in the cave for quite a long time.

It was an escape from the world that she no longer wanted to face.

She thought it would be better to avoid meeting people from the outside world, even if it meant starving and freezing in the wilderness.

But she never had to starve in the cave.

It was all thanks to the grace of an Nameless God who was watching over her.

The Nameless God visited her regularly and gave her gifts.

A dagger and a cloak.

And even some edible black bread.

They were things that she needed to survive in the mountains.

If she wanted to eat meat, she could hunt rabbits with the dagger.

If she felt cold, she could wrap herself with the old cloak.

The items were somewhat crude or worn out, but they were good enough for using in the cave.

Thanks to them, Eutenia's cave life was quite comfortable.

“Thank you for taking care of me every day.”

So Eutenia prayed as usual today.

She had never seen his face, but she was sure of his existence.

She hoped that someday, when she became a better believer, he would let her hear his voice.

As Eutenia was praying with her hands clasped, she heard something falling from the sky.

Thud.

The sound echoed in the cave and Eutenia looked ahead.

There was a small wooden plate with a soft sponge cake on it.

“...What is this?”

She said as she brought the cake closer to her.

Eutenia was a noble lady of a baron’s family, but she was only a poor noble from a rural village.

Even for her, the sponge cake in front of her was not an easy food to get.

There was also a wooden fork next to the sponge cake.

She took out the dagger from her pocket and cut the cake neatly.

She took a piece of it.

“I should eat it gratefully since he gave it to me.”

She exclaimed as she saw the fork digging into the cake softly.

It was much softer than the black bread that she ate every day.

She swallowed her saliva as she saw the piece of cake on the fork.

She took a bite of it.

“Mmm...”

The cake melted softly in her mouth.

She tasted the sweetness of sugar from the cake.

It was a sweetness that she could never feel from the hard black bread.

No, she didn’t have many chances to eat such food in her whole life.

She let out an exclamation with a bright face as she chewed on the cake.

“...It’s sweet. It’s so good.”

The cake that she put in her mouth disappeared in an instant.

She finished eating all the cake that came into her mouth and looked at the cake again.

Maybe he gave her a special meal today.

It was a different food from the usual black bread.

Thud.

Another thing fell in front of her as she tried to eat the cake again with a wave of emotion.

This time, it was not food but clothes.

“This is... clothes?”

Eutenia picked up the clothes that fell in front of her.

It was a refined tunic at first glance.

It looked like something that she could wear outside without any problem.

It was different from the old and dirty items that she had received so far.

It didn’t seem like something that she could use in the mountains.

“Ah...”

As soon as she saw the clothes that fell in front of her, Eutenia realized what the god who watched over her wanted.

He gave her clean clothes unlike before.

Eutenia thought there was only one meaning to it.

He wanted her to go outside wearing this.

He meant that her escape in this dark cave was coming to an end soon.

“He wants me to go out.”

She had decided to live for him since he saved her life from the bandits.

She couldn't stay in this cave forever either.

She had something to do.

And that must be his will.

“If that's what you want.”

As if to support Eutenia's determination, one last gift fell from the sky.

Thud.

A thick magic book rolled on the floor.

Chapter 8: Awe and Fear (4)

< 8 : Awe and Fear (4) >

“I’m starting to understand it now.”

At the entrance of an empty cave.

There, Eutenia was reading a magic book by herself, murmuring softly.

She was wearing a neat tunic that she had received from the great person she served.

It had been a week since she had received the book as a gift from him.

Eutenia had been busy trying to understand the magic book during that time.

And now, she had achieved some results.

“What I learned from my father was quite helpful.”

Eutenia’s slender finger turned the page of the thick magic book.

Magic was not an easy subject that anyone could understand.

If Eutenia had not learned the minimum education as a noble, she would have needed more time to understand the magic book.

Fortunately, Eutenia had a natural talent for handling magic.

It meant that she understood the basics of magic in just a week.

“Then, I should try it out now.”

Thud.

She closed the magic book that was open and got up from her seat.

She held the magic book in her arms and walked slowly toward the outside of the cave.

Rustle. Rustle.

Eutenia’s light footsteps brushed past the bushes.

She came out of the bushes and looked for a large stone on the ground.

A rough-looking stone was one.

And next to it was a flat-shaped stone.

Eutenia looked at the stones around her and picked up one that had a suitable weight.

“Is this weight okay?”

A heavy sensation came from her palm that held the stone.

Thump. Thump.

She tossed and caught the stone lightly and adjusted her posture.

Right after that, she threw the stone vertically high and reached out her hand toward the sky.

A blue haze bloomed from her palm and began to wrap around Eutenia’s body.

The magic that wrapped around Eutenia began to spread around her.

At that moment, Eutenia condensed her magic and used it.

“Barrier.”

Boom—!

The stone that was falling above Eutenia’s head bounced off a translucent barrier.

A hemispherical shield that spread around her protected her from the stone.

It was a low-level defensive magic, barrier.

She looked at the shield that protected her with sparkling eyes.

The barrier of blue color prevented anything from approaching her.

She poked the barrier around her with her hand, but the condensed magic blocked even Eutenia.

“It’s amazing. This must be magic.”

Swoosh.

Eutenia, who had been admiring the barrier for a while, waved her hand and scattered the gathered magic.

The solid cohesion of magic was loosened, and the barrier around her disappeared without a trace.

It was a supernatural miracle that she created in thin air with just her gesture.

It was the moment when Eutenia became interested in magic.

“If I keep learning these magics, I’m sure it will help his wish.”

Magic is a study that reproduces things and phenomena.

It reproduces phenomena by studying the flow, and imitates things by observing their essence.

That's why extreme magic can create miracles that defy nature.

And Eutenia was a human who was born with talent for learning such magic.

A genius does not need much time to realize their potential.

Eutenia was no exception.

She recalled the contents of the magic book and reached out her hand toward the empty front.

“Shield.”

A translucent blue barrier appeared in the air where Eutenia's hand touched.

The shield magic was not in the magic book that Eutenia received.

It was something that she implemented herself by understanding the characteristics of barrier magic.

She created a shield in midair and tapped it lightly with her hand.

Boom—!

Ripples occurred where Eutenia's hand touched.

“It still needs some improvement. Maybe I need more magic.”

Eutenia, who had been touching the shield several times, moved her hand like before and scattered it.

She tried each magic once and wanted to modify and use it again.

She became interested in learning new magics for the first time.

After that, Eutenia continued to use barrier and shield magics and observed their changes for a long time.

Eutenia's magic experiment lasted until sunset.

The execution agency of the empire, Cloud's Centurios branch office.

There, Rick Swail, a third-class investigator, looked at his superior.

Rick's expression was more serious than ever.

He usually had a smile on his face and joked with his superior.

But Rick was not in a situation where he could even pretend to laugh with his superior.

The reason was the case he was reporting.

"Rick... How big is the damage of this case?"

The squint-eyed investigator who was sitting in front of Rick asked him.

Second-class investigator, Hus Allemier.

He was showing his displeasure without hiding it after hearing Rick's report.

"Four villages disappeared."

Rick reported to his superior in front of him with a stifling feeling.

It was a case where four villages had vanished altogether.

The villages were not destroyed or looted by bandits.

All the objects and facilities were left as they were, but only the people were all missing.

It was not a case that could be explained in normal terms.

Rick's words made Hus scratch his throat and ask the next question.

"What's the possibility that they were attacked by bandits?"

"Everything that could be worth money in the village was left as it was."

"There was nothing missing?"

"Yes. There was no sign of tampering."

If bandits had moved, there should not have been anything worth money left in the village.

But there was no trace of looting, let alone any proper bloodstains, in the village.

That was why Rick was sure that it was not the work of bandits.

Bandits could not create such a scene.

At least, it was not an act motivated by money.

Hus listened to Rick's story and asked another question.

"What's the possibility that they moved somewhere as a group?"

"There was no one left. Among the vanished villages, there was one with a person who had a disability, but even they disappeared without a trace.

Rick, who had a hunch, searched for signs of people around the village.

A large-scale movement would inevitably leave some clues.

But he could not find any evidence that the villagers had moved in groups near the village.

The second possibility that Hus thought of was also meaningless.

As one possibility after another was denied, Hus glared at the wooden board he was holding with a click of his tongue.

“So you’re saying that only the people disappeared without any trace?”

“Yes. At least that’s what I confirmed.”

Rick said that was the reason he came to see Hus today.

No matter how much he searched the village, he could not find any proper clues.

It was a case where only the villagers disappeared as a whole, leaving everything else as it was.

In Rick’s shallow opinion, the only thing he could guess was the work of a magician.

That’s why he came to see Hus, a high-level combat magician, to report and ask for his opinion.

But Hus showed a gloomy reaction even after hearing Rick’s words.

Even Hus, who was a magician himself, did not seem to have any idea.

“People just vanished. If it were me, I would rather focus on the fact that you couldn’t find any traces.”

“Mr. Hus. Is there any possibility that it was the work of a magician?”

“The work of a magician?”

“I mean, the possibility that they used magic to erase the village.”

Rick laid out his reasoning to Hus, who was pondering.

But Hus shook his head as soon as he heard that story.

He looked at Rick with incredulous eyes instead.

“Nonsense. If they used magic, there would be no reason for the objects around them to be intact.”

“Couldn’t they have used magic only on people?”

“Rick Swail. Do you move while distinguishing between your enemies and allies?”

“...”

“If there was such a great magic, there would be no misfortune of dying by friendly fire on the battlefield.”

Rick became speechless at Hus’s words.

He thought that if it was magic, something similar would be possible.

But according to Hus, who was a combat magician, even magic was difficult to do such a thing.

There was no magic that could identify and move objects and people separately.

That was the conclusion of this conversation.

Rick felt more frustrated by Hus’s realistic words.

“But, several villages have disappeared without a trace.”

“I think it’s more likely that you missed something.”

“...Mr. Hus.”

“But if what you said is true, maybe someone made an offering to an evil god or something.”

“Offering...?”

Offering.

The moment he heard that word, Rick felt like his chest was cleared.

It was the only clue thrown into the frustrating case.

He looked at Hus's face with anticipation.

"I saw this in an old document. The priests who worshiped the evil god sacrificed people for their evil deeds."

"The priests of the evil god..."

"Of course they all died in the last war. They moved directly from the holy land, so there wouldn't be any left."

"I see."

"Of course I think you did a sloppy investigation."

The priests of the evil god.

Sacrifice.

Offering.

The three keywords matched in Rick's head and drew a picture.

If there were still priests who worshiped the evil god.

And if they were plotting something by offering people as sacrifices.

It wouldn't be impossible to understand why four villages disappeared at once.

Rick came to a conclusion in his mind and decided to search around the village again.

"Mr. Hus."

"Did you decide to go back and investigate?"

“I’ll find the traces of the evil god and come back.”

“What? Wait there...”

Bang.

Rick closed the door and ran outside.

The number of villages where people went missing was four.

If he searched thoroughly within their radius, he might be able to find traces of the evil god.

Clang.

Rick grabbed his sword on his waist and moved toward his horse that he had tied up.

Chapter 9: Awe and Fear (5)

< 9: Awe and Fear (5) >

-You have reached level 4.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.3)> has grown.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.4)> has been achieved. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

It had been several days since I handed over the magic book to Eutenia.

In game time, it was about ten days.

During that time, I hunted diligently and as a result, I was able to reach level 4 at a fast pace.

When I reached level 4, my magic power increased significantly once again.

Also, when the Eye of the Observer leveled up, the speech bubble showed different content than before.

-Bread.

Of course, even though it showed different content, it was only a level of displaying two letters of dialogue.

It was not much different from when emoticons appeared.

Eutenia, who woke up from her sleep and practiced magic, prayed and looked for bread.

It clearly meant that she wanted me to give her some bread.

I chuckled at Eutenia's request and looked at her.

"Hey, did I leave bread with you?"

I briefly wondered if I should get rid of it for good.

I took out a baguette from my inventory and put it down in front of Eutenia.

Thud.

Eutenia thanked me after seeing the baguette that fell on the floor.

-Thank you.

-Thank you.

The extremely short dialogue felt awkward.

Eutenia finished her thanks and went into the cave to tear and eat the bread.

I calmly watched her eat.

It was true that she looked cute eating bread like that.

Did I develop some affection for her while watching her?

I didn't feel like doing anything to her anymore.

"Go ahead, eat. I should take care of your food since you learned magic."

And if I kept watching her, I could also see Eutenia using barrier magic.

The magic book I gave to Eutenia had an effect.

Now that the character realized that she could use magic, I felt like giving her other magic books and testing them out.

If I gave her various magic books, I could surely train her into a perfect mage character.

If only I had enough money in my wallet.

“I can’t play the game as I want without money.”

The cost of 10 draws had risen to 70,000 won, so it was not easy to press the draw button once.

Fortunately, the <Paid Currency Shop> did not increase its level when I reached level 4.

The price of 10 draws was still at 70,000 won.

It was not long before payday, so I decided to try it once when I got paid.

I thought about that as I watched Eutenia.

“Grow well and eat well. Then you can smash everything with your hands.”

As I watched her, Eutenia came out again after finishing her meal.

She had a magic book in her hand as she came out.

She seemed to be practicing magic again.

I was about to move the screen as I prepared for training.

It was boring to just watch her practice magic, so I thought I would go hunting while Eutenia practiced.

If it wasn’t for one character coming towards me from afar.

A man in armor ran towards me in the corner of my sight where I was about to go hunting.

“What is this? I’ve never seen this outfit before.”

I had taken care of several villages so far, but this was the first time I saw someone wearing this outfit.

The man in blue uniform moved towards where Eutenia was.

As soon as he saw Eutenia, he showed signs of caution and started approaching her.

He had a sword in his hand that looked much better than the ones used by the thieves.

A decent-looking sword.

And a neat-looking uniform.

He didn't look like a thief by his outfit.

Eutenia raised a speech bubble over her head when she saw the man approaching her.

-Cloud investigator

Cloud investigator.

These two letters were all that came out of Eutenia's mouth.

It seemed like the man's name was Rick.

Was it because Eutenia spoke to him?

The man who approached Eutenia also stopped and raised a speech bubble over his head

-You are

-You

-You

The two who faced each other began to talk

Did they know each other from before?

I watched them talk smoothly

It was also fun to watch the interaction between characters like this

But there was no way to know exactly what Rick and Eutenia were talking about

It felt like deciphering some kind of code

-Village

-Yes

Sometimes there were conversations that I could understand along the way

The word that the man just said was one of them

Yes

These two letters were something I could clearly understand

“Oh, I can understand that.”

Of course, I couldn't understand anything else

Whoever came up with the idea, cutting the dialogue into two letters because the level was low was not a good idea

I sighed and continued to watch their conversation

Eutenia and Rick exchanged a few more words after that.

The conversation that had been going on was ended by the man raising his sword towards Euteneia.

I wondered what the point of talking was, when it all came down to fighting.

Of course, fighting was the essence of a game.

The moment of battle that I had been waiting for had arrived.

“The prey has walked into my trap.”

I was done watching the interaction.

Now it was time to turn the character in front of me into karma.

Tap.

I lightly touched the man who was aiming his sword at me.

It was a plan to deal 1 damage and observe his reaction.

And at that moment.

I witnessed an unexpected sight.

-No way.

Clang!

The man swung his sword and blocked my touch.

A 0 damage appeared above his head, who had defended against the attack.

He had completely nullified the attack with his sword.

I couldn't help but be surprised by the man who had blocked my touch attack without any damage.

“What? He blocked it?”

Tock.

I moved my finger and tried another touch attack.

Of course, the man's reaction was not much different from before.

Clang!

His sword swung again and a 0 damage appeared above his head.

It was a proof that his defense was not a coincidence.

“Wow, what is this. Is he a boss monster or an elite monster?”

There are some games that have monsters with unique patterns.

Elite monsters. Or boss monsters.

They show different patterns from normal monsters, and force different strategies to defeat them.

And the male character in front of me seemed to belong to that category.

“So basic attacks don't work on him.”

I didn't expect him to block my basic attack.

It was natural to be surprised by an unexpected pattern.

But if he was a game monster, there had to be a way to break him down.

I decided to use the <Lightning> skill that I had bought with expensive money.

Squeeze.

I overlapped the target area of the <Lightning> skill completely over the moving character.

-You used <Lightning>.

Zap!

The screen flashed and lightning struck down on the man.

The man, who faced the falling lightning, bent his body and took a defensive stance.

It was impossible to block the lightning with a sword.

The lightning that fell from the sky pierced through the man's defense.

-Argh!

The man screamed as he was hit by <Lightning>.

A 9 damage appeared above his head.

It was a low number compared to the usual 15 damage that I dealt.

It meant that I needed more mana than when hunting other characters.

But considering that he was an elite monster, the fact that I could attack him at all was important.

“You're dead now.”

I started to spam the <Lightning> skill.

Zap! Zap! Zap!

The pleasant sound of lightning rang out from the speaker one after another.

It had been two days since Rick, a third-class investigator of Cloud, left to find the traces of the evil god.

During that time, Rick had wandered around several villages looking for clues, but he had only been disappointed every time.

He couldn't find any signs of the evil god around the villages.

That's why he ended up at a village that faced the entrance of a mountain range after a long time of thinking.

But something happened when Rick tried to leave the village and enter the mountain range.

The horse that he rode into the mountain path suddenly threw Rick off and tried to run away.

Rick barely calmed down the horse and tied it up in the village, but he couldn't move with it anymore.

He had no choice but to leave the horse behind and move alone.

"The atmosphere around here is not good."

Rick felt goosebumps as he felt the eerie aura around him as he entered the mountain path.

There was something in the mountain range.

Something that could not be measured by human eyes.

Rick walked forward without letting go of his guard.

He felt cold sweat running down his back with every step he took.

After about ten minutes of wandering around the mountain path,

Someone's figure came into Rick's sight as he was on alert.

'There's someone here.'

Rick's eyes scanned over the person standing in front of a cave.

It was a nameless girl with ash-colored hair fluttering in the wind.

Click.

Rick's hand tightened around his sword.

She looked too clean to be living in the mountains.

She seemed suspicious no matter how he looked at her.

'Is she a priestess of the evil god?'

The book in her hand also looked unusual.

There was no reason to carry such a thick book around while visiting the mountains.

And the thickness and appearance of the book looked like a scripture or a magic book.

A mage.

Or a priestess.

Either way, it was a profession that raised enough suspicion.

"I'll find out if I check it myself."

Risking his life was the duty of an investigator.

To confirm the identity of the other party, he had to face them at least once.

Swoosh.

Rick drew his sword and started to move towards the girl.

Chapter 10: Awe and Fear (6)

< 10 : Awe and Fear (6) >

Rick drew his sword and started moving towards the girl.

He didn't want to surprise her, so he didn't bother to hide his footsteps.

The sound of Rick's steps echoed through the bushes, and the girl, who was staring at the sky, turned her eyes to him.

The distance that seemed to be hundreds of steps was quickly shortened.

Rick arrived in front of the girl with swift steps and stopped a few paces away from her.

"...A Cloud investigator?"

The girl said as she scanned Rick once.

She recognized his identity by looking at his uniform.

Her eyes alternated between his neat uniform and the sword in his hand.

He was wearing a Cloud uniform and holding a sword.

It wasn't hard to guess what Rick was thinking.

"Are you living here?"

"That doesn't seem like something you would be interested in."

The girl's eyes showed wariness at Rick's question.

It was a suspicious reaction.

She was wary of him, a Cloud investigator.

Rick intuitively realized that the girl in front of him was hiding something.

“If you didn’t do anything to the nearby village, it would be better for you to cooperate with the investigation.”

“What happened to the village?”

“Yeah. Several villagers disappeared without a trace.”

She couldn’t help but be surprised by the news that the whole village had disappeared.

The girl showed a puzzled look at Rick’s words.

She looked innocent, as if she had nothing to do with it.

But she was a person who lived alone in the dangerous mountains.

She didn’t seem to be starving, judging by the baguettes in the cave.

She was too well-fed for someone who lived in the mountains.

Rick didn’t relax his tension towards the girl.

“The whole village disappeared, that’s amazing.”

“You’re quite calm about it. But miss, where did you get those breads behind you?”

“Those breads? Oh, you mean the grace.”

“Grace...?”

“It’s the meal that the great one gave me.”

The great one. And grace.

Both were words that could be misunderstood.

Rick was sure that the girl in front of him was a priestess of someone.

She wasn't from the holy land, judging by her clothes and word choice.

And even if she was a high priestess of the holy land, receiving bread was something strange.

It was more likely that she had a connection with an evil god.

“Who is this great one?”

“How can a mere human call his name?”

“...Is there any possibility that he took away the villagers?”

The last question was half-joking.

Of course, Rick didn't expect a meaningful answer either.

But the girl in front of him was more peculiar than he thought.

She answered Rick's question with an affectionate face.

“I don't know either. But if he did take them away, they would be going back to where they belong. Wouldn't they be happy then?”

“She's completely crazy.”

“You should be careful with your words. You might get punished by heaven.”

The girl in front of him was not normal.

The moment he realized that fact, Rick pointed his sword at her.

There was no point in questioning her further.

She was clearly a person who served an evil god.

If he didn't execute her here and now, there might be more damage in the future.

"So it seems that this great one of yours took away the people."

"What are you doing?"

The girl asked as she saw the sword aimed at her.

She still pretended to be innocent.

Rick felt nauseous at her sight.

She was a girl who lived alone in the mountains where all kinds of beasts appeared frequently.

She was obviously not an ordinary being.

Even if she wore a human disguise, her essence as a priestess of an evil god did not change.

"What am I doing? You swallowed up so many people with your evil god and you have the nerve to ask me that."

"...I see."

"I see?"

"I think this world would be better off without people like you."

She said with cold eyes.

As soon as her words ended,

Rick felt a huge pressure from the sky.

He couldn't see it.

But he could sense it.

Something beyond his perception was targeting him and moving.

It aimed for his head.

Rick reflexively raised his sword to protect his head.

Clang!

A heavy vibration ran through his hand that blocked the attack.

He had fended off a sudden attack, but he couldn't help being shocked.

“...!”

He couldn't see its shape or form.

But he felt a crushing force on his body that had a definite presence.

The girl in front of him had done something.

He sensed that and rushed towards her.

“I won't let you do anything else!”

He closed the gap between them with light steps.

Five steps.

Four steps.

——And three steps.

As Rick was about to swing his sword at the rapidly closing distance, he felt the pressure again and lifted his sword.

Clang!

With a heavy impact on his sword, Rick reflexively stepped back a few steps.

“I told you. You’ll be punished by heaven if you’re rude.”

The girl, who hugged the book, smiled and looked at him.

She was watching him after doing something.

Ugh.

Rick clenched his teeth at the sight of the relaxed girl and fixed his posture.

He would only lose the advantage if he let the enemy take the initiative.

Rick readied himself and ran towards the girl again.

If only it wasn’t for the enormous amount of magic that started to gather above his head.

‘An attack magic is coming.’

It looked like a simple magic of the lower realm.

But the amount of magic gathered for the magic was extraordinary.

It was too late to get out of the range of the magic.

He had no choice but to defend himself.

Rick pulled up his whole body’s magic and prepared to withstand the attack.

Boom!

With a thunderous roar, a powerful lightning bolt pierced through Rick’s body.

Rick screamed in agony as if his guts were burning.

It was this powerful even though he reduced the impact by pulling up his magic.

If he took a few more hits, his life would be in danger.

Rick suppressed the pain that came from his whole body and analyzed the situation.

The enemy could pour out magic from a distance.

If he kept his distance, he would have to endure the enemy's attacks one-sidedly.

He had to close the gap between him and the girl somehow.

‘Rick Swail. Pull yourself together.’

Rick encouraged himself and got ready again.

He would be attacked if he stayed still.

He had to break through the enemy's long-range attacks to get close to her.

A simple charge would be easily blocked.

Rick devised a strategy to deal with the priestess of an evil god and ran forward with his sword in his hand.

“Huff...”

Tap tap tap—.

His body moved forward with light movements.

Even as Rick showed irregular movements, the magic that poured out at him did not stop.

Boom! Boom!

With successive thunderous noises, lightning bolts fell on the places where Rick had passed by.

The threatening lightning bolts were meaningless if they didn't hit him.

Rick wrapped his body with magic and charged at the girl.

“Die now—!”

His sword swung at the girl who was close in an instant.

The girl who held the magic book was not prepared for any response.

Rick did not doubt that his strike would cut her down.

Until he saw her lips move before him.

“...Barrier.”

Crack!

The sharp sword strike grazed the surface of the barrier and passed by.

A large crack appeared on the surface of the barrier where the magic-filled sword had brushed by.

He was momentarily confused by the sudden appearance of the barrier.

But he quickly regained his posture and swung his sword again.

He thought he could destroy the barrier in front of him with one more swing of his sword.

If it wasn't for the lightning bolt that fell on his head from above.

“Kuh... Kuh...”

Boom!

Rick's body twitched as it was hit by the lightning bolt from the sky.

Rick tried to block the next attack by pulling up his magic after being hit by the lightning bolt.

But the evil god who watched him did not allow it.

Boom! Boom!

Several more lightning bolts fell on Rick's head with his sword in hand.

Rick's body convulsed as he was hit by consecutive lightning bolts.

"Kuk... Kuh..."

Thud.

His sword fell from his hand and dug into the ground.

Rick collapsed on the spot with his eyes rolled back.

But the wrath of the evil god that was directed at him did not spare him even when he was down.

Boom! Boom!

Lightning bolts rained down from the dry sky without pause.

Rick's consciousness faded as he felt his body being pounded by lightning bolts.

As his consciousness scattered, Rick looked up at the girl in front of him.

She was filled with awe in her eyes.

Cloud. Centrius branch.

Hus Allemier, a second-class investigator, looked at the paper in front of him with a troubled expression.

He had left for an investigation to find traces of an evil god, saying that he was a third-class investigator, Rick.

It had been ten days since then.

But Rick, who had left for an investigation, had not returned to the branch yet.

If he had not found any traces near the village, he would have come back to ask for help from Hus, but what came back was not Rick but a single report.

“Rick Swail...”

Hus read the contents of the paper in front of him again.

Rick Swail.

Missing.

His horse was found in a nearby village.

A Cloud investigator who missed the regular reporting deadline, and even left his horse behind and disappeared.

Something must have happened to him.

He recalled his junior who had disappeared and clenched the report in his hand.

“Evil god... evil god.”

Without leaving any traces, the villagers of four villages had disappeared altogether.

It was hard to believe when he first heard the report from Rick.

What kind of thing could make people disappear without any traces?

He thought Rick had not done a thorough investigation.

But now, even Rick, the investigator who had reported it, was gone without a trace.

“...”

There was something here.

He sensed that and bit his lip.

A being that could erase people without a trace.

And a being that could wipe out a whole village without a sound.

Such a being was staying nearby.

“I need to consult with the holy land.”

Hus took out a piece of paper and dipped his dry pen in ink.

Swoosh.

He spread the paper neatly and started writing a letter on it.

The enemy was not an ordinary criminal, but a different kind of being.

And to deal with an evil god, he needed an expert who matched him.

Chapter 11: Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost (1)

< 11 : Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost (1) >

-You have reached level 5.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.4)> has grown.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.5)> has been achieved. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

Several days have passed since I hunted the elite monster.

About ten days in game time, I guess.

During that time, I had been hunting steadily and finally reached level 5.

Level 5.

It was a low number for a game level, but it took longer than I expected to achieve it.

Maybe it was because the karma requirement increased as the level went up, and also because the villagers who were converted to karma did not respawn in the village.

Unlike other games, there was no clear space that could be called a hunting ground.

I had to explore new areas in order to hunt.

At this point, I wondered what part of this game was idle-type.

-“Thank you.”

However, level 5 showed more drastic changes than before.

First of all, <Eye of the Observer> evolved and started to display rough dialogue contents.

Now I could understand most of what Eutenia was saying.

A whole five letters of dialogue were fully displayed.

Compared to the crude speech bubbles with two letters that used to appear, it was a huge improvement.

“She’s more polite than I thought.”

Considering how she used to say things like “Bread. Thanks.” all the time, her personality now seemed completely opposite to what I had seen before.

Apparently, Eutenia was a courteous character.

It made me feel bad for mistaking her as rude because of the low-level <Eye of the Observer>.

It was not like I gave her a lot of bread, though.

I left Eutenia alone as she thanked me for the bread, and scrolled down the message tab to check the next message.

-Warning: Excessively biased karma in one direction may trigger <Causality Adjustment>.

-<Karma’s Nickname> has tilted.

-<Karma’s Nickname: Offering> has been activated.

-From now on, you can obtain karma or items through offerings directed at you.

Next, there was a change in the skill <Karma's Nickname>.

The warning about <Causality Adjustment> was the same as before, but this time there was one more thing added.

A skill called <Karma's Nickname: Offering> appeared.

Offering usually refers to a ritual of presenting offerings to transcendent beings like gods.

It seemed that I could receive offerings from other characters since this skill was activated.

Of course, the only being who could offer me anything right now was Eutenia.

“Offering, huh. The only thing I can think of is the magic book.”

The only item that came to my mind was the [Magic Book: Barrier] that I had given to Eutenia.

Even that was something that I could only get back if I could communicate with her at least minimally.

I decided to skip over the offering part for now.

I moved the scroll to find the next message.

As I scrolled down, a new skill with a name I had never seen before greeted me.

-You have acquired <Apostle Selection (Lv.1)> skill.

-You can select an apostle by spending 200 karma points.

-The karma requirement for <Apostle Selection> will double every time you select an apostle.

The name of the new skill was <Apostle Selection>.

It looked like a skill for interacting with characters just by its name.

According to the description of <Apostle Selection>, I could designate one character as my apostle.

Apostle.

It usually means someone who acts on behalf of God's will.

Then, if I made Eutenia my apostle, would I be able to convey my will to her completely?

I wanted to test the skill on Eutenia right away.

“It's a bit annoying that it costs 200 karma points, though.”

Karma was needed to raise the player's level, but the accumulated karma did not decrease and remained as it was.

It did not seem like my level would go down if I used up the accumulated karma points either.

It was a resource that had no use anyway, and there was no point in saving it up either.

After thinking for a while, I decided to try using <Apostle Selection> skill anyway.

Click.

I clicked on the skill icon of <Apostle Selection>, and a target marker appeared that allowed me to select a target.

I overlapped the target marker on Eutenia's head and used the skill.

-Do you want to select [Eutenia Hyrost] as your apostle?

-You need 200 karma points to select an apostle.

-Yes / No

When I used the skill, a message popped up asking me if I wanted to register Eutenia as my apostle.

My answer was obviously 'Yes'.

I clicked 'Yes' on the new window, and the screen flickered for a moment as Eutenia looked up at the sky.

A large question mark was floating above her head as she looked at the sky.

-You have selected [Eutenia Highlost] as your apostle.

-You have spent 200 karma points to create a new divine tool for your apostle.

-[Divine Tool: Grimoire] has been bound to [Eutenia Hyrost].

-[First Apostle: Eutenia Highlost] has become your apostle.

-Due to the effect of <Apostle Selection>, you will share your mana with the selected apostles.

-Due to the effect of <Apostle Selection>, you will be able to send separate messages to the selected apostles.

Several messages appeared one after another as the skill was used.

The contents of the messages were all unfamiliar to me.

I used karma points.

I created a new divine tool.

Most of the messages were about that.

As the parade of new messages passed by, the last one was an explanation of the additional effects of <Apostle Selection> skill.

I would share my mana with the character who became my apostle, and I would be able to send messages to them.

As if to prove that, a small chat icon appeared above Eutenia's head.

“Does this mean I can talk to her if I press this?”

The chat icon only appeared above Eutenia's head, who became my apostle.

I could easily guess that I needed to use this button to talk to my apostle.

It was amazing that I could communicate with an AI character who was only observable before.

The more I thought about it, the more I felt curious.

I clicked on the chat icon above her head to talk to Eutenia.

Beep.

And a warning message popped up on my screen when I clicked on the chat icon.

-You need a divine tool as a medium.

It said that I lacked a divine tool as a medium.

If I scrolled up, I could see a message saying that I had created a new divine tool.

And below that, there was another message saying that the divine tool was bound to her.

I couldn't help but scratch my chin as I saw the message about needing a divine tool.

“Could it be in the inventory?”

There was one place that I could think of.

If I had acquired a new item by using the skill, the item would probably be in the inventory.

I opened the inventory with a slight hope and checked it out.

Sure enough, there was an item that I had acquired in the inventory.

The name of the item in the inventory was [Divine Tool: Grimoire].

It was an item that gave the wearer a trait called <Shadow Touch>.

“True to its name, it's really unfriendly.”

No matter how I thought about it, this game was very unfriendly.

It was so unfriendly that it would probably rank in the top 10 of unfriendly games.

I gave a bitter laugh and dragged [Divine Tool: Grimoire] in front of Eutenia.

Thud.

The newly made item fell at Eutenia's feet.

A dark cave with human warmth left behind.

There, Eutenia sighed and tore off a piece of baguette.

Her worried eyes looked at the magic book lying at the entrance of the cave.

After Cloud's investigator fell, Eutenia had one thing to worry about.

She had been surviving thanks to the kindness of the great being who cherished her.

But she couldn't rely on the help of a transcendent being forever.

"Sigh... This magic won't be much help to you."

She looked at the magic book in her hand as she sighed.

A magic book containing barrier magic.

It was something that the great being who watched over her had given her.

She didn't know his name.

She hadn't even seen his face.

Yet she could easily guess that he wanted her to learn this magic.

And his action did help her.

The day Cloud's investigator came looking for her.

He pointed his sword at her without any reason, and barrier magic protected her from his attack.

If she hadn't learned barrier magic, she would have surely lost her life to his attack.

"What can I do to help you?"

Eutenia's eyes, lost in thought, looked at the sky outside the cave.

She had lost her family and her neighbors.

Now she had only one thing left.

If she lost that last thing too, she wouldn't have the confidence to live on anymore.

For Eutenia, who had lost everything, the existence of the great being who watched over her was special.

Even if he was a devil, she had no way out of his shadow now.

Of course, she didn't think that he was a devil who had been taking care of her so far.

-“Eutenia Hyrost.”

-“Accept your fate.”

As if answering her wish, a voice reached Eutenia's ears as she looked at the sky.

Her heart started beating wildly at the voice that came to her.

She wanted to see his face.

She wanted to hear his voice.

She had thought such arrogant things hundreds of times before.

Yet she couldn't hear his voice until now.

This moment was very touching for Eutenia.

“Ah... You were watching over me after all.”

Eutenia's body was wrapped in light as she spoke with emotion.

A warm white glow that enveloped her whole body.

Eutenia felt like she was embraced by someone in the bright light.

From within the dazzling light, another voice came to her ears.

-“Become my apostle.”

-“Revere me. Worship me. Offer me.”

-“Sing a hymn of life.”

Apostle.

The moment she heard that glorious name, Eutenia felt an overflowing mana in her body.

A new connection with a great being was formed.

And through that connection, infinite mana flowed into Eutenia’s body.

First Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost.

That was the new name given to her.

Chapter 12: Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost (2)

< 12 : Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost (2) >

Eutenia Hyrost, the First Apostle.

That was the new name given to her.

“So that’s how it is. I, for you...”

Eutenia closed her eyes and smiled as she accepted her new destiny.

A tremendous amount of magic flowed into Eutenia from the transcendent being.

It was incomparable to the tiny amount of magic that an individual could possess.

An overwhelming power that surpassed cognition.

Eutenia felt awe as she faced it.

She felt an immense sense of omnipotence just by receiving this power.

Then how great was the being who bestowed this power to her?

“If I have this power, I can surely be of help to you.”

Nevertheless, she hoped to be useful for the plan of her lord.

That was the only guidepost left for her now.

Thud.

A book fell in front of Eutenia, who was cherishing her faith in her chest.

She looked down at her feet at the sound that came from right in front of her.

“A book...?”

Eutenia picked up the book with a black cover that was placed in front of her.

The book in Eutenia’s hand was tied with a thin chain along with a fancy decoration.

The book was surprisingly light despite its thick appearance.

Clank.

Eutenia unlocked the chain and turned the cover.

The first page revealed unfamiliar letters that she had never seen before.

She couldn’t read them, but she could understand them.

The book that Eutenia had contained contradictory contents.

“Grimoire. Is this the name of this book?”

Mystery, Grimoire.

It was a book that contained the will of the great being she served.

Eutenia realized the true name of this book and at the same time, she sensed that this was an item made for her.

The size.

The touch.

The texture when it touched her hand.

All of them were for Eutenia.

Even the ability inside it.

“Shadow Touch. You have such an ability.”

If one was the true owner, they would recognize its value by touching it.

Eutenia, who held the Grimoire, was no exception.

Eutenia stroked the Grimoire and drew out the power that was sleeping inside it.

Shadow Touch.

The ability of the Grimoire to convert the poured magic into physical force was activated.

Numerous hands stretched out from her shadow and began to tear apart everything around them.

“...”

Crack.

One of the trees nearby snapped in half in an instant.

Bang!

The place where the shadow’s touch passed was torn apart.

Every time Eutenia lowered her hand toward the air, the hands that stretched out from her shadow exerted physical force.

The terrain changed according to Eutenia’s command.

The enormous power that she merely borrowed made this possible for her.

Eutenia's eyes sparkled with intoxication from the overwhelming power.

“Ah, really...”

It was truly a beautiful grace.

She thought so as a voice rang in her ears again.

A majestic voice that echoed heavily in her ears.

It was the same voice that had called her to be an apostle just before.

-“Apostle. Offer a sacrifice.”

“A sacrifice...?”

Eutenia looked up at the sky again at the voice calling her.

A sacrifice.

The only thing she had now was her flesh that barely survived on baguettes.

There was nothing valuable enough to offer as a sacrifice for Eutenia, who was stuck in the mountains.

As she looked at the sky with curiosity, another message flowed into her ears this time.

-“I will take back the magic I gave you before.”

“Oh... You want me to return the magic book.”

-“Offer a sacrifice. Give me a proof of your oath.”

Nodding

She nodded and put down the Grimoire on the ground.

Then she reached out for the magic book nearby.

The magic book with barrier magic written on it.

It was something she had received from the great being not long ago.

“I owe you a lot for this.”

Eutenia’s hand brushed over the cover of the magic book.

It was just something she had borrowed from her lord.

She had to return it to him someday.

As she tried to return the magic book, Eutenia’s gaze turned to the Grimoire.

She faced another problem as she tried to return it.

“How do I offer this as a sacrifice?”

She knew what offering meant.

But she didn’t know how to perform a sacrificial ritual for her lord.

The one who helped her with this curiosity was the Grimoire given to her.

A hand rose from Eutenia’s shadow and grabbed the Grimoire, then turned a page and opened it.

What was spread out in front of her was the content of the sacrificial ritual.

The necessary preparations and the suitable place.

And the spell needed for the ritual.

Eutenia’s eyes scanned the content of the Grimoire in front of her.

“This is really a helpful item.”

It gave her great power when she needed it.

It gave her knowledge when she needed it.

It was truly an item worthy of an apostle who followed the great being.

Eutenia skimmed through the content of the Grimoire and got up from her seat.

Then she moved the hands of her shadow to draw a picture on the ground.

“——Life. Build a staircase.”

The ground was torn apart and various geometric patterns were drawn on the ground.

Circle.

Triangle.

Circle.

Square.

Around the shapes drawn in sequence, there were letters that could not be read by mouth.

They were words of endless praise for the great lord.

They were the only connection for those who longed for the unreachable sky.

“——One path leads to glory.”

Eutenia placed the magic book in the middle of the shapes drawn on the ground.

The magic book that was placed as a sacrifice absorbed light.

Eutenia continued to mutter spells as she placed the magic book.

The altar and the sacrifice.

And the spell.

Only when they became one, the sacrificial ritual was completed.

“——One path leads to death.”

Thump. Thump.

Eutenia stepped back after placing the sacrifice.

The Grimoire that was floating around her also retreated.

A powerful magic swept over the huge altar where Eutenia and the Grimoire were.

“——Revere. Adore. Sacrifice.”

——Sing the hymn of life.

When Eutenia’s spell ended.

The light that rose from the center of the altar subsided.

The magic book that she had placed in the middle of the altar also disappeared completely.

Eutenia scanned the altar where the magic book had disappeared.

The magic book that had occupied the place was really offered to the god, as if it had vanished without a trace.

“Is this what sacrifice means?”

She gave something to the great being with her own hands.

Even though it wasn’t originally hers, it was a strange feeling.

Her cheeks flushed as she looked at the altar where the sacrifice was over.

She felt a little excited after the sacrifice was over.

Eutenia smiled and hugged the Grimoire to her chest.

“I feel good.”

Holy Land, Crossbridge.

This place, which was overflowing with all kinds of pilgrims every day, was full of priests who served six temples.

The priests of Crossbridge recognized the existence of other gods, but they did not acknowledge their worship.

Serving any god other than the six gods was heresy to them.

Other than the great six gods, there were only evil gods and false gods.

That was the only way and truth allowed for the priests of Crossbridge.

And moving to investigate those who denied that simple truth were the elite forces of the Holy Land, called heresy inquisitors.

“A letter from Hus.”

Evan Allemier.

He was a heresy inquisitor who muttered as he looked at the letter sent to him.

The sender of the letter was Hus Allemier of the Empire.

Evan’s brother and at the same time a second-class investigator of Cloud.

Evan tore open the seal and began to check the contents of the letter he received from his brother.

“Hmm...”

The content he received from his brother was not a simple greeting or something like that.

The disappearance of an investigator who was chasing an evil god's existence.

The villagers who suddenly hid their faces.

Evan's face hardened as his eyes went down to the letter.

When his gaze reached the last line of the letter.

Evan had no choice but to sigh as he put down the letter.

“...An evil god. You're thinking dangerously.”

Evil god.

Among other gods than the six gods, it was a term that referred to those who deceived people and caused chaos.

The acts of evil gods were mostly harmful to humans.

Indiscriminate destruction.

Human sacrifice.

Sorcery that made people into sacrifices.

None of them fit with order and justice.

Yet they couldn't be easily stopped because they were inherently beyond human beings.

“There’s no hero yet.”

Where there is darkness, there is light.

The existence of evil gods that threatened the peace of the continent inevitably brought forth the emergence of heroes.

But no temple had received a divine providence for the appearance of a hero yet.

Either the existence of evil gods itself was false, or it wasn’t at a level that threatened the continent.

Any decent heresy inquisitor would have sneered and passed by this content.

Evan would have ignored the content of the letter if it wasn’t for Hus who sent it.

‘But I guess I should go and see for myself. There’s a possibility that it’s heresy.’

But he couldn’t ignore a letter from his brother so easily.

The fact that Hus asked him for help meant that something needed help had happened.

Evan opened a drawer and took out a sheet of paper.

He then began to write down his documents for going out diligently.

It was preparation to go to his brother in the empire.

Chapter 13: Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost (3)

< 13 : Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost (3) >

The skill that made Eutenia an apostle, <Apostle Selection>.

The effect of this skill was more profound than I thought.

First of all, it allowed me to create a divine artifact that belonged to the apostle by consuming karma.

I didn't know if the name or shape of the divine artifact was always the same, but it was certain that its effect was extraordinary.

The name of the divine artifact that I gave to Eutenia was [Divine Artifact: Grimoire].

[Divine Artifact: Grimoire] granted its owner a trait called <Shadow Touch>.

Eutenia, who used <Shadow Touch>, could exert physical force within a certain radius by consuming mana.

It was a trait that seemed much more effective than any ordinary skill.

I didn't know why I didn't get such a high-end trait, though.

“It doesn't consume much mana either. I don't need to set any limits.”

The second trait that the apostle had was direct mana sharing with the player.

It meant that I could substitute the mana that Eutenia used with my own mana.

I could also set a limit on how much mana I shared with the apostle.

But for now, I didn't think I would have to limit Eutenia's mana usage.

The biggest reason was that my mana had increased greatly through leveling up so far.

I could now use the <Lightning> skill recklessly.

Thanks to the increased mana, I didn't lack mana much.

And the amount of mana that Eutenia used for <Shadow Touch> was not too burdensome either.

Unless I added another apostle, there was no reason to set a limit on Eutenia's mana sharing for now.

“And the last one is, of course, this game's crazy communication feature.”

The last feature added by <Apostle Selection>.

It was a chat button that enabled conversation with the apostle.

A chat button. Simply put, it was an item that looked like a feature that allowed communication.

But this item was also much more profound than it appeared.

The message I sent was not delivered as it was.

‘Give me back the barrier.’

The message I sent to Eutenia just before was only six letters long.

Give me back the barrier. It was a simple request to return the barrier spellbook that I had given her.

I'm sure I sent it like that.

But just like the speech bubble that distorted Eutenia's words, this game didn't deliver my message kindly.

No, rather, it exaggerated my words to a level close to translation.

-“Apostle. Offer your sacrifice.”

-“Sacrifice...?”

It doesn't match my message by even one letter.

Where in this is my message?

But the message didn't care about my complaint and started a conversation with Eutenia on its own.

-“I want to take back the magic I gave you before.”

-“Oh... do you want the spellbook?”

-“Offer your sacrifice. Give me the proof of your oath.”

The meaning itself was consistent with what I sent.

But the tone and atmosphere itself looked like a solemn imitation of a god.

Maybe the tone is adjusted to be similar to that of the creator.

If not, maybe I should at least have some mood.

As a result, my intention was accurately conveyed though.

“Here's the spellbook.”

Ding.

I received the spellbook back from Eutenia and opened my inventory and used it right away.

It was a spellbook that I used after a long time since I got it through drawing an item.

-You have learned <Barrier(Lv.MAX)>.

-You can now use barrier magic by consuming mana.

I learned <Barrier> skill by using the returned spellbook.

Of course, since it was a skill that didn't help with hunting, I wouldn't use it much in front of me.

At best, it would be something I would use reluctantly when Eutenia was in danger.

Well, even then, I wouldn't use it often because Eutenia learned magic too.

“It was really a long care.”

I fed and clothed Eutenia while using items for her for several days.

She was finally able to communicate with me now.

In some sense, it was also time to harvest the reward for taking care of her all this time.

Why was this game an idle game?

It was an idle game because it was a game where growth was possible with minimal effort.

I grew my character so much with my effort, so now it's time to reap the harvest.

“Now you have to pay for your food.”

Squeak.

I opened the chat button on Eutenia's head and activated the chat window.

And I started to write a message to Eutenia.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

The message I wrote was simple.

Move a little now.

Go out and do some activities in the surrounding area.

That way, I can drop lightning bolts randomly.

She understood what I meant perfectly and smiled happily.

-“Is that so? I can finally be of help to you.”

-“If that's the will of the great one, I'll follow you anytime.”

Was it because the graphics evolved from before?

When I looked at Eutenia quietly, her smiling face felt quite cute.

I seemed to have grown fond of the character after raising her for a long time.

I grew fond of a character.

I felt like my wallet would be in danger for a while.

A village in the outskirts of the Central region.

There, Peter looked up at the sky with a pitchfork in his hand.

He was a young man who was born and raised in this village, and followed his parents' path as a farmer.

He had dreamed of being a soldier when he was young, but he had given up on that dream by now.

Being a soldier was enough for him to play the role of a self-defense force member in the village.

The most precious thing to him was this village.

He woke up in the morning, worked hard on farming, cooled his sweat with the blowing wind, and smiled at the ears of grain fluttering in the wind.

That was the greatest happiness for Peter the farmer.

He was a person who naturally suited farming.

"It's dark today. Maybe it will rain tonight."

He finished his work and looked up at the sky, murmuring to himself.

Dark clouds were slowly covering the blue sky.

It would take some time for it to rain, but he felt like it would rain tonight or tomorrow.

Since it might rain, he thought he should prepare as much as possible before it rained.

"...Huh?"

As he was about to clean up, he saw someone walking towards him from afar.

Thud. Thud.

He saw one person approaching the village with small steps.

She was wearing a white tunic, holding a large book in her arms.

“...”

Her ash-gray hair fluttering in the wind was quite alien to Peter.

She was not a villager, but a stranger for sure.

The girl who held the book in her arms was more beautiful than Emily, who was called the most beautiful girl in the village.

No, rather than being beautiful, she looked dignified.

Could she be a noble lady who came to visit the village?

The girl who was coming to him now had an appearance that made him think so.

“Hey, what... she’s really coming here?”

As the girl approached him, Peter lightly brushed his bangs.

He also dusted off the dirt on his clothes from farming.

He couldn’t show a dirty appearance in front of a guest anyway.

After Peter hurriedly fixed his appearance, the girl who had been walking from afar finally stopped in front of him.

Her eyes, which looked like they were out of this world, scanned Peter from top to bottom.

The book she held in her arms looked very expensive.

She looked at Peter once and opened her mouth.

“Hello?”

“Huh? Oh, oh! Yes...!”

Peter answered her with a clumsy tone at her soft voice.

He couldn't answer properly because he was flustered.

Ugh.

He sighed at his pathetic appearance.

But she didn't care about that, and stroked the book in her arms and asked him.

“Are there many people living in this village?”

“People...? Oh, there are about forty people living in our village!”

“Forty people. That's a bit disappointing.”

She nodded her head at Peter's answer and said.

Forty people is disappointing, what does that mean?

Peter didn't understand what she meant.

But he didn't bother to ask her about it.

It bothered him that she came alone, but she was most likely a noble lady who lost her way, right?

The book she had alone would be hard to get even if he sold the whole village.

“There's another question I want to ask you. Is there a place where many people live nearby?”

“A place where many people live? West! There's a city to the west!”

“A city... A city must have a lot of people.”

“Yes, yes. That's right.”

She seemed satisfied when she heard that there was a city.

Peter didn't know why she was satisfied, but he thought it was good that the noble lady liked it.

It wouldn't be good to be disliked by a noble anyway.

It was a rational choice that Peter made according to his own judgment.

Tap. Tap.

She gently tapped the book with her slender fingertips and opened her mouth again to Peter.

“You're very kind. Can you tell me your name?”

“My name is Peter.”

“Then Peter, can you call the villagers for me?”

“...Huh?”

Peter tilted his head at her request to gather the villagers.

It was fine to answer her questions, but why did she ask him to gather the villagers?

His question was only for a moment.

He turned his head at the strange sound coming from behind his shoulder.

Snap.

The pitchfork in Peter's hand was broken in half.

And the rest of the broken pitchfork was held by a hand that stretched out from the girl's shadow.

Peter's eyes widened in horror and looked at the girl.

“The great one wants me to make a decision.”

She still smiled and looked at Peter.

Her hand stroked the cover of the book again.

Seeing that, Peter realized that something was terribly wrong.

What he saw in front of him was not a lost noble girl.

Chapter 14: Apostle, Euthenia Hyroste (4)

< 14 : Apostle, Euthenia Hyroste (4) >

It had been two hours since the girl of unknown origin entered the village.

And Peter, who had been watching her, had his eyes filled with horror.

Two hours.

It was not enough time for a single person to destroy a whole village.

Yet the girl who came to the village alone made it possible.

The reason was simple.

She was a monster who had transcended the category of human.

“Ah, ah...”

Blood.

The thick smell of blood tickled Peter’s nose.

He covered his mouth with his hand as the smell of blood pierced his nose.

He felt a headache from the screams that reached his ears.

The village that Peter saw was the opposite of what it had been before, full of peace.

Thud. Splash.

Thin raindrops began to wet the ground filled with screams.

But there was no sign of the human screams fading away.

Too many lives had been lost in this place.

“It looks like it’s almost over. You don’t have to worry too much.”

The girl said with a casual look as she looked at Peter.

The thick book that she was holding was wide open, caught by the shadows.

The people who ran away to survive were also dragged back to the center of the village by the shadows’ hands.

The village that Peter saw was hell.

Hell on earth.

A place where no one was allowed to survive, a place that should not exist.

“Why, why are you doing this...?”

Peter, who had been looking around, asked with a trembling voice.

The line between life and death was decided in an instant.

It was just a difference in answer.

Peter agreed with the girl’s words without knowing anything, and the rest refused without accepting them.

And hell unfolded.

It was all incomprehensible to Peter.

The girl coming to the village, and the village becoming like this, everything.

The girl answered with a smile that looked purer than anyone else in the world when she heard Peter's question.

"Because the great one wishes for it."

"What...?"

"To take back what one has created with one's own hands. What's wrong with that process?"

To take back what one has created with one's own hands.

It was a crazy idea that would make anyone lose their mind.

She treated people's lives lightly for such a reason alone.

Peter could not understand that.

The god he thought of was not such a being.

He did not even want to believe that such a being was the god who created him.

Peter pointed at the girl in front of him with his finger and shouted.

"Cr, crazy...! You're crazy!"

"Do you think so?"

"..."

"But if it's for him alone, maybe it's not so bad to be crazy."

Clack. Clack.

The girl's footsteps headed toward the center of the village.

There were all kinds of words and pictures made by the shadows' hands decorating there.

He could not read them.

He could not even understand them.

Yet it seemed certain that the girl in front of him was trying to do something.

Something insane that no sane human would ever attempt.

“_____.”

The girl stood in front of the altar made of pictures and raised her hand.

Crash!

The pages of the thick book turned, and red letters rose above the opened page.

The girl gently touched the bookshelf with her fingertips and took a breath.

Hoo.

A soft breath and a sweet voice.

What came out of the girl's mouth was a ritual spell for a transcendent being.

“——Life. Build a staircase.”

A beautiful voice echoed like reciting a poem.

But its content was the opposite of that.

It disregarded the value of life that looked up at the sky, and forced a meaningless death for the sake of a great being.

Yet it only praised the god who judged them endlessly.

“——One way leads to glory.”

“——One way leads to death.”

The girl's footsteps circled around the altar of death where no glory could be seen.

Every time she took a step forward, the piled up lives were wrapped in holy light.

The girl in front of him was a being beyond human.

And what she prayed for was a being who was even more distant than that, sitting in a faraway place.

Peter felt coldness in his body as he looked at the altar made by the girl.

“——Revere. Adore. Sacrifice.”

He shivered.

His flesh felt cold from watching the ritual.

But he could not take his eyes off from the altar full of malice.

A short but meaningful prayer was about to end.

The girl returned to her original place to finish it.

And the last prayer flowed out of her mouth.

“——Sing the hymn of life.”

The moment the ritual ended with the girl's prayer.

Peter saw a huge eye in the sky covered with dark clouds.

The eye of something incomprehensible and unfathomable.

The giant eye looked at Peter, and the girl in front of him, and finally at the altar where the offerings were placed.

And then a strong light flashed.

When the light that had taken over Peter's sight faded away, there was nothing left in the middle of the altar.

Not even a trace that a person had existed there.

The sacrifice was over.

“Ah...”

An exclamation came out of Peter's mouth involuntarily.

The other was a being of a different level from a mere human.

There was no point in resisting, and his fate was decided by just facing him.

It did not matter much whether he had seen the spectacle or not.

Anyone would feel awe at the sight of such a being.

Peter stared blankly at the altar where the villagers had disappeared, and the girl who had finished the ritual came to him with the book in her arms.

“How do you feel about seeing the eye of the great one?”

She still had a smile that looked innocent.

Peter clenched his fist as he faced the girl.

He realized that he was not sane anymore after watching the ritual.

He was soaked in fear.

He was trembling from facing a being that he was not even allowed to see, let alone glimpse its trace.

“What...”

“What?”

“You, you... what are you!”

Peter, who was sweating coldly, asked for her identity.

The girl’s eyes were filled with interest when she heard Peter’s question.

Tock. Tock.

She tapped the cover of the book she was holding and opened her mouth.

“Hmm, are you asking about this?”

“...Yes.”

A question about her identity.

The girl’s answer was simple.

“Apostle, Euthenia Hyroste.”

A hand of shadow stretched out from the darkness and stopped in front of Peter.

Thud.

The dark fingers pressed down on Peter’s forehead.

But the shadow’s touch did not completely crush Peter.

The hand that had played a cruel prank returned to Euthenia’s shadow.

“I am the first servant who serves the great one.”

“What? Why are there so many coming in?”

The smartphone screen that showed Euthenia’s appearance.

I had been watching her conversation from the moment she entered the village until now.

Even when Euthenia started hunting characters, I thought she was just doing automatic hunting for me instead of me.

But I couldn’t help but be surprised when I saw the message that popped up right after the sacrifice ended.

I received a huge amount of karma from the sacrifice that Euthenia performed.

-[Apostle: Euthenia Hyroste] has performed a sacrifice for you.

-The offerings dedicated to you: 43

-The effect of <Karma’s Blessing: Sacrifice> is activated.

-Karma increased by 86 according to the number of sacrificed offerings.

The number of characters that Euthenia sacrificed for me was 43.

I heard the number of villagers from Peter, and it was also written in the system message, so there was no doubt.

But the amount of karma I gained was a whopping 86.

Even if I compared it to the karma I got when I hunted by myself, it was twice as much.

Hunting the same number of characters gave me twice as much karma.

It was an absurd rate that anyone could see.

“Does hunting by character give twice as much? Wow...”

I got twice as much experience as I moved when Euthenia sacrificed an offering.

It was either because of the effect attached to <Karma's Blessing>, or because Euthenia was my apostle.

I don't know yet.

But one thing for sure was that it was definitely more efficient than me hunting by myself.

If I keep collecting karma and increasing the number of apostles, the speed of leveling up will increase accordingly.

Maybe depending on the case, even characters who are not apostles can be sacrificed.

I was drawing a hopeful training plan in my head, and Euthenia looked at the sky and said after finishing the ritual.

-“I tried my best in my own way, but I don't know if you liked it.”

Did you like the experience?

That was a foolish question.

Who wouldn't be happy to get twice as much experience?

Euthenia was a precious partner for me right now.

I took out a baguette from my inventory and threw it to Euthenia.

“Good job. Euthenia. You're the character I chose.”

It was only natural to reward her for sacrificing an offering.

The baguette I gave to Euthenia was an expression of gratitude.

Euthenia bowed her head and bit into the bread.

She still seemed to like bread well enough.

But I couldn't end it with such a reward for a character who gave me 86 karma points.

I thought of stroking Euthenia's head and brought my finger close to the screen.

Swoosh!

As my finger brushed over her head, a scream came out of the speech bubble from Euthenia.

-“Eek.”

Thud!

Euthenia fell to the ground after receiving my stroke.

Apparently, my touch hurt more than I thought.

I felt embarrassed watching her, so I quickly turned off my smartphone screen.

I felt like hiding somewhere for a while.

Chapter 15: Black Magician (1)

< 15 : Black Magician (1) >

Cloud. The branch of Centurion.

Hus Allemier, a second-class investigator of Cloud, looked at the man in front of him with a complicated expression.

The name of the man opposite him was Evan Allemier.

He was a heretic interrogator from the only holy land on the continent, Crossbridge, and he was also Hus's brother.

Evan, who faced Hus, observed his younger brother while savoring the tea in front of him.

Hus opened his mouth first, feeling uncomfortable with Evan's gaze that kept looking at him.

“Brother, you didn't have to come here in person...”

Hus had sent a letter asking for help, but it was only a request for advice.

He thought that even if he got more help, at best one of Evan's subordinates would come down.

But Hus's expectation was shattered and Evan himself came here from the holy land.

He even used his vacation to meet him.

It was a very burdensome thing for Hus, who faced Evan.

Evan looked at Hus like that and said with an expression as if nothing had happened.

“I thought it would be nice to make time to meet my brother after a long time.”

“I see. It would be very reassuring if you helped me personally.”

Of course, it was only burdensome for Hus, but the heretic interrogator of Crossbridge was a very reliable existence.

Heretic interrogator. They were close to elites even in the holy land.

They moved in small numbers to collect information on heretics, and sometimes they executed them on the spot.

As they performed their missions with a small number of people, the power of the heretic interrogators was all strong.

Hus, who had learned magic in his own way, had no confidence in holding out against Evan for long.

“By the way, nothing has changed. Are you still staying as a second-class investigator in this backwater?”

“Brother, that’s...”

“Hus. I believe you wouldn’t say that you like this rural area.”

Nevertheless, Hus was awkward with Evan because he had often encountered Evan’s personality.

The Centurion region was located on the outskirts of the empire.

It was a place that suited the word rural.

Staying in the Centurion branch like this was also a very dissatisfying thing for Hus himself.

But Hus himself was stuck here even after the friction with the branch chief.

Due to various complicated problems, promotion did not seem easy for the time being.

It was not pleasant to show his appearance to his brother Evan as it was.

“I think I’ll go up when the time comes.”

“Hus.”

“Yes, brother.”

“You are a member of the proud Allemier family.”

“...”

“Don’t forget that it is our duty to raise the name of the family.”

Hus felt his lost eye twitching as he heard Evan’s words.

Allemier family.

He had lived not to tarnish the name of the family until now.

He worked hard to catch up with Evan’s back that always went ahead.

But no matter how hard he ran forward, he couldn’t see any signs of catching up with Evan’s back.

And now he had to listen to his brother’s shameful scolding.

Hoo. A sigh flowed out of Hus’s mouth as he faced Evan.

“It’s all my fault.”

“Is that so?”

“Please stop telling me embarrassing stories and let’s talk about work now.”

The scent of tea leaves spread softly from the teapot on the middle of the table.

Evan moistened his lips with the teacup he held and savored the scent spreading in his mouth and nodded his head.

Tuk.

The teacup held by Evan returned to the table.

He then smiled and began to get to the point.

The reason why Evan came all the way to this remote place.

It was about the traces of evil gods found somewhere here.

“Then let me hear about work. What exactly happened?”

“The residents of four villages nearby disappeared in an instant. That too without any trace.”

People disappeared.

Evan frowned as he heard that.

There were many reasons to doubt what Hus thought too.

They ran away as a group because they didn’t want to pay taxes.

Or thieves came and kidnapped them.

Rick, a third-class investigator who disappeared before, believed that too until then.

“It doesn’t seem like you’re trying to say that they simply ran away or were attacked by bandits.”

“There was no blood or corpse left in the village. It’s strange if there was a fight.”

“There were no traces of escape either, so you suspect it’s the work of an evil god?”

Maybe it was because they had already exchanged the contents by letter once.

Evan quickly grasped what Hus wanted to say.

The residents hid their appearance without a trace.

This was not unprecedented in the history of the empire.

At the time when the evil gods appeared and the heroes were active, those who were sacrificed to the evil gods by the wicked magicians did so.

Those who were dedicated to God disappeared without leaving any trace.

The blood and sweat they shed, even their clothes, disappeared without a trace.

“As you said, brother, I suspect the existence of the evil god cult now.”

“Is this all you have to say, or...”

“Rick Swail. One of my subordinates also disappeared after going out to find traces of the evil god.”

“Did he disappear without a trace like the others?”

“Yes. Only the horse he rode was left behind.”

People who disappear without a trace.

And an investigator who disappeared while chasing that trace.

If these circumstances were gathered, there was enough room for doubt.

Hus looked at Evan in front of him and asked to fit the last piece.

“Do you think there is a possibility, brother?”

“It’s definitely suspicious.”

“Then...”

“I’ll see for myself and report it to the holy land. Let’s start by searching around where you suspect first.”

There is a possibility that the evil god cult is active.

As Evan’s words of affirmation fell, Hus swallowed his saliva with a heavy feeling.

He was the one who drove out his subordinate who talked about the possibility.

It was practically no different from Hus himself pushing him to death.

And now his death became an opportunity for the heretic interrogator from the holy land to move to find traces.

Rick Swail.

Hus sent a short word of regret to his subordinate who had disappeared now.

A crossroad in the Centurion region.

Eutania sat in the back seat of the carriage that rattled along, holding a book and slowly looking around.

Unlike the mountain village where she used to live, there was a road here that was maintained for carriages.

It was because there was only one carriage in the village.

Considering the story that there was a large city nearby, it seemed to be a crossroad leading to the city.

Eutania, who was enjoying the scenery with her head resting on the book, turned her head to the driver's seat and opened her mouth.

“You're surprisingly good at driving a carriage.”

“...I learned a little over my shoulder.”

The one who sat in the driver's seat and held the reins was Peter.

He drove the carriage forward with a dark face, holding the reins tightly.

Peter, who survived by Eutania's mercy, had no choice but to drive the carriage to the city.

It was because the distance from the village to the city was quite far.

In addition to Eutania, there were a lot of foodstuffs piled up in the back seat of the carriage he was driving.

Eutania had brought the foodstuffs that had been stockpiled in the village.

Every time he saw Eutania and the foodstuffs in the back seat, a heavy burden piled up in Peter's heart.

If he wanted to, he wanted to throw everything away and run away right now.

“Do you resent me?”

“...”

“I also had a time when I resented someone.”

Swoosh.

Eutania touched her ash-colored hair while saying that.

Her hair, which she touched with her hand, was much damaged unlike before.

It had been a long time since she lost her home and ran away from the world.

The young lady of the count who used to act spoiled to her parents had long disappeared beyond the world.

Even if she wanted to go back to those days, there was no one left who knew how to go back.

The only thing left in this place now was herself, who claimed to be an apostle of God.

“Why did you... do that...”

“I resented the whole world. Because all the people I loved disappeared.”

“...Is that why you want to pay them back?”

Revenge on the hateful world.

Peter asked if that was Eutania’s thought, but Eutania shook her head firmly.

She just stroked the book and told her motive.

“I don’t mean that. It’s just that there was someone who reached out to me back then, so I decided to live for him.”

Heeheeheehee!

The conversation was interrupted by Peter pulling on the reins.

Peter stopped the carriage and looked at the crossroad where the carriage had been passing by.

A cut tree was placed in the middle of the crossroad, blocking the advance of the carriage.

And behind the tree that blocked the carriage.

There were men of various colors armed there.

“Damn... are they bandits!”

They were bandits who blocked the road.

The man who drew his sword at the front met Peter’s eyes.

The bandit leader who met Peter smiled slyly.

He licked his sword with his tongue and opened his mouth.

“I was hungry, but it worked out well.”

Chapter 16: Black Magician (2)

< 16 : Black Magician (2) >

“I was hungry, so this is perfect.”

“What do you want...!”

Peter shouted at the leader, then glanced at Eutenia.

She was Eutenia, who had wiped out a whole village by herself.

Peter was curious how Eutenia would deal with the thieves.

She just smiled slightly at Peter’s look.

He had no choice but to face the leader of the thieves again.

“I want everything.”

“...What?”

“Give me everything you have! I’ll sell you as slaves, and use the food in the carriage for myself.”

The leader’s attitude was more hardline than they expected.

He didn’t even offer to let them go if they dropped their belongings.

He claimed that the food was theirs, and that they would capture the people and sell them as slaves.

Peter sighed at the hopeless exchange.

He turned his head completely and looked at Eutenia, who was smiling.

Eutenia was still holding a book in her arms with a calm expression.

“It doesn’t look like they’re going to let us go. What should we do?”

Peter asked Eutenia in a troubled voice.

There were more than ten thieves blocking the road.

Peter couldn’t drive them away by himself.

It was natural for him to ask for Eutenia’s help.

Swish.

Eutenia stroked the cover of the book with her slender fingers and spoke to Peter.

“Don’t you think it would be nice to talk a little more?”

“They are thieves.”

“Have you ever thought that they might be reformed?”

“...If they were like that, they wouldn’t be talking about slaves.”

It was a common sense answer.

Eutenia nodded reluctantly as Peter continued to look troubled.

She got up from the back of the carriage with the book in her arms.

The hem of her tunic fluttered slightly in the mountain breeze.

“It looks like you’re in trouble. I’ll help you a little.”

Eutenia’s gaze turned to the thieves who were blocking the road.

They were still looking at the carriage with contempt.

They had the advantage in numbers.

They didn't feel threatened by a naive-looking young man and a girl holding a book.

It wasn't a bad judgment in a normal situation.

The only problem was that Eutenia, who was in front of them, was far from ordinary.

"Hello, everyone."

"Hahaha...! This time, a pretty lady came out instead of a coward."

"My name is Eutenia Hyrost. I'm an apostle who serves the great one."

"Apostle? What the hell is that?"

The leader asked with a sour face when he heard the title of apostle.

Apostle of God.

It was not a concept that was used in the six temples of Crossbridge.

They officially recognized only the saintess and the saint king, and did not acknowledge any other apostles below them.

The leader of the thieves, who lived on the outskirts, had no idea what an apostle was, since it didn't exist in the six temples that were most popular.

Eutenia kindly answered his question.

"An apostle is someone who serves the great one closest to him."

"What! You're talking complicatedly, but you're just a cleric!"

"Are you not interested in serving the great one?"

Eutenia tried to persuade them to join her faith when she faced the thieves.

But the thieves just snorted and even made obscene gestures at her.

One of the thieves behind the leader shouted at Eutenia with an angry voice.

“Hmph, I’ve hated those who sell God since I was young. If there was a God, I wouldn’t be like this!”

“Is that so?”

Thud. Thud thud thud.

As soon as Eutenia finished speaking, a strange sound echoed from behind the leader.

It sounded like something that was locked together was twisted apart.

The leader slowly turned his head toward where the sound came from.

When his head turned completely, he saw something and screamed.

“Aaah...!”

“Boss? What’s wrong!”

“Jack is dead!”

What he saw was his colleague’s body twisted in a grotesque direction.

He opened his mouth wide and looked at Eutenia at the sight of the horrible tragedy that happened in an instant.

There was only one person who could be suspected as the culprit in this place.

Eutenia was still smiling with a book in her arms, without caring about what happened in front of her eyes.

The leader shouted at Eutenia with her calm expression.

“Did you do this?”

“It’s unfortunate. If you had served him, you wouldn’t have ended up like this.”

“She’s a magician! Kill her now!”

The leader was the first to act in the ominous situation.

He raised his sword and aimed at Eutenia, ordering her to be killed.

The most threatening thing in a battle was a magician.

So he wanted to eliminate Eutenia first.

But even though the leader ordered it, the thieves who were waiting didn’t move.

He turned his head again and checked behind him.

“What are you doing...”

“Aaah!”

“Bo, boss... help me!”

“Aaaaaah...!”

Hands stretched out from the shadows on the ground and poured out toward the thieves.

Someone who was caught by the shadows screamed, and someone who faced the shadows ran away.

The result of those who were caught by the shadows was mostly the same.

Thud. Thud thud thud.

They died with their bodies twisted by the shadows' grip, accompanied by a chilling sound.

The leader bit his lip at the flood of shadows that burst out.

“Damn, crazy...!”

He was not an exception to the attack of the shadows, just because he was the leader of the thieves.

The hands that came out of the ground aimed at him and poured out.

He swung his sword desperately.

Clang! Clang!

The jaws that were aiming at him bounced off with a heavy sound.

But that wasn't all of the shadows that were after him.

He couldn't stop the wave of shadows that kept pouring out.

“Ugh...!”

“Repent of your sins and return to his side.”

Eutenia's gentle voice rang out.

The leader tried to resist by fending off the shadows, but there was a limit to the number of hands he could handle.

The hands that started to reach out from beyond the shadows.

The leader's hand that was fending off the shadows lost its strength, and he dropped the sword he was holding at some point.

Thud.

The leader's sword rolled on the ground as it lost its power.

The shadow's hands that reached out in an instant restrained the leader's arms and legs.

“Wa, wait!”

“...?”

“Just wait a minute!”

The hands from all directions reached out to the leader who was restrained.

He shouted at Eutenia in a desperate voice as he saw the hand that was aiming for his head.

It was his last attempt to ask her to stop the attack for a moment.

Eutenia looked at him with a cold gaze, as he suddenly made a ridiculous claim.

“What is it?”

“We have a black magician among our comrades who didn't come here!”

“Black magician...?”

“If you kill me, he won't leave you alone!”

The words that came out of his mouth were a threat to Eutenia.

It was something that most people wouldn't care about.

But Eutenia stopped the shadow's hands that were moving toward him.

She wasn't afraid of his threat.

She was just interested in one word that came out of his mouth.

“A magician... That sounds interesting.”

Black magician.

Eutenia recalled all the shadow's hands when she heard that word.

The shadow's hands that had filled the air disappeared in an instant.

The thieves who were restrained by the shadows became free.

Only three of them survived out of more than ten thieves.

It was a miserable sight for those who had been so arrogant to Eutenia.

“Huuk, hoo...”

The leader breathed roughly as he checked the number of surviving thieves, including himself.

Cold sweat ran down his forehead as he felt relieved.

The other thieves also felt relieved.

They picked up their weapons that had fallen and looked at Eutenia, who was counting the dead thieves.

They wondered why Eutenia suddenly let them go.

It was just a threat from some thieves who did nothing but steal.

The black magician he mentioned was probably not a great magician either.

Peter couldn't understand why Eutenia spared them.

“Why did you do that?”

“I wanted to see the magician.”

“Excuse me...?”

Peter looked at her with a blank expression as he heard her answer.

She didn't stop the shadows because she was afraid of the thieves' threat.

She stopped the attack because she simply wanted to see the magician.

Ever since she received a magic book from her master, Eutenia had been interested in magic.

The magic books and theories that the black magician would have.

And the power of magic that other magicians used.

She thought this was a great opportunity to see various kinds of magic.

Tap. Tap.

Eutenia's footsteps approached the leader who was sitting in the middle of the mountain road.

His body flinched every time she got closer to him.

When she reached him, Eutenia looked down at him and asked.

"You said there was a magician, right?"

"Ye, yeah! One of our comrades is a terrible black magician! He even sacrifices people!"

The leader still tried to exaggerate the black magician's power.

But those things didn't matter much to Eutenia.

She smiled kindly at him with a book in her arms and matched his eye level.

Then she asked him in a soft voice.

"Then will you guide me to him?"

Chapter 17: Black Mage (3)

< 17 : Black Mage (3) >

Roan Hebris.

He was a black mage who had reached his mid-forties this year.

He realized early on that he had no talent for magic and switched to black magic, but that did not mean he had outstanding achievements in black magic.

To succeed in black magic, one needed effort above all.

The effort to capture innocent people and use them as sacrifices for magic.

That was the nature of black magic.

And Roan was not the kind of person who could execute such effort aggressively.

He ended up being trapped in mediocre skills, and kept spinning in the same place.

He occasionally joined a band of thieves to get prisoners for his sacrifices, but that was the only thing that changed.

Roan's own skills were always stuck in the past glory.

“It would be nice if I could offer all these guys as sacrifices.”

Roan muttered as he put the prepared ingredients into the boiling cauldron.

Roan's eyes were filled with boredom as he looked at the cauldron.

He was getting tired of making potions.

He knew that without even the minimum research, he would regress, but he wanted to give up what he was doing now.

But the thieves who were with him would not let him go.

The potions that Roan produced were one of the main sources of income for the band of thieves, along with the slaves.

Living a life of being praised was not bad, but sometimes he wanted to escape.

That was human nature.

Tsk tsk.

Roan clicked his tongue and dropped a clump of hair cut from the slaves into the cauldron.

“If I had continued to learn magic, I might have been teaching magic in some rural village.”

Although his achievements would be less than black magic, being a mage was still a respectable profession.

Especially if it was a rural area that seemed to have nothing to do with magic.

He might have missed the opportunity to be regarded as a quirky mage in some rural village, and be called a sage.

As Roan thought so, he heard a voice ringing outside his tent.

It was a familiar voice to Roan's ears.

It was none other than the voice of the thief who was guarding his tent.

“Master!”

“What is it? I told you not to bother me when I’m making potions.”

Roan said with an annoyed expression as he heard the thief’s voice.

If any impurities got in, the effect of the potion would go wrong.

That’s why Roan had told him several times not to bother him when he was making potions.

But the thief ignored his voice and flapped the entrance of the tent and rushed in.

The thief breathed heavily and looked at Roan.

At the same time, a leaf carried by the wind gently landed on top of the cauldron.

An impurity got mixed into the potion he was making.

Roan frowned as he watched it all.

“Master! You’re here!”

“Didn’t I tell you not to come in! You’ve contaminated the potion!”

Roan yelled at the thief who came in abruptly.

There was an order to everything, no matter how urgent it was.

The thief shook his head with a desperate expression, ignoring Roan’s scream.

Huff.

He took a breath and said in a trembling voice to him.

“It’s a big trouble!”

“What kind of trouble is it that you did this? Did the band of thieves get wiped out or something?”

“The boss has been taken hostage.”

“Wha, what...?”

Roan opened his mouth wide at the thief’s words.

It was definitely a big trouble indeed.

The leader of the band of thieves had been taken hostage.

Where in the world was such an absurd story?

Moreover, if someone could take hostage of the thieves, it meant that some kind of expedition force had come.

If he was caught by an expedition force, Roan, who was a black mage, would surely be executed.

He felt nervous about the situation that was going wrong and asked the thief.

“How many people came for the expedition?”

“Expedition force, you say?”

“Yes! Expedition force!”

“I didn’t see any expedition force, only two people came.”

“...?”

Roan looked at the thief with an incomprehensible expression.

But the thief’s face looked more serious than ever.

Two people.

Only two people had defeated and captured the band of thieves and taken their leader hostage.

That was even more serious than an expedition force coming in.

“Who are they? Did they look like knights or something?”

“A man wearing shabby clothes and a woman holding a book!”

“A book...?”

“It seems like a mage has come! Please defeat the enemy mage with your powerful black magic, Master!”

The more Roan heard from the thief, the more perplexed he became.

A mage who had wiped out a band of thieves in an instant.

And there were only two of them.

Could Roan win against such beings?

Roan thought not.

He had devoted decades to magic, but he was not much stronger than others.

The best option was to run away if possible.

“A mage...”

“We don’t have time! Master! Master, use your strong black magic to punish the enemy!”

“No, I...”

“Master! Hurry!”

But he had no courage to run away, leaving behind the thief who looked at him with a fervent expression.

A mage's assets were his magic books and research materials.

Even if he was a black mage, his essence did not change.

If he left everything here and ran away, everything that Roan had built up for decades would be gone.

Hoo.

Roan sighed and passed by the thief.

As he walked out of the tent, he saw the leader who was being held hostage as he had been told.

“Oh, Roan...! Save me!”

The leader called out Roan's name and asked for his salvation as soon as he faced him.

Roan looked at the leader who was captured, and the unwelcome guests standing behind him.

A young man with a naive impression.

And behind him, a girl holding a thick book.

A deep magic was swirling from the book that the girl was holding.

It was a priceless treasure that he could guess its value just by looking at it.

“Are you the mage who lives here?”

Roan and the girl's eyes met in the air.

The girl asked Roan about his identity with an innocent expression.

But Roan was not swayed by the girl's innocent expression.

The person in front of him was a mage.

And not just any mage, but a mage with a tremendous power that he could not even guess.

He could not take her lightly.

“Yes. I am Roan Hebris, the black mage. And who are you?”

“My identity, you say?”

“Isn't it fair to answer one question if you asked one?”

“I guess so.”

“Then tell me who you are.”

Gulp. Roan swallowed his saliva and watched the opponent's movements with a wary eye.

At Roan's request, Eutenia walked forward with light steps.

Eutenia stopped right next to the leader who was tied up.

She stopped at a slight distance from Roan and opened her mouth in a gentle voice.

“I am Eutenia Hyrost, an apostle of the great one. An apostle who serves him.”

“Apostle...”

“Was it a strange story for you?”

“No. I feel like I understand a little bit now.”

An apostle of God.

He did not know exactly what kind of god he was, but he knew that facing an apostle of God was not a good thing.

A person who walks the path of black magic must understand all kinds of rituals.

Offering to an evil god was no exception.

He offered sacrifices and received power worthy of them.

That was the basic content of black magic.

Seeing Eutenia, who called herself an apostle, Roan realized that he had to make a quick decision.

“I see. I’m glad it helped.”

“This is all I have to do.”

“You’re going to use magic, aren’t you?”

Crackle.

Sparks flew from Roan’s hand as he pulled up his magic.

He made an arrow of lightning and shot it at the target.

The arrow flew like a ray of light and collided with the target in an instant.

“Lightning Arrow!”

“Craaack...!”

The arrow that Roan threw pierced through the leader of the band of thieves who was next to Eutenia.

The leader’s body flashed and he started to foam at the mouth and convulse.

Roan attacked not Eutenia but the leader of the band of thieves.

The leader who was hit by the unexpected attack screamed and fainted.

Eutenia watched him and stroked the cover of her book. She said to Roan:

“That’s interesting.”

“I knew it from the moment I saw you.”

“Is that so?”

“Please take me as your disciple.”

Plop.

Roan knelt down and buried his head on the ground.

This was the only conclusion he could make.

The enormous aura that moved from behind Eutenia in the shadows.

Roan knew from the moment he faced it that he could not beat her.

He had no outstanding talent for magic, but he had a natural eye for judging the level of others.

She was an apostle of an evil god.

She was connected to the being she served by some kind of bond, and used a near-infinite amount of magic.

She was literally an ideal being that mages dreamed of.

How dare he fight against such a being?

It was no different from a foolish moth jumping into a fire.

Eutenia tilted her head at Roan’s request.

“That’s too bad. I can’t take you as a disciple.”

“...Yes?”

“I recruit believers, but I don’t accept disciples.”

“Then please take me as a believer! I will serve the great one!”

Eutenia smiled at Roan’s repeated bowing.

A hand stretched out from the shadows and stroked Roan’s head, who was lying down.

“Shall we? I’m sure he will be pleased.”

Chapter 18: Black Mage (4)

< 18 : Black Mage (4) >

“——Revere. Worship. Offer.”

In the hideout of the fallen thieves.

There, Eutenia performed the ritual of offering.

She drew complex patterns on the floor to make an altar, and gathered the ones who would be sacrificed in the center of it.

Around the altar, she wrote praises for the god in abundance.

Roan, who saw a proper ritual for the first time in his life, watched it with interest from beginning to end.

It was not an easy opportunity to witness a complete ritual of offering to the god.

Even from Roan's perspective, who had lived as a black mage for decades, this ritual was something he encountered for the first time.

“——Sing the hymn of life.”

As Eutenia's last prayer declared the end of the ritual, the sacrifices on the altar disappeared with a white light.

Roan, who was watching the ritual, clapped his hands without realizing it.

The great being revealed his grace and accepted the offerings that were dedicated to him.

It was an amazing sight that Roan faced for the first time in his life.

What miracle in the world could be more surprising than this?

It was only natural for Roan to utter admiration from his mouth.

“That was amazing, Apostle.”

“I’m a little embarrassed to receive applause.”

“Not at all. Just by witnessing this ritual, I feel full of thoughts that the great one is watching over me.”

“Is that so?”

“Of course.”

Peter, who also watched Eutenia’s ritual for the second time, had a trembling expression as well.

He glimpsed something that humans could not reach.

It was not something that he could get used to even after seeing it several times.

However, he looked uncomfortable towards Roan, who praised Eutenia’s ritual.

A black mage and an ordinary village youth.

There was an insurmountable difference in perception between them.

No matter how much time passed, Peter would never understand a black mage.

“Now that the ritual is over, I want to take a look at your laboratory.”

Eutenia hugged her book and looked around with a smile after finishing the ritual.

The number of people reflected in Eutenia's eyes was only six left.

Four of the surviving thieves followed Roan and converted.

They seemed to have surrendered to survive at first, but their eyes changed after the ritual.

If they received more education from Roan, they might become devout believers.

Of course, Roan, who would teach them, was showing more enthusiasm than anyone else in this place.

“Then shall we go and take a look?”

“Is that okay?”

“Of course. If it's you, Apostle, you can do anything.”

Roan, who used to be angry when thieves came in, was now more actively guiding Eutenia than anyone else.

If he had a tail, he might have wagged it vigorously.

Thump. Thump.

Eutenia followed Roan's footsteps towards the tent with a relaxed pace.

Peter also followed Eutenia to the tent.

When they entered the tent on one side of the hideout, there was Roan's laboratory filled with all kinds of magical tools.

“Is this your laboratory?”

“It's not much, but these are what I've collected over my lifetime.”

“There are interesting-looking cauldrons and glowing stones.”

“Oh, that thing is a luminescent stone. If a mage charges it once, it can be used for about 10 hours.”

Eutenia’s eyes filled with curiosity scanned the inside of the tent slowly.

There were all kinds of magical items in Roan’s tent.

A large cauldron placed in a corner.

Various animals preserved by magic.

Roan’s research records written in neat handwriting.

And a few magic books on one corner of the bookshelf.

It looked shabby but it was full of valuable items for an inexperienced mage.

Magical items were expensive things even if you tried to get them in the city.

“There are magic books here too.”

A hand stretched out from Eutenia’s shadow picked up a book on the corner of the bookshelf.

Roan flinched at the hand that met his shadow.

Eutenia ignored Roan’s reaction and turned the pages of the magic book she took out of the bookshelf.

Flip.

Her calm eyes began to scan the contents of the magic book.

The name of the magic described in the magic book was ‘Lightning Arrow’.

It was a magic that shaped lightning into arrows and shot them at enemies.

It was also the magic that Roan used against the boss when he first met Eutenia.

The image of lightning that he had encountered once flashed through Eutenia's mind as she opened the magic book.

As Eutenia began to read the magic book, Roan opened his mouth.

“Oh, that magic is...”

“Is it a magic called Lightning Arrow?”

“Yes. That's right.”

“It's interesting. He might like it too.”

The Lightning Arrow in Eutenia's hand was a low-level magic.

Nevertheless, Eutenia felt a lot of possibilities from the magic book in her hand.

The magic that her master used was different from the ordinary magic in terms of scale.

It was much harder to make complex magic bigger.

The precision of the formula required by the caster changed depending on the scale of the magic.

That's why high-level magic that applied effects to a wide range of areas required more complex and diverse changes.

But Eutenia realized that she didn't need such things.

Complex formulas were nothing but struggles to increase the range and reduce the consumption of mana.

Eutenia Hyrost. She was an anomalous being who received mana from the god like the sea.

Mana efficiency was something that Eutenia didn't need to value.

Eutenia's eyes sparkled as she read the magic book.

"Does he... have an interest in magic too?"

"I learned magic because it was his will."

"...I see."

"Can you give me some space for a moment? I feel like reading when I see the book."

A hand moved from Eutenia's shadow brought a chair to her.

Eutenia sat on the chair that the shadow brought and began to turn the pages calmly.

Roan, who declared that he would occupy the tent, looked at Peter with a questioning look.

But Peter just nodded his head at his gaze.

The two of them eventually left the tent with awkward expressions.

Inside the tent, Eutenia's time alone began.

There are moments in life when you have to deal with sudden and urgent problems.

For me, yesterday was one of those moments.

I had no time to even play the game because of the sudden rush of schedule.

Considering that I had logged in to the game almost every day since I started it, it was quite an unusual thing.

“Ugh...”

I grabbed my dull head and lifted my upper body, and the sunlight coming through the window met me.

Ten in the morning.

Or maybe eleven.

The sun was already close to the zenith.

I picked up the water cup that I had left on the bedside table and moistened my throat.

Gulp. Gulp.

The lukewarm water that had cooled down went down my esophagus.

My dry throat felt relieved.

“Ha... I feel alive now.”

I still felt a bit sluggish, but I felt like I had regained some consciousness.

I reached out and picked up the smartphone that was on my bedside.

It was to check if there were any messages last night.

As I operated the smartphone and checked the message window, the icon of the game that was on the main screen caught my eye.

Come to think of it, I couldn't play the game yesterday.

I didn't know what happened in the game while I was offline.

It wasn't a passive game since Eutenia started moving.

I clicked on the game icon and launched the game for the first time in a while as a mobile game.

“I wonder if anything happened last night.”

Lately, I left Eutenia alone and hunted on the opposite side of her route.

I was curious what Eutenia had done in the meantime.

I scrolled down and looked at the logs that came up during the day.

Was there a lot of things that Eutenia did last night?

Today’s message log was longer than I expected.

- [Apostle: Eutenia Hyrost] performed an offering for you.
- Offerings dedicated to you: 17
- The effect of <Karma’s Blessing: Offering> is activated.
- Your karma increased by 34 according to the number of offerings.

The first thing that came up was the message of offering sacrifices.

It seemed that Eutenia had offered more sacrifices.

Was it because she had the <Fanatic> trait?

She was very active in offering sacrifices.

Looking at this, I thought I had picked a good character.

“Huh? What’s this...”

And below that, there was an unexpected message.

I received a new magic book from Eutenia as an offering.

The name of the item I checked by opening the inventory was <Magic Book: Lightning Arrow>.

Judging from the fact that I didn’t remember getting a magic book from a draw, it was sure that it was an item offered by Eutenia.

You can also get a new magic book from an offering by an apostle.

It was an unexpected thing for me.

“You can get magic without drawing?”

You can get a magic book without a 10-draw.

My evaluation of this game changed a bit when I learned that fact.

It might not be such a pay-to-win game after all.

Of course, considering that I only got a magic book now, the probability itself didn't seem very high.

Squeeze.

I clicked on the inventory and clicked on the magic book.

It was to learn a new magic by using the magic book.

-You acquired <Lightning Arrow (Lv.MAX)>.

-You can now use Lightning Arrow magic by consuming mana.

The name of the new magic was <Lightning Arrow>.

Similar to <Lightning> magic that I used before, it was a magic that shot lightning at targets.

It was natural to test it when you got a new magic.

I threw magic at a nearby village to test it out.

Kwaaaaang!

A heavy streak of lightning struck down on the village, causing damage to a wide range of areas.

It looked more like a javelin than an arrow.

“Wow...”

Crackle. Crackle.

Tiny sparks flew around where the magic hit directly.

The damage that <Lightning Arrow> inflicted on enemies was 30.

It was twice as much as <Lightning>.

Chapter 19: Black Mage (5)

< 19 : Black Mage (5) >

-You used <Lightning Arrow>.

Along with the message announcing the skill's use, the characters within the skill's range were stunned.

It was a skill that dealt 30 damage and had a stun effect.

While it took three uses of <Lightning> to knock down a character, <Lightning Arrow> was enough with just two.

Moreover, <Lightning Arrow> was a skill that inflicted damage on a wide area.

It could clear out the characters faster than the <Lightning> skill.

I couldn't help but marvel at the power of the magic book I received from Eutania.

“Why is this AoE skill so strong?”

The damage and the range were completely superior to <Lightning>.

Of course, it consumed more mana than the skill I used before, but even considering that, it was an incredible performance.

It was a skill that wouldn't be strange to get from a 10-pull.

And I got this amazing skill for free.

It was a moment of gratitude for Eutania, who brought me an unexpected harvest.

“Ah, this is why I enjoy raising my character.”

Baguette. Sponge cake. Hard rye bread.

I fed Eutania various kinds of breads that I got from the store and raised her.

It was not long ago that she did that.

And she didn't forget the favor she received from me and brought me a magic book.

They say it's a dog-eat-dog world.

Even Eutania, who demanded things like she left behind a 7,000 won bread, didn't forget the kindness she received from her master.

I felt like giving her a gift as I watched her admirable appearance.

“First, I have to deal with these guys and then think about it.”

Of course, I had to finish off the characters left in the village first.

I kept using <Lightning Arrow> repeatedly.

Bang! Kwang! Kwaaaaang!

The vibrations that burst out of my smartphone one after another conveyed the atmosphere of the fierce battlefield.

Every time I threw a spear of lightning, the characters piled up in the village fell down.

It was an optimal skill for hunting the crowded characters.

-You used <Lightning Arrow>.

-You used <Lightning Arrow>.

-Your karma increased by 7.

.

.

.

-You used <Lightning Arrow>.

-Your karma increased by 5.

Many messages popped up and countless characters were converted into karma.

Crackle. Fizzle.

The electric shocks left on the ground also inflicted continuous damage on the nearby characters.

It wasn't enough to completely finish off the opponents, but it was still a merit to be able to deal dot damage.

How many more times did I throw <Lightning Arrow>?

I realized that there were no more characters left in the village and finally lifted my finger from the skill button.

“Phew... It's hot and nice.”

It was much more efficient than hitting one by one with <Lightning>.

The mana consumption increased by several times, but it was enough to handle one village.

I felt like I could enjoy the game comfortably for a while.

After finishing a satisfying hunt, I turned the screen and looked for Eutania.

I wanted to give her something in return for giving me such a wonderful gift.

“I received a gift... It would be nice to give her something back.”

I received an unexpected gift from Eutania.

It was a gift that made me feel good enough to forget about last night's fatigue.

It was worth enough money if compared to cash.

It would be nice to treat her well since she was a character I liked.

I moved the screen and found Eutania stuck somewhere in the mountains.

She was sitting in a tent, reading a book.

-“This magic is... amazing.”

The ash-haired character calmly turned each page.

Looking at the strange-looking tools around her, she seemed to be studying magic.

I opened my inventory and checked the items to find something that suited her.

“Nothing suitable in my inventory... Maybe I should try pulling some gacha.”

The only items left in my inventory were a few iron swords.

But I couldn't just give an iron sword to Eutania who was learning magic.

The only option left was gacha.

Just recently, my salary came into my bank account.

It wouldn't be bad to try some gacha for a change, so I touched the shop button on the top right corner of the screen.

-The <Paid Currency Shop> is currently under maintenance.

“Maybe you're used to being petted by now.”

And then I quickly turned my finger around and touched Eutania's head.

If I couldn't pull any gacha, the only thing I could give her was a pet.

Swoosh.

My swift touch brushed past Eutania's head.

She lifted her head and looked up at the sky.

- “Huh...?”

Thud.

Eutania fell to the ground after being petted.

Unfortunately, she still hadn't adapted to being petted.

I looked at the fallen Eutania for a moment, and then threw my smartphone on the bed after turning off the screen.

I wasn't feeling fresh in the morning.

Maybe I should go to the bathroom and take a shower.

“There are definitely... a lot of suspicious points.”

Evan Allemier.

The heretic inquisitor of the Holy Land, Crossbridge, opened his mouth as he scanned the empty village.

The village that came into Evan's sight was very quiet.

There were traces of dishes or laundry that people had used, but there was no sign of people anywhere in the village.

If they had been attacked, there would have been bloodstains, but all Evan saw were footprints and bizarre paintings.

Bizarre paintings.

Only a part of the half-erased painting was the only clue that caught Evan's eye in this place.

Hus, who was examining the pattern on the floor next to Evan, looked at his brother and asked.

“Do you know what this painting is, brother?”

“It's a pattern that hasn't been drawn for long. There's probably only one possibility left.”

“...”

“There's a pattern that looks like an altar, and ancient letters around it. I think this painting is...”

An altar for a ritual.

Even though Evan trailed off at the end, Hus didn't fail to understand what he meant.

There weren't many places that used ancient letters until now.

Only the six temples of Crossbridge or the magicians who explored the ancient ruins could handle them.

An altar that was shaped geometrically with ancient letters mixed in.

It was an altar made by the cultists who worshiped the evil gods for their trade with the evil gods.

The Holy Land had a history of fighting and inflicting great damage on the cult of the evil god in the past.

It was possible because of the sacrifice of the heroes and the activities of the paladins.

Whenever an evil god appeared to disturb the world, a chosen hero would inevitably follow.

Since the next hero hadn't appeared yet, it was a common opinion of the Holy Land that there was still time before the evil god's forces moved.

But what existed in front of Evan's eyes now was a genuine altar of an evil god.

The evil god was already exerting a secret influence on this world.

It meant something simple.

A hero will appear soon.

"An evil god, you say."

"Yes. I'm sure."

"All our guesses so far were true."

"I guess so. I found the signs of an evil god sooner than I thought."

Hus's face darkened as he heard Evan's words.

It was one thing to vaguely guess the content, and another to accept it as a fact.

The appearance of an evil god that threatened the continent.

It was a very heavy story for Hus, who sacrificed one of his subordinates to collect evidence.

“The appearance of an evil god means...”

“A hero will appear soon. The Holy Land will be busy for a while.”

When the shadow of an evil god loomed over this world, a hero would inevitably appear.

This was an unchanging law that never changed.

The gods of the six temples did not tolerate their rules being broken.

Even if the order was reversed a little, what had to happen would happen anyway.

Especially if the opponent was an evil god who transcended this world.

Now that he had found evidence of an evil god, it was time for Evan to report to the Holy Land.

Clank.

Evan adjusted his sword on his waist and grabbed the reins of his horse that he had tied nearby.

“Will you come back with me to headquarters? I’m going to bring my subordinates for extermination after reporting to the regional chief.”

“No. Let’s hold off for now.”

“Yes...?”

“We might provoke them and they might hide somewhere we can’t find them.”

“Do you not trust Cloud’s power, brother?”

Cloud was an executive agency responsible for the security of the empire.

Hus sent a dissatisfied look at Evan when he heard an opinion of distrust against Cloud in the territory of the empire.

But Evan shook his head and denied Hus’s words.

“That’s not it. I’m saying this could be an opportunity.”

“An opportunity? What do you mean?”

“The enemy hasn’t fully grown yet. If we prepare thoroughly, we might be able to exterminate them without much damage.”

They had succeeded in finding traces of a cult before divine guidance came down.

In some sense, it meant that the enemy’s forces hadn’t taken root properly yet.

An evil god’s cult that hadn’t fully grown yet.

If they were lucky, they might be able to cut them off at once.

Maybe they could succeed in exterminating the cult as soon as a hero appeared.

And for that, they needed thorough preparation.

Preparation so thorough that they didn’t even consider a second chance.

“Extermination will involve moving with the empire’s power. You’ll also participate in combat when the time comes.”

“Then... I’ll listen to your advice, brother.”

“That’s right. For now, just focus on watching the enemy’s movements. This is a request that I can only tell you, my brother.”

“If that’s what you want, brother.”

Evan finished the conversation and got on his horse and grabbed the reins.

Heeheeheehee!

Evan’s horse snorted loudly as it greeted its master.

There was a lot to do in the Holy Land now that he had found traces of an evil god.

He thought it would be hard to take a vacation for a while, and Evan signaled his horse.

Chapter 20: The Order (1)

< Chapter 20 : The Order (1) >

The bandit's hideout, located in a remote mountain road.

In that place, where not many people were left, Roan looked at the girl who was sitting across from him.

On the opposite side of Roan, there was a girl with ash-gray hair who was holding a thick book with a faint smile.

The girl's name was Eutenia Hyrost.

She was the Apostle of God who made Roan into a servant of the evil god, and also the person who called for this meeting today.

At Eutenia's request, the only ones who remained here were her and Roan, just two people.

Roan looked at Eutenia, who had woken up from her coma after a few days, with a wary gaze.

“What do you want to talk to me about?”

“I received a Divine Grace from the great one yesterday.”

“A Divine Grace came down. That's amazing.”

Eutenia's body trembled slightly as she mentioned the trust.

For some reason, her forehead was swollen red in the middle.

Maybe she had fallen on the floor last night.

That thought crossed Roan's mind for a moment.

But Roan quickly shook off the useless thought and waited for Eutenia's next words.

"The great one wants to entrust you with an important task."

"An important task...!"

"Yes. There is one important task that will be given to you from today."

"What kind of task is it?"

Roan felt his heart pounding as he heard Eutenia's words about an important mission.

The girl in front of him was an Apostle of God.

Her words were practically representing the will of the god she served.

The great being who was watching over them wanted to entrust him with something.

Gulp.

Roan listened carefully to the task that would be given to him.

Soon, along with Eutenia's gentle voice, the content of the task that Roan had to perform flowed out.

"Roan Hebris. You are an archbishop who serves the great one from today."

"An, archbishop?"

"Yes. You are in charge of conducting important rituals while serving the great one closely."

“How can I take such a position...”

Archbishop.

It was a position given to the highest clergyman who governed each region.

It was practically giving Roan full authority over this area.

Of course, this story did not come to Roan without any reason.

As far as Roan could see, there was no significant power in the order yet.

Eutenia added another word to Roan, who looked burdened.

“It’s not a position given without any conditions.”

“I understand that.”

“Instead, you have to faithfully expand the order’s power in this area.”

As expected, it was as Roan had expected.

She gave him a seat in a shocking position, but she wanted him to grow it into a power worthy of it.

She gave him a shell of an archbishop of an order that had nothing.

If it had been an ordinary situation, Roan would have refused this offer sharply.

But now, there was a miracle of God clearly in front of Roan’s eyes.

It was a miracle named Apostle.

As long as the Apostle with immense magic power was sitting right in front of him, there was no choice for Roan to refuse.

“You want me to expand the order’s power.”

“That’s right. You’re a smart person, Roan.”

“You flatter me.”

“And the next promised support is...”

“The next support is...?”

Smile.

Eutenia smiled and lifted up the book.

She got up from her seat with the heavy-looking artifact in her arms.

Eutenia got up from her seat, and Roan also got up from his seat following her.

Eutenia looked at Roan who got up from his seat and said,

“You’ll find out what the next support is when you try the ritual yourself.”

“Huh? What do you mean by that?”

“It’s exactly what I said. If you practice the ritual that you learned from me, you’ll surely get a response from the great one.”

Eutenia’s words ended there.

Click. Click.

Eutenia, who finished talking, walked out of the hideout leisurely.

Roan stared at the door of the building where Eutenia had left with blank eyes.

The last thing she said was something that Roan couldn’t understand either.

“A ritual...”

He needed a sacrifice to perform a ritual.

It seemed that he would need to prepare a sacrifice for the ritual after receiving Eutenia's teachings on it.

In other words, if he didn't have enough sacrifices, he would have to move himself.

Roan spread all his fingers and started to fold them one by one.

One. Two. Three.

Roan sighed as he recalled the number of slaves he had locked up in the prison.

"I guess I'll have to go out myself to fill the number."

A few days had passed since I received the gift from Eutenia.

Maybe it was because the busy time was over.

I was able to spend some leisure time on the long-awaited holiday.

Of course, even though I had more time than usual, it was only enough to spend a little more time on games.

The best friend of modern people is the smartphone, no matter what anyone says.

It has become a life partner.

It would be hard for anyone to dream of a life without a smartphone.

I was no exception to that fact.

"Did she send me another magic book today?"

As soon as I logged into the game, I clicked on the inventory with my fingers full of anticipation.

It was to check for any possible offerings.

Needless to say, the list of items in the inventory was not much different from before.

Nothing happened while I was away, like Eutenia sending me a magic book or something.

Click. Click.

I kept opening and closing the empty inventory, wondering if it was lagging.

But there was no such thing as an item appearing in the inventory.

“Well, that makes sense. There’s no way a magic book would come in every day.”

I wished Eutenia would send me a magic book every day, but unfortunately that seemed impossible.

Even I thought it was unreasonable.

A game where a magic book appears in the inventory every time you log in.

Who would pay for such a game?

At least it wouldn’t be a positive thing for the game’s payment model.

I looked at the shop button in the upper right corner of the screen with a sigh of regret.

“I hope it’s not still under maintenance.”

I glanced back and forth between the empty inventory and the shop button.

Last time, the <Paid Currency Shop> was under maintenance, but it seemed unlikely that it would still be under maintenance.

My salary had just been deposited into my account.

If I spun the 10-pull, I could fill my empty inventory with decent items.

Should I pull or wait?

After thinking for a while, I decided to touch the shop button.

Press.

The screen switched to the shop page, and a new message popped up at the bottom of the screen.

-<Paid Currency Shop (Lv.MAX + 1)> skill has been expanded.

-You have acquired <Paid Currency Shop (Lv.MAX + 2)> skill.

-You can now purchase items from the shop using paid currency.

The messages that came up one after another were unexpected.

The level of <Paid Currency Shop> skill had increased.

And it was called Lv.MAX + 2, an absurd level that I couldn't understand at all.

I couldn't help but exclaim at the sight of the evolved gacha shop.

“What? Why did this go up? I haven't even leveled up yet!”

The shop level grew on its own without even leveling up.

And what was more shocking was that the price of the 10-pull, which had been 69,900 won, had gone up again.

10 pulls for 79,900 won.

It was almost 80,000 won.

It was a much more burdensome amount than before.

Huh.

A bitter laugh escaped my mouth as I looked at the price that had risen before I knew it.

“Really... It’s a legendary game in many ways.”

The shop evolves on its own without the player’s consent.

And even before evolution, the previous shop was not even selectable.

What game could offer such a beautiful payment structure?

Before I knew it, my eyes were drawn to an item that was emitting a brilliant light among the items that came out of the gacha shop.

[Devil Sword: Ednos].

It was an item that emitted a purple halo from its background.

Chapter 21: The Order (2)

< 21 : The Order (2) >

It was an effect I had never seen before.

None of the items that had appeared so far had such an effect.

Even the magic books did not have any effect.

A special effect that did not show up when I acquired the magic books was flowing out of the new [Devil Sword: Ednos] that I obtained.

It must be a proof that this item is more important than ordinary magic books.

“A Devil Sword? Such an item exists?”

I admired the effect that wrapped around the Devil Sword and examined the item closely.

[Devil Sword: Ednos] had a shape closer to a dagger than a normal sword, despite its name.

There was a jewel-decorated handle below the beautifully sculpted blade.

Squeak.

I clicked on the item in the inventory and looked at it, and detailed information about [Devil Sword: Ednos] was displayed.

Maybe it was because of its name.

[Devil Sword: Ednos] had a characteristic that could not be found in ordinary items.

“The name of the characteristic is... <Magic Accumulation>?”

<Magic Accumulation>.

That was the name of the characteristic given to [Devil Sword: Ednos].

The effect of <Magic Accumulation> characteristic was to absorb up to 10 spells.

The absorbed spells were stored inside [Devil Sword: Ednos], and it was possible to empty the space again by releasing the stored spells.

A characteristic that stores the opponent’s spells.

It would be difficult for me to use it myself, but I think it would be a great advantage in a battle between characters.

You can release powerful spells that were already stored.

You can also erase the opponent’s spells suddenly and return them to the target.

It was a characteristic that could create various benefits for the character depending on the situation.

“It feels like I get better things because it’s an 80,000 won draw.”

It seemed that the level of items from the draw had increased overall.

Compared to before, [Sponge Cake] came out more often than [Baguette].

[Steel Sword] was replaced by [Sharp Steel Sword], which showed that it was worth 80,000 won for sure.

The value of 80,000 won.

I rubbed my chin and thought for a while, but I was convinced again after seeing the Devil Sword I drew this time.

“This is enough to make up for it. Then now... who should I give this Devil Sword to?”

After the draw was over, it was time to think about how to distribute the items.

Unlike magic books, Devil Swords were not items that I could use.

Normally, I would have given this to Eutenia as well, but it was an item that did not suit her very well.

Eutenia was a magician who could use divine arts.

Giving her a Devil Sword that absorbs magic would not be efficient in any way.

If not Eutenia, then who should I give this sword to?

A man who hovered around Eutenia caught my eye as I thought about it.

-[Roan Hebris] acquired <Fanatic> characteristic.

-Karma increased by 1 point.

The name of the character who hovered around Eutenia was Roan Hebriss.

He was a character who acquired <Fanatic> characteristic after being influenced by Eutenia since their meeting.

At first, I didn't notice him because I was focused on the magic books, but I found out later when I checked.

After talking to Eutenia, I learned that Roan wanted to become my character.

Of course, there was a limit to karma, so I couldn't make anyone my apostle.

But there was no reason to leave a character with <Fanatic> characteristic alone.

I fixed my screen focus on Roan, who was busy moving around.

"I forgot you were there."

The other day, in my conversation with Eutenia, I promised Roan that I would give him a decent position.

The position translated by the speech bubble translator was archbishop.

<Divine Calling of Karma: Offering> worked for characters who were not apostles as well, so it was part of our conversation later that Eutenia would teach him offering.

The offerings that Roan offered me could also be converted into karma.

I planned to increase the number of characters with <Fanatic> characteristic centered on Roan, and ultimately use the power to facilitate karma supply.

"I can't give him nothing when he's an archbishop."

An archbishop is an archbishop even if it's just a name.

When Eutenia left for a trip to collect magic books, Roan had to work hard in her place.

It would be a troublesome situation if he got stabbed by another character while working alone.

I couldn't just leave a person who was supposed to be an archbishop alone.

After thinking for a while, I decided to give [Devil Sword: Ednos] to Roan as a gift.

I calculated that it would be helpful for Roan to use the characteristic of [Devil Sword: Ednos] that stores magic.

“A characteristic that stores magic. Then it must be...”

The characteristic of the Devil Sword that stores magic.

My eyes naturally turned to the skill button in the corner of the screen.

<Lightning Arrow>.

A powerful spell that inflicted area damage and dot damage.

What if I stored <Lightning Arrow> to the limit in [Devil Sword: Ednos]?

An item that allows the character to use <Lightning Arrow> up to 10 times.

In a way, it would be a state that could be said to be stronger than me when I was low level.

“Yeah. Magic is always better with area skills.”

The image of Roan using <Lightning Arrow> with the Devil Sword.

It felt like my chest was swelling just by thinking about it.

After deciding what to do with [Devil Sword: Ednos], I put down my smartphone on the desk and got up from my seat.

It was time to get hungry.

I thought about making some ramen.

I moved to the kitchen to boil some water, thinking about what kind of ramen to eat today.

“I’ll give him the item later.”

A huge empty space in a corner of the hideout.

Roan's hand was busy there.

There were glowing stones around the darkened empty space, and there was a geometric pattern drawn with white paint on the ground.

Many words of praise written in ancient letters around the complex patterns.

It was the altar that Roan, who became the archbishop of the sect, learned from Eutenia and created.

The altar where offerings were placed was located higher than usual.

Ugh.

Roan put down the bowl after using up all the remaining paint to write the last letter carefully.

“Is this the end...?”

Cold sweat ran down Roan's forehead, who had completed the altar.

It was an altar dedicated to the god.

It was a task that required more care than performing magical things.

Roan emptied his hands and stepped back a few steps to look at the altar.

A satisfied smile hung on Roan's lips as he checked the altar he had made.

Despite being the first altar he had drawn, it did not look lacking in any way.

It was a well-made altar in Roan's own opinion.

“You worked hard, Roan.”

“Not at all. It’s all thanks to you, Apostle.”

Next to Roan, who was eating sponge cake while watching him, Eutenia was sitting.

With a hand stretched out from the shadow holding the cake plate, Eutenia reached for the cake and ate it.

It was no different from a trick, Roan stared blankly at her for a moment.

He had thought so since she used the shadow to take out a book, but to Roan’s eyes, it was a truly extraordinary sight.

“By the way, are all the offerings ready?”

“...”

“Archbishop Roan?”

“...It’s nothing. I have prepared enough offerings.”

Roan shook his head to shake off his thoughts and looked at the altar in front of him again.

What was important to him now was the offering ritual.

How the apostle ate cake was none of his business.

“Then let’s proceed with the ritual.”

As soon as all the preparations for the ritual were over, Roan moved to the right place where he had to be.

Hoo.

A sigh flowed out of Roan’s mouth facing the altar.

It was a ritual to offer offerings to God and receive a response.

It would be a lie if he said he wasn't nervous.

Roan calmed his tense body and began to recite the prayer with his hands wide open.

“——Life. Build a staircase.”

The atmosphere changed to a devout one as Roan's calm voice echoed.

All the believers around him knelt down toward the altar as the ritual began.

Eutenia was no exception, who was watching the ritual.

Everyone stared at the altar and watched the ritual, and Roan continued his silent prayer.

“——One path leads to glory.”

The majestic prayer that shouted out to God.

One word became awe that shook people, and the next word became a roar that shook heaven and earth.

A fierce pulse.

And an exclamation of reverence.

The gate of heaven revealed itself to those who looked up at God with humility.

A huge gaze showed its presence and looked at those who prayed to him.

“——Revere. Worship. Offer.”

The flesh of those who were offered as offerings was wrapped in bright light.

There were no offerings left on the altar.

The offering ritual was successful.

Roan's lips curled into a smile of emotion as he realized that fact.

He shouted out to his master with a loud voice in ecstasy.

“O Great One!”

And at the same time, something strange happened on the empty altar.

Thud.

A sword that fell from the sky stuck in the center of the altar.

The sword stuck on the altar was wrapped in thick darkness.

Chapter 22: The Order (3)

< Chapter 22 : The Order (3) >

A beautiful sword wrapped in darkness.

It was clearly a blessing from the divine.

Gulp.

Roan swallowed his saliva unconsciously as he faced the sword.

He was about to approach the sword placed on the altar when suddenly.

Boom!

A bolt of lightning struck down from the sky.

“Ahh!”

“What, what is that? Lightning?”

The believers who were watching the scene screamed in terror at the sudden lightning.

Crackle. Sparkle.

The lightning that hit the altar sparked for a moment, then was absorbed into the sword.

Everyone who surrounded the altar became solemn at the sight of the phenomenon that occurred.

But the anomaly that happened to the altar was not over yet.

As soon as the thunder that shook Roan's ears subsided, spears of lightning fell from the sky one after another.

Bang! Boom!

The sound of thunder was so loud that it seemed to burst their eardrums.

The believers covered their ears at the sound of thunder that shook their heartbeats.

“O, O Lord!”

“O Mighty One!”

Powerful lightning strikes continued to hit the ground.

Every time a bright light flashed in front of their eyes, they heard thunder roaring in their ears.

It was a scene that only a transcendent being could create.

Many people shouted the name of their god at the awe-inspiring scene that followed the ritual.

Boom!

Every time the spear of lightning collided with the sword on the altar, dark energy spewed out and swallowed up the remaining current.

Once. Twice.

The lightning that fell like divine punishment struck several times.

After a final blow that resembled a firework to mark the end of the ritual, the barrage of lightning that fell toward the sword ended.

“How, how can this be...!”

Roan let out a sound of astonishment as he watched it all.

At the last moment of the sacrifice.

Their god gave them a clear answer.

Crackle.

A faint current flowed from the sword that absorbed the power of lightning.

It was a sight that no mere human could imitate.

Roan looked at the sword on the altar and remembered the conversation he had with Eutenea in the past.

‘If you practice the ritual of offering that you learned from me, surely He will answer you.’

Eutenea said this to Roan.

She said that there would surely be an answer from Him to Roan.

Then that meant that the sword on the altar was meant for Roan.

Thud. Thud.

Roan approached the altar and looked at the sword.

The sword that had been spewing out darkness tempted Roan with its beautiful appearance.

The blade had a refined shape and a splendid handle.

There was nothing he didn’t like about it.

“O Mighty One! If this is Your will for me, I humbly accept it.”

Roan grabbed the sword with his trembling hand.

Clack.

As he held the sword given by God in an awkward posture, he felt a tremendous force coming from his palm.

What Roan was holding was not a simple object.

It was a magic sword that swallowed magic and returned it back.

That was the identity of Ednos, which Roan was holding.

Roan muttered to himself as he realized what he was holding.

“Ednos... I see. That’s what this thing is called.”

He felt a sense of omnipotence as if he could wield great power with just holding it.

It was an object given by God who watched over them.

It was a treasure worthy of being called a miracle.

This Ednos would be a symbol of Roan’s authority from now on.

Perhaps understanding what it meant to receive Ednos, Eutenea congratulated Roan who held it in his hand.

“You got a good thing. Congratulations, Roan.”

“It’s all thanks to you, Master.”

“You’re still humble.”

A hand stretched out from the shadow and lightly tapped Roan’s shoulder.

Tap. Tap.

It was a gesture of encouragement for Roan.

Eutenea smiled and asked him as she tapped his shoulder.

“Don’t you have something else to do for His Holiness?”

“Yes. I have something to do.”

“I hope you succeed.”

“...Yes.”

As soon as she withdrew her hand from his shoulder, Roan walked back to the front of the altar again.

He then turned around and looked at the believers who knelt down behind him.

They all looked at Roan with different expressions.

Fear. Awe. Admiration.

He faced each emotion one by one and lifted Ednos in his hand.

“I declare in the name of Archbishop Roan Hebris at this place.”

Flash!

Ednos in Roan’s hand began to emit light.

The light was so bright that it blinded their eyes, and the believers naturally bowed their heads.

“We will build a temple here! A temple to serve the Mighty One!”

A temple to serve their master.

That was the most important plan in Roan’s mind, who became an archbishop.

He would build a temple for God.

And he would gather the followers of God.

That was the only way he could repay a little bit of the authority he had received.

“Everyone, cheer! For the Mighty One!”

Roan’s sword tip flashed and turned into a spear of lightning that shot out.

Boom!

The magic that Ednos fired flew straight to the mountain next to it and collided.

A huge explosion and thick smoke rose up.

The believers who witnessed all these miracles spontaneously applauded.

Cheers and applause.

The sound of clapping was so loud that it echoed throughout the mountain.

Roan smiled with satisfaction as he watched the scene.

Archbishop, Roan Hebris.

It was the moment of the birth of the Order led by him.

The Holy Land, Crossbridge.

In the Temple of Abundance, which had the most influence among the six temples, there was a saintess who was respected by everyone in the Holy Land.

The girl who folded her hands and prayed devoutly to the sky was Serena Ederunt.

She was the saintess who led the Temple of Abundance, and also the closest being to God in the Holy Land.

Her prayer echoed softly in the silence as she closed her eyes.

A faint light flowed from her body as she prayed.

“O Goddess of Abundance who watches over all——.”

Next to Serena, there was a knight with a sword.

It was customary for a person who matched her status as the most important person in the Holy Land to have a guard.

Knight, Lian Crost.

He was a chosen knight with a white holy sword, and also the vice-captain of the Knight Order.

Lian watched Serena praying with a devout expression and guarded his surroundings.

How much time had passed since Serena started praying?

The light that wrapped around her body disappeared, and Lian, who had been guarding her with his holy sword, moved.

“Phew. The prayer is finally over.”

Serena got up from her seat and looked at Lian as she finished praying.

Maybe because she had been holding her posture for a long time, her legs lost strength and she wobbled for a moment.

Lian didn’t miss that small gap and went to her side to support her.

Thud.

Serena, who was caught by Lian's hand, looked at him for a moment and then straightened her posture and smiled at him.

"I guess I'm not as fit as I thought."

"Be careful. Everyone in the Holy Land will worry if you get hurt."

"Thank you, Lian."

"It's nothing. But did the Goddess of Abundance say anything to you?"

It was a regular prayer time, but sometimes Serena received a revelation from God.

Revelation.

Also known as Divine Grace, it was something that only she could hear as a saintess.

Lian's question to Serena was also about the Divine Grace that the Goddess of Abundance gave.

Nod.

Serena nodded her head at Lian's question and said.

"Yes. I received a Divine Grace."

"Divine Grace... I see."

"Aren't you curious what it is?"

"Of course I'm curious. What kind of Divine Grace did you receive?"

The content of the Divine Grace was not disclosed to anyone except for the core members of the Holy Land.

But Lian was a knight who guarded the saintess, and also a person who held the position of vice-captain of the Knight Order.

He also moved around with Serena most closely on normal days.

He was someone who had enough qualifications to be told the content of the Divine Grace by Serena.

So he didn't hesitate to ask her about it.

“She said that a new hero will appear in the temple soon.”

“A new hero? Could it be... that the evil god has started to interfere in this world?”

Lian's eyebrows twitched when he heard the word hero from Serena's mouth.

Hero.

It was a name that referred to the owners of the six divine artifacts that appeared with the Divine Grace.

There was only one condition for a hero to appear.

The evil god who disturbed the world had appeared.

The gods who watched over the six temples in the Holy Land did not exert their influence on the ground except for certain exceptions.

And the appearance of the evil god was an exception that made them move actively.

Lian was surprised to hear the name of the hero and agreed with Serena's answer.

“The evil god has started to move. No, actually, it seems like he started moving much earlier than we expected.”

The evil god's movement.

That alone was enough to cause an emergency in the whole Holy Land.

But he said that he had been moving much earlier than Lian expected.

Lian asked again at the successive bad news.

“What do you mean by that?”

“For some reason, causality has been reset. That’s why Divine Grace came down later than usual.”

“...”

“Karma is fair to everyone, so if it doesn’t tilt enough, divine artifacts won’t be released either.”

Lian’s face darkened as he recalled the appearance of divine artifacts recorded in history books.

Without using their power, most heroes were nothing more than talented humans.

Even if they were chosen as heroes, they would have a hard time blocking Lian’s sword without divine artifacts.

Divine artifacts were objects that had a lot of meaning for heroes.

And what Serena said implied that the heroes’ divine artifacts would not be able to exert enough power for a while.

“That’s a difficult story. The elders will have a headache for a while.”

“That’s right. It’s hard enough to bring the heroes here safely.”

“What are you going to do, Saintess?”

“I guess I’ll enjoy my freedom for a while.”

“Freedom...?”

“Anyway, the Inquisition or the Knights will take care of finding the heroes, so I’ll be relaxed for a while, right?”

When the temple became busy preparing for the arrival of the heroes, paradoxically, Serena’s schedule as a saintess decreased.

It was because most of the official events were suspended due to the mobilization of most of the manpower outside.

Chuckle.

Lian let out a faint laugh at Serena’s words.

He rarely smiled, but Serena smiled back at him as she saw his smile.

“You won’t be quiet if you’re lazy.”

“Oh, lazy. Rest is also a preparation for facing the evil god.”

“Of course I didn’t expect you to have no excuses.”

“I can’t beat you, Lian.”

They smiled at each other and looked beyond each other at the shadow of the evil god that loomed over the continent.

Chapter 23: The Corrupted Sword

(1)

< 23 : The Corrupted Sword (1) >

-[Roan Hebris] has performed a sacrifice for you.

-Sacrifices dedicated to you: 21

-The effect of <Karma's Blessing: Sacrifice> is activated.

-Your karma increases by 42, proportional to the number of sacrificed offerings.

Right after the sacrificial ceremony led by Archbishop Roan Hebris and his followers ended.

I was able to confirm the message that I had acquired a considerable amount of karma.

The amount of karma I gained from this ceremony was much more than I expected.

It was not only because the karma increased by the sacrifice was high, but also because a special event had occurred.

At the same time as Roan announced the establishment of the temple, new event messages appeared.

-[Roan Hebris] has acquired the <Religious Leader> trait.

-Your karma increases by 5.

[Roan Hebris] has declared the birth of a Order.

Your karma increases by 50.

Was it because I personally appointed Roan as the archbishop?

Or was it thanks to Roan declaring the birth of the Order?

At the bottom of the screen, there was a message that Roan had acquired the <Religious Leader> trait.

It seemed to be an upgraded version of the <Fanatic> trait that Roan had before.

The sum of the karma I received from the birth of the sect and Roan's trait acquisition was 55.

If I added the karma I gained from the sacrifice and the karma I had saved from hunting, it was enough to raise my level.

-You have reached level 6.

-<Observer's Eye(Lv.5)> grows.

-<Observer's Eye(Lv.6)> becomes. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

With the huge amount of karma I got, I reached level 6.

Of course, as my level increased, <Observer's Eye> also became a higher level.

There was no significant graphic upgrade or speech bubble output change.

However, I felt that the speed of moving the screen was faster than before.

The range of screen movement that was allowed also seemed to increase by a large margin.

In short, it seemed like the map had expanded as my level increased.

“There is no change in graphics... And what has changed in Karma’s Blessing?”

The next thing that changed after <Observer’s Eye> was <Karma’s Blessing>, which had been warning me every time my level increased.

Unlike before, there was no new skill activated like <Karma’s Blessing: Sacrifice>.

The change that occurred this time was about the content that the system had been warning me about.

- Warning: Excessively biased karma in one direction may trigger <Causality Adjustment>.
- <Karma’s Blessing> has tilted.
- A low level of <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.
- Heroes appear due to <Causality Adjustment>.
- Causality Adjustment Progress: 1%

Karma’s Blessing had always warned me about <Causality Adjustment>.

And its result appeared today.

The appearance of heroes.

I didn’t know exactly what changes would happen, but it was undeniable that it would be a penalty for me.

I couldn’t help but lose my appetite as I saw the new message.

“Does hunting too hard increase the difficulty?”

It’s not fun if the game is too easy.

So some degree of difficulty adjustment was understandable.

But it bothered me that this change appeared after the sect was born.

Even if heroes were special bosses with unique characteristics, they had little influence on me.

It seemed more likely that they would try to interfere with my characters while they were hunting.

If I didn't want to see my well-raised characters disappear, I would need to check on their whereabouts from time to time.

"It looks like I have to keep an eye on my characters from now on. And the next message is... What is this?"

After checking on Karma's Blessing, I scrolled down again.

It was usually where there would be a message about <Paid Currency Shop>.

But since <Paid Currency Shop> had already leveled up once, there was no skill level increase this time.

Instead, there was a message that I had acquired a new skill.

The skill I acquired this time was called <Descent>.

-You have learned <Descent(0 / 5)>.

-For each of the following conditions you meet, <Descent>'s progress will increase by one stage.

-Usable Karma: 221 / 999,999 (Incomplete)

-??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-??? (Incomplete)

Descent.

It was a word that meant a divine being descending to the ground.

I didn't know how the gods descended in the game world, but the <Descent> skill I had required me to complete five quests to use it.

Even then, the first quest was to collect a million karma, which was hidden by unreadable characters.

It seemed that I had not reached the level where I could unlock the quests.

It was not surprising that they would be unlocked sequentially, since the first quest was already headache-inducing.

“A million karma? That's a ridiculous number.”

And the first quest was to collect a million usable karma.

Judging by the fact that the karma I spent on making apostles was not counted, it meant that I had to collect an additional million after excluding the consumed karma.

The karma I had collected so far by playing the game was barely around 300.

But I had to collect a whopping million.

It was a daunting number just to think about.

“But difficult games are fun.”

Still, I had no intention of giving up this game.

This game was already one of the few escapes that healed my mind exhausted by work.

And the pleasure of clearing a difficult game was indescribable.

It was definitely not because of the simple reason that I had already spent more than 200,000 won on this game.

“...”

Probably.

Probably.

The night sky darkened as the sun set.

Peter, who was looking at the bright stars, had Eutenia sitting next to him reading a book.

Maybe it was because the letters were not visible under the dark night sky.

Eutenia was holding a glowing stone that cast a shadow.

Flip.

Eutenia turned the page with her finger and asked Peter, who was looking at the night sky.

“Do you like stars?”

“I used to like them when I was young.”

Peter’s eyes looked at the shining Polaris.

He devoted himself to farming as he grew older, but Peter liked the night sky when he was young.

He looked at the distant night sky and connected the constellations one by one with his fingers.

That was his favorite solo game when he was a little boy.

Of course, by now, the night sky had changed a lot from then.

“So you used to like them when you were young.”

“...Yes.”

“That was a good hobby.”

Eutenia, who was still looking at the book, said with a faint smile on her face.

The place where he stood now was not the village where he used to look at the stars.

It was nothing more than a shabby hideout of thieves located in a rugged mountain.

The village where he used to look at the stars had already disappeared.

And it was done by Eutenia, who was sitting next to him.

Even if he looked up at the sky with admiration now, he could not face the same sky as before.

“Do you like looking at the sky?”

Nevertheless, Polaris remained in its place, shining brightly.

Peter, who had caught the light of Polaris in his eyes, asked Eutenia.

Flip.

Eutenia looked at the sky again after turning another page.

“I might have liked it when I was young.”

“What about now?”

“I don’t think I like it as much as I did then.”

A short and clear answer.

Peter opened his mouth after hearing it.

“That’s an unexpected answer.”

“Was it unexpected?”

“Since heaven is close to God, I thought you would like the sky.”

Eutenia smiled faintly at Peter’s words.

God.

And heaven.

Both were undoubtedly wrapped in countless veils.

Eutenia stopped turning pages at Peter’s question that linked them together.

Instead, she looked at Peter and said to him.

“It seems that you think so.”

“Aren’t you curious?”

“About where the great one is?”

“Do you think God is somewhere in that sky? Or beyond the countless stars?”

Peter’s hand reached out to the sky.

He tried to grasp the vast sky with all his might, but there was nothing in his hand.

That’s what heaven was like.

It was visible but unreachable.

A place that was never allowed to humans.

A realm of mystery that humans could not access.

“It seems that you think the great one is in heaven.”

“If you can’t hold what you see, you might not see what you hold.”

“That’s a very interesting thought.”

“Is my word wrong?”

Thud.

Eutenia closed the book she had opened.

She got up from where she was reading and hugged the divine instrument that was lying next to her.

A thick magic flowed from Eutenia’s body as she hugged the divine instrument.

It was the most certain and clear evidence that she was loved by a transcendent being.

“I’m not such a great person, so I don’t know everything.”

“...”

“But I think it means that he is always with me and stays inside me.”

Eutenia said as she stroked the book she hugged.

The words of an apostle chosen by God.

Peter could not argue with her words at all.

“I see.”

“It’s just my personal opinion though.”

“If you, an apostle of God, say so, I think it’s not a wrong story.”

That was all Peter could do: agree with her words.

Peter was not a chosen being by God.

He only faced an evil god who took away sacrifices.

That was all he knew about God.

“It was a pleasant conversation. I remembered the book I was looking for, so I guess I have to go back now.”

“...Okay.”

The conversation with Eutenia ended there.

Eutenia turned away from Peter after finishing the conversation.

She started walking towards the empty tent.

Peter watched her back as she walked quietly towards the tent.

Peter’s eyes were full of confusion as he looked at Eutenia.

“It seems that the six gods do not look down below.”

Even though an apostle of an evil god walked around freely, there was no divine punishment coming down on them.

God exists.

Yet justice is not seen.

Only the empty sky he grasped represented Peter’s heart.

Peter lowered his arm that was reaching for Polaris.

And at that moment.

A burning pain began to be felt from Peter's right arm, which had returned to its place.

“Ugh...!”

Peter bit his teeth and lifted his clothes to look at his right arm.

A black mark appeared on Peter's arm, which had nothing on it.

A mark of a wing pierced by a splendid sword.

A sign that represented a hero chosen by the god of honor.

Peter showed a bewildered look at the appearance of the mark that appeared without any warning.

“A mark...?”

Peter's finger stroked the mark on his arm.

The mark was as if it had always existed on Peter's skin, and he did not feel any bumps.

The pain in Peter's arm disappeared as the mark of the hero became clear.

A mark that suddenly appeared on his skin.

Peter scratched his arm hard with his nails to erase the mark.

But there was no sign of the mark on Peter's arm disappearing.

The mark had already taken its place on Peter's arm completely.

“...I see.”

Peter muttered to himself as he looked at his arm and reached a conclusion about the mark.

The six gods he had been looking for had already given him an answer.

Yet Peter had no knowledge to recognize the mark.

He was in such a position as a young man from a rural village in the outskirts.

He had never faced the scriptures of the temple, let alone met a priest in his life.

He finished his own judgment on the mark arbitrarily and sighed deeply as he touched his forehead.

“It seems that I’ve been with the fallen ones for too long, and now I’ve even got a mark of an evil god.”

Chapter 24: The Corrupted Sword

(2)

< 24 : The Corrupted Sword (2) >

Evan Allemier.

He was a heretic inquisitor of Crossbridge and the eldest son of the Allemier family.

Evan had just finished his short vacation and was on his way back to Crossbridge.

The information he had learned during his vacation was shocking enough to shake the Holy Land.

The movement of the Evil God Cult.

And the imminent appearance of the Hero.

Both were troublesome matters that would only get worse as time passed.

That's why Evan chose to return to the Holy Land as quickly as possible, even if it meant taking some risks.

He started moving along a shortcut that he had heard from his brother, Hus.

“This road is quite rough.”

Clack— clack—.

As he urged his horse on, Evan looked around and opened his mouth.

The shortcut that Hus had told him about was more rugged than the usual road he took.

It was not a problem if he ran carefully, but he could understand why people did not often pass by this way.

Evan would not have chosen this adventure if he had some time to spare.

He had been running for hours, kicking up dust along the way.

He decided to change his horse when he reached the border.

He spotted some people on the road when the summer sun was at its zenith.

“...Are those people?”

He saw a few figures on top of a shabby-looking carriage.

He was still too far away to see them clearly, but he could barely make out their shapes.

But if he kept running at this pace, he would surely crash into them.

He grabbed the reins and slowed down as he saw the carriage in the distance.

Hee-haw—!

As Evan slowed down his horse, the people on the carriage looked at him.

Two men.

And one woman.

That was all he could see of their party.

“There’s someone coming from the other side.”

One of the men who was looking at Evan coming from afar opened his mouth.

The young man who caught Evan's eye had a naive face.

He was sitting on the driver's seat, holding the reins, so he must have been a young coachman or an errand boy.

Clack. Clack.

He slowed down his horse until it was visible to the eye and approached the carriage.

He stopped his horse.

Hee-haw!

His horse snorted loudly as it came to a complete halt.

His brother Hus lived here, but Evan was still an outsider from the Holy Land.

He got off his horse and walked slowly towards the carriage, hoping to ask them for directions.

"I'd like to ask you for directions, if you don't mind."

As he brushed off the dust on his body and walked towards the carriage, Evan spoke.

His clothes were covered with dust from riding his horse for a long time.

As he approached them while dusting off his clothes, one of the men showed a sign of caution.

The man who wore a robe with a hood looked older than the young coachman.

As Evan's gaze met his, the man opened his mouth to him.

“Where are you going?”

“I’m heading to the Holy Land.”

“The Holy Land... Are you a holy knight?”

There was nothing on Evan’s clothes that indicated that he belonged to the temple.

Yet the man asked him if he was a holy knight and showed a wary look.

There was no reason for an ordinary person to be suspicious of a traveler heading to the Holy Land.

It was clearly a suspicious sight.

Crackle.

Evan felt an unpleasant sensation in his aura as he raised his holy power.

It was an energy that repelled holy power.

The dark magic of another dimension.

The power of abomination that black magicians had accumulated by offering sacrifices.

“What are you going to do if I’m a holy knight?”

A black magician who was wary of holy knights and his companions.

It was an obvious suspicious combination.

Evan’s role as a heretic inquisitor of the Holy Land was to deal with those who served heresy and corrupted magicians.

He sensed something ominous and moved his hand to his sword hilt naturally.

He had planned to just ask for directions and move on.

But he had learned too much to just pass by them now.

“Nothing. I was just curious.”

“Is that so. You seem very curious.”

“I’m always like that.”

In the tense atmosphere, the black magician’s throat moved as he faced Evan.

Gulp.

He swallowed his saliva and twitched his hand.

Evan did not think that the black magician in front of him had achieved much.

He was only at a level that could be handled by third-class investigators of the empire.

It would not take long for him to finish him off if he acted himself.

Evan made up his mind and took another step towards the black magician.

“You black magicians are indeed very curious.”

“What did you say....”

“You wouldn’t dabble in forbidden magic with just a little curiosity, would you?”

——Clang.

Evan’s sword was drawn out of his scabbard with a friction sound.

He drew his sword with a natural motion and swung it at the black magician in front of him.

It was a swift sword strike that most magicians could not even react to.

Clang!

The only thing that blocked Evan's sword was a hand wrapped in darkness.

The hand came out of the shadow behind the black magician, who was the target of Evan's sword.

"That was close, Roan."

The shadow that blocked Evan's sword came from the feet of the girl who was behind the black magician.

Beyond the shadow that blocked his sword.

A girl with ash-gray hair was sitting on the carriage, looking down at the two men.

She was holding a large book in her arms, smiling innocently.

Seeing the girl who had moved the shadow to block his sword, the black magician behind her sighed in relief and replied.

"Phew... Thank you. I would have been dead for sure if it weren't for you, Apostle."

"Be careful. He seems like a dangerous person."

"He does. I didn't expect him to swing his sword at me out of nowhere."

Apostle.

And black magician.

Evan overheard their conversation and backed away a few steps, on guard.

The magic he had just encountered was very unfamiliar to him.

It was the first time he had faced such a high-level magic.

The being in front of him was different from the black magician in essence.

While the girl was moving her shadow, Evan could sense a tremendous amount of magic around her.

A tidal wave of magic that seemed endless.

She was clearly a high-ranking magician who could not be opposed by any ordinary means.

“Who are you?”

“Are you curious about my identity?”

“Yes. Reveal yourself.”

“Shouldn’t you introduce yourself first if you want to hear someone else’s identity? That’s the polite thing to do.”

Tap. Tap.

The girl tapped her book with her finger and spoke.

Every time her slender finger touched the book, a powerful wave of magic emanated from it.

It was an awe-inspiring level of magic, unlike her innocent-looking face.

Despite her seemingly willing to reveal herself if he played along, Evan quickly weighed his options in his head.

The apostle in front of him was a threat to the Holy Land.

If he could reveal his identity to learn more about her, it was a relatively cheap deal.

Evan made up his mind and told her his name.

“My name is Evan Allemier! I’m a holy knight who serves the God of Honor.”

“The God of Honor? Your actions just now were not very honorable, I think.”

“...There is no honor to show to the wicked.”

Evan tried to ignore her sarcastic words.

It was not a lie that he had blurted out for convenience.

Life and death were always at stake during a battle.

He could only fight honorably with those who deserved respect.

This was also written in the doctrine of the temple.

The girl nodded as if she understood his answer, which could seem half-hearted.

“I see. Well, since I heard your introduction, I guess I should introduce myself too.”

The girl who was sitting on the carriage got up from her seat.

She hugged her book and stepped down lightly, facing Evan who was glaring at her from below.

She did not seem to worry about falling from such a height, as a hand of shadow reached out to support her.

Thud.

She landed safely on the ground and looked at Evan with a faint smile.

Then she spoke in a clear voice that echoed in the narrow road.

“My name is Eutenia Hyrost. I’m the first apostle who serves the Great One.”

“Apostle... Do you mean the apostle of the Evil God?”

“It’s very rude of you to call the Great One an evil god.”

Ignoring her displeased look, Evan was plunged into serious thoughts after hearing her identity.

The apostle of the Evil God.

That meant only one thing.

The Evil God had gained enough influence in this world to send down an apostle.

Evan looked at Eutenia with a tense face and raised his sword.

He had to eliminate the apostle in front of him if he could.

He had no choice but to fight from the beginning.

“I only spoke the truth.”

“Did you? You’re quite an impolite person.”

“A god who devours people does not deserve respect. We have decided to call those who turn their eyes away from this obvious truth evil gods.”

He wielded his sword to punish evil.

That was the path that Evan Allemier had chosen.

He looked at Eutenia with a fierce gaze, imbued with holy power.

“Don’t you regret doing something foolish?”

“I’m not afraid of death or running away. Otherwise, I wouldn’t have chosen to be a holy knight.”

Hearing Evan’s words, Eutenia sighed briefly.

She immersed herself in thought, her ash-gray eyes reflecting her book.

A thick book whose origin was unknown.

And Evan standing beyond it.

She looked back and forth between them and released a strong wave of magic from her body.

“Fine. I didn’t intend to let you go anyway.”

She opened the book she was holding and declared to Evan.

At the same time, countless hands stretched out from beyond her shadow.

An unfathomable realm of darkness.

The overflowing hands became a wave that aimed at Evan.

The first apostle, Eutenia Hyrost.

The apostle who had received the divine power of the Evil God unleashed her full strength at Evan.

Evan faced Eutenia’s attack and ran towards her with his sword, filled with holy power.

Chapter 25: The Corrupted Sword

(3)

< 25 : The Corrupted Sword (3) >

Evan stared intently at the shadows that rushed towards him.

To a warrior, the most important organ was the eye.

The eye that saw the attack.

And the eye that predicted the future.

Intuition was nothing more than a prediction based on the eye and experience, with a little adjustment.

Woo-woo-woo-woong-.

Evan's sword emitted a pure white light, and a warm holy power wrapped around his body.

“O Goddess! Grant me the power to punish your enemies!”

Evan recited the prayer of the paladin and swung his sword at the approaching shadows.

Clang! Clang!

The busy sword repelled the shadows that poured down on him.

Every time Evan's sword infused with holy power swung, the shadows that touched it retreated a little bit.

But it was only enough to create a brief gap.

It was impossible to completely suppress the endless onslaught of shadows.

Evan's steps began to be pushed back by the wave of shadows.

“Do you think you can keep running away?”

Left.

And right.

Shadows that popped out from both sides moved towards Evan.

Evan's eyes, which moved busily, assessed the danger of the attack.

Clang!

He blocked one of them and twisted his body.

Shoo-oo-oo-ook-!

The shadow that aimed at him stretched out and grazed Evan's shoulder.

The cloth that wrapped around Evan's shoulder was torn off.

Evan swung his sword at the shadow that passed by and looked at the remaining enemies in front of him.

‘I can't get close because of the shadows.’

There were too many shadows that Eutenia unleashed.

The moment his body was caught by Eutenia's shadows, it would be hard to move properly.

Even if he tried to approach, the shadows' interference was severe.

But he had to get close to inflict effective damage.

Thud.

Evan took a step forward and began to calculate the path to reach his enemy.

‘Even if I make a gap, I’ll only have one chance at best.’

The Inquisitor was a position given only to those who were pure and strong among the paladins.

Even so, Evan had no confidence in fighting against an Apostle for a long time.

The Apostle he faced was an unreasonable being to that extent.

It was a moment when he needed a proper choice.

Evan raised his holy power after judging the value of his movement.

The sword in Evan’s hand emitted a stronger light than before.

“O Goddess! Guide me!”

He took a deep breath and ran towards the front with his sword in his hand.

His eyes, which had been honing his skills continuously, showed him the way to go.

Between the countless shadows that stretched out.

There was a short gap created by the changing trajectories of the shadows.

Evan found the small gap and dove into it, aiming for it.

Clang! Clang!

The blades of light that flashed several times pushed away the shadows and moved forward.

Every time Evan's sword swung, the shadow's hand that twisted its orbit hit the ground.

“_____.”

The distance between them narrowed in an instant with his quick steps.

Evan gasped and looked at Eutenia.

It was close enough to touch her with his sword.

But Eutenia still didn't show any sign of reacting.

It seemed like there was no other chance to inflict effective damage than now.

-Huhhuhhuhhuhhuhu-

With a short breath, his right arm muscles contracted.

It was the moment when Evan's sword filled with brilliant light slashed towards her front.

“Barrier.”

Kwaang!

With a loud crash, Evan's sword stopped.

There was no sensation of piercing through something in Evan's hand that held the sword.

He frowned at the sight of his sword hanging still in midair.

Right in front of Eutenia, who had opened her book.

There was a barrier that created a huge ripple.

“Did I fail...?”

“Are you very disappointed?”

He breathed heavily as his sword was blocked by the barrier.

It was a barrier made with immense magic power.

It was not something he could break through with a few more swings of his sword.

Rather, it would be problematic if he wasted time.

If he couldn't cut down the Apostle in front of him, he had to at least deal with the black mage next to her and retreat.

He quickly changed his target and turned his head to look at the black mage.

He intended to take care of the black mage instead of Eutenia.

“Be free!”

“...!”

And then he faced the lightning spear that flew towards him fast.

Magic came out of the dagger that the black mage pointed at him.

He was already swinging his sword at the barrier, so it was hard to respond properly.

He clenched his teeth as he saw the lightning strike that aimed at him.

Kwa-aa-aa-ang!

With a blinding shock, Evan's body flew backwards.

He was pierced by the lightning spear and flew back more than ten meters from where he was hit.

“Ku-huk...!”

Thud!

Evan, who flew far away, hit a tree behind him and stopped.

Dust rose from where Evan collided.

He staggered up from his place and looked ahead.

He had reduced the damage as much as possible by raising his holy power, but he still suffered this much damage.

If he took a few more direct hits, his body wouldn't be able to endure it.

He spat out blood and glared at the black mage.

“You had... one more trick up your sleeve.”

“This is the Divine grace of the great one!”

He bit his tongue at the shout of the black mage who raised his dagger wrapped in darkness.

It seemed like he used the power of a tool.

But the power of a tool was only temporary.

If I used all the power I had, the only thing left afterwards would be ruin. That was what I thought.

“Divine Grace, you say? Such a tool, in the end...”

“It seems like your time is up.”

“What did you say?”

Eutenia, who had been watching our conversation, closed her book with a dull sound.

The shadows that flowed from under her feet also faded away.

Her ash-colored eyes stared at me.

Her dry gaze, devoid of any humor, scanned me.

“Didn’t I warn you?”

“What are you talking about?”

“There is always a price for the words you spit out.”

Before Eutenia finished her words, I felt a strong flow of magic from the sky.

Crackle. Crackle.

In the empty sky, a huge lightning power was shaping itself.

It was a miracle.

A miracle that transcended cognition, used by a transcendent being, close to the name of divine punishment.

“This is...!”

It was not magic used by the black mage in front of me.

A god from another dimension looking down at me.

A god from beyond the dimension who interfered with the world by creating a miracle.

I held my breath as I looked up at the sky.

Before I knew it, there were countless spears of lightning in the sky.

It was not hard to understand who that miracle was meant to judge.

I couldn't guarantee my life if I took it properly.

I had to avoid it to survive.

“The price of blasphemy is always one.”

Crackle-!

A thin streak of lightning passed by my side as I looked up at the sky.

A black scorch mark was created on the trajectory of the lightning.

A faint smoke rose from the ground and gently touched my cheek.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

My heart started beating wildly as I faced the favor of a transcendent being.

My breathing was also disrupted by the sudden tension that engulfed my whole body.

“Hoo...”

I raised my holy power and moved my sword with a sense of alertness at its peak.

A being that transcended humanity was watching me.

From beyond the dimension that a mere human could not see, an eye with malice stared at me.

The Apostle in front of me was nothing compared to him.

He was a giant whose end could not be measured.

The only thing allowed to a worthless human was a kick that was like a joke.

“O Goddess...!”

I moved my lips that were bleeding and shouted the name of the Goddess with all my strength.

The Goddess of Honor was the object of reverence that I always prayed to.

There was no meaningful response to my voice that shouted towards the sky.

But I didn't stop shouting at the sky.

With a mere human body, I couldn't help myself.

The only thing left for me to find at this moment was faith, which could save me.

“Guide me...!”

Kwang!

Lightning struck from the cloudy sky.

At the same time, darkness fell on my face.

As I lifted my head, there was lightning in its place.

Countless spears of god aiming to pierce me through.

How much holy power would I have to raise to block that many?

It seemed to be beyond the realm allowed to a paladin.

“O Goddess...”

Clank.

The sword in my hand was wrapped in light.

It was proof that my faith in the Goddess was still firm.

It was once a light so bright that it hurt my eyes, but now it was dimmer than the thunderclouds in the sky.

How many could I block?

That was a question that even I, who held the sword and scattered holy power, couldn't be sure of.

“O Goddess...”

Crackle!

The spears of lightning that had gathered in the sky finally began to pour down on me.

As I saw them pouring down on me, I swung my sword with all my strength.

Kwang!

Lightning collided with the ground and exploded in front of me.

“O, God...”

My ears went deaf as I lifted my sword again.

Kwang! Kwa-aa-aa-ang!

The falling thunder shook the ground.

Every time the lightning bombardment fell, a white flash swallowed up my sight.

One of the spears of lightning that fell pierced me and tore me apart inside.

I flew back and rolled on the ground after being hit by magic.

I staggered up from my place again after being hit directly by magic.

The hilt of my sword trembled roughly in my hand.

“...”

There was no more voice calling for the Goddess.

Instead of my voice, only irregular thunder sounded.

Evan Allemier.

He chose to run away for the first time since he became a paladin.

Chapter 26: The Corrupted Sword

(4)

< 26 : The Corrupted Sword (4) >

I realized that a new elite monster had appeared after some time had passed since the battle began.

After finishing the ramen I had cooked, I casually looked at my smartphone and saw someone fighting with Eutenia.

There was a male character who was fighting with Eutenia with a sword that glowed with light.

He blocked the shadows with his skilled swordsmanship and struck Eutenia's barrier with a blow.

Of course, he was blocked by Eutenia's barrier and failed to inflict any damage, so he retreated.

“Is it an elite monster?”

I recalled the elite monster that had attacked Eutenia last time.

The one that appeared before also swung his sword to bring down Eutenia.

It felt no different from the situation now when I compared them.

Seeing these scenes, I wondered if targeting the characters I raised was a common trait of the elite monsters.

“He definitely looks stronger than the last one.”

His sword movements were different.

He swung his sword swiftly and blocked Eutenia's shadows several times.

Bright light flowed from the sword he held.

It seemed like a trait that boosted the user's attack or defense power.

He looked clearly stronger than the elite monster I had defeated before.

Of course, Eutenia would win easily if they fought to the end.

-“Liberate!”

Was it aiming for the gap of the opponent who was fighting with Eutenia?

Roan used the [Devil Sword: Ednos] that he had gifted before and blew away the opponent.

Kwaaaaang!

With a heavy impact sound, the elite monster flew far back.

He used <Lightning Arrow>, which caused up to 30 damage and induced electric shock.

I felt proud of the performance of [Devil Sword: Ednos] that Roan showed me.

It was worth the price of 80,000 won.

“Wow. This is why I keep doing gacha.”

The opponent who was hit by <Lightning Arrow> took 8 damage and crashed into a tree.

He hit the tree and staggered for a moment, then soon got up again with his sword in his hand.

He showed signs of movement even after being hit by <Lightning Arrow>, which had powerful damage and an additional status effect.

It was different from the previous opponent who was knocked out by simply being hit by <Lightning> magic.

He seemed to be more durable and resilient than the usual enemies in terms of defense and endurance.

It was definitely an opponent who made me feel that the game's difficulty had increased.

“But it still seems easy so far.”

If one <Lightning Arrow> was not enough, I could just use <Lightning Arrow> until he died.

Squeak.

I pressed the skill button and activated the target area for <Lightning Arrow>.

I learned this fact while playing the game for a long time, but if I kept touching while setting the target area, I could fire continuously.

When I activated the continuous fire function, the skill was fired without pressing the skill button again.

Of course, there was a drawback that it took a little more time than using the skill normally.

-“Oh Goddess!”

As I aimed at the character in front of me with the activated target area, he raised his sword and looked for the goddess.

Suddenly looking for the goddess?

His glowing sword and combat style suggested that he was a character with a paladin setting.

Crackle. Crackle.

The sound of electricity flowing indicated that <Lightning Arrow> was ready.

I started to fire <Lightning Arrow> at the opponent.

-“Guide me!”

The character who uttered a passionate line swung his sword at the incoming magic.

Kwang!

The <Lightning Arrow> bounced off his light-filled sword and fell in another direction.

He used his sword to deflect the magic in another direction.

I couldn't help but admire his skill as I watched him twist the direction of my magic.

His ability was more impressive than I expected.

“Wow, he can deflect magic.”

Of course, even if he was an elite monster, he couldn't block all magic.

Bang! Kwang! Kwaaaaang!

The character couldn't handle the consecutive <Lightning Arrows> and got hit by them.

The elite monster who was hit by <Lightning Arrow> took 9 damage and wobbled.

His defense seemed to have decreased due to the continuous attacks.

The character who entered electric shock state groaned and raised his sword again.

-“Ugh...”

The more I saw him, the more impressed I was by his performance.

He had a strong defense that greatly reduced magic damage.

He also had swordsmanship that could block magic.

My eyes naturally moved to the skill icon in the corner of the screen.

The corner of the screen where the skill icons were gathered.

There was the <Apostle Selection> skill that was activated by meeting the activation conditions.

“Can I make an elite monster into an apostle?”

In the case of the previous opponent, I just knocked him down with <Lightning> magic.

But there was still a chance to choose for the elite monster in front of me.

There are countless games that allow taming monsters.

Then, what would happen if I designated an elite monster as an apostle?

I felt a greed rising in my heart as I looked at the <Apostle Selection> skill.

The opponent was an elite monster who could deflect magic.

If it was possible to make him my apostle and enhance him, he had a high possibility of showing a superior performance than other characters.

“Ha... What should I do?”

There was no clear difference between an elite monster and a normal character.

Maybe it was possible to influence an elite monster as well as a character.

If successful, it could be an opportunity to get a powerful character.

But I also wondered if the game developers had made the game so sloppy.

Is it possible? Or is it impossible?

As I was having a time of doubt, I clicked on the skill icon and activated the target area.

“Do you think I’ll lose anything?”

It’s a break-even deal.

I used the skill with that thought.

Squeak.

I placed the target area activated by the <Apostle Selection> skill on top of the enemy character.

The outline of the character in the target area turned blue.

I touched the target area again to designate the character as the target of the skill.

-Do you want to select [Evan Allemier] as an apostle?

-You need 400 karma to select an apostle.

-Yes / No

As soon as I used the skill, a selection message for the <Apostle Selection> skill appeared.

The name of the character I was fighting was Evan Allemier.

And the amount of karma required to make Evan a new apostle was 400.

After acquiring <Lightning Arrow>, I barely managed to reach the limit by hunting diligently.

Seeing the selection message pop up, it seemed possible to make Evan an apostle.

If I use 400 karma, I can create an elite monster as my apostle.

If I don't care about the amount of karma I have to pay, there was no reason for me to hesitate from my point of view.

“...This really works.”

I pressed the accept button without hesitation.

Squeak.

As the selection message on the screen disappeared, Evan's body was wrapped in a bright white light.

Maybe it was because his body was wrapped in light.

Evan looked up at the sky right away.

Evan's face, looking at the sky, looked very exhausted.

As Evan looked at the sky, messages appeared one after another at the bottom of the screen.

-You have selected [Evan Allemier] as an apostle.

-You have consumed 400 karma to create a new artifact for your apostle.

-[Artifact: Astrape] has been bound to [Evan Allemier].

[Evan Allemier] has rejected the path of an apostle.

- <Apostle Selection> has been postponed.

As soon as I activated <Apostle Selection>, a new item was created in my inventory.

Until then, it was similar to when I made Eutenia an apostle.

But after that, something happened that I didn't even expect.

Evan rejected becoming an apostle, and a message popped up saying that <Apostle Selection> was temporarily postponed.

The character himself refused to become my apostle.

I felt like I had been hit in the back of my head by an unexpected situation.

“Where did my karma go after eating 400 and running away?”

The opponent is an elite monster with outstanding abilities among many characters.

To that extent, I had some expectations for the impossible situation of <Apostle Selection>.

But the problem was with the karma that was consumed.

Maybe it was because a message popped up saying that I had created an item by consuming karma.

The usable karma had already been reduced to the bottom, and the next consumption amount of <Apostle Selection> skill went up to 800.

Moreover, there was already [Artifact: Astrape] bound to Evan in my inventory.

-“...So that's how it was.”

I looked at Evan on the screen with a bewildered expression.

Evan, who had postponed <Apostle Selection>, muttered to himself and soon ran somewhere.

There was Evan's horse standing still in the direction where Evan ran.

An icon of a person running away appeared several times over Evan's head as he ran away.

Seeing Evan run away so quickly, a possibility flashed through my mind.

One possibility that I had forgotten while thinking only about using <Apostle Selection>.

-(Escape)

“Does he die and my karma flies away?”

I stopped moving my finger that was moving to aim at Evan.

The karma is consumed only in the process of creating an artifact.

And [Artifact: Astrape] is bound to Evan who was proceeding with <Apostle Selection>.

Then what will happen to [Artifact: Astrape] if Evan dies?

It was likely that it would be stuck in my inventory and unusable.

I thought of a possible possibility and had no choice but to think hard about a perfect solution.

“It seems like it will fly away as it is. It seems like there is a possibility that it can be done again when you look at the postponement status.”

The postponement of <Apostle Selection> was only because Evan refused to become an apostle.

If Evan accepts becoming an apostle again, <Apostle Selection> could proceed normally.

It was just a possibility, but still.

But the postponement of <Apostle Selection> itself was not the first time.

There was enough room to hope for the possibility of completing <Apostle Selection>.

I had to persuade Evan somehow.

I moved my finger to activate the conversation with Eutenia.

“Eutenia. You have to go and get the newcomer.”

There is no way for me to persuade the character in the game in a normal way.

The only way I can use is to send someone who can communicate with the character directly to Evan.

And the only one who could do that for me was Eutenia.

Squeak.

I activated the chat window and sent a message to Eutenia asking her to bring Evan somehow.

Of course, the message I sent was translated into a plausible language by the speech bubble translator and sent.

-“Welcome a new apostle. The one who lost his light will find a new path.”

Chapter 27: The Corrupted Sword

(5)

< 27 : The Corrupted Sword (5) >

“Haa, ha...!”

Evan looked around, breathing heavily.

He had felt a sense of dread after facing the minion of the evil god and ran away for hours.

The sky had darkened and the sunset was casting its glow.

The horse he had been riding was swept away by the evil god’s magic long ago.

Evan couldn’t help but feel a great loss for losing his horse.

He had grown fond of the horse while traveling through the empire’s territory.

And what was more inconvenient was the fact that he had to walk on his own legs across the vast land of the empire.

“Phew, maybe I’ve finally gotten away...”

Evan gently rubbed his chest, which was starting to ache.

Maybe it was because he had run too hard to survive.

His lungs were in pain from breathing roughly.

The evil god's magic that had been chasing him also seemed to have disappeared at some point.

Maybe he could take a rest now.

He calmed his breath and looked for a suitable place to rest.

That was when he heard a stern voice in his ear.

-“Accept your fate.”

It was the mysterious voice that had been echoing repeatedly since he met the apostle of the evil god.

The unidentified voice kept throwing meaningful words at Evan.

But even though the voice echoed, there was no magic falling from the sky toward Evan.

There was no response when he tried to talk to it.

It just repeated the same words to Evan periodically.

Evan realized that it was nothing but a trick of the evil god after hearing it over and over again.

“...Shut up.”

He snapped at the unknown voice and walked forward, looking ahead.

He felt a bitter taste in his mouth after walking on the mountain road for a long time.

Gulp.

He swallowed his saliva and moved his creaking legs.

His eyes caught something far away as he walked silently.

A little ahead of the rugged mountain road.

There was a small village there.

“A village?”

Evan’s face brightened when he saw the village.

He was feeling a severe thirst after running for so long.

If there was a village, he could get some water to drink.

If he was lucky, he might be able to solve his lodging problem as well.

He hoped that the villagers would be friendly to outsiders and moved toward the village.

He had served the god and sacrificed himself for the people all his life, so he thought it wouldn’t hurt to ask for some luck.

“...”

Thud. Thud.

His footsteps echoed on the dense mountain road.

How many more steps did he force himself to take?

He kept moving forward and soon reached the entrance of the village.

The village in the valley was much smaller than he had expected.

There were wooden houses built crudely, and not many of them either.

As he approached the village, a villager who was standing at the entrance asked him:

“Who are you? I’ve never seen you before.”

“...Evan Allemier. I’m a pilgrim who left the holy land and wandered around the empire. Can I get some water if it’s not too much trouble?”

The villager tilted his head after hearing Evan’s story.

Was there something wrong with his identity that he made up?

Evan looked at him nervously with his eyes.

The villager hesitated for a moment and then nodded at Evan.

“Water? I can spare you some water.”

“I’m sorry to ask for your help.”

“You seem to be a follower of the god, so I understand. I have no reason not to give you such a simple help.”

It seemed that he could get some water from the villager fortunately.

The villager left his spot and soon came back with a bowl in his hand.

There was water filled in the bowl that he brought to Evan.

It was the first cool water he had seen in hours.

The water was a bit dirty, but it was drinkable enough.

He was about to drink the water by bringing the bowl to his mouth when he felt something.

-“Accept your fate.”

He instinctively threw away the bowl that he was holding as he felt something.

It was an action that stemmed from his intuition.

The water barely touched his lips before he dropped it.

Swoosh.

He quickly drew his sword and looked behind him.

There was a sharp spear of lightning that appeared in the sky out of nowhere.

“Wh-what are you doing?”

“Oh God—!”

Evan ignored the villager’s panicked scream and infused his sword with holy power.

His sword glowed with faith and vibrated once.

The evil god who had been chasing him had somehow found him again.

This meant that hiding in the village was no longer possible.

Crackle. Crackle.

The spear of lightning from the sky aimed at Evan and shot at him.

He took a deep breath and swung his sword to deflect the evil god’s attack.

“Th-thunder...?”

Boom!

The lightning spear that bounced off Evan’s sword hit the ground and exploded.

The explosion was so loud that it made the ears of the villagers who were watching numb. They flinched at the sight.

Evan, who had deflected the attack that was flying towards him, took a deep breath and looked at the villager.

He wanted to check if he was safe from the god's attack.

“Are you okay? Be careful not to get hurt...”

“Aaah! More, more are coming!”

“What...?”

As Evan turned his head, a rain of lightning began to pour down from the sky.

Kwang! Bang! Kwaang!

The lightning spears that rained from the sky swept away everything in the village.

Evan felt his head go blank as he saw the lightning storm in front of him.

It was an absurd number of magic spells.

It was a scene that could be called a natural disaster.

Evan couldn't stop it alone.

It was beyond his range of ability.

“Sa-save me...”

The villager who was in front of Evan clung to his feet and begged him.

Evan, who saw that, felt his hand holding the sword tremble.

He was weak.

He couldn't even save the person who was suffering in front of him.

He became a paladin to save people.

But he couldn't even properly save the people who were dying in front of him.

"It's because I came here..."

The god was only after Evan.

The reason why the god attacked this place was because Evan had come to this village.

He couldn't save the people who were dying because he was weak.

It was all because of Evan.

It was because Evan was weak.

If only he had a little more power.

If he had the power to save people from the god's attack, this tragedy wouldn't have happened.

"Pilgrim!"

He needed power.

But even so, the goddess of honor didn't look at him.

She didn't answer his prayers that called out to her.

The only one who looked at Evan was the god from beyond the dimension.

Crack.

Evan, who clenched his teeth at his pitiful situation, pushed away the villager who clung to his feet.

And then he warned him with a cold voice.

"I'll draw his attention. If you don't want to die, run away somewhere."

“Huh...?”

“If you understand, move quickly.”

“...Yes, yes!”

The villager who understood Evan’s words started to run away hesitantly.

Kang! Kank!

Evan deflected a few more lightning bolts that fell from the sky, and then ran in the opposite direction of where the villager was moving.

His goal was the deep mountain range where no one lived.

If Evan didn’t go to the village himself, there would be no chance for other villagers to be swept away by the god’s attack.

-“Accept your fate.”

He ignored the voice that echoed in his head, and kept running towards the mountain.

He had to get away.

From the village where people lived.

And from the god who looked at him.

That was the only way for Evan Allemier to keep his faith.

Two days had passed in game time since I used <Apostle Selection> on Evan Allemier.

During that time, I had been busy following Evan around and tormenting him.

I didn't do anything too serious to bother Evan though.

I just turned on the game whenever I was bored and threw <Lightning Arrow> around him.

Of course, I was careful not to hit Evan directly if possible.

It would be troublesome for me if Evan died and [Divine Skill: Astraphe] got locked up again.

Sometimes I also spammed <Lightning> skill next to Evan when he was sleeping.

I couldn't stand seeing him sleep peacefully after he swallowed my 400 karma.

-“Oh goddess.”

Every time I did something radical to annoy Evan, he clasped his hands and prayed to his goddess.

He seemed to be a devout paladin.

He showed that he didn't lose his faith in his goddess even in difficult situations.

How pure must a character be to pray even when he was suffering from extreme pain?

If it were me, I would have cursed at the goddess who didn't help me long ago.

I admired him as I watched him from my perspective.

“You're amazing. You're the best.”

I gave him a sound of applause instead of <Lightning> skill.

Kwaring! Bang! Kwarrung!

Every time a cheerful thunder sound echoed, Evan got up with his sword and started spinning around.

He seemed to be dancing along with my applause.

When Evan started moving like that, I matched him with a catchy beat made of <Lightning>.

Kwaring! Kwaring! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

As he heard the beat made of <Lightning>, Evan spun around faster.

Of course, he kept looking around cautiously, but he never stopped praying to his goddess.

-“Oh goddess of honor.”

I wondered how great the goddess was that I wanted to see her face at this point.

Evan Allemier.

He was a very faithful character.

Unless I broke his will properly, there would be no chance for Evan to accept <Apostle Selection>.

And a simple whip was not enough to do that. That was the conclusion I came to after a few days.

Eventually, Eutenia’s intervention was inevitable.

“It’s about time for Eutenia to step in.”

I had to use another character to persuade Evan directly.

And if I knew Eutenia well, she would be able to convince Evan.

No, she had to.

There was 400 karma at stake for Evan.

That's when I was about to send a message to Eutenia.

-“Oh goddess of honor, goddess of abundance, goddess of knowledge, goddess of hunting, goddess of order... Please help me, anyone.”

Evan, who had been wandering around for a while, finally stuck his sword into the ground and started praying.

But the target of his prayer was different from before.

He started spitting out the names of other goddesses along with the goddess of honor.

He had been calling out to his goddess all day long.

But it seemed like he served more than one god.

Chapter 28: The Corrupted Sword

(6)

< 28 : The Corrupted Sword (6) >

A small cave in the mountains.

Evan, who was sleeping in the darkness, opened his eyes.

Blink. Blink.

He prepared his eyes to adapt to the darkness without light.

After finishing the dark adaptation, Evan got up from his seat and felt a dull sensation in his ears.

He felt a cold feeling in his body that was leaning against the cave wall and sleeping.

“There must have been some noise...”

What woke Evan from his sleep was an unidentified sound.

Evan moved with his sword to find the source of the sound.

Thud. Thud.

The sound of footsteps echoed in the cave as he stepped.

In the cave where no one was, only Evan’s presence was felt.

Evan came out of the cave and started looking for the source of the sound.

“There doesn’t seem to be anything suspicious.”

But there was no trace outside the cave.

He didn’t even feel any signs of animals passing by.

Under the bright night sky, only the quiet scenery of the forest entered Evan’s eyes.

Evan couldn’t understand what had woken him from his sleep.

It was at the moment when Evan moved to get some fresh air in the peaceful-looking forest.

-“Accept your fate.”

As Evan tried to move away from the cave a little more.

A lightning spear appeared in the sky.

Crackle.

The lightning spear that appeared scattering sparks slowly changed direction.

It started to aim at Evan with the lightning spear and Evan hurriedly jumped into the cave.

Bang! Boom!

As soon as Evan entered the cave, a thunderstorm began to pour down.

He lifted his sword with both hands at the thunderous sound that echoed violently outside the cave.

“O Goddess—!”

A bright light burst out of his hand holding the sword.

It was divine power, a unique possession of paladins who had firm faith.

The bright divine power that burst out became a lantern that lit up the dark cave.

Evan hid in the cave and waited for the lightning storm to pass while praying.

The only thing Evan could rely on now was his sword that emitted light.

“Guide me, please.”

Was it a struggle for survival?

Or was it a desire for salvation?

He couldn't decide which one his prayer was, and he kept looking at his sword filled with light.

The moment of salvation had not yet come.

There was no promise left when it would come.

But Evan kept holding his sword and praying.

That was the qualification to be called a paladin.

It had been three days since Evan was trapped in the cave.

During that time, he sat in his seat, prayed and slept repeatedly.

Of course, there were moments when he wanted to go outside from time to time.

They were moments when hunger and thirst came up impulsively.

-“Accept your fate.”

Every time he tried to go outside, he saw the falling lightning spears and hid again.

The thunderstorm hit violently every time Evan went outside.

His body, which had not eaten or drunk anything for several days, had become quite weak.

He couldn't even be sure that he could block the attack of the evil god as before.

In the end, there was only one way for Evan to choose.

"...O Goddess. I swear I will be a paladin who follows your will."

He was hungry.

And thirsty.

His hand holding the sword firmly didn't have enough strength.

But Evan kept reciting the oath of a paladin with his dry and cracked lips.

The current pain was only temporary.

To forget the pain in front of him, it was better to focus entirely on prayer.

For that, he chose the oath of a paladin that he had uttered when he first became a paladin.

"I swear I will protect your honor."

His lips cracked every time he uttered a word.

His throat losing moisture cried out for pain as if it would tear periodically.

The sound coming out of his mouth gradually decreased.

But Evan continued to pray on.

“I swear I will fight for my honor.”

There are many trials in a person’s life.

The current trial was just one of many trials.

To overcome trials, only those who can do so can move on to a more valuable direction.

Evan was a person who had such a thought.

And he chose faith and prayer as a way to overcome it.

“I swear I will annihilate evil ones and save weak ones.”

He followed the light all his life.

He believed that saving others and punishing evil would someday become the light that would save him.

He never doubted that the brightest light shining far away was the answer.

So now he had to go towards that light.

Only the sun shining in front of his eyes could be the signpost for the future.

“So, O Goddess, please guide me to the right path.”

So, O Goddess.

If you hear this voice,

If you see the frail lamb with your eyes,

Please guide me to the right path.

It had been five days since Evan was trapped in the cave.

He could somehow suppress his hunger, but his thirst was unbearable.

So Evan used the water that was pooled on the floor of the cave to keep his throat moist.

But there was a limit to using only the water that was pooled in the cave.

People die without water.

Evan, who reached his limit, eventually drew his sword.

“O Goddess. Guide me.”

He couldn’t survive by being trapped in the cave forever.

He would either starve to death. Or fight and die.

There were only two choices left for Evan.

If there were no sane options left, then there was only one path he could take.

He would not wait for a false salvation.

He had to carve his own way with his own hands.

He would rather die fighting than die miserably.

Evan made up his mind and raised his holy power with a prayer.

“Please guide me to the right path.”

Clang.

The sword he lifted was imbued with a sacred light.

The intense light that rose up was more majestic than ever before.

It was the holy fire that burned everything he had.

Evan stepped out with his sword in hand, feeling that this was his last moment.

He would fight the evil god when he came.

He would cut down the apostles of the evil god with his sword.

That was the path given to Evan, the holy knight.

-“Accept your fate.”

As Evan stepped out, he heard the voice of the evil god in his ears.

But Evan ignored him and moved forward.

He had to go out to live like a human being.

Evan followed his faith and drew his sword and kept advancing.

As Evan’s footsteps moved away from the cave, lightning spears appeared one by one in the distant sky.

The fierce arrows of malice aimed at Evan and demanded him to run away.

“I will decide my own fate!”

It was his destiny to face his end as a holy knight.

Evan took a stance and pointed his sword at the falling thunderbolts.

He could block them if he swung his sword.

He could move forward if he blocked them.

A fierce scream came out of Evan’s mouth as he gripped his sword.

“Come at me! You wicked evil god!”

One more step forward than now.

Evan swung his shining sword.

Clang! Clang!

Every time he swung his sword with a glow, one of the evil god's blows was cut off.

Evan was stronger now than ever before.

His eyes filled with determination faced the evil god who looked down on him.

“I am Evan Allemier, the Inquisitor of the Holy Land!”

There was only one thing he wanted to protect.

His proud self at this moment.

Evan had to be a holy knight of the Holy Land.

He also had to be an Inquisitor who protected the Holy Land.

That was the fate that Evan chose for himself.

“Evil god! Receive your judgment!”

Evan shouted in a confident voice toward the evil god.

A strong resolve rose in Evan's heart as he confronted the evil god.

Only to take one more step forward.

He put everything he had into swinging his sword.

And he failed.

A dark and silent cave engulfed in darkness.

There, Evan, who was covered in blood, stabbed his sword into the ground.

A dark light rose from the sword that Evan stabbed in.

It was only now that he had achieved a level of growth as a holy knight.

Even though it meant nothing against the evil god.

“Sigh...”

Crack.

He heard a sound of cracking from his clenched teeth.

Evan felt a metallic taste in his mouth and then looked at the sword he stabbed into the ground.

A clear light flowed from Evan’s sword.

It was proof of a glorious holy knight.

Even in the Holy Land, there were few knights who had such a light on their swords.

“So I... survived again.”

Evan muttered to himself as he looked at his sword.

A white aura flickered in front of Evan’s eyes.

It was a warm and gentle light.

Anyone who faced this light would believe in the existence of the goddess and offer their prayers.

But Evan did not have any faith left to pray now.

“Why...”

He could not die.

Even as he broke down and became ragged, death was always a fear that approached him.

In the end, Evan gave up resisting and returned.

He could not move forward with his own strength.

He needed someone else’s help to get out of here.

And there was only one being left who could help Evan.

“Why won’t you help me!”

Evan’s angry voice echoed in the cave.

Even though the evil god came after him and sought him out, the goddess of honor did not help him at all.

The trial that faced Evan still had no end in sight.

He was hungry.

And thirsty.

But he could not eat even a piece of bread, nor drink even a sip of water.

He, a holy knight, lived worse than a street rat.

“Why are you just watching me from above! When that wicked evil god is constantly watching me!”

If the goddess had helped him a little bit.

Or at least gave him some water to quench his thirst.

He would have kept shouting the name of the goddess in this dark cave.

Believing that one day, the day of salvation would come.

But the goddess never looked at Evan even once.

The closest thing to Evan was the evil god.

The monster of the sky that swallowed innocent people with lightning.

“I keep calling you—!”

There was no answer to his screaming voice.

But Evan kept shouting the name of the goddess.

His eyes that held his sword were red.

At this moment, Evan felt like he was abandoned by everything in the world.

The only thing left was Evan himself.

He felt an endless loneliness rising in his chest.

“I, I, what have I been doing until now...!”

- “Accept your fate.”

Evan’s head went cold at the voice of the evil god calling him.

What had he just said with his own mouth?

He had denied God.

He had insulted God, blamed God, and rejected his own foundation.

He who did not serve God was no longer a holy knight.

Evan Allemier.

He was a human who wanted to die as a holy knight.

He realized his situation and let go of his sword.

“Oh Goddess! I dared to doubt you!”

Thud! Thud! Thud!

He slammed his forehead hard on the cave floor.

The light that flowed from his stabbed sword became fainter.

He did not give in to the fading light, and he kept hitting his head on the ground.

Blood flowed from his forehead and ran down his cheeks.

“I dared to, doubt you...”

Despite his reddening vision, he continued to offer prayers of apology.

There was no salvation for those who doubted God.

All he could do now was to ask for forgiveness from the Goddess who looked at him.

His voice calling God echoed in the cave.

Even though he knew that there was no response to his act, he never stopped his voice.

At some point, Evan stopped counting time.

He just looked at the sword in his hand.

His light had weakened since he doubted the Goddess.

He could not light up the cave with a strong glow as before.

The only thing left for Evan now was a sword that he held heavily in his hand.

“...”

There was no sound of prayer from his mouth either.

Evan quietly looked at his sword.

The sword that had been through countless battles with him was now badly damaged.

Evan's sword had always been with him.

Even if the Goddess of Honor completely abandoned him, the sword he held would stay with him until the end.

He looked at his chipped sword and got up from his seat.

“Sigh...”

A heavy sigh came out of Evan's mouth.

The silent time he spent trapped in the cave.

During that time, he had thought about his future countless times.

What he should do.

What was the right way left for him.

And now he had reached a conclusion.

“What a pathetic life.”

Swoosh.

He brought the sword he held to his neck.

This was the result of a long time of thinking.

He could not escape from the evil god's sight alive.

If he decided to die in a proper way, this was the only way left for him.

He smiled bitterly and put strength into his hand holding the sword.

“What a pitiful sight.”

A sweet girl's voice echoed in the cave.

It was a very familiar voice to Evan.

The First Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost.

The apostle of the evil god appeared in front of Evan.

Evan lowered his sword from his neck.

The sacred light rose from the sword he held.

“Did you come to mock me?”

His sword emitted a feeble glow.

It was a weak sight compared to before.

No one would remember him as an Inquisitor by looking at him now.

Click. Click.

Eutenia approached Evan with a relaxed step.

“I don't know. Maybe.”

“...”

Evan raised his light to cut down Eutenia who came closer to him.

His hand holding the sword felt heavier than before.

But until Eutenia came right in front of him, Evan's sword did not swing.

Eutenia's hand moved toward Evan who stood still.

“Holy knight, have you broken down?”

Eutenia stroked Evan's cheek with her hand.

As her cold touch brushed past his cheek, Evan felt no strength in his sword.

He was not bound by any magic.

It was just that his body felt fear on its own and stopped.

What was he afraid of now?

Evan tried to shake off his weakness by recalling the spark that remained in him.

“...”

He liked people's smiling faces.

He liked the people of the temple who welcomed him.

That's why he decided to become a holy knight.

He wanted to protect people's smiling faces with his own hands, and spread God's will across the continent.

He saved countless people while working as a holy knight.

Even if no one praised him for that obvious deed, it was an act that came from believing that the Goddess would watch over his good deeds.

“I...”

His voice did not come out well because of his dry throat.

He had something to say, but he could not spit it out properly.

He was an Inquisitor belonging to the Temple of Honor.

He always had to be more pure than others, and more devout than anyone in the temple.

The moment his faith was shaken, his value as an Inquisitor was gone.

But he could not say anything about himself.

He had doubted his faith many times.

He had seen God turn away from him in the darkness.

Who would believe him if he claimed to be pure?

“I...”

His eyes looked at Eutenia in silence.

She was an apostle of the evil god.

Maybe he could kill her with his sword now.

But his hand holding the sword did not move.

The light from his sword flickered and mocked his precarious state.

What could he do with this weak sword?

What he held now was nothing but an illusion.

The illusion of his past as a holy knight of the Temple.

-“Accept your fate.”

Accept your fate.

He heard the familiar voice of the evil god.

The fate that was set for him.

What was the fate given to him?

The strength slowly left his hand holding the sword.

He had lived glorious days.

But there was no glory at the end of this road.

In the end, at the end of this long ordeal, he was no longer a holy knight.

He was not a holy knight now.

He was not an Inquisitor either.

And now he was—

“I am... a weak human.”

Thud.

The light of faith went out.

Chapter 29: Apostle of Thunder (1)

< 29 : Apostle of Thunder (1) >

-[Second Apostle: Evan Allemier] has become your apostle.

-Due to the effect of <Apostle Selection>, you will share your magic power with the selected apostles.

-Due to the effect of <Apostle Selection>, you will be able to send separate messages to the selected apostles.

It had been a few days since I started spending time to convert Evan, whom I had chosen as an apostle.

Maybe my bold investment over the past few days paid off.

As soon as Eutenia entered the cave to persuade him, Evan accepted <Apostle Selection> as if he had been waiting for it.

Even though Eutenia didn't say much, Evan quickly gave up and put down his sword.

The [Divine Artifact: Astraphe] that was sealed by accepting <Apostle Selection> was also completely liberated.

“I finally became an apostle.”

I made Evan, who used to be a paladin, my apostle.

He was incomparable to ordinary characters.

If he used the [Divine Artifact: Astraphe] that I created by consuming karma, he would surely become a much more powerful being than most characters.

I immediately opened my inventory and checked the effect of [Divine Artifact: Astraphe].

The divine artifacts that I created using <Apostle Selection> had different characteristics attached to them.

“Blue Flash? It sounds like a very good characteristic just by reading the description.”

The [Divine Artifact: Astraphe] that was bound to Evan had a characteristic called <Blue Flash>.

<Blue Flash>.

The effect of this characteristic was twofold.

One.

It continuously consumes magic power and transforms the user’s body into lightning for a certain period of time.

Two.

It shares all the skills that inflict lightning damage with me.

In other words, it was a characteristic specialized in inflicting elemental damage.

“So you’re going to be a magic swordsman instead of a paladin.”

A sword imbued with light and a sword imbued with lightning.

I didn’t know which one was stronger.

But considering Eutenia's precedent, it was certain that Evan would become incredibly strong after receiving the divine artifact.

I dragged an item from my inventory and placed it in front of Evan.

[Divine Artifact: Astraphe] was a piece of equipment shaped like a light gauntlet.

Thud.

As the divine artifact fell in front of Evan, Eutenia picked it up and handed it to Evan's hand.

Evan looked at Eutenia with a puzzled expression as he received the divine artifact.

-“This is...”

-“It's a proof that the great one has chosen you.”

-“Proof?”

-“You are now an apostle who serves the great one.”

Evan, who was looking at the dark gauntlet, nodded his head and put it on his hand.

As soon as [Divine Artifact: Astraphe] was worn on Evan's hand, blue lightning burst out and a speech bubble appeared above Evan's head.

By wearing the divine artifact, I was able to send messages directly to Evan.

The current flowing through Evan's body showed why the characteristic was called <Blue Flash>.

Evan's eyes sparkled as he wore Astraphe.

-“...An apostle of God.”

-“Did you like his gift?”

-“To be honest, I don’t think I deserve to receive such a thing.”

Crackle. Crackle.

Evan, who was sparking lightning around him, picked up the sword that had fallen on the ground.

As soon as Evan gripped the sword with the gauntlet on, blue lightning burst out from the sword he was holding.

The light of lightning overflowing enough to blind the eyes.

He looked at it and lifted his sword.

Evan Allemier.

He spoke with a devout expression as he looked at his sword.

-“Still, I will ask you.”

-“O God who looks down on the earth. What fate should I accept?”

Maybe it was because he used to be a character who was a paladin.

Evan showed me a polite attitude even when facing me.

Every word that came out of his mouth was holy.

Maybe he would show me the same blind loyalty that he had for the goddess.

As I wondered what to answer to Evan’s question, I noticed his face soaked in fatigue.

“Come to think of it, I’ve been pretty rough on him.”

I had been disturbing his sleep and blocking his movement for days.

It was quite a long time in game time.

If he had been starving and trapped in a cave for a long time, his fatigue would not be ordinary.

He used to be my enemy until recently, but now he was a character who moved for me.

It was right to treat him well, since he became my character.

That way, he would bring me more things that would benefit me.

Just like Eutenia, whom I had spent time and raised before.

“First, eat something.”

I dragged a bread from my inventory and placed it in front of Evan.

Thud.

Evan caught the baguette that fell on the opposite side of his hand.

Evan’s eyes looked up at the sky as he held the baguette.

I looked up at the sky and gave him a plausible impression using the message function.

“It’s a meal that I personally give you.”

It was a baguette that cost 7,000 won. No, it was 8,000 won now.

It was not something I gave lightly.

Maybe my answer was a bit lacking in dignity.

The speech bubble translator repackaged my message and delivered it to Evan.

-“I will fill your hunger and quench your long thirst.”

-“Then witness the truth.”

It was just a word to eat something first.

It felt like a god-like speech that I couldn't help but admire.

Seeing my message, Evan asked me again.

-“Truth? What exactly is the truth?”

“That's right. What is that truth?”

That was a word that the speech bubble translator spit out on its own.

I was curious about what the truth was, too, because of the exaggerated answer.

Of course, the speech bubble translator also prepared an answer for that, and fluently replied to Evan.

-“Harvest the wicked ones. Then I will use them as food and return to my rightful place.”

-“Destroy the idols of false faith and erect your faith in their place.”

Evan tore the bread in silence at the translator's unique answer.

He seemed to have nothing more to say at the textbook-like answer.

It was amazing how the AI's performance felt more and more amazing as I watched it.

I, Hus Allemier, a second-class investigator of the imperial execution agency, Cloud, looked at the documents with a tired gaze.

It had been a month since I requested help from the holy city to unravel the mysterious disappearance cases.

And the one who came to help me was my brother, Evan Allemier, a heretic inquisitor.

I had to spend a few days in exhaustion, watching out for Evan who came in person.

But even after Evan left, who was investigating the surroundings, my mind was never at ease.

The cult of the evil god was moving.

I heard it directly from Evan, the heretic inquisitor.

Since then, I had to tremble every day with anxiety that the cult might move.

It was something that even the heretic inquisitor admitted.

It was almost a fact that the cult was showing signs of movement near here.

“Another disappearance case.”

My gaze, which was looking at the disappearance cases with him, also changed.

It was a case that happened several times a month, but still, I couldn't help but suspect the cult's movements.

There was a cult that offered people to the evil god.

If there was a suspicious group nearby, it was natural to suspect them first.

But just because I suspected them, I couldn't go around searching recklessly.

I had already lost one investigator.

If I forced an investigation with insufficient power without forming a subjugation team, I couldn't rule out the risk of being attacked by the cult's

fanatics.

If I lost more troops, I wouldn't be able to avoid responsibility.

Even if I couldn't stand it in the branch office of the frontier, it was obvious how my brothers and family would look at me.

"Sigh... It's frustrating when I'm not sure."

But if I kept still, I would be scolded from above.

It was a dilemma.

Hus sighed and reached out for a piece of paper nearby.

He intended to ask Evan about the progress of his work in the holy city.

Evan had gone to report that the cult had appeared himself, so by now, the holy city must have reached a conclusion.

He felt like he could focus more on his work if he heard that a subjugation team had been formed in the holy city.

"I wonder if they have reached a decision in Crossbridge..."

Hus's hand stopped as he picked up his pen to write a letter to Evan.

He felt a sudden pain in his right arm as he tried to write a letter.

He put down his pen and rolled up his sleeve on his right arm.

A black mark appeared on his skin as he rolled up his sleeve.

He opened his mouth wide as he saw the familiar mark on his arm.

"This is..."

A black feather pen tilted slightly.

As far as Hus knew, who was from a prestigious family, the picture on his right arm was the mark of the Temple of Knowledge.

There was only one case where the mark of the temple suddenly appeared on someone's arm.

Hero emergence.

The mark given to heroes who resisted the advent of the evil god.

“Does this mean I’ve been chosen as a hero?”

Hus's finger stroked the feather pen engraved on his arm.

The fact that he had the mark of knowledge meant that Hus Allemier had been chosen as one of the most important people of this era, a hero.

It was not any other temple, but the Temple of Knowledge.

The place that revered wisdom and magic would make him a great mage.

He recalled the image of the temple located in Crossbridge and smiled faintly at his lips.

“A hero... This is not a bad story.”

He put back the paper he had taken out.

There was no need to write a letter to Evan anymore.

He could go to the holy city himself now.

Besides, he didn't need to work as a second-class investigator of Cloud anymore either.

Hus was a hero chosen by the goddess of knowledge herself.

Who would dare stop him from going to the holy city as a hero chosen by the goddess?

It was also his last day to see the annoying face of his branch manager today.

“Most of all, I’m looking forward to seeing my brother’s expression.”

What he was most looking forward to was his brother’s reaction when he faced him.

Evan was a heretic inquisitor of the holy city.

And Hus was one of the most important people in the holy city, a hero.

How would Evan look at his brother who became a hero?

He certainly wouldn’t be able to keep his stern face as before.

Hus looked forward to meeting his brother with a satisfied face and pushed away the documents in the corner.

He felt like he would be happy all day today.

Chapter 30: Apostle of Thunder (2)

< 30 : Apostle of Thunder (2) >

Inside the crude and shabby cult.

There, under Roan's guidance, a feast was held for the new apostle.

The large table was filled with appetizing breads and vegetables.

Of course, these dishes were prepared by the cult's followers who followed Roan's instructions.

Roan, who had spent his life training only dark magic, could not make any food other than drugs.

"Congratulations on becoming a new apostle!"

Roan raised his voice and congratulated Evan, who was sitting at the table.

Evan looked at him with a subtle expression.

He was the one who tried to kill him with his own sword.

But now he was receiving congratulations for becoming an apostle of the evil god, which made him feel awkward.

Roan acted as if nothing had happened, and Evan pretended to be fine and replied.

"...Thanks. I appreciate your congratulations."

"I heard that you got an amazing ability this time."

“An amazing ability.”

“Didn’t you get the ability to control lightning? I know how powerful his lightning is, because I also used it for a while.”

Evan looked at the Astrape that he was wearing on his hand.

He had not yet tested the performance of this device properly.

But he knew well that this device had an enormous power.

As it had various abilities, he would be able to gain overwhelming strength compared to before if his proficiency increased.

Moreover, Evan was now receiving a huge amount of magic instead of divine power.

He nodded his head and agreed with the feeling of his power being more abundant than before.

“He gave me a powerful power. It’s too much for me.”

It was a power that he had obtained by selling his faithful faith.

It was natural that he felt some resistance to using it.

Nevertheless, Evan did not intend to abandon his given task.

It was the direction he chose with his own will.

Even if it was a broken faith, Evan had to bear the consequences.

If he was going to fall into hell, he had to fall to the bottom of hell.

That was the only way left for Evan, who had chosen the wrong path.

“With you as an apostle, there will be nothing to fear in our cult for a while.”

Roan tilted his wine glass with a light laugh.

Evan also lifted his glass and drank along with him.

When he was in the holy land, he did not drink as a principle, but when he returned to his family, he sometimes enjoyed wine.

He smiled bitterly at the taste of wine that he had not drunk for a long time.

He did not know where he got it from, but it was not a bad wine for Evan.

It seemed like something that would cost quite a lot.

Evan tore off some bread and drank wine, then suddenly turned his eyes to the corner of the table.

“Hey, who is that guy?”

In the corner where Evan’s eyes met, Peter was eating bread with an awkward expression.

Even from Evan’s perspective, who joined them for the first time today, Peter’s appearance stood out especially.

He did not look like a follower of the cult, nor did he look like a worker.

He did not do much work either.

Peter tore off some bread with his fingers and opened his mouth in surprise when he saw Evan pointing at him.

“Uh... are you talking about me?”

“Yeah. You don’t look like an ordinary follower.”

“I am...”

Peter stuttered in response to Evan’s question.

With bread in his hand, Peter's eyes kept wandering in the air.

Thud. Thud.

Evan's fingers tapped on the table slowly with his gauntlet on.

It was clearly a gesture to urge him to answer quickly.

Seeing Peter unable to give a clear answer, Roan stepped in to save him.

"Oh, Peter? He is the servant and assistant of the first apostle."

"...Servant?"

"Servant and assistant? Is he not a follower of the cult?"

"Not yet. He has not officially joined the cult yet, but he must also revere him in his heart."

Evan became interested in Roan's answer.

He was not a follower of the cult, but a mere servant.

Evan tilted his wine glass again and drank it.

Then he looked at Roan and asked him about the cult.

"I'm surprised. I thought you were sacrificing everyone you saw. Isn't that what you were doing?"

"No. We don't do that."

Eutenia answered Evan's question instead of Roan.

She did not touch the wine, but ate bread with dignity.

Evan asked again at Eutenia's answer that denied his words.

"...What are you talking about?"

“The humans we sacrifice are only the unbelievers.”

“Unbelievers?”

Several villages had disappeared completely.

It was a fact that Evan had confirmed himself by riding a horse around.

Yet Eutenia denied that they had sacrificed the whole village.

Evan looked at Eutenia with a doubtful gaze, and Eutenia continued to explain.

“Peter is also a survivor from the village.”

“Survivor? So you leave those who serve him alone?”

“Yes. If everyone serves him, then we will have to find other sacrifices.”

Evan thought of a small possibility in his mind at Eutenia’s words.

They only sacrifice those who do not serve the god.

The cult’s method was not much different from the inquisitors’ work.

Except that their actions were radical and their targets were too broad.

What if they could convert everyone they reached to their cult?

Then there might be a situation where no one would be sacrificed.

Whether it was realistic or not, the important thing was that there was such a possibility.

“Let’s change our method from now on.”

“What method do you want?”

“We’ll take a few days to convert them. We can sacrifice them later.”

“Do you mean we should spend more time spreading his teachings?”

“Yes. If more people serve him, he will be very pleased.”

What was his destiny as an apostle?

The god of the other world told him to straighten his faith.

What their master wanted was one thing.

To drive out the six temples and their gods, and carve his name in their place.

He said that if he could accomplish that great task, it would not matter if he influenced the existing method a little.

So Evan was able to make a decision about what he had to do.

“Are you satisfied with that?”

“That’s enough for me.”

“Then let’s decide to do that from now on. There’s no problem, right, Roan?”

“Of course not. Who would oppose expanding the power of the cult?”

Evan looked at the gauntlet in his hand after hearing the confirmation from the members of the cult.

His destiny was to save people.

And for that, the whole holy land had to collapse.

The reason why the war repeated was only one.

The six temples defined their master as an evil god, and kept moving their troops to subjugate him.

As long as the six temples and the god of the other world were opposed, this infinite cycle would continue endlessly.

But what if his new master took their place instead of the six temples?

Then there would be no more war.

In a world ruled by the god of the other world, everyone would forget about heroes and apostles and live a peaceful life.

“If everyone serves him, there will be no more chaos or strife.”

Evan started pouring wine into his empty glass with a new goal in mind.

To suppress the cult and drive out the six temples of the holy land.

That was Evan’s new goal.

There was no salvation in this world just because there was a god who existed.

But by destroying Crossbridge, he could save more lives that would die in the future.

It was enough for him to be the only one who dirtied his hands.

If Evan wore all the blood and sin and fell into hell, then peaceful days would follow after that.

“Phew...”

In the middle of the noisy feast.

Peter escaped from the cult’s building and sighed.

He managed to get into the feast by joining the cult’s schedule, but the atmosphere of the cult was hard for Peter to adapt to.

He was not even a member of the cult in the first place.

It was so bad that he was treated as a servant, who used to be an outsider.

It was natural that Peter felt uncomfortable.

“How did I end up like this?”

Peter muttered as he put some bread that he had brought from the feast in his mouth.

The cult distributed bread at mealtime.

If he did not sneak into the followers' gap at mealtime and get some bread, he would have to starve and endure it.

That was also why he followed Eutenia into the banquet hall this time.

If he did not fill his stomach by looking around, he would have to skip dinner.

And now he could not go back to his village either, because it had been gone for a long time.

The more he thought about it, the more miserable he felt.

“Besides, I have this weird mark on my arm.”

Peter rolled up his sleeve and looked at his arm.

There was a black pattern on Peter's arm that had been engraved on him a few days ago.

A shape of a sword piercing through wings.

No matter how he looked at it, it seemed like a mark of an evil god that could be seen even in the dark.

Peter reached out his finger to erase the pattern and rubbed it.

As he did so, a sound of a door opening rang out behind Peter.

“...”

Creak.

The one who came out of the door was Evan.

He came out and looked around, then soon found Peter standing in the corner.

Peter quickly lowered his sleeve and hid his arm as soon as he saw Evan.

He nodded his head reflexively with a feeling that he should not deny it when Evan approached him and asked him a question.

“You’re the one who said you’re Eutenia’s servant.”

“Ah, yes, yes...!”

He had been staring at Peter since inside the banquet hall.

Peter hid his arm behind him in panic as Evan came closer to him until he was right in front of him. Evan looked at Peter’s arm that was hidden behind him and asked him:

“Are you hiding something?”

“No, no! It’s nothing.”

“Nothing, you say...”

“It’s just... a simple mark.”

Chapter 31: Apostle of Thunder (3)

< 31 : Apostle of Thunder (3) >

“It’s just... a simple mark.”

Mark.

Evan’s eyes narrowed as he heard Peter’s story.

Evan reached out and grabbed Peter’s arm.

He then rolled up Peter’s sleeve, trying to confirm the mark that was engraved on his arm.

Peter, who was flustered, tried to shake off Evan’s hand, but his strength was no match for Evan, who had trained in martial arts all his life.

Evan, who rolled up Peter’s sleeve, opened his mouth as he saw the black pattern engraved on his arm.

“This is...”

“Do you know this mark?”

“The mark of a hero.”

Peter’s face hardened as he heard the story.

The mark of a hero.

Peter, who had lived away from the temple all his life, did not know the word hero.

Heroes were beings that came out of old stories from his family.

They each had special weapons and excellent combat skills, and they were strong warriors who defeated the evil god.

Peter's chest began to tighten as he heard stories about heroes.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

He felt dizzy as his heart beat wildly.

What he thought was the mark of the evil god was actually a mark that indicated a hero.

Peter wondered if he had heard it wrong and asked Evan.

“Hey, hero...? Really?”

“It's definitely the mark of a hero. And it's a hero chosen by the goddess of honor.”

Peter's hand began to tremble faintly at Evan's confident voice.

The other person was a knight who belonged to the holy land.

There was no doubt that what he guaranteed was true.

If the story was true, the situation was very dangerous for Peter.

The person in front of him was an apostle who served the evil god.

For him, a hero would be a thorn in his eye.

“Um...”

Peter's head spun furiously as he tried to say something.

He was a hero.

The only threat to him was not Evan, who he was facing right now.

Apostle Eutenia. And Archbishop Roan.

It didn't matter which side found out about his mark, Peter's life would be in danger.

He had to keep his identity secret from everyone in the order to survive.

"What do you want to say?"

The choice that Peter made in desperation was to ask for help from the apostle in front of him.

He didn't know why he made that choice.

But it was the only way that Peter could think of right now.

Evan laughed bitterly at Peter's story.

He let go of Peter's arm and asked him.

"Do you want me to keep it a secret?"

"Yes, yes... I don't want to cause everyone trouble because of one mark."

"You chose a difficult path. It will be a tough fight from now on."

"Yes."

I have to hide the mark among the countless followers of the evil gods in this place.

Peter also knew the risk of that.

He even thought of wrapping it with a bandage, that's how serious it was.

But Evan's words that followed were more shocking than Peter had imagined.

“If you’re going to hide it, hide it thoroughly. From the church’s followers, and from the people of the holy land, all of them.”

“...”

“If either the church or the holy land finds out about the mark you have, they won’t leave you alone.”

It meant that not only the church, but also the six temples of Crossbridge might try to kill Peter.

Peter couldn’t help but wonder why.

Originally, heroes were beings who fought against the evil gods with the temples.

At least the heroes in the old stories that Peter knew did that.

But Evan’s words warned Peter of an unexpected danger.

His words contradicted the common sense that Peter knew.

Peter asked Evan for the reason.

“What do you mean by that? Why would the holy land try to kill me?”

“It’s not hard to change a hero in the early stages of the mark appearing. If you’re the only survivor of a village sacrificed as an offering, you’re a risk factor from the holy land’s perspective.”

“You can change a hero?”

“If the divine power hasn’t been assigned yet, it will take some time, but a hero will appear again.”

It will take some time, but a hero will appear again.

It meant one thing.

If Peter revealed his connection to the church to the people of the temple, he would be killed.

Peter was already deeply involved with the church.

If his past actions were discovered by the holy land, it was natural that they would try to eliminate him.

His head hurt as he clenched his hand around the hero's mark.

Because of this damn mark, he was in a situation where he couldn't even think of running away.

"Of course, it's better not to reveal your identity even after enough time has passed."

"Yes."

"If you reveal your identity to the temple after some time, I'll take care of you myself."

Evan's sharp eyes looked at Peter.

He smiled coldly with his mouth, but his eyes showed complex emotions.

It was a good thing that he didn't kill Peter right now.

But was this apostle in front of him really someone he could call an ally?

Gulp.

Peter swallowed his saliva without realizing it as he faced Evan.

Evan patted Peter's tense shoulder and walked past him to approach the steep road.

"You seem to have trouble understanding why I made this choice."

"That, that's..."

“I was a paladin who served the goddess of honor.”

“Ah...”

Evan looked at the night sky where no one else was.

The bright moon reflected in Evan’s eyes.

He looked at the dark night sky for a moment, then moved his gauntlet to clench his fist tightly.

The sound of metal friction echoed from Evan’s clenched gauntlet.

“I was trapped in a small cave, avoiding the threat of death, and constantly shouting the name of the goddess.”

“Yes.”

“God never answers the call of humans. The only ones who are interested in the weak are the gods from another world who want to take over this world.”

The evil gods who looked down on their world.

The huge presence that looked down on the ground every time he performed a ritual flashed through Peter’s mind.

The god that Peter faced was always one.

The being that coveted the offerings on the ground with its huge eyes.

And the monster that swallowed Peter’s village whole by sending Euteneia.

It was something from another dimension that a mere human could not oppose.

Yet, the great gods who were revered by everyone on the continent never intervened.

All they did was engrave a crude mark on Peter's arm.

"Even if I was a paladin, I never got an answer from the goddess."

Crunch.

The sound of grinding teeth resonated around.

Unlike his calm voice, Evan's eyes were filled with malice as he looked at Peter.

Evan, who faced the sky, raised his hand with the gauntlet in the air.

He looked like he was holding something in his hand.

Evan called out the name of his divine power in a solemn voice.

"——Astraphe."

The moment Evan called out the name of his divine power.

A blue flash began to spread from his hand.

Crackle. Sparkle.

Sparks flew from the flash in his hand as it gradually grew in size.

The flash in Evan's hand formed the shape of a huge spear as time passed.

A strong light that brightened the surroundings.

Evan, who carried the heavy thunder spear, changed his angle and aimed at the sky.

"Those who do not look down on the lower ones do not deserve to rule from above."

As if answering Evan's heart, the thunder spear in his hand trembled violently.

Evan threw the thunder spear in his hand toward the sky.

Kwaaaaang!

The thunder spear that flew from Evan's hand pierced through the clouds in the sky.

A blue trail pierced through the clouds, and at the same time, the clouds that were penetrated by the thunder spear began to emit lightning.

Kwang! Kwarrang!

The thunderclouds that appeared in the sky poured down lightning toward the ground.

Peter's mouth opened wide at the sight of lightning pouring down to the ground.

As lightning rain continued, thunder sounded in Peter's ears one after another.

“...”

The atmosphere that shook.

And below it, the rain of thunder that poured down.

Peter could understand what Evan wanted to say by looking at the scene in front of him.

This was a warning.

Evan, who had become an apostle of an evil god, warned Peter and the goddess who had given him the mark of a hero.

The lightning that filled his sight was not an attack that a human body could withstand.

The moment Peter got out of the church's sight, Evan's attack that he had just seen would fly at him.

"Do you understand what I'm thinking now?"

"...I think I have some idea."

"Good. I'm going to drag them down myself."

A declaration to the sky.

Evan, who spat out a declaration of war, stretched out his hand with a gauntlet toward the air.

Crackle.

A blue thunderbolt burst out of his gauntlet.

Peter looked at his gauntlet wrapped in light and asked Evan.

"Is that really... possible?"

"Do you think it's impossible?"

"That..."

"I rolled on a battlefield and crawled on the ground. I drank muddy water and starved my stomach, but still kept calling God's name."

Peter remembered Evan's miserable appearance.

Evan's appearance when he was brought by Euteneia was very different from when he first met him.

The proud paladin of the first day was gone, and all that was left was a dirty man who was exhausted by hunger and thirst.

If he had such hardships during that time, it was understandable why Evan was so broken.

“I held my sword and prayed for years. I doubted my faith constantly, but tried to keep my mind steady.”

“...”

“If not today, then tomorrow. If not tomorrow, then next time. I believed that salvation would come someday.”

But still, the hope of a paladin was cruelly trampled on.

What he saw was not the goddess he served, but an evil god from another dimension who observed humans.

It broke. It snapped.

He rolled in an abyss and was crushed by darkness.

His firm faith collapsed and beyond that appeared human evil that had no end in sight.

“And yet! And yet if they say this is some kind of joke——!”

Evan’s bloodshot eyes looked at Peter.

Squeak.

He smiled a smile that did not suit his previous solemn appearance.

A twisted smile that felt out of place.

Evan smiled like that and declared to the being who had engraved the mark on Peter.

“Now it’s time to pay the price for my long faith.”

Kwang!

A blue lightning bolt fell behind Evan’s shoulder as he looked at Peter.

Chapter 32: Bipolar (1)

< 32 : Bipolar (1) >

Holy Land, Crossbridge.

Hus Allemier, who arrived at one of the six temples, the Temple of Knowledge, was treated as a guest of honor there.

It had been a long time since a hero with a mark appeared in the Holy Land.

Moreover, Hus was from a noble family of the empire with a clear identity.

A mage hero from a noble family who could become a patron was a blessing for the Temple of Knowledge.

It was only natural that Hus received a lavish treatment when he visited the temple.

“Hus, do you have any discomfort?”

As Hus was immersed in reading magic books in the temple’s library, a priest came up to him and spoke.

The priest was asking about Hus’s convenience.

Before he knew it, freshly brewed tea and snacks were placed on Hus’s table.

Hus couldn’t help but chuckle at the priest’s attitude.

As far as he remembered, the priests of the temple only showed this kind of attitude when his family donated money at the clan level.

But as soon as he came to the temple with the mark of a hero, they showed him an extreme hospitality.

Hus realized anew the power of authority.

“How long has it been since I came to the library?”

“It’s been five hours since you started reading.”

“Five hours...”

It seemed that he had been stuck in the library for five hours already.

There were many magic books in the Temple of Knowledge.

And most of those books were not easily available in the market.

In fact, the library was only open to Hus, who was chosen as the hero of knowledge.

It was a pleasant thing to browse through magic books with high-level contents in his own library.

However, since Hus was chosen as a hero, he had other schedules besides reading.

He couldn’t stay in the library and indulge in knowledge forever.

“Is the next schedule set?”

“Today you will meet the saintess.”

“The saintess...”

Hus closed the book he was looking at and nodded at the priest’s words.

The saintess chosen by God.

She was one of the most important figures in the Holy Land, except for the Holy King.

Hus had not met the saintess who served the Goddess of Knowledge yet.

It was the duty of the saintess who belonged to the temple to tell him about the divine device and the hero.

Hus needed to meet the saintess in order to become a true hero.

“Do you want to leave right away?”

“Is there any reason not to? Let’s go.”

Meeting the saintess was also an anticipated schedule for Hus.

Creak.

He got up from his seat and followed the priest out of the library.

He had been visiting the Temple of Knowledge for several days now.

The structure of the temple that he saw every time he passed by was already familiar to his eyes.

The priest who guided Hus turned around a long corridor and headed to the second floor.

“What kind of person is the saintess?”

“Are you asking about the saintess? She is very wise.”

“And?”

“She also has a warm heart as much as her experience.”

Experience.

Hus couldn’t help but ponder for a moment when he heard that word.

It felt like he heard a word that didn't suit the position of a saintess.

But seeing the priest who stopped in his place, he quickly erased that word from his mind.

There was a refined door in front of where the priest stopped.

“Is this it?”

“This is the room of ritual. If you go inside, you will be able to meet the saintess.”

“I see. I'll go in then.”

“I'll wait outside until you come out.”

Squeak.

The tightly closed door opened and revealed the scenery of the room where the saintess was.

A altar with artistic patterns carved on it.

Several majestic candlesticks surrounding it.

And an old woman sitting in the middle of them.

As soon as he entered the room, Hus's eyes stopped at the old woman in front of him.

“You are...”

He had heard that he would meet the saintess, but he had no idea that he would face an old woman.

But there was no one else left in this room except for her.

The old woman answered with a bright smile at Hus's unfinished words.

“You are the new hero. Welcome. I am Aurora, the saintess of knowledge.”

“The saintess...?”

“The Goddess of Knowledge likes those who have accumulated a lot of knowledge. Thanks to that, I received her grace.”

The identity of the old woman who sat before Hus’s eyes was none other than the saintess chosen by the Goddess of Knowledge.

Hus was taken aback by the unexpected appearance.

The saintess he had imagined in his head was much younger than her.

But considering the nature of the temple that loved knowledge, it was not an incomprehensible decision.

The saintess in front of him looked more dignified and wise than any other person he had met.

“Saintess... I see.”

“Were you surprised?”

“No, no. If I think about it, it’s a decision that makes sense.”

Aurora nodded her head with a satisfied smile at Hus’s honest answer.

Even if the romance in his head was gone, it didn’t mean that his life in the temple would disappear.

Saintess Aurora was a person who would help Hus a lot in his life in the temple.

It was better for both of them to maintain a proper distance.

“I see. The new hero. You must have a lot of questions to ask me, including the divine device that you are allowed to use.”

“Of course.”

“Let’s start with the story that you asked the priests separately.”

Hus listened carefully to Aurora’s words.

The topic she brought up was the story he was looking forward to very much.

The story that he asked the priests separately.

It was about his brother who was serving in the Holy Land.

Several days had passed since I arrived at the Holy Land.

During that time, I had not seen my brother Evan even once.

“Are you looking for Evan Allemier, a knight who works at the Temple of Honor?”

“Yes, he is my brother.”

It was already a situation where I was chosen by the goddess.

I had a pile of things to talk to Evan about.

More than anything, I was curious about how Evan would react to me becoming a hero.

As I waited for the story about Evan, Aurora picked up a paper that was nearby.

The paper that Aurora picked up was a profile of Evan that the priests had found out by wandering around the Holy Land.

“According to what the priests have investigated, Evan Allemier, a heretic inquisitor who serves the Goddess of Honor, is...”

“My brother is...?”

“He has not returned to the Holy Land since he applied for a vacation last time.”

“What?”

Thud.

I tried to lean on a candlestick nearby and fell down with it.

Was it because of the one eye that I lost a long time ago?

Or was it because the information about my brother was shocking?

Either way, it was hard for me to accept the situation.

Centrius province, located on the outskirts of the empire.

A carriage that was passing by a remote road stopped in its place.

The owner of the carriage was Shuron, a merchant who was building up a decent-sized business.

Shuron looked at the front of the carriage with an annoyed expression.

For some unknown reason, the carriage could not move forward.

“Hey! Why did you stop the carriage!”

Shuron urged the coachman with an angry voice.

The horses that were heading to the city stopped still at some point and did not move.

It was an incomprehensible situation for Shuron who was sitting in the back seat.

The coachman answered him as he looked at him.

“I think something is blocking it.”

“What? Is there a rock on the ground or something?”

“No, it’s not...”

“Then what is it!”

There was nothing that could be an obstacle in front of Shuron’s eyes.

But the horses did not move and stayed still.

What was blocking the road?

Shuron got off the carriage and approached the coachman’s seat.

He wanted to check for himself what was wrong with the horses.

“I don’t know why either.”

“Don’t give me some nonsense! I’ll cut your next salary, you hear me!”

The coachman had already gotten off the carriage and checked the horses once.

But Shuron didn’t trust him and went closer to the horses to see for himself.

Shuron’s eyes scanned over the legs of the horses that were standing still.

There was no sign of anything stuck or wrong with them.

The only strange thing was that they both raised their heads in the air and snorted.

Thump. Thump.

This time, Shuron moved a little further and reached out to where the horses were standing still.

Thud.

His hand that reached out to the air hit something invisible and stopped.

“What, what is this...?”

Shuron’s fingers touched the invisible wall.

There was a transparent barrier in front of him, created by some kind of force.

Come to think of it, when the horses stopped, he remembered that the carriage shook quite roughly.

If there was a barrier blocking their way, it also made sense that the horses stopped by pushing their foreheads against it.

Shuron was surprised by the transparent barrier that blocked his way and spoke to the coachman.

“The road is blocked! Turn the carriage around!”

“Sir, to turn the carriage around, we need...”

“We’re stuck here! We have to get out somehow!”

An unknown force was blocking their way.

Shuron guessed that this was a magical phenomenon.

They wouldn’t be able to use this road until a decent mage came and dispelled it.

It was unfortunate that their progress was delayed, but it was best to make a quick decision and save some time as much as possible.

He made up his mind and ordered the coachman when someone appeared from the nearby forest.

“The barrier made by our apostle is reliable.”

The one who showed up from the forest was a middle-aged man wearing a tunic.

He smiled with a friendly face and looked at Shuron.

The man clearly said “the barrier made by our apostle”.

He was obviously involved in this matter.

Shuron couldn't help but ask his identity after hearing such a suspicious word.

“A barrier? Who are you?”

“Me? I am Archbishop Roan Hebris. I am a faithful servant of the great one.”

“Archbishop? What the hell...”

Archbishop was a religious position that oversaw a diocese.

Shuron had some information about the temples nearby.

But the man named Roan in front of him was an unfamiliar name to Shuron.

He was undoubtedly a suspicious person.

As Shuron looked at Roan with a wary eye, Roan slowly walked towards him.

And then he extended one hand to him with a dignified attitude and said.

“I want to invite you to our cult. Would you accept my invitation if you don't mind?”

Chapter 33: Bipolar (2)

< 33 : Bipolar (2) >

Reception room in the church.

There, Shuron was tearing apart the bread that was placed in front of him with an anxious expression.

On the table where Shuron was sitting, there were fruits and bread prepared for him.

It seemed that the invitation to the church was not just an empty word.

The food on the table looked quite elaborate.

They were at least giving him a minimum of hospitality.

“Do you like the food?”

“Ah, um... I think so.”

“Aaah...!”

The reason why Shuron could not eat comfortably was one.

There was a scream echoing from the corner of the reception room.

The one who was screaming was his companion, Mabu.

Mabu, who was dragged to the church with Shuron, was immediately caught by the believers and hung on a pillar.

And now he was being whipped by the church's believers.

It was not enough to kill him, but it was inevitable that he would get goosebumps when he heard the scream.

"You look very uncomfortable."

Archbishop Roan, who was sitting opposite Shuron, asked him in a friendly voice.

It was obvious why Roan showed him Mabu's whipping.

It was a kind of warning for Shuron to judge for himself.

If he offended Roan's mind too much, it might be his turn next.

He didn't want to be dragged to this place and whipped.

Shuron pretended to be okay and put bread in his mouth, then pointed at Mabu with his finger and said.

"It's a bit noisy around here."

"Haha, don't mind it. It's a church event. We'll try to make it as less annoying as possible."

"Do you really have to do that?"

Even if he made mistakes sometimes, Mabu was still Shuron's subordinate.

He couldn't feel comfortable seeing Mabu being harassed by them.

So he tried to bring up the topic without offending Roan.

Did he notice Shuron's intention?

Roan answered him in a smooth tone.

"That's just a process of verifying the fruits of faith."

“The fruits of faith...?”

“Some people do not serve the great one and act foolishly. They are all for verifying his faith.”

In other words, Mabu was being whipped because he was not a believer of the church.

Shuron felt cold in his stomach as he saw Mabu being whipped.

Mabu and Shuron were both distant from the church’s believers.

And outside, there was one of the upper staff waiting with luggage.

Even so, the fact that only Mabu was being whipped meant that others might not know when their turn would come.

There was no need to ask why they didn’t whip him, Roan threatened Shuron first.

“Don’t worry about those lowly ones. Our upper lord is a faithful believer, isn’t he?”

“...”

“So we don’t think we need to verify your faith.”

“Haha...”

Shuron looked at Roan with a stiff face and gave an awkward laugh.

Of course, Roan’s words didn’t end there.

He clasped his hands neatly and looked at Shuron with a serious face.

It was a fierce look different from before.

“But what if the upper lord says he is a foolish unbeliever...”

“Wha-what happens to unbelievers...?”

Gulp.

Shuron swallowed his saliva and waited for Roan’s next words.

Would he be whipped like Mabu?

Or would he be dragged somewhere in the church and tortured?

He couldn’t breathe properly because of the tension and focused on Roan’s words.

“Even then, we can’t treat you like that, can we? Instead, you’ll have to listen to a boring sermon before you go.”

“...You’re good at joking, archbishop.”

“So which one are you?”

“Ah, of course I believe in the great one!”

It’s best to go along with them in front of crazy people.

That was the basic principle of survival that Shuron learned from doing business.

Of course, it would be better to avoid them if possible, but this situation was obviously unavoidable.

Shuron’s answer seemed satisfactory to Roan, who nodded and put bread in his mouth.

“I’m glad. You are a faithful person who serves the great one!”

“Serving the great one is natural. Those heretics and unbelievers should all be punished.”

“But do you know the name of the great one?”

“The name of the great one...?”

Shuron felt cold sweat running down his back as he heard Roan’s question.

The name of the god they worshiped.

He had no reason to know that.

And he didn’t remember hearing it in the conversation so far.

He moved his eyes frantically as he felt the tension rising again.

“Don’t you know?”

“That’s...”

“Haha, just kidding! How can a mere human utter the name of the great one casually.”

“That’s true.”

It was another prank by Roan.

Whew.

Shuron let out a sigh.

He felt like his life span was shortened by 10 years every time he was tricked by Roan.

Shuron wanted to get out of here as soon as possible.

And to do that, he had to find out why they were holding him back.

“Well, about the reason why we invited you this time...”

Did he read Shuron’s mind?

Roan finally started to hint at the purpose.

If they suddenly stopped the upper lord passing by, he had a rough idea of what it was.

He was definitely going to bring up the money issue.

“Actually, Mr. Sangdanju, you are a devout follower of the cult, aren’t you? Haven’t you been behind on your donations lately?”

“...Donations, you say.”

Shuron had admitted himself that he was a follower of the cult.

He had no good excuse for the money issue.

If he tried to make a long explanation here, he might slip up and get caught in a trap.

It was a cunning scheme that made him feel like he was being set up.

“I’m afraid we are short on money for building the temple, so we need you to make a generous donation.”

There was only one way to defend himself in this situation.

Shuron had to name the amount first.

As long as it wasn’t an insulting amount, they would probably let it go for the sake of saving face.

So Shuron tried to tell Roan the reasonable amount he had calculated in his head.

“If we’re building a temple, of course I have to donate! I’m doing this for the cult...”

“Thirty percent of the goods you brought should be enough.”

But Roan was faster than him.

He cut him off and declared the amount.

And he called the goods they were carrying “offerings”.

They were all his own goods, but he chose a word that made it sound like he was doing them a favor.

Shuron’s voice came out weakly from his mouth.

“But, that’s...”

“And there’s one more thing I’d like to ask you, Mr. Sangdanju.”

Of course, Shuron didn’t get a chance to make an excuse.

He was already overwhelmed by the cult’s atmosphere.

He couldn’t go back to the previous topic once it had changed.

Shuron bit his lip, realizing that the archbishop in front of him was no ordinary guy.

He felt like the bread he had eaten was coming back up.

He had to pay thirty percent of his goods for some stale bread and fruits from nearby.

It was no different from paying a toll to bandits.

“Phew... What is it?”

He sighed again and said.

He felt like giving up halfway.

He had already given up everything he could, so what difference would it make if he agreed to one more request?

He should be grateful that they didn’t take everything from him.

Shuron looked down at the table, and Roan brought up the next item.

“I’d like you to use your carriage to sneak four people into the city.”

“Wait, you want me to sneak them into the city?”

The archbishop’s next item was about the city.

He wanted him to use Shuron’s carriage to avoid the checkpoint and get them in.

It was a completely different topic from before, and Shuron looked puzzled.

Why did the archbishop ask him to give up thirty percent of his goods?

It seemed like he wanted to make room for people to get in his carriage.

“That’s right.”

“Hmm...”

Sneaking people into the city was a very tricky thing for Shuron too.

Not to mention the difficulty of getting people in, but being associated with heretics was risky in itself.

If he was caught with some troublemaking heretics, even Shuron would have a hard time escaping punishment.

How could he refuse Roan’s proposal?

As Shuron pondered over that, Roan added something ominous.

“Of course, you don’t have to worry about anything once they get in. There are some devout followers of our cult among the nobles of the count’s house.”

“The count’s house... has followers of your cult?”

“Yes. There’s some misunderstanding that makes it hard for them to get in, but it will be resolved once they do.”

The count’s house that ruled the city was backing up the heretics.

The atmosphere became more awkward as Shuron felt his chest tighten.

It was hard to believe what the heretics said, but if it was true, then the situation was reversed.

If he didn’t accept their request, his boss in the city might suffer a disadvantage.

Shuron weighed his options as he heard a scream from a groom who was hit by someone.

“Can I really trust you?”

“You lack faith. I was going to say that you, as a loyal follower of the cult, would receive the protection of both the cult and the count’s house.”

“No, how could I doubt what the archbishop says? I just wanted to be sure.”

“You are very thorough. Of course, if this problem is solved well, you will receive the favor of the nobility.”

His boss had already suffered a huge loss.

He had to grab any benefit he could, no matter how hard it was.

It was a risky offer, but it could be a big gain if he succeeded.

Thud. Thud.

Roan’s finger started tapping on the table slowly, facing Shuron.

It was a gesture that urged Shuron to answer quickly.

How many times did Roan’s finger hit the table?

After a long hesitation, Shuron made his decision about the cult's offer.

"I'll do it."

Naturally, Shuron's choice was to accept Roan's offer.

He had no choice.

Chapter 34: Bipolar (3)

< 34 : Bipolar (3) >

The reception room where Shuron left after the conversation.

Eutenia, who was watching Roan's actions there, asked him.

“Did you know the count's family?”

He was tidying up the table that had been messed up after Shuron left.

The believers who had been waiting to pressure Shuron also left, and only the archbishop and the apostles remained in the reception room.

Was it because of the story that Roan had told to Sangdanju?

Eutenia asked if Roan's words that he knew the count's family were true.

He smiled warmly at Eutenia and answered.

“Of course not.”

“Then it was a lie.”

“It wasn't a complete lie. This is an act of selling the future. Eventually, the count's family will be under the influence of the church.”

Roan's story to Shuron was a lie.

Nevertheless, Roan confidently declared to Eutenia.

He said that the entire count's family that ruled the city would eventually be under the influence of the church.

That was the goal of the plan that Roan would execute in the future.

Evan, who had been listening quietly, also seemed curious about Roan's plan and asked him.

"What are you thinking, archbishop?"

"You'll understand quickly if you know the current situation of the city."

"The situation of the city?"

"The count who rules the city has two sons."

"Two sons..."

Roan had been investigating the power relations in the Centrius region to expand his church.

That was also true for the city he was going to visit this time.

The trade city Lituas-Centrius was one of the territories belonging to the Meyer count's family.

It was also one of the most important places among the territories belonging to the Meyer count's family.

The Meyer count's family, who ruled this huge city, had been suffering from a long-standing succession problem.

It was because of their two sons under the count.

"One is Lex Meyer, the eldest son. He is the son of the former countess who passed away."

"Then the other one is..."

“The other one is Max Meyer. He is the son of the current countess. And the countess and her relatives want to support Max as the next count.”

“Is the eldest son’s power weaker?”

“That’s the situation. If things go on like this, Max Meyer will have a high chance of becoming the next Meyer count.”

The eldest son who was competing with his half-brother for power.

Moreover, his brother had a very strong power from his relatives who supported him.

In this situation, it was not difficult for Roan and his church to intervene.

At least that’s what Roan thought.

Evan seemed to understand Roan’s thoughts to some extent.

He nodded his head and agreed with his plan.

“So you’re going to side with the eldest son.”

“Of course. It would be easier to benefit from going to the eldest son who has weaker power than the second son.”

“You’re sure you’ll benefit from it.”

“What do I have to be afraid of? The great one is watching over us.”

Roan would never have tried this plan if he was alone.

But now he had some members of his church, as well as two apostles who helped him.

With this power, it wasn’t bad to try something risky.

Besides, he calculated that it wouldn’t be hard to escape if something went wrong.

It was a conclusion based on his observation of their strength for a long time.

“That’s a great attitude. Then what can I do to help you?”

“You just need to stay with Lex Meyer for a while.”

“Stay at his house?”

Evan asked back with a puzzled face at Roan’s words that he should stay at his house.

It was a surprising story if he didn’t know the process.

But Roan was full of confidence now.

One of his actions as a black mage was to manipulate people.

If he had a stage, he thought it wouldn’t be hard to persuade a nobleman who didn’t know much about the world.

Especially if he had plausible actors who could match his play.

“It’s not like you’re not looking like a knight among us. You’re the only one who can be assigned as a guard.”

“...I see. Then I have no choice.”

“Do I have a role too?”

This time it was Eutenia’s turn with a book in her arms.

Of course, there were tasks waiting for her as well.

She was an amazing magician who could use various magic, including barriers created by applying barrier magic.

The reason why she tested the barrier against Shuron was also for the big things that would follow.

“There is something you have to do, first apostle.”

“What is it?”

“Can you act like a noble lady?”

“...?”

Eutenia tilted her head at Roan’s words.

It was a reaction that she couldn’t understand.

Roan expected that reaction as well.

Well, the suggestion he was about to make was so shocking.

Roan spoke to Eutenia with a friendly face.

“I think you’ll have to become a noble lady.”

Time passed again and the weekend came.

I was drinking beer alone last night, and now I’m eating ramen for breakfast and watching TV.

The news was coming out of the TV that I turned on.

It was a corner that reported news from overseas.

-“Currently, large-scale riots are occurring in Africa and other places...”

Africa.

Canada.

USA.

France.

News from various countries in the world came out through the anchor's mouth.

As I listened to the news from abroad, I had a lot of thoughts.

It felt like a completely different world when I remembered that it was on the other side of the earth.

I finished eating all the ramen and I wasn't interested in the news anymore.

It was a rare weekend, so I wondered if I should go out, but when I saw the hot weather, I didn't want to go out.

On a day like this, it was best to stay at home and play games with the air conditioner on.

Thud.

I put down my chopsticks and picked up my smartphone and ran the game.

"Come to think of it, something came into my account."

I applied for so many things that I don't remember well, but I think something came into my account.

Maybe the most likely possibility was that it was the tax refund I had applied for a few months ago.

I remembered that the expected amount was similar to the money that had been deposited into my account.

Since I didn't have any urgent expenses, I wondered if I should spend some of it on the game when I had some spare time.

I thought about using the gacha to get some matching outfits for my followers, and before I knew it, the loading was complete and the game screen appeared.

The game looked even more vivid than yesterday.

The graphics had changed along with my level.

-The number of your cult's followers has increased significantly.

-Some of your followers have acquired the <Fanatic> trait.

-Your karma has increased by 11 points.

The first message that caught my eye was that the number of my cult's followers had increased and my karma had gone up.

It seemed that Roan had been busy while I was away.

One well-trained character was worth ten mediocre ones.

He was more competent than I had imagined.

-You have reached level 7.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.6)> has grown.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.7)> has been achieved. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

In addition to these minor updates, my level had also increased by one.

As my level went up, so did my total amount of magic and the level of my <Eye of the Observer> skill.

That was why the graphics had become sharper, because my level had gone up by one.

Now, the characters on the screen looked more proportional.

There was still a casual vibe to the game, but not as much as before.

“Another warning came up.”

Of course, not everything was positive when my level increased.

Just like when I had leveled up before, <Karma's Judgment> displayed a new message.

The message informed me of the difficulty adjustment due to <Causality Correction>.

It was natural that the game would become harder as my level increased.

But unlike before, when it warned me of the appearance of a hero, this time the message had a different content.

- ◦ Warning: Excessively biased karma in one direction may trigger <Causality Correction>.
- ◦ <Karma's Judgment> has tilted.
- ◦ A low-level <Causality Correction> has occurred.
- ◦ Due to <Causality Correction>, [Divine Tool: Ascalon] has been released by one level.
- ◦ Causality Correction Progress: 3%

As the progress reached 3%, a new way of difficulty adjustment had taken place.

The release of [Divine Tool: Ascalon].

Considering that there was no divine tool with the same name among those I had created, [Divine Tool: Ascalon] must have belonged to the hero who had announced his appearance before.

Just like the apostles, the heroes also seemed to use divine tools.

Judging by the name divine tool, there might be other gods besides me.

“Well, how hard can it get anyway?”

It didn't matter if other gods or heroes with divine tools popped up. The strategy for this kind of game was mostly simple.

Pay to win.

If you pay, you become stronger accordingly.

There is no enemy that you can't beat if you throw enough cash at them.

If you think about it, using gacha doesn't increase your karma, so the developers must have taken this into account to some extent.

Of course, how much money you need to spend to face the final boss is another question.

"In that sense, maybe I should do some spending today."

I had received some money that I could use freely besides my salary.

I had already set aside enough money for this month's rent and living expenses.

Therefore, the money that came in this time was nothing but pocket money for me to enjoy myself.

I could use gacha and order some chicken and beer without any problem.

I imagined a golden day of fun in my head and happily tapped on the store icon.

-Welcome to <Paid Currency Store>.

-<Paid Currency Store> sells various items for smooth gameplay.

The first thing I checked when I entered <Paid Currency Store> was the price of gacha.

In most games, you wouldn't have to worry about this, but in this ruthless game, that assumption was meaningless.

80,000 won for 10 pulls.

The price was still the same as before.

If the price was unchanged, there was no need to hesitate.

I moved my finger and touched the gacha button.

-Preparing items. Please try again later.

And then I was stunned by the message that appeared on the screen.

Preparing items.

Along with that message, the gacha button was deactivated.

I was dumbfounded by what happened in an instant.

I scanned the screen with a blank stare.

A natural mutter escaped from my mouth.

“What, they need to prepare data for sale...?”

Chapter 35: Bipolar (4)

< 35 : Bipolar (4) >

The Guildford Mercenary Corps was a well-known mercenary group in the empire.

They had a reputation for clean work and excellent skills.

Not to mention the cheerful personality of their leader, Guildford.

That's why people came from far away to entrust their requests to Guildford.

The current mission of the Guildford Mercenary Corps was also given by a requester who came from a distant place.

The task was to investigate an old building after clearing the way of the monsters that blocked it.

It was not a difficult job for someone with Guildford's abilities.

In fact, until halfway through, there was no problem with the monster extermination.

“Boss? Why did you suddenly stop?”

If it weren't for the mysterious pain that Guildford felt in his arm, that is.

Guildford stopped walking as he felt a sharp pain in his right arm.

He had no memory of being injured by a monster during the battle.

Yet, he rolled up his sleeve and checked his right arm as he felt a stinging sensation from it.

“Hmm...”

Guildford endured the burning pain as he closely observed the strange phenomenon that was happening on his arm.

His skin was turning red and black spots were slowly rising above it.

A pattern of black barley grains.

If he looked closely at the pattern, he could remember seeing it somewhere before.

Guildford, the leader of the mercenary corps, was holding his arm with a grim expression. Jenny, the mage of the mercenary group, asked him.

“Boss? What’s wrong?”

“Something seems to be wrong with my arm.”

“Let me take a look.”

The strongest force of the mercenary corps was undoubtedly their leader, Guildford.

As soon as he said there was a problem, Jenny rushed to him.

When the mage approached him, Guildford moved his hand away and showed his arm to Jenny.

He had some idea of what was going on, but he thought that a mage would know more about this kind of thing.

Jenny’s eyes scanned Guildford’s arm carefully.

“What do you think? Does it look like a problem?”

“Boss. Did this just happen?”

“Hmm.”

“I think this is... a hero’s mark?”

A hero’s mark.

Guildford began to ponder as he heard the words that confirmed his suspicion.

Heroes were those who were chosen by the goddess to fight against the evil god.

If what was left on his arm was a hero’s mark, then Guildford would have to make a decision soon.

Would he disband his mercenary corps and head to the temple?

Or would he pretend not to know and continue to lead his mercenary group?

Either way, there were pros and cons to each option.

“Which temple’s mark is it?”

“The temple of abundance.”

“The temple of abundance, huh...”

“You just have to go to the holy land since you have the mark. By the way, boss, you being a hero might be a better match than I thought?”

Guildford had never been to the holy land himself, but he knew well enough about the temple of abundance.

The temple of abundance was one of the most influential temples in the holy land.

If Guildford went to the temple of abundance and revealed that he was a hero, they might welcome him as a hero.

But Guildford felt a reluctance for some reason.

He didn't want to leave his beloved mercenary corps, and he didn't want to be bound by the duty of being a hero.

"I'm not going to the holy land."

"...What do you mean?"

"Don't we have things to do? I think I like being a mercenary leader more than a hero."

Guildford said that and walked past Jenny to move forward again.

When Guildford started walking again, his subordinates who were waiting for him also followed him.

Guildford shouted loudly in a cheerful voice to his subordinates who were walking behind him.

"Alright, it was nothing! Let's keep moving!"

Jenny, who was standing still, was startled by the sight of the group that had gone far away.

She had fallen behind by dozens of steps while she was spacing out.

She sprinted with all her strength toward the front where the group was.

Haa.

Her rough breathing echoed around her because of her hard running.

Jenny barely caught up with Guildford and looked at his arm as she spoke.

"Boss, are you really not going to the holy land?"

“Let’s drop that topic. I like my current comrades.”

“Geez, our boss really loves sweaty men!”

The mercenaries around them burst into laughter at Gaff’s words, who was the vice-leader.

Everyone was laughing except for Guildford, who had an awkward expression on his face.

Guildford, who was walking ahead, raised his middle finger at Gaff.

And then he said with a forced laugh.

“Gaff. Save your nonsense for the drinking table.”

“Hurk! How dare I disobey the words of our hero!”

“Hahaha!”

The mercenaries laughed again at Gaff’s reply to Guildford.

Guildford shook his head as he heard Gaff’s voice from behind.

They were the same as always.

Even if a mark appeared on Guildford’s arm, the mercenary corps didn’t change much.

Thud. Thud.

The rough footsteps of the mercenaries echoed on the mountain road.

Maybe it was because they had cleared most of the monsters that were coming at them.

While Guildford and the mercenaries were walking on the road, no new monsters appeared.

“Boss! There’s something over there!”

Instead of monsters, what appeared in front of Guildford was an unidentified building that was shabbily built.

The wall that had been painted with colorful paint could not withstand the traces of time and only remnants were left.

The roof of the building also partially collapsed for some reason.

He didn’t know what its original purpose was, but it was not a building that could be used continuously.

Guildford and the mercenaries stopped in front of the building that they had found.

“The building looks very old.”

“Is that the building that was mentioned in the request?”

“It probably is.”

The building was too small for its size.

It was a contrast to the effort that had been put into building it.

It was not big enough for all the mercenaries of the corps to fit in.

Guildford turned his head and picked out some people as he saw the building that looked smaller than expected.

Jenny, the mage.

And Gaff, the vice-leader.

He thought it would be enough to take these two with him.

“Gaff.”

“Yeah, boss!”

“Jenny.”

“Yup.”

“Only you two follow me inside. The rest of you wait outside.”

The mercenaries who received the order to wait looked for a place to rest and started chatting.

Guildford, who had picked out the people who would go inside, opened the door of the building.

Creak.

The inside of the building was revealed along with the sound of the hinge shaking.

Maybe it was because the building had been neglected for a long time.

There was a lot of dust inside the building.

“Achoo...!”

“Jenny! Why are you coughing in my direction... Oh, boss! There’s an expensive-looking sword over there?”

Gaff, who was turning his head away from Jenny who was coughing, found something and shouted.

Beyond the roof that had fallen inside the building due to the passage of time.

There was an old altar and a sword that emitted a suspicious light.

The light from the sword on the altar was fundamentally different from the light that was reflected by the sunlight.

Guildford's hand moved reflexively at the sight of the sword that had a brilliant light.

“...”

Guildford reached out his hand toward the sword and grabbed it.

Clack.

At the same time as his hand gripped the sword tightly, the mark on Guildford's arm began to emit light.

He felt a warm sensation from his hand that held the sword.

At the same time, a powerful voice echoed in Guildford's head.

The voice that reached Guildford's ears was an imposing male voice.

-“Hero. Have you opened your eyes?”

Guildford turned his head and looked around as he heard the voice.

But there was no one else in the building except for Jenny, Gaff, and himself.

He couldn't find anyone unfamiliar.

Guildford, who couldn't find the owner of the voice, asked a question to the unidentified voice.

“Who are you? You're hiding your appearance.”

-“My name is Shinki Ascalon. I have been waiting here for a hero who will save this world.”

“Could it be...”

-“Yes. The sword you are holding is me.”

Guildford gaped at the sword as he heard its voice introducing itself.

A sword that could talk by itself.

He had never thought that he would meet a sword that was only passed down in legends.

As Guildford looked at the sword with a surprised face, Ascalon emitted a strong light once and asked him.

-“Hero of abundance. What is your name?”

“I am the leader of the Guildford Mercenary Corps... Guildford Proud.”

-“A hero from a mercenary background. You must be quite skilled in combat. In that aspect, you might be better than the previous heroes.”

Ascalon didn't show any reaction after hearing Guildford's identity.

Rather, he showed that he had met several heroes before.

From what he had heard so far, the artifact in front of Guildford seemed to have something to do with the hero's mark.

He knew about the heroes.

This was an opportunity for Guildford to get some information that he lacked.

Guildford decided not to miss this chance and asked Ascalon what he was curious about.

“Ascalon. I have something to ask.”

-“What are you curious about?”

“What is your relation to the heroes?”

-“Each hero is given an artifact that suits them. And I am the artifact prepared for the hero of abundance.”

“That means...”

-“It means that you are my master.”

The artifact in front of him was Guildford's.

In terms of ownership of material, and also in a religious sense.

It was a very pleasant thing to hear that the artifact that shone in front of him was his.

As long as there was no annoying talk from the temple.

“I like that. Being a master.”

-“Of course, there aren't many people who would hate an artifact.”

“Is that what you think?”

-“At least, that's how it was for all the previous heroes. If you have any other questions, I'll answer them as much as I can.”

“Then Ascalon, is there no problem if I don't go to the holy land?”

Guildford asked his next question to the artifact in his hand.

He didn't need to go to the temple and be dragged around by them to drive out the evil god.

That was what Guildford thought.

He thought it would be fine to smash the cult of the evil god that he saw while running his mercenary corps.

He just had to do his role in some way.

Ascalon laughed unpleasantly at Guildford's question.

-“Of course, you can do that. As long as you are confident enough.”

“I am Guildford Proud, the leader of the Guildford Mercenary Corps. Do you think I don't have enough confidence?”

-“Even if you are better than the previous ones, that's only compared to them.”

“What do you mean by that?”

-“You will have to go through the hardest time among all the heroes so far.”

Guildford understood that Ascalon's words were not a light warning.

Guildford pondered over Ascalon's words as he continued his story.

-“The law of the world will not favor you.”

“The law of the world...?”

-“The supreme karma of the world is a being that has a bipolarity of good and evil.”

-“Good can only exist with evil. And the same goes for evil.”

-“When this boundary collapses completely, the world will be filled with chaos.”

“Are you saying that there is something wrong with the goddess now?”

The story of the supreme karma was a unfamiliar topic for Guildford.

Even so, he could understand the next part a little bit.

Evil exists because of good.

It was a very tricky thing to say that the great being that ruled the sky had to protect it.

Even if they were gods, they were not free from some constraints.

And Guildford asked about the problem that the gods who looked down on the earth had.

-“There is a simple but difficult problem.”

“What problem?”

-“The problem is that they can only extend their hand of salvation to you if there is a great evil.”

The law of the universe.

It was too big and huge a problem for Guildford to solve.

Chapter 36: The Demon (1)

< 36 : The Demon (1) >

It had been three days since I received the incomprehensible message that an item had dropped.

Of course, the enjoyable weekend had also come to an end, and the weekdays that required me to repeat the same routine of going to work had returned.

The weekdays that followed the sweet break were always exhausting.

After a hard day at the office, I collapsed on the floor as soon as I arrived home.

I dumped the items in my pocket and looked at the screen of my smartphone that was lying on the floor.

The memories of the last weekend flashed through my mind as I stared at the dark screen.

“I wonder if they have finished fixing the data glitches by now.”

The excuse that an item had dropped was absurd in the first place.

It would have made some sense if they had used that expression to preserve the game’s concept.

But it had been three days since the message appeared, so they should have wrapped up the maintenance by now.

After a tiring day, I felt a sudden urge to try my luck with the gacha.

I picked up my phone that was shaking on the floor with a renewed interest in the gacha.

“Nothing beats seeing new skills and new characters in a game.”

The games that were commonly called bonsai games were especially appealing in that aspect.

You could level up and use new skills.

Or you could spin the gacha and get new characters.

Those were the things that made the game fun to play.

I hadn't seen much of Eben's performance yet, but that didn't stop me from wanting to pull more gacha.

As soon as the game loading was completed, I pressed the shop button and entered the <Paid Currency Shop>.

“Did they raise the price while I was away?”

The first thing I checked when I entered the shop was the price of the 10-pull gacha, as usual.

I had lost all trust in the game's management.

I couldn't just press the button without checking the price, or I might end up paying a much higher amount than before.

Fortunately, there was no change in the gacha price in the past few days.

I felt relieved and touched the gacha button.

“Please, let me get a magic book.”

Click.

As I pressed the button, a bright light flowed out and the gacha screen unfolded.

This time, it didn't show me the ridiculous maintenance message that there were no items left.

The results of the gacha flashed by quickly in front of my eyes, shining brightly.

-You have acquired [Stylish Tunic].

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Stylish Tunic].

-You have acquired [Stylish Tunic].

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Sponge Cake].

-You have acquired [Hard Rye Bread].

-You have acquired [Magic Book: Creature Maker].

-You have acquired [Stylish Tunic].

As before, most of the gacha results were useless junk items.

To make matters worse, I even got a [Hard Rye Bread] instead of a [Baguette].

If it had been the time when Eutania was starving, it might have been different.

But now, I didn't think she would be satisfied with such hard bread.

I would rather have gotten some clothes that I could give to the cult members.

“I got one magic book.”

The only thing that seemed useful among the items was a magic book called [Magic Book: Creature Maker].

Creature Maker.

The name suggested that it had something to do with the pets or familiars in the game.

I clicked on the Creature Maker that had entered my inventory and checked the description.

I wanted to see if it had any value to give to Eutania before using it.

“What? There’s a limit on how many times I can use it?”

According to the description of [Magic Book: Creature Maker] in my inventory, I could create a creature up to five times.

A skill that could only be used five times.

Considering the cost of pulling the magic book, the limit was not a pleasant factor.

I had always been reluctant to buy items that had a duration or a limit.

It was too late to do anything about it since I already got the item, but I usually didn’t value these kinds of consumable skills.

They made me hesitate to use them.

“Sigh... I guess I have no choice.”

But I couldn’t give an item with a limit to Eutania either.

There was a risk that it might disappear unlike the other items.

This magic book was something that I had to use myself.

I sighed for a moment and then moved my finger to touch the magic book.

Click.

As soon as I pressed the magic book with my finger, a pop-up window appeared asking me if I wanted to use it.

-Do you want to learn the <Creature Maker> skill?

-The magic book will disappear when you learn it.

-Yes / No

There was no point in thinking about it any longer.

I pressed the 'Yes' button without hesitation and used the magic book.

The magic book disappeared from my inventory and a new skill button appeared at the bottom of the screen.

-You have learned <Creature Maker(Lv.MAX)>.

-You can now create creatures by consuming mana.

-The creatures you create with mana are living beings that can grow well without your help.

-<Creature Maker> can be used up to five times.

A new skill called <Creature Maker> that used the magic book was created.

As it was written in the item description in my inventory, <Creature Maker> was a skill that could only be used five times.

It meant that I could only make up to five creatures with this skill.

Considering the limit, it would be better to use it as efficiently as possible.

“Creatures. What kind of creatures should I make?”

And it was also a skill that had a relatively high degree of freedom compared to other skills.

What kind of creatures would be most effective to create with this skill?

That would be the dilemma that I had to think about from now on.

I looked at the <Creature Maker> skill and continued my serious contemplation.

I kept thinking until my stomach growled from skipping dinner.

The trade city of Lituania-Centurius, the center of the Centurius region.

Shuron, who was standing in line at the city gate, looked back with a worried expression.

Behind Shuron, there was a carriage that was decorated extravagantly.

It was the cult members who had modified the ordinary carriage to that extent.

Although the interior structure was quite horrible, it looked like a noble's carriage from the outside.

The carriage procession was also lavish enough to resemble a noble's entourage.

Above all, the person who was riding in the carriage looked like a noble herself.

“It's so boring.”

Eutania, who was sitting in the carriage wearing a frilly dress, opened the window and muttered.

She looked like a flawless young lady of a noble family to anyone who saw her.

Archbishop Roan had also told her to act like a noble, but it was a very burdensome task for Shuron.

Claiming to be a noble was a risky act that could have serious consequences.

And he had to do it in front of the city guards.

Shuron was trembling with fear at the thought.

“Please wait a little longer.”

Of course, regardless of whether Eutania was really a young lady of a noble family or not, Shuron had no choice but to be careful around her.

Even Archbishop Roan, who oversaw the cult, followed her every whim.

It was only natural for Shuron to watch his words and actions in front of her.

Shuron got off the horse and approached the guard as he looked at him.

“What’s this? It’s not your turn yet.”

“Well, our young lady is very bored right now.”

“Your young lady?”

“She’s the daughter of Count Eysalia from the kingdom. She came along with us on our business trip with a knight and a servant.”

The guard looked at him with suspicion after hearing his words.

If he thought about the usual noble processions, the guard's doubt was very reasonable.

If there had been an agreement between the noble families beforehand, there would have been no need to waste time like this.

But Shuron had come to the city without any notice.

“We didn't hear anything from the guard station.”

“It wasn't on our schedule originally. She said she would visit and greet you later.”

“Hmm...”

“Don't you think it would be troublesome for both of us if our young lady gets angry? I don't want to get scolded by her either. Please let us pass quickly for the sake of our count's reputation.”

Shuron handed him a money pouch.

It contained several times more coins than he usually used.

The guard's eyes changed as he received the pouch from Shuron.

He felt the weight of the pouch in his hand and then glanced at his colleague and said.

“It seems like our young lady is having a hard time.”

“What should we do?”

“She sure has some presence as a count's daughter. We better be nice to her if we don't want to get in trouble.”

“I need to clear the queue first.”

The guard turned his head back to Shuron after finishing his conversation with his colleague.

He gave Shuron an awkward smile and said,

“Did you say you were with the lady?”

“Yes.”

“I’ll go and apologize to her. If you want, I can also report this to the main office.”

Shuron recalled what the archbishop had told him earlier as he heard the guard’s words.

The only one who had a connection with the church was the first son of the count’s family.

That was what Roan had told Shuron.

Shuron nodded at the guard and told him his request.

“Then please contact the first son for me.”

“The first son, sir? I’ll report that as soon as possible.”

“Here is the carriage that the lady is riding in.”

Shuron and the guard arrived at the side of a splendidly modified carriage.

There, Eutenia opened the window and looked down at Shuron and the guard.

She had a noble appearance and demeanor that anyone could recognize.

The guard bowed his head to her without any doubt and said,

“I’m sorry for making you wait. I’ll escort you inside right away.”

“Is this boring time finally over?”

“I’ll handle it as quickly as possible. I’ll also report that you’re looking for the first son, sir.”

“That’s good.”

Eutenia gave a faint smile at the guard’s words.

She seemed satisfied with the guard’s attitude.

There was nothing suspicious about them, except for the fact that their group was relatively small.

The guard looked up at Eutenia and asked her about the escort.

“Do you need any escort...?”

“Escort? I have Sir Evan with me, so I don’t think it matters...”

Evan and the guard’s eyes met through the window.

The guard lowered his head again after facing Evan’s cold gaze.

A trained physique. And a sharp aura.

He was clearly an experienced knight.

The guard realized that he had nothing to worry about after seeing the knight.

“I understand! Then I’ll just report about the knight, sir!”

“I’d like to go inside now.”

“Pass! Let the carriage and the whole queue pass!”

The road that blocked Shuron’s group was completely opened with the guard’s order.

No one doubted the carriage that entered with Shuron at the front.

The guard who guided them also disappeared into the castle for his report.

It was the moment when the church entered the city.

Chapter 37: The Demon (2)

< 37 : The Demon (2) >

Rex Meyer.

The eldest son of the Meyer Count House looked at the soldier who came to him.

It was not uncommon for soldiers to visit him for his schedule, but it was rare for another noble to bypass his family and seek him out directly.

Rex asked the soldier, who knelt before him, about the identity of the guest.

“Who is looking for me?”

“It is Viscount Eysalia, your grace.”

“Viscount Eysalia House? Where is that family from?”

“It is a family located in the Hegros Kingdom beyond the border. We have already verified their status.”

Rex Meyer was not well-versed in social circles.

He barely remembered the name of Eysalia Viscount House, let alone anything else.

A noble family from another country, and one that he had no connection with, came to see him.

It was a situation that Rex could not understand.

After hearing the soldier's words, Rex pondered for a moment and then turned his head to look at his knight.

“Viscount Eysalia House. What do you think is the reason why they came to see me, Sir Palios?”

Sir Palios was one of Rex's few allies in the Count House.

He had served him since he was young, and had overcome many hardships with him.

Rex trusted what Palios said.

Palios thought for a while after hearing Rex's words, and then told him his guess.

“If the viscount came to see you, it must be to propose a marriage, your grace.”

“A marriage?”

“Perhaps he wants to see you in person and then decide whether to send a marriage proposal to your father, the count.”

Marriage.

Rex's face slightly heated up when he heard Palios' guess.

He did not know the exact purpose, but if a viscount from a neighboring country came to see him, there was nothing else but that.

Rex was already past his prime for marriage.

If Eysalia Viscount House had a daughter who was close to his age, it was not strange for them to come and see him personally.

Rather, this could be an opportunity for Rex.

He did not know how powerful Eysalia Viscount House was, but if they had a strong influence in their kingdom, he might be able to adjust the tilted succession balance.

“Hmm. I haven’t thought about that yet. For now, I’ll invite the viscount to the castle myself.”

“Your grace.”

Just as Rex was about to make a decision on the invitation from Eysalia Viscount, who wanted to meet him.

The soldier who had been listening to the conversation lowered his head.

It meant that he had something else to say.

Seeing that the soldier’s story was not over yet, Rex asked him about the next issue.

“Is there any problem?”

“The viscount wishes to meet you as quietly as possible.”

“What do you mean by that?”

He wanted to meet Rex as quietly as possible.

It was understandable if he was shy and made such a request.

However, it was hard to find a place in this city where the Count House’s influence did not reach.

The best he could do was to clear out some people around the reception room.

“The viscount has rented a mansion.”

“He wants me to go to his mansion?”

“I heard that you only brought one servant and one knight with you. I don’t think you have to worry too much.”

Rex listened to the soldier’s report and imagined the situation in his head.

One servant. And one knight.

It was not a composition that posed a great threat to Rex’s safety.

Besides, the skill of Sir Palios, who escorted Rex, was outstanding even in the Count House.

With Palios by his side, he did not have to worry about his safety.

After judging the other party, Rex looked at Palios and opened his mouth.

“Sir Palios. Let’s go to the mansion with just the two of us.”

“Are you sure that’s enough, your grace?”

“Wouldn’t it be noisy if we increased the number of people?”

“That’s true. I understand.”

The Meyer Count House had many eyes and ears spread by his half-brothers.

Moreover, Viscount Eysalia, who requested a meeting with Rex, also wanted a quiet meeting.

In that case, he thought it would be enough to have only himself and his escorting knight.

He did not want any unnecessary rumors to leak out if he increased the number of people.

He decided to take only reliable people with him.

“I trust that Sir Palios, a great knight, will protect me well.”

“It is an honor, your grace.”

“I wonder when you will call me your lord.”

Palios had always been by Rex’s side.

But what Palios was loyal to was none other than Count Meyer.

Palios laughed heartily at Rex’s words.

“Haha! I believe that you will undoubtedly become the heir, your grace.”

“...”

“When that day comes, I will gladly offer my sword to you.”

If he ever became the count.

Palios promised Rex a distant future.

Becoming the heir was still a faint possibility.

But even for the sake of saving his face in front of Palios, he had to become the count.

And this meeting was going to be a stepping stone for that.

“In order to do that, I have to... handle this matter well first.”

Rex’s voice, immersed in his thoughts, echoed in the room.

Palios, who was watching him, smiled contentedly.

<Creature Maker>

It had been an hour since I acquired magic.

During that time, I looked at my smartphone and had many doubts.

Was it right to use this skill now?

How should I create creatures with this skill?

Since I could only use this skill five times, I had to invest a lot of time in deciding where to use it.

And after much deliberation, I came to one conclusion.

“Let’s just try it once.”

You can get a rough idea of anything once you use it.

The <Creature Maker> skill was no exception.

If I used this skill to create a creature in reality, I would be able to understand how to use the skill effectively.

Now that I had made up my mind, it was time to try out the skill.

I moved my finger to the <Creature Maker> skill located at the bottom of the screen.

Tap.

As I touched the screen, a guide message for the <Creature Maker> skill popped up.

<Creature Maker> showed a different message from the usual skills.

-You have used <Creature Maker>.

-Please specify the amount of mana you want to consume.

The first thing that appeared when I used the skill was a window to set the amount of mana to consume.

Other skills always consume a fixed amount of mana.

But in the case of <Creature Maker>, it seemed that I could create creatures by consuming as much mana as I wanted.

It was a strange and amazing system.

“The more mana, the stronger it will be, right?”

The more powerful the skill, the more mana it consumes.

Since it was the first creature I created, it wouldn't hurt to put in a lot of mana.

I set the amount of mana to consume to about half of what I had.

Squeeze.

As I set the amount of mana and pressed the confirm button, another window with different content popped up.

- ◦ Please specify the aggressiveness of your creature.

Just like when I set the amount of mana, there was a slider bar that I could move on the window.

But instead of mana, it was an item that set the aggressiveness level of the creature from 1 to 10.

The aggressiveness of the creature.

It seemed that the more aggressive it was, the more powerful it would be.

I moved the slider bar to set the aggressiveness of the creature to the maximum.

“I want it to be strong. Like a boss monster that looks like an evil dragon.”

I always had a fantasy about dragon pets whenever I played any game.

A black dragon flying in the sky.

Just seeing that made me feel more satisfied with the game.

That's why I imagined an evil dragon in my head and adjusted the details of <Creature Maker> accordingly.

The last setting left after finishing the appearance of the creature was only one thing.

- ◦ Please specify the size of your creature.

The size of the creature.

It was an item that determined how big my pet would be.

A dragon had to be big no matter what.

It had to be able to send people flying with just a flick of its tail, and break trees with just its steps.

It was an item that did not require much thought.

“The size has to be maximum.”

I finished setting all the details and pressed the confirm button on the window.

As I finished setting all the items, a light spread on the screen and a target marker popped up.

It was a message that told me to specify the range where I would place the creature.

I did not want to cause any damage to the academy by placing it anywhere, so I put the creature on a mountain range where no one was.

As soon as I touched the screen after setting the target area to the mountain range.

A bright light burst out around the target area, and a guide message popped up at the bottom of the screen.

-You have created [Abyssal Demon: Cuebaerg].

-Due to the penalty of <Creature Maker>, you cannot recover the mana you consumed for 24 hours.

-[Abyssal Demon: Cuebaerg] reveres you.

-<Karma's Judgment> converts [Abyssal Demon: Cuebaerg]'s actions into your causality rate.

The name of the demon that appeared after I finished all the settings was Cuebaerg.

The appearance of the creature with the name Abyssal Demon was truly ferocious.

No, it was more than ferocious.

It was monstrous.

Maybe it was because of the description of Abyssal Demon in front of it.

It looked like an unidentified mass that crawled out of the abyss.

“What is this? Where is my dragon?”

A tentacle protruded from the huge mass filled with darkness and moved toward the sky.

It looked like it was greeting me.

Its appearance was completely different from the dragon I had imagined.

Maybe I set my values wrong.

That thought crossed my mind.

I tried to ignore Cuebaerg and moved my finger quickly to the other side of the map.

“That’s totally opposite of what I wanted.”

The cursed creature of the abyss was not what I wanted.

Rather, it was closer to the opposite of what I wanted.

Sigh.

I let out a sigh and touched the <Creature Maker> skill button again.

As I used <Creature Maker> skill, a detailed setting window appeared as before.

-You have used <Creature Maker>.

-Please specify the amount of mana you want to consume.

I had already used almost half of my mana to make Cuebaerg.

I decided to use 80% of my remaining mana to make a new creature.

But this time, I changed all the values to the opposite of what I had before.

I thought that if I adjusted the settings to the opposite side, I would get the dragon I wanted.

Because Cuebaerg, which was completely opposite to my expectations, came out from my previous settings.

“Please, let it be a dragon this time.”

Aggressiveness setting 1.

Appearance setting 10.

And finally, size setting 1.

It was the exact opposite of what I had before.

I compromised a bit on the size and aggressiveness.

I didn't care if it was a bit small, as long as it was a dragon.

I finished setting everything and set the target area of <Creature Maker> to a rugged mountain range.

As I touched the target area, a light burst out and guide messages kept popping up.

-You have created [Kerubim: Estasia].

-Due to the penalty of <Creature Maker>, you cannot recover the mana you consumed for 24 hours.

-[Kerubim: Estasia] reveres you.

-<Karma's Judgment> converts [Kerubim: Estasia]'s actions into your causality rate.

A coarse curse word naturally came out of my mouth when I faced the result.

This time, it looked too pious.

Chapter 38: The Demon (3)

< 38 : The Demon (3) >

A small village in the southeast of the empire.

Hans was born and raised in such a small village, and lived as a farmer until he reached middle age.

The village was located in a remote mountainous area, where outsiders rarely visited.

Only occasionally, tax collectors or officials would come to the village to impose taxes.

It was rare for Hans to see unfamiliar faces in his village.

That's why the village he knew was always quiet and peaceful.

At least until yesterday.

“What's that noise?”

Boom!

A heavy collision sound echoed in Hans' ears as he was returning home.

From the mountain where the sound came from, a huge smoke rose into the air.

He didn't know exactly what had happened, but judging by the smoke, it was not a good sign.

Hans felt uneasy as he watched the smoke from afar, and then he started to move towards the source of the smoke.

It could be a situation that could affect the village.

Someone had to check the scene.

“What on earth happened here?”

A sound that he only heard when lightning struck echoed from the mountain.

Something bad had happened in the mountain, there was no doubt about it.

Hans quickly moved along the familiar mountain path, and soon he was able to see the cause of the noise.

In the middle of a forest hidden by dense trees.

There was something with a huge body lying there.

“Th-this is...!”

-Grrrrrrrrr.

The black mass twitched slightly.

The tentacles that extended from the mass acted as legs to move its body.

Boom! Thud!

The mass with tentacles was slowly advancing with a heavy sound.

Every time the huge thing moved forward, the trees around it were twisted and fell down.

Hans covered his mouth as he saw the moving body in front of him.

“...”

What Hans saw was a monster.

A monster that looked like it came out of somewhere in hell, not this world.

Hans realized for the first time in his life that he had met a being that fit the word monster best.

The ground shook and the forest collapsed just by moving.

The body that he had to look up at with a headache was so big that it seemed like it wouldn't budge even if he stabbed it with a sword.

It was a disaster-like being.

It was not a being that a mere human could face and survive.

'I have to go back.'

Hans realized the seriousness of the situation and started to back away slowly.

He shouldn't have met such a dangerous being.

The best thing to do was to get away from there as quickly as possible.

He also had to evacuate the people in the village.

To deal with such a thing, the lord who ruled the region had to come up with a solution himself.

As residents of a small village, there was nothing they could do.

Hans finished his judgment of the situation and tried to leave the place.

At that moment.

An eye popped out from the back of the monster that was walking towards the opposite side.

-Grrrrrrrrr.

“Hu-huh...!”

Hans’ body stiffened as he met the monster’s eye.

A huge eye that popped out from the mass stared at Hans.

He was caught.

That was the only thought left in Hans’ mind.

Thud! Boom!

The monster that met Hans immediately started to run towards him.

The noise echoed one after another, and the distance between Hans and the monster quickly narrowed.

-“What are you?”

The monster brought its large eye closer to Hans, who had closed the gap.

At the same time as the monster’s eye approached, an unfamiliar voice echoed in Hans’ head.

It was not a language that Hans knew.

Yet he could understand its meaning.

The monster was asking him a question.

A question about Hans’ identity.

Hans answered his name to the monster with a trembling voice.

“Ha-Hans...”

-“Hans? Is that what you call your life forms?”

“What do you mean...?”

-“Are those things gathered over there all life forms called Hans?”

A tentacle that stretched out from the darkness pointed in the direction of the village.

It was a question asking if everyone in the village was Hans.

It seemed that he was not asking for his name, but rather for the concept of being human.

Hans’ answer itself was wrong.

He corrected his answer again.

“We... we call ourselves humans.”

-“Humans. That is your name.”

“Yes, yes. What are you...?”

-“I am the Lord of the Abyss, Cuebaerg. I came here by the call of the Great One.”

The Lord of the Abyss, Cuebaerg.

It was a name that Hans had never heard before.

Of course, even if there was a more impressive name, a mere farmer from a rural village would not know it.

Thud. Rumble.

Cuebaerg’s eyes came closer to Hans as he finished speaking.

-“And the Great One desires the souls of humans.”

“Wha...?”

-“Humans, become one with the Abyss.”

A thick tentacle stretched out from the darkness and grabbed Hans’ body.

Hans’ panicked eyes looked at Cuebaerg.

Below the giant eyes that were staring at Hans.

There, a large mouth revealed itself.

The huge mouth opened wide, and beyond it, an endless abyss welcomed Hans.

As Cuebaerg moved himself towards his mouth, Hans struggled and screamed.

“Wa, wait! Spare me!”

-Grrrrr.

“I don’t want to die like this! Save me! Please! No!”

Despite his pleas, Cuebaerg’s tentacle did not stop.

The slowly moving tentacle stopped at the top of the open mouth.

The tentacle that was wrapped around Hans’ body started to loosen its grip.

Hans tried to grab the tentacle that was slipping away from him to avoid falling down.

But Cuebaerg’s tentacle refused his touch and dispersed like mist.

Hans’ body fell towards Cuebaerg’s huge mouth as he lost his hold.

“Aaaaaahhhhh!”

Crunch.

With a gruesome sound, Hans' consciousness was cut off.

The only archbishop of the Order, Roan Hebris, looked at the door where the guest started to enter.

Roan was currently in a mansion that he rented from the lord of Shuron.

He rented it for the purpose of using it for himself and the Order's party.

And the guest who came to the mansion was the person he was aiming for.

The first prince of the Count of Meyer, Rex Meyer.

He entered the mansion with his only escort.

"This is the mansion where Lady Eysalia stays."

As Rex and Palios stepped into the mansion, Peter, who greeted them, closed the door again.

Thud.

The sound of the door closing echoed and Palios glanced at Roan.

But he soon moved his steps to follow Rex as he found Eutenia.

Tap. Tap.

Rex walked towards Eutenia and found his seat opposite her.

Then he gracefully greeted her with a noble's salute.

"Nice to meet you, Lady Eysalia."

Eutenia smiled innocently at him as she received his greeting.

Rex's cheeks turned red as he faced Eutenia.

He stared at her for a moment, then sat down awkwardly on the chair opposite her.

As Rex, who came to see Eutenia, sat down, Eutenia's sweet voice rang out in the hall.

"Are you Rex?"

"...Yes?"

"Answer."

"I am Rex Meyer, but you are being too rude for a first meeting..."

It was a rude attitude for anyone to see a viscountess from a neighboring country.

Palios, who escorted Rex, also frowned at Eutenia.

But Roan, who watched that scene, couldn't help but curl his lips with a smile that leaked out.

It was funny to point out the rude attitude of Eutenia.

If he thought about what would happen next, it was a scene that made him laugh naturally.

"That's enough."

"What did you say...?"

"Roan. I've set up a barrier in the mansion, so you can do whatever you want now."

Eutenia opened the book that was on her lap and spoke.

As Eutenia said that it was her turn, Roan, who was watching the situation, got up from his seat.

It was now Roan's job to solve it.

Swoosh.

As soon as Palios heard the word barrier, he drew his sword.

He seemed to have noticed that the situation was turning bad.

But in Roan's opinion, it was too late to react.

From the moment they entered the barrier of the First Apostle Eutenia, it was impossible for them to get out.

"A barrier? What are you trying to do?"

"Sir Palios?"

"Your Highness, be careful. It seems that they have set a trap for you."

Palios, who drew his sword, stepped in front of Rex and started to guard around.

He seemed to be wary of Roan and Eutenia's movements.

Peter, who received Palios' sharp gaze, flinched reflexively.

But Roan had already prepared a plan to subdue the knight who stood up to protect Rex.

Among the apostles of the Order, there was a person who specialized in subduing opponents.

Roan looked up at the ceiling of the mansion.

"Sir Evan. It's your turn to move."

"Is it already time for that?"

At the voice that came from the ceiling, Palios raised his sword in an instant.

A blue flash struck down towards the floor and Evan revealed himself.

Crackle. Sparkle.

Evan, who appeared in a lightning strike, reached out to Palios.

Evan came down on a current and appeared behind Palios, so Palios had no choice but to give up his back without being able to respond properly.

“You bastard, when did you get there...!”

“——Astraphe.”

A strong spark flew from Evan’s hand that grabbed Palios’ head.

Zap!

The current flowed through the gauntlet and Evan’s lightning strike poured out towards Palios.

The blue flash that came out of Astraphe covered Palios’ body in an instant.

Palios, who was hit by Evan’s lightning strike in contact, screamed in pain.

“Aaaahhh...!”

“Sir Palios!”

“Aaaahhh! Ugh...”

Palios, who screamed from the current flowing through his body, collapsed.

Rex looked at Evan with fear-filled eyes as he saw Palios’ eyes roll back and faint.

But Evan ignored Rex and just grabbed Palios’ neck and dragged him away.

Rex could only sit blankly and watch Palios being dragged away.

Evan, who passed by Rex and moved, looked at Roan and spoke.

“Is this one enough?”

“Of course, Apostle. You did well.”

“Call me when the situation is settled.”

“I will.”

After a brief conversation, Evan took Palios with him and disappeared somewhere in the mansion.

With Palios gone, who had been guarding Rex’s side, Roan finally approached Rex.

The eyes of Rex, who was terrified, and Roan, who was calm, met in the air.

There was no one left to protect Rex anymore.

Rex, who was left alone, trembled his hand and threatened Roan.

“Do you, do you know who I am? If I disappear, the count’s family will surely take action.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes! If you don’t want to get in trouble, you better let me go right now!”

“What a pity. The trouble has already happened.”

“What do you mean...?”

Roan leaned his face towards Rex, who was puzzled.

As Roan’s face got closer, Rex’s pupils began to widen.

And at the moment when Rex's pupils expanded to the limit.

The face of the black mage with a playful smile filled the sight of the young nobleman who couldn't hide his surprise.

“Aren't we here?”

Chapter 39: The Demon (4)

< Chapter 39 : The Demon (4) >

It had been almost 20 minutes since Rex was confined in the mansion.

He had no guards to protect him, nor Palios to advise him.

He realized that his status as a count's son meant nothing in this situation.

He finally gave up resisting.

He knew he had no way to fight against them.

He sighed and asked Roan who they were.

“Who are you?”

“We are the Order. We serve the great one, and spread his will to the world.”

“The great one...?”

Rex frowned when he heard the name of the Order.

There were only six temples that were legally recognized by all countries in the continent.

And they were the ones that had been approved by the Holy Land.

The Holy Land's Inquisition would hunt down any other religions that they considered heretics.

Rex thought that the Order that Roan mentioned was far from the six temples of the Holy Land.

Besides, there was no reason for the temples affiliated with the Holy Land to approach him in this way.

The Order was most likely a heretic group that had not been authorized by the Holy Land.

“Do you know about the great one?”

“I don’t think he is one of the six gods that I know.”

“You are quick to catch on. The great one is different from those fakes.”

Roan admitted that they were not part of the Holy Land, but rather a heretic group.

But like any other heretics, he was overly confident.

After all, if he wasn’t confident, he wouldn’t have done such a thing to a noble.

Especially when he had easily subdued Palios, who was one of the most skilled people in the count’s family.

It was proof that he had some strength.

“So, why did you people who serve the great one come looking for me?”

“Our reason for coming to see you today is simple.”

“What is it...?”

“Join the Order. And receive the protection of the Order.”

Rex’s face darkened when he heard the purpose of the Order’s visit.

He thought they would ask for money at most, but it was a more difficult request than he expected.

Joining the Order meant joining a heretic group.

Of course, the Inquisition of the Holy Land would not be able to punish a noble of the empire.

But it was obvious that he would have frequent conflicts with the Holy Land.

Especially, the count Mayer, who was a devout follower of the six temples, would not look kindly on Rex joining the Order.

“You want me to join the Order?”

“It’s not a hard thing to do.”

“It’s heresy! I will be branded as a heathen by the six temples! My father will look at me with strange eyes!”

Heresy.

Roan’s eyebrows twitched at the word that Rex uttered.

Rex realized that he had made a mistake.

The Order had the upper hand in this situation.

Provoking the Order would not do any good for Rex.

“That’s a disrespectful word.”

“No, I mean...”

“Since you have been brainwashed by the evil six temples, I will let it slide this time.”

“Oh, okay.”

Fortunately, it seemed that Roan was willing to overlook his slip of tongue, so Rex nodded along.

Roan corrected Rex's words and then began to explain to him.

"I'm not asking you to openly declare your faith. I know that would cause trouble for you."

"..."

"But if you sincerely decide to serve the Order, we will support you from our side."

Roan did not want Rex to publicly show his support for the Order.

Rather, he promised to support Rex from the Order's side.

But it did not seem like he was offering only financial support.

It was obvious what he meant by supporting Rex in this situation.

He wanted to interfere in the succession dispute of the count's family.

"Support...?"

"You can keep your faith in your heart for now. After all, you will become the count someday."

"Are you saying you will make me a count?"

"Of course. All you have to do is keep your promise with us after you become a count."

The reason why Rex came here was to find allies who would support him.

He even tried to make a connection with a viscount from a neighboring country, Eysalia.

His situation was not good enough that he had to consider joining hands with foreign nobles.

It was because his younger brother's faction had become too powerful for him.

His relationship with his brother Max was also at its worst.

If Max became the count, he would surely try to get rid of Rex, who was an eyesore to him.

He touched his chin and opened his mouth, looking at his pitiful self.

“What do you want from me?”

He was already thinking of bringing in foreign nobles.

Being a heretic doesn't mean I can't get involved in the dirty factional fights.

Even though I knew it was a foolish thing to do, I decided to listen to the church's conditions.

Roan answered my question with a friendly smile.

“One. You will hand over the city's death row inmates to the church.”

“Death row inmates?”

“They're going to die anyway, so why do you care?”

“I guess you're right. Fine.”

It wasn't hard to hand over the death row inmates.

They were doomed to be executed anyway.

If I became an earl, I would even be willing to increase the number of death row inmates.

It was none of my business what happened to those who committed crimes and were dragged away by the heretics.

The only problem was the second condition.

“Two. You will not interfere with the church’s activities in the city.”

“What do you mean by that...?”

“It’s exactly what I said. You will not hinder the church from proselytizing or performing rituals.”

“You want me to leave them alone no matter what they do?”

“I don’t expect that much. I just ask that you don’t get involved in the activities that are approved by the church’s leadership.”

Don’t interfere with the church’s activities.

It was a simple but difficult request.

If I let the church do whatever they wanted, my influence as an earl in the city would inevitably decline.

This could cause trouble for me in the future.

My troubled gaze turned to Roan.

Roan continued his proposal, as if he had something in mind for himself.

“Of course, we will also provide you with adequate support from our side.”

“What kind of support?”

“We will assign Evan, a knight, to escort you for the time being. In addition, we will grant you the honorary bishop position in the Order.”

“...Honorary bishop.”

“It’s the second highest rank in the Order, after me. Do you not like it?”

“Does that mean the Order will take responsibility for me if something goes wrong?”

“Of course. And as long as it doesn’t interfere with the Order’s affairs, you can move the believers as you please.”

He could move the Order’s believers.

This meant that Lex had gained his own power base that he could control.

It was a good offer for Lex.

Also, it opened up a way for Lex to escape to the Order if something went wrong.

If he hid in the Order, even Max, who had become an earl, would have a hard time killing Lex.

It was a fairly attractive option.

“One last thing. I will make you an earl within a year at the latest.”

“A year? You think that’s possible in just a year?”

“Do you think it’s impossible?”

He said he would make him an earl in just a year.

It seemed impossible to Lex.

But from the moment he heard that from Roan, Lex’s heart started to beat wildly.

How long had he dreamed of becoming an earl himself?

Even though the succession was already heavily tilted towards Max, Lex had not given up and held on.

Lex Meyer wanted to become an earl.

If possible, he wanted to sell his soul to the devil and become the next Meyer earl.

“I...”

He didn’t want to end up like the firstborn of a noble family who only cared about the family’s reputation and was killed by his younger brother.

As if he could read Lex’s mind, Roan lightly tapped his shoulder.

It was not the way to treat the eldest son of an earl.

He looked at Lex with a compassionate gaze, as if he was the archbishop looking at a believer of the Order.

“Don’t worry too much. The Great One will be with you.”

“Ha...”

“So, Lex. Come with us.”

Roan extended his hand to Lex.

Blink. Blink.

Lex’s eyes stared at Roan’s palm.

It was a palm that contained a lot of meaning.

Maybe it was like shaking hands with the devil from hell, as he had expected.

But even so, Lex couldn’t refuse the palm in front of him.

“Fine. I’ll join the Order. I get it all... Now give me back Pallios.”

With a weak voice, Lex grabbed Roan’s hand.

Lex Meyer.

He wanted to become an earl.

He wanted to inherit his father's will and become a great lord who ruled over the earldom.

That's why he joined hands with the Order.

Even though he knew it was wrong.

Cloud, Centurion branch.

Agent, a first-class investigator, looked at the report with a dark expression.

Usually, Cloud's reports would only contain relatively common incidents like robbery or theft.

But today's report that the Agent received was not like that.

It was full of things that required more attention than usual.

The first incident on the report was like that.

On that page, there was a cooperation request from Crossbridge to Cloud's headquarters.

"The Inquisitor of the Holy Land went missing here?"

The Inquisitor of Crossbridge went missing while he was on vacation in the Centurion region.

The Inquisitor's name was Evan Allemier.

He was a knight who was famous for his devout faith in the Holy Land.

He was also the brother of Hus Allemier, a second-class investigator who had left Cloud a while ago.

That meant they wanted Cloud's Centurion branch to take charge of searching for the Inquisitor.

Agent turned the page with a troubled expression and muttered to himself.

"Why did he have to disappear here and cause trouble? As if I didn't have enough complicated things to deal with."

Hus Allemier, the second-class investigator who quit Cloud, had a very awkward relationship with Agent, the branch chief.

He had argued with the Agent until the day he quit.

It was not a pleasant thing for the Agent to have to look for the family of such a colleague.

Besides, the Inquisitors were among the important forces in the Holy Land.

It was not a matter of sending a mediocre investigator if one of them suddenly disappeared.

Agent himself was likely to have to step in.

"Hoo."

He sighed and looked at the next page.

The next page also contained information from Cloud's headquarters.

Abyssal Beast, Couverg.

A monster had appeared in the southeast of the empire.

The monster had a level of intelligence that allowed it to communicate, and it introduced itself as Couverg.

“Couverg...”

Couverg was as notorious as its grandiose name.

More than 10 villages had already been destroyed by Couverg.

And because of its nature of crushing everything in its path, a small castle on Couverg’s route was in danger.

The moment Couverg reached the castle, the empire would lose an earl and a castle.

That’s why Cloud’s headquarters wanted the nearby branches to send out hunting teams as soon as possible.

Agent pondered while holding his chin as he read about Couverg.

“If Hus was here, I would have sent him to the hunting team.”

Now that Hus Allemier had left, there was no one in the Centurion branch who could replace him.

For anything less than that, the Agent had to fill in the gap himself.

But the Agent couldn’t handle both cases at the same time.

Both were urgent matters, so the Agent had to make a decision himself.

Would he search for Evan Allemier?

Or would he join the hunt for Couverg?

Agent got up from his seat, alternating between the reports.

“Damn it...”

He crumpled up one of the reports on his desk and threw it away.

It was a report about the hunting team for Couverg.

The crumpled paper left his hand and rolled on the floor.

Thud.

After throwing away the report on the hunting team, Agent gave a hollow laugh and looked at the first report.

“...Hus Allemier. I’ll make sure to thank you for this.”

The search for the missing Inquisitor, Evan Allemier.

That was the Agent’s decision.

Chapter 40: Estasia (1)

< 40 : Estasia (1) >

A mountain range in the southwest of the empire.

There was an angel there, descending with a holy light.

Curly silver hair.

And blue eyes with no expression.

The name of the girl who came down to the earth with a small stature was Estasia.

Estasia, who came down with bright radiance and spread her large wings wide, looked around with bored eyes.

“Yawn...”

She saw a quiet mountain scenery with no one in sight.

The earth where she descended was a strange place even for angels.

If Estasia had not been summoned by the god of another world, she would never have come here in her lifetime.

It required a tremendous amount of magic to break through the boundary of heaven and come down.

Flutter.

As Estasia folded her large wings, the brilliant light that wrapped around her disappeared.

Estasia, who had put away the light, sat on a rock and gave her impression of the surrounding scenery.

“So this is the earth.”

Only a few angels ever came to the human world.

Moreover, recently, due to the rapidly tilted celestial balance, it was rare for goddesses to send angels to the earth.

It was a very unusual thing for Estasia, a seraphim, to come down to the earth.

The one who called her to the earth was none other than the god of the outside world.

The reason why the god of another world called her was simple.

To gather the souls that went astray, and to spread his will on the earth.

Only a few angels, including Estasia, could answer such a call.

“But it’s annoying...”

Estasia had already crossed the boundary of corruption due to her unique personality.

She had a bad reputation in heaven for her personality.

The halo that symbolized the angel emitted a splendid light.

The angel’s halo was the only way for them to communicate with their master.

As Estasia’s halo absorbed the light, tiny star dust scattered around her.

Anyone who saw it would feel reverence.

Estasia, in the midst of such sacred and majestic scenery, offered a sincere prayer to her master.

“Please give me some bread.”

That was the end of her prayer.

As the light of the halo went out and she folded her wings, the radiance that enveloped Estasia also disappeared.

Estasia, who finished her prayer in an instant, looked up at the sky with sparkling eyes.

She thought that something might react from the sky since she had finished her prayer.

And as if to answer her expectation, a piece of bread fell from the sky.

What fell from the sky was a baguette with the length of a human arm.

“It’s a baguette.”

“Wowaaak...!”

As Estasia caught the baguette that fell for her, a scream rang out around her.

She turned her head and looked at the direction where the sound came from.

There was a man screaming around the table where Estasia was sitting.

He seemed to have approached her after finding Estasia praying.

He looked like he had hurt his leg while climbing the mountain, as he was limping.

“A human?”

The human man looked at Estasia with confusion.

She remembered the command she received from the god who brought her here when she faced a human.

Harvest souls.

That was the order of the great being who sent Estasia down.

Estasia looked at the man in front of her and wondered for a moment if she should kill him.

“...”

But she soon erased that command from her mind.

She didn't have any attack magic or anything like that.

And it was too bothersome to move and attack him directly.

Estasia gave up on attacking and bit into the baguette in her hand.

The man in front of her asked her a question as she ate the baguette.

“Are you... an angel...?”

Nod. Nod.

Estasia agreed with his words.

She even spread her wings on her back to show him her large wings.

As Estasia spread her wings, a light burst out around her.

The man knelt down reflexively and prayed at the sight of the light that wrapped around Estasia.

“Holy goddess in heaven——.”

“You won’t get a baguette even if you pray there.”

“Thank you for sending us an angel.”

The man continued to pray while Estasia was eating bread in front of him.

The sight of him praying was also a good spectacle for Estasia.

Of course, he wouldn’t be able to get a baguette like Estasia just by praying.

She watched him pray until she finished eating all of her baguette.

The man’s prayer ended only after Estasia finished her meal.

The man, who had finished his prayer, got up from his seat with a devout expression.

He then looked at his leg and exclaimed in a loud voice.

“No way! My leg healed completely after I finished praying...?”

“Oh, I did that.”

Estasia was an angel specialized in healing and defense.

It was natural that the man’s natural healing ability increased when he entered her domain.

His leg seemed to have mostly recovered while he was praying.

The man, who was healed by Estasia’s power, kept bowing to her and thanking her.

It was not an easy thing to move around the mountain with a hurt leg.

“Angel. Thank you. Thank you.”

“Okay.”

“Thank you. I’ll come back again.”

“Don’t come back next time.”

Estasia saw off the man who thanked her and left.

She thought he wouldn’t come back since she had scolded him.

Estasia got up from her seat and yawned after sending the man away.

She started to feel sleepy after finishing her meal.

It was usually time for a nap.

She was full too.

It was a perfect situation to go into the cave and sleep.

Estasia, who got up from her seat, slowly walked into the cave.

And then she started to sleep in the cave.

Estasia’s nap in the cave lasted until the next morning.

The third day since she came down to the earth.

The front of Estasia’s cave was more crowded than yesterday when she opened her eyes in the morning.

All kinds of fruits were piled up on the table that Estasia used, and many people were kneeling down in front of the table.

Estasia tilted her head at the incomprehensible sight, and an old man at the front of the crowd stood up.

He introduced himself as the village chief and spoke to Estasia.

“These things here are all offerings for you, angel.”

“Offerings?”

“Yes. Please harmonize the earth and heaven well, and make the world peaceful.”

Offerings.

That meant that all the fruits in front of Estasia’s eyes were hers.

Estasia’s eyes scanned over the fruits on the table.

Grapes. Strawberries. Apples. Oranges.

They were all fruits that Estasia liked.

She preferred fruits over bread.

There was no reason not to touch them if she saw her favorite fruits in front of her eyes.

“Are these all mine?”

“Yes. They are our sincerity for you.”

“Okay.”

Estasia, who sat down, reached out for the fruits.

The first fruit she touched was a grape.

As she put a grape in her mouth, sweetness filled her mouth.

It was the taste of fruit that she hadn’t had in a long time.

Estasia’s mood improved with the sweet taste and she spread her wings wide.

The people who were in front of her started to pray together.

“Holy goddess in heaven——.”

“Please make this year a good harvest——.”

“Please make our youngest not sick——.”

Estasia thought as she ate the fruits while watching them pray in front of her.

She thought it would be annoying if there were humans, but they brought fruits to her on their own.

It wasn't such a bad thing to have humans around.

Then, wouldn't it be possible to eat only fruits without doing anything if the number of humans following her increased?

Such a thought crossed Estasia's mind.

“Goddess in heaven——.”

Estasia, who bit an apple, got up from her seat with the apple in her hand.

And then she put a halo on her head and emitted a bright light.

The people who were praying looked at Estasia intently as she shone brightly.

It was the moment when the angel they liked showed her full power.

There was no one here who wouldn't look at her.

Estasia, who was emitting a bright light, coughed lightly and looked around.

“Ahem.”

“The angel speaks!”

“Everyone listen carefully!”

Estasia, who coughed once, looked at the people who were looking at her.

There were many people lined up in front of her, young and old.

They seemed to have a shallow understanding of theology regardless of Estasia’s presence here.

They all accepted Estasia and the being behind her without any doubt.

“Oh, angel...”

“So let’s all pray together to the great one.”

Estasia’s voice, which showed a devout attitude, made the people bow their heads again.

And then they started to pray again to the god in heaven.

But the target of their prayers had changed greatly from before.

As they prayed to the god of another world, Estasia admired her competence while eating an apple.

Chapter 41: Estasia (2)

< 41 : Estasia (2) >

Sometimes in life, you encounter some luck that is hard to understand.

Like finding some money that fell on the street by chance.

Or winning an event that you didn't expect.

Or having a big action that you did casually result in a big outcome.

For me, the scene that was unfolding before my eyes was like that.

The screen of my smartphone that had the game turned on.

There, I saw a number of karma that I never thought of.

“What, what is this?”

The amount of karma that increased in just a day or two was 720.

Considering the recent moves of the cult, it was not from the offerings.

Roan seemed to be aiming for the expansion of the cult, and he went into the city nearby.

Then it was better to think that it was karma that increased for some reason.

I moved my eyes to the bottom of the screen and checked the messages that were generated while I was resting from the game.

“What on earth happened?”

At the bottom of the screen, there were messages with unexpected contents lined up.

Most of them were about karma generation.

Of course, there was hardly any content about the offerings that the cult conducted.

The new protagonists of karma generation were the two creatures that I made last time.

The abyssal beast Cuebaerg.

And the cherub Estasia.

The two creatures were active and accumulated a lot of karma for me.

-[Abyssal Beast: Cuebaerg] has harvested life.

-<Karma's Judgement> calculates the causality rate.

-Karma increased by 42.

-[Abyssal Beast: Cuebaerg] has harvested life.

-<Karma's Judgement> calculates the causality rate.

-Karma increased by 56.

.

.

.

-<Karma's Judgement> calculates the causality rate.

-Karma increased by 22.

Among the two creatures, the one that gave me the most messages was Cuebaerg.

Maybe it was because I set its aggressiveness to 10.

Cuebaerg was moving around the spawn point, destroying everything in its path.

Considering Cuebaerg's size, it was natural that it caused damage just by moving.

And if it also attacked directly, it was understandable that many characters were swept away and disappeared.

All of Cuebaerg's activities were converted into a large amount of karma by <Karma's Judgement>.

I didn't even look at Cuebaerg after creating it, but it earned me so much karma like this.

I felt proud of Cuebaerg, who was diligently hunting automatically, and focused on it.

"Ah... but I can't let it go on for too long."

And then I turned the screen to another direction.

It was not a sight that I wanted to see often.

If all of my characters looked like that, I would have quit the game and gone to play another game a long time ago.

Cuebaerg's appearance was far from my taste.

I turned my eyes away from Cuebaerg, who was hunting, and also checked Estasia's messages.

"She was the pet who asked me for bread... What on earth happened?"

Estasia was a creature with the opposite appearance of Cuebaerg.

It was because I was startled by Cuebaerg's birth and placed all the options on the opposite side.

Maybe it was because she was the opposite of Cuebaerg in every aspect, from appearance to personality.

Estasia showed a completely different behavior from Cuebaerg.

-[Cherubim: Estasia] has manifested a miracle.

-<Karma's Judgement> calculates the causality rate.

-Karma increased by 5.

-The number of followers of the cult has increased greatly.

-Some followers have acquired the <Fanatic> trait.

-Karma increased by 7.

[Cherubim: Estasia] has manifested a large-scale miracle.

-<Karma's Judgement> calculates the causality rate.

-Karma increased by 10.

.

.

.

-The number of followers of the cult has increased greatly.

-Some followers have acquired the <Fanatic> trait.

-Karma increased by 14.

Maybe it was because her aggressiveness was only 1, but I didn't see any messages about harvesting life.

Rather, most of Estasia's messages were events that I had never seen before.

The creation of karma by the manifestation of miracles.

I didn't know what miracles meant exactly, but it was clear that Estasia had done something outrageous.

And even though she gained a lot of karma, the causality rate adjustment didn't move much.

It was a stark contrast to the karma acquisition pattern so far.

“What are you up to?”

The number of followers and the cumulative amount of karma increased.

What kind of things did she do to get these results?

I was curious about Estasia's actions, so I focused the screen on her.

A complex mountain range somewhere on the map.

There, Estasia was spreading her wings in front of a crowd of people.

Estasia looked very holy with her halo and wide-open wings.

Maybe that's why, but many characters around her were bowing their heads to the ground.

“What is this?”

Estasia was surrounded and lifted up by a crowd of people.

When I looked at the characters near her, some of them had the Fanatic trait.

Fanatics were a trait that only occurred in some of the followers.

Most of the characters on the screen were my followers.

I was dumbfounded by the sight of many followers that appeared where Roan was not.

“Why are you there?”

Many followers appeared even though Roan did not preach.

And the appearance of some of the followers was even worse.

They kept bringing fruits and offering them to Estasia.

Of course, Estasia put the fruits she received in her mouth.

A bitter laugh escaped my mouth at the scene of tribute in front of me.

-“Next time, bring more strawberries.”

-“Yes!”

The absurdity was not over yet.

Estasia ordered the next menu to the followers who brought her fruits.

I thought so since she asked me for bread, but that angel was not ordinary.

There must have been something wrong with the AI structure.

Otherwise, there was no way to explain the scene of an angel exploiting other characters.

I couldn't help but wonder as I looked at the angel at the top of the social structure.

“...Is this a good thing?”

But it was okay since karma came in. Maybe I got a good creature.

With a strange AI in front of me, my mind quickly compromised with the situation.

Anyway, Estasia was definitely an amazing creature in terms of karma increase.

The best reward for a creature who did a good deed was to praise it by stroking it.

I reached out to Estasia right away.

I wanted to stroke Estasia's head, who gathered followers.

-“...?”

But my praise did not reach Estasia properly.

Thud.

A shield of light appeared above Estasia's head with a heavy collision sound.

Estasia lifted her head and looked up at the shield floating in the sky.

I also looked down at the shield that appeared on the screen and expressed my doubt.

My hand that tried to stroke Estasia was blocked.

“What is this?”

I couldn't help but marvel again at the hand that was blocked by the shield.

She was an amazing pet in many ways.

Crossbridge, Temple of Abundance.

There, Saintess Serena opened her eyes after praying to the sky.

Serena's eyes sparkled with a ring of light as she finished her prayer and opened her eyes.

Serena looked at her hand and the statue of the goddess alternately for a while, then sighed and got up from her seat.

As Serena finished her prayer, Knight Lian, who was waiting nearby, approached her.

“Are you all right, Saintess?”

“Of course, Lian.”

“You look pale.”

“I guess it's because there are too many troublesome situations happening at once.”

Serena recalled the contents of the divine message she had just heard.

Despite the appearance of a hero, the goddess she served gave the temple a bigger trial by not coming to the temple.

The terrifying minions of the evil god that started to appear simultaneously.

The evil followers of the evil god cult who moved to swallow up the empire.

Neither of them could be left alone.

With many worries on her mind, Serena's face darkened, and Lian asked her:

“Did you receive a divine message?”

“Yes. I received a divine message.”

“What is the content of the divine message?”

“It’s a lot this time. The first thing I received was about the hero chosen by the goddess.”

The whereabouts of the hero of abundance.

Lian’s face hardened as he heard Serena’s story.

Even though all the marks of heroes had appeared, nearly half of them did not come to the temple.

If a hero with a mark died, another hero would be born soon, but if not, it was likely to become a more troublesome situation.

The training and subjugation schedule for nurturing heroes would be messed up.

They needed to bring the heroes to the temple somehow to prevent that.

“The hero of abundance, you mean.”

“Yes.”

“Did you find out about him?”

“His name is Gilford Proud. He seems to be the captain of Gilford Mercenary Group.”

“Gilford Proud. That’s his name.”

“And he had a divine weapon called Ascalon.”

Serena made a troubled expression as she recalled Gilford’s face, who hid his mark and wandered around.

She had to investigate more details, but Gilford didn't seem like a bad person from his actions.

She didn't want to punish him unless there was a problem.

And he received Ascalon from the goddess of abundance as well.

Ascalon was called the strongest among all divine weapons in six temples.

It made your body stronger just by holding it, and when all seals were released, it could even hurt gods.

It was an absurd item among celestial treasures allowed to humans.

The goddess they served entrusted humans with even a blade that could challenge her.

If Ascalon lost its owner and became sealed again, there would be significant restrictions on what they could do in holy land.

Lian confirmed again with Serena about Ascalon after hearing that he had it.

“Are you saying that he has Ascalon?”

“It's a difficult situation.”

Serena looked at the white holy sword hanging on Lian's waist and said.

Ascalon was incomparable to the imitation divine weapon that Lian had.

It made your body stronger just by holding it, and when all seals were released, it could even hurt gods.

It was an absurd item among celestial treasures allowed to humans.

The goddess they served entrusted humans with even a blade that could challenge her.

If Ascalon lost its owner and became sealed again, there would be significant restrictions on what they could do in holy land.

“We have to bring him to the holy land somehow!”

“Lian. Calm down. We have a lot of other things to do.”

“Ha... Gilford, you said. I’ll order the knights to investigate him separately.”

“Okay. I’ll leave that part to you.”

The matter of the hero Gilford was something that could not be ignored by the whole holy land.

“And the other one is a fallen angel named Estasia...”

“A fallen angel. A tricky opponent.”

“She’s a bit strange.”

“Yes...?”

“She’s fallen, but not a fallen angel.”

Lian made a puzzled expression as he heard Serena’s words.

When an angel falls into evil, they lose their halo and wings’ light and become a fallen angel.

So Serena’s words were very contradictory.

How could such a state exist?

Of course, Serena didn’t understand it either, who uttered the words.

“I don’t know what I’m saying either.”

She was fallen, but she was a good angel.

She didn't know why the good angel has fallen either.

Chapter 42: Estasia (3)

< 42 : Estasia (3) >

A mansion in the city.

Eutenia was staring at a book with a blank expression, while Peter and Roan were having a conversation in front of her.

Evan, who would have been with them, had entered the inner castle with the eldest son of the count.

Therefore, the only ones left in the mansion were Eutenia and these two.

Archbishop Roan, who was in front of Eutenia, quietly opened his mouth as he looked at Peter and Eutenia.

“I’m planning to kill the count when I get a chance.”

“Kill the count?”

He wanted to kill Mayer Count, the lord of the city.

Peter was shocked by Roan’s words.

It was a grave crime to try to kill a noble.

And if the other party was a count who ruled a territory, the matter would be too big.

It was incomprehensible to Peter, who had always looked up to the nobles as if they were heaven.

Of course, Roan's way of thinking was the opposite of Peter's, who had lived as a dark mage all his life.

"That's the fastest way to replace the count."

"But if you get caught..."

"Once the count is taken care of, Evan's movements will become an internal matter of the count's family. If that happens..."

Eutenia interrupted their conversation and intervened as Peter worried about the punishment if they were caught.

"My master has sent me a divine message."

Eutenia closed the book she had opened and said to Roan.

While they were talking, her master had secretly sent her instructions.

Roan and Peter's attention focused on her as Eutenia said she had received a divine message.

The story that the god of heaven told humans was something that anyone living on earth would be curious about.

Roan asked Eutenia with an expectant face.

"Are you saying that you received a divine message from the great one?"

"I think I have to go out for a while. He entrusted me with a task."

"It seems like you're leaving the city."

Roan nodded at Eutenia's words.

The trust that Eutenia received from him was something that she could not fulfill in this city.

To keep the word of the great being, she needed to pack her belongings and leave the city.

Working for her master was the only meaning of existence left for Eutenia.

“He said I have to go to the southwest of the empire.”

“The southwest of the empire... Is there something there?”

“An angel descended from the sky.”

“An, an angel...!”

Peter was shocked by the word ‘angel’.

He looked more surprised than when he heard the words ‘kill the earl’.

Peter was hiding in a place where the cult that served the evil god gathered.

The fact that an angel who conveyed the will of heaven came down meant that it would not be strange even if they were slaughtered by the angel.

Peter imagined the appearance of the angel in his head and soon felt sorry.

‘The apostles of the evil god are finally trying to kill the angel.’

The apostle of the evil god brought up the story of the angel, surely to get rid of him.

That was what Peter judged and looked at Eutenia.

At that moment, a story that was completely opposite to Peter’s expectation came out of Eutenia’s mouth.

“Thanks to the angel sent by the great one, the number of believers in the cult has increased a lot. So he decided to send me.”

“Huh. Without me knowing, the grace of the great one spread there.”

“...?”

The feeling of astonishment soon turned into confusion.

Peter looked at Eutenia and Roan alternately with an expression of incomprehension.

Why did the evil god send down an angel?

It would have been normal for the evil god to send down a demon instead.

At the very least, he could have understood if it was not just an angel, but a fallen angel.

But the angel sent by the evil god was creating believers for the cult.

It was a situation that completely contradicted Peter's common sense.

“I'm thinking of appointing a new bishop for the cult in the southwest. It would be nice if Roan, the archbishop, could write a letter of appointment for him.”

“A new bishop... I see. After this is over, we will transform into an even bigger cult.”

Of course, regardless of Peter's bewilderment, the conversation of the cult proceeded faithfully.

Hearing Eutenia's words, Roan began to think about the letter of appointment that he would deliver to the new bishop.

Soon after Eutenia arrived in the southwest, a new bishop would be born there.

Neither Roan nor Eutenia doubted the appearance of the angel.

Was he the only one who had a strange thought?

Peter looked at Roan with a puzzled face, and Eutenia, who was next to him, spoke to Peter.

“Peter. Get ready to move soon.”

“Yes, yes?”

“You have to drive the carriage, right? Roan will talk to the earl’s house and prepare a map for you.”

She was telling him to prepare to move soon because they were leaving soon.

A journey to meet the angel.

When Eutenia said that she would accompany him, Peter asked her reflexively.

“Am I... going too?”

“Who else will move the carriage without Peter?”

“Oh...”

Eutenia had entrusted Peter with driving the carriage as if it was natural.

He had become a true servant in no time, even though he felt like he was just pretending when he talked to Evan.

Before he knew it, it had become something he could not deny.

Would he remain as Eutenia’s servant forever at this rate?

Peter, who was full of worries about his future, was spoken to by Eutenia again.

“Peter?”

“...I’ll get ready.”

Under Eutenia's continued urging, Peter reluctantly accepted her request.

If Eutenia had decided so, there was no other choice left for Peter but to follow her.

So Peter prepared for Eutenia's trip without being able to solve the many questions in his chest.

It had been a week since Estasia descended to the ground.

During that time, many changes had occurred around her, but the biggest change was that the cave became more splendid.

The cave where Estasia stayed was now decorated with countless ornaments.

It was a completely different look from the barren cave that she saw on the first day.

They were all gifts from the believers who flocked to see Estasia.

Estasia smiled as she looked at the splendid cave and went outside.

“Ahem.”

As soon as Estasia came out of the cave with a cough, the believers who were waiting outside rushed to her.

The believers who came to see Estasia each had a basket in their hands.

Estasia sat at the table and looked at the baskets in the hands of the believers one by one.

All kinds of baskets contained various fruits.

The first one who ran to Estasia was a believer who had a basket of strawberries.

“Angel. These are the strawberries you asked for last time.”

“Good job.”

Estasia took the basket of strawberries and put one in her mouth.

The sweetness of the strawberry filled her mouth.

It was a fresh strawberry, maybe because it was just picked.

She felt like stuffing her mouth with strawberries because they tasted so good.

Estasia put a handful of strawberries in her mouth and put the basket on the floor.

Another basket came in front of Estasia, who was chewing on the strawberries.

“Angel! I’m the one whose leg you healed! I found some sturdy grapes and brought them!”

“Hmm. They look delicious.”

The one who came with grapes was the human who met Estasia on the first day.

He brought a bunch of grapes with big seeds and handed them to Estasia.

Estasia took the basket and put a grape in her mouth and rolled it around.

It was as sweet as the strawberry, and it filled her mouth with juice.

She also stuffed her mouth with grapes, and another basket came in front of her.

“I brought you some apples.”

Apples. Strawberries. Grapes. Oranges.

All kinds of fruits were lined up, waiting for her to come.

Estasia took the fruits one by one, tasted them, and put them on the table.

There were enough fruits to last her all day, even if she ate nonstop.

Every time she woke up and got up, she was given this many fruits.

They brought her countless fruits just by sitting still.

It was a dreamlike situation for Estasia, who hated working.

“I like apples too.”

Estasia moved her wings as she was impressed by the taste of the apple.

Flap.

Estasia’s wings spread wide, and a halo rose above her head.

The people around her were moved and cheered by the sight of Estasia with her halo and wings.

They were all believers who served Estasia and her master.

They came to the cave every day to see Estasia.

“An angel has spread her wings!”

“This is the holy light...”

“Hey! Everyone be quiet!”

The village chief, who had become the representative of the people who came to the cave, opened his mouth.

The number of people who came to see Estasia had increased greatly, but even so, they all accepted the village chief as their implicit leader.

He was also the one who established various rules for meeting the angel.

The village chief, who calmed down the people, knelt down and prayed to the angel.

The believers around him also joined in prayer following the village chief.

Estasia, who was watching the praying believers in front of her, muttered with a satisfied face.

“The earth was... better than I thought.”

She had heard a lot about the earth from other angels early on.

That there were humans with evil hearts crawling on the ground.

That there were some humans who enslaved their own kind.

That sometimes they could find monsters from the abyss that appeared to lure humans.

They were all stories about the horrors of humans and monsters.

But the ground that Estasia experienced was different from the rumors.

“I don’t have to work and fruits keep coming.”

The humans on the ground were very kind to Estasia, who was an angel.

If she wanted to eat fruit, they brought her whatever fruit she wanted.

If it was a hard-to-find fruit, they would try their best to get it, even if it took some time.

She could taste a lot of fruits that were hard to get in heaven here.

“Jewels keep coming too.”

Not only fruits, but also expensive jewels were brought to Estasia.

Estasia's cave was littered with sparkling jewels that the believers had collected.

They were precious items that they brought to her as offerings.

They were expensive-looking items even to Estasia, who didn't know much about jewels.

She thought she could sell them and buy fruits if she had any problems later.

Of course, now they were just toys that she threw and played with when she was bored.

"This is heaven..."

Heaven was not where the angels lived, but here was Estasia's heaven.

It was a paradise that did not exist anywhere on the ground.

Estasia, who only rolled around in the cave all day, felt happy these days.

Now was the time to offer a sincere prayer of gratitude.

"_____."

She smiled and clasped her hands, and her halo shone brightly.

The angel's halo worked properly and connected the sounds of heaven and earth.

Estasia, who connected the halo, began to pray to the god who would hear her voice.

"Please give me delicious fruits tomorrow and the day after..."

-“Estasia! Where are you and what are you doing!”

“Huh...?”

But the voice that came to Estasia's ears was that of the angel who lived with her.

It seemed that the halo was connected incorrectly.

Estasia immediately disconnected the halo.

Flash.

The light of the halo went out, and the voice that rang in Estasia's ears also disappeared.

When the voice disappeared, Estasia sighed with relief and muttered.

“Phew... I almost let them know that there are a lot of fruits on the ground.”

The fruits here were all Estasia's.

It wouldn't happen because of the magic problem, but it would be troublesome if other angels came to the ground.

Estasia, who was startled by the unexpected situation, began to adjust the connection of the halo again.

It was a moment when she almost had a big problem.

Chapter 43: Prelude (1)

< 43 : Prelude (1) >

A lot of time had passed since I picked Estasia.

During that time, Cuebaerg faithfully earned me karma, and the number of believers who followed Estasia also increased greatly.

Of course, I also needed someone to lead those believers, so I asked Eutenia to appoint a new bishop.

The cult that started with just a few people was now expanding into a large scale.

I finally realized that the game was on track with the drastically changed speed of karma acquisition.

“This is a real idle game.”

I get a huge amount of karma every day without doing anything.

The amount of karma required increased as the level went up, but it was still an amazing speed.

At this pace, I might reach the next level soon.

Maybe I could even create the next apostle in no time.

I bit into the chicken burger in my hand with satisfaction as I looked at the messages that filled the screen.

“This is real food.”

Chicken and burger.

It was a rare combination that was good enough.

They were both delicious on their own, but they were also great together.

As I ate the chicken burger that I bought on my way home and looked at my smartphone, I heard an on TV.

-“3-stage combined super dinosaur robot! Crush the evil enemies with your powerful strength!”

I reflexively looked at the TV screen when I heard the narration in my ear.

As soon as I got home, I turned on the TV and saw a children’s toy .

It was a product that combined three dinosaurs into a giant robot.

It looked quite impressive when it showed the combined form.

I always wanted those kinds of toys when I was young.

While I was looking at the dinosaurs behind the robot, a huge dragon figure flashed through my mind.

“Ah. I need to draw a dragon.”

I still had the dragon creature that I failed to draw last time in my mind.

For me, dragons were something like a dream.

I didn’t care if they could combine into a super robot like the one on TV, I just wished I could have one dragon.

I felt a pang of regret for the dragon, and the <Creature Maker> skill under my smartphone caught my eye.

“Should I try making one more?”

The magic that was sealed by the penalty of <Creature Maker> had already returned.

It was possible to use the <Creature Maker> skill again.

I looked back and forth between the skill icon on my smartphone and the three-stage combined super dinosaur robot.

And after some deliberation, I decided to use the skill.

“Please, let it be a dragon.”

There was no reason to hesitate once I made up my mind.

Tap.

I moved my finger and touched the <Creature Maker> skill icon.

As I tapped the icon to activate the skill, the creature creation option appeared on the smartphone screen.

-You used <Creature Maker>.

-Please specify the amount of mana you want to consume.

The first thing that came up was the same as before, a screen to set the mana amount.

I didn't know how mana affected the creature, but I guessed that more was better.

I adjusted the slider bar to 85%, which was the amount of mana I wanted to use.

It was not all of my mana, but enough to have some fun.

After setting the mana, the next thing that popped up was a window to set the aggressiveness.

-Please specify the aggressiveness of the creature.

The aggressiveness value I set when I created Cuebaerg was 10.

And Cuebaerg was currently destroying everything in sight as he moved.

For Estasia, I set the aggressiveness to 1.

As a result, Estasia did not attack anyone at all.

Looking at these two examples, I thought that too much or too little aggressiveness would result in a weird creature.

“I’ll set the aggressiveness to 4, just right.”

That’s why I set the new creature’s aggressiveness to 4.

Of course, this also applied to the appearance setting that appeared next.

Estasia and Cuebaerg’s appearances were very different.

I had to find a compromise between them.

-Please specify the appearance of the creature.

-The closer to 1, the more ferocious it will look.

-The closer to 10, the more gentle it will look.

Based on my previous experience, I also set the creature’s appearance to 4.

I hoped that this would produce a decent creature with a moderate appearance.

-Please specify the size of the creature.

-The closer to 10, the bigger it will be.

The next item to set was the size.

Cuebaerg was too huge.

And Estasia was about the same size as a human.

Considering these two extremes, I thought it was reasonable to regard human size as 1.

How big should the creature be to get what I wanted?

As I pondered while looking at the setting window, I decided to set the creature's size to 5.

“Please come out as a normal one.”

All that was left was to see what kind of creature would pop out.

After finishing all the settings, I touched the confirm button and used the <Creature Maker> skill.

Squish.

As I moved my finger to designate the target location, the smartphone screen was wrapped in light and a message appeared in an instant.

-You created [Shadow Beast: Alpha].

-Due to the penalty of <Creature Maker>, you cannot recover the mana you consumed for 24 hours.

-[Shadow Beast: Alpha] reveres you.

-<Karma's Judgment> converts [Shadow Beast: Alpha]'s actions into your causality rate.

The creature that I made by paying 85% of my mana as a cost revealed its appearance.

The name of the new creature was [Shadow Beast: Alpha].

And the appearance of the new creature that revealed itself was that of a dragon, which I had longed for so much.

Black scales.

Golden eyes slit vertically.

Horns on the head and wings on the back.

It was a dragon itself, in almost every aspect, that I had idealized.

“Is this a dragon——.”

Except for the fact that it was a baby dragon that looked smaller than Estasia.

My voice stopped as I checked the size of the dragon.

The size of the newly appeared dragon was strange.

I blinked and looked at the screen again.

“——but why is it so small?”

I couldn't help but wonder at the sight of Alpha, who appeared on the construction site.

I was sure I had set the creature's size to 5, but Alpha's size didn't even look like 0.5.

It was very small for a creature.

There was no trace of the dignity of a dragon.

Gilford Proud.

He was the leader of the Gilford Mercenary Corps and the chosen hero of abundance. He was moving to the western region of the empire with his comrades.

The mark of abundance that appeared on Gilford's arm had been hidden by a gauntlet for a long time.

He didn't want to be bothered by the temple officials who would notice his mark.

The new artifact that Gilford obtained, Ascalon, also did not emit light unless he used it.

Therefore, there was no difference from before except that Gilford had two swords now.

"Leader. Are we really okay with this?"

As Gilford led the mercenary corps to move, Jenny, the only mage in the mercenary corps, asked him.

There was only one thing that Jenny could worry about at this point.

It was about the mark on Gilford's arm and the temple of abundance.

Gilford had said before that he wouldn't go to the temple, but she still seemed worried about their movements.

Gilford patted Jenny's shoulder and said to her.

"Don't worry. It will be more helpful for the world if we become stronger."

"Leader always says to relax, but..."

"And I don't like being affiliated with complicated places like temples. If I did, I wouldn't have recruited mercenaries like this."

"..."

“Isn’t that the same for you guys?”

When Gilford asked the mercenaries around him, they all nodded in agreement.

Among them, the most enthusiastic response came from Gaff, the deputy leader of the mercenary corps.

Gaff spoke loudly enough to echo around him.

His voice was so loud that Gilford and Jenny’s ears hurt from listening to him.

“Of course! Who among mercenaries likes complicated things?”

“Yeah, yeah. It’s better to just use our bodies a bit and earn more money.”

“Besides, most of the mercenaries here can’t even read! What difference does it make if you’re a leader or not?”

“...I can read.”

“And if there’s a problem with the leader, we’ll step in too! Of course, only if you pay us!”

“Our mage is such a smart person, I’m worried he might not be human.”

The mercenaries’ rough laughter echoed around them.

Jenny’s face turned red as she saw the mercenaries laughing at her.

She clutched her staff tightly and trembled.

Thump. Thump.

Gilford’s hand tapped Jenny’s shoulder again.

“Besides, we have such a capable mage on our team, don’t we?”

“Leader...”

“It’s rare for a mercenary band to have a mage with them. Especially such a talented one.”

“Even if you praise me like that... I don’t think you have anything else to offer me...”

“So don’t worry and stay with us until the end. I don’t want to part with good comrades like you.”

Gilford said calmly and withdrew his hand.

As he expressed his will, he continued to walk forward.

At that moment, Ascalon, the sword he carried on his waist, began to emit a bright light.

All the mercenaries’ eyes turned to Gilford as they saw the glowing Ascalon.

Gilford spoke to Ascalon, which was surrounded by a brilliant aura.

“Ascalon?”

-“I don’t want to ruin the good mood, but it seems like we have some trouble ahead.”

“Trouble? What are you talking about?”

-“A little away from here, a minion of the evil god has revealed itself.”

A minion of the evil god.

Gilford’s face hardened at Ascalon’s words.

He had already heard about the appearance of the evil god from Ascalon.

But he didn’t expect to hear about its minion so soon.

“What kind of minion is it?”

-“A cherubim from heaven has fallen to the earth. It looks like a fallen angel.”

“A fallen angel...”

-“The cherubim that appeared on the earth seems to be affecting the heavenly order in some way. If we don’t take action soon, things will get out of hand.”

A fallen angel from heaven.

A minion of the evil god would surely lure people with its wicked schemes.

The image of a fallen angel with black wings flashed through Gilford’s mind.

The evil fallen angel would surely have a powerful force given by the evil god.

As he pictured the fallen angel in his head, Gilford grabbed Ascalon on his waist.

“Do I have to deal with it?”

-“Since it’s related to the cult of the evil god, it would be better for you, the hero, to step in.”

He had said he wouldn’t go to the temple, but he didn’t mean to ignore the evil god’s forces completely.

If he could solve it, he was willing to do so.

If there were people suffering because of the fallen angel, he couldn’t just stand by and watch.

After hearing the story, Gilford decided to face the fallen angel himself.

Hoo.

He let out a deep breath and asked Ascalon.

“How far is it?”

-“It should take about half a month to get there.”

“Half a month. That’s not too far.”

-“What are you going to do?”

“Well, that’s obvious.”

Gilford looked around at his comrades.

Gaff and Jenny.

And the reliable mercenaries.

They would all fight with Gilford.

Swoosh.

He drew out Ascalon and shouted to them.

“We’re going to hunt down the fallen angel. Anyone who’s afraid can leave right now.”

Chapter 44: Prelude (2)

< 44 : Prelude (2) >

It had been five days since Peter left the city with Eutenia.

With the support of Viscount Shuron, they had prepared a carriage with their belongings and were smoothly moving towards the southwest of the empire.

Of course, they couldn't travel all day long, so they would stop and make a fire and prepare a meal in the evening.

At the crossroad where they parked their carriage.

As usual, Peter lit a fire and was about to approach the carriage to get some ingredients.

If only he hadn't noticed Eutenia sitting on a large rock.

“What on earth is that?”

On Eutenia's lap, a strange creature was blinking its eyes.

Black scales covering its whole body.

Sharp horns sticking out of its head.

A small tail swaying from side to side.

There was also a golden pupil that was split vertically.

Peter recalled the picture that was displayed in the city and quickly realized that it was a dragon.

“Could it be... a dragon?”

“Are you curious about its identity?”

“...Anyone would be curious if they saw that thing.”

It was usually a place where a book would be instead of a dragon.

But now, instead of a book, there was a young dragon that he had never seen before.

It was a creature that he couldn't even face until this morning.

Peter's question towards the creature in front of him was natural.

Eutenia stroked the dragon's head and said to Peter, who was curious about the dragon's identity.

“This child's name is Alpha. It is a descendant of the great one who sent it to me personally.”

“This thing is a descendant of the great one?”

Peter made a puzzled face after hearing Alpha's identity from Eutenia.

When people think of the descendants of the evil god, they usually imagine terrifying and powerful monsters.

But in Peter's eyes, Alpha looked like it couldn't even harm small animals, let alone people.

A tiny thing like that was a descendant of the evil god.

It was not a very believable appearance for Peter.

“It's very small. It looks like it can't even kill a rabbit.”

“Do you really think so?”

But Eutenia immediately denied Peter’s words.

It was an attitude that showed that Peter was underestimating Alpha.

Peter couldn’t understand why Eutenia said that.

No matter how strong it was, the difference in size was hard to ignore.

Unless Alpha used magic, it seemed impossible for it to catch an animal bigger than itself.

“Are you saying that this little thing can bite and kill a rabbit?”

“It can.”

“You mean it can kill it by biting, not by using magic?”

“This is not Alpha’s main body.”

This is not its main body.

Peter began to ponder after hearing Eutenia’s words.

If that tiny thing was not its main body, then Alpha’s real body existed somewhere else.

But when Peter looked around, he couldn’t see anyone who looked suspicious of hiding.

At least to Peter’s eyes, Eutenia and Alpha were all there was.

“If this is not its main body...”

“This is a kind of organ. An organ that acquires visual and auditory information and supplements information.”

Purr.

Alpha closed its eyes and snorted at Eutenia's touch.

It seemed to like her touch.

Eutenia stroked Alpha's head and looked at Peter with an innocent smile and asked.

"Do you want to see what Alpha looks like?"

"I'm curious, but..."

"Then I'll show you."

It would be a lie to say he didn't want to see it.

Peter stared intently at Alpha.

Alpha was still closing its eyes and looked peaceful.

Peter added another word as he looked at Alpha.

"Is it going to pop out of thin air or something?"

"——Alpha."

The moment Eutenia's gentle voice echoed.

Peter stepped back from the change that occurred around him.

The anomaly happened on the ground where Peter was standing.

Eutenia's shadow spread out and soon the shadow on the ground began to ripple like waves.

Woo woo woo woo woong.

Peter started to panic at the howling sound that shook his ears.

"What, what is this... Are you trying to use the hand of shadow?"

“That’s not it.”

A wall of shadow suddenly rose up around Peter, who was looking at the ground.

It looked like the shadow had a clear shape.

The large and huge wall blocked the way between Peter and the carriage.

It looked several meters high even to the eye.

Peter slightly distanced himself from the wall of shadow that rose from the ground.

“Wh, what...?”

Peter rubbed his eyes and checked the situation again after the sudden change.

What appeared in front of Peter was not a wall.

It was a huge creature wrapped in shadow.

Flash.

A part of the shadow opened and a golden eye looked at Peter.

The bright eye was the only thing that held light in the darkness.

Peter was then able to recognize what Alpha’s main body was.

“Is this...”

The huge darkness that existed in front of him.

That was the essence of the dark beast.

What it looked like on the outside was just an illusion.

Even the huge shadow that entered Peter's sight was only a part of the dark beast.

Alpha was only sticking out a part of its head to consider Eutenia and Peter.

Eutenia laughed quietly at Peter's attitude, who couldn't hide his surprise.

"Do you still think Alpha is weak?"

"...Looking at its size, it seems like it could easily eat me too."

He retracted his words that it looked like it couldn't even kill a rabbit.

For a monster of that size, eating a small creature like a rabbit would be nothing special.

Rather, he was worried that he might be eaten by it.

It was not for nothing that the evil god chose Alpha as his descendant and sent it down.

"It's okay. As long as I'm here, nothing like that will happen."

A hand stretched out from Eutenia's shadow and stroked Alpha, who showed itself from the ground.

The main body of Alpha also shook its head and enjoyed the touch.

Alpha seemed to have a gentler personality than expected.

It looked like a pet that was playing with its owner.

Peter looked at Eutenia, who was handling Alpha.

"...It does look tame."

"Do you think so?"

A little dragon and a girl with ash-colored hair.

He saw the girl smiling as she stroked the dragon.

Peter thought that it was a pretty picture under the setting sun.

If only he could erase their identities from his mind.

Cloud, Leotis branch.

This was the place that governed the Leotis region, located in the southeast of the empire.

The branch chief and first-class investigator of the Leotis branch, Gedur, was a warrior of a minority race.

Red-eyed Gedur.

He was a person who rose to the position of branch chief of Cloud with his skill alone.

Gedur was appointed as the captain of the Kueberg subjugation team that he was forming at the headquarters, thanks to his outstanding skill.

There was even a rumor that Gedur would become a special-class investigator if he successfully handled this subjugation operation.

“How is the preparation going?”

Gedur wiped his huge muscular body with a towel and asked his subordinate.

He was asking about the preparation of the subjugation team.

The preparation of the operation was up to Gedur, the captain of the subjugation team, and the Leotis branch, which was the main force of the operation.

Gedur’s subordinate told him in a voice full of spirit.

“Personnel are arriving from each branch! So far, from Centrius...”

“Your voice is small. Did you eat less today?”

But Gedur’s mouth burst out with dissatisfaction at his subordinate’s voice that was full of energy.

Gulp.

The subordinate swallowed his saliva as he faced Gedur.

A vein popped up on Gedur’s forehead as he looked at his subordinate.

“No!”

“Answer louder. There can be no weaklings in our Leotis branch.”

“I’ll report again!”

“Yes.”

Gedur started to wipe his sweat again, and his subordinate reported in a louder voice.

His subordinate’s voice echoed in the office.

He was so loud that his throat turned red.

Gedur looked at his subordinate with a satisfied expression then.

“From Centrius branch, eight third-class investigators! Three second-class investigators! Among them, three are magicians!”

“...”

“From Upliod branch, sixteen third-class investigators! Two second...”

“Wait. Is that all they sent from Centrius?”

Gedur stopped his subordinate again as he listened to the report.

This time, it was a problem with the content of the report.

The number of personnel sent was less than what Gedur expected.

The subordinate immediately confirmed Gedur's question.

“Yes! The total number of personnel sent from Centrius branch is eleven!”

“Agent? What about Agent? Didn't he come here?”

“Agent Period, the branch chief, did not accompany the personnel!”

It was a monster that was causing a lot of damage.

He thought that Agent, the branch chief of Centrius, would come, but Gedur's expectation was in vain.

Moreover, the number of personnel sent to the subjugation team was also too low.

Considering the number of investigators assigned to each branch, Gedur thought that Centrius branch had more room.

Gedur asked his subordinate, hoping that they would at least send a competent magician from Centrius.

“What about his subordinate, Hus Alemier? Is he on the list?”

“There is no investigator with that name on the list!”

“Agent! That damn bastard!”

Crash!

Gedur's fist slammed down on the desk.

A large crack was made where his fist and the desk met.

The subordinate's body flinched at Gedur's gesture of hitting the desk.

"Why didn't he come?"

"Agent Period, the branch chief, is currently performing another mission assigned by the headquarters."

"What? He has another mission?"

"That's what I heard from the personnel."

Bang! Boom!

Gedur hit the desk a few more times.

Some parts of the desk that were hit by Gedur's fist collapsed completely.

Unable to overcome the frustration in his chest, Gedur got close to his subordinate.

And he whispered in his ear with a small voice.

"There's a monster attacking over there, is that mission so urgent?"

"Th, that... I don't know either. All I know is that it was a request from the holy land to the headquarters..."

"Where are the magicians? He had magicians that he always cursed at!"

"Th, that too... I haven't received any reports..."

The subordinate's body shrank as Gedur's voice got louder.

But there was no solid answer from his subordinate.

All he knew was what he heard from the personnel.

"Why are there so few people!"

“There was an unpleasant incident recently, so they were short of personnel...”

“There was a problem on site? Well, that’s annoying but unavoidable.”

“Hoo...”

Gedur distanced himself from his subordinate after hearing why there were so few people.

His voice sounded like he understood.

The subordinate let out a sigh from his mouth.

But Gedur came back to his subordinate right away.

And he whispered in his ear with a small voice again.

“Your voice suddenly got small?”

“I’m sorryyyyyy!”

“Quiet! As soon as you go out, proceed with the formation of the magic soldier unit!”

“I understand!”

“Weakling! Get out of here!”

Crash!

Gedur, who had driven out his subordinate, breathed roughly.

It seemed that fewer people would gather than Gedur expected.

But it was impossible to delay the time indefinitely because of the lack of numbers.

Kueberg was moving towards the self-made spirit even at this time.

“I can’t miss this opportunity.”

The promotion to a special-class investigator was what Gedur had been waiting for.

It was unacceptable to lose this chance by failing the subjugation.

Grit.

Gedur clenched his teeth as he thought of Agent, the branch chief of Centrius.

Whether it was for the people or for Gedur himself.

This subjugation had to be successful.

Chapter 45: Prelude (3)

< 45 : Prelude (3) >

In a small study room at the Meyer Count's mansion,
the Countess of Meyer looked at her loyal knight, Kedol.

Kedol was a knight who had accompanied her from her family when she married into the Meyer house.

He had always been a bridge between her and her parents, keeping them in touch.

He was also a person who handled the noisy matters in the count's house, along with the maid Amy.

The Countess of Meyer, who had a book open on the table, whispered a secret story to her knight, Kedol.

“Sir Kedol, the news I told you last time, it seems to be true.”

“Are you talking about Palios?”

“Yes. Don't you know that Palios is no longer following that Lex guy around?”

Knight Palios was an outstanding knight who followed the first prince, Lex Meyer.

He was a person who had sworn loyalty to the Count of Meyer, and he was escorting Lex according to his belief and the count's order.

The loyalty of Knight Palios, who always protected Lex, was a very annoying factor for the countess, who wanted to get rid of Lex.

But recently, he seemed to distance himself from Lex.

It was not hard for the countess, who had been watching Palios and Lex, to find out the reason.

Since the day Lex said he had been attacked while going out, a strange knight had started to follow him around.

“It must be because of that Evan guy.”

Knight Evan.

He was a knight who had saved Lex from an ambush while he was out and swore allegiance to him anew.

Lex had taken in Evan, who had been a free knight, and with his strong support, he had easily gained access to the castle.

Evan had pushed aside Palios, who had been the closest aide, and took his place. It was natural for Palios to avoid Lex, according to the countess's thought.

“Sir Kedol. I think this is an opportunity.”

“An opportunity to execute the plan we have been postponing?”

Of course, the disappearance of Palios, who had been a thorn in her eye, was a kind of opportunity for the countess.

She had not been able to touch Lex recklessly because of Palios's family and his power.

Now that Palios, who had been a problem, was gone, she could act as soon as the count left his seat.

The countess and Kedol had countless plans to eliminate Lex in their minds.

She nodded her head with a satisfied expression at Kedol's words.

"Of course. I can't let that child go on like this forever."

"That's right. For the sake of Prince Max's future, we have to get rid of Lex Meyer as soon as possible."

Most of the count's family, including the countess's parents, already supported Max.

The successor was practically decided.

No matter how hard Lex tried to reverse this situation, he had a big limit due to his lack of supporters.

Still, the reason why the count was postponing the declaration of the successor was because Lex Meyer, the firstborn, was still holding on.

As the countess, she wanted to quickly dispose of Lex and secure Max's position as the successor.

"The sooner he gets proper education, the better."

"I'm looking forward to when Prince Max, who has received good education, becomes the count. He will surely be a great lord."

Those who followed Max also wanted to confirm the succession as soon as possible.

They had lined up quickly to get the benefits that came with it.

To get something out of it, they had to hurry up the process.

Kedol was also waiting for the benefits that came with the succession of the count.

As Kedol flattered her with an expectant face, the countess laughed out loud with a fan in her hand.

“As expected of Sir Kedol. You know my heart so well.”

“It’s only natural, since I’ve been serving you for the longest time.”

“Good. Sir Kedol. Let’s think of a way to get rid of that incompetent Lex for that future.”

The first thing they had to do for their goal was to select a plan to deal with Lex Meyer, who was a thorn in their eye.

Even if she was the countess, she had to be careful when it came to killing a noble.

If she openly killed Lex, she would have a pile of troublesome problems.

Keeping face and justification was essential for nobles.

So she had to choose an appropriate time and place to deal with Lex and his knight.

“He will go out in half a month.”

“The count is going out... Then we have to send Lex out of the castle too.”

It had to be a situation where the count was absent for sure.

It was to buy enough time to clean up the incident.

Also, depending on where the commotion occurred, the person who would be blamed for it changed.

Naturally, it was difficult to cause trouble in the castle.

If Lex died in the castle, there was a high chance that it would become a problem between the countess and the count.

If they were going to do it, they had to do it in a place that wouldn’t cause any trouble.

“What would be the best way to deal with Lex?”

“How about giving him an opportunity?”

“An opportunity...?”

The countess listened to him at his words.

Giving an opportunity to someone they were going to kill.

It was hard for her to empathize with him as the countess.

Kedol continued to explain his strategy to the curious countess.

“Give him a chance to earn some merit and send him out.”

“Merit? What do you mean?”

“There is an abandoned fortress in the southeast. Its value has dropped as the empire’s territory expanded, and more importantly, it’s old and ruined and no one takes care of it.”

“There was such a fortress?”

“Yes. So we tell Lex that the bandits who occupied the fortress are causing trouble, and send him to subjugate them with some soldiers.”

Lex was already desperate to secure his position.

If the count suggested to Lex to subjugate the bandits, Lex would have no reason to refuse.

To the countess, Kedol’s plan seemed quite feasible.

She liked Kedol’s plan and asked him for more details.

“Are you going to prepare the bandits?”

“Of course. As well as hiding some assassins in a suitable location, Lex will never come back alive.”

“That’s a good plan.”

“But things like the number of soldiers or the plan to send Lex out... I think you have to persuade the count yourself.”

“It’s not hard for me to move him. Sir Kedol. Proceed as you said.”

It had been almost ten years since the countess married into the count’s house.

For her, controlling the count was not a difficult thing.

The count was a person with a fiery temper, but she knew how to deal with someone like him.

It was easy for her to help Kedol’s plan.

“Soon we’ll see Max as the eldest son of the count’s house.”

If the plan went as planned, there would be no more obstacles in front of Max Meyer.

Chwak.

The countess folded her fan and smiled as she thought of the bright future.

She had no idea what would happen to her in the future.

“They’ve done it cleanly.”

Cloud’s first-class investigator, Agent Period, muttered as he looked at the empty village.

Plates filled with food.

And the scorch marks on the floor.

Except for the people who had lived in this village, the traces of life were left as they were.

Only people had disappeared from the village.

It was a strange sight for anyone to see.

“So this was what they reported.”

What the Agent saw in the village was what had been reported once before.

If there had been a battle, there should have been some bloodstains somewhere, but there was no trace of blood anywhere in the village.

Only the traces that they had been alive were left cold.

The soup that looked like they had left for eating was already swarming with flies.

The village had been neglected for quite some time.

If they could make people disappear from a village of this size in an instant, it was also understandable that an inquisitor had gone missing.

“It’s no wonder that the inquisitor disappeared in this situation.”

The villagers who had disappeared without leaving any trace of movement.

As far as the Agent knew, there weren’t many people who could do this.

A cult of the evil god.

Or a high-level black mage who deals with corpses.

The cultists offer human lives as sacrifices to the evil god, and the black mage uses the dead as his own power.

The sight that existed in front of him was something that only those people could access.

Either way, they were dangerous enemies.

“It would be faster to deal with the black mage than the cult. But I’m worried about the fact that the missing person is an inquisitor.”

Black mages usually don’t form groups because of their unique personalities.

Therefore, if the enemy was a black mage, Agent could try to subjugate him alone.

But if the enemy was a cult, it was a different story.

No matter how strong Agent was, he couldn’t fight against all the members of the cult by himself.

He had to match numbers with numbers.

To subjugate the cult, he had to bring enough personnel from Cloud.

“Hmm...”

This was also an efficient method for searching for the cult or the black mage.

If he brought more investigators from Cloud, he could find the enemy’s location faster.

The cult and the black mage.

Agent decided to weigh more on the former between the two.

The news of the hero’s appearance had already spread throughout the empire.

The reason why the inquisitor of the holy land came around the same time was probably because he was chasing after the traces of the cult.

Besides, there was no harm in being prepared thoroughly.

“I’ll have to mark the location for now.”

Agent took out a map from his pocket after making a decision.

The map of Centrius region was only allowed to Agent, who was the chief investigator in Cloud.

Agent had been drawing his own map whenever he had time.

It was to check the location on the map whenever a large-scale incident occurred.

He took out a map with approximate locations of villages marked on it, and engraved a mark on each place where reports had come up and where he had visited.

The villages marked on the map tended to cluster in similar areas.

“If I investigate a few more places, I might be able to guess their direction.”

The marks engraved on the map were evidence of the enemy’s activity range.

If he calculated their direction based on the order of disappearance of villages, he could also calculate their movement.

If he brought a team of investigators from Cloud and calculated the range of disappeared villages, he would be able to find their location soon.

After making a rough judgment about the enemy, Agent moved his steps toward his horse that he had tied up.

Thud. Thud.

Only Agent's footsteps echoed in the desolate village.

Chapter 46: The Battle of Cuebaerg

< 46 : The Battle of Cuebaerg (1) >

People often say that life is like a wheel that keeps rolling.

Those who live a life full of twists and turns might be different, but I think most of them show a similar pattern.

I'm no exception.

Every morning, I face the same routine as always.

I wake up with sleepy eyes and take a shower, then I hurriedly put on my clothes and head outside.

Then I board the subway and drag my tired body to work.

Some days, I'm nervous about getting scolded for a small mistake, and some days, I'm filled with anticipation and wait for the time to clock out.

And some days, I buy a can of beer on my way home to relieve the stress that piled up during the day.

When I get home and the next day comes, another day like yesterday begins.

Life is nothing but going back to where I started no matter how much I move forward.

As I live such a life, I sometimes fall into the illusion that I have become a cog in the wheel of society.

Even though in reality, nothing would stop if I disappeared.

“Phew... I survived another day.”

But people still live with hope for the next day, because they each have a reason for their lives.

Family or friends. Or a lover.

Or something precious of their own.

For me, gaming was one of those small pieces that made up my reason for living.

A world beyond my smartphone that allowed me to escape from the boredom of life for a moment.

There, I don't shy away from adventure or challenge, and I don't fear failure.

This shoddy game was nothing less than an escape route from my daily life.

“I should play a game for a while and then make some ramen.”

That was why I threw my stuff and started the game as soon as I got home.

Of course, someday, I might get tired of the game and quit the one I loved.

And I might regret wasting my time and money on the game.

Here is my edited and translated version of your text:

Even so, at this moment, I felt happy to be immersed in the game.

I loved this world beyond the narrow screen of my smartphone so much.

“I wonder how much karma I have earned today.”

Tap.

As I touched the screen of my smartphone, the main screen disappeared and the game started loading.

The first thing I checked after launching the game was the amount of karma that had accumulated.

The most important currency in this idle game was karma, no matter what anyone said.

I needed to collect karma to increase my player level, and I needed to spend karma to create new characters.

More than anything, one of the goals of the game was to reach one million karma.

-The progress of <Descent> skill will increase by one stage whenever you meet the following conditions.

-Available karma: 715 / 999999 (Incomplete)

- ◦ ??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)
- ◦ ??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)
- ◦ ??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)
- ◦ ??? (Incomplete)

The total amount of karma that had accumulated so far was 715.

It was far from reaching the target value of <Descent> skill, but it was not much left to create the next apostle.

The amount of karma that I obtained had increased significantly lately.

Most of the new karma was generated by Cuebaerg and Estasia.

At this pace, I might be able to create a new apostle soon.

I felt satisfied as I watched the increasing amount of karma, when messages started popping up from the bottom of the screen.

Here is my edited and translated version of your text:

“Ah... what’s this? A level up?”

I lowered my gaze and read the new messages that had popped up.

Most of the messages that were displayed were about Cuebaerg’s karma acquisition.

It seemed that Cuebaerg was busy making karma even at this time.

And below those messages from Cuebaerg, there was a level up message that I hadn’t seen for a long time.

I had finally gained a level after accumulating a lot of karma.

-You have reached level 8.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.7)> has grown.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.8)> has been achieved. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

Of course, most of the messages that appeared as I leveled up were not much different from before.

The growth of <Eye of the Observer> skill. The increase of mana value.

And the warning message from <Karma’s Balance>.

It was similar to the usual output, except for one exception.

-Warning: Karma that is excessively biased in one direction has a high possibility of triggering <Causality Adjustment>.

-<Karma's Balance> has tilted.

-A low-level <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

-Causality Adjustment Progress: 4%

As I obtained a large amount of karma from Cuebaerg, the causality adjustment of <Karma's Balance> had exceeded 4%.

Of course, that was also the result of Estasia constantly reducing the causality adjustment value.

By my calculation, the causality adjustment should have reached 6% by now.

That's how actively Cuebaerg was hunting.

I hated his face, but he was the hope of the sect who had a stronger heart than anyone else.

-A new condition for <Descent (Lv.0)> has been revealed.

And there was one message that had a different content from usual.

It was about the next condition for <Descent> skill being revealed.

The evolution conditions for <Descent> skill were what I considered as the endgame content of this game.

The first condition that was opened was too difficult to achieve.

I had to collect almost a million karma without using it.

How could anyone collect a million karma without spending it?

Besides, I had no idea how long it would take to collect a million karma.

It was a harsh condition for me.

“But I should check out the new quest content anyway.”

But that didn’t mean I would leave <Descent> skill alone forever.

It was still a goal that I would eventually clear someday.

If there was an easy goal, I thought it would be okay to achieve it step by step.

With that thought, I checked the content of <Descent> skill again, and there was one evolution condition that had been hidden before and was now revealed.

-[Relic: Ergus’ Stake]: 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

The new evolution condition for <Descent> skill was to acquire a designated item.

The name of the item was [Relic: Ergus’ Stake].

It was an item classified as a relic category, like magic swords or divine artifacts.

I couldn’t help but ponder deeply about this unfamiliar category of relic.

“Relic? What is this?”

It didn’t seem like an item that I could get from the gacha.

I didn’t think they would put something like that as a mission for unlocking the skill.

Then maybe it was an item related to the gods in the game.

As I was pondering that, the image of Evan, who used to be a paladin, flashed through my mind.

Evan was a faithful paladin who served the goddess before he became my apostle.

Maybe Evan would know something about [Relic: Ergus' Stake].

“Should I ask Evan?”

The characters in this game could communicate with the player to a certain extent.

If I used the communication function to ask him, I might be able to get an answer from Evan.

If Evan knew a lot about the relic, I might be able to order him or other apostles to retrieve the relic.

There was no reason to delay the conversation if I had made up my mind.

I immediately found Evan in the city and pressed the speech bubble button above his head.

-Please enter the message you want to send.

Second Apostle, Evan Allemier.

The conversation with an apostle that I hadn't had for a long time began.

-Gwoooooooo.

Cuebaerg's strange roar echoed on the mountain road where trees had fallen.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

The forest collapsed and landslides occurred every time Cuebaerg's body moved.

Lord of the Abyss Cuebaerg.

He was born and raised in the deep abyss, and he was a predator by nature.

He grew up in the dark abyss where no light reached, and devoured everything that stood in his way.

The invaders from the outside world. The noisy kin.

And the abyssal beasts that roamed around to eat Cuebaerg.

There was nothing that Cuebaerg hadn't tried to swallow.

-Gwooooo.

Cuebaerg's body had grown grotesquely large because he had absorbed the power of the prey he had eaten so far.

Cuebaerg, who had eaten countless abyssal creatures and absorbed their power, became a powerful lord of the abyss.

All his kin followed Cuebaerg, and all kinds of abyssal monsters ran away from him.

There were less than ten beasts in the entire abyss that could compete with him.

Cuebaerg responded to the call of a greater being because he felt bored with his life in the abyss.

-“I've become much weaker.”

But Cuebaerg, who was born in the abyss, couldn't fully exert his power on the surface as well.

Cuebaerg was a creature that grew up in the abyss after all.

His body structure was not suitable for moving on the surface.

It took him days to travel a distance that he would have passed in an instant in the abyss.

And because of his excessively large body, he felt a lot of fatigue when he moved for a long time.

He was still a powerful predator, but his might in the abyss had long disappeared.

-“I need to eat more and grow faster.”

But that didn't mean Cuebaerg had completely given up on growing on the surface.

He felt more possibilities on the surface than before.

There were countless creatures on the surface that I had never seen in the abyss.

And the creatures called humans showed that they could counter animals stronger than themselves with the power of knowledge.

If I ate and learned from them, I would become stronger than before.

And the great being who sent me down would be pleased with me.

That was why I was moving busily to overcome the limit of an abyssal beast.

-Harvest life.

A familiar voice rang in my head as I moved my tentacles and walked forward.

It was the voice of the great being who pulled me out of the abyss.

The voice of the great being had been repeated since the first day I arrived on the surface.

The great being wanted me to harvest life.

I wanted that too, so neither of us had any reason to refuse.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

I left the mountain range at a fast speed and finally entered a vast plain.

-”Are those humans?”

And I saw the sight of humans gathered in my eyes.

Many humans were standing in front of a huge structure made of piled stones, leaning on it.

I knew the name of the structure that humans were leaning on through my learning.

Castle.

A structure to protect humans from external attacks.

Of course, it was a meaningless act against a huge being like me.

The humans seemed to know that too, as some of them were holding weapons and leaning on the castle.

“A monster is coming!”

One of the humans who spotted me shouted loudly to the surroundings.

Woo woo woo woo!

A majestic horn sound echoed and the humans started to move chaotically.

Their movement was also something that I had learned before.

Humans moved together in groups and imitated a giant creature.

Sometimes I saw superior species being hunted by them, so their movement was quite efficient.

-“Foolish humans, gathering in one place.”

But the fact that they were gathered together was very foolish from my perspective.

Even if a bunch of bugs gathered together, they were nothing but bugs in front of me.

As a predator, I just had to swallow them in one bite.

They even saved me the trouble of moving by gathering together for easy swallowing.

There was no need to go elsewhere after finding the gathered humans.

I didn't refuse the tempting prey in front of me.

-Gwoooooooo.

My ferocious roar rang out, and soon I started to charge toward the humans.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

The ground shook and dust rose every time my body moved.

The humans who were heavily armed with all kinds of equipment also raised their weapons to face me.

The moment they recognized each other as enemies.

The battle between me and the humans began.

Chapter 47: The Battle of Cuebaerg (2)

< 47 : The Battle of Cuebaerg (2) >

Revalt Birch Forest, Liotes Region.

There, Gedur, who had set up his camp in front of the castle, checked the strength of Cloud's troops.

The number of hunters who had gathered around the Liotes branch had already exceeded two hundred.

Each and every one of them was not a mere soldier, but an elite who had passed Cloud's entrance exam.

Their opponent was a monstrous beast with a huge size.

They couldn't win with just numbers.

The members of the hunting party also needed to have a matching strength.

"...I don't like this."

Even so, Gedur showed a displeased expression as he looked at the two hundred hunters.

In Gedur's eyes, the number of magicians was quite insufficient.

Among the participants of the Cuebaerg hunting party, there were only about thirty magicians.

Gedur had gathered them together and formed a magic corps.

But he had doubts about whether they could provide enough firepower.

The enemy was too large, so he assumed that its durability would also be proportional.

“Why are you so worried? If worse comes to worst, you can just step in yourself, right?”

Another branch chief who was next to him answered him as he saw Gedur’s grumbling.

Indeed, as he said, Gedur was the strongest force here.

He was a person who was close to being first-class in both achievements and skills.

Of course, it was natural for Gedur to step in if the worst situation came.

But Gedur wanted to finish the job as surely as possible.

If he failed to stop it, the birch forest would be ruined, and there would be noise in his promotion.

“I prefer certainty.”

“That’s true, but wouldn’t it be over quickly if you or I stepped in?”

“Don’t be too complacent.”

“Don’t worry. I’ll make sure to report your achievements to the higher-ups.”

Gedur suppressed his anger at the sight of the lax branch chief.

He couldn’t beat up the guy who said he would report well to the superiors.

How did such a guy get into Cloud?

He felt annoyed and put more strength into his hand holding the ax, when he heard a suspicious sound in his ears.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

A mysterious roar began to echo from somewhere.

When he looked in the direction of the sound, he saw a huge body approaching the hunting party.

“...!”

The Abyssal Lord Cuebaerg.

The moment he faced the monster he had been longing for, Gedur felt like his breath stopped.

It was ominous. And unpleasant.

The distorted appearance made him feel like he was looking at something he shouldn't.

It was a creature that shouldn't exist in this world.

Was this what it would look like if all the unpleasantness in the world was tied together in one lump?

As he watched the approaching creature, Gedur felt a nauseous feeling in his stomach.

The pupils of the hunters who faced Cuebaerg began to lose their focus.

One of the hunters who was at the front shouted with a broken voice.

“The monster is coming!”

Woo woo woo woo!

The horn players who had joined from the birch forest began to blow their horns with a rattling sound.

An unidentified monster was approaching.

They couldn't afford to be stunned, no matter what kind of being it was.

The hunters began to regain their senses at the sound of the horns in their ears.

Gedur, who had calmed himself down, also looked at the hunters and gave orders.

“First line! Prepare the barrier scrolls! Magic corps, prepare your magic as planned!”

Cuebaerg's size was reminiscent of a small hill.

If they held up a normal shield, Cuebaerg would crush them just by walking.

That's why Cloud had prepared a large amount of scrolls for this battle.

They wanted to avoid direct contact with Cuebaerg as much as possible.

If the worst situation came, Gedur would draw his aura and step in himself, but until then, he intended to keep his distance from Cuebaerg as much as possible.

Everyone prepared for their roles with tension as the distance between them and Cuebaerg got closer.

“The enemy is coming!”

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

Cuebaerg, who had stretched out countless tentacles, moved his tentacles at a fast speed and advanced toward the castle.

It was a surprisingly agile movement for such a large body.

If it kept coming at this speed, it would soon face the entire troop.

The moment Cuebaerg passed over the mark of the hunting party, moving at such a fast speed.

Gedur raised his ax high and ordered the magic corps.

“Activate the trap!”

“——Dig!”

The magicians who received Gedur’s order began to activate the magic circles they had prepared in advance.

Kwaang!

With a huge explosion, the ground that Cuebaerg was stepping on collapsed.

The magic circle that the hunting party had set up created a large pit.

Cuebaerg’s body twisted due to the sudden hole that appeared on the ground.

Kwoong.

A heavy sound echoed and dust rose from where Cuebaerg was.

“Tsk. I made it too small.”

Gedur’s eyes pierced through the dust.

He saw Cuebaerg’s body hanging over the huge pit that the magic circle had made.

Gedur clicked his tongue as he saw Cuebaerg stuck in the trap.

It was because Cuebaerg's body was so huge that the plan to drop it into the pit had failed.

“The enemy has stopped moving!”

“Activate all the remaining traps! Block the enemy from moving and start shelling!”

“Stone Spike!”

Despite that, the trap that had been activated earlier was not completely meaningless.

Cuebaerg, who was startled by the sudden trap, stopped for a moment.

Gedur ordered the rest of the traps he had prepared to prevent Cuebaerg from moving.

Kugugugung.

The earth where the magic circles were engraved vibrated and huge spikes of rock began to rise.

A mid-level earth magic, Stone Spike.

The magic that created spikes of rock was activated and numerous spikes popped out of the ground.

The spikes that popped out overlapped over Cuebaerg and blocked its movement.

-Gwooooh.

Some of the spikes pierced Cuebaerg's body, but they broke without piercing its skin.

It was proof that Cuebaerg's skin was tough and hard.

There was a high possibility that ordinary weapons would not even scratch Cuebaerg's surface.

Only high-level magic prepared by the magic corps could inflict wounds on Cuebaerg.

Gedur, who had blocked Cuebaerg's movement with traps, immediately ordered the magicians to attack.

“Magic corps! Start attacking!”

“——Giga Lightning!”

“——Fire Storm!”

“——Flare!”

Powerful magic that the magic corps had prepared in advance began to pour down.

They were strong magic that several magicians activated simultaneously with coordination.

Kwreng! Kwreng!

Lightning fell from the sky in heaps and struck Cuebaerg's body.

As the lightning fell toward it, Cuebaerg twisted its body, and then a storm of fire flew toward it.

Kwagwagwagwang!

The heat storm that exploded the air and wrapped around Cuebaerg's body continued to burn it.

Was it because even a strong monster couldn't ignore the high-level magic?

Cuebaerg screamed as it was bombarded by powerful magic.

-Gwoooooh.

Rain of lightning. And a storm of fire.

Cuebaerg writhed under the wide-range high-level magic that inflicted continuous damage.

Tuduk. Tududuk.

As Cuebaerg showed violent convulsions, the spikes of rock that surrounded it began to crack.

The magic that restrained Cuebaerg was about to break.

The magic that was breaking under the power from the massive body made the commander of the magic corps shout.

“Prepare the next magic!”

If Cuebaerg ran wild with its huge body, it was obvious that this area would be devastated.

They needed to keep pressing Cuebaerg and accumulate damage.

That was also the first plan that the Cuebaerg hunting party had planned.

The magic corps tried to prepare more magic to keep pressuring Cuebaerg as the restraint began to loosen.

“Stone Spike!”

“Fire Storm!”

-“Foolish humans.”

If Cuebaerg hadn't brought out new eyes from its skin, that is.

Squeak.

The darkness on Cuebaerg's surface split and a huge eye appeared.

The eye that popped out of the dark was bloodshot.

A creepy and grotesque black pupil.

The hunters at the front closed their mouths as they faced Cuebaerg's eye for the first time.

-“I will bring you death.”

The moment Cuebaerg opened its eyes and pronounced death to the hunting party.

Kugugugung.

The ground shook and a massive amount of magic gathered in Cuebaerg's eye.

Everyone in the front line sensed it with a clear magic light that could be seen with the naked eye.

A powerful attack was coming.

An attack that was different from ordinary magic would come to them.

One of the branch chiefs who felt the threat of the upcoming magic ordered his hunters.

“First line! Prepare the barrier magic...”

“Scatter.”

But Gedur cut off the branch chief's order and ordered to scatter.

The branch chief, who had received all kinds of expensive scrolls, couldn't understand Gedur's decision.

The scrolls he had received this time were equipped with the latest magic made by the Central Tower.

“What are you talking about? Why are you breaking formation when we have the 12-layer barrier scroll from the Central Tower...”

He protested against Gedur’s decision and pleaded with him.

Cloud was originally an organization specialized in small-scale actions.

As the enemy’s attack was approaching, there was no time to delay.

Gedur, who was furious, grabbed the branch chief’s collar with one hand.

The branch chief’s body was lifted into the air by Gedur’s strength.

Maybe he felt the ominous atmosphere.

A lieutenant who was nearby shouted at Gedur.

“We don’t have much time! The attack is coming soon!”

“...Damn it.”

“Please give us an order!”

“Deploy the barrier!”

“Barrier deployment!”

Gedur reluctantly ordered to deploy the barrier in a hurry.

The soldiers tore the scrolls and deployed the barrier magic at once.

Woo woo woo woo.

The surrounding magic shook and the latest barrier magic developed by the Central Tower unfolded.

The thick barrier composed of 12 layers looked sturdy enough to compete with the castle wall.

It was something that would give peace of mind to the soldiers inside in any situation.

If only the enemy in front of them didn't have a hill-sized body.

Gedur's eyes were filled with deep anxiety as he looked at the deployed barrier.

"Magic corps! Deploy the barrier!"

"Barrier deployment!"

As the magic corps deployed the barrier, a black beam shot out from Cuebaerg's eye.

The evil magic vibrated the air that it penetrated and stretched out the light of destruction.

Kwagwagwagwang!

The black beam destroyed all the spikes it encountered, and approached the hunting party that had deployed the barrier.

As Cuebaerg's black beam crossed with the barrier that was deployed at the front line.

Gedur, who had thrown the branch chief to the ground, clenched his teeth and pulled out his aura.

"...Huh?"

"The barrier is..."

"Aaaah——!"

Crack.

The barrier collapsed and the black beam swept past the hunters at the front line.

The screams of the hunting party echoed around as the barrier collapsed in an instant.

The barrier that the empire was proud of was meaningless in front of Cuebaerg's black beam.

The barriers that were stacked up broke one by one and the black beam swept through the hunting party.

Some of those who were hit by the black beam disappeared from the front line without even screaming.

-Gwoooooh.

After the black beam that made a loud noise tore through a formation and disappeared.

Gedur, who had been preparing for Cuebaerg's attack, looked around the front line with a blank look in his eyes.

——Hoo.

Gedur's sigh filled with emptiness leaked out on the battlefield.

What reflected in Gedur's eyes, who had raised his axe, was the sight of the first line that had completely evaporated.

Chapter 48: The Battle of Cuebaerg (3)

< Chapter 48: The Battle of Cuebaerg (3) >

I touched the speech bubble button to start a conversation with Evan, and then I lay down on the floor and looked at my smartphone.

A small chat window appeared on the smartphone screen.

Using this chat window, I could communicate with the apostles that I had chosen.

It was not a dialogue based on a predetermined script, but a free communication that felt like talking to a real person.

It was an amazing result of the development of AI technology.

Of course, I didn't have to try to maintain the dignity of a god, since I was in an omnipotent position.

The stories that I told were changed into dignified sentences by the 'God Translator'.

I just had to write whatever I wanted to say, and it would somehow turn it into a sentence that exuded the authority of a god.

So I asked Evan the questions that I wanted to ask him without any worry.

“Do you know anything about the holy relics?”

“Are you talking about the holy relics?”

“Yeah. The holy relics.”

“If you mean the objects that symbolize the six temples, I know a lot about them. They are the artifacts that were lost during the great war a long time ago.”

Maybe it was because they were classified as holy relics.

The holy relics were all objects related to the temples.

The six temples.

And the great war that happened long ago.

It was the first time I heard this story since I started the game.

The background of the game had many complex histories that I did not know.

The game itself was very unfriendly, and the interactions between the characters were too extensive.

Anyway, the important thing now was the whereabouts of the holy relic.

If Evan knew about the holy relic, then the next thing to ask was about Ergus’s stake.

“What about Ergus’s stake?”

[Holy Relic: Ergus’s Stake].

It was an item that had to be obtained in order to evolve the <Descent> skill.

Evan, who heard the story about Ergus’s stake, showed a moment of hesitation.

Was he trying to imitate a person who was recalling his memory?

The more I played the game, the more I felt that there were many parts that were full of details.

After pondering for a while, Evan raised his head and looked at the sky and said.

-“Ergus’s stake... I’ve heard of it before. It’s one of the very famous holy relics.”

“A famous holy relic. Then you must know it well.”

-“According to the records I read, they used Ergus’s stake to seal the progenitor of vampires in the previous war.”

The word that came out of Evan’s mouth as he talked about the stake was unexpected.

Vampire.

It was a different race that was also called by another name, vampire.

It was a very unfamiliar word in this game where only humans were visible.

But then again, in a world where angels like Estasia existed, it was not strange that vampires existed as well.

“The progenitor of vampires?”

-“Yes. Pluto, the progenitor of vampires, was the ruler who reigned over all vampires.”

-“I heard that they used stakes to suppress the evil god during the war, but now they are sealing the progenitor of the vampires.”

In many novels and comics, I saw vampires being afraid of garlic and stakes.

This game seemed to faithfully reproduce that setting, as it had a stake called a holy relic stuck in a vampire.

If Eergus's stake was stuck in a vampire, all I had to do was find that vampire and retrieve the stake.

By the way, the progenitor of the vampires.

It sounded like a powerful monster just by its name.

They couldn't kill such a dangerous enemy and had to seal it instead.

There must have been a reason why they couldn't kill the progenitor of the vampires in the war.

For example, it might have been a monster that couldn't be killed by ordinary means.

"Is that vampire still alive?"

- "Indeed, it is a story worth your curiosity. She was the only one who was sealed after all the vampires were exterminated."

"Uh... I'm definitely curious."

- "Vampires are creatures that are not bound by lifespan, so they must be alive now."

- "The reason why the church doesn't retrieve the stake is because she will be fully released if the stake is removed."

"Fully released if the stake is removed..."

If I retrieved Eergus's stake, the sealed vampire would be unleashed into the world.

The progenitor of the vampires that even the temple couldn't kill and had to seal.

As soon as I heard the story about Pluto, the progenitor, my eyes went straight to the <Apostle Selection> skill icon.

The progenitor of the vampires must have had a great power.

And there was no rule that said I couldn't target a vampire with the <Apostle Selection> skill.

Maybe she could also become my apostle.

Just like Evan, who was an elite monster, surrendered and became my apostle.

I felt hopeful about the sealed progenitor and asked Evan about the location of the stake.

“So where is that stake?”

-“The location of the holy relic is... I only know that it is in Everlint province in the west of the empire. I don't know the exact location.”

I had no way of knowing where that was right now.

This unfriendly game didn't show me the names of the regions.

But one thing was certain.

At this moment, Eutenia was closer to the west than anyone else.

She was heading west to meet Estasia for her mission.

If I planned to retrieve Eergus's stake, it would be better to entrust it to Eutenia after she finished her work.

I didn't know where Everlint province was anyway.

-“Maybe you can find some related documents if you search through the temples near Everlint.”

I could order Eutenia to investigate the documents in the temples near Everlint.

Eutenia would surely finish her research quickly and bring back the stake.

At least I believed in Eutenia like that.

She never disappointed me once.

“Okay, I got it. That’s pretty useful.”

-“It is an honor for me as your servant that you want to listen to my humble story.”

-“I only dedicate this body to you with the same heart as always.”

My conversation with Evan ended with his words of utmost praise.

He was an AI who served me very faithfully, perhaps because of his setting as a holy knight who served a god.

I thought it might be nice to give him a gift sometime.

Of course, that was only if I got something good from the gacha.

“...I’m getting hungry.”

As I looked at the chat window with Evan, I rubbed my hungry stomach and muttered.

I had forgotten about the time as I was immersed in the game.

As soon as I realized my hunger, the fatigue that had accumulated throughout the day also started to hit me at once.

I had obtained some rough information through Evan, so it would be fine to check the rest after having a meal.

“I guess I’ll have to boil some ramen.”

I decided to have dinner and turned off the screen of my smartphone, throwing it towards the bed.

Thud.

The smartphone that was thrown onto the soft bed bounced off strongly as if it had entered the matrix.

And then it slipped into the narrow gap between the wall and the bed, hiding its appearance.

In an instant, I blinked my eyes and stared at the bed where the smartphone had disappeared.

“Ah...”

It seemed like I had to postpone having dinner for a while.

Right now, I had to find a hanger to get my smartphone out.

A desolate battlefield after a round of bombing.

Gedur's eyes, holding an axe, looked at the traces of the first line that had disappeared.

There was nothing to be found there except for black scorch marks and torn pieces of clothing.

The formation of the expedition team had collapsed in one attack by Cuebaerg.

Gedur looked down at the chief of staff who was rolling on the ground, after looking at the empty spots of the missing members.

The chief of staff avoided Gedur's gaze with a panicked expression.

“The only fate on the battlefield is death.”

“I, I didn't mean to...”

The story about promotion had already vanished from Gedur's mind.

He had lost Cloud's elites in front of his eyes.

And the formation to face Cuebaerg was completely destroyed.

There was no way to defeat Cuebaerg who had broken through the trap at this point.

Not only that.

There was no way to stop Cuebaerg from heading to Jarkling either.

If the castle was breached, all the blame would point to Gedur, the leader of the expedition team.

Everything that Gedur had built up in his life had collapsed completely at this moment.

“There is only death left for a coward as well.”

Most of the prepared traps had been exhausted.

The magic power of the magic soldier unit would soon reach its limit as well.

There was a ballista unit waiting in the castle, but it was doubtful how effective it would be against that giant monster.

The Cuebaerg expedition had failed.

If they continued to fight like this, the expedition team would be annihilated and Jarkling would be destroyed.

“That's an order. Evacuate the people.”

So Gedur said, pointing his ax at the chief of staff.

I told him to evacuate the people in Jarkling.

The preparations for evacuation were already done to some extent, in case of the worst scenario.

As soon as Gedur gave the order, they could start evacuating right away.

When Gedur ordered the chief of staff to evacuate, the chief of staff asked him back with a bewildered look.

“Are you telling me... to order an evacuation?”

“Yes. Or do you not want to evacuate?”

“N-no, I’ll start right away. Horn blowers! Send the signal!”

As Gedur put away his ax that he had pointed at him, the chief of staff quickly got up and started giving orders.

Woo woo woo! Woo woo woo woo!

The horn sound of the horn blowers echoed and the soldiers in the castle became busy.

As the chief of staff moved with some of his subordinates to help with the evacuation, Gedur looked at the magic soldier unit.

The commander of the magic soldier unit met Gedur’s eyes with an uneasy look.

“It seems like the magic soldier unit is lacking a lot of power compared to the expedition target.”

“...Yes.”

“It would be better to secure enough mages before proceeding with the expedition next time.”

“Yes? Gedur, sir, what are you saying...”

“Magic soldier unit! That’s an order! Support the evacuation line!”

The commander of the magic soldier unit blinked his eyes in confusion at Gedur's order.

He had only ordered the magic soldier unit, not the entire expedition team.

But Gedur tapped his forehead with his finger and said.

“You. Can't you hear my order? I told you to support the evacuation line.”

“...I'll go and support the evacuation line.”

“Yeah. If I had more time, I would have fixed your weak wills, but it's a shame.”

The magic soldier unit also started to move with the chief of staff according to Gedur's order.

The chief of staff looked at Gedur with a subtle expression as he saw the sudden increase in personnel.

But Gedur just gave him a middle finger.

He clenched his teeth and drove his horse towards the castle.

As the line that started to leave the battlefield got closer to the castle.

Gedur looked at Cuebaerg with the remaining troops.

“...He's coming.”

Cuebaerg, who had escaped from the restraint, was approaching Gedur and his men.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

The huge ground shaking that came from Cuebaerg's movement reached their legs through the ground.

He had sent away even the remaining troops to preserve them.

Now all that was left were his men who had followed him from Cloud, and the investigators from Riotis branch.

He watched Cuebaerg approaching the expedition team and chuckled, saying to his men.

“Why did you guys become knights with such good skills? Why did you join Cloud so stupidly?”

“Sir...”

“Nobody answers? You guys have lost a lot of spirit. Do I have to hit you with an axe handle to make you answer?”

Gedur was usually proud of Cloud.

His men didn’t expect him to ask such a question on the battlefield.

Of course, Gedur wrapped the aura around his axe in response to the silence.

The lieutenant who saw that reluctantly answered him.

I told them to evacuate the people in Jarkling.

The preparations for evacuation were already somewhat done, in case of the worst situation.

They could start evacuating as soon as Gedur gave the order.

When Gedur ordered the chief of staff to evacuate, the chief of staff questioned him with a puzzled look.

“Are you telling me... to order an evacuation?”

“Yes. Or do you not want to evacuate?”

“N-no, I’ll start right away. Horn blowers! Send the signal!”

As Gedur put away his axe that he had aimed at him, the chief of staff quickly got up and started giving orders.

Woo woo woo! Woo woo woo woo!

The horn sound of the horn blowers echoed and the soldiers in the castle became busy.

As the chief of staff moved with some of his subordinates to help with the evacuation, Gedur looked at the magic soldier unit.

The commander of the magic soldier unit met Gedur's eyes with an uneasy look.

"It seems like the magic soldier unit is lacking a lot of power compared to the expedition target."

"...Yes."

"It would be better to secure enough mages before proceeding with the expedition next time."

"Yes? Gedur, sir, what are you saying..."

"Magic soldier unit! That's an order! Support the evacuation line!"

The commander of the magic soldier unit blinked his eyes in confusion at Gedur's order.

He had only ordered the magic soldier unit, not the entire expedition team.

But Gedur tapped his forehead with his finger and said.

"You. Can't you hear my order? I told you to support the evacuation line."

"...I'll go and support the evacuation line."

"Yeah. If I had more time, I would have fixed your weak wills, but it's a shame."

The magic soldier unit also started to move with the chief of staff according to Gedur's order.

The chief of staff looked at Gedur with a subtle expression as he saw the sudden increase in personnel.

But Gedur just gave him a middle finger.

He clenched his teeth and drove his horse towards the castle.

As the line that started to leave the battlefield got closer to the castle.

Gedur looked at Cuebaerg with the remaining troops.

“...He's coming.”

Cuebaerg, who had escaped from the restraint, was approaching Gedur and his men.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

The huge ground shaking that came from Cuebaerg's movement reached their legs through the ground.

He had sent away even the remaining troops to preserve them.

Now all that was left were his men who had followed him from Cloud, and the investigators from Riotis branch.

He watched Cuebaerg approaching the expedition team and chuckled, saying to his men.

“Why did you guys become knights with such good skills? Why did you join Cloud so stupidly?”

“Sir...”

“Nobody answers? You guys have lost a lot of spirit. Do I have to hit you with an ax handle to make you answer?”

Gedur was usually proud of Cloud.

His men didn't expect him to ask such a question on the battlefield.

Of course, Gedur wrapped the aura around his ax in response to the silence.

The lieutenant who saw that reluctantly answered him.

"We wanted to protect our precious ones."

"That's a very stupid reason."

"..."

"But I like stupid guys."

Gedur smiled cheerfully and some of his men bit their lips.

Everyone here sensed it.

Most of the expedition members here wouldn't be able to return alive.

That was why Gedur suddenly brought up such a trivial talk.

Did they feel a courage that they didn't have before on the battlefield?

The lieutenant who heard Gedur's answer asked him back this time.

"Then why did you join Cloud, sir?"

"That's also a very poor question."

"..."

"Savages can't become knights. You dumbasses."

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

Cuebaerg's sound got louder.

The ground shaking became stronger and Gedur's legs started to tremble.

He got closer every time he opened and closed his eyes.

The monster from the abyss was coming towards him.

Cuebaerg's sinister and huge eyes were also staring at Gedur continuously.

"But I'm glad that only those who love the empire are left here."

"...Sir."

"I'm thinking of leaving a mark on that giant eyeball with my ax if possible."

Hoo.

Gedur took a breath and pointed his ax forward with an aura on it.

The ultimate state of no-mind, aura.

As the brilliant flame wrapped around his ax, a flame of struggle ignited in Gedur's heart.

He was born as a savage and held an ax.

And he lived his life swinging only an ax.

Even at the last moment of his life, he always had a huge ax with him.

"This is the last order!"

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

As death approached, Gedur shouted.

The expedition to subdue Cuebaerg had failed, but he still had something to do.

If not now, then for the next time.

If not the next time, then for the time after that.

Gedur and his men had to swing their weapons until they died.

“Everyone! Die here!”

As soon as Gedur’s last order came out.

The expedition members who were waiting for the order scattered in all directions.

Chapter 49: Under the Name of the Evil God (1)

< 49 : Under the Name of the Evil God (1) >

“Captain. Is this the place where the angel is?”

A mountain range located in the southwest of the empire.

At the place where rumors of an angel’s descent were rampant, Jenny, a mage, asked Gilford, the mercenary captain.

Gilford, who heard Jenny’s story, looked serious.

It was because of the stories he had heard from the people on his way here.

Gilford nodded and answered Jenny’s question.

“Yes. At least, that’s what it seems like from what we’ve heard so far.”

“But captain, why do you look so pale?”

“I’ve been thinking a lot after hearing the stories of the people who came down from there.”

Gilford had asked many people for directions to get here.

And they all kindly told him the way.

But what bothered Gilford was that all the people he met were friendly to the fallen angel.

A fallen angel was an angel who had abandoned their duty and fallen into evil.

There was no way such a being would do anything beneficial to humans.

But none of the people Gilford encountered expressed any complaints about the fallen angel.

Rather, some of them even carried fruits to offer to the fallen angel.

Gilford was troubled by the shocking sight of the people, and Jenny, who was next to him, agreed with his words.

“True, everyone seemed to like the angel.”

“The problem is that most of them didn’t look like they would believe in the evil god.”

“It’s not like people who believe in the evil god have a mark on their face, right? It’s natural that it’s hard to tell.”

“How can anyone who believes in the evil god be normal?”

Jenny looked at Gilford with a blank expression after hearing his answer.

I agreed with the idea that no sane person would follow an evil god.

But Gilford’s thoughts seemed too far-fetched.

I looked at Jenny, who was staring at me with weary eyes, and Gilford asked her.

“Why are you looking at me like that?”

“I just thought you were surprisingly naive for a leader.”

“If you don’t have the eye to distinguish trustworthy people, it’s hard to survive as a mercenary for long.”

“Well, I can see where you’re coming from. They all seemed friendly enough.”

At least they looked innocent and kind to the eye.

It was hard to imagine that such people were followers of an evil god.

And the relationship between the people who were descending the mountain seemed very harmonious.

An evil cult that was peaceful and friendly.

Those words didn’t seem to match each other.

There was a huge gap between the image of the cult that Gilford and Jenny knew and what they saw.

“We’re almost there.”

Gilford said as he climbed up the rough mountain path and saw a wooden building in the middle of the slope.

Beyond his pointing finger.

There was a wooden building that was being built.

It looked like they were building a new building, as people were busy working on it.

Thud. Thud.

The sound of the mercenaries’ footsteps echoed as they moved toward the building under construction.

When Gilford and his party reached the middle of the mountain, they all exclaimed as they discovered something.

“What is this...”

“Wow...!”

In front of the cave where many people gathered.

There was an angel with wings shining brightly.

A halo shining brightly above its head.

Pure white wings spread out behind its back.

Anyone would see it as an angel descended from heaven.

And above all, the dignity of the angel praying devoutly made everyone unable to doubt Estasia.

“Is that... a fallen angel?”

The being standing in front of the altar looked like a pure white angel.

No one would doubt its identity as it looked pure and holy.

Gilford let out a low voice as he saw the angel.

It looked far from the fallen angels he had in mind.

Jenny, who was looking at Estasia, asked Gilford with a worried voice.

“Leader. Something seems wrong here.”

Gilford felt it too. Something was terribly wrong.

As he approached the praying angel, he felt his body filled with vitality and his wounds healed.

He had experienced this phenomenon once before.

Only the high priests of the temple who required donations to meet could show such miracles.

And even then, their effects were inferior to the miracle that the angel in front of him showed.

He grabbed Ascalon on his waist and asked it.

“Ascalon. Are all fallen angels like that?”

“...It looks like a normal angel. Maybe it hasn’t completely fallen yet.”

“Do you think that makes sense?”

“Even so, the fact that it is a servant of an evil god doesn’t change.”

“...”

“...”

“...I don’t like talking to strangers.”

Clang.

Estasia declared and got up from her seat.

She saw Gilford’s sword on his waist and was shocked.

“Oh, oh, oh, Ascalon...!”

She backed away from Gilford as she saw Ascalon.

She had been praying when Gilford’s voice interrupted her concentration.

The people who were praying raised their heads as they heard her loud voice.

Their eyes were all on Gilford and his party who had disturbed her prayer.

The mercenaries looked flustered by the crowd’s gaze.

Jenny grabbed Gilford's sleeve with a feeling of pressure, but Gilford ignored her and spoke to Estasia.

"Do you know anything about this sword?"

"I'm an angel... How can I not know about Ascalon?"

"Then it'll be quick. I'm Gilford, the leader of Gilford's Mercenaries. I want to talk to you for a moment."

Estasia tilted her head at Gilford's words.

She understood that he was a hero who had Ascalon.

But she didn't understand why she had to talk to him.

"...Talk?"

"Yeah. If you refuse, I'll have to force you to tell me."

"..."

"..."

Gilford grabbed Ascalon on his waist as he said that.

He warned her that he could draw his sword at any time if there was a problem.

If she knew about Ascalon, she would surely realize who he was.

That's why Gilford chose to threaten her with his sword.

But the situation around him didn't go as he expected.

As soon as Gilford grabbed Ascalon, the people around him stood up and blocked his way to Estasia.

Gilford scanned the crowd that blocked him with a bewildered eye.

“You rotten mercenaries... How dare you... say such things to an angel...!”

Among the crowd that blocked Gilford, there was an old woman who looked very old.

She was blocking Gilford from approaching Estasia with her body that was hard to move.

Gilford’s hand that was holding Ascalon shook as he saw the old woman.

Should he draw his sword or not?

Guilford, who was in a dilemma, spoke to Nopa.

“You have no idea who that woman is. She is—”

“How dare you... try to harm... an angel... who heals... the sick...?”

“She is a demon sent by the evil god—”

“If you want to harm... the angel... you have to kill me first...!”

Nopa, who was raging in front of Guilford, stopped him from finishing his story.

That was not the only thing that made Guilford feel uneasy.

A young child with a branch in his hand jumped out from beside Guilford, who was holding Ascalon.

The child picked up a branch and ran towards Guilford.

Guilford looked at the child who was running at him.

“Don’t bother our angel!”

The child who ran at Guilford stabbed him hard in the side with the branch.

Of course, the branch that the child was holding broke against Guilford's armor.

But Guilford still felt a sharp pain in his heart.

Guilford stared at the child with a confused look in his eyes.

He came here to do the hero's work.

But for some reason, he felt like he had become a wicked villain instead of a hero.

"Bad person! Don't bother the angel!"

"...This is insane."

"Bad person, go away! We will protect the angel!"

Guilford let go of Ascalon and sighed deeply.

Finally, 'that season' came along with the scorching heat.

The weather was so hot that opening the door made me feel stuffy.

The humidity and temperature were too high.

And the blazing sun of midsummer that I had to face every time I went out.

It was a season when I couldn't enjoy comfort without an air conditioner.

I turned on the air conditioner and stayed in my room for the weekend.

"Ah... this is paradise."

I lay down on the floor with the air conditioner on and looked at the ceiling with a satisfied face.

What is true happiness?

It is rolling on the floor with the air conditioner on full blast.

The cool air conditioner wind brushed my cheek and gave me the greatest happiness.

I picked up my smartphone to play a game while rolling on the floor with the latest cooling technology.

“Then now... let’s see how much karma I’ve accumulated today.”

Lately, I’ve been logging into the game every day and checking the karma that I’ve accumulated.

Thanks to the characters who were busy moving around, karma was accumulating faster as time went by.

Squeak.

I skipped the loading screen and entered the game to check the accumulated karma.

The total accumulated karma was 1722 karma.

Considering how much karma usually increased, it was an unbelievable increase.

“...What? Why is there so much karma?”

Even if I thought about the karma I checked before going to bed, it showed a change in value close to twice as much.

I acquired an enormous amount of karma in just one night.

It was something I couldn’t understand with my previous play experience.

I lowered my gaze to the bottom of the screen and checked the message box that existed there.

There were much more messages in the message box than usual in just one day.

I scrolled through the messages and read them one by one.

Most of the messages were about Cuebaerg.

[Abyssal Demon: Cuebaerg] harvested a life.

<The Divine Voice of Karma> calculates the causality rate.

Karma increased by 28.

[Abyssal Demon: Cuebaerg] harvested a life.

<The Divine Voice of Karma> calculates the causality rate.

Karma increased by 36.

<Karma's Balance> calculates the causality rate.

Your karma increased by 16.

I reflexively exclaimed in awe as I checked the message that appeared. It was an unbelievable amount of karma that I had gained.

While I was not logged into the game, Cuebaerg had acquired almost a thousand points of karma by himself.

He had earned an amount of karma that was comparable to what I had accumulated so far.

Needless to say, most of it was from hunting down other players' characters.

What on earth did Cuebaerg do while I was away?

It was incomprehensible unless he had started a war or something.

“Did he start a war or something?”

As I scrolled down Cuebaerg's message, I saw some information about <Karma's Balance> at the bottom.

<Karma's Balance> was a trait that imposed a causality penalty whenever I acquired karma.

It adjusted the game's difficulty according to the amount of wealth I obtained.

Of course, there had to be a causality adjustment for the karma I had gained this time.

I read the message related to <Karma's Balance> at the very bottom of the message box.

-Warning: Karma that is excessively biased in one direction has a high possibility of triggering <Causality Adjustment>.

-<Karma's Balance> tilted.

-A low-level <Causality Adjustment> occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Hieroglyph] was unlocked by one level.

Causality Adjustment Progress: 7%

As expected, <Karma's Balance> had proceeded with a causality adjustment for the karma I had gained this time.

The causality adjustment rate had increased by about 3% compared to last time, reaching 7%.

The causality adjustment rate also increased proportionally to the sudden increase in accumulated karma.

The result of this causality adjustment was the unlocking of [Artifact: Hieroglyph].

It had a different name from [Artifact: Ascalon] that I had read last time, but there was no doubt that the boss monster had become one level stronger than before.

“It still seems manageable for now... but I don’t know what will happen in the future.”

I lifted up my smartphone and looked at the screen, feeling uneasy about the situation that had changed drastically in an instant.

I didn’t feel it much yet, but the game’s difficulty was steadily increasing.

There might come a time when I would feel frustrated by the game’s difficulty and reach the limit of my growth.

How much money would I have spent on this game by then?

As I was staring at the screen with worry, a small anomaly occurred on my smartphone.

“What’s this?”

Ding.

A banner popped up at the bottom of the screen with a cheerful notification sound.

I opened my eyes wide and looked at the new banner.

The banner had information about the summer event.

Summer event.

It was an event that almost every game would do at least once.

And this game’s summer event had shocking content that I had never expected.

Limited event! Get an extra 10-draw ticket when you use a 10-draw ticket!

<Caution> You can only receive the 10-draw ticket once.

It was a 10-draw payback event.

As soon as I saw the banner, I touched the shop button as if I was possessed by a ghost.

Chapter 50: Under the Name of the Evil God (2)

< 50 : Under the Name of the Evil God (2) >

As soon as I saw the banner, I touched the shop button as if I was possessed by a ghost.

Thud.

The screen went dark for a moment as I pressed the button, and then the <Paid Currency Shop> page popped up.

79900 won for a 10-draw.

The price was the same as usual, but today there was another factor that made it different.

It was the small text below the draw button that had been newly added.

If you do a 10-draw during the event period, you will receive a ticket that allows you to do another 10-draw.

You can only receive the 10-draw ticket once during the event period.

As it was written on the banner, they were really doing a payback event.

I thought the developers would only suck the users' money, and they had nothing to do with events.

Who would have imagined that they would do a summer event like this?

I marveled at the unexpected event and looked at the draw button that was shining brightly.

“They actually prepared an event like this.”

If you do a 10-draw, you get a ticket that allows you to do another 10-draw through the event.

In other words, you could do 20 draws for the price of 79900 won, which was the cost of a 10-draw.

They wouldn’t give you unlimited tickets even if you kept drawing, but it was enough profit with just one 10-draw.

It was obvious that if you were going to draw, you should do it while the event was going on.

I exited the game with excitement for the first event I was going to participate in.

“I just need to check my balance and then I’ll do it right away.”

And then I launched the bank application and checked the balance in my account.

I was going to check how much I had left and then immediately do the draw.

Thud.

My finger that was running the application stopped in its tracks as it faced the balance.

“...”

I slowly read the balance that was displayed on the screen from the front.

The amount left in my account was strange.

Blink. Blink.

I rubbed my eyes in disbelief and looked at the screen again.

But no matter how many times I closed and opened my eyes, the numbers on the screen didn't change.

My balance had decreased significantly.

It was much lower than I had expected.

It had broken through my psychological threshold and dipped slightly below it.

It seemed that money had leaked out from here and there without me knowing.

Of course, having such a doubt didn't mean that the money that had gone out of my account would come back.

I couldn't help but worry as I looked at my devastated account.

“Ha... This is really the best event ever.”

If you do a 10-draw, you get to do another 10-draw.

It was an event that the developers had prepared ambitiously, after raising the price of a 10-draw whenever they could.

If I missed this event, I wouldn't know when it would come back again.

Should I save the money I have in my hand?

Or should I cut down on my future spending?

As I was lying on the floor and agonizing, a cup noodle that was rolling on the floor came into my sight.

“...Maybe I should just reduce my food expenses.”

A plan to reduce my food expenses popped up in my head as I saw the cup noodles.

I always think about this whenever I need to spend money on the game, but it's also the first idea that comes to my mind.

If I just eat cup noodles for every meal for a few days, I can easily afford to do the draw.

There's no better way to raise funds than this.

It's an amazing idea no matter how I think about it.

"I have to do it right now."

I can't miss the 10-draw event that gives 100% payback for just a few meals.

I decided to eat only noodles and launched the game.

Ding.

As I opened the <Paid Currency Shop>, the draw button that was shining brightly welcomed me again.

If I had decided to live on noodles, there was no need to hesitate anymore.

I pressed the draw button that was shining in the middle of the screen with a firm click.

And then, with a bright light, the draw items started to appear one by one.

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

I couldn't help but grab the back of my neck as I saw the final result of the 10-draw.

Swear words naturally came out of my mouth at the ridiculous draw outcome.

It was an impossible event from a probabilistic point of view.

How could the same item pop out 10 times in a 10-draw?

The probability of getting the best hand in poker was much higher than this.

“No, this is... How is this possible?”

The strength left my hand that was holding the smartphone.

It wasn't rare for a game to give you nothing but trash in a random draw, but it was always unpleasant whenever it happened.

Sigh.

I looked at my smartphone again after letting out a sigh.

When I touched the screen to move on from the draw screen, a message popped up saying that I had received a 10-draw ticket.

You received a [Free 10-draw Ticket].

Do you want to do a 10-draw right now?

Yes / No

I was already on edge from the previous draw.

If I didn't get anything comforting from the new draw, I wouldn't be able to sleep peacefully tonight.

I immediately chose 'Yes' to the message that asked me if I wanted to do another 10-draw.

Thud.

As the screen changed, the output window for the next draw appeared.

"Ha, really... Please give me something good."

I looked at the draw screen with a desperate hope.

I did think that I needed a lot of [Stylish Tunic], but that didn't mean that I only wanted [Stylish Tunic].

This time, I hoped to get a useful item like a magic book.

Shhh.

Just like before, a bright light burst out and the results of the 10-draw started to appear one by one.

-You obtained [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You obtained [Stylish Tunic].

-You obtained [Baguette].

-You obtained [Magic Book: Giga Lightning].

-You obtained [Sponge Cake].

-You obtained [Sponge Cake].

-You obtained [Holy Relic: Etalia's Compass].

-You obtained [Stylish Cloak].

-You obtained [Shoddy Dagger].

-You obtained [Baguette].

I looked at the items that were displayed on the screen one by one.

Iron sword. Tunic. And a baguette.

My eyes stopped as they found something among the basic items that always came out.

There was a magic book in there.

Fortunately, this time I didn't get 10 [Stylish Tunic] in a row like a disaster.

"Giga Lightning? Is it a lightning-based skill?"

I opened the screen with the magic book and started to examine the name of the new magic I had drawn.

[Magic Book: Giga Lightning].

It was an offensive magic book that I had obtained after a long time.

It seemed like a skill that dealt lightning damage, judging by the name.

It was good enough to get an offensive magic, but the fact that it was lightning-based was even better.

It was because the attribute of magic was also important now that I had Evan as my apostle.

“Maybe it’s an advanced skill of Lightning. I wonder if Evan can use it too.”

If it was a lightning-based magic, it could be shared with Evan through the trait of [Artifact: Astraphe].

The value of lightning-based magic increased just because of that reason.

It was possible to make Evan grow by learning lightning-based magic.

I checked the magic book from the 10-draw and continued to look at the next item.

Normally, I would have moved on after checking the magic book, but this time there was an item that I didn’t expect.

“And Etalia’s Compass...”

[Holy Relic: Etalia’s Compass].

It was a rare item that I had obtained along with the magic book in this draw.

Like the magic sword that had appeared before, it was an item that emitted an extraordinary aura.

The first thing that caught my eye on the draw screen was the appearance of Etalia’s Compass.

It looked like a jewel with a string attached to it, rather than a compass as its name suggested.

I looked at the screen with Etalia’s Compass and touched the screen to end the draw.

“I guess I have to go to the inventory and look for the description.”

According to Evan’s explanation, holy relics were objects that symbolized the six temples.

They were materials needed to evolve the <Divine Power> skill, and they had a high difficulty of acquisition by default.

And one of those holy relic items came out of a 10-draw.

Of course, I couldn't use this item to grow the <Divine Power> skill, but it was still valuable nonetheless.

I was surprised by the unexpected encounter and pressed the inventory.

As the inventory opened, I saw the magic book and the holy relic lined up in the item window.

“Then let's check the description.”

Thud.

I moved my finger and clicked on [Holy Relic: Etalia's Compass].

As I clicked on the item, its image enlarged and a detailed description of the item appeared below it.

My eyes scanned the description of the item slowly.

After reading the whole description, I was shocked by the more radical content than I expected.

“...Why is this item coming out of a draw?”

The special ability of the holy relic item that I obtained for the first time.

It was something that matched very well with the name of the compass.

The Temple of Abundance in Crossbridge.

Saint Serena was sitting in the temple's office and reading a book, when a priest came over and handed her some tea.

Before she entered the Temple of Abundance, Serena had kept a distance from tea due to financial problems.

But ever since she became a saint and entered the temple, she had been eating sweet things whenever she felt like it.

She sent away the nun who brought her tea and snacks, and opened her mouth as she ate a piece of cake.

“The empire’s expedition failed to subjugate Cuebaerg.”

The one who listened to Serena’s story was naturally her knight escort, Lian.

The Abyssal Lord Cuebaerg.

He was one of the apostles of the evil god who was opposed to the six temples.

The failure of the expedition to subjugate the monster that was ravaging the empire was a huge misfortune for the holy land.

“...That’s bad news.”

“It is. Not only for the empire, but also for us. It’s a big problem.”

The Cloud, the elite group of the empire, had participated in the expedition to subjugate Cuebaerg.

If such elites had failed in their mission, it wouldn’t be easy to succeed with ordinary forces.

Moreover, the empire, which had suffered a great loss from this expedition, would surely ask for help from the holy land.

Crossbridge, which served the six temples, couldn’t be free from the responsibility for the apostles of the evil god.

The holy land also had a high possibility of having to prepare for the next expedition.

“It would be difficult to dispatch many troops from the holy land, even if we form an expedition together.”

“And the heroes won’t be free either in the next expedition.”

“Has the council already decided?”

“Yes. They decided to send out the hero of wisdom and the hero of hunting for the expedition.”

Serena brought up the topic of heroes and lifted up her teacup quietly.

The six heroes chosen by the goddess were those who existed to defeat the forces of the evil god.

The council had decided to mobilize them for the next expedition, judging that they had grown enough.

Lian thought they were still lacking, but there was nothing he could do if the council had made a decision.

He expressed his dissatisfaction with the situation of the heroes who were sent to battle sooner than expected.

“That’s faster than I thought.”

“Is that what you think, Lian?”

“Of course. And there are still heroes who haven’t come to the holy land yet.”

“Ugh...”

“Especially if the most important hero of abundance doesn’t come... Saint?”

Serena's hand that was holding a teacup trembled at Lian's words.

She reacted violently especially when it came to the hero of abundance.

It was because she remembered what she had gone through at the council meeting.

She put down her teacup that she had been holding on her desk.

And then she tried to calm herself and spoke to Lian.

"I'll find him."

"What?"

"I'll find him myself. That mercenary named Gilford."

"You're going to go find him right now?"

Serena nodded at Lian's words.

The Temple of Abundance was one of the top temples in the holy land, but its status had been falling continuously because of the missing hero.

Not to mention, many elders at the council meeting were giving Serena a hard time.

She couldn't stand it anymore and decided to take matters into her own hands.

She couldn't wait for the hero forever and endure the situation.

That's why Serena told Lian the story that she had been keeping in her heart while attending the council meeting.

"Lian. Let's leave the holy land together."

"..."

“And then we’ll find the hero of abundance and bring him back.”

Naturally, Lian opposed Serena’s plan when he heard it.

The apostle of the evil god was wreaking havoc in the empire.

He was worried that something might happen to Serena if she went to the empire.

“That’s a dangerous plan. It would be better to send someone else...”

“No. We have to go. Only I can know his location.”

“Saint.”

“I’ve been patient enough. But this Gilford guy doesn’t seem to have any intention of coming to the temple.”

Serena was determined.

Lian tried to persuade her somehow, but Serena just stuffed a snack into his mouth.

It meant that she didn’t want to hear his words.

Gulp.

Lian swallowed the snack that had entered his mouth and looked at Serena with a disappointed expression.

“Do you have to go?”

“Yes. I have to go no matter what.”

“...All right. Then I’ll ask the knight to take out the holy relics.”

She was unhappy that the saint was going by herself, but the problem of Ascalon and the heroes had to be solved someday.

After a short hesitation, Lian nodded at Serena's words.

It was a matter that required the secret escort of the holy land.

He thought he had to talk to the captain separately.

Serena's face brightened when she heard Lian's words.

She put down the snack that she was about to put into Lian's mouth and held his hand.

"Lian...!"

"But you have to promise me that you won't go out for a while when you come back."

She always tried to act wise, but her essence was still nothing more than a young girl who hadn't even reached adulthood.

He sighed and thought of the holy relics that were stored in the knight order.

Which holy relic should he take with him to prepare for any situation?

That was the most important homework given to him from now on.

Chapter 51: Under the Name of the Evil God (3)

< 51 : Under the Name of the Evil God (3) >

Gilford, who had gone to find Estasia, had to come out without being able to do anything.

It was because everyone around him was hostile to Gilford and his mercenaries.

No matter how skilled Gilford was in combat, he could not swing his sword at unarmed opponents.

Moreover, even the old men and children around Estasia threw themselves in front of Gilford to stop him.

He did not accept the path of the hero to cut down such people.

Gilford Proud.

To him, the path of the hero meant protecting people and punishing evil.

A hero who existed to harm innocent people was a meaningless being.

That's why Gilford had no choice but to leave Estasia alone and descend the mountain empty-handed.

“Boss, are you okay?”

Maybe it was because he had been looking exhausted while coming down from the mountain.

Gilford, who was sitting blankly looking at Ascalon, was approached by Jenny, the mage who was next to him.

Gilford looked at her with a worried question from Jenny.

Gilford nodded his head and spoke to Jenny.

“...Yeah. I’m fine.”

“Are you sure you’re alright?”

“I just needed some time to think. It seemed impossible to persuade those people.”

As he said that, Gilford recalled Estasia’s appearance in his head.

Contrary to Ascalon’s story of a fallen angel, what was there was a clear angel.

An angel who had the miracle of healing people.

Even if she claimed that the angel who healed people was a servant of the devil, they only dismissed Guilford as a madman.

Some even argued that the being who sent down the angel was the true god.

How could he convince those who had witnessed the miracle by any means?

It seemed impossible for Guilford, who had spent his whole life swinging his sword on the battlefield.

“Everyone seemed to like the angel... It’s probably hard for us to persuade them, right?”

“It’s impossible to persuade them with words, after they saw the miracle of healing.”

“That’s true... Oh, how about this?”

Jenny, who was pondering in front of Guilford, showed a sign of having a good idea.

He asked her what it was.

“What’s your plan?”

“You know, the sword that the leader has, the one they call a divine weapon?”

“Are you talking about Ascalon? It’s certainly a special weapon, but…”

“We can ask the sword to send down angels from our goddess.”

That was Jenny’s plan.

To use Ascalon to send down angels.

It was a way of countering the angel with another angel.

“Send down angels?”

“Angels are messengers of god, so if our goddess can send down angels too, wouldn’t people listen to our side?”

“That’s not a bad plan, if it’s possible.”

The problem was the angel that came down from the sky.

If they could also send down an angel from their side, they might be able to settle this issue to some extent.

He had to ask Ascalon first if it was possible to summon an angel.

Guilford decided that and looked at Ascalon.

Keeling——.

Ascalon started to emit light as it met Guilford’s gaze.

“Ascalon. Is what we just talked about possible?”

-“...It’s impossible right now.”

But Ascalon’s answer was firm.

The goddess couldn’t send down an angel.

It denied the basis of Jenny’s plan.

Guilford grabbed the hilt and asked Ascalon why.

“Why not? Aren’t the angels the servants of the goddess? Can’t she control her own servants?”

-“The gods who are bound by causality can’t interfere with the world actively. Because Karma’s decree doesn’t allow it.”

“The same reason as before.”

Karma’s decree.

And causality.

He had already said that these two factors would be a problem for the heroes in this war.

This time, too, causality was the problem.

She couldn’t even manage her own angels properly and let them go down to the world, and she couldn’t even send an angel to deal with that problem.

It was a contradictory situation for anyone to see.

Why did the devil have so many possibilities, and why did the goddess have so many impossibilities?

It was a reality that even Guilford, who was chosen as a hero, couldn’t understand.

Maybe Ascalon sensed something from Guilford's attitude.

It told Guilford about another possibility.

-“The gods can't interfere with the world. But you, who have a divine weapon, might be able to do it someday.”

“You mean I can do it? When will that be?”

-“When most of Ascalon's sealed power is awakened. Then you might be able to summon an angel.”

“So you're saying there's no hope for now.”

Even if he became stronger when the sealed power was released, he didn't know when that would happen.

Guilford clicked his tongue at Ascalon's words and got up from his seat.

It was hard for Guilford's party, who were outsiders, to persuade those who followed the angel.

There was no clear solution right now.

Guilford got up from his seat and looked at the castle where Estasia was, and Ascalon blinked again strongly.

-“There is not a difficult way to solve this kind of thing in the first place.”

“You should have told me sooner if you had a way.”

-“There is no need to worry so much about a simple method. I don't understand why you insist on needing an angel.”

“What do you mean?”

-“Those people over there are followers of the cult. They are not worthy of feeling guilty for killing them.”

Guilford could guess Ascalon's intention from the ominous conversation.

"Don't tell me... You want me to cut down all those people with my own hands?"

- "That would be the most rational and simple method."

Ascalon's words were simple.

Those people over there were all heretics, so there would be no problem even if he executed them.

Guilford's eyes narrowed at Ascalon's words.

He couldn't believe what the divine weapon he was holding had said.

He grabbed the scabbard with Ascalon in it and asked Ascalon again.

"...Are you serious?"

- "The followers of the cult are like tumors. If you leave them alone, they will grow and erode your body. If you don't cut them off when they are small, they will spread gradually."

"You..."

- "If you let them go because they are human, the whole humanity will eventually rot away. Do you still plan to protect them as fellow humans then?"

Guilford's gaze at Ascalon became more fierce.

His hand holding the scabbard was stronger than before.

An emotional voice came out of Guilford's mouth.

"You're out of your mind."

-“Also, every time you kill a follower of the cult, the balance of the decree will also be restored. This should be a good thing even when you look at the future.”

The balance of the decree would be partially restored.

And he could also eliminate the followers of the devil who could cause trouble later.

It might seem like a good enough story to Ascalon, who was a divine weapon.

If only from the perspective of Ascalon, who was a divine weapon.

“...”

“You are a hero who saves humanity. Think of the people you are carrying on your shoulders.”

But Guilford had met people as he climbed up the mountain himself.

Some were kind enough to guide Guilford, and some threw themselves to block Guilford.

A fearless child even stabbed Guilford with a thin branch.

What Guilford encountered as he climbed up the mountain was a living person.

It was not Karma’s deed that tilted the decree, nor a tumor that ate away at human bodies.

It was not easy for him to kill a kind person who didn’t even have a weapon, even if he became a hero.

“Do you call such a being a hero?”

-“Yes. That’s the duty of a hero.”

He became a mercenary to cut people down.

But he didn't wield his sword to cut anyone down.

He was not a knight who knew honor, but just a mere mercenary.

But even so, he had one rule engraved in his heart since he first wielded his sword.

That's why Guilford spoke to Ascalon, who enjoyed fighting.

"Ascalon. I'm not a knight and I don't know much about honor, but I still know some human decency."

"What are you trying to say?"

- "I don't kill children, even if they are followers of the cult."

Clang.

He pushed Ascalon back into the scabbard completely and turned his body around.

And he looked at the members of his mercenary group who were looking at him.

Jenny. Gaff. And countless mercenaries who followed him.

They were waiting for his decision as they looked at Guilford.

Guilford gave an order to his comrades as the leader of the mercenary group.

"We're leaving this place. Follow me right away."

- "Guilford Proud. The duty of a hero is——."

“It’s a good but tricky item.”

I muttered as I looked at the new item I got from the payback event.

It was because of the troublesome trait that the new item had.

The [Relic: Etalia’s Compass] that appeared from the 10-pull had a unique trait, <Divine Pursuit>.

<Divine Pursuit> sounded complicated from the name alone, and it had the following effects:

The relic is bound to the first wearer until they die.

During the sunrise, the relic has the following functions:

While <Divine Pursuit> is activated, the relic shows the direction of the relic that the wearer is thinking of.

If the distance to another relic is too close, it loses its detection function and gives a warning.

While <Divine Pursuit> is activated, the wearer cannot use magic.

If <Divine Pursuit> is deactivated, it cannot be activated again until the next sunset.

It can detect other relics that the character is thinking of.

This part alone made it an amazing item.

If I just gave a command to the character, the AI would automatically detect the target.

It would be easy to find out the direction of any relic, no matter where it was.

If I used this relic, it would also lower the difficulty of finding Ergus’s stake, which was my goal.

The problem was the tricky conditions below.

“It’s bound to the wearer, so I have to give it to Eutenia, but the part where she can’t use magic is vague.”

The wearer couldn’t use magic normally while <Divine Pursuit> was activated.

I was planning to give this item to Eutenia, who was a mage, so not being able to use magic was a tricky issue.

It was practically disarming for a mage to not be able to use magic.

Of course, there was not no way to use magic.

She could use magic again if she stopped using the relic.

“It seems like she can use magic again if she stops using it...”

But there was a long cooldown before she could use it again after deactivating it.

She could only activate it again after the next sunset, which meant she had to wait for two days in practice.

It would delay the search for two days in game time if I cut off the effect of the relic to use magic.

It was a powerful penalty that matched the powerful effect.

I couldn’t just give the bound item to Philip, who was next to Eutenia, either.

“Eutenia? Evan? No, Evan is also a magic swordsman, so he can’t fight properly without magic.”

I had no choice but to look at the [Relic: Etalia’s Compass] and think for a long time about who to give it to.

Evan and Eutenia. And Roan.

The figures of the cult members also flashed through my mind for a moment.

Cuebaerg's face also passed by briefly, but it was lucky that he didn't put the relic in his mouth.

Estasia, who was stuck in her place and didn't move, was needless to say.

I thought about the owner of the relic for a long time and came to one conclusion.

"Ha... I'll just give her the magic book I have and think about it later."

I decided to give her the magic book I had drawn first and then think about it.

I turned the inventory page and opened the page with [Magic Book: Giga Lightning].

It was a new magic book that I got from the draw.

I would have used it right away if it was before, but now I had a family to take care of, so I couldn't help it.

It was best for efficiency to give Eutenia the magic book first and let her learn the magic.

"I hope she learns it quickly and gives it back. I want to try out the new magic too."

After Eutenia learned all the magic and returned the magic book as a donation, it was my turn to learn <Giga Lightning>.

If I learned lightning-based magic, Evan, who had [Divine Weapon: Astrafer], could also use it.

And Roan's [Magic Sword: Ednos] had an effect of storing magic.

A total of four people, including me, could use the same magic.

We were sharing one new magic among four people.

It couldn't be anything but the maximum growth efficiency for anyone to see.

“Eutenia was... probably on the west side, I think.”

After leaving the inventory open with the magic book in it, I started looking for Eutenia somewhere.

As far as I remembered, she seemed to be passing by somewhere in the middle of the cult and Estasia.

Swish. Swish.

I flipped through the map at a fast speed and looked for Eutenia who was moving westward.

And as soon as I found Eutenia's figure moving on a carriage,

New messages started to appear at the bottom of the screen one after another.

<Fanatic> has died.

The amount of karma gained by faith has decreased by one.

<Fanatic> has died.

The amount of karma gained by faith has decreased slightly.

.<Fanatic> has died.

The amount of karma gained by faith has decreased slightly.

The decrease in karma gain due to the death of fanatics.

That was the content of the new message that popped up.

I was startled by the sudden message and quickly checked on Eutenia.

She looked fine, reading a book.

That meant there was only one thing this meant.

“My followers are dying...?”

Somewhere, there was a problem with my followers.

A big problem that would kill my followers who had the <Fanatic> trait.

Chapter 52: Under the Name of the Evil God (4)

< 52 : Under the Name of the Evil God (4) >

Agent Period, the branch chief of Centrius.

He was leading a group of Centrius investigators up the mountain secretly.

In the middle of the mountain where the agents and Cloud's investigators were climbing, there was a large fortress that belonged to a cult that worshiped an evil god.

According to the information that Agent had gathered beforehand, that place was the headquarters of the cult.

There were hundreds of cultists staying there, including an altar for the evil god.

The information was obtained by torturing one of the cultists that Cloud's investigators had encountered nearby.

The cult was also responsible for the large-scale missing person cases that had occurred recently.

Cloud had no reason to let the cult members who disturbed the public order go.

Agent decided to attack them right away, judging that the cult was small in size.

“We’re almost at our destination. There will be a battle with the cult soon, so stay alert.”

Agent said cautiously as he climbed up the mountain, followed by his investigators.

The investigators who followed Agent were those who could not be dispatched to the Cuebaerg extermination team.

Most of the elite investigators had been dispatched to the extermination team, so the investigators who participated in this operation were relatively inexperienced.

Agent also took that into account and decided to lead the way himself this time.

It was a way to minimize the damage to the investigators involved in this operation.

As Cloud’s investigators approached the wooden fence of the fortress, a lieutenant who followed him asked Agent.

“The fence is higher than I expected. Are you sure you can handle it?”

“Don’t worry. I’ll take care of it.”

“I’ll trust you and wait for you, chief.”

After finishing his conversation with the lieutenant, Agent spotted the fence and slowly approached it.

He stuck close to the fence and drew his sword from his waist.

Swoosh.

As Agent drew his sword and gave a signal, his subordinates followed him and stuck to the fence one by one.

Then they started to move slowly towards the entrance of the fortress, following the plan that he had explained beforehand.

Agent took out three daggers from his pocket and checked on his subordinates' movements.

“It's been a while since I did this.”

Pababak!

The daggers that Agent threw stuck into the fence in sequence.

At a glance, they looked like stairs.

Agent tapped on the daggers with his hand and confirmed their stability, then he positioned himself and jumped up from his spot.

Thud. Thud. Thump.

Agent's body bounced up as he stepped on the daggers embedded in the wall.

Every time Agent climbed up using a dagger, the dagger that was stepped on by him lost its strength and bent.

But Agent's body went up to the height of the fence in an instant, contrary to that.

Agent quickly jumped over the fence using a dagger and scanned the enemies around him.

‘Two below. Five in front.’

There were also two enemies passing by below where he was falling.

His sword moved swiftly as he identified the enemies he had to eliminate.

Slash!

Agent slashed one enemy as he fell and rolled on the ground to absorb the impact, then he rushed towards the nearby enemy.

The cultist who was holding a crude wooden spear looked at Agent with a bewildered expression.

He seemed to have not understood the situation properly yet.

“Wha, what...?”

It was very easy for an Agent to take down a confused enemy.

Puff!

The sword that pierced through the wooden spear and stabbed into the enemy’s chest.

The cultist stared blankly at the scene that unfolded in an instant.

A scream burst out of the mouth of the cultist who was stabbed by Agent a beat late.

“Aaaargh!”

“That makes two.”

Agent pulled out his sword and scanned the enemies that were gathered together.

He shook off the blood from his sword vigorously and guarded against the movements of the approaching enemies.

The number of enemies he saw now was only five, but it would increase as time passed.

He needed to quickly suppress the outside and enter before he was surrounded.

Tadadadadak.

Agent made his decision and started running towards the main gate.

Of course, the five cultists who faced Agent did not stay still either.

“It’s an enemy!”

“He’s running to the gate! Stop him!”

“Fireball!”

One of the cultists fired a magic spell at Agent.

A low-level fire magic, fireball.

It was dangerous even if it was a low-level magic, but it was a familiar magic for Agent.

Agent spotted the flying magic and increased his speed to dodge it.

Bang!

The fireball that missed its target exploded behind Agent.

“The enemy is coming!”

“Get ready!”

The cultists who were guarding the gate reacted to Agent’s figure running towards them after avoiding the attack.

They pointed their sharp spear tips forward and waited for Agent.

They formed a formation that made it difficult for Agent to approach.

Of course, for Agent who was classified as a first-class in Cloud, the soldiers who had not received proper training were nothing.

As he ran towards the gatekeepers, Agent adjusted his breathing.

Aura.

It was a technique that only a warrior who had crossed the line of life and death could manifest.

“Hoo...”

Ziiiiing!

Agent’s sword started to glow with a blue aura.

The materialized aura vibrated constantly and had the property of destroying anything it faced.

That’s why it was impossible to defend against the aura attack indefinitely, no matter how hard the metal was.

Agent, who manifested his aura, charged towards the enemy in front of him.

The cultists were bewildered by the sight of the aura they had never seen before and continued to respond.

“Raise your spears! The enemy is coming!”

“You think you can stop me with that?”

The length of the aura that wrapped around his sword increased greatly, and Agent swung his sword at the gatekeeper.

Kwagwagwagwang!

Agent’s aura, which had stretched nearly five meters, shattered the spears of the gatekeepers in one breath.

Agent’s sword strike could reach much farther than the spears that they held.

The aura pierced through the spears that were pointed forward and cut down the gatekeepers who maintained their formation in one go.

The posture of the gatekeepers who were hit by the vibrating aura collapsed in unison.

“Aaaargh!”

“Cough!”

“That makes six.”

Whish.

Agent turned his sword back and looked at the gate of the fortress.

It was to open the closed gate and let the investigators outside in.

The rope connected to the gate was tied to a nearby pillar and firmly fixed.

Agent lifted his sword that had lost its aura after confirming the structure.

They hesitated to attack him recklessly after seeing his prowess.

“Who are you!”

“You’re too scared to come close, huh? Is that all your faith can do?”

Agent taunted the cultists who were looking at him and swung his sword at the rope.

Squeak.

The rope that supported the gate was cut and the gate of the fortress slowly opened.

The cultists’ faces darkened as they saw the gate opening.

Beyond the opening gate, Cloud’s investigators were waiting with their swords drawn.

The moment the gate opened wide after losing its rope.

Agent gave an order to the investigators who were waiting for him.

“Everyone! Annihilate the cult of the evil god!”

“The gate is open! Charge!”

Cloud’s investigators poured in like a flood with a fierce shout.

The cult and Cloud.

It was the start of a battle between two incompatible groups.

In the midst of the shout, Agent raised his sword with an aura.

After capturing the eldest son of the count, Archbishop Roan Hebris had dealt with many things in the city.

Mostly about Rex Meyer’s safety or Shuron’s upper class’s behavior.

But he couldn’t leave the cult empty for too long as an archbishop.

There were many things that didn’t work properly without the archbishop’s approval in the cult.

That’s why Roan returned to the cult as soon as his work was done, to organize the state of the cult.

The first thing he did when he arrived at the cult was to gather his officers and hold a meeting.

It was to hear the reports on what had happened in the cult so far and to discuss the future plans.

“So we’re trying to establish a communication method with the new bishop.”

Of course, even when Roan was away, the cult was doing various things.

Like building new buildings continuously.

Or preparing a communication method for the new bishop, as he said.

Roan looked at him and asked him about the communication method.

“A communication method... Do you plan to prepare a communication crystal for the new bishop?”

“It’s hard to communicate with a normal crystal at that distance. It would cost too much to prepare a crystal. So we were working on training a messenger bird.”

“Don’t worry too much about the cost. I’ll contact Rex Honorary Bishop and get a crystal...”

Creak.

Roan couldn’t finish his sentence and had to look at the door of the meeting room.

A cultist suddenly opened the door and came in.

Blood was flowing from his forehead.

It looked like he had been cut by something sharp.

The cultist who came in bleeding looked at Roan and reported to him as soon as he saw him.

“Archbishop! We have a big problem!”

“What is it? Did you get attacked?”

“Cloud has invaded the cult!”

Roan’s face darkened at the report of Cloud.

Cloud was a name that was familiar to him even before he learned black magic.

It was an organization under the royal authority that captured criminals from various places and maintained public order.

To become a Cloud investigator, one had to pass a strict test, and the combat skills of the investigators were rated as comparable to knights.

Those Cloud investigators had prepared and attacked the cult.

He had thought that Cloud might come someday, but he had never expected it to be now.

“Where are the intruders now?”

He jumped up from his seat and asked the cultist about the enemy’s location.

The cultist who reported to him grimaced in pain, as if his wound was hurting.

But he soon regained his senses and reported the enemy’s location to Roan.

“Ugh... They are fighting with the cultists at the entrance of the main building.”

“What’s the situation?”

“It seems like they will break through the entrance soon. Especially because of the one who uses aura...”

Roan’s face became more grim as he listened to the report.

Cloud’s investigators were ruthless people who fought countless times with vicious criminals.

There was no way that the cultists could hold out for long against the well-trained investigators.

And if there was an investigator who used aura, it was only a matter of time before the main building was breached.

In a desperate situation, Roan ordered the cultists around him.

“The meeting is over. Gather all the cultists you can and bring them to the entrance of the main building.”

It was the first crisis he faced since he founded the cult.

He watched the cultists running around to gather people and moved towards the entrance where the battle was taking place.

He was going to join the battle himself.

Thump. Thump.

Roan’s hurried footsteps echoed in the corridor.

As he got closer to the entrance of the main building, he started to hear loud noises in his ears.

“...”

People’s screams.

The sound of weapons clashing.

And a strange man’s voice giving orders.

A battlefield with all kinds of noises unfolded before Roan’s eyes.

Clang! Bang!

The cultists were fighting with Cloud’s investigators, clashing their swords.

“Die! You filthy servants of the evil god!”

“Aaaah!”

They were trying to push back their opponents with all their strength.

And on the ground, there were countless cultists bleeding and falling down.

Many cultists had already fallen victim to Cloud's investigators who suddenly attacked.

Roan drew his magic sword that he had in his pocket at the sight of the carnage in front of him.

The cult was a place where he had poured his blood and sweat for a great being.

And Cloud's investigators were trying to trample on it with their muddy footsteps.

He couldn't stand it as Roan.

"Damn you..."

Clack.

Roan gritted his teeth as he looked at Cloud's investigators.

The cult was everything to him.

Trying to eliminate the cultists was denying everything he had done so far.

And it was an insult to the great one he served.

Roan aimed his magic sword that he held in his hand at the entrance of the main building.

And he used magic on the investigators who were trying to break in.

"How dare you try to enter here!"

Crackle. Crackle.

The magic sword Ednos that he held started to spark with a huge amount of electricity.

It was releasing the vast magic power that he had kept inside him again.

The moment he shot the lightning power that he created at the enemy.

Kwaaaaang!

The spear of lightning flew and blew away the enemies who were blocking the entrance.

Chapter 53: Under the Name of the Evil God (5)

< 53: Under the Name of the Evil God (5) >

<Fanatic> has died.

The amount of karma gained from faith is reduced.

Even at this moment, messages kept popping up that my followers were dying.

I moved the screen to find where the problem was happening.

Eutania. Estasia. Evan. And Roan.

As I switched the screen from one to another, I quickly realized where the trouble was happening.

The headquarters of the Order, located at the entrance of the mountain range.

There, a battle was raging between the Order and another faction.

“Filthy royal dogs! As long as I live, you will never set foot in this place!”

From the building where the Order’s followers were lying dead or wounded, Roan shouted with his [Magic Sword: Ednos] in his hand.

In front of him, there were characters wearing uniformed outfits.

Were they hit by Roan's magic?

About half of the uniformed characters were incapacitated.

He must have used his magic several times already.

“Are you Roan Hebriss?”

“Yes. I am Roan Hebriss, the archbishop of the Order.”

“Didn't you fire your magic eight times already? You don't have much mana left, do you? It would be better for you to give up and surrender peacefully.”

The man who seemed to be the leader of the uniformed characters said, pointing his sword at Roan.

He was right.

The [Magic Sword: Ednos] that Roan had could store up to 10 spells.

If he had already used eight of them, he would only have two left.

On the other hand, the uniformed characters still had half of their forces left.

But Roan was still blocking the entrance, holding his ground.

“The great one is watching over us. I will overcome this ordeal and protect his will!”

“As expected of the Order's followers, they are all insane.”

“Come at me if you don't value your lives!”

That's when I understood the situation.

While I was away, the uniformed characters had attacked the Order.

The Order was currently without any apostles.

If another faction attacked them, the only one who could fight back properly was Roan.

I sighed at the tangled mess that had happened.

I had been too focused on expanding my territory, and neglected to defend my base.

“This is not a simple idle game. It’s a game that requires defense as well.”

The monsters that periodically came to Eutania had headed for the Order instead of the apostles this time.

I thought I could just leave the characters alone, but it turned out that if I neglected them too much, they would be wiped out.

I had not considered the increasing difficulty of the game.

I couldn’t watch the game 24 hours a day, but I should have at least brought enough forces to defend it.

I felt a deep anger boiling in my heart as I saw the invaders who killed the Order’s followers.

“How dare they touch my precious karma suppliers?”

The Order’s followers were precious characters who provided me with stable karma.

They sometimes offered useless items, but they regularly donated through the altar.

They killed such precious followers.

It was an unforgivable act.

I looked at the character who was running towards Roan with his sword drawn.

It was time to make him pay for defying a human as a mere AI.

“You are dead.”

Stab.

I touch the skill icon and move the target to Roan.

The skill that I activate by pressing the icon is <Barrier>.

It is to protect Roan and his followers from the enemy’s attack.

The moment the character who quickly closed in on Roan swings his sword.

I touch the target and cast the <Barrier> spell.

You used <Barrier>.

A translucent barrier appeared, separating Roan and the opposing character.

It was so big that it could be mistaken for a boundary rather than a barrier.

Clang! Clang!

The leader character swung his sword at the barrier that blocked his way several times.

But the barrier that I had created did not break by his sword.

The character showed a surprised expression in his speech bubble as he saw the barrier in front of him.

“You were hiding such magic!”

“Oh, great one!”

“Don’t worry. I’ll break it soon and send you to your great one’s side.”

He was a character who kept scratching my nerves.

Was it right to give him a normal death?

No matter how much I thought about it, I felt that I couldn’t completely vent my anger with just that.

Annoyed by his appearance, I touched one of the skills at the bottom of the screen.

I chose a moderately powerful magic among the skills that I had.

You used <Lightning>.

Crack!

A lightning bolt fell from above the leader character’s head with a thunderous sound.

Clang. Clang. Clang!

Maybe it was because he was an elite monster that appeared after a long time.

He tried to block the falling lightning with his sword.

But it didn’t matter if he blocked this attack or not.

The reason why I used the lightning magic was to break his defense from the beginning.

“Go ahead and try to block it. I’ll keep shooting.”

Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap.

I move my finger and keep pressing the skill button.

It was a skill chain that I had learned from my long playing experience.

As my finger moved fast, messages popped up one after another at the bottom of the screen.

You used <Lightning>.

You used <Lightning>.

You used <Lightning>.

You used <Lightning>.

You used <Lightning>.

Crack! Crackle! Crackling!

The thunderous sound that repeated from the speaker.

At the same time, as the lightning fell like a machine gun, the leader character swung his sword frantically.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

The fallen lightning bounced off in sequence.

It was a skillful swordsmanship that proved he was an elite monster.

As I watched him swing his sword in sync with the thunder, I felt like he was playing a rhythm game to the beat.

Clang! Bang! Clang! Bang! Bang!

He parried the falling lightning dozens of times.

His defense, which had been trained to the extreme, seemed to have reached its limit, as I saw him make a mistake.

He tried to block a lightning bolt that fell at an angle, but he ended up taking a direct hit.

“Cough! Ugh!”

The boss character who was hit by <Lightning> flinched for a moment.

Of course, I didn’t miss that opportunity and used <Lightning> magic a few more times.

Clang! Clang!

The character who was hit by lightning consecutively stopped completely in his place.

He seemed to be afflicted by a status effect from being continuously hit by <Lightning> magic.

This was the situation I had been waiting for.

“Phew... Now it’s time to get serious.”

I finally stopped moving my finger that was using <Lightning> magic.

Then I placed my smartphone on the table and put both fingers on the smartphone.

The action I was about to do now.

It was the basic attack of this game that I hadn’t used for a long time.

I moved my fingers to the character and started to tap him with both fingers.

Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap.

Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap.

The sound of tapping the screen echoed and the smartphone on the table shook.

But I didn't care and kept moving my fingers busily.

To vent my anger for losing my followers.

And to completely shake off the stress that had been building up until now.

“You should just give up and surrender peacefully.”

The entrance of the cult's main building, where the standoff situation continued.

There, an agent who pointed his sword at Roan spoke to him.

He thought he could break through the main building quickly, but the fierce resistance of Roan and his followers made the standoff situation drag on.

Moreover, Roan's surprise magic attacks were very dangerous.

More than half of Cloud's investigators had already been incapacitated by Roan's magic.

No matter how much he was an archbishop, he couldn't use magic indefinitely, but if the battle dragged on, Cloud's damage would only get worse.

As an agent, he felt the need to end this battle as quickly as possible.

“The great one is watching over us. I will overcome this ordeal and uphold his will!”

But Roan still showed a stubborn attitude.

The other followers also threw their lives at him, but the archbishop in front of him showed even more fanatical faith than them.

He could understand why he was in the position of an archbishop.

He clenched his teeth at Roan's resistance.

Fanatics like them were always a headache.

"They're all crazy, just like the cult's followers."

"Come at me if you don't value your life!"

This time, Roan pointed his dagger at the agent and shouted at him.

He was telling me to brace myself for his magic as he approached me.

The agent tilted his sword after hearing Roan's words.

He couldn't back down now, even if Cloud's power had suffered a great loss.

If he didn't finish this operation, more people would disappear than the ones who died now.

He had to wipe out the enemy's base completely when he had the chance.

'I guess I have to break through by myself.'

The agent calculated the trajectory to swing his sword at Roan, who was within his reach.

No matter how much he was an agent, he couldn't block Roan's magic, which was too powerful.

He had to dodge or avoid the magic that was shot in front of his eyes.

Step.

He took a step forward and looked at Roan with his sword raised.

And the moment Roan blinked as he watched him.

The agent's body sprang forward.

“Damn it...!”

Roan aimed his magic at the agent who was watching him, but it was too late. The agent had already reached right in front of Roan’s nose.

Their eyes met at close range.

Roan’s face turned pale with panic, and the agent’s sword glowed blue with aura.

An attack with aura couldn’t be completely blocked.

Either get attacked or stab together.

Roan only had two choices left.

“Die.”

The agent’s sword flashed in the air.

Roan also moved his dagger as he saw the agent approaching him.

He was trying to shoot a lightning bolt right in front of him, even if he had to risk getting caught in it himself.

Crackle. Crackle.

The dagger that Roan held was wrapped in lightning.

But the agent’s sword moved faster.

The moment the agent’s sword swung at Roan’s neck to cut it off.

A translucent wall appeared and blocked the agent’s sword.

“...!”

Clang!

The agent's sword, which was wrapped in aura, collided with the barrier that suddenly appeared.

As his sword, which he swung with full force, was blocked by the barrier, the agent frowned and pulled back his sword.

Roan, whom he watched, was clearly flustered by the agent's attack.

But he still managed to create such a strong barrier in that short gap.

It was an amazing skill that surprised even the agent who swung his sword.

“So you were hiding this kind of magic!”

The agent exclaimed as he looked at Roan.

He was a crazy follower of an evil god, but Roan was a great magician with impressive skills.

Of course, while he was admiring him, his sword was still moving to break the barrier.

There was no defense that could withstand an attack with aura.

If he kept swinging his sword, the barrier would eventually collapse.

“O great one!”

“Don't worry. I'll break it soon and send you to the side of that great one.”

He threatened to kill Roan, who was calling out to the evil god, and swung his sword with force.

No. He was about to swing it.

The agent felt something and quickly retreated as he was about to swing his sword.

A massive amount of magic was leaking out from the sky where he had been standing.

The magic of lightning, which had been scattered like a mirage, soon began to form a shape.

“What is this...?”

It wasn't Roan's magic.

Rather, it was much more powerful and dense than his magic.

The agent raised his sword as he watched the magic forming in the air.

It was a dangerous magic. If he allowed a direct hit, he wouldn't survive.

Clang!

The agent swung his sword with aura at the lightning that fell toward him.

‘It's heavy.’

He felt a heavy sensation in his hand that parried the lightning.

He could parry it a few times, but he wasn't confident that he could handle such an attack continuously.

He was lucky that only one lightning bolt had fallen for him.

He checked the sensation in his hand after parrying the lightning.

Clang! Clang!

Another lightning bolt started to fall from the sky above his head.

‘...Is it coming again?’

The agent swung his sword at the lightning again.

But this attack was strange.

As soon as he parried the lightning with his sword, another lightning bolt fell down.

Clang! Clang!

He also parried the next lightning bolt, but then another lightning bolt fell from the sky.

Clang! Bang! Clang! Bang! Bang!

He kept parrying the lightning that fell without stopping.

At first, he could see and parry it, but at some point, he had to rely on his intuition to parry it.

He couldn't keep up with the increasing frequency of the attacks.

He barely parried the lightning that fell from the sky dozens of times.

As he maintained the flow and swung his sword, he failed to parry the lightning.

“Cough! Ugh...!”

Clang!

The sharp lightning tore through his body.

The agent who was hit by the lightning tried not to let go of his sword, but another lightning bolt fell from the sky.

Clang! Clang!

His body started to convulse as he was hit by the lightning.

He was an agent with high resistance to magic, but even that resistance couldn't completely suppress the damage from the lightning.

“Ugh... Ugh...”

Thud.

His hand, which held the sword, lost all its strength.

His electrocuted hand refused to hold the sword any longer.

Along with that, his legs also lost their strength.

His legs refused to walk, and his body fell backward.

Thud.

His eyes looked at the empty sky as he fell to the ground.

‘Who... used magic?’

No matter how hard he thought, he couldn’t find any magician around him who could use magic against him.

Even Roan, the archbishop, didn’t show any sign of using magic.

Yet, powerful magic kept falling from the sky.

As an agent who knew well about magicians, he couldn’t understand this phenomenon.

Of course, he didn’t need much time to understand the reason.

Right after the lightning that fell on his head ended.

A huge presence revealed itself to him beyond that.

“...Ah.”

An overwhelming presence.

It was a gigantic aura that couldn’t be thought of as a human’s.

A being that couldn't be properly seen by the eyes of a mere creature.

Such a being was moving in front of him now.

He felt like his breath stopped by the massive presence that crushed his body.

The only thing he could do as he faced the alien being was to let out a groan from his mouth.

“...Ah.”

He understood why Roan called him a great one.

He was a being that couldn't be measured by human eyes.

A being that was great by itself, and deserved reverence by its birth alone.

There was only one name that the world called such a being.

God.

The evil god of another dimension was moving to punish him.

“...Aah.”

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

His heart started to beat wildly as he saw the god's figure approaching him.

He couldn't resist.

And he couldn't defy.

He was the rule of the world, the truth, and the order.

He had insulted the great god as a mere human, and now it was time to pay the price.

He felt more and more pressure as the god grew larger in his sight. He closed his eyes.

He felt tremendous pain throughout his body.

“Ah... Aah... Aaah... Aaaah——!”

A scream burst out of his mouth along with the pressure that hit his whole body.

The time of pain continued until he lost consciousness.

Chapter 54: The Necromancer

King Arcrosis (1)

< 54 : The Necromancer King Arcrosis (1) >

The incident of the external forces raiding the church while I was away.

I had a satisfying time smashing the screen, but I was still bitter.

If the church had some defenders, the damage could have been reduced.

The apostles were characters who could use powerful abilities with their artifacts.

But Evan and Eutenia were both busy with their own affairs, so it was hard to summon them to the church.

It was a time when the church needed new forces to protect its base.

“I can’t call the apostles either. And it’s awkward to appoint Roan as an apostle.”

I had already decided to use the <Apostle Selection> skill on the vampire that Eutenia would find.

It was also inappropriate for Roan, who was acting as the archbishop, to double as an apostle.

I couldn’t move the existing apostles.

Nor could I appoint Roan as an apostle.

In the end, there was only one conclusion I came up with after a long time of thinking.

“There’s no other way... than that.”

It was to use <Creature Maker> to create a new creature that would guard the church.

I moved my eyes down to the screen and looked at the skill icon of <Creature Maker>.

It had been quite a while since I created [Dark Beast: Alpha].

The mana that I had been paying as a penalty was also fully recovered long ago.

If I used <Creature Maker> now, I could create a new creature.

If I couldn’t use the apostles to protect the church, I could use the creatures to protect it.

Having decided to make a creature, I wondered what kind of creature I should make using the skill.

“Since it’s going to be the guardian of the church, it would be better if it had a scary face, right?”

The guardian of the church should have some dignity.

It wouldn’t scare the enemies if it looked too gentle.

That’s why I planned to set its appearance close to the low value.

Of course, if I set it too low, a creature like Cuebaerg might pop out again, so I thought of adjusting the value to 2 or 3.

After finishing my thoughts on the appearance, the next item was the aggressiveness.

“For aggressiveness... well, let’s make it 5.”

There was Estasia, the cherubim, as a side effect of the low aggressiveness item.

She had never moved from her place since I created her with <Creature Maker>.

She was still living in the cave where she first settled.

Meanwhile, a large and splendid building was being built in front of Estasia.

The more I saw it, the more mysterious it was that Estasia’s faction was flourishing.

Anyway, apart from that fact, it would be unacceptable for the guardian of the church to be idle like Estasia.

A moderate level of aggressiveness was necessary, so I decided to make the new creature’s aggressiveness 5.

“The size is... hmm.”

The last item was about the size.

I recalled the creatures that I had made so far in my head.

Cuebaerg. Estasia. And Alpha.

Alpha was an exception, so I excluded him, but it would be troublesome if the size was too big.

It was because it was the guardian of the church that would live there.

It seemed better to have a size that was not much different from a normal character.

Either 1 or 2 seemed good enough, so I decided to make the new creature's size 2.

“Appearance 3. Size 2. Aggressiveness 5. This is how I'll do it.”

After deciding on all the items, I activated the <Creature Maker> skill.

The mana consumption was 85% of the total.

The creature's appearance was 3.

The aggressiveness was 5.

The size was 2.

After setting each item, I pressed the create button and a target location appeared in the middle of the screen.

I tried to set the target location to the church building, but I moved it to the back mountain of the church just in case.

“Please come out normal.”

After setting the target location to the back mountain, I touched the target location again to activate the skill.

Squish.

As soon as I pressed the screen, a huge light filled the screen.

When the light that blocked my sight for a while faded away, a creature of human size

appeared in its place. It was a creature that wore a shabby hood over its head.

You have created [Commander King: Arcrosis].

Due to the penalty of <Creature Maker>, you cannot recover the mana you consumed for 24 hours.

[Commander King: Arcrosis] reveres you.

<Karma's Judgment> converts [Commander King: Arcrosis]'s actions into your causality rate.

The name of the new creature that was created with the light was [Commander King: Arcrosis].

When the summoned creature lifted its head, I saw that its eyes were dark and empty where they should have been.

It was a mage creature with a skeleton outfit that had no flesh at all.

There was only one name for such beings.

Lich.

An immortal being that a mage creates by sacrificing his own body.

I didn't know if it was a problem of appearance or size, but the creature that appeared this time looked like a lich.

“...”

I stared blankly at [Commander King: Arcrosis] on the smartphone screen.

He looked evil as befitting his name of Commander King.

He looked like a very powerful creature just by his appearance.

Yet I couldn't help but look at Arcrosis with an ambiguous expression.

The being I wanted to create was none other than the guardian of the church.

It was hard to imagine a guardian of the church with such a face.

It felt like I was threatening the world somehow.

A wicked lich guarding the church.

I felt like I had become an evil mastermind who coveted the world.

Although the church was originally a place where other characters were sacrificed, I couldn't help but feel weird about it.

Wasn't I a merciful being who bestowed miracles on the believers until now?

Not to mention Cuebaerg, who I made last time, but lich also didn't seem to suit my image well.

I looked at Arcrosis and recalled my actions so far.

“Hmm...”

All I could remember was traveling around villages and using magic.

I gave up thinking as short memories passed through my head.

And then I nodded quietly at Arcrosis.

I looked at it again and realized it was a creature that suited our church well.

I could think of it as the gatekeeper of the hell gate.

I probably couldn't make it a guardian, but it seemed fine for other tasks.

It must be incredibly powerful to have the nickname of Commander King.

The guardian of the church was something I could make again in a day or two.

“That's the vibe of our church.”

Having made up my mind, I threw [Commander King: Arcrosis] to a place far away from the church.

He looked more likable than Cuebaerg, but he was also not someone I wanted to see often.

After leaving Arcrosis in a secluded place, I closed the smartphone screen.

And then I picked up the cup noodles that were rolling on the floor and got up from my seat.

I was hungry from playing the game, so I thought of filling my stomach with some noodles.

“I’m hungry, I’ll have to boil this and eat it.”

I picked up the cup noodles and headed to the kitchen to boil them.

It was a mild-flavored cup of noodles that I impulsively bought after a long time.

It was something that I didn’t eat often, but I bought it at a convenience store on my way home from work.

I wondered how it would taste after a long time.

The magic training room located in the basement of the Temple of Knowledge.

Hus Allemier, the hero of knowledge, was practicing his newly acquired magic with a white book open in front of him.

The name of the book in Hus’s hand was ‘Hieroglyph’.

It was the only artifact allowed to the hero of knowledge.

The hieroglyph that Hus had could store any magic that he identified with his eyes.

Thanks to that ability, Hus was able to break through the limits of his talent and reach a higher level.

The reason why high-ranking mages visited the Temple of Knowledge every day was also to teach Hus various magics through the hieroglyphs.

“Chain Lightning.”

Zap!

As Hus uttered the name of the magic, a streak of lightning shot out from his finger.

The blue lightning that came out of Hus’s hand hit the targets on the track sequentially.

It was a mid-level electric magic that could efficiently hit multiple enemies with one magic.

Hus had learned it because he could hit many targets with low mana consumption, but he was not satisfied with the power and range of chain lightning.

He thought it would be better to prepare another magic for real combat.

Hus closed the hieroglyph completely as he expressed his dissatisfaction, and then he heard a sound of opening the door behind him.

“Hus, you were here.”

Creak.

The one who entered the magic training room by opening the door was Aurora, the saintess of knowledge.

Hus saw Aurora, who was the saintess, and greeted her with a sm

And then he greeted Aurora briefly.

Aurora also smiled with her eyes and greeted him back.

“By the way you came here in person, I guess you have something to tell me.”

“Of course. Today was the day of the elders’ meeting, after all.”

“The elders’ meeting...”

“And there were a lot of urgent things to tell you during that time.”

“What are they?”

Hus had spent most of his days in the magic training room since his brother Evan Allemier went missing.

Was it because he had lost his idol that he had been chasing all his life?

Or was it to fill the void left by his brother?

Hus didn’t know why, but he showed himself immersed in magic training all day long.

Naturally, his conversations with Aurora decreased as time went by.

Aurora rarely came here unless she had something important to tell Hus.

“The holy land has decided to form a Cuebaerg subjugation force from the empire.”

“Cuebaerg subjugation force? That’s a new name. What is Cuebaerg?”

For Hus, who had been stuck in the magic training room, the name Cuebaerg was quite unfamiliar.

As if she had expected Hus’s question, Aurora looked at the paper in her hand and answered him.

“Cuebaerg is the name that the evil god’s minion who appeared in the empire calls himself. He’s a monster that made a city and more than 20 villages disappear so far.”

“The evil god’s minion...”

Hus’s face darkened at the mention of the evil god’s minion.

The evil god who coveted the continent.

For now, his followers were suspected to be the culprits who made his brother disappear.

Evan Allemier disappeared on his way back after finishing his investigation of the church.

Considering Evan’s skills, who was selected as a heretic interrogator in the holy land, it was impossible that he was caught by bandits.

So it was natural that Hus pointed to the church as the cause of Evan’s disappearance.

“So the empire ordered Cloud to subjugate this Cuebaerg.”

“Cloud is leading the subjugation, yes.”

“And in the process, half of the subjugation force, including the leader Gedur, were killed by Cuebaerg.”

“Gedur chief...”

It was rare to find someone who didn’t know Gedur among Cloud’s investigators.

Gedur, a first-class investigator, was a well-known figure.

And he failed to lead the subjugation operation.

It was a clue to how strong Cuebaerg was.

As Hus continued to listen to Aurora's words, he understood why she brought up the subjugation force.

Perhaps she wanted to involve the heroes in the holy land in the new subjugation force.

"So this time, the heroes are going to step up?"

"You're right. That's very heroic of you."

"If it's an evil god's minion, then it's an enemy that the heroes should deal with. I understand. How should I prepare?"

"You'll get a call from the temple tomorrow. I'll tell you the details then."

Hus nodded at Aurora's words and looked at the hieroglyph.

Heroes of knowledge grew faster than other heroes.

It was not strange to say that they could be deployed to the field right away.

When Hus looked at the hieroglyphs in silence, Aurora coughed lightly while waiting for him.

She seemed to have something more to say to him, or she was waiting for him to look at her.

"Do you have something else to tell me?"

"...Of course."

"What is it?"

"The other one is the news from Cloud, who went to search for the heretic inquisitor Evan Allemier..."

The news from Cloud, who went to search for Evan.

As soon as he heard that, Hus approached Aurora closely.

And then he grabbed her shoulders and asked her about Evan.

He spoke in a higher tone than usual, perhaps because he was excited.

“Don’t tell me you found my brother?”

“...No, that’s not it.”

“Then what... What else do you have to tell me?”

“Most of the agents from the Centurion branch, including the branch chief agent Period, who went to search for him, have gone missing, they say.”

Most of the agents from the Centurion branch went missing.

It was actually more like annihilation than disappearance.

And even his former boss, agent first-class investigator, had lost contact.

Hus’s expression was completely distorted as he heard the story of his former colleagues.

“The Centurion branch... was annihilated...?”

His brother who found the trace of the evil god disappeared, and his former colleagues who chased him also disappeared.

People kept disappearing just by trying to get close to the cult.

What kind of being was he fighting against?

And what was he fighting for?

He tore at his chest as he felt a bad feeling in his heart.

He had already lost too much before the fight even began.

It was a war that he couldn’t even guess how much more he would lose.

Chapter 55: The Necromancer King, Arcrosis (2)

< 55 : The Necromancer King, Arcrosis (2) >

In the northern region of the empire, there was a secret society of black mages who hid themselves from the empire's oppression.

The name of the secret society was 'Abyss'.

The members of Abyss were all black mages who had mastered the necromantic magic to a high level.

Black mages were usually difficult to unite, but Abyss was an exception.

The reason why they formed a secret society named Abyss and shared their purpose was only one.

They had the ambition to overthrow the empire with their black magic someday.

“...”

And Kerington, the leader of Abyss, was looking at the meeting room with a serious face.

There were five executives of Abyss in Kerington's eyes.

They were all fearsome black mages who could handle high-level magic.

However, those beings were now all silent, staring at one place.

The uninvited guest who participated in this meeting was the cause.

The uninvited guest acted as if he owned the place, even though no one here had invited him.

Moreover, none of the officers here expressed any dissatisfaction with the uninvited guest.

“You seem to have a lot on your mind.”

The red gleam in his eyes looked at the black magicians from under his worn hood.

The immortal, who had a gaunt face and a skeletal hand holding a staff.

The king of death, who had never answered anyone’s summons except for the origin of black magic.

The undead king, Arcrosis.

He was a demon who had existed before the black magicians were born, surpassing the lifespan granted to living beings.

He was also a person who had achieved magic that surpassed everyone here combined.

As Arcrosis flashed his eyes and transmitted his will, Kerington, who was facing him, opened his mouth.

“Lord of death. Who among us do you intend to make a contract with?”

Dealing with demons was not something new for Kerington.

Black magicians were more familiar with demons than anyone else on the continent.

Whatever the being in front of him wanted, he would give him a suitable reward if he granted his request.

That was the rule of contract that all demons accepted.

Of course, if he offended the demon's mind, everyone here could be annihilated.

Kerington asked Arcrosis with a tense face, and Arcrosis slammed his staff on the ground and said.

“If you want, I'll make a contract with everyone here.”

“A contract with all of us?”

“Someone like you... with so many humans?”

At the words that he would give everyone here a chance, the officers who were listening couldn't help but marvel.

The opponent was a king of death, different from other demons.

He was a being who could raise tens of thousands of dead and turn the world into a hell.

He decided to make a contract with all the humans here.

There was no more shocking offer for black magicians than this.

As the black magicians in the meeting room reacted to the contract, Arcrosis's eerie voice continued.

“There's no reason why I can't. But there's one condition for that.”

“What is the condition? Do we have to offer our souls? I'll bring some humans right away.”

Kerington tried to calm his excited heart and asked Arcrosis.

It was a contract with the king of death himself.

It was the same as the highest honor for a black magician.

It would be strange if there was no condition for such a contract.

He was ready to pay whatever price Arcrosis wanted.

As Kerington asked him expectantly, Arcrosis brought up an unexpected story to them.

“Souls of dozens of humans are trivial to me.”

“Then what do you want...”

“But the great being who looks down on the earth thinks differently about offerings.”

“The being who looks down on the earth... Do you mean the evil god!”

The officers of Abyss were in an uproar at the unexpected mention of the evil god.

They were discussing the contract, and suddenly he brought up the topic of the evil god.

Kerington swallowed his saliva at the situation that was going worse than he thought and looked at him.

“You humans call him so often. He is a being who cherishes even the humans who pray to him.”

“...”

“And it’s all thanks to him that you can make a contract with me.”

“Does that mean...”

“Pray to him every day. And perform the ritual of offering to him regularly.”

The contract condition that the king of death, Arcrosis, proposed to them.

It was to pray to the evil god every day.

It meant that only those who sincerely served the evil god could make a contract with the king of death.

The officers of Abyss looked at each other's faces once after hearing Arcrosis's words.

They seemed to have their own thoughts.

Edella, the only woman among the officers of Abyss, looked at Kerington, their leader, and asked him.

"It sounds like he wants us to become his followers."

"Edella. It's just a matter of having one more god to worship. Where can you find such an easy condition?"

"Well, that's true, but..."

"It's a chance to make a contract with the king of death! I would even offer him my soul if I could!"

Edella, who had a nervous expression on her face, reluctantly nodded at Kerington's words.

Everyone here knew how important the king of death was.

After the origin of black magic disappeared, how many people had tried to summon the king of death?

And now, the king of death suddenly appeared before them.

Even if their faith in the evil god was not in vain, most of the officers sitting here were willing to pay the price.

All the officers, including Edella, nodded their heads, and Kerington's eyes turned back to Arcrosis.

And then he spoke his opinion to Arcrosis in a serious voice.

“We have all decided to serve the great one.”

“Is there no falsehood in your heart? Do you truly believe and follow the great one?”

“Of course!”

“False faith will lead you to ruin.”

“My heart is sincere for the great one. As long as you are with us, our hearts are also his.”

Arcrosis smiled at Kerington’s words.

He had no lips to curl up, but still everyone here felt his smile.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

Arcrosis’s staff hit the floor of the meeting room several times.

As his eyes flashed and his staff hit the floor, a bleak voice echoed in the meeting room.

“Then I will make a contract with you.”

“From today on, your hearts will stop beating, and only my magic will keep you alive forever.”

As soon as Arcrosis’s words ended, all the officers in the meeting room collapsed on their seats.

Thump.

Kerington’s neck twitched as he bowed his head.

His heart stopped completely, and death magic took its place.

Even though their hearts had stopped, the blood color of the fallen black magicians did not change.

Rather, they began to regain consciousness one by one and lifted their heads.

The black magicians who got up from their seats looked at each other with surprised eyes.

The curse of immortality that guaranteed eternal life to the living.

That was the identity of the curse that the king of death, Arcrosis, had cast on them.

“Archbishop. What is that snake on your shoulder...?”

In the meeting room that was set up temporarily in the barracks, an officer of the church asked him, looking at Roan.

It was because Roan had brought a strange snake into the tent prepared for the meeting.

On Roan’s shoulder, there was a sleek snake with black scales.

The scales that wrapped around the snake were smooth and graceful, but unlike other snakes, they had a strange texture.

It looked ominous on the outside.

Roan smiled as he recalled the identity of the snake on his shoulder, answering the question about it.

“It is a guardian beast that the great one has bestowed upon us.”

“The church’s guardian beast...!”

“That little snake is the church’s guardian beast?”

The officers of the church asked him in surprise at Roan's voice.

The great one had personally sent a guardian beast for the church.

It was an inestimable grace for the believers who served God.

Of course, Roan, who had met the guardian beast, also thought so.

Sssss.

He stroked the head of the snake that flicked its tongue and introduced the church's guardian beast to them.

"Say hello to everyone. His name is Beta."

Shadow beast Beta.

That was the identity of the guardian beast that came down to the church.

He looked like nothing more than a small snake on the outside, but no one would say that if they faced his true form.

The shape of a huge snake that wriggled and moved in the dark shadows.

That was the dreadful true form of the shadow beast Beta.

As Roan called Beta's name, Beta revealed his head from the shadows and flicked his tongue.

"Th-that is...!"

"That is the guardian beast that the great one has sent...!"

"...It looks like a giant snake."

All the believers who saw the true form of the shadow beast marveled at it.

The shadow snake that showed its head from the darkness was beautiful enough to awe anyone who saw it.

A great guardian beast that hid in the shadows and protected the believers of the church.

No one here could doubt his majestic appearance.

A believer who met his golden eyes shining in the shadows clapped his hands and said to Roan.

“What a magnificent sight. That’s amazing.”

“I agree. Beta. You can go back in now.”

Sssss.

At Roan’s gesture, Beta tucked his head back into the shadows.

Maybe it was because everyone here had witnessed his strange spectacle.

Everyone seemed more excited than before the meeting started.

After confirming that Beta had completely disappeared into the shadows, Roan looked around and began the meeting.

“Well, that’s enough introduction for Beta. Let’s all be grateful for the grace of the great one who gave us the guardian beast.”

“Yes, Archbishop.”

“Then I’ll talk about the reason why I called you all here today.”

“Yes.”

“Apart from the restoration project that is currently underway in the church, we will separately mobilize some people for the next operation.”

They would launch a new operation with the church’s personnel.

One of the believers swallowed his saliva at Roan’s words.

There was only one operation among the huge ones that the church had planned that required new personnel.

He tensed up as he recalled the contents of the operation in his head and asked Roan.

“Do you mean... that operation is starting?”

“Of course. We can’t just sit still after what happened to us.”

“...”

“How do you think the great one sent us a guardian beast himself? I have no face to look up at the sky these days.”

Roan looked at the church members who had changed their expressions to awkward ones.

The church headquarters raid by Cloud for Agent Period.

The church suffered a severe human loss from this incident.

Many of the believers who followed the church lost their lives to Cloud.

In the end, their master intervened and slaughtered all the enemies, including the agent, but it was a very shameful situation for Roan, who had not fulfilled his duty.

He had no face to look up at the sky, and that was not an empty word.

“That’s why I’m going to make sure that such a mishap never happens again.”

“Huh.”

“We have to make them pay for it, too, but we have something to deal with first.”

“... Yes.”

“What we’re going to start from now on is one thing. The great operation that we planned for the longest and prepared for the biggest.”

The biggest operation that Roan had been preparing for since he became an archbishop.

The most troublesome operation was to keep an apostle with him just for this.

More than anything, it was one of the processes that the church had to go through at least once to expand its power actively.

Roan spread his arms wide and looked at them.

And then he declared his grand intention to the officers here.

“It’s to take over the Count’s territory!”

The succession war of the Count’s family led by Rex Meyer.

It was time to put an end to this long story.

Chapter 56: The Necromancer King, Arcrosis (3)

< 56 : The Necromancer King, Arcrosis (3) >

Another exhausting day has passed.

I had promised myself to survive on ramen for a while, but my weary body overpowered my frugal spirit.

The result was the beer and convenience store chicken that were now on the table.

Click.

I opened a can of beer that I bought in a pack of four for a cheap price and took a sip.

The cool sensation in my mouth seemed to wash away the fatigue of the day.

After refreshing my mouth with the beer, I looked at the TV screen where the news was playing.

“This is the world news. The unrest that was occurring in some African countries is spreading across the continent.”

“It has been 20 days since the situation started in South Africa, the capital of the Republic of...”

The TV was showing the world news as usual.

The African continent had been quite noisy since the last time.

It didn't really affect me much, since it was a story from a faraway land.

It was almost on the other side of the globe, no matter how short I looked at it.

It was natural to feel a distance from the news of the global village.

"Is there anything interesting?"

Beep.

I pressed the button on the remote control to change the channel.

I was hoping to find an interesting movie on TV.

But no matter how many times I changed the channel, I couldn't find a movie that I liked.

I was too lazy to go online and search for one.

I just left the TV on some random channel and took out my smartphone to start playing a game.

"Ah, I'll just play a game."

Since it was an idle game, the characters in the game moved on their own without me controlling them.

I just wanted to eat chicken while watching the game.

As I launched the game and touched the loading screen to move on to the next screen, I saw the characters moving busily.

They looked like believers who were cutting and moving wood around.

They seemed to be repairing the broken church.

As I watched the busy believers, I quickly switched the screen to check the remaining karma.

“I wonder how much karma I have accumulated today.”

I read the karma value that was floating in one corner of the screen.

1972 karma.

It almost felt like I was looking at a year.

The overall increase of karma had slowed down significantly since Kueberg’s karma acquisition rate had decreased.

Moreover, I had lost some believers due to the attacks from external forces, and the bonus from faith had also decreased.

It was natural that the karma acquisition rate had decreased, as two bad news had overlapped.

The only surprising thing was that there was a karma value obtained by [The Necromancer King: Arcrosis].

“The karma itself didn’t increase much... but there’s a new item added this time.”

Swish.

I scrolled down the accumulated messages to find the messages about Arcrosis.

Below are the messages that always informed me about Kueberg’s hunting.

There were new messages that appeared because of Arcrosis.

[The Necromancer King: Arcrosis] has performed a sacrifice for you.

Sacrifices offered to you: 42

The effect of <The Divine Voice of Karma: Sacrifice> is activated.

The karma increased by 84, proportional to the number of sacrifices offered.

The number of believers in the church increased significantly.

Some believers acquired the <Fanatic> trait.

The karma increased by 14.

As I slowly looked at the messages that appeared, the first thing I saw was a message that Arcrosis had sacrificed for me.

A creature, not a character, had performed a sacrifice for me directly.

It was a contrast to Kueberg, who had only obtained karma through hunting.

As I scrolled down a bit more, I also saw a message that the number of believers had increased greatly.

The increase of believers at the same time as the sacrifice.

I couldn't help but wonder about the two incompatible messages.

“How can they become believers after being sacrificed?”

To perform a sacrifice, one had to offer a character.

But the characters that were offered were now my believers.

It meant that the believers who were sacrificed by Arcrosis were still living their faith lives.

I couldn't understand the situation, and I had no way of finding out where Arcrosis was right now.

On the day I gave [Shadow Beast: Beta] to Roan, I tried to find Arcrosis myself, but I failed.

“I don’t know what’s going on. But I’m too lazy to look into it myself.”

Arcrosis had long hidden his presence from the mountain where he was summoned.

Even if I tried to find him, I would have to search the whole map thoroughly.

I didn’t feel like going through that trouble just to find Arcrosis.

As long as I was getting karma, it was undeniable that he was doing something helpful for me.

Maybe if I left him alone, he would be like a stock that I bought and forgot, and someday he would bring me a nice profit.

“Well, he’ll probably earn me some karma somehow.”

I left behind a hopeful dream about Arcrosis and continued to scroll down.

There was still some scroll left below the messages about Arcrosis.

There was another message that had been delivered besides the new creature.

I found a familiar name there.

“It looks like the magic book I gave to Eutenia came back.”

At the bottom of the message box, there was a message that came from Eutenia.

She had sent me a magic book using a sacrifice.

The identity of the magic book I received from Eutenia was [Magic Book: Giga Lightning].

It was something that I had obtained from a draw and handed over to Eutenia.

I checked the magic book that was newly added to my inventory and immediately used it to learn the magic.

You have learned <Giga Lightning (Lv.MAX)>.

You can now use the Giga Lightning magic by consuming mana.

<Giga Lightning> has been added to the shared list of [Divine Device: Astrafer].

The magic book in my inventory disappeared and the skill icon of <Giga Lightning> appeared in one corner of the screen.

The icon of <Giga Lightning> looked like a rain of lightning.

It was common sense to try out a skill once you learned it.

I moved my location to another mountain nearby so that I wouldn't cause any damage to the church.

If it were usual, I would have thrown magic at any village, but now I couldn't do that.

There were no intact villages near the church anymore.

“Well, there are no characters... I guess I'll just try it on some animals.”

Squeeze.

I touched the skill icon of <Giga Lightning> and activated a new target area.

Then I placed it on a hillside of the mountain and touched the target area.

A light burst out from the target area and soon a thin dark cloud began to rise over the whole mountain.

The moment the dark cloud condensed into a huge cloud.

Boom!

A lightning bolt struck down at the same time as an anomaly occurred on the whole mountain.

You used <Giga Lightning>.

Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

Lightning began to fall randomly over a wide area.

A deer that was passing by the mountain was hit by lightning on its head and stopped completely.

The damage that appeared above the deer's head was 30.

It was a bit insufficient to knock down a character, but <Giga Lightning>'s effect wasn't over yet.

Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

The deer that was hit again by the successive lightning turned into ash and disappeared.

As long as <Giga Lightning> lasted, lightning continued to fall.

If you survived one hit and relaxed, you would get hurt by the next lightning strike.

“This is really an area-of-effect skill.”

Lightning that strikes randomly at multiple targets.

It was a magic that showed great utility in sweeping away enemies.

It was a powerful magic even when used as an area-of-effect skill, but it was also effective when used on a single target.

The irregularly falling lightning looked hard to defend against.

It was a perfect skill except for the fact that it required a lot of mana consumption.

“Ah... I made a valuable purchase after a long time.”

I was impressed by the power of the new magic and put down my smartphone and tore off a chicken leg.

I was very satisfied with the power of the new skill.

I felt like I was matching the lightning attribute, but it wasn't a bad feeling.

It wasn't uncommon to match the concept of skills while playing games.

The stress that had accumulated throughout the day was completely relieved.

Cold beer. Crispy chicken.

And the best area-of-effect skill on top of that.

It didn't take much to turn a hard day into the best moment.

The new branch of the church is located in the southwest of the continent.

The countless crowds that had flocked to see Estasia had long become a force.

They had controlled the growing crowd over time and continued to build buildings to accommodate the people of the church.

At first, there were some outsiders who resisted their control.

But they all silenced their complaints and became believers of the church after seeing Estasia's appearance.

The miracle of the angel they faced directly had such a strong power.

Along with the growing power of the church, the first building that symbolized the church was also completed.

It was natural that Estasia participated in the completion ceremony of the historic first building of the church.

On the day the building was completed.

The old man who took on the role of bishop took Estasia to the front of the building.

He looked at Estasia in front of the building that was built with effort and sincerity and said.

“The temple for you and the great one has finally been completed.”

The temple was built for the angel and the great one.

Estasia nodded her head quietly at his words.

She was facing the old man with a very different appearance from the first day.

There was a small gold crown on her halo, and gold necklaces and bracelets were hanging on her neck and arms.

Everything had changed completely except for the clothes she wore down from heaven.

No angel in heaven would think of her as a poor and lazy angel anymore.

Estasia, who was wearing gold ornaments, looked at the entrance of the building with a wing pattern and said.

“Is this my new home?”

As summer came and it got hot, Estasia also felt uncomfortable living in a cave.

She had been wishing for a more comfortable space lately.

The old man smiled happily at Estasia's words and opened the door.

And he gave her the answer she wanted to her question.

"Of course, we have prepared a large space for you behind the temple."

"A space for me..."

"Please come inside. I'll show you around."

The old man led Estasia inside and didn't forget to give an order to the young man who was waiting next to him.

He was a naive young man named Alphonse.

Alphonse had prepared a drink in advance according to the old man's order.

"Alphonse! Bring the drink you prepared!"

"Yes!"

Alphonse approached Estasia with careful steps as soon as he heard the old man's order.

It was the highest honor for the people of the church to serve Estasia.

It was a glorious thing that Alphonse, a loyal believer of the church, would never refuse.

As Alphonse came closer with a drink, the old man pointed at him and told Estasia.

"This is a cool drink prepared for you. Have a sip before you go."

Alphonse took his place next to Estasia with a tray with a drink on it.

Estasia turned her head and looked closely at the glass on the tray.

There was strawberry juice and ice in the glass.

They had prepared ice separately to make the drink cool.

Estasia lifted the glass with ice and said to the old man.

“There’s ice in the juice.”

“We brought a magician to freeze it for you. Please have a taste.”

“Okay.”

Estasia brought the glass to her mouth and took a sip of the strawberry juice with ice.

The sweet scent of strawberries cooled by ice went down her throat.

Gulp.

She swallowed the strawberry juice that came into her mouth in an instant and relaxed her expression.

She put down the glass she was holding on Alphonse’s tray and said, enjoying the coolness of the strawberry juice.

“This is heaven...”

“I’m glad you’re satisfied. It was worth bringing a magician.”

“Make it for me sometimes.”

“Of course. Come on, let’s go inside.”

Thud. Thud.

They opened the door and entered, and they were greeted by a wide corridor of the building.

In any other building, there would have been many doors in the corridor, but this was a church where believers gathered.

On the first floor, there were only small doors except for one big door.

The old man started to introduce Estasia to each small door one by one.

“This is the kitchen.”

“Okay.”

“There will be believers who will be in charge of your snacks here.”

“Awesome.”

After the kitchen, there was a food storage room.

The food storage room was still empty.

“This is the food storage room.”

“Okay.”

“All kinds of ingredients will be stored here.”

“Awesome.”

After the food storage room, there was a room with piles of desks.

The old man pointed at the empty desk with his hand and said.

“This is where the financial management department of the church will be located.”

“Okay.”

“They will decide and select the treasures that will be offered to you.”

“Awesome.”

Food storage. Kitchen. Laundry room. Cleaning tool storage.

The old man continued to explain the various facilities on the first floor of the church.

Every time he did, Estasia just nodded her head and agreed with his words.

After checking out the many buildings on the first floor, they came out.

The old man opened the biggest door in the middle of the first floor and said.

“This is the last space on the first floor. It’s the chapel and your room behind it.”

Creak.

As the door of the chapel opened, a humble space was revealed.

Except for an old-fashioned chair in the middle of the stage, there were only a few wooden chairs barely placed.

The interior of the chapel had not been properly decorated yet.

Only the chair on the stage maintained its splendor among the humbleness.

Estasia passed by the chapel and pointed at the chair on the stage and asked.

“What’s that chair?”

“It’s a chair for you to sit on.”

“Okay.”

As expected, when she asked, the chair was Estasia’s.

Estasia nodded her head and approached the back of the chair.

There was a small door behind the splendid chair.

Estasia reached out and opened the door in the chapel.

Clank.

The place that was revealed as the door opened was another room that was beautifully decorated.

“This feels nice.”

The room beyond the chapel was decorated with bright colors unlike the outside, and there was also a soft-looking bed.

Estasia’s eyes scanned the room that was decorated with various ornaments that looked familiar.

They were things that she had received as gifts from the believers of the church.

Estasia looked around the room with sparkling eyes, and the old man said to her as if he had been waiting.

“This is a space for you.”

“Is this my home?”

“Yes. You can use it as you please.”

Hearing the old man’s words, Estasia jumped into bed with a satisfied face.

The soft bed that was made with care by the believers supported Estasia.

The softness that came from her back was completely different from the hard floor of the cave she had been sleeping in.

Estasia lay down on the soft bed and smiled happily.

And she stuck to the bed and said to the old man.

“I like it because it’s soft.”

“I’m glad you’re happy.”

“Shall we stop here for today?”

The old man looked flustered at Estasia’s words.

There were still many places in the church that he had to show her.

There were countless things to see on the second, third, fourth, and fifth floors.

Estasia’s attitude puzzled the old man, who tried to persuade her by telling her about the second floor.

“If you go up the stairs, there are more things prepared for you!”

“Stairs?”

“Yes. The second floor is upstairs.”

“Stairs are too bothersome to climb.”

“...”

But Estasia’s face became more listless when she heard the word stairs.

In silence, Estasia and the old man looked at each other.

The old man’s face was full of earnestness toward Estasia.

But despite his appearance, Estasia spoke to him in a firm voice.

“I’ll only see this much today.”

“I understand. We’ll stop here for today.”

The old man looked regretful, but in the end, Estasia’s opinion was the priority here.

He nodded his head and had no choice but to stop the tour of the church with Estasia.

It was a guided tour that ended in just 10 minutes after entering the building.

Chapter 57: Turmoil (1)

< 57 : Turmoil (1) >

“We’ll be completely out of the Centrius region once we pass this valley.”

Count Meyer looked at Baron Betenge, who was following him, and nodded his head.

Behind Count Meyer, there were countless escort troops, including Baron Betenge.

They were following Count Meyer because of the invitation from the duke that was sent to the major nobles of the empire.

The official reason was that the duke’s daughter had her coming-of-age ceremony, but the real reason was to strengthen the bond within the noble faction.

Count Meyer couldn’t refuse the duke’s invitation.

Especially now that the royal authority had fallen greatly due to Cuebaerg’s problem, the cohesion within the faction was very important.

“What do you think about this matter, Baron Betenge?”

Maybe it was because the long journey was already boring.

Count Meyer looked at Baron Betenge, who was moving next to him, and asked.

He remembered what happened before he left the city.

Baron Betenge asked him back at Count Meyer's sudden question.

"Are you talking about the duke's invitation?"

"I'm talking about Rex."

"Ah... Prince Rex. I heard he was sent to subdue bandits to gain military experience."

Count Meyer had given Rex an order and attached a hundred men to him before leaving the city.

It was an order to subdue the bandits who were staying in an abandoned fortress.

It was partly because of Count Meyer's wife's suggestion, and partly because he thought it would be good to give Rex some experience.

Besides, the captain of the hundred men he attached to Rex was also a fairly competent person.

Considering that Rex had a knight escort by his side, Count Meyer thought that Rex wouldn't get hurt.

"Right. Do you think Rex will succeed without any trouble?"

"Isn't that fortress broken and unable to function properly?"

"It lost its strategic value, so they didn't feel the need to repair it."

The fortress that was occupied by bandits was built when the empire's territory was much narrower than it is now.

It was meant to protect the empire's border from external enemies.

But as time passed, it lost its strategic value and became a completely ruined junkyard.

It would cost too much to repair the fortress now.

That's why Count Meyer was able to send Rex to subdue the bandits.

Baron Betenge pondered for a moment at Count Meyer's words, and then gave him his opinion.

"The bandits are few in number and the fortress is ruined, so the prince should be able to capture it easily."

"Do you think so too?"

"Of course. The bandits can't stand against the elite soldiers of the city."

"That's what you think too."

Baron Betenge didn't stop there and added a little flattery to Count Meyer.

"Besides, Prince Rex is like you, isn't he? He will surely show his excellent abilities like you."

"I trust your words, since you are the best swordsman in the whole county!"

Count Meyer's face smiled with satisfaction at Baron Betenge's words that assured Rex's success.

He was secretly anxious when he sent his son to the battlefield to gain experience.

No matter how much Count Meyer's wife badmouthed Rex, Rex was his precious first son.

As Count Meyer and his escort troops were moving along the valley,

One of the knights at the front of the column spotted something and shouted in a loud voice.

It was a shout to order the following column to stop.

"Stop! Everyone stop!"

The rider next to the knight waved a flag, and soon the advancing column of Count Meyer stopped.

Count Meyer looked at the knight who had stopped the column.

The knight was looking at a point not far from his party.

His gaze naturally turned to the front of the valley.

A little ahead of where Count Meyer's column had stopped,

There was a middle-aged man wearing a tunic standing there.

“Who are you? Identify yourself!”

The knight at the front asked the identity of the suspicious person who suddenly appeared.

The eyes of all the escort troops who were moving along the valley turned to the man in front of them.

He was a man who had not been seen in the valley until just now.

And he was alone in this treacherous valley.

There was no one here who wouldn't suspect him, who was blocking the column by himself.

At the question of the knight who asked his identity, the man bowed politely in the direction where Count Meyer was and said.

“I am Roan Hebris, Archbishop of the Church.”

“Church...? What are you talking about?”

“I am the most humble servant who serves and spreads His will.”

Count Meyer frowned at the name of the church.

The man in front of him was undoubtedly a heretic who served an evil god.

Count Meyer's mouth naturally uttered a derogatory term for him as he looked at Roan.

"...Heretic."

"That's a very insulting remark."

"What business do you have with me, heretic?"

Why did this heretic come to find Count Meyer?

Count Meyer thought that as he looked at Roan.

Roan looked at him with a crazed look in his eyes as he licked his tongue.

He reached out his hand toward Count Meyer and said.

"I don't care much since you're going to die soon anyway.

"What are you...?"

"I came here to kill you."

Shriek.

A snake that was sticking out of Roan's sleeve showed its head.

It was a clear declaration of war.

The soldiers who were waiting for the enemy raised their weapons at Roan's threat.

There was nothing left to do but fight, since the enemy had clearly expressed his hostility.

The knight at the front pointed his sword at Roan and ordered his soldiers.

“He’s a heretic! Prepare for battle!”

“Charge! Annihilate the enemy!”

With a fierce shout, Count Meyer’s soldiers started to move.

The knights at the front charged at Roan on their horses.

Thud—. Thud—.

The distance between Roan and the knights began to shrink rapidly.

But Roan looked relaxed even as he faced the knights who were aiming at him.

As the knights who had charged forward reached right in front of Roan,

Roan looked at the snake that was sticking out of his sleeve and opened his mouth.

“Beta. You can eat now.”

Kugugugugung!

With a sound that shook the ground, Roan’s shadow expanded greatly.

And a snake’s head emerged from the shadow at a fast speed.

A huge snake wrapped in darkness.

A dark beast.

A monster of the abyss that hid in the shadows appeared on the ground.

The knights who saw the monster for the first time in their lives pulled their reins hastily.

“What, what is that!”

“It’s a monster! A monster has appeared!”

“Stop charging! We’ll collide if we go like this...!”

It looked huge enough with just its head that was visible to the naked eye.

What would happen if such a creature lifted its head completely?

Anyone here could easily guess that.

The knights tried to stop their horses and avoid the collision, but Beta was faster than them.

The shadow that was swaying in the dark flashed its golden eyes and opened its mouth wide.

Shiiiiiiiiiiik!

Beta’s huge mouth that was like a bottomless pit swallowed the knights.

Behind Beta’s closed mouth was a dark abyss.

A huge abyss with no light.

An unknown space with an unfathomable depth opened up.

People and horses, as well as carriages, were sucked into it.

“Uh, uh, uhuhuhu...?”

“Co, Count!”

Right after the knights at the front were completely sucked into Beta’s mouth,

Beta closed its mouth completely toward the empty air.

Crunch. Crackle.

With a horrible cracking sound, the knights who had been charging forward disappeared in an instant.

From behind Beta's closed mouth, screams of people echoed.

"Aaaaaaaah—!"

"Aaah! Save me...!"

Crackle. Crunch.

Beta chewed its mouth several more times after swallowing people.

With every movement of Beta's mouth, a horrible sound echoed.

When Beta stopped moving its mouth completely,

There was no more screaming from Beta's mouth.

In a blink of an eye, a terrible tragedy happened and Count Meyer looked at Beta with a blank stare.

"What, what is that...?"

Count Meyer's loyal knights had vanished into the monster's stomach in an instant.

The knights that I had spent tens of years pouring the count's funds into raising had fallen prey to the monster's meal.

My hand was trembling at the unbelievable sight that unfolded before my eyes.

The loss I suffered now was a huge blow that the count's house could not easily recover from.

But what was even more frightening was the fact that the monster that had swallowed up the knights did not have a single wound on it.

“Didn’t I tell you? You are destined to die soon.”

“Why are you doing this to me?”

The count’s voice, looking at Beta, was even more powerless than before.

Why did he attack me?

Roan smiled at the count’s question.

His eyes, which had a friendly smile on them.

And Beta’s golden eyes, piercing through the thick shadows.

The two pairs of eyes poured out at the count at once.

“You asked why I’m doing this?”

“Yes, yes. I’m a count. There’s nothing good for you by doing this to the Church...”

“Why not? If you die, Prince Rex will inherit the count’s seat.”

What came out of Roan’s mouth was unexpectedly a story about Rex.

If the count died, Rex would become the next count of Meyer.

Roan was talking to the count like that.

The count’s face was even more puzzled than before at Roan’s words that he would make Rex a count.

“What do you mean, Rex will inherit the count’s seat?”

“Didn’t you know? Prince Rex is already a loyal believer of the Church.”

“Prince Rex is a believer of the Church?”

“Of course. Prince Rex promised to build a temple for the great one in the city once he becomes the count.”

Then, all the pieces of the puzzle fell into place in the count’s mind.

Snap.

The count clenched his teeth as he talked to Roan.

His beloved son was a heretic.

It was a reality that he could not tolerate as a count.

Of course, there were people who moved for the count’s sake while he was conversing with Roan.

Baron Bettinge, who had been by the count’s side all along, grabbed his hand and shouted loudly.

“Count! There is no time for this! Retreat quickly! I will buy you some time!”

“Baron...”

“I can’t stand to see the city fall into the hands of the heretics! Go back as soon as possible and save the count’s territory!”

Baron Bettinge’s determined eyes looked at the count.

Baron Bettinge had been with the count since they were young.

The count felt his eyes moisten at the baron’s words that he would sacrifice himself to save him.

He was grateful for his luck to have such a loyal subordinate until the end.

“Baron, I...”

“We can’t win against that monster with just this number of troops!”

“...I know.”

“You have to go back to your territory and gather as many soldiers as you can!”

To face the dark beast, he needed an army of a suitable size.

Baron Bettinge’s words were nothing but the truth.

And it was the count’s role to raise an army at this point.

He needed to go back to his territory as quickly as possible.

The count expressed his gratitude to Baron Bettinge, who was willing to make such a sacrifice for him.

“Baron Bettinge! I swear I will take care of your family!”

“Count! Please come back alive.”

As soon as he finished his farewell, the count turned his horse and ran away.

Roan watched him go and said, “Count Meyer. Do you really think you can escape like this?”

“You evil heretic! You and that monster will never pass through here as long as I live!”

“I don’t intend to pass through here.”

Roan ignored Baron Bettinge and looked at the fleeing count.

The count was running away with some of his escort troops towards the direction where his territory was.

But Roan did not move an inch from his spot, let alone chase after him.

At that moment, Baron Bettinge felt a bad omen.

Swoosh.

A dagger flew out of Roan's chest.

It was a beautiful dagger wrapped in a sinister aura.

“Blame your own foolishness.”

“Gah...!”

Crash!

At the same time as a thunderous sound echoed from the sky, the count fell off his horse.

The horse that was struck by lightning died instantly, and the count who was holding the reins also did not escape unscathed.

He hit his head on the ground as he fell, and his limbs twitched.

His blurry vision looked at the direction where the city was.

That was the last scene that Count Meyer remembered.

Chapter 58: Turmoil (2)

< 58 : Turmoil (2) >

Rex, the eldest son of Count Meyer, led his army to carry out the mission he was given.

He only had one hundred men, including his escort knights.

He had heard that the bandits were only about thirty, but he was still anxious about his first battle.

It was a fight where people's lives were at stake.

He had accepted the count's offer to earn some merit, but he couldn't help feeling nervous.

Soon, he reached the location where the ruined towers were visible. He looked at Evan, who was next to him, and asked.

“Ev, Evan.”

“What is it?”

“We won't fail this subjugation, right?”

Evan was a powerful force that the Church had assigned to him.

Rex looked at him with an uneasy gaze, but Evan was still calm and composed.

He seemed to be looking for something, as he kept glancing around.

He looked at one of the towers nearby and said.

“If the fortress was intact, it wouldn’t be easy to attack it with this number of troops.”

“So...”

“But there’s no need to worry too much.”

Rex’s face brightened at Evan’s words.

He looked confident to anyone who saw him.

Maybe if there was any problem, Evan would step in and wipe out the bandits himself.

Rex was hoping for that as he looked at Evan.

But then, Evan suddenly stopped and said.

“We won’t have to fight the bandits anyway.”

“Evan, what are you saying...”

“——Astraphe.”

Ignoring Rex’s puzzled gaze, Evan raised his hand with a gauntlet on it.

Crackle. Crackle.

Blue flashes gathered in Evan’s hand as he broke the air with thunder.

The lightning bolts in Evan’s hand intertwined and grew in size.

The blue current that grew bigger and bigger eventually formed a shape of a spear.

Evan turned around with the spear in his hand.

“Let’s start the operation now.”

“Yes...?”

“Move back if you don’t want to get swept away.”

After warning him, Evan pushed Rex aside, who was looking confused.

Then, he threw the spear of lightning at the hundred men who were following him.

The spear left Evan’s hand and flew towards the hundred men with a blast.

Boom!

The spear of lightning collided with the soldiers and exploded.

With a heavy sound, some of the hundred men who were chasing Evan fell down.

The soldiers who were hit by Evan’s surprise attack screamed in pain.

“Argh!”

“Ugh...”

Crackle.

Blue sparks flew over the ground where the electrocuted soldiers fell.

The soldiers who were hit by Evan’s lightning attack were all incapacitated without exception.

It was something that happened in an instant in an unexpected situation.

The hundred men were shocked by the sudden attack from their ally in the front.

The captain of the hundred men shouted at Rex, who was bewildered by the situation.

“Prince! What is going on here!”

“I, I...”

But Rex was also confused by the captain’s question.

He had no memory of receiving a notification from Evan that he would attack the hundred men.

The soldiers who were not attacked moved away from Evan and raised their weapons.

Evan stepped forward instead of Rex, who was at a loss for words.

And he opened his mouth to the captain, who was resentful of Rex.

“Don’t feel too wronged. Prince Rex didn’t know about this operation either.”

“What do you mean, he didn’t know? What kind of operation is this?”

“This operation is to make sure that none of the soldiers who participated will return alive.”

“...!”

The cold death sentence that fell upon the entire White Corps, including the White Commander.

At the same time, enemies who had been hiding in all directions began to pour out.

They were all wearing uniform outfits and holding weapons in their hands.

Rex was only able to understand the situation then, seeing the faces of the believers who surrounded him.

The ones who surrounded Rex and his soldiers were all followers of the cult.

Evan had obediently followed the subjugation for the sake of disposing of the soldiers.

“...Evan, sir? Why are you doing this?”

“To get rid of them and disguise the cult’s followers as soldiers.”

“Ah, no, but... there’s no need to kill them...”

“We don’t have much time. Do you want to lose your neck to your brother who became an earl?”

Evan snapped at Rex and raised his gauntlet.

Crackle.

A blue current appeared again with a thunderous sound.

It was the thunder spear that had blown away the soldiers just before. It reappeared in Evan’s hand.

The cult’s followers who had been waiting also began to move after Evan.

They each held sharp weapons and pressured the soldiers in a tight situation.

The White Commander, who was surrounded by the followers in an instant, let out a sigh.

“Prince Rex! We will be annihilated at this rate!”

“White Commander....”

“Please make a decision quickly! Soldiers, hold back the enemies from approaching!”

The White Commander urged Rex to make a decision, while gathering his soldiers in a formation in the narrow space.

But it was already too late. The morale of the soldiers had been shattered by the previous attack.

It was hard to maintain a numerical advantage with the troops that had lost nearly 30% of their combat ability.

Gulp.

The White Commander swallowed his saliva as the situation became more difficult.

Even at this moment, the followers with weapons were approaching the White Corps.

“—Astraphe.”

“Prince Rex! Don’t abandon us!”

“It’s too late. Blame yourselves for choosing the wrong master.”

By then, the thunder spear in Evan’s hand was also completed.

Crackle!

The spear roared and sparked as it flew towards the soldiers.

A blue beam cut through the air and landed in the center of the soldiers.

Kwagwagwagwang——!

A dazzling flash exploded and a thunderstorm swept over the soldiers.

“I finally made it.”

It was Friday evening again before I knew it.

I lay on my bed and looked at the screen of the smartphone in my hand.

On the game screen, I saw Eutenia with Estasia.

Eutenia had finally delivered the bishop's appointment letter to the new bishop, Estasia.

Of course, I also had to see Estasia, who had changed a lot in the process.

I snorted at the sight of Estasia wearing all kinds of accessories.

"She looks familiar with sunglasses on."

Gold necklace, gold bracelet. And a small gold headpiece.

She looked awkward with the excessive jewelry she was wearing.

She must have put on everything that was expensive.

Her outfit reminded me of the nouveau riche.

If she wore sunglasses, she would fit right in on any SNS.

She had amassed wealth by plundering the cult's followers every day.

"Hmm... I feel like playing a prank on her."

Estasia was living a leisurely and luxurious life unlike the other members of the cult.

She just sat there and food and jewels were delivered to her.

Of course, Estasia had played a big role in gathering the followers, so I didn't want to completely deny her merit.

But somehow, watching her act so arrogant, I felt like teasing her a bit.

I looked at Estasia for a while and then tapped on the icon above Eutenia's head to write a message.

"I should give Estasia some work."

Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap.

I typed a message and sent it to Eutenia.

Eutenia received the message and looked up at the sky for a moment.

Was it because of the message translated by the 'Divine Translator'?

She seemed to be troubled by the sudden message.

She looked at the sky for a long time, then decided to approach Estasia.

And then she began to carry out the order I had given her through the message.

"Estasia."

"Yeah."

"I have a message from the Great One."

Estasia tilted her head at Eutenia's words.

She was not an apostle, so she could not receive messages from me directly.

She asked Eutenia about the message she heard for the first time.

"A message?"

"Yes. The Great One has something to say through me."

"What is it?"

The corners of my mouth rose slowly as I saw Estasia's reaction.

From my perspective, who knew what was going on, I couldn't help but laugh.

The story that Eutenia was about to tell was the highlight.

I watched the screen closely, looking forward to Estasia's next reaction.

Eutenia spoke to Estasia with a serious face.

"From today on, Estasia has to walk around the building every day and monitor if the followers are doing their work well, according to the Great One."

"...Me?"

"Yes. The Great One said that only Estasia can do it."

Estasia's face turned serious as she heard Eutenia's words.

Clatter.

One of the gold bracelets on Estasia's arm slipped off and rolled on the floor.

Was it too shocking for her to receive a direct order from me?

Estasia looked at Eutenia with a dark face and asked.

"What happens if I don't do it?"

"If you fail to do your job properly, lightning will strike the strawberry fruits around you, as a warning."

"...!"

"Of course, I trust that Estasia, the faithful angel, will do her duty diligently."

Gulp.

I suppressed the laughter that was about to burst out and looked at the screen.

Was it because she was fooled by Estasia's angelic appearance?

Eutenia, who knew nothing, showed infinite trust in Estasia.

But Estasia was a greedy creature, contrary to her expectations.

She exploited the characters around her every day, collecting countless fruits and jewels.

And she spent all day in the cave without doing any work.

She trusted her just because she was an angel.

It showed how much the characters knew about angels.

“What do you mean by doing your duty diligently?”

She would be lucky if she just pretended to work and stayed in her room.

Of course, I only gave her a simple order because I wanted to tease her.

I was more interested in Estasia's reaction than her working hard.

Estasia was sweating profusely as she heard my order.

“Ugh....”

“I'll be going now.”

“Hey, wait....”

“I wanted to talk more with Estasia, but I have no choice because the Great One gave me another mission.”

“No... Estasia doesn't like work....”

She couldn't communicate with me without Eutenia.

Estasia tried to stop Eutenia somehow, but Eutenia coldly pushed her away after finishing her work.

She had to check the [Holy Relic: Etalia's Compass] that she had received before arriving.

Now that she had completed the mission of appointing a new bishop, it was time for her to leave for the next mission.

Eutenia smiled and said goodbye to Estasia.

"I'll be back soon, since it's a mission nearby."

"...."

"See you later, Estasia."

That was the end of their conversation.

Eutenia left the place on a carriage as soon as she finished her mission.

And only Estasia was left alone, staring blankly at Eutenia's empty spot.

Estasia stood still in shock until the sun set.

Of course, I watched her with a satisfied smile.

She was a creature that was fun to watch.

Chapter 59: Turmoil (3)

< 59 : Turmoil (3) >

Evan and his group, including Rex, were able to pass through the city gate without any trouble.

There were some gatekeepers who looked at them with suspicious eyes after hearing the news of the white captain's death, but no one dared to stop the people that Rex vouched for.

Evan led the believers, who were disguised as soldiers, to the inner city.

There was only one reason why he would take the believers to the inner city.

Rex quickly guessed Evan's intention by his suspicious movements.

"Evan, sir... Why are you taking the believers with you? Don't tell me..."

"I'm going to take over the inner city from now on."

"..."

"It would be better to clear out the inside before the news spreads."

That was the moment when Rex's guess turned into certainty.

He was going to take over the inner city.

That meant only one thing.

Evan was planning to overthrow the lord of this city today.

Rex felt a headache coming on at Evan's words.

My father, Count Meyer, was still alive and well, and the countess and her troops remained in the inner city.

It seemed impossible for the believers, who could barely form a single battalion, to take over the inner city.

"Evan, sir, I think you're being too reckless..."

"We need to clear out the inner city before the news reaches them."

"What? News? What news?"

"Everyone except the honorary bishop will wait here until we come out after clearing the inner city."

Rex was flustered by Evan's plan to attack the inner city and tried to dissuade him.

But Evan ignored him and even left the believers outside.

Rex followed Evan, who was heading toward the entrance of the inner city alone.

As Evan and Rex approached the guards at the entrance,

One of the guards looked at Evan with a suspicious eye and asked,

"Sir Knight. Who are those soldiers behind you?"

"Oh, they are..."

There was no reason for the soldiers who had no business in the inner city to be waiting at the entrance.

It was natural for the guards to be suspicious.

Rex was about to step forward to convince them, but Evan stopped him and spoke to the guard.

“Open the gate.”

No matter how loyal he was to the first prince, he couldn't ignore the entrance procedure of the inner city.

The guard frowned at Evan's rude attitude and said,

“You can't enter the inner city with unauthorized troops.”

“I told you to open the gate.”

“You need permission...”

“Then die.”

Evan's hand grabbed the guard's head.

The guard was startled by Evan's sudden touch.

Zap!

A blue lightning flashed from his hand that held the guard's head.

After a flash of light, the guard collapsed on the spot.

Evan knocked down one of the guards and looked at the other one next to him.

He raised his weapon and looked at Evan with a panicked expression.

“What are you doing! Even if you're a knight of the prince...”

“——Astraphe.”

“Gah...!”

Crash!

At the same time as a light flashed from Evan's hand, the rest of the guards who were guarding the entrance also fell down.

Evan's eyes scanned over the two fallen guards and moved on.

The guards at the entrance were only a small part of the troops guarding the inner city.

If he crossed the gate and entered inside, a real battle would begin.

Gulp.

Rex swallowed his saliva at Evan's swift action.

He asked nervously,

"Do you really... intend to take over the inner city by yourself?"

"Yes."

"The knights guarding the inner city are on a different level from the white battalion that went on the expedition."

"I don't care."

"Sir Evan, you can't... You can never take over the inner city by yourself."

Before Rex's voice could finish, the bell tower started ringing.

The soldiers who detected the abnormal situation at the entrance of the inner city began to ring the bell.

Along with the bell sound, the soldiers who were waiting came toward the entrance.

Five. Ten. Twenty.

A countless number of troops approached Evan and Rex.

But Evan didn't back down even when he faced the incoming soldiers.

He just drew his sword from his waist.

Shing.

Evan held the sharp sword in his hand and looked at Rex with a worried expression.

"You still don't know who I am, do you?"

"What...?"

"Remember this. Who I am."

Thump.

Evan's right foot stepped forward.

Evan held his sword and took a stance to charge at his enemies.

His sharp eyes scanned over the enemies who were coming toward him.

"And where I am right now."

Zap.

At the same time as his eyes flashed, a blue lightning wrapped around Evan's body.

With a thunderous sound, Evan's body emitted a dense light.

Rex's eyes shook as he faced the shocking scene in front of him.

Evan, who was wrapped in blue lightning, exuded a strong confidence.

He smiled faintly at Rex and said,

“I am the second apostle, Evan Allemier.”

As soon as Evan’s words ended,

A blue flash dashed forward.

Kwang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

The blue lightning stretched out in succession, and the enemies who were hit by it were split in half.

They couldn’t stop it. And they couldn’t avoid it either.

The swift slash of light that flashed with lightning didn’t even allow them to see it with their eyes.

In an instant, Rex opened his mouth wide and watched the flash of light that stretched out.

“Gah!”

“Aaargh...!”

“Ugh... What is this...”

As Evan’s body returned to its place with the lightning wrapped around him, he revealed his figure.

There was nothing intact among the things that were standing in the path of the flash.

They were all cut in half, covered in blood.

Rex let out an exclamation without realizing it as he saw the carnage that was created in a moment.

His legs trembled as he couldn’t understand the scene.

“The second apostle...?”

An overwhelming power that transcended cognition.

The knight in front of me was no longer a knight.

An apostle.

A lawful agent chosen by the heavenly god.

His swordsmanship tore the sky apart, and his footsteps ran faster than light.

It was then that I realized who I had been with all this time.

And why Evan had entered the inner city alone, despite my dissuasion.

He had the power to do so.

The overwhelming power to knock down countless knights by himself, and plant his flag in the inner city stained with blood.

“Do you believe me a little now?”

Evan shook off the blood on his sword after cutting down the incoming soldiers.

Nod. Nod.

I nodded vigorously at his question.

No one would deny his words after seeing the overwhelming dance of his sword.

Evan swung his sword to shake off the blood, and then pointed his sword tip at the count's mansion.

“Is the countess there?”

“...Yes.”

“Where do you think Max Meyer is?”

“Max would probably... be with his mother.”

The countess always called Max for education at this time of day.

If my guess was right, Max would be with the countess right now.

Evan scanned the windows of the mansion after hearing my words.

The count's mansion had as many windows as there were rooms attached to it.

He looked at the windows and then asked me about the exact location of the countess.

“Which floor is the countess on?”

“There is a small study on the fourth floor. She usually conducts Max's education there.”

“I see. Then let's go there.”

Evan started walking toward the mansion with his sword in his hand.

The apostle of God was approaching with his sword drawn.

The countess and my brother would surely meet their end today.

Thud. Thud.

Evan's footsteps echoed in the silent garden.

Perhaps they noticed that the soldiers they had sent to the front had been annihilated.

This time, the knights who were guarding the count's mansion appeared and blocked Evan's way.

“You can’t go any further!”

“Sir Prince! What are you doing!”

The knights pointed their swords at Evan and me, and asked.

They looked confused because they saw me among the attackers.

There was no one on my side among them.

They were all knights who supported Max, the second son.

They were now pointing their swords at me, and I sighed.

“Sigh...”

“Sir Prince. It’s not too late. Surrender and beg for forgiveness from the count.”

“I don’t know anymore...”

“Sir Prince?”

I felt confused and frustrated, and I vented out my complaints.

Evan, who had dropped his sword, looked at the knights.

He looked at them one by one and said,

“Will you die with honor, or will you die namelessly?”

“You have no name to give to the intruder!”

“Then that will be your last words.”

A sword light flashed from Evan’s sword tip.

Swish, swish—!

When Evan's sword returned to its place after moving in the air several times,

There were no knights left standing on the ground.

Evan shook off the blood on his sword again and started walking forward.

He walked as if nothing had happened, and I gasped at his sight.

"This is the fourth floor, right?"

Creak.

Evan opened the door of the mansion and entered.

As Evan said, the place where Max's education was conducted was a small study on the fourth floor.

I nodded my head at Evan's question, and he stepped toward the stairs of the mansion.

There were also soldiers inside the mansion to stop the intruders, but they couldn't stop Evan and fell to the ground.

Evan kept cutting down those who blocked his way and went up.

His footsteps reached the fourth floor after staining his sword with the blood of countless people.

The number of people he had killed in the inner city had already exceeded two hundred.

"...This is the fourth floor."

Whish.

Evan reached the fourth floor and swung his sword to shake off the blood again.

Even while shaking off the blood, his eyes scanned the hallway of the fourth floor.

At the end of the hallway where his eyes reached,

There was a knight holding a sword.

He looked different from the knights he had faced so far.

I recognized his familiar face and grimaced.

“Sir Kedol is ahead.”

“Stop! Who are you!”

Kedol shouted in a loud voice as Evan approached the place where the study was.

Knight Kedol.

He was a confidant of Countess Meyer.

He was always a cunning man who prepared wicked schemes, but that didn't mean his skills were lacking.

He was a leading knight of his territory before he followed Countess Meyer.

But I didn't think Evan would lose to Kedol.

That was because Evan Allemier was a different being from others.

“Did you ask for my name?”

“I am Knight Kedol! If you have any honor, tell me your name!”

“Honor... That's an interesting word.”

“Do you have no honor to give your name?”

Snicker.

A chuckle escaped from Evan's mouth.

Evan pointed his sword, which still had blood on it, at Kedol.

And he told him his name.

"Evan Allemier."

"Allemier...? Don't tell me... The genius of Allemier family who was chosen as the next owner of the holy sword!"

Kedol seemed to recognize him as soon as he heard the name of Allemier family.

The genius of Allemier family.

It was a story I had never heard before.

It seemed that he was famous before he became my knight.

Why did such a person join the church?

I couldn't understand it.

Evan shook his head as he saw Kedol's reaction and answered,

"I threw away those trivial titles. I'm in a higher position than that now."

"What position is higher than the owner of the holy sword! Are you saying you're a hero or something?"

"No way. I can't be a hero. And I'm not a holy knight either."

He wasn't a hero. He wasn't a holy knight either.

He denied everything, and Kedol frowned.

“What do you mean you’re not a holy knight? Then what are you...”

“The faith that Crossbridge has now is rotten. What’s the point of believing in something that doesn’t listen to your prayers or answer your calls?”

“What are you talking about? You... don’t tell me...”

“I abandoned my faith in the goddess. And in exchange, I accepted a new faith.”

There was only one destination for those who abandoned their faith.

Even Rex, who knew Evan’s identity, couldn’t help but be surprised by his words.

A former holy knight who discarded his faith and sided with the evil god.

He couldn’t understand what had happened.

Kedol was also taken aback by his words, and he asked with a trembling voice.

“You abandoned the goddess and... accepted the evil god...”

Evil god.

Evan’s eyes flashed at that word.

He asked Kedol back with a cold voice.

“Evil god? What is evil?”

“...”

“Is it justice to lock up my faith in a slum?”

“You...”

“Is it justice to abandon the people who hope for salvation? Is it justice to sacrifice everything for the sake of one thing?”

“Evan Allemier. You... have fallen.”

Kedol drew his sword at Evan’s denial of the goddess.

Vroom—.

A blue flame of light flickered from his sword.

Aura.

The soul flame that was granted to the knights who had crossed many trials.

As Kedol’s sword was wrapped in aura, Evan’s sword was also wrapped in light.

Zap. Zap.

A blue lightning wrapped around Evan’s sword, and his sword turned into a thunder sword.

“At least the justice I know is not like that.”

“Then are you justice now?”

“No way. Justice and evil are nothing but arrogant standards of humans.”

The lightning that wrapped around his sword soon spread to his whole body.

Zap—!

As sparks flew out strongly, Evan’s eyes turned blue as well.

Evan, who had become a blue lightning, pointed his sword forward and said,

“Understand this. Who I am. And who I am representing here.”

A knight with a sword of aura.

An apostle with a blade of lightning.

Their eyes clashed in the air.

Kedol’s eyes sharpened as he faced the lightning, and Evan’s momentum also became sharper as he faced the aura.

When they were both fully ready to cut each other down,

Evan ran forward and said his name again.

“I am the second apostle, Evan Allemier.”

Evan Allemier.

The second apostle of the church raised his sword that was forged by faith.

As long as he had the title of apostle, he had only one role left for him.

“———The sword of the great one.”

Chapter 60: Divine Protocol (1)

< 60 : Divine Protocol (1) >

Dream.

In a deep dream, I was walking alone on an empty street.

I knew it was a dream, even though I was dreaming.

Lucid dream.

In this imperfect world, I understood who I was.

Thud. Thud.

Only the sound of my footsteps echoed clearly in the empty street.

Without any reason, I just repeated walking forward, and then I saw a human figure at the end of my sight.

“Hello?”

A black-haired girl with a black umbrella.

She was dressed in black as well, and her eyes looked at me.

The girl in black had eyes that were like a bottomless abyss.

The more I looked into them, the more I felt like I was being sucked into somewhere.

It didn't feel like meeting a person.

I stared blankly at the girl for a moment and opened my mouth to her.

“You are...”

“Wait. There is a condition for asking questions about each other.”

“A condition?”

I asked a question at the girl’s words.

The condition for asking a question.

The question I wanted to ask was nothing more than a simple self-introduction.

Even for asking just a name, there was a condition attached.

She was truly a difficult opponent.

Since it was just a dream anyway, I decided to listen to what she had to say without delving too deeply into it.

The girl nodded her head when she heard me and told me about her condition.

“You have to win a game against someone else before you can ask them a question.”

“A game? What kind of game?”

“Well, it could be a board game like chess, or something like poker or dice.”

“Do I really have to go through such trouble?”

I didn’t hate games, but I didn’t feel like playing them in my dream either.

Just to ask for someone’s name, I had to play a game first.

Why should I bother with such hassle to hear someone else's name?

But the girl was very stubborn.

She ignored my complaining attitude and continued to tell me about her condition.

"The rules have to be fair for everyone. Only the winner of the game can ask the other person a question."

"Are you saying you want to ask me something too?"

"Only if I win, of course."

She was nothing more than a stranger I met in my dream.

I could easily answer whatever she asked me.

It's not like my secrets would leak out even if I spilled them here.

It didn't matter much whether it was a trivial or a difficult topic.

Yet she insisted that she would only ask me after winning a game.

My subconscious must have created the girl in front of me, but she had a rather strange personality.

"Fine. If you want it that much, let's play a game."

I reluctantly accepted her proposal, seeing how eager she was for a game.

It wouldn't hurt to try and see who would win.

If I won the game, I could also hear an answer from the girl in front of me.

Not that it would be anything more than a cliché response from my subconscious.

When I agreed to play a game, the girl asked me what kind of game I wanted to play.

“What game do you want?”

“A game. What game should we play...”

“Any kind of game is fine.”

“Then let’s do poker.”

Maybe it was because it was a dream, but my head felt slightly fuzzy.

If I played a game like chess in this state, I might lose without putting up a fight.

That’s why I chose poker, which was a relatively intuitive game.

When I picked poker, the girl pointed at the floor with her finger and said,

“Now that you’ve chosen the game, you have to make it.”

“Make what?”

“The tools for playing the game.”

She unexpectedly asked me to make the tools for the game.

She must have thought that I could make them since it was my lucid dream.

After all, this is my dream. There’s no reason why I can’t do whatever I want.

I thought about how to make the tools for poker as the girl requested.

I wished for a table for poker to appear on the floor, and suddenly, an empty table materialized out of thin air.

I felt a strange sense of wonder as I saw the table that appeared in front of me in an instant.

“...This really works.”

“Do you need chairs too?”

“Chairs... Yeah. Let’s make some chairs.”

Making chairs was not much different from making a table.

As soon as I imagined the shape of a chair, a pair of chairs appeared around the table.

It was amazing that I could create anything I wanted just by thinking about it.

Every time I made something, I felt like I was an omnipotent god.

The girl quickly sat down on one of the chairs and put down her parasol.

I also sat down opposite her and created some cards in my hand.

“How are we going to play?”

Shuffle shuffle shuffle.

As I fiddled with the newly created cards, the girl asked me about the rules of the game.

There were many different types of poker.

The one that was most familiar to me was seven-card stud, where four cards were revealed.

It was the most common way of playing poker that I had experienced online and offline.

I also knew how to play Texas hold ’em to some extent.

I shuffled the cards in my hand and answered the girl's question.

"Let's play seven-card stud... No betting, just one round."

"You mean, we'll decide the winner with one game?"

"Yeah. This is not a situation where we can stay for long."

This is a dream. Sooner or later, I'll wake up.

There's nothing more frustrating than waking up from a dream before the game is over.

Besides, we only have one chip each.

That's why I suggested playing one round to determine the winner.

As soon as I finished shuffling the cards, the girl nodded and said.

"That sounds good to me."

"Is it okay if I deal the cards like this?"

"Sure."

I distributed the cards according to the rules of the seven-card stud.

There were only two people and no betting time, so the card distribution was done quickly.

After receiving all the cards, I checked my own cards without showing them to the girl.

Four cards were revealed.

If I combined them with the cards in my hand, I had a pair of tens.

"..."

A pair of tens.

To be honest, it was not a very good combination.

I looked at the girl's face over the cards in my hand.

Did she have a better combination?

She looked at me with a relaxed smile on her face.

I didn't feel much value in the pair of tens I had in my hand as I saw her expression.

'It looks like I'm going to lose.'

Judging by the cards that were revealed, the girl already had a pair.

If I showed my cards as they were, I had a high chance of losing.

I stared at the cards in my hand and started to think of a way to win.

There was no way to change the outcome with the conventional method.

So, naturally, the idea that came to my mind was an unfair one.

'In this dream, can't I change the cards as I please?'

I could make a table and chairs just by thinking about it.

Making the cards I wanted would be nothing.

With that thought, I tried to do it on the cards in my hand.

What I wanted was the strongest poker hand, a royal flush.

As soon as I wished for the best hand, the cards in my hand changed into what I wanted.

With the royal flush in my hand, I showed my cards on the table and said.

“I won.”

“It seems like you used some dirty tricks.”

“...”

As soon as I showed the royal flush, the girl showed her cards and said.

The girl had a full house.

If I had played the game normally, I would have definitely lost.

I couldn't help but feel a bit guilty at the girl's remark.

She saw through my cheating.

Maybe it was because this was a dream, and my subconscious was transmitted to her.

“This is the only time I'll let you get away with this.”

But the girl's complaint was all she said.

She didn't make a big deal out of my cheating.

She scattered her cards on the table.

And then she looked at me and asked.

“So, what was the question you wanted to ask so badly that you resorted to such a dishonest method?”

“Question?”

“You must have had a reason why you wanted to win.”

The question I wanted to ask her.

I stared blankly at her eyes and thought about it, and then I reached the first question that came to my mind.

There was only one question that I wanted to ask from the beginning.

Her name.

That simple name was what I had to go through this annoying game for.

I erased the cards on the table and asked her.

“What’s your name?”

“Name... That’s an important but simple question.”

“I made all these things just to ask you that.”

As I said that while erasing the table and cards, the girl covered her mouth and smiled slightly.

Thump.

The girl got off the chair and picked up her parasol again.

The black parasol cast a shadow over her head.

The girl’s jet-black eyes looked at me as she picked up her parasol.

“Okay. I’ll tell you.”

“...”

“My name is——.”

The faint voice of the girl in my ear.

Her name, which echoed clearly in my ear one letter at a time, ended.

I woke up from the dream.

“What a weird dream I had.”

After taking a shower and boiling some water for instant noodles, I grumbled as I looked at my smartphone with the game on.

The image of the girl I met in the dream flashed through my mind as I looked at the game screen.

A dream of playing poker with a stranger I met in a dream.

Even if I went to someone who could interpret dreams, they would only tell me some nonsense.

It was definitely a side effect of watching a video of card magic before going to bed.

I reflexively uttered her name as I recalled the memory of the girl.

“Estelle...”

The name of the girl that I could hear through the game.

It was probably just a mix of some memories from somewhere.

Anyway, we would never meet again.

It was a meaningless name in the end.

I put aside the story of Estelle and turned my attention back to the game screen.

“It’s nothing. I should just play the game and forget about it.”

The first thing I looked at on the game screen, of course, was the event message that was printed out last night.

Maybe it was because I had acquired quite a lot of karma in the meantime.

My player level had gone up by one without me noticing.

I checked the changes that occurred as my level went up by looking at the messages that popped up at the bottom of the screen.

The message box at the bottom of the screen was filled with messages related to leveling up.

You have reached level 9.

<Eye of Observation (Lv.8)> has grown.

<Eye of Observation (Lv.9)> has been achieved. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

The first thing I could check was the message about <Eye of Observation>.

The level of <Eye of Observation> skill had gone up again as my level increased.

The graphics had changed to a more crisp and vivid appearance than before.

If the previous graphics had a casual feel to them, the current graphics had a more realistic feel to them.

But still, the proportions of the characters were still somewhat distorted.

I checked the changes in <Eye of Observation> skill and mana amount and scrolled down further.

Warning: Excessively biased karma in one direction may trigger <Causality Adjustment>.

<Balance of Karma> has tilted.

A low-level <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

Causality Adjustment Progress: 7%

The adjustment progress was still at 7%, which was not much different from before.

I thought it would go up faster as time passed, but there was no drastic change yet.

At this pace, I felt like I could grow smoothly for a while.

“And... I got a new skill.”

As I scrolled down a bit more, there was also a message saying that I had acquired a new skill.

A new skill that I got without a skill book.

It had been a long time since I got a skill through leveling up.

It seemed that the benefits of leveling up were not limited to the total amount of mana.

I looked at the description of the new skill with anticipation.

You have acquired <Divine Response Device (Lv.1)>.

This skill only responds to characters with the <Fanatic> trait.

The skills activated through <Divine Response Device> will consume your mana.

<Divine Response Device> skill applies a 24-hour cooldown for each individual character.

The skills accessible by characters with the <Fanatic> trait vary depending on their divine contribution.

The name of the new skill was <Divine Response Device>.

Unlike the previous skills, this skill had a very complex description.

First of all, this <Divine Response Device> skill was not the type of skill that I could activate directly.

Characters with the <Fanatic> trait could use it individually according to their own will.

Of course, even if other characters used the skill, the cost would be paid with my mana.

In other words, it was a skill that was similar to a macro that automatically activated my skills depending on the situation.

“It seems like this skill allows the cultists to cast magic when they pray to me.”

Characters with the <Fanatic> trait could choose one of the shared skills and use it.

Of course, it was not a system that allowed them to spam skills without any restrictions.

They had to meet a certain level of value called divine contribution in order to use the skill.

Moreover, if the same character wanted to use <Divine Response Device> again, they had to wait for 24 hours after using the skill.

It was a skill that occasionally allowed them to use magic, not a skill that made all characters into apostles.

“I can also set the skills to share.”

As I scrolled down the description of <Divine Response Device>, there was a separate setting option there.

I looked down at the individual setting option of <Divine Response Device>.

There was a list of skills that I had along with buttons to set access permissions.

Skills available for sharing: <Lightning> / <Lightning Arrow> / <Barrier> / <Giga Lightning>

The skills that I had acquired through magic books were all displayed there.

Of course, special skills like <Apostle Selection> or <Eye of Observation> were not registered.

I had to acquire skills through magic books in order to register them in <Divine Response Device>.

Also, the minimum divine contribution required to grant access permission varied depending on the mana cost of each skill.

For the most costly skill, <Giga Lightning>, only Eutenia and Roan could meet the divine contribution requirement.

“Hmm...”

I looked at the required divine contribution and accumulated contribution of each cultist.

As I kept looking at the description of <Divine Response Device>, I naturally had one thought in my mind.

I don't have enough magic skills.

There are not many skills that I can share with the cultists.

As I looked at the skills on the list, a devilish temptation slowly rose in my heart.

“I feel like doing some more gacha.”

The thing that came periodically as I played the game.

It was none other than the urge to spend money.

Chapter 61: Divine Protocol (2)

< Chapter 61: Divine Protocol (2) >

I didn't need a great excuse to convince myself.

I was already half-way tempted by the devil's lure, waiting for the last word that would seal the deal.

In that state, I could rationalize and move on with my actions even with a lame and unsatisfying reason.

A quick compromise.

And a reasonable justification.

Humans would have been doomed long ago if they didn't have such a function.

It was also the influence of that function that made me quickly compromise on the new payment.

"Last time, I got 10 free spins as a payback... So if I spin again, it's like getting 30 spins for the price of 20, right?"

I dragged the excuse that I used to persuade myself last time all the way to today.

It was a pathetic excuse that anyone could see through.

It was nothing more than a pretext to spin the 10 times draw.

Yet, in my mind, it was enough to make it work.

In the end, I was just a helpless human in front of my spending urge.

“I guess there’s no special benefit after all.”

With half of my reason gone, I brought my finger to the <Paid Currency Shop> button.

Click.

As soon as the screen changed, the shop screen that allowed me to spin 10 times appeared.

The 10 times draw button shone brightly, along with the dazzlingly decorated shop screen.

The moment the shop screen appeared, all my spending plans flew out of my head.

In front of the new skill that could share characters and skills, my spending plans were nothing.

“Please... Let there be a magic book.”

I put my smartphone in front of me and clasped my hands together, praying fervently.

Please, let there be a magic book beyond the screen.

If possible, let there be 10 rare items.

With that desperate wish, I touched the draw button on my smartphone.

The screen flashed white and the draw items started to appear.

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

I looked at the first items that came out with a tense face.

Three [Rusty Iron Swords].

They were among the worst items that could come out as a failure.

It was a bad start.

I hoped for a magic book to appear and watched the next items.

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

The next items that popped up were also all [Rusty Iron Swords].

I couldn't help but frown at the ominous atmosphere.

I remembered the nightmare of getting 10 [Stylish Tunics] last time.

Sigh.

I exhaled and looked at the next item.

This time, I sincerely hoped for a magic book to appear.

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

The moment I saw another batch of [Rusty Iron Swords] pop up, my hand that was holding the screen started to tremble.

I also felt a strange sensation of nausea as I saw the continuous output of [Rusty Iron Swords].

“No way. No way, right? No way I’ll get failures again?”

The situation was becoming more and more like the nightmare of the past.

I swallowed and looked at the last item.

If the last item was also a [Rusty Iron Sword], then it would be a repeat of the previous nightmare.

Moreover, [Rusty Iron Sword] was an item that even the believers avoided because of its rust.

What would the last item be?

Thump. Thump.

With my heart pounding wildly, the light that revealed the last item burst out.

-You have acquired [Magic Book: Control Weather].

As the last item showed itself with a purple halo, I lifted my smartphone and smiled.

A magic book with a purple halo.

It meant that it was a much more valuable magic than the previous magic books.

As soon as the brightly shining magic book appeared, I erased the nine [Rusty Iron Swords] from my mind.

It was a magic of a different grade than the existing ones.

It didn’t matter what kind of items came out as failures anymore.

“Wow... A purple light came out of the magic book.”

I examined the [Magic Book: Control Weather] that had entered my inventory.

The skill I could acquire by using the magic book, <Control Weather>.

<Control Weather> was a magic that consumed a huge amount of mana to control the weather.

As the name suggested, it was a very different type of magic from the combat magic that I had encountered so far.

“Control Weather... It seems like magic with a high utility aspect.”

The place where I used <Control Weather> could be changed to the climate I wanted.

The duration of the magic that remained in the tile depended on the size and intensity of the area where I controlled the weather.

I could make it rain continuously in a tile where there was a drought.

I could make the scorching sun shine down on a place where there was a dense forest.

I could completely transform the environment of the area over time.

It seemed like it could be helpful for large-scale battles between characters, or for supporting the expansion of my faction.

“If I really wanted to combine it with offensive magic, it doesn’t seem impossible either.”

Maybe I could make it rain and then scatter lightning magic at the same time.

I didn’t know for sure because I hadn’t tried combining magic yet, but this game was faithful to the laws of physics.

There was a high possibility that it would have some effect if I tried it in reality.

It would be a wide-range diffusion of lightning magic on a wet area.

Besides, just being able to control the weather gave me a feeling of something divine.

Maybe Roan could go around and solve the drought himself.

“For now... I’ll have to give the magic book to Eutenia.”

The first magic book I acquired was always Eutenia’s.

Only after Eutenia learned the magic and made it her own, could I learn the magic myself.

Of course, if Eutenia wasn’t a character with talent for magic, I wouldn’t have supported her so much.

I took out the magic book from my inventory and brought it to Eutenia, who was traveling in a carriage.

Eutenia looked up at the sky as she saw the magic book fall on top of the carriage.

“You have bestowed upon me a new magic book. I thank you for your grace, O great one.”

As I watched Eutenia express her gratitude to the sky, I closed the game on my smartphone.

I planned to work on the details of <Divine Response Device> after I finished eating all the ramen.

Squeak.

I tore off the lid of the cup of ramen and lifted up the noodles with wooden chopsticks.

The steaming noodles had swollen up considerably by now.

“Now our influence has reached Rituania – Centrius as well.”

The tower room is located in the inner city.

There, Roan, the archbishop, looked down at the cityscape and spoke.

After Evan led his followers into the inner city, the battle there was over in no time.

The countess and Max Meyer were executed, and the inner city was occupied by our forces.

And Rex Meyer had a simple succession ceremony and became the next count.

There was resistance against Rex both inside and outside, but there was no successor to replace him in his family.

Now swearing loyalty to the emperor was the only hurdle left for Rex.

It was safe to say that we had taken over the entire county.

“All thanks to your plan, Archbishop Roan.”

“Except for the fact that it was reckless, wasn’t it a fun plan?”

“A fun plan... I don’t have that kind of taste, so I don’t know.”

Evan chuckled as he heard Roan’s words.

In retrospect, it was a reckless plan even by Roan’s own standards.

If Rex’s weak personality and Evan’s force hadn’t followed him, it would have been difficult.

It was also a great luck that the count had left his seat at that time.

It would have been a very tricky task to get rid of the count who stayed in the inner city with his soldiers.

“Anyway, it’s certain that we were blessed by our great one.”

“Certainly... It seems so.”

Everything went well without any major problems, so they could assume that their master had taken good care of them.

It wasn’t something anyone could do to overthrow an entire family with a few people.

Now all they had to do was expand their power based on this city they had acquired.

They had agreed to receive prisoners from the city continuously, so they didn’t have to worry about sacrifices either.

They had grown much larger than when they first created their cult.

Considering also recruiting new followers from this city, they could expect an unprecedented growth.

“Are you not pleased? The fact that more and more of our followers will fill this vast city.”

“...I’m quite pleased.”

“You’re still so curt, Apostle.”

“That’s how I’ve always been, so there’s nothing I can do about it.”

Roan smiled back at Evan’s attitude.

The apostle in front of him had done more than he had expected.

He was truly a worthy being of the name of God's apostle.

Moreover, unlike his blunt demeanor, he was also very devout.

The appearance of the unbeliever he had first met had long disappeared.

Now, he looked like someone he could trust with anything.

"By the way... Lately, I feel like I can sense His presence closer to me."

That's why Roan decided to confide in him the concern he had been thinking about recently.

A subtle sensation that had been tickling his chest since some time ago.

He felt like the grace of the great being he served was wrapping around him.

He felt like he and the great being were together, no matter where or when he was.

Evan, who heard Roan's words, replied with a look of disbelief.

"Can you feel His power closer to you?"

"Yes. Even without the dagger He gave me, I think I could ask for a miracle, at least a little."

Evan, who was connected to the heavenly god, pondered over Roan's words.

Roan understood why he was hesitating.

The apostles, including Evan, were connected to the great being through their divine instruments.

It was hard to imagine using miracles without their divine instruments.

"Are you really able to use it without a divine instrument?"

“Not often, but I think it wouldn’t be too hard once every two days.”

“It seems a bit different from the power of an apostle. Let’s see it for ourselves first.”

Evan decided to check it out for himself after hearing Roan’s words.

Roan nodded and stretched his hand toward the bottom of the tower.

He felt a warm energy rushing from his hand in the air.

It was a similar sensation to when he used magic with Ednos.

He sensed the energy gathered at his fingertips and began to pray to the sky.

“O great one. Judge your enemies with your brilliant light.”

As his prayer continued, the energy at Roan’s fingertips grew larger and larger.

The magic that was expanding reached its limit and he felt a tight sensation at his fingertips.

Roan released all the power he had been holding in his hand.

At the same time as the light that had been lingering at Roan’s fingertips burst out, a thunderous sound echoed from the sky.

Boom!

A sharp roar and a bolt of lightning fell toward the ground.

The lightning that Roan saw was not much different from the divine punishment he had seen before.

Evan, who saw the lightning that Roan dropped, opened his mouth.

“This is…”

He summoned lightning with nothing but his bare hands.

A miracle of God.

It was enough to call it that way.

It looked similar to the phenomenon of high-ranking priests in the holy land manifesting special miracles.

A strong faith created a connection with God.

The two men, Evan and Roan, were amazed by the majestic sight.

“How is it, apostle?”

“It looks similar to the miracles used in the holy land.”

“Is that so?”

“The method may be a bit different, but the result is similar, and that’s what matters.”

The former holy knight verified the miracle of God.

It was a situation where his strong faith had been rewarded once again.

Maybe not only Roan, but other believers could also use miracles.

An idea flashed through Roan’s mind as he saw the miracle he had created with his own hands.

“If this is the miracle He has bestowed upon us, wouldn’t it be an indicator of the believers’ faith?”

“An indicator?”

“The one who can produce a stronger miracle is the one who believes and dedicates himself to the great one.”

If there were others who could produce miracles besides Roan, he could judge their faith by the miracles they created.

Then he could assign ranks to them based on the miracles they performed.

He needed a proportionate number of administrators to maintain the growing church.

Those who could wield strong miracles would be trustworthy to entrust the church's important tasks.

Roan couldn't help but admire his own brilliant idea.

"Isn't it a reasonable way?"

"Strong faith brings forth strong miracles..."

"That's right. If another believer who can perform miracles appears, we give him more responsibility than others."

"I don't know if anyone else will show up, but it's a decent idea."

Evan, who leaned against the wall, agreed with Roan's idea.

If the believers could bring forth miracles, it would be possible to distribute roles like in the holy land.

The church would become a place that truly served and followed God.

He could reorganize the entire organization in a similar structure to the holy land.

Roan's eyes were filled with anticipation for the future as he thought of the countless possibilities of the miracle in his hand.

"We'll have to divide the ranks of the believers based on the miracles they can produce from now on."

Miracle.

It was the moment when a new concept of power given to the church's believers was established.

Chapter 62: Divine Protocol (3)

< 62 : Divine Protocol (3) >

“What is that device, and what is it used for?”

Peter, who was driving the carriage, asked Eutenia, who was sitting in the back seat.

Eutenia had Alpha on her lap, and in her hand was a blue jewel.

The blue jewel hanging from a string was emitting light and pointing in one direction.

It was clear that it had some special ability, but Peter had no idea what it was.

Eutenia answered Peter’s question with a gentle voice.

“It’s a device that can guide us to the location of the progenitor of the vampires.”

“The progenitor of the vampires...?”

The progenitor of the vampires.

Peter felt a chill run down his spine as he heard Eutenia’s words.

He had been startled when he met a real angel a while ago, but he was sure that the enemy was a terrible evil god.

I could tell by the way he was looking for the progenitor of the vampires, a name that struck fear into anyone who heard it.

There must have been some mistake when they sent down an angel.

Surely, the only beings that suited the evil god were vampires and demons.

That's what Peter thought as he asked Eutenia, who nodded and answered him.

"Our goal is to find the relic that is with the progenitor of the vampires."

"A relic? Are you telling me that you are using it to seal the progenitor of the vampires?"

"You know well, Peter."

Peter shuddered as he saw Eutenia confirm his words.

He didn't know what the relic was, but it seemed to be an important item that could seal a vampire.

And they were trying to get their hands on it and release the evil vampire from its seal.

That was a wicked idea that only a follower of the evil god would have.

Peter's grip on the reins tightened involuntarily.

He heard Eutenia's plan to do such a terrible thing and asked her why.

"Why... Why do you want to release the vampire from its seal?"

"Are you curious?"

"...Yes."

"Do you still want to know even if it might put you in danger?"

Eutenia asked as if she was hiding a dreadful secret.

But even if he didn't hear her secret, Peter's life was already on the edge every day.

Under his bandaged arm, there was a mark that showed he was chosen by the goddess of honor.

The day he revealed this mark, he would be killed by Eutenia or the holy knights of the temple.

So far, Evan hadn't said anything, so nothing had happened.

But he never knew when or why his secret would be exposed.

He didn't think he would be in much more danger by hearing one more secret from her.

"I'm always ready... for that kind of risk."

"Do you have some faith in me now, Peter?"

"..."

Peter's face hardened at Eutenia's question of faith.

He tried to force a smile, but his face didn't move easily.

Eutenia was the one who wiped out his village.

And she asked him if he believed in the evil god who sent her to his village.

Unless something changed his mind drastically, he would never sincerely follow the evil god.

Even though he ate food from the cult every day.

He wanted to refuse even the food, but he couldn't starve himself as a human being.

"Well, it's okay. Someday you'll understand the will of our great lord."

“...I guess so.”

“Did you ask me why I’m looking for the vampire?”

“Yes.”

“The reason is... that it will help our lord’s advent.”

“Advent...!”

Peter felt like he couldn’t breathe at the word advent.

Releasing the progenitor of the vampires from its seal was a problem, but saying that they would bring down the evil god was an even bigger problem.

They wanted to summon the god who watched over the earth from the sky.

That could cause more trouble than now.

Eutenia didn’t care about Peter’s attitude and stroked Alpha’s head with her free hand as she spoke.

“Peter, aren’t you curious? If the heavenly god comes down to earth, what do you think he will do?”

“That is...”

“Will he judge the unbelievers? Or... will he create a paradise for us?”

“...”

Peter couldn’t relate to the word paradise that Eutenia said.

Could he call it a paradise where the whole world bowed under the cult?

Would there be happiness in a place where the evil god ruled directly?

He didn't know much, but he could at least guess that it wouldn't be a happy world.

As Peter looked at the distant wilderness, Eutenia continued her story.

“Maybe he will grant us some simple wishes.”

“Wishes?”

“If he asks me for a wish, I would ask him to bring back Peter's villagers.”

Eutenia said she would make a wish if the god came down to earth.

A wish.

The wish that Eutenia said was completely different from what Peter expected.

It was about bringing back the villagers that she had taken away at their first meeting.

Peter asked Eutenia why she wanted such a wish.

“Why do you want... such a wish?”

“Because you worked hard for me.”

“What?”

“I don't care if the whole world disappears, but... Peter is not like that, right?”

She said she would ask for the souls that she had taken with her own hands, with her own mouth.

It was an absurd idea to anyone who saw it.

It was none other than Eutenia herself who took everything away from Peter.

Yet she spoke sincerely to him.

She said she would ask for her wish to return his loved ones when everything was over.

His words that were about to come out of his mouth got stuck in his throat at her words.

“I...”

“So I think if we dedicate the whole world to our great lord, he might spare us a village or so.”

“...I see.”

It was a selfish idea.

She took everything from herself, from others, from the world, and offered it to the evil god.

And the last wish she wanted to ask for was something for someone else.

Peter couldn't understand her.

“That's what I think. Oh, we have to go right here.”

Zing.

The crystal with light in it moved in another direction.

Eutenia looked at the direction where the crystal turned and told Peter who was driving the carriage.

Peter started to turn his horse around after hearing Eutenia's words.

From the dusty cobblestone road, Peter's low voice echoed.

“I understand.”

A complicated feeling rose in Peter's heart as he held the reins.

The ones he faced were always selfish.

The heavenly gods, and the apostles on the ground.

They were always self-centered beings.

The headquarters of the Order, located in the Centrius region.

Eliot, a layman of the Order, was praying there.

Since he joined the Order, he repeated the routine of visiting the chapel every day and offering prayers.

From the moment he first learned of the great being, Eliot decided to dedicate his body and mind to him.

The ruler of the sky and his powerful apostles who followed him.

Not to mention the growing influence of the Order's teachings.

There was nothing lacking to accept the existence of God.

Eliot, who understood the existence of a real God, became an enthusiastic believer of the Order.

Even the executives of the Order admired Eliot's daily faithful prayers.

“——We thank you for watching over us today, O great one.”

As always, Eliot opened his eyes after finishing his 30-minute prayer.

In his sight, he saw a picture hanging on the wall of the chapel.

A huge silhouette of a person drawn on a large canvas.

The picture did not have any hands, feet, or facial features, but everyone in this place knew who it was meant to represent.

A picture of a believer praising the great being who looked down on the ground.

They dared not draw the face of the great being, so they only depicted him with an outline.

Eliot wiped away the tears in his eyes and got up from his seat as he looked at the majestic silhouette.

“Ha... What would have happened to us if it weren’t for you...”

The image of Cloud’s raid flashed through Eliot’s mind.

The day when many investigators led by Agent Period raided the Order, it was their God who saved them.

The great being dropped a powerful lightning bolt like a divine punishment and annihilated their enemies.

Thanks to that, the surviving believers of the Order were living a safe life today.

Moreover, some of the believers were now spreading the teachings of the great being in a large city called Lithua-Centrius.

They could never be grateful enough for the grace of the great being.

“I will serve you and spread your will to the world.”

As he was about to get up from his seat, Eliot felt a warm light wrapping around his body.

A sensation that something transcendent was with him.

There was only one thought in Eliot’s mind as he felt the light of unknown origin wrapping around him.

The great being was watching over him.

The reason why the light wrapped around him right after his prayer ended was nothing else but that.

“This is...”

Eliot raised his trembling hand to the sky as he marveled at the light that wrapped around him.

A holy light sparkled in Eliot’s palm.

What kind of outcome this small sparkle could create.

Eliot could intuitively realize the outcome just by looking at the light.

He grabbed the light that wrapped around his hand.

And then he shot the light towards his eyes.

“_____!”

Bang!

A bolt of lightning struck in front of Eliot’s eyes with a loud noise.

A powerful lightning bolt flashed through the ceiling of the chapel.

The light that burst out in front of his eyes was no different from the vivid lightning he had seen before.

At that moment, Eliot was amazed by the miracle he had created with his own hands.

One of the executives of the Order who was with him in the chapel approached Eliot and said.

“You had a faithful belief, and you finally succeeded in manifesting a miracle.”

“A miracle...?”

Eliot looked at his palm as if he couldn't believe it.

He dropped lightning with his tiny palm.

He had never learned magic, nor did he have any tools to use magic.

It was Eliot who said that.

The executive of the Order said this to him.

The miracle that Eliot had caused.

It was a sight that could not be explained otherwise.

“Yes. A miracle.”

“Did I... create a miracle?”

“Your strong faith reached the great one. The great one gave you a strong power.”

Eliot's heart started to beat wildly as he heard the executive's words.

Eliot. He was recognized by the great being.

The heavenly being gave him the power to create miracles.

He, who was nothing but an ordinary human, was recognized by the great being.

It was undoubtedly the most monumental moment in Eliot's life.

“O great one...”

“You even pray to him at this moment, you have a truly admirable faith.”

“There is no greater honor for me than being recognized by the great one.”

The executive laughed out loud at Eliot's moved expression.

He looked like he understood everything.

Thud. Thud.

The executive walked a few more steps towards Eliot and put his hand on his shoulder.

And then he patted Eliot's shoulder and said.

“By the way, we can't leave someone as talented as you as a layman.”

“...Yes?”

Eliot opened his eyes wide and looked at him.

It was because of the ominous words that came out of the executive's mouth.

The face of the executive that Eliot looked up to was full of firm determination.

He looked at Eliot and continued his words.

“I have to personally suggest to the archbishop that he should use you well.”

“That, that is...”

“A person with a great faith needs a place that suits him, right?”

“James...!”

He would personally talk to the archbishop about Eliot.

In other words, he meant to place Eliot in an important position in the Order.

Eliot's eyes moistened again as he heard the executive's words.

He was directly recognized by the great being, and moreover, he heard that they would use him greatly.

For Eliot, today was the best day of his life.

“Hehe... It's not confirmed yet, so don't get your hopes up too much.”

He looked at Eliot with a kind smile.

Behind him, a faint halo was shining.

Chapter 63: Black Sky (1)

< 63 : Black Sky (1) >

Several days had passed since I handed over the skill book to Eutenia.

It was only a few days for me, but it must have been much longer for the characters in the game.

Did she finish deciphering all the magic books that I gave her?

After work, I logged into the game and checked the [Magic Book: Control Weather] in my inventory.

It seemed that Eutenia had been practicing her magic whenever she had time, while completing the quest that I gave her.

Eutenia showed me that she could learn any magic book that I gave her without any difficulty.

Considering that Roan couldn't achieve the same results even if he got the skill book, it was right to think that Eutenia was special.

“I made a great character.”

I felt satisfied as I looked at the [Magic Book: Control Weather] in my inventory.

How many people among the players of this game had a filial character like Eutenia?

Eutenia was a gem of talent that I barely found among countless characters.

It was a lucky chance that I got with an amazing probability.

I gave Eutenia a cake through the trade window as a reward for returning the magic books.

Maybe it was because it had been a long time since she had a cake.

Eutenia smiled happily and ate the whole cake that I gave her.

Of course, she didn't share a single piece with the horseman character in front of her.

“Thank you for your grace today.”

I watched Eutenia eating for a while, then I moved my eyes to the inventory and looked at the magic book.

The [Magic Book: Control Weather] in the inventory was emitting a purple glow unlike other magic books.

It was the same glow that I could see from rare items like [Magic Sword: Ednos].

I wondered how powerful the magic would be.

Click.

As I pressed the magic book in the inventory, a message popped up asking me if I wanted to learn the skill.

-Do you want to learn <Control Weather> skill?

-The magic book will disappear when you learn it.

-Yes / No

Of course, my only choice was ‘yes’.

As soon as I pressed the acquisition button, the magic book in my inventory disappeared and a new skill icon appeared at the bottom of the screen.

A skill icon with an intuitive design of a cloud and a sun.

I had successfully acquired the <Control Weather> skill by using the magic book.

-You have acquired <Control Weather (Lv.MAX)>.

You can now use the Control Weather magic by consuming mana.

Now that I had acquired a new skill, it was time to try it out for myself.

I moved the screen to create as much distance as possible from Eutenia.

If I used the magic recklessly, there was a possibility that Eutenia would also be affected by it.

Swoosh. Swish.

After switching the screen a few times, I saw a village with people.

Having discovered a new village, I immediately touched the skill icon of <Control Weather> to activate the skill.

“Do I have to choose the weather condition that I want to change first?”

As soon as I pressed the icon of <Control Weather>, six buttons appeared on the screen.

Clear. Cloudy. Rain. Heat. Storm. Eclipse.

These were the list of weather conditions that <Control Weather> supported.

I touched the ‘Storm’ button among the six buttons.

I thought that I could confirm the change of the tile more clearly than other weather conditions.

Thud.

As soon as I pressed the storm button, a target marker appeared to set the range of the skill.

“I can also adjust the skill range separately?”

The new target area had an additional marker that allowed me to adjust the range.

I touched the marker and tried to manipulate the range of the target area.

The skill’s range increased when I pulled the marker, and it decreased when I pushed it in.

Of course, there was no such thing as increasing the skill’s range without any penalty.

The estimated mana consumption that appeared at the top of the screen increased as I pulled the marker.

On the contrary, when I reduced the range, the estimated mana consumption decreased.

“There’s also a duration setting besides the range.”

There was also a button to set the duration on the upper right corner of the target area.

The minimum duration was one hour, and I could maintain the weather phenomenon for up to seven days at most.

I could see that the mana consumption decreased when I set the skill’s duration shorter.

It seemed that <Control Weather> was not a low-mana-consuming skill, so it would be difficult to abuse it even with my greatly increased mana amount.

When I reduced the size of the target area to a reasonable level and set the duration to one day, an estimated mana consumption of about 2% appeared.

This level was not too much of a burden for me to use the skill for testing purposes.

After finishing all the settings, I pressed the target area and activated the <Control Weather> skill.

-You used <Control Weather: Storm>.

-The effect of <Control Weather> will last for one day.

As soon as I used the skill, dark clouds began to gather around me.

It was not just raining, but maybe it was because I chose the storm option.

The trees within the range of the skill were shaking violently.

The dark clouds that gathered quickly did not take long to produce their result.

A few minutes after the clouds started to form, rain began to pour from the sky.

“Wow...”

Splash.

Thick raindrops were falling in the area where <Control Weather> was activated.

The weather around me changed according to the weather environment I had altered.

As the storm hit the village, I saw a piece of laundry hanging on a line fly away in the distance.

I felt a strange sense of wonder as I watched the rain pouring from the sky.

It was the most extensive and intuitive magic among all the spells I had used so far.

The sight of the weather changing at my fingertips was very interesting.

“It’s not bad, except for the high mana consumption.”

Maybe because it was a high-tier magic, it was not a low-mana-consuming spell.

But even considering that, it was undoubtedly a fun spell.

I could whimsically change the weather as I pleased when I used the skill.

“But I wonder... how far can I extend the range?”

After using the skill with a reduced range, I felt like trying to use it with the maximum range possible.

If I used most of my mana to cast <Control Weather>, how far could I change the weather?

It was a curiosity that anyone who played the game would have.

My eyes naturally went to the skill icon of <Control Weather>.

“I should check it out.”

It was only natural to experiment right away if I was curious.

I touched the <Control Weather> skill and pressed the ‘eclipse’ button to select the weather I wanted.

Then I moved the marker to expand the target area of the <Control Weather> magic as much as possible.

When I extended the target area to the limit of my mana, the target area grew to about 20% of the movable area.

It was undoubtedly a very large area, comparable to a village.

“I could probably extend it more if I reduce the duration.”

The current range was based on the default duration of three days.

If I reduced the duration of the skill from here, I might be able to expand the range proportionally.

I adjusted the duration setting of <Control Weather> and lowered the duration of the skill to one day.

As I reduced the duration of <Control Weather>, the estimated mana consumption decreased by a third.

If I moved the marker in this state, I would be able to widen the range of the skill more than before.

“Good. The range keeps increasing.”

I continued to move the skill marker and widened the scope of the skill.

It was a huge area, covering half of the movable range. The estimated mana consumption reached 89% of the maximum mana amount.

I had already used 2% of my mana to make it rain.

If I used up all my mana here, there was a high chance that the characters would not receive enough mana from me.

I stopped moving the skill marker when the estimated mana consumption reached 89%.

Then I touched the target area again and cast the <Control Weather> skill.

-You used <Control Weather: Eclipse>.

The effect of <Control Weather> will last for one day.

As I touched the target area, messages indicating that I used the skill appeared one after another.

At the same time, something strange started to happen on the whole screen.

Boom——.

The screen darkened and a loud noise echoed from somewhere.

I couldn't tell where the sound was coming from, but it was clear that something big was changing.

“What? The skill sound is... why is it so loud?”

Boom——!

The sound from the speaker kept getting louder.

The screen of my smartphone also kept getting darker.

Boom. Boom——.

The volume that kept increasing reached the point where it filled the whole room and more.

The moment the sound reached the output limit of the speaker.

A thick darkness descended on the entire screen.

* * * * *

The western part of the empire. The Ketterland region.

Van Krite, a special investigator of Cloud, looked ahead with a sharp gaze.

In front of him were black-robed dark mages who had fallen to the ground.

They had all been defeated by Van's swordsmanship.

The dark mages who lay in front of him were the low-ranking members of a secret organization called 'Abyss'.

Van had been dispatched here personally to investigate the traces of Abyss, which had started to move recently.

"Did you find any clues?"

The subordinate who was accompanying him asked Ban, who was looking serious and troubled.

Ban Krite was a fairly famous investigator within Cloud.

He had formidable power, brilliant strategy, and a handsome appearance to match.

There were countless investigators in Cloud who admired him.

The subordinate who was with Ban was also one of those who respected him.

He asked Ban this question because he trusted Ban's sharp insight.

"The altar is bothering me."

"The altar?"

The subordinate's gaze followed Ban's words to the altar nearby.

It was an altar of demon worship used by the Abyssal black mages.

The altar was covered with numerous geometric symbols.

The black mages had to offer sacrifices through such altars to gain power.

The subordinate knew about the existence of these altars from seeing them every time, but he didn't know much about the types of altars.

Ban added an explanation for the subordinate about the altar in front of them.

“Black mages accumulate karma by offering sacrifices to the beings of the abyss.”

“It's a well-known story that black mages offer beasts or humans as sacrifices.”

“But this altar is much bigger and more elaborate than the other altars we've seen before.”

It was bigger and more elaborate than the usual altars.

That was what made Ban's expression dark.

The symbols on the altar were not mere decorations, but had magical meanings.

The fact that the symbols on the altar were big and elaborate was something that Ban had to seriously consider.

“Elaborate means... it might be a more important altar.”

“It might be offered to a more extraordinary being than the usual demons.”

The altars that the black mages had were altars that required a considerable level of difficulty to make.

How amazing would a being have to be to use such a splendid altar?

As Ban was pondering, a name that he had read in an ancient document flashed through his mind.

The Necromancer King, Arcrosis.

The being that became the origin of all black mages, who summoned the most evil and dreadful demon.

Could such a being be summoned through this kind of altar?

Ban sighed and turned his back on the altar.

“Are you done with the investigation?”

Thud. Thud.

The sound of Ban’s footsteps echoed in the cave where the black mages were hiding.

As Ban was about to leave the hideout, the subordinate who was following him asked him.

The subordinate had some evidence collected from the hideout in his hand.

Ban nodded his head and answered the subordinate’s question.

“I have a bad feeling about this. I feel like this is different from the demons we’ve seen so far.”

“Maybe we’ll have to fight a much stronger demon than before.”

“That might be the case. We have a lot to report today.”

The higher the rank of the demon contracted by the black mage, the more sacrifices Cloud would have to make.

If the enemy was the legendary Necromancer King, there was a chance that Ban’s skills would not be enough to stop him.

He couldn’t let his guard down just because he had easily defeated his previous opponent. The next one might be much tougher.

As he was pondering the identity of the demon, Ban stepped out of the hideout.

He was faced with a completely different problem than what he had been worrying about.

“What is this... how can...”

“...”

Right in front of the hideout he had just left.

Where the sun had been shining just moments ago, there was now a black sun in the sky.

In the dark night sky, even the stars were barely visible.

A black sun. A gloomy sky.

And the dark world below it.

Ban’s eyes were trembling violently as he faced the black sky.

“What on earth is happening?”

Black Sun

What he saw before his eyes was a scene that defied human common sense.

Chapter 64: Black Sky (2)

< 64 : Black Sky (2) >

The tower in the inner city.

There, Rex was staring blankly at the city.

Even though he had become a count, he felt unreal about his position.

Next to Rex was Palios, the knight who had been protecting Rex for a long time.

When Evan left his post after completing his mission, Palios took his place.

Palios looked at Rex's back as he gazed at the city and asked.

“Did you really have to go that far?”

There was a hint of resentment in Palios's voice that reached Rex.

Palios's words made Rex's face uneasy.

Even after Rex became the Count of Meyer, Palios swore loyalty to him as promised.

But he seemed to dislike the process.

When Rex ascended to the countship, the Countess of Meyer and Max Meyer were executed.

Thanks to that, Rex was able to consolidate most of the power, but it was inevitable that some resistance would pop up.

“Do you resent me?”

“...I resent myself for not being able to protect the prince then, and the count now.”

“You know it couldn’t be helped.”

“But if you had spoken up... couldn’t you have spared them?”

“How can I leave them alone when Max’s faction is still intact?”

A deal with the devil.

That was a fitting name for this deal.

Rex was able to become a count thanks to the deal he made with the Cult of the Evil God.

And in return, the cult took over the entire inner city of the count’s territory.

The cult’s followers were watching Rex from every place in the inner city.

And in the underground of the count’s territory, a mysterious altar was being built.

“They call you a bishop, but have you become a full-fledged follower of the evil god?”

“It’s just a pretense.”

“Then...”

“They need an excuse to bind me.”

“Are you happy living as their puppet?”

Palios’s sharp question pierced Rex’s ears.

The term puppet was not wrong.

Rex's decisions required the approval of Roan, the archbishop, without fail.

And yet, he had become a count and was living a comfortable life without the threat of death.

Was he supposed to be dissatisfied with this life?

Rex gave a bitter smile at his own appearance, which had become a fat livestock.

“Palios, I want to tell you something...”

As Rex was about to say something to Palios.

Something strange started to happen around Rex.

Boom——.

A loud noise that tore his ears started to echo.

Rex quickly covered his ears as the noise that seemed to burst his eardrums rang out.

But the unidentified noise that echoed in his ears penetrated his hands and reached him.

“My lord! What is that...!”

“Ah...”

Palios, who also covered his ears, looked at Rex and shouted loudly.

But Palios's voice was buried by the huge noise and didn't reach him properly.

Boom——.

The noise didn't stop and continued to echo in the sky.

At the same time, the sun that rose in the sky also started to turn black.

The repeating noise.

And the darkness that began to descend.

At the same time, people's screams erupted from the entire inner city as the strange phenomenon occurred.

“What, what is this...!”

“Aa, aaaaah—!”

“Th, th, this is...”

Some people were running away to escape from the descending darkness.

Some people were covering their eyes to avoid seeing the dark sky.

Some people were crying and wailing to the sky with their ears plugged.

“Sn, sniff... save me!”

“The sun, the sun is turning black!”

Boom——.

Boom——.

The irregular noise that echoed under the screams gradually subsided.

As the sound diminished, Rex took his hands off his ears.

Palios also lowered his hands that covered his ears as the sound faded.

But despite that, the darkness that began to spread over the city continued to thicken.

The sun that turned black retracted the light that shone down on the ground.

Rex looked at the sky with a horrified expression as the light slowly disappeared.

“A black sun...”

A black sun rises under the black sky.

The moon and the stars lose their light completely, and the vast sky is filled with darkness.

A disaster that he had never seen before in his life.

The darkness that covered the world completely began to scatter a deep silence.

In the world that lost its light under the dark sky, Rex only felt the presence of Palios standing behind him.

“...My lord. Do you know anything about what is happening now?”

“A black sun. The symbol of the evil god.”

“The symbol of the evil god...?”

“I have a vague memory of reading it in a book once.”

The day when the sun loses its light.

And the day when the mad beasts lose their reason and go berserk.

A long time ago, he had read a book about the evil god.

The thick darkness that he saw before his eyes was a horrific scene that only the evil god could create.

A huge fear of the evil god rose in Rex’s chest as he looked at the sky.

“Palios.”

“...My lord.”

“Do you think we can fight against such a being, as humans?”

A world where nothing could be seen in the darkness.

Only the torches lit by the soldiers barely entered their sight.

There were not many emotions that a mere human could face in a world that had lost its light.

Fear and awe.

There was no room for fighting spirit in that place.

In the darkened view, Palios's voice echoed towards Rex.

“I think... it's impossible.”

The shadow of the evil god covered the whole city.

Those who saw the light could not see even in front of them, and those who spoke could only scream with their voices.

A world dominated by thick darkness.

The human world became abnormal.

The holy city, Crossbridge.

In the conference room located in the Holy Palace, the Holy Emperor looked around with a dark gaze.

The number of people for the meeting was less than usual.

It was a grand meeting where all the saintesses, elders, and knight commanders gathered, but for some reason, today there were two empty

seats.

The saintess of abundance, Serena Ederlant, who represented the Temple of Abundance, the most influential of all temples.

And the vice-knight commander, Lian Crost, who would be escorting her.

The two did not attend the meeting.

The Holy Emperor, Haifright II, who looked around the room, turned his eyes to the elders and opened his mouth.

“Where did the saintess of abundance go?”

“...”

The elders who received the Holy Emperor’s gaze avoided each other’s eyes and remained silent.

They didn’t want to be blamed for the missing saintess, especially when they already had enough headaches from the current situation.

The one who endured the Holy Emperor’s gaze and stepped forward was the knight commander, Revels Ederlant.

The black holy sword, Revels Ederlant.

He looked at the Holy Emperor with a stern face.

And he spoke on behalf of everyone about why the saintess of abundance had disappeared.

“I will explain that.”

“Sir Revels will explain? I see.”

“The saintess of abundance took one of the holy relics and left the holy city four days ago.”

“The saintess left the holy city by herself?”

“It seems that she tricked Sir Lian and secretly slipped out with the holy relic.”

Tsk tsk.

Some of the elders who heard Revels’s words clicked their tongues.

They couldn’t understand the attitude of the saintess who was absent in this emergency.

Most of them were trying to shift the blame to Revels.

The Holy Emperor asked Revels why she had left.

“The saintess did not request any escort, and sneaked out of the city?”

“Judging by the letter she left behind, it seems that she received a revelation about the hero and went to fetch him.”

“The hero of abundance...”

“Even so, Sir Lian is with her, so she will probably return to Crossbridge without any problems.”

One of the elders stood up from his seat at Revels’s words.

The identity of the elder who stood up was the first elder, Antonio.

Antonio rebuked Revels, who had brought up the matter of the saintess of abundance, and said.

“Sir Revels! Aren’t you too protective of the saintess just because she is your daughter? She took out a holy relic and left without permission, this is a serious crime!”

“...Elder Antonio. Bloodline is not very important in handling the affairs of the temple.”

“You may think so, but not everyone here does! Wasn’t it the holy knights who allowed her to take out the holy relic in the first place?”

Ignoring Revels’s attitude that denied his words, Antonio continued to press him.

“The holy relic was taken by Sir Lian for the purpose of strengthening the escort...”

“Isn’t the vice-knight commander also a member of the holy knights!”

“That is...”

“You will also have to take responsibility for this matter, Sir Revels!”

As the atmosphere in the meeting room heated up with Antonio’s rising voice.

A heavy thud echoed several times in the meeting room.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

The Holy Emperor, who was listening to the conversation, interrupted them by hitting the gavel.

The Holy Emperor’s sharp gaze swept over the knight commander and the elder once.

Antonio, who received the Holy Emperor’s fierce gaze, quietly stopped talking and sat down.

“Elder Antonio. Did I summon this meeting to ask for responsibility?”

“...I was too excited.”

“You should calm down and listen to the story.”

“I understand, Your Majesty.”

The Holy Emperor's gaze soon turned to Revels, who was across from him.

The knight commander, who received the Holy Emperor's eyes, had the same stern face as before.

The Holy Emperor spoke to him about the conclusion of the saintess's runaway incident.

"And Sir Revels. The punishment for the saintess of abundance will be discussed again when she returns."

"...I understand."

"Prepare a search party to find the saintess."

"Yes. Your Majesty."

"Then let's end the matter of the saintess of abundance here."

As the matter was settled, Revels also returned to his seat and sat down.

Only then did the Holy Emperor put down the gavel he was holding in the quiet atmosphere.

And he looked over the faces in the meeting room again.

One of the saintesses who should have attended the meeting was missing, but it was not a matter that could be postponed to the next time.

In the quiet atmosphere, the Holy Emperor spoke to the people who attended the meeting.

"It's finally quiet now. Then let's start the meeting."

"Yes."

"You all know this, but the black sun, the symbol of the evil god, has risen in the sky again."

“The black sun...”

The people in the meeting room became solemn as they heard the story of the black sun.

The black sun.

It was the symbol of the evil god that only showed itself when the evil god stretched out his beasts to the world.

Under the blackened sky, one could not see even an inch ahead without a torch, and even the crops did not ripen as they did not receive sunlight.

According to the old records, there was a time when the black sun stayed in the sky for as long as two months.

The black sun that devoured the sky was a big problem for the holy city.

“According to the results of looking through the eyes of the goddess, we estimate that the range of the black sun covers part of the empire, including the holy city.”

“What about the Hegros Kingdom?”

“As soon as you enter inside the border line, the black sun completely hides its appearance.”

The elders began to murmur from all sides as they heard about the black sun.

The dark sky that covered the holy city and part of the empire.

If this phenomenon lasts for months, the crops and fruits in the holy city will not ripen properly.

It could cause a huge food shortage in the whole holy city.

Especially if the black sun also rises in the southern grain belt of the empire, it would be difficult to get food support from the empire.

It was a matter that could lead to the starvation of many people in the holy city.

The opinions of the elders on this matter began to pile up from here and there.

“We need to find out how long the black sun will last.”

“What about wrapping the holy city with a holy barrier?”

“How can we solve the problem by covering only the holy city when the black sun covers the empire as well as the holy city?”

“If that doesn’t work, we can ask for food support from the Hegros Kingdom...”

A plan to create a holy barrier that covers the entire Crossbridge.

A plan to research the duration of the black sun.

And a plan to receive food support from the Hegros Kingdom across the border.

All kinds of measures came out in the conference room of the Holy Palace.

As the conversation leaned towards food support from another country.

Revels, who had been listening quietly, looked at the elders and opened his mouth.

“It’s difficult to get support from the Hegros Kingdom.”

“Sir Revels.”

“Even if we put aside the food situation of the Hegros Kingdom, there is the beast rampage phenomenon under the black sun.”

The phenomenon of beasts going berserk whenever an eclipse occurred.

The elders who attended this meeting also knew it well.

Revels's words also seemed to be expected, and the elder who brought up the food support answered.

“Can't the elites from the holy city take care of the food transportation?”

“It's hard to transport enough food to feed the whole holy city with that manpower.”

“What's the point of having the holy knights if they can't even do that?”

“The holy knights are the force for the defense of the holy city. We can't allocate all of them to the transport operation.”

As before, an argument began between the elder and the knight commander.

The elders and the knights, who were so hostile to each other that they were called enemies.

It was very common for a dispute to arise between the two organizations over the same issue.

The elder frowned at Revels, who brought up the defense of the holy city.

“You always talk about expanding the holy knights, but you haven't even secured enough power yet.”

“There is a limit to the size that can be maintained with the current budget of the holy knights. If we lose our core force, the defense capability of the holy city will decline.”

“Can't the elites from the Holy Land take care of the food transportation?”

“That's not enough to feed the entire Holy Land.”

“Then what's the point of having the Knight Order if they can't even do that properly?”

“The Knight Order is the main force for the defense of the Holy Land. We can’t assign all of our personnel to transport operations.”

As before, an argument started between the elder and the knight commander.

The elders and the Knight Order were not on good terms, to say the least.

It was very common for them to have disputes over the same issue.

The elder frowned as he saw Revelz bring up the topic of the defense of the Holy Land.

“You always talk about expanding the Knight Order, but you haven’t even secured enough manpower yet.”

“There is a limit to how much we can maintain with the current budget of the Knight Order. If we lose our core forces, the defense capability of the Holy Land will decline.”

Revelz shook his head as he brought up the budget of the Knight Order in response to the elder’s words.

The elder’s face grew redder as the conversation dragged on.

He had thick veins on his neck as he spoke to Revelz.

“Then how do you propose we solve this situation?”

“If we don’t find a way to deal with the Black Sun fundamentally, we will eventually suffer huge losses.”

“Do you know how to solve the Black Sun fundamentally, Revelz?”

“Isn’t that a problem that the theologians of the Holy Land should research?”

“If that was possible, why did The Great Famine come in the war 200 years ago?”

“It’s been 200 years since then. There are many elders who are from brilliant theologians, so there must be many good solutions.”

The Knight Order and the elders started to pass the buck to each other about the problem.

Whew.

Holy Emperor sighed as he watched the two people arguing in front of him.

He had seen this scene many times before, but he couldn’t help feeling uncomfortable seeing them fight even in an urgent situation.

They were races that could never be bound by one name if it weren’t for their faith in the goddess.

His deep voice echoed in the conference hall as he let out a sigh.

“Enough! Be quiet.”

“Yes, Holy emperor-nim.”

“Yes, I understand.”

As soon as they heard Holy Emperor’s voice, the elder and the knight commander who were quarreling closed their mouths.

Holy Emperor’s gaze turned to the knight commander who was nearby.

He had stepped forward to settle this matter himself.

He gave a new order to the knight commander Revelz, who faced him.

“Lord Revelz.”

“Yes.”

“Make sure you prepare the troops to transport the food.”

“But, for the defense of the holy land...”

“That’s an order.”

“...Yes. I understand.”

The emperor’s gaze turned to the elder.

The elder who had been arguing with Rebels was a scholar who had gained fame before becoming an elder.

He looked at the emperor with an anxious expression.

The emperor gave him an order as well.

“Also, gather the theologians of the holy land and conduct research to solve the problem of the black sun.”

“...Your Majesty.”

“This is also an order.”

“Ah, I understand.”

“Elder Antonio, you need to prepare an envoy to send to the Hegris Kingdom.”

“I understand. Your Majesty.”

The noisy meeting came to a halt with the emperor’s words.

The emperor, who had organized the situation, looked at the elders with a serious face.

There was a mountain of work to be done, as he had convened the meeting for an urgent purpose.

They could not afford to waste time arguing over the same thing.

The emperor's stern voice echoed in the meeting room again.

“This is a serious matter, so I will consider any plausible suggestions even after the meeting is over.”

“Yes.”

“Then, for now... let's deal with the next agenda item.”

Under the rising black sun.

The meeting at the imperial palace continued without a pause.

Chapter 65: Black Sky (3)

Chapter 65 : Black Sky (3)

-You used <Control Weather: Solar Eclipse>.

-The effect of <Control Weather> will last for one day.

After using the <Control Weather> skill, I faced a simple but annoying problem.

The problem was that I couldn't properly identify the game screen.

In the darkened screen, except for the skill icons on the map, most of the objects were not displayed normally.

Only faint outlines were floating on the black screen.

"I can't... see the screen."

As a result of using the solar eclipse effect over a wide area, I faced a situation where I couldn't even see the map properly.

It was an unexpected situation for me.

Even if I used the solar eclipse effect, shouldn't the player be able to see the screen normally? That's how a normal game should be.

But this crazy game didn't output a proper screen.

I was harmed by the effect of the skill I used.

"No, even so, logically... shouldn't the skill I used not hinder me?"

I couldn't proceed with the game properly in this state.

It was ridiculous that the game was blocked by using one skill.

And once the skill was activated, it was impossible to cancel it before the duration expired.

All I could do was wait until this skill ended.

I looked at the black screen with a frustrated feeling and muttered.

“This is really a legendary game.”

If I had enough magic power, I would have used <Control Weather> again, but now I had to wait until time passed because my magic power was low.

It took enough time for my magic power to fully recover.

Realizing that there was no way out, I calculated the remaining duration of the skill in my head.

Using the time difference between reality and game, I tried to estimate how long I had to wait.

“It lasts for one day in game time... so maybe it will be solved in less than half a day.”

The time display in the game's guide message is mostly based on the time in the game.

And there was some time difference between the game and reality.

My personal feeling was that there was a flow difference of two to three times.

Since I set the duration of <Control Weather> to one day, it was likely that the skill would be released when I woke up after sleeping.

Thud.

I turned off the screen of my smartphone and lay down completely on the bed with it in my hand.

I stretched out my arms and legs and a yawn came out of my mouth.

“Yawn...”

I gave up playing the game and lay down on the bed, looking at the TV.

The news that I had turned on as soon as I entered the house was coming out of the TV that was turned on.

I turned it on to fill up some sound in the house.

I watched the world news on TV with sleepy eyes.

It was quite a long time since I saw world news.

-“South Africa has declared a state of emergency and closed its borders.”

-“Experts say this situation is...”

The news showed an announcer talking about world affairs.

It seemed that something went wrong on the other side of the world.

There are many countries on Earth.

And not all of those countries can be peaceful at the same time. It's inevitable that some countries will have problems.

“I get sleepy again when I watch that.”

As I watched world news leaning over, my eyes began to close slowly.

Drowsiness spread throughout my body lying on the bed.

The announcer's voice sounded like a lullaby in my ears.

I couldn't play games with my smartphone anymore, and today's schedule was over long ago.

There was no reason to keep my eyes open in this situation.

I closed my eyes completely without resisting the sleepiness that came over me.

"I just have to sleep..."

Squeak. Squeak.

The announcer's voice and my breathing mixed in my ears.

The sound that rang regularly added a little more peace to my mind.

My consciousness gradually faded away, and my eyelids became heavier and heavier.

At that moment when my consciousness went completely dark,

I fell asleep.

-“And... other countries...”

-“And...”

-*Zzz. Zzzz.*

The branch of the Order located in the southwest of the continent.

There, Estasia stared blankly at the sky with dull eyes.

It was usually a time when the sun would be high in mid-sky, but today it showed a different appearance than usual.

The sky turned dark as a black sun rose up.

This strange sight was not unfamiliar to Estasia, who was a Cherubim.

A solar eclipse artificially created by using magic.

It was a phenomenon that only the gods of the other world could intentionally reproduce on the ground.

“Hmm...”

Estasia turned on the fire of her halo and wondered about the black sun in the sky.

The solar eclipse in front of her eyes was deliberately caused by the master who sent her down.

Then why did he make a black sun?

Estasia came to a conclusion in her head after thinking for a while.

He got angry while observing the ground.

That was the cause of this solar eclipse that Estasia thought of.

Suddenly, she remembered how she had been rolling around in her room all day yesterday.

At the same time, she recalled what the Apostle Eutenia had warned Estasia a while ago.

If you don't watch people every day, the great one might punish you.

It seemed that Estasia's laziness yesterday had angered the god who was watching her.

“Ugh...”

Estasia groaned and stepped back as she came to a conclusion in her head.

It was because of the result she reached while thinking about why her master was angry.

She remembered how she had been lying around in her room all day yesterday.

She had no choice but to do her job as a watcher.

“Today... might be a bit busy.”

Estasia wiped her cold sweat as she faced the ominous situation.

She increased the output of her halo.

A bright light spread out and a glowing aura rose around Estasia.

Estasia, wrapped in a cluster of light, shone brilliantly even in the darkness.

The people near her cheered as they saw her spreading her wings and lighting up her halo.

Estasia’s appearance was like a beacon for them in the dark, as she was the only one shining in the black sun eclipse.

“An, angel...!”

“I can see the way now!”

“Sniff... I can see better when I’m near the angel...”

People who saw Estasia’s light started to approach her one by one.

For them, who had lost their light, Estasia was the only source of hope and salvation.

Among those who came to Estasia, there was also the bishop of the church.

The bishop came close to Estasia with a fearful face and asked her about the situation.

“Angel! Do, do you know what this phenomenon is?”

“It’s an eclipse caused by the black sun.”

“The black sun...”

“It seems like the Great One is angry.”

The Great One was angry.

The believers who heard that sighed in unison.

It was a shocking news for them, as if the sky had fallen.

They started to voice their thoughts in the serious situation.

“The Great One is angry...!”

“We’re in big trouble now...”

“How can this be? Angel! Why did you say that the Great One is angry!”

People’s eyes were fixed on Estasia, who explained the situation.

Estasia turned her eyes away with an awkward expression, feeling their gaze.

She thought that she was responsible for this situation.

But she couldn’t say that in front of the believers.

She had to maintain her dignity as an angel, after all.

“Well, you see...”

“I’m sure it must be hard for you, angel, who received the wrath of the Great One directly.”

“Yeah...”

“But thanks to your intervention, we didn’t receive any punishment, right?”

“Maybe... so...?”

Estasia couldn’t completely deny what the bishop said.

She didn’t have the courage to face the believers who blamed her.

Estasia gave a vague answer, and the bishop nodded his head with a moved expression.

He shed tears and expressed his gratitude to her.

“Thank you! Angel! You calmed down the wrath of the Great One for us!”

“Uh, yeah.”

“We should pray to the Great One right away. Let’s gather the lost believers and go to the chapel.”

“Okay.”

The bishop’s conclusion was one thing.

They had to pray together and appease the anger of heaven as soon as possible.

That was the only reasonable solution that they could think of.

Estasia also thought that it was the most reasonable way.

She hoped that if they kept praying, the Great One would calm down.

“Everyone! Let’s go to the chapel!”

“Yes! Bishop!”

“We have to offer our prayers of repentance to the Great One and calm his anger!”

It was Estasia's duty to lead the believers to the chapel.

She was the only one who shone in this darkness.

If they were not near Estasia, they would have trouble seeing ahead.

Only Estasia could be their guide in this darkness.

Estasia reluctantly searched for each believer and headed to the chapel.

It was a tremendous hardship and ordeal for Estasia, who never went up more than two floors even on normal days.

When Estasia found the last remaining believer and returned to the chapel,

She saw everyone praying in their seats except for hers.

“Angel!”

“Ugh... I'm tired.”

“We prepared a seat for you, angel.”

“I see...”

The bishop personally guided Estasia to a splendid seat with jewels on it as she approached him.

Estasia sat down on her seat with her tired legs from going up and down the stairs.

She couldn't avoid praying in this situation, no matter how hard it was.

Estasia sat down on her seat and started to pray.

Flutter.

Estasia's wings moved and her halo became brighter by one level.

Estasia clasped her hands politely and started to pray to God.

“Oh... Great One who is always with us...”

Estasia closed her eyes and prayed. Her eyebrows twitched slightly.

She hoped that this darkness that covered the sky would disappear as soon as possible.

If this situation continued, there was a possibility that they would point at Estasia as the culprit.

If that happened, she wouldn't be able to drink cool strawberry juice properly for a few days.

Her hands trembled as she prayed.

“P-please... give us the light... for us...”

Was it because the sky turned black?

The believers, who had only Estasia shining in front of them in the darkness, never left her side even when it was time to eat.

Estasia was freed from her overnight work of praying when the next day came and the sun rose.

Chapter 66: Black Sky (4)

< 66 : Black Sky (4) >

Crossbridge, Imperial Palace.

The Holy Emperor, Haifright II looked around the conference room with tired eyes.

The black sun that had caused everyone to worry had disappeared in just one day.

But contrary to that, the atmosphere in the conference room was even more gloomy.

The elders who had been arguing loudly until yesterday were all silent.

Even the knight commander who had been actively advocating for military expansion was now avoiding eye contact.

This was all because of the single reason that the black sun had vanished overnight.

The emperor sighed and opened his mouth as he looked at the attendees of the conference.

“The black sun has hidden its presence.”

“...”

“...”

The urgent problem had fortunately ended without any trouble.

Even though the emperor declared the end of the crisis, no one reacted to his words.

They all bowed their heads and remained silent.

In the silence that filled the conference room, the emperor frowned.

He looked at Antonio, who was sitting closest to him, and spoke.

“Elder Antonio.”

“...”

“The black sun is gone.”

“...”

The first elder’s face darkened as he heard the emperor’s words.

He kept twitching his eyebrows and lips, trying to suppress some reaction.

The emperor knew well why the elder was showing such a look.

The argument from yesterday was clearly in Antonio’s mind.

If not, there was no reason for the first elder, who liked to talk, to keep his mouth shut like this.

The emperor’s gaze moved to the fifth elder next to him.

The fifth elder was the one who had been decided to study the black sun by the emperor’s order.

“——The black sun.”

“...”

“The black sun has disappeared.”

“...Yes.”

The fifth elder also quietly spoke in response to the emperor’s gaze.

The corner of his mouth kept moving up and down as he answered the emperor.

He seemed to have something to say, but he couldn’t say it out loud.

The emperor sighed again as he saw the cowering elder.

He shook his head in disappointment and gave an order to the fifth elder he was facing.

“We don’t know when the black sun will rise again in the sky.”

“Yes.”

“Make sure that the theologians do not slack off in their research on the black sun.”

“...Yes. I understand.”

As the emperor’s gaze passed by the elder, he finally calmed down his mouth.

The aftermath of the argument that had become a vain effort was quite big.

The emperor moved on from the fifth elder and looked at the knight commander on the other side.

Knight Commander, Revelz Ederant.

A holy knight chosen by the black holy sword, and a nobleman from one of the empire’s prestigious families, Revelz was not much different from them.

Revelz flinched as he received the emperor’s gaze, just like the other elders.

“Lord Revelz.”

“...”

“Lord Revelz?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

Revelz answered his call as the emperor called his name again, closing his eyes tightly.

He had lost his usual confidence, and only a weak look remained on him.

The emperor chuckled at Revelz’ appearance.

It was not a common sight to see such a great knight commander show a frail look.

The emperor did not forget to ask him a question as well.

“The black sun has disappeared.”

“...Yes.”

“What do you think, Lord Revelz?”

“...I think it’s fortunate that we can move on without any major problems. It seems that this black sun was just a simple warning.”

“You think so.”

The black sun.

The greatest curse that the evil god could cast had vanished overnight.

It also meant that a full-scale invasion had not yet taken place.

Somewhere in the continent, the forces of the evil god were still preparing for war.

It was not something to be overlooked just because the black sun had disappeared.

Revelz added his opinion with a bitter look in his eyes.

“But we should not be complacent. We don’t know when the black sun will rise again.”

“Lord Revelz is right.”

“...”

“Lord Revelz. How is the task that I entrusted to you yesterday?”

This time, it was the king who asked him about the agenda that was discussed at the meeting.

The task that the king had entrusted to him yesterday.

It was to prepare the escort troops for the food transport team that would be sent to the Hegros Kingdom.

Of course, the situation had not progressed enough yet.

Revelz’ face became even more embarrassed by the king’s inquiry.

He spoke with a dark expression to the king.

“...I am still preparing the formation.”

“I hope you learned a lot from this incident.”

“Yes.”

“Next time, make sure you have enough troops ready to deploy at any time.”

“As you command... I will comply.”

As the king's gaze was withdrawn, Revelz also quietly sat down in his seat.

Was it because everyone who had been talking to the king closed their mouths?

A thick silence fell over the meeting room again.

The noisy meeting room seemed like a momentary illusion.

In the silence, the king's eyes looked over the faces of Crossbridge.

Despite his old age, his eyes still showed a strong light.

The king looked at the members of the meeting who were in charge of the six temples and said.

"I could not hide my deep disappointment in Crossbridge for what happened yesterday."

"...We are ashamed."

"No, it's not just yesterday. We still haven't found half of the hero, and no one predicted it until the black sun rose."

"..."

Bang!

The king's fist hit the gavel and the wooden board, and the wooden board that was hit by his fist shattered.

Everyone looked at him with a surprised expression as he broke the wooden board in an instant.

Despite breaking the wooden board whole, there was not a single wound on his hand.

The king, who had gathered everyone's attention, became stern.

He swept away all the fragments on the desk and warned the priests in the meeting room.

“Do you all plan to prepare for the evil god only after you die?”

“...”

“The great six gods do not help those who cannot even take care of their own affairs.”

He recited a verse from the scripture and rebuked them.

Even the elders who would have spoken out against him at any other time could not say anything to Haifright II at this moment.

The king moved his eyes to his hand in his boiling emotions.

He had said everything he had to say, and now he had to do what he had to do.

“I will end the discussion about the black sun here. The next agenda is about subjugating Cuebaerg.”

The lord of the abyss, Cuebaerg.

Subjugating the servant of the evil god who was devouring the empire was the next agenda of the royal court meeting.

“It seems to be somewhere around here.”

Somewhere in Ketterunt province, located in the west of the empire.

Eutenia, who had a holy relic in her hand, said that.

The gem in Eutenia’s hand emitted a red light and stayed still.

It was a reaction that only appeared when there was a holy relic nearby.

It also meant that there was a holy relic somewhere near Eutenia.

Peter, who heard her voice, looked around.

“Do you mean that guy who is called the ancestor of vampires is around here?”

“Probably. I’m glad we made up for the time we wasted yesterday.”

Peter nodded quietly at Eutenia’s words.

As Eutenia said, they had to stay in one place for a whole day yesterday.

The whole sky was covered with darkness and they could not move normally.

No matter how Eutenia could create light with magic, it was dangerous to drive a carriage with a small light in the darkness.

Besides, she could not use magic while using Natalia’s compass.

It was meaningless even if she created light and moved around.

In the end, they had to stop in one place and light a fire and wait for the darkness to go away.

“I thought something big was going to happen yesterday.”

“I can’t presume to know his thoughts... but maybe he was testing us on earth.”

“Testing us on earth...?”

“It’s just my guess.”

Eutenia said as she put Alpha on her shoulder while holding a book.

She stopped talking because she thought it was disrespectful.

Peter also felt awe when he faced the black sun yesterday.

He did not say anything about her master while following Eutenia from behind.

“Whatever the reason... I hope we don’t see such a sight again.”

He looked scared whenever he looked at the sky.

He seemed too young to serve her master, but maybe someday he would bow under his greatness.

Eutenia smiled with satisfaction and urged her steps forward.

As Eutenia, who had Natalia’s compass in her hand, continued to move forward, the gem in her hand began to show a change at some point.

“The signal is getting stronger.”

Woo woo woo.

The gem that emitted a red light trembled more strongly than before.

It meant that they were much closer to the holy relic than before.

If they moved in the direction they were moving, they could meet the holy relic.

Eutenia moved forward with anticipation.

Peter, who followed her, also spoke with a hopeful face.

“We’ll meet the vampire soon.”

“If this direction is correct... No, I’m not sure.”

“...What?”

Eutenia, who was walking along the compass of Etalia, denied his words with a suppressed laugh.

Peter looked puzzled by Eutenia's sudden change of attitude.

But Eutenia looked at the compass and the surrounding terrain with a serious face.

She thought there was something wrong with the direction that the holy relic was pointing.

“We’re getting farther away from the mountain. It seems like the holy relic is in the middle of the road.”

“In the middle of the road? You don’t mean...”

The compass of Etalia was moving away from the mountain.

There was only one thing that this fact indicated.

The possibility that the holy relic was not in a specific place was high.

Considering the characteristics of the holy relic that Eutenia had heard, the compass of Etalia was detecting another holy relic now.

There was an unidentified holy relic nearby.

Eutenia showed a sign of caution on her face as she realized that.

“It’s more likely that it’s on someone than in a place.”

“You mean there are people who have a holy relic?”

“Maybe those people over there?”

In the middle of a rough road that was not well maintained.

There were people who were approaching Eutenia and Peter.

Two people wearing thick cloaks.

One was a man who looked like a knight with a sword and a strong face.

And the other was a girl who hid her face with a hood next to the man.

Even though she hid her face, there was an inexplicable dignity from the girl.

“Isn’t this cloak too hot?”

“There’s cooling magic on it.”

“Still, it’s hot. Isn’t your cloak cooler than mine, Rian?”

The distance that gradually narrowed.

The distance that narrowed enough to have a conversation with each other.

The girl who was talking to the man who accompanied her turned her head to the front.

Eutenia and the girl’s eyes met in midair.

“Instead of being fussy, you should walk a little more for your health... Miss?”

“That gem... could it be... a holy relic...?”

Over the shoulder of the man wrapped in a cloak.

The girl saw Eutenia’s hand holding Etalia’s compass and muttered.

Chapter 67: The White Knight (1)

< 67 : The White Knight (1) >

Serena Ederlant, the Saintess of Abundance.

She spotted the people coming from the opposite direction while she was traveling with Lian to find the hero.

A girl who looked like a noble.

And a young man with a naive expression who followed behind her.

At a glance, they looked like a lady who was traveling with her attendant.

They didn't seem much different from Serena herself, who was accompanied by Lian.

Serena's eyes alternated between the girl and the young man, and then naturally landed on the girl's belongings.

"You should walk a little more for your health instead of being fussy..."

"Huh...?"

As Serena was listening to Lian's words, a large book entered her sight.

It was an elegant-looking book wrapped in an antique cover.

It looked quite expensive even from the outside.

The girl held the book in one hand, and in the other hand, there was a gem that glowed and vibrated red.

The gem's appearance was strangely familiar to Serena.

A book that she had read in the temple flashed through Serena's mind.

Dictionary of Divine Relics.

It was a dictionary written by one of the heroes who fought in the war long ago.

It recorded the characteristics of the Divine relics that existed during the war.

It was a treasure of the temple.

"Miss...?"

"Is that gem... a Divine relic...?"

The identity of the gem naturally slipped out of Serena's mouth as she recalled its name.

The gem in front of Serena's eyes was undoubtedly a Divine relic.

And if she thought about the effect that the Divine relic had, the situation where the gem was glowing in front of her was quite troublesome.

The attention of the surroundings quickly focused on Serena, who unknowingly revealed the identity of the gem.

The girl who held the gem heard Serena's words and her eyes sparkled.

Lian, who was next to Serena, exclaimed with a bewildered expression.

"Did you say that's a Divine relic?"

"Yes."

According to Serena's memory, that thing was definitely a Divine relic.

The name of the Divine relic was Etalia's Compass.

The Divine relic called compass had a function that suited its name: it specialized in finding other Divine relics.

It guided the user to where the Divine relic they had in mind was located.

It had some tricky conditions to use, but it also had a powerful performance.

"Etalia's Compass. A Divine relic that finds Divine relics."

And more importantly, it meant that these people were using Etalia's Compass to find Divine relics.

They were collecting Divine relics without the permission of the temple, which managed the Divine relics.

Serena had no memory of any reports about Etalia's Compass coming up in Crossbridge.

They were illegally possessing Divine relics without the approval of the temple within the empire.

"You seem to know a lot about Divine relics."

Serena faced the girl who raised the vibrating gem and spoke.

Etalia's Compass was discovering a nearby Divine relic and emitting a strong light.

Serena had brought a Divine relic for safety in case of an emergency.

The gem in front of her was reacting to the Divine relic that Serena had and kept vibrating.

She had been caught possessing a Divine relic, and she had already talked about their Divine relic as well.

It was impossible to completely deny that she knew about Divine relics.

Serena reluctantly answered the girl's question.

“Well... I studied a lot.”

“Is that so?”

“Then what about you? Why are you looking for Divine relics?”

Serena tried to dodge the question and asked back at the girl.

The girl tilted her head as she heard Serena's question.

She didn't understand why Serena was curious about that.

The girl looked at Serena and then at the gem in her hand and said,

“Why do you care?”

“Possessing Divine relics without permission from the Six Temples is illegal within the empire.”

“You sound like someone who works for the temple.”

“Ugh...”

Did she talk too stiffly?

The girl questioned Serena's identity as she suspected her to be someone from the temple.

Serena's face darkened under her hood.

She wasn't very good at disguising or infiltrating.

She had relied on Lian's help several times when dealing with other people and hiding her identity.

Even this conversation gave room for speculation because of Serena's mistake.

As Serena struggled to come up with an answer, Lian stepped forward to intervene.

Flap.

His cloak fluttered as he moved forward.

Lian blocked between Serena and the girl, and took out a ring with a seal engraved on it from his pocket.

It was a ring given to inquisitors who were sent out by Crossbridge.

Lian showed them the ring and joined their conversation.

“It seems like we need to reveal our identity. We are inquisitors belonging to Crossbridge.”

“Inquisitors?”

“Yes. By the imperial decree of His Majesty the Emperor, it is forbidden to possess Divine relics without the approval of the temple.”

“Is that so?”

“If you are using Divine relics legally, it would be better to show us the permit issued by the temple.”

It was a moment when the inquisitor’s seal that he had brought for emergencies showed its usefulness.

They had revealed that they were from the temple, but it was hard to guess Serena’s identity from that alone.

It was a second-best choice to avoid the worst.

Serena breathed a sigh of relief in her heart at Lian’s attitude, who stepped forward to replace her.

She believed that Lian would handle everything as long as it was not too serious.

As Lian, who introduced himself as a heretic inquisitor, demanded a permit from the group in front of him, the girl smiled and clenched the jewel.

“You are the ones who worship a false god, aren’t you?”

“False... god...?”

“A false god? Don’t tell me you...”

At the unexpected story, Lian and Serena’s voices burst out at the same time.

A false god.

The girl in front of them was denying the six gods of Crossbridge.

There was only one force on the continent that could deny the six temples.

The cult of heretics who served the evil god.

They were the only ones who denied the six gods.

Swoosh.

Lian drew his holy sword from his waist as the situation turned ominous.

“A false god, isn’t that right?”

“Are you... a follower of the evil god...!”

“There is only one who can be called a true god, and he is always glorious.”

The people in front of them were undoubtedly followers of the evil god.

They thought they were just treasure hunters looking for holy relics, but it was a more serious situation than that.

Lian gritted his teeth as he faced the girl holding a book.

His faith had been insulted.

And by a wicked group of people who served the evil god, no less.

A faint light began to emanate from the white holy sword that Lian held.

“A follower of the evil god, I can’t let this go.”

Serena, who was behind Lian, also raised both hands and drew out her holy power.

If they were facing heretics, there was no way to avoid a conflict anyway.

She planned to use holy spells to help Lian if a battle broke out.

Maybe it was because Lian was showing signs of excitement as he drew his sword.

The girl stroked her book with a gentle voice and said,

“You seem to be upset.”

“Shut up! You heretics!”

“It seems like this is not the holy relic we were looking for, and it would be troublesome to waste any more time here.”

But unlike Lian and Serena, who were preparing for battle, what came out of the girl’s mouth was a disappointing story.

She said she would give up on the fight and leave.

The girl declared that she would leave this place without any resistance.

But there was no way that Lian and Serena would let her go.

Lian glanced at Serena and blinked his eyes.

He pointed his holy sword at the girl and said,

“Do you think I’ll let you go easily?”

“You’ll have to anyway.”

“What nonsense are you...”

“——Alpha.”

The girl ignored Lian’s words and stroked the black dragon on her shoulder.

The black dragon responded to the girl’s touch with a small cry.

At that moment, the shadows around her began to rise.

Whooosh!

A black body emerged from the spreading darkness.

A shadowy figure that looked like a giant beast’s mouth blocked the way between the four people.

The shadow that rose up in an instant swallowed up the girl and the young man who were in front of Serena.

“What is this...!”

“Didn’t I tell you? You can’t stop me.”

A golden glow flashed in the darkness, staring at Serena and Lian.

It was the gaze of a predator looking at its prey.

Lian quickly backed away, holding Serena in his arms, as he saw the size that he couldn’t even guess with his eyes.

Of course, even as he did so, the beast of shadows was slowly closing its mouth.

The girl hidden in the shadow of the beast looked at Lian and Serena through its parted mouth.

She spoke with a gentle voice from within the closing shadow.

“I hope we can meet again.”

“...”

“Well then.”

Crash!

With a loud noise, the beast’s mouth closed.

At that moment, the huge darkness that had swallowed them up was sucked into the shadows.

The evil magicians who manipulated shadows disappeared into the sunlight as they were.

It was an unbelievable sight even with their eyes.

People who were standing there disappeared into the shadows.

It was a mystery that even the great magicians of the empire could not reproduce.

“What is this...”

Lian looked at where they had been with empty eyes as they disappeared in an instant.

The spreading shadows were gone in no time, and only the blazing sun remained in their place.

Was it reality that they faced?

Or was it an illusion?

It was a situation that was hard to believe even with their own eyes.

Lian looked at Serena and opened his mouth as he stared blankly at where they had been looking for traces of shadows.

“Saintess. Are you... alright?”

“Yes...”

“I think we need to reconsider our journey ahead.”

Evil magicians who wielded shadows.

The followers of the evil god that Serena and Lian faced were much more powerful than they had expected.

They watched the traces of the shadows for a long time after they disappeared.

There was no sign of the people who had vanished like a mirage.

“...They seem to be very dangerous.”

“I agree with you.”

The two of them started to move again after Serena, who had hugged her cloak, showed signs of hunger.

Chapter 68: The White Knight (2)

< 68 : The White Knight (2) >

“The wind is cool today.”

The summer sky was blazing with the sun.

A moist breeze flowed in through the open window.

The cool wind brushed my cheek and passed by in the scorching sunlight.

It was a refreshing wind that I could not imagine on a normal day.

I reached out to the window, feeling the wind coming into the house.

And then I closed the window completely.

“But air conditioning is still the best.”

No matter how cool it was outside, air conditioning was the best in summer.

Beep.

I picked up the remote control and turned on the air conditioner as soon as I closed the window.

The air conditioner turned on and cool air slowly started to flow in.

The outside air was nice in the cool weather, but the cool wind inside was more pleasant.

After turning on the air conditioner with the remote control, I lay down on the bed with my smartphone.

“Then let’s play some games that I’ve been putting off today.”

I couldn’t play games properly during the weekdays because I was busy.

I planned to finish everything that I had postponed when I had some free time.

Thud.

I touched the screen of the smartphone with the loading screen, and soon the game scene appeared.

The first thing I saw was Eutenia moving on a carriage.

My eyes naturally went to [Divine Relic: Etalia’s Compass] in her hand as I logged into the game.

“She’s working hard without resting.”

Eutenia had been busy moving around with [Divine Relic: Etalia’s Compass] for days.

Even when I logged into the game for a moment, it was hard to see Eutenia resting and stopping the operation of the Divine relic.

It was understandable, since the Divine relic had a very heavy penalty.

If you stop using the item arbitrarily, you will have to wait for two days of game time to reuse it.

That’s why it made sense that Eutenia was moving around without a break.

“You’re working hard.”

I felt like giving her a reward or something when I saw her struggling.

I opened my inventory and handed her a [Sponge Cake].

A cake appeared on Eutenia's lap, who was looking at the compass.

Eutenia looked at the cake for a moment, then looked up at the sky and thanked me as usual.

-“Thank you.”

This should be enough for a gift for her hard work.

There was nothing else to give besides cake anyway.

If I wanted to prepare a better gift, I would have to spin the lottery.

After giving Eutenia a gift, I moved my eyes to the bottom of the screen and started checking the message box.

It was to check what happened last night.

When I clicked on the message box at the bottom of the screen, I could see some messages related to Estasia.

-[Cherubim: Estasia] has manifested a miracle.

-<Karma's Judgment> calculates causality rate.

-Karma increased by 5 points.

-The number of followers of the Order increased significantly.

-Some followers acquired <Fanatic> trait.

-Karma increased by 2 points.

-[Cherubim: Estasia] has manifested a large-scale miracle.

-<Karma's Judgment> calculates causality rate.

-Karma increased by 15 points.

Estasia was different from Cuebaerg in that she could obtain karma without hunting.

She could obtain karma through special events called miracles.

Moreover, the karma that Estasia obtained was a kind of karma that could reduce causality rate correction factor.

That's why it was enough to make me happy that there were more messages related to Estasia than before.

“There are quite a lot of events related to Estasia lately.”

In the early days, there were more events related to Cuebaerg, but these days there were more events related to Estasia than him.

It felt like Cuebaerg's activity cycle had slowed down overall.

The amount of karma he obtained was similar to before, though.

Maybe it was because as Cuebaerg's activity decreased, karma acquisition increased elsewhere.

It was thanks to the followers of the Order who were actively working.

I read down the karma acquisition messages with satisfaction and found some strange messages at the bottom.

“What is this?”

At the very bottom of the message box.

There were some messages that I had never seen before.

I read them one by one with tense eyes.

The content of the new messages was enough to surprise me.

- You acquired <Regular Meeting (Lv.MAX)> skill.
- You can temporarily summon up to 12 distant invitees' astral bodies to the meeting room.
- The number of participants in <Regular Meeting> cannot exceed 12 people.
- You cannot inflict damage on each other in the meeting room.
- You can place items from your inventory in the meeting room.
- You cannot communicate with the apostles during <Regular Meeting>.
- <Regular Meeting> skill will be deactivated for 14 days after use.
- You can set a cycle to automatically open meetings.

I acquired a new skill without leveling up.

The name of the skill was <Regular Meeting>.

According to the description, it was a skill that could temporarily summon up to 12 people to the meeting room.

And you couldn't hurt each other in the meeting room.

“<Regular Meeting>? Summon them to the meeting room?”

It was a skill that could gather apostles for a meeting, or so it seemed, but it wasn't that kind of skill when I read the details.

You couldn't communicate with the apostles during the regular meeting.

It meant that it wasn't a skill for communication between me and the characters.

And you could place items from your inventory in the meeting room, according to the description.

That was more absurd than not being able to communicate.

“Why do you need to put items from your inventory in the meeting room?”

It was more efficient to go directly to the target and give them something if you wanted to give them something.

<Regular Meeting> had a penalty of two weeks of game time for holding it.

Even if you tried to give something with this skill, you would have to wait at least a few days.

But you could freely put things in the meeting room.

What was the point of putting bread and snacks from your inventory there?

It was hard to understand from the perspective of reading the skill description.

“...Is that really what it means?”

I thought about it and realized that it might be true in this game.

You had to gather them in the meeting room and take care of their snacks too.

The more I looked at it, the more amazing skill it was.

And there was one more skill associated with this <Regular Meeting> skill.

It was a skill called <Regular Meeting: Invitation>.

-You acquired <Regular Meeting: Invitation (Lv.MAX)> skill.

-You grant a ring to the target that allows them to enter the meeting room.

-The target with the ring will be transported to the meeting room as soon as <Regular Meeting> is opened.

This skill was a skill that allowed me to select the characters who would attend the <Regular Meeting>.

The characters who received the skill were given a ring, and only those with the ring could enter the meeting.

The total number of characters who could attend the meeting was 12.

<Regular Meeting: Invitation> skill was not something that I could use recklessly.

I sighed briefly and looked at <Regular Meeting> and <Regular Meeting: Invitation> skills.

I wondered how to use these skills.

“A meeting between the characters. How do I do this...”

As I was thinking about how to use the skills, I saw Eutenia eating cake.

Eutenia was eating the cake that I gave her, just like last time, without leaving anything behind.

Even if the meeting was held, Eutenia and the apostles would have to attend anyway.

I would definitely use <Regular Meeting: Invitation> on Eutenia sooner or later.

If I wanted to test the skill, it would be best to use it on Eutenia first.

“First of all... I’ll give it to her first.”

I decided and used the skill right away.

Squeak.

A target marker appeared on the screen with a cluster of light.

I placed the target marker on top of Eutenia and touched it, and the target marker disappeared and light wrapped around Eutenia.

When the light that wrapped around Eutenia faded, there was a ring on her palm.

It was a gold ring with a mysterious pattern engraved on it.

Eutenia found the ring and smiled as she put it on her finger.

Gilford Proud.

He was the leader of Gilford's Mercenary Corps and the Hero of Abundance, and he was now passing through the western part of the empire.

Around Gilford were mercenaries who followed him.

He would have normally gotten a carriage to move around, but this area was not easy to get a carriage.

And it was even harder to get a carriage that could carry all the mercenaries.

That's why they were walking on foot, enduring the summer sun.

"Leader... where are we going?"

Jenny, who blocked the sunlight with a thick magic book, asked Gilford, who was walking ahead of her.

Jenny, a mage, looked exhausted as if she had reached her limit of stamina.

She was different from other mercenaries who didn't train their stamina properly.

Gilford stopped his steps and spoke to her, seeing her worried look.

“It would be better to talk while resting.”

“I agree... too.”

“Let’s all take a break here.”

At Gilford’s order, the mercenaries put down their luggage and sat down on the ground.

Moving under the scorching sun was exhausting even for mercenaries who had crossed countless battlefields.

All the mercenaries sat down and rested, and Jenny also sat down on a nearby rock.

Gilford leaned against a tree next to her.

The lush leaves made a shade that blocked the sunlight.

It was a place where he could avoid the sun.

Gilford looked at Jenny in the shade and opened his mouth.

“According to Ascalon, there are some enemies in this area who are showing signs of unrest.”

“Signs of unrest?”

“They are trying to awaken the sealed ancestor of vampires.”

The ancestor of vampires.

Jenny opened her eyes wide and looked at Ascalon when she heard that story.

The story of Ancestor Pluto was quite famous among mages.

Research on monsters was a common field even for non-black mages.

As far as Jenny knew, the ancestor of vampires was a monster that was sealed in a war long ago.

“Hu, they are trying to break the seal of the ancestor of vampires?”

“Yes. Their goal is to break the seal and get their hands on the Divine relic that was used for sealing.”

“Isn’t that very dangerous? Can we stop them with just our mercenary corps?”

“Of course, since he is powerful enough, we need to stop them before he breaks free from his seal.”

“Leader...”

Jenny looked at Gilford and the mercenary corps with a worried expression.

The ancestor of vampires was powerful enough, so the magic that sealed him must have been powerful too.

They were trying to break through such magic by force and release him from his seal.

They were followers of an evil god.

Their level could not be ordinary.

“Don’t worry. Even if he wakes up, I’ll put him back to sleep.”

Gilford tapped Ascalon and said to the worried Jenny.

Woo woo woo.

Ascalon, who was hanging on his waist, responded.

Ascalon spread his voice to Gilford.

-“The ancestor Pluto is a dangerous being.”

“Even if we all attack her, we can’t beat him?”

-“If Pluto wakes up, she will surely annihilate you.”

“Hmm...”

-“It would be better to finish the job before she revives. Even a weakened ancestor is enough to deal with you.”

Ascalon completely shattered Gilford’s boastful words to Jenny.

Gilford smiled bitterly and looked at Ascalon, then pulled it out completely.

A brilliant light burst out from the divine weapon in the shade.

Woo woo woo.

Ascalon started to vibrate more strongly.

Ascalon, emitting a strong light, continued to talk to Gilford.

-“You should give up the idea of proceeding with a weak mental state like before.”

“There’s no need to worry about that. If she’s not that kind of opponent, I don’t have to avoid fighting.”

-“I hope you keep your word.”

Ascalon had been showing a negative attitude towards Gilford ever since he faced Estasia.

Tsk.

Gilford clicked his tongue as he held Ascalon.

It was annoying when a colleague who had been fighting with him for a long time showed such a look.

Gilford also complained to Ascalon.

“You make me look so pathetic.”

-“You have already given up your duty as a hero once.”

“...I had no choice but to do that then.”

-“Of course, you don’t have to worry too much this time. You will have reinforcements to help you.”

But Ascalon didn’t care much about Gilford’s words.

Rather, he brought up the story of reinforcements to Gilford.

He had someone who was looking for him desperately.

Gilford was surprised by Ascalon’s words and asked him about the reinforcements.

“Reinforcements to help me?”

-“There is someone who is looking for you desperately.”

“Someone who is looking for me? Are you telling our location to the enemy?”

-“I have no reason to do such a troublesome thing. It’s just a simple foresight. According to my foresight, she will meet you soon.”

“Who is she?”

-“The Saintess of Abundance, Serena Etherlent.”

The Saintess of Abundance, Serena Etherlent.

Someone from the temple was looking for Gilford.

Gilford’s face hardened at the unexpected news.

Chapter 69: The White Knight (3)

< 69 : The White Knight (3) >

A deep dream.

A slow illusion unfolds in my head, straddling the boundary between reality and fantasy.

In my blurry vision, I looked at the face of the girl I met for the second time.

A black-haired girl with an umbrella.

She was the mysterious girl who appeared in my dream last time.

Estel, who faced me, smiled and greeted me.

“We meet again.”

“Yeah.”

There were only two of us, me and Estel, left in the empty alley.

It was the same as the last dream.

If this was a lucid dream like last time, I could also create things as I did then.

I imagined a table in my head and looked ahead.

Then a table appeared between me and Estel, just as I imagined.

“Have you been well?”

Estel sat down on the opposite side of the table and asked me.

It was a simple question of how I was doing.

I sat down on the chair in front of me and answered her question.

“Have I been well? Well, I guess...”

“I see.”

“But don’t you have to win a game to ask questions?”

I remembered the last dream as I listened to Estel’s story.

I had to play a poker game to hear her name.

In the end, I cheated and won.

Estel shrugged her shoulders at my question.

Then she lowered her umbrella that made a shade, looked at me and said.

“That’s only for valuable questions.”

“Is asking your name that valuable?”

“Don’t you think your name has that much value?”

“Hmm... Now that you say that, it seems like an important question.”

What value does a person’s name have?

It was a difficult question to answer if I received it.

I didn’t think giving my name had much weight, but I couldn’t deny the value of the name itself.

The name and role of each other form relationships between people, don't they?

In that sense, Estel's claim that her name had enough value made sense.

Estel added a little more to her argument, as if to back it up.

"Not many people know my name."

Not many people know Estel's name.

That's what she said.

Well, who would know the name of someone who appears in my dream?

It might be something only I know.

I don't know if that fact has any value though.

"That's what you say."

"Yes."

"I guess I have to play a game again if I want to ask something."

"Of course."

To ask a question, I had to play a game.

That was the rule that Estel told me in my dream.

She didn't answer any questions that didn't follow that rule.

I had enough time in my dream, so there was no reason not to go along with her request.

I tapped the table and asked Estel.

"So, what game do you want to play this time?"

“I think it would be fair to let you choose the game.”

“...Are you confident you’ll win?”

“I’m pretty good at games.”

She said she was good at games.

Listening to Estel’s words, I felt like I shouldn’t play a game that required skill.

I wasn’t very good at games either.

I just played games I liked for a long time.

I looked into Estel’s eyes and thought of a few games.

Most of them were games related to luck.

“Okay. Let’s go with a simple game.”

If it was a game of luck, I wouldn’t lose because of skill.

If I lose because of bad luck, there’s nothing I can do about it.

I accepted Estel’s request and said to her.

“Which game is it?”

“Coin toss.”

“A simple game indeed.”

“Simple is good. You only need this one thing.”

A silver coin appeared on my outstretched finger.

It was a coin with markings on both sides.

I made the coin and put it on the floor and asked Estel.

“Which side do you want?”

It was a question asking her to choose either heads or tails.

Estel picked up the coin and looked at it for a moment.

She tossed it lightly and caught it, then handed it to me.

“Tails.”

“You want tails?”

“Yes. I’ll go with tails.”

“Then if heads comes up, I win.”

Estel chose tails. I chose heads.

If I tossed the coin and heads came up, I would win.

The betting was over, so it was time to toss the coin.

I put the coin on my finger and tossed it up, then caught it on the back of my hand and covered it.

Thud.

Estelle looked at the covered coin and opened her mouth.

“I won.”

“How do you know without looking?”

“Because I’m lucky.”

Estelle’s words made me move my hand slightly to the side, revealing the coin.

The shadowy shape of the coin was visible on the back of my hand.

The coin that appeared where I moved my hand showed the back side, just as Estelle had said.

I had lost the coin toss.

“...You were right.”

“I won, didn’t I?”

“Yeah. Go ahead and ask whatever you want.”

I clenched the coin in my palm and leaned back on the chair, saying so.

It was a simple matter of answering her question as promised.

I didn’t think there would be anything remarkable to ask.

As soon as I accepted my defeat, her pitch-black eyes reflected my image.

“Then I’ll ask you something?”

“Sure.”

“Do you like doing bad things?”

The question that Estelle asked after winning was short and simple.

Do you like doing bad things?

It was a philosophical question that I had only heard in moral classes at school.

Since it was a dream, there was no need to hide my answer.

I just had to tell her the truth.

I told her what came to my mind.

“Sometimes?”

“Sometimes?”

“Well, I don’t really feel like doing anything too bad.”

My personality was just average.

Sometimes I was moral, sometimes I was indifferent, and sometimes I was evil.

I was an ordinary human being.

Estelle nodded her head with a smile, hearing my answer.

“I see. I like doing bad things.”

“I see. That’s your preference.”

What does it matter what the preference of someone I met in a dream is?

I agreed with her casually.

She seemed like someone who could make such a joke.

“That’s why I’m doing it right now.”

“...What?”

If it weren’t for the last sentence, that is.

With the last sentence full of doubt, I woke up from my dream.

The summer sky with the window open.

The sound of cicadas echoed under the midday scenery, and I sat up with a rough breath.

Cold sweat ran down my forehead as I woke up from my sleep.

“Ah...”

I breathed heavily and looked at my palm, soaked in sweat.

It was a realistic dream.

Only my empty palm proved that it was a dream.

Serena found the mercenary group while she was moving along the road, wary of her surroundings. It was at dusk.

She had escaped from the rugged mountain road and found the mercenary group resting at the end of the road.

They all had sturdy physiques and were sitting on the road, tearing apart jerky.

They looked like seasoned mercenaries, except for the mage who hugged his staff.

And at the end of the mercenary group, there was a man with a familiar face sitting there.

Gilford Proud.

He was a mercenary that Serena had seen familiarly in the oracle.

“You are...”

Serena stopped walking and looked at Gilford as she passed by.

The mercenary in front of her was too familiar to her.

And for good reason, she had been traveling around looking for him.

The Ascalon on his waist proved that her eyes were not mistaken.

Serena and Lian stopped in their tracks, and Gilford lifted his head and looked at her as he ate his jerky.

He lifted his head and his cheerful face showed his personality.

“What’s up?”

“...”

Serena and Gilford’s eyes met.

The hero who fled from the temple.

And the saintess who searched for such a hero.

Their strange encounter took place here.

Serena wondered what to say to him and looked at him, when Gaff, who was eating a potato, intervened and said,

“Hey, miss! Our leader is quite popular! You’d better come back when you’re older!”

Serena and Gilford both looked at Gaff as he spoke with a potato in his hand.

Lian, who was behind Serena, was also provoked by Gaff’s voice.

He flicked his cloak and stepped forward in front of Serena.

He grabbed the white holy sword on his waist and said to Gaff,

“Shut up, mercenary. How dare you be rude in front of someone who is not your equal?”

“...What did you say?”

“I said shut up. She is not someone who should hear such words from you.”

Lian’s cold eyes looked at Gaff.

Gaff heard Lian's warning and picked up an axe that was nearby and got up from his seat.

He stuffed all of the potato in his mouth in an instant.

He dragged his axe and walked towards Lian.

Screech.

When Gaff reached Lian with his axe, their eyes met in the air.

Serena, who was behind Lian, sighed and looked at the two of them.

"You look like a knight, but do you think your head will be fine after being hit by an axe?"

"You're as vulgar as your profession. You're a perfect match for a mercenary."

"It seems like our knight's head is badly damaged! I'll have to fix it with my axe!"

Lian and Gaff glared at each other with hostility.

Gaff's arm, holding the axe, was bulging with thick veins.

A knight and a mercenary.

Two incompatible beings stared at each other with murderous intent.

Serena spoke with concern as Lian tried to draw his sword.

"Settle it at a reasonable level."

"I understand."

It would only make things worse if he killed his colleague in the place where he came to take the hero.

He had to guide the situation at a reasonable level, with his sword drawn.

Lian nodded at Serena's warning.

Swoosh.

A white holy sword emerged from Lian's waist with a sharp friction sound.

As soon as the holy sword, shining with white light, appeared.

Gaff, who was facing him, swung his axe first.

"I'll split your head in two!"

Shriek——!

Gaff's heavy double-edged axe cut through the wind and flew towards Lian.

With a blast, the axe rushed towards him.

Lian caught the swinging axe and moved.

Clang!

The white holy sword stretched out and deflected Gaff's axe to the side.

Gaff's eyes widened at the sight of his twisted axe.

"...!"

As his axe went astray, Gaff showed a gap.

Lian's holy sword moved to take advantage of that gap.

Thud.

The white holy sword pierced Gaff's shoulder, who was holding the axe.

Gaff's face turned pale as the holy sword pierced him.

“You’re as crude as your skill.”

Lian pulled out the holy sword that pierced his shoulder and immediately stepped back, saying so.

Blood spurted out from where the holy sword was pulled out.

Gaff screamed and covered his wound with blood flowing from his shoulder.

Thump!

The heavy axe fell from Gaff’s hand and rolled on the ground.

“Aaargh...!”

“Are you ready to take responsibility for tarnishing her honor?”

The fight ended in an instant.

A mere mercenary’s skill was not enough to compete with the vice-captain of the Holy Knight Order.

Lian claimed the right of the winner and pointed his sword at Gaff’s neck, who had dropped his axe.

Gaff bit his lip and looked at the holy sword flashing in front of him.

The price of losing a duel against a knight who claimed her honor was always one thing.

Gilford glanced at him and moved his holy sword to cut off Gaff’s neck.

At that moment, Gilford, who had been watching their fight, shouted in a loud voice.

“Stop!”

A hearty voice echoed, and people’s attention turned to Gilford.

Gilford threw away the jerky he was eating and stepped forward with his unarmed hand.

Gilford's eyes stared at Lian as he stepped forward.

Lian sneered at Gilford and said to him,

“Why should I?”

“...I'll apologize for Gaff's rudeness.”

He said so and bowed his head to Serena.

Lian had claimed her honor, so he apologized directly to her, who was the party involved.

But Lian didn't care about Gilford's attitude and pressed his sword against Gaff's flesh.

Blood flowed along with a thin line as the sword touched him.

“Apology? Is that all his life is worth?”

“What do you want then?”

“A duel with you.”

“A duel...?”

A duel.

Gilford looked surprised by the unexpected proposal.

And that was their trick.

They wanted to make a big deal out of it and reduce Gilford's options.

Lian tapped Gaff's shoulder with his holy sword and made a proposal he had prepared for Gilford.

“Let’s have a duel. If you win, I’ll spare him without any conditions.”

“And if you lose, you’ll kill Gaff?”

“If you don’t accept my condition.”

“What condition?”

If he won, he could save Gaff.

But even if he lost, there was a way to save Gaff.

It was too good an offer for Gilford to look at Lian’s sword with suspicion.

Lian told him his condition.

“If you lose, come back to the holy land quietly. The Hero of abundance, Gilford Proud.”

Chapter 70: The White Knight (4)

< 70 : The White Knight (4) >

The unexpected intruders who came looking for Guildford uttered a surprising word.

The Hero of Abundance.

Guildford's eyes narrowed when he heard that name.

The people in front of him already knew Guildford's identity.

He looked at Serena and Lian alternately and said.

“Are you from the Holy Land?”

“Yes. I'm Lian Crost, the vice-captain of the Crossbridge Knights.”

“The vice-captain of the Knights...!”

“Isn't he the second highest person among the knights?”

The mercenaries around him murmured at Lian's introduction.

That's how shocking Lian's identity was.

Knight Lian Crost.

And Serena Ederlunt, who was with him.

They were each the vice-captain of the Knights and the Saintess of Abundance.

They came from the Holy Land to take Guildford with them.

Ascalon had already told him about their visit a few days ago.

It matched Ascalon's story that meeting the Saintess was inevitable.

Guildford winked at the holy sword on Gaf's shoulder and said to Lian, who was pointing his sword at him.

"The vice-captain of the Knights... You're quite radical for someone who serves God."

Lian did not deny Guildford's words.

He just lowered his sword and glared at Guildford with a fierce aura.

The aura of a knight who had reached the peak was so intense that it touched Guildford's skin.

"There is no other way to make you realize your weakness than to face you with a sword."

"Make me realize my weakness?"

"That you are still weak as a hero who has not received proper training."

Lian finished his words and took off one of his gloves and showed his bare hand.

He then threw his glove at Guildford.

Thud.

Guildford's hand caught Lian's glove.

Throwing a glove at someone was an action taken when challenging them to a duel.

Guildford also knew well about the etiquette of dueling.

“Weak... That’s a word I haven’t heard in a long time.”

Squeeze.

Guildford squeezed Lian’s glove hard.

Guildford was also a veteran mercenary who had been in the business for a long time.

He was not someone who would be called weak by anyone.

“Guildford Proud. I’ve heard that you’ve made quite a name for yourself as a mercenary. But do you think that will work against the evil god?”

“I don’t think that the mercenaries’ way will work against the Order. That’s inevitable.”

“Then why don’t you come to the Holy Land? You can’t grow without learning. And you can’t complete without mastering.”

Lian’s words were close to the orthodox view.

Most heroes would willingly join the Holy Land knowing that fact.

Of course, some of them might be after the glory that comes from being a hero.

But Guildford’s position was different from theirs.

He was not alone.

He had comrades that he had to take responsibility for.

“I am a mercenary before I am a hero. And I am the leader of the Guildford Mercenaries.”

“Is it because of the mercenary group you’re leading...?”

“It’s not just that, I don’t like being tied to a place like the temple. I have my own way of fighting against the evil god.”

Lian sighed briefly and pointed his sword at Guildford.

Guildford pointed Ascalon at Lian as well.

The holy sword and the divine weapon that were drawn emitted brighter lights than before.

Woo woo woo woo——

Ascalon, responding to the light of the holy sword, vibrated longly.

Lian, who pointed his sword at Guildford, stared at him and said.

“What about the people?”

“What do you mean?”

“What are you going to do about the people who are suffering from the evil god while you are being stubborn?”

“...Don’t misunderstand. I’m going to try to save people in my own way.”

He would walk a different path from the temple.

That was Guildford’s thought.

He had lived as a mercenary all his life, and he had lived a rough but free life more than anyone else.

He didn’t want to wear a mask of heroism and move in a predetermined direction now.

Besides, he didn’t want to part with his comrades either.

Being a mercenary was something that Guildford Proud could never give up.

Lian shook his head as if he didn't like Guildford's words.

"We are pursuing the way that can save the most people."

"I'm sure you are."

"This is the most efficient way to save people. But you... Why are you trying to deviate from justice?"

There was a big gap between the way of heroes that Lian spoke of and the way of heroes that Guildford spoke of.

Guildford realized that the difference in perception between them could not be easily narrowed.

There was a wall that they could not understand each other.

If they couldn't understand each other, they would inevitably clash.

It was a fight that could not be avoided.

Swoosh.

Guildford drew Ascalon from his waist.

The eyes of the two men who drew their swords met in the air.

As they looked at each other, Ascalon, who was emitting light, spoke to Guildford.

- "It seems like you don't have time to talk to each other."

"...What do you mean?"

Right after Guildford's question, filled with doubt.

A heavy explosion rang out and shook Guildford's ears.

Kwaaaaang——!

The intense explosion that reached his ears made Guildford turn his head to find the cause.

A nameless cliff far away from the mountain road where they were.

There, a huge flame and smoke rose up.

The smoke that began to cover the cliff faintly was enough to guess the scale of the explosion that occurred from afar.

“What the hell is going on?”

A sudden explosion of unknown origin.

The only one who had an idea of what it was here was Ascalon.

Lian, who had covered his ears from the explosion sound, looked at Guildford’s Ascalon and asked.

Woo woo woo woo.

Ascalon vibrated and answered Lian.

-“It seems that the followers of the evil god are trying to break the seal of the progenitor.”

“The progenitor of vampires? You don’t mean Pluto...?”

-“If you intend to keep fighting, I won’t stop you. However, by the time the fight is over, the progenitor might be released.”

Lian bit his lip after hearing Ascalon’s words.

The murderous aura that had been rising in Lian’s eyes had long subsided.

Guildford, who was watching him, lost his will to fight and put Ascalon back in his scabbard.

There was nothing to gain from fighting each other in this situation.

Rather, they would only blame each other for letting the progenitor of vampires escape.

Lian also sheathed his holy sword that he had drawn.

Then he spoke to Serena who was behind him.

“Lady. I think we need to borrow the eyes of the Guardian.”

“...Alright. I’ll check the situation.”

“Thank you.”

Serena, who heard Lian’s request, knelt down on the floor.

She clasped her hands and began to pray in a polite posture.

Guildford realized that the saintess was preparing to use her divine power.

Now that the situation had occurred, he and his mercenary band could not just sit still.

Guildford looked at Gaf, who was sitting on the spot where Lian had passed by, holding his shoulder.

“Gaf. Are you alright?”

“Captain... I made a fool of myself.”

“Don’t worry too much. The opponent was the vice-captain of the Holy Knights.”

“...”

“Get up, Gaf. We still have a lot to do.”

Guildford reached out his hand to Gaf, who was sitting down.

Squeeze.

Gaf grabbed Guildford's hand tightly.

Gaf, who got up from his seat, looked at him with a complicated gaze.

"...Captain."

"Put on a bandage. I'll lead the men."

"I'm sorry, captain."

Guildford handed a bandage to Gaf and passed him to approach the mercenaries.

The mercenaries had mostly stopped eating and grabbed their weapons since the fight with Lian broke out.

Guildford looked at the mercenaries who were still sitting on the floor and shouted.

He wanted to take them along for the upcoming fight.

"Worms! Get up from your seats!"

"Captain! Are we going to fight now?"

One of the mercenaries who was sitting asked Guildford's shout.

Nod.

Guildford nodded immediately.

"Yes! It's a glorious mission for our Guildford Mercenary Band!"

"What about the payment?"

"I'll buy you beer until you all pass out!"

The mercenaries cheered at Guildford's shout.

The mercenaries who followed Guildford were like this.

They liked money and beer, and they also enjoyed adventuring with Guildford.

That's why Guildford couldn't give up this mercenary band.

Guildford gave orders to the mercenaries and crossed his arms, looking at Lian.

"You said you were the vice-captain of the Holy Knights. When are you going to move?"

"...Wait a little. The saintess is assessing the situation herself."

Lian's expression was slightly relaxed as he answered Guildford's question.

The veteran mercenary and the second-in-command of the Holy Knights.

It was the moment when a temporary alliance of cracks was formed.

Somewhere in the mountains of Ketterland province.

There, Eutenia was preparing magic with her bare hands to shoot at her enemies.

Eutenia's hand did not have Etalia's compass.

After a long search, she finally found the location of the relic.

It was finally time to reap the fruits of her efforts after moving without using magic for a long time.

Nothing could stop Eutenia without the restraint of the compass.

"It feels refreshing to use magic after a long time."

A lightning bolt shot out from Eutenia's hand toward a cliff where flames were flickering.

Kwaaaaang——!

A loud noise echoed as rocks around the cliff collapsed.

The rocks that fell with the lightning covered the people below.

The people below screamed as they were hit by large rocks.

“Aaaaah...!”

“It's an enemy! Everyone get ready for battle!”

With a horn sound, those who were attacked by Eutenia began to move busily.

There were guardians of the seal where Eutenia's lightning struck.

They were those who lived to protect Pluto, the progenitor of vampires, and the stake that sealed him.

The guardians of the seal, who had inherited their lineage for a long time, had a power as strong as their history.

Despite Eutenia's sudden attack, most of them were still safe.

Eutenia watched them and said.

“You all look surprisingly tough.”

“It's only natural for the guardians who protect the seal.”

“If this is not enough, I can use stronger magic.”

As Eutenia raised her hand to use the next magic.

An arrow flew toward where Eutenia was.

Zap.

The arrow cut through the wind and moved at a fast speed.

However, it was impossible for the arrow that aimed at Eutenia to achieve its purpose.

A hand that stretched out from her shadow grabbed the flying arrow and stopped it.

“Wh... what?”

Peter, who was surprised by the arrow that stopped in front of him, took a few steps back.

Thunk.

Eutenia cleared the arrow with her shadow and looked at the direction where the guardians were.

There was one guardian who was aiming his bow at her from a distant cliff.

Even though she had used magic from an invisible place, he had found her location.

She smiled at him and said.

“It looks like you have good eyes.”

The guardian who shot the arrow quickly put another arrow on his bowstring.

The taut bowstring was ready to send an arrow to Eutenia at any time.

It was a fast speed that matched his skillful archery.

Peter spoke in a flustered voice as he saw the arrowhead shining in the distance.

“Ah, no... this is not just good eyesight...”

“Since I received a dangerous gift, I should give him a proper return.”

Eutenia raised her hand and began to draw more powerful magic.

She was preparing magic to deal with the guardians.

Her hand stretched toward the sky moved like a conductor who commanded the weather.

As her hand moved, the wind blew and clouds formed.

“Ah...”

Dark clouds began to gather in the sky, and soon the ground was covered with a faint shadow.

Crackle. Crackle.

The dark clouds that gathered in the sky spat out light and gradually transformed into a huge thundercloud.

The guardians looked up at the sky as the dark clouds suddenly rolled in.

At the moment when the thundercloud that had been condensing reached its limit.

Eutenia burst out all the magic she had gathered.

“——Giga Lightning.”

Giga Lightning.

It was the most powerful wide-area attack magic she knew.

As Eutenia’s hand came down, the thundercloud that she had created in the sky released the thunder that it had accumulated.

Kwaaaaang——!

The irregular thunderbolts began to strike down at the enemies on the ground alternately.

“Th, they... cough!”

“Aaaaah...!”

Every time it rained, lightning flashed, followed by thunder that shook their ears.

In the flash that shook their eyes and ears, the thunderbolts mercilessly judged their enemies.

It was not easy to see properly in such bad conditions, and in such conditions, the thunderbolt attacks continued to pour out.

The screams of the guardians echoed again in the flashing light.

“Everyone, uh... ugh!”

“Cr... ugh...”

“Aa, aaaah, aaaaaah!”

Kwaaaaang——!

The lightning kept falling toward the ground.

The rain of thunderbolts that continued to fall tore apart the formation of the guardians.

Even if they survived after being hit by lightning, they could never be free from the ensuing attacks.

A bombardment of lightning that could not be blocked or escaped from.

Eutenia's magic ended only a few minutes after the thundercloud was completed.

“It's a bit cleaner now.”

Right after the huge magic that blocked her sight disappeared.

Eutenia shook off her wet hair and smiled.

There was only one guardian left where her magic had passed.

Chapter 71: The White Knight (5)

< 71 : The White Knight (5) >

Gilford's eyes scanned the edge of the cliff through the rising smoke.

What he saw there was a gruesome scene of the fallen guardians.

Shattered bushes.

Broken bows.

And countless lives that had vanished on top of them.

The soaring flames and the remaining moisture proved that this was all the work of a mage.

“...How horrible.”

Gilford's gaze passed through the people lying down and moved to the bottom of the cliff.

A small cave entrance located below the cliff.

There was a girl waiting for them with a book wide open.

Thud. Thud.

The footsteps of the mercenaries approaching the girl echoed.

The girl, who had been leaning against the wall and reading a book, lifted her head and looked at Gilford and his party.

“It seems that uninvited guests have arrived.”

The girl’s gentle voice resonated with everyone in this place.

The first one to step forward in response to the girl’s voice was Lian.

Lian drew his white holy sword and stared at the girl holding the book.

And then he greeted her with a complicated emotion.

“I see you again so soon.”

“That’s right. You came back even though I let you go once.”

“Who are you?”

“I am the First Apostle, Eutenia Hyroste.”

The First Apostle.

Gilford frowned at Eutenia’s words.

Thinking about the meaning of the word apostle and the number in front of it, it was not hard to guess who she was.

“...The First Apostle?”

“The first servant of His Great one.”

Apostle, Eutenia Hyroste.

She was surely a being with a high rank within the cult of the evil god.

She was the first among the apostles.

Everyone in this place had a hunch that it would not be an easy battle.

Squeak.

Gilford drew his divine weapon, Ascalon, from his waist.

Ascalon emitted a clear light as it came out of its sheath.

Following Gilford's action, the mercenaries nearby also raised their weapons.

“Evil god's apostle. Why are you trying to awaken the progenitor of vampires?”

Lian, who was at the front of the party, asked Eutenia.

It was a question about why Eutenia had knocked down the guardians and occupied the cave.

Eutenia stroked the pages of the book with a relaxed hand as she heard Lian's question.

She treated the book in her hand as if it were something precious, and answered while caressing it.

“Because that is His Great one will.”

“Is that really the only reason?”

“Following God's will and spreading His will. Is there anything more important than that?”

Lian looked dumbfounded at Eutenia's answer.

Gilford also thought that it was an answer that would make Lian confused enough.

Wouldn't anyone who serves God think that way?

It was just that their object of faith was an evil god.

Clang.

Gilford adjusted his equipment and took a stance with Ascalon in his hand.

“That god being an evil god is the problem.”

“...You are foolish people.”

“Is there anything more foolish than following an evil god?”

Eutenia’s face hardened as she continued to hear Gilford’s words.

She seemed to be displeased with what she heard from him.

Thump.

She closed the book she was holding and glared at Gilford.

Gilford tightened his nerves so that he could respond at any time to the anger that came from Eutenia’s ash-colored eyes.

“You dare to use the word evil god for Him, you have been rude to His Great one since before.”

“Being rude is better than being merciless.”

Eutenia shook her head at Gilford’s words.

She looked like she had made some kind of decision.

Eutenia reached out and stroked the black dragon on her shoulder.

The young dragon cried out with a thin voice as it received her touch.

“I was going to spare those who ran away, but I guess I can’t do that anymore.”

“Attack is coming! Be careful!”

“——Alpha.”

As soon as Lian shouted to his surroundings, sensing something strange,

the shadow under Eutenia's feet spread out in all directions.

The shadow spread out quickly enough to cover all the surrounding area.

All the mercenaries, including Gilford, were bewildered by the shadow that spread out in an instant.

Gilford held Ascalon and guarded around him, while urging his mercenaries to be careful.

“Everyone be alert! We don't know what will happen from anywhere!”

“Gilford! Scatter the mercenaries! If we stay together, we might get more damage!”

Lian moved away from the mercenaries with Serena and said.

Nod.

Gilford nodded at Lian's words and looked at the mercenaries again.

He was about to give them an order as he turned his eyes to them.

“Everyone, keep your distance and watch out for...!”

“Leaderaaaah——!”

“Gaff?”

Gilford's words were interrupted by a voice that called him out loud.

Gilford turned his head to the voice, and there he saw Gaff running towards him.

Gaff was running towards Gilford with all his might, ignoring his injuries.

At that moment, when Gilford was puzzled by Gaff's appearance,

the huge darkness that surrounded Gilford began to rise.

The anomaly that Gilford had been wary of appeared from the shadow.

“Leader!”

“Ah...”

While Gilford was frozen in panic, Gaff, who was running towards him, rammed into him with all his might.

Boom!

With a heavy thud, Gilford’s body flew far away.

Gilford, who had rolled on the ground from the impact of Gaff’s charge, quickly regained his posture.

He stabbed Ascalon into the ground and looked at Gaff.

He saw a sad face that was trapped in the darkness that surrounded Gilford.

Gaff, who had seen Gilford being thrown out, dropped his axe and opened his mouth.

“I’m sorry, leader...”

“Ga... Gaff! Get out of there quickly!”

“I guess it’s too late—.”

The moment Gaff was about to say his last words to Gilford,

Crack.

With a creepy sound, Gaff’s body disappeared into the darkness.

Gilford’s eyes stared at the darkness that had swallowed Gaff.

In the huge shadow covered in black, only the golden glow was flickering ominously.

The only thing left where Gaff had been was a monstrous creature.

“Ga, ff...?”

“Gilford! Snap out of it!”

“Gaff, I...”

Gilford’s colleague had disappeared in front of his eyes.

Gaff.

The colleague who had been with him for the longest time.

A subordinate and a friend who had been with Gilford from the beginning to the end, a reliable mercenary.

A loyal friend who never gave up and tried hard to catch up with him, despite the difference in talent between them.

Gaff’s last moment had burst in front of Gilford’s eyes.

“Gilford Proud!”

A colleague who seemed to be with him forever had died.

Gilford’s hand holding Ascalon began to tremble.

Instead of tears of sorrow, what burst out from him was anger.

Gilford recalled Gaff’s appearance and let out a fierce scream.

“A... Aaaaaah...!”

He screamed as if he wanted to spit out all the emotions that were lumped in his chest.

His scream, which sounded like a scream, echoed.

His eyes were bloodshot as he screamed.

Woo woo woo woo!

Ascalon, which was stuck in the ground, vibrated in resonance with Gilford's emotion.

Ascalon emitted a brighter light than ever before and spoke to Gilford.

-“The causality rate has not tilted enough yet. It is a forbidden area for you.”

“...”

-“I see. You are willing to use up your life span.”

Gilford's eyes glowed with a deep light as he grasped Ascalon.

His body had temporarily transcended human limits by accepting the power of the divine weapon.

The powerful magic that tore through Gilford's body turned his rage into strength.

Gilford, who overlaid an aura on the shining divine weapon, pulled out Ascalon with his bloody hand.

His appearance holding a sword that glowed with an eye-catching light was comparable to that of a hero in mythology.

-“Hardship and adversity make heroes.”

Gilford stared at the shadow with his divine weapon in the midst of swirling light.

Beyond the shadow illuminated by his eyes,

he could see the figure of the dark beast that was breathing in the shadow.

“They’re fighting again.”

As I ate ramen and played games, I saw Eutenia fighting against unidentified enemies.

She was fighting with the dark beast that I had given her before.

Lately, it was not uncommon for believers to fight.

As the difficulty level increased, monsters appeared from all directions.

Many believers, including Roan, had frequent fights.

Except for Estasia, who didn’t like to move from her place unless necessary.

“Is this boss a bit strong?”

I slurped up my ramen quickly while watching Eutenia’s battle with interest.

She was fighting against a knight who used a shining sword.

Every time the light flashed from the knight’s sword, Eutenia’s magic became translucent and scattered.

That’s why Eutenia was using both shadow touch and magic simultaneously.

Maybe it was thanks to my constant support for her growth,

but Eutenia didn’t seem to be pushed back much by the knight even though her magic was weakening.

-“The evil god is watching this place.”

-“I know.”

Thump.

I put down my chopsticks and looked at my smartphone with astonishment.

They called me an evil god while I was eating ramen as a good citizen who paid taxes to the game.

It was a serious insult to the customer.

I picked up my smartphone and touched the location where the knight was with my finger.

“Who are you calling an evil god?”

Bang!

The knight swung his sword to block my attack.

It seemed to be a common trait of the elite monsters these days.

He easily parried my basic attack as if it was nothing.

I didn't expect my basic attack to work in the first place.

I quickly glanced at the corner where the icon of <Giga Lightning> was located.

“The difficulty has increased a lot.”

-“Everyone, be on guard! The evil god's attack is coming!”

“But I won't let this stop me from clearing the mobs.”

I activated <Giga Lightning> and focused on the skill range to include the enemies.

I planned to use <Giga Lightning> to wipe out the normal characters first.

As soon as I touched the screen to set the target area, light spread out and dark clouds began to gather.

The wide-area attack skill <Giga Lightning> was activated.

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

At that moment, when I was about to attack the enemies with <Giga Lightning>.

The knight who was fighting with Utenia retreated back and raised his sword towards the sky.

A brilliant light burst out from the sword that the knight raised.

A large speech bubble appeared above the knight's head, who was emitting a bright white light.

-“O white one! Lead us to the light!”

As the knight emitted light, the effect of <Giga Lightning> that was flashing became faint.

At the bottom of the screen, a message box showed new messages one after another.

Confused by the messages that I had never seen before, I read the contents of the messages.

-<White Zone> is in effect.

-The range of <Giga Lightning> is reduced by 75%.

-The duration of <Giga Lightning> is reduced by 75%.

-The damage of <Giga Lightning> is reduced by 75%.

A message appeared that the power of the magic was weakened by a special pattern.

The range, duration, and damage of <Giga Lightning> skill were all reduced by 75%.

It was practically a 75% reduction in the overall performance, calculated by multiplying 75% three times.

Reading the message, I understood why Utenia's fight had lasted so long.

The boss character in front of me had a special pattern that reduced magic damage.

It was natural that Utenia, who had developed her character mainly with magic, had a hard time.

Rather, it was admirable that Utenia was fighting evenly with the boss, considering the difference in compatibility.

“No way, how can he have such a cheat pattern?”

All the skills I had were magic-based skills.

I was suffering a huge penalty in the battle with this boss.

But I couldn't just hit the boss with my basic attack when he was at full strength.

I had to somehow save my mana and clear the enemy characters.

As I was preparing to spam <Giga Lightning> with a feeling of frustration, the two characters started to have a different conversation.

-“Holy maiden! How ready is the holy sanctuary proclamation!”

-“Lian! It's almost done!”

-“Please do it right away!”

It was a dialogue where the knight character asked another character for something called holy sanctuary proclamation.

Holy sanctuary proclamation.

It was a skill that looked ominous just by its name.

When I heard the name of the skill from the boss character, I couldn't help but be on guard.

“Holy Ray Blast? What is that?”

It seemed like a new pattern was about to come at us.

Since it was a pattern that the boss used himself, it was likely to have a negative effect on us.

There was no point in using a skill to interrupt the pattern, as the knight would try to defend it as before.

Feeling a sense of danger, I canceled the skill I was about to use and moved my finger to the barrier skill.

I wanted to protect Eutenia in case of any unexpected situation.

As I prepared to activate the barrier skill, another character who was kneeling down began to pray.

-“O Goddess, lead us to abundance.”

-“O Goddess, grant us peace.”

-“O Goddess, bestow us comfort.”

I could see the speech bubbles popping up one after another, indicating that they were preparing to use some kind of powerful skill.

Thud.

I kept pounding on the barrier, trying to cover Eutenia with it.

I thought that even a weakened barrier would provide some meaningful defense if I stacked it repeatedly.

As I activated more than ten barriers by tapping on the target area,

The character who finished casting stood up and displayed a huge speech bubble.

-“Holy Blast – Auras Saint.”

And with that speech bubble as the last thing I saw, the screen went black.

Beep, beep, beep——.

My smartphone’s screen made a strange noise and flickered erratically.

I was so startled by the sudden shutdown of my smartphone that I dropped it on the floor.

“What is... this...?”

Thud.

My smartphone spun in the air once and landed with a dull sound.

From the bottom of the screen, new messages popped up.

-An anomaly has occurred in <The Eye of the Observer>.

-An anomaly has occurred in <The Eye of the Observer>.

-An anomaly has occurred in <The Eye of the Observer>.

-An anomaly has occurred in <The Eye of the Obser——.

– ##### SYSTEM ERROR #####

-Please observe another area.

Chapter 72: The White Knight (6)

< 72 : The White Knight (6) >

Below the cliff where a fierce battle was taking place.

Lian sighed and tightened his grip on the holy sword.

He had thought that in the worst case scenario, the evil god might be watching over this place personally.

And unfortunately, the evil god had indeed exercised his power over the battlefield.

It was the worst situation that Lian had feared.

The presence of the evil god that he faced was much more immense than he had expected.

He felt his whole body tense up just by meeting his gaze.

If he hadn't asked Serena to use the holy proclamation in advance, he would have been fighting under the interference of the evil god by now.

“...”

After Serena used the holy proclamation, the gaze that Lian had felt disappeared completely.

The effect of the holy area, which temporarily blocked the 'eye of the observer', was working normally.

But the holy maiden's holy proclamation was not an omnipotent miracle that lasted forever.

It was something that should have been used by mobilizing dozens of priests, but she was maintaining it alone.

She could only keep the holy area for a few minutes at most.

If the holy area disappeared, there was a high chance that the evil god would intervene in the battle again.

Lian calmly looked around with his holy sword in hand.

“Haah, ha...!”

Gilford, who had awakened the power of Ascalon, was breathing heavily and continuing to fight.

Gilford had not fully awakened the power of Ascalon yet.

The aura surrounding Ascalon was also much fainter than before.

The prolonged battle was starting to take its toll on Gilford as well.

He wouldn't last long at this rate.

Lian's gaze turned from Gilford to Serena, the holy maiden.

“...Lian. I can't keep it up for much longer.”

“I know.”

Serena looked exhausted from supporting the battle.

She also seemed to be reaching her limit soon if the battle continued.

On the other hand, Eutenea, who was facing Lian, still looked like she had some leeway.

Did she have a near-infinite amount of magic?

She didn't even show signs of magic depletion that usually occurred in long battles for mages.

Lian, who alternated between looking at his allies and enemies, realized that it was time for him to make a decision.

“Mercenary. Are you listening to me?”

Lian spoke to Gilford while keeping an eye on Eutenea's movements.

Gilford glanced at Lian briefly and then coughed and caught his breath.

His voice didn't come out properly because of the continuous battle.

He cleared his throat roughly and shouted at Lian with a weakened voice.

“...What is it?”

“Gilford Proud. I want to make a contract with you as a mercenary.”

“What... did you say?”

Lian smiled bitterly and lifted his holy sword as he saw Gilford's eyes narrow.

He told him about the contract he had in mind.

“I'll hire your entire mercenary corps.”

“You can't be serious...”

“Take Serena and return to the holy land. The cost will be paid by the Temple of Abundance.”

The white holy sword and the holy proclamation were undoubtedly powerful forces.

But there was a huge gap between them and an endless miracle of nothingness.

A powerful miracle required a corresponding price.

The price for maintaining the white area that suppressed the mage was also not small.

Lian's divine power had already diminished considerably, and Serena was overwhelmed by just keeping up the holy area.

In this situation, if the holy area was broken, Lian's party would surely be annihilated by the evil god.

The plan to stop the apostle had failed as soon as the evil god joined the battle personally.

That's why Lian chose to retreat.

He decided to preserve both the hero and the holy maiden for the next moment.

"Didn't you say that the evil god is watching?"

"The evil god's eyes can't reach the holy area. We can escape completely if we use a holy relic now."

"Holy relic...?"

"A holy relic, Heliya's amulet."

Its effect was to teleport the user and nearby people to a predetermined coordinate.

The current amulet had its coordinates fixed to a distant street corner from here.

There was a waiting time to use the amulet, but Lian was confident that he could earn enough time for it.

However, the problem was Gilford's attitude.

Gilford shook his head and refused Lian's words even though his aura was fading away.

"I can't accept that... I'm staying here too. I have to avenge my dead comrades."

"I'll take care of your revenge for you, so go ahead."

"What did you say...?"

"I'll knock her down and follow you."

Lian declared that he would take Gilford's revenge for him, raising his holy sword.

Someone had to stay behind and protect them until the transfer was complete, if he was going to use the holy relic anyway.

Both the hero and the holy maiden were necessary for the future.

Naturally, it was Lian's duty to stay behind.

That was why he volunteered to be Serena's escort knight.

He had anticipated that this moment would come someday.

"Lian! What are you talking about!"

Serena, who had been listening to their conversation, shouted at Lian.

She looked worried about Lian, who said he would stay behind.

Lian thought that she would naturally try to stop him, knowing Serena.

Lian pointed at Gilford with his chin and answered Serena.

"You have the hero by your side."

“That’s not the problem. You just said that you’re going to stay here!”

“I don’t think I’m going to die. Just go back to the holy land and wait for me.”

“Lian! The evil god is watching over this place! We need more power...!”

Tsk.

Lian clicked his tongue and cut off Serena’s words.

It was a sharp look that he didn’t usually show to her.

Lian looked at Serena with an annoyed expression and said.

“Or do you not trust the vice-captain of the holy knights that much?”

“...Lian?”

“And Gilford! Don’t refuse my contract if you’re a real mercenary!”

I heard Lian’s scream as Gilford opened his mouth with a weary expression.

“This is the last time I’ll listen to you...”

“Is that so? Please take care of the saintess...”

“I can’t stand watching this any longer.”

The one who interrupted Lian’s words was Eutenia, who had been looking at him from behind a thick barrier.

Eutenia, who had been keeping a distance, stretched out her hand and complained.

Flames of magic formed in masses and flew towards them.

I infused my holy sword with power and weakened Eutenia’s magical attack.

Paah!

As the light flashed from my holy sword, the flames of magic quickly faded away.

The barriers that surrounded Eutenia also burst one by one.

In the midst of the sound of magic exploding in my ears, I gave my last farewell to Serena.

“I hope you understood what I said.”

“Lian...”

“Activate the relic. I’ll follow you soon.”

I stepped forward and raised my holy sword.

My cold eyes met Eutenia’s on the other side.

The reason I stayed here was not only because of the amulet’s malfunction, but also because of the mage in front of me.

It was always the duty of those who wielded the white holy swords to capture the black mages of the Order.

Now it was my turn to fulfill my role.

“I kept you waiting.”

“Do you think I’ll let you go?”

“Then I’ll have to make you let me go.”

The Apostle, Eutenia Highrost.

She had to be defeated at all costs.

Her mastery of magic was already on par with the great mages of the continent.

On top of that, she had an absurd amount of magic power.

If she wasn't dealt with here, she might become a being that would threaten the holy land.

My sword shone with light again.

“Come on! Apostle of the evil god!”

Eutenia looked at Lian's back with a blank face.

As he said, the heretics behind him had succeeded in escaping from here.

It must have been because they were afraid of the great one who was watching over her.

But the paladin in front of her remained in his place.

Eutenia raised her hand and spoke as she looked at Lian's back with a disappointed expression.

“...Are you confident?”

“I'm enough to handle a mage by myself.”

“Is that so?”

Eutenia knew that Lian's words were not from vain confidence.

His holy sword was constantly weakening her magic.

Her weakened magic was not difficult to fend off physically.

It was natural for him to be confident against Eutenia, who was a mage.

But that didn't mean Eutenia would let him do as he pleased.

She held up her grimoire with the shadow's touch and declared to Lian.

"You will pay for your arrogance today."

"Do you trust this thing?"

As soon as Lian finished his words,

Alpha sprang up from the shadows and aimed at Lian.

But Lian saw Alpha's movement and dodged him.

He then covered his sword with aura and struck Alpha hard.

He wouldn't fall for the same trick twice.

"I have many excellent means besides magic."

"Whether it's the shadow's touch or that monster over there, it won't do any good."

"My means are very different from yours. Faith is my greatest weapon."

"You believe in an evil god. I'll make you a promise here. I'll kill you before the effect of the sanctuary ends."

Lian raised his sword and ran straight towards Eutenia.

His sword seemed to affect Alpha's shadow as well, as the shadow's area had shrunk considerably.

Eutenia looked around and prepared a magic to use against Lian.

It was hard to maintain a stalemate when there were many people, but now she could pour all her power into one person.

She started preparing magic with both hands and released it sequentially towards him.

“Barrier.”

“A futile attempt! White one—!”

A barrier made of enormous magic power blocked Lian’s charge.

Instead of attacking Lian, she chose to use the barrier to hold him down.

Lian quickly raised his holy sword’s power to face Eutenia’s magic.

As his sword flashed with light, cracks appeared on the barrier.

Kwang!

The barrier weakened by his sword was completely shattered by Lian.

Right after he broke the barrier, another barrier unfolded towards Lian.

“Barrier.”

“Double magic! White one!”

He continued to raise his sword’s power.

Lian Crost’s holy sword had the effect of weakening magic.

She knew she couldn’t hold him down with her barrier for long.

It was also difficult to inflict effective damage on Lian with magic.

That’s why Eutenia chose one way.

She used the barrier magic consecutively to bind Lian as much as she needed.

“—Life. Build the stairs.”

“What are you trying to do now!”

Eutenia used magic and started praying as she prepared another barrier.

Lian felt a bad sign and kept breaking the barriers and approaching, but there was still enough distance between them.

Eutenia used the barriers alternately with both hands to restrain Lian’s movement.

At the same time, she recited a prayer with her mouth.

The shadow’s hand on the floor was drawing a pedestal around Lian.

It was a feat that no one in the Order could do except Eutenia.

“—One path leads to glory.”

“—One path leads to death.”

Kwang! Kung! Kwang!

Lian’s sword swung fast and smashed Eutenia’s barrier.

Every time his sword strike attacked to break the barrier, light flashed from his sword.

As Eutenia’s barrier usage cycle shortened, Lian’s sword swinging speed also increased.

Maybe he felt more impatient than before in this unfavorable situation.

He swung his sword with a tense face.

Eutenia, who saw the pedestal starting to form, continued to speed up her prayer.

“—Revere. Adore. Sacrifice.”

“Stop! You better stop this nonsense!”

Before long, Eutenia’s prayer reached its end.

Kung! Kung! Kung! Kwang!

His sword strike, which had become faster than before, destroyed Eutenia’s barrier at a fast speed.

It was a speed that was impossible to handle if she didn’t use all her magic for defense.

Even the shadow’s touch that occasionally approached him was repelled by the aura wrapped around his sword.

Kung! Kung! Kung! Kung! Kung!

His swordsmanship, which had reached its peak, cut the barrier smoothly.

Lian, who had sped up, soon reached Eutenia’s vicinity.

As he swung his sword, he tried to cross the boundary line of the pedestal made by the shadow.

Eutenia recited the last prayer.

“—Sing the hymn of life.”

Right after Eutenia’s clear voice finished the prayer,

Lian’s body was wrapped in a bright light cluster.

He looked at his holy sword in shock as he was trapped in the pedestal.

The light that flowed from his holy sword had completely faded away.

Thud.

He dropped his holy sword on the ground and asked Eutenia with trembling eyes.

“What, what... what did you do?”

“I’m just sending all life back to where it belongs.”

“What... did you say...”

Lian’s limbs wrapped in light turned into light and scattered.

The light that enveloped Lian gradually grew in size and began to cover the entire pedestal with light.

As the light spread more and more, it reached its limit at one point.

The dazzling light faded away in an instant.

There was no longer any sign of Lian where the light disappeared.

“That was a bit of a tough opponent.”

Eutenia muttered as she looked at where Lian had disappeared.

The only thing left in his place were the pedestal with strange patterns and the holy sword.

Chapter 73: The Ancestor of Vampires, Pluto (1)

< 73 : The Ancestor of Vampires, Pluto (1) >

The smartphone that I had dropped on the floor did not break.

I was worried when it made a loud noise as it fell, but fortunately, the screen did not crack.

The game screen that had gone black also returned to normal soon.

And the only character that remained on the screen was Eutenia.

The characters that were fighting with Eutenia had all disappeared.

Eutenia was alone, looking at the sword in her hand. I could not help but stare at her with curiosity.

“Did she... defeat them all by herself?”

The enemy was a boss character with a vicious pattern.

A pattern that reduced the power of magic.

And a pattern that obstructed the player's vision.

Both of them were patterns that made normal play impossible.

The boss with such a pattern had vanished from its place in just a few minutes.

There was no other explanation than Eutenia had taken down the boss.

It looked like Eutenia was in a tough situation, but it was not as serious as I expected.

I quickly moved my eyes to the message box at the bottom of the screen and checked the messages that had been printed recently.

-Please observe another area.

-Please observe another area.

-Please observe another area.

-[Apostle : Eutenia Highlost] has performed an offering to you.

-The sacrifice offered to you : 1

-The effect of <Karma's Blessing : Offering> is activated.

-Your karma increases by 2 according to the number of sacrificed offerings.

At the top of the message box, there was a message about the vision-obstructing pattern that the boss character had used.

Sometimes, in games where the boss monsters have vicious patterns, there are cases where certain patterns obstruct the player's vision.

This game also had a vicious pattern that obstructed the player's vision.

As the game's difficulty increased, there might be other bosses with such patterns.

I needed to come up with a countermeasure for this pattern.

The only countermeasure that came to my mind right now was sound play.

“She also did an offering in the meantime.”

Below the warning message about the vision-obstructing pattern, there was a message about Eutenia's offering.

It seemed that Eutenia had also proceeded with an offering after finishing the battle.

The number of sacrificed offerings was one.

And the amount of karma gained was 2.

The number of offerings and Eutenia alternated in my head, raising a question.

The number of characters I saw before the pattern was activated and the number of characters that Eutenia offered did not match.

“Why is there only one offering?”

Before the vision-obstructing pattern was activated, I saw at least a dozen characters.

If she had offered them all, she should have gotten at least 30 karma points.

But Eutenia only had one offering.

That meant that she only killed one enemy.

Then what happened to the rest of them?

Eutenia failed to kill them.

The number of characters I saw with my eyes and the number of offerings did not match.

I could not help but wonder as I looked at the screen.

“Is it a temporary event? Or is it a teaser boss?”

There were two possible scenarios.

The large number itself was part of the pattern, or it was close to a teaser for a specific boss.

If it was the latter, I might face that boss again someday.

I remembered the vicious pattern of the boss I faced this time and thought about my current power level.

Eutenia and Evan.

And the followers of the cult.

Except for the creatures that were hard to move freely, these were all the available forces of the cult.

If I faced a stronger boss next time, could I fight with this power level?

I ran a simulation in my head, but there was no positive result.

“I need to keep leveling up if it’s an event boss.”

Defeating the bosses that would come in the future.

And keeping all the characters who participated in the battle alive.

That was my goal.

If I kept having close battles like this time, I might lose a character someday.

To prevent that, I needed to level up continuously.

Especially, I needed to avoid focusing too much on magic settings like this time.

“I should think about how to train physical characters.”

Evan was good at sword fighting, but he was more powerful in brain-type damage.

The next apostle would be better off with a physical setting.

I should also spend money regularly when I have some spare cash.

After finishing my rough plan for the future, I looked at Eutenia who was heading to the cave with a sword.

She was holding the sword that the boss character had used.

She probably did not offer the sword separately, so the weapon must be an item that could not be offered.

A small speech bubble appeared above Eutenia's head as she headed to the cave.

-“I need to check if I pulled out the stake properly.”

There was only one stake that Eutenia could mention in this situation.

The holy relic that she had been looking for a long time.

She finally achieved her goal.

I followed her to the cave with the game screen.

According to Evan, there was also a sealed ancestor of vampires where the holy relic was.

Eutenia was heading to where the ancestor of vampires was sealed.

“There is a vampire sealed by the holy relic, he said.”

The ancestor of vampires, Pluto.

He was the character I had been waiting for to choose as the next apostle.

If I followed Eutenia, I would also see the vampire.

I looked at the screen with anticipation.

It was time for <Apostle Selection>, which I had not done for a long time.

“I’ve been waiting for you for a really long time. Let me see your face.”

It was a meeting that I had waited for a long time.

It was time to see the result of my waiting.

Eutenia entered the cave where the ancestor of vampires was sealed.

She looked around with interest in her eyes.

In the narrow cave, there were metal rods with flames rising from them, stuck on the walls at regular intervals.

They did not look like ordinary candlesticks.

There were no candles that should have been on the candlesticks.

It looked like they were using some magical means to light the fire.

“What a strange sight.”

Thud. Thud.

Eutenia’s footsteps echoed in the narrow cave filled with shadows.

The guardians who would have normally guarded this cave were all gone now.

This mysterious cave was completely transformed into Eutenia’s space.

As she continued to move forward, a large magic circle came into Eutenia’s view.

Above the magic circle, there was a girl with her eyes closed, bound by chains.

And in front of the magic circle, there was Peter, standing blankly with a stake in his hand.

“Peter?”

“Oh... The battle is over already...?”

“Have you been trying to pull it out all this time?”

It had been quite a while since Peter had entered the cave.

But the stake was still in its place, and Peter’s face was flushed with exertion.

Eutenia could easily understand what was going on.

The stake that sealed the ancestor of vampires.

She had also considered the possibility that it would not come out easily.

As Eutenia approached the stake, Peter let go of it and stepped back a few steps.

Then he scratched his head awkwardly and spoke to Eutenia.

“This is harder than I thought... to pull out...”

“Is that so?”

A hand reached out from the shadows and pulled out the stake.

Thud.

The stake that had been stuck in her heart came out, and the wound where the stake had been healed.

The blood that swirled around gathered to Pluto’s heart and healed her wound.

Seeing the vampire heal herself from the wound caused by the stake, Peter opened his mouth wide.

“Wait, that... It was hard to pull out...”

“Different people have different ways.”

“That’s...”

“Shh. She’s starting to wake up.”

At Eutenia’s words, Peter had to shut his mouth immediately.

Blink. Blink.

As her heart recovered, Pluto opened her eyes that had been hanging on the magic circle.

Under her faintly lifted eyelids, she showed the red pupils characteristic of vampires.

Her ruby-like red eyes were like jewels.

Her eyes moved slowly and scanned her surroundings.

Pluto’s eyes met Eutenia’s as she looked around with a blank expression.

A hoarse voice came out of Pluto’s mouth as she found Eutenia.

“...Ah.”

“You finally opened your eyes. The ancestor of vampires, Pluto.”

Blink.

Her eyelids moved slowly again as she heard Eutenia’s answer.

She still seemed to be affected by being released from the seal.

It would take some time for her to recover fully.

Pluto closed and opened her eyes again and asked Eutenia.

“...Where am I?”

“The Ketterunt region of the Empire. The cave where you were sealed.”

“Sealed?”

“Don’t you remember? You lost in a war hundreds of years ago and were sealed here.”

Blink. Blink.

Pluto blinked again and looked at Peter and Eutenia alternately.

She seemed to ponder for a moment after hearing Eutenia’s story.

It looked like she was recalling some memories from the past.

Pluto, who had been lost in thought for a while, nodded her head and agreed.

“I... lost the last war I fought in.”

“I’m glad you remember something.”

“I know I was sealed by a stake. But who are you?”

“My name is Eutenia Highrost.”

“Eutenia?”

“I’m the first apostle of the great one, and the person who came to save you.”

Hmm.

Pluto nodded at Eutenia's answer.

It was a situation where she had just woken up from a long seal.

Even from Eutenia's perspective, there must have been a mountain of things to worry about.

Shhh.

Pluto's gaze moved to the chains that bound her.

The chains connected to the magic circle were still restraining Pluto's body.

"This is annoying."

Pluto, who had been looking at the chains, pulled the hand that was connected to them.

Clang.

The thick iron chains broke like thin threads in an instant.

It was a sight that did not seem like the result of pulling a huge chain.

Pluto, who had broken one chain, pulled the rest of them as well.

Clank. Thud.

The chains that were pulled by Pluto broke without exception.

Pluto, who had broken all the chains that were connected to her, shook her hand and looked at Eutenia.

"Are you human?"

"I'm a pure human."

"Then why did you wake me up?"

“Because the great one wanted it.”

If Eutenia’s master had not ordered it, there would have been no such thing as waking up Pluto.

She would not have even known about the existence of the progenitor of vampires, let alone waking her up from her seal.

So Eutenia’s words were nothing but the truth.

Pluto heard that story and jumped off the altar that had bound her.

Now that the seal was broken, there was no point in restraining her any longer.

“The great one. Is it the one I know?”

“I only know one true god.”

“That’s different from those humans who worship six.”

“Those who have wrong beliefs must be corrected, I think.”

Pluto nodded her head quietly as she heard Eutenia’s confession of faith.

She had been annoyed by the followers of the six temples during the war.

Now that she heard Eutenia’s words, they were nothing more than cute to her.

After finishing her explanation about her situation and her faith, Eutenia told her about her master.

If Pluto had participated in the war hundreds of years ago, she would have known which side had the right belief.

“The great one is calling you. If you answer his call, you will surely find the way you want.”

“The way I want...”

Blink.

Pluto blinked again as she faced Eutenia.

Pluto grabbed her head with one hand and staggered for a moment.

Eutenia stretched out her shadow and supported her body.

Pluto leaned on Eutenia’s shadow and said to her with a serious expression.

“What is the way I want?”

“...What?”

“I can’t remember well.”

“It seems... your memory hasn’t fully returned yet.”

She was a person who had been sealed for hundreds of years.

It was possible that so much time had passed.

Eutenia thought so and tried to move on.

But then Pluto asked her an unexpected question.

“And by the way, you... umm, what was your name again?”

“...”

Eutenia’s cold gaze looked at Pluto.

Chapter 74: The Ancestor of Vampires, Pluto (2)

< 74 : The Ancestor of Vampires, Pluto >

-“Don’t misunderstand. I’m just in a strange state because I haven’t been able to preserve my memories through blood magic for a long time.”

After following Eutenia into the cave’s interior, I had to watch the conversation between the two people that was close to a chat for a while.

As I watched the dialogue between Eutenia and Pluto, a bitter smile came out involuntarily.

The character of the ancestor of vampires looked less dignified than I expected.

I had to shake my head while tapping my forehead as I watched Pluto make excuses to Eutenia.

“Is this... the ancestor?”

When I think of the ancestor of vampires, I usually imagine someone like the leader of the vampires.

I expected a noble with dignity who leads bats around.

But Pluto, who I actually met, looked more loose than I thought.

I don’t know if it’s because she was sealed for hundreds of years or because her AI was half-broken, but it was.

In some ways, she was an AI that could be compared to Estasia.

“But at least she looks like a rare character, so she’ll be strong if I make her an apostle.”

Pluto was treated as dangerous in many places according to the settings.

She was so dangerous that they used a holy relic to seal her in order to restrain her actions.

If I could have Pluto under me, she would definitely do more than one part.

Fortunately, it seemed that I didn’t need to invest a lot of time to make Pluto an apostle like Evan.

Pluto, who heard Eutenia’s story, decided to accept her opinion without saying anything.

-“So, have you made a decision?”

-“I have nowhere to go now, and there are no people left, so I guess I have no choice.”

-“That’s a great decision. The great one will welcome you too.”

The fact that Pluto’s screws were loose due to complex problems was a great help in persuading her.

Eutenia continued to persuade Pluto, who had no complete memories.

Pluto, who had nowhere to rely on, decided to entrust herself to the Order.

Pluto was in a hostile position with the characters of the temple anyway.

There was nowhere else for her to go except for the Order, unless it was a deserted place.

In this situation, it seemed like I could proceed with <Apostle Selection> for Pluto right away.

-“Maybe so?”

-“The great one I know loves even those who are lacking with love.”

• ○ ■ ■ “...”

As I watched their conversation, I immediately moved my finger to the <Apostle Selection> button at the bottom of the screen.

It was the <Apostle Selection> skill that I used for the first time in a long time since I made Evan an apostle.

Click.

As soon as I pressed the skill icon, a target that could select a target popped up.

I placed the target on top of Pluto and designated her as the target and activated the skill.

-Do you want to select [Pluto Astria] as an apostle?

-You need 800 karma to select an apostle.

-Yes / No

When I chose Pluto, a guide window popped up asking me if I wanted to select her as an apostle.

The karma required to make Pluto an apostle was 800 karma.

It was twice as much as 400 karma that I spent when I made Evan an apostle.

The next apostle of Pluto will consume 1600 karma.

The karma consumption increased to a burdensome level.

I touched the ‘Yes’ button with trembling fingers and moved on to the next screen.

-You have selected [Pluto Astria] as an apostle.

-You consumed 800 karma and created a new artifact for the apostle.

-[Artifact : Death Scythe] has been bound to [Pluto Astria].

-[Third Apostle : Pluto Astria] became your apostle.

-You will share your magic power with the selected apostles by the effect of <Apostle Selection>.

-You can send separate messages to the selected apostles by the effect of <Apostle Selection>.

As soon as I used the skill, Pluto raised her head and looked at the sky.

At the same time, guide messages started popping up at the bottom of the screen one after another.

The first thing that popped up was a message that Pluto was selected as an apostle.

She accepted <Apostle Selection> at once like when I selected Eutenia.

And then what popped up next was a message that I created an artifact for Pluto by consuming karma.

The name of the item bound to Pluto was [Artifact : Death Scythe].

I immediately opened the inventory and checked the appearance of the artifact bound to Pluto.

“This time, the artifact is a scythe?”

[Artifact : Death Scythe] had the shape of a scythe wrapped in black light.

The scythe that glowed black matched Pluto's appearance well.

Unlike Eutenia and Evan's artifacts, this time it was an artifact that had the shape of a direct weapon.

The name of the trait that [Artifact : Death Scythe] had was <Proof of Blood>.

It was a trait that looked related to Pluto's race, vampire, just by looking at the name.

"<Proof of Blood>... The performance itself looks pretty good."

The effect of this trait was three things.

One. A bloodsucking effect that absorbs the blood of enemies hit by the artifact and restores Pluto's health.

Two. A buff effect that suppresses Pluto's own bloodlust and amplifies the power of blood magic.

Three. An elastic effect that temporarily increases the length of [Artifact : Death Scythe].

Either way, it was an effect that focused on combat.

It had less versatility than Eutenia's <Shadow Touch>, but it seemed to have more merit in combat.

"I thought she would be focused on magic, but she looks closer to a hybrid character than I thought."

Pluto, who wore an artifact, was a continuous dealer with a bloodsucking effect.

She could use both magic and physical attacks alternately, and if she used her unique combat endurance, it seemed possible to fight for a long time.

It was a kind of character that would be useful in many ways if I had one.

I don't know the exact performance until I check it, but it looked like a pretty good character for now.

I took out [Artifact : Death Scythe] from the inventory and placed it on top of Pluto.

I handed over the artifact to Pluto and tried to have a conversation with her using messages.

“Take this and hunt hard from now on... Huh?”

Puff.

The [Artifact : Death Scythe] that I dropped was stuck on Pluto's head as it was.

I didn't take out weapons from the inventory often, so it was an unexpected disaster.

Pluto, who was looking up, looked at the [Artifact : Death Scythe] stuck on her head.

Blink. Blink.

Pluto, who looked at the scythe stuck on her head, reached out to the scythe and raised a speech bubble.

Pluto's speech bubble overlapped with [Divine Tool: Death Scythe], completely hiding Death Scythe's appearance.

-“This must be his gift. He gave it to me in a more radical way than I expected.”

-“...Doesn't it hurt?”

-“It's nothing to me.”

-“Pluto is amazing.”

-“And I feel a strange power overflowing in my body, as if I’m connected to him.”

Pluto pulled out the scythe that was stuck in her head and started swinging it in her hand.

Blood spurted out from the wound for a moment, but soon the bleeding stopped and new skin grew.

Was it thanks to the regenerative ability of vampires?

It didn’t take long for Pluto’s wound to heal completely.

It was a scene that made me understand why she had to be sealed with a holy relic.

But even though Pluto was fully healed, I wasn’t comfortable with giving her the scythe.

“...See you next time.”

I felt sorry for sticking the scythe on Pluto’s head and talking to her right after.

In the end, I confirmed Pluto’s swinging of the divine tool and turned off the screen of my smartphone by pressing the button.

I thought I had to postpone the conversation with her until next time.

Loneliness.

For Pluto Austria, the past hundreds of years were nothing but loneliness.

She was alone in the dark seal.

Vampires’ memories are long but not infinite.

Even if she lived forever, she couldn't keep everything in her mind.

Hundreds of years of loneliness were enough time to take away most of her memories.

The only thing left for her in the dark was her burning memory.

Every day, her past memories faded away, and when a year passed, several years' worth of memories disappeared.

As she watched her memories vanish every day, all she could do was remember loneliness.

'I don't want to forget.'

As useless memories piled up, so did the memories that vanished.

After hundreds of years of being sealed, she forgot almost everything except herself.

Who am I?

And why am I here?

Only those memories were the force that supported her.

After all the time of loneliness and oblivion passed by.

There was nothing left for Pluto who woke up from the seal.

"I feel like I used to speak more elegantly before."

Pluto said as she swung the scythe in front of Euteneia.

It was a small memory she found in a broken little fragment.

She used to be a king in the past.

She was at the top of all vampires, a great ancestor and ruler of nobles.

But now she had nothing left, neither country nor people.

All of her relatives disappeared after a long war.

The only thing left in the aftermath of the war was an immortal who couldn't be granted death.

“Elegant speech?”

“I think I used to speak more like a king.”

“What kind of speech was it?”

“That... I don't remember.”

Euteneia made a strange expression as he heard Pluto's words.

Pluto saw him make that expression periodically.

She couldn't understand what emotion it was, but it didn't seem like a look of respect for his lord.

Rather, he was a being who served the god who gave her this scythe.

The apostle who served the heavenly god would not care much about the ancestor of vampires.

“He must have liked you very much.”

“I don't remember if he was the one I served.”

“...I see.”

“But there's one thing I think I know.”

Pluto smiled and looked at the scythe in her hand.

The Death Scythe she held was not an ordinary scythe.

A divine tool that connected her to the heavenly god.

That was what this Death Scythe was.

And by receiving this Death Scythe as a gift, Pluto got a glimpse of God's existence.

The heavenly god reflected in Pluto's eyes was a very large being.

"He's so big and strong that he's out of reach for a vampire like me."

Incomprehensible.

A being beyond cognition that cannot be understood or accepted.

Euteneia's master was a being that could not be fully traced even by the eyes of an immortal race.

How long did he live and how much did he know to reach that level?

As an immortal race with the curse of oblivion, no matter how much time passed, they would never get there.

The scythe given to Pluto's hand was proof that such a being was paying attention to Pluto.

Pluto's slender fingers slowly traced the black scythe.

"It seems that even if you live as long as Pluto, there are things you give up on."

"Because no one can reach there, everyone looks up to him."

"That's true."

Pluto cut her finger with the blade as she touched the scythe with her fingertips.

Swoosh.

The blood that flowed from the wound swirled around her.

Blood magic.

It was a special magic that only the bloodline of vampires could use.

Her blood magic, holding the Death Scythe, was enhanced by some kind of magic.

The red blood drops that circled around her reflected in Pluto's red eyes.

"The great one...."

Pluto Austria.

She lost everything she had.

Wealth. Honor. Power. And family.

Everything she had built up in her lifetime disappeared completely in the flow of time.

Now the only thing left for her was the scythe in her hand and the huge gaze watching over her.

The incomprehensible being was the only pillar that could support her now.

"I hope he doesn't see me as a strange vampire."

A new bond she built after losing everything.

What kind of existence would it remain for Pluto in the future?

With a fluttering feeling about the future in her chest, Pluto swung the scythe hard.

Chapter 75: The Ancestor of Vampire, Pluto (3)

< 75. The Ancestor of Vampire, Pluto (3) >

In the Knight Commander's office of the Knight Order located in Crossbridge.

There, Knight Commander Revels Etherland looked at the rosary hanging on the wall.

Below the rosary on the wall were the names of the Knight Order's officers.

Revels' gaze was fixed on the second rosary in the place.

Lian Crost.

The rosary hanging in the place where the name of the vice commander was written was cracked and half of it had fallen off.

Looking at the broken rosary, Revels gave an order to his adjutant without turning his head.

"Broadcast to the whole Knight Order. Today, the knight we respected, Lian Crost, has fallen."

Saying that, Revels reached out and picked up the broken rosary that was hanging on the wall.

This rosary was an object that the knights who held important positions in the Knight Order had put a part of their souls into.

If the knight connected to the rosary died, the miracle on the rosary would be released and the rosary itself would be broken.

In the end, Lian's rosary being broken meant that Lian himself had met his death for some reason.

Lian Crost, Revels' subordinate and vice commander of the Knight Order, had died.

That fact was nothing less than a great tragedy for not only Revels but also the entire Knight Order.

"Are you saying that Vice Commander has fallen?"

"Yes. He died honorably protecting Lady Saint from the evil heretics."

"...How could this be."

The adjutant's face darkened as he heard Revels' story.

Lian Crost, who had a white holy sword, was not a light name in the whole sanctuary.

He was always mentioned among the ranks when discussing power in the sanctuary.

And he was killed by someone while he was out.

No knight in the sanctuary would easily accept this incident.

Revels spoke again to his adjutant, who had a gloomy face.

"I understand your distress, but don't you have to do your job first?"

"I'm sorry. I'll broadcast it right now."

"Good, work hard."

Creak.

The adjutant opened the door and left the Knight Commander's office after hearing Revels' words.

As soon as the adjutant left, Revels was left alone in his office.

Revels' gaze turned to the map on the wall where he was alone.

List of Sealed Danger Factors.

On a map that warned of numerous danger factors on the continent, a bead at the location of the ancestor of vampires was broken.

It meant that the seal that confined The Ancestor Pluto had completely lost its effect.

It was a situation where he could tell why Lian, who had taken Lady Saint out, had lost his life.

Lian's party had encountered a force of evil gods that was stirring up trouble in the empire.

"Hoo..."

Revels sighed and raised his left hand.

He then tapped twice on the green gem in the center of his ring.

Tap. Tap.

As soon as Revels' finger tapped on the gem, a light came on in the middle of it.

Magic was activated and a person's voice mixed with noise began to flow out of the gem.

-“It's been a long time since you contacted me this way.”

“It's hard to meet you right now.”

-“You know better than me why that is.”

The voice of an old man from behind his ring was that of Holy Emperor Haifright II.

The ring in Revels’ hand was an object used to have secret conversations with Holy Emperor when necessary.

Revels cleared his throat as he heard Holy Emperor’s voice.

And he began to speak in a cold voice toward Holy Emperor.

“Lian Crost is dead.”

-“You mean The Knight of Holy Sword is dead? What about Lady Saint?”

“Lady Serena is still alive. It seems she used an amulet that was smuggled out.”

-“That’s a headache. Losing The Knight of Holy Sword at this time. Who do you think is behind this?”

Heeheeck

Revels’ gaze turned to Pluto’s bead that had broken out of its seal.

There was only one thing he could guess from hints here.

A battle broke out between Lian and The Evil God’s forces.

And it was such an urgent battle that Lady Saint had to use The Sanctuary Declaration herself.

“There is only one reason why Lady Serena would use The Sanctuary Declaration without any reason. It seems highly likely that The Evil God himself moved.”

-“Revels. Come to think of it, The Evil God seems to be showing too much freedom lately.”

“It must be because of The Karma Causality.”

-“What could be the reason for The Causality to suddenly tilt to one side?”

Revels also knew well about The Karma’s Sky Ceiling that suppressed the gods.

The Karma’s Sky Ceiling was a role that restrained the interference of the gods in the world according to The Causality.

Nevertheless, The Evil God showed more active interference in the world than before in this invasion.

It meant that The Evil God still had a lot of room for The Causality.

On the other hand, The Six Goddesses showed less activity than before in the previous crisis.

This meant that there was a big gap in The Causality between The Goddesses and The Evil God.

If this situation continued, there was a possibility that he would have to be wary of The Evil God’s intervention in all battles.

-“I guess I need to pray myself.”

Revels heard a sigh from behind his ring.

Revels, who was holding Lian’s rosary, was also troubled.

Revels put down the rosary he was holding on the desk and asked Holy Emperor over the ring.

“What are you going to do about the ancestor who has been released?”

-“The Ancestor Pluto... She was a monster that had been a nuisance since the war hundreds of years ago. Don’t you think it’s best to face a monster with a monster that suits her?”

“You don’t mean...”

-“I will use ‘that thing’ in the Temple of Abundance.”

“That’s too dangerous...”

As Revels tried to dissuade him, Holy Emperor cut off his voice and spoke.

-“I will send you a recommendation letter for Lian’s successor at the next elders’ meeting.”

“...Yes.”

-“I will take care of the matter of causality myself. Revels, you prepare a search party to recover the holy sword and Lady Saint.”

“I understand.”

It was Holy Emperor’s own warning not to interfere with the future matters.

Revels was also responsible for losing Lian, so he had no choice but to keep his mouth shut.

Holy Emperor finished talking about Lian’s successor and causality with Revels and left him one last request.

-“Don’t worry too much about that thing. As long as Lady of Knowledge is there, it won’t get out of control.”

Click.

Holy Emperor’s answer was the last one.

After Holy Emperor’s voice died down, the light on Revels’ ring disappeared.

Revels’ face was full of complex emotions as he looked at the green ring that had gone out.

Knight Commander, Revels Etherland.

His gaze, immersed in his thoughts, turned to the rosary where one spot was empty.

“Did I say you could have that?”

In the carriage moving away from the cave where Pluto was sealed, Peter looked at the sword in Eutenia’s hand and said.

Eutenia had a white sword in her hand that emitted a faint light.

The white sword was a trophy that Eutenia had taken after shaking off the pursuers who had chased her.

The sword decorated with fancy jewels was something that anyone could guess its value by looking at it.

From Peter’s point of view, it was a treasure that he could never buy even if he saved money for his whole life.

Normally, she would have offered it to The Evil God she served, but for some reason she said she would give it to Peter today.

Peter naturally doubted her intentions as he saw her like that.

“Don’t you like it?”

Eutenia tilted her head and asked him back as she heard Peter’s words.

If her words were true, there was no reason for Peter to refuse from his point of view.

He clenched his hand holding the reins.

He said to her again in a cautious voice at the unbelievable luck.

“Can I really have this sword...”

“It doesn’t matter. I can’t use it anyway.”

“Huh?”

“It’s a sword that not anyone can use. And it’s not something that can be offered either.”

Eutenia’s words made Peter realize why she was giving up the sword.

Apparently, that sword was something that could not be offered to The Evil God she served.

If that was the case, it made sense for her to give it to Peter who followed her around.

If she gave him the sword, it would mean that one more fighting power would be created.

Eutenia, who had no greed for money, might have been willing to give up something that could not be offered to Peter.

“Then I’ll take it.”

Peter nodded his head and accepted Eutenia’s offer.

He had never held a sword in his life.

But the first sword he held was an ominous-looking sword.

He felt an inexplicable expectation in his chest.

“That sword has an evil aura flowing through it.”

As soon as Peter accepted Eutenia’s offer, Pluto, who was next to her, opened his mouth.

Pluto pointed at the white sword with a disgusted expression and said.

The white sword that Eutenia had had an evil aura flowing through it according to Pluto's claim.

Eutenia smiled as she heard Pluto's words and looked at him.

"An evil aura?"

"It's a horrible sword to look at."

Pluto hated the sword that Eutenia had too much.

A vampire hated something that looked horrible to him.

A thought crossed Peter's mind as he looked at Pluto.

If it was something opposite to vampires, wouldn't it actually be a good thing?

'The evil aura for vampires... Isn't it actually a holy aura?'

Peter looked at Eutenia this time as he looked at Pluto.

Eutenia was an apostle who handled The Evil God's power.

But she had no discomfort in touching the sword.

Come to think of it, she also handled the holy relics related to the gods freely.

She could touch the things that the evil vampire hated without any influence.

Where did the evil beings end and where did the good beings begin?

The line that distinguished between them was not clearly drawn.

Peter fell into a dilemma as he held the reins and looked ahead.

"...Ah."

And he soon discovered something and sighed.

Ahead of the mountain road where the carriage was running.

A group of men who had knocked down a log and blocked the road were seen.

Eutenia heard Peter's sigh from behind and asked him.

"Peter. Did you find something?"

"There... It looks like someone is there."

"Thieves?"

"It seems so."

There was a group of thieves blocking the road far away from where the carriage was.

It was common to encounter thieves on a secluded road.

Rather, the journey so far had been too smooth.

Pluto also showed interest as he heard about the thieves and looked at Eutenia.

"Thieves have appeared?"

"I guess so. What are you going to do, Pluto?"

"Let me see."

Whirr.

Pluto picked up the scythe that was lying in the corner and got up from his seat.

A dark aura began to rise from the Death Scythe in Pluto's hand.

Artifact, Death Scythe.

The treasure that the apostle Pluto had received from The Evil God was thirsting for blood.

Pluto raised the scythe he was holding and took a stance.

“——Death Scythe.”

Woo woo woo woo!

The Death Scythe responded to Pluto’s voice and resonated with a thick darkness.

Pluto’s red eyes, which were slanted, shone on the enemies blocking the road.

Behind Pluto, a huge scythe of darkness appeared.

It was the power of Death Scythe to reap the lives of enemies on behalf of its master.

Pluto swung the scythe he was holding hard and said his last farewell to the enemies in front of him.

“Goodbye. Humans.”

“Uh, ugh...?”

“Wha, wha, what is that!”

Maybe it was because they faced the black shadow that appeared behind Pluto.

They seemed to realize that something was wrong and started screaming all at once.

But the Death Scythe in Pluto’s hand had already drawn a large trajectory.

The huge scythe that appeared behind Pluto also followed the trajectory he had drawn and cut through the bandits.

Crash!

The tree that blocked the road shattered and fragments scattered in all directions.

The bandits who were cut by the scythe also fell to their places and blood spurted from their bodies.

“——Gather.”

Pluto ordered the blood that rose from the bandits who were cut by Death Scythe.

Thump.

Peter felt his heart tighten for a moment as he heard Pluto's voice.

The blood that rose up succumbed to the command of the noble bloodline and gathered around her.

The blood that gathered seeped into Death Scythe and disappeared, and a red mist rose around Pluto.

She used blood magic to harvest blood and looked at the road where the bandits had disappeared and said.

“It's been a long time since I drank blood.”

She said that with sharp fangs in her mouth.

Chapter 76: Council Meeting (1)

Chapter 76: Council Meeting (1)

“The rain is pouring down terribly.”

Swoosh.

As if announcing the arrival of the rainy season, the rain was falling heavily outside the window.

I’m not a fan of the hot and humid summer weather.

But I didn’t mind the sight of the rain falling outside the window.

The irregular sound of raindrops.

The blurred vision with splashing water droplets.

When I stood by the window and watched the rain, I realized what tranquility was in the sound.

“Summer is almost over, huh.”

It felt like yesterday when I frowned at the heat of early summer, but before I knew it, there was less than a month left of summer.

It seemed like time flew by in the blink of an eye.

Not that I wanted to say goodbye to the air conditioner right now.

I stared blankly at the rain for a while, then yawned and turned around.

I picked up my smartphone that was on the table, and sat on the bed leaning against it. As always, I launched the game.

“I guess I’ll play some games.”

Tap.

As soon as I touched the screen, the game’s loading screen popped up.

I had seen the same screen so many times that it was familiar and boring.

Of course, there were some elements that I grew fond of after seeing them for months.

The <Paid Currency Shop> button located at the top right corner of the game was one of them.

When time passed and the main screen was displayed normally, I checked the message box at the bottom of the screen first.

“Oh... A quest item has arrived.”

It seemed that Euteneia had offered an item after retrieving a holy relic.

There was a message related to that in the message box.

[Holy Relic: Ergus’s Stake].

I finally acquired one item related to the quest of <Descent> skill.

I quickly operated the screen to check the message window of <Descent> skill.

A new screen popped up with a greatly reduced karma and a progress bar of the quest.

-The progress of <Descent> will increase by one step every time you meet one of the following conditions.

-Available Karma: 1328 / 999999 (Incomplete)

-[Holy Relic: Ergus's Stake]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

-??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-??? (Incomplete)

My eyes naturally went to where it said 'complete'.

[Holy Relic: Ergus's Stake] was marked as complete in the quest content.

It was the first quest I cleared since I started the game.

A sense of accomplishment filled my chest as I saw the glowing completion mark.

"I finally filled one. There are still four left... But I'm sure they'll be filled soon as I play."

The first item, one million karma, was still far from being achieved.

The required karma amount increased as the number of apostles increased, and from the next apostle onwards, I had to pay 1600 karma to select them.

It was better to think of it as a quest that could only be achieved in the late game.

The items that were still locked would also be unlocked later as my level increased.

I enjoyed my joy while looking at the completion mark, then soon moved my eyes to the skill icons at the bottom of the screen.

"I cleared a quest, so now I have to deal with other things."

I closed the message window of <Descent> skill and pondered over <Regular Meeting> and <Regular Meeting: Invitation> skills.

A skill that temporarily gathers designated characters in one place, <Regular Meeting>.

This skill allowed communication between characters regardless of distance.

There was a drawback that the communication channel between me and my apostles was temporarily blocked, though.

It was difficult for me to intervene immediately in <Regular Meeting>, but it was not a bad skill in terms of sharing information among characters.

The AI in this game tended to operate independently anyway.

They had to fill in their lack of information through interactions with each other.

“Judging by its classification as a system skill, it seems like it’s not only possible for apostles.”

<Regular Meeting: Invitation> skill, which selected characters to attend <Regular Meeting>, had already been used once on Euteneia.

It was a method of giving a ring to the target character.

Considering my experience of using <Lightning> on an animal, it might be possible to invite non-human targets as well.

Of course, they would need fingers to wear rings anyway.

I didn’t think long and used <Regular Meeting: Invitation> on a target nearby.

“First of all... You should get an invitation.”

The first target I chose was Pluto.

Pluto Astria.

She was the progenitor of vampires, not human, and one of my apostles.

If my guess was right, Pluto, who had fingers, would be able to receive an invitation without any problem.

Squeeze.

I pressed the skill icon of <Regular Meeting: Invitation> to activate the target area.

Then I touched Pluto, who was next to Euteneia, to designate her as the target of the skill.

-[Third Apostle: Pluto Astria] has been added as a member of <Regular Meeting>.

A ring was given to Pluto along with a new message at the bottom of the screen.

Pluto was included in the range of <Regular Meeting> skill.

Pluto, who received the ring, tilted her head for a moment, then put it on her finger.

After inviting Pluto to the meeting, I moved the screen to another direction right away.

There were many other targets to invite to <Regular Meeting> in the order.

“Next... Creatures should be possible to invite too, right?”

The next thing I found after Pluto was Estasia, who was located in the Ketterunt branch of the order.

Estasia was not a human, but a character with ten fingers.

I thought she could wear a ring without any trouble.

I didn't hesitate and used <Regular Meeting: Invitation> on Estasia.

Estasia, who entered the range of the skill, was wrapped in a light and acquired a ring.

-[Cherubim: Estasia] has been added as a member of <Regular Meeting>.

Estasia also joined <Regular Meeting> without any problem, just like Pluto.

After inviting Estasia, I moved the screen again to find the next target.

There were many other targets to invite to <Regular Meeting> in the order.

Apostle Evan and Archbishop Roan.

And if possible, the magical skeleton that flew around with a staff.

I also thought of Kueberg for a moment, but I quickly erased him from my mind.

“He doesn't even have fingers to wear a ring, right?”

Kueberg had no fingers to put a ring on.

He couldn't stick a ring in his eye just because he had no fingers.

It was easy to put a ring on a finger even if it was just a bone, but it was impossible for a lump without fingers.

I excluded Kueberg from the target list and moved the screen to find the next target.

It took quite some time to give rings to everyone, as the order had grown large and moved globally.

“You too, get an invitation. And you too...”

Evan, who was training with a sword behind the order.

Roan, who was busy with meetings in the city.

And the magical skeleton that I luckily found flying in the sky.

I successfully invited all the targets to <Regular Meeting>.

I made a mistake in targeting the skill once, but it was a minor thing considering the result.

“Well, it shouldn’t be a big problem.”

The message box only showed the names of the characters who used the skill.

There was still a problem that I didn’t know who I accidentally used the skill on, but I decided to blame it on the magical skeleton that flew around quickly.

It wouldn’t happen again unless it was Arcrosis.

I would find out who I used the skill on when I convened <Regular Meeting>.

If there was a problem, I could deal with the character then.

It wasn’t something I needed to worry about for long.

After finishing inviting all the characters, I pressed the skill icon of <Regular Meeting> and set the meeting time.

-<Regular Meeting> has been reserved.

-Do you want to decorate the <Regular Meeting> place?

-Yes / No

Tap.

Without hesitation, I pressed ‘Yes’ and entered the map of the meeting place.

The only thing left was to fill the meeting place with items from my inventory.

Of course, since my inventory was poor, it didn’t take long to decorate the meeting place.

Daniel Hesrof.

He was a farmer who lived in Eberlint province.

He had spent his life raising livestock and had a unique skill of quietly slaughtering animals. He was called the silent butcher by his neighbors.

Thanks to that, Daniel had built up an unprecedented scale of ranch in Eberlint province.

But for Daniel, who had only raised beasts all his life, the sight he faced now was very unfamiliar.

Under a dark space.

People were sitting around a circular table.

A huge bone wearing clothes.

A shining angel flapping its wings.

And even an unidentified girl who moved shadows to get cake.

They were all suspicious-looking figures sitting around Daniel.

“Before we start the meeting, let us swear to our great one.”

And opposite to where Daniel was sitting, there was a man who looked like an evil leader.

His name was Roan Hebris.

According to his introduction, he was an archbishop of the order.

He was also the center of today's meeting.

Roan wore a luxurious robe and had charisma in his eyes as he looked at people.

Roan looked at all the attendees of the meeting, including Daniel, and raised one hand as if taking an oath.

“For our great one.”

-“For our great one.”

“For our great one.”

The voices of the attendees echoed in an instant as they raised their hands and shouted before the start of the meeting.

Blink. Blink.

Daniel blinked his eyes and stared blankly around him.

Then all the attendees' eyes focused on Daniel who was watching them.

Daniel raised his trembling hand and shouted at them as he felt their eyes on him.

“F-for our great one...”

“It seems you're a bit awkward because it's your first time. I understand completely.”

“...I'm ashamed before our great one.”

Daniel was an outsider who had nothing to do with them, but he realized that this place was very dangerous.

A meeting place where angels and undead coexisted.

They all had an extraordinary aura about them.

Gulp.

Daniel swallowed his saliva and lowered his arm, pretending to be calm.

As soon as Daniel followed their slogan, Roan looked around and started the meeting.

“You must have all come here by the call of our great one, but there are many people I don’t know.”

-“I agree.”

“So let me ask you to introduce yourselves first, starting with those who see me for the first time.”

Roan’s eyes moved to the undead next to him, asking for an introduction.

The undead was nothing but bones, but had a huge physique.

Daniel looked at the undead with a tense gaze.

The undead’s mouth clattered, and a bleak voice echoed in Daniel’s ears.

- ◦ “Call me Arcrosis.”

“What! The legendary necromancer Arcrosis!”

-“You seem to know me well.”

Necromancer Arcrosis.

Roan was shocked as he heard the name of the undead.

It was already horrifying to see an undead, let alone one with the nickname of necromancer.

Daniel was also startled to hear Arcrosis's identity from Roan's mouth.

Arcrosis finished his introduction, and this time it was the turn of the black-haired girl next to him.

She spoke in a bored voice, resting her chin on her hand and looking at Roan.

"I'm Pluto Astria."

"Ah, no! The progenitor of vampires Pluto!"

"You know me too?"

Pluto Astria.

Roan was shocked again as he heard the name of the girl.

Vampires were monsters that sucked human blood in ancient times.

But the leader of those vampires, the progenitor, was here.

Daniel felt a chill run down his spine as he heard Pluto's introduction.

The faces of the attendees in this meeting were more impressive than he expected.

Pluto's next was the angel with wings spread out.

The angel fluttered its wings and explained itself to Roan.

"Estasia."

"Yes. I heard your introduction well."

"..."

Unlike before, Roan didn't give any further explanation.

Estasia looked at Roan with a cold gaze.

But Roan didn't care about Estasia's gaze and just stared at Daniel who was next to her.

Gulp.

Daniel met Roan's eyes and swallowed again.

Roan looked at Daniel with a seemingly friendly face and opened his mouth.

"There's one left."

"That's right."

"Who are you?"

All eyes in the meeting place turned to Daniel.

It was Daniel's turn to reveal his identity.

Could he reveal his identity among these great people?

Complex thoughts crossed Daniel's mind.

But even then, time kept passing by.

Unable to withstand the pressure of time, Daniel stiffened his face and revealed his identity.

"Daniel Hesrof."

"Daniel? If you don't mind, can I ask what people call you around here?"

"People call me Daniel the silent butcher."

“Daniel the silent butcher... You must be a born assassin with great skills.”

“...”

Where did it all go wrong?

In the midst of growing misunderstandings, Daniel just nodded quietly.

He would have corrected everything if he had courage, but unfortunately, Daniel didn't have that kind of courage.

In Daniel's silence, Roan continued the meeting.

Chapter 77: Order Meeting (2)

Chapter 77: Order Meeting (2)

The meeting of the Order, which started with self-introductions, continued for several hours.

The food supply plan of the Order.

The plan to clean up the factions within Lithua-Centrius.

The plan to expand the communication network between the Ceterant branch and the main mountain of the Order, etc.

As an outsider, Daniel had a hard time understanding what these plans were about.

He had no choice but to watch their conversation with his mouth shut for all that time.

There was nothing he could say as a mere farmer among them.

It was natural that he would get hungry after watching the meeting for hours.

Daniel tried to eat the bread that was in front of him.

But every time he reached for the bread, Estasia, who was next to him, kept taking the bread he was aiming for.

“.....”

It happened not once, but several times.

Because Estasia, who was next to him, kept taking the bread, Daniel had to watch the meeting on an empty stomach.

Daniel, who watched Estasia's mischief, couldn't help but doubt that she was not an angel, but a devil.

Was she trying to give him a silent warning not to eat the bread?

Or was she claiming that all the bread here was hers?

The meeting continued in Daniel's troubled gaze.

"That's how it ends up."

"Is that so?"

"It can't be helped."

"I see."

Among the difficult topics of the meeting, there were some surprising stories for Daniel to hear.

They said they would use the miracle of weather control to increase food production.

Controlling the weather with a miracle.

Daniel, a simple farmer, couldn't even imagine such a thing.

If that was possible, the farmers wouldn't have to worry about droughts.

"By the way, what happened to that story?"

"Didn't you know?"

"No. I didn't get any report."

"Let me explain briefly."

Nevertheless, the participants talked about that topic as if it was natural.

They wanted to control the weather, clean up the factions in the city, and extend their influence over the entire empire.

The more he saw, the more frightening the Order was.

He couldn't even understand why he was invited to this meeting with these people.

If he understood their identities and the influence of the Order, he would know how valuable the information he heard was.

Most of that precious information went in one ear and out the other.

The meeting continued in a heated atmosphere, and before long it reached its end.

The topic they brought up at the end of the meeting was about preparing for war with the Holy Land.

“The long-term plan to increase the power of the Order is as we have discussed so far. If we have a little more time, the gap between us and the Holy Land will shrink.”

The Holy Land was a place that even Daniel, a farmer, knew.

The Holy Land, Crossbridge.

A neutral country that exerted its influence over the entire continent with six temples at its center.

They collected huge donations from most countries and mediated most of the conflicts on the continent.

What the Order was talking about was preparing for a full-scale confrontation with Crossbridge.

It was a worrying story for Daniel, who had to care for his children and grandchildren.

‘Could it be... I won’t be branded as a heretic and punished, will I?’

The Inquisitors of the Holy Land executed or converted those who believed in heretics.

And most of them lost their lives in the process of conversion.

It was a situation where Daniel could also be marked as a heretic for attending a meeting that prepared for a total war with the Holy Land.

Gulp.

Daniel swallowed his saliva as he listened to the content of the meeting.

It was a meeting where he doubted his ears as the topics went on.

“Is Centrius region going to be your base?”

“Yes. We plan to expand our influence throughout the Centrius region from Lithua-Centrius.”

“What about the troops that can use miracles?”

Roan, who waited for his question, answered him.

“We are organizing a holy army by gathering those who can use miracles among the believers.”

“Someday we might have to fight the whole Holy Land. If the Holy Land intervenes, the Empire will join them too.”

“I think the Empire won’t have the strength to join if the great one releases more monsters like Cuebaerg, but...”

Roan’s story was about Cuebaerg, who warned Evan about the Empire’s participation.

Cuebaerg was also a familiar name to Daniel's ears.

Cuebaerg's activity area was not far from the Everlint region where he lived.

The monster that destroyed a city was notorious even in his area.

They said that the being called 'the great one' released such a monster.

If the great one really intervened, it would not be difficult to shake the whole empire.

Evan shook his head at Roan's mention of Cuebaerg and disagreed with his opinion.

"We shouldn't rely too much on the great one. We have to prove to him that we are useful."

"I agree with you to some extent. Then, Arcrosis, what do you think about the movement of the empire..."

The conversation moved to the necromancer who was listening to them.

Clack. Clack.

Arcrosis, who was wearing old clothes, opened his mouth to them.

A cold aura spread out and his voice came clearly to Daniel's ears.

-“I made a contract with the black mages in the northern part of the empire.”

“Black mages in the north? You mean...”

-“They are called Abyss. They are not bad in terms of potential. When the time comes, countless undead armies will move.”

This time, it was about the black mage organization led by Arcrosis.

Monsters and holy army.

And even angels.

It was enough to be a formidable force.

But now, there was an undead legion led by black mages added to that.

The danger of the Order, which had risen as much as it could in Daniel's mind, broke through the ceiling and rose another level.

Daniel felt dizzy in front of Roan, who exclaimed with excitement.

“Abyss... The great one's foresight is beyond my reach!”

“Even if a war breaks out, the undead army will distract the empire's attention for a while.”

“That's right. We only need to be careful of the war with the Holy Land.”

If Abyss joined the war, the empire's attention would have to turn to them.

That was Roan's conclusion after hearing Arcrosis's story.

The conversation started to flow in a positive direction according to the plan of joining Abyss and the black mages.

They discussed how to attack the Holy Land while suppressing the empire.

Daniel nodded his head and agreed with them.

Meanwhile, the meeting time passed quickly.

“Well. I think this is enough for today's meeting!”

As most of the military topics were over, Roan looked around the participants and said.

Maybe it was because Roan's voice was loud.

Estasia, who had eaten all the bread and fallen asleep, opened her eyes and lifted her head.

The long meeting was finally over.

Daniel, who was uncomfortable, sighed with relief and prepared to get up.

“Is this the end of the meeting?”

Evan also got up from his seat and asked Roan.

Roan nodded his head and answered him.

“Yes. This space will disappear soon.”

“It was quite useful.”

“I think so too.”

Eutenia also agreed with Evan’s words and got up from her seat.

Evan’s gaze went to Eutenia, who was getting up.

His eyes lingered on the ring on her hand.

It was the ring that everyone who attended the meeting had.

Swoosh.

Evan pointed to her ring with a wink as he looked at Eutenia’s ring.

“By the way, Eutenia. You’re wearing a ring on your left ring finger.”

Eutenia lifted her hand with the ring on it at Evan’s question.

The ring was on her fourth finger of her left hand.

Eutenia looked at the ring and smiled happily.

She stroked the ring with her finger and spoke loud enough for Evan to hear.

“Doesn’t it suit me best here?”

“Is that what you think?”

“I have no one but the great one left. Wearing it on the left ring finger, which is connected to the heart, means that I will dedicate my heart to the great one forever.”

Eutenia spoke of her blind devotion to the great one.

As far as Daniel knew, everyone here revered the great one.

But this woman named Eutenia seemed to be more fanatical than them.

Daniel admired her faith and got up from his seat.

Everyone was ready to leave, so he thought he would quietly slip out with them.

“Did it have that meaning on your left ring finger?”

But Roan asked a question after hearing Eutenia’s story, and the atmosphere of leaving the meeting was interrupted.

Eutenia nodded her head with a smile on her face to Roan.

Her gentle voice echoed throughout the meeting room.

“Of course, it does for me.”

“Really? Then I have to wear it on my ring finger right away.”

“What?”

“It means that I will dedicate my heart to the great one!”

Right after that, Roan put the ring he was wearing on his left ring finger.

The smile disappeared from Eutenia's face, who was talking to Roan.

She was not the only one who reacted to Roan's oath.

Pluto also got up from his seat and spoke to everyone.

"That, that's what it was? I have to change it and wear it right away."

Pluto took off the ring he had on his middle finger and put it on his left ring finger.

The ring on Pluto's ring finger reflected the light of the halo on Estasia's head.

Next was Estasia, who was next to him.

Estasia also took off her ring and put it on her left ring finger.

She smiled happily and flapped her wings as she said.

"By doing this... maybe he'll let me off for a day even if I don't work."

Seeing Estasia flapping her wings, Arcrosis, who was across from her, was not still either.

Arcrosis got up from his seat with a sinister aura and pulled out his ring from his finger that had nothing but bones left.

Clatter. Clatter.

The sound of his finger bones scraping against the ring rang out.

- "It had that meaning. I'll join in too."

With that, Arcrosis put the ring on his left ring finger bone.

The ring wobbled because there was no flesh on it.

But Arcrosis didn't seem to care and just moved his eerie hand.

As most of the participants moved their rings, their eyes naturally turned to Daniel.

Roan, who was looking at the ring on Daniel's finger, asked him.

"Daniel. What about you?"

Daniel's mind was full of confusion as he faced Roan.

He was careful not to let his true feelings show and shook his head to refuse Roan's suggestion.

Wearing a ring on the left ring finger was a ritual for lovers.

And Daniel already had a loving wife.

"I have a wife."

"Is that all your loyalty to the great one?"

"..."

Sigh.

Daniel took off the ring he had on his index finger.

He wondered if this ring was the cause of everything.

He picked it up because it looked expensive and rolled on the floor, but when he came to his senses, he was dragged into an unknown space.

And everyone in this space had rings on their hands.

The only thing in common between them and Daniel was the ring on their hand.

'I wish I never came here again.'

Daniel smiled as he put the ring on his ring finger and looked around.

The Order, the Holy Land, and the black mages.

They had nothing to do with Daniel.

With Daniel's wish not to come back here again, the regular meeting of the Order came to an end.

Chapter 78: Order Meeting (3)

Chapter 78: Order Meeting (3)

When the regular meeting of the Order was over, Daniel opened his eyes on a pile of soft hay.

He got up from the hay with cold sweat and looked around.

How much sweat did he shed while he was sleeping?

He felt a chill down his spine as he looked around.

He breathed heavily with a troubled look on his face.

“Hoo, hoo...”

He was dragged into an unknown group called the Order until a moment ago.

But when he opened his eyes, he was in his ranch as usual.

It was a short but long moment of horror. Was it a dream or reality?

He saw a gemstone ring on his hand.

The ring on his left ring finger was the same as the one he saw at the meeting.

He was startled and stepped back.

“Hu... Huk...!”

He remembered the participants who wore rings on their left ring fingers.

It was the ring that the apostle named Eutenia wore on her finger.

The ring on Daniel's ring finger was proof that what he had seen was not a dream.

He was shocked to see the ring and quickly took it off his finger.

It was an expensive-looking ring with a gemstone, but to him, it was nothing but a cursed object.

He buried the ring in the hay.

"This... this filthy ring."

He buried it deep in the hay so that it would be hard to find it again if he ever wanted to sell it.

The ring that connected him to the Order was the most terrible thing for him.

The Order that was preparing for a war with the Holy Land.

If he was exposed by the Inquisitors of the Holy Land, Daniel and his family would not be safe.

After burying the ring, Daniel looked around and ran out of the stable.

When Daniel came out of the stable, his wife Anna Heslop was waiting for him.

"Honey! Why are you so late today?"

"...I had some trouble."

Anna looked at him suspiciously up and down.

She must have come to look for him because he didn't come out of the stable for a long time.

He was late because he attended the meeting of the Order.

But even if she asked him why, he couldn't explain anything about the Order.

Daniel gave up on explaining to Anna.

And he pretended to be normal and walked towards the house.

As Daniel started to walk back to the house, Anna called his name from the front of the stable.

She seemed to have something else to say to him.

He thought she would ask him some annoying questions and asked her impatiently.

“What?”

“What's that ring on your ring finger?”

Anna's question about the ring made Daniel look at his hand.

His left hand was covered with dust from the hay.

There was a ring with a gemstone on his ring finger.

Daniel backed away as soon as he saw it.

The ring he had taken off and buried in the hay had somehow returned to his finger.

“Aaaah! Why is this here!”

“Are you trying to give it to me as a gift?”

Anna approached him with a hopeful look on her face, seeing the ring on Daniel's finger.

But Daniel shook his head and denied it firmly.

It was a cursed object that made him attend the Order's meeting whenever he wore it.

It was a perfect way to get caught by the Inquisitors of the Holy Land and cause a tragedy.

Daniel didn't have the courage to give such a thing to Anna.

He took off the ring from his finger again and hid it behind his back.

"This is... not like that!"

"Then what is it?"

Daniel's hand holding the ring trembled.

He had buried it in the hay to avoid any trouble, but somehow it came back to his hand.

He had to face the headache-inducing situation that he had tried so hard to avoid.

What could he say to fend off Anna's inquiries?

He sighed and decided to confront her head-on.

"This is..."

"What is that ring?"

"It's something to throw away."

As soon as he finished his sentence, he steadied himself and threw the ring far away.

The ring left his hand and flew fast, rolling down the hill.

If he couldn't explain the ring properly, he thought he should get rid of it somewhere it couldn't come back to his hand.

He saw the ring flying away in front of his eyes and Anna's eyes sparkled.

She hit his shoulder hard and expressed her anger with a furious voice.

"Honey! Why did you throw away that expensive-looking ring!"

"This ring is cursed..."

"Why did you throw it away!"

"No, this ring is evil..."

"Why did you throw away that expensive thing!"

No matter what he said, Anna didn't listen to his story.

She only hit his back harder with her hand.

He looked blankly at the hill where the ring had disappeared.

He had acted for his family's sake, but all he got was a harsh hand.

No matter how much time passed, Anna would never understand his actions.

The next morning.

Daniel was busy with his work at the slaughterhouse, holding a butcher knife.

Around him, there were neatly cut pieces of meat.

He was nicknamed the Silent Butcher, and he dismantled the livestock with skillful technique.

He had the best knife skills in Everlint, as everyone agreed.

“Hmm... I feel something hard stuck on the knife.”

As he was cutting the animals, Daniel felt a strange sensation on his knife and stopped.

His butchering skills were so refined that he could tell where the knife should go without looking.

But today, his knife was not moving smoothly.

He sensed something odd and twisted the knife's path to cut around it.

Squish. Squish.

Something caught his eye as he handled the meat with his expert knife skills.

“...What is this?”

He reached out and pulled out the foreign object that was between the meat.

It was a metal ring soaked in blood.

He used a cloth to wipe off the ring, and then he recognized what it was.

A gold ring with a gemstone in the center.

It was the same ring that he had thrown away yesterday down the hill.

He dropped his knife in shock and backed away.

“Aaaaaah! Why! Why is it here!”

The ring that Daniel had thrown away came back to him.

Daniel's eyes, filled with horror, looked at the ring of the cult.

No matter how he hid it or threw it away, it always returned.

Daniel Hesroff was destined to never escape from that gold ring.

He looked at his other hand, which had dropped the knife.

Then, a trembling voice came out of his mouth.

“Ah... don’t tell me...”

Even as he dropped the knife in surprise, the ring was still on his hand.

Vroom.

The ring on his hand vibrated.

The gemstone on the ring sparkled as it caught the sunlight from the window.

“Why is that skeleton wearing a ring on his pinky finger and making a fuss?”

I muttered as I looked at the smartphone screen with beer and snacks on the table, after the <Regular Meeting> of the cult had ended.

The first <Regular Meeting> of the cult was rather dull than I expected.

After all, considering that the characters in the meeting room were just chatting among themselves, there was nothing much to talk about besides the cult.

I couldn’t interfere with the characters during the meeting either.

From my perspective, all I could do was watch their actions while drinking beer.

The guy named Daniel who participated in the meeting also didn't complain about his position until the end.

If I knew where he was, I would have gone to see him, but it was hard to watch him when I couldn't even locate him.

-The <Regular Meeting> has ended.

-There is a cooldown time before the next meeting can be held.

As soon as the meeting ended, the screen switched to where Eutania was, and a message box popped up with the message that the <Regular Meeting> was over.

The <Regular Meeting> skill had a cooldown time before the next meeting could be held.

I couldn't hold another meeting until the cooldown was over.

It wasn't a skill that had a cost, but it wasn't a skill that I could spam either.

And right now, I had no reason to hold another meeting, so I opened my inventory and checked the contents.

I wanted to check the status of the items that I had placed in the meeting room.

“They're really gone without a trace.”

As I scrolled down and checked my inventory, the breads that I had acquired from the gacha were completely gone from my inventory.

The breads that I had brought to the meeting room had all disappeared.

Eutania and Estasia had eaten the bread happily during the meeting, and they ended up eating all of it.

Since there was no more bread left in my inventory, I had to spin the gacha again to fill it up.

I sighed and looked at my inventory, which had become empty.

“Sigh... I’ll have to spin the gacha a few more times when I get paid in a few days.”

Eutania ate a lot of cake, but Estasia ate more bread.

Estasia, who usually only ate fruits, ate a lot of bread this time for some reason.

I didn’t know how many times I had to spin the gacha to replenish what they ate.

Of course, there wasn’t only spending on bread in this <Regular Meeting>.

I also had a modest income from the <Regular Meeting>.

I couldn’t understand this income, though.

I lifted my head and looked at the message written at the top of the message box.

-[Daniel Hesroff] has acquired the <Fanatic> trait.

-Karma has increased by 1.

Daniel Hesroff.

He was the guy who introduced himself as the Silent Butcher.

He was the mysterious character who became my follower after participating in this meeting.

Lately, I only gained followers through the cult, so

it had been a long time since I saw a message like this.

I chuckled naturally when I saw Daniel’s message.

“Why are you a fanatic?”

He was the character who accidentally clicked on the wrong thing and gave me a ring while trying to aim at the flying Arcrosis.

But he became my fanatic after just one meeting.

It was a hard-to-understand sight for me.

He seemed to lack motivation to become my follower.

Was there a reason to become a fanatic just because he received a ring and attended the meeting?

As I pondered, I recalled the meeting content and found a plausible answer.

“Maybe... he was moved by my generosity of investing hundreds of thousands of won every month for them?”

Who else in the world would be as generous as me for their followers?

Not long ago, I gave a holy relic to an apostle while eating ramen.

I was intoxicated by my own generosity and muttered nonsense while drinking a can of beer alone.

Thunk.

As I put down the can of beer that I had lifted, a new message popped up at the bottom of the screen.

I stared blankly at the message box.

“...What is this?”

It wasn't a message related to Daniel or the <Regular Meeting>.

Rather, it was a message that came up for a completely unexpected reason.

Swish.

I scrolled down and looked closely at the new message.

The new message was related to the <Divine Response Device>.

-The accumulated divine contribution points in the <Divine Response Device> have exceeded the threshold.

-From now on, you can share the <Eye of the Observer> skill with the targets who have the <Fanatic> trait.

The skill that I had since the start of the game, <Eye of the Observer>.

It was a message that said that I could now share it with the characters of the cult.

Chapter 79: The Sword of Fire (1)

Chapter 79: The Sword of Fire (1)

Inside the carriage that was leaving the Ketterland region.

There, Gilford was bowing his head with a dark expression.

In his hand, he held Ascalon, which had been drawn out of its sheath.

His eyes, which looked at Ascalon while bowing his head, were filled with frustration and despair.

Not only Gilford, but also all the mercenaries, including Jenny, had gloomy faces.

The death of Gaff, who had been the vice-captain of Gilford's mercenary band, was a significant event for them.

"...Gaff."

Gilford, who was leaning on Ascalon, muttered Gaff's name.

He was his friend before he was his vice-captain, and also his comrade who had fought through every battlefield with him.

He had once been his rival, too. But now that he was gone, all that was left for Gilford was emptiness.

His eyes, clouded with confusion, looked at the most sacred sword in the world.

Even though it shone brightly, Gilford's eyes were still dull.

Ascalon spoke to him, who was staring blankly at the sword.

-“Your divinity has grown by one level.”

“...”

-“If you grow a little more, you will gain a different power. You won’t have to run away helplessly like before.”

It was a message that Ascalon had become stronger by one level in Gilford’s hand.

Strength.

It was something that he would have been happy about normally.

Gilford would have pursued strength more than anyone else in the past.

He dreamed of becoming stronger to help people, shake off his obscurity, and collect gold.

But now, he couldn’t feel happy even when he heard that he had become stronger.

His strength had no meaning in front of the evil god’s power that he had faced.

Gilford looked at Ascalon with his cracked lips and opened his mouth.

“Is that... so important?”

Being a mercenary was dangerous as well.

They always stood on the edge of life and death, and a moment’s mistake could cause the loss of the mercenary band.

He had lost countless comrades so far.

But Gilford had fallen into a deeper sorrow than ever before, because Gaff was a more special existence to him than anyone else.

Facing the sacred light that flickered in front of his eyes, Gilford bit his dry and cracked lips.

-“Think about the battles that will come.”

“The battles that will come...?”

-“Aren’t you a hero? No matter what you have gone through, or what you think, you have something that you must do.”

“A hero... yes. I was.”

It was as Ascalon said.

Gilford Proud was a hero.

He was chosen by the Goddess of Abundance, and he possessed the divine sword Ascalon.

His heroic duty never vanished, even when he was broken and bent.

Ascalon’s voice pierced his ears, who held the sword.

-“You have experienced war. It is losing what you cherish countless times, and declaring victory on top of a pile of corpses.”

-“There is no other meaning to war.”

A bitter laugh escaped from Gilford’s lips.

He had lost his friend.

And he had lost his comrades.

After losing what he cherished, there was only one thing left for Gilford.

Duty.

The eternal duty that weighed down on his back.

“Ascalon. What exactly is a hero?”

—“.....”

“What is so great about being a hero, that I have to.....”

Gilford’s hand tightened around Ascalon.

The weight of the hilt in his grip was heavy.

He could see the image of Gaff, who vanished screaming on the sharp blade.

This was a curse.

As long as he carried the burden of a hero, he would never escape the shadows of his comrades.

—“Do you think the load you bear is too heavy?”

“What am I supposed to.....”

No one wants to lose anyone.

Jenny, Gaff, and the countless mercenaries who followed him.

He didn’t want to lose any of them.

But he also wanted to protect them all.

He wanted to free all the people who suffered because of the evil god.

Even though he knew it was impossible, Gilford wished for it.

Because that’s what a hero does.

“What did I covet for, in the first place?”

He remembered the faces of the mercenaries who drank heavily and laughed with him.

Gilford wanted all the mercenaries who followed him to stay with him until the end.

He wanted them to be with him until they grew old and retired from being mercenaries.

Even when they were too old to fight, he wanted to meet them with their wrinkled faces and share a beer.

-He refused to give up on his mercenary band.

He wanted them to stick with him until the end of this arduous journey.

He wanted them to accompany him in the future, just like they had overcome all the ordeals together so far.

But the enemy was a completely different beast from anything they had faced before.

“Did I... kill Gaff...?”

The evil god’s minion.

Its power covered the sky and sliced through the earth.

It was a forbidden act for ordinary humans to oppose them.

The chosen ones who were called heroes.

Only they could stand against the evil god.

He foolishly ignored that fact and led his comrades to fight against the evil god.

He believed that he could defeat the enemy with his comrades, as he always did.

And this was the result.

He became a loser who fled from the shadow of the evil god after losing his comrade.

“Boss...”

Jenny, who had been watching him from the side, reached out her hand towards Gilford’s shoulder.

Her slender fingers covered Gilford’s shoulder.

But even so, it felt like a rock was pressing down on his shoulder.

Gilford, who had been staring at Ascalon with bloodshot eyes, shook off her hand.

“I... killed Gaff with my own hands.”

The light that leaked from Ascalon gradually dimmed.

In it, Gilford howled.

A beast-like scream came out of his mouth.

Sighs and cries.

In front of the pain that tore his throat, he had to make a choice.

Would he fight until only one remained?

Or would he fight with one left?

The fight against the evil god was different from the heroic tales he had imagined.

-“Hardships and trials are what make a hero.”

A mercenary and a hero could not coexist.

Gilford realized that after he lost all the possibilities of his future that supported him.

It had been a few days since <Regular Meeting> ended.

During that time, I tested various minor things in the game.

Things like checking how far I could share basic skills, including <Eye of Observation>.

Or changing the authority sharing settings of <Divine Response Device> over and over again.

Needless to say, there was only one person who could share <Eye of Observation> with me: Roan.

That was because it required a higher divine contribution limit than other skills.

“Sigh...”

Time passed without any significant results.

In the passing time, I repeated work and games with a bored feeling.

And then, when the rainy season that poured down heavily stopped and the suffocating heat returned,

I was able to face the moment I had been looking forward to.

Payday.

It was the day that everyone who lived in the modern world eagerly awaited.

“Finally, this day has come.”

There was no one who wouldn't be happy to see the amount of money that came into their bank account on payday.

Except for the money that went out, it was also the most relaxed day than any other time.

It was enough to make me think that it would be okay to buy some beer and chicken on my way home from work.

Once I had made up my mind, there was no reason to hesitate.

I packed some chicken on my way home from work and returned to my house.

And as soon as I entered the house, I threw my luggage and immediately placed the chicken on the table.

“How long has it been since I ate chicken?”

The first thing I did after washing the beer and arranging the chicken was to check the balance in my bank account again.

I opened the bank application and checked my account, and I could see the balance of my account that was more solid than usual.

It was an amount that made me feel reassured just by looking at it.

At the same time, in my head, the consumption plan for this month repeated fiercely rising and disappearing.

Among the plans that came to mind, of course, there was also a plan to spend money on mobile games.

“Come to think of it... maybe I should try some gacha for a change.”

Chick.

I opened the beer can on the table and then tore off a piece of crispy chicken.

The smell of greasy chicken filled my mouth.

The taste of chicken eaten on payday was more special than usual.

I moistened my oily mouth with beer and then turned on my smartphone and ran the game.

With a grease-free hand, I swiped the loading screen and the familiar game play screen appeared.

“It doesn’t look like any important messages popped up while I was away.”

Swipe.

I moved my finger to check the message box, and then shifted my gaze to the <Paid Currency Shop> button at the top of the screen.

When was the last time I did a gacha?

From what I could remember, it was probably when I got the magic book for <Control Weather>.

It had been quite a long time since I did a 10-pull in the <Paid Currency Shop>.

Since I got paid today, I decided to go all out and do some gacha.

“Let’s go for 30 pulls this time.”

I touched the <Paid Currency Shop> button on the screen.

The screen went dark for a moment, and then the gacha screen that I hadn’t seen for a long time greeted me.

The 10-pull button that glowed brightly.

And below it, the price tag for 10 pulls.

The 10-pull was still the same price as it was back then.

It hadn't changed at all since the last time I did a gacha.

“Please... give me 30 magic books.”

I had done many 10-pulls before, but this was the first time I did 30 pulls at once.

I touched the 10-pull button with a pounding heart.

Hoping that all 10 would be magic books.

As soon as I touched the gacha button, a flash of light appeared on the screen, and then the results of the gacha started to appear one by one.

I checked the items that came out of the gacha with tense eyes.

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Sponge Cake].

The first items that appeared were all bread.

It wouldn't be a bad situation if some decent items came out later.

I was running low on bread anyway, thanks to Estasia who ate a lot of bread at the <Regular Meeting>.

I kept an eye on the gacha items with anticipation for magic books.

-You have acquired [Sponge Cake].

- You have acquired [Baguette].
- You have acquired [Magic Sword: Lagius].
- You have acquired [Baguette].
- You have acquired [Apple Pie].
- You have acquired [Apple Pie].
- You have acquired [Baguette].

Sponge cake. Baguette. Apple pie.

I couldn't help but make a dumbfounded expression as I saw the items that came out one after another.

Except for [Magic Sword: Lagius], they were all edible items.

I looked at the smartphone that was lying on the floor and chuckled sarcastically as I swiped the screen.

“Are you telling me to open a bakery or something?”

It was true that I needed more bread in my inventory, because Estasia had eaten a lot of bread at the <Regular Meeting>.

But that didn't mean I wanted different kinds of bread.

The only consolation was that [Magic Sword: Lagius] appeared in the gacha.

It was the second time I got a magic sword from a 10-pull.

The appearance of the magic sword with a purple halo was a sharp dagger wrapped in darkness.

“I would have really opened a bakery if it wasn't for this.”

Unlike [Magic Sword: Ednos] that I got before, it looked practical.

[Magic Sword: Ednos] was more like a decoration, but [Magic Sword: Lagius] was sharp enough to use in real combat.

I had to check the details to be sure, but it didn't seem like a thing that focused on magic attacks.

Tap.

I touched the screen and brought up the detailed information of [Magic Sword: Lagius].

And then I started to read the traits of [Magic Sword: Lagius] with my eyes.

“The name of the trait is <Shadow Memory>... and the effect is...”

The name of the trait that [Magic Sword: Lagius] had was <Shadow Memory>.

And its effect was to move the user to the location where they activated the trait, after 10 seconds.

It was a trait specialized for hit-and-run tactics.

Chapter 80: Sword of Fire (2)

Chapter 80: Sword of Fire (2)

“It’s a bit awkward to give this weapon to Eutenia or Evan.”

The effect of <Shadow Memory> itself was decent for anyone who used it, but I couldn’t think of any character who looked suitable for wielding [Magic Sword: Lagius].

Eutenia preferred to fight by projecting her firepower from a fixed position.

Pluto had her device as her weapon, and Roan already had [Magic Sword: Ednos].

It was also difficult to give it to Evan, who mainly used long swords.

“The weapon looks like a dagger, and the trait seems to fit an assassin well.”

As I pondered, the image of Daniel, who introduced himself as the Silent Slayer, flashed through my mind.

The Silent Slayer.

It was a name that sounded like a formidable assassin to anyone.

A skill that I used wrongly had coincidentally brought an assassin to me.

Moreover, he had acquired the Fanatic and Assassin traits, so it wouldn’t be bad to give it to him if he was an assassin.

The problem was that I didn’t know where Daniel was.

I wanted to see his skills as the Silent Slayer, but it was hard to find him since I didn't know his location.

“Hmm... I'll put this on hold for now.”

I decided to postpone the disposal of [Magic Sword: Lagius] for later.

After making that decision, I moved the screen and closed the detailed description of the item.

Then I moved my finger to the draw button again.

This time, I decided to spin the 30 draws, so I still had 20 draws left.

Phew. I took a breath and touched the draw button with my left index finger.

This time, I hoped for a magic book.

“Please let there be at least one magic book this time.”

As soon as I pressed the button, light burst out from the screen and the draw items started to appear one by one.

My busy eyes quickly scanned over the results of the draw.

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Refined Robe].

-You have acquired [Sponge Cake].

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Magic Book: Feather Fall].

-You have acquired [Rusty Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Apple Pie].

-You have acquired [Apple Pie].

-You have acquired [Baguette].

Rusty iron swords. Refined robe.

Various kinds of breads.

And among them, a new magic book that shone brightly.

This time, more diverse items came out than before.

Along with various items and a magic book, this draw was also satisfactory in its own way.

“Ooh... A magic book came out.”

I touched the [Magic Book: Feather Fall] that appeared in the middle of the draw.

The graphic of the book enlarged and the information about [Magic Book: Feather Fall] appeared on the screen.

A simple description below said that you could learn <Feather Fall> magic by using it. There was also a detailed explanation of <Feather Fall> magic written below.

It reduces the falling speed of the target and mitigates the damage caused by falling.

That was the effect of <Feather Fall> magic.

I looked at the magic book with an ambiguous expression after checking the effect of <Feather Fall> magic.

“It’s not an attack... nor is it a defense.”

It was indeed a magic book that I had been looking forward to, but the effect of the magic was vague.

It was neither an offensive magic like <Lightning>, nor a defensive magic like <Barrier>.

It had no other effect than reducing the falling damage of falling objects.

It was a magic that could only be targeted when in a falling state, so it was not even something that I could use.

It was only applicable to characters who fell from high places.

I intended to register the magic in <Divine Response Device> after giving it to Eutenia and having her learn <Feather Fall> magic.

If there was no <Divine Response Device>, I wouldn't have even thought of giving it back to her after handing it over.

I finished judging [Magic Book: Feather Fall] and looked at the draw button again for the last draw.

“This is the 30th one.”

The draw results so far were decent enough.

Both the first and second draws had magic swords and magic books.

There were 10 draws left until the end.

If there were good items in the last draw as well, today's draw would be a complete success.

I stopped my finger in front of the shining draw button.

And I started to count the timing in my mind.

“Let's go.”

Three. Two. And one.

As soon as the number in my mind ended, I pressed the draw button and spun the 10 draws.

As before, light leaked out and the draw items appeared one by one.

I stared at the screen of my smartphone with wide eyes, checking the halo behind the items.

-You have acquired [Sponge Cake].

-You have acquired [Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Crude Dagger].

-You have acquired [Crude Dagger].

-You have acquired [Apple Pie].

-You have acquired [Baguette].

-You have acquired [Refined Tunic].

-You have acquired [Apple Pie].

There was no halo behind the items during the nine items that came out.

Gulp.

I swallowed unconsciously as I watched the draw.

There was only one item left to come out.

If the last item was also a junk item, then this 10 draws would be completely ruined.

I looked at the last item with tense eyes.

-You have acquired [Floating Soil].

As the last item appeared, a green halo shone behind it, and the 10 draws were finished.

The green halo was an effect that I couldn't find in any of the items so far.

It also meant that I had acquired an item that was different from the previous items.

With the screen glowing green, I looked at the appearance of the item.

“[Floating Soil]? It doesn't look like a magic sword, a magic book, or a holy relic.”

[Floating Soil] was an item that looked like a lump of clay.

It was a special item with a halo effect, but it didn't have categories like holy relics or magic books like the existing items.

It meant that it was an item that was different from the others in terms of classification.

It looked like it would be hard to guess what it was for without checking it out for myself.

“What kind of item is this?”

What on earth is this lump of clay for?

I closed the store and opened the inventory to solve my curiosity.

Thanks to the increased operation speed from playing the game for several months, it took less than two seconds to close the store and open the inventory.

When I opened the inventory, there was a round lump of clay among the items I had acquired from the draw.

Squeeze.

I touched [Floating Soil] to check the details of the item.

-[Floating Soil] is an earth spirit.

-Feed [Floating Soil] some soil.

-It grows well when it eats soil.

When I read the detailed description of [Floating Soil], it didn't have any characteristics unlike other items.

Instead, there were various explanations about [Floating Soil].

The fact that [Floating Soil] was an earth spirit, and that [Floating Soil] could be fed soil.

And finally, the fact that [Floating Soil] grew well when fed soil.

The last description was especially human-like.

It was completely different from the stiff descriptions of the items I had encountered so far.

“Did someone else translate the last two lines?”

Snicker.

A chuckle escaped from my mouth as I looked at the item description.

In the knight commander's office at Crossbridge.

There, Knight Commander Revelz looked at Serena with cold eyes.

Serena stood in front of Revelz with her head bowed.

She held the broken rosary of Lian in her hand.

The long-awaited reunion of mother and daughter took place in a chilly silence.

Serena, who hesitated in front of Revelz, opened her mouth while caressing the rosary.

“I…….”

Thud.

Serena’s words did not continue to the end.

No matter what she said here, this incident was entirely Serena’s fault.

She knew that too, so she couldn’t go on with her words.

She had lost a person who was equivalent to the vice-commander of the Holy Knight Order by her judgment.

Losing the owner of the holy sword was a painful loss for the entire holy land.

Revelz, who was facing Serena, raised his right hand.

“Ugh……!”

Slap!

Revelz’s hand hit Serena’s cheek.

He had moved his hand without force, so Serena didn’t stagger after being hit.

Serena’s cheek turned red from Revelz’s slap.

Her eyes were moist as she held her cheek.

Was it from the pain of being slapped?

Or was it from the sorrow of losing a knight?

Either way, Revelz's feelings were complicated as he looked at her.

"Serena."

".....Yes."

Revelz looked at his hand that had hit his daughter.

It was the first time he had raised his hand against her.

He had never needed to do that before, nor did he want to.

But this time, he couldn't bear it.

The Serena in front of him was not only his daughter, but also the saintess who oversaw the entire Temple of Abundance.

She had to bear the responsibility for what she had done.

"I won't blame you any more for bringing the hero here."

"Yes."

"This is an order from His Holiness. Stay in the temple and reflect on your actions for a while."

".....I understand."

A reflection order.

That was the command of the Holy Emperor for Serena, who had left the holy land without permission.

Serena, who had received the order from the Holy Emperor, moved toward the door with her head bowed.

She opened the door of the knight commander's office with a weak hand.

Revelz watched Serena leave and said his last words to her back.

"I will inform you of the details of your punishment after the elders' meeting is over."

Bang.

The door of the knight commander's office closed after Serena left.

I had already assigned another task to the lieutenant, so now only Gilford and Revelz were left in the knight commander's office.

Revelz's gaze turned to Gilford.

He slowly looked at the hero who was a former mercenary.

"Gilford Proud."

A sturdy muscle and a sharp eye.

He looked like an excellent warrior even to the naked eye.

Gilford, who was called by Revelz, faced him and answered.

".....I'm listening."

"I have a lot of things I want to say to you personally, but today you have many people waiting for you, so it will be difficult."

"Is that so."

"Then I'll ask you one thing."

There was only one question left for Revelz to ask the hero who had not come to the holy land for a long time after the mark appeared.

Revelz asked Gilford with a cold expression.

“Why didn’t you come to the holy land for so long?”

The reason why Gilford didn’t come to the holy land.

He asked about the reason why Saintess Serena had to mobilize Lian as her escort and go after him.

Gilford’s face darkened at Revelz’s question.

He looked back and forth between Ascalon, which was attached to his waist, and Revelz, who was in front of him.

After a long time of looking between them, Gilford opened his mouth with a low voice.

“I just thought there was no reason to come.”

“No reason to come?”

Saying that there was no reason to come to the holy land was tantamount to denying the representative of the holy land.

It was also a kind of insult to the holy land in some sense.

Gilford, who was looking at Revelz, continued to answer his question.

“I have comrades, so I thought I could be helpful even if I moved separately with them.”

“……That’s an arrogant thought.”

“It must seem that way.”

“Arrogance comes with a price.”

“That’s true. The price was quite heavy.”

Revelz could easily guess what the price was, seeing Gilford’s dark complexion.

Losing someone precious had caused a change in Gilford’s mind.

“Do you want to remain a hero?”

“I don’t intend to refuse my duty. The moment I stop in my place because I lost one thing, I will lose everything else that remains.”

“Then I’m glad.”

Fortunately, Revelz was a person who knew well how to deal with people like this.

He had been in the holy land for decades.

He had met many people like Gilford, and he himself had gone through such a period.

Thump. Thump.

Revelz’s footsteps echoed in the knight commander’s office as he approached Gilford.

“There’s no time. Gilford Proud. So I’ll make you an offer for the first and last time.”

Revelz reached out his hand to Gilford as he came close to him.

Knight Commander, Revelz Edelrant.

What he said was the best offer that the holy land could make to Gilford.

“I’ll hire your mercenary band as Saintess Serena’s escort. So join the expedition to Cuebaerg.”

Chapter 81: Sword of Fire (3)

Chapter 81: Sword of Fire (3)

As soon as I checked the items that came out of the 30 draws, I handed over the magic book to Eutenia, who was traveling in a carriage.

Eutenia, who received the [Magic Book: Feather Fall], thanked me as before and opened the book.

Pluto, who was next to her, also showed interest in the book, but soon lost interest in it and looked at the scenery around him again.

For a vampire, a human's magic book didn't seem to have much meaning.

That's why Pluto fiddled with his Death Scythe instead of the thick magic book in his hand.

“Well, it makes sense since he uses blood to cast magic.”

If there is a magic that suits vampires, there is no need to learn human magic.

As long as he accumulates enough sacred contribution points, he can borrow simple magic through the <Sacred Response Device>.

Besides, Pluto's [Divine Artifact: Death Scythe] has an effect of amplifying the power of blood magic.

It would be more effective in terms of output to use blood magic rather than ordinary magic.

I decided that and turned my attention away from Eutenia and Pluto.

Eutenia would offer the magic book as a tribute when she fully mastered the magic.

“Now it’s time to check this out...”

After moving my gaze away from Eutenia, I looked at my inventory and saw [Floating Soil] in one corner.

According to the item description, [Floating Soil] was an earth spirit that grew by eating soil.

Spirit.

A creature that often appears as a pet or an enemy monster in games or novels.

It looked more like a character or a monster than an item.

It felt awkward to see such a spirit in my inventory.

The category of [Floating Soil] seemed to be wrong somehow.

“It came out of the draw, so it must be an item, but it also seems more like a pet.”

Should I consider a pet as an item?

I thought about that and remembered the <Creature Maker> I used before.

If something like that was classified as a skill, there was no reason why I couldn’t classify a spirit as an item.

It wasn’t like there were no games that put pets in the inventory.

After pondering for a while, I decided to take out [Floating Soil] from my inventory.

“[Floating Soil], huh... Let’s see your face.”

Squeeze.

I opened my inventory and touched [Floating Soil] with my finger.

Then I dragged the item all the way and dropped [Floating Soil] on the empty plain.

The lump of soil that came out of the inventory revealed itself on the field.

Maybe it was because of the word ‘floating’ in front of it.

The lump of soil that was placed on the field showed a floating appearance that suited its name.

-“Soil.”

The lump of soil that floated in the air started to spin around in its place.

Above its head, if I could call it that, a speech bubble with the word ‘soil’ written on it appeared.

It was more important that a speech bubble appeared than whether I could call it a head or not.

It was a situation where the lump of soil was floating in the air by itself and even displaying a speech bubble.

It was a strange sight that didn’t look like a simple pet to anyone who saw it.

“What is this thing that can even talk?”

I couldn’t help but be flustered by the sight of [Floating Soil].

Usually, only humans or similar categories of characters display speech bubbles.

Even the dark beasts couldn’t show speech bubbles above their heads.

But this thing looked like a lump of soil and had a speech bubble on its head.

Was it because the race of spirits was special?

I watched the talking lump of soil to see how far it could speak.

-“Soil.”

“Hmm.”

-“Soil.”

“...”

-“Soil.”

But even as time passed, the lump of soil didn’t say anything other than ‘soil’.

Seeing [Floating Soil] repeating the same word, I tried to guess its intention somehow.

Could it only say soil?

Or was it asking for soil?

Considering the description of [Floating Soil] that said it grew well by eating soil, either one was a plausible story.

“Is that thing asking for soil?”

I was troubled by [Floating Soil]’s request for soil.

Unfortunately, I didn’t have any magic that could feed it soil.

Most of the magic I learned was about breaking and destroying things.

I didn't bother with anything other than attack magic because they were not helpful for hunting.

It was very difficult for me to feed it soil directly, even if it asked me to.

-“Soil.”

“I wonder if it will say something else if I hit it.”

Instead of feeding it soil, I touched the lump of soil on the screen and nudged it slightly.

Shiver.

It shook its body once and spun around in its place.

Then it looked up at the sky and showed another speech bubble above its head.

It had one more letter than before.

-“Soil-soil.”

I stared at the lump of soil with a speech bubble with a blank look.

It seemed that my guess that it could only say soil was true.

My eyes moved from the lump of soil on the screen to the pile of soil on the ground.

Despite the soil scattered around, it didn't eat any of it.

It seemed that it couldn't eat soil by itself and needed someone else to feed it.

As I wondered how to feed it soil, I saw a new speech bubble that the lump of soil displayed.

-“Water.”

“...”

I had to revise my hypothesis based on the new speech bubble.

It wasn't that it could only repeat the same word.

It was just asking me for soil.

Now it was asking for water.

I looked at [Floating Soil] coldly and moved my eyes to the skill icon at the bottom of the screen.

-You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

-The effect of <Weather Control> will last for one day.

If it wanted water so much, I should feed it myself.

I used <Weather Control> to create a storm over a wide area.

It was a kind of stress relief to shake off the strange feeling I got from talking to the lump of soil.

The characters in the village that was included in the range of <Weather Control> hurriedly ran into their houses to avoid the rain.

I continued to spam <Weather Control> and scattered storms everywhere the village was.

[Floating Soil], who was caught in the storm, also floated up and soaked wet.

-“Soil.”

The lump of soil that spun fiercely as if it was a god.

I couldn't help but chuckle at the sight.

An earth spirit that I feed soil and water with my own hands.

It reminded me of the palm tree I used to grow when I was young.

Of course, the palm tree dried up and died because I didn't water it often.

“Do I have to raise soil by feeding it and watering it when it's not even a character I can make into a disciple?”

Leaving the lump of soil that was happy in the rain, I started to look for another way to raise it.

Fortunately, I had several AI macros at my disposal.

If I couldn't raise it with my own hands, I could let someone else do it for me.

I moved the screen busily to find Evan, who would be somewhere in the Order.

Evan Allemier.

He was the second apostle of the Order, and he stretched his stiff body as he walked toward the clearing that was made in the back mountain of the Order.

After the overthrow of Lithua-Centurios, he stayed in the Order and taught swordsmanship to the young ones.

It was supposed to be a time to rest after the training of the young ones in the Order was over, but he had a new task recently.

It was because of the new order that his master gave him four days ago.

It was an order to take care of the earth spirit in the back mountain.

“How are you doing today?”

Evan, who went to the back mountain, greeted the earth spirit that floated in the air.

Whirr. Whirr.

The lump of soil that flew in the sky spun around in its place and welcomed Evan.

It was a marvelous sight to see a lump of soil floating in the air.

If he hadn't heard the story of the earth spirit, Evan would have doubted it was a magician's magic.

Evan reached out his hand toward it and stroked it with his palm.

"Yeah. I think I'm doing well too."

Evan, who was stroking the earth spirit, also smiled and replied.

He was doing this by the order of the great being he served, but he himself was also secretly enjoying this task.

Raising a spirit itself was a hard and tedious task.

But Evan felt quite satisfied with raising the earth spirit.

It wasn't so bad to grow a spirit with his own hands.

"You must be very hungry."

Floating Soil, who was spinning fiercely, stopped spinning and stayed in place.

Oooh.

The lump of soil that stayed in place shook its body once.

Evan couldn't understand the spirit's words, but he could easily predict what the spirit would say in this situation.

It must have waited for Evan to feed it soil all day long while starving.

Evan nodded at the spirit's answer and walked toward the shovel that was stuck in the clearing.

It was something he had stuck on the ground after feeding the earth spirit soil yesterday.

“Just wait a little longer. I'll feed you enough soil today too.”

Thud.

Evan lifted the shovel that was stuck in the ground.

Maybe it was because he had been feeding Floating Soil diligently for two days.

Near where the shovel was stuck, there was a small clearing that had been created.

And as if to prove that Evan's efforts were not in vain, the spirit's size was also tens of times bigger than the first day.

Floating Soil grew bigger and bigger as it ate more soil.

“It might be hard to stroke you if you get any bigger.”

Oooh.

Floating Soil spun briefly after hearing Evan's words.

It was a spirit that knew how to act cute unlike the first day.

Evan stuck the shovel deep into the ground and moved his arm skillfully to scoop up some soil.

As Evan scooped up some soil with the shovel, Floating Soil came down a little and stretched out its body.

Evan sprinkled the soil on top of Floating Soil.

“Huff...”

Thump. Thump. Thump.

He pressed the soil that he sprinkled on the lump of soil with his shovel.

If he didn't fix the soil properly after sprinkling it, Floating Soil couldn't absorb it well.

Only the soil that was firmly fixed could enter the spirit's influence.

That was why the earth spirit couldn't absorb the soil around it indiscriminately.

He had to put the soil one by one on top of it and shape it himself.

“Maybe I'm getting used to this after doing it for a few days.”

It was not an easy task to scoop up soil and feed it to the spirit every day.

And even the soil he fed to the spirit was not all consumed.

About half of the soil he scooped up with his shovel flowed down without being fully absorbed.

He had to repeat this hard work every day.

But Evan didn't complain about his master at all.

He was rather happy to take care of the spirit.

“I'll feed you until you're full today too.”

Thud.

Evan's shovel scooped up some soil from the ground again.

And he sprinkled the soil on the spirit's head and pressed it with his shovel.

It was a simple but hard work.

But Evan was grateful to his master.

What he saw in front of him was still nothing but a lump of soil.

But if he fed it soil and raised it every day, someday it might form a solid ground.

A huge earth that flies in the sky.

He could easily imagine how much potential there was on it.

“A sky fortress... I look forward to the day when I can face it with my own eyes.”

His current hardship was his master's plan for the future of the Order.

The spirit that grew by eating soil formed a huge earth, and on that vast territory, new buildings were built for the great being.

The value of the fortress floating in the sky was incomparable to any magnificent castle on the ground.

It could move anywhere and take the people of the Order as far as they wanted.

Thinking of the miracle he would face someday, Evan moved his shovel diligently.

“I have to prepare hard now for that day.”

A small clearing in the back mountain of the Order.

In the empty clearing, only the sound of Evan's shovel echoed.

Chapter 82: Sword of Fire(4)

Chapter 82: Sword of Fire(4)

Hus Allemier, the second son of the Allemier family and the hero of knowledge, looked at the passage in front of him with a serious face.

A secret passage that led to the underground of the temple.

There, Aurora, who was holding a lantern, was leading the way.

Hus had been in the temple of knowledge for quite some time, but even he had never faced the underground space of the temple.

Even the high priests of the temple had never told Hus that such a secret passage existed.

Even though Hus was the one who had to be protected first in case of trouble in the temple.

Hus asked Aurora, who was going down the passage with a lantern, as he followed her.

“Holy maiden. What is this passage?”

“It’s a place that is treated as a top secret within the holy land. Only I and the direct priests of the Holy Emperor’s Court who received the order of His Majesty can enter this passage.”

Only Aurora and the direct priests of the Holy Emperor’s Court who received the order of the Holy Emperor could enter the underground passage of the temple.

It also meant that only Aurora knew about this passage in the temple of knowledge.

Thud. Thud.

The sound of their footsteps echoed in the dark passage.

The passage that led to the underground was stuffy and narrow.

“But is it okay for me to enter this place?”

“It doesn’t matter since you will find out anyway.”

“I will find out anyway...”

“It’s because what happens here is not completely unrelated to the heroes of knowledge.”

Flicker. Flicker.

Candles lit up around the quiet passage and brightened up the dark passage.

It was a magical device that was made with a lot of cost at a glance.

It was a sight that suited the temple of knowledge, which focused more on magic and technology than other temples.

Hus scanned the structure of the underground passage that was twisted and turned.

The passage to the secret space was like a maze.

“The passage structure is very complex.”

“It’s because of an important space that existed here before Crossbridge was built.”

“This is a highly classified area within the holy land. Only I and the priests who have received the order of His Majesty the Holy Emperor can set foot

here.”

Only Saintess Aurora and the direct priests of the Holy Emperor’s Court who had received the Holy Emperor’s order could enter the underground passage of the Temple of Knowledge.

It also meant that Aurora was the only one who knew about this passage within the Temple of Knowledge.

Thud. Thud.

The sound of two people’s footsteps echoed in the dark passage.

The passage leading downward was stuffy and narrow.

“I understand that this is a place where no one can enter. But is it okay for me to come here?”

“It doesn’t matter, since you will find out sooner or later, Mr. Hus.”

“Sooner or later...”

“What happens here is not completely irrelevant to the heroes of knowledge, you see.”

Whoosh.

Candles lit up around the quiet passage, brightening up the dark passage.

It was a magical device that had been made with a huge amount of money at a glance.

It was a typical appearance of the Temple of Knowledge, which focused more on magic and technology than other temples.

Hus scanned the structure of the underground passage that was twisted and connected.

The passage leading to the secret space was like a maze.

“The structure of the passage is very complex.”

“It’s because of the important space that existed here before the Crossbridge was built.”

“An important space?”

“The Crossbridge is a place where the six temples hide something very important. That’s why the passage leading to this space only exists in the Temple of Knowledge and the Holy Emperor’s Court.”

What came out of Aurora’s mouth, the Saintess of Knowledge, was a story that had been passed down from long before now.

A mysterious secret space that had existed since the time when the Crossbridge was being built.

The passage that Hus was standing on now was a staircase leading to that secret space.

The moment Aurora and Hus reached the end of this passage, he would learn the huge secret that the Crossbridge was hiding.

“I understand that it’s connected to the Holy Emperor’s Court, but why is the Temple of Knowledge connected to this place?”

Hus could also understand that there was a big secret under the holy land.

But even so, it was strange that only the Temple of Knowledge was allowed to enter the secret space.

Aurora smiled lightly at Hus’s question.

The flame of the lantern in Aurora’s hand flickered and scattered around.

“It’s because the Saintess of Knowledge has been managing this place continuously.”

“Are you saying that you are managing this place yourself?”

“Of course, I’m in charge of it now. That’s why only the current Saintess of Knowledge has the knowledge of this place.”

Hus nodded at her words as he passed through the rough curve in the passage.

It was natural that she knew about this place if the Saintess of Knowledge had been managing it for generations.

The reason why only the Holy Emperor’s Court and the Temple of Knowledge were connected to the passage would be the same.

“I think I understand a little bit after hearing your story.”

“The most noble knowledge has always been inherited by the Saintess of Knowledge. The same goes for the huge secret located under this temple.”

Thud. Thud. Thunk.

Aurora stopped in front of a huge stone slab after walking down for a long time.

Hus and Aurora had arrived at the secret place of the Crossbridge by now.

The thick stone slab with the emblem of the Holy Emperor’s Court was blocking their way forward.

Aurora placed her palm on the stone slab that was blocking the passage.

Krrrrrrrr—.

The stone slab started to move aside with a heavy vibration.

Hus looked at Aurora’s palm that was touching the stone slab.

He didn’t know exactly how the security worked, but he was sure that it recognized Aurora and opened the door for her.

There was a level of security magic installed here that was hard to find even in the empire.

“It’s been a long time since a hero of knowledge entered this place.”

Aurora said as she stepped forward after disabling the security magic.

Hus also followed Aurora naturally and headed to that place.

The moment the stone slab that blocked their sight disappeared, the secret space of the holy land that was wrapped in a veil was revealed.

A sigh of admiration naturally escaped from Hus’s mouth.

“Ah...”

Beyond the passage where the stone slab had disappeared.

A huge space filled with all kinds of crystals appeared.

The secret space that Hus saw was a place full of all kinds of magical equipment.

It was nothing less than a magical research facility.

Hus’s eyes wandered around and headed to the huge crystal located in the center of the research lab.

The crystal in the center of the lab shone brightly and emitted a clear radiance.

“What is that……?”

Hus immediately walked toward the crystal as soon as he saw it.

The crystal in front of Hus was emitting a warm and clear energy.

Inside the blue crystal, something unknown was moving like a pulse.

Hus unconsciously reached out his hand toward the crystal in front of him.

The moment Hus's hand touched the crystal, he felt his magic twist inside him and stepped back.

“Ugh—!”

Hus looked at his palm that had touched the crystal.

His palm was reddened by the backlash of magic resistance.

Seeing his palm twitching from the sudden shock, Hus frowned and used magic on his hand.

Cure.

It was the healing magic that Hus learned for the first time after coming here.

The low-level healing magic wrapped around Hus's palm and quickly eased the spasm.

“Are you okay?”

“……I made a fool of myself.”

Hus hid his healed hand behind his back and spoke to Aurora.

Aurora looked at him with a faint smile, then approached him and looked at the giant crystal.

The blue light from the crystal dyed their pupils blue.

Aurora pointed at the crystal in front of them and explained its identity to Hus.

“This crystal is the reason why Crossbridge was built.”

“This thing··· is the reason for Crossbridge's existence·····?”

“That crystal you see is the remains of a god that he left on the earth.”

The remains of a god.

Hus closed his mouth after hearing Aurora’s words.

The jewel that was pulsing in front of him was not an ordinary thing, as Hus expected.

No, it was much more important than that.

It was a thing that could prove the legitimacy of all six temples.

Aurora stretched out her hand toward the crystal that injured Hus and continued her explanation.

“The holy relic, the Heart of Origin. It is the power source of all the divine barriers in Crossbridge, and the only perpetual machine in the world that emits divine power without any power source.”

“A thing that emits divine power…….”

“Crossbridge is a space designed to concentrate the efforts of all the temples and protect the Heart of Origin.”

Although it was called a holy relic, Hus understood that the Heart of Origin was different from any other holy relic.

It was a level of divine power that could shake a mage’s magic just by approaching it.

It was an amazing thing that it emitted such a powerful divine power endlessly.

Depending on how it was used, it could create miracles of unbelievable scale.

If it was such a thing, then it was understandable that Crossbridge was built to protect this one thing.

The thing in front of him was nothing less than the hope of all humanity.

“To protect the remains of a god, Crossbridge was created··· There is an unbelievable thing here.”

“It seems that you quickly understood the value of the Heart of Origin.”

“This is a dangerous thing. It would be the same as falling into the hands of an evil god, but it could also be abused by wicked humans·····.”

“·····.”

As Hus was about to mention the endless possibilities of the Heart of Origin.

Aurora gave a bitter smile and looked away after hearing Hus’s words.

Hus looked at her with a suspicious expression, seeing her attitude different from usual.

“·····Lady Saint?”

“Unfortunately, the Holy Blue Empire is also using this thing for a dangerous purpose.”

Aurora’s gaze moved to the glass tube on the opposite side.

Hus’s gaze also followed Aurora to the direction where the glass tube was.

Inside the glass tube connected to the Heart of Origin.

There was a man who was sleeping with his eyes closed.

Aurora stared at the man in the glass tube and said.

“Arain Crost. The former hero of knowledge.”

The headquarters of Cloud, located on the island.

There, Van Krite, who attended the meeting, looked around at the people in the meeting room with a dissatisfied face.

The people who attended the meeting at the headquarters were all top-class investigators classified as special agents.

They had been granted the right to execute anyone by the emperor who ruled the empire, and they were the strongest in the empire except for the royal guard.

At the meeting where they gathered, Van slammed his fist on the table and opened his mouth.

“There is a black mage causing trouble in Alterius province. I’m sure I reported it.”

Kwang!

A crack formed on the table with a dull sound.

The documents that were swept by Van’s fist also scattered in all directions by the gust of wind.

The secret society of black mages who moved in the shadows of the empire, Abyss.

They were the documents that Van had collected information about them and submitted to Cloud’s headquarters.

They were the information that he had obtained by traveling around the northern part of the empire for nearly a year.

But the answer that came back to Van who submitted the report was the opposite of what he expected.

“Van, investigator. Didn’t I just say it? You have to participate in the subjugation of Kueverg in the sanctuary.”

The leader of Cloud, Levenov, stroked his mustache and said.

It was an answer that had nothing to do with what Van had been investigating, the subjugation of Kueverg.

Grit.

Van clenched his teeth after hearing Levenov's answer.

The special investigators of Cloud had strong autonomy, but they still couldn't completely ignore the orders from above.

If Levenov, the leader, made such a decision, it was a situation that Van couldn't ignore.

"Levenov. Did you read the report?"

"I already checked the content of the report you sent."

"And you still tell me to go on another operation?"

"I'm talking about the priority of work. To restore the fallen status of the empire, it is necessary for the special investigators to join the subjugation team."

It was infuriating for Van to hear that.

There was no one in Cloud who could follow Van in investigating the black mages.

And it was a situation where Van reported that the contractor of the Death King might be active.

Moreover, the hiding places of the mages became stronger and more solid as time passed.

If he couldn't subjugate them when he found their traces, it would become harder and harder to find or attack them.

But Levenov only talked about the subjugation of Kueverg in this situation.

Van felt frustrated and frowned at Levenov.

“The black mages who contracted with the Death King might be active. But you tell me to watch the heroes kill monsters.”

“You were the one who refused to lead the subjugation team last time.”

“Gedur was in charge of it. He was close to becoming a special agent.”

“He failed anyway. The gap between experienced special agents and those below them is clear.”

“.....Levenov.”

“And I didn’t say you should just watch. You can finish off the monsters if you want.”

He meant he should come back with some achievements.

Van sighed deeply and rubbed his forehead.

He had said everything he could say.

He couldn’t think of any more excuses to resist the order.

He gave up and asked Levenov one last question.

“Can’t you send another investigator at least?”

“What can I do when other investigators are busy?”

“.....Ha.”

“Of course, Cloud understands the seriousness of the black mages. We will support your investigation with full force after this subjugation is over.”

It was all because of his age.

Van bit his lip at the work that came to him by rotation.

Kwang.

Van slammed the table again and covered his face with one hand.

He thought he had almost found all the traces of Abyss, but he was in a crisis of having his investigation delayed for months by the headquarters.

He was Van, a young genius who had a headache from his tragic fate.

Chapter 83: Divine Contribution

(1)

Chapter 83: Divine Contribution (1)

The blue sky.

The sunlight shining down below.

And me, holding a smartphone under it.

In the clear and bright weather, I was playing a game on my smartphone.

The game I was playing was the same as always.

It was an idle game that I had been playing for months without getting bored.

“Haaham…….”

On a sunny day, it was best to stay at home with the air conditioner on and play games.

I suppressed a yawn that came out of my mouth and looked at the screen of my smartphone with sleepy eyes.

Maybe it was thanks to Roan who had earned me a lot of karma lately.

As I looked at the bottom of the screen with half-closed eyes, a level-up message was displayed.

When was the last time my level went up?

I couldn't remember exactly, but it seemed like a lot of time had passed since I reached level 9.

-You have reached level 10.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.9)> has grown.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.10)> has been achieved. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

The skill <Eye of the Observer> that evolved along with my level had reached level 10 by now.

Even though it was level 10, there was no visible change.

At most, the area I could move to had widened.

Below that, as always, there was a warning about <Karma's Balance>.

-Warning: Karma that is excessively biased in one direction has a high possibility of causing <Causality Adjustment>.

-<Karma's Balance> has tilted.

-A low-level <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Artifact: Ascalon] has been released by one stage.

-Causality Adjustment Progress: 9%

The causality adjustment had reached 9% by now.

Unlike before, it seemed to speed up.

It was probably because I had leveled up drastically since I acquired Kueverg.

As the causality adjustment reached 9%, a message that [Divine Artifact: Ascalon] had been released also popped up.

It meant that the boss who possessed [Divine Artifact: Ascalon] had become stronger than before.

As I looked at the message of the divine artifact's release, I remembered the boss monster that Eutenia had faced before.

“The boss I met last time had some tricky patterns.”

There was one character who weakened magic.

There was one character who hit the alpha hidden in the shadows.

And finally, there was one character who blocked my sight.

They were all characters with difficult patterns.

It meant that they had grown stronger, which was a burden for me.

“I wonder if I can take them down with my current characters if I meet them again.”

But the game's difficulty adjustment was already done.

There was no way to undo it by regretting it now.

It was natural that the enemies became stronger as my level went up.

Leveling up was a great way to boost my specs, but there was also a penalty for the difficulty level depending on the level.

As the player grew through leveling up, the boss characters also grew through causality adjustment.

The only way to get stronger without penalty in this game was to spin the 10-pull and get new items.

It was to increase the number of rare items and create a difference in effective item specs.

“If my specs are not enough, I’ll have to make a new payment plan then…….”

Unfortunately, I was not someone who could pay unlimited amounts of money, whether it was 1 million won or 10 million won.

I had to pay as much as I could afford and level up to boost my specs at the same time.

The most efficient way was to balance my level and item specs.

By mixing the utility of both, I could create the most powerful character with less money.

As I expressed my regret for my wallet, I scrolled down and checked the next message.

“And the next message is……. Hm?”

Swish.

As I moved my finger to scroll down the screen, I stopped my finger and felt interested in a message I had never seen before.

Below the causality adjustment message by <Karma’s Balance>.

There was a message in an unfamiliar format.

I woke up in an instant and read the message that appeared on the screen carefully.

-[Apostle 1: Eutenia Hyroste] has exceeded the standard value of divine contribution.

-You can unlock [Divine Skill: Grimoire] by spending 100 karma.

Eutenia, the character I appointed as the first apostle.

She had exceeded the standard value of divine contribution, according to the message.

Below that, there was another message saying that I could unlock her divine skill by spending 100 karma.

I clicked on the new message in the message box to check it more closely.

Then, the screen went dark and a selection window with choices written on it appeared.

-Spend 100 karma to unlock the power hidden in [Divine Skill: Grimoire].

-Do you want to unlock [Divine Skill: Grimoire]?

-Yes / No

The new selection window asked me if I wanted to unlock the divine skill.

Unlocking the divine skill.

When I received a warning related to <The Heavenly Voice of Karma> earlier, the message box said that [Divine Skill: Ascalon] had been unlocked.

It was a message saying that the difficulty had been adjusted, just like last time.

That's why I thought that only boss characters could unlock their divine skills and adjust the difficulty.

But this was a system that also applied to my apostles.

I couldn't help but be surprised by the unexpected message.

“Eutenia's divine skill can be enhanced...?”

I looked at Eutenia, who was riding a carriage on the screen.

She was moving to return to the order, and there was a book with a luxurious cover on her lap.

[Divine Skill: Grimoire].

It was the divine skill that I gave to Eutenia after completing her <Apostle Selection>.

Eutenia's grimoire had the effect of creating shadowy hands from the darkness.

Looking back, it was more of a versatile trait than a combat-oriented one.

“Still... it seems like magic is more of her main weapon than shadows.”

I don't think <Shadow Hands> is a useless trait for Eutenia.

It was a trait that had a decent effect in terms of support.

But Eutenia's main strength was always the wide-range bombardment with magic.

She was not like Evan, who showed off the power of his divine skill in battle.

<Shadow Hands> was a trait that was hard to become Eutenia's main strength.

And now, as an apostle of the enlarged order, Eutenia's trait seemed somewhat lacking in dignity.

“Maybe it's time to enhance Eutenia.”

In that sense, being able to enhance Eutenia's divine skill was a very positive news.

It was an opportunity to raise Eutenia's combat power, which had been focused only on the magical aspect.

Besides, unlocking the divine skill was not only possible for Eutenia.

Evan and Pluto might also be able to unlock their divine skills and improve their performance.

Of course, they would have to accumulate enough divine contribution before that.

I smiled involuntarily at the thought of Evan and Pluto wielding their enhanced divine skills someday.

“But there are other places where I can use divine contribution besides setting permissions... That's a bit surprising.”

Divine contribution was a system that was added when I acquired the <Divine Response Device>.

That's why I thought that divine contribution was only valid within the <Divine Response Device>.

But it turned out to be a value that applied to the whole system.

My evaluation of divine contribution changed in my head with the unexpected harvest.

It felt like its importance had risen by several levels than before.

“If I can enhance the specs of my apostles by spending 100 karma with enough divine contribution... This is worth trying.”

I revised my evaluation of divine contribution in my head and looked at Eutenia on the screen again.

It had been a long time since I directly enhanced Eutenia's specs besides magic.

I brought my finger to the ‘Yes’ button with anticipation.

Click.

As soon as my finger touched the ‘Yes’ button on the choice, the selection window disappeared and light burst out from Eutenia’s body.

At the same time, a new message was added to the message box.

-[Apostle 1: Eutenia Hyrost] has started the trial.

A bright light enveloped Eutenia’s body.

It was a clearer light than the light cluster that Estasia had surrounded herself with.

Eutenia looked up at the sky with her dazzling self.

Above Eutenia’s head, who was looking up at the sky with light, a small speech bubble floated up.

-“.....?”

When the light that had wrapped around Eutenia subsided.

I could see Eutenia standing in the darkness, holding a book in her arms.

The first apostle, Eutenia Hyrost.

She blinked her eyes and looked around at the scenery.

A pitch-black world where only darkness descended.

She stood alone in the darkness, holding a book in her arms.

It was the first time she had ever seen such a sight since she was born into the world.

She closed her eyes and opened them again at the sudden change of scenery.

“.....”

But closing and opening her eyes did not change the scenery that surrounded her.

She was in the darkness.

A thick and dense darkness.

And a vast and endless darkness.

Her eyes went to the grimoire in her arms in the darkness.

Even in a world where she was the only one, the divine skill that her master gave her was always with her.

“What’s going on?”

She hugged the grimoire tightly and took a step forward.

Splash. Splash.

Every time she took a step forward, ripples spread around her.

The footsteps that cut through the darkness felt like walking in deep water.

Yet she did not feel any cold sensation on her legs.

It flowed like water, but it did not have the same temperature as the sea.

She muttered as she looked at the shadows that covered the floor while walking through the darkness.

“It seems like Alpha is not here either.”

It was a big enough shadow for Alpha to come out easily.

But Alpha did not show any signs of coming out of the shadows.

The terminal body of Alpha, who usually sat on her shoulder, was also gone.

She thought that Alpha, a shadow beast, would follow her no matter what, but it was a situation where her expectations were completely wrong.

It seemed like she had to give up on the idea of getting out of here with Alpha's help.

Eutenia put more strength into her hand that held the grimoire.

She continued to walk forward with a regretful expression.

-“Prove yourself.”

Splash.

Her steps stopped again in place as she walked forward.

An unidentified voice rang in Eutenia's ears.

She looked around with a puzzled face and repeated what she had just heard.

“Prove...?”

The unidentified voice told her to prove herself.

But Eutenia could not fully understand his words.

He suddenly told her to prove herself.

What exactly did he want her to prove?

As Eutenia was lost in thought, the voice echoed in her ears again.

Along with the unidentified voice, the space that Eutenia was standing on also began to shake.

-“This is the world of shadows.”

Black trees sprouted from the shadows that stretched out widely.

They had dry and barren shapes with black leaves scattered between them.

The trees that started to rise one by one each sprouted their own leaves.

In an instant, the trees that sprouted densely created a forest of giant shadows.

-“This is the space that the great one created for his apostles.”

Beyond the lush forest, a huge wall began to rise.

Through the blurry boundary line, the shadowy bricks that were tightly packed revealed their appearance.

On top of the long shadow wall, a towering tower boasted its presence.

A black castle built in a moment.

A beautiful castle that seemed to come out of a fairy tale was fully present in front of Euteneia.

-“Prove yourself. Prove your qualifications.”

With the shadow world as the background, the voice that followed Euteneia spoke.

The scenery that seemed like an illusion created in a moment flowed along with the voice and shook violently.

The only thing that the voice hidden in the shadows wanted was one thing.

Euteneia’s proof towards the great being.

-“Prove that this whole world exists for you.”

And the apostle’s proof towards the shadow.

Chapter 84: Divine Contribution

(2)

Chapter 84: Divine Contribution (2)

-“It’s not as hard as I thought.”

I looked at Eutenia’s image reflected on the screen.

Eutenia was jumping over the wall that blocked her way by moving the shadows around her.

The trial given to Eutenia.

It was to break through various gates using the shadows.

All the shadows that swayed around her became gates that blocked her way.

Yet she skillfully handled the shadows and broke through the gates sequentially.

Of course, it wasn’t like that from the beginning, but it was a result of some practice.

“She’s doing well as I expected.”

It wasn’t a long time considering the purpose of the trial.

Eutenia was quick to adapt to handling the shadows.

She transformed the shadows into various shapes in an instant, and gradually expanded the size of the shadows.

It was an exponential growth rate for anyone to see.

At this rate, she seemed to be able to clear the trial without any trouble.

I left Eutenia alone, who was breaking through the gates without any problem, and continued to focus on what I had been doing since earlier.

“I can just leave her alone and she’ll clear it by herself.”

While Eutenia was breaking through the gates, I was checking the remaining messages in the message box.

There were various messages piled up in the message box, excluding Eutenia’s liberation.

Among them, there was also information about the liberation quest of the <Descent> skill.

After obtaining the [Sacred Divine Artifact: Eregus’s Stake], the quest content was unlocked for the first time in a long time.

I looked at the screen with a throbbing heart at the unlocking of the quest that took place after a long time.

-A new condition for <Descent(Lv.0)> has been revealed.

The second quest to be solved, excluding the karma quest that was expected to be achieved last, was given.

Now it was time to check its content.

Click.

I manipulated the screen and opened the progress screen of the <Descent> skill.

Most of the functions could be used without any problem even while Eutenia was undergoing the trial.

Checking the progress of the <Descent> skill was also not a difficult task.

That way, one new quest that was added to my eyes came into my eyes as I ran the progress screen of the <Descent> skill.

-Every time you meet one of the following conditions, the progress of <Descent> will increase by one step.

-Usable Karma: 1572 / 999999 (Incomplete)

-[Sacred Divine Artifact: Eregus's Stake]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

-[Philosopher's Stone]: 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-??? : 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-??? (Incomplete)

Right below the quest I completed last time.

A new quest to collect the [Philosopher's Stone] had been added.

I was filled with countless questions when I saw the quest details.

The [Philosopher's Stone] was an item that did not belong to any category like 'Holy Relic'.

It meant that I could not find out more about its acquisition path or its effects by myself.

I looked at the newly unlocked quest and pondered while stroking my chin with one hand.

“Get the [Philosopher's Stone]?”

I could not guess what kind of item it was by its name alone.

Was it something that I had to obtain while playing the game, or was it something that I could get through a lottery?

I was in a situation where I could not understand the exact way to get it by myself.

In the end, to get information about the item, I had to collect the necessary information from the Apostles.

My gaze naturally shifted to Eutenia, who was undergoing a trial.

“Hmm...”

If it were normal, I would have asked Eutenia about the [Philosopher’s Stone] right away.

But it was difficult to talk to her right now.

She was in the middle of a trial, and the chat function with her was also blocked.

The only thing I could do was to suppress my curiosity until she finished the trial.

I rested my chin on the table and watched Eutenia’s progress.

“She can do anything with her shadow now.”

Eutenia was manipulating her shadow to overcome the wall that blocked her way.

The wall of a distant height crumbled under Eutenia’s shadow.

The shadow moving under Eutenia’s feet had grown to a monstrous size compared to when it first appeared.

She seemed to have quite a talent for not only magic but also manipulating shadows.

Using her shadow, she broke through the wall and faced the next gate that blocked her way.

“Is this a combat gate?”

Under the collapsed wall, there was a huge iron bar that trapped something inside.

Eutenia’s body stopped in its tracks as she moved her shadow forward.

It was because she had discovered what the iron bar was holding.

When I saw what was trapped by the iron bar, I could easily predict that Eutenia would have to fight in this gate.

Eutenia opened her small mouth and muttered as she saw what was beyond the iron bar.

-“This is...”

Beyond the iron bar made of shadows.

There was a monstrous creature with a massive body that exuded an oppressive aura.

It was a monster with a body as huge as the wall she had crossed.

Kugugugung—.

As Eutenia reached the gate for the trial, the iron bar lifted up and the monster’s eyes looked at Eutenia.

Behind the monster with a gigantic body, there was an entrance leading to the inside of the castle.

Eutenia had already passed through numerous gates and reached the last remaining wall.

It seemed that the monster in front of her was the final gate that blocked Eutenia’s way.

-“I guess I have to defeat it.”

She couldn't enter the castle unless she defeated the monster.

Realizing that, Eutenia began to prepare to face the monster.

Splash.

A large shadow swirled around Eutenia as she took a step forward.

Eutenia's shadow had expanded continuously as she passed through numerous gates.

The shadow, which had grown incomparably larger than its original size, reached the area where the monster was.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

The shadowy monster with a bulky body began to walk toward Eutenia.

The ground shook and shadows sprang up every time the monster took a step.

"He's quite impressive, isn't he?"

It was a monster with a body as big as the wall.

If such a monster had appeared at the beginning of the trial, Eutenia, who had her magic sealed, would have had a hard time dealing with it.

But now, it was a situation where quite some time had passed since the trial began.

Eutenia also looked much stronger than before.

Her skill in manipulating shadows had reached an incomparable level to when she could barely move the shadow's fingers.

That's why Eutenia was not intimidated at all by the huge monster in front of her.

-“I hope the great one is not disappointed.”

Eutenia said that and raised her hand toward the sky.

Thorns made of shadows rose up around Eutenia who raised her hand.

Whoosh! Wham!

Thorns of a monstrous size sprang up from Eutenia’s shadow and blocked the monster’s movement.

The monster writhed and spat out a speech bubble toward Eutenia as it was pierced by the thorns.

-Krrrrrr!

The thorns, as thick as pillars, pierced through the monster’s body and fixed it in place.

The monster tried to free itself from Eutenia’s thorns by moving its bulky body.

The shadows shook from the massive impact every time the monster moved its body.

Of course, Eutenia’s attack did not stop there.

The thorns of shadow alternately sprang up and attacked the shadowy monster.

Every time a thorn popped out of the rippling waves, the monster twisted its body and screamed.

It was too one-sided to be a game to test her.

-Krrrk... Krrrrrr.

Was the difficulty of the trial itself too low?

Or was it because Eutenia was such an excellent character?

The monster was no match for Eutenia at all.

It was in a situation where it could not even move as it pleased despite having a huge body.

It was not a fitting sight for a trial.

“How can I be disappointed in you?”

The battle continued as Eutenia’s one-sided abuse.

Based on her overwhelming shadow manipulation ability, Eutenia relentlessly pushed the monster back.

The monster, overwhelmed by Eutenia, could not show any proper reaction, and only allowed the opponent’s attack while screaming.

At that moment, when the thorns that had been tearing the monster’s body were withdrawn, and the monster that blocked Eutenia staggered.

Boom!

The monster fell to the ground with a heavy thud, and the door beyond it opened wide.

-“Is this the end?”

The monster that fell to Eutenia’s attack did not move from its spot.

Eutenia had easily defeated the monster and passed through the gate.

She looked at the monster lying on the floor for a moment, then moved past it toward the open door.

Splash. Splash.

Only the sound of water made by the shadow echoed in the empty world.

Eutenia walked through the swamp of shadows and stepped beyond the open door.

-“This is...”

The place where Eutenia arrived after passing through the gate guarded by the monster was a magnificent hall made of shadows.

A splendid and refined space formed by light and darkness.

There were numerous decorations and structures made of shadows in there.

The carpet on the floor was waiting for its owner to step on and pass by.

The chair of shadow at the end of the carpet was waiting for its owner to sit on it.

It seemed that this whole space was made for Eutenia alone.

My guess that the monster blocking Eutenia’s way was the last gate was not wrong.

“Is it over when you sit on that chair?”

At the end of the carpet that was like a milestone, only a splendid chair was waiting like a terminal.

There was only one way for Eutenia to go.

Clack. Clack.

Eutenia’s footsteps stepped on the steady carpet of shadow and moved forward.

Unlike the sticky swamp of shadows, everything in here had a solid shape.

As Eutenia walked forward, the armors displayed nearby bowed to her.

She arrived at the throne at the end of the carpet while receiving the armors' courteous greetings.

-“It was not a bad experience.”

As soon as Eutenia sat on the chair of shadow that marked the end of the trial.

Numerous shadows appeared in the hall and bowed their heads toward her.

A black and white world where only light and shadow existed.

There, she received reverence from all the shadows.

The speech bubble that said that this whole world existed for her was not wrong.

Right after Eutenia received the reverence of the shadows, several messages were also printed on my message box.

-[First Apostle: Eutenia Hyrost] has passed the trial.

The first message that came up was a message that Eutenia's trial was over.

Eutenia's trial finally came to an end after more than an hour of watching.

It was fortunate that she had a talent for manipulating shadows, otherwise I would have had to leave my smartphone on and dive for hours.

It was the same as being anxious even if it was an idle game.

If the trial had not ended, I would have been worried about data problems and could not quit the game.

-[Divine Artifact: Grimoire] has been released by one level.

-The <Shadow Touch> trait of [Divine Artifact: Grimoire] has been deleted.

-The <Shadow World> trait has been added to [Divine Artifact: Grimoire].

After the message about the trial, a message about Eutenia's growth was printed.

The <Shadow Touch> trait of Eutenia's Divine Artifact disappeared, and she acquired a new trait called <Shadow World>.

By the name and situation, it seemed more appropriate to say that the trait had evolved rather than deleted.

It was a situation where it had changed into a higher trait of <Shadow Touch>.

After confirming the release of [Divine Artifact: Grimoire], I looked at Eutenia who had finished the trial.

“Was it longer than I thought, or shorter?”

Eutenia's trial was over, and her Divine Artifact became even more powerful.

As if to prove that, the shadow world where Eutenia existed was also collapsing.

The ceiling that formed the hall cracked and light leaked through the gap.

The shadows that bowed to her also shattered and scattered in all directions.

Light flowed into the tiles that had only shadows and the whole space was collapsing.

As a bright light poured into the space that surrounded Eutenia.

-“Eutenia. Where have you been?”

Eutenia returned to the original map.

Chapter 85: Divine Contribution

(3)

Chapter 85: Divine Contribution (3)

Church headquarters.

In the midst of the rain that continued to pour from the gloomy sky, Archbishop Roan Hebris was on his way to attend an event outside.

Behind Roan, his fervent follower James was following him.

Roan looked briefly at the sight of the believers outside the window.

In the rain, countless believers were standing and waiting for Roan.

He checked the sight of the believers outside and then asked James a question.

“James. How many believers who have awakened miracles have you confirmed?”

“The total number of those who have been found regardless of their rank is 143.”

After Roan awakened miracles in the city, many believers began to awaken miracles as well.

That’s how 143 believers who could use miracles were found so far.

Considering the total number of people affiliated with the church headquarters, it was not a very large number.

Was it because of the lack of faith of the believers?

Or was it because of their lack of devotion to the great being?

It was a rather regrettable part for Roan.

Roan frowned as he recalled the miracle he had faced a while ago and continued his question.

“143... Is there still no one classified as a first-class believer?”

First-Rank Believer.

That was the term used to refer to those believers who could use high-level miracles among those who had awakened to miracles.

More precisely, they called the believers who could summon the ‘Rain of Lightning’ as first-rank believers.

It had been quite some time since Roan had announced that he would grant a high position to the first-rank believer.

However, so far, there was no believer who had reached that level except for the apostles.

James, who had heard Roan’s story, spoke to him with a dark face.

“It seems that Elliot, the believer you recommended so much, might be able to reach the first-rank soon.”

“Elliot. The believer you praised so highly.”

“He is a very devout believer. He worships with his whole body every day without fail.”

“He might be able to reach the first-rank... We have to keep an eye on him.”

The believers who could perform miracles were important assets for the church.

Roan himself could bring forth the rain of lightning from his hands and sweep away his enemies.

But not all believers could perform high-level miracles.

Most of the believers could barely summon a single bolt of lightning.

Of course, there were some believers who could create a spear of lightning among them.

In such a situation, someone who had the potential to reach the first-rank was nothing less than a blessing for the church.

Roan gave an order about Elliot, and James followed him with a bow.

“I will follow your command, Archbishop.”

Before long, they came out of the building and saw the believers who greeted them one by one.

In front of the believers, there was a large stage prepared for Roan to show his miracle today.

Roan walked towards the stage, watching the believers who greeted him.

The sound of his feet squelching on the rain-soaked ground echoed.

Roan passed by the believers and approached the stage, climbing up the stairs to the top.

As Roan stepped onto the stage as announced beforehand, one of the church officials who was standing on the stage shouted loudly to the believers.

“Everyone, be quiet. The Archbishop is here.”

Roan, who had climbed onto the stage, looked at the believers who were lined up below.

The number of people who had gathered in the church was incomparable to before.

The appearance of the church, which used to look like a bandit's den, had also changed to a refined one.

In the church that now looked like a place to worship God, the believers were looking at Roan while being soaked by the rain.

Their faith towards their master was something that even the fierce rainstorm could not stop.

Roan, who faced the believers who were looking at him, pulled back his hood and opened his mouth to them.

“Praise the Great One.”

“For the Great One!”

At Roan's voice, the believers began to chant words of praise in unison.

The voices of countless believers mixed in the air and resonated loudly.

In front of such believers, Roan lifted up his dagger.

Ednos. It was the first thing that Roan had received from his master, and now it was regarded as a sacred object of the church.

Roan, who held up Ednos, which had gained a symbolic value, spoke to the believers.

“We have gathered under the grace of the Great One, and we are the ones who move to serve the true master on earth.”

The goal of the church was one.

To summon the Great Being here and create a world for him.

The believers who heard the will of the church clenched their mouths and shed tears of emotion.

In front of the sobbing believers, Roan cut through the swirling wind with Ednos.

“All kinds of storms will cease under the Great One, and the flags of those who stand in his way will also be mercilessly broken.”

Under the wind that was split by Ednos, Roan, who held the sword, declared with a serious face.

The reason why Roan, the Archbishop, came to this place today.

It was to demonstrate the greatest miracle to the believers.

Today was the day that had to be a symbolic moment for all the believers.

And it was the day that had to be a turning point for them to crave miracles.

Roan, who lifted up his sword, proclaimed to the believers in a majestic voice.

“Behold. The miracle will cut through the clouds.”

“...”

“Here today, witness the moment of glory.”

The moment Roan’s sword, which was stirring the sky, stopped.

Miracles began to happen around Roan.

The bright sun rose and tore apart the dark clouds, and the fierce storm subsided.

As the rain stopped, warm sunlight began to shine down on Roan and the believers.

All the believers looked up at the sun that appeared through the dark sky.

Under the burning sun, a huge presence was facing them.

“Ooh... The Great One!”

“Even the storm was pitiful in front of the Great One!”

The believers who were standing up knelt down one by one at the sight of the miracle they faced.

They knelt and shed tears of joy, praying.

Roan looked at them and put the dagger he was holding in his chest.

Was it because he had shown the believers a scene that dominated even the sky?

He felt that the grace of the Great Being in him had increased.

He felt a thrill that made his hands tremble at the sight of the admiring believers.

The more he devoted himself to the Great Being, the more miracles his master gave him.

He spread his arms wide to the believers who were crying tears of joy and praying.

“Worship. Praise. Obey.”

“The Greatest One will return!”

He saw one person who was far away from the believers who shouted at him.

There, a painter was holding a brush and drawing Roan and the church.

There were tears in the eyes of the painter who was drawing Roan.

After finishing Eutenia's spec-up, I moved the screen to Evan right away.

It was because I heard from Eutenia that there was not enough information about [Philosopher's Stone].

I didn't think Evan would know anything about [Philosopher's Stone], so it was to give him a new order.

I moved the screen and looked at where Evan was, and he was feeding Soil to [Floating Soil] as always.

[Floating Soil] was eating the Soil that Evan gave him while being soaked.

It was already hundreds of times bigger than before.

He seemed to be feeding him diligently.

I was proud of Evan's appearance and told him about this quest.

-“Is your mission to bring back the Philosopher's Stone this time?”

Evan quickly understood my words and nodded.

He didn't seem to know much about the Philosopher's Stone, but if I instructed him like this, he would somehow find a way to get it.

That was why I spent money to train his character.

Of course, Evan was not the only apostle I sent for this quest.

I also planned to send Eutenia with him.

I also told Evan that Eutenia would accompany him.

“Yeah. You go with Eutenia and get it.”

Of course, my words were not delivered directly, but through a high-end translator.

A new dialogue was printed on the chat window with archaic vocabulary.

-“Fulfill your mission. The wise apostle will help your feat.”

-“I see. I’ll move with Eutenia then. Understood.”

Evan understood me even though I spoke like that.

Rather, it would be easier for them to understand each other when they talked among themselves.

Evan nodded his head and agreed to my suggestion that he go with Eutenia.

And then he told me his plan through the chat window.

-“I have heard some rumors about it. It seems like something that high-level magicians or alchemists would be interested in, so I’ll try to find out more from them myself.”

He said he would look for high-level magicians or alchemists himself.

Indeed, it looked like an item that only those NPCs would know by name.

Evan’s idea of meeting other magician characters was reasonable enough.

As he did in the last quest, Evan was very smart in this direction.

-“Great One. What should I do with the earth spirit while I’m gone?”

That’s right.

I had also entrusted Evan with the training of [Floating Soil].

The lump of Soil had grown to the size of a hut while in Evan’s care.

I looked at [Floating Soil], who had grown fat and plump, and thought about it.

Pluto, the vampire, didn't seem suitable for this quest that involved going into the city.

So it seemed better to leave [Floating Soil]'s care to Pluto instead of Evan.

I moved my finger and told Evan about the plan for the spirit training.

“Just leave it to Pluto. How hard can it be to feed Soil?”

-“A new apostle will take over your role.

-“I understand. Thank you.”

-“Sniffle.”

The lump of Soil that had been watching Evan and me talk raised a speech bubble above its head and sobbed.

I couldn't tell if it was crying or laughing, but there was something called the mood, right?

To me, it seemed like a situation where it was crying, judging by the circumstances.

Evan, who had accepted my order, stuck the shovel he had been using to scoop up Soil back into the ground.

He seemed ready to leave this place as soon as he received the order.

Then he tapped the [Floating Soil] next to him with his palm and said,

-“I'll see you again when the mission is over. Until then, grow into a splendid being.”

-“Soil.”

Did it understand what Evan said?

It responded to Evan's words by slowly rotating in its place.

It was a heartwarming sight of the two characters.

After saying goodbye to the [Floating Soil], Evan packed his belongings and started to descend the mountain.

The place where Evan had been standing was a mountain right behind the church.

He would probably need to stop by the church to prepare for the quest.

As I watched Evan go down the mountain, the [Floating Soil] that was left alone in its place raised speech bubbles one after another.

-“Soil.”

-“Sniffle.”

-“Soil.”

-“Sniffle sniffle sniffle sniffle.”

I had no idea what it was saying.

However, I could tell that it was feeling down after Evan left.

As soon as Evan moved out of sight, the [Floating Soil] spun furiously in its place.

It was a completely different speed from when it was seeing Evan off.

The [Floating Soil] scattered some Soil around as it spun fast.

Then, at some point, it lifted its body into the air and shot up towards the distant sky.

-“Sniffle sniffle sniffle sniffle sniffle sniffle sniffle sniffle.”

I watched the [Floating Soil] disappear with a speech bubble for a moment.

I was startled, but I quickly moved the screen to chase after it.

The [Floating Soil] was not the kind of character that could communicate normally with others.

It was not the kind of character that could find its way back on its own if it left by itself.

There was a high chance that I wouldn't be able to find its trace for a long time if I lost it here.

“What is that? Where is it going?”

Swish. Swish.

I pushed the screen quickly with my index finger to keep following the [Floating Soil].

That's how the chase between the [Floating Soil] and me had to continue for a while.

Chapter 86: Floating Sanctuary (1)

Chapter 86: Floating Sanctuary (1)

Mark.

The sign of the evil god that was inherited by the cursed bloodline.

For the forest fairies, it was a curse that weakened their connection to the spirit realm.

A fairy with a mark could not summon spirits, and therefore, could not properly handle them.

This was a fatal flaw in the society of fairies, which was mostly composed of spirit users.

But paradoxically, they had a natural affinity with spirits that was higher than other fairies.

Most of the fairies despised and shunned these heterogeneous beings, calling them Soily.

“Perin. Rendel wants you to fetch water.”

“Ah, okay...”

Perin was also one of the fairies who was born with a mark.

She had a mark on her left hand since birth, and because of that, she was rejected by all spirits.

The fairies around her also always scorned and discriminated against her.

Perin always showed a bright appearance because of her unique personality, but behind her, there was only a dark past.

Thud.

Perin looked at the water bottle rolling in front of her eyes.

It was the thing that the fairy who told her to fetch water had thrown at her.

Perin grabbed the water bottle that was rolling on the ground, and tried to approach the fairy who had thrown it at her.

“Hey, next time, please be a little kinder...”

“Don’t come near me!”

As Perrin approached the fairy with the water jug in her hand, the fairy backed away and stretched out her hand towards Perrin.

Perrin had to stop her steps when she saw the fairy quickly move away from her.

The fairy looked at the mark on the back of Perrin’s hand with a disgusted eye.

It was a look that said she couldn’t tolerate Perrin coming near her.

Not only that, but she also shouted at Perrin with a loud voice.

“Perrin! What if your filthy curse spreads to me!”

“The mark doesn’t spread...”

“Shut up! How do I know if something will happen! Just be quiet and get some water!”

With that, the fairy turned her back on Perrin and went back to the village.

For Perrin, who was born with the mark, this kind of treatment was familiar.

Perrin touched her golden hair with a gloomy expression, as she watched the fairy who despised her.

It was the golden hair that her mother had always told her was beautiful since she was born.

Although the one who used to stroke Perrin's hair was no longer there, her hair was still Perrin's pride.

Perrin, who was touching her hair, soon regained her spirits and looked around.

She could see the other fairies who were getting water and going back.

"If I don't get water quickly, I might get scolded..."

Perrin started to walk briskly towards the lake with the water jug in her hand.

Most of the other fairies had already gotten water and were going back.

It seemed likely that Perrin would be the last one to go back even if she went to the lake now.

The fairy who gave Perrin the water jug had deliberately told her late.

It was the usual harassment towards Perrin.

But Perrin, who couldn't handle spirits, had nowhere to go even if she left this place.

She had no choice but to endure the harassment and do the tasks that were given to her.

"I have to hurry..."

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

As she moved forward with light steps, Perrin saw something moving in the distance.

She lifted her head and ran towards the unknown thing, trying to figure out what it was.

Between the white clouds in the sky, there was a brown cloud that was moving.

She had seen dark clouds, but never a brown one.

It was a sight that Perrin had never encountered before in her life.

A huge curiosity rose in Perrin's chest as she faced the brown cloud.

"There's a brown cloud coming."

The brown cloud seemed to be moving towards her, as it grew bigger and bigger.

It was a situation where she could observe the cloud properly from the direction of the lake that she was heading to.

Perrin's steps became faster as she ran towards the lake.

Her nimble steps cut through the wind and crossed the forest in an instant.

Maybe it was because she moved faster than usual.

Perrin was able to reach the cliff where the lake was located in no time.

"Phew... I'm already late anyway, so it won't hurt to take a quick look."

Perrin left the water jug at the lake and went straight to the cliff.

A cool breeze brushed past Perrin's cheek, along with a distant view.

In her sight, there was something coming from far away.

What she thought was a brown cloud was something that grew bigger and bigger as it approached her.

Perrin gasped involuntarily as she faced the identity of the cloud that appeared before her eyes.

“Wow...”

What flew towards the cliff where Perrin was, was an island floating in the sky.

The tiny island that came from afar lowered its altitude and approached where Perrin was.

Perrin could tell at a glance that it was a spirit, as she faced the island that came towards her.

The island that slowly started to descend soon came down right in front of Perrin.

Perrin's eyes sparkled as she saw the island flying at arm's length.

The tiny island stopped at the edge of the cliff and slowly rotated.

“Hey, there... Hello!”

-“Sob. Sob.”

Gulp.

Perrin swallowed her saliva and waved her hand at the spirit, and the spirit's voice reached her ears.

The spirit's voice was something that even a fairy's ears couldn't understand.

But the ability she had to resonate with spirits told her exactly what the spirit was thinking.

The spirit in front of Perrin was sad right now.

It had lost its long-time friend who took care of it, and it was hurt in its heart.

That's why it was flying around here and there, trying to ease its sorrow.

"You must be very sad that your precious person left. I understand how you feel."

Perrin reached out her hand and gently stroked the soil in front of her.

The spirit's emotion flowed into her through the air as she touched it.

She smiled brightly at the small tremor that came from her fingertips.

The spirit was happy to receive Perrin's stroke.

It was the first time that Perrin met a spirit that didn't reject her touch.

Perrin carefully stroked the spirit, making sure it wasn't uncomfortable, and continued to talk to it.

"I'll comfort you well. Don't be too sad!"

-“Sob.”

It felt like she was an old friend, even though she had just met the spirit.

Perrin thought that this was why fairies made contracts with spirits.

The fairies who carried spirits with them always cherished them and had a good time.

Perrin hugged the spirit that welcomed her and brought her ear to the lump of soil.

She wished that this time would last forever.

Perrin also had a desire to be with a spirit, even though she didn't show it normally.

“What's your name, spirit?”

-“Sob. Sob. Sob.”

“I see! How about ‘Yuto’?”

-“Sob.”

“I'm glad you like it!”

Perrin happily gave the spirit a name.

The name she gave to the spirit was ‘Yuto’.

She chose the name that was closest to the identity that the spirit told her.

The spirit that received the name shook its body, as if it was happy.

In the process, some soil splashed on Perrin, but she didn't mind and kept stroking Yuto.

Yuto, who received Perrin's touch, soon rubbed his cheek and started a conversation.

-“Sob. Sob. Sob. Sob.”

“Are you saying I can ride on top of you?”

-“Soil.”

That was what Yuto, the spirit who had just received a name, said to Perrin.

He offered to let her ride on him.

She had seen many spirits who could fly in the sky, but there were not many who were as big as him.

How wonderful would it feel to fly in the sky on such a large spirit?

A floating island and Perrin standing on it.

It was a story that she would only see in fairy tales, unfolding before her eyes.

Perrin nodded her head vigorously at the spirit's words and cheered.

“Sure!”

- ◦ “Soil.”

As soon as Yuto said he would let her fly in the sky, Perrin climbed on top of him.

When she stepped on the floating island, Yuto's soft Soil floor welcomed her.

Yuto quickly increased his altitude and began to fly high in the air with Perrin on his back.

Perrin had to work hard to keep her balance on Yuto's flying body so that she wouldn't fall off.

The flight with Yuto that started like that ended only when the sun set.

For her, who had become friends with a spirit for the first time, the matter of floating on water was already long forgotten.

-“Yuto! Run faster!”

-“Soil.”

I smirked as I looked at the smartphone screen.

On the screen that was tracking [Floating Soil]'s movements.

[Floating Soil] was flying happily in the sky with a fairy on his back.

The fairy on top of [Floating Soil] was excitedly guiding him to change directions here and there.

Apparently, she had given him the name Yuto.

Of course, it didn't matter much to me whether his name was 'Yuto' or 'Floating Soil Yuto'.

What mattered was the fact that the fairy in front of me was moving [Floating Soil] at her will.

"Do you like it when you carry a fairy? You didn't carry Evan even though he fed you."

He looked very different from when Evan was feeding him.

He only spun around and splashed Soil when he was with Evan, but now he was flying with a person on his back.

No, should I call her a fairy instead of a person?

Anyway, it was a very absurd sight for me.

Maybe it was because he was a spirit, but he had a very fussy personality.

Maybe I should have given him the title of spirit master from the beginning.

As I watched Yuto speeding through the air, I couldn't help but think about how to deal with him in the future.

"Looking at the situation, he doesn't seem to be leaving without a reason."

From what I could see, Yuto was following that fairy well.

And the fairy also had some kind of daily routine as an NPC.

NPCs with fixed schedules tended to return to their original places after some time.

When the flight with Yuto ended, that fairy NPC would also likely move Yuto to go back home.

But looking at his attitude now, it seemed like he would come back soon even if they parted today.

As long as I knew where that fairy was, I could easily find [Floating Soil]'s location again.

“Maybe it’s better to leave him alone for a few days since he’s not properly managed?”

It was a game that didn’t have a proper marking system anyway.

As long as I could check his location, it wouldn’t be bad to leave him alone for a while.

The spirit itself was not a kind that could communicate or control.

If I had enough karma, I could also make the fairy a follower and control Yuto.

A flying island was like a dream for anyone.

If there was a way to control it, I had to consider both options.

“It’s annoying to watch... I’ll have to check the nearby village and go.”

I decided and moved the screen to check the village where the fairies were.

There were not many fairies in the village that existed between the forests.

It was not a bad size for hunting, but there was no merit to clean it up right now.

After I decided on the disposal of the follower, it wouldn't be bad to send someone to take care of the fairies.

Click.

I zoomed out the map screen and took a screenshot.

After confirming the location of the village where the fairies were, I started to move the screen again.

It was to find Eutenia and Evan who were moving according to my command.

Maybe it was because some time had passed since I gave them the order.

As I moved the screen, I could see the two who were moving after receiving my command.

Evan, who wore a hood and carried a heavy load, and Eutenia were moving somewhere together.

But it was very different from how Eutenia usually moved.

Eutenia and Evan were not riding a carriage for their movement.

-“This is my first time riding something like this... but it doesn't feel bad at all.”

-“Alpha is a wonderful boy.”

They were moving on a dark beast.

Eutenia was sitting on Alpha's head, reading a book and relaxing.

Evan, who was standing a little farther away, was looking around and enjoying the wind.

Maybe he was wary of the eyes of other characters.

Eutenia avoided the roads where people walked, and moved on a rugged mountain path instead.

As a result, countless trees on the mountain were colliding with Alpha's body and barrier and getting destroyed.

-“Seeing this magic... I wish I had learned some magic too.”

Alpha, who had a barrier on him, was plowing through the rough terrain like a bulldozer.

Eutenia seemed to reinforce the barrier whenever it cracked, so there was no problem with the barrier breaking.

Instead, the forest that was caught up in their sprint was changing horribly.

There were also beasts that were lying on the ground, crushed by Alpha's size, in the trail that Alpha passed.

As I watched Alpha's charging figure, I had to make a blank face again, just like before.

“Was this possible to use it like this?”

An island that carried a fairy and flew like a fighter jet in the sky.

And a shadow dragon that cut across the land like a bulldozer.

They looked very different from when I first drew them.

I scratched the back of my head and looked at the screen.

Should I be happy or regretful?

I didn't know which reaction to show.

Chapter 87: The Floating Sanctuary (2)

Chapter 87: The Floating Sanctuary (2)

After meeting Yuto, Perin returned to the village in the evening.

She was carrying a water bottle filled with water.

She was late because she had been playing with Yuto, and she got scolded for it.

But she was prepared for that, so it wasn't too hard to endure the nagging.

Besides that, Perin had a lot of things to tell the fairies.

It was about her encounter with Yuto today.

She couldn't summon spirits with the mark, but there was no problem playing with the spirits that were already summoned.

Perin wanted to tell the villagers about that fact, so she waited until the nagging was over.

After the nagging went on for a while, Perin went to find Rendel.

“Hello, Rendel!”

“Perin. What's up?”

Rendel was the elder of the village who took care of the fairies who had lost their families.

He was also one of the few fairies that Perin could talk to easily in this village.

Rendel was reading a book when he looked at her.

Perin organized what she wanted to say to him.

Her adventure today was interesting and exciting even in her own opinion.

She wanted to tell Rendel everything that happened without leaving anything out.

“Rendel! I met a new spirit this time! There was a spirit who didn’t run away from me.”

“You met a spirit?”

“Yes! I was a bit late because of that...”

Rendel frowned as he listened to Perin’s story.

Did he say something he shouldn’t have?

Perin stopped talking and looked at Rendel’s expression.

Seeing her like that, Rendel took off his glasses and put them on the desk.

He turned his chair to face Perin and asked her.

“Perin. Where did you meet the spirit?”

“I met him at the spring where I went to fetch water.”

“The spring... So you were the only one who saw him and not the others.”

“I went late to get water and that’s when Yuto came to me.”

Rendel’s eyes moved to the mark on Perin’s hand as he heard Yuto’s name.

He stared intently at the mark engraved on Perin's hand.

Perin felt embarrassed by his gaze and unconsciously covered the mark with her hand.

When Perin hid the mark, Rendel continued to question her.

"Yuto. Is that the name of the spirit?"

"Yes. It's the name I gave him."

"What does Yuto look like?"

"He's a huge pile of soil. If I had to guess his size, um... He's about as big as a small island."

The Yuto that Perin met was only big enough to fill up a fairy.

Perin gestured with her hand to show Yuto's size, and Rendel's eyes sparkled.

Was it because he heard about the spirit?

Rendel seemed more interested in Perin's story than usual today.

A vague sense of unease crept into Perin's chest as she faced Rendel.

Rendel measured the size that Perin gestured with his hand, and compared it to himself.

He looked at Perin with an ambiguous expression and said.

"That's pretty small for a spirit. He must have a weak grip."

"..."

"What other features does he have?"

"Yuto can fly very well. He's also very fast..."

“A spirit of earth that can fly?”

Rendel’s expression changed drastically as he heard that Yuto could fly.

This time, he smiled brightly at Perin.

Perin felt uneasy by his creepy smile and instinctively stepped back a few steps.

But Rendel got up from his seat and grabbed Perin’s arm.

Perin was caught by both arms by Rendel in an instant and pleaded with him in pain.

“Re, Rendel... It hurts if you hold me so hard!”

“Sorry. But Perin, who else did you tell this story to?”

“I only told you so far...”

Perin had come to see Rendel right after she was scolded.

She was late to fetch water because she was playing with Yuto, so she had no time to talk to the other fairies.

This was the first time she mentioned Yuto to anyone.

Rendel listened to Perin’s story and turned his head to look out the window.

He checked the surroundings for a moment, then looked at Perin and warned her.

“Don’t tell anyone else about this today.”

“Why not?”

“If they find out that you have a mark and you’re friends with a spirit, they might try to threaten the spirit.”

It sounded unbelievable, but Perin had no choice but to nod at Rendel.

Rendel's reaction was not good.

She wanted to sneak away and meet Yuto quietly, but she had to get out of here and go home first.

She couldn't refuse Rendel's words outright.

"Okay, I understand."

"Tomorrow we'll go to the spring together and check out the spirit you met."

"...Okay."

"Then go back for today. And be careful what you say about the spirit on your way back."

That was the end of Rendel's words.

Perin said goodbye to Rendel and left the building.

She still felt uneasy in her heart.

She wondered if she might lose Yuto to the other fairies if she made a mistake.

She decided to go to the spring early in the morning and walked home.

There is a border line in the north of Centrius that leads to the royal territory.

Around that border line, there are information dealers who sell various information about the empire.

They were pushed out of the system and could not handle information within it.

They were not as detailed as the first-class ones who sold information in the system, but they knew a lot about various information of the empire.

Evan, who wore a hood to hide his face, stopped in front of a building with Eutenia.

It was where the information dealer he was looking for was located.

“This is the place I told you about.”

“The building is quite big.”

“It’s safer to hide something in a crowded place.”

The shop that Evan visited looked like an ordinary tavern from the outside.

It was a place that the Allemier family, who couldn’t enter the center, sometimes used.

Evan grabbed the door of the tavern and opened it wide.

Creak.

As soon as Evan opened the door and entered the building, he saw men who were already drinking beer heavily.

Evan passed by the men who were tilting their glasses and headed to the counter of the tavern.

There was a man who was wiping a glass with a blank expression on his face.

“What can I do for you?”

The man who was wiping the glass asked Evan and Eutenia as they approached.

Evan put his hand that was not wearing a gauntlet into his pocket.

Clang.

A silver coin came out of Evan's pocket and landed on the counter.

It was the cost to enter the space where they sold information.

Evan handed it to the man in front of him and said.

"I want to rent a room."

"What kind of room do you want?"

"I want a big and fancy room. It would be inconvenient to have a shabby room with a mage accompanying me."

"You can go to the third room."

The man handed Evan a key.

It was the key to enter the space where the information dealer was.

Evan took the key and nodded, then went up the stairs that led to the upper floor.

Squeak. Squeak.

Every time Evan stepped on the wooden stairs, an unpleasant friction sound echoed around.

Eutenia, who was following behind Evan, looked at the key in his hand and asked.

"They seem more careful than I thought."

"It's a fairly reliable place."

"I hope he knows a lot of things."

Evan nodded at Eutenia's words.

He had to stay with her until this journey was over.

He also hoped that the information dealer he was going to meet knew a lot of things.

That was why he chose this shop.

This shop was the place where Evan compromised as much as possible without excluding the system.

"If it's the third room, it should be here."

Evan reached the second floor and headed to the third room from the left.

The squeaking sound did not stop even when he reached the second floor.

He frowned at the noise that irritated his ears and inserted the key he got from the counter into the keyhole.

Clank.

When he turned the key all the way, the lock was released with a crisp metal sound.

Evan opened the door that was unlocked and looked at the empty room.

"It seems like no one is here. Is this the right place?"

"We need to close the door first."

"Okay."

Eutenia, who entered the room with Evan, closed the door.

Darkness fell on the windowless room as the door closed.

At the same time, a small hole appeared on the right wall of the room they entered.

There was an information dealer who was smoking a cigarette with a lantern on in the small gap between the walls.

He looked at Eutenia and Evan with a bored expression as he smoked.

Rattle.

Evan dragged a chair and placed it in front of the information dealer.

He sat down facing him and said.

“I came to buy some information.”

“What kind of information do you want?”

“Information about the system or the mages around here...”

Tap. Tap.

The information dealer pointed at the wall between them with his finger as he heard Evan’s words.

Evan frowned at his attitude.

He was interrupting Evan’s words before he even started talking.

Evan glared at the information dealer who was tapping the wall with his finger.

“What are you doing?”

“If you want to talk about that, I’ll have to take a gold coin first.”

Clank.

As Evan tried to move his gauntlet, Eutenia grabbed his shoulder and shook her head.

She then handed him a gold coin.

Huff.

Evan sighed and handed the gold coin to the information dealer.

The information dealer smiled and put it in his pocket.

“I’m glad you’re smart. Those things are all high-class information, you know.”

He praised Eutenia for stopping Evan.

Evan looked at the information dealer who was eyeing his pocket and then turned to Eutenia.

He asked her in a relaxed tone.

“Eutenia. How much longer do we have to wait?”

“It’s done now.”

“So the barrier is finally ready.”

Evan got up from his seat as he heard Eutenia’s words.

It was the time he had been waiting for.

This mission required him to change his target several times depending on the situation.

He had no intention of solving it quietly from the start.

The information dealer looked puzzled by the conversation between Evan and Eutenia.

“What are you talking about...”

“You’ll find out soon enough.”

Crack.

Evan’s fist broke the wall between the rooms and created a space.

In an instant, Evan smashed the wall and reached for the information dealer’s head with his gauntlet.

The information dealer, who was caught off guard by the surprise attack, widened his eyes and looked at Evan.

Fear rose in his trembling eyes.

Evan slowly told him his purpose.

“I’ll ask you once. I’m looking for a mage. A mage who is skilled in alchemy but not in combat. Is there anyone like that around here?”

“L-let go of me! You can’t get away with this...”

“——Astraphe.”

Zap.

A lightning bolt erupted from Evan’s hand.

It was the Astraphe he was wearing that emitted a weak current.

The information dealer screamed in pain as the blue current ran through his body.

“Aaaahhh...!”

“——Astraphe.”

Zap. Zzzz.

Evan unleashed another bolt of Astraphe.

The information dealer's scream shook the room again.

But no one came to this place despite his loud cries.

It was thanks to Eutenia, who had set up a high-level soundproof barrier around them.

Eutenia's barrier not only blocked the walls, but also the vibrations that could spread through the floor.

“Ugh, ugh...”

The information dealer's body convulsed from the direct hit of Astraphe.

Evan had lowered the output and used the shock, so the information dealer did not faint.

But Evan's gauntlet that was holding the information dealer's head was still intact.

The information dealer looked at the other side of the gauntlet with half-opened eyes.

Evan, who was holding the twisting information dealer, asked him the same question again.

“This is the second time. Is there a mage who is good at alchemy around here? Preferably someone who is quiet.”

Chapter 88: The Floating Sanctuary (3)

Chapter 88: The Floating Sanctuary (3)

The next morning.

Perin woke up earlier than usual.

She would normally sleep in and get up late, but today she had to get up early.

She was worried about Rendel, who had talked to her last night.

Perin got up from her bed and started to prepare her bag.

She had a lot of things she wanted to show to Yuto, her first friend.

She put everything from the mysterious grass she had picked in the forest to the shining stone she treasured in her bag.

Then she put on her bag and left the house, checking if there were any other fairies around.

“There’s no one around, right?”

Perin looked around and confirmed that there was no one else, then ran towards the spring.

She was afraid that Rendel might follow her and create an awkward atmosphere between the three of them.

Besides, Yuto might abandon Perin and become friendly with Rendel.

Perin had always been rejected by the spirits when she tried to make a contract with them, so it was not an impossible thing.

Rendel was different from Perin. He was a fairy who had made contracts with countless spirits.

“Please wait a little, Yuto.”

As she recalled the memories of having fun with Yuto, a smile formed on Perin’s lips.

What should she do today with her new spirit friend?

Perin quickened her pace as she thought about it.

She hoped that nothing would go wrong and she would meet Yuto without any trouble.

Until an unexpected gust of wind blew over her head.

“Huh?”

A breeze swept over Perin’s head as she crossed the forest.

At the same time, a huge shadow of a bird appeared around her.

Perin looked up at the darkened surroundings and lifted her head.

She saw a familiar figure above her where the wind was blowing.

Her eyes widened as she recognized the fairy flying over her head.

“Perin. Where are you going?”

It was Rendel who was flying on a giant eagle-shaped spirit.

He asked Perin as he flew towards her.

Perin had been nervous about being caught by Rendel.

So when she faced him in this situation, she couldn't think clearly.

She blurted out the first thing that came to her mind.

“Ah, um... I just... I missed Yuto so much!”

Rendel smiled kindly at Perin's words.

He didn't scold Perin for her ridiculous excuse.

Instead, he lowered the altitude of his flying spirit and followed her closely.

Rendel narrowed the distance between him and Perin and spoke to her in a friendly voice.

“I see. I thought you were ignoring our promise.”

“N-no, that's not it!”

“I would have been very hurt if you did. Let's go quickly.”

Perin breathed a sigh of relief in her mind as Rendel didn't show any displeasure.

She was worried that he might reprimand her, but luckily he was only kind to her.

He even seemed more friendly than usual.

Perin's mind became more complicated by his behavior.

Rendel, who was riding a spirit, silently chased after Perin.

Soon, they arrived near the spring.

Perin saw Yuto from afar.

“Yuto!”

-“Soil!”

Perin ran towards Yuto with her arms wide open.

Yuto also hugged her as he came closer.

He welcomed Perin without running away or avoiding her.

Perin embraced him and rubbed her cheek on his soil pile.

Rendel watched them stick together and opened his mouth to Perin.

“Is this Yuto?”

“Yes. I gave him that name.”

Rendel looked at Perin’s answer and scanned Yuto up and down.

There was a hint of greed in his eyes as he looked at Yuto.

Perin, who had a better sense of empathy than others, easily noticed his emotion.

Rendel examined Yuto carefully and approached him.

He reached out his hand towards Yuto, who was floating in the air.

“I see. Then...”

- ◦ “Soil?”

The moment Rendel reached out to Yuto.

Yuto threw soil at him and moved away.

Splash. Thud.

Rendel took off his glasses that were splashed with soil.

He wiped the soil off his glasses and looked at Yuto with a cold gaze.

“...”

“Rendel?”

Stomp. Stomp.

Rendel took a few more steps towards Yuto.

And Yuto backed away even more.

No matter how close Rendel tried to get, Yuto only kept his distance from him.

Rendel sighed at the sight of Yuto rejecting him and said.

“I don’t know if it’s because I have contracts with many spirits, but it seems like this kid doesn’t like my touch.”

“Y-yeah, it seems so.”

Some possible ways to continue the conversation are:

He didn’t seem to mind that Yuto rejected him, even though he got soil on his face.

He gave up on Yuto easily and told Perin to play with him.

Perin was relieved by his words, as she was afraid that Yuto would fall for Rendel and ignore her.

But contrary to her expectations, Yuto only showed affection to Perin and avoided Rendel.

Perin smiled brightly and thanked Rendel.

“Thank you so much!”

“I’ll see if you can make a contract with him while you play with him. Just be careful not to get hurt by the spirit.”

“You’re the best, Rendel!”

Perin jumped on Yuto’s back and hugged him.

Yuto moved left and right, showing his excitement.

Perin could fly far away with Yuto, but Rendel could also fly with his spirit.

Rendel would help her get back to the village safely, even if she traveled far.

Perin asked Yuto to fly away.

“Uh...”

As she was about to fly away with Yuto, she saw a fairy disappearing into the forest.

She was thirsty from the early morning, or maybe it was a small boy holding a water bottle.

The boy saw Perin and Rendel and covered his mouth, then turned around and started to move.

Perin made a puzzled expression as she watched the fairy disappear into the forest.

On his way back after the experiment with Perin.

After moving Yuto to a different location and sending Perin home, Rendel returned to his house with some of Yuto’s soil that he had collected from the ground.

He couldn't examine Yuto as he pleased right now, since Yuto was rejecting his touch.

But he hoped that he would find a clue to make a contract with Yuto as time passed.

He had also moved Yuto to a place where the fairies' eyes couldn't reach, so he could research freely with Perin from now on.

Rendel smiled naturally as he thought of Yuto's identity.

He tried to hide his smile as he touched the pouch that contained Yuto's soil.

"It's the first time I've met such a spirit."

What Rendel had encountered was undoubtedly a floating earth spirit.

Floating earth spirits were a name for earth spirits that could fly among the earth spirits.

They were also one of the few secret weapons that the fairies had in their prosperous days.

It was recorded that the floating earth spirits had been completely wiped out by the ancient war, but thanks to Perin, he had met a real floating earth spirit.

The value of a flying territory was beyond comparison with anything else.

There was even a story that the fairy queen's paradise in the legend was made of floating earth spirits.

To meet such a floating earth spirit with his own eyes.

It was like a fortune for Rendel today.

"..."

He was walking happily with his imagination, but he soon had to stop in his tracks as he felt a presence.

He heard an unfamiliar sound in his ears, which made him wake up from his happy dream and face reality.

The forest where Rendel was standing was a gloomy outskirts that no ordinary fairies would visit.

It was hard to see any good intention in hiding and watching in such a forest.

Rendel slowly turned his head and started to look for the owner of the presence that he felt through the wind.

“Stop hiding and come out.”

Crunch.

The sound of stepping on the bushes echoed along with Rendel’s voice.

Rendel’s gaze naturally headed towards the direction where the sound came from.

The person who appeared in front of Rendel after stepping on the bushes was someone he often ran into.

It was Egersuit, the warrior chief who led the village’s warriors.

Egersuit put a hand on Rendel’s shoulder with an unpleasant smile.

“Elder Rendel. It seems like you have found something amazing.”

Rendel realized the situation right away from Egersuit’s words.

The story about Yuto had leaked out.

Someone had discovered Yuto and told Egersuit, or Perin had spread the information somewhere else.

The suspects who could have leaked the information started to flash through Rendel's mind.

But even while doing so, Rendel didn't forget to answer Egersuit calmly.

"What are you talking about? I don't know what you mean."

"Don't play dumb. A kid told me everything after seeing it."

Egersuit told Rendel that someone had seen his appearance.

Could it be that one of the fairies who came to the spring had seen Yuto?

Rendel's face hardened as he thought of a conclusion about the suspect.

"Who told you such nonsense?"

"What do you want to do with that information? It looks like you even set up a barrier at the spring."

"A barrier? I don't know what you're talking about."

Rendel had set up a barrier to prevent this kind of trouble.

Unfortunately, the barrier seemed to have no effect.

Egersuit shook his head slowly at Rendel's consistent denial.

And then he added more force to his hand that was holding Rendel's shoulder.

"Elder Rendel. Don't you know my personality well? I'm doing this for everyone's sake."

"Since when is this for everyone's sake?"

"I'm trying to work for the prosperity of the fairy race."

"That's some top-notch nonsense."

There was no way to completely avoid this situation now.

Tsk.

Rendel bit his lips as he clicked his tongue.

Egersuit seemed to have expected that, and he tapped Rendel's shoulder and whispered in his ear with a light voice.

"I'll leave the magic part to you, Elder Rendel. It's hard to find a way to make a contract with that thing without you anyway."

"..."

"If you refuse, I'll put a restraint on that filthy thing first, and then proceed with the contract."

There were some magic that were banned among the fairies.

Egersuit was talking about using such magic to put a restriction on Perin.

Rendel frowned at Egersuit's words.

Restraint was a means to suppress the fairies who went against the order.

It was not an easy magic that could be applied to any fairy either.

"You're talking crazy. There could be a clash between the mark and the magic. Maybe..."

"It's a proven magic over a long time, and you doubt it? And do you think the evil god would care about such lowly things? I'll take care of it properly."

Snort.

Egersuit scoffed at Rendel's worry.

He looked like he had no intention of giving up at all.

He was eager to get Yuto by any means possible.

Rendel sighed deeply at Egersuit's attitude.

He had been thinking of using some risky methods if a problem arose.

He would have to deal with some unpleasant guys, but the big picture of his plan wouldn't change.

Rendel adjusted his crooked glasses and pulled Egersuit's hand off his shoulder.

"How many of you know about this?"

"Not many yet. But if you want to use that spirit publicly, you'll have to disclose some information, won't you?"

"I guess so."

"Either you make a contract and announce it publicly, or else—."

"Put a restraint on it?"

"It's a lowly thing with a mark on it, so it won't be treated as a kin. Don't worry too much about the village's backlash."

The restraint was not something that could be done quietly.

He had to get the consent of the village to put a restraint on Perin.

Fortunately, most of the fairies in the village had a negative view of Perin.

There was a high chance that the control would be given to Rendel, the elder, if the restraint was carried out.

He had no choice but to answer Egersuit, who had an unpleasant but plausible plan.

“I need to research the contract with the floating earth spirit. Keep your mouth shut for a while.”

“I’m not a loose-lipped person.”

“What are you going to do with the kid who reported it?”

“Don’t worry too much about that kid. He wants to join the warrior corps, so he won’t spill anything easily.”

Rendel nodded at Egersuit’s words and started to walk again.

Egersuit also followed Rendel’s steps.

It was the moment when an implicit agreement was made between them.

Rendel glanced at Egersuit who was following him.

He didn’t like him from the start, but he liked him even less today.

“I’ll have to meet that kid first. Arrange a place for me.”

Evening, when the sun was setting.

The sound of two fairies walking on the grass echoed in the dense forest.

Chapter 89: The Floating Sanctuary (4)

Chapter 89: The Floating Sanctuary (4)

It had been a few days since I left Yuto alone, who had run away to the forest where the fairies lived.

Yuto was quietly waiting for the fairy named Perin, without running away or doing anything else.

It seemed that their relationship was quite friendly.

Maybe I needed a spirit master from the beginning to handle a spirit properly.

Anyway, the fact that Yuto was tied to that fairy meant that I had to recruit a fairy for Yuto's sake.

If Yuto grew bigger than he is now, he could carry several people on his back.

There was enough value to appoint a new apostle for controlling Yuto.

“It's different from a carriage in terms of speed.”

Yuto's moving speed was not so fast that the screen of my smartphone couldn't catch up.

But thanks to his ability to move without being affected by the terrain, there was no means that could match Yuto in long-distance travel.

If I think about the time it takes for Eutenia to travel by carriage, I can save a lot of time from now on.

That's why I couldn't help but worry about the next <Apostle Selection> skill.

“Hmm...”

There were two characters that I was considering to select as apostles.

One was Daniel, an assassin who was called the Silent Butcher.

And the other one was Perin, who could freely manipulate [Floating Earth Spirit].

Both of them had enough value to be appointed as apostles, considering their roles in the future.

But in Daniel's case, his location was still unclear.

If I wanted to appoint Daniel first, I would have to postpone <Apostle Selection> until the next meeting.

“Considering the time it takes to train a character... It's hard to wait that long.”

An assassin who specialized in physical attacks would be nice, but I was not a patient person who could endure forever.

So I decided to select Perin as an apostle right now.

I still needed time to fully handle a character even after establishing communication with an apostle.

I couldn't afford to waste any more time.

I moved the screen right away and headed towards Perin.

Perin was sitting on top of Yuto's head, leisurely enjoying the scenery.

-“Yuto! Isn’t it fun to see the mountains from above?”

-“Soil.”

They seemed to communicate well or not at all.

I chuckled as I watched the two characters interact.

The combination of a fairy and a spirit suited each other very well.

I looked at them and touched the <Apostle Selection> skill icon at the bottom of the screen.

Press.

As soon as I pressed the skill, a message window popped up asking me if I wanted to select an apostle as usual.

-Do you want to select [Perin Shtait] as an apostle?

-You need 1600 karma to select an apostle.

-Yes / No

The karma consumption was doubled from before, 1600.

It had started to become a big burden.

The next apostle would have a much longer interval between selections than now.

It was a pity, but it was also a natural phenomenon that occurred as the level increased.

I pressed ‘Yes’ and proceeded with the procedure to select Perin as an apostle.

-[Perin Shtait] has been selected as an apostle.

-You have consumed 1600 karma to create a new artifact for the apostle.

-[Artifact: Fake God Tree Yggdrasil] has been bound to [Perin Shtait].

-[Perin Shtait] has rejected the path of the apostle.

-<Apostle Selection> has been postponed.

Right after that, I confirmed the message that <Apostle Selection> had been rejected.

Perin had refused to become an apostle herself.

It was a rejection that I experienced for the first time since I selected Evan as an apostle.

I stared at the screen blankly at the message that she had rejected <Apostle Selection>.

Perin in the screen was playing with Yuto as if nothing had happened.

She even said some strange words to Yuto with a gentle face.

-“Yuto... I guess being a servant of the evil god is a bit too much, right?”

-“Soil.”

I couldn't help but raise my right index finger at her behavior.

How dare an NPC reject my offer to become my subordinate?

And on top of that, riding on a pet that I bought with my money, and even badmouthing me?

I couldn't tolerate her actions any longer with my broad mind.

She might not die since she was selected as an apostle, but she had to pay for scratching my heart in front of me.

My trembling finger approached the screen.

“How dare you refuse to become my subordinate?”

My father always told me this.

A man who draws his sword must cut something, even if it's grass.

I couldn't cut grass here, but I thought I could teach a lesson to one rude fairy.

If I can't have it, I have to make it mine.

Fortunately, I had plenty of effective means for that.

“Show me what you've got.”

I aimed my finger at Perin, who was sitting on top of Yuto.

And then I lightly touched her head once.

Tap.

As my magic decreased a little, a faint scream came out of Perin's mouth.

-“Eek!”

-“Soil.”

Perin, who was hit by a basic attack, clutched her head and looked up at the sky.

But I had no intention of forgiving her with just one hit.

She had committed the sin of insulting a player who paid cash every month.

She had to pay for it with her body for scratching my heart in front of me.

I kept tapping Perin's head with my finger.

Tap.

-“Eek!”

-“Soil soil.”

Tap.

-“Eek!”

-“Soil soil soil.”

Tap.

-“Eek!”

-“Soil soil soil soil.”

After hitting her forehead several times with basic attacks, Perin’s forehead swelled up red and she teared up.

Yuto, who was carrying her, also made incomprehensible noises and echoed her.

It was probably because I taught her some manners after she failed to grasp the situation.

Not long after that, Perin changed her attitude.

She expressed her acceptance with a more polite demeanor than before.

-“I-I’ll do it! I’ll be your apostle, evil god!”

-“Soil soil.”

“Why am I am evil god!”

If only she didn’t call me by that wicked name.

Evan and Eutenia always called me by the supreme honorific.

My karma balance was a bit skewed, but I thought I was still decent enough.

Who would be good if not me, who paid money to the game company to maintain the world?

I quickly compromised in my head and nodded with gratitude for my mercy.

Meanwhile, a message about Perin popped up at the bottom of the screen.

-[The 4th Apostle: Perin Shtait] has become your apostle.

-By the effect of <Apostle Selection>, you will share your magic with the selected apostles.

-By the effect of <Apostle Selection>, you will be able to send separate messages to the selected apostles.

The rest of the process was completed as Perin accepted <Apostle Selection>.

Perin now received magic from me and could communicate directly with me.

In other words, I could also tell her bad things directly.

A speech bubble icon appeared above Perin's head.

I immediately touched the icon that appeared above Perin's head.

“How dare you? Reject my offer... Huh?”

And then I started to express my feelings towards Perin in a long text.

In a flash, ominous and dreadful words were written in the chat window with Perin.

As soon as I pressed the send button to deliver the vicious message to Perin.

The ‘new translator’ translated my sentence into a short and concise one.

- ◦ “I forgive your sins.”
- ◦ “Oh, evil god! Thank you.”

At the same time as the message of forgiveness popped up, Perin looked up at the sky and muttered her thanks.

She was forgiven without me doing anything.

It was a ridiculous and unbelievable sight no matter how I thought about it.

I opened my mouth wide and glared at the smartphone screen.

“No, I haven’t forgiven you yet!”

Rendel’s laboratory, located in the fairy village.

There, Rendel took off his glasses and clutched his head.

His eyes were full of bloodshot veins.

He was not satisfied with the results of his research so far.

He bit his lips as he looked at the wooden board in his hand.

“Damn it...”

Rendel had been continuing his research on Yuto every day since he met Perin.

Most of it was for establishing a contract with Yuto.

He had tried to contract with Yuto several times when Perin was not around.

But no matter how much he researched, he couldn't find any clues.

The forced contracts he had attempted had failed several times, and no matter how much he searched through the documents, he couldn't find any more useful information.

It was the end of the road for Rendel, the greatest sage of the village.

Blood trickled from his lips as they touched the sharp teeth.

“Why! Why won't you accept my contract!”

He poured out his questions that filled his head and threw the wooden board that was on his desk.

Bang!

The wooden board bounced off the wall and rolled on the floor.

He threw things to vent his anger, but he couldn't calm down the frustration in his heart.

He got up from his seat and punched the desk several times.

“I followed all the procedures! Why are you rejecting me!”

He could easily find documents about contracts with spirits that had materialized.

But even if he referred to those documents, he couldn't see any signs of success in contracting with Yuto.

It was Yuto who rejected the contract with Rendel.

The same was true for his attempts at forced contracts with spirits.

He couldn't do anything properly against Yuto, who was of a high rank.

There was nothing left for Rendel to try.

He bit his lips and slammed his head against the wall, when he heard a voice from behind him.

“What a pathetic sight, Elder Rendel.”

He turned his eyes to the back.

Egersuit had quietly entered Rendel’s laboratory without him noticing and spoke to him.

Rendel looked at him with a twisted head and a glare in his eyes.

He was annoyed by Egersuit’s presence.

Rendel scolded Egersuit, who had sneaked into his laboratory without his knowledge.

“You seem to have no manners, our warrior chief.”

“Is it also polite to throw wooden boards on such a dark night?”

“I put up a soundproof barrier and threw my own stuff. What’s the problem?”

“Isn’t it barbaric for a fairy who loves trees? Everyone respects Elder Rendel, but you should show some exemplary behavior.”

Spit.

He spat out blood-stained saliva and glared at Egersuit.

Egersuit looked at him with a faint smile on his lips.

Rendel felt very annoyed by his smiling face.

But by now, he had very limited options.

“Stop talking nonsense and tell me why you came here.”

“How is your research going?”

“...I still need more time.”

“Still? It sounds like you have no idea how long it will take.”

He was angry, but Egersuit was right.

Rendel clenched his fists and nodded at his words.

“It takes time for a difficult research.”

“Elder Rendel. We don’t have much time.”

“What are you talking about?”

“That wretched thing is getting closer to the spirit day by day. What do you think will happen if there is a conflict in the village?”

“Are you saying that Perin will run away?”

“That’s right.”

It was not an impossible story.

Perin was not on good terms with everyone in this village.

She had been staying here only by barely avoiding exile.

She could easily leave if there was a problem.

But Rendel still needed more time for his research.

“She won’t leave anytime soon. I still need to do more research.”

“Isn’t it time to use that method?”

“That method is the last resort. If I put a curse on my kin without any care...”

“Elder Rendel.”

“...”

Egersuit sighed and shook his head.

He looked like he had already made up his mind.

“The target of the curse is not just anyone. It’s a wretched being who has caught the eye of the evil god.”

“Well, that’s true, but...”

“Besides, she has the unwanted Yuto with her. How long do you have to leave that dangerous thing alone?”

“Sigh.”

Rendel’s eyes, soaked in thoughts, looked out the window.

A bright moon was rising in the dark sky.

Under the moon that reflected in Rendel’s eyes, the trees glowed with light.

It was a beautiful and clear scenery, unlike Rendel’s dizzy head.

Egersuit’s sharp voice pierced Rendel’s ears as he looked out the window.

“I trust that Elder Rendel will make a wise choice. I will convene a meeting tomorrow morning, so come with a clear decision.”

With that, Egersuit opened the door and left the laboratory.

Bang!

A loud noise echoed as the door of the laboratory closed after Egersuit left.

Rendel closed his eyes quietly as he watched him leave.

After the commotion, he had long forgotten about his research.

Only the glittering night sky remained vivid under his eyelids.

Chapter 90.1: Floating Sanctuary

(5) Part 1

Chapter 90: Floating Sanctuary (5) Part 1

On the way back home after finishing the contract with the god she first met.

Perin smiled faintly as she looked at the mark engraved on the back of her hand.

She became an apostle of the god she called the evil god, but he didn't seem to be as bad as she thought.

The evil god introduced Yuto to her and gave her a mysterious gift called a miracle.

The mark in her hand was also a sign that was engraved on a special person, he told her.

She also heard that she had to leave this village soon, but Perin asked for a few more days of grace.

It was to say goodbye to the fairies in the village and leave for a few days.

“I don't know how they'll react when I tell them I'm leaving.”

Perin, who had hidden Yuto and the miracle in the forest, wondered how the other fairies would react to her farewell.

There were several times when Perin had decided to leave the village.

But this was the first time she said goodbye properly to the fairies in the village.

She was also saying goodbye to the village she had grown fond of for a while.

Maybe there were some who would be sad to hear that Perin was leaving among the fairies.

Of course, she couldn't tell them that she became an apostle of the evil god.

“By the way, I feel a little sorry for Rendel.”

As the village came closer, Rendel's image flashed through Perin's mind.

At first, Perin thought Rendel might take Yuto away from her.

But even after a long time since he introduced Yuto, Rendel didn't do anything suspicious.

He only occasionally stroked Yuto when Perin wasn't around.

He even gave Perin some rare plants to use for decorating Yuto.

Rather, Perin wondered if she was too harsh on Rendel.

“Rendel?”

As Perin pondered about Rendel, she saw a busy-looking village in her sight.

The center of the village where a withered tree stood.

There, many fairies were talking with serious faces.

Among them, Rendel was also present.

Apparently, something big had happened in the village.

Perin ran towards Rendel and the fairies to find out what was going on.

“.....Perin?”

At the sound of Perin’s footsteps running towards the village, Rendel, who was talking with the fairies, looked at her.

Rendel looked at Perin with a stiff face.

The faces of the fairies who were talking with Rendel were also dark.

It seemed that it was much more serious than Perin expected.

Thinking that Rendel might ask her to run an errand, Perin ran straight towards him to help him.

“Rendel! Is there anything I can help you with?”

Perin stopped in front of Rendel and asked him with a smile.

But Rendel’s face was still dark.

Rendel quietly closed his mouth and looked at Perin.

At his attitude, all the fairies around him glared at Perin.

Their eyes were directed at the mark on Perin’s back of hand.

Perin hid the mark as she backed away from their gaze.

“.....”

Perin was scared by the sudden gaze of the fairies.

She had many experiences of being sneered at by fairies who saw her mark.

But this was the first time that everyone looked at her without saying anything.

Perin was confused by their unfamiliar gaze and backed away.

As soon as Perin backed away,

The fairies around her turned their backs on her.

It looked like they were surrounding Perin in the center.

“What are you doing all of a sudden?”

“Perin.”

“Yes?”

“There was no other choice.”

As Perin looked at Rendel with a puzzled look, he said something ominous to her.

As soon as their conversation ended,

The fairies around her rushed towards Perin.

Thud!

With a heavy thud, Perin fell to the ground and groaned from her mouth.

“Ouch……!”

Perin frowned and checked her situation.

She felt hands pressing down on her arms and head.

She couldn't move freely in this situation.

The fairies around her had grabbed her and restrained her.

Perin lifted her head and looked up.

Rendel was holding a wooden staff in his hand.

“We will now perform the ritual of banishment on Perin Shtait.”

Rendel declared in a solemn voice to Perin and the fairies.

Banishment.

Perin’s face turned pale at his words.

She had heard stories about banishment from the old tales of the fairies.

It was a magical means to punish a fellow who strayed from the right path and harmed the fairies.

A fairy who was banished would suffer terrible pain and could not rest without the permission of other fairies.

Perin bit her lip as she remembered the banishment.

“Rendel! Please, please let me go!”

“You filthy thing, stay still!”

“I didn’t do anything! Really, sob……!”

“Aah!”

The fairy who held Perin’s mouth tried to stop her, but Perin bit his hand hard.

The fairy screamed and let go of his bleeding hand.

Perin freed her mouth and struggled to get closer to Rendel.

“I didn’t do anything! You said if I lived well, other fairies would like me! Why are you doing this to me!”

“You are too dangerous. That’s why we decided that we can’t control you without banishment.”

“I’ll leave the village, I’ll leave! So please, just let me go……!”

“Shut up and be quiet!”

The fairy who grabbed Perin’s head tightened his grip.

Perin felt a pain as if her head was going to crack and tears filled her eyes.

Meanwhile, Rendel’s staff was getting closer to Perin.

The staff with a blue light looked like a monster’s shape in Perin’s eyes.

Rendel uttered a short spell towards Perin.

“——Obey the order. Submit to the providence.”

“No, no……!”

“——We are born under the tree and sleep under the mound of earth.”

The blue light touched Perin’s skin and unknown symbols began to be engraved on it.

The symbols with light spread over Perin’s body and gradually grew in size.

A hot heat spread from where the symbols were drawn.

The spreading symbols were eating away at Perin’s body.

The heat from her body made Perin scream.

“Ah, it hurts! Stop……!”

“——Live under the same dream under the great will.”

“Stop it……!”

“——Obey. He is…….”

Despite Perin’s screams, Rendel continued the ritual.

The symbols that were engraved faded dozens of times as the blue light flickered.

Perin, who was under the symbols, kept pleading in pain.

Rendel, who was conducting the ritual, also had cold sweat running down his forehead.

As the ritual continued in screams, it finally reached its end.

Perin screamed again.

“Stop it! Stop it!”

Crack. Bang!

With her voice, the symbols engraved on her body shattered.

The symbols that wrapped around Perin became fragments of light and scattered in all directions.

The ritual that Rendel was conducting failed.

Only the mark on Perin’s hand remained, blinking with light.

Rendel vomited blood and stepped back a few steps.

“Cough… ugh……!”

Rendel looked at Perin with wide eyes.

There was disbelief and fear in his eyes.

Perin, who had stopped the ritual, tried to get up.

But the hands that pressed her down were still there.

Some of the fairies went to Rendel and supported him.

“Rendel! Are you okay!”

Rendel wiped the blood on his mouth with their support.

No one here cared about Perin’s condition.

Rather, they were taking care of Rendel, who tried to engrave the banishment on her.

A huge sense of betrayal rose in Perin’s heart.

Dark emotions that had sunk into the abyss rose up slowly.

With a voice in her ear and darkness in the sky.

-“Who covets what is mine?”

The sky, where the evening sun had set, was suddenly covered with dark clouds.

It was an unnatural sight for anyone to see.

The anomaly that filled the sky did not stop there.

Crackle. Sparkle.

Lightning began to flash from the clouds in the sky.

The fairies’ hands trembled at the sight of the clouds glowing blue.

“The sky is weird?”

“What is this…….”

The fairies who held Perin down couldn’t finish their words.

Boom!

A streak of lightning fell between the fairies who surrounded Perin.

With a bright streak of light and a thunderous sound that shook their ears, smoke rose from the ground where the bushes had burned.

The fairies who were hit by lightning also convulsed and rolled on the ground.

Perin was the only fairy who could move safely after being hit by lightning.

“Rendel Elder, what is this……?”

Egershut, who was near Rendel, asked him.

Then Rendel laughed hollowly and looked at the sky.

He had a look of transcendence on his face.

It was the first time for Perin to see such a face of Rendel.

He opened his mouth with a sarcastic smile on his face as he looked at the sky.

“It’s the evil god.”

“……What?”

“We touched something that belongs to the evil god. Now he is looking at us.”

As soon as Rendel’s words ended,

Another lightning bolt came down from the sky.

Zap!

With a flash of light, one of the fairies near him fell to the ground.

The fairies’ eyes turned to the fallen fairy.

His last breath was buried in thunder and disappeared.

“You did it…….”

The fairies who stood up summoned spirits and looked around.

Among them, there was a fairy who tried to find the cause of this incident.

He was one of the men near Rendel.

He pointed at Perin with his finger and shouted at her.

“You did it! You brought the evil god here!”

Perin opened her eyes wide and looked at him.

He gritted his teeth and slowly moved away from her.

His words were just the beginning.

The fairies who heard his accusation joined him in line.

They pointed their fingers at Perin and poured out hateful insults.

“You filthy and vulgar thing!”

“I knew you would cause trouble someday! You finally brought out the evil god!”

“Get out of here! You dirty seed!”

Perin didn’t know what to do with their insults.

Rendel was the one who did wrong first by trying to engrave banishment on her.

But everyone here was spewing hatred at her.

Everyone had their own reasons to blame Perin.

The fairies had always hated Perin, but today their hostility was different from usual.

Moreover, some of them were spouting absurd accusations at her.

“You brought the evil god here from the start to kill us all!”

“No, I didn’t...”

Perin tried to say something in response to the fairy’s words.

But her words never came out of her mouth.

The fairy who was scolding Perin cut her off.

He glared at Perin with bloodshot eyes and continued to berate her.

“What do you mean, no? You are a disgrace to our fairy race!”

“I said no! I really...”

“Shut up! How dare you, a filthy and wicked servant of the evil god, speak in front of us!”

Ouch.

Perin clenched her teeth at the finger pointing at her.

At this moment, she was evil.

No matter what she said, the fairies here would not believe her.

But still, Perin had to speak.

She had to tell them everything about the feelings she had been holding inside.

“I... I said no.”

“...”

“I said no! I just wanted to get along with everyone!”

Her true feelings burst out.

Perin’s voice that came out of her mouth was the most desperate one in her life.

When was the last time she spoke so honestly?

It was the first time since she lost her family who cared for her.

Perin’s fist that spoke her true feelings was trembling uncontrollably from the overflowing emotions.

“I said no so many times! But you all ignored me because of my mark! No one listened to me!”

She wanted to be friends with everyone.

She had been trying hard for a long time with that one thought.

She tried to be like other fairies.

She tried to eliminate her flaws and get closer to others.

She tried to change the minds of the fairies who hated her. She remembered the moments when she trimmed the trees in the village with clumsy hands.

She also remembered how she scratched her hand until it bled to get rid of the mark on it.

There were times when she cried alone and expressed her loneliness to the trees in the forest.

There was a time when she thought that if she could use spirits even with a mark, she would be accepted by others.

“That’s why, I kept on wanting... I endured until now...”

And then she met the spirit she had been longing for.

Yuto. The only and mysterious friend who came to Perin, who was a loner.

She made a precious friend and promised to be with him forever.

As long as she was with the spirit, she would be recognized as a proper fairy.

She returned to the village where everyone was with that imagination.

“Just that one thing... I only wanted that one thing——!”

But nothing changed for her.

The fairies in the village still hated and feared her.

Even though she had no power to deserve that.

They hated, blamed, and shunned her for having a mark on her hand.

A marked fairy was nothing but an outsider from beginning to end.

It was impossible for her to be accepted by others no matter what she did.

“No one... looks at me...”

As time passed, Perin was the one who got hurt.

There were things in the world that could not be changed like a mountain.

Like the mark that was clearly engraved on the back of her hand.

That’s why she had to admit it eventually.

Chapter 90.2: Floating Sanctuary

(6) Part 2

Chapter 90: Floating Sanctuary (5) Part 2

All the fairies around her did not want her to remain a good child.

She could no longer be a good child.

“So now, I...”

Perin’s eyes stained with blood looked up at the sky.

The sky was dark and rain was pouring down.

Plop. Plop.

The sound of rain hitting the leaves reached Perin’s ears clearly.

The rainwater that ran down her cheeks cooled down Perin’s burning head.

The passion that had been burning inside her also cooled down in the cold rainwater.

“Now... I...”

In the rain that quenched the heat, Perin realized.

All her efforts were in vain.

The fairies in front of her did not love Perin.

And Perin no longer loved them either.

There was no reason to maintain this dry relationship anymore.

“As long as I have Yuto... I don’t need anything else.”

What came out of her frozen emotions was evil.

The evil that represented the sky on earth.

The apostle of the evil god who opened his eyes in purity looked at the fairies.

Sometimes there are moments like that.

When I cry watching a movie, or get emotional over a line of words that I like.

When I read a book and feel frustrated for the protagonist who is in a difficult situation.

These things don’t happen often, but sometimes they come to me.

I find myself empathizing with stories that are not even my own.

The situation I am in right now is one of those cases.

-“I told you to stop!”

What is displayed on the screen is the appearance of Perin, the fairy I contracted with.

She is being pinned down by other fairies, and subjected to a suspicious magic.

No one stops their actions despite her voice demanding them to stop.

They ignore Perin’s story completely and are trapped in their own world.

A dryness fills my mouth as I watch the screen.

I unknowingly grip the smartphone in my hand tightly.

“...”

It’s just a trivial tragedy that happens to a character.

It’s nothing more than a story of AI’s causing friction according to a predetermined scenario.

Everything I see in front of me is fake, and nothing but a play prepared for me.

At the end of this story, a character for me will be completed, and will continue to move for me.

Even so.

Even so, I don’t feel comfortable watching the screen.

Even though I know this is fake, I have to feel uncomfortable with the sight in front of me.

“...Stupid bastards.”

It’s a different feeling from crying while watching a sad movie.

It’s also very different from feeling like my character is losing something.

I feel angry watching the screen right now.

Clear anger.

I’m angry that they’re messing with my character, but what makes me even angrier is that she’s being ignored.

-“Rendel! Are you okay!”

She is the character I chose.

They ignored the character I chose.

They criticized and insulted her, and kept twisting her story.

I couldn't just let go of their attitude.

Even if I knew it was a scripted plot.

-“What do you mean! You are the disgrace of our fairy race!”

They're just NPCs for crying out loud.

They live like hamsters according to set rules, with false lives.

They don't know anything about the truth, and look at the same sky every time.

Who are they ignoring right now?

Who are they trying to mess with the toy under me?

“That's why it makes me feel worse.”

I don't intend to sit in the VIP seat and watch the tragedy forever.

The only thing that suits the heartbreaking tragedy is them who reject me.

Those who have come under me should not suffer such things.

That's because I'm paying for it.

I am – hoping that these little creatures move according to my will.

“Die.”

I don't care about being a god or whatever, such a ridiculous role in the game.

There are only strict rules on this small screen.

I'm above and they're below.

Those who go against my will don't need to exist.

Everything I see must be my world that moves for me.

That was the 'rule of the game' that existed between me and them.

-You used <Lightning Arrow>.

A streak of lightning pours out from where I touch it.

Kwaang!

Along with a bright light, Perin, who was on the screen, was surrounded by fairies who fell to the ground.

A faint smoke rises from where the blue lightning fell.

At that, all kinds of fairies on the screen screamed and raised their weapons.

They seemed to be trying to resist something against my attack.

-“Uh, ugh!”

-“It's an evil god! The evil god has returned!”

The fairies who moved around screaming loudly looked very pathetic.

They surrounded Perin, who was standing alone, and held their spirits in their hands with fearful faces.

As I watched them guarding one another, a bitter impulse rose up in me.

The lightning just now was just a warning.

I haven't even unleashed a proper attack yet.

I decided to give them a more powerful lightning strike this time.

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

A different level of magic was activated from <Lightning Arrow>.

As soon as I used the magic, numerous thunderclouds appeared on the screen.

The screen darkened more than before, and so did the faces of the fairies.

Some of them tried to use defensive magic for the impending attack.

But it was futile in front of <Giga Lightning>.

Unlike <Lightning Arrow>, this magic was not over after dodging it once.

-“Magic is pouring down!”

Along with the cry of a fairy looking at the sky, lightning bolts began to rain down.

Kwaang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

With successive explosions, a blue flash swept across the screen.

Every time a lightning bolt struck, a fairy fell to its place.

The periodic flashes faithfully erased the fairies around.

A lot of speech bubbles rose up on the screen along with the bombardment of lightning created by <Giga Lightning>.

The contents of the speech bubbles were mostly the screams of the fairies hit by the lightning.

-“Aaaah...!”

-“Cough!”

-“Run, run! We’ll all die if we stay here!”

The <Eye of the Observer>, which had reached a certain level, captured the screams of the characters in detail.

The number of fairies in the forest noticeably decreased with this attack.

It was impossible to completely eliminate the fairies with this attack, but it was clear that the backbone of the fairies had been reduced to karma.

Even the remaining ones could be dealt with for sure if I used magic a few more times.

I moved my finger to the skill icon to continue using magic.

“I guess you finally arrived.”

I stopped my finger as I spotted the character I had been waiting for.

It was the character I had ordered a long time ago, who had just arrived at the village.

I had used him as a stress reliever, but basically, catching him was a waste of time for me.

It didn’t matter if I left the rest of them to the other characters.

I lifted my hand from the skill icon, and a giant scythe flashed on the screen.

It was time to check the performance of the character after a long time.

The elder of the fairy village, Rendel, looked around with a hollow gaze.

Thanks to the meeting that Egersuit forced, Perin’s golden ritual had been passed just a while ago.

Rendel also prepared for the golden ritual with the thought that he had no choice.

He thought it was the best thing to suppress Perin after failing the research.

Once they captured Perin, they planned to lure Yuto to the village naturally.

But what came to the village was not Yuto, but an unknown liquid.

He had no choice but to infuse power into his staff as he saw the smoke rising from around him.

“It seems we’ve done something crazy.”

Crackle. Sparkle.

Sparks flew from the barrier that wrapped around Rendel and the fairies.

Rendel’s barrier barely offset the lightning that struck from the sky.

But the fairies who were not skilled at handling the barrier were not safe.

Most of the fairies who were hit by the lightning turned into black ashes and scattered.

Those who survived the lightning were also trembling and unable to move.

All of this was done by the sky god who was watching them from above.

The whole village of fairies had to pay the price for attracting the attention of the evil god.

“El, Elder Rendel! Is there no way to solve this situation?”

Egersuit, who was next to Rendel, asked him with a fearful face.

The warrior chief who used to hold his sword proudly was long gone.

Rendel snorted at Egersuit’s appearance and slammed his staff down.

A way to solve the attention of the evil god?

If there was such a being who could do that, he wouldn't be called by an ordinary name.

He would be doing great deeds under a noble name like a hero or a saint.

“Maybe you should try putting a gold seal on the evil god?”

“Elder Rendel! Are you joking in this situation?”

“Joking? Maybe we can survive if we put a gold seal on the evil god. Maybe we can even control him and rule the world.”

Hahaha——

A sigh-filled laughter came out of Rendel's mouth.

Everyone shunned him by the name of evil god, but he was a being who could compete with the six heavenly gods.

There was no way that a mere law of attraction would work on such a being.

What kind of name would he have to bring to blind his eyes?

He thought that only the name of the great world tree would be able to divert his attention for a moment.

“You're really crazy.”

“What else can I do without going crazy? We're all going to die anyway.”

“If you think hard enough, there might be a way to survive.”

“I'm not good at thinking as a mage, so it would be better for you stubborn warriors to think!”

Egersuit's face turned red at Rendel's words and he drew his big sword.

The sword was his symbol as well as his weapon.

He pointed his sword at the sky and prepared to break out of the barrier.

Seeing Egersuit trying to fight against the evil god, Rendel's lips curled up in mockery.

As he met eyes with Egersuit, who was about to say something displeased,

A seductive voice began to creep into their ears.

“You are still foolish.”

Rendel and Egersuit's eyes turned to where the voice came from at the same time.

Bats were flying together under the sunset hidden by clouds.

And there was a girl sitting on top of them.

Dark hair that glowed red even under the dark sky.

Ruby-like eyes that shone brightly in red.

The girl who commanded the bats like fish caught their attention immediately.

“A, vampire...?”

The ancestor of vampires, who was famous by name.

The only existing vampire and an ancient monster who had been with them since the beginning of history.

Pluto Austria.

The fairies who saw her realized her identity in an instant.

“You shouldn't exist...”

A being that shouldn't exist showed herself clearly in front of them.

Pluto's eyes sparkled in the darkness, and Rendel sank into despair again as he looked at her.

"I didn't know the vampire was still alive..."

"You seem to be very surprised."

"There's no reason not to be. The sealed ancestor of vampires is right in front of me."

Rendel dropped his staff on the ground as he faced Pluto.

It wasn't hard to guess who she was representing.

The ancestor in front of him was the agent of the evil god.

She came to spread his will to the fairies here and collect the price of their share.

Egersuit was more confused than anyone else by Rendel's gesture of laying down his weapon in front of Pluto.

He pointed his sword at Rendel's neck and asked him urgently.

"Elder Rendel! Are you really crazy?"

"I don't want to see your face as the last thing I see."

"Rendel! Wake up!"

Rendel did not yield to Egersuit's threat.

Rather, he spread his arms wide and waited for the death that would come to him.

As if responding to Rendel, Pluto took a stance with her death scythe in her hand.

Darkness formed a giant scythe to match the appearance of the noble ancestor.

A giant scythe of darkness pointed at them right in front of them.

Egersuit, who was thinking of blocking Pluto's scythe, moved his sword in front of Rendel.

“Elder Rendel! I'll block it! Request reinforcements with magic as soon as possible!”

“Again, you are really... foolish creatures.”

Pluto smiled and swung her scythe.

Egersuit's greatsword also swung toward Pluto's scythe that was rushing at them.

The moment the shape of the jet-black scythe and Egersuit's greatsword collided,

Pluto's scythe pierced through the greatsword and grazed past them.

The slash that broke through all defenses in an instant cut across Rendel and Egersuit's bodies.

Swoosh—

With a clear sound, a deep wound was engraved on Egersuit's chest.

Egersuit's eyes widened as he stood still with blood gushing out of his chest.

“Kuh... Huk...!”

Crack!

Egersuit stabbed his greatsword into the ground and covered his wound with one hand.

Fear of death was clearly visible in his bloodshot eyes.

He tried to stop the bleeding from his wound by leaning on his greatsword.

But there was no sign of his wound calming down despite Egersuit's desperate touch.

As he was covering his wound, Pluto walked toward them leisurely.

“Didn't you say that you were born under the tree and died under the dirt?”

Pluto recalled the fairies' spell and raised her hand that was not holding the scythe.

Then she lightly snapped her fingers together.

Snap—

The moment Pluto flicked her thin fingers,

Blood exploded from Rendel and Egersuit's chests.

With a loud noise, blood splattered and created a gruesome scene.

“I guess you can't go back to the dirt.”

Pluto lifted her scythe and spoke as she used blood magic.

The ancestor of vampires in their blurred vision.

That was the last sight that Rendel and Egersuit saw.

Chapter 91: The Floating Sanctuary (7)

Chapter 91: The Floating Sanctuary (7)

On the way to the imperial central region, under the direct control of the royal family.

Evan looked at the information broker who was tied up with a rope.

It had been a few days since Evan and Eutenia had taken the information broker out of the building.

Thanks to Eutenia's soundproof barrier, it was not difficult to gather the data that the information broker had.

That's how Evan and Eutenia quietly escaped outside with the dark beast and carried the information broker along with the data.

The information broker had been dragged around by Evan's party for several days, bound by a rope.

It was natural that complaints flowed out of the information broker's mouth, who had been dragged around continuously.

"Isn't this a bad thing for both of us?"

Maybe it was because it had been quite a while since he last tried to resist.

The information broker seemed to have finally gained the courage to speak to Evan.

Evan chuckled at the information broker's words.

From the beginning of his story, it was obvious what he was going to say to him.

In the end, he was going to ask Evan and Eutenia to let him go before any trouble arose.

"It's a good thing for us."

"C-Cloud won't stay still! They'll keep chasing you if they get a report!"

The information broker was momentarily flustered by Evan's words.

He brought up Cloud's name, trying to persuade Evan's party.

Cloud was an execution agency that operated throughout the empire and caught criminals.

If the rumor that Evan and Eutenia had kidnapped him spread, it was natural that the investigators of Cloud, pressured by the shop side, would chase after them.

But the information broker seemed to know nothing about them.

Evan grabbed one of his shoulders with his gauntlet-clad hand.

Crack.

A strong force went into the gauntlet that held his shoulder.

"You're making a funny joke. The guys from Cloud were never on good terms with us in the first place."

"Y-Yes...?"

"And even if we run into them, it'll only take some time, and there won't be any more problems."

The information broker's face hardened as he met Evan's eyes.

He would take care of them himself if Cloud came looking for him.

That was what Evan was saying right now.

Evan let go of his hand from the information broker, who blinked his eyes with a stiff face.

And then he leaned against a nearby rock and spoke to the information broker.

“Do you understand?”

“...Yes.”

“If you understand, then it would be better not to make such threats in the future.”

“...”

Gulp.

The sound of swallowing saliva echoed in the wilderness.

Evan added one more word to the information broker.

“And trying to dig up our information... If you want to live long, you'd better refrain from doing that.”

He was warning him about the unique trait that information brokers had.

The information broker sweated profusely and tried to avoid Evan's gaze.

Evan also turned his gaze and looked at Eutenia.

Eutenia was stroking Alpha's head and talking to him about something.

“Eutenia. Are you done with the preparations?”

“I’m almost done. How about you, Evan?”

“I’m done too. Now we just need to decide on a method.”

Evan recalled his mission in his head as he answered Eutenia’s question.

Their master had given them one task.

That was to get the thing called the ‘Philosopher’s Stone’.

To find this Philosopher’s Stone, Evan had captured an information broker who knew about the mage.

At the same time, he was able to safely obtain the information about the mage that he had been longing for.

So now it was just a matter of contacting the mage and bringing him with them.

Thud.

Evan pressed down on the information broker’s thigh with his toe.

The information broker opened his eyes wide and looked at Evan and Eutenia as his thigh was stepped on.

“Let me hear the information you told me last time again. Here.”

“Th-That... The information about the mage?”

“Yeah.”

As Evan’s sharp gaze turned to him, the information broker nodded his head without a word.

In his hand, which was tied with a rope, were the data that he had organized about the information he had acquired.

The information broker flipped through the data and checked a few things again.

And then he began to recite the information that Evan had requested one by one.

“Name... Elbon Claude. Age... 57. A mage belonging to the central magic tower of the empire.”

“Eutenia. We’re planning to infiltrate the magic tower directly to find this guy.”

“Specialty... Alchemy. He is estimated to be one of the best in alchemy among the central magic tower. “

“He must know enough about the thing we’re looking for. It won’t be hard once we secure the mage and a workshop to lock him up.”

Evan’s words to Eutenia were mixed in between the information broker’s words.

Still, the information broker ignored him and continued to recite the information.

Every time the pace of the story slowed down, Evan’s foot pressed down on his thigh.

That’s how the terrified voice of the information broker kept echoing in the wilderness.

Eutenia, who was listening to the information broker’s story, also focused on the story with an interested face.

“Family relations... None. He cherishes his disciple who he took in five years ago. He also often goes out of the magic tower...”

“From my point of view, I don’t like it very much, but if there’s a problem, we can use his disciple as a hostage.”

“He avoids researching combat magic... His actual combat power is...”

“He seems to be quite weak in terms of combat, so it should be possible to quietly get out even if a fight breaks out.”

After a while, the information broker’s story was coming to an end.

Evan made one last radical suggestion to Eutenia.

“In the worst case scenario, we might have to make a scene.”

The information broker flinched at Evan’s words.

It was no wonder, since Evan’s last words meant that he was determined to attack the central magic tower.

It meant that he would cause trouble openly within the system depending on the situation.

This kind of method was something that Evan would never have considered before.

But Evan had become a personality that would adopt even radical methods if necessary, after becoming an apostle of God.

After wreaking havoc on the fairy village with Pluto.

I finished the battle and watched the smartphone screen while drinking beer.

On the screen, Pluto and Perin were moving to the edge of the forest.

There were no more fairies left in the village, thanks to Pluto sweeping them away with his blood magic.

As soon as the fairies in the village were annihilated, Perin came out with only a small twig from his house.

It was a very contrasting behavior from his previous emotional appearance.

“Did he not have much attachment to the village?”

The NPCs in the game are usually honest about their desires.

In this situation, it was normal to look around the empty houses and take some gold or something.

But Perin didn't take anything except for a twig.

Did he not have anything to begin with?

Or did he leave behind everything he had?

Either way, it was something I couldn't know as I watched them from beyond the screen.

“Well... I got all the karma, so it doesn't matter.”

As I watched them while cooling my throat with cold beer, I saw Yuto waiting for them at the place they were heading to.

Yuto looked different from when I first met him, planting a lot of trees and grasses.

Of course, all of that was Perin's work.

Perin said he had to decorate Yuto and brought some grasses from around and planted them.

Perin saw Yuto and spread his arms wide and hugged him.

Perin also hugged him with both arms as soon as he saw him.

It was a reunion that happened less than an hour after they parted.

Yet, the two characters hugged each other and talked as if they had met after a year.

-“Yuto!”

-“Sniff sniff.”

Pluto smiled as he watched the two characters reunite.

Of course, a sneer came out of my mouth as I watched them.

What kind of reunion is that when they met again in less than an hour?

No matter how hard they squeezed, it was a scene that wouldn’t even produce a single tear.

As I watched Perin and Yuto who loved each other so much, I put down the beer can and muttered.

“Amazing, amazing.”

What can I say when they like each other?

All I could do was watch the smartphone screen and make my own comments.

As I admired them, Pluto put his scythe in the air and approached them.

And then he asked Perin, who was rubbing his cheek against Yuto’s.

-“Perin.”

-“Yes, Lord Pluto.”

-“You said you became an apostle of the great one this time, right? Then... where is the gift you received from the great one?”

Pluto’s question was about the divine device that Perin had acquired by becoming an apostle.

The information that Perin had become an apostle had already been delivered to Pluto long ago.

So he seemed to be asking about the divine device that Perin had.

Pluto had always been interested in various divine devices, including Deathside.

He had also asked Eutenia about something similar, so it wasn't strange that Pluto was interested in Perin's divine device.

“Surely... The divine device that came out this time was quite unusual.”

I recalled the divine device that Perin had in my head and muttered.

The divine devices that were given through <Apostle Selection> usually emit a unique aura.

But Perin didn't have anything that looked like a divine device right now.

That was because Perin's divine device was different from other divine devices in its peculiar appearance.

I jumped onto Yuto as soon as I heard Pluto's question.

Then I introduced him to the divine item I had received and told him about it.

-“This is the divine item I got.”

-“Soil.”

-“Is that... a divine item?”

Pluto opened his mouth with a blank expression as he looked at the shape of the divine item that I was pointing at with my hand.

The reason was that I was pointing at a tree while standing on top of Yuto.

[Divine Item: Fake Divine Tree Yggdrasil].

The huge tree that was stuck in the middle of Yuto was the identity of the divine item that was given to me.

As the name Fake Divine Tree implied, my divine item had the shape of a tree.

-“Yes! This is the gift I received from the great one!”

I nodded vigorously and reaffirmed the truth to Pluto.

The tree that had taken root on Yuto was a divine item that gave me various abilities.

And it was an item that had extraordinary abilities that matched its unusual appearance.

The name of the trait that [Divine Item: Fake Divine Tree Yggdrasil] had was <Fake Domain>.

It was a type of ability that settled in one place and defended a base.

-The recovery speed of living creatures within the range of <Fake Domain> increases.

-The growth speed of plants within the range of <Fake Domain> increases.

-A defensive barrier that protects the range of <Fake Domain> is created every hour.

-A concealment barrier that makes the range of <Fake Domain> invisible is created every hour.

-A magic cannon that bombards a target is charged every hour. The magic cannon can be charged up to 5 times.

The magic cannon that was charged every certain time.

The defensive barrier that protected the area where the trait was active.

And on top of that, the concealment barrier that gave stealth effect to the area where the trait was active.

They were all effects that were specialized in defending a designated area.

These types of fixed items were means that could only be used to defend a base where important facilities were located.

In other words, it was an ability that was not helpful at all unless it was a situation where a base had to be protected.

“But you chose a really artistic location.”

If only the base where the divine item was installed didn't fly in the sky.

I wondered if Yuto flew because I got this divine item.

Or maybe Yuto was drawn to me because I had this ability.

Either way, it was an interesting situation without a doubt.

I lifted up a can of beer as I looked at the divine item that took root on Yuto.

Chapter 92: Fate (1)

Chapter 92: Fate (1)

Darkness as black as pitch.

In the thick darkness that settled around me, I blinked quietly.

It was a sudden darkness, but I didn't need any dark adaptation to see ahead.

I could understand what was there just by looking at it.

This place was not a space where the laws of the world applied.

A space of heterogeneity and aberration, an impossibility.

A dream.

A lucid dream that continued from the past had caught me again.

“Another dream like this?”

There were times when I had dreams that continued from the previous ones.

Even the past of the dream that I didn't remember in reality came to mind vividly, and I often continued the dream.

The memory of the dream only continues clearly in the dream.

In reality, even the vivid dream disappears in an instant, except for some parts that impressed me.

A world that is like an illusion that cannot remain as an experience even though I experience it directly.

That's why I wonder if we call this a dream.

"Estelle! Are you here?"

If it was a lucid dream that continued from the past, the elements that made up the dream would not be much different.

I called Estelle's name, who always welcomed me.

But what came to my ears was only my own voice echoing from all sides.

She doesn't show up even if I call her name.

It seemed that I had to find her myself.

It was a situation that was no different from before.

"It would be better to come out at once, but it's going to be annoying."

There might be a way to get out without meeting Estelle, but there was no reason to avoid her either.

After all, dreams are bound to wake up over time.

If you are familiar with dreams or have a false awakening, you may not be able to do so, but I was not one of those people.

It wouldn't be bad to spend time in a dream until it wakes up on its own.

I decided and started walking to find Estelle.

Thud. Thud.

The clumsy footsteps echoed around me as I walked in the darkness.

"..."

Shapes were drawn every time I stepped into the darkness, and new light was added to the shape of the building.

Something new kept sprouting up in the space that was only darkness.

The moment when something is created from nothing was more amazing than I thought.

What would it look like if you played back the moment when you load game graphics slowly?

As the walk continued, the city around me was completed.

And at the end of the city that was created like that, there was a girl with a different atmosphere as always.

“You’re a little late today?”

Estelle.

A girl with a heterogeneous atmosphere who waits for me every time in a lucid dream.

Estelle’s eyes, surrounded by darkness as black as pitch, looked at me.

I felt it every time I faced her, but Estelle’s eyes were very unique.

Her eyes, which resembled black obsidian, had a depth that looked somewhat transcendent.

Maybe because she is a being that I face in a dream, she has a different atmosphere from ordinary people.

I waved my hand lightly toward Estelle and answered her question.

“I called you, but you didn’t come.”

“Did you call me?”

“Yeah. I called and waited. I thought you’d come if I called your name.”

“Unfortunately, I can’t move around here as I please. I just have to wait for you to come.”

Estelle said she couldn’t move on her own unless I came to her.

The existence in the dream is established by my observation.

That’s why she could move only when I recognized her.

To meet Estelle in a dream, I had to wander around until I saw her.

There was no reason to feel compassion for someone I met in a dream, but it reminded me of a fairy tale I saw when I was young.

“I remember reading a fairy tale before.”

“A princess trapped in a castle?”

“A scarecrow who is sad because he can’t move alone.”

“...A scarecrow. That’s an unexpected answer.”

I heard Estelle’s impression of my answer and walked with her through the city.

The footsteps of two people standing side by side echoed through the city.

It felt strange to walk around in a city where no one was there.

Was it creepy?

Or was it awkward?

It felt like looking at a city that had been destroyed for some reason.

“What game are you thinking of playing today?”

I asked Estelle about today's game as we walked through the city.

Estelle always suggested games every time she met me.

She wouldn't refuse to play games today either.

When I asked Estelle about today's game, she answered with an excited face unlike usual.

"I have a pretty interesting proposal today."

"An interesting proposal?"

"Do you like scary stories?"

"Scary stories?"

Scary stories.

I read ghost stories or something like that from time to time.

I also had a lot of memories of watching horror movies with my friends, testing our courage.

But I didn't enjoy it very often.

Above all, I was the type who felt my heart sink when a ghost suddenly popped out.

But why are you asking me about scary stories?

I looked at Estelle with a suspicious expression.

And Estelle's finger pointed to the wall of the movie theater.

"Shall we make it a bet that whoever screams first loses?"

On the wall that Estelle's finger pointed to, there was a poster for a horror movie.

A bet that whoever screams first loses.

It wasn't a kind of confrontation I liked.

I didn't have any hobbies to go see horror movies except to tease my friends.

"No, that's..."

"Are you not confident?"

But after Estelle's one word, I had no choice but to accept the proposal.

How dare you ask me if I'm not confident in front of a man?

I couldn't tolerate such a thing.

If I have the pride of a man in my chest, I'm not afraid of horror movies or anything like that.

"Fine. Let's go in."

I accepted Estelle's proposal and went straight into the movie theater.

It would be over soon.

How scary could a movie be in a dream?

Estelle would scream in no time if I wanted her to.

That was what I thought when I accepted the proposal.

But I soon regretted it.

The situation in the movie theater was very different from what I had in mind.

"This is interesting. They have these things here?"

“Hmm...”

First of all, the movie was too scary.

I barely managed to hold back my scream, but the movie was so vivid and stimulating, maybe because it was in a dream.

And the ghosts that popped out without warning were enough to make my liver cold.

They all looked grotesque and they came out periodically, so I couldn't help but be surprised.

Even with the pride of a man boiling in my chest, I couldn't completely suppress the horror of the movie.

“Isn't it more immersive because there's only two of us?”

What's more, the problem was that there was no one else in the movie theater except us.

All the other seats were empty, and only Estelle and I were watching the movie.

The horror that came from the closed space was more than I imagined.

Every time something suddenly popped out, I felt like a scream would come out of my mouth.

But I had to endure and hold back.

To win the bet with Estelle who provoked me.

No matter how bizarre and grotesque the scene in front of me was, it was nothing but an illusion in a dream.

If I brainwashed myself and endured it, I could somehow hold back my scream.

“...It’s nothing.”

“Is that so?”

I pretended to be calm and talked to Estelle, and she tapped my hand with her cold fingers.

Every time her fingers touched my hand, I felt like the scream I was holding back would come out.

Even though she wanted me to scream, she looked like she didn’t care about the movie at all.

She looked mischievous as she pretended to be scared.

I snorted at her and asked.

“...Is that a scream?”

“Yes. Unfortunately, I couldn’t hold back and screamed.”

“Why didn’t you scream sooner?”

It was my loss that I had to watch the movie until the end.

I looked at her with that thought in mind, and Estelle pointed to the monster’s face on the screen with her hand.

The monster on the screen had been frozen since Estelle screamed.

She pointed at the monster with her hand and asked me in a playful voice.

“Wasn’t the movie more fun than you thought?”

Fun? What fun is there?

If you tell me to watch this movie again, I’ll scream and get out of here from the start.

It was such a shocking and bizarre movie.

But Estelle watched it with a smile until the end.

I resented her attitude and answered her.

“Next time, you can come in and watch it by yourself.”

“Why? I had fun watching it with you.”

“Sigh...”

It was a movie that was different from normal horror movies.

And she liked this kind of movie.

I sighed involuntarily at her taste that contrasted with her appearance.

Well, maybe it's natural for weird people to appear in dreams.

“Then, what do you want to ask me today?”

As I got up from my seat, Estelle grabbed my arm and sat me down.

And she asked me about the question I wanted to ask her.

A formal scream, but she seemed to consider it as my victory anyway.

A question I wanted to ask Estelle?

I looked at her face and pondered, then asked her a simple and meaningless question.

“Why do you keep showing up in my dreams?”

I know it's a meaningless question.

It's just a random dream that Estelle appears in.

But still, I asked her for that reason anyway.

I didn't care what answer she gave me.

And Estelle leaned closer to me and answered.

“Well... we have a very special relationship.”

“A special relationship?”

“If you call the choices that God has set for us destiny, then you can call this a fateful encounter too.”

What kind of nonsense is this?

I looked at Estelle with a blank expression, and the dream began to crumble down.

The scenery around me, including the movie theater, collapsed as it cracked.

It seemed that it was time to wake up from the dream.

I looked at Estelle waving her hand at me in the collapsing dream.

She said goodbye to me as she sent me off.

“Let's watch a movie together next time.”

“What genre?”

“It was as thrilling as today's story.”

I nodded quietly at Estelle's story.

That memory was the last scene of this dream.

It had been two weeks since Peter returned to the cult with Pluto.

During that time, Peter had been adapting to life in the cult, watching the eyes of the believers.

The apostles who had arrived with Peter had long disappeared somewhere, so Peter had to adapt alone in the cult.

Fortunately, it was not a difficult task for Peter to have a meal in the cult.

The cult's officers who knew Peter's face invited him to dinner every night.

Thanks to that, Peter was able to fill his stomach with a splendid feast every evening.

He still had to live by watching the eyes of the believers, but his quality of life was much higher than before.

“Where should I eat today?”

He could eat without working.

He had to move around as he pleased, but there was no one who forced him to work.

There was no believer who had the guts to order Peter, who was acquainted with the cult's officers, to work.

Euteneia's gaze, which had been monitoring Peter's whereabouts, was also off him now.

As long as he spent time wandering around the cult all day, he could enjoy a comfortable bed with dinner every night.

It was like paradise for Peter, who used to be in charge of cooking and driving every day.

“Should I go back to Mr. James? No, it would be rude to visit him too often...”

Still, Peter felt uneasy while staying in the cult.

He himself was an outsider who had nothing to do with the cult.

He had some connection with Euteneia, but that did not prove his affiliation.

He was neither a believer of the evil god nor did he work under the orders of the cult.

The meals and beds he had in the cult were all thanks to someone's kindness.

Staying here felt like sitting on a bed of nails for him.

"Peter, long time no see."

As Peter sat on the bricks of the flower bed and wondered about dinner, someone approached him and spoke to him.

Peter turned his head and looked at the direction where the voice came from as he heard a familiar voice.

There stood a person he had known for a long time.

Archbishop Roan Hebris.

The only archbishop of the cult was standing there.

"Oh, oh... Archbishop, hello."

"Haha, you don't have to greet me like that."

Peter greeted him politely as he met Roan after a long time.

Roan's position in the cult, which had grown so much in no time, was no different from that of a king.

It was incomparable to his old position when he used to beg for bread.

Roan, who received everyone's respect, was like a god to Peter now.

Peter could not act as casually as he used to with him.

Especially since there was a mark of a hero on Peter's arm.

He had to look good to the high-ranking people of the cult in order to survive somehow after being exposed as a hero.

"Ah... yes..."

"I'm sorry to ask you this, but... have you awakened your miracle?"

"Huh? Miracle...?"

Peter tilted his head at Roan's question about miracles.

He must have had the power of a hero since he had a mark on him.

But it seemed that Roan was not referring to the power of a hero when he said miracle.

As Peter looked at Roan with a puzzled expression, Roan clicked his tongue and patted Peter's shoulder.

"It seems that you haven't manifested your miracle yet."

"Yes, yes..."

"That's unfortunate. But if your faith grows, you will be able to awaken your miracle soon."

"Yes?"

It turned out that Roan was trying to teach Peter about faith in the evil god.

Peter stepped back in confusion at Roan's attitude.

But Roan did not care about him and followed him closely.

He grabbed Peter's hand tightly and looked at him with an intense gaze.

“You have done a lot for the cult. You must have accumulated a lot of merit for the great one.”

“No, I...”

“You don’t have to be so humble. I believe that you can become a first-class believer if you are Peter.”

“A first-class believer...?”

First-class believer.

An unfamiliar word popped out of Roan’s mouth.

It seemed to refer to believers who had strong faith among the cult members.

It had nothing to do with Peter.

As Peter tried to say something in defense,

One of the believers next to Roan gave him a hint.

“Archbishop. It seems that it is time for your schedule.”

Roan let go of Peter’s hand with a regretful expression as he heard the believer’s words.

Phew.

Peter sighed inwardly as he got out of his grip.

He was finally freed from Roan’s sermon.

But Roan did not seem to let Peter go as he promised him the next time.

“I’m afraid I don’t have much time left. I have to go now.”

“Yes, yes. See you later...”

“If you don’t mind, I’ll send someone tonight. It would be nice to have a conversation over dinner.”

The problem was that the next time was tonight.

“Huh?”

“Well then...”

Roan finished his words and waved his hand at Peter as he walked away from his seat.

Peter stared blankly at Roan’s back.

He didn’t have to worry about dinner tonight.

An unexpected encounter was waiting for him in the evening.

Chapter 93: Fate(2)

Chapter 93: Fate(2)

Elbon Claude.

He was one of the members of the Sage Council, where the prestigious magicians of the empire gathered, and he was in charge of alchemy at the central magic tower of the empire.

According to the world, he was Elbon, the sage of gold and steel.

He was so well-known that any magician who walked the path of alchemy in the empire would know his name.

The effective potions that circulated in the empire all came out through Elbon's workshop.

He was a person who had an enormous influence on the alchemy of the empire.

However, there were also some drawbacks to Elbon.

The most representative one was that he had a weird personality and a harsh mouth.

“Anyway, those dirty priests. Unlike their master, they only say things that are unbearable every time they open their mouths.”

“Master. I'm worried that someone might hear you.”

Enia Claude, his disciple who was flustered by Elbon's blasphemy, stopped him and said.

Enia looked around and checked the reactions of the people in the tavern.

Fortunately, no one seemed to care much about their conversation.

Elbon's mouth was famous for not caring about people or places.

It was rumored that even insults to the royal family came out of his mouth in the magic tower where no one could see.

So Enia, his disciple, always had to watch his mouth when he was outside.

“What do you mean by that? Are you saying that I can't even talk like this while drinking with my own money?”

Bang!

Elbon, who was dissatisfied with Enia's words, slammed the table with his fist.

Enia shrank as Elbon glared at her while hitting the table.

It looked far from the image of a sage.

His disciple was in a situation where he was drunk and angry.

It was obvious that he could not calm down his temper with ordinary words.

“No, that's not it...”

“Disciple! Is my story wrong?”

“M-Master is always right! But you have dignity as a sage, so please be careful what you say outside...”

“Reduce the production of potions and donate through the temple? They're just leeching off in the name of God!”

As Enia expected, Elbon exploded his temper.

The cause was a request from the Temple of Abundance that was delivered to Elbon a while ago.

The temple asked Elbon to reduce the number of dangerous potions he made and to conduct his own relief work through the temple.

The empire was a country where the breath of six temples worked strongly.

And the Temple of Abundance was one of the most influential temples among them.

Even Elbon, a member of the Sage Council, could not completely ignore the temple's request.

So he had to donate money to the temple and wrap up his relief work in Enia's hometown.

At the same time, it was also Enia's job to soothe her master who was angry every day.

It was not an easy task to soothe a sage who drank and got angry every day.

"Master is right! Right, but..."

"Be quiet if you're right! How dare you try to stop your master without knowing how much I've helped you!"

"No, that's not it! Your dignity as a sage..."

"It seems that Master has had too much to drink."

Just as Elbon emptied his beer and tried to yell at Enia again,

Someone holding honey beer sat down next to Enia.

The man who sat down with beer was someone familiar to Enia.

A priest who worked at the Temple of Abundance located in Jedo.

He smiled as he watched Elbon and Enia.

It happened to be a situation where Enia's master was making inappropriate remarks.

Enia tensed up and asked him why he came here with her eyebrows twitching.

“P-Priest? What are you doing here...”

“It's been a long time, Miss Enia. The honey beer here has a good flavor. We should be grateful to the goddess of abundance who allows us to enjoy this pleasure.”

After greeting her, the priest took a sip of his beer.

Elbon's eyes rolled at the sight of the priest who suddenly sat down.

As soon as he saw him, Elbon threw his beer glass on the floor.

And then he started to roar at him.

“How dare those who have fed off my back with the emperor's authority show their faces in front of me!”

“Don't be so angry. Aren't we all trying to do good together? The goddess will also bless you, Master.”

“Blessing? I don't even remember seeing her face, let alone her blessing! What's the point of that blessing?”

“M-Master...”

Enia smiled and blocked the way between Elbon and the priest.

But Elbon pushed Enia away and looked at the priest.

The priest also quietly put down his beer glass, as if he couldn't let Elbon's words pass.

The eyes of the smiling priest and the flushed Elbon met in the air.

The first to open his mouth was the priest.

“I can understand your complaints about me, but your insults to the goddess are hard to overlook.”

“Insults are what you’re doing. Isn’t that what the temple’s doctrine taught you?”

“You won’t gain anything from angering the goddess. It is because of her that fruits are born and sweet harvests come.”

“Huh.”

Elbon sighed at the priest’s words.

Enia’s hair bristled as she watched Elbon.

Considering her usual master, it was a situation where harsh words would come out at this point.

Sure enough, Elbon started a major blasphemy against the priest.

“Farming is done by farmers and harvests are also done by farmers. What did the goddess help with?”

“Didn’t you have a good harvest last year? This abundance is the grace that the goddess has given us.”

“That’s the result of the farmers’ efforts, shedding blood and sweat.”

“It is the goddess of abundance who leads us to such a future.”

The priest and Elbon, both of them stared at each other with sharp eyes.

To Enia, it didn’t seem like a constructive conversation between a magician and a cleric.

They had different backgrounds of knowledge.

They would only run parallel lines no matter how they talked from different perspectives.

But both of them seemed to be unwilling to give up on the argument that would follow.

Enia sighed and pulled back her chair, showing a half-resigned look.

“That depends on nature and the farmers’ efforts!”

“It is the goddess who guides us to the right future with the farmers’ faith and efforts.”

“What?”

“The guidance of the goddess to the right future. We call it fate. The fate that is determined by God’s providence cannot be changed.”

Fate.

Enia looked at the priest with a hollow feeling as she listened to their conversation.

If fate had everything set up, then this scene in front of her eyes was also predetermined by fate.

Then it was a very dull fate.

Enia denied fate in her head, but she had to keep watching this meaningless conversation.

Until they stopped piling up their glasses of alcohol and reached their limit.

The heated debate continued until both of them got drunk and collapsed.

Of course, it was Enia’s job to carry her drunken master back home.

As usual, I came home after work and turned on the game while watching TV.

The snacks for soothing my tired day were also on the table.

Sundae. Fried food. Tteokbokki.

It was a combination commonly called a snack set.

In my small studio apartment, there was also an air conditioner turned on along with the snacks.

I faced the snacks and air conditioner and indulged in my own small happiness.

“Phew, I worked hard today.”

Snap.

I tore open some wooden chopsticks and put them in front of me with the unpacked snacks.

I couldn’t separate them neatly like splitting wood, but it didn’t matter for eating.

I picked up a fried food with wooden chopsticks and opened a can of cola next to me.

The cola greeted me with bubbles and fizz as it leaked out.

“Hmm...”

Of course, while I was doing that, the news that I turned on to break the silence on TV was still going on.

Was it because it coincided with the rush hour that the world news corner started?

The news program showed world news similar to last time.

An announcer I was familiar with from watching the news several times brought out a map.

It was a map of Africa colored by sections.

-“The riots that were simultaneously taking place in some African countries are now leading to border closures.”

-“Nearly 10 countries have entered border closures.”

-“All countries except two have declared martial law, and the remaining two countries are expected to soon...”

The situation in Africa that had been talked about since before seemed to be getting worse.

After all, even at work, there were occasional talks about Africa.

I didn't care much about it, so I didn't know exactly what was going on.

I ate a tteokbokki and continued to watch TV.

-“The government also announced that it would designate the entire African region as a travel ban area.”

-“Until the travel ban is lifted, flights to the African continent will...”

Following the border closure of the countries, the country also imposed a travel ban.

I was a person who was far from traveling abroad, so it wasn't a very regrettable story.

But it was clear that something was happening there that was different from the usual situation.

The people living there must be having a hard time, I thought as I gulped down my beer.

“Maybe I should stock up on some ramen, just in case.”

It still seemed like a distant story to me.

But sometimes I saw scenes that reminded me of the disaster movies I used to watch.

Usually, in those cases, people would hoard a lot of food and tools.

I also thought that maybe I should get some ramen later, if I had the chance.

As I was eating my late-night snack and thinking about that, a new message popped up on the bottom of the screen where I had left the game on.

“What’s this? A notification?”

I heard a notification sound in my ear and immediately looked at the screen of my smartphone.

Several messages appeared and the scroll bar of the message box moved up.

Judging by the length of the messages, they were not just about acquiring karma.

I scrolled down with my left hand and checked out the new messages.

-[Second Apostle: Evan Allemier]’s Divine Contribution has exceeded the threshold.

-You can spend 100 Karma to initiate the Liberation of [Divine Instrument: Astrape].

A notification message about the Liberation of a Divine Instrument.

Evan’s Divine Contribution had finally reached a level where he could proceed with the Liberation of a Divine Instrument.

It was the second time I would do this, after Utenia.

Fortunately, I had some karma left after appointing Perin as an apostle.

Tap.

I touched the message about the Liberation of a Divine Instrument and activated the selection window.

-Spend 100 Karma to unleash the power inherent in [Divine Instrument: Astrape].

-Do you want to liberate [Divine Instrument: Astrape]?

-Yes / No

There was nothing else to watch while eating my late-night snack anyway.

I thought it wouldn't be bad to enjoy my snack while watching Evan solve his trial.

I had enough karma left, so there was no reason to hesitate.

I clicked on the 'Yes' button without hesitation.

And at the same time, the screen went black.

-[Second Apostle: Evan Allemier] has started his trial.

Chapter 94: Fate (3)

Chapter 94: Fate (3)

In the back alley of the island, where darkness began to fall.

Evan looked at his gauntlet.

The divine artifact, Astraphe.

The mark that Evan received from the great being was shining with a different light than before.

A huge change had occurred in Astraphe since Evan passed the trial given by the great being.

Evan let out a heavy sigh as he looked at Astraphe, which had turned into a dark color.

“...Ah.”

The appearance of Astraphe, which glowed from his arm, looked more intense than ever.

And that was not the only change that happened to Evan.

After losing his divine power and inheriting the power of God, he had been constantly using the power of lightning.

There was also some kind of change in the power of lightning that he wielded.

The blue flash that always wrapped around Evan's hand was now filled with black darkness.

Black lightning that gave a creepy feeling just by looking at it.

The black lightning that spread every time he used his power made him realize that he had become much stronger than before.

Sparks of black color caught Evan's eye as Eutenia, who was next to him, turned the page and spoke to him.

"It looks like you passed the trial safely."

Trial.

As soon as he heard Eutenia's words, a brief memory came back to Evan's mind.

In a dark space where lightning struck, he had to keep swinging his lightning.

Cutting off the falling lightning with Astraphe's lightning.

That was the trial given to Evan.

Cutting off the lightning was not an easy task.

The falling thunderbolts were far beyond the speed that human eyes could measure.

Moreover, it was frequent that the lightning and the lightning would cancel each other out when they collided.

"It seems so. It took me quite a while to get out though."

That's why Evan had to create black lightning with his own hands in there.

A thunderbolt that was heavier and stronger than the existing lightning.

Only with that could he cut off the falling lightning completely.

And soon he succeeded in creating black lightning.

It seemed to Evan that it took him quite a while to succeed, though.

Maybe it was because he was alone in a dark space, but it was hard to gauge the concept of time.

“It didn’t take longer than I expected.”

“How long did it take?”

“About half a day at most?”

Half a day, huh?

Evan nodded at Eutenia’s words.

If she said so, maybe he got out faster than he thought.

The result he got in half a day was quite satisfying, too.

Besides, the ability he gained by changing Astraphe was not only black lightning.

He also gained an ability that would be helpful someday, even if he didn’t have a chance to use it right now.

“What was my state like while I was in the trial?”

While he was doing the trial, he was also curious about what his condition was like.

Evan asked Eutenia about his appearance for half a day.

Eutenia smiled faintly and answered Evan’s question.

“You were sitting in your seat with a blank expression.”

“That doesn’t sound very pleasant.”

“It’s okay. I was watching over you so that you wouldn’t die from a surprise attack.”

“...That’s not what I meant.”

Evan tried to say something to Eutenia, but soon gave up and adjusted Astraphe’s position.

There were many things that didn’t communicate well with people like Eutenia, who were important figures in the order.

It was either because of the environment they grew up in or because their original personalities were twisted.

But when he talked to them, Evan felt like he was getting influenced by their tendencies too.

What was changing Evan more than God’s power was human influence.

They say that your position makes you who you are.

Living as God’s apostle made him feel like he was becoming a human being worthy of that role.

“What are you thinking about?”

As Evan thought about that, Eutenia, who held the bookshelf, asked him.

It wasn’t something to talk about in front of her.

Evan shook his head right away.

And then he changed the topic to the plan.

“It’s nothing. Anyway, what are you going to do about the plan?”

“I couldn’t hear much about Elbon around here. Most of them seem to disguise themselves or send out their disciples.”

“Did you hear anything about his recent whereabouts?”

“They said he caused a commotion at a bar about a week ago... but after that, no one has seen him. Maybe he’s being careful.”

Evan pondered over the information about his target.

It would be better if he could meet Elbon outside if possible, but if that was difficult, he would have to lure Elbon out or enter the tower.

According to the information he heard from the informant, Elbon was very fond of his disciple.

He even gave his surname to his disciple, who was from a commoner background.

If he contacted Elbon while holding his disciple, he might get some kind of reaction.

Evan made a decision and told Eutenia.

“Let’s go with catching his disciple who goes out. That seems better.”

“Is that so?”

“Even if something goes wrong with the plan, the disciple can at least substitute for Elbon’s role to some extent.”

Enia Claude was Elbon’s disciple.

As a disciple of the sage, she must have inherited a lot of knowledge from her master.

She might not be as experienced as her master, but she had some skills of her own.

She could be used as a substitute for Elbon depending on the situation.

That was what it meant.

If that was impossible, then he would have to look for another alchemist.

Eutenia, who heard the plan from Evan, turned the page and replied.

“That’s the plan, huh? I got it.”

“I’ll leave the handling of the disciple to you. I’m counting on you.”

Of course, it was Eutenia’s role to deal with the mage.

Eutenia accepted her role without a word.

“Most of them are my responsibility. I’ll be busy for a while.”

“That’s why the great one uses you as the first apostle.”

“I don’t mind such praise.”

“Then let’s proceed with the plan as it is.”

Evan finished his conversation with Eutenia and took out a cigarette from his pocket.

He didn’t have this habit from the beginning.

It was a habit he acquired after joining the order.

He put the cigarette in his mouth and moved his gauntlet to grab the end of it.

Then he raised his magic and moved the power of the artifact.

“——Astraphe.”

Crackle.

A short spark and smoke rose from Evan's cigarette.

Almost ten days had passed since the commotion at the bar.

Enia's master was annoyed by the interrogation at the tower and avoided going out, and the priest who had been talking to him was also punished at the temple.

It was because he had a quarrel with the sage while he was drunk.

Both the sage and the cleric were now stuck in their own places and didn't come out.

That made Enia have to go out alone for a while.

The herb shop that she and her master often visited was also a destination for Enia alone this time.

She had a hard time choosing herbs while feeling her master's absence until she left the store.

"Thank you again today. Please send my regards to the sage."

"I'll be going now!"

Enia barely organized the herbs she had chosen and paid the gold and left the store.

In Enia's hand was a basket filled with herbs.

Being a mage didn't mean that he was free from carrying things.

No matter how great a mage he was, if he didn't have a magic tool that could store space, he had to carry it himself.

Enia walked with a basket full of contents in her hand toward the tower.

The basket in her hand felt heavier than usual today.

“Why did you have to fight in such a place, master.”

If her master had been there, he would have given her a scolding and put an energizing potion in her mouth.

He was her master who had no experience in combat but had amazing skills in alchemy.

Enia also drank his potions every day and stayed up all night to learn more from him.

That’s why she tried hard to learn more from Elbon under him.

Enia continued to express her regret for her master as she checked that there was no one around.

“I told you not to do that, but you didn’t listen to me. It’s true that all geniuses are weirdos.”

It was always Enia’s job to stop Elbon’s mouth.

But she couldn’t completely stop him, and she had to listen to most of his stories by herself.

He would be such a nice person if he just kept his mouth quiet and had a gentle personality.

Enia made such an empty thought as she turned around the corner of the street.

It was a corner that Enia and Elbon often used because it was easy to get into the tower.

It was also a place where there were no problems with security because it was located in the back of the market.

“Master is really... But why is there no one here today?”

As she turned around the corner, Enia felt a sense of incongruity and looked around.

Usually, there were quite a lot of people behind the market too.

It was because there were vendors who laid out their mats on the street and merchants who solicited customers.

But today, for some reason, it was empty.

As Enia tilted her head and walked forward, she heard a voice from the roof of the corner where she was walking.

“Hello?”

Enia turned her head toward the voice she heard.

On the roof where a sweet voice rose, there was a girl in a robe sitting there.

In the girl’s hand was a large book that looked expensive.

It was an unfamiliar face that wasn’t in Enia’s memory.

She greeted Enia suddenly.

Enia accepted the greeting with a bewildered voice.

“Uh... hello?”

“Are you Enia Claude? I’m looking for the disciple of the sage Elbon Claude.”

“I am Enia, but... why are you looking for me?”

The girl in front of her seemed to be looking for Enia.

And she knew that Enia was her master’s disciple.

It was a suspicious story to anyone’s eyes.

Enia had no choice but to question the girl who looked friendly.

Enia put down the basket she was holding in one hand.

And she moved her hand to the wand on her waist, ready to respond at any time.

She looked at the girl who was smiling and made a logical deduction.

“If you need to talk to him, you can go to him directly.”

“It would be troublesome if I go without an appointment.”

“Then I’ll report to him first, and then make an appointment later——.”

“That would be a bit difficult. You have to come with us.”

As Enia tried to say the next word.

The girl interrupted Enia’s words.

Thud.

Enia ripped the wand from her belt and pointed it at the girl.

A bright light flickered at the tip of the wand aimed at the opponent.

Enia, who had prepared the magic wand, frowned and spoke in a sharp tone.

“You should watch your mouth.”

“You seem confident.”

“You must think I’m easy because I learned alchemy, but I also graduated from the combat magic course. You better run if you don’t want to get hurt.”

If she couldn’t avoid a clash, she had to fight.

Enia, who had made that decision, glanced around.

She checked if there was anyone else hiding nearby.

Between the alleys. On the rooftops. And at the corner of the street.

Enia's eyes scanned and passed over the places where people could be.

Fortunately, there was no sign of anyone around.

Enia, who was relieved, looked back at the girl who was still holding the magic wand.

Right after that.

Swoosh.

The page of the book that the girl was holding turned over.

“It would be boring to just take you away, so let's test your skills first.”

That was the signal that marked the beginning of everything.

Shadows burst out from all directions along with the sound of the page turning.

The shadows that flowed out in an instant blurred like covering the eyes.

The shadows that covered the floor continued to multiply and began to draw grass and trees.

A world of shadows filled with darkness and gloom.

In it, the girl looked down at Enia with a haughty face.

“...”

Enia blinked her eyes several times at the sight she faced for the first time.

But all she could see was gloom.

Darkness. Shadows. Light. And darkness again.

The world was covered in black and white.

Only two people stood in it.

The girl who did not lose her colors and Enia who lost all her light.

Enia's eyes looked at her own palm that had faded in color.

“Ah—.”

Thump.

With that memory as the last, Enia's vision went dark.

Chapter 95: Fate (4)

Chapter 95: Fate (4)

The central magic tower of the empire, located in the middle of the island.

Elbon, the master of alchemy, was wandering around the lobby of the tower with a worried expression on his face.

He had a good reason to be concerned. His beloved disciple had not returned to the tower for a whole day.

All Elbon had asked his disciple Enia to do was to buy some simple herbs.

It was too risky for Elbon to go out himself, since his reputation had been tarnished by the commotion he had caused at the tavern.

Some of the followers of the Temple of Abundance had even sent him threatening letters, so it was only logical to send his disciple Enia instead.

But Enia, who had left the tower to run Elbon's errand, had not come back yet.

Elbon had been immersed in his research for a long time and only realized that fact after staying up all night.

It was inevitable that he would be worried about his disciple's situation.

"He's not the type to get into trouble..." Elbon muttered.

The herb shop that Elbon had sent Enia to was a place they had visited together many times before to buy ingredients.

There was no reason for Enia to forget the location of the shop and get lost.

It was also hard to imagine that Enia had been attacked by someone.

Enia was a magician with talent in combat magic, unlike Elbon.

She was a rare gem that Elbon had found among the commoners of the countryside.

That's why Elbon had always asked other masters to teach Enia combat magic.

If she had to fight outside the tower without preparation, Elbon might even lose to Enia.

There was hardly any situation in the island where Enia could be harmed by a villain.

“What is he doing out there... tsk tsk.”

Elbon clicked his tongue and continued to pace around the lobby with a displeased look on his face.

The junior magicians avoided him as they saw his sour mood.

Even some of the masters from other branches frowned and went inside when they saw Elbon.

But Elbon kept walking around the lobby.

He wondered if he had been too harsh on his disciple and made him run away in resentment.

That thought even crossed Elbon's mind.

Eventually, Elbon came to one conclusion after wandering around for a while.

“I have no choice. I have to go out myself...”

As he decided to go out of the tower himself, he saw one of the tower's staff members coming in.

The staff member had a crude-looking envelope in his hand.

The staff member spotted Elbon and stopped. He held out the envelope and said,

“Master. There is a letter for you.”

“A letter? For me?”

Elbon's eyes narrowed as he heard that there was a letter for him.

The letters that were sent to Elbon usually came in elegant envelopes.

And the seals on the letters were also from famous families that Elbon recognized.

But this letter had a seal that Elbon had never seen before.

The sender's name was not even properly written on it. It was a suspicious letter.

Elbon took the letter from the staff member and felt annoyance and doubt rising in his mind.

The staff member who delivered the letter tried to leave after saying,

“I'll be going then. If you need anything, please call me at the lobby...”

“Wait. Who sent this letter?”

But Elbon stopped him and asked about the sender of the letter.

He was already busy enough trying to find his disciple, and now someone sent him an incomprehensible letter.

If it was from someone insignificant, he intended to throw it away.

The staff member looked embarrassed as he heard Elbon's question. He said with an uncertain expression,

"I don't know who sent it. I just received it from someone outside."

"Tsk. Fine. Go ahead."

Elbon spat out his tongue and waved his hand at the staff member.

The staff member finally bowed and left.

He sent such a letter when I'm already swamped with finding my disciple.

Elbon suppressed his rising anger and roughly tore open the envelope.

Thud.

The envelope ripped apart without using a knife. It was a rough gesture.

Elbon bit his lips as he took out the letter from the envelope and checked its contents.

If it was something unimportant, he planned to shred it into pieces.

"What kind of rude people sent this letter? Tsk."

Elbon opened the letter and started reading it carefully.

The first thing that caught his eye was the bloodstain on the letter. It was at the bottom of the letter. He saw it as soon as he opened it. A foul smell of blood entered his nose through Elbon's nostrils.

Elbon's brows furrowed involuntarily.

It was a barbaric act, whoever it was.

Elbon's gaze moved to the top of the letter.

"..."

Elbon read the letter with a grim expression, line by line.

The first line was a courteous greeting.

And then the sender's purpose followed.

They wanted to meet with Elbon.

They said they would visit the tower and go to Elbon's laboratory, so he should tell the tower in advance to avoid the inspection.

They also said not to reveal the contents of this letter to anyone else.

The letter was full of unreasonable and rude demands for Elbon.

If it weren't for the last line of the letter, Elbon would have thrown it away in anger.

'We have attached Enia Claude's bloodstain as well. If the contents of this letter are not fulfilled by the scheduled time, we cannot guarantee the safety of your disciple.'

Crack.

Elbon clenched his teeth as he read the letter.

He then looked at the bloodstain on the bottom of the letter again.

It was his disciple's blood.

He could verify it with the reagents in his laboratory.

Elbon felt a surge of rage in his throat.

"Th... these bastards...!"

Elbon's face turned red as he crumpled the letter in his hand.

He had to go back to his laboratory right now.

And he had to use the reagents to check if the letter was true.

If the letter was true.

At that time, either Elbon or the sender of the letter would have to pay a huge price.

Elbon, who held the letter in his trembling hand, shouted at the staff of the magic tower who was standing in front of the elevator.

“I need to go to the seventh floor! Open the elevator now!”

Elbon’s rough voice echoed in the lobby of the magic tower.

Enia Claude.

The only direct disciple of the alchemy master had been kidnapped.

“It’s been a long time since I returned to the empire.”

The borderland between the empire and Crossbridge.

In the carriage of the expedition force heading to the southeast of the empire, Hus, the hero of knowledge, looked out the window and said.

Hus Alemier, who had been an investigator of Cloud, had become a hero of knowledge after receiving the goddess’s choice. It had been almost a year since then.

He was returning to the empire where he was born after a year.

During that time, he had tried to find traces of his brother Evan, but he had not achieved any meaningful results.

Therefore, Hus had to admit the fact that he did not want to believe.

Evan Alemier, the heretic inquisitor, had died.

And it was at the hands of the followers of the evil god that he had been wary of.

“By the way, you said your hometown was the empire, right?”

The voice that came to him made Hus look up and face the opposite side.

Ting.

Sion, who had let go of his bowstring, looked at him with a smile on his face.

Sion Arius, the hero of hunting.

Chosen by the goddess of hunting, Sion held his divine weapon ‘Astra’ in his hand.

The beautiful bow had a sacred atmosphere that suited its name as a divine weapon.

Seeing Sion’s appearance looking at him with a twang of his bowstring, Hus nodded and said.

“I was born in the Alemier family of the empire.”

“A noble with a squint. You would have looked fierce if you weren’t a mage.”

“I was quite popular in Cloud. Is it so strange that a mage has a squint?”

“They’re usually not into rough stuff, right? Unless you lost your eye in an experiment, it’s natural to look weird.”

“...An accident happened when I was young. If it weren’t for my brother, I would have risked my life instead of my eye.”

Hus touched his one eye that was twitching as he said that.

The one who saved him from the accident that happened in his childhood was his brother Evan Alemier.

Evan always scolded him with a heavy tone, but his affection for his family was sincere.

He was someone who sincerely wished for the prosperity of his family.

He would have helped Hus even if it was difficult if Hus had a hard problem.

Just like he came to see him on vacation when he received a letter saying that there was a suspicion of an evil god's appearance.

"Your brother... The one you're looking for so much?"

Sion asked about Evan after hearing Hus's words.

The rumor that Hus was looking for someone was already famous throughout the holy land.

The disappearance of a competent and diligent heretic inquisitor was a big event in the holy land itself.

Especially since he was the family of a hero of this era.

Some people even knew Evan well from before.

It was not strange that Sion, who lived in the temple of hunting, knew about Evan.

"Yes. He was strict but an excellent person."

"That's why you're looking for him. And there are also rumors in the holy land."

"He disappeared after I finished investigating with his help. That's why I... I think he fell victim to the followers of the evil god."

“Is there no possibility that he is alive?”

Thud.

Sion pulled back on Astra’s bowstring again.

The possibility that Evan was alive.

He had not considered it, but it was a story with low probability when he thought about it rationally.

Evan that Hus knew was not someone who would succumb to the forces of evil gods.

He would have resisted them even if he had to die.

And there was no reason for the followers of evil gods to keep a holy knight alive for long.

He guessed that they tortured him enough and offered him as a sacrifice to their evil god.

“Brother is not someone who can be subdued by torture or anything. Even if those cultists tried to persuade him, he would refuse without hesitation.”

“What if they are holding him as a prisoner?”

“Even so, too much time has passed. It’s been over a year since I left the empire.”

“A year. A year is definitely a long time.”

“I wish I could believe that my brother is alive, but it doesn’t seem like such a good story.”

Hoo.

Hus let out a rough breath and looked out the window.

The shadow he had been chasing all his life was gone.

Now all that was left was the hero of knowledge who carried the fate of the world, and the emptiness of his brother that he would feel every time he returned to the empire.

Thud.

Hus opened his bag and took out a cigarette that was inside and put it in his mouth.

It was the thing that his brother hated so much for its unique smell.

But there was no brother left to complain to him now.

Seeing Hus light up the cigarette with magic in the carriage approaching the power of evil gods, Sion put down his divine weapon and said.

“Well, you never know until you check. I’ll wish you luck for now.”

“I appreciate your heart.”

“When the Kueberg expedition is over, I’ll help you search for a few days using spirits, so let me know if you need help.”

Searching with spirits.

It might be a story that could have an effect.

As long as Evan was still alive, that is.

“...You’re talking like a hero for once.”

“Well, people call us heroes, right? Even if it’s just to please them, we have to act accordingly sometimes.”

Hus looked at the hero in front of him in the carriage heading towards the evil god’s power.

He didn't like him at first, but now he had lost that feeling long ago.

It was Hus's first time to move with the heroes in an expedition.

If he could finish this expedition safely.

Then he wouldn't mind having a drink with Sion.

Chapter 96: Fate (5)

Chapter 96: Fate (5)

The central magic tower of the empire was scattered with experts of magic studies, called masters.

Sigor was one of those central tower masters.

He was one of the best ice magic experts in the empire.

The world called him – Sigor of the North Wind.

He established the combat magic studies using ice magic, and was one of those who developed the empire's combat magicians.

Sigor was enjoying his tea in his laboratory as usual.

“Hmm... The aroma is good.”

As Sigor sipped his steaming tea, someone opened the closed laboratory door roughly.

Bang!

The door that was opened forcefully hit the wall, making a dull collision sound.

Sigor frowned at the noise that shook his ears and looked at the unwelcome visitor who came to him.

What reflected in Sigor's eyes was the appearance of an old sage who looked at him with an urgent face.

Elbon Claude.

The master of alchemy had visited Sigor's office.

"Sigor! Where is your assistant?"

"I sent him out for an errand... Why do you ask so suddenly?"

"I have something to talk to you quietly! It's good that no one is here!"

Elbon took out a staff from his waist and used magic toward the door he had opened.

Clang.

The laboratory door closed with a rough sound, just like when it opened.

Sigor shook his head as he watched his laboratory door being treated roughly.

He knew that the old man in front of him had a strange personality, but he felt like he was getting older by a year every time he faced him directly.

He sighed and put down his teacup and asked Elbon.

"Would you like a cup of tea?"

"I like your tea, but I don't have time for that this time."

"What is it that you came to see me so suddenly?"

Elbon was not someone who could be easily met for trivial matters.

If Elbon came to see him without an appointment, it meant that he had something very urgent.

Maybe he developed an amazing potion and wanted to show it to him first.

He thought so as he looked at Elbon while he was talking.

In the meantime, Elbon spoke to him with a dark face.

“Enia has been kidnapped.”

“Enia? No, who did such a thing...”

“I don’t know who kidnapped her. But they seem to have something to do with me.”

At the news that Enia had been kidnapped, Sigor finally understood Elbon’s attitude.

Enia was the only disciple that Elbon had taken care of.

She had talent in all kinds of magic, so Sigor also taught her combat magic studies.

She was a genius who could take over the next generation of sages if she had time.

And she was kidnapped by someone.

She either suffered an overwhelming surprise attack or a formidable expert entered the island.

There was no doubt about it.

“Enia is the one I taught combat magic. She wouldn’t be easy to deal with. Where was she when she was kidnapped?”

“I sent her to the market to buy some herbs. But she was kidnapped there.”

“...This is not a normal matter. How did you confirm that?”

“I received a letter from those who took her away.”

Thud.

Elbon took out a piece of paper from his pocket and threw it on the desk.

It was a long letter with a seal on it.

Sigor immediately reached for the letter.

And he picked up the unidentified letter and asked Elbon about it.

“Is this the letter they sent?”

“Yes. You’ll know when you read the content.”

“I’ll take a look.”

Sigor’s eyes scanned the kidnapper’s letter.

The content of the letter was a typical ransom demand.

They wanted to meet Elbon for personal reasons.

Except for the excessively rude requests and expressions, that is.

And the identity of the seal at the end was very shocking.

Enia Claude. It was a seal made by Elbon’s disciple herself with blood.

Elbon, who was a master of alchemy, would not have failed to verify the authenticity of the seal.

Sigor finished reading the letter and pointed to the seal on the paper and looked at Elbon.

“Is this really Enia’s blood?”

“Yes. I checked it myself.”

“If this content is true, then what they really want is you, Elbon.”

“That’s right. They must have kidnapped Enia to target me.”

Sigor fell into deep thought after hearing Elbon’s words.

He understood what Elbon wanted and why he came to see him.

But this matter was not a light one.

It would be better to find a solution through consultation with the upper tower if possible.

That would be the most rational way for Elbon's own safety as well.

But he didn't think Elbon would agree to that method.

That was the problem.

He sighed deeply and spoke to Elbon.

"I think it would be better to hold a meeting and discuss this matter as soon as possible."

"I can't do that."

"Elbon. I'm sorry about Enia, but if we take some time and search the tower..."

"Sigor."

Elbon looked at Sigor with a serious face.

Among the faces of Elbon that Sigor had seen so far, it was the most solemn and dangerous look.

Elbon, who faced Sigor, spoke to him in a dark voice.

"She is my only disciple who I poured everything into."

"...I know that very well."

"And they want me. If I sacrifice Enia and get over this, when will I have to hide in the tower?"

“...”

“It’s something that can’t be solved without moving myself. Either negotiate with them, or grab the root. In the end, it means that I need to meet them in person.”

It was as Sigor expected.

Elbon wanted to take charge of this matter himself.

Moreover, Elbon’s story was not entirely wrong.

To root out the cause of the situation, they needed to face the ones who kidnapped Enia directly.

It was a situation where he had a plausible reason to go along with his worry for his disciple.

That’s why it was highly likely that he couldn’t break Elbon’s stubbornness right now.

Sigor had to compromise with the reality in front of him.

As he was pondering, Elbon finally told him the purpose of his visit to the laboratory.

“That’s why I want you to help me.”

“Do you mean to escort you, sir?”

“I think it would be fine if I persuade one or two of them somehow. If possible, I’d like you to come with me after getting access to the tower’s defensive magic.”

Elbon was prepared for a clash with the enemies.

Sigh. Sigor sipped the tea he was holding again.

All he could get from the cold tea was a lukewarm temperature and an overly brewed scent.

Sigor finished the tea he was holding and nodded his head toward him.

He knew that if he didn't agree, Elbon would eventually try to meet the other party alone.

Someone had to follow Elbon's back.

"This is the only time I'll join you in this reckless thing."

"Don't worry. When it's over, I'll give you a mountain of medicine that you like."

"Receiving a mountain of medicine from you, sir. For a while, my assistants will be clinging to me for medicine."

"That's right. Who made the medicine?"

The conversation about this matter ended there.

After that, Elbon's talk about giving him medicine as a reward continued.

The talk about medicine was not a bad thing, but Sigor's heart was heavier than ever as he took on the job.

In the midst of the meaningless conversation, Elbon smiled emotionlessly.

The smile of the sage who lost his disciple was very cold.

A huge tower standing majestically in the center of the island.

In front of it, Eutenia and Evan were walking toward the entrance with their hoods pulled up.

Eutenia uttered a short exclamation as she faced the tower for the first time in her life.

She was born as a child of a knight who had a territory, but the place where Eutenia lived was nothing more than a small village in the countryside.

There was no situation where Eutenia, who lived in a rural village, could actually face such a huge tower.

The magnificent product of magic that she saw for the first time was very impressive to her.

“Is this the tower? It looks really high.”

“Is this your first time seeing the tower?”

“I learned magic by myself. So this is my first experience of facing a tower like this.”

Evan nodded his head as he heard Eutenia’s story.

It was just that she had never seen the tower before.

Eutenia finished her short admiration and hastened her steps toward the tower.

Thud. Thud.

The sound of their footsteps echoed in the crowded square.

Eutenia pushed through the crowd blocking her way and moved her steps to the front of the tower.

At the entrance of the tower, there were guards guarding it.

As Eutenia and Evan approached the entrance, the guards raised their spears at the same time.

“Stop. Only those who are related to the tower can enter.”

They were guards who were equipped with expensive magic tools at a glance.

It was natural for them to block suspicious people who came in wearing hoods.

Normally, they would have to show their identity cards or show their faces and pass through.

But Eutenia put her finger on the spearhead that blocked them.

And then she smiled at them and said,

“I came to see Elbon. He should have arranged to meet me at this time.”

“I heard about it in advance. I’m sorry for being rude.”

Did Elbon carry out his promise properly?

The two guards put down their spears without any doubt.

They thought there would be no problem if they had the guarantee of a sage.

The guards who opened their way let Eutenia and Evan enter the lobby of the tower.

Eutenia followed behind her and Evan quietly told her,

“It would be better to prepare some countermeasures soon.”

“It’s okay. I’ve been preparing from before.”

“Is that so? It would be better to be thorough if possible. We don’t want to disappoint him.”

“Of course.”

The conversation between the two stopped as they reached the elevator of the tower.

Elbon's office was located on the seventh floor.

To get to Elbon's office, they had to use the elevator.

As Eutenia and Evan got on the elevator, the staff who operated it looked at them.

And then he asked Eutenia where they wanted to go.

“Which floor do you want to go to?”

“I think the seventh floor would be fine.”

“The seventh floor. I see.”

The staff moved the lever and closed the elevator door after hearing Eutenia's words.

Clang. Rumble.

The elevator door closed with a loud noise.

The staff used magic to move the elevator, and the elevator carrying people started to go up.

The elevator that transported people using magic was something that only existed in the tower.

It was natural for Eutenia's eyes to sparkle with curiosity as she faced the elevator.

“The seventh floor.”

“Did we arrive already?”

“It’s a thing that the central tower’s magicians are proud of. It’s one of the fastest in the tower. You can get off here.”

It didn’t take long for the tower’s elevator to reach the seventh floor.

Eutenia got off at the seventh floor, amazed by the tower’s novelty.

The seventh floor was a place where magicians who studied alchemy gathered.

It was not difficult to find Elbon’s laboratory in such a place.

The laboratory of Elbon, who was called a sage, was the most conspicuous one on the seventh floor.

Evan pointed to the door of the laboratory with his bare hand that was not wearing a gauntlet.

“That’s where we should go.”

“It seems so.”

“He kept most of the demands we sent him. Do you think he followed everything to the end?”

“Usually, he would bring some guards to protect himself... but maybe he didn’t if he really cared about his disciple.”

The corridor on the seventh floor was relatively quiet compared to the lobby of the tower.

Eutenia and Evan walked past the quiet corridor and headed to Elbon’s laboratory.

Maybe it was because the owner of the laboratory had the title of a sage.

Elbon’s laboratory had a more splendid nameplate than anywhere else.

The door that had to be passed to enter the laboratory also had a luxurious appearance.

Eutenia's hand was covered with magic as she reached the door of the laboratory.

Eutenia grabbed the door handle with her hand covered with magic and said,

“There's no magical measure.”

“Is there any other problem?”

“Except that there are two magicians inside.”

Eutenia, who had sensed the situation in the laboratory with her aura, opened the door.

Creak.

The hinges squeaked and revealed the inside of the laboratory.

The laboratory of Elbon, the sage of gold and steel, was a very splendid and spacious place.

There was no one else in the large laboratory where equipment was scattered except for two magicians.

Only four people were there, including Eutenia and Evan who had just entered.

“...”

Eutenia's eyes scanned the magicians in the laboratory.

One was an old sage.

And one was a relatively young magician with a cold face.

There was one more person than Eutenia and Evan had expected.

As Evan closed the door behind him, Elbon's old eyes turned to Eutenia.

"Are you the ones who sent me the letter?"

There was a deep hatred in his eyes that looked at her.

Elbon's fist on his knee was trembling with blood as he shook it.

It was natural for him to be angry.

Eutenia had forcibly taken away Elbon's precious disciple.

But the one who had the upper hand in this situation was Eutenia.

Eutenia felt the cold touch of the brooch she held in her hand.

The brooch she held in her hand was what Enia had attached to her robe.

"It seems that the letter wasn't delivered properly."

A faint smile appeared on Eutenia's lips.

A thin finger covered Eutenia's lips.

Shh.

Eutenia closed one eye and asked them to be quiet quietly.

At the same time, she repeated what she had written in the letter to Elbon in her own voice.

"I told you not to tell anyone."

"This guy is just..."

"It seems that your disciple wasn't that important to you."

Thump. Rattle.

The brooch that Eutenia held in her hand fell in front of Elbon.

Elbon, who was about to make an excuse to her, shut his mouth.

Chapter 97: Fate (6)

Chapter 97: Fate (6)

The laboratory was filled with silence.

Elbon's eyes, stained with complex emotions, looked at the freaks in front of him.

It had been several minutes since they came to Elbon's laboratory.

Elbon was known to be impatient by nature, but he was especially intolerant when it came to his disciple.

He had been more enraged than ever since he found the brooch on the table.

Next to Elbon, Sigor was watching him with a worried face.

'I don't know what to say.'

The self-proclaimed follower of the god had been aggressive towards Elbon from the start.

Eutenia Hyrost.

The one who kidnapped Elbon's disciple was a fanatic of the cult that served the god.

If they were rational beings, they would not have used such extreme measures.

They were doing this because they were insane followers of the god.

They had walked into the magic tower, which could be called the enemy's territory, on their own feet.

They would not have chosen this action if they did not have confidence in their skills.

If this continued, Elbon would also be swayed by their intentions.

‘Normally, there would be no room for compromise with the followers of the god, but...’

Still, Elbon could not resist them strongly.

He was worried about the safety of his disciple who was captured by them.

Enia was Elbon's greatest masterpiece that he had nurtured with his heart and soul.

Losing her here would be an irreparable loss for Elbon.

Sigor stepped forward instead of Elbon, who was silent.

“Did you say your name was Eutenia? You may be a deviant being, but there is a limit to your rudeness.”

“Was I rude? But it was a matter of my precious disciple.”

The ash-colored eyes under the hood looked at Sigor.

It was an arrogant and oppressive attitude.

He looked down on the magicians who lived in the tower.

Of course, he must have come here because he was sure he could get out safely.

But this was the central magic tower of the empire.

It was the essence of magic where all kinds of geniuses and magic studies of the empire gathered.

He did not know what it meant to fight in the territory of a prepared magician.

There was no magician who would endure humiliation in his own territory.

Eutenia's words made Sigor respond with a rough attitude.

“Do you not understand where you are standing? This is the tower.”

“Of course I know.”

“If you try any nonsense, the defensive magic circle installed in the tower will crush you in seconds.”

Sigor glared at the intruders with angry eyes and warned them.

As long as Elbon, the sage of the tower, knew him, Sigor's words were not empty.

He was a master of ice magic.

He was one of the most powerful combat magicians in the system, and he had access to the defensive magic installed in the tower.

He had mastered countless combat magics and was a master of battle who had gone through numerous battlefields.

Moreover, he had priority over all the defensive magics in the tower right now.

The opponent was showing an arrogant attitude in front of him.

Sigor could not tolerate their attitude towards Elbon.

“You seem to have some confidence in the magic of the tower?”

“Yes. I wouldn’t have said this if I didn’t. This place is a collection of countless magics that the empire has been researching.”

“But that won’t help you save your disciple who will suffer.”

His voice was gentle, but his words were sharp.

Sigor’s face frowned at Eutenia’s threat to Enia.

Elbon, who was sitting in his seat, was lost in deep thought after hearing that.

Hoo-.

Elbon’s sigh echoed in the laboratory.

To save Enia, he had to find out what they wanted first.

Elbon, with a troubled face, opened his mouth towards Eutenia.

“What do you want from us?”

“We would appreciate it if you followed us quietly. Of course, we also need to take all the equipment from the laboratory.”

“Where are you taking me?”

“That’s a secret.”

Eutenia answered, bringing her finger to her lips as before.

Her proposal was simple.

She wanted to kidnap Elbon from this place, just like she did with Enia.

And she wanted to take all of Elbon’s research data with her.

The only difference from when she took Enia was that she promised to release Enia in exchange for Elbon.

She was saying that she would kidnap the Sage of the Tower in front of the Master of the Tower.

It was an offer that the Tower could never accept, even if it meant losing Enia.

It was an offer that Sigor would not let go of, even if Elbon agreed to it.

As if to prove Elbon's expectation, Sigor spoke with a more enraged voice.

"I cannot accept such an offer!"

"...Sigor."

"Do you think you can exchange a mere disciple for the Master of the Tower!"

Sigor rejected Eutenia's offer with a firm voice.

At the sight of Sigor, Elbon tapped his forehead.

The conversation was over as soon as Sigor refused.

It was an unreasonable offer that Elbon's side could not easily accept from the beginning.

If they could not accept the other's offer, Elbon had to use money or something else to persuade them.

At the moment when Elbon was about to bring up the topic of Enia's ransom,

A cold voice flowed out of Eutenia's mouth.

"It doesn't matter if you refuse."

"What did you say...?"

"I was planning to take you by force anyway."

Eutenia said so and pulled out her right hand from under her cloak.

In Eutenia's hand that came out of the cloak, there was a thick book.

There was no way to avoid a clash of force between them.

The moment he sensed that fact, Elbon drew out his staff that was hanging on his waist.

Sigor, who was behind Elbon, also moved his hand and drew up his magic power.

Eutenia looked at the two of them and expressed her dissatisfaction with a regretful face.

"I asked you to come quietly... It seems like it will be a bit difficult."

"You finally show your true colors, spawn of the evil god! I command you! Activate the emergency extermination order!"

From Sigor's mouth facing Eutenia, a command for the Tower's defensive magic circle came out.

It was a command that Elbon also knew well from hearing rumors.

Emergency extermination order. It was a means that only a magician who had the priority command right of the Tower could use.

From the moment the activation was declared, a pulse that interfered with magic power was emitted throughout the Tower, and everyone except the magicians of the Tower was restricted from using magic power.

It gave a fatal disadvantage to unauthorized intruders.

The use of the emergency extermination order caused damage to the magic research of the Tower, so it was a command that was restricted unless it was an urgent situation.

As Sigor's voice echoed, the artificial spirit that managed the Tower responded to Sigor's voice.

-“Confirmed activation of emergency extermination order by priority commander. The emergency extermination order will be executed according to the rules.”

-“Detected unauthorized intruders.”

-“Activating magic barrier – crackle.”

-“Failed – sizzle – fizz – emergency... extermination – error occurred.”

-“Failed to execute emergency extermination order.”

-“It will take 5 minutes and 48 seconds to recover from critical error.”

However, what came back from the artificial spirit of the Tower was not a normal answer.

Sigor's face turned dark at the voice of the artificial spirit reporting an error.

The Tower's defense system was not working properly.

The magic that gave an absolute advantage to the magicians of the Tower was neutralized for some unknown reason.

It was a situation where a problem that could not be compared to Enia's kidnapping occurred.

Eutenia, who they were facing, turned over a page in her book and spoke in a relaxed voice.

“It looks like I can block it for about 5 minutes if I concentrate.”

“Impossible...”

“It was an interesting magic. Unfortunately, its effect is hard to see with your eyes.”

“What are you talking about, cough...!”

Boom!

As soon as Eutenia’s voice ended, a scream burst out of Sigor’s mouth.

Elbon quickly turned his head and looked at Sigor.

Sigor’s abdomen, who was trying to use magic, was pierced by a giant shadow’s fang.

He failed to properly respond to the sudden attack from behind.

Sigor, who was bleeding and glaring at Eutenia, turned into ice and disappeared.

In an instant, Sigor moved to the other side of the laboratory, his abdomen covered with red frozen ice.

“Sigor!”

“I’m, ugh... fine! It’s just that the Tower’s defense system... seems to be temporarily disabled...”

“I know! I’ll join the fight too!”

Elbon shouted in a hurry to Sigor, who used magic to stop the bleeding from his wound.

Elbon was not very good at combat magic, but this was his laboratory.

He was not so weak that he could do nothing in his own territory.

A prepared magician was much more powerful than an unprepared one.

That was true even for Elbon, who walked the path of alchemy.

Swish.

Elbon gripped his staff and stood up, glaring at the intruders.

Eutenia, the magician who neutralized the Tower's defense system, blocked Elbon's way.

"It seems like you want to fight. Aren't you worried about your disciple?"

"Kuh..."

"It won't take long even if we fight properly."

"Ice Spear!"

Sigor, who had teleported near Elbon, used magic against Eutenia.

Ice Spear. It was a mid-level ice magic.

A spear of ice that condensed in the air flew towards Eutenia.

Crash!

The spear that rushed at high speed was blocked by a wall of shadow that rose from below Eutenia.

The ice spear shattered into pieces as it collided with the shadow, scattering ice fragments everywhere.

Eutenia, who was targeted by Sigor, was unharmed.

"Do you use ice magic?"

"Ice Storm!"

But Sigor's magic was not over yet.

The ice fragments that scattered and fluttered were swept by the wind and began to move.

An ice storm that was created in an instant assaulted Eutenia with pressure.

With a coldness that could make flesh ache and sharp ice fragments that spun fiercely.

Eutenia pulled up her shadow more as she felt the threat of the closing ice storm.

It was a sight of her shadow thickening and wrapping around her body quickly.

Elbon, who saw the movement of the shadow that tried to surround her, pointed his staff at Eutenia.

“Elemental Burst!”

Boom!

The last of Elbon’s elemental explosion magic mixed and ended the chain of magic that aimed at Eutenia.

Thick smoke rose in the laboratory, and the furniture that was swept by the explosion flew around.

Ice Spear. Ice Storm. Elemental Burst.

The destructive power created by the three magics in succession.

It was clear that Eutenia could not completely block the current attack from her appearance of pulling up her shadow desperately.

Even if she managed to block it, she would have suffered a fatal wound.

Elbon looked at Eutenia beyond the smoke with a hopeful voice.

“I wonder if we got her.”

“...Elbon.”

“Sigor! We don’t know yet, so we have to pursue the other guy...”

“Get away.”

Elbon could not hide his bewilderment at Sigor’s voice.

Sigor suddenly told Elbon to get away from him.

Get away. What did he mean by that?

As Elbon turned to look at Sigor, who was full of wounds,

A huge change occurred in the wall of the laboratory.

“Wha...?”

“Elbon! Hurry up and evacuate—!”

As the smoke cleared, Elbon detected a huge change in the scenery.

A change.

It was a sight that could only be described by such a word.

Beyond the smoke where Eutenia stood,

The wall of the Tower that could never collapse collapsed.

Crunch!

What appeared beyond the collapsed wall was a giant hand.

A giant rose from the shadow of the Tower cast by Eutenia’s body.

A giant born from the shadow of the Tower made by sunlight was as big as the shadow itself.

“...”

If God himself came down to earth, would he move such a huge body?

That thought crossed Elbon’s mind as he looked at the giant of shadow.

Right after Elbon witnessed the giant's appearance,

A giant hand made of shadows moved toward the tower.

It was a swift movement, despite its massive size.

The shadowy hand passed through Eutenia, who was blocking its path, and approached me.

A gust of wind brushed against my cheek as I faced the black giant.

“El... sir... avoid... it...”

“This is...”

A faint breeze on my cheek.

And then a strong wind that pushed me back.

The voice that reached my ears in the turbulent air faded away.

My body flew to the corner along with the raging wind.

Crash! Craaash!

The sudden blast of wind shook my vision as I looked ahead.

In the shaking sight, I had to watch the laboratory equipment being scattered around.

The unfixed equipment in the laboratory was swirling in the air by the wind.

“Elbon sir!”

“Cough... ugh...”

My body hit the wall hard after being flung away.

Thud.

Blood spilled from my mouth as I hit the wall.

My sight returned for a moment and then blurred again.

The blood must have rushed to my head from what just happened.

I groaned in pain and held my head, trying to regain my senses.

I moved my eyes to find Sigor, who should be somewhere in the laboratory.

“Elbon sir! Snap out of it!”

“A few steps away from where I was thrown.

There was Sigor, who was trying to resist the giant with his cold magic.

He was a master of combat magic, indeed.

But he didn’t look like he could hold on for long.

There was an overwhelming difference in size between him and the giant.

‘The evil god created a monster.’

The girl in front of me was a monster.

She had disabled the tower’s defense magic in a short time, and at the same time, she was pushing back the master-level mage of the tower.

She was a monster born from a combination of innate talent and endless magic power.

I thought she was just a fanatic who served the evil god, but that was a big mistake on my part.

I knew what to call such a being.

An apostle.

She was an apostle of the evil god, sent by him.

She was a sword forged to destroy the human kingdom.

“Why... why are you doing this!”

Sigor saw me spitting blood and shouted at Eutenia.

His cold magic that blocked the giant’s fist was losing its power.

His magic power was gradually running out as he fought Eutenia.

With the tower’s defense system disabled, it was an uneven fight from the start.

The opponent was an agent of the evil god with infinite magic power.

And Sigor was a mage who couldn’t overcome the limits of humans.

Still, he didn’t back down and kept resisting the giant.

Eutenia brushed her hair with her hand and answered Sigor’s scream as he resisted in the laboratory filled with noise.

“That’s because it’s his great will. Didn’t you refuse my offer to take you peacefully?”

“Stop! If you attack like this one more time, Elbon sir will die!”

“Do I need to show mercy to unbelievers? You even refused to take the hostage I worked hard to catch.”

“No matter how much you want Elbon sir, you don’t intend to kill him and take him away!”

Sigor’s argument was reasonable from a human perspective.

But the opponent was not a being that could be measured by human common sense.

Eutenia shook her head at Sigor's words.

It was a reaction that showed she didn't need any hesitation at all.

She declared coldly to Sigor with her head down.

"It doesn't matter if I kill him and take him away. I can just make him an undead anyway."

"..."

"I guess it's a pity to see the equipment being destroyed."

"Stop... right now."

"But it's not bad to show some resistance like this. The unbelievers of the empire will know his greatness."

My eyes saw the giant beyond the broken wall.

The black pupils filled with darkness looked down at me and Sigor.

The giant started to move its fist on the opposite side that it hadn't stretched out yet.

Sigor's magic power, which had reached its limit, wouldn't be able to stop the next attack.

The moment of destruction was coming.

I felt a sense of emptiness as I sensed my end and closed my eyes tightly.

'...I remember that stupid conversation we had at the bar.'

In the face of impending doom, I recalled my conversation with the priest.

That day, at the bar, he talked about fate.

He said that human rise and fall were determined by fate led by six gods.

It still sounded ridiculous to me now.

If human fate was predetermined, then human effort would be worthless in the end.

It would be nothing but a script for a play that had its beginning and end set.

There would be no value in such a life other than being a toy for the gods.

‘Of all things, it had to be the evil god, not the god of abundance. Really...’

If the future given by the gods was fate, then what was the name for the destruction given by the evil god?

A curse? Or a retribution?

Or a cruel joke by a transcendent being who was after a bait?

If it wasn’t even that,

It was really——a damn fate.

Chapter 98: Bone, Flesh, and Blood

(1)

Chapter 98: Bone, Flesh, and Blood (1)

The cult building is located in the Ketterun branch.

There, Estasia was looking at the cult members one by one.

Normally, she would have been rolling around in her room every day, but lately, she was relatively active.

Of course, it was not Estasia's will to move around and inspect the cult.

It was because of the mission she received from the great being who was watching her from the sky.

To check and manage whether the people in the cult were working diligently.

That was the task given to Estasia, who was surrounded by countless fruits.

"The angel is watching us here!"

"We have to work harder!"

Estasia, who was secretly watching the believers preparing the meal, was surprised by their reaction.

She thought she was hiding and watching, but she revealed to the believers that she was monitoring them.

It seemed that the bright halo on her head was the problem.

If not, it might have been the wings sticking out next to her.

The reaction of the believers who found Estasia was as fierce as usual.

Estasia, who had been hiding behind the wall, had no choice but to approach the believers.

And then she began to offer words of encouragement to the believers who were cooking.

“Ahem... You’re all working hard. If you work hard...”

“Angel! Do you want a strawberry?”

“Yes.”

Estasia ended up eating a strawberry unexpectedly.

Munch munch.

She looked around at the believers preparing lunch as she ate the strawberry in her mouth.

Maybe it was because there were so many new members in the cult now.

The amount of food prepared at the branch was quite different from before.

Of course, there were also people preparing food for Estasia in one corner.

They were magicians hired by the bishop to freeze Estasia’s strawberries.

They were excellent people who took care of Estasia’s heat from early summer when the hot sun was burning.

Estasia tapped the magician’s shoulder with her hand that had five gold bracelets on it.

“You’re working hard.”

“Thank you! Angel!”

“I want apple juice for dinner.”

“Yes! Leave it to me!”

The magician brought by the bishop had also become a loyal believer who served the great being.

She didn’t know exactly what happened, but it was clear that the bishop had indoctrinated the magician regularly.

Above all, most of the humans living on the ground liked angels.

They also tended to be friendly to the angel’s requests.

The magician might have decided to join the cult because of Estasia’s existence.

Estasia shrugged her shoulders in admiration of her own charm that spread endlessly.

One of the believers who was cooking stuck close to Estasia and talked to her.

“Angel? Where are you going this time?”

“I’m going to rest now.”

“Will you come out for worship?”

“Yes. I have to pray every day.”

“As expected, you are diligent, angel! The great one might be amazed by you.”

Nod. Nod.

Estasia nodded her head in agreement with the believer's words.

Estasia was very busy moving around lately.

She checked as many as seven rooms a day.

It was practically checking all the rooms that she could check without climbing stairs.

If she worked so diligently, there would be no reason for the great being who watched her to create a black sun again.

"I have to go now."

"Come back again! We'll prepare some delicious snacks for you!"

"Okay."

Her job of watching over the believers was over for now.

She said goodbye to them and went outside.

Estasia walked down an empty hallway by herself.

Only her small footsteps echoed in the quiet hallway.

There were usually no people in the hallway around this time when lunch was not far away.

She always walked along this silent hallway alone at times like this.

She liked noisy atmosphere too, but this quiet atmosphere wasn't bad either.

Sometimes she wanted to be alone too.

"..."

Estasia's eyes looked up at the sky shining through the window as she walked down the hallway.

I looked up at the clear sky, where clouds were drifting by.

Above them, a huge sun was shining brightly, casting its radiant light on the ground.

They say that humans can't look directly at the sun with their eyes.

But for angels, it was a sight that they could gaze at for as long as they wanted.

There were many differences between humans and angels, besides the halo and wings.

I learned all of them after I came down to Earth.

"I wonder what the angels in heaven are doing right now."

As I thought idly, staring at the sky, my halo started to act strangely.

It flickered wildly, losing its steady glow.

My face darkened at the sight of my halo's reaction.

It meant that it had detected something unusual.

Something that only angels could sense.

I opened my mouth dumbly, feeling a surge of shock.

"Wha...?"

Humans wouldn't notice anything odd.

But I, as an angel, could see it clearly.

There was a small crack in the boundary between heaven and earth.

It was a phenomenon that occurred when a transcendent being tried to distort the boundary on purpose.

There was only one meaning behind the crack in the boundary.

An angel was descending.

And not just any angel, but a high-ranking one.

“Other angels shouldn’t come down...”

Woo woo woo woo!

I stepped back a few steps, feeling anxious about the crack that appeared in the distant sky.

It was far away from where I was, but still within this continent.

But if an angel came down to Earth, it was only a matter of time before we met.

If the angel wandered around the continent, they would eventually find the branch of the Order where I was.

And that angel wouldn’t be friendly to me.

I was a runaway who escaped from heaven, after all.

“Yawn...”

I rubbed my sleepy eyes and looked at the screen where Perin’s face was displayed.

Maybe it was because I had just eaten dinner.

I felt a strong wave of drowsiness hit me.

I tried to keep my eyes open and stay alert.

I could brush my teeth and go to bed right away, but there was something I had to do before sleeping.

With extreme willpower, I resisted the urge to sleep and focused on the screen.

-“You know, YYuto has grown a lot.”

-“That’s because we worked hard!”

-“Soil.”

On the screen, Perin and Pluto were having a conversation.

The topic was mostly about Yuto.

After I took Perin as my apostle, I entrusted Yuto’s care to her and Pluto.

And the result of their efforts was Yuto’s current appearance on the screen.

Yuto had grown so big that even one character wouldn’t be enough to fill him up. He could fit ten people easily now.

And despite his huge size, he didn’t lose any of his soil that he carried on his back.

-“Soil soil.”

-“Yggdrasil helped us a lot too!”

-“Of course, your miracle was also amazing.”

It must have been Perin’s miracle that helped Yuto maintain his size.

Her miracle itself was designed to assist the base.

A flying island that could move and hide while attacking from outside.

Anyone who had a dream of flying units would admire its performance.

It was a product of synergy between Perin and Yuto.

“I should order her to bring Eutenia soon.”

Yuto was big enough to be deployed in battle right away.

If he was ready to use, then I should use him as soon as possible.

That’s why I raised him diligently in the first place.

I tapped on the speech bubble above Perin’s head to give her an order.

And I started typing a chat message to her, who was stroking Yggdrasil.

“Hey.”

-“Hello! How are you today?”

“Get on Yuto and bring Eutenia here.”

-“Are you giving me a mission? A mission to bring an apostle... Okay, I got it!”

Perin nodded her head brightly, after receiving a simple order through the chat.

It was an order to bring Eutenia using Yuto.

He wanted to use Yuto’s ability to fly in the sky, to speed up the movement of Evan and Eutenia.

It was hard to get there by riding Alpha, but coming back to the Order was easy with Yuto flying.

Yuto, upgraded with Yggdrasil, had stealth and protection functions, so there shouldn’t be any problem.

It was finally time for Yuto and the new apostle to show their skills.

-“But I... don’t know what the other apostles look like...”

Perin accepted my order right away, but she added one concern.

She didn’t know anything about the other apostles, because she was new.

Considering when Perin joined, her worry was reasonable.

I suggested a solution for that.

It was to send Pluto with Perin.

“That makes sense. Then go with Pluto and find them.”

-“Are you saying I should go with Pluto?”

“I can tell you where to meet them, but Pluto can confirm if they are the right ones.”

Of course, Pluto wasn’t an old apostle either.

But she had spent a long time riding a carriage with Eutenia, so she knew her well.

If Pluto moved with Perin, they would be able to find Eutenia without any trouble. That was my calculation.

I gave them that order.

Then, Perin and Yuto answered me with speech bubbles on the other side of the screen.

-“Got it! I’ll do my best with Yuto and come back safely!”

-“Soil!”

That was the end of my conversation with Perin.

I closed the chat window that I had opened for talking to the apostles.

And I quietly looked at the screen of my smartphone.

As soon as our conversation ended, Perin started chatting with Pluto again.

Yawn. I yawned again as I watched my smartphone.

-“I feel it every time I feed Yuto, but it’s nice here because the trees are big.”

-“Do vampires really get hurt by sunlight?”

-“If they are old enough, they don’t get hurt by sunlight, but it still feels a bit uncomfortable.”

-“I see. That’s an interesting trait of vampires.”

Blink. Blink.

My eyelids started to close as I watched Perin and Pluto.

My vision became blurry, and my consciousness became hazy.

Even if I opened and closed my eyes, my consciousness didn’t come back.

It was a sign of irresistible sleepiness.

My head slowly tilted forward, and a short fear escaped from my mouth.

“I should brush my teeth and sleep...”

But I couldn’t overcome the strong urge to sleep with the fear of cavities.

Droop. Droop.

Thud.

My forehead pressed down on the screen of my smartphone.

I didn’t know what button I was touching.

But my body that lay on the table wanted to sleep like this.

-You can get various items that will help you in the game play by using 10 draws.

A comfortable and cozy feeling enveloped my head.

And I fell asleep, giving in to my desire.

Without knowing what was happening on my smartphone that was pressed by my forehead.

Chapter 99: Bone, Flesh, and Blood

(2)

Chapter 99: Bone, Flesh, and Blood (2)

The Levart forest, which was destroyed by the evil god's power.

There, special investigator Van Krite was sighing as he held the reins.

Normally, he would have been chasing after the black mage, but today he had no choice but to join the expedition.

His role was to guide the expedition from the holy land who came to subjugate Cuebaerg.

Next to Van on the right was the expedition leader with a holy sword.

As Cuebaerg's hideout approached, the expedition leader Oren looked at Van.

"Is this where Cuebaerg is?"

"He should show up soon. This is where his hideout was discovered."

"I see."

Oren nodded at Van's story.

Van, who was driving his horse forward, looked at Oren next to him.

The knight in thick armor was someone Van knew well.

The blue holy sword, Oren.

He was one of the owners of the holy sword, which only the chosen ones in the holy land could receive.

Moreover, Oren's exploits of subjugating many black mages were well known in the empire.

Facing a young genius, he felt a strong urge to cross swords with him.

"I have a question for you."

As he watched Oren cautiously move forward, Oren spoke to Van again.

He seemed to have something to say to him.

There wasn't much time left until they encountered Cuebaerg.

In this situation, Oren wouldn't throw a trivial joke at him.

Van accepted Oren's question without hesitation.

"What are you curious about?"

"Will you participate in the battle when it breaks out?"

"I'd rather finish it as a guide if possible... but the higher-ups want me to show my skills."

"That's a headache."

Van was here because of the orders from above.

They told him to wash away the disgrace of last time with his own hands as a member of Cloud.

The only person Cloud sent to the expedition was Van, who was assigned as a guide.

Special investigators were treated as the best in Cloud.

The higher-ups thought that Van alone was enough, and they left everything to his judgment on the spot.

If he didn't achieve anything meaningful in this subjugation, Captain Levernoff would surely nag him until his ears bled.

“Are you in trouble too?”

“I'm just a nominal leader of the expedition. I never had any skill in hunting monsters.”

“Well, there are heroes and saints behind us...”

“This expedition is a big deal for the holy land. They probably want to announce the arrival of new heroes and show that the holy land is still strong.”

Three heroes and a saint were mobilized for the subjugation of Cuebaerg.

They were heroes who were said to rival an army by themselves, gathered in one place.

They were not fully matured yet, but they were not to be taken lightly as heroes.

The power of their divine artifacts was formidable.

Thinking of the heroes, Van tapped his sword on his waist.

“I hope they grow up fast so that the world can be more peaceful.”

“I agree with you. It would be good for them to gain experience like this.”

“But don't be too careless. We've lost quite a few investigators to him.”

“That's why we're prepared, aren't we? Don't worry. This time we brought out even the holy relics that the church has.”

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

As Van conversed with Oren, something huge came into his sight.

A creature covered in darkness beyond the mountain was moving grotesquely.

Van looked at it with a tense face as he spotted the huge body that started moving from afar.

There was only one unidentified creature that could be found here.

The abyssal lord Cuebaerg.

The being they had been looking for finally appeared before their eyes.

“...”

“Sir?”

“He’s here. We’d better get ready.”

Oren and Van’s eyes turned to the monster at the same time.

The black lump-like thing made a strange sound as it approached them.

Thump—. Thump—. Thump—. Thump—.

The horses that were moving forward stopped as they felt the tremors that spread periodically.

It was huge. And majestic.

The eyes buried in the darkness made those who saw them feel oppressed.

“That’s...the infamous Cuebaerg.”

“We’ll face him soon enough.”

Van said as he watched Cuebaerg's huge eyes.

Cuebaerg's appearance was very alien.

He called himself the lord of the abyss.

He looked like what would happen if you squashed together things from the abyss.

He was not a being that belonged on the surface.

Such a being should never crawl out of the abyss.

“Halt!”

Thud!

At Oren's command, the procession that was moving forward came to a complete stop.

The knights who were following Oren also stopped and drew their weapons.

They all knew why he had halted the formation, even without him saying it.

Thump—. Thump—. Thump—. Thump—.

The vibration from the footsteps was getting bigger and bigger.

It was the sound of the giant beast that Cuebaerg had created, clearly reaching everyone's ears.

The enemy was approaching.

And it was not a human one, but a monster from the abyss.

In this situation, there was only one thing that Oren, the commander, could do.

“Everyone, prepare for battle! Cuebaerg is coming!”

As soon as Oren shouted to the sky with his holy sword drawn,

The blue holy sword began to emit a brilliant light.

“.....Ah.”

I was in a deep sleep and only woke up when the sun was high in the sky.

I raised my upper body and held my forehead in the bright sunlight.

Did I press my forehead somewhere while sleeping?

I felt a dull sensation on my forehead as I woke up.

It seemed that I had slept in a bad position last night.

I looked at the smartphone that I had been lying on.

The game was running on the smartphone that I had intended to sleep on.

“Ah... I fell asleep while playing the game last night.”

The last thing I remembered was ordering Pluto and Perin to bring Eutenia back from the island.

Right after that, I must have fallen asleep without resisting the drowsiness.

As if to prove that, the game screen showed an inventory that had been moved to a strange position.

It looked like I had pushed the inventory to the corner of the screen with my forehead while sleeping.

I dragged the inventory back to its proper place.

And then I checked the contents of the inventory.

I quickly found something strange in the inventory.

“What is this...?”

There were too many items in the open inventory.

Items like robes and iron swords that I had thought were worthless and kept in the corner of the inventory were piled up like a mountain.

And that wasn't all.

There were unfamiliar items in the inventory that I didn't know when I had acquired them.

Six shiny sword-shaped items in the middle of the inventory, and one item that looked like a magic book.

And next to them, an item that looked like a ticket.

I couldn't help but exclaim at the sight of so many items in the inventory.

“Did Eutenia go on a rampage last night? Why are there so many items...?”

Just in case, I clicked on one of the sword-shaped items, and [Magic Sword: Aterinus] appeared with a description.

[Magic Sword: Aterinus] was an item with a trait called <Heat Conversion>.

It was a trait that converted magic into flames when infused with magic.

It was an item that only seemed to come out of a lottery draw, but it was newly added to my inventory.

And it wasn't the only magic sword in my inventory.

All the items next to it belonged to the category of magic swords.

As I looked at the pile of magic swords in my inventory, a bad thought crossed my mind.

“No... please don’t tell me.”

Six magic swords of different types.

A [Magic Book: Ice Arrow] next to them.

And finally, a [Random Creature Summon Ticket (Low Grade)] that looked different from the other items.

They all looked like items that could only be obtained through a lottery.

My face, which had been surprised by the items, lost its smile.

There was only one reason why these items were stuffed in my inventory.

The 10-times lottery at the <Paid Currency Shop>.

I thought of the possibility that I had tapped the 10-times lottery while I was asleep last night.

“Oh, no... Please, no. Please.”

I quickly went back to the home screen of my smartphone and opened the text messages.

I thought that if I had paid for items in the game, the payment details would be left in the message box.

Swipe. Tap.

As I entered the message box, I could see the numerous messages I had received overnight.

The first thing I found in the message box was a payment confirmation message from the card company.

-[WEB sent] Card 89,900 won one-time payment approved. (08/19)

-[WEB sent] Card 89,900 won one-time payment approved. (08/19)

-[WEB sent] Card 89,900 won one-time payment approved. (08/19)

Swipe.

The payment details kept pouring out as I moved my finger.

My mouth widened in proportion to the payment details that I saw.

I looked up at the screen with my mouth open, but the scroll that was going up did not seem to end easily.

How many lotteries did I spin last night, that the payment details from the card company did not seem to end?

As I kept scrolling up, I was able to stop my finger when I reached the end of the payment history for last night.

I let out a hollow laugh as I checked the payment history for the day.

“Ha... ha...”

I laughed at the absurd situation.

I repeated the messages I had just seen in my head and calculated the amount I had paid.

The 10-times lottery that had risen to 89,900 won without me knowing.

21 messages saying that I had purchased a 10-times lottery for 89,900 won.

That meant that I had spun 210 times in total.

And the cost of spinning that much was 1,887,900 won.

One hundred eighty-eight thousand seven hundred ninety won.

I dropped my smartphone from my hand at the amount that made me dizzy.

Did I ever spend so much money on a game in one day?

At least as far as I could remember, I had never spent close to two million won in one day.

“I must be crazy, really...”

I grabbed my head and curled up at the thought of spending nearly two million won in one day.

Two million won. Two million won!

It was an amount that anyone would feel burdened by spending.

Chapter 100: Bone, Flesh, and Blood (3)

Chapter 100: Bone, Flesh, and Blood (3)

In the midst of chaos, Hus's eyes looked at the battlefield.

He was the hero of knowledge – Hus Allemier.

What he saw before him was hell.

Monsters crawled out of the abyss and approached them, and countless people tried to stop them from all sides.

It was different from the situation when he fought against criminals in Cloud.

What he faced now was a monster beyond human standards.

He could never kill the monster in front of him with a human perspective.

“It looks like they're closing in on us.”

And Hus had a role that suited his position here.

He was the hero chosen by the goddess of knowledge.

He was the successor of the legendary mage in the long history, and also the hero of magic who would help other heroes in the future.

His role was to assist everyone on this battlefield with magic.

As he watched the approaching Cuebaerg, Hus raised one hand up.

He aimed his hand at the huge monster of the abyss and muttered the name of the magic softly.

“——Stone Spike.”

Mana surged from Hus’s hand holding the hieroglyph.

The hieroglyph.

The ultimate grimoire that stored and reproduced all magic shone brightly.

Chwarararak——.

The pages of the hieroglyph in Hus’s hand turned quickly, and a huge vibration began to ring around Cuebaerg.

It was a earth magic that shot out spikes of rock to pierce the opponent.

Kugung. Kung. Kugugung.

Cuebaerg showed signs of caution at the sight of the ground swelling up sequentially.

-Gwoooooooo!

It started to move roughly and tried to advance forward.

But Hus’s Stone Spike did not let Cuebaerg move easily.

Kwaaak! Kwak!

The spikes that sprang from the ground pierced Cuebaerg’s body and held it firmly.

Black liquid poured out from Cuebaerg’s body pierced by pillars of spikes.

Cuebaerg screamed in pain and writhed.

-Gwooooo.

“I won’t let you get out of there. Stone Spike.”

Kung. Kung. Kung. Kung.

Cuebaerg writhed to break Hus’s Stone Spike.

But no matter how much Cuebaerg moved, the spikes that pierced him did not show any signs of breaking.

It was magic cast by a mage who inherited the qualities of a great hero with all his might.

It was not easy to break the sturdy spikes with overwhelming mass.

As Hus held Cuebaerg’s movement, a large light began to gather in Cuebaerg’s eyes.

A tremendous amount of mana condensed in front of Cuebaerg’s pupil, and Oren, the leader of the subjugation team, raised his sword.

“It’s preparing magic! Stop its attack!”

He said that and took a stance and swung his sword at Cuebaerg.

Light burst out from Oren’s sword and rushed toward Cuebaerg.

Immediately after Oren’s sword and Cuebaerg’s eye far away, a new line was engraved on it.

The ability of the blue holy sword, ‘Sword of Purification’, was activated and hit the distant enemy.

Black liquid leaked from the line made by Oren’s sword.

Cuebaerg shrieked in pain as he was cut by the sword.

-Gwoooooooooooooo!

“.....This is still not enough.”

But Oren’s blow was not enough to completely stop Cuebaerg’s attack.

Next to him, Gilford and Ban also ran towards Cuebaerg.

Tadadadadak—.

The two ran towards Cuebaerg, stepping on the rocks that Hus had created, and approached him.

Their swords were surrounded by thick aura as they approached the monster quickly.

Ban, who was worthy of his title as a special investigator, had a clear blue aura around him.

And Gilford, who received Ascalon’s help, wielded an aura that was amplified to an enormous size.

Their swords sequentially slashed at Cuebaerg’s pupil.

-Gwooo! Gwooooooooo.....!

“Its mana is shaking! Don’t let it use magic!”

With a cross-shaped wound, black liquid burst out from Cuebaerg’s eye.

The mana that had been condensed in front of Cuebaerg’s eye also twisted violently as it shook severely.

It could not shoot magic smoothly in that state.

In severe cases, it could release unfinished magic in strange directions.

Hus prepared another magic by lifting up the hieroglyph as he saw Cuebaerg shaking.

Using his device, Hus loaded magic right after that, and Zion's voice echoed behind him.

“Hus! I'm ready now!”

Hearing his voice, Hus looked back at him.

There he saw Zion holding his bow.

Zion was an archer who used a bow, so he was placed in the back with Hus.

He was the hero of hunting, who had a wind-imbued arrow on his bowstring.

Hus looked at Zion's bow and nodded quietly at him.

It was the situation that Zion had asked him before the subjugation of Cuebaerg began.

Hus used magic with his free hand in front of Zion.

“——Fire Wall.”

“Good, good. I'm shooting now, so get out of the way!”

Zion's voice rang out as soon as he said that, Oren swung his sword and prepared to give orders to those around him.

Oren's voice, who took a deep breath, echoed around.

He ordered the troops near Cuebaerg to back off.

“Everyone! Get away from the enemy!”

“It's the hero's attack! Get some distance from the enemy!”

The other knights relayed Oren's order, and those who were close to Cuebaerg quickly backed away.

The situation was cleared in an instant, and Zion's bow aimed at Cuebaerg's pupil without any obstacles.

Zion's arrow, which was surrounded by a fierce wind, was a fatal attack that no one could avoid.

Cuebaerg, who had a bulky body, was no exception.

Zion released the arrow from his hand.

At the same time, the flames of 'Fire Wall' spread to the wind and flew quickly toward Cuebaerg.

"Monster, eat this!"

Kwagwagwagwagwang——!

The wind with flames rushed toward Cuebaerg.

Cuebaerg's pupil shrank in an instant as he saw the arrow flying toward him.

Cuebaerg writhed violently to avoid the flying arrow.

Thud. Thud.

In his frantic writhing, which completely ignored his own safety, cracks began to form on the spikes that bound him.

But the arrow shot by the hero of hunting never missed its target.

-Gwooo... Waaack!

A direct hit.

A storm of heat burst out from the cross-section of the arrow that collided with Cuebaerg.

The burning flames engulfed Cuebaerg's entire body, and the sharp wind tore his skin.

Kwaaaang!

A violent scream erupted from Cuebaerg's mouth as he was hit by the fire and wind.

Black liquid gushed out from the wound that the arrow had passed through.

Zion smiled and shouted at Hus as he saw Cuebaerg in pain.

"It looks like he took a big hit, huh?"

"It looks like a fatal wound. Is this the end?"

"Hus. You don't seem to know, but you shouldn't say that unless you're sure....."

Hus, who had uttered a careless answer at the sight of Cuebaerg, whose half of his body was crumbling.

Zion looked like he was dissatisfied with Hus's words and tried to say something to him.

As they were talking while watching Cuebaerg collapse.

Cuebaerg's skin tore and a strange voice came out from behind it.

The skin that was not pierced by any ordinary weapon cracked, and an alien sound came out from beyond it.

Cuebaerg's voice was so bizarre that it made the listener's spine chill.

Everyone who watched the progress of the battle looked at the direction where the sound came from.

-Grrr... Gwak... Gurururuk.....!

-Eeeek... Kruruk.....!

-Gwooooooooooooo.....!

Beyond the jet-black skin that covered Cuebaerg.

All kinds of monstrous shapes began to pour out from there.

Hus could understand why Cuebaerg looked like that as he watched their appearance.

Cuebaerg was a monster worthy of the name of lord, as he claimed himself.

He was like a territory that carried his subordinates in his body.

Zion chuckled and opened his mouth as he saw Cuebaerg spewing out countless monsters.

“I think I get it now. Maybe he was the lord of the abyss because he looked like this?”

“Damn monster, he had other monsters inside him.”

Hus and Zion raised their weapons again at the same time.

The battle with the monster that ravaged the empire was not over yet.

The battle with the many minions that Cuebaerg had.

The real battle had just begun.

“I’m going crazy.”

I scratched my head with both hands and looked at the screen beyond my smartphone.

It was bad enough that I had wasted 2 million won on gacha, but now my creature that I had made last time was also damaged.

It was my precious creature that I had created using my <Creature Maker> skill.

It was a desperate situation indeed.

I sighed deeply as I watched Cuebaerg being attacked.

“Ha…….”

Even though he looked like someone I didn’t want to see often, he was my child that I had created with my skill.

He was being attacked by boss characters that I didn’t know where they came from.

And they were pouring all kinds of vicious attacks on Cuebaerg in a swarm.

There is no parent who would be happy to see their child being hit.

Even if that child was born by my touch alone.

I looked closely at the message at the bottom of the screen as I moved it on my smartphone screen.

A warning about Cuebaerg kept popping up in the message box.

-[Abyssal Beast : Cuebaerg] has entered <Reduced Form>.

-To preserve [Abyssal Beast : Cuebaerg], you must retrieve its body.

-If [Abyssal Beast : Cuebaerg] dies, the connection with it by <Karma’s Blessing> will be completely severed.

Cuebaerg entered a phase called ‘Reduced Form’ when it suffered fatal damage.

And while it was in that reduced form, I had to rescue Cuebaerg.

There wasn't much time left to save Cuebaerg.

If I wanted to protect Cuebaerg, I had to intervene right now and get him out of there.

But the situation was not so easy that I could interfere recklessly.

I saw familiar faces of characters in the area where Cuebaerg existed.

“Why did that boss have to show up there?”

The last time I sent Eutenea, I encountered characters that I guessed were teaser bosses.

And those bosses had a special pattern that blocked my sight.

They were enemies that were not easy to damage even with magical damage, let alone physical damage.

I haven't finished setting up my physical character yet.

If I encounter a situation where my sight is obstructed again, it would be difficult to respond rashly.

Moreover, the firepower of the enemies I see now seemed much stronger than before.

If I send my apostles and fight a frontal battle recklessly, I wouldn't be surprised if someone died.

So I needed to avoid colliding with them right now to avoid any damage.

“Then who should I send there…….”

But it was also difficult to leave Cuebaerg alone just because it was dangerous.

Cuebaerg was also one of my precious characters.

Even if I looked at the karma I had collected so far, Cuebaerg's contribution was considerable.

I couldn't let such a great character die.

I had to save him and build a foundation for him to use again later, even if he was weakened now.

How to rescue Cuebaerg in this situation.

An idea flashed through my mind as I looked at the characters on the screen and the message at the bottom.

“.....Maybe I should send Evan.”

The second apostle, Evan Allemier.

My eyes turned to Evan, who had a special ability among my apostles.

Evan inherited my lightning magic and could temporarily transform into a lightning form.

He could ignore any physical damage while he was in lightning form.

Maybe Evan could escape safely by avoiding the enemy's fire.

He also gained a powerful trait after passing the trial recently.

“When I think about it, the trait I got recently was pretty good.”

The name of the trait that Evan acquired was <Black Lightning Wings>.

It was a type of trait that gave a huge advantage in terms of movement or speed.

Thanks to this trait, Evan was more agile than anyone else among my apostles.

It would also be a great help in terms of time to approach Cuebaerg.

I reached the head of Uto, who my apostles were riding on, and moved my finger toward my smartphone.

I had to make a decision now.

Who to send. And how to bring Cuebaerg back.

“After all, you’re the only one.”

The decision I made after a short deliberation was Evan.

Tuk.

I touched the speech bubble that appeared above Evan’s head.

It was time for my second apostle to step up.

Chapter 101: Bone, Flesh, and Blood (4)

Chapter 101: Bone, Flesh, and Blood (4)

After all kinds of monsters poured out from the collapsed interior of Cuebaerg.

Hus and the other expedition members had to face the abyssal monsters that came like a tidal wave.

Cuebaerg, with its house-sized body, spewed out countless monsters to the outside.

Dealing with the monsters that Cuebaerg spat out was much more troublesome than facing its huge body.

Most of the firepower that the expedition had prepared was effective only for large targets.

It was only possible to sweep away the enemies by projecting massive firepower from a terrain that could withstand the onslaught.

“...They’re really filthy and numerous.”

“Barrier on the right! Monsters are coming!”

“Gilford! Don’t get too far away!”

“Support! We need support!”

Sion and Hus's bombing only produced effective results for the first few times, and by now they were not able to perform as well as before.

The expedition that was created to face Cuebaerg had formed a relatively flexible formation.

It was mixed up and broken by the fast-approaching abyssal monsters.

Except for the rear, which had kept a distance from the beginning, they were fighting in a chaotic melee.

In such a melee where countless numbers were mixed up, it was impossible to indiscriminately project firepower.

The barrier that Hus had created was also already broken by the enemies several times.

“The Holy Sanctuary Cannon – Auras Saint!”

Perhaps the only consolation was that they had completely blocked the gaze of the evil god who was looking at this place.

The sanctuary created by the Saint of Hunting and the priests weakened the monsters and blocked the eyes of the evil god.

In such a sanctuary, elite troops were moving and slaying the monsters.

Of course, among the isolated paladins, there were also many who fell under the onslaught of the enemies.

Those who were judged to be alive among the wounded were treated by other paladins and moved in the direction where Oren was.

It was a possible means because half of the troops were paladins who could handle holy power.

“Aaaah! Aaah...!”

“Move the wounded soldiers to where I am as much as possible!”

“Sion! We need fire support on the right side of the barrier!”

“I’m already doing it! It’s not as fast as you think!”

“Cough...!”

“Hus! The barrier is about to break! Prepare the next barrier!”

Bang! Bang!

Sion’s arrows fell among the rushing enemies and exploded with a loud noise.

The merit of being able to hit any target against multiple enemies was gone in this situation.

It would be better to put all the front lines in the barrier and hold on, but the mobility of the paladins in front was not free either.

They had to continue this situation until some of the monsters were cleared.

Meanwhile, isolated paladins were gradually exhausted by the attacks of monsters.

Hus sighed as he looked at the situation of the battlefield that had changed into a strange flow.

“There’s no hell like this.”

He knew why the paladins on the front lines were fighting recklessly.

They were trying to prevent monsters from approaching heroes and saints as much as possible.

They were blocking monsters at the expense of their stamina.

But if they kept going like this, they would likely suffer more losses.

They had to find another way to end this battle efficiently.

Some way to drive the monsters into confusion.

“Where are you going, Hus!”

“The barrier has already been renewed.”

“Sion! There are enemies coming from behind!”

“I told you it’s not that fast!”

Hus floated in midair and escaped from outside of barrier.

He looked at ground.

At his fingertips, there was a blue lightning bolt.

Chain Lightning.

Hus didn’t like this magic very much, but it was a fairly efficient attack method in this situation.

Chain Lightning was a magic that had a narrow range compared to other wide-area magic.

It was also one of few wide-area magic that could distinguish friend from foe.

Hus raised his hand and fired magic toward ground.

A single lightning bolt that was attached to Hus’s fingertip connected to ground.

“——Chain Lightning.”

Crackle, crackle, crackle!

The chain of lightning that spread sequentially electrified bodies of monsters on ground.

Monsters hit by Hus's Chain Lightning screamed and burned black.

The lightning that knocked down enemies spread to another target, forming a huge chain of lightning.

Crackle! Crack!

Hus moved his finger flexibly toward direction where he needed to hit, using Chain Lightning skillfully.

The number of monsters reduced faster than before by Hus's magic.

-Gwoooooh!

-Kieeek!

The paladins who were fighting in front heard screams of monsters from behind and looked back at Hus.

They had admiring faces at sight of Hus clearing monsters.

Among paladins who looked at Hus, there was also Oren, leader of expedition.

Oren seemed relieved by sight of Hus hitting monsters without harming allies.

He swung his holy sword and cleared monsters, shouting in a loud voice to Hus.

"Hus! I ask you for a little more!"

"..."

But Hus shook his head at Oren's words.

He couldn't keep this method until end, it would only increase consumption.

He had to find a more efficient way to end this battle.

His eyes turned to a bunch of monsters in middle of front line.

There, several monsters were gathering their bodies to protect something.

As if they were trying to protect something precious to them.

“...Did they call it a lord?”

If they had such monsters, there must also be an entity that commanded them.

That would be the one that could be called Cuebaerg's main body.

Hus's finger pointed toward direction where monsters were clustered.

Hus's finger, pointing at them, turned blue.

His eyes, aimed at the direction where the enemies were, emitted a fierce killing intent.

Hus unleashed a lightning magic at the monsters that were clustered together.

“——Lightning Spear.”

Kwaaaaang!

A spear of lightning pierced through the center of the monsters.

The monsters that were hit by Hus's attack twitched and fell to the ground.

Among the fallen monsters, a small white figure was visible.

As Hus had expected, the monsters that Kuverg had spat out were guarding something.

The other monsters around them started to climb up to fill the gap left by the ones that were struck by lightning.

It was a clear sight of them trying to protect something precious.

“That one must be it.”

The command unit that directed the countless monsters.

There was no doubt that the white monster was its identity.

If Hus’s guess was right, then by taking out that monster, the other monsters around it would lose control and become a rabble.

There was no need to deal with the monsters that rushed in recklessly, risking their lives.

Hus, who had finally found the enemy’s commander, prepared his magic once again.

This time, he was going to pour out his magic and finish off Kuverg’s main body.

Crackle.

With a spark, Hus generated lightning and was about to use his magic.

“——Lightning Spear.”

“——Astraphe.”

Shuuuuuung— Kwaaang!

A black streak from the sky cut through Hus’s Lightning Spear.

Hus’s pupils shook for a moment at the sight of the lightning that cut his magic.

It was a pattern that he had never seen from the enemies before.

Moreover, it was not blocking his lightning magic, but cutting it. It was something that Hus could not understand at all.

The anomaly that Hus and the expedition team faced was not only that.

While he was astonished by his magic being cut by something, he heard another voice of a knight from around him.

“What is this…….”

“Look, look at the sky!”

Hus lifted his head and looked up at the sky, following the voice of the knight that pierced his ears.

Under his gaze, far below the sky.

He saw the sun starting to turn black.

Everyone who saw the blackening sun let out a deep sigh.

“Ha, the sky…….”

“The sun is suddenly turning black!”

“Evil god……! It’s an evil god! The evil god is making the black sun rise!”

Black sun.

An impossible disaster that only an evil god could cause.

Under the deep darkness, the sun loses its light, and those who walk on the ground become blind beggars.

They have to rely on a small light made by humans and wait for the curse of the evil god to be lifted.

The meaning of the black sun that suddenly rose in the sky was clear.

The evil god had started to move against them.

And it was to warn them who had tried to hunt down his minions.

“Ah…….”

A deep sigh came out of Hus’s mouth as he looked at the sky.

What kind of magic did he use to create such a result?

He couldn’t even guess how long he had to walk on the path of magic to reach such a level.

That was not a magic that could be reproduced by a mere human body.

The only thing possible for those on the ground was to light a small fire and be satisfied with seeing an inch ahead of them.

In no time, lights powered by holy power began to rise around him in the darkened sky.

“Don’t panic! The sanctuary proclamation of Her Holiness is still working normally!”

“Hus! Please secure our vision with magic!”

“Everyone! Be alert for incoming monsters!”

“Aaah! He, help me! I’m being attacked by enemies! Cough……!”

Confused voices echoed from all directions.

Oren tried to maintain his command in the darkness, and Hus attempted to restore his vision with light magic.

There were also knights who disappeared somewhere by monsters in the darkness that settled around them.

The black sun amplified the power of monsters abnormally.

It might not have a dramatic effect on high-level monsters, but it was a different story for these ones that came from all sides.

As time passed, the monsters' offensive would become stronger and stronger.

They needed to clear this chaos as quickly as possible.

“We need backup! The monsters have become stronger than before!”

“We can't provide long-range support because we can't secure our vision properly!”

“This situation will continue and we'll all be in trouble……!”

Hus frowned in the faint light and prepared his magic again.

The longer this went on, the more damage would be done to the expedition team.

To minimize the damage, he had to take out Kuverg's main body as quickly as possible.

Hus pointed his finger at the place where Kuverg's main body was.

And right after that.

A black lightning bolt fell on the spot where Hus was pointing.

“…….”

Light that embraced darkness.

It was an absurd sight.

How could black lightning exist?

Yet Hus had to face the corrupted light that fell in front of his eyes.

Kwang! Kwarrang!

Black lightning fell under the black sun.

The black light that fell in the pitch-black world was a very bizarre sight.

A human voice echoed from the rain of lightning that poured down irregularly.

“——Revere. Worship. Obey.”

A solemn and serious man’s voice.

A familiar man’s voice that he didn’t know where he had heard from was ringing in the sky.

Kwang! Kwaaang!

As soon as I heard his voice, a black lightning bolt fell from the sky.

A black lightning that looked unnatural and monstrous.

Only the hand of a god tainted by evil could create such a miracle.
Underneath it, Hus looked up at the sky.

“This voice...”

In the sky that Hus looked up at, a huge thundercloud was visible.

The thundercloud that swallowed the black lightning was slowly expanding its size.

Like the cries of the monsters spreading in all directions, the thundercloud hanging in the sky also gradually extended its territory.

When the thundercloud that was growing bigger and bigger reached its saturation point,

The pitch-black cloud spat out the lightning that had been condensed inside it towards the ground.

Kwaaaaaaang!

With a thunderous roar that shook the heavens and the earth, a black pillar of light struck the ground.

The paladins who were watching him were deafened by the roar of the lightning and covered their ears.

Hus's eyes stared at the center of the lightning that struck violently.

There was a huge sphere made of black lightning where the lightning struck.

“——The great one is watching you.”

Crackle. Crackle.

Black lightning splashed around and a man wearing a gauntlet emerged from inside it.

On the man's back, there were wings of black lightning that were dyed in pitch-black.

Everyone gasped in horror at the sight of the half-wing fluttering behind the man.

A sinister look leaked from the eyes of the man who was wrapped in lightning.

There was no one among those standing here who could not guess what the man's identity was.

“.....He's an apostle. Prepare for battle.”

“He's an apostle! An apostle has appeared! Everyone, prepare for battle!”

Except for Hus, who was floating in the air and looking at the scene.

Hus Allemier stared at the man who revealed himself with blank eyes.

The person standing there was very familiar to Hus.

A voice without strength burst out of Hus's mouth as he looked at Evan Allemier.

“.....Brother?”

The Apostle of Black Lightning.

And the Hero of Knowledge.

The eyes of the two people who were separated by fate met each other in the air.

Chapter 102: Bone, Flesh and Blood (5)

Chapter 102: Bone and Flesh , Blood (5)

Hus doubted the sight before his eyes.

Right in front of him, where the paladins were aiming their weapons at an apostle-level enemy, there was a familiar face.

Evan Allemier.

The eldest son of the Allemier family and his brother who always led Hus Allemier.

His blood relative who loved his family more than anyone and was loyal to the family.

He was standing there, wrapped in black lightning.

It was an incomprehensible sight.

It was also a sight that he should not understand.

The Evan Allemier in his memory was always a paladin who boasted of his devout faith.

That's why Hus tried to deny the reality that he was facing.

“What? You’re saying that person is my brother?”

“...”

Hus's voice echoed under the barrier he had created.

But Hus completely ignored Sion's voice and stared at Evan, who was looking at him from afar.

Evan's eyes, which were immersed in thick bloodlust, also showed signs of confusion for now.

Evan looked at Hus with a stiff face, spreading lightning around him, and then regained his composure and approached the main body of Cuebaerg.

He was trying to retrieve Cuebaerg, who was protected by the monsters.

The paladins raised their swords at Evan's appearance, and Oren, the leader of the expedition, tried to attack Evan with the power of the holy sword.

“Stop! Everyone stop.”

“Hus? What are you talking about?”

Oren stopped his swinging sword with a puzzled look at Hus's voice.

Thud. Thud.

Meanwhile, Evan did not stop moving.

He moved forward and scattered lightning around him.

The black lightning spread out in all directions, threatening the paladins who were nearby.

Crackle— Crackle!

The paladins quickly retreated back, raising their holy power at the sight of the approaching lightning.

In an instant, the front line that had been restraining Evan retreated back.

“That man is my family. So... let me talk to him.”

“Family? You mean that man is the missing heretic interrogator?”

“...Yes. He’s the person I’ve been looking for.”

“It’s clear that he has become an apostle of the evil god by his current state. There is no way to have a normal conversation with a fallen heretic.”

Fallen.

Hus’s heart sank at that word.

He knew what Oren was talking about.

They were in a situation where they were fighting against the evil god’s minions, so it was natural to judge Evan that way.

But Hus thought there was a misunderstanding.

Evan was a believer who had a pure faith before he was a paladin.

Everyone around him, including his family, acknowledged Evan’s faith.

So Hus thought that the current judgment of Evan was a mistake by the paladins.

Hus denied Oren’s words and tried to move forward.

“There must be something wrong.”

“Hus! It’s dangerous!”

“Brother... there’s no way he would fall for something like an evil god.”

“Hus! He’s an apostle of the evil god! If you approach him unarmed——!”

The distance between Evan and Hus narrowed gradually.

Evan’s eyes looked at him as he approached.

His face, which he saw up close, looked much rougher than before.

He must have gone through many hardships while he was out of sight.

Hus, who judged that way, opened his mouth to Evan, who had picked up Cuebaerg's main body.

"Brother! I thought you were dead because you didn't contact me!"

"...Hus."

"But why are you here?"

Evan's eyes looked at Hus for a moment.

His eyes were soaked with joy.

They were his brother's eyes that always welcomed him.

But Evan soon lowered his gaze from him and looked at the white monster in his hand.

Hus's face darkened at Evan's attitude.

Evan lowered his gaze and asked him without looking at him.

"Hus. What are you now?"

"Huh? Brother, what kind of question is that..."

"I asked you what qualifications you have to stand here."

Hus's eyes naturally went to his clothes.

He was wearing clothes with the mark of the temple, and he was in a situation where he was carrying out an operation with the expedition team.

Hus realized then what Evan meant by his question.

Evan doesn't know that Hus has become a hero of knowledge now.

Hus flicked his clothes and told Evan his identity with a confident voice.

He wanted to brag to Evan that he had become a hero chosen by the goddess.

He said:

“Brother, I have become a hero of knowledge.”

“...You have become a hero of knowledge?”

“Yes. I was chosen by the goddess of knowledge, and I have this mark of a hero...”

Hus looked at Evan with a face full of expectation.

For the faithful paladins, becoming a hero chosen by the goddess was a great honor.

Evan, who had a pure faith, would also be proud of Hus.

Hus expected a fierce reaction from Evan as he approached him closer.

But what came out of Evan's mouth was the opposite of what he hoped for.

“So you're my enemy.”

The cold answer pierced Hus's ears.

Blink. Blink.

Hus blinked several times, unable to believe the story unfolding before his eyes.

But the scene reflected in Hus's eyes remained unchanged.

Evan Alemier was wearing a gauntlet that gave off a sinister feeling, looking down at Cuebaerg.

The situation he faced was not a dream.

Evan had declared that he had become his enemy, with Hus in front of him.

“Wh-what?”

“I said you’re my enemy from now on.”

“What do you mean... why do we have to be enemies?”

It was an incomprehensible story.

Evan was his blood and a member of his family, as well as a brilliant teacher who always led him.

But Evan had become his enemy.

It was an unacceptable situation for Hus.

If he told this fact to the elders of his family, they would ridicule him and blame him for making up such a story.

Yet Evan’s expression was still serious.

He moved his gauntlet and added to Hus.

“Didn’t you say you’re the hero of knowledge? It’s just a matter of having different roles.”

“Brother, what are you talking about...”

Before Hus could finish his sentence, Evan raised his head.

His emotionless eyes slowly met Hus and the other heroes.

At the same time, cracks appeared on the wings behind Evan.

Crackle. Crackle.

The shockwaves of lightning spread in all directions, and black lightning flickered irregularly in Evan's hand.

Hus felt uneasy and stepped back at the sight of Evan wrapped in dark energy.

Evan, who was looking at the expedition members, opened his mouth in a blunt voice.

“Let me introduce myself to the poor heroes here. I am the second apostle, Evan Alemier.”

“_____.”

“The sword that exists for the sake of the great one.”

As soon as Evan finished introducing himself,

Hus dropped the hieroglyph he was holding in his left hand.

Thud.

The hieroglyph that fell to the ground floated in the air by magic.

Even though the artifact was floating by itself, Hus did not pay attention to it.

He had heard the story he did not want to hear.

“.....”

The second apostle.

Evan's words meant one thing.

The Evan in front of Hus's eyes was no longer a noble paladin who served God.

Evan Alemier had fallen.

And he became the second apostle who served the evil god.

“The second apostle……?”

Hus’s voice trembled as he heard Evan’s words.

He had affirmed with his own mouth what he had to deny with all his might.

He had to accept the cruel reality that faced him.

The brother in front of him was not the Evan he knew.

He was an apostle of God who served the evil god.

And for the hero of knowledge, he was an enemy of humanity who had to be annihilated.

“I see you finally understand what I’m saying.”

Evan, who scattered dark lightning, came forward.

The paladins who were maintaining the front line also approached Hus with tense expressions.

They were wary of each other.

The two factions were incompatible with each other.

The killing intent that vividly touched Hus’s skin proved that fact.

Hus reached out to his eyes covered with a bandage and sighed.

He did not want this kind of ending.

“Brother… no, you…”

Hus's breath became rough as he looked at Evan.

Hus Alemier.

He had worked hard all his life.

There was always a bright light shining in front of Hus.

A light that was intense and warm at the same time.

The one standing in front of him was always a person close to perfection.

Hus had always been compared to Evan, but he tried to become a person worthy of his family name.

To move forward a little more.

To stand shoulder to shoulder with his brother someday.

“That's why... why...”

When he achieved what he aimed for, he wanted to be recognized by others.

He wanted to be acknowledged by the adults who always compared him to Evan.

He wanted to be acknowledged by Evan, who always told him to become a person suitable for his family name.

What he needed was his family's recognition.

That's why he was so happy when he became the hero of knowledge, and he looked forward to Evan's reaction.

He thought that Evan, who always told him to become a person suitable for his family name, would be happy to hear the news.

He must have been happy.

But Evan's reaction was very different from his expectation.

“Why...? Why did you side with the evil god...?”

Hus's eyes, which were bloodshot, stared at Evan.

His breath became faster as he looked at Evan.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

His heart pounded violently, and his blood rushed through his body.

His head was burning with hot blood, and his breath was leaking with anger.

The world he longed for no longer existed.

Everything had collapsed.

Chapter 103: Bone, Flesh and Blood (6)

Chapter 103: Bone, Flesh and Blood (6)

In the darkness, Evan's gaze met his blood relative in front of him.

Hus, whose pupils were shining brightly, looked like a hero from a legend.

His eyes, filled with light, seemed to have regained his sight, and he looked at Evan clearly.

It was another chance for Hus to get back the eye he had lost as a child.

A miracle.

That was the only way to describe the scene.

It was ironic.

He had followed the goddess all his life, but he was abandoned, while Hus, who had parted ways with him, received a once-in-a-lifetime miracle.

Evan's voice, soaked with emotion, flowed from his lips as he faced the light in Hus's eyes.

“So this is how it ends.”

It was useless to deny that he was jealous of the blood chosen by the goddess.

He had stopped envying those who were loved by the goddess.

Now he had to accept the sight before his eyes as it was.

The six goddesses did not choose him.

They chose the weak and pitiful souls standing here.

They would be called heroes, and they would burn themselves for the god until they died.

That was the way of the hero.

All Evan could do was watch them go to their doom.

“...Hus Allemier. This is all your choice... If this is also your fate, you have to accept it.”

Hus, who heard Evan's voice, raised his magic power.

Crackle.

The blue magic that wrapped around Hus's body slowly changed into a shape of lightning.

He was preparing a magic of the lightning system.

Evan understood why Hus wanted to use lightning magic.

Evan wielded the power of lightning.

Hus also wanted to use lightning magic to fight against Evan.

He wanted to knock down Evan with lightning from the front.

That was Hus's plan.

“...Astraphe.”

Evan, who understood Hus's thoughts, raised his hand.

Crack. Crack.

Red lightning sprang from Evan's fingertips.

The light that flowed through the gauntlet became a sharp spear, and Evan held the lightning spear and looked at Hus.

The gauntlet that held the lightning spear kept vibrating violently.

The power of lightning had become stronger than before, and Evan's hand could not fully withstand it.

If he did not shoot the spear as soon as possible, Evan's hand would have to pay a price that matched it.

Evan aimed the spear he was holding at the barrier where the heroes were gathered.

“——Lightning Spear.”

Hus, who had gathered both hands in one place, also held a bolt of lightning between his palms.

The bolt of lightning that shook in his palm changed into a shape of a long spear.

Hus aimed the tip of the spear he had made at Evan.

Black lightning and blue lightning.

The lightning spears with killing intent aimed at each other.

Good and evil. Light and darkness. And power and magic.

All of that was about to collide in one place.

“Is that your magic?”

“Evan Allemier. You will pay for betraying God’s will and falling into corruption.”

The one who shot the lightning spear first was Hus’s side.

Kwaaaaang!

The blue beam of light that was shot with a shock wave tore through the air and flew out.

The great magic created by the hero was aiming at Evan.

Evan, who saw Hus’s magic flying towards him, also threw the spear he was aiming at with all his strength.

The black lightning that was amplified by magic dyed the sky and moved forward.

The black trail that spread like an afterimage collided with the blue lightning that flew ahead in midair.

“...!”

And then, a huge explosion occurred in midair.

Crack! Crackle!

Black and blue lightning splashed in all directions, and the aftermath of the collision spread out.

The two lightning that met in midair twisted and struggled with each other.

Underneath the spreading wave, everyone held their breath and watched the collision of lightning.

For a moment, they forgot that the sun had disappeared behind a dazzling spectacle.

“This is...the apostle of evil...!”

“Hus! Hurry up and prepare defensive magic...!”

Someone who looked at the two colliding lightning exclaimed in awe.

Another one sensed the outcome and shouted out loud with the hero’s name.

Hus, who was watching his own magic, also looked no different from them.

His eyes, flickering with light, were gauging the progress of the collision.

He chose to hold a hieroglyph and raise one hand in the air as he watched his magic.

Blue magic surged again from Hus’s hand that was raised towards the sky.

“How can this be...?”

Hus, who was preparing his next magic, frowned.

At the same time, the black lightning devoured the blue flash.

The two lightning that moved to swallow each other ended their fight.

The lightning spear that swallowed and enlarged the black lightning flew at a faster speed towards Hus.

The lightning spear that had accelerated more than before collided with Hus, who was floating in the air.

Kwaaaaang——!

Hus’s body, which collided with Evan’s lightning, flew for ten meters and slammed into the ground.

Oren, who was watching Hus fly after being hit by the lightning spear, let out a loud scream from his mouth.

“Lord Hus! Wake up!”

“Hus...!”

“Someone nearby has to protect Lord Hus!”

“Everyone! Prepare for the enemy’s attack!”

I watched as Oren, who had given orders to the paladins in the front line, swung his sword that was filled with light.

The blue sword emitted a light of purification and moved to cut down Evan.

The divine power, like a ray of light, drew a blue trail and rushed towards Evan.

It was an attack that would be hard to react to for ordinary people.

But Evan was different.

His body, wrapped in black lightning, turned into light and instantly left his place.

“——Astraphe.”

“Did he dodge the attack...?”

Swoosh! Boom!

A few trees near Evan were cut down and fell to the ground.

Evan, who had turned into lightning, appeared far away from there.

He returned with lightning spreading around him and looked at Oren, who was holding the sword.

Only the chosen paladins could receive the holy sword from the Holy King.

The blue sword that Oren held was one of the few holy swords that Crossbridge possessed.

Evan, who had turned into lightning, easily avoided Oren's sword, and Oren swung his sword in the air again.

“Let's see how long you can run away!”

Swoosh! Bang! Kwang!

The trees nearby fell in a row as Oren swung his sword repeatedly.

But Evan easily dodged Oren's sword again and again.

He avoided Oren's attacks by drawing chaotic trails of black light around him.

Oren bit his lip as he saw Evan dodge his attacks without any injury.

Evan was wary of Oren as he watched over Cuebaerg, who was in his hand.

“Captain! I'll shoot, so duck!”

“Sion...?”

The next one to attack was Sion, the hero of hunting.

Swoosh——!

Evan took out his wings of lightning as he saw the arrow coming with a shock wave.

He flew up to deflect Sion's arrow.

He spread his wings and moved his body of lightning to soar into the air.

He tried to dodge Sion's arrow as he floated in the air, but he frowned as he looked down.

“...Can't I shake it off?”

The arrow that flew straight towards Evan suddenly bent vertically.

And the arrow kept changing its direction according to Evan's movement.

It was an arrow that chased its target until it hit it.

It was meaningless to dodge such an attack.

He frowned and raised his gauntlet.

If he couldn't avoid it, he had to block it.

“——Astraphe.”

Kwang!

The arrow that was hit by the lightning that fell from the sky exploded in midair.

Evan, who had destroyed the arrow with lightning, looked at Sion on the ground.

He guessed that Evan would block the arrow, and Sion aimed his next arrow at him.

Oren also waited for Evan to come within his range.

It was always a headache to face many opponents alone.

Especially if they were heroes.

But Evan's role was to buy time until Uto arrived after retrieving Cuebaerg.

He had already achieved his goal, and there was no reason to stay here any longer.

-“Can you hear me?”

As he prepared to bomb the heroes with Astraphe, Evan heard a familiar female voice in his ear when he raised his magic power.

Eutenia Hyrost. The first apostle of the master he served was calling him.

She seemed to be trying to communicate with him using some kind of magic.

He opened his mouth and looked up at the sky as he heard Eutenia's voice coming towards him.

“Eutenia. I'm listening.”

-“If you keep fighting recklessly, Cuebaerg might get hurt.”

“That's true.”

Cuebaerg, who had shrunk into a small body, was trembling in Evan's hand.

He looked nothing like the lord of the abyss that he used to be called.

Cuebaerg might get injured or die if he kept fighting.

And Eutenia's contact meant that Uto, who was carrying her, was not far from here.

Evan's mission was to arrive at the scene first, retrieve Cuebaerg, and buy time for Uto to come.

He had already achieved his purpose, and there was no reason to stay here any longer.

-“We're almost there, so you can get ready to come back.”

“What about the pursuers?”

-“He will release a suitable opponent for them.”

“Then I don't have to worry. I'll be right back.”

Evan finished talking with Eutenia and looked at Hus on the ground.

Hus, who had bounced back after being hit by Evan's attack, quickly recovered and returned to the front line.

It was very regrettable for Evan to leave Hus alone like this.

But he couldn't settle things with Hus without any plan with so many heroes in between them.

Unfortunately, he had to postpone the confrontation with his blood relative.

As Evan prepared to retreat, Hus glared at him.

Hus, who was bleeding and glaring at Evan, spoke to him with a voice full of hatred.

"Where are you running away? We still have things to talk about."

Hus sensed that Evan was going to flee and started preparing another magic.

Evan shook his head with a blank face as he saw Hus preparing his magic.

He regretted it too, but now was not the time.

He couldn't risk Cuebaerg's life for his petty feelings.

He lowered his head and said goodbye to Hus.

"It's not time yet. Maybe someday we'll have a chance to settle this."

"Shut up with your nonsense! Do you think we'll let you go easily?"

"I hope you'll grow more than now when I see you next time."

As soon as Evan finished speaking, a huge shadow rose from the ground.

The dark beast Alpha.

The shadow beast that Eutenia controlled came to take Evan away.

Evan looked at his brother beyond the rising shadow.

Unlike before, there was a monster above Hus's head, wrapped in flames.

It was undoubtedly the 'suitable opponent' that his master had released as a bait to save Cuebaerg.

He smiled bitterly as he faced his brother for the first time in a long time and muttered to himself.

“Goodbye, Hus.”

Chapter 104: Uninvited Guest (1)

Chapter 104: Uninvited Guest (1)

“I was so scared, I thought I was going to die.”

I leaned back on the bed and looked at the screen of the smartphone that I had placed on the table.

On top of Yuto, who had the Yggdrasil plugged in, the apostles were gathered together.

The urgent rescue operation for Cuebaerg was successfully completed.

Evan, who I had sent to buy some time, arrived at the scene first and rescued Cuebaerg. Then, Utenia safely brought Evan back.

In the process, the <Random Creature Summon Ticket (Low)> that I had acquired this time also contributed a lot.

I summoned a creature to hold back the enemies while bringing Evan back.

“I would have slept well tonight if any of them had died.”

The main characters of the cult, including Evan, were the ones who grew up on my blood-like money, time, and affection.

If any of them had died, I would have tossed and turned all night.

It was a great relief that no one died while carrying out this operation.

It would have been a way to fight and clear the boss, but it would have been a loss if I had lost even one character in the process.

There was no need to rush to attack the boss in an unprepared state.

It was fine to attack the boss after having enough equipment and supplies.

I wasn't trying to see the game's ending right now anyway.

“But I still need to find a solution for that sight-blocking ability.”

Especially, the sight-blocking ability that nullified <The Eye of Observation> itself had to be dealt with somehow.

The skills I used were not the kind of skills that identified Pia.

So it was almost impossible to spam skills in a state where my sight was blocked.

Ordinary characters might not abuse sight-blocking, but I needed to find a breakthrough if I wanted to challenge the boss.

Otherwise, I had to make sure that the characters could endure until the duration of that pattern ended.

Attacking the boss was something that had to be done carefully.

“By the way... What do I do with him now?”

As I was thinking about the boss that would come out later, I stared at Cuebaerg on the screen.

He used to be a big and hideous monster, but now he looked different from before.

He had turned into a round and white rice cake-like shape.

His large single eye was not visible anymore, and even the occasional tentacle that came out of his body looked much shorter than before.

It looked more like a short horn than a tentacle.

He was so cute that Perin, who was holding Cuebaerg, said so.

-“Cuebaerg, I thought you were a terrifying monster... But you look cuter than I thought.”

Looking at him now, I couldn't imagine him as the monster that rampaged through the forest.

Pluto also nodded his head with Deathside on Yggdrasil, maybe because he hadn't seen his original appearance either.

But Evan knew about Cuebaerg's existence from the beginning, maybe because of that.

He told Perin, who was holding Cuebaerg, about Cuebaerg's truth.

-“He didn't look like this before.”

-“Really? But he's cute now.”

-“Huk huk.”

-“...But Yuto is cuter!”

-“Huk.”

Yuto expressed his displeasure at Perin's compliment for Cuebaerg.

And Perin reacted to Yuto's words that he understood.

As they continued to chat with each other while making huk huk sounds, I couldn't help but sigh at their banter.

I covered my eyes with one hand and muttered.

“Really, you guys...”

What would they have done if they hadn't met each other?

They were a match made in heaven.

I swept my face with my hand that covered my eyes and looked at the screen. My eyes went to the skill icon at the bottom of the screen.

There was one skill there that I faced without a cooldown timer for a long time.

<Regular Meeting: Summon>.

It was a skill that I hadn't paid attention to for a while after using it last time.

"I guess <Regular Meeting> cooldown must have been over by now."

The last time I used <Regular Meeting> was right after I selected Pluto as an apostle.

A lot of time had passed since then.

I wondered if it was okay to hold <Regular Meeting> again now.

Moreover, I had plenty of bread to put in the <Regular Meeting> in my inventory.

My inventory was full of bread from the gacha that I had unknowingly done last night.

As I recalled the memory of the gacha, I suddenly felt my face burning and a pang in my back.

"Ah, my two million won... Sigh."

Looking at the contents of my inventory, it didn't seem like the gacha results were good.

The meaningful items were only half of the gacha attempts at best.

Besides, the <Random Creature Summon Ticket (Low)> was clearly an inferior version of <Creature Maker>.

The gacha that I had done while sleeping had gone horribly wrong.

I sighed with disappointment and opened my inventory full of bread.

“It’s good to have a lot of bread for the meeting...”

I could arrange the bread as I pleased in the <Regular Meeting> where several characters were summoned at the same time.

The bread that I had placed in the meeting room could also be eaten by the characters there.

In the last meeting, Utenia and Estasia had taken care of all the bread.

But this time, they wouldn’t be able to eat all the bread even if they wanted to.

That was because my inventory was stacked with more bread than they could handle.

-<Regular Meeting> has been reserved.

-Do you want to decorate the <Regular Meeting> place?

-Yes / No

There was no need to think long after making a decision.

Tuk.

I manipulated the screen of my smartphone and reserved the start time for the regular meeting.

The only thing left to do was to fill up the meeting room with items from my inventory.

I had two million won worth of items left, and I might go crazy if I didn't do something like this.

So I arranged the items that I had piled up in my inventory in the meeting room as I pleased.

“...”

Of course, it took a lot of time to decorate the meeting room with the enriched inventory unlike before.

A very long time, that is.

My hand that was decorating the meeting room with grotesque items from my inventory stopped only just before the <Regular Meeting> started.

-Daniel Heslop.

The butcher who was called 'The Silent Slayer' by the world stared blankly at what was in front of him with dull eyes.

He had put on a ring with a gemstone on it for quite some time now.

He had tried to remove the ring while staying at the farm, but no matter what he tried, it was impossible to get rid of the Evil God's ring.

He realized that it was impossible to escape from the Evil God's ring and chose to pray.

He prayed to the Evil God in heaven with fear and trembling.

Even now, he was praying every night for the Evil God to spare his life.

“That's about it for our stories. Let's move on to the important matters.”

But Daniel's fervent prayer seemed to have no effect at all.

He ended up being dragged into the cult's meeting anyway.

And this time, there was one new face added to the meeting.

The fourth apostle, Perin Stait.

She was a fairy who had a naive face that didn't suit the name of an apostle of evil god.

He couldn't understand how such a fairy became an apostle of evil god.

“Are we going to talk about something important now!”

“Yes. If you have any questions about something you don't know, feel free to ask in between.”

“Okay!”

Perin's personality was also similar to her bright voice.

She seemed to have nothing to do with dreadful war plans or subjugation operations.

She looked like an angel by appearance alone, but Estasia's problem was her inner self that she hid inside.

She had been dozing off in the last meeting.

She even snatched away the bread that Daniel was trying to eat. Thinking about it, Estasia's inner self was not an angel but a devil itself.

Daniel suppressed a sigh that was about to burst out and stroked his beard as he pondered. Then, Loan, who was facing him, started talking about this agenda item.

“Cuebaerg has been defeated by a subjugation force sent from the holy land.”

“Cuebaerg has been defeated...?”

Daniel exclaimed in surprise as he heard Loan's words.

He was shocked by the news that Cuebaerg had been defeated.

Daniel knew well about Cuebaerg's infamy from hearing about it often.

He also knew that Cloud's subjugation force had been annihilated by Cuebaerg.

Cuebaerg was a monstrous beast that had ravaged one of the empire's provinces.

It was natural for Daniel to be astonished by the news that such a beast had been subdued.

Seeing Daniel's bewildered reaction to the news, Evan nodded his head from beside him.

I saw it with my own eyes. They managed to save the body, but it seemed like it had lost its former glory.

"It was a hunting party with three heroes, so it was inevitable that Cuebaerg would suffer."

"Three heroes...!"

Daniel was shocked again by the news of three heroes participating.

What kind of beings were heroes?

They were the ones who were chosen by the gods and ruled over the peak of humanity with their power.

And three of them joined the hunt.

Cuebaerg's existence must have been much more threatening than Daniel thought.

As the meeting progressed, Daniel was surprised by the shocking stories that came out.

While he was watching the meeting and nibbling on a bread, Estasia opened her mouth.

“Cuebaerg is the weakest among us... This shouldn’t happen again.”

“...”

The meeting room was silent for a moment at Estasia’s voice.

In the silence, Evan’s serious gaze turned to Estasia.

The topic of hierarchy within the order was sensitive for everyone.

His eyes asked what she meant by her remark.

The other participants were not much different.

They all looked at Estasia in silence, and she opened her mouth again.

“He is the weakest...”

“Well... Maybe he is right now.”

“What about Archbishop Roan...?”

“Archbishop Roan has the miracle of the great one following him, and he also has a guardian that he bestowed upon him.”

Nod.

Roan nodded his head as he listened to their conversation.

He looked satisfied with their talk.

Roan looked around the participants and brought up a topic.

“That might be true. You are all amazing people who are attending this meeting.”

“It’s a meeting where only the elites of the order gather.”

“Maybe that’s why Cuebaerg wasn’t invited. Maybe he wasn’t good enough to attend the meeting.”

Was Roan’s story convincing?

Except for Perin, who was new to the meeting, most of them seemed to agree.

But Daniel, who was listening to Roan’s story, felt like dying from embarrassment rather than denying it.

It was obvious that he was stronger than Cuebaerg.

Then what was he?

He wasn’t even close to being stronger than Cuebaerg, he would be sent to hell with one hit if he met him.

The atmosphere here, where they affirmed their own strength, did not suit Daniel at all.

“Don’t you think so, Daniel?”

“...”

As Daniel felt embarrassed by Roan’s story, Roan’s gaze turned to him.

He asked if Daniel didn’t think so either.

Daniel felt a chill on his back as he received Roan’s question.

Roan’s eyes demanded him to affirm quickly.

Daniel felt suffocated as he received the question.

It was a meeting where only the big shots of the continent gathered.

It was obvious what kind of treatment he would receive if he denied his own strength.

As Daniel struggled to think with his head spinning, Roan urged him again with another question.

“Daniel?”

“Of course.”

“I knew you would say that.”

Roan nodded his head as if he understood, as Daniel reluctantly agreed to his question.

As if it was obvious.

Daniel smiled stiffly and gave Roan a light response.

Cold sweat ran down his forehead.

Chapter 105: Uninvited Guests (2)

Chapter 105: Uninvited Guests (2)

The meeting of the cult continued with Daniel in front of them, nervous that his lies would be exposed.

The cult still had many important issues to discuss.

One of them was the mission that the first and second apostles had been sent to perform.

Daniel had only learned of their deployment at this meeting, but he kept his mouth shut as if he knew it all along.

Perin, who had just joined the meeting, was also quietly listening.

Roan, who was leading the meeting, asked Eutenia a series of questions.

“Apostle. Did you succeed in securing the alchemist you were aiming for?”

“I did manage to bring him back alive. But he doesn’t seem to last long by the looks of it.”

“So you did succeed in securing him. Is his life in danger by any chance?”

“I think it might be risky in the worst case scenario. But even if he dies, it won’t be a big problem.”

Eutenia’s gaze shifted to Arcrosis, who was in a corner of the meeting room.

King of the Undead Arcrosis.

He was a legendary demon who could command hundreds of thousands of undead.

Eutenia looked at him and asked.

“Isn’t it possible to revive him even if he dies with the power of the King of the Undead?”

Eutenia wanted to revive the alchemist as an undead through Arcrosis’ power if he died.

Daniel thought it was a devilish idea.

How could anyone think of such a thing?

But for Arcrosis, who was questioned by Eutenia, it didn’t seem to matter much.

Arcrosis nodded at Eutenia.

He raised his finger, which was nothing but bones, and spoke to Eutenia.

-“It’s not hard to make him a lich as long as he has a minimum of form left.”

“What if he becomes a lich? Will he lose his memory or something?”

-“It won’t be a problem unless he’s severely damaged.”

“That’s good. We won’t have to look for another target if something unpleasant happens.”

Eutenia looked satisfied with Arcrosis’ answer.

This meant that they had a plan to revive the alchemist through Arcrosis if he died.

It was indeed a cult-like behavior that served an evil god.

Daniel shivered slightly at the sight of the cult's conversation and nodded his head.

The discussion about Eutenia's mission continued for a few more words.

"I'll proceed with the philosopher's stone once the alchemist regains consciousness."

"Is that so?"

"And Perin agreed to take responsibility for moving from the island to the cult. It might take a little longer if we need anything else."

"I understand. I trust you with this mission, Apostle."

"Eventually, everything will go according to His will."

That was the end of Eutenia's story.

Eutenia finished her conversation with Roan and reached for a bread in the basket.

Daniel's eyes also turned to the basket with bread.

For some reason, he felt like there were more breads in the basket than last time.

It must have been Daniel's illusion.

Sometimes it happens.

When people are tense, even the surrounding objects can appear distorted.

The number of breads that Daniel remembered might have been distorted because he was so nervous last time.

"Next... Estasia. I heard you have something important to say."

Roan moved on to the next topic and looked at Estasia this time.

After Eutenia, it was Estasia's turn, who had changed the atmosphere of the meeting room strangely.

Estasia looked around at the other participants with a dark complexion.

Her expression was ominous to anyone who saw it.

Daniel swallowed his saliva at the sight of Estasia.

She seemed to be about to bring up something serious.

As if to prove it, Estasia brought up an important issue to everyone around her.

“Another angel came down from heaven.”

“Another angel came down? Is it His doing?”

“...No. It seems like he came down with an order from heaven.”

Everyone around Estasia looked troubled by her words.

Daniel also had his own worries after hearing her words.

The Estasia in front of him was an evil angel sent by an evil god.

If what Estasia said was true, then this time a proper angel came down from heaven.

He thought that what was supposed to come had finally arrived and nodded his head as if that was so.

Then Roan spoke to the attendees with a very serious face.

“One of the six goddesses has sent down her own kin. She must have a plan to wreak havoc on the world with her foolish and ugly angel.”

“Pfft.”

Foolish and ugly angel.

Daniel felt a surge of laughter as he heard that story.

It was a combination of three words that did not match at all.

Even in the midst of fear, he heard a bizarre word that made his lips curl reflexively.

Suddenly faced with the urge to laugh, Daniel put a strong force on his face.

His face, strained from trying not to laugh, turned into a fierce expression in an instant.

“What’s wrong, Daniel?”

“...”

“Don’t tell me...”

Roan narrowed his eyes and looked at him as he saw Daniel’s appearance.

Daniel’s eyes moved quickly as he met Roan’s gaze.

He would be doomed if he laughed here.

He had to come up with a plausible answer somehow.

Under the pressure of his surroundings, Daniel managed to exhale the air in his lungs.

Then, with a dark face, he looked at Roan and gave him a hastily made excuse.

“Just hearing the story... makes me uneasy. How dare they try to go against the will of the great one...”

“That’s very like you, Daniel. I thought you would say something like that.”

“I’m sorry if I disturbed the meeting.”

Fortunately, Roan did not doubt Daniel.

Rather, he seemed impressed by Daniel’s loyalty to the great one.

Phew.

Daniel let out a sigh in his mind and relaxed his fist under the table.

As he was relieved by the crisis that had passed in front of him,

Roan looked at Daniel again.

“By the way, Daniel.”

“...What is it?”

“Can you tell me where your hideout is?”

“Hideout?”

Daniel’s fist tightened again as he heard Roan’s words.

Hideout.

It must have been a request to reveal his whereabouts.

He thought that someday he would have to face such a question, but he did not expect it to be now.

Daniel looked at Roan with a tense face and asked him why.

Roan smiled brightly and told him the intention of his question with a friendly attitude.

“The great one has ordered me to help you. Especially, I need to know for sure where your hideout is.”

As soon as he heard the reason from Roan, Daniel realized one important fact.

He could not escape from this question no matter what he did now.

Cold sweat began to run down Daniel's back as he looked at the meeting room.

“Haa, haa...”

Daniel woke up from his dream with a rough breath in the farm where the sun was shining down.

He got up from the haystack with a butcher knife in his hand.

He was startled by the sight of the butcher knife as soon as he woke up and put it down.

He must have been preparing to ship out the livestock and got dragged into the meeting.

He looked around as he caught his breath and saw the ring on his finger.

The ring he had found last time was still on his finger.

“Ah...”

Daniel frowned as he remembered something as soon as he saw the ring.

It was because of the conversation he had with Roan at the meeting.

In the meeting room, Roan asked Daniel for the address of his hideout.

It was because he had received a trust from the evil god to help him.

It was a trust given by none other than the evil god himself.

The evil god who kept sending back the ring did not know where Daniel was either.

Daniel had no choice but to tell Roan the truth about where his farm was located.

“I’m in big trouble, big trouble.”

Daniel shook his head as he recalled the unpleasant memory.

It was only a matter of time before someone from the cult came here since he had given them his address.

If that happened, they would also find out that he had no great abilities.

The cult would not harm Daniel recklessly since he was chosen by the evil god himself.

But how could he face Roan if they found out that he was not a great assassin?

He felt his chest tighten just thinking about it.

He felt an urge to rip off the ring on his finger right away.

“Is the owner here?”

“...?”

As Daniel was wandering around the barn, worrying, he heard a stranger’s voice from outside.

The voice that came from outside was a thick male one.

Daniel was startled by the voice calling him and looked outside the barn.

Two cloaked figures were entering the farm from the border.

They had swords on their waists as they entered the farm.

They did not look like thieves, but it was still a bad situation.

“Is the owner not here?”

He could not ignore the voice that kept ringing outside.

Daniel had no choice but to go outside as they kept calling him.

Thud. Thud.

The cloaked men came straight to Daniel as he stepped out of the barn.

The men with imposing figures stopped in front of Daniel and looked down at him over their hoods.

“I’m the owner of this farm... Who are you?”

“We don’t need to know that, we just have something to ask you.”

“Yes, yes... Please ask.”

As he answered, Daniel saw something flickering behind the cloak.

He faintly saw a familiar pattern between the cloaks that covered their bodies.

It was the symbol used by the Temple of Abundance that Daniel had found.

Cold sweat ran down Daniel’s forehead as he saw the symbol.

It was obvious who they were, hiding the symbol of the temple.

Heretics Inquisitors.

That was who they were, standing in front of Daniel right now.

“We’re chasing a suspicious person around here.”

“Yes.”

Daniel's alertness rose to the highest level as he recognized their identity.

The Heretics Inquisitors were those who executed the followers of the evil god and black magicians.

And Daniel had received a ring from the evil god and was summoned to a meeting.

If they found out about that, they would execute him on the spot.

Daniel continued to answer while watching their moves.

They also scrutinized Daniel's appearance in detail.

"Have you seen anyone with suspicious behavior or appearance lately?"

"Behavior or appearance... No, I don't know."

"You don't seem to know. Well, if you're busy with farm work, that might be possible."

Thud. Thud.

The Heretics Inquisitor who heard the answer came closer to Daniel by a few steps.

Then he grabbed Daniel's shoulder with his gloved hand.

He looked into Daniel's eyes as he held his shoulder and asked another question.

Not about a suspicious person, but about Daniel himself.

"You've been running this farm for quite a long time, haven't you?"

"Yes, yes..."

"Then why are you sweating so much?"

“I’m not feeling well today, so I keep sweating...”

“Oh, I see. You’re not feeling well. You should take it easy with your farm work.”

Daniel used his health problem as an excuse for the Heretics Inquisitor’s question.

He was not at an age where his body was strong.

The Heretics Inquisitor nodded his head reluctantly, even though he looked doubtful of Daniel’s story.

It was difficult to keep holding someone who said he was not feeling well.

He let go of his shoulder and stepped back.

Then he stroked his beard and warned Daniel as if to say something.

“We’re going to be around here for a while.”

“For a while... You must have something important to do.”

“That’s right. So you should know what to do if you see any suspicious people...”

“Of course. I’ll let you know right away if I find any.”

Daniel nodded reflexively at the Heretics Inquisitor’s words of warning.

That was the end of their questioning.

They turned their bodies and headed for the border of the farm as soon as they finished talking.

Just like when they came in, heavy footsteps echoed.

The Heretics Inquisitor who had talked to Daniel turned his head and added one more thing before leaving the farm.

“By the way, that’s a nice ring. Other people must be jealous of you.”

He said his last goodbye and left the farm.

Until the Heretics Inquisitors who had visited the farm disappeared from his sight, Daniel felt a chill that covered his whole body.

Chapter 106: Uninvited Guests (3)

Chapter 106: Uninvited Guests (3)

After the meeting was over.

I finished my meal and shower, and sat down in front of my smartphone with a devout mind.

I had safely rescued Cuebaerg and finished the meeting, so now it was time to check the items in my inventory.

Tap.

When I touched the screen to activate the inventory, I saw a lot of items filling up the inventory.

The by-products of the 210 draws that started with deep sleep and proceeded without even checking the results.

Now I could finally see those by-products properly.

“First, the magic books... <Ice Arrow>...”

I started to check the magic books in the inventory one by one.

The first thing that caught my eye was [Magic Book: Ice Arrow], which I obtained through 10 draws.

<Ice Arrow> was a magic that inflicted frost damage, as the name suggested.

There were several magic books in the inventory, including [Magic Book: Ice Arrow].

The magic books that Eutenia obtained by raiding the magic tower also came into the inventory through communion.

“<Enchant: Fire>... <Enchant: Lightning>...? They are all enchantment-type magic.”

The magic books that Eutenia sent me were <Enchant: Fire> and <Enchant: Lightning>.

They were magic that temporarily added fire and lightning to weapons.

Weapons with enchantment could inflict additional damage proportional to each attribute.

Enchantment itself was a skill that was awkward for me to use, but it was a useful magic for the cult's believers.

If I put them in the <Divine Response Device>, many believers would use them.

I didn't hesitate to use the magic books and learn the magic.

-You have learned <Enchant: Fire (Lv.MAX)>.

-You have learned <Enchant: Lightning (Lv.MAX)>.

As the magic books disappeared from the inventory, a message appeared to inform me of the skill acquisition.

<Ice Arrow> was a magic that Eutenia had not yet acquired.

It would be better to use this magic book after Eutenia finished her learning.

After I dealt with the magic books that I received from Eutenia, I looked at the magic swords that were sleeping in the inventory.

There were seven magic swords in the inventory.

“As for the magic swords... one was a sword that handled fire, and another one was what I drew last time...”

One of the seven magic swords was a product that I had been waiting to give to Daniel.

It was a magic sword that had an effect of returning to the location where the trait was activated after 10 seconds.

And another one was [Magic Sword: Aterinus], which I checked as soon as I woke up from sleep.

[Magic Sword: Aterinus] was a magic sword that converted mana into fire attribute.

Now it was time to check out the other magic swords besides those two.

I started to look at each of the magic swords located in the inventory by touching them.

-[Magic Sword: Asilore]

-During <Ice Field>, targets within range have their movement speed and attack speed reduced.

-The ice storm of <Ice Field> continuously inflicts damage on targets within range.

The first one I checked, [Magic Sword: Asilore], was a magic sword that inflicted frost damage.

It also had an effect of applying area debuffs to nearby enemies.

It looked like a equipment that was more suitable for auxiliary purposes than for main use.

It was a magic sword that I had to think about where to use it.

-[Magic Sword: Egernot]

-During <Muah's Time>, user's dynamic vision is enhanced.

-During <Muah's Time>, user's thinking speed becomes faster.

-During <Muah's Time>, [Magic Sword: Egernot] becomes sharper.

[Magic Sword: Egernot] was a weapon that felt like it enhanced user itself.

It gave bonuses to abilities that were not intuitive, such as dynamic vision and thinking speed.

Especially, the last effect was an effect that had no meaning unless you wore this item.

To use [Magic Sword: Egernot], you had to adopt this item as your main weapon without fail.

-[Magic Sword: Refrost]

-During <Perpetual Machine>, lightning strikes periodically occur.

-During <Perpetual Machine>, user's all actions receive speed correction.

-During <Perpetual Machine>, all attacks of [Magic Sword: Refrost] induce electric shock on targets.

The next one I checked, [Magic Sword: Refrost], was a magic sword that inflicted lightning damage.

It also had a function of amplifying user's abilities, similar to the previous sword.

The last item was an effect that gave status effects to targets who were attacked.

It reminded me of <Lightning> series of magic that I often used.

-[Magic Sword: Heimklopf]

-It blocks physical attacks up to 10 times.

-If the accumulated attacks exceed 10 times, <Overload> occurs and the attack of [Magic Sword: Heimklopf] is enhanced.

After the meeting, I had a meal and a shower, and then I sat down in front of my smartphone with a devout mind.

I had successfully rescued Cuebaerg and finished the meeting, so it was time to check the items in my inventory.

Tap.

I activated the inventory and saw many items filling it up.

They were the by-products of the 210 draws that I did while I was in deep sleep.

I couldn't even check the results before.

Now I could finally see them properly.

“First, the magic books... <Ice Arrow>...”

I started to check the magic books one by one.

The first one that caught my eye was [Magic Book: Ice Arrow], which I got from 10 draws. It was a magic that inflicted frost damage, as the name suggested.

There were several other magic books in the inventory, including [Magic Book: Ice Arrow]. They were the ones that Eutenia obtained by raiding the magic tower and sent to me through communion.

“<Enchant: Fire>... <Enchant: Lightning>...? They are all enchantment-type magic.”

The magic books from Eutenia were <Enchant: Fire> and <Enchant: Lightning>. They were magic that temporarily added fire and lightning to weapons.

Weapons with enchantment could inflict additional damage according to each attribute.

Enchantment was a skill that was awkward for me to use, but it was useful for the cult's believers.

If I put them in the <Divine Response Device>, many believers would use them.

I didn't hesitate to use the magic books and learn the magic.

-You have learned <Enchant: Fire (Lv.MAX)>.

-You have learned <Enchant: Lightning (Lv.MAX)>.

As the magic books disappeared from the inventory, a message appeared to inform me of the skill acquisition.

<Ice Arrow> was a magic that Eutenia had not learned yet.

It would be better to use this magic book after she finished her learning.

After dealing with the magic books from Eutenia, I looked at the magic swords that were sleeping in the inventory. There were seven of them.

“As for the magic swords... one was a sword that handled fire, and another one was what I drew last time...”

One of the seven magic swords was for Daniel, who had been waiting for it. It was a magic sword that returned me to the location where I activated its trait after 10 seconds.

And another one was [Magic Sword: Aterinus], which I checked as soon as I woke up. It was a magic sword that converted mana into fire attribute.

Now it was time to check out the other magic swords besides those two. I moved my finger with anticipation toward the remaining magic sword.

And then I was shocked by the description of the new item that appeared.

- ◦ [Magic Sword: 
- ◦  .

The name was not displayed properly.

The letters in the item description were broken and there was no readable content. It was the first time I encountered such an item while playing the game.

Maybe it was not translated properly or there was some kind of bug. I thought so and tried to read the item description again.

But at that moment, the icon of the magic sword disappeared from my sight.

“...”

I looked at the screen with bewildered eyes as the item vanished in an instant.

Blink. Blink.

I blinked several times, wondering if I saw it wrong.

But no matter how many times I closed and opened my eyes, the item did not come back.

A question popped out of my mouth as I looked at the screen.

“What? Why did it disappear all of a sudden?”

It was what people called item evaporation. I frowned as I looked at the empty slot in the inventory where the magic sword with unreadable name had disappeared.

An item that was there just a moment ago was gone. Well, it was not in a normal state anyway, but it was an item that I got from drawing.

It was not something that I could let go easily.

“Ah...”

I had to contact the game company about this item evaporation.

I tried to find a contact button somewhere in the game.

I wanted to talk about the missing item and get it restored by the staff.

But as soon as I tried to find the contact button, a new message popped up at the bottom of the game screen.

It was a type of message that I had never seen before.

- ◦ You have used [Magic Sword: .

The new message said that I had used that item.

An item in the magic sword category.

It was a ridiculous story.

If I had used the item, there should have been at least some feedback.

It looked like an excuse for the item evaporation.

The situation was clearly an error. I thought so and tried to find the contact button again.

“Wait... If I used the item, there should have been some feedback, right? This is no different from losing the item because of a bug.”

I would have done that if another message had not appeared at the bottom of the screen.

Below the message about using the item, there was another message with a different content.

It was a message about the result of using the item.

-You have obtained [Contract of Regression] by using [Magic Sword: ].

It was a message that said I had obtained another item by using the magic sword.

I felt a little relieved then.

Maybe the magic sword itself had an effect of obtaining an item.

It was not completely incomprehensible.

The problem was that the name and description of the item were unreadable due to an error.

If the item was used normally, I wouldn't have to bother contacting them.

My head felt a little dizzy, and I didn't feel like thinking too much.

“Ah... Maybe it was just a name error.”

I thought so and turned off the screen of my smartphone.

I felt sleepy because my head was a bit hazy.

I decided not to resist the urge to sleep that came to my mind.

Thud.

As soon as I closed my eyes, I felt the strength leaving my body.

-“The effect is wearing off slowly...”

As my eyelids closed, I checked the screen of my smartphone.

Fortunately, it was turned off.

There would be no mishap like losing 2 million won like yesterday.

I felt relieved and buried my head on the table.

Thump.

A dull sound echoed in my ears.

**

In a rural village in the northern part of the empire.

There stood a boy with a sullen face, holding a sword in his hand.

His sword, dripping with thick blood, was wrapped in a bluish glow.

The boy, who held the bloodstained sword, smiled eerily on his face.

He swung his sword to shake off the blood, and then sheathed it in his waist.

And then he started to stroll around the village with slow steps.

“...”

Thud. Thud.

Only the sound of the boy's footsteps echoed in the quiet village.

The boy's eyes reflected the scenery of the country village where no one was left alive.

It was a situation where only the boy remained in the village that had been quiet from the beginning.

It was all the result of his own hands.

The boy's gaze, which had swept over the empty village, now turned to the sword on his waist.

“So you're saying—.”

Artifact, Clawsolas.

The peerless sword that the boy, who had nothing, had recently obtained.

It was emitting a brilliant light even when it was in its sheath, showing its beautiful appearance.

It was something that he would not have been allowed to touch in the first place.

But now it was a thing that only he was allowed to possess.

The boy looked at Clawsolas with a bright face and asked.

“So you're saying I just have to clean up as much as I can with my own hands?”

-“That's right. That's the fastest way to adjust the causality rate.”

Then a man's voice rang in the boy's ears, who was wearing the sword.

A deep and heavy voice of a man.

It came from Clawsolas, which he was wearing, and it was the voice of the ego that lived inside the artifact Clawsolas.

It was also the being that ordered him to deal with the humans in the village after he received the artifact.

The boy spoke to Clawsolas with a curious voice.

“Causality rate... Is that so important?”

-“Yes. The evil god’s rampage is also caused by the imbalance of causality. He needs to balance it at least to move.”

“That’s what you’re saying... It’s a command that doesn’t suit the goddess of order at all.”

-“She doesn’t like it either. It’s just a temporary expedient. But this is one of the few ways to maintain order.”

A goddess who sacrifices innocent humans to restore her power.

Snicker. The boy who was talking with Clawsolas let out a small laugh.

It didn’t feel like a goddess’s command to save humans with mercy.

Thanks to that, he got the right to judge people with the name of a hero.

The boy looked alternately at the fallen villagers and his sword, and then spoke his thoughts to Clawsolas.

“But wouldn’t it be better if other heroes joined me?”

-“This is something that must be done secretly from other heroes.”

“What do you mean? It’s something that the goddesses need, so why do we have to keep it secret?”

-“Only she is willing to take risks and prepare for the evil god.”

“What?”

The boy questioned Clawsolas’ words.

Clawsolas said that this was the only way for the goddesses to recover causality as quickly as possible.

But only the goddess of order was using this method.

It was hard to accept this story.

Why would they avoid the most efficient way and go around the hard way?

Unless they were fools, it was a choice that they had no reason to avoid.

-“The other goddesses refuse to interfere with the world too much for providence. They are even more reluctant if it goes against their ideals.”

“Only the goddess of order is trying to save the world?”

-“That’s why she is wary of other goddesses. Especially the goddess of coordination who harmonizes their opinions.”

The boy stopped and crossed his arms in thought.

Listening to his story, it seemed that the relationship between the goddesses was not very good.

There was a difference of opinion between him and the goddess of order who chose him over the issue of evil god.

He thought that anyone who was a celestial god would have transcended human wisdom.

But they were even arguing over their opinions, refusing to take the most efficient way.

It was unexpected for him.

And it was also an opportunity for him.

The boy tapped on Clawsolas’ hilt and asked him.

“So does that mean I’m the only hero who can save our goddess?”

-“You’re the only one who can do this. Philun. If you show a great performance, she will reward you accordingly.”

“I got it. I’ll do it.”

Philun, who had been grumbling, started to move out of the empty village.

He was already fascinated by his own appearance, which had become a hero of the old stories.

His footsteps were very light under the setting sun, where he wielded the artifact.

Murder and evil.

Philun's eyes, where the banner of injustice dwelled, were dyed red by the sunset.

A confession of faith flowed out of Philun's mouth as he headed for the next village.

"I'll kill hundreds or thousands of them for the goddess."

Chapter 107: Divine Command (1)

Chapter 107: Divine Command (1)

The western region of the empire.

The province of Atelot.

There, the archangel Aronia opened her eyes, wrapped in a bright cluster of light.

The first thing she saw as she descended to the ground with a clear light was a green meadow.

As a gentle breeze blew, the grass swayed with countless scents of grass.

The sky was shining with warm sunlight, illuminating the scenery.

She gasped in awe for a moment at the sight of the ground she was seeing for the first time.

She had come down from heaven to carry out the will of the goddess, and everything she saw was new to her.

“Is this the ground...!”

Aronia, one of the seraphim in heaven.

She belonged to the highest rank among the angels, and she engraved everything she saw in her eyes.

She needed to find out her exact location first in order to meet the heroes.

That's why Aronia decided to look around first.

"This is... a human field, I guess?"

She walked a little further from where she landed and soon encountered a wheat field shining with gold.

Perhaps it was because the harvest season was approaching.

The wheat that filled the field was glowing with a vivid golden color.

The field full of ripe wheat was like a painting.

Aronia admired the beautiful scenery and reached out to touch the wheat field.

The abundant grains of wheat swayed and returned to their place as they touched Aronia's palm.

"It's fun how they bounce back."

Aronia spread her palm and tapped the wheat, cutting across the field.

The wheat moved flexibly like waves as her palm passed by.

She smiled brightly as she walked through the field, tearing through the wheat.

She had an angelic face and walked through the field for a long time.

The field was so wide that it was hard to see the end even if she walked.

She went forward, tearing through countless golden lights, and stopped for a moment to think about her schedule.

"Hmm... I can't go to where the heroes are right now. Maybe I should ask for directions and find the temple first."

There were temples on the ground where humans worshiped the goddesses.

She thought that she could easily get the information she wanted there.

She could find out where the heroes were or contact them where they were staying.

Then she could meet them and help them with their work, or even teach them herself.

They were still inexperienced even though they were heroes.

If Aronia, who was famous in heaven, guided them, they would be much stronger than they were now.

“Okay. Let’s go to the temple first.”

Aronia saw a human passing by in her sight as she made up her mind.

He was a middle-aged man wearing a hat made of straw and carrying a scythe.

He was a stranger, but if she revealed that she was an agent of the goddess, he might help her kindly.

Aronia decided to ask him where the temple was.

She pushed aside the wheat that blocked her way and walked forward.

Then she spoke to him in a holy voice.

“Ahem, listen. I am here to carry out the will of heaven...”

“A-a-angel...!”

But before Aronia finished speaking, the man who saw her opened his eyes wide and looked at her.

He had never seen an angel descending to the ground before.

He stuttered and stepped back a few steps in confusion.

Aronia was puzzled by his interruption, but tried to understand his feelings and continued speaking.

“I am a seraphim, sent by the will of heaven...”

“An angel! An angel has appeared in our village!”

“Huh...?”

But the man’s reaction was the opposite of what she expected.

Instead of being afraid or awed by the angel’s appearance, he shouted with joy and spread the news to everyone.

Aronia narrowed her eyes at the incomprehensible man.

It was natural for humans to be surprised by the sight of an angel.

She was a divine messenger who had descended from heaven with the goddess’s will.

Any human should show respect and reverence to her.

But the next words that came out of the man’s mouth were something that even Aronia could not accept easily.

An angel has appeared in our village too.

That meant that there was another angel besides Aronia somewhere nearby.

Aronia grabbed the man’s hand and asked him in a flustered voice.

“Wait a minute! What do you mean by that?”

“An angel has appeared in our village too! Hahaha! Thank you for coming, angel!”

“No, not that! You said ‘in our village too’!”

The man seemed to understand what Aronia meant and nodded his head.

“Oh, that’s because an angel appeared in another region first.”

“What did you say? Tell me more!”

Aronia’s voice grew louder as she sensed the possibility of another angel nearby.

She had heard of other angels who had fallen from heaven.

Sometimes, there were angels who broke the goddess’s rules and became corrupted.

The evil god used his karma to turn them against their own kind and sent them down to earth.

Lately, there were even fallen angels near Aronia’s area, so it was not strange that there were fallen angels on earth.

And if such beings were around, it was also Aronia’s duty as a heavenly angel to punish them.

That’s why she kept asking the man about the whereabouts of the angel.

“An angel came down in the Keterlant region, not far from here. And people from around there flocked to see the angel...”

“Keterlant region? Which direction is that?”

“Keterlant region is a bit more west from here...”

“I see! Do you know the name of that angel?”

Aronia asked him one more important question.

The name of the angel who had descended in Keterlant region.

The man hesitated for a moment and then nodded as if he remembered something.

“Estasia? I think I heard that name...”

“Estasia!”

Aronia exclaimed in shock as she heard the name of the angel from the man.

Heavenly Angel Estasia.

It was a name that was too familiar to her.

It was the name of her subordinate who had run away from her not long ago.

It had been a few days since I had suffered a 2 million won disaster in my sleep.

After a bitter weekend, I had to go through an extreme diet every day.

My bank account balance had dropped below my psychological comfort line because of the last disaster.

Money was something that you never knew when you would need it.

If I didn't have some emergency funds for urgent situations, I might get into trouble someday.

That's why I set my own standards for my account balance.

I considered the emergency funds as a kind of insurance.

“But today was too hard to avoid.”

But there were always days when I was too tired to be rational.

A weary mind often made it impossible to make reasonable decisions.

I stopped by the mart and bought a cheap chicken because I was soaked in work fatigue.

The combination of cheap chicken and cheap beer that tasted like urine.

This was the result of my self-imposed austerity measure.

A feast for myself in my small room.

I turned on my smartphone and sat at the table to enjoy my rare feast.

“Ah... A hungry pig is better than a full Socrates. I need to fill my stomach first.”

Crack.

I opened a can of beer and looked at the screen of my smartphone.

The first thing I saw on the game screen was Eutenia watching over two kidnapped alchemists on Yuto.

Of course, there was no chance for the alchemists and their apprentice trapped on Yuto to escape to the ground.

They would only face death if they tried to jump off from there.

“Now that I look at it, Yuto has grown quite big.”

Yuto had grown much bigger than before.

It was the result of Eutenia using her shadows to gather a lot of soil.

I wondered if I should have left it to her sooner.

On the expanded Yuto, there was also a makeshift workshop for the alchemist.

It was to secure the [Philosopher's Stone], one of the materials for the <Descent> quest.

It would be nice to make other items with the alchemist's help after this was over.

“Did you find out all the ingredients you need to make the Philosopher's Stone?”

“It seems like I need some more time to decipher them...”

“I can't give you more time forever. I have to take your apprentice for some education soon...”

“Wait! You can't do that!”

I watched the conversation between Eutenia and the alchemist and turned my gaze to a corner of Yuto.

What was her name? Enia?

The alchemist's apprentice was also very obedient.

She had been like this ever since she received Roan's ideological education for a few hours.

Roan was good at making anyone his follower, so he must have given her a hard time convincing her.

Of course, after that, the alchemist would get angry whenever he heard the words ‘apprentice’ and ‘education’.

He was more cooperative with Eutenia's orders when she threatened him.

“Evan took Cuebaerg with him last time.”

Evan had gone somewhere to find a new habitat for Cuebaerg.

According to their conversation, he seemed to have released Cuebaerg in a place like the sea.

It was to provide him with a suitable environment for recovery, since he had lost most of his power.

Cuebaerg said he was fine, so I thought he would grow on his own if I let him go in the sea.

I was sorry that I couldn't get the karma from Cuebaerg anymore, though.

“Eutenia will make the items on her own if I leave her alone... Maybe I should look around somewhere else this time.”

Eutenia would probably bring me the Philosopher's Stone soon if I left her alone like this.

I left Eutenia, who was training the alchemist well, and started moving the screen to another place.

Of course, I didn't just move the screen without doing anything else.

It would be boring if I just watched without doing anything.

So I kept sprinkling rain as I moved to another place.

They could cool down with some refreshing rain in this hot summer. It was my consideration for them.

-You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

-You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

-You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

-You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

-“Aaaah!”

I saw a speech bubble screaming and something flying by as I moved the screen while using the skill repeatedly.

It wasn't like before, when a character flew up because of the storm.

I had hit something that was already flying with my magic and made it fall.

I wondered what it was and checked the area where I had used my magic.

“What is that?”

I heard something falling for sure.

But I couldn't tell where it fell.

There was no message saying that I gained karma, so it probably wasn't a character that I hunted.

I searched around for a while, but I couldn't find anything noticeable.

If it was something that was flying from the beginning, it could be a bird or a monster.

I didn't need to worry about those things.

“Oh well, it's nothing.”

I quickly concluded and continued moving the screen.

Of course, I didn't forget to scatter rain on every corner I passed by.

Chapter 108: Divine Command (2)

Chapter 108: Divine Command (2)

Swoosh.

The sky was filled with moisture as a storm raged on.

Aronia got up from the ground, covered in dust and rain.

Her hair, which she used to take pride in, was dirty and muddy.

She ran her wet fingers through her hair, carefully removing the clumps of dirt.

The moist soil felt unpleasant and sticky on her skin.

“Ugh... Ugh...”

Aronia looked at her muddy hands with a grimace.

She hated how her hair had turned into a mess of dirt.

The reason for this situation was the sudden storm that had hit her.

As Aronia was flying around, looking for Estasia, who was somewhere out there, the air currents twisted and threw her off balance.

She crashed into a mountain and slid down, until she managed to get up.

Aronia clenched her fists and shouted at the sky, filled with anger.

“Evil and wicked god... You are trying to interfere with the will of heaven!”

It was impossible for the air currents to twist so abruptly without a large-scale weather control magic.

And it was a strong enough current to make Aronia lose control of her flight for a moment.

It had to be the work of the evil god, who was behind this sabotage.

Aronia quickly guessed that the culprit of this incident was the wicked god.

He was trying to stop Aronia, who represented the will of heaven.

“But I, Aronia, will not stop because of such a trivial interference.”

Aronia had been working hard for days to find traces of Estasia.

And she had finally found out where Estasia was staying.

She couldn't stop now, just because of some twisted air currents.

Aronia moved her wings, which were folded behind her back, and regained her balance.

Then she used magic to inspect the parts of her body that were covered in dirt.

She wanted to fix her appearance first, which was tarnishing the dignity of an angel.

“I will not hesitate and move on quickly.”

Aronia didn't want to stay in this miserable state any longer.

She believed that angels should always be pure and holy.

Especially an angel of judgment, who was the most noble among angels, couldn't afford to be covered in dust.

She hastily brushed off the dirt from her body with her hands.

Then she stretched out her hand to the air and recited a short spell.

“O Goddess, grant me a ray of light that pierces through the darkness.”

Zap!

A beam of light struck Aronia's hand that reached out to the ground.

The dark clouds that covered the sky were pushed back by the bright and holy light.

At the end of the beam of light, there was a silver spear that shone with radiance.

Aronia grabbed the spear that landed on the ground.

Starlight, the divine spear that was only allowed to angels of judgment.

She held it in front of her and started to float in the air with her wings spread wide.

“_____.”

Under her fluttering wings, countless lights flowed down.

Aronia, who was respected by all angels in heaven, revealed her full power.

In this state, no magic from the evil god could stop her anymore.

Aronia lifted Starlight and thought of the wicked servant of the evil god that she had to kill.

Estasia, the fallen angel whose name alone made her teeth chatter.

She had always been lazy and slothful, even when she was an angel. She had to be punished for sure.

“Estasia, who follows the evil god! No matter how much you try to stop me, I will definitely deal with you myself.”

Memories of Estasia came flooding into Aronia’s mind.

Estasia, who skipped work and hid in a corner to nap when it was her turn to do something in heaven.

Estasia, who ate all the strawberries that Aronia had collected and pretended not to know anything.

Estasia, who learned only defensive magic and skipped offensive magic because she was too lazy to move.

Estasia, who dozed off while offering prayers of gratitude to the Goddess and only turned on her halo.

Estasia, who always prayed for strange things like strawberries or grapes.

The more she thought about it, the more Estasia seemed like a spawn of a devil in her past memories.

“How did you not fall from heaven sooner? It’s a miracle!”

Aronia’s face turned red as she recalled Estasia.

Those who violated the rules of heaven were all enemies of the Goddess.

And she, as an angel of judgment, had to show an example and deal with those traitors.

Especially if it was Estasia, who used to be her subordinate.

It had nothing to do with the basket of strawberries that Estasia had stolen from her.

This was the justice proclaimed by the god.

His creations had to follow the will of heaven under the great principle.

“I will, I will give you the punishment you deserve.”

Aronia aimed Starlight at the front and began to gather divine power at the tip of the spear.

A faint shield spread out in front of her, blocking the wind that brushed her cheek.

Behind her, her large wings flapped and pushed away the atmosphere that weighed her down.

Aronia had reached the peak of speed and power, which were expressed by the void in heaven.

She was unmatched in her specialty of fast movement, even among the angels in heaven.

Her actions now were preparations for flying at her maximum speed.

“Hoo...”

Aronia sighed briefly and gripped the handle of Starlight tightly.

Dozens of rings of light formed behind her.

The rings gathered together in one place, adjusting their sizes, and then resonated with each other, drawing in divine power.

Aronia activated her vision and aimed herself at the sky.

At the moment when the condensed divine power exploded.

Zap!

Aronia’s body shot up to the sky in a flash of light.

A projection magic that launched herself to the extreme.

That was Aronia's vision, as an angel of judgment.

Inside the carriage heading to Crossbridge.

Hus was lost in his thoughts, looking out the window.

His face, unlike before, had no eye patch on it.

He had regained his lost eye, so there was no need to wear an eye patch anymore.

But he couldn't shake off the frustration that bound his heart.

The cause of his frustration was his brother, Evan Allemier, whom he had encountered last time.

“...”

His brother, whom he admired, had become an apostle of the evil god.

And Hus had failed to stop him.

He was pushed back in battle by Evan, who had surpassed the category of a normal mage.

No.

Not only him, but the entire expedition force had been defeated by him without a fight.

Evan had calmly resisted against all of them by himself.

He might not be able to handle them all alone, but it wouldn't be hard for him to buy enough time as he wanted.

He had actually succeeded in doing that and took away Kueverg.

“Hus. You don’t have to be so sad.”

“...”

“You’ll have plenty of chances to stop your brother with your own hands.”

Sion, who was facing Hus, tried to comfort him with his words.

To stop his brother with his own hands.

Hus touched his eye as he heard that.

If Evan and Hus both survived, there might be a chance for that someday.

“Comfort? Call it a prediction from a great hero.”

“That’s a lame joke.”

“Is it? That apostle, Evan, was obviously very strong, right?”

“Ha...”

“Then who else can stop him if not us?”

Hus shook his head at Sion’s words.

He didn’t know anything yet.

There would be no opportunity for the heroes for a while.

The elders’ council would protect and shelter the heroes who were in danger in the expedition.

There was no need to risk sending out the heroes who hadn’t finished growing yet.

It would be up to the monster in the basement of the temple to buy them time to grow.

“We won’t be able to leave the holy land for a while.”

“What? How do you know that?”

“I heard some related information from Lady Aurora.”

Hus gave Sion a small hint.

There was ‘that thing’ living in the basement of the temple.

‘That thing’, which was kept secret from outsiders, was a being created to deal with apostles like Evan.

To replace the hero who can only exist once in a generation, the holy land created the oldest hero.

The past hero who grew up through generations was a collection of all the skills that Crossbridge possessed.

The holy land would use it to suppress the evil god’s forces until the heroes’ growth stopped.

Even after fighting with it, would Evan be able to survive safely?

And if Evan did survive, would that really be a good thing for humanity?

The more I thought about it, the more complicated my head felt.

“What? Does Aurora also tell you that?”

“Yes.”

“Our Merry doesn’t tell me anything.”

Even though he didn’t know the situation well, Sion kept talking to Hus with a smile.

Hus sneered at Sion's attitude of talking openly about his own temple.

"You're saying something risky. She's still a saintess of the temple, you know."

"I'm fine because I'm close with Merry."

Sion said confidently, as if it wasn't just a lie.

The Merry he was talking about was the saintess of hunting from the temple of hunting.

Unlike other saintesses, she was a person who became a saintess at a relatively young age.

She was also a person who always followed Sion around without any hesitation.

Was it because of Sion's unique personality?

Or was it because Merry was still young?

They were different from other heroes and often hung out together.

"Didn't Merry become a saintess not long ago?"

"Don't mock me and talk. How can there be such a thing among the same saintesses?"

"Each temple has different situations. Aurora is exceptional in terms of experience."

"What? Does our Merry have to become a grandmother to give me a hint?"

"That might be possible."

Hus moved his gaze from looking out the window to Sion on the opposite side.

A faint smile appeared on Hus's lips, who had been wearing a serious expression.

Sion, who was looking at Hus, also smiled while snapping his bowstring.

I felt complicated in my head, but now it felt like my worries had flown away in an instant.

Even though I knew it was a stupid thing to do, I kept hanging out with him because of Sion's personality.

Hus expressed his gratitude to Sion with a hollow feeling.

"It feels better to laugh like this. Thank you."

"See? It's better when you smile."

"It would be better if you didn't smile like that."

"What can I do? My smile is my best charm."

Sion said that and lay down on the wall of the carriage with his legs propped up.

Thud.

A light gray footprint appeared on the outer wall where Sion's foot touched.

It was a mark made by the dust that Sion had stepped on.

The priests would have a hard time cleaning the carriage, Hus thought as he looked at Sion and added one more thing.

"Do you know? Maybe the evil god will spare me once if he sees my smiling face."

Chapter 109: Divine Order (3)

Chapter 109: Divine Order (3)

At the branch of the cult in the Ketterland region, Estasia felt an inexplicable chill as she looked up at the sky.

For some reason, her throat was dry and her nose was ticklish today.

She rubbed her twitching nose and blinked her halo as she gazed at the sky.

She soon let out a big sneeze and closed both eyes.

“Achoo!”

Estasia looked at the sky with a blank expression after a long time without sneezing.

It was still summer, with warm sunlight shining down.

It was not a weather to feel cold for no reason.

But she suddenly coughed out loud.

I was reminded of my days in heaven today.

“Hmm...”

When I was still in heaven, I always felt a shiver whenever my boss chased me to nag at me.

It was a survival skill I acquired to avoid the angels’ scolding.

But now that I had descended to the earth, I didn't need to worry about my boss following me.

Unless it was another angel who came down to the earth.

"I should go get some strawberry juice."

Considering the personality of Aronia, who was my direct boss, the chances of her coming down to the earth were slim.

Aronia was diligent but not meticulous.

She was also an unlucky and naive angel.

She had many troublesome aspects that made it hard to send her down based on her abilities alone.

Even if the goddesses personally sent an angel down, they would not likely choose Aronia.

That's why I ignored the inexplicable chill and entered the kitchen on the first floor of the cult.

"Oh! Did you come, angel-sama!"

"Yes."

"Here is the freshly made strawberry juice!"

As I folded my wings and entered the kitchen, a believer who saw me greeted me with a smile.

He quickly brought me a strawberry juice with ice in it.

It was made by a mage who was waiting in the kitchen and put ice in it for me.

Estasia always came to the kitchen at the same time, so the believers had prepared a strawberry juice for her in advance.

She nodded and took the cup of strawberry juice from a believer.

“Good job.”

“Thank you! Angel-sama!”

Gulp.

She took a sip of the strawberry juice from the believer.

Sweetness spread from her lips.

The uneasy feeling she had been feeling since earlier faded a little.

She quickly finished the strawberry juice and handed the cup back to the believer.

“Do you have oranges for tomorrow?”

“We don’t, but we’ll get them for you! Don’t worry!”

“Thank you.”

“No, thank you! We are grateful that you are here with us!”

That was the end of her visit to the kitchen.

She stroked the head of the believer who took the cup and went outside.

She always felt this way while she was here, but the cult people loved angels very much.

They would do anything for her, even if it was hard.

It was like paradise for Estasia.

She hoped that this happiness would last forever as she left the cult building.

“The weather is nice today...”

I stepped out of the cult and was greeted by the sunny weather.

The heat that had been lazily wrapping around my body was also relieved by the cool strawberry juice.

My eyes looked at the sky where the warm sunlight was shining.

On the other side of the blue sky, I saw the endless horizon and the colorful clouds filling the space between them.

And I also saw something flying across the clouds.

“...”

Blink. Blink.

I closed and opened my eyes at the sight of something piercing through the clouds.

I was trying to identify what it was that was flying from afar.

It was a straight line that cut through the dark clouds.

My eyes were filled with caution at the trail of light that moved at a very fast speed.

My halo, which was looking at the sky, also resonated with the divine power and emitted light.

“No, don’t tell me...”

A huge divine power was coming from far away through my halo.

There was only one being that had such a divine power.

An angel.

And it was an angel of a higher rank than me.

I raised my divine power to guard against the intruder, who was drawing a trail of light and flying towards me.

My wings spread wide and a bright light surrounded me.

I was ready to show my full power for the first time since I came to the earth.

“——sia.”

“Aronia...?”

“Estasia!”

Boom!

A huge sound echoed from the distant sky as an angel wrapped in light revealed herself.

She had bright golden hair that reached her waist.

And a halo that shone even brighter than her hair.

The angel who appeared in front of Estasia was someone she knew well.

Archangel Aronia.

She was the highest rank of angels in heaven, and Estasia’s former boss.

“Why are you here, Aronia...?”

Estasia looked at her old boss with a bewildered expression.

She was as always, surrounded by a holy aura.

Aronia stopped in mid-air with a spear in her hand, and the sky opened up and a ray of sunlight pierced down at her.

Behind the hovering Aronia, a bright halo burst out.

It was the heavenly light that only seraphim could have.

Aronia arrived at the cult and looked down at Estasia with a displeased eye.

“Estasia! It’s been so long since I’ve seen you!”

“Uh, yeah.”

“You! How could you run away from heaven like that, even if you hate your work!”

“That, that’s...”

Estasia’s body shrank under Aronia’s sharp gaze.

She used to run away whenever Aronia nagged at her.

She had to listen to Aronia’s scolding in a place where she couldn’t escape, and Estasia felt very uncomfortable.

She thought she would never hear from her again after running away from heaven, but she followed her to the earth and nagged at her.

It was an awkward situation that she couldn’t even imagine.

“And... And you even became a fallen angel after being tempted by the evil god...!”

“...”

“Huh? But your halo is normal.”

Aronia was scolding Estasia, but then she noticed her halo and tilted her head.

She probably thought Estasia had fallen long ago.

Aronia looked at Estasia with a puzzled face.

And then she asked Estasia a question.

“Estasia, haven’t you fallen yet?”

Nod.

Estasia nodded and affirmed Aronia’s question.

As she said, Estasia had not given up her angelic nature yet.

Estasia was no different from when she was in heaven.

She was always an angel who hated work and liked to play and eat.

Aronia asked her again with a curious face.

“Why is that? You would suit being a fallen angel better.”

“Too lazy...”

“...”

I was shocked when I heard Estasia’s answer.

I flinched when I saw Aronia’s eyes glinting with anger.

Sigh.

Aronia sighed briefly and shook her head with the spear in her hand.

She was lost in thought for a moment, then spoke to Estasia with a thin eye.

“I heard about you. You haven’t fallen yet, so let’s go back to heaven with me when this is over.”

“No.”

“Why, why don’t you want to go back? Isn’t it our duty to pray to the Goddess of Harmony and serve her?”

“Praying doesn’t give me strawberries or oranges.”

I was afraid of Aronia, but I didn’t hate or dislike her.

But I didn’t want to go back to heaven with her either.

This place was like paradise for me.

No one bothered me here, and everyone liked me and gave me gifts.

I had no reason to leave this place and go back to heaven.

Besides, I couldn’t go back as I pleased because of the oath I made with my master.

Aronia shouted at Estasia with trembling lips.

“That, that’s because you always pray for weird things!”

“Have you ever received strawberries?”

“No? Of course not!”

“Here, praying gives me cool strawberry juice.”

I licked the traces of the strawberry juice I had just drank and said.

Maybe she understood that my words were not empty.

Aronia looked at me with a blank expression for a moment.

But that was only for a moment.

She soon clenched her hand around the starlight and aimed it at me.

“You are——.”

“Aronia...?”

“You are... always like that. Even though I’m higher than you, you treat me like a fool and tease me all the time.”

“No. I don’t think of Aronia like that...”

I tried to explain to her as she pointed her weapon at me.

But Aronia didn’t seem to listen to my words.

Rather, she showed resentment towards me.

“You have no sense of duty as an angel, and you always send weird prayers to the goddess.”

“I don’t do that...”

“What do you think of the goddess?”

Vroom.

A massive divine power began to shake around Aronia, who aimed her spear at me.

She was an archangel who had received the most divine power among the angels.

As she used the starlight to condense her divine power, a tremendous current of light gathered at the tip of the spear.

Aronia showed clear hostility towards me and I answered her seriously.

“I never thought of Aronia like that.”

“Don’t lie. If not, you wouldn’t play with me all the time!”

“Aronia...”

The angel's spear created the light of judgment.

Rings of light formed and made a straight path in front of Aronia's spear.

No one was unaware of what the sharp tip of the spear was aiming for.

Aronia didn't listen to what I had to say, and I bit my lip and raised one hand.

I didn't mind being attacked once or twice.

I was exceptionally sturdy even in heaven.

But it was different if the attack happened here.

"I will judge you on behalf of the goddess."

It was a strike prepared with sincerity by the highest angel.

I felt uneasy about the attack and tried to persuade Aronia.

"Aronia. If you shoot that here, you might hurt the people here."

"Don't tell me you came here without knowing what kind of place this is!"

The air shook violently.

Aronia's eyes were filled with bright light as she prepared the sincere attack and looked at her target.

Her eyes showed clear hostility.

She was determined to attack the whole cult, including me.

I raised my divine power against the shining spear.

Aronia's announcement echoed as I prepared the divine barrier.

“The ones who deceived you and made you like this must be the evil followers of the evil god here!”

“No, no...”

“I know everything. There are people who lure others with cunning words and make them fall into a wrong faith.”

“I said no...! I’ve never been deceived by these people!”

I deployed the barrier with full power against Aronia’s glaring eyes.

It was difficult for a lower rank angel to block an attack from an archangel in normal cases.

But I was an angel who gave up all attack magic and focused only on defense.

I thought I might be able to stop Aronia’s strike if it was me.

Aronia’s cold eyes shone through the barrier that spread out with full power.

She put more strength into her spear and opened her mouth.

“Wrong faith needs judgment accordingly.”

“Aronia—.”

“If I clean up these heretics, maybe I can change your mind a little.”

“I, I...”

Crack.

A sound of grinding teeth came from Aronia’s mouth.

She hated the cult sincerely.

And she hated me for being with the cult.

She clearly didn't care if some people died from her attack.

"So I can't forgive you. You who betrayed me, the heretics who control you, and the evil god who commands them all!"

"..."

"I don't care who they are. I'll take them all down and save you."

To prepare for the next attack, I made a divine barrier that covered the entire cult.

And I also put up several layers of light shields in front of the barrier.

I couldn't let Aronia hurt the people of the cult here.

It was my job and responsibility.

I couldn't hide and blame my laziness even at this moment.

Aronia gave me a final warning as I used magic consecutively.

"So, Estasia. Go back to heaven and reflect quietly."

As soon as Aronia finished her words.

Light burst out from the end of the starlight.

Boom!

The light that fell with a huge amount of light swept the surroundings.

Chapter 110: Divine Command (4)

Chapter 110: Divine Command (4)

Under the scattering light from the aftermath of the attack, Estasia opened her eyes that had been tightly shut.

The shield that she had placed in front of the holy barrier was completely shattered, and only the cracked barrier was barely holding on.

Thud.

A part of the barrier that covered the entire church began to collapse.

It was a sign that it could not withstand the attack of Aronia, the archangel.

Estasia let out a weak groan as she watched the collapsing barrier.

“Ugh...”

Blood dripped from her hand as she squinted one eye.

The backlash of hastily drawing out the divine power was something that only her hands could bear.

It was perhaps a fortunate thing that she had managed to withstand the attack of the fallen angel from heaven with all her might.

Estasia, with a frown on her face, looked up at Aronia, who was still hovering above her.

Aronia, who was looking down at Estasia, had a somehow awkward expression on her face.

Estasia lifted her head and opened her mouth toward Aronia.

“Aronia, stop this nonsense...”

“—Estasia.”

“Yes...”

Aronia also called her name when she heard Estasia’s voice.

Aronia’s eyes were still soaked with anger.

So this is what an angel looks like when she is truly angry.

It was the first time that Estasia saw such a face that made her think that.

“You didn’t have to push yourself if you were alone. But why... are you trying to protect the followers of the evil god?”

Estasia, who was facing Aronia, realized that she was asking that question sincerely.

Aronia seemed to believe that Estasia could handle her attack.

That was only true when Estasia deployed the barrier for herself alone, though.

Estasia looked at her palm that was bleeding from the aftermath of using the barrier recklessly.

Instead of staining her slender palm with blood, Estasia had protected the followers once.

She didn’t know how many more times she could block Aronia’s attacks, but what mattered to her was that she had succeeded in protecting the people right now.

That was her duty as the guardian of the order.

“The people here love angels.”

Estasia’s small voice echoed in the silent courtyard.

It was a voice that resembled her, calm and relaxed, but still full of emotion.

With that voice, Estasia shook off the blood that was dripping from her hand.

In Estasia’s eyes, which were wrinkled with pain, a clear determination rose.

She raised her hand again, which had shaken off the blood, and began to tell Aronia her thoughts.

“They always love angels, bring gifts for them, and even give me delicious strawberries every day.”

“.....”

“I can’t just leave and run away from a place where there are people who love such a lacking angel so much.”

The followers of the order loved Estasia.

She received an abundance of love and lived happily every day in that affection.

Sometimes her master would appear and play cruel pranks on her, but Estasia also loved the order where she stayed.

This place was now the only paradise for Estasia.

She could not stand to see such a paradise trampled by another angel.

That’s why she decided to protect it with her own hands.

“To abandon the people who love angels and run away... that’s not very angelic of you.”

“You...”

“So I’m going to protect this place from Aronia. It doesn’t matter what you say now.”

Aronia, who had listened to Estasia’s words, bit her own lips.

She looked back and forth between the spear in her hand and Estasia, then sighed deeply and aimed the spear again.

Aronia’s mind did not change no matter what Estasia said.

She let out a short sigh and unleashed a barrage of attacks toward Estasia.

“You’re really foolish. Don’t you think they’re all just acting to lure you out?”

“It’s okay. Even if it’s all a lie, I can pretend to believe it for now.”

“There’s no choice now. If you’re going to protect them, I’ll have to deal with you and the minions of the evil god together.”

As soon as Aronia finished speaking, the divine power that was spread around began to resonate.

Woo woo woo woo!

The air trembled and Aronia’s spear absorbed the light.

She seemed to be trying to shoot the same blow as before at Estasia.

Estasia also gathered her will and pulled up the divine power in her wounded hand.

A cozy cluster of light and a barrier that covered the whole order appeared again.

“I’ll keep blocking it no matter how many times.”

“Try to block it if you can. I don’t know how long you can last, though.”

The moment Aronia’s cold voice reached Estasia’s ears.

Behind Estasia, who was facing the light-filled spear, the followers of the order stuck their heads out of the window one by one.

Their eyes were directed at Estasia, who was confronting Aronia.

Some of them looked like they had just come out while cooking, holding cooking utensils like ladles or knives in their hands.

The followers who stuck their heads out of the window started to cheer for Estasia.

“Angel! Hang in there!”

“Don’t listen to that crazy fallen angel!”

“There’s no one but the angel!”

“O great one! Please help the angel!”

Estasia’s eyes began to turn red at the voices echoing behind her.

She wanted to protect her precious people.

Responding to her feelings, the divine barrier that surrounded the order became clearer than before.

Estasia thanked the followers of the order with her eyes wet with tears.

“Thank you all...”

“You, crazy fallen angel...”

Of course, Aronia, who heard the shocking story, shook her head and gathered light.

She looked even more provoked by the followers' words.

Aronia aimed her spear, which had enough divine power, at Estasia and the followers.

She expressed her will to pour out attacks and wipe them all out.

As the two angels simultaneously emitted bright light, Estasia spoke to Aronia in midair.

“Aronia. I’m going to protect everyone.”

“Just die cleanly together.”

The moment Aronia’s angry words ended.

Kwaaaaang!

Just like before, a fierce light burst out.

* * * * *

– You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

– You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

– You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

– You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

How long has it been since I started moving while spraying weather control skills in all directions?

After traveling for a long time in the rain, I finally arrived at the branch of the order where Estasia was.

The place where Estasia stayed was quite far away on the map.

It was so close to the edge of the continent that the sea would appear if I left the mountain range on the outskirts.

The branch was located in a place that could be called the fringe even in the empire.

“What’s going on here?”

The first thing I did when I arrived at the branch was to question the scene of the mess.

Except for where the building was, the surroundings were completely torn apart.

And in front of the order building, there was Estasia and an unknown angel facing each other.

Estasia, who took out a shield filled with light, and an unidentified angel holding a spear.

Looking at their appearance, I understood why the order had become like this.

They must have had a serious fight.

I immediately began to guess the identity of the angel who was confronting Estasia.

“I don’t remember meeting any other angels besides Estasia... Could she be a creature too?”

I had never encountered another angel in the field, except for Estasia, who I created using a skill.

It also meant that it was difficult to meet an angel in a normal way.

She wouldn’t be a character that naturally spawned in the field like other characters.

Then maybe she was an event character or a creature.

As I pondered over the angel in front of me, I stretched out my index finger toward her.

I wanted to see how she would react.

“Evil god...”

Ting!

As soon as I touched the angel on the screen with my finger, she quickly raised her spear and blocked my normal attack.

It was a common behavior of elite monsters.

Seeing the angel calling me an evil god, I realized that she was an event monster.

Otherwise, there wouldn't be any character who had such a wicked way of thinking to claim that I was an evil god when they saw me.

I quickly made a decision and began to think about what to do with the angel who was facing Estasia.

“Angels are pretty rare... Can't I capture her?”

I had never met an angel in the game, except for Estasia, who was a creature.

Just like Pluto, the progenitor of vampires, angels were also very rare characters.

Unlike fairies, which I had found in piles, there was a possibility that I would never meet an angel again if I killed her here.

Should I kill the rare character with my own hands and get karma?

Or should I try to capture her somehow and train her?

It was time to choose.

“But there’s also the problem that I don’t have enough karma to select her as an apostle right away... This is more troublesome than I thought.”

I didn’t have enough karma to make her an apostle.

And it was also difficult to earn karma right now.

The best option was to make her a fanatic by physical means, like when I first met Eutenia.

While I was wondering what to do with the angel, she was still moving diligently against Estasia.

She looked at Estasia, who was sitting on the ground, and raised a speech bubble.

“Estasia! Have you finally summoned the evil god!”

“Are you insane? What are you saying?”

– “But today, even the evil god can’t protect you!”

The angel who said that retreated and spread his wings wide.

Flap.

He lifted his spear toward the sky from among the fluttering feathers.

The angel flew up to the sky and closed his eyes, spreading a brilliant light.

Above his head, a sparkling speech bubble appeared.

– “O great goddess. Blind the eyes of the wicked one, and bestow a great miracle upon this place.”

“.....Where have I seen this before?”

I felt uneasy at the sight of the speech bubble floating above the brightly shining halo, and moved my finger.

It was a familiar sight, the same pattern that the recent bosses had been using.

If I left him alone, he would surely repeat the same story as before, something like ‘Holy Proclamation’ or whatever.

It was a pattern that had given me a headache several times already.

In a state where I hadn’t even prepared a countermeasure, I couldn’t just let him finish his pattern.

I put my finger above the angel’s head, who was flapping his wings, and prepared to hit him repeatedly to break through his defense.

– “Holy Proclamation, Angelus—— Ugh!”

Tap tap tap tap!

The angel stopped his skill under my finger that kept hitting the screen.

She was rubbing her forehead with tears in her eyes, along with her spear.

But stopping the angel was only temporary.

She quickly lifted her spear again and tried to continue what she had been doing.

– “O, O great goddess. Blind the eyes of the wicked one——.”

“Ah, seriously……! Stop using that dirty pattern!”

I kept tapping on the screen every time the angel continued his speech.

It was to stop her pattern somehow.

Of course, the angel who was attacked by me didn’t stay still either.

She also tried to avoid my interference and finish casting her skill.

– “Holy—— Ow!”

Tap tap tap tap.

– “Holy Pr Ⅱ …… Eek!”

Tap tap tap.

– “Holy—— Aaah! Wait a minute!”

Tap tap. Tap tap tap tap!

– “Ho, Holy……! Pr… Pffft……!”

And so, the standoff between me and the angel lasted for a long time.

Chapter 111: Divine Command (5)

Chapter 111: Divine Command (5)

-“Stop it already!”

The stalemate that hurt my fingers ended when the angel who had been bothering me for a long time flew up.

Maybe she had no intention of playing along with the boring interference anymore.

She quickly widened the distance and started to prepare a different pattern at a fast speed.

Whirring.

A golden ring appeared behind the angel’s wings and spun.

Unlike before, she seemed to use the patterns that were less likely to be interrupted first.

Seeing that, I moved my fingers quickly following the angel and touched the screen.

“You’re talking nonsense. Do you think I’m crazy to leave you alone?”

I had been in trouble more than once when I watched what patterns came out.

Now I had no intention of letting the enemies do as they pleased.

If they used annoying methods to pressure me, I had to overcome that annoyance and stop them.

Especially if the lives of my followers and Estasia depended on the outcome of the battle.

I couldn't lose them here, neither my followers who followed me nor Estasia who was with them.

That was the responsibility I had to bear for spending nearly 3 million won on the game.

-“Don't follow me!”

“I'll never let you go.”

-“You're really persistent, aren't you? You must be an evil god!”

The angel with the golden ring added on moved faster than before.

It seemed that the skill she had just used was a movement skill.

She was moving around messily, avoiding my fingers.

Every time the angel moved, the golden trail split, and my fingers touched the air.

The speed of the angel moving with all her might was not easy to follow even with my eyes.

Watching the angel flying around busily, I put down the smartphone I was holding on the table and loosened my fingers.

“Alright. Let's try this.”

-“Merciful goddess, please guide the poor lamb to the path——!”

“I'm not good at games, but... if I do it enough, I'll get better, right?”

Whew.

I took a short breath and looked at the smartphone screen.

The angel was moving at a fast speed, trying to dodge my attacks.

It wouldn't be an easy task to catch up with her and hit her.

But there were moments when pride came along as I played the game.

No matter how annoying and frustrating it was, there were moments when I had to finish it.

For me, this was one of those moments.

“...”

I stretched one finger to the skill icon and traced the path of the angel with the rest of my fingers.

I couldn't catch up with the speed of the angel doing acrobatic flight.

I had to predict the path in advance to hit the skill.

Or use a wide-area skill that covered the whole range.

Click.

I decided to use my head a little and touched the <Giga Lightning> skill icon.

And with the rest of my fingers, I predicted the path of the moving angel and touched it.

It was a range that could hit the angel, but not harm the church.

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

Dark clouds covered the screen in an instant, and lightning began to strike the ground.

Crash! Boom!

Lightning fell randomly within the skill range.

Maybe she started to be wary of the falling lightning.

The angel who entered the range of lightning wrapped herself in a barrier and started to move to avoid it.

She seemed to have confidence in handling the skill for a few times.

-“You seem to think you can threaten me, you evil god!”

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

If she avoided the skill, I just had to use it more.

I alternated <Giga Lightning> on top of each other in the same area.

The dark clouds became thicker than before, and a black aura fluttered.

The terrain that was hit by <Giga Lightning> would not be safe, but if I gave up the church yard and caught the angel, it would be a good deal.

I kept stacking <Giga Lightning> in the same area.

As <Giga Lightning> overlapped, both a wide-area skill and a continuous skill, the frequency of lightning falling increased.

-“But I won’t succumb to such a threat!”

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

-You used <Giga Lightning>.

-“Goddess, please... Aaargh!”

The angel was mumbling something confidently, but she got hit by a lightning bolt and popped up a speech bubble.

Cracks began to appear on the barrier of the angel who was hit by the lightning.

The lightning that fell this time was not powerful enough to completely break the barrier.

But the situation from now on would be completely different from before.

I fired countless <Giga Lightning> and moved my finger to the <Lightning Arrow> skill icon.

As I moved my finger, a chain of lightning poured down from the sky.

-“Wh... what...?”

Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

The lightning of the overlapped <Giga Lightning> spread out in all directions.

It was practically a situation where it attacked all targets within range.

The angel who felt the crisis reinforced her barrier and tried to avoid the lightning somehow.

But there was no place for her to escape within range.

There was a massive density of lightning falling in every area within range.

-You used <Lightning Arrow>.

On top of that, I used another magic targeting the angel.

Zaaaap!

A spear of thunder fell right next to the angel who was trying to dodge desperately.

I missed the attack, but I didn't care much.

I just had to shoot until I hit.

I had long passed the level where I had to worry about running out of mana.

-“Th-this is...”

A space filled with dense lightning.

The sound effects of the skill overlapped and spread within it.

Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

Zaaaaap!

The density of the noise that went beyond the regular beat and hurt my ears.

In that bombardment, the angel's barrier was breaking and restoring repeatedly.

“How dare you play with a person as a character?”

-“Aaargh!”

“This is... the power of 3 million won.”

A huge amount of light burst out through the screen.

The beam of thunder that filled my eyes to the point of blinding.

In that overwhelming sight, the angel kept moving forward.

She was holding on with her barrier for now, but a gruesome scene would follow if she got a status effect for a moment.

Did she notice that too?

She pushed her spear forward and prepared to get out of the skill range.

-“M-merciful goddess... please give me the strength to overcome this ordeal...”

-“Aronia. I won’t let you go like this.”

-“Estasia...?”

Of course, I had no intention of letting her go nicely.

Estasia seemed to feel the same way, as she stretched out her hand and created a shield of light.

The large shield blocked the space for the angel to escape over a vast range.

If she tried to get out of the skill range, she had to break Estasia’s shield first.

I smiled at Estasia’s appearance, who was active after a long time.

“Well... what are you going to do now?”

It was a moment of dilemma.

Now the angel had to make a decision.

Would she keep fighting against me?

Or would she surrender quietly?

I looked at the screen, waiting for the angel’s decision.

Of course, my hand watching the angel kept projecting <Lightning Arrow>.

Aronia looked at the sky with despairing eyes.

Did the evil god looking at the ground have an endless power that kept rising?

The lightning falling from the sky showed no sign of ending.

Rather, Aronia's divine power, which had been receiving lightning continuously, was in danger of having problems.

Aronia clenched her teeth and raised her spear at her own situation, which was being one-sidedly dominated by the evil god.

It was too unfair a situation no matter how she thought about it.

“Show yourself and fight fair if you're an evil god!”

The evil god kept dropping lightning without even showing his appearance.

But Aronia had to keep dodging and blocking the evil god's attacks.

She couldn't inflict any damage on the evil god with the divine spear she was given.

She could only attack if she saw his appearance, but she didn't even know where the evil god was right now.

She had used up a lot of her divine power to create barriers for the proclamation of the sanctuary.

The remaining divine power was not enough to maintain the sanctuary even if she proclaimed it.

“Aronia. Give up now.”

“Do you think I’ll give up like this?”

“I won’t let you go, Aronia.”

And Estasia, who had been saving her divine power, also took out a shield and pressured Aronia.

Of course, if she had enough time, she could break through Estasia’s shield easily.

But Aronia didn’t have much time left.

If she let her guard down for a moment, she would be hit by the evil god’s lightning.

The moment her movement was blocked by the electric shock, the evil god would keep dropping spears of thunder and bind Aronia.

That would be the end of Aronia.

“Ugh... I have to break through this place somehow...”

Aronia opened her eyes wide and looked for a way to get out of here.

She intended to blind the evil god’s eyes and end the fight, but she had spent too much divine power in an unexpected situation.

The evil god, who always fought with ease, had used cheap tricks today.

On top of that, some of Aronia’s ‘bad luck’ had overlapped and worsened her situation.

It was impossible to settle things with Estasia right now.

She had to retreat and plan for later.

“...”

Aronia made a decision and looked at the gap in the shield that Estasia had hastily made.

There was a place where the bond was noticeably weaker than elsewhere.

It seemed possible to break through there with a little force.

Aronia raised her Starlight and gathered her divine power and aimed at the shield.

Crack.

The moment the barrier that wrapped her broke from the impact of lightning, Aronia's spear flew towards the gap in the shield.

Aronia's Starlight created a golden beam of light and collided with the wall of the shield.

“Are you aiming for the shield?”

Kwaaang!

Part of the wall collapsed with Estasia's sharp voice.

It was only a space where about four shields disappeared, but it was big enough for an angel to pass through.

Aronia quickly made a crack in the wall and flew towards it.

She intended to escape from the evil god's sight through the crack she made.

She flew faster than anyone else in this place and said goodbye to Estasia.

“Estasia. I'll finish this next time.”

“Aronia...!”

“Next time I come... Aaargh!”

As she tried to escape through the crack, Aronia was suddenly thrown to one side by a twisted air current.

She was thrown to the ground by the twisted air flow at an unbelievable speed.

Koong! A heavy collision sound and dust rose around Aronia.

At the same time, the barrier broke and a dull shock spread throughout Aronia's body.

The evil god had interfered with Aronia's flight in the same way as before.

“Uh, ugh...”

She couldn't afford to lie down quietly after being caught off guard by an unexpected method.

Aronia leaned on her divine spear and got up, looking at the sky with trembling eyes.

She didn't know what method he used, but it showed a power that was different from ordinary magic.

She had to get out of here as quickly as possible before the evil god interfered with her flight again.

Flap.

Aronia spread her wings and leaped into the sky again.

A golden ring behind her accelerated Aronia's body quickly.

“Quickly... I have to get out of here... ugh...”

But her body, which had accelerated, was twisted by the air current and slammed into the ground again.

Cough. Cough.

Dust flowed in over the broken barrier and Aronia coughed from her mouth.

Her body, which had endured a great speed, was in pain.

She groaned and coughed in pain, and a streak of lightning made by the evil god fell on her.

Crash!

Aronia's body convulsed as it was struck by lightning.

“Uh, ugh...”

Aronia looked up at the sky with tears in her eyes as she was hit by lightning.

Cold rain was pouring down from the sky.

It felt like her wounds hurt more as the cold rain fell on her injured skin.

Her eyes were filled with resentment as she faced the pain that kept coming.

The light that wrapped around Aronia's eyes was also faded now.

Aronia, who fell to the ground, raised her trembling hand to the sky.

“...”

She had no more divine power left.

And her body was not in a condition to fight either.

The lightning that kept falling tore her body apart with a heavy thunder sound.

The clouds that covered the sky cooled her wounded body down.

It was an arrogant judgment.

She thought she knew better than anyone about angels, so she stubbornly moved alone.

The end she faced was nothing but enduring the evil god's attacks in pain.

"Aronia."

Crackle. Sizzle.

A huge spear of thunder appeared in the cloudy sky.

The spear of thunder that aimed at her looked painful even at a glance.

With that spear of thunder above her head, Estasia, who had approached her before she knew it, looked down at Aronia.

It was a familiar but awkward face.

It was also a face that made her miss and annoyed her.

"Estasia..."

She reached out her hand and stroked Estasia's cheek, battered and bruised.

In Estasia's eyes that met hers, she saw her own reflection.

She was pitifully rolling in the mud after losing to the evil god.

She had no will or ability to fight anymore.

Estasia smiled at Aronia, who was teary-eyed.

She brushed Aronia's hair with her bleeding hand and said.

"Then... let's eat strawberries."

The moment Estasia's words to Aronia ended.

Zaaaap!

The spear of thunder made by the evil god fell.

Chapter 112: Divine Command (6)

Chapter 112: Divine Command (6)

Kwaaaaang!

A loud noise erupted from the speaker as <Lightning Arrow> struck the ground.

I moved my finger away from the angel named Aronia, who I was aiming at, and looked at the smartphone screen with a bewildered expression.

It was not because Estasia, who was in the range of the skill, blocked Aronia.

The reason why I stopped my finger was the ominous message that appeared in front of my eyes.

The moment I was about to shoot lightning at Aronia, a new message popped up.

-[Sudden Event]

-For 20 seconds, there is an added chance of summoning a high-grade creature from [Random Creature Summoning Ticket (Low-Grade)].

-Remaining time 00 : 00 : 19

Sudden event.

It was the first time I saw this type of event message.

My finger, which was looking at the message, stayed still.

I still couldn't grasp the situation properly.

Why did such an absurd event exist, and what was a high-grade creature?

I kept staring at the message with such questions in mind.

-Remaining time 00 : 00 : 11

Soon, the time had decreased to only 11 seconds left.

There was no time to think long for an event with a time limit.

I quickly moved my finger and opened the inventory.

Then I scrolled down and started looking for [Random Creature Summoning Ticket (Low-Grade)] somewhere in the inventory.

I moved my eyes busily and scanned each item's location.

But finding the desired item in the inventory quickly was not an easy task.

The item that I could easily find normally was not visible when I tried to find it urgently.

-Remaining time 00 : 00 : 06

“Ah, no... Where is it? Where is it?”

My frantic finger scrolled up and down the inventory.

The more anxious I became, the harder it was to find the item.

I couldn't even identify the icon of the item that I was familiar with.

The colors of the items that came into my eyes were also blurred and indistinguishable.

I shook my finger and moved the scroll from the top to the bottom of the inventory.

Meanwhile, the time on the message box kept flowing.

-Remaining time 00 : 00 : 02

-Remaining time 00 : 00 : 01

Remaining time 2 seconds. And then 1 second.

I moved my finger to find the item and hit the screen randomly.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

The sound of scratching the smartphone screen echoed with a rough noise.

I hoped that one of the items I pressed would contain a ticket.

As I hit the screen like that, in front of me, the countdown mercilessly approached zero.

“Huh...?”

The whole screen was wrapped in light, and Aronia, who was lying in front of Estasia, disappeared.

Aronia, who disappeared from the screen, began to descend while receiving light under the sky where lightning fell.

The sky opened and light poured out from beyond the clouds.

The bright beam of light that came from beyond the open clouds illuminated Aronia's figure.

Despite being a scene where an angel descended from heaven, Aronia, who had been battered, was still lying down.

Aronia appeared with a brilliant glow and landed in front of Estasia's eyes while lying down.

Aronia, who came down to the ground while lying down, landed on the spot where he had been lying before.

As a result, nothing had changed.

-You have summoned [Seraphim: Aronia].

-[Seraphim: Aronia] respects you with awe?

-<Heavenly Calling of Karma> converts [Seraphim: Aronia]'s actions into your causality rate.

As Aronia came down from heaven and plunged into the swamp again, several messages poured out from the message box at the bottom of the screen.

[Seraphim: Aronia] was newly summoned, or <Heavenly Calling of Karma> would now be affected by Aronia.

Most of them were similar to when I created Estasia.

I looked at Aronia with a dumbfounded face as I saw the messages that appeared in front of me.

I used it because they said there was a chance of getting a high-grade creature if I used it within 20 seconds, but what actually appeared was Aronia who had been there all along.

This is hardly 'random'.

Not to mention that it wasn't even a proper 'summon'.

"What is this? No, you said it was a summoning ticket..."

I felt empty as I saw the ticket that disappeared without a trace.

I used it hastily because there was a time limit, but the result was a summoning in place.

I don't even know what I was aiming for when I used the ticket in 20 seconds.

Of course, it's better to be recognized as a creature than a fanatic.

Maybe if I had a rare creature in front of me, such a sudden event would happen to the ticket holder.

It could be seen as a capture event in its own way.

The more I dug into it, the more I realized it was a game with no foundation.

“Well, whatever... I guess it's fine since I succeeded in taming?”

Since I got an angel, a rare species, in my hands, I didn't feel too bad about the cost of one ticket.

I got Estasia-level power for a cheap price.

Maybe it was a creature that was much stronger than Estasia.

I decided to move on with a good mood, thinking about the future possibilities.

The more powerful characters I had, the better.

Tuk.

I closed the inventory with my finger and turned my gaze to the angels on the screen.

Aronia and Estasia, who were summoned by using the ticket, were having a conversation.

-“Aronia.”

-“...Estasia.”

-“There are a lot of good humans here.”

-“...”

-“Strawberries and grapes come out every day.”

Pfft.

I couldn't help but laugh at the conversation.

That was because Estasia was making her followers bring them to her.

Anyone who saw it would think there was a vending machine that produced unlimited strawberries and grapes.

Aronia also smiled faintly at Estasia's words.

-“That might be a little nice.”

-“Yeah.”

-“I think I kind of understand why you want to stay here...”

I didn't know the details of what happened between them, but from listening to their conversation, it seemed like Aronia had tried to take Estasia away.

Maybe he wanted to take Estasia away because they were both angels.

When I learned the truth, I felt a bit sick.

I picked up my smartphone with one hand and looked at the two angels who were talking on the screen.

They looked tilted.

“How dare you laugh at me?”

Thud. Thud.

I tapped Estasia and Aronia's heads with my finger.

Screams filled with screams rose above their heads.

After confirming that, I turned off the screen of my smartphone and put it down on the table.

I was so engrossed in playing the game for a while that I felt more tired than I thought.

It would be nice to take a break and turn off the game for a while.

I locked my smartphone and started putting cold chicken in my mouth.

The crispy chicken in my mouth was more delicious than ever in this good situation.

A week later.

Estasia was drinking strawberry juice as usual and looked down at Aronia below.

Aronia, who had healed his wounds completely, was busy cleaning Estasia's room.

Even though Aronia was working hard to clean the room, Estasia didn't lift a finger.

Rather, she gave him some advice in a relaxed manner towards Aronia who was cleaning.

"Aronia. There's dust over there."

"...Estasia."

"You can't move the ring down there. It's my favorite."

Estasia gave Aronia some advice and sipped her strawberry juice.

She enjoyed her leisure alone while passing on her work to another angel.

This was the scene that Estasia had always dreamed of.

Of course, Aronia's expression was not good as he received orders from Estasia.

He moved his broom hard with a dissatisfied expression on his face.

He flapped his wings and protested to Estasia who was eating and playing.

"When I was in heaven, I was your boss...! How can you boss me around like this!"

"Aronia. This is natural here."

"Ugh..."

"Estasia is on top here. Yeah."

Estasia reminded him of their positions with a confident face.

After Aronia surrendered to the evil god and joined the cult, he had to follow Estasia's orders.

Their master confirmed that Estasia's position was higher than his.

There was no one higher than Estasia in the Ceterant branch of the cult.

Even though he was a fallen angel from heaven, he couldn't go against Estasia's orders.

Maybe it was because he was being bossed around by an angel who used to be his subordinate.

Aronia had to complete his assigned tasks with his face flushed with shame.

“Just wait. Someday I’ll fix your lazy personality...”

“...I don’t like that. Aronia do it for me.”

“Estasia! Aaargh...!”

“Aronia. Do you want a strawberry?”

“Yes please.”

Aronia, who was moving his broom with anger, stopped in front of Estasia.

Estasia put a plump ripe strawberry in Aronia’s mouth.

They were high-quality fruits that the cult’s followers had brought with difficulty.

Aronia shivered and flapped his wings as he put a strawberry in his mouth.

The halo above his head also flickered brightly.

A few white feathers fell to the floor from Aronia’s wing flapping.

“You dropped some feathers. You need to clean those up too.”

“Ugh...”

“I wish I had known you were good at cleaning. I would have asked you to do it when we were in heaven.”

“You wouldn’t have listened to me anyway! I was your superior and you were my subordinate!”

Aronia expressed his short displeasure and resumed his sweeping with a depressed look.

He had to clean up the feathers that had fallen to the floor because of his wing flapping.

His expression turned gloomy as he looked down at the floor and swept.

Estasia, on the other hand, didn't care whether he was sad or not. She just ate fruits and watched.

She teased Aronia while putting an orange in her mouth and asked him another question.

“Aronia.”

“Yes. What is it this time?”

“Why did you come to the master?”

Estasia's question was unexpected.

Aronia's broom stopped again as he was moving busily.

His eyes gazed blankly at the sky as he stopped his broom.

The sky beyond the window was filled with a sunny autumn scenery.

Blink. Blink.

He opened his mouth with a hollow voice as he stared at the sky blankly.

“I don't know. I really don't know.”

“...”

“Maybe it was because of what the goddess said at the end...”

He closed his mouth tightly as he was about to say something.

Estasia looked at him with a puzzled expression.

But there was no continuation of Aronia's cut-off words.

He shook his head slightly with his mouth closed.

Then he turned his gaze to Estasia and spoke in a slightly lowered voice.

“No, it’s nothing. I just hated being hurt.”

“Aronia. You’re weird.”

“The weird one is not me, but Estasia.”

“Hmm...”

Estasia doubted Aronia for a moment, but soon put down the fruit basket and lay down on the bed.

She decided not to dig deeper if he thought that way.

She wrapped her body with her wings and rolled around on the bed.

Only Estasia’s face hidden in her wings peeked out from the outside.

She spoke to Aronia with her face sticking out.

Let’s have a snack together when you’re done cleaning. It was a simple promise.

“Let’s eat fruits together when you’re done with that.”

“Okay. I’ll finish quickly.”

“Yeah.”

Aronia continued his sweeping at a faster speed than before after hearing Estasia’s promise.

Of course, because Aronia had cleaned up the chapel by himself, they could only eat fruits together after an hour had passed.

It was a bonus that half of the fruits in the basket had already disappeared into Estasia’s stomach.

Chapter 113.1: The Price of Slaughter (1) Part 1

Chapter 113: The Price of Slaughter (1)

Inquisitors.

They were the knights who represented the law and order of the temple, dispatched from the holy land.

Their role was to execute the black magicians who made contracts with demons, the followers of the evil god, and those who committed blasphemy, and to bring them to the religious trial.

Albert, a knight who was sent to the southern region of the empire, was one of those inquisitors.

He was traveling around the Everlint province with his apprentice knights.

Albert finished his work for the day and looked at the apprentice knights in front of him.

The appearance of the apprentice knights who had collected information according to Albert's orders was a mess.

“So, any new news?”

Albert asked one of them, who was standing on his left.

He was an apprentice knight who was in charge of contacting the temple, since it was his first time in the field.

It was to organize the information that the temple sent him regularly.

Was it because he felt pressured to face Albert like this?

He swallowed his saliva with a nervous face and started to talk to Albert with a trembling voice.

Some of the cult's members were confirmed to be heading to the Everlint region."

"The heretics are moving to the Everlint region?"

"Yes. I don't know their exact purpose, but the knights of the southern region are pursuing them."

"I see... They're coming to the Everlint region, huh."

Albert stroked his beard as he checked the information that came from the temple.

It seemed like no ordinary matter, judging by the fact that they had caught the heretics in a group.

There was a high possibility that the cult had sent a large number of people for some purpose.

Was it a support for the cult's forces in the Everlint branch?

Or was there something in the Everlint branch that the cult wanted to retrieve?

Albert rolled his eyes as he pondered, and continued to ask more questions to the apprentice knight.

"How many heretics are there?"

"About twenty, estimated. So far, two have been killed and one captured."

“One captured... You must have heard from him about the heretics’ destination. What happened to him?”

“He killed himself while we were trying to get information about the cult’s headquarters.”

The information that the heretics were moving to the Everlint region was obtained by interrogating the captured heretic.

The ‘Shadow Squad’ of the holy land was known for their best skills in information gathering and prisoner torture.

If they had learned something from their interrogation, there was no doubt about the content of the information.

Tap. Tap.

Albert tapped the table with his finger and asked one last question about the order.

“Was there any additional instructions?”

“The order was to annihilate the heretics with the pursuit team as soon as possible.”

“Alright. I got it. You’ve done well, so take a break for a while.”

“Thank you...”

The apprentice knight bowed his head and left outside after hearing Albert’s order.

It was Albert’s own consideration for the knight who had repeated long journeys.

Creak.

As the door closed and the apprentice knight disappeared, Albert’s worries continued as he sat on his chair.

He recalled the information that the apprentice knight had left behind, and began to think about his future plans.

“Hmm...”

He had to annihilate about twenty heretics.

It seemed that the headquarters wanted the inquisitors in the Everlint region to deal with the heretics together.

They wanted to pressure the heretics from both sides and cut off their escape route.

It was a sure way to mobilize many people, since there were quite a lot of enemies.

But the problem was the order that Albert had received before.

He had come here to kill a black magician who had hidden in the Everlint region.

And he had made considerable progress in investigating the black magician he had been chasing.

“How is it going with tracking him down?”

Albert’s eyes turned to another apprentice knight as he pondered his mission.

The apprentice knight he met this time, Crook, was a person who had not much left to remove his label as an apprentice.

He was also a reliable person who had been with Albert for a long time.

As Albert’s eyes turned to him, Crook cleared his throat and told him some information.

It was the information about the black magician they had been chasing all this time.

“We found traces of black magic along with some testimonies. It seems certain that he is hiding in this village.”

“We’re almost there.”

“Judging by the increasing traces, the black magician is also quite desperate. I think it would be better to search all the buildings in the village tomorrow, even if we have to force our way in.”

They were close to catching the black magician they had been pursuing.

If they didn’t move quickly, they might lose the black magician they had almost found.

It was foolish to leave the black magician alone and go after the heretics.

It would be better to finish the work here quickly and then move on, even if they joined a little late.

Swoosh.

Albert pushed his chair away and got up from his seat after hearing the report from his subordinate.

The lightweight armor he wore under his cloak made a metallic friction sound.

“I’ll do as you planned. I’ll search all the buildings in the village, even if I have to use force.”

Albert got up from his seat and put his hand on Crook’s shoulder, who had given him the report.

Thud. Thud.

Albert’s touch lightly tapped his shoulder.

It was to praise Crook’s merit in front of him.

Crook flinched at Albert's sudden touch, but he soon tried to maintain his calmness.

"I understand. I'll prepare to fight as you ordered, Albert."

"Crook. When this mission is over, you'll be a full-fledged knight."

"Albert..."

"Someday, you'll become a great inquisitor and join me in the mission."

Crook's face was filled with emotion as he heard Albert's words.

He was finally recognized as a knight after a long apprenticeship.

It was a moment of joy that he couldn't compare with any other moment in his life.

Crook looked at Albert with a determined posture.

And he thanked Albert.

"Thank you, Albert! I'll never forget the teachings you gave me..."

Albert nodded and smiled as he heard Crook's gratitude.

The extermination of the heretics after the subjugation of the black magician would be the last operation with Crook.

May the goddess lead this frail soul to the path of glory.

Albert finished his short prayer to God and drew a cross with his finger.

Daniel Heslop, a farmer in Everlint, was on his way home after finishing his work on the farm today.

He had a lot of work today, so he didn't get home until evening.

There was urgency in Daniel's face as he hurried home after finishing his work quickly.

He still had a leather pouch with tools from the slaughterhouse hanging on his waist.

It was impossible for Daniel to avoid Anna's nagging when he was late for dinner.

It was better to get home as soon as possible.

"Huff, huff..."

As he got closer to home, Daniel's mouth burst out with rough breaths.

It was a distance that he could have easily caught his breath when he was young.

But now that he was getting old, he couldn't expect the same stamina as before.

What he gained from losing his youthful strength was cunning.

The skills that came from his experience were the only thing that supported Daniel now.

But even with his developed skills, it was not easy to calm down Anna, who was annoyed.

Daniel looked around the fence that surrounded his house with a worried face.

As soon as he opened the door and crossed the fence, Anna's nagging would start.

"I wish you would end your nagging quickly today, I'm tired..."

Daniel sighed and approached the door, catching his breath.

Thud. Thud.

The moment Daniel's footsteps crossed the yard and reached the closed door.

Daniel's eyes caught a strange footprint on the floor.

The muddy footprint was completely different from the shoes Daniel had.

Daniel frowned at the footprint.

“Did someone come in with muddy feet? Who the hell is...”

It was unlikely that the villagers had done this.

Daniel didn't like anyone coming into his house with muddy feet.

He had scolded a young child in the village for doing that, and the child had cried.

The villagers who knew Daniel's temper wouldn't have come to see Anna without even cleaning their shoes.

Then the guest who came this time was a stranger.

The image of the inquisitor who had visited his farm a while ago flashed through Daniel's mind.

“Could it be...”

The inquisitor who had visited him was wearing armor with the temple's emblem on it.

What would happen if the inquisitor who had visited him then suspected him and came to his house?

And what if he heard from Anna about the secret of the ring Daniel was wearing?

Daniel's face darkened in an instant.

Daniel's hand holding the doorknob trembled greatly.

Daniel's hand, worried about Anna who was left alone in the house, opened the door roughly.

“Anna! Anna...”

Bang!

A loud noise echoed as Daniel entered the house.

As soon as he opened the door and entered, he saw muddy footprints scattered messily on the floor.

They were not ordinary guests.

It was clear that they had come to ransack Daniel's house on purpose.

Daniel started to follow the footprints in front of him, calling Anna's name anxiously.

He hoped that Anna in the house would be safe.

“Anna! Where are you!”

Daniel's eyes scanned the house that had changed messily with things scattered around.

The more he saw, the more he wanted to pray to God for this horrible sight.

He prayed in his heart to the evil god he prayed to every day, hoping that Anna was safe.

He felt like he could sacrifice as many livestock as he wanted if only Anna was safe.

As he searched the house nervously, Daniel soon found something.

Inside the bedroom that Daniel and Anna used.

There he saw Anna standing with her back against the curtain.

Chapter 114.2: The Price of Slaughter (1) Part 2

Chapter 114: The Price of Slaughter (1) Part 2

“Honey?”

“Anna! Are you okay...”

“Watch out, honey!”

Before I finished my words of concern for Anna, she shouted at me.

She was warning me of something.

Right after her voice ended, a black sphere flew past my ear.

I widened my eyes at the sight I had never seen before.

The black sphere exploded as soon as it hit the wall.

Boom!

The pillar that touched the sphere turned black and rotted.

I saw the magic flying in front of me and asked Anna.

“What the hell is this?”

“I barely managed to save our lives, but we’re lucky.”

As soon as my voice of doubt ended.

A man emerged from behind the curtain where Anna was leaning.

He was wearing a robe and holding a black sphere in his hand.

When I faced the man who appeared behind Anna, I realized he was a black mage.

He was not like the inquisitors I was wary of.

He was the black mage that the inquisitors were after.

I tried to overcome the fear that surged in my chest as I faced the black mage.

“What do you want from our house?”

The black mage in front of me had tried to subdue me, not kill me.

If I could talk to him, I might be able to send him away without any trouble.

That’s why I chose to talk to the black mage.

I wanted to persuade him and save Anna.

“I need more sacrifices. There’s a guy who runs a big farm in this village.”

“Are you only after the livestock? I heard that black mages don’t hesitate to sacrifice humans...”

“The demon I contracted is greedy. He won’t be satisfied with just a few humans.”

“That’s... a relief, I guess.”

“So lead me to your farm. I’ll spare this woman if you do.”

Zzzz.

The black mage brought the black sphere in his hand closer to Anna as he spoke.

I finally understood his purpose from his words.

He still kept Anna alive, which meant he had something to do with me and my farm.

He wanted to use the countless livestock on my farm as sacrifices for his black magic.

I thought of my farm as I saw the black mage threatening me with Anna.

“...”

It was the farm that I had worked hard for all my life.

If I lost the livestock on my farm, it would mean that everything I had done was gone.

But even that farm was not more valuable than Anna.

I could sacrifice the livestock on my farm for Anna.

I made up my mind and nodded at the black mage.

“Fine. Follow me.”

Chapter 115: The Price of Slaughter (2)

Chapter 115: The Price of Slaughter (2)

“This is where we’ll hide.”

Outside, darkness had fallen.

Daniel led the black mage to a crudely made cart and lifted the leather cover.

“Get in here.”

The black mage still held a black sphere in his hand.

He frowned at the sight of the cart, which had some luggage on it.

It seemed that he was repulsed by the appearance of the cart, which was infested with bugs from carrying livestock byproducts and farm supplies.

He lifted the leather cover with his free hand and glared at Daniel.

“You want me to get in there?”

“...This is the best we can do.”

“Damn, this is why I hate country folks. How am I supposed to hide my body?”

“If you cover yourself with leather, it won’t look suspicious from a distance.”

Fortunately, Daniel's cart had a piece of leather that he had prepared for tanning.

If he covered himself with leather and moved, no one would suspect Daniel's appearance.

He sometimes visited the farm late at night.

The black mage climbed onto the cart with a scowl on his face.

Even then, his magic was still aimed at Daniel.

"Don't get out of my sight. If you try to escape, I'll kill you right away. Got it?"

The black mage pulled the leather over his head and warned Daniel with a sharp look.

It meant that he would not spare Daniel if he did anything rash.

No matter how much his opponent was a farmer, he did not like having him in his blind spot.

Daniel nodded and agreed with the black mage's words.

He had no reason to provoke the black mage right now.

If they were caught by the heretic inquisitors who might be lurking around, not only the black mage but also Daniel might be misunderstood.

"I promise you. I won't get out of your sight."

"Then hurry up and move."

"...All right."

Daniel finished answering the black mage and grabbed the cart.

He often carried heavy loads, but he always got help from the villagers.

Daniel felt that the cart was heavier than usual today.

Rattle rattle rattle.

Daniel started pushing the cart and left the fence.

In the dark night, an unpleasant sound of wheels echoed.

Daniel moved forward with caution, wary of someone who might be watching him from somewhere.

The sharp eyes of the black mage under the leather cover were still watching Daniel.

“Drive as quietly as possible. If we get caught, you’ll die first.”

“Huff...”

It felt like he was carrying a whole cow that he had slaughtered on his cart.

Sweat dripped from his hands holding the cart.

His breath became rough in the dangerous night trade.

Still, Daniel’s steps did not falter.

There was no sound from the cart that Daniel was driving except for his rough breathing and the sound of wheels.

It was thanks to Daniel moving quietly as if he was working.

“Let me know if you see anyone nearby.”

Nod.

Daniel quietly moved his head and looked ahead with a wary look.

There was still some distance left to the edge of the village.

It wouldn't be strange to meet someone at any time.

As if to prove him right, he saw a lantern flickering in the distance.

Daniel swallowed nervously as he watched the movement of the fire far away.

He followed the trace of the lantern and looked down at the black mage's sharp eyes.

"There's someone coming this way."

"...You deal with him."

"It would be better if you hid yourself more."

The black mage lifted the leather cover with an annoyed face at Daniel's words.

His sight was blocked by more than half under the leather cover.

He seemed to be trying to hide himself as thoroughly as possible.

Daniel looked away from him and looked ahead again.

A young man holding a lantern was approaching him.

The young man with the lantern was a stranger who had come to the village recently.

He had not seen him with the heretic inquisitors, but he was likely to be related to them somehow.

Daniel greeted him without lowering his guard.

"Wow, you're out late. You're new here... What was your name again?"

"Oh, I'm Renble. You're Daniel, right? The one who runs a ranch. I heard from others that you're the richest man in town."

“You don’t have to flatter me.”

The young man who met Daniel smiled and returned his greeting.

Daniel watched Renble as he exchanged greetings with him, but he kept his attention on the black mage hiding under the leather cover.

Was it because he was moving alone with a cart in the dark night?

The young man who had followed Daniel to look at the leather approached him with a lantern.

As he got closer to the black mage, Daniel felt a cold sweat run down his spine.

“What are you doing here without a lantern at night? Do you mind telling me what’s going on?”

“Are you curious?”

“If I can help you with anything, even for a moment... Ugh, there are so many bugs.”

Renble, who was holding the lantern and examining the leather, stepped back when he saw the bugs clinging to the leather.

The leather, which had not been fully tanned yet, was infested with all kinds of insects.

Renble looked disgusted by the sight of the bugs, as if he had grown up in a sheltered environment.

Daniel took advantage of his reaction and pushed the cart forward, approaching him.

As the cart full of bug-ridden leather came closer, Renble retreated even further.

“I guess you don’t like bugs.”

“I’m sorry, but I can’t stand them. They look so repulsive...”

“Of course, I don’t like them either. I haven’t been able to take care of this leather properly, so it’s worse than I expected.”

It was common for leather to rot or get infested with bugs if it was not tanned properly after slaughtering.

Daniel, who had spent his whole life skinning animals, knew that well.

He had moved the leather that he couldn’t deal with right away to his farm, and it turned out to be useful for him now.

Renble sighed as he listened to Daniel’s story and looked at the leather.

“Ah...”

“I think it will be a mess if I leave this in the yard for too long, so I’m going to sprinkle some more salt on it and put it in the farm.”

Seeing the leather crawling with bugs, Renble nodded vigorously and backed away a few more steps.

Renble frowned and backed away, and Daniel smiled and tapped the cart.

He was trying to shake off the bugs that had stuck to the handle.

The black mage, who was hiding in the cart, flinched at Daniel’s touch, but luckily Renble didn’t seem to notice.

Renble, who had moved far away, spoke to Daniel.

“Oh, I see. You should be careful on the dark road.”

“I’ve been traveling this long, I know the way even without a light.”

“I guess I worried for nothing. I’m a bit tired, so I’ll go ahead.”

Daniel also gave Renble a brief warning, something he always said when a stranger came by.

“It’s better not to wander around at night. The villagers won’t like it.”

“I’ll keep that in mind. Well then...”

Renble quickly agreed and grabbed his lantern, starting to walk away.

But he didn’t forget to turn his head and glance at Daniel periodically.

Daniel sighed softly as he watched Renble get farther away from him and looked at the cart.

The black mage was still hiding under the leather, holding it tightly.

Because Renble had moved to the back of the cart, his view was mostly blocked.

He couldn’t even see Daniel’s movements properly.

“Phew...”

Daniel took his sweaty hand off the handle and rubbed it on his pants.

He was trying to wipe off the sweat that had come out of his nervousness.

As he rubbed his palm on his pants, something caught his hand.

Thud.

Daniel looked at what had caught his palm.

What Daniel had in his palm was a leather pouch that contained his butchering tools.

He had forgotten to take them off in his haste, and they were still hanging from his waist.

Daniel could easily identify his butchering tools even in the darkness.

“Did that guy just pass by?”

A small voice echoed in Daniel’s ears as he touched the pouch.

It was the voice of the black mage, muffled by the leather.

But Daniel had no room to care about the black mage’s voice right now.

His attention was drawn to the butchering knife in his hand.

Daniel’s right hand had unconsciously grabbed the butchering knife.

Daniel’s eyes followed the sharp blade that reflected the moonlight.

“...”

He felt the cold touch of the handle on his fingertips.

The knife was heavy but light, and very familiar to him.

It was like an extension of his limbs, for he had devoted himself to his work as a butcher.

He had taken countless lives of livestock with the knife he held.

He could not comprehend how many lives had slipped through his fingers.

“Are you deaf? I asked you if he went by. Don’t tell me you’re still watching him?”

His hand holding the blade was full of calluses.

Impulse and instinct.

He felt the sensation of the sharp blade through his skin.

He remembered the feeling of cutting through flesh with his fingers.

He also remembered the texture of breaking bones with his hand.

His eyes moved from the knife to the leather in front of him.

“...”

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

The moment he faced the leather where someone was hiding, his suppressed heartbeat burst out clearly.

The knife in his hand was cold.

But his eyes looking at the knife were hot.

His blood boiled as he looked at his enemy.

What he saw in front of him was an animal's hide.

The hide of an animal that he had quietly cut off its throat with his knife.

“If you don't answer by the count of three, I'll chop off one of your arms. Three.”

Daniel's face hardened as he looked at the cart.

There was a livestock in front of him.

A livestock that was cowering in fear, wearing the hide of a dead animal.

Daniel's hand holding the butchering knife quietly tightened its grip.

His hand moved in the blind spot hidden by the height of the cart.

“Two.”

His instinct whispered to him.

Kill the beast in front of you.

Kill the beast that threatens you and your family.

His rough breathing stopped for a moment.

He held his breath and quietly lifted his knife.

He never made a loud noise when he killed livestock.

“One.”

Breaking bones and cutting throats.

That was the butcher’s job.

The knife in his hand pulsed.

The butcher’s knife that had soaked in countless blood thirsted for new blood.

His hand moved up in the silence.

His eyes were calm as he clenched his knife with both hands.

“Thunder—.”

Thud. Thwack.

His knife pierced through the beast’s hide in the silence.

That was the end of its life.

The silent butcher never made a loud noise.

Daniel, who had stabbed his knife into the thick hide, continued to move the cart.

His eyes were soaked in silence as he looked at his farm.

Chapter 116: The Price of Slaughter (3)

Chapter 116: The Price of Slaughter (3)

The next morning.

I had to go to the farm earlier than usual.

It was to finish the work that I couldn't finish yesterday, before anyone else came.

There were still traces of the black mage I had killed yesterday on my farm.

It was the first time I had ever used a knife on a person, even though I was Daniel.

The dead black mage was still hidden in a corner of the slaughterhouse.

I had to clean up his traces before anyone found out.

“This is a mess.”

I said as I entered the slaughterhouse and saw the leather in the corner.

I had brought the black mage I killed last night and covered him with it.

The slaughterhouse was a place where I had forbidden anyone else to enter.

I had hidden the black mage there with the door locked, but I didn't know when someone would come.

If someone found out the truth under the leather, it would be the end of me.

Not only the inquisitors of the holy land, but also the Cloud of the empire would come to investigate me.

“I have to hide this somehow.”

I fiddled with the tools on my waist, and then turned my head when I felt a presence outside.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

From beyond the closed door of the slaughterhouse, I heard heavy footsteps.

The footsteps that reached my ears were getting louder.

The footsteps stopped right in front of the door of the slaughterhouse.

Someone had come to the slaughterhouse.

Bang.

A heavy hand shook the locked door.

I took my hand off my waist and leaned my back against the door.

“Who is it?”

I asked the person behind the wall, sticking to the door.

I wanted to find out if he was an inquisitor by his voice.

When he heard my voice, the man on the other side made a rustling sound with a hoarse voice.

It was not a familiar voice to me.

He shook the door for a while, and then spoke to me inside.

“Huff, is this... where Daniel lives...?”

“I’m Daniel.”

I admitted my identity to the voice that was looking for me, breathing heavily.

He must have known exactly who I was and came for me.

I didn’t know why he came, but he looked very urgent.

Bang. Bang.

The man banged on the door again after hearing my answer.

He spoke louder so that I could hear him.

“I’m Elliot, sent by the order. I came to see you.”

“Is that so.”

“Can I come in and see your face, please? Can you open the door?”

Order.

The unexpected word made my eyes harden.

I had told Archbishop Roan the location of my farm at the last meeting.

If Roan had sent someone to contact me, it wouldn’t be strange if he arrived now.

But to face the order in this situation...

It was the worst situation for me.

“Wait a minute.”

I couldn’t just leave Elliot waiting at the door.

If the inquisitors saw a follower of the cult standing at the door, it wouldn't be strange if they blew up the whole village, not just me.

Even if it meant exposing myself as an ordinary farmer, I had to hide Elliot in the slaughterhouse.

Clank. Creak.

I unlocked the door and opened it, looking at Elliot who was standing at the door.

He was bleeding from his forehead, looking at me.

“You can come in.”

“The smell of blood...”

“It's a slaughterhouse. The smell must have lingered.”

Elliot immediately covered his nose as he entered the slaughterhouse.

The peculiar smell of the slaughterhouse was hard to bear.

And the stench of the black mage and the leather I had brought in at dawn was also mixed in.

I asked Elliot to be careful and locked the door of the slaughterhouse.

The door was closed as tightly as before he came in.

He pulled back his hood and spoke to me.

“You can speak freely. Besides, you have a ring on your left hand.”

“A ring?”

“It's a ring that only those chosen by the order receive. Everyone in the order will respect your words as their priority.”

I looked at the gemstone ring on my left hand.

It was the cause of dragging me to the regular meeting of the order.

It seemed that this ring had a tremendous power hidden in it.

I nodded and accepted Elliot's suggestion.

There was no reason not to speak freely if he said so.

"Let's do that."

"Yes. That's fine."

"Do I have to do the same to others?"

"Of course, you can speak freely to anyone else in the order... Ah, ah!"

As he tried to get closer to me, Elliot stepped on the leather.

Swish.

He slipped forward as he stepped on the leather.

He tried to regain his balance, but some of the leather under his foot slid forward.

As the leather slid forward, it revealed the black mage that was covered by it.

Elliot panicked and backed away as he faced the dead black mage.

"Ah, ah, ahhhh...!"

"What are you doing?"

"I'm sorry! I didn't know that's what you meant by a slaughterhouse..."

"..."

“This person must have been your target yesterday. You did a good job, worthy of your name as the silent butcher...”

Elliot tried to make excuses under my glare.

I sighed and rubbed my forehead.

I had covered him with leather to avoid the eyes of the inquisitors, but I ended up exposing him to someone from the order.

It seemed that Elliot had a huge misunderstanding after seeing that.

Daniel spoke to Elliot, who was backing away with a scared expression.

“This thing... it’s not what you think.”

“Oh... I’m sorry. It seems that wasn’t your full power. If you used your full power, you would have dealt with the target much more cleanly.”

“Huff...”

“Anyway, I’m so glad to meet you like this! I think I can trust and ask you for a favor, since you are the renowned Daniel!”

As Daniel made an awkward face in the growing misunderstanding, Elliot started to talk about his request.

A request for Daniel himself.

Daniel looked at Elliot with a doubtful expression.

What kind of request could the church have for him, who was nothing more than a farmer in the frontier?

Daniel couldn’t easily imagine what it was.

“A request...?”

“Yes! I have a desperate request for you, Daniel, the Silent Slayer!”

“What is it?”

“My subordinates who were traveling with me to this place were ambushed by the heresy inquisitors and scattered in all directions!”

“What did you say?”

“I barely escaped and came to ask for your salvation! Please, save my subordinates who are in danger!”

Daniel felt suffocated when he heard Elliot’s request.

Asking him to save his colleagues who were chased by the heresy inquisitors meant that he had to fight against them.

They wanted me, a mere farmer, to fight off the heresy inquisitors.

That was an absurd request, even if they were desperate.

Did they really think I was some formidable assassin?

I felt cold sweat on my palms as I thought that.

“Did you say you were ambushed by the heresy inquisitors?”

“I’m ashamed to ask you this favor on our first meeting, Daniel. But you are the only one I can rely on right now!”

“I…”

“Please, I beg you! They are loyal followers of the Great One! You have to save them!”

Elliot quickly approached me and grabbed my pant leg.

Squeeze.

I looked at him with a bewildered gaze as he held onto my pants.

I had no power to kill the heresy inquisitors and rescue the church's believers.

That was something only the evil god in the sky could do.

I grabbed Elliot's hand that was holding my pant leg.

And as I tried to pull it off, I spoke to him.

"Listen carefully. I can't do that..."

"Help me! Daniel!"

"..."

"Daniel! Please, I implore you! You are the only hope we have from the Great One!"

The more I tried to shake him off, the more he clung to me.

This was troublesome.

I couldn't do anything for them in this situation.

I was not their savior.

I didn't have the ability to perform miraculous feats like the others in the church.

All I could do was slaughter weak beasts.

I had killed a careless black mage on impulse, but that was nothing but a fluke.

"Don't count on me."

So I had to reject him harshly.

I had to reveal my pathetic identity, even if it meant crushing his hopes.

I glared at Elliot who was hanging onto my pant leg.

I wanted to make him face reality.

“Daniel...?”

“All I can do is turn living meat into dead meat.”

“What do you mean...?”

“I can’t accept your request—”

Thud.

My words were cut off.

I hastily got up and looked at the locked door outside.

There was a voice echoing from outside.

A voice that was familiar to me.

“Landlord! Are you there!”

It was the voice of a heresy inquisitor.

As I heard the powerful voice of the heresy inquisitor, a chill ran down my spine.

My eyes, frozen cold, looked at the scene of the slaughterhouse.

There were a dead black mage and a church believer hiding in the slaughterhouse.

If the door of the slaughterhouse opened.

And if the heresy inquisitor saw this sight, what would happen?

It was obvious that it would be the end.

“I don’t think we have much time to talk. For now, we need to hide...”

“Landlord! We know you’re here! We have some questions for you, so come out for a moment!”

“Damn it, that heresy inquisitor bastard.”

I pushed Elliot away and checked the lock of the slaughterhouse.

Thankfully, the lock of the slaughterhouse was firmly closed.

If I pretended to be absent, maybe the heresy inquisitors would give up and go back to the village.

As I held my breath and tried to endure, I heard Albert’s voice again from outside.

“There are footprints on that building. Could it be that the landlord is there?”

This time, his voice sounded like he had pinpointed my location.

It seemed that Elliot had left his footprints when he came in here.

If they followed Elliot’s footprints, it was natural to guess that I was here.

I glared at Elliot with cold sweat dripping from my forehead.

Elliot was also trembling after hearing the word heresy inquisitor.

“Landlord! Are you there?”

Bang! Bang!

The door of the slaughterhouse shook with the rough knocks of the heresy inquisitor.

I grabbed the lock with my shaking hand as I saw it shaking.

I couldn't let them discover Elliot and me.

The moment this door opened, Anna and I would be as good as dead.

The lock that I held with my stiff hand kept shaking from the violent knocks.

"Maybe you can't hear me because the knocks are too quiet!"

Crash!

A louder noise rang out.

A small crack appeared on the door that collided with the heresy inquisitor's fist.

If this continued, the door would eventually open.

There were armed heresy inquisitors in front of me, and behind me were the believers of the evil god sent by the church.

It was a situation of being trapped on all sides.

"Ah..."

And when that moment came, those weak humans would suddenly realize something.

The final moment.

There was nowhere to lean on,

Only their pitiful human flesh remained below.

All they could do was shout out the name of God.

"Oh God..."

Chapter 117: The Price of Slaughter (4)

Chapter 117: The Price of Slaughter (4)

“God... please...”

Daniel’s lips trembled faintly as he cried out the name of God.

He couldn’t believe what he had just said.

He looked at his own pathetic reflection and frowned.

What was he trying to do?

He was asking for help from the evil god he had feared so much.

The evil god he had begged for his life every night, and now he was begging for his future.

“Ha...”

It was a ridiculous sight.

He had lied and acted tough in the meeting, but in the end, he revealed his weakness and tried to prolong his life.

How could he not feel like a fool for criticizing the others who attended the meeting?

How dare he call anyone the source of evil when he was crying out for salvation to the evil god in danger?

Daniel was much more pitiful than the evil he had despised.

He was hoping for a miracle to happen right away.

Deep in his heart, he wished that a lightning bolt would strike and end this painful situation.

“Hey! Owner! Are you in there?”

But of course, there was no miracle for those who didn’t act.

There was no lightning falling on the heads of the inquisitors.

And yet, Daniel’s crisis was getting closer and closer.

Bang! Boom!

The lock bent under the forceful blows from the other side.

The wooden planks that blocked the door also cracked slightly.

Daniel clenched his teeth and held the twisted lock firmly.

Two voices reached his ears from behind and in front of him.

“What should we do?”

“Owner! I don’t know if you can hear me, but we don’t have much time left.”

“I have to abandon my comrades and run away from here if Daniel doesn’t step up...”

“Open the door by the count of three! Or I’ll break it down!”

The cultist who was clinging to him and the inquisitor who was trying to break the door.

Daniel got up in the frustrating situation.

His thick hand opened the leather pouch and grabbed the butcher knife inside.

It was the same knife he had used to kill the black mage last night.

A cold sensation spread from his fingertips as he held the knife.

At the same time, the rough voice of the inquisitor reached his ears.

“One!”

Bang!

The inquisitor pounded on the door as a warning.

As he had said before, he would enter as soon as he counted to three.

The image of the inquisitor flashed through Daniel’s mind.

His hesitant hand slowly lost its strength.

The knife would not penetrate the armor made for the paladins.

And if he failed to kill him with one strike, the inquisitor would quickly heal his wound and attack Daniel.

“Two!”

Daniel couldn’t handle all the inquisitors with his hand.

What he needed now was overwhelming power.

He needed power to deal with them all and suppress those who would come after them.

People called them monsters.

It was something that only those who attended the regular meeting of the cult could do.

To protect this village and Anna, he had to become a monster like them.

As Daniel pondered, the inquisitor's final count echoed.

“Three!”

A thick wall stood in front of Daniel's eyes as he held the butcher knife.

Even if he crossed that wall and knocked down the inquisitor, there would be more enemies waiting for him afterwards.

One after another.

And after another one, there would be more enemies waiting for him.

Cloud. The six temples. The lord's army.

None of them were opponents that Daniel could overcome with his hand.

That's why he had to become a monster.

And there was only one way to become a monster.

To offer everything to the evil god.

That was the only way given to him.

“Daniel... The door will open soon. You should prepare for battle...”

Daniel's eyes, who had made up his mind, looked at Elliot.

A wretched life that had nothing and begged for mercy from him.

Daniel's eyes, filled with madness, poured down on him.

In the delusion that dominated his mind, Daniel threw the butcher knife to the ground.

And he spoke to Elliot, who was holding him and asking for help.

“Pray.”

“What?”

“Pray to God if you want to live.”

He had to become a monster.

He had to hope that the ridiculous stories he had shared in the meeting would all become true.

Would a great one be given a great place?

Or would he become a great one by rising to a great place?

Daniel, who was nothing but a farmer in the countryside, didn't know the answer yet.

But he wished fervently in his heart.

“I warned you three times, so now I have no choice but to break in!”

Please let him be worthy of this place.

Swoosh.

Daniel took off the ring with a gemstone on his finger.

And he clenched it tightly in his right hand, raising it high toward the sky.

It was foolish to hope for a miracle from God.

But he decided to hope for a miracle today.

“—God. I will live according to your will.”

Daniel's rough voice declared to the sky.

I will live for you.

I will move according to your will.

I will shout your name for my whole life.

So—.

“Please grant me the power to punish your enemies with this humble life.”

The moment his eyes, full of determination, looked at the sky.

A faint mist rose from Daniel’s body.

The surge of power and emotion that flowed through his whole body.

The evil god in heaven answered his oath.

Everything that Daniel saw was changing every moment.

The change of senses that transcended human beings.

In it, a majestic voice pierced Daniel’s ears.

-“Accept your fate.”

Crash!

A large sword plunged into the ground from the empty air.

The sword, wrapped in a restless light, fell in front of Daniel’s eyes.

It was not hard to understand what kind of gift the sword that fell right in front of him was.

The sword with an old-fashioned appearance had an ominous aura that anyone could see.

As Daniel reached out for the fallen sword.

More swords kept falling around Daniel.

“What is this...”

Crash! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

Six swords that pierced the ground in sequence.

The swords that fell from the sky surrounded Daniel in a circle.

Each sword had a different color and a mysterious aura.

And a dagger fell into Daniel’s hand as he looked at the swords.

Thud.

Daniel looked at the dagger that fell into his hand.

A black dagger that contained darkness.

He realized then that the swords next to him were not his.

“...So that’s how it is.”

This was a gift to celebrate the birth of a great assassin.

And it was a prey dedicated to the divine tool in his hand.

Daniel lifted the divine tool that was given to him with a slow gesture.

What he held in his hand was a slaughterer.

Just like he gave the last moment to the livestock on his farm, it was an object that pronounced the last moment to all the magic swords.

He clenched the divine tool – Latimeria – and glared at the six magic swords.

It was time to see the miracle that was given to him.

“Yawn...”

I let out a yawn and looked at the screen of my smartphone.

Unless I had a special appointment, I usually played games on weekend mornings.

It was a habit that I had continued since I started this game.

Of course, there were days when I couldn't wake up in the morning, but in that case, I logged into the game after lunch.

It was important to log in consistently no matter what game I played.

There was nothing to call homework in this game, but still, I checked my karma and characters almost every day.

I felt happy just by watching the characters who were influenced by me.

“I wonder if gods would feel the same way if they really existed.”

They were like children in some sense.

I also spent a lot of money on feeding and dressing them.

And I didn't like leaving them alone when they treated me like a god.

I couldn't help all the characters, but it was fun to lend a hand to those who asked for help.

Usually, I also got some karma for doing that.

The wish of my karma was to bring down divine punishment on them.

“Let's check my karma first.”

I ran the game and checked my accumulated karma right away.

The total karma I had collected so far was 3300 karma.

It was barely enough to make the fifth apostle.

The karma supply had decreased since Kueberg, who had been faithfully collecting karma, was recuperating. It couldn't be helped.

The good thing was that the karma supply didn't decrease too much.

As I looked at the piled up karma, I turned my eyes to the <Apostle Selection> skill icon in the corner of the screen.

“This consumption is 3200, so the next consumption is about 6400. Hmm...”

The karma consumption of the <Apostle Selection> skill increased exponentially as I selected more apostles.

Until now, I had made apostles with relatively little karma, but the consumption for this apostle was very burdensome.

At this pace, it seemed impossible to keep making apostles endlessly.

The game's karma goal was one million karma, but I couldn't use karma for apostle selection if the consumption exceeded ten thousand.

Personally, I thought the sixth apostle was the limit.

After that, it would be more efficient to strengthen the existing characters.

“I'll have to think about it for a while after making the fifth apostle...”

I planned to stop making apostles for a while after making the fifth one.

Of course, I had already decided who to make the fifth apostle.

The silent assassin who attended the regular meeting of the cult, Daniel Hesrof.

I intended to make him my new apostle.

Coincidentally, I had quit the game yesterday in front of the believers who were heading to where Daniel lived.

If I searched around this area, I had a high chance of finding Daniel's hideout.

"Where is Daniel, where is he..."

I moved the screen right away and started looking for Daniel somewhere on the map.

Naturally, it took quite some time to find Daniel on the wide map.

Had it been about five minutes since I started moving the screen?

I found a farm on a hillside far away from where I started the game.

There were men in armor shouting in front of a small building on the farm.

- "We'll count to three and then open the door!"

- "...!"

- "If not, we'll break in!"

Inside the building illuminated by <The Eye of Observation>, there were Daniel and one of the cult's believers.

It looked like Daniel and the men were confronting each other with the door between them.

In the corner, there was a dead character, who was probably killed by Daniel, the assassin.

I could get a glimpse of Daniel's skill from the neat appearance of the dead character.

Daniel, who had knocked down the character, was holding the door and watching the men behind the wall.

If I waited a little longer, a fight would break out between Daniel and the men.

“What’s going on? Are they fighting?”

-“Daniel... The door will open soon. You should prepare for battle...”

The believer next to Daniel also sensed the situation and warned him.

It was just the right situation to find him.

If I waited a little longer, I could see Daniel’s skill for myself.

How skilled was Daniel, the silent assassin?

As I looked at him with anticipation in my eyes, Daniel threw his knife to the ground.

I couldn’t help but be shocked by his action.

I expected him to be strong, but I never thought he would fight without a weapon as an assassin.

“Could it be... A well-trained assassin can win with his bare hands?”

Could an assassin who had trained to the extreme assassinate with his bare hands?

It seemed that Daniel had enough confidence to beat the men without a weapon.

As I watched him throw his weapon away, Daniel stretched his body with his bare hands and looked at the believer.

Speech bubbles appeared above Daniel’s head as he looked at the believer with a serious face.

-“Pray.”

-“What...?”

-“Pray to God if you want to live.”

Every word was full of faith.

He had no less faith than the leaders of the cult.

It was hard to believe that he had become a fanatic just a while ago.

He spoke sincerely to the believer and then looked up at the sky.

His eyes were looking right at me.

He was showing the skill that only the game’s boss characters could do.

He proved his worth with just one glance, and he showed me a determined face with a speech bubble.

-“God. I will live according to your will.”

-“Please grant me the power to punish your enemies with this humble life.”

The words he uttered as he looked up at the sky.

It was an oath of loyalty to me.

The assassin who had reached the limit swore loyalty to me by himself.

And I hadn’t even used <Apostle Selection> yet.

It was an action that I couldn’t imagine as someone who had been beating up characters and making them apostles.

I smiled with joy at the sight of the character who swore loyalty to me by himself.

A great character wanted to be my subordinate by his own will.

“Daniel...”

-“...”

“I don’t think my 3200 karma is too much for you.”

Daniel Hesrof.

I met him because of the ring I gave him by mistake.

But that mistake seemed to be the greatest luck in my game life.

It made me meet such a reliable character.

It was stupid to postpone <Apostle Selection> any longer with such a character.

I touched the skill icon of <Apostle Selection> and targeted Daniel right in front of me.

Daniel’s body was wrapped in bright light and messages appeared one after another at the bottom of the screen.

-[Daniel Hesrof] has been selected as an apostle.

-You have consumed 3200 karma to create a new divine tool for the apostle.

-[Divine Tool: Latimeria] has been bound to [Daniel Hesrof].

-[The Fifth Apostle: Daniel Hesrof] has become your apostle.

-You will share your magic with the selected apostles by the effect of <Apostle Selection>.

-You can send separate messages to the selected apostles by the effect of <Apostle Selection>.

My karma drained as <Apostle Selection> proceeded.

I only had about 100 karma left after spending 3200 karma.

But I didn't regret it.

I got 'Apostle Daniel', who was much more reliable than that.

I opened my inventory and checked the items I had stored after making Daniel an apostle.

A new item was added to my inventory as I selected a new apostle.

"...Latimeria."

The name of the item that Daniel acquired as he became an apostle was [Divine Tool: Latimeria].

[Divine Tool: Latimeria] was a dark black dagger that suited Daniel.

I clicked on Daniel's divine tool with anticipation in my eyes.

The icon of [Divine Tool: Latimeria] enlarged and the item's details appeared on the screen.

As I read the information on the screen with great expectation, my eyes stopped at one place.

The trait of Daniel's divine tool was extraordinary.

"What... [Magic Sword Devourer]...?"

The name of the trait of [Divine Tool: Latimeria] was [Magic Sword Devourer].

And its effect was to destroy magic swords and absorb their traits.

Chapter 118: The Price of Slaughter (5)

Chapter 118: The Price of Slaughter (5)

“Huff...”

As I heard the explosive sounds ringing in my ears, I aimed Latimeria, the dagger in my hand.

The dark purple dagger I held was a special sword unlike any other in the world.

The supreme predator that devoured all magic swords and dominated over them.

The king of magic swords.

That was the true identity of Latimeria.

Holding the most noble weapon that the heavenly god had created, I began to hunt the magic swords that surrounded me.

“——Lagius.”

Crash!

Latimeria slashed down the magic sword Lagius.

The shadow dagger cracked and shattered.

The shadows that flowed out of Lagius dispersed and were absorbed by Latimeria.

The moment Latimeria devoured the magic sword Lagius, I realized that I had gained a new ability.

From now on, I could use the power to return to the place where I had marked.

“——Aterinus.”

Crash!

Latimeria slashed down the magic sword Aterinus.

The flame magic sword broke and collapsed.

Red flames burst out and were absorbed by Latimeria.

Now I could transform my magic power into a huge flame.

Also, the enemies who were cut by my dagger would not heal easily even if they used holy power.

“——Ashilore.”

Crash!

Latimeria slashed down the magic sword Ashilore.

The ice magic sword turned into ice fragments and scattered.

A cold chill swept over Latimeria that I was holding.

From now on, a storm of coldness would rage in Latimeria's territory.

And the enemies who were hit by the storm would be slowed down by the coldness and lose their stamina continuously.

“——Egernot.”

Crash!

Latimeria pierced through the magic sword Egernot.

The magic sword of swiftness turned into ashes and crumbled.

An ashen wave spread from Latimeria that I held.

My body, holding the sword, began to accelerate as if reversing my age.

Latimeria's blade also looked sharper than before.

“——Lifrost.”

Crash!

Latimeria smashed the magic sword Lifrost.

The magic sword of lightning oxidized and turned into a beam of light.

Crackle. Sparkle.

Latimeria, absorbing the power of lightning, vibrated and sparked.

The current running through my body accelerated me.

Now, the enemies who were cut by Latimeria's blade would not be able to move freely due to the aftermath of electric shock.

“——Heimklopf.”

Crash!

Latimeria destroyed the magic sword Heimklopf.

The magic sword of protection turned into pieces of rock and scattered.

With this, I had destroyed all the magic swords and sensed a strong and solid energy surrounding me.

While using the enhanced divine skill after devouring the magic swords, I could be protected from the enemy's attacks up to ten times.

And when that time of stability ended, Latimeria would reveal a sharper blade than before to the enemy.

“This is... the miracle of the great one...!”

Eliot, who had watched the whole process, shouted with an ecstatic gaze toward me.

Tears flowed from Eliot's eyes as he watched the ritual.

It was a scene where a mere human was chosen as an apostle of God.

He had witnessed with his own eyes a miracle that ordinary humans could not encounter in their lifetime.

It was natural for Eliot, who was watching me, to be moved.

I left Eliot alone and turned my body to face the door.

The lock was about to break completely due to the shock that came from outside.

Without even looking back, I spoke to Eliot as I faced the broken lock.

“Was it Eliot? If you don't want to get involved, you'd better hide behind the workbench.”

“Oh, okay!”

Eliot nodded vigorously and followed my instructions to hide behind the workbench.

Right after Eliot ran and hid his body.

The door of the slaughterhouse burst open with a huge explosion.

Kwaaaaang!

As the door that blocked the slaughterhouse broke, countless wooden fragments flew in all directions.

My eyes met with the inquisitor who came in while scattering the fragments.

He was wearing armor as before, but he had even taken off his cloak as if he had given up hiding his identity.

In midair, the eyes of inquisitor Albert and butcher Daniel met.

“Boss. If you were here, why didn’t you listen to me? Then I wouldn’t have had to break in and come in.”

“I have no hobby of welcoming uninvited guests.”

“By the way, what is this stinky smell...? Oh, I see, there was a dead person here.”

Albert’s gaze turned to the dead black mage as he entered the slaughterhouse.

The neatly killed black mage looked like he had been ambushed by an assassin.

Gulp.

The apprentice knights who followed Albert swallowed their saliva.

Albert pointed his finger at the black mage lying on the floor and asked.

“What is that thing over there?”

“Probably a black mage.”

“You know that’s not what I’m asking. Why is there a dead black mage here?”

“He tried to threaten me and my family. So I had no choice but to kill him.”

Albert smiled faintly as he heard that.

He looked like he was immersed in curiosity.

Daniel knew very well what kind of people they were who made such expressions.

Most of them were those who coveted what was his.

And if not, they were those who harmed him and his family.

Albert met Daniel’s eyes and shrugged his shoulders.

“I’ll find out more details when I take the villagers and interrogate them.”

It was obvious what the inquisition of the temple meant.

They would torture the suspects until they confessed.

Daniel didn’t think he would be safe even if he told them he wasn’t an apostle of the evil god.

Of course, he had become a heretic as the knights said by now.

As Daniel caressed Latimeria in his hand and looked into his eyes, questions kept pouring out of Albert’s mouth.

“But before that, I want to know your identity first.”

“You asked about my identity?”

“Yes. A normal person wouldn’t be able to handle people like this. Are you a mercenary hiding in the countryside?”

Daniel snorted at Albert's words.

Ever since he had a connection with the church, the stories that came from around him were always like this.

Could he be an assassin with overwhelming skills?

If so, how many lives had he taken with his own hands?

The misunderstandings that poured out repeated themselves over and over again, creating a legend without form.

Daniel himself was nothing but an ordinary farmer.

“My identity. Yeah, my identity...”

There was nothing to say about his identity.

He was always nothing but an ordinary farmer.

At best, he was nothing but a farmer who was better at using a sword than others, that was all.

But all those things were worthless.

In the end, they didn't guarantee who Daniel Hesrof was.

What they wanted from him was not such a humble answer.

Even if he affirmed with his own mouth, no one who heard him would believe him.

What answer should he give to those who denied the truth?

That was the task given to Daniel now.

“My identity is...”

Daniel felt it in his bones.

He could never go back to his normal life.

The world wanted a cruel fate for him.

A legendary assassin.

A silent reaper of lives.

The greatest agent of evil.

If they all wanted him to be that, he had no choice but to become that.

That was surely the only path given to him.

“——The Silent Butcher.”

“What?”

“By your terms, I’m the fifth apostle of the evil god.”

Daniel’s calm voice revealed his existence to the world.

The fifth apostle. Daniel Hesrof.

He proclaimed himself as the most secretive shadow that the world desired.

A cold wind blew around Daniel, who held a dagger.

With the cold wind, frost began to fall everywhere.

Lightning struck from the clear sky and left a large burn on the ground.

“The fifth apostle...?”

“He’s an apostle-level enemy! Be on guard!”

Shriek.

The swords of Albert and the apprentice knights were drawn out in an instant.

Frost settled on their swords as they touched the cold wind.

Albert, the inquisitor of the temple, drew out his holy power and drove away the frost that covered his sword.

Albert's eyes clearly warned of the apostle in front of him.

Daniel looked at the three swords that were drawn toward him and said.

“Forgive me.”

“What...?”

“I don't think I can spare you.”

Whiiiiing.

Along with the cold wind, a shadow cloak fell from Daniel's shoulder.

Daniel put on the hood of the shadow and looked at each of the enemies in front of him.

The cold wind and lightning kept bothering them.

They were already injured before the battle even started.

Albert frowned as he saw the frost that surrounded his sword and opened his mouth.

“Is this... an ice magic...?”

“Albert! I feel sluggish!”

“Everyone, raise your holy power! Wrap your body with it and you'll be able to resist the magic to some extent!”

As he said that, Albert's body was wrapped in a faint light.

Just by being here, Daniel was causing damage to his enemies.

Even though he hadn't fought properly yet, they were gasping for breath.

Daniel knew how absurd the dagger he held was.

And at the same time, he felt awe for the god who gave him such power.

He bestowed such power with a mere prayer of a humble farmer.

The evil god he served was more formidable than any celestial being.

'Of course, with great power... comes great responsibility.'

He didn't think this power was given to him for free.

From the moment he grasped Latimeria, Daniel Hesrof became an apostle of God.

An apostle was someone who represented and executed God's will.

Perhaps his first task was to deal with the inquisitors of the temple in front of him.

He took a step forward, aiming his dagger at his enemies.

Despite his age, he felt a sharp sense as if he was in his prime.

"They're coming! Be on guard!"

He stepped forward without making a sound.

Silence and stillness descended on every space where Daniel stepped.

He never made a noise when he reaped lives.

That was his own way of showing respect for death.

Swoosh.

In the silence, Daniel's dagger moved, scattering the darkness.

Latimeria's figure was hidden in the distorted haze.

“——Latimeria.”

Woo woo woo woo.

The black dagger resonated with its master's call.

At that moment, all the abilities that Latimeria had were activated.

A tremendous power flowed through his blood, and Daniel's body shot out like a flash of light.

A black trail was drawn in the air, and the black haze spat out light and heat.

“Kuh, ugh ugh...!”

Clang!

Albert blocked Daniel's strike with his sword imbued with holy power.

Albert's hand trembled as he crossed swords with him.

The immense force and speed created a strong impact.

Of course, that was not the only anomaly that Latimeria created.

The light and heat that burst out of the dagger began to damage Albert's hand.

Pale smoke rose from Albert's hand as he crossed swords with Daniel.

“Uh... ugh...!”

“I can see how good the inquisitor is.”

“Like a filthy apostle of the evil god... you use despicable methods...!”

Shocked by the impact, Albert tried to distance himself from him.

Clang! Clank!

Daniel blocked Albert's swift sword swings and retreated a few steps back.

It was a knight's strike that he wouldn't have been able to react to normally.

But under the area created by the overlapping characteristics of many magic swords, Daniel's body enhanced by Latimeria made it possible.

The enemies slowed down and Daniel sped up.

At this moment, the slaughterhouse where he held his dagger was a space full of irrationality.

"I am... I am knight Albert! I won't let you evil god's minions do as you please!"

Enraged, Albert swung his sword at Daniel.

He moved forward, enduring the cold and lightning with his holy power.

Every time his sword swung, a heavy shockwave exploded in the air.

'Of course, with great power... comes great responsibility.'

He didn't think this power was given to him for free.

From the moment he grasped Latimeria, Daniel Hesrof became an apostle of God.

An apostle was someone who represented and executed God's will.

Perhaps his first task was to deal with the inquisitors of the temple in front of him.

He took a step forward, aiming his dagger at his enemies.

Despite his age, he felt a sharp sense as if he was in his prime.

“They’re coming! Be on guard!”

He stepped forward without making a sound.

Silence and stillness descended on every space where Daniel stepped.

He never made a noise when he reaped lives.

That was his own way of showing respect for death.

Swoosh.

In the silence, Daniel’s dagger moved, scattering the darkness.

Latimeria’s figure was hidden in the distorted haze.

“——Latimeria.”

Woo woo woo woo.

The black dagger resonated with its master’s call.

At that moment, all the abilities that Latimeria had were activated.

A tremendous power flowed through his blood, and Daniel’s body shot out like a flash of light.

A black trail was drawn in the air, and the black haze spat out light and heat.

“Kuh, ugh ugh...!”

Clang!

Albert blocked Daniel’s strike with his sword imbued with holy power.

Albert’s hand trembled as he crossed swords with him.

The immense force and speed created a strong impact.

Of course, that was not the only anomaly that Latimeria created.

The light and heat that burst out of the dagger began to damage Albert's hand.

Pale smoke rose from Albert's hand as he crossed swords with Daniel.

“Uh... ugh...!”

“I can see how good the inquisitor is.”

“Like a filthy apostle of the evil god... you use despicable methods...!”

Shocked by the impact, Albert tried to distance himself from him.

Clang! Clank!

Daniel blocked Albert's swift sword swings and retreated a few steps back.

It was a knight's strike that he wouldn't have been able to react to normally.

But under the area created by the overlapping characteristics of many magic swords, Daniel's body enhanced by Latimeria made it possible.

The enemies slowed down and Daniel sped up.

At this moment, the slaughterhouse where he held his dagger was a space full of irrationality.

“I am... I am knight Albert! I won't let you evil god's minions do as you please!”

Enraged, Albert swung his sword at Daniel.

He moved forward, enduring the cold and lightning with his holy power.

Every time his sword swung, a heavy shockwave exploded in the air.

Daniel was retreating with leisurely steps, but no sword could touch him.

Every time he took a step forward, Daniel moved back two steps.

The distance between them showed no sign of narrowing.

“I... I only wanted to protect it.”

“Protect what? The altar of the evil god? Or maybe... the wicked spawn of the evil god!”

“You don’t make any sense.”

Daniel sighed deeply as he measured the distance that had opened up.

As much as the gap between them, there was an incomprehensible chasm between their minds.

By now, they had grown too far apart to ever reconcile.

Daniel tilted his dagger as he glared at Albert and the apprentice knights.

He had no intention of wasting any more time.

He had many tasks waiting for him as an apostle.

He had to end this now.

“——Latimeria.”

The moment Daniel called the name of the divine tool, looking at the mark of time he had engraved.

Daniel’s flesh turned into a shadow and scattered, and he reappeared behind Albert.

Thud.

The dagger moved silently and pierced Albert’s back.

The blade of Latimeria, enhanced to the extreme, cut through the knight’s armor like paper.

Daniel pierced Albert's heart with his dagger and quickly withdrew it.

“Gah... Huk...!”

Thump.

Albert's body leaned forward with a heavy sound.

He uttered a short death cry and stopped breathing with a bewildered face.

That was the end of Albert, the inquisitor.

The apprentice knights, who had their backs exposed to the assassin, slowly turned their heads as they saw their superior die in vain.

Daniel looked at the remaining two apprentice knights with a cold expression.

Behind him, Albert turned into black ash and scattered.

As they faced the assassin who saw their master's remains fluttering, Daniel shook off the blood on Latimeria and said.

“Pray to God if you want to live.”

Chapter 119: The Price of Slaughter (6)

Chapter 119: The Price of Slaughter (6)

Somewhere in the Everlint region, there was a cliff.

Below it, fully armed knights were busy moving around.

They were the holy troops gathered for an operation under the command of a heretic inquisitor sent to the southern region of the empire.

The one who led them was a heretic inquisitor named Kelter, who wore an eyepatch on one eye.

Kelter ordered the knights to search for the heretics who might be hiding nearby.

“Search every inch of the area! There must be traces of the enemy!”

Kelter looked around as he gave orders to the knights.

It had been two weeks since he discovered and pursued the movement of the cult that crossed the empire.

Kelter and his party had executed forty percent of their forces and were chasing the remaining remnants.

He had also sent a request for cooperation to stop them from entering the Everlint region, but for some reason, the heretic inquisitor Albert still did not move.

It was impossible to block the fleeing heretics from the front without any support.

In the end, it was up to Kelter alone to exterminate the heretics.

Kelter frowned as he watched the exhausted knights.

“Why is there still no news from the other heretic inquisitor in Everlint!”

Kelter’s mouth burst out with complaints about Albert.

It had been a long time since he sent a request for cooperation through the temple.

If heretic inquisitor Albert had joined them, he should have come here and stopped the enemies by now.

But there was no sign of any support, not even a proper contact.

It was impossible unless he deliberately ignored the request for support.

Crash!

Kelter hit a nearby tree with annoyance, and his adjutant approached him with a troubled expression.

“Sir Kelter... Don’t worry too much. There will be news soon.”

“Soon? When is that soon? What’s the use of news after I kill those bastards?”

“Ke, Kelter sir...”

“That’s why I said they should pick proper people for heretic inquisitors!”

Grind.

Kelter clenched his teeth and vented his anger as he held the reins.

In his view, most of the current heretic inquisitors were mediocre at best.

Considering the special nature of heretic inquisitors, they should have picked only the elite among the elite, but the holy land kept lowering the threshold because they thought they were short of numbers.

Because of those lacking people who wore the title of heretic inquisitors, he still couldn't get proper support.

They should have raised the standards and selected proper knights for heretic inquisitors.

That was Kelter's thought.

"Don't you think so too?"

As he was thinking that, Kelter turned his head and looked at his adjutant.

The adjutant who had been agreeing with him suddenly became quiet.

As he turned his head, Kelter saw his adjutant's face with his mouth shut.

The adjutant was looking at something with a terrified face and trembling.

"What are you looking at?"

Kelter's eyes followed his adjutant's eyes.

Six steps away from where he was standing.

There was a knight lying on the ground bleeding.

"Uh..."

"Could it be... He was ambushed by an enemy? He killed a knight without making any noise or traces?"

Clang!

Kelter drew his sword as soon as he found the knight lying on the ground.

As soon as Kelter drew his sword, the body of the fallen knight turned into ash and scattered.

His comrade was killed without any sound or trace.

And even the ambushed comrade disappeared without any trace.

It was a scene that could not be created by an assassin of mediocre level.

Kelter raised his alertness and looked around with his sword pointed.

“It’s an enemy attack! Everyone be on guard!”

“Sir Kelter...”

“Did you see any sign of an enemy? Where is he now?”

“From above... He came down from above...”

The adjutant who faced the enemy trembled and held his sword.

He came down from above.

Kelter’s eyes followed his adjutant’s words and looked at the cliff nearby.

There was a sheer cliff above where Kelter was standing.

It was a height that no one could survive jumping down from.

It was almost impossible for an assassin to sneak down from such a cliff.

Kelter frowned as he heard him say that he came down from above.

“He came down from above?”

“Yes, yes! He definitely came down from above...”

“How did he come down from above?”

Before Kelter finished questioning his adjutant, a black mist fell from the sky to the ground.

It fell at a speed that could barely be captured by enhanced senses, and it headed towards a knight who was riding a horse.

Kelter's eyes naturally followed the mist and looked at the knight who was holding the reins.

Thud. Thump.

As soon as the mist landed on the horse, a sound of bones breaking echoed around.

“Kuh... Huk...”

With a short death cry, the knight dropped his head.

A faint figure of a person was visible beyond the mist that wrapped around the knight.

There was an unidentified man wearing a black hood there.

Thump!

The knight in front of them fell off the horse with a heavy impact.

The adjutant who looked at the fallen knight pointed his finger at the enemy and opened his mouth.

“Ah, an assassin...!”

“You bastard! Stay there!”

Kelter swung his sword and approached the assassin who had landed.

Kelter's sword cut through the place where the assassin was with a sharp momentum.

But as soon as he approached the assassin, his body turned into a shadow and dispersed.

The assassin who had been in front of him disappeared without a trace.

Kelter's eyes wandered in the empty air with astonishment.

He then understood his adjutant's words.

The assassin came down from above and disappeared without a trace again.

The flesh of the knight who was killed by the assassin turned into smoke and scattered.

“Both the dead knight and the enemy who attacked him... They all disappeared without a trace.”

“...”

“Sir Kelter, it must be an assassin sent by the cult to deal with us! We have to gather the scattered knights right away...”

The adjutant's voice trembled with fear.

But Kelter immediately signaled him to shut his mouth.

In the silence, Kelter scanned the surroundings of the cliff.

There were many places where people could hide.

He didn't know when or where a hidden enemy would pop out.

In the sudden silence, Kelter gave orders to his subordinates.

“Be on guard. You never know when an enemy will suddenly pop out.”

As soon as Kelter finished speaking with his sword in his hand,

A black mist fell from the sky again.

Kelter's face hardened as he saw where the mist rose.

The enemy was falling from above the cliff again.

This time, it was his adjutant next to him that the mist was falling towards.

In an instant, the adjutant's head was grabbed by the assassin's hand and he looked at Kelter.

He had a terrified face and asked Kelter for help.

"Ke, ke, Kelter sir, I... I don't want to die..."

"Snap out of it! There's an enemy behind you—!"

Thud.

With a quiet sound,

Chapter 120: Get Rich Quick (1)

Chapter 120: Get Rich Quick (1)

In the lucid dream that I was getting used to, I looked at the girl in black sitting across from me.

Estelle.

The girl who always greeted me in the lucid dream that came whenever I forgot.

She was someone I would miss if I didn't see her, since we had met face to face many times.

As I played chess with Estelle, a thought suddenly came to my mind.

It was a simple but fun idea.

It was also close to an experimental idea.

I moved the piece in my hand and looked at Estelle's face across from me.

"Did you come up with a good move?"

"I did come up with an interesting idea."

Thud.

I moved the queen and knocked down Estelle's bishop.

Estelle's slender finger took out the fallen bishop from the chessboard.

This made the number of pieces I had slightly more than Estelle's.

She seemed to not care about the advantage or disadvantage of the game from the beginning.

She asked me with an interested face as she heard my story.

"What kind of idea is it?"

"An idea that could turn someone's life upside down."

"It doesn't seem like an idea that anyone can have."

"It's an idea that only someone like me can have."

What came to my mind was simple curiosity.

It was the kind of curiosity that could only be satisfied by winning the game.

I was in a favorable situation in the chess game as well.

If I won the game like this, I planned to ask Estelle the question that was in my mind.

She kept giving vague answers, and she clenched her jaw and clicked the piece in her hand.

"Are you going to tell me if you win the game?"

"Even if I lose, if you use your question to ask me, I'll have no choice but to know."

The idea that came to my mind was simple.

Estelle in front of me was a convenience of my subconscious created by my dream.

So the answer she gave me was nothing more than what came out of my mind.

If I asked her something I didn't know, what kind of answer would Estelle give me?

Would she be able to give me a normal answer then?

Or would she make up nonsense stories and try to dodge it?

Either way, there was no doubt that an interesting answer would come back.

"You're mean today. You're basically asking me to lose, aren't you?"

Estelle put down the piece she was holding and grabbed the last rook and said.

It was useless if I didn't win anyway.

I secretly hoped that she would lose easily, and started to think about the next move.

"I'd appreciate it if you did."

"Sorry, but playing properly is also a rule, so it's hard to lose on purpose."

"I don't know why we have so many strict rules between us."

I muttered with a disappointed feeling at Estelle's words.

Why was she so difficult in my mind?

It would be enough to just talk without playing games for such a simple story.

It was regrettable that even trivial stories had to be exchanged through games.

I didn't hate playing games with Estelle though.

“I’m sorry. But someday we’ll be able to talk freely without any strict rules.”

“Yeah? Check.”

“This is just a process of getting used to each other.”

Estelle, who was cornered, moved her king back.

But this move was predicted and prepared by me.

Thud.

The bishop I had prepared moved and pressured Estelle’s king again.

Swoosh.

The two hands on the chessboard moved alternately.

How many times did they exchange moves after the first check?

The white pieces that kept pushing Estelle to the corner put out their last move.

“Checkmate. It seems like it’s over.”

“I can’t move anymore. Too bad.”

“Phew... I’m glad I won.”

I declared checkmate and finished the game, leaning back on my chair and sighing.

I wasn’t very good at chess, so I was worried if I could win, but luckily I won easily against Estelle.

The online chess I played briefly in the past seemed to help unexpectedly.

As I stretched and loosened my body to wake up from the drowsiness, Estelle picked up her parasol and got up from her seat.

Click. Click.

She stopped in front of me with light footsteps and looked at me and asked.

“So, what question did you want to ask by winning?”

The question I wanted to ask Estelle who lost the game.

And if Estelle’s answer was true, even though I didn’t know it, it would be very helpful.

It was about lottery tickets.

I asked her with a curious face, urging Estelle for the information I wanted so much.

“Lottery winning numbers.”

“What?”

“Tell me the lottery winning numbers.”

“Really... That’s an original idea.”

Estelle looked at me with narrowed eyes and said.

Thud.

The end of Estelle’s parasol went on my toe that was sitting on the seat.

She leaned her upper body on the parasol that was placed on her toe and put some strength into it.

In an instant, a strong pain attacked my thumb toe that had weight on it.

“Ouch...!”

“I’m sorry, but this is the only time I’ll answer this kind of question.”

“Only this time?”

“It means I won’t give a stupid answer to the same kind of question ever again. Do you understand?”

Estelle lifted a finger and brought it to my lips and asked.

Her eyes that were like deep abysses stared at me and demanded an answer.

This was the last time this kind of question was possible.

I realized that and nodded to Estelle’s question.

I added one strict condition to the question.

“I’d appreciate it if you could give me the first prize winning numbers.”

“Hoo... Okay. I’ll tell you.”

Estelle sat on the desk next to her and clicked her parasol.

Right after that, a clear voice started to flow slowly from Estelle’s mouth.

“2.”

“Oh, okay. Number 2.”

She started to tell me the lottery numbers honestly from her mouth.

As soon as I heard Estelle’s voice, I made a piece of paper and a pen on the table.

And I wrote down the numbers Estelle called one by one on the paper.

She seemed to not tell me again if I said I didn’t hear it, judging by her attitude.

“11.”

“Number 11. Good.”

“15.”

“Number 15.”

“21.”

“Number 21. Four so far.”

The numbers on the paper I was holding increased in an instant.

The numbers that increased one by one became five, and the sixth number came out of Estelle’s mouth.

As soon as all six lottery numbers came out of Estelle’s mouth,

The world where Estelle and I were sitting collapsed, and bright light poured in from all sides.

It was time for this lucid dream to end slowly.

“That’s it for today, I guess.”

“Yeah. 2. 11. 15. 21. 27...”

“I won’t lose so easily next time we meet. Stay healthy until then.”

“Yeah. You too. 2. 11. 15. 21...”

I repeated Estelle’s lottery numbers in my mouth to not forget them.

The memory in the dream was more volatile than other memories.

Estelle looked at me with a troubled eye, but the lottery numbers were important for everyone.

Chapter 121: Get Rich Quick (2)

Chapter 121: Sudden Fortune (2)

At a small lake located in the Atelot region.

There, Pluto looked at the huge lump floating on the lake.

In the middle of the lake, there was a white lump the size of a rock floating.

The lump, which looked very soft on the outside, had fish that had not been swallowed dripping from its mouth.

The identity of the white lump that was reflected in Pluto's eyes was none other than the abyssal beast, Cuebaerg.

He was summoned by the great being she served, and protected by the second apostle, a monster.

“Cuebaerg. You seem to be getting used to the lake too.”

-“It feels better to be in the water. It reminds me of the abyss a little bit.”

“Is the abyss where you lived filled with water like this?”

-“Unlike the surface, it is full of sticky poison. It is a place where those who do not have resistance to the poison of the abyss cannot survive.”

Pluto nodded her head at Cuebaerg's answer.

She was born and raised on the surface from the beginning, so she knew nothing about the abyss.

So she had to guess about the abyss from Cuebaerg's stories.

Of course, even if it wasn't the abyss, she didn't know anything properly now.

It was a side effect of being sealed with a stake in a cave for hundreds of years.

She didn't go through memory preservation through blood magic in time, so only the memories she had in the cave remained in her head.

Immortals who lived for a long time had to preserve their memories periodically.

Otherwise, they could lose important memories in the waves of time.

"I wonder if there are immortals among the beasts living in the abyss."

Pluto reached out her hand over Cuebaerg, who was catching fish, and asked.

She wanted to know if there were immortals like her in the abyss.

The soft touch of Cuebaerg was transmitted through her fingertips.

Cuebaerg had a soft texture as he looked.

She had heard that his appearance was distorted by the difference in magic density between the abyss and here, but now he was maintaining his original form unlike before.

He lost most of his original power and his subordinates who were brought from the abyss.

Cuebaerg answered her question after spitting out some fish that he couldn't swallow.

-“I haven't seen any beings that can be called immortals. There are only some who live long, but they all have their own lifespans.”

“I guess there are no immortals in the abyss.”

-“At least among the beasts, there are none. Even I, who dominated one region, could not defy my lifespan.”

According to Cuebaerg, there were no immortal beasts in the abyss.

Pluto felt a strange feeling in her chest as she heard that story.

She didn't know why she became immortal because she lost her old memories.

But only a few were promised eternal life on the surface.

She would watch the beginning and end of the world with the great being who watched over her.

In a world where countless lives bloom and die, she would act as God's will forever.

Death was not a concept allowed to vampires.

“That's true. I guess lifespan is not something anyone can defy...”

-“You seem to have a lot of worries.”

“I don't have any remaining memories. He must have been watching over me since long ago, but I don't remember anything about him.”

There was nothing left for Pluto who had lived for a long time.

She just lived according to her position that someone had set for her.

The only thing that was fortunate was that the one who gave her a role was God of Heaven.

Except for that, there was nothing that made her feel stable since she woke up.

-“...”

” And I don’t even remember myself. Aren’t you afraid? That someone who knows me that I don’t know is somewhere in this world.”

The only thing left in Pluto was faint fear.

The feeling of fear from ignorance.

That’s why Pluto hoped that someone who knew her that she had forgotten was somewhere in this world.

Brrr.

Cuebaerg shook his body once and chased away the fish around him and looked at her.

His eyes, which looked like real eyes, looked at Pluto and opened his mouth.

-“No one in the abyss would know about you.”

“Is that so?”

-“But you don’t need to worry too much. He knows everything about you and still chose you as an apostle.”

Pluto opened her eyes wide and looked at Cuebaerg as he answered her question.

Cuebaerg, who floated on the water, moved away from Pluto’s touch and showed him swimming in the lake.

The feeling of suffocation that had accumulated in Pluto eased a little as she watched Cuebaerg swim and comfort her.

Being comforted by a round monster.

It was not a scene that suited the great ancestor.

Pluto stared at Cuebaerg with her ruby eyes and muttered to him.

“That’s true. Maybe it was a needless worry.”

-“You are a blessed being. If you do your job quietly, you might be loved by the great one forever.”

“Loved by the great one forever...”

-“And if you’re done with that worry that only immortals have, I have a favor to ask you.”

Pluto’s worries seemed to be coming to an end.

Cuebaerg, who floated on the lake, spun his body around and told him his purpose.

He seemed to have something to ask Pluto.

Pluto, who heard that Cuebaerg had a favor to ask, asked him with a serious face.

“A favor?”

-“I think it’s time to leave this lake.”

“You said you just got used to it, but now you feel the lake is too small for you.”

-“To grow, you also need a suitable opponent. I’ve had enough time to grow under protection, so I need to move to a bigger water.”

Cuebaerg’s request was simple.

He had grown enough in the lake, so he wanted to leave the safe place and go somewhere else.

It seemed that it would be a burden to live in the lake if Cuebaerg grew a little bigger.

“A bigger water...”

-“Let me go to the sea. I need to catch more prey and grow bigger there.”

Sea.

Pluto tilted her head at the unfamiliar word.

She had never heard of the sea in hundreds of years.

It was because she had been trapped in a cave for a long time.

“Sea?”

-“You seem to have forgotten your memory of the sea too. It’s not important, so don’t worry about it.”

“Ah, okay. I’ll talk to Evan about it.”

-“Then I’ll ask you to do that.”

“Sea... Sea is nothing. Yeah.”

Pluto, who accepted Cuebaerg’s favor, twitched her eyebrows and picked up Deathside next to her.

It was not a pleasant thing for her, the ancestor, to be pointed out her ignorance.

She decided to look up the sea when she returned to the order.

Behind Pluto, Cuebaerg was making a fountain by spitting water out of his mouth.

Setius was one of the many branches of the Obtos ducal family.

Of course, even though he was a branch, he was quite distant from the direct line of the ducal family.

He was practically a stranger except for large events.

The reason why he was in charge of the auction house this time was also because his father, who was greedy for money, helped him out.

So he had to achieve some results this time no matter what.

And luckily, this auction had a top-grade magic crystal on display.

It was an item that anyone who was involved in magic research would covet.

It was an unbelievable opportunity for Setius, who was aiming for a sure hit.

As soon as the top-grade magic crystal entered the auction house, Setius nagged his subordinates every day.

“It’s not easy to find such a magic crystal in any mine in the empire. It’s a treasure that can be called that.”

“...”

“And even several magic towers that are after the magic crystal are participating in this auction.”

“Yes, yes... That’s right.”

“In such an important place where such guests are coming, you can’t even leave a speck of dust on the floor!”

Setius kicked a water jug in the corner and shouted at the servants who were cleaning the auction house.

Thump. Rattle.

The water jug kicked by Setius rolled on the floor.

The servants who heard Setius's roar also shrank greatly.

Setius pointed at the wet floor with his finger and yelled at them.

"Polish it until it shines! There shouldn't be a single dust on the floor!"

"Oh, okay! We'll polish it again!"

"If it's still like this when I come back, I'll beat you instead of warning you!"

Setius scolded them with a loud voice and turned his body and walked down the corridor.

The secretary who assisted him also followed him quickly with his legs.

Setius didn't calm down even after scolding them.

He snorted and clenched his fist.

He didn't forget to complain to his secretary who followed him either.

"What do you think this place is! How can you do anything with that attitude!"

"You're right. I'll train those servants again."

"As far as I can see, there's no one but you here who's not stupid!"

"I'm glad that thanks to Setius's skill, it will be the best auction ever. I'll take some time and make sure there are no problems with these people."

Setius suppressed his rough breath and nodded his head at his secretary's words.

He felt a little better after hearing his secretary's words.

Ahem.

He cleared his throat to soothe his rough throat and looked at his secretary.

And he asked him about the participants of this auction.

“Hmm. So, are there any new families who have requested participation?”

“This time, we received a participation request from Mayer Count family.”

“Mayer Count family... Is that one of those mediocre families in Sentirius region?”

Mayer Count family.

Setius tried to recall the awkward name.

He didn't remember it well because he didn't hear it often.

He had heard a rumor that the count died and his eldest son became the next count.

But that was all he knew about the count family.

Setius gestured to his secretary to explain in detail.

“They are a family of change that rules over Lituas-Sentirius.”

“Sentirius is the place on the way to the holy land.”

“They didn't apply for a long time, but they seem to want to participate after hearing the rumor about the magic crystal.”

“Hmph. They act like the top-grade magic crystal is theirs.”

Setius snorted at the secretary's words.

There were three ducal families participating in this auction.

And there were also many famous magic towers that were after the magic crystal.

There was no chance that a count family from the border would win the top-grade magic crystal in such an auction.

The best thing for a count family was a decent magic tool that was put in to fill the order of the auction.

Setius thought for a moment after hearing his secretary's words, and stroked his beard and said to him.

"I'd like to refuse, but... maybe we can sell some less valuable items."

"It might be troublesome if we refuse the participation request of the count family."

"We don't like it, but we have to accept it. Send them an invitation."

This auction was the best auction he had prepared himself.

And he also needed spectators who would watch his auction with their own eyes.

Mayer Count family would be a suitable audience for his auction.

Setius imagined the upcoming auction in his head and smiled wickedly and continued walking.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

In the corridor where the servants were busy polishing the floor, Setius and his secretary's footsteps echoed.

Chapter 122: Get Rich Quick (3)

Chapter 122: Fortune 3

A few days had passed since Eutenia suggested the auction house raid.

During that time, I watched Eutenia and the apostles prepare for the raid on my smartphone.

Maybe it was because they were planning to raid an auction house where nobles gathered.

Eutenia used even a count's house that she never mentioned before.

The Mayer Count's House.

It was a noble family that ruled the territory that Roan and the church's believers had taken over.

Eutenia used them to find out information about the auction house.

I realized that it had been quite a long time since I started the game, seeing Eutenia move the count's house.

“Come to think of it, there was such a thing.”

Roan and the church's believers had done many things while I watched.

And while I wasn't watching, they did even more things.

It seemed like a simple thing to see the characters move, but when I thought about it, it was a moment when many things changed.

It was the charm of an idle game that many things changed in the blink of an eye.

Even if I didn't pay much attention to my smartphone, the characters were diligently doing their roles.

Someday, they might grow enough to solve everything without me.

-“You're saying you'll go to the auction house with me?”

-“Yes. Pluto and I are going to infiltrate the auction house together.”

-“Didn't you say it was a difficult place where many nobles gather?”

-“It is. That's why we're planning to break through with a small number of people. Besides, Pluto, you... It won't be a big problem even if you show your face to others.”

As I watched my smartphone with such thoughts, speech bubbles appeared above Eutenia and Pluto's heads in the church building.

They were having a conversation in a large conference room where no one was.

There was also Peter, who always played the role of Eutenia's servant.

Peter, who was wearing clothes that suited his role, looked at them with an uneasy face.

“Wasn't he originally a servant? What role is he playing this time?”

He seemed to be joining this operation, seeing him attend the meeting.

It was a rare sight to see the three of them together since they rescued Pluto from the seal.

I was curious about Peter, who was wearing different clothes than usual.

I saw him learn swordsmanship from Evan a few times, but I still had a lot of doubts about his skills.

He wasn't at the same level as Eutenia and Pluto, at least.

-“But... what do you want me to do by bringing me here...”

Peter didn't seem to have any idea what his role was either.

He asked Eutenia and Pluto, who were talking.

Eutenia lifted up a ring with the Mayer Count's seal on it, in response to Peter's question.

It was something she got from Roan earlier.

She told Peter with the ring in her hand.

-“I have something to ask you, Peter. Of course, it's not related to combat.”

-“What is it?”

-“Please attend the auction with Bishop Rex Meyer.”

That's what Eutenia said as she handed over the seal she was holding to Peter.

It seemed that she was looking for someone to gather information from the auction house.

Peter was perfect for that kind of job.

He always acted like Eutenia's servant whenever he saw her.

But Peter seemed to be shocked by Eutenia's proposal, as he blinked his eyes and looked at her in front of him.

-“Me, me and the earl are going together?”

-“Yes. It won’t be a hard task for you, Peter. But it’s not an easy one either.”

-“With the earl... Okay, I understand. Then what do I have to do?”

Eutenia answered his question.

-“Please collect information about the situation and the catalog inside the auction house. Of course, you have to be careful not to be caught by the other people there, or it will be dangerous.”

-(gulp)

I chuckled as I saw the emoticon floating above Peter’s head.

Things that couldn’t be expressed in words still appeared as emoticons in speech bubbles.

But seeing an emoticon inserted between serious conversations made me feel like the whole conversation was funny somehow.

In the early stages of the game, there were mostly those kinds of emoticons.

I felt a great sense of accomplishment when I saw different conversations than before.

Especially in Eutenia’s case, since she was a character I raised from the beginning, I had a lot of thoughts as I saw her old self overlapping.

“I feel like the kids I raised have grown up already.”

It was just the other day that I fed Eutenia bread one by one.

Now she was a dignified priest who offered sacrifices regularly.

It was a bit annoying to feed her bread, but it was also fun in its own way.

But when I saw Eutenia, who had grown into one of the top forces of the church, I sometimes missed the days when I stroked her and raised her.

Ah. Of course, stroking her was still something I could do.

Except for the fact that Eutenia would writhe on the floor in pain after being stroked by me.

“What if I win the lottery? Maybe I’ll buy them some equipment and skills.”

They were characters that I had raised with care and effort for months.

And Estelle’s lottery that she told me in my dream was also only a few days away from the draw.

If I won the first prize in the lottery, cars and fine dining would automatically follow.

I planned to include some spending on the game in my happy imagination after winning the lottery.

The wealth to freely draw 89,900 won per 10 times.

I felt like I had everything in the world just by imagining it.

-“And I’ll have to use a skill for them when they break in.”

I felt a surge of care for my characters as my mood improved.

I decided to use a solar eclipse skill for them on the day of the operation, and carefully lifted the lottery paper I had bought before.

If this paper won the first prize, I would have to confess to Estelle in my dream right away.

Of course, if I didn’t win the lottery, it would rain heavily nationwide that day.

On the day of the special auction at the Obtos duchy.

The auction house of the duchy was crowded with countless nobles, creating a sea of people.

Setius, who attended the auction, was watching the auction with a satisfied expression.

It was an auction that everyone from the famous ducal families to the humble noble families in the countryside participated in.

Of course, the treatment of the noble families from the prestigious and rural areas was completely different.

The nobles from the prestigious families could bid from the special seats, while those who couldn't had to try bidding from the general seats of the auction house.

Even though the general seats of the auction house were furnished with high-end furniture for the nobles, it was still a different level.

“So far, so good. If we finish this successfully, maybe the duke will see me differently.”

Maybe it was because there were unusually many people and money gathered today.

The items exhibited at the auction house were all sold at more than their value.

The more expensive the items sold at the auction house, the more commission the auction house would take.

This situation where the participants lost their reason and spent money was a great opportunity for Setius to turn into a huge achievement.

Not to mention, he couldn't even guess how much commission he would get for bringing in a top-grade magic crystal to the auction house.

As he looked at the nobles who participated in the auction with satisfaction, his secretary next to him spoke with a bright smile.

“As expected of Setius. The duke will surely admire your ability.”

“Of course, of course! You have a good eye for people!”

“You’re too kind. My talent is nothing compared to Setius’s discernment.”

Setius, who felt good by his secretary’s words, lifted up his wine glass in front of him.

Gulp. Gulp.

He didn’t even have time to enjoy the wine as he felt his throat burning.

But it was a charming wine with a bitter grape flavor that lingered in his mouth.

It was a product prepared for the nobles of the conference hall, so it was incomparable to the cheap wine that was rolling around in the market.

Setius, who quenched his thirst with wine, tapped his finger on the table and spoke to his secretary.

“Good. We should start preparing to move that item soon.”

There was only one thing that could be called that item in the special auction.

A product that existed only a few in the empire, a top-grade magic crystal.

He was preparing to put it up for auction.

It was a product that had been locked up in a magic vault until now, but now it was time to show its appearance to the audience sitting in the auction house.

He had placed a pile of excellent knights in the auction house for that one item.

The secretary nodded his head and answered Setius’s words.

“I’m already keeping an eye on it with strict security. Should I order them to transport it?”

“Yes. We have to prepare from now on if we want to put it out on time, so it’s better to take it out of the vault right away.”

“Understood. I’ll do as you instructed.”

When the top-grade magic crystal came up as the highlight of the auction, everyone in the auction house would be sincerely amazed.

But sweet fruits always attract many insects.

He had to protect the item thoroughly until it came up for auction.

Taking out the item from the vault just before the auction was also for that reason.

As he gave orders to his secretary, Setius tried to pour wine into his glass to moisten his throat.

Suddenly, all the magic lanterns in the auction house started blinking at once.

“Are you all enjoying the auction?”

At the same time, a gentle voice echoed through the auction house.

Everyone who was watching the auction turned their eyes to a corner of the auction house.

Everyone’s eyes were drawn to a place where a girl holding a thick book was walking towards the direction of the host.

Setius’s hand trembled roughly at the sight of the girl walking to the front of the auction house.

He had not received any prior information about the girl he saw in front of him.

“Wha, what...?”

“Setius, what is that...?”

“I don’t know either. Wasn’t it your preparation?”

Setius’s bewildered eyes turned to his secretary.

But the secretary also shook his head in confusion.

It was then that Setius realized the situation.

An unexpected situation was happening.

And it was a situation that Setius himself did not want at all.

“I’m also enjoying this auction.”

Tap. Tap.

The girl’s light footsteps echoed on the stage.

The host who was conducting the auction also looked flustered.

As the girl who came up on the stage took her place in front of the host, he moved forward with a magic device that had amplification magic on it.

The host, who held the magic device, had a puzzled expression on his face.

He looked at the girl who came up on the stage and delivered his voice through the magic device.

“Excuse me, but it’s troublesome if you come up here without permission.”

“You might die if you say one more word?”

But the girl didn’t care about the host’s attitude, and just smiled with her finger on her lips.

The host then realized his situation and was startled.

Before he knew it, a shadow that sprang from the floor had grabbed his head firmly.

A fearful voice soaked in fear came out of the host's mouth.

“Uh... uh uh...”

“Shh.”

“...”

Setius, who was watching the silent host, got up from his seat.

It was a situation where a magician who handled bizarre magic had invaded the auction.

Anyone who saw the spectacle in front of them would know that it was an emergency situation.

Setius got up from his seat and pointed his finger at the girl on the stage.

He gave an urgent order to the security forces that were sitting in the auction house.

“Get, get that woman down—!”

“You too.”

As soon as the gentle voice from the stage ended,

Setius sensed that something had happened to him as well.

Swish.

He felt a cold sensation on his neck.

A shadow that sprang from the floor had grabbed Setius's neck.

Setius's heart, touched by the black shadow, began to warn him urgently.

“Ahh...”

“Please be quiet, everyone. You're interrupting me from introducing the auction items.”

“...”

Silence fell over the conference hall as soon as the girl's words ended.

In silence, the girl looked down at each of them in the auction house.

The girl who held two people's lives was very relaxed.

Thud.

The girl picked up a magic brooch that came out as an auction item and pinned it to her chest.

And then she spoke to the nobles hiding among the standing knights.

“I've prepared a special item for a fun auction.”

There was no item that could be called a product in the girl's hand.

She had even pinned the brooch that existed to her chest.

Yet she opened her mouth imitating the host who had been conducting the auction until then.

She spoke about the only auction item she could offer to those who attended this place.

“The item I'm going to show you this time is... your lives.”

A short and simple threat.

Right after that, a pitch-black world descended on the entire auction house.

Chapter 123: Get Rich Quick (4)

Chapter 123: Get Rich Quick (4)

In the dark auction hall, knights with drawn swords glared at the girl in front of them.

She held a large book in one hand and looked around the hall with a calm expression.

The knights standing in the hall were all from noble families who came to hire guards.

Despite having such knights in front of her, the girl still showed a relaxed attitude.

One of the nobles protested loudly at the girl's attitude, which seemed to look down on them.

“Who are you? How dare you act so crazy when you don't know who we are!”

“My identity, you ask?”

The girl stepped forward with a smile, her feet immersed in deep shadows.

A large wave spread from the black sea where the girl stood.

She looked down at the noble who spoke to her from the swaying shadows.

The difference in height created by their gazes felt like a difference in respect to everyone in the hall.

The girl looked down at everyone in the hall and revealed her identity in a clear voice.

“The first servant of the great one.”

“What...?”

“The first apostle, Eutenia Hyrost. And today, I will be your auctioneer.”

As soon as Eutenia’s voice ended, a huge figure rose from the darkness, making a loud noise throughout the hall.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

Black giants emerged from the rippling shadows and blocked the door of the hall.

The sight of the giants standing at the door made them guess that they had to break through them to get out of here.

The nobles who saw the giants blocking their escape glared at Eutenia on the stage.

“The apostle of Evil God...”

“Evil God? That’s rude to the great one. Those who speak rudely will lose their right to participate in the auction.”

As soon as Eutenia’s slender finger pointed at the noble, a thorn of shadow sprang from under his feet.

Puff.

The shadow thorn pierced through the noble’s abdomen in an instant.

His eyes turned red as he convulsed with the thorn in him.

He looked at his knight and screamed in a trembling voice.

“Sa... Save me...!”

“My lord! Are you alright!”

“Protect me, ugh... Everyone, protect me...!”

“You insolent bastard! How dare you do this to him!”

The knight who saw his master being attacked quickly cut off the thorn with his sword.

Clang!

The thorn that touched the knight’s sword with aura turned into smoke and scattered.

But the wound made by Eutenia’s shadow did not disappear and remained there.

Another knight quickly pressed on the bleeding noble’s wound to stop it.

The knight who cut off the thorn pointed his sword with aura at Eutenia.

The blue aura wrapped around his sword shone brightly.

He had to avenge his master who was attacked by an Evil God apostle.

“You wicked apostle of Evil God! I won’t let you do as you please here!”

Aura.

The symbol of a warrior who stands on the edge of life and death.

The aura that emanates from a warrior who has reached enlightenment vibrates endlessly and cuts through everything that collides with it.

The existence of a knight with aura was nothing but fear for magicians.

The knight seemed to trust his aura as he ran towards Eutenia with his sword wrapped in it.

The distance between him and Eutenia, who was standing on the ground, shortened in an instant.

Just before his sword reached Eutenia, a sound came out of her mouth.

“——Alpha.”

A golden eye glowed in the sea of shadows.

It broke through the deep darkness and opened its mouth at the knight who rushed at Eutenia.

Squeak.

A huge wall of shadow surrounded the knight with a sword.

The dark beast swallowed him whole and closed its mouth, making a sinister sound.

Crunch. Crunch.

As the beast sank into the shadows with the knight in its mouth, the auction hall where the nobles gathered was engulfed in a huge commotion.

Eutenia watched as most of the nobles who had been watching over their count panicked at the sight before them.

“Ah, Sir Altus...! No!”

“My lord! Don’t move!”

The count who lost his knight also vomited blood and glared at the beast.

It was a situation where an elite knight who could handle aura was easily devoured by a beast.

It was natural for him and his knights to be flustered.

Eutenia, who quickly dealt with one knight with her beast, looked at other knights.

“The others are quiet.”

“...”

Was it because they were aware of the situation unfolding in front of them?

None of the knights surrounding the count tried to jump forward.

There was no reason for them to risk their lives and defy Eutenia, when even a knight who could handle aura was easily defeated.

Eutenia was satisfied with the silence of the knights.

She looked around at the knights who were holding their weapons and protecting their masters.

“I hope there is no one else who will make a mistake here.”

No one provoked Eutenia even after she finished her words.

They realized that she was deliberately stalling for time, even though she could start a fight right now.

Seeing the other knights back down, Eutenia sat down leisurely.

Numerous shadows appeared from the darkness and made a seat for her.

Eutenia sat on the throne of shadows and tapped her finger on the armrest as she watched the guests in the hall.

“Then let’s have a chat slowly. We have plenty of time left.”

The auction hall of the Duke of Obotos, covered with black darkness.

There, the knights stayed close to their masters with their mouths shut.

They knew who was ruling this place filled with darkness.

Behind the auction hall where the auction was in full swing.

In the corridor of the building where the items needed for the auction were moved, Pluto stared ahead with Deathside in his hand.

In front of him were soldiers carrying large boxes and knights who were directing them.

They looked like forces protecting the items to be auctioned.

Pluto blocked their way in the middle of the corridor and looked at the boxes they were guarding.

“Is that what I think it is? The magic stone that’s supposed to be auctioned off?”

Pluto said, holding Deathside.

One of the knights in front of him stepped forward to block Pluto on behalf of the others.

Clank.

The knight drew his sword and pointed it at Pluto with both hands.

His eyes, full of caution, scanned Pluto up and down.

“I can’t tell you any information about what we’re carrying. And no one who hasn’t reported to us can access it. If you’re from outside, get out of here right now.”

“You’re managing it more strictly than I thought.”

“I’m warning you again. Put down your weapon and get out of here. If you don’t comply, we’ll use force.”

The knight who stood his ground warned Pluto.

It was a clear threat that he would cut him down if he came closer.

But Pluto didn’t care about his threat and just brought his finger to his mouth.

He opened his mouth and showed his fangs, then brought his finger close to them.

Snap. A sharp sound came out as blood started flowing from Pluto’s finger.

He pointed his bleeding finger at the ground and said,

“I’ll make it painless for you, so don’t worry too much.”

Plop.

A drop of blood fell from Pluto’s finger to the ground.

The soldiers who watched him kept dropping red drops on the ground with puzzled expressions.

But Pluto just kept dropping blood from his finger in front of them.

Plop. Plop.

Pluto’s action made the knight frown and approach him with his sword.

The sharp sword in his hand was still aimed at Pluto.

“What are you doing? Stop it right now or I’ll take it as an insult to the Duke of Obotos...”

“Boom.”

“Boom? What are you saying...”

Boom——!

A heavy explosion engulfed the knight’s body in flames.

It was blood magic, a vampire’s unique magic that controlled blood from his body, that attacked him.

As soon as the flames that wrapped around him disappeared, he collapsed on the spot, unconscious.

Thick smoke came out and enveloped the soldiers who coughed.

The other knights who saw their colleague fall victim to a surprise attack quickly formed a line.

“Enemy attack! Be careful!”

“How dare you do this in the Duke of Obotos’ territory, you must be out of your mind!”

“The enemy is a magician who uses blood magic! Watch out for his long-range attacks!”

The ones in charge of transporting the items were also classified as elites in the Duke of Obotos’ house.

They didn’t lose their composure and fail to respond just because one knight was ambushed.

They quickly formed a line and the soldiers also maintained their formation by raising their spears.

The knights left behind the soldiers who were protecting the items and stepped forward to eliminate Pluto, who was a threat.

Of course, blood kept dripping from Pluto’s finger even then.

“Hmm...”

“The enemy uses blood to cast magic! Don’t let it touch you! Be careful!”

The knights who raised their swords slowly approached Pluto to surround him.

He then stretched out his finger that he was holding.

The blood on his finger splashed onto the knight in front of him.

Did they not expect Pluto to splash blood like this?

The knight who got blood on his face widened his eyes and lifted his sword.

“Boom.”

“Aaargh...!”

Boom!

Another explosion engulfed the knight with Pluto’s blood magic.

The knight who suffered a fatal wound fell to the ground, spewing smoke.

Pluto, who had taken care of two knights with his blood magic in a row, took a step forward.

Thump. Thump.

His heavy boots made footsteps on the corridor of the auction hall.

The knights who had a hole in their line narrowed their gap and tried to deter Pluto who was approaching.

“Don’t come any closer! That’s not something you can touch!”

“Me? I don’t think I’m in a position to hear that kind of talk.”

“Shut up! Everyone! Prepare the scrolls!”

The knights who took out scrolls from their pockets tore them at once.

Pluto’s eyes scanned their scrolls.

The sentences printed on the top of the scrolls were from the central magic tower of the empire.

It was also a familiar item for Pluto, who had been dealing with the alchemist Elbon for a while.

Pluto lifted Deathside with both hands as he saw the knights using scrolls.

A vampire’s body was stronger than other races.

Especially for Pluto, who was the ancestor of vampires, it was not easy to inflict meaningful damage with any means.

“What a waste of effort.”

Pluto swung Deathside at the knights who rushed at him with scrolls torn.

Various lights burst out from their bodies.

From acceleration to all kinds of enhancement magic, they covered the knights who swung their swords at Pluto.

The swords of the knights with aura also emitted bright flames.

But Pluto calmly blocked their attacks with Deathside wrapped in darkness.

Even if he had forgotten most of his past memories, the martial arts he had learned were still in his fingertips.

“Die! Monster!”

Clang! Bang!

The sound of metal collision and explosion came out as many lights attacked Pluto.

One of the swords that swung at him pierced Pluto's shoulder.

But even that wound became another means of attack for Pluto.

He allowed the knight to attack him and moved the blood from his wound to activate blood magic.

Boom!

A fierce explosion blew away the knights who had rushed at him.

They groaned in pain as they flew away from Pluto.

“Cough...!”

“Ugh...”

Pluto ignored the knights rolling on the ground and approached the soldiers guarding the box.

The soldiers were also tense because of the fallen knights in their line.

Thump. Thump.

Pluto's footsteps echoed again in the corridor.

The wound on his shoulder had healed completely by now.

“Don't come any closer!”

One of the soldiers who pointed his spear at Pluto warned him as he approached the box.

Pluto faced the soldiers and raised Deathside with both hands.

Unlike when he took down the heavily armored knights, he intended to finish them all at once this time.

Along with the magic that protected the magic stone he was looking for.

“——Deathside.”

Darkness moved and created a black scythe in the air.

The black scythe could move along Deathside's trajectory and strike whatever Pluto aimed at.

Pluto swung Deathside hard at his enemies in front of him.

His blade made a transcendent slash that reached out.

Slash!

A black trail was drawn in the air as the soldiers guarding the box were cut down in an instant.

The magic that protected the box also broke completely by Deathside's strike.

The layers of magic shattered and the box that the soldiers were guarding collapsed in a moment.

“...”

Beyond the scattered darkness, Pluto's eyes saw a large purple gemstone.

A top-grade magic stone.

The purest and largest one among all existing magic stones was reflected in his eyes.

Chapter 124: Get Rich Quick (5)

Chapter 124: Get Rich Quick (5)

At the Holy Palace in Crossbridge.

There, Emperor Highpride II faced the priest in front of him.

The faces of the two people in the office were frozen in a cold situation.

There was one reason why Highpride II and the priest had such expressions.

It was because of the full story of the auction house raid that came from the Duke of Obotos' territory.

Highpride II glared at the priest standing in front of him with fierce eyes.

His darkened face showed an intense aura that did not match his age.

“How many people were injured?”

“Count Alimir was seriously injured, and ten knights, including those from his house, were killed. The number of soldiers who died is also considerable.”

“Of all things, the nobles of the empire were hurt...”

Hoo.

A deep sigh escaped from Highpride II's mouth.

The finances of the Holy Land were mostly funded by the donations from the nobles of the empire.

And an apostle of the evil god appeared at the place where those nobles gathered.

And because of the apostle, one of the counts of the empire was seriously injured.

It was not hard to guess which side the injured nobles would point their arrows of blame at.

As if to prove Highpride II's expectation, the priest continued his report in a cautious voice.

"The nobles of the empire are protesting against the appearance of the apostle. They say they will not donate to the temple for a while unless we send heroes right away."

"Even though the knights at the auction house were among the elite in the empire, they couldn't inflict any damage on the apostle?"

"The knights are those who prioritize protecting their nobles. As long as they don't provoke him, he won't bother them, so they just confronted him without shedding blood..."

"..."

The emperor could easily guess what happened behind the story.

They chose to compromise and comply with his demands rather than risking losing their knights by recklessly facing the apostle.

The situation of the knights was probably not much different.

If they provoked the apostle and lost their nobles they were escorting, their families would hold them accountable.

Only Count Alimir survived, and his knights died because of this background.

“The Duke of Obotos is also claiming responsibility for the missing auction items. We need to come up with some measures.”

“Measures? Do you think sending heroes is a measure?”

“I think that’s the best option for now.”

Highpride II looked at the map of the continent hanging on the wall after hearing the priest’s words.

He understood why the empire needed heroes when an apostle appeared.

It was their role to stop the forces of evil gods.

But right now, it was difficult to deploy heroes to deal with an apostle.

“We can’t send heroes.”

An apostle was a different enemy than other heretics of the cult.

The apostles were monsters that the evil god created and nurtured to destroy the world.

And unlike the monsters that served the evil god, they were cunning and wicked.

They hid among humans and manipulated their movements.

Maybe there were even some nobles who joined forces with the cult.

If they went to subjugate the apostle in a precarious state, they might lose their heroes.

‘I still need more time.’

The heroes needed time.

Time to grow properly so they could do their part.

That was why he had sent as many heroes as possible to the subjugation of Kueberg.

He wanted them to gain experience without getting hurt.

Highpride II wished for them to have a stepping stone to grow.

Of course, he would have to suppress the elders' opposition to achieve his will.

"It won't be easy. The elders will surely resist."

"Persuading them is my job."

"Your Majesty..."

"Of course, leaving the empire as it is would also be a problem... I have to put out the fire somehow."

He couldn't send heroes to the empire.

Then he had to send something else that could replace him.

Someone in the underground of the temple came to Highpride II's mind as he pondered.

A dark history that the Holy Land had created in the past when they were looking for a way to replace heroes.

A hero who claimed himself to be the eternal guardian, and the product of a long research that continued his legacy.

He thought of the old hero in the underground.

As he looked at the map and wondered, Highpride II ordered the priest.

"Bring me the Saintess of Knowledge."

"The Saintess of Knowledge... Do you mean Aurora?"

“Yes.”

“What should I tell her?”

There were two people needed to move the guardian in the underground.

The Hero of Knowledge. And the Saintess of Knowledge.

The one who had the closest relation to this grand plan was Aurora, the saintess.

She was the one that Arien Crost, the former Hero of Knowledge, wanted to protect even after his death.

The plan started from her, the oldest saintess.

He had to get her help to move it.

“Tell her this. ‘It seems like it’s time to use ‘that’.’”

“...”

“Also, bring me the Hero of Knowledge. Aurora will help you bring him.”

The priest who received Highpride II’s order opened the door and left.

Highpride II watched his back and prayed with his hands clasped.

I hoped that my decision was right.

And that the great goddess would watch over this world.

The auction house raid led by Eutenia was successfully completed with the achievement of their goal.

They had safely obtained the highest grade magic stone that they had aimed for from the beginning.

Of course, there were also various other harvests besides the highest grade magic stone.

Thanks to the apostles who participated in the operation, they also stole other auction items along with the highest grade magic stone.

They had prepared everything from magic tools with numerous enchantments to various kinds of magic scrolls.

They were not easy items to obtain.

“Why don’t we just rob the auction house every day?”

I had such a thought because it was so rewarding.

The cult had gained a lot of spoils.

Eutenia and Pluto, who participated in the operation, were happily dividing their loot.

It was to the point that a gold necklace was hanging on Yuto, who was in the middle of them.

There were also items that I could use among the spoils.

The magic book that Eutenia had offered and stuck in the inventory was one of them.

-[Magic Book: Monster Taming]

A magic book that contains the skill of <Monster Taming>.

According to Eutenia’s explanation, it was a magic that temporarily tamed a monster.

It was a skill that could temporarily influence the monsters that existed in the game.

I didn’t know how to move the monsters yet.

But anyway, it was a good thing that I had more skills to use.

I could check the details later when I had time.

-“This kind of thing might suit Pluto better.”

-“Really?”

-“Doesn’t the jewel in the middle match well?”

I closed the inventory and watched the apostles chatting on the screen.

They were wondering how to use the spoils they had obtained.

I watched them talk and didn’t forget to glance at the desk clock next to the TV.

The reason why I checked the time with the desk clock was simple.

Today was the day of the lottery draw that I had been waiting for.

There wasn’t much time left until the lottery broadcast.

I put down my smartphone with the game on and looked for the TV remote somewhere.

“Where did I put the remote? Why does it always disappear when I try to find it?”

Luckily, the remote was hidden under the pillow.

I didn’t know why it was there, but anyway, I was glad I found it.

Beep.

I pressed a button and turned on the TV.

And then I changed the channel to match the one where the draw was being broadcasted.

Just then, an intro video was playing on TV and the lottery draw started.

I picked up my lottery ticket with a nervous heart and looked at the TV screen.

-“Hello. I’m your host for Live Happy Lottery...”

The host appeared on the draw and greeted us.

I usually checked online rather than watching the draw, so it felt strange to watch it like this.

But today’s lottery was a special one that Estelle had predicted in my dream.

It was a lottery with a possibility of winning first place, so I wanted to match it with a devout heart on live broadcast.

Of course, I also wanted to check my numbers as soon as possible.

-“Let’s start with last week’s winning news.”

“Last week’s winning news?”

-“Total sales of lottery tickets 104.3 billion won. The first prize was 25.7 billion won and eight people won...”

“No, I don’t care. Just draw quickly.”

The live draw started with showing last week’s lottery results.

It told us how much money was sold last week and how much money was given to first place winners.

The winners of last week took 3.2 billion won each.

If I was lucky, I might also receive 3.2 billion won today.

Of course, if there were more winners, I might get less than that.

I watched the broadcast dreaming of a golden future, and soon, last week's winning news ended.

“Huh... Will they draw now?”

-”We'll show you live how lottery funds are used in ‘Lottery Man Goes’, today...”

“Ah.”

As I waited for them to draw finally, I couldn't help but stare at the TV screen with a blank face.

After last week's winning news, what came next was a program that showed where lottery funds were used.

I thought they would finally start drawing, but it was a disappointment.

The screen that showed the hosts moved to Osan city in Gyeonggi province.

I watched the scene of sharing on the screen and lost my mind.

I knew they were doing good things with lottery money, but I wished they would just draw faster.

“Sharing... Yeah, sharing is good.”

That's how it started and it took several minutes to end.

I appreciated their intention, but it made me feel like yawning.

When the screen changed and the hosts appeared again, I finally came to my senses and focused.

The hosts on the screen were introducing each other and having a conversation.

The time for the long-awaited draw was approaching.

I took a deep breath to calm myself and looked at the lottery ticket in my hand.

The lottery ticket in my hand had become wrinkled.

“Are they going to draw now?”

-“Regardless of the order of the balls, if the numbers match, it is considered a win. Now, let’s start the draw.”

“Ah, finally...”

As soon as the host pressed the button, the drawing machine appeared on the screen and the balls started moving quickly.

Whiiiiing.

The wind blew from the drawing machine and the balls came out one by one in order.

I opened my eyes wide and focused on the screen, comparing each winning number with the ticket in my hand.

My life would be determined by the numbers that came out here.

-“The first lucky number. Number 2!”

“Oh... 2.”

Fortunately, the first number matched.

Swoosh.

I picked up a pen nearby and drew a line on the matching number.

-“The second lucky number. Number 11.”

“Oh... 11.”

-“The third lucky number. Number 15.”

“Oh... 15.”

• ◦ ■ ■ “Now, what is the fourth number? Number 21.”

“Oh... 21.”

-“Let’s see the fifth ball. Number 27.”

“Oh... 27.”

-“The sixth number is... Number 35.”

“Oh... 35... No, it’s not. Then I’m not first place?”

All the other numbers matched, but unfortunately, the last number was wrong.

I waited for the bonus number for second place, but there was no match for that either.

All but one number matched.

The ticket I bought this time was not first or second place, but third place.

The amount of money you get when you win third place is around 1.5 million won on average.

It was a far cry from the amount you get when you win first place.

“Third place... Well, it’s not first place, but it’s a decent harvest.”

Still, it was a considerable amount for a thousand won ticket.

After taxes, I could recover about half of my previous expenses.

As I was satisfied with my own way, I was about to check how to receive it on my smartphone.

But before it was over, the host's voice came out of the draw broadcast.

-“This week... Surprisingly, most of the numbers match last week's winning numbers.”

“What?”

-“But please be assured that this draw was also conducted fairly in the studio.”

-“That's all for today's draw broadcast. Thank you.”

Thud.

The broadcast ended with the host's final remark.

I felt doubtful about what he said and immediately closed the game and opened the internet.

And then I went to a portal site and searched for the horrible imagination that came to my mind.

“Could it be?”

Last week's winning numbers.

I looked at the search results that appeared with a short keyword and gave a hollow laugh.

When I heard the numbers, I felt familiar somehow.

On my smartphone screen, there was a familiar sight of winning numbers.

They were the six lottery numbers that Estelle had told me in my dream.

“It was... last week's winning numbers.”

Apparently,

The goddess of luck had seen last week's draw.

Chapter 125: Monster Wave (1)

Chapter 125: Monster Wave (1)

The morning after the lottery frenzy was over.

I regretted not buying more tickets with the same number, as I ate ramen and played a game on my smartphone.

The lottery issue must have been resolved by now.

Now, I wanted to check the magic book I acquired yesterday.

[Magic Book: Monster Taming].

The item I received from Utenia was the main character of today's story.

“Monster taming... Since it would be hard to command monsters with words, I guess I'll be able to control them.”

Taming usually meant placing monsters under the influence of a player.

In other words, it was possible that I could have a character that I could control directly.

This game only allowed me to interfere with the movements of characters by talking or using skills.

Having a character that I could control directly meant that I could have more impact on the game than before.

I touched the [Magic Book: Monster Taming] with an excited heart.

When I used the magic book, a confirmation window popped up asking me if I wanted to use it.

Of course, I pressed 'yes' and acquired the skill.

-You have acquired <Monster Taming (Lv.MAX)>.

-You can now use the monster taming magic by consuming mana.

Along with the message that announced the acquisition of the skill, a skill icon for <Monster Taming> appeared at the bottom of the screen.

It was not an intuitive icon that matched the word taming.

And the detailed description of the skill was also vague.

It allows you to tame monsters on the field when used.

It was a description that only had abstract content, without any detailed explanation of the skill.

There was no choice but to try out the skill myself.

I looked at a farmer who was passing by nearby to test <Monster Taming>.

"I wonder if this works on people too."

Tap.

When I touched the skill icon, a button to select a target popped up.

It looked like I had to select a single target to use it, just like Lightning.

I moved the target to the farmer who was passing by, confirmed it, and activated the skill.

<Monster Taming> was activated and light wrapped around the farmer's body.

As I watched the farmer who was hit by the skill, he briefly looked around.

-“My eyes just flashed...”

-You used <Monster Taming> on an intelligent being.

That was all that happened to the farmer.

I followed the moving farmer and kept observing him, but nothing changed for him.

Even if I moved my finger and tapped his head, he only screamed and said nothing else.

In the end, <Monster Taming> had no effect on people.

“I guess it doesn’t work on people.”

It would be nice if I could tame people too.

I must have asked for too much in a game where there was a separate skill for <Apostle Selection>.

The only thing left to do was to find a monster and use taming on it.

After failing to tame the farmer, I started wandering around the map to find monsters.

Swish. Swish.

Every time I moved the screen, lush forests covered with all kinds of plants greeted me.

Was it because <The Eye of the Observer> had grown a lot?

Unlike before, I could see animals quite often.

“Deer. Turtle. Wolf. Don’t tell me you’re monsters too?”

As I looked at the animals roaming in the forest, I had one dilemma.

Would the animals I saw in front of me be treated as monsters too?

Usually, most of the animals encountered in games were considered monsters.

It might be a little different from the dictionary definition of a monster, but it was a plausible story if I thought of them as mobs.

Seeing a deer that came to the stream to drink water, I decided to try using the skill once.

I had to experiment to know more, after all.

-(Drinking water)

“There’s nothing but animals around here. Just be a monster.”

I brought my finger to the deer that had an emoticon above its head.

And then I placed the target of <Monster Taming> skill on top of the deer.

Squish.

When I clicked on the deer in the middle of the target, a bright light burst out from the screen and wrapped around the deer that was drinking water.

Along with the deer wrapped in light, a message popped up at the bottom of the screen.

-You used <Monster Taming>.

-The effect of <Monster Taming> lasts for 27 hours.

Did <Monster Taming> skill work properly on the deer?

This time, along with the message that said the effect lasted for 27 hours, a large amount of mana drained from the mana gauge.

The deer that received the skill effect raised its head.

Red light glowed from its eyes, and black aura flowed from its body.

I was surprised by the enhanced deer, but also stared at the gem-shaped icon that appeared in the middle of the screen.

“What is this? Did I make this appear by using the skill?”

As I was curious about the icon that appeared as soon as I used the skill, a message about the skill appeared at the bottom of the screen.

Unlike before, it was a message that had a detailed explanation of how to use the skill.

-You can guide the tamed monster in the direction where the guidance marker appears.

-Move the marker to guide the monster.

It seemed that I could guide the monster through the marker that appeared on the screen.

It looked like I could only control its direction of movement, not its detailed actions.

I was disappointed by the effect of <Monster Taming>, but I followed the message and moved the guidance marker.

The deer that was tamed by the skill moved its red eyes in the direction of the marker.

The deer that emitted a red glow opened its mouth and raised a speech bubble above its head.

-Grrrrrr.

Black smoke spewed from the mouth of the roaring deer.

It looked more like a wolf than a deer now.

I watched the deer and moved the marker towards the other animals around.

When I moved the marker to control the tamed monster, the deer's head turned in the direction of the marker.

I pulled the marker to a distant location and tried to guide the deer's behavior.

“Right, let's move.”

As soon as I moved the guidance marker, the deer ran in the direction of the marker.

Clack. Clack.

The sound of the deer's hooves echoed in the forest.

The deer that started to accelerate as it ran through the forest rammed into the animals on the path of the marker one by one.

Crash! Bang! Boom!

Every time its sharp horns collided with animals, they flew far away.

I couldn't help but admire the animals that spun as if they were going to fly to the sun.

“Wow, this is amazing...”

As it ran in the direction of the marker, it sent all the animals it collided with flying.

Still, the deer didn't slow down and kept running.

It felt like playing a difficult racing game with the marker.

Even if I moved the marker in a zigzag direction, the deer only had a slight delay and knocked down everything on its path.

Of course, since the tamed deer was not invincible, its horns were badly damaged.

I was moved by the primal fun I felt for a long time and dreamed of the most ideal scenario.

“This is it... I have to make a horde of terrifying deer.”

A herd of red-eyed deer running across a vast plain.

Everything would turn into a wasteland where they passed.

My heart raced at the sight I imagined and I searched around with the marker.

I had to find more deer hiding somewhere nearby.

For my dream of a deer horde that filled all ranks with cavalry.

“Is this your first time in Sanctuary?”

A floating island in high altitude.

There, Perin, who held a staff, spoke to Peter.

Peter nodded as he ascended to Sanctuary, which all members of the Order called it.

He knew it existed from Roan’s story, but this was his first time stepping on it.

He finally set foot on a place that everyone in the Order would envy.

Although Peter himself was not affiliated with the Order, he understood how amazing it was to face this place.

“This is... Sanctuary...”

Peter muttered as he looked down from the edge of the island.

A strong wind blew on Peter’s cheek as he looked down.

He remembered what Perin had told him as he felt the wind on his cheek.

According to Perin, there was no wind in Sanctuary normally.

It was because Egdrasil’s barrier blocked out the harsh wind that came into Sanctuary.

But now, they temporarily disabled the barrier to help Peter enter Sanctuary.

That’s why Peter could feel this kind of outside wind for once.

“Isn’t it amazing to see the world from above?”

“...Yeah.”

The view of the ground from Sanctuary looked very small.

It was a different dimension from what he saw from a high mountain.

It felt like he had everything on earth below him.

Was this how it felt like to be a god who ruled over earth from above?

Maybe this Sanctuary was created by an evil god who wanted to make his apostles feel the same way.

As Peter admired looking down at earth, Perin stroked Egdrasil with his hand and said,

“Yuto is also a very good friend.”

“Yuto?”

“The spirit that keeps Sanctuary floating. It’s a special spirit that doesn’t return to Spirit Realm!”

“Oh... A spirit lifted Sanctuary.”

A spirit that could lift an island in mid-air.

It was an incomprehensible realm for Peter.

Peter had a special sword that knights used around his waist, but even that was just something Yutenia gave him.

In the end, Peter remained ordinary from beginning to end.

Except for the fact that he had a hero’s mark on his skin wrapped in bandages.

Peter grabbed his bandages that made him feel uncomfortable and looked at Perin who was acting timidly.

“What did you say? You’re coming back to Sanctuary again?”

Perin was a fairy.

A race that Peter had never encountered before he came here.

A fairy that only existed in old stories was the guardian of Sanctuary and lived here.

Peter felt both unfamiliar and friendly with the fairy in front of him.

It was the magic of mystery created by the stories he heard long ago.

“Roan... I mean, the archbishop asked me to see what we need for fortification when he comes back.”

“Are you building a fortress in Sanctuary?”

“Well, I don’t think it’s really necessary if we have the barrier. Maybe it’s enough to just make some houses if we grow a bit more.”

Sanctuary suited the fairy very well.

The giant tree and the blue grass that decorated the floor.

It was surely a paradise for fairies to live in, except for the old man who was examining the magic stone in the corner.

Except for the old man.

As Peter was thinking that, he looked down at the ground again and saw something he hadn’t seen before.

“Huh? What’s that...”

A spot on the ground far away from Peter’s feet.

There, a huge dust cloud was spreading.

The thing that moved while spreading dust was a familiar creature to Peter.

A majestic and sharp horn.

And four agile legs.

Peter opened his mouth in surprise as he identified what they were moving so swiftly.

“De, de, de, deer...”

A familiar animal running with red eyes.

It was a deer mad with rage.

Chapter 126: Monster Wave (2)

Chapter 126: Monster Wave (2)

It had been a few hours since I started collecting deer with <Monster Taming>.

It was not an easy task to gather deer.

The animals around ran away as soon as they heard the sound of the deer's hooves.

But I was a man of stubbornness and guts.

For the sake of my dream of a deer horde, I could find deer without much difficulty.

I opened my eyes wide and searched for deer nearby for my goal.

It was not a simple thing to tame a fleeing deer and join it with other deer.

-You used <Monster Taming>.

-You used <Monster Taming>.

-You used <Monster Taming>.

-You used <Monster Taming>.

After wandering around for hours looking for deer, I finally made the deer horde I had been longing for.

A horde of terrifying deer that flashed red eyes and breathed out steam.

I had made a fearsome unit that only had cavalry.

I couldn't help but be moved by the sight of the deer that emitted a dreadful aura.

Since it was the result of wasting hours of time, I had a lot of affection for the deer horde.

“Why do they look so cool when they're gathered?”

The sight of the proud deer standing with their horns in front was magnificent.

They wouldn't look awkward even if they got up and punched with their hooves.

When I moved the marker that tied them up slightly forward, the tamed deer moved their feet forward gracefully.

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

The sound of their heavy footsteps echoed as they moved in sync.

I looked at the deer rolling forward and expressed my short admiration.

“It feels like I'm a commander of the Demon King's army.”

They were more like monsters than deer.

When I gathered and moved monsters like this, it felt like I was a commander of the Demon King's army that would appear in novels.

Usually, the Demon King's army didn't collect monsters that were so ferocious.

I usually scoffed at stories about evil gods and such, but today I felt like becoming a commander of the Demon King's army.

-Grrrrrrrrr.

-Grrrrr.

As they looked at the guidance marker and breathed out together, I decided to move the marker with determination.

I wanted to see the power of the deer horde that I had worked hard to collect.

As I pulled the guidance marker, all the deer started running at once, led by the first one I tamed.

A huge dust cloud rose as they ran forward together.

Kugugugugung—!

The earth shook and a loud noise came out of the speaker every time the deer stepped on it.

It was a sound that made my chest swell with pride.

I moved the marker on my finger back and forth to guide the direction of the charging deer.

-Grrrrrr!

Every time the deer's hooves tore up the ground, the trampled place became barren.

The flowers that bloomed brightly were broken and rolled on the floor, and the lush grasses flattened and merged with the ground.

They affected the terrain just by moving in a group.

I felt a different kind of fun from when I tore up the map with magic, as I saw the ground change every time I moved my finger.

It felt like I was painting over the natural scenery with the guidance marker.

“Ah... This is why I raise deer.”

I led the deer horde through the golden field, and they trampled it with their hooves.

Nothing remained intact where the deer went.

Sometimes, beasts blocked the deer's path, but they were eliminated by their sharp horns.

Nothing could stop the deer that ran in a group with enhanced power.

That was true even for predators that preyed on deer.

The deer's eyes that glowed red did not discriminate.

-(Drinking water)

-Grrrrr!

-Craaaash!

The deer showed no mercy to the wolf pack that was drinking water.

The wolves were flung into the air by the deer's horns.

Did Genghis Khan feel like this when he roamed the plains with his men?

I tried to control the rampaging deer delicately, and removed all the obstacles around them without mercy.

As I guided the deer without pause, I spotted a hunter holding a bow in the distance.

-“Is that a deer?”

-Grrr.

-“It looks sturdy. It would be perfect to roast and eat.”

The hunter aimed his bow at a deer that was running ahead of the others, as if he had caught sight of it.

He spoke in a speech bubble.

But there was no way he could stop the charge of the enhanced deer horde with one measly arrow.

The arrow that the hunter shot flew past the head of the leader deer.

The hunter looked disappointed as he watched the leader deer run away.

-“Eek... My hand trembled and I missed.”

But he didn’t seem to give up just because he missed one arrow.

The hunter pulled the bowstring again and aimed at the leader deer.

He only realized the true nature of the deer horde a few seconds later.

Koo-goo-goo-goo-gung!

Far behind the leader deer that was running around.

There, the invincible deer horde with glowing eyes revealed themselves.

The deer horde that appeared in front of the hunter immediately charged at him.

-“Aaaaaah!”

-Karma increased by 1.

The hunter was hit by the deer horde and flew in the air, spinning. Soon, he became a star in the sky and disappeared.

Of course, leaving behind 1 karma was a bonus.

I smiled with satisfaction as I watched the deer horde blow away the hunter.

The performance of the deer horde that I had collected with difficulty for hours was more than satisfactory.

After checking the power of the rampaging deer, I moved the marker to select the next destination.

“I should take them to the castle this time.”

How far could I break through with these deer?

I was going to experiment with that from now on.

A city in Atelot region, Ode-Atelot.

The captain of the guard who was in charge of security there yawned, unable to bear the boredom.

Today was the day that his hundred-man unit guarded the gate of the castle.

He blinked his eyes as he yawned and looked beyond the gate.

In a little while, it would be time for the ten-man unit that had gone out to patrol around the castle to return.

The reason he came out to the gate was also to receive a direct report from the ten-man captain.

“Captain. It’s time for the soldiers who went out for patrol to return.”

“Is it that time already?”

As if to remind him of that fact, one of his subordinates told him.

It was a procedure to check again in case of emergency.

The captain answered his subordinate and looked at the distant forest.

The atmosphere that swayed under the scorching sun distorted the appearance of the forest.

The captain took off his helmet and wiped his sweat, and then his subordinate who had reported to him pointed at something far away with his hand.

“Captain...”

“Do you see them coming back already? You really have an amazing eye.”

“That’s not the whole ten-man unit that went out for patrol... It looks like only one soldier is rushing back here.”

The captain praised him for a moment, but he couldn’t help but be confused by the content of his report.

Despite sending out a ten-man unit for patrol, his subordinate only saw one soldier returning. That meant something had gone wrong.

The captain’s eyes turned to where his subordinate’s finger pointed.

While they were talking, the soldier was running desperately. Maybe because of that, the captain could also see a soldier bleeding and approaching slowly in his sight.

“Did they fight in the forest...?”

This area was patrolled regularly by Ode-Atelot’s guard unit.

If a soldier who went out for patrol came back injured from there, it meant there was something problematic around.

For example, like encountering an enemy force that was exploring their patrol area.

Sensing an ominous atmosphere, the captain gave an order to his subordinates in his hundred-man unit.

“Everyone! Raise your alert!”

“Yes!”

“Stop the checkpoint for now! I’ll give further instructions after I get the report!”

The captain’s eyes stared at the soldier who was approaching with injuries.

The soldier was running with blood dripping from his head, gasping for breath.

There was no sign of any other soldiers behind him.

The captain raised his hand at the sight of the soldier.

Clank.

The guard unit raised their spears and stopped the soldier who was running urgently.

The soldier stopped in front of the guard unit that had a fierce aura.

He caught his breath and looked at the captain.

“Huff, huff...”

“What happened? Why did you come back alone?”

“It’s a disaster, huff... a disaster, sir!”

“Explain in detail. What happened to the other guards?”

“That’s, that’s...”

The soldier who was reporting trembled as the captain interrogated him.

The soldier who had turned pale looked behind him periodically, as if he was terrified.

The captain reached out his hand to the soldier's shoulder and calmed him down.

The soldier's eyes that met the captain's were bloodshot.

The captain gripped the soldier's shoulder firmly and asked him.

"I'll ask you again. Why did you come back alone? And what happened to the ten-man captain and the other guards?"

"They were all killed by them! I had no choice but to run away!"

Ouch.

The captain's hand that held the soldier's shoulder tightened.

The captain pressed his forehead against the soldier's and glared at him.

The soldier's face became even whiter under the captain's fierce gaze.

"Make yourself clear! Who killed them all?"

"Deer! Watch out for deer!"

"Deer? What are you talking about?"

"Deer are coming!"

He suddenly warned them to be careful of deer.

It was an incomprehensible story for the captain.

What did he mean by deer coming?

They could easily catch a deer or two if they stuck together as a ten-man unit.

That's what he thought as he was about to question the soldier again.

“What do you mean by deer, ah...”

He saw a huge herd of deer coming from afar and stopped talking.

Koo-goo-goo-goo-gung!

From the forest far away, deer were running with smoke rising behind them.

They had sharp horns on their heads and glowing eyes.

They looked like demons from hell.

As he saw the deer running with a loud noise, he quickly threw the soldier inside.

And he gave an order to the guards who were guarding the gate.

“Deer are coming! Close the gate!”

“Close the gate!”

It was obvious what would happen if the deer came into the city.

The guards who heard the captain’s order rushed to the gate and started to close it.

Those who were being checked also ran inside, but the guards had no time to stop them.

Screech.

The heavy gate moved and made a loud friction sound.

The guards who closed the gate quickly locked it with a bolt.

Barely in time to close the gate, one of the guards who was on duty on the wall shouted in a loud voice.

“Deer are coming!”

Right after his warning voice ended.

There were successive impacts on the closed gate.

Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

A pile of deer rammed into it and made a loud noise.

The captain looked at the gate that was shaking from being hit by deer and felt a chill on his back.

Despite being made sturdy, the gate was shaken by the deer's collision.

If this continued, the gate might collapse because of the deer.

He looked at his subordinate next to him and gave an order.

He had to call those who he needed most at this moment here.

“It's an emergency! Report to the lord and the guard commander immediately!”

“What should I report?”

“A monster wave has occurred!”

Chapter 127: Monster Wave (3)

Chapter 127: Monster Wave (3)

The deer squad that I created with my <Monster Taming> skill was more terrifying than I imagined.

They had incredible destructive power from their enhanced bodies and speed.

The deer charged at the gate one after another, breaking the wall and storming into the castle.

As soon as the deer broke through the gate, the characters behind the wall screamed and ran away.

Then, the deer marched into the city.

-“Aaaah!”

-“It’s the deer! Run for your lives!”

The characters who hid inside the buildings had no choice, but the ones who were on the street flew far away and became stars in the night sky.

The guards who couldn’t escape were trampled by the deer’s hooves.

Of course, there were some soldiers in the town who tried to fight back against the deer, but many of them faced a hopeless situation under the merciless bombardment of the deer.

I watched the castle turn into a hellish scene, and moved my guidance marker to the center of the inner sanctum.

I moved the marker more for experimental purposes than for conquering the castle.

I wanted to see how the deer would react if I placed the marker in an inaccessible place.

-Rrrrrrr!

-“Deer... There are deer!”

– “How can this be... The evil god has unleashed his demons on the earth!”

The soldiers who were confused by the sight of the deer rushing towards the inner sanctum started to move.

They couldn't just ignore the deer invading their sacred place, even if they were soldiers.

Of course, I was still gaining a large amount of karma during that time.

I wonder if the karma gain from <Monster Taming> is considered as my direct involvement.

The karma that came from the deer horde was not as much as when Kueberg moved.

“I wish there wasn't such a difference in the karma gain.”

When I use my skill to obtain karma directly, it's only about half as efficient as when the apostles moved.

It meant that I couldn't just abuse <Monster Taming> everywhere.

That was probably one of the factors that made this game a passive game.

As I watched the deer's movements, I saw men in armor coming out of the inner sanctum.

Clank. Clank.

I heard the heavy sound of metal rubbing every time they took a step.

They wore thick armor and watched the deer that were rampaging through the streets.

They looked like knights who belonged to the castle.

“Oh... Are these the elite characters who were hiding in the castle?”

Unlike the soldiers who were guarding the entrance, these were strong characters who came out this time.

The knights who saw the deer drew their swords at once.

Ching.

The swords of the knights who quickly pulled them out glowed with a blue haze.

It was similar to the light that wrapped around Evan's sword when I first met him.

The difference was that the light that enveloped the knights' swords flickered faintly.

It looked like a skill that only elite characters who met certain conditions could use.

The knight who led them pointed his shining sword at the deer.

-“We'll clean up the demons that invaded the castle.”

-“Yes, sir!”

-“Be careful not to get hurt, everyone.”

It seemed like the knights were going to subdue the deer horde themselves.

As if to prove it, they ran towards the deer together.

The sword of the knight in front cut off the neck of a deer that was blocked by the wall.

A blue flash that wrapped around his sword drew a trail, and the deer that was cut by his sword fell to the ground.

Beyond the deer that he killed, there was a character who was soaked in fear hiding.

-“K-Knight... Thank you!”

-“I’ll slay the demons myself! Everyone, go inside the buildings and hide!”

The character who saw the fallen deer thanked the knight.

The knight also gave him instructions after receiving his gratitude.

The characters started to hide in their houses one by one when they heard that the knight would take action.

The knight who held his sword moved his head to find his next target.

It was a scene of the knights moving and killing the deer one by one.

Normally, I would have tried to stop the knights myself.

But today, I didn’t make that choice.

“It seems that every castle has some characters of that level.”

Of course, there were several reasons for that.

One of them was to check the strength of the characters who lived in the castle.

I wanted to see the difference between the apostles and elite characters that I had with my own eyes.

Just by observing the battle in front of me, I could roughly estimate the level of the enemies.

This information would be useful in the war with the empire that would happen someday.

-Rrrrrrr!

-“Die! You dogs of the evil god!”

Another reason was that the taming effect on the deer was not permanent.

The deer would return to their original state after 27 hours of using the skill.

The deer were nothing but consumables, not something that I could train and nurture.

So I had no reason to try to protect them at all costs.

It was enough to protect them with the leaders and apostles of the cult.

“It seems that the deer are easily caught by elite characters.”

I made a conclusion as I saw the number of deer quickly decreasing after the knights started to move forward.

Of course, there were also some knights who were pierced by the deer’s horns and turned into karma.

The deer shook their horns at the knights who blocked them.

But most of the knights moved strategically and cut down the deer.

-“There are not many enemies left!”

“And be careful, we don’t know when or where the dark mages will attack next.”

“Yes.”

“This is the dark mages’ territory. They are most powerful in their own domain, so we need to be on guard.”

Hoo.

With a white breath, Ban’s thoughts faded away.

He had been chasing the traces of the dark mages for a long time.

It was a clue that he barely caught after many trials and errors.

He couldn’t afford to waste any more time and let them slip away with their accumulated power.

As Ban moved towards the cave, he heard a voice from behind him.

It was his subordinate, who pointed at somewhere with his finger and told him something.

“Inspector Ban. There are five undead moving on the left.”

“Don’t move, everyone. I’ll handle them.”

As if to prove Ban’s warning, he saw the undead moving in the distance.

If the undead that faced Ban and his subordinates went back, it was only a matter of time before the information reached the dark mages.

But in this place where snow piled up, the inspectors’ movements were not free.

Ban decided to move himself instead of his subordinates.

Shriek.

The sword that Ban wore reflected the dazzling sunlight and came out.

“...”

In the blizzard that blocked his sight, Ban's blue eyes looked beyond.

His refined senses could detect even the movements of the enemies far away.

Ban, who covered his sword with aura, stared at the undead that walked slowly.

The snow piled up also slowed down the undead's movements.

Ban aimed the tip of his sword at the undead, and then swung it with a big motion.

The aura that was on the edge of his sword flew out in a crescent shape.

“O-aura...!”

His subordinates were amazed by the flying aura for a moment.

The aura that flew at a fast speed collided with the undead.

Kwaang!

The loud explosion was buried by the magic of the mountain range.

Snow flew up from the aftermath of the explosion where the undead were.

Crack.

Ban confirmed the faint cracking sound in his ears and put his sword back in its sheath.

“I took care of them. Let's keep moving.”

“...”

Maybe they were impressed by the inspector's skill.

The inspectors gaped at Ban who had cleared the undead.

Ban flipped his hood back on and glared at them.

It was good to be surprised, but now they needed to move as fast as possible.

Ban frowned and grabbed his hood as he opened his mouth to them.

“What are you doing? We better get into the cave before the blizzard gets worse.”

With that, Ban started to move towards the cave that was his goal.

The inspectors who were staring blankly at him also came to their senses and followed him.

Thud. Thud.

The white mountain range where the blizzard was raging.

The inspectors' footsteps echoed regularly in the quiet mountain range.

Chapter 128: Ruler of Death (1)

Chapter 128: Ruler of Death (1)

Abyss.

It was a secret society of dark mages located in the Alterius region, founded with the ambition of overthrowing the empire.

But as time passed, so did the purpose of the society change naturally.

Now, Abyss was moving for a greater ambition than toppling the empire.

The descent of a god who would look down on the world.

A grand undertaking that was more superior and noble than ruling a mere nation.

That was their goal.

The dark mages of Abyss were looking forward to the reaction of the lowly humans when the holy celestial god descended to the earth.

“Kerington. Where is Arcrosis?”

And there was one being who planted such a dream in them.

The necromancer king of the undead, Arcrosis.

He was only allowed to be summoned by the primal dark mage, and he was the ultimate necromancy that all dark mages longed for.

He came down to the continent himself and opened the way for the dark mages.

After Arcrosis appeared in Abyss, the dark mages of Abyss acquired a level of necromancy that was incomparable to before.

Just by his presence, such a change occurred.

Then what would happen if a being higher than him—the ‘evil god’ descended to the earth?

It was not an easy task for anyone to guess what would come next.

Because an irreversible cataclysm would occur in the whole world.

“Arcrosis is not here. I heard he is researching a connection channel with the abyss.”

Kerington, the leader of Abyss who was imagining the near future, spoke to Edella who was questioning him.

Edella, who was the only red spot in Abyss, had a very eccentric personality here.

In fact, most dark mages were like that, but Edella was especially different from others.

She showed an obsessive attitude towards Arcrosis after making a contract with him.

It was natural that everyone in Abyss found her annoying.

Of course, Arcrosis did not care about her attitude at all.

When he returned an answer after recalling what Arcrosis had left behind, Edella looked at Kerington with a doubtful face and said,

“The abyss?”

They say he's looking for a way to bring the abyssal beasts to the surface. Of course, it seems like he hasn't achieved anything yet... But how could we ever understand the will of the oldest demon?

Edella nodded as she listened to Kerington's story.

As Kerington said, Arcrosis was a being of a different caliber from them.

Whatever he tried to do, a mere dark mage like her could not comprehend it.

Even if she stepped forward, it was impossible for her to help him.

"I see. He's not in the abyss today either."

"Do you have something to see Arcrosis for?"

"Is that even a question? Obviously, I want to learn necromancy from him."

Kerington sighed at Edella's snappy attitude.

No matter how talented she was in dark magic, there was an order to everything.

Besides, they had promised eternal life to Arcrosis.

Time was nothing but a trivial obstacle for the abyssal officers.

Tap. Tap.

Kerington tapped the floor with his staff and lectured Edella.

"Follow the order. You're not the only one who gave your heart to Arcrosis."

On the day they made a contract with Arcrosis,
their hearts stopped functioning.

The time granted to them also came to a halt.

They wore human skins, but their essence was closer to liches.

Kerington scolded her as he recalled the heartbeat he no longer felt, and Edella lowered her head with a dissatisfied face.

“That’s up to Arcrosis to decide.”

“Edella...!”

“Anyway, let me know when Arcrosis comes. The king of the undead would see that a genius like me has more value to teach.”

With that, Edella slammed the door and left the meeting room.

Thud.

The sound echoed in the cave as the door closed.

Kerington stared at the door that Edella had left through and furrowed his brow deeply.

He suppressed the anger that rose in his heart, and soon he looked at the altar with a rough sigh.

It was an altar dedicated to the god that Arcrosis had created himself.

“O great one. Please let that damned woman be struck by lightning and die soon.”

Kerington whispered his wish as he looked at the altar.

It would have some effect if he performed a ritual with a sacrifice, but what he was saying now was more like a complaint, so he didn’t bother to do that.

As he was about to get up from his seat after making his wish,

he felt something and shuddered.

“This is...”

Kerington’s sharp sense warned him of danger.

He felt a strange sensation from the magic link that connected him and looked at the closed door.

The magic bond that extended beyond the closed door was collapsing.

It was a phenomenon that only occurred when the necromantic magic used by a dark mage was dispelled.

“The undead are destroyed...?”

The undead that Kerington had created with his magic were destroyed.

The weather in Alterias was harsh, but not enough to easily damage the undead.

Besides, Kerington’s necromancy had improved since he met Arcrosis.

The undead he made were stronger and sturdier than before.

So there was only one thing that the destruction of his undead meant.

“Could it be... an intruder has come.”

There was an intruder nearby.

And someone who could easily take down the undead.

* * * * *

At dawn, when the blizzard began to subside,

Van, a special investigator, advanced with a sharp gaze.

He saw a cave hidden in the darkness ahead.

Two huge undead were guarding the entrance of the cave.

As he faced the undead guarding the entrance, Van finally confirmed that he had reached the abyssal headquarters.

There was only one place in the snowstorm where the undead would guard.

It was the abyssal headquarters where the dark mages lived.

“Get ready.”

It was the moment I had been waiting for so long. I had finally found the enemy’s headquarters.

Clang.

As soon as I confirmed the presence of the enemy, I quietly drew my sword.

The investigators who followed me also cautiously raised their swords.

It was a fight against a horde of dark mages.

It would surely be more difficult than the previous raids we had conducted.

“Yes.”

“Let’s take care of the undead at the entrance and then move inside.”

All the investigators looked at the cave entrance with tense expressions.

As I raised my sword, I started running towards the place where the undead were.

We had taken many rests and recovered our stamina before reaching this place.

Now we had to prove that our preparations were not in vain.

Pababababak!

My sword tip sparkled as I cut through the snow and moved forward.

The blue aura on my sword drew a clear trail in the air.

“First, these two.”

Thud. Thwack.

The two undead that were slashed by my sword fell to the ground.

That was the end of suppressing the sentries guarding the entrance.

After quickly taking down the enemy, I and the first-class investigators of Cloud entered the cave.

I checked on those who followed me and started going inside the cave.

“...”

There were candles lined up in the cave where we had entered after killing the undead.

The flickering candles lit up our sight, and there was a staircase leading down from the entrance.

The spiral staircase looked quite deep.

I measured the length of my sword and the width of the cave as I moved my steps towards the bottom of the staircase.

“Cloud is here! The investigators have appeared!”

“Skeleton soldiers! Stop them!”

As I went down the staircase with candles and searched around, I soon encountered the dark mages on the lower floor.

The dark mages who patrolled the cave had two undead each on their sides.

It was a typical combat style of dark mages to cope with unexpected attacks.

The dark mages who faced me immediately spread their hands and started preparing magic.

The undead were responsible for buying time while the dark mages prepared their magic.

The undead, armed with unknown weapons, blocked my way.

– Clank. Clank.

The eerie sound of undead echoed in the cave.

I had heard it many times while fighting against numerous dark mages, but it was still hard to get used to it.

I frowned and held my sword as I guarded against the wall.

Wasn't it said that prepared mage's territory was most dangerous?

It seemed that not only the dark mages in front of me but also the defense magic of their hideout was activated.

I could tell by the way the hands started to reach out from the cave walls.

“What a dreadful place.”

I uttered a short remark at the sight of the palms filling the walls.

But even then, my eyes were still focused on the movements of the enemies.

I moved my sword tip as I gauged the distance.

The silent swing cut through the two undead that blocked me.

These undead were not enough to steal the time of a special investigator.

Squeak. Thwack.

The dark mages who saw the undead split in half were horrified.

“Th, the skeleton soldiers...!”

“Quick, call for help! Cloud’s attack... Urgh!”

Of course, I had no reason to let the dark mage who tried to scream go.

The blue trail grazed the necks of the dark mages who were preparing magic.

The headless dark mages fell to the ground with a scream towards the sky.

They were the ones who contracted with demons, so they wouldn’t go to a good place even if they died.

I looked at the hands that started to come out of the wall after killing the dark mage.

“Did they bury the undead in the wall?”

It was an hideout where a bunch of dark mages who learned necromancy gathered.

It was natural to bury the undead to counter external invasions.

I was momentarily wary of the number of undead that looked more than I thought.

The investigators who came down from upstairs quickly joined me.

The investigators were also surprised to see the undead.

“Mr. Van, we’ll take care of this place.”

Maybe he guessed my thoughts.

My lieutenant hit the arm of an undead with his sword and spoke.

He meant not to waste time on the undead on the wall.

I looked back at my lieutenant and investigators, and then nodded and gave an order.

“Six of you stay here and block this place. You, follow me.”

It was an order for everyone except one investigator that I pointed out to deal with the undead here and move on.

The investigators who followed me were also first-class investigators recognized by Cloud.

They thought they could hold on somehow even if there were a few more undead.

I gave instructions to my subordinates and started moving forward again with my sword aimed.

It was a difficult situation to spend too much time on low or mid-level undead.

“Hoo...”

I adjusted my ragged breath and my footsteps echoed in the cave.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

The sound of footsteps echoing in a narrow space sounded clearer than outside the cave.

The various sounds that overlapped as if to announce my position made me frown.

“...”

The cave was a place where sound echoed well.

Even a small sound would resonate loudly.

It was hard to hide one's presence in a cave where sound echoed easily like this.

By now, the commotion outside might have been reported to the abyssal officers.

“Mr. Van, something is wrong.”

“Yeah. It seems so.”

And as if to prove it, an unknown vibration came from the cave floor.

Thud—. Thud—. Thud—.

It felt like someone was hitting the floor with a huge hammer.

The vibration that came through my shoes was gradually increasing its intensity.

It meant that whoever was making the vibration was getting closer to us.

“Get ready.”

I raised my aura and lifted my sword as I looked ahead.

A huge shadow of an enemy was shining from behind the corner.

It wasn't hard to guess what it was by looking at its shape alone.

Soon, a woman's voice echoed from behind the corner.

“So you guys came to our hideout again?”

“Th, that's...!”

As I saw what came out from behind the corner, my subordinate shouted in surprise.

The identity of the undead that came out with a huge rumble was a corpse golem.

A grotesque golem made by piling up countless corpses like rags.

There was a woman sitting on top of the golem that made me nauseous just by looking at it, wearing a big hat.

She was a slender woman compared to the huge golem.

“Hello? I’m Edella. The dark mage who will decorate your end.”

“Black Rose Edella...”

“You seem to know me, huh?”

Edella looked at me with a sinister smile as she heard my voice.

Black Rose Edella.

The wanted criminal that Cloud had been chasing for a long time revealed herself.

Chapter 129: Ruler of Death (2)

Chapter 129: Ruler of Death (2)

My eyes sharpened as I faced the wanted criminal in front of me.

Edella was a notorious dark mage in Cloud.

She was infamous for her cruelty, even to her own hands. The Cloud investigators who lost to her had to return as hideous undead.

She was a very unwelcome opponent for Cloud.

“Did you come all this way to catch us?”

“Yeah. Did you feel a bit of remorse for your wrongdoings?”

“Only eight of you? You’re underestimating our abyss too much.”

Edella sneered at me and the investigators with sincere eyes.

Arrogant.

And ignorant.

No matter how great a dark mage she was, it was meaningless once I reached this place.

Van Krite.

He was one of the special investigators who were considered the peak in Cloud.

“What are you relying on? The new demon you’re worshipping? Or is it your necromancy?”

I aimed my sword at the corpse golem and measured the distance with my fingertips.

I knew that they had contracted with a new demon.

It was what I expected from the repaired altar.

Edella answered with a displeased face at my guess about her backer.

“Demon? Don’t compare him to such beings. Well, not that he would care...”

My eyes narrowed as I heard Edella’s words.

I was an investigator who specialized in dark mages, so I had some knowledge about dark magic.

Dark magic was basically a magic that received negative power by offering sacrifices and karma to demons.

It was hard to understand how dark mages would stop worshipping demons.

My spinning thoughts soon reached one conclusion.

“Could it be... you’re offering sacrifices directly to an evil god.”

Edella’s face changed as she looked down at me from the top of the corpse golem.

She seemed displeased by my words, and raised one hand with a complaint.

A dark light followed Edella’s hand, and the corpse golem raised one hand as well.

“Evil god... He would be hurt by your words.”

“So the abyssal dark mages have finally joined hands with the cult.”

“That’s why Cloud’s investigators are no good. After you fall into hell, it will be useless to cry and beg in front of him.”

It seemed that my guess was correct.

The power on Edella’s hand was more turbid and dark than other dark mages.

The two who had been talking for different reasons aimed their weapons at each other.

One was to buy time, and the other was to dig information.

There was no reason to continue the conversation once one’s purpose was over.

As the corpse golem walked forward with its fist aimed, I tore off my cloak and threw it forward.

“What...!”

Flap.

The cloak fluttered and blocked Edella’s sight.

Edella’s voice of confusion echoed from behind the cloak.

And a blue flame rose on my sword in front of the cloak.

I drew a large trail in the air with my aura-covered sword.

Swoosh!

The cloak tore and a crescent-shaped aura flew out towards the other side.

“Barrier!”

Edella tried to block Van's aura with a barrier she had prepared in advance.

The translucent barrier that blocked the space between them collided with the aura.

Bang!

The barrier shattered and the residual magic scattered.

The aura that flew out completely destroyed Edella's barrier and cut off part of the shoulder of the corpse golem behind it.

“_____.”

Not missing the gap created by the broken barrier, Van's body shot forward with his sword aimed.

Whoosh.

As Van's body leaped forward with the aura, the corpse golem stepped back and swung its fist at him.

Whooosh!

The fist of the corpse golem came crashing down with a shockwave.

Van tilted his sword diagonally as he faced the fist coming at him.

“That's impossible...!”

Squeak.

The sword tip with the aura cut through the corpse golem's fist and advanced forward.

Van's swordsmanship combined with the vibrating aura sliced through the corpse golem's flesh like paper.

Edella's face hardened as she saw Van cut off the golem's arm.

The severed part of the corpse golem also spewed out a chilling scream.

The scream of the dead's resentment echoed throughout the cave.

– Kiiiiiiiiiii!

“Shut up.”

Van cut off the screaming part as well and stepped on the corpse golem as he climbed up to its head.

Chop. Chop.

The corpse golem's shape collapsed wherever Van's sword touched.

His swordsmanship reached its peak and cut through everything that touched his sword.

Edella panicked and started to cast magic as she saw Van shredding the corpse golem and coming up.

The corpse golem also tried to recover itself, but Van's sword was faster than that.

“Fire arrow! Fi, fire arrow!”

“It's nothing but a futile struggle.”

Bang!

The fire arrow that touched the aura exploded and burst.

But Van's swordsmanship brushed off even the aftermath of the explosion and moved forward.

Whoosh. Thud.

The thin hands that stretched out from inside the golem also tried to stop Van, but they were not enough to block his swinging sword.

Van's body cut through everything that blocked him and reached the top of the corpse golem in an instant.

Only then did Edella, who was at eye level with Van, thrust her hand with magic at him.

“Not, not like this...!”

“Die, witch.”

The sword with the aura crushed Edella's last resistance.

Van tore off the magic barrier on Edella's hand and dug one more step forward.

Whoosh.

Van, who reached the top of the golem, stabbed his sword into Edella's chest without hesitation.

Black blood splashed on Van's cheek as he stabbed his sword.

The blood that flowed from Edella's chest was not red but black.

“Ku, kugh...!”

Edella glared at Van with a miserable face as she was stabbed by the sword.

Black blood was flowing from her mouth as well as from the stabbed part.

Thud. Thump.

The blood that fell from her mouth dropped onto the silent corpse golem.

Edella grabbed the sword that pierced her and opened her mouth.

“Curse, you...!”

“...”

“You... will never, be at peace, even if you die...!”

What poured out of her mouth was a curse.

She was cursing Van who killed her.

It was not easy to listen to such a story, so Van twisted his sword hard.

Edella’s body shivered with the brighter flame of the aura.

The curse that poured out of Edella’s mouth also seemed to subside a bit.

“Now it’s quieter.”

It was nothing but a loser’s struggle.

There was no reason to listen for long.

After Edella’s mouth that cursed him became silent,

Van sighed and pulled out his sword.

Dark blood like ink stained the sword that came out of Edella’s body.

As he pulled out his sword, Van tried to shake off the blood on it.

– “Who touched my doll?”

Boom!

Edella, who was wounded, exploded.

* * * * *

“Puh...”

Deep darkness.

A realm of darkness where nothing could be seen. The first thing that Van Krite saw when he regained his consciousness was the darkness.

In the darkness that was so thick that he couldn't even make out any shapes, he felt a sharp pain in his right arm.

He suppressed a groan as he touched his painful arm.

“Ugh...”

Something hot was oozing from his shoulder that his hand reached.

He lifted a finger to feel the sticky sensation on his palm.

Whoosh.

A blue light burst from his fingertip, illuminating his vision.

He moved his finger to his shoulder, where the pain was coming from.

He saw his skin torn apart in the dim blue light.

“Did I get hurt by Edella's exploding corpse?”

He bit his lip as he checked the state of his shoulder.

It looked horrible.

The pain seemed to intensify as he looked at his wound.

But he couldn't afford to focus on his injury right now.

He made the light on his finger brighter.

His fist wrapped in light revealed his surroundings.

“...”

The first thing that caught his eye was his own leg.

It was submerged in the black darkness.

The darkness filled the floor like stagnant water, rippling and swaying.

He turned his head and saw the investigator who had followed him.

He must have been caught in Edella's explosion.

The investigator had lost half of his body and was lying dead with his eyes wide open.

Van moved quickly towards the dead investigator.

"You did well."

Swoosh.

He closed the investigator's eyes with his palm.

The investigator's face was twisted with pain even with his eyes closed.

This was how it usually went with the dark mages of the Abyss.

It was a dirty and ugly fight, and the end was miserable.

Even if he won the fight, it often led to bad outcomes.

He got up from where he had closed the investigator's eyes.

He let out a sigh as he stood up, bleeding from his wound.

"Hoo..."

He looked at the darkness that soaked his feet.

It didn't look like the cave he had been in before.

He had ended up in a completely different place from where Edella had exploded.

And he couldn't see any of the dark mages of the Abyss who might be targeting him around here.

He muttered to himself in this unfamiliar landscape that didn't seem to belong to this world.

"I don't think this is a cave... Where am I?"

A place where there was no sun.

And a place where the dark abyss writhed on the floor.

It was a place that even his intuition couldn't understand.

As he looked around the strange place for the first time, burning light on his fist,

A cold voice echoed in his ears.

-“Are you curious where you are?”

It was a voice that sounded low and high, majestic and light at the same time.

It conveyed a contradictory sense of feeling to him, and he shut his mouth.

It was a strange sound that seemed to be made of many voices mixed together.

And yet it sounded like it wasn't a sound at all, but rather it penetrated directly into his brain.

Pit-

His blue light flickered and faded away from his fist.

With a creaking sound of bones, he turned his head towards a direction.

-“You suddenly became quiet.”

“...”

-“Or maybe you’re too scared by the darkness.”

The cold voice continued to ring in his ears, even though he closed his mouth.

He tensed up at the sound and reached for the sword at his waist.

But there was only an empty scabbard there.

He couldn’t grasp any weapon in his hand.

He swallowed hard as he realized he was unarmed.

-“If you don’t know, I’ll tell you where you are.”

Whoosh.

Flames erupted in the empty air.

Two pairs of flames lined up side by side, lighting up his vision in the darkness.

The flames spaced apart created a path that led to the front of him.

He followed the path of flames slowly with his eyes.

And then he stopped at what was at the end of it.

-“A world where life is born without receiving light, and where they devour each other in a survival of the fittest.”

There was only one thing standing at the end of the burning flames.

A huge death wearing a robe over its head.

Death.

That was the only word he could use to describe the being that existed before him.

The death hidden under its thick robe stretched out its hand towards the distant sky.

At the same time, the darkness on the floor rose up towards the sky.

The pillars of darkness reaching for the sky opened their mouth as death spoke.

-“This is the Abyss.”

The eerie voice dug into his ears once more.

As if it wanted to make sure he knew where he was.

Chapter 130: Ruler of Death (3)

Ruler of Death (3)

The Abyss.

That cursed place, where not a single ray of light could penetrate, was only known to the people of the continent by rumors.

Even Van, who had traveled across the empire for his special investigator mission, had never set foot in such a place before.

The pitch-black darkness, where it seemed impossible for any life to survive.

Only the being in front of him was shining faintly in the midst of it.

It was the sight of the living death, gesturing at him with its empty gaze.

-“Eternal darkness, where no light can reach.”

-“Do you know what kind of creatures live in such an abyss?”

There was no lie in the words that the creature conveyed with its raised hand.

Faced with the death that spoke to him, Van had to ponder his situation.

Why did he fall into the abyss?

And what was the thing in front of him?

If he didn't know that, it would be impossible to get out of this place.

“Hey, why... why am I in the abyss?”

That’s why Van pulled out his sword belt from his waist.

He had to fight back with his sword belt if he had no sword.

That was the only chance he had to survive.

The death kindly answered Van’s question, who raised his sword belt.

-“It seems you have no interest in the life of the abyss. But if you want, I’ll tell you everything.”

“...I don’t care about those things.”

-“Did you ask why you came here? That’s a simple story. I invited you myself.”

It was certain that the being in front of him had called him.

But he didn’t know how it had summoned him to the abyss.

Even if he asked about the way it had brought him here, there was no guarantee that he could fully understand it.

The form of death that reflected in Van’s eyes was alien to humans at a glance.

Van’s question continued as he pointed his sword belt at it.

“Why did you call me here?”

-“Because there is someone who broke my doll, I invited you here myself.”

At Arcrosis’s words that he had broken his doll, Edella’s face flashed through Van’s mind.

The moment Van’s sword strike cut off Edella’s breath.

He had to face her exploding flesh along with a strange voice.

From the moment she bled black blood, it was clear that Edella was no longer human.

The doll that the being in front of him spoke of was none other than Edella, who had become an undead.

“Then let me ask you one last thing. What are you... what is your identity?”

The death with a form had brought a human from the surface to the abyss.

And it had turned a promising dark mage into an undead and controlled her.

What kind of being could do such a thing?

As Van asked that question with curiosity.

The death in front of him smiled.

-“Did you ask about me?”

Even though it was hard to distinguish his face, Van could feel that he was laughing.

The being in front of him was laughing.

He was mocking him for asking his name.

Feeling a cold chill, Van nodded.

Seeing his attitude, he told him his name with a smile.

-“My name is Arcrosis. You humans call me by many names, but my essence is only one.”

King of the Dead Arcrosis.

Van felt a shiver run down his spine as he heard that name.

He had heard of that name from the old legends of the dark mages.

Arcrosis.

The oldest demon.

The one who made a contract with the first dark mage.

And the one who ruled over the depths of life and death.

That was the identity of the being in front of him.

“A... Arcrosis...”

-“It seems you know about me.”

Anyone who knew about dark magic would not be ignorant of Arcrosis’s name.

He was literally a legend.

A monster that should only remain in stories, never to reveal himself in reality.

Yet such a being was in front of Van’s eyes.

He was surrounded by countless bones, looking down at Van from a far higher dimension.

“...I met a being that shouldn’t exist.”

Van wondered how the dark mages of the abyss could be so confident, and it seemed that Arcrosis in front of him was the reason.

Crunch.

Van gritted his teeth as he learned his identity.

The words of the monster who introduced himself as Arcrosis were undoubtedly true.

He felt it too, a presence he had never sensed before.

-“An existence that shouldn’t exist. What an interesting expression.”

In the rippling waves, countless bones poured out endlessly.

The abyss he was standing on was already Arcrosis’s domain.

He had no chance of winning against the necromancer who was ready at the peak.

Even if this wasn’t the abyss, Van would have no possibility of defeating Arcrosis in front of him.

There was an insurmountable gap between the devil of defeat and the young genius.

‘It seems like I can’t go back.’

Van felt uneasy as he faced the existence of the underworld.

No matter what he did, he couldn’t beat the necromancer in front of him.

Arcrosis was such an existence.

He was a monster of the underworld who lived in eternal immortality.

‘Is Van Krite, the best in the world... going to die here?’

He couldn’t win.

Even if he met his glorious end here, no one in the empire would be able to find his corpse.

In such a place, Van had to fight with a sword that had nothing but a hilt left.

It was a ridiculous situation.

He had to fight by infusing aura into a crude hilt.

-“Are you afraid of death?”

Did he read Van’s inner thoughts?

Arcrosis asked with a click of his finger that had nothing but bones left.

Van smirked at Arcrosis’s words.

He wasn’t afraid of death because what he had achieved would disappear.

It was because he wouldn’t be able to grasp what he would achieve in the future.

“If I say I’m not afraid, it would be a lie.”

Van’s eyes glared at Arcrosis as he gathered the last remaining flame.

Whoosh.

The last courage that remained in his heart became a flame and rose up.

Aura was the fruit of courage given only to those who crossed the boundary of life and death.

If he couldn’t overcome the threat of death, that small flame would fade away and go out at any time.

So those who wielded aura always had to choose.

Would they burn everything and become ashes?

Or would they become embers without even producing a proper flame?

“Still, fighting is the role given to me.”

For Van, the former was always the only choice given to him.

He had to burn everything he had and become a fire that never went out.

That was the only way he could strike a sharp blow to the enemy in front of him.

His enemies had changed over time.

Once, they were robbers in the back alleys.

Another time, they were evil black mages.

And now, they were the oldest demons.

He always had to do his role, as usual.

-“How brave.”

Death, who was watching him struggle against his fate, spat out a pleasant voice.

Van, who was aiming at him with a hilt covered with blue aura, uttered his last regret.

No one would find him if he died in the abyss.

And even his soul that would perish here, might not be able to enter heaven.

“If I knew I would die in the abyss, should I have prayed more often?”

-“Unfortunately, praying won’t help you.”

Arcosis denied Van’s voice.

It didn’t seem like it was simply because he was an existence that opposed the six heavenly gods.

There was something that only an existence that had lived for a long time could see.

Something that would make even a small prayer a futile struggle.

-“The sky has tilted. The world has begun to go against the order, and the harmony has rejected the light.”

“.....I don’t understand what you’re saying.”

-“So don’t hope for salvation. The world is a battlefield of great beings, and everything on the earth is nothing but a pawn.”

The oldest demon had a different idea of the world.

He could see that from the way he spoke of things that Van couldn’t follow even if he staked his whole life.

Of course, he had no life left.

Van Krite would die here today.

Van ignored his nonsense and focused on the hilt that was burning with the flame of his soul.

“A pawn... Yeah. Maybe so.”

He did his best at this moment, even if someone else had created the reality he faced.

Van grabbed the hilt and ran forward, cutting through the darkness.

Thud thud thud thud——.

Every time he took a step forward, the flames that lit up Van’s path went out.

In the narrowing distance, Arcrosis’s hand with a ring on it reached out to Van.

-“It’s been a long way since we first talked.”

He adjusted his rough breath and measured the distance between him and the monster.

Left. And right.

Van’s swordsmanship tore off the undead that popped out irregularly.

Crackle.

The undead’s hands that touched the aura turned into ashes and collapsed.

The dry hands of the dead could not stop Van, who burned everything.

His sharp slash cut through the undead and quickly closed the gap between him and Arcrosis.

It was only a little more until he could reach Arcrosis with his sword.

-“Let me ask you one more time. Have you ever faced the creatures of the abyss?”

Even in the narrowing distance, Arcrosis maintained his relaxed attitude.

He folded his fingers in the wriggling darkness.

The surface began to ripple.

And beyond that, sharp eyes began to leak out.

Van finally understood why Arcrosis asked him that question.

“Well, yeah, it wouldn’t be easy as I thought...”

The depth of the water covered by darkness was different from what he felt at his feet.

In the spreading waves, an unknown existence began to rise up.

The reason why Arcrosis asked him if he knew the creatures of the abyss.

It was because Necromancer King Arcrosis had turned them into undead himself.

At the sight of the monster that defied its lifespan and revealed itself, his feet stopped for a moment.

-“Let me introduce them for the first time. They are the slaves of the abyss.”

As soon as he finished introducing the monsters of the abyss that appeared with the huge darkness,

The giant monsters that emerged from the shadows rushed towards Van.

A huge shadow spread over Van’s head holding a hilt.

He couldn’t avoid it. Not to mention block it.

There was only endless shadow spreading beyond the horizon.

At the last moment when he faced an unstoppable attack,

“Ha...”

Van Krite closed his eyes tightly.

Thump.

That was the last time his heart stopped.

Chapter 131: Ruler of Death (4)

Chapter 131: Ruler of Death (4)

Inside the carriage heading to the capital.

There was a wounded investigator, gasping for breath.

He was the only one left of the eight who had gone to the north of the empire.

His name was Van Krite, who had lost the fight and survived alone.

“Ugh, hah...”

In the moving carriage, Van looked at his shoulder, trying to catch his breath.

A viscous liquid was dripping from his shoulder, where red blood had flowed.

Cold blood ran through his veins instead of hot blood.

His hand, which had touched his cold shoulder, moved to check his pulse.

“Ha, ah...”

Nothing.

His finger, which had penetrated his skin, felt no heartbeat.

His heart had stopped since the day of the battle.

It didn't move anymore, nor did it feel warm.

His hand lost its strength as he felt his still pulse.

'Did I make it out alive?'

Van had faced a wall in the fight with the king of the dead.

It was the first wall he had ever encountered as a genius.

An insurmountable wall.

It was a wall that was too distant and thick.

'I couldn't win.'

But he tried to resist.

And he failed.

At the moment he failed and prepared for death, the king of the dead took his heart away.

He gave him one condition in exchange for his heart.

'Don't say anything...'

His heart stopped.

But Van was still alive and moving.

In front of the ruler of death, life and death were nothing but simple concepts.

He had to accept death in exchange for life, and restriction in exchange for freedom.

Van Krite.

He had lost.

He had fallen to the ground in a powerless defeat.

“Hah, huh...”

A bitter smile appeared on his lips as he gasped for air.

Thud.

A tear rolled down his cheek and fell on his hand.

The tear that fell on his hand was not black.

“...”

The investigator who had lost his faith looked out the window with wet eyes.

It was a pathetic life.

But he didn't have the courage to end it easily.

He was still alive.

“Me too...”

A voice full of lumps came out.

He had wielded a sword for 15 years.

A long time had passed.

He had pursued justice.

He had pursued heroism.

He had pursued the sword.

And again, he had pursued justice.

“Is this... the end?”

The window that let in the sunlight closed with a hollow sigh.

Van Krite.

He had failed.

I got up with a gloomy feeling and looked out the window.

Today, the sunlight coming in from outside was unusually bright.

I stared at the scenery bathed in sunlight with dull eyes.

Chirp chirp-.

The sound of birds chirping reached my ears.

“How peaceful.”

The world reflected in the window was peaceful.

Children riding bicycles.

A father playing with his child.

Students exercising alone.

And even ladies chatting on a bench.

It was a peaceful scene like any other weekend.

“Peace is good, I like it.”

The weather was good and the world was peaceful.

Seeing the world soaked in peace, I felt like I should do some gacha.

Come to think of it, it had been quite a long time since I last did gacha.

The last time I did gacha was definitely when I did 210 draws while sleeping, as far as I remember.

“Heh. Just thinking about it gives me goosebumps.”

I got chills all over my body when I thought of the 210 draws.

I had clung to my account because I couldn’t give it up, but it was not a small expense by any means.

But thanks to the lottery, my nightmare also subsided somewhat.

Now it was time to overcome the wounds of the past and do some gacha again.

I launched the game without hesitation and leaned against the window.

“But today will be different... I got 10 magic books with only 10 draws. Is this good?”

I muttered nonsense while waiting for the game to load, and soon the game’s main screen appeared.

As always, a poor karma.

As always, a poor inventory.

And in one corner of that inventory, there was an item named [Contract of Regression].

The name of the item looked awkward today, so I clicked on it to check the details.

“Contract... Oh, this is what I got from using the cursed sword.”

It was something I received by using a bug item with a broken name.

The effect was much more unfriendly and unintuitive than other items.

Besides, it was the kind of item that required a cost to use.

There was no reason to activate it right away unless it was necessary.

“Well, I’ll use it when I need it.”

I passed on the contract of regression and went straight to the <Paid Currency Shop>.

Right now, the 10-draw gacha was more important than that useless item.

I felt a tingling sensation in my fingers as I hadn’t done gacha for a long time.

I tapped the screen with my thumb and the shop screen loaded quickly.

“...?”

And I faced the messages that popped up on the screen.

It was a message that I hadn’t seen in a long time.

But it wasn’t a very welcome message.

I read the message on the screen with a gloomy eye.

-<Paid Currency Shop (Lv.MAX + 4)> skill has been expanded.

-You have acquired <Paid Currency Shop (Lv.MAX + 5)>.

-You can now use paid currency to purchase items from the shop.

It turned out that the shop skill level had increased.

It was nothing big.

Thud.

I pressed the confirm button and closed the message.

And I turned my head and looked at the peaceful people outside the window.

“Speaking of which, inflation is serious these days.”

The murderous prices seemed to kill me by force.

But even so, today was a very hard situation to resist gacha.

I turned my eyes back to my smartphone with a fanatic look.

Gambling addiction was a serious social problem.

But who would save the continent in danger if I wasn't there?

I could already hear the prayers of the believers who were calling for me.

“Ah, ah... No!”

I couldn't see or hear anything even if I covered my eyes and ears.

The believers who desired me with deer-like eyes.

The leaders of the sect who were waiting for bread and cake from me.

I briefly thought of Cuebaerg, but I shook my head and tried to get rid of the distraction.

The rabbits were well-fed and well-grown these days.

I knew it well because I had used the rabbit horde of terror once.

“Ha... You guys want me so much.”

99,900 won for 10 draws.

I tried to ignore the clear number in front of me and reached for the draw button.

I could ignore the price tag of the items, but I couldn't ignore the screams of the suffering believers.

To them, I was a saint, a merciful savior, and a Buddha.

I obediently brought my finger to the 10-draw button.

As I felt my finger being sucked into the draw button, the item output screen popped up in an instant.

-You have acquired [Soft Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Hard Iron Sword].

-You have acquired [Demon Doll].

I quickly scanned the items that appeared one by one.

Maybe it was because the draw price had increased by 10,000 won.

Now the junk items felt like they had evolved a level.

Among them, there were also items that I had never seen before, like [Demon Doll].

-[Demon Doll]

-[Strawberry Cake]

-[Demon Doll]

My eyebrows twitched at the sight of [Demon Doll] that kept coming out.

It didn't feel very good for some reason.

I patiently watched the draw results continue.

I was confident that I would laugh if a magic book came out at the end.

-[Demon Doll]

-[Demon Doll]

-[Demon Doll]

“Stop.”

I’m not doing a doll draw right now.

The sight of [Demon Doll] kept coming out made me choke, but I tried to hold it back and calm myself down.

That’s how nine items passed and it was time for the last item.

I took a deep breath and watched the moment when the last item appeared.

The moment when a bright light burst out of the screen as the last item appeared.

-[Karma 2x Coupon (1 day)] x 5

I had to face the 10-draw result screen with a strange expression.

[Karma 2x Coupon (1 day)].

It was a new type of item that appeared on the screen.

It was an item that seemed to have an obvious purpose just by looking at its name.

Experience coupon.

It was a common type of item that often appeared in online games.

“They give this out in gacha?”

I wondered about the value of the item in my head as I faced the experience coupon.

An item that made your level go up faster was not a bad thing.

Rather, the more you had, the better.

Some games even sold these items as products, so it wasn't that bad to use money to draw them.

Karma was also used as a kind of currency, so it was a good situation to see a currency 2x coupon and an experience 2x coupon bundled together.

The problem was the meaning of karma in this game.

“It seems like a headache to raise it recklessly.”

If I used the 2x coupon, I would get a similar efficiency to the apostles who were starving even if I hunted myself.

But if I raised my karma carelessly, I had a high chance of getting the backlash of causality adjustment.

It was a dilemma whether to use it or not.

I had to think carefully about how to use the coupon.

As I looked at the [Karma 2x Coupon (1 day)], another item caught my eye.

“What is this?”

[Demon Doll].

It was the item that came out the most in this gacha.

Thud.

I moved my finger to see the details, and a large image of the doll appeared.

It looked like a big rice cake that resembled Cuebaerg's main body.

From the description, it was a similar item to other normal items that only had a name value.

It meant that it couldn't do anything other than being a doll.

“Where am I supposed to use this?”

Hmm.

I looked at the [Demon Doll] with a serious eye.

How long had I been looking at the doll?

A brilliant idea came to my mind as I glared at the screen.

When I didn't know what it was, it was best to give it to 'that guy'.

“I have to go there.”

Swoosh.

I quickly made a decision and moved the screen to find 'that guy' and started moving.

He would take care of the doll he received himself.

If he threw it away, I would just have to punish him somehow.

The Keterunt branch of the sect in the west of the empire.

There, a solemn worship was held in the chapel as usual today.

Of course, Estasia, the symbol of the Keterunt branch, was not free from worship either.

Estasia, who had a crown on her halo, prayed with the believers in the chapel as usual.

The only difference from usual was that there was one more angel next to her.

“Strawberries... please give me a lot.”

The halo flickered and bright lights spread around.

Tears flowed from the eyes of the believers who worshiped with Estasia’s sincere prayer.

How could there be such a pure angel?

Even though they closed their eyes tightly, some believers confessed their faith out loud.

To them, Estasia was a proof of faith and a bridge that connected them with God.

“Aronia... please give me a little.”

“Estasia...?”

“Shh. I’m praying.”

Estasia did not yield to the interference of the fallen angel who tried to disturb her prayer from beside her.

Rather, she calmed Aronia down and led her to worship.

The believers’ cheeks were wet with hot liquid at the sight of Estasia, who was an angel in the scriptures itself.

It was evidence that they had hot faith.

As the sacred worship proceeded, Estasia, who had closed her eyes, felt something and lifted her head up.

“...?”

She felt a huge presence from the sky.

Her master was surely looking at this place.

But she also felt uneasy, so Estasia quietly created a barrier.

An invisible secret barrier spread over Estasia’s head.

And soon something fell from the sky.

“Huh...?”

Thud.

The white thing that collided with Estasia’s barrier bounced off to Aronia.

Aronia screamed and looked for the culprit who hit her with something.

She turned her head and saw a white doll in front of her eyes.

It was a soft white lump doll that looked like a rice cake.

“Eh, Estasia. What is this?”

Aronia lifted up the doll that fell in front of her eyes and asked Estasia.

Estasia also looked at the doll for a moment.

But soon she lowered her head and closed her eyes again.

She did not forget to scold Aronia softly.

“Shh. You have to focus on your prayer.”

“No, a doll fell from the sky... Ack! Ugh!”

Thud. Thud. Thud.

More dolls fell from the sky and collided with the barrier several times.

The dolls that hit the barrier all slapped Aronia's cheek.

Aronia couldn't regain her senses and screamed from the continuous bombing of the dolls.

Maybe it was because of the noise that continued.

The eyes of the people who were praying all turned to Aronia.

"Tsk tsk tsk tsk... How impious that angel is. How can she play pranks during worship time?"

"That's right. She must be a fallen angel after all."

"By the way, isn't our angel amazing? She's still focused on her prayer even though there's a commotion!"

The believers poured out harsh words at Aronia.

But they also didn't forget to praise Estasia.

They still had the lumps from the attack that happened in the past.

Aronia hugged the doll with a sad face at the sight of the believers.

A spitball popped out of Aronia's mouth that was hidden by the doll.

"...It's not my fault that a doll fell from the sky."

Aronia muttered quietly behind the doll.

But none of the believers believed her story.

Thud.

Another doll fell from the sky and hit Aronia's head and passed by.

She had to bury her face in the doll with tears in her eyes.

Chapter 132: Fall of the Hero (1)

Chapter 132: Fall of the Hero (1)

It had been a few days since I got an experience double coupon from a 10-pull.

I had already used one coupon and earned a large amount of karma.

It was an item that I bought with expensive money, even if it had some drawbacks.

To use the coupon properly, I had to try it once in advance.

That was what I did.

“Hmm... I got about 3,000 karma last time, right?”

That was how much karma I gained from using the coupon.

On top of hunting diligently, the karma that I usually received was doubled as well.

3,000 karma per coupon.

Not a bad level.

Except for the one I used for testing, I still had four coupons left.

How to use the remaining four was a problem that I had to think about in the future.

“I could get much more karma if I use them when my level is higher... but the causality rate adjustment is a concern.”

There were many things that I had to pay attention to while playing the game.

There was always a backlash, except for spending money.

The most important thing in game play was not to raise the difficulty recklessly.

It was not a game that I could just leave alone and go wild.

“But there are some convenient parts of being idle.”

Of course, even when I was not logged in, the characters worked hard to earn karma for me.

The church was also growing its power continuously.

These were all advantages of being an idle game.

Just like the characters that I saw on the screen right now.

-“For the time being, we plan to spend time on fortifying the holy land.”

The church’s headquarters where Yuto landed.

There, Archbishop Roan gathered the apostles and talked.

What Roan talked about was Yuto’s fortification.

It was also something that I had been thinking about since I got [Artifact: Fake Divine Tree Yggdrasil].

“Fortification. That’s a good idea. A flying fortress is cool.”

A sky fortress that bombed the ground while flying.

Wouldn't that be every man's dream?

I agreed with Roan's plan on many aspects.

Roan, who came up with a good idea, pointed at Yuto who landed on the ground with his finger and spoke.

-“First of all, we will start with installing the magical part.”

-“The magical part...!”

Perin's eyes sparkled as he heard Roan's story.

He was happy that Yuto was evolving in some way.

Of course, Roan ignored him and continued to explain.

-“Even though the guardian of the holy land has stealth and bombardment abilities, I think the holy land should be the last bastion for the church.”

-“The last bastion...”

-“For that, Apostle Eutenia helped us a lot. The fortification plan will be based on the magic circle that she drew for us.”

Nod.

Eutenia, who was listening, nodded her head in agreement.

She also contributed a lot to the fortification plan.

And behind her, Peter, the mage, was packing up his stuff.

Why was he doing that there?

As I alternated between looking at the two of them with a short thought, Roan added an explanation.

-“Since Apostle Eutenia will be away for a while on a mission, the fortification plan will start after we transport the carriage and the two of you to the destination.”

It turned out that Eutenia was leaving the church for a while.

It seemed to be part of the operation to get the [Philosopher’s Stone] that I ordered before.

As if to prove that, there was a brief conversation between Eutenia and Peter.

Eutenia looked at Peter, who was struggling to load his luggage, and popped up a speech bubble.

-“Peter. You should be careful not to ruin the cake when you move it.”

-“Huh? Cake? Do we need that?”

-“You never know how long the journey will be.”

-“Hmm...”

She asked him to be careful not to ruin the cake.

It was a rather absurd command from my point of view.

After all, Eutenia liked cake more than any other apostle.

When did she start liking cake?

As I racked my brain and wondered about the beginning, I remembered giving her a cake when she was hiding in a cave.

“Did I feed her too much cake?”

Even by the standards of that time, it was a cake that cost more than 6,000 won each.

It was natural for her to react that way, since she had grown up eating expensive cakes.

Especially since most of the times when a cake came out of the lottery, I gave it to Euteneia as a reward.

Did I make one of my characters a cake addict?

That's how much Euteneia loved cakes.

“Well... Euteneia does her job well, at least.”

Of course, this was a luxury problem for a character who was worth the money.

No one could deny that Euteneia was the hardest worker in the cult.

Roan also moved busily, but most of the big tasks were done by Euteneia's hands.

Her personal strength was also one of the top among the apostles.

“Please keep up the good work. As for the cakes... I'll try my best to find them.”

I alternated between looking at the cup noodles and the smartphone on the table, and then smiled warmly at Euteneia.

I felt like giving her a compliment for once in a long time.

Of course, the characters who received my praise were all in pain, but I thought it was a worthwhile thing if my intention was conveyed.

It's not like I'm the one who's hurting anyway.

With that in mind, I reached out my finger towards Euteneia, who was sitting with her shadow spread out.

And right after that, Euteneia suddenly got up from her seat and moved.

My finger, which lost its target, swung around in the air and hit Peter's back of his head, who was carrying a load.

-“Aaargh...!”

Thud.

With a heavy sound, Peter fell to the floor.

The bag he was holding also dropped and rolled on the ground.

As Peter collapsed, Euteneia, who was nearby, ran towards him quickly.

“Oh... You're coming to help your colleague right away.”

— “Ca, cake...!”

“So that's what you were worried about.”

Euteneia was not concerned about Peter, but the cake.

I put my hand on my forehead as I watched Euteneia use her shadow to grab the cake.

Thump.

I didn't forget to hit Peter's head with my remaining finger.

A speech bubble popped up over Peter's head along with a crisp sound of impact.

* * * * *

A secret space located underground of Crossbridge.

There, Hus looked at the Saintess of Knowledge, Aurora, who was operating the magic device.

The Saintess of Knowledge, Aurora.

The longest-ruling saintess in Crossbridge had the most secrets.

The secret space he visited this time was also the place he learned from Aurora's guidance.

"Why did you come down here again?"

Hus, who was watching Aurora operate the device, asked her.

This space was full of unfamiliar things for Hus.

At the same time, it was a space hidden behind a thick veil.

When he asked Aurora, who was busy moving her hands, she smiled faintly and told him.

"I received a trust from God after a long time."

"Did you say trust?"

Hus widened his eyes at the word trust.

The saintesses of Crossbridge were beings who received direct trust from God, but that didn't mean trust came down often.

Moreover, it was a rare occasion for Aurora to receive trust alone.

Hus, who was curious about the content of the trust, sent a glance at her, and Aurora let go of her hand from the device.

"It's a trust from the Goddess that came down after a long time."

"What was the content of the trust?"

"The apostles of the cult are after the holy relics."

The apostles of the cult.

As soon as he heard that, Hus's brother's face came to his mind.

As far as he knew, Evan Allemier was one of the apostles of the cult that served the evil god.

Maybe Evan was the apostle who was after the holy relics.

That thought crossed Hus's mind.

“Do you know which apostle is moving?”

“Unfortunately... I didn't hear that much. You must be worried about your family.”

“.....”

“It's a tragic fate, but we still have to bravely accept our role.”

Aurora's hand drew a cross on her chest.

There was a hint of affection in her eyes that were smiling.

It was a look that looked beyond this place to something else.

Aurora, who faced Hus with a complicated look, continued.

“Just like I did in the past.”

Just like she did in the past.

At Aurora's words, Hus felt his left eye twitching.

It was a new eye that was given to him along with a brilliant miracle.

The brightly shining pupil sometimes showed him things that humans could not see.

“The saintess of the past...”

“I also had to make a choice. It was a very difficult choice for me, and the outcome was not very good either.”

“Is that so...”

“But I don’t regret it now. The Goddess is guiding me on the right path.”

O Goddess, guide me on the right path——.

A short prayer came out of Hus’s mouth.

Hus’s hand clenched the rosary that was wrapped around his neck.

Aurora, who was watching him, approached the device again.

Clank. Rattle.

The complex machine moved and a strong light poured out of the blue crystal.

“Actually, there is something you have to do here today, Hus.”

“What do I have to do?”

“Please take out the hieroglyphs. This is a task that only the hero of knowledge can do.”

This place, located underground of Crossbridge, was a secret even to other saintesses.

But she said that this secret was only allowed to the children of knowledge.

The hero of knowledge had a role that suited him.

His power was indispensable for the great work that was carried out in the holy land.

“What do I have to do?”

Chwarararak.

The bookshelf of hieroglyphs in Hus’s hand turned quickly.

Hus's eyes, holding the hieroglyphs, also shone brightly.

When Hus asked her about his role with the artifact in his hand, Aurora pulled down the lever of the device.

“You have to reproduce this magic, Hus.”

What appeared as the lever was pulled was a magic.

It was a small-scale magic, but it contained complex patterns.

Hus realized why he was needed as he looked at the magic with his eyes glowing.

The device here could only reproduce magic of that size.

Only Hus, who used the miracle of hieroglyphs, could activate magic on a larger scale.

“So that's what it was.”

“Can you do it, Hus?”

“I've finished analyzing the magic. It's okay to move on to the next step.”

Clank. Rattle.

Aurora's hand operated the lever again.

Then, this time, a space with a huge magic circle began to rise up.

Aurora winked at Hus as if that was her goal.

Now, her eyes were filled with strong anticipation.

“That's where you have to use magic, I guess.”

Nod.

Hus's eyes stared at the center of the magic circle as he moved his head.

Light and light flashed and drew huge lines in the air.

The ability of the hero of knowledge to reproduce the magic he had seen once.

The miracle of hieroglyphs reproduced the powerful magic he had seen on a larger scale.

“——Hieroglyphs.”

One line creates light.

Another line strengthens the light that stretches out.

Many lines overlap and create complex patterns.

Countless lines and power wanted to do only one thing.

The endless movement of great power.

“Ah, aah...!”

A scream burst out of Aurora's mouth as she watched the magic.

The power flowing from God's remains was moving towards the hero's remains.

The powerful power began to defy the order of the world as it shook.

The soul that was forcibly held back also went against the natural order and was trapped in the decaying body.

The hero of the past, who was trapped in the reproduction of the miracle, opened his eyes.

“This is, no way...”

“Arein!”

Crack. Splash.

The glass tube that had been storing the old hero’s remains broke.

The preservation liquid from the broken glass tube soaked the floor heavily, and in it, the dead man who opened his eyes floated in the air.

The former hero of knowledge, Arein Crost.

The dark power flowing from his body dominated the entire space.

“Ugh, ugh...!”

Hus frowned at the pressure of the power that pressed down on his whole body.

He had become a hero and gained endless power, but even with his power, he could not bear the pressure now.

But Aurora ran towards Arein even in that pressure.

She quickly approached Arein and hugged him with all her strength.

“Are you awake, Arein?”

“.....”

“Arein. Finally, finally our promise has come true.”

She looked at the dead man who came back to life with moist eyes.

A short kiss.

Aurora’s lips touched Arein’s and then parted.

She caressed Arein’s cheek with affectionate eyes.

The hero who woke up from a deep sleep greeted her with a slow voice.

– “Ah, Au, rora...”

“Arein. Arein... You promised to protect me forever.”

An eternal promise.

The oath that bound the hero even after death was there.

Arein’s hand hugged Aurora’s head, who had grown old.

There was a difference of many years between the hero who died long ago and the saintess who became an old woman.

“There are evil apostles of the evil god who threaten the holy land. Arein... Please defeat them all for us.”

Aurora whispered in Arein’s ear in the endless oath.

The hero of knowledge.

An unrivaled genius.

The talent of destruction.

Impossible.

The hero who inherited all those adjectives nodded his head briefly.

For God. For the holy land.

For his only lover.

The vow was eternal. And it had to be eternal.

Chapter 133: Fall of the Hero (2)

Chapter 133: Fall of the Hero (2)

Eutenia Hyrost, the First Apostle of His Majesty.

She held a shining relic in her hand as she rode in a carriage across the eastern part of the empire.

On her front seat sat Peter, who drove the carriage and held the reins.

They had one goal for their exploration of this region: to find a relic that could create the ‘Philosopher’s Stone’.

“Is the compass still pointing in the same direction?” Peter asked Eutenia, turning his head slightly.

His eyes were drawn to the relic she held. It had a special power: it could point them towards their target relic.

Their plan relied on this power. They would travel through sanctuaries and narrow down their search area based on where the compass pointed. Then Eutenia would investigate that area herself.

“Yes, it is. Watch out for the uphill road,” she replied.

“I wish we could get some signal of a relic. This is frustrating,” he muttered.

They had been searching for three days now, but they had not found any trace of a relic yet.

They could only estimate a rough range by using the compass from above, but finding a relic required them to search on foot.

They knew it would take time, so they had brought enough food for ten days.

“It seems like finding this relic is harder than we thought,” Eutenia said as she ate a piece of cake. She wore a ring-shaped compass on her finger and kept an eye on it while she ate.

The compass of Etalia was an amazing relic, but it also came with a serious drawback. While using it, she could not use any magic at all. And if she stopped using it to cast magic, it would take days for it to reactivate. So she had to be very careful during their search.

That was why she asked Peter to do some small tasks for her.

“I hope we can find it soon,” she said, putting another forkful of cake in her mouth.

She hated being without magic for so long.

Peter seemed to share her impatience. He nodded and said, “Me too. Then we can return to the church sooner...”

“And we’ll be one step closer to His Majesty’s advent.”

“Ah, yes... that’s right.”

But Peter looked embarrassed and turned to the front at Eutenia’s words that followed.

Eutenia smiled faintly as she saw Peter’s expression.

He was diligent in carrying out his mission, no matter what.

Lately, he even showed signs of talking comfortably with other apostles or Roan.

He still seemed to be afraid of Eutenia, though.

“Peter.”

“Yes.”

It was a natural thing to think about.

The reason why Peter was still alive was close to Eutenia’s whim.

Now there was no reason to get rid of him either.

Eutenia decided to play a light prank on Peter.

“Peter, would you save me or Roan if we fell into the water?”

Eutenia asked Peter, who was driving the carriage, with a playful face.

Roan and Eutenia.

They were both people who were bound by a bad fate with Peter.

Peter looked back with a blank face at Eutenia’s question.

“Will I die if I tell the truth?”

“That won’t happen. I promise.”

“Then... I don’t plan to save either of them.”

Peter answered without hesitation.

He wouldn’t save either of them.

Eutenia asked him why he would abandon both of them so ruthlessly.

“Why?”

“Why should I save the monsters who roam around the city by themselves?
Unless they save me.”

“Is that so?”

Monsters who roam around the city by themselves.

It wasn't a very wrong thing to say.

Since they started following the great being, they had received countless blessings.

After giving his reason, Peter hesitated for a moment and added one more thing.

“Actually, Archbishop Roan might be worth saving once because he gave me a lot of meals...”

Snort.

Eutenia's lips curled up as she heard Peter's words.

She spoke to the back of Peter's head, who was driving the carriage, with a more playful voice than before.

“Do you want to skip dinner tonight?”

“Right... of course.”

Peter felt awkward and looked ahead as Eutenia continued her words.

She smiled softly at his reaction.

He was always faithful to his mission, no matter what happened.

He had even started to talk more casually with other apostles or Roan lately.

But he still seemed scared of Eutenia.

“Peter.”

“Yes.”

It made sense, when she thought about it.

The only reason Peter was alive was because of Eutenia's whim.

She had no reason to kill him now.

She decided to tease him a little bit.

"What if I or Roan fell into the water? Would you save us?"

She asked him with a mischievous grin as he drove the carriage.

Roan and Eutenia.

They were both his enemies by fate.

Peter turned his head with a blank look at her question.

"Will you kill me if I tell you the truth?"

"No, I won't. You have my word."

"Well... then I wouldn't save either of you."

He answered surprisingly boldly.

He wouldn't save either of them.

She wondered why he would say such a heartless thing.

"Why not?"

"Why should I bother saving those monsters who wreak havoc in the city by themselves? Unless they save me first."

"I see."

Monsters who wreak havoc in the city by themselves.

That wasn't entirely wrong.

They had received many blessings since they followed the great one.

He paused for a moment after giving his reason, then added another sentence.

“Actually, Archbishop Roan might deserve to be saved once since he fed me well...”

She chuckled at his words.

She spoke to his nape with an even more playful tone than before.

“How about no dinner for you tonight?”

“Yes...? You said I could tell the truth.”

“It’s okay to tell the truth. I didn’t intend to scold you from the beginning.”

“But why are you saying that...?”

Eutenia pointed to the grimoire on her lap with her finger as she met Peter’s resentful gaze.

Tap. Tap.

She tapped on the thick cover of the divine instrument and clasped her hands.

She prayed and said to Peter.

“It wouldn’t hurt to fast for a day and thank His Majesty.”

“No...”

Peter’s flustered voice echoed around.

But she tried to ignore his gaze and held back her laughter.

She felt a fullness in her stomach filled with cake.

She felt like she wouldn't be hungry even if she didn't eat dinner today.

"I'm kidding."

Clatter. Clatter.

Only the sound of the carriage driving on the deserted mountain road echoed.

"Daniel! We have a big problem!"

A small ranch in Eberlint province.

Daniel, who was sharpening a butcher knife there, looked up and saw his opponent.

A young man wearing the clothes Daniel gave him was looking at him with a serious face.

The young man joined the ranch at Roan's order and became a believer of the church who was now an assassin and a ranch worker.

"Really...? But you said I could be honest."

"You can be honest. I wasn't going to scold you anyway."

"Then why do you ask...?"

Eutenia pointed at the grimoire on her lap with her finger, facing Peter's indignant look.

Tap. Tap.

She tapped the thick cover of the sacred device and folded her hands.

She pretended to pray and spoke to Peter.

“How about fasting for a day and showing gratitude to His Majesty?”

“No...”

Peter’s voice was full of panic.

But she ignored his eyes and suppressed her laughter.

Her stomach was satisfied with cake.

She didn’t think she would need dinner tonight.

“I’m joking.”

Clack. Clack.

The sound of the carriage moving along the empty mountain road was the only thing that broke the silence.

“Daniel! We have trouble!”

A small farm in Eberlint territory.

Daniel, who was honing a slaughter knife there, raised his head and met his visitor’s gaze.

A young man in the clothes Daniel had given him looked at him gravely.

He had followed Roan’s orders and joined the farm, becoming a follower of the church who doubled as an assassin and a farmhand.

He put down the knife he was holding and looked at the young man who looked urgent.

“What’s going on?”

Daniel’s expression was very serious as he looked at the young man.

He was a young man who had come here risking his life to become an assassin.

If he said it was a big deal, it wouldn't be a normal thing.

Daniel looked at the young man nervously, trying not to show his shaken heart.

‘What is it? Did the holy knights of the temple come? Or is it another heretic inquisitor?’

Of course, there were many worries in Daniel's head.

The holy knights of the temple. The heretic inquisitors.

They were both people who wouldn't be strange to come looking for Daniel.

“That, that's...”

‘Or maybe... did the archbishop come to dispose of me because he thought the assassin training was not going well?’

It was also a possible situation for Archbishop Roan.

While he was worrying about everything, the young man couldn't hide his confusion.

Daniel grabbed his shoulder hard and pressed him.

“What happened? Tell me quickly.”

“That's... two cows that pulled out their stakes ran wild and broke the fence of the barn!”

“!”

The fence of the barn collapsed.

Daniel's heart pounded at the news.

The collapse of the barn fence was definitely a serious matter.

Daniel picked up the butcher knife he had polished.

As soon as Daniel picked up the knife, the young man who saw him flinched and backed away.

“Uh, uh...”

“Get out of the way.”

“Yes, yes...”

Daniel pushed the young man aside and went outside.

And then he started walking towards the barn where the stakes had been pulled out.

Thud. Thud.

The staff were surprised by the sound of Daniel's footsteps filled with emotion.

‘Stupid bastards. They can't even manage one barn.’

As the young man said, there were cows running wild right in front of the barn.

Daniel felt angry as he saw them.

All the grooms who gathered here were those who came to become assassins.

Daniel didn't know much about assassination, but he knew enough that those who couldn't handle animals couldn't become assassins.

“Da, Daniel...”

“Get out of the way. I’ll take care of it.”

He dropped the knife he was holding and stared at the frantic young man.

“What is it?”

His face was grave as he eyed him.

He was one of those who had risked their lives to become assassins and followed him here.

It must be something serious if he was so alarmed.

He tried to calm his nerves and not show his fear as he watched him.

‘What could it be? Did the temple’s holy knights find us? Or another heretic inquisitor?’

He had many things to worry about in his mind.

The holy knights. The heretic inquisitors.

Either of them could come after him without any surprise.

“It’s... it’s...”

‘Or maybe... did the archbishop decide to get rid of me because he thought I wasn’t training them well enough?’

That was also a possibility with Archbishop Roan.

He kept fretting over everything, while the young man looked lost and flustered.

He grabbed his shoulder firmly and demanded an answer.

“What happened? Spit it out.”

“It’s... two cows that broke free from their stakes went berserk and smashed down the barn fence!”

“!”

The barn fence was smashed down.

His heart raced at hearing that.

It was a big problem indeed.

He picked up his butcher knife again.

The young man shrank back as he saw him wield it.

“Uh... uh...”

“Move.”

“Y-yes...”

He shoved him aside and headed outside.

He walked towards the barn where the stakes had been torn out.

Thump. Thump.

His footsteps were heavy with emotion, startling his workers.

‘Idiots. They can’t even take care of one barn.’

Just as the young man said, there were cows rampaging near the barn entrance.

He felt a surge of anger as he saw them.

All these men here had come to be assassins.

He didn't know much about killing people, but he knew that those who couldn't handle beasts had no chance of being killers.

“Da-Daniel...”

“Stand back. I'll handle this.”

“I understand.”

Elliot nodded and stepped back as Daniel approached the rampaging cows.

Daniel pushed past Elliot and looked at the cows dragging the stakes.

The animals that had escaped from the broken barn fence were frolicking as if their time had come.

They looked nothing like the gentle creatures that had been in the barn.

‘I could probably drag them around now.’

Daniel clenched his fist as he watched the stakes being pulled.

He felt a strong vitality in his fist that was different from before.

It was a change that had occurred when he obtained the miraculous Latimeria.

His body had also become stronger since he became an apostle, so he thought he should use some of his strength to deal with them.

“...”

Daniel lifted his knife and glared at the cows with a determined expression.

He didn't intend to use the slaughter knife, he was just holding it out of habit.

Then, the cows that met Daniel's eyes froze.

Blink. Blink.

The cows that were staring blankly at Daniel slowly began to back away.

“The cows are going back to the barn!”

Maybe even beasts recognize their master.

The cows that faced Daniel quietly returned to the barn.

The stakes that had tied them up were also dragged back to the barn.

Seeing the cows returning to the barn on their own, Daniel took a few more steps forward and drove them completely into the barn.

“This, this is... the silent butcher...”

“Even beasts can’t withstand Daniel’s aura.”

“Master. I learned something new today.”

The employees who watched Daniel send the cows back with just his eyes all exclaimed in admiration.

Daniel felt a strange impulse at their sight.

He felt like teaching those stupid guys a lesson with his knife.

He suppressed the urge that rose in his chest and glared at them.

The employees closed their mouths at Daniel’s fierce eyes and the aura that emanated from them.

“Shut up.”

“...”

“Make sure you secure the stakes. If this happens again, I’ll tie you up in the barn instead of the cows.”

“Yes, sir! We’ll make sure this never happens again!”

As the disciples carried planks and headed to the barn, he finally put away his knife and clicked his tongue.

Maybe it was because he hung out with those who wanted to be assassins.

Lately, he felt more weird impulses than usual.

Of course, taking care of the beasts calmed down my impulses quickly.

‘Assassins? They can’t even raise cows.’

I turned away from the employees who were repairing the barn and headed back to the slaughterhouse.

There was still a thief left in the farm, who was lucky enough to be taken care of by one of the employees last night.

I planned to erase his traces completely by burning him at night.

Of course, I had to do it secretly from the villagers.

I carried the load with a cheerful heart and moved on.

The red gem ring on my little finger reflected the sunlight.

In the history of Crossbridge, there was a hero who was called the peak of magic.

Arien Crost.

A genius of the Crost family, who had dedicated glory to the holy land for generations.

He mastered all kinds of magic before he became a knight, and all the magic towers of the empire accepted him as an honorary member.

He was also the one who re-established the space magic, which was considered obsolete.

From the moment Arien became a hero, it was natural that everyone in Crossbridge expected him to do great things.

“Arien...”

The most precious person for Arien Crost, who was the greatest hero, was the saintess.

Aurora, the saintess of knowledge.

She guided him, who was the hero of knowledge, and was closer to him than anyone else.

Her brilliant and beautiful existence was enough to captivate his heart.

Their feelings deepened as they crossed the battlefield, and Arien worried about Aurora, who would be left alone until he died.

The oath that promised eternity was also for Aurora, who would be lonely.

‘I will protect this world and you forever.’

The words of a great mage have power in them.

He came back from death to keep his oath, and he would also destroy his enemies according to his eternal promise.

Someone would have to pay a huge price to carry out the forbidden plan, but it was certain that it was not Arien himself who had to bear it.

Arien stroked the cheek of the saintess in front of him.

He felt her cold palm and her pitiful appearance.

“Arien. I found out where the apostles are aiming for the holy relic.”

Aurora, who held his hand stroking her cheek, handed him a paper and opened her mouth.

It had been several days since Arien came back to life, but he was still not used to the changes that time had made.

Most of the minions led by the evil god had been taken care of by Arien's hand long ago.

The continent must have had a short but peaceful days until then.

Until he fell into an endless sleep.

“The apostles of the evil god...”

“I know it's hard to understand, but this is reality. The heroes are not fully grown yet, and the minions of the evil god are running wild in the broken balance of causality.”

“They pushed a new evil god into their place without bearing their own burden. They used a despicable method.”

In the unilaterally broken causality, even faith would be hard to come down properly.

Arien quickly understood what kind of fight they had been through.

And they would have to endure such a fight in the future as well.

In that sense, the forbidden magic that Crossbridge prepared was not a bad trump card.

Except for the fact that the research that started when Arien died bore fruit when Aurora's time was almost up.

“The apostles of the evil god are coveting the lost holy relic... but we don't have enough power to stop them as a holy land.”

“Is that so.”

He looked at his lover withering away with his eyes soaked in obsession.

Many years had passed.

His youth, which was like a bright flower, withered away in time, and his heart, which used to beat wildly, had also become calm long ago.

Still, he had to fight.

There were values that did not change even after time passed.

“Let’s move right now.”

“Arien...!”

Arien was the only mage in the continent who could handle space magic.

Even if their destination was in the east of the continent, there was no problem in moving quickly and preparing for a response.

As soon as he got up from his seat, Arien tried to prepare for battle, but Aurora reached out and hugged him tightly.

Arien, who was embraced by Aurora’s arms, also stroked her hair.

Many emotions crossed his eyes as he looked at his lover.

“Don’t worry. I’ll be back soon.”

“I trust you. Arien.”

Aurora stepped back after hearing Arien’s answer.

He met her eyes and lifted his hand in the air.

It was like lifting a light book with his hand.

“Hieroglyph...”

As he lifted one hand and looked for his magic, Arien's eyes stopped.

He remembered the hero he met last night in his memory.

The hieroglyph, which was the symbol of the hero, was no longer his.

He smiled bitterly and activated his magic with his bare hands.

"It's not mine anymore."

"It's been a long time."

"A long time..."

Many rays of light spread out, drawing geometric shapes.

It was the moment when Arien's specialty, space magic, unfolded.

On top of the complex magic circle, Arien said a short goodbye to Aurora.

Aurora also waved her hand with a smile at Arien.

"Then I'll see you again. Aurora."

"Come back safely."

Paah!

Right after a short flash in the underground laboratory.

Arien Crost completely hid his presence there.

Chapter 134: Fall of the Hero (3)

Chapter 134: Fall of the Hero (3)

The early bird catches the worm.

That was an old proverb that said only the diligent ones could succeed.

But in my opinion, it was hard to catch a worm just by waking up early.

Because I, who had woken up early today, had fallen asleep for another 30 minutes on my seat before I finally woke up.

It made me wonder if it would have been better to sleep for an extra hour more comfortably.

“Yawn...”

I admired the weekend morning scenery with sleepy eyes, and then got up from my seat with slow steps.

I had set an alarm with a big intention to become a morning person even on weekends, but it seemed like I was wrong to succeed.

A slight drowsy feeling remained in my mouth, and a yawn came out naturally.

I went into the bathroom and washed my face with cold water, and then looked at myself in the mirror.

For some reason, I felt like my skin was fluffy these days.

“Am I going to become a celebrity at this rate?”

I muttered nonsense while looking at the mirror, and then came out of the bathroom and picked up my smartphone.

And then I unlocked it and ran the game icon.

Tuk.

The loading screen flashed by in front of my eyes, and then the familiar scene of the cult appeared.

It seemed that I had quit the game last night after watching over the cult.

I started to check the messages that popped up last night, with the bustling cult scene as the background.

- [Cherubim: Aronia] manifested a miracle.
- <Karma's Judgement> calculates the causality rate.
- Karma increased by 4.
- [Cherubim: Estasia] manifested a large-scale miracle.
- <Karma's Judgement> calculates the causality rate.
- Karma increased by 24.
- The number of cult followers increased greatly.
- Some followers acquired the <Fanatic> trait.

The messages that came up last night were not much different from usual.

First of all, Estasia, who was conducting worship at the cult branch, was steadily supplying karma.

And Aronia, who was attached to her side, also occasionally sent karma.

The karma sent by the two angels was not a small amount.

In addition, the karma obtained by the increase of cult fanatics was also considerable.

“If I add up the karma I got last night, it’s about 6500 or so.”

The effect of the karma double coupon made the karma grow faster than before.

If I used another coupon, it might be possible to exceed 10,000 cumulative karma.

I wondered for a moment whether to use one more double coupon, but then I shook my head and stopped my hand from heading to the inventory.

6500 was not a small amount of karma.

It was a matter of regretting it later if I got greedy and hit by causality adjustment.

“It’s better to use cash for spec-up if possible.”

Except for the fact that money was not enough, spec-up using payment was the most efficient way.

And someday I had to clear the quest to collect 1 million karma.

1 million karma.

Even assuming the late game, it was not a small number.

To clear that quest, it might be more efficient to use a karma double coupon later on.

Rather than moving with an impatient mind now, it would be better to watch over the characters leisurely.

“Let’s watch over the characters’ status today.”

With that decision, I moved the screen and started to check each character's appearance one by one.

The first character I visited was Estasia.

Estasia, who was staying at the cult branch, was located on the fourth floor, which she would normally not even approach.

It was a rare thing for her to be on the fourth floor, so I watched her closely.

She was patrolling the fourth floor slowly with Aronia.

– “Aronia. Do you want to go down now?”

She finished patrolling at the speed of light and approached the stairs leading to the lower floor.

And then she looked at Aronia, who was following behind her, blankly.

Only then did I understand the secret of how she was able to climb to the fourth floor.

It was because Aronia, who was following her, lowered his posture in front of Estasia.

– “Move a little on your own.”

– “I'm lazy. Carry me.”

– “How did I end up like this...”

Aronia said that, but he still carried Estasia down to the first floor.

It turned out that he had used a self-made angel escalator to climb up.

That made sense. Estasia had no reason to climb up to the fourth floor willingly.

I tried to press Estasia, but accidentally hit Aronia's back of the head, and quickly moved the screen to where another apostle was.

– “Wow! That's amazing!”

This time it was Perin and Pluto.

Perin looked at Pluto, who was floating in the air, with his pointed ears twitching.

Pluto was showing off his martial arts while swinging his scythe in the air.

Like dancing with a sword in his hand, he was performing flashy movements with his scythe in sequence.

– “I feel like my old skills are coming back little by little.”

“Don't you remember how you were before?”

The scythe flashed in the air, leaving a blue trail behind.

Dancing with a scythe.

I didn't know what to call that action.

But it felt awkward to name it something like scythe dance or scythe art.

Whisk. Whisk.

The scythe that was swinging in the air at a fast speed suddenly slipped out of Pluto's grip.

– “Ah...”

Pluto sighed for a moment as he lost his scythe.

Soon, the scythe that had made a big turn stuck on top of Pluto's head.

A weak spray of blood started to burst from where the scythe was stuck.

Perin, who was watching him, exclaimed in horror at the sight of Pluto bleeding.

– “Blood...! Blood is flowing from your head!”

– “It’s okay. It’ll heal soon.”

– “But...”

The dementia vampire seemed to be still out of his mind.

The commotion of the two continued for quite a long time.

It was uncomfortable to watch them, so I tried to pull out the scythe with my finger, but it ended up being a disaster as the scythe got stuck deeper.

In the end, I had to move the screen to another place with a regretful feeling.

There were still many apostles in the world who needed my care.

Of course, Eutenia was an exception, as she always showed the best results.

* * * * *

The eastern part of the empire where desolate winds blew.

The relic search by Eutenia and Peter there had reached its fourth day.

Four days was a short but long time.

The food that had been filled in the carriage had almost halved by now.

Meanwhile, Eutenia’s search also made great progress.

“We’re getting closer to where the relic is.”

The compass that pointed to where the relic was began to bend sharply even if it moved a little bit.

The fact that the angle of the compass moved meant one thing.

There wasn't much left until where the relic was hidden.

Realizing that there wasn't much left until finding the relic, Eutenia ordered Peter to stop the carriage.

As Peter stopped the carriage according to Eutenia's order, she jumped off the carriage with the help of shadows and said,

“It would be better to search on foot for the rest.”

It meant that they should walk to where the compass pointed now.

The direction that the arrow pointed was a rocky mountain where the carriage could not move, so it was natural to search on foot now.

Peter also followed Eutenia and jumped off the carriage right away.

And then he took care of the holy sword and food he received from her and talked.

“Can we leave the carriage like this?”

“Don't worry. We can find it easily even if it disappears.”

“Okay.”

Peter strapped a white holy sword to his belt and then put a bag of food on his shoulder and started walking after her.

Whiiiiing. As we stepped into the rocky mountain, the barren wind of the east brushed against our cheeks.

It was hard to find even a blade of grass in this place, close to the edge of the east.

We were sick of wandering around without any food in this desolate land.

That's why Peter had brought a pouch full of provisions with him.

"We're almost there. Maybe we'll get a signal soon."

"Are you talking about the signal we saw last time?"

"Yes. Ethelia's compass sends a signal when there's a relic nearby."

I answered Peter and looked around with a regretful expression.

If I could use magic, I would have finished the search by now, but I couldn't because of the compass I was holding.

I felt a great inconvenience as magic, which was like my second nature, disappeared.

I couldn't light a fire when I prepared dinner, and I had to turn the pages of books with my own hands.

But today was the end of living without magic.

As long as I could find the hidden relic, I would be as free as ever.

"Today will be the last time I have to move around with this compass."

I smiled with anticipation for magic.

I estimated the distance and it was clear that the signal would come as soon as we crossed the mountain.

That's how it was last time when we found the relic.

With that expectation, I was looking for the relic and took a step forward.

Then, a faint wave of mana caught my senses.

"..."

It was a weak and blurry wave of magic that I couldn't detect unless I focused my consciousness.

But my senses, which became sharper as magic was sealed, could catch it.

The wave of magic that I felt from afar soon turned into a magic spell with a glow.

Crack.

A sharp arrow of lightning revealed its presence.

On a hill far away from the mountain where I stood, an unknown mage was preparing a spell.

“Could it be...”

I quickly calculated the power of the spell that I sensed.

Based on the arrangement and attribute of magic, the spell that the enemy was preparing was definitely Lightning Arrow.

It was much stronger than Lightning, but it was inefficient against large beasts.

It seemed that he chose Lightning Arrow to secretly take care of me.

In front of the Lightning Arrow that was gradually completed, I had to decide what to do.

‘I can counter Lightning Arrow without using a barrier.’

Under my shadow, there was Alpha, a dark beast that could move even when magic was sealed.

Alpha was one of the largest beasts among beasts.

It would be hard to even scratch Alpha's skin with Lightning Arrow magic.

If Alpha moved, he could easily block the attack.

“——Alpha.”

I was close to the relic, and I couldn't afford to delay the search by stopping the compass.

That's what I decided, and I tried to summon Alpha to block the attack.

Woo-woo-woong!

Alpha, who received my command, slowly emerged from the shadows.

At that moment, the shadows rose and completely blocked my sight.

“Ugh...!”

Crash!

The magic arrow that pierced through Alpha hit my shoulder.

The top of the hill where the magic was fired.

There, a sharp gaze was looking at me.

Chapter 135: Fall of the Hero (4)

Chapter 135: Fall of the Hero (4)

-Krrrrrrr...

Alpha let out a short scream and started to hide in the shadows.

Rough breaths escaped from his mouth, pierced through the abdomen.

He was trying to heal his wounded body in the shadows.

It seemed unlikely that I could summon Alpha for a while.

“I’m sorry, Alpha.”

I squinted in pain as I said a brief farewell to Alpha.

It was my mistake.

I grabbed my bleeding shoulder and put the compass I was holding in my pocket.

I was sure of it after the attack that pierced through Alpha.

He was not someone I could fight with my magic sealed.

‘He’s not an easy opponent.’

The magic that flew at me collided and caused another change.

It was the first time I encountered such a skill since I became an apostle.

An unbearable pain came from my shoulder with a hole in it.

Pain was poison for a mage, disrupting their concentration.

I moved the shadows to cover my wound and faced the mage who was looking down at me from the hill.

“Peter. You should back off.”

-Krrrrrrr...

With a short scream, Alpha retreated into the shadows.

He was bleeding from his abdomen, gasping for air.

He was trying to heal his wounded body in the shadows.

I knew I wouldn't be able to summon him for a while.

“I'm sorry, Alpha.”

I muttered a brief apology to Alpha as I squinted in pain.

It was my fault.

I clutched my bleeding shoulder and put the compass I was holding in my pocket.

The attack that pierced through Alpha confirmed it.

He was not someone I could fight with my magic sealed.

‘He's not an easy opponent.’

The magic that flew at me collided and caused another change.

It was the first time I encountered such a skill since I became an apostle.

A terrible pain came from my shoulder with a hole in it.

Pain was poison for a mage, disrupting their concentration.

I moved the shadows to cover my wound and faced the mage who was looking down at me from the hill.

“Peter. You should back off.”

“Huh? But...”

“He’s not someone I can protect you from while fighting.”

Peter stepped back a few steps, holding his sword, at my words.

I felt sorry for him, but giving him the sword was for his own protection.

Besides, the effect of the sword I gave him could also interfere with me.

I checked on Peter as he backed off and started to shape magic in my palm.

“Lightning Spear.”

Crackle. Crackle.

A bright spear of lightning emerged from my fingertips.

I overlaid my shadow on the spear of lightning.

The spear, vibrating with darkness, aimed at the distant enemy.

As I was about to shoot the spear at him,

A short voice echoed in my ears.

“—Teleport.”

‘He disappeared...?’

The target I was aiming at vanished from my sight in an instant.

But not for long.

Soon, he reappeared right in front of me.

I was startled by the sight of the man who had jumped across space.

The spear of lightning I was holding also flew towards the empty hill.

“Barrier!”

The man who had shifted in front of me had a bright light flashing in his palm.

I didn’t know how he had moved in front of me, but it was clear that he had prepared an attack magic to take me down.

I hastily stretched out my shadows and created a barrier.

Five layers of barrier, covered by shadows, blocked between me and the man.

And right after that,

A dazzling flash burst out of his hand.

“Lightning Burst.”

Bang! Zzzzzz!

The barrier was shattered by the light that came out of his palm.

The flash that broke through the barrier flew towards me beyond it.

Shadows rose from below me and wrapped around me in an instant.

“Ugh...!”

Zap!

The flash collided with the shadows and scattered in all directions.

The lightning that came at me slid off the surface of the shadows.

After most of the bright lightning faded away,

I released the shadows and got out.

I gasped for air after completely neutralizing his magic.

“Who are you...?”

I asked the man in front of me, trying to endure the pain.

It was a short exchange, but I could gauge his skill a bit.

The mage in front of me was no ordinary one.

He was definitely the most powerful one among the mages I had faced.

“Arein Crost.”

“Crost... You can’t be.”

Arein Crost.

There was no mage in the world who didn’t know his name.

She also knew his name well, as she had exchanged opinions with mages like Roan and Elbon.

Eutenia bit her lips as she heard Arein’s name.

Arein, who had revealed his identity to Eutenia, asked her about hers.

“I’m just a mage. Which apostle are you?”

“I am the first servant of the great one, Eutenia Hyrost.”

Eutenia, who had raised her shadows while staggering, looked straight at Arein and said.

The eyes of the two people who met in midair began to analyze each other's condition.

Arein, who was looking at Eutenia, soon gave a brief impression.

"So this is the first apostle... The minions of this evil god are nothing special. The evil god must have lowered his standards."

"I can't let your insulting words about the great one go easily."

"What are you going to do if it's hard? Are you going to try to kill me?"

Unlike Arein's expressionless face, Eutenia's mask was slowly cracking.

She didn't hide her anger towards Arein and raised her magic.

She didn't care if she was ignored.

But she couldn't stand by when her master was insulted.

"...If I have to, I will."

Shadows spread from Eutenia's feet in all directions.

Arein Crost was definitely strong.

He was an formidable enemy that couldn't be compared to the mages she had met so far.

But Eutenia knew how to subdue such an opponent.

She had actually tested the effect on other people before.

"You're arrogant. That's typical of those who serve the evil god."

"Well, we'll have to see how it turns out."

She only needed a brief moment.

She could do it if she had time to make an altar for the great being and pray to him.

The shadows on the floor were a great device to hide Eutenia's intention.

He wouldn't see the words of praise engraved under the shadows.

All Eutenia needed was to hold Arein for a moment.

“Lightning Spear.”

Crackle.

A bright magic light burst out of Eutenia's fingertips and shot out a huge spear of lightning.

The lightning, cutting through the ash-gray world, rushed towards Arein.

At the same time, countless shadowy hands began to draw an altar on the ground.

The spikes of shadows rising from the ground and the sharp spear of lightning flying from the front.

Arein raised his hand to face the attacks that came at him.

“Shield.”

Boom!

The spear of lightning that flew in with a loud noise was blocked by Arein's barrier and faded away.

The spikes of shadows that sprouted from the ground also had no different result.

Clang. Clang clang clang.

The spikes that rose with an unpleasant sound bent in a grotesque direction.

The shadows continued to draw the altar under the split spikes.

“You’re not using your overflowing magic properly.”

“Is that so? It’s a pity that the person who would teach me will soon die.”

“It’s hard to become a great mage if you just push in a lot of magic stupidly.”

With a sneer in his words, Arein raised his massive magic.

His magic, wriggling with an incomparable density to before, began to gather in his palm.

It was an awe-inspiring amount of magic even for Eutenia, who had endless magic.

Eutenia had to think about what to do with the magic that was being shaped in Arein’s palm.

Should she stop the magic she was preparing? Or should she pour her power into the altar instead?

Eutenia quickly decided to finish the sacrifice ritual.

“...Giga Lightning.”

“Shield.”

Eutenia used her magic while counting down the time left until the altar was completed.

Crackle. Crackle.

The shield that appeared above Arein’s head blocked her magic, but Eutenia’s attention was all on the altar.

5 seconds. 4 seconds. 3 seconds.

Eutenia's hand continued to shoot out the next magic as she counted down the time.

2 seconds. And 1 second.

Eutenia finally counted the last count in her mind.

She stretched out her countless shadowy hands to Arein as soon as the count ended.

“—Life. Build a stairway.”

Woo woo woo woo.

The air vibrated and a strong pressure spread in all directions.

Eutenia was the one who ruled the world of shadows.

It was not a difficult thing for her to buy time under the shadowy area that dominated the surroundings.

She moved her shadows to crush Arein and kept reciting prayers to God.

“—One path leads to glory.”

“—One path leads to death.”

Arein's eyebrows twitched slightly as he heard Eutenia's prayers.

But Arein didn't care about her and just kept completing his magic.

Ziiiiing.

The magic that gathered in Arein's palm shook violently.

Their eyes watched each other's next move.

“—Revere. Adore. Sacrifice.”

“Do you intend to sacrifice me to the evil god?”

A strong light burst out of the altar engraved on the ground and shook the shadows.

It was the scene of a grand ritual that offered a sacrifice from the earth to the heavenly god.

Arein, who was watching Eutenia, also noticed her plan and tried to sweep away the shadows.

But it was not easy for Eutenia’s shadows, which had completely filled the surroundings, to disappear.

Eutenia believed without doubt that Arein in front of her would become a sacrifice and vanish.

“—Sing the hymn of life.”

As Eutenia recited the last prayer,

Pssst—.

The light of the altar faded and the ritual ended.

Eutenia looked at Arein beyond the dimmed light.

Arein was still standing on the altar even after the ritual was over.

Eutenia wondered at the sight of Arein, who was still on the altar.

“What is this...?”

“Too bad. I’m immune to sacrifice. I’m already dead.”

Immune to sacrifice.

Eutenia’s mind stopped at his words.

Her plan to sacrifice Arein by spending time had failed.

But Arein's palm still had a massive amount of magic.

Eutenia felt a sense of crisis and a huge amount of shadows flowed from her shadows.

“Bar, rier...”

“Blaze.”

In front of the dozens of barriers that appeared,

Arein's magic flashed.

Boom!

The world of shadows was torn apart by the explosion that shook the heavens and earth.

The blazing flash tore through the barrier and burned away the wall of shadows that covered Eutenia.

And as Eutenia, who was covered by shadows, faced the light,

She was thrown back with a strong impact.

“Argh...!”

Thud. Thump.

She was pushed back to near Peter, who was hiding behind a tree, after flying far away.

She felt her strength draining from her palm in the pain that engulfed her body.

Her back was torn and her stomach was pierced.

It was a fatal wound that she couldn't even guarantee her life, let alone continue the fight.

Her blurred vision lit up Arein.

He was still preparing his magic in perfect condition.

"I told you. It's hard to become a great mage if you just push in a lot of magic stupidly."

"Hu, ugh..."

"Besides, if you had a brain, you wouldn't do such a foolish thing as following the evil god."

Arein raised his hand towards Eutenia.

Crackle. Crackle.

A spear of lightning formed in his hand aimed at Eutenia.

As she faced the magic that came at her, Eutenia sensed her end.

'My magic... doesn't move well.'

Eutenia's body, which had suffered severe damage, couldn't use magic as before.

Her broken body only held onto a faint thread of magic.

She felt the fullness that came from the great being gradually fading away.

'Is this the end?'

She couldn't use proper magic in her current state.

Although her shadows were weakly wriggling below her, it was impossible to block Arein's magic with that much.

The wound she received from Arein was too deep.

If she went on like this, she would eventually meet her end from bleeding out.

“Pe, ter... cough, run away...”

Eutenia said to Peter, who was watching her behind the tree.

He was likely to be caught up in the magic that aimed at Eutenia if he stayed there.

Peter was just an ordinary young man from a rural village, whom she had dragged along from the beginning.

She regretted that she couldn't convert him until the end, but she couldn't leave him to die here either.

Peter looked at Eutenia with a conflicted expression as she fell down.

“...”

“Al, pha... you too... don't interfere...”

Eutenia also ordered Alpha, who was swaying under the shadows.

Alpha was injured, but he was trying to step forward to protect Eutenia.

But there was no reason for Alpha to sacrifice himself for her as well.

She would die anyway if she left him alone like this.

It would be troublesome if Alpha died for her sake.

“Just die. Apostle of the evil god.”

Arein's palm clearly formed a spear and started to fly towards Eutenia.

It was her end that she faced with her weakness.

She had already made several mistakes.

There was only one fate for a mage who lost in a fight.

She had met the heavenly god and given a second life, so Eutenia had no regrets left.

She smiled bitterly as she faced the flashing lightning in front of her eyes.

“Great one...”

Eutenia sensed the last moment of her life and prayed to God.

As she aimed at Eutenia, the spear of lightning flew in.

Boom!

With a short blast, Eutenia’s hair fluttered as she sensed her end.

She saw a blue flash of lightning spreading in front of her eyes.

But even after the thick thunderbolt exploded,

The pain from Eutenia’s body remained unchanged

“...”

What appeared in front of Eutenia instead of Arein’s lightning was a sword with a pure white blade

The sword that stopped in front of Eutenia emitted a bright light

Pah!

The holy sword emitted light and scattered Arein’s lightning in all directions

Eutenia lifted her head and looked at the owner of the sword, a familiar sight she had encountered once before.

“This is...”

At the end of the holy sword that held the light, she saw Peter holding the sword.

Peter, who held the holy sword with both hands, blocked Eutenia’s front.

Peter swung the holy sword to cut off the magic despite her dissuasion.

Peter’s eyes stared at Arein as he blocked the magic.

Arein, who saw Peter suddenly jump out, also opened his mouth in confusion.

“What is this... What are you doing?”

Right in front of Eutenia, who was bleeding from her abdomen.

Peter’s arm, which stretched out the sword, emitted a light of honor.

Everyone who saw Peter’s mark froze.

The pattern of a sword piercing through wings meant only one thing.

Everyone in this place knew the weight of Peter’s mark.

“Hero of honor...”

The hero of honor, chosen by the goddess of honor.

That was his identity.

Eutenia, who faced Peter’s identity, smiled emptily and dropped her hand.

Chapter 136: Fall of the Hero (5)

Fall of the Hero (5)

Peter clenched the holy sword in his hand, trying to calm his ragged breath.

It was an impulsive act.

He had no intention of stepping forward like this, until the moment Eutenia told him to run away.

The man standing in front of him, Arien, was the monster who had knocked down Eutenia.

‘Why, why did I...’

What kind of being was Eutenia?

She was the one who had single-handedly annihilated the village where Peter lived.

She was also the one who had defeated the holy knights and the saintess of the temple by herself.

It was a foolish act to draw his sword and stand up to protect such a being.

And Peter had done just that, such a foolish thing.

Arien’s murderous gaze glared at Peter, who was holding the holy sword.

“Why is the hero of honor here?”

“Ah, no... this is... I was dragged along by this woman...”

Peter's eyes looked at his own mark, which was emitting light.

The bandage that had been covering his mark was undone, and the hero's mark was shining brightly.

He had revealed his mark, which he had tried so hard to hide, to someone else.

And that someone else was Arien, a mage who seemed to belong to Eutenia and the temple.

Arien spoke to Peter, who was hesitating, in a cold voice.

"I'll hear your story after this is over. Get out of the way. I have to deal with the apostle."

Crackle.

A blue lightning bolt rose from Arien's hand.

He was about to shoot a spear of lightning, just like before.

Sweat poured out of Peter's palm, which was holding the sword.

He felt like he was walking on thin ice.

"So, this is..."

"Move if you don't want to die. If you don't move by the count of three, you'll die too."

"That is..."

"Three."

The lightning on Arien's palm became more intense.

The magic that had blown away Eutenia was not as powerful as before, but it was clear that it would be dangerous if it hit him.

Peter's eyes darted between Arien and Eutenia, who were in a predicament.

“Two.”

Arien's count continued, even as Peter hesitated.

His mind was tangled with all kinds of thoughts.

He had no confidence to fight and win against Arien.

But he couldn't just leave Eutenia to die, either.

That would be problematic in its own way.

He bit his lip, unable to make a quick decision.

“One.”

Arien's magic aimed at Peter and Eutenia, who had been counting.

He had to make a decision now.

Would he swing his sword and struggle in vain?

Or would he escape from here and run for the rest of his life?

Peter lowered the sword he was holding.

“Ha...”

A hollow laugh escaped from Peter's mouth, who faced Arien.

The thoughts that had filled his mind were erased in an instant.

His mind felt cold in a flash.

He realized that they were all worthless worries.

His will was never important from the beginning.

“Lightning Burst.”

Arien, who was glaring at Peter, shot the magic he had prepared in his palm.

And Peter tilted the white holy sword he was holding.

Flash!

The white holy sword emitted a strong light again.

The magic that Arien had shot faded, and soon only its fragments sparkled as they scattered.

It was the power of the holy sword that Eutenia had given to Peter.

“I warned you.”

“...”

Arien’s face darkened as he watched the magic scatter.

He had crossed the line by defying Arien’s warning.

There was no turning back now.

Even if he surrendered now, it wouldn’t end well.

In the worst case, Arien would try to kill him, even at the cost of losing a hero.

But Peter didn’t regret his choice.

“You don’t listen to me...”

“I won’t let you kill her.”

Peter pointed the white holy sword at Arien.

He declared to Arien, with a firm resolve.

He wouldn't let Eutenia die.

This was a continuation of his 'impulsive act'.

The things he had been suppressing all this time were mixed up, and they were spilling out of his chest in a murky way.

He felt like he would go crazy if he didn't be honest with himself, even a little bit.

Arien asked him in a cold voice, after hearing his declaration.

"Why do you choose that?"

He met Arien's gaze and gave a bitter smile.

The reason for doing this.

Well, he didn't have a clear reason that he could express in words.

His body had moved on its own at some point.

"I don't know."

"Explain. How can a hero protect an apostle!"

Arien shouted at Peter, aiming his magic at him.

Yeah.

He wouldn't understand.

It was hard to understand even for himself, who was doing this.

It was a funny story, but it was true.

Even at this moment, when he was pointing his sword, Peter's mind knew what was more beneficial for him.

Defending the monster who had swallowed his family and villagers was a foolish act, no matter who saw it.

But Peter's hand couldn't let go of the holy sword he was holding.

"I don't know. I'm ignorant and uneducated. I don't know anything about those things."

Various memories flashed through Peter's mind, who was spouting nonsense.

One day, when he was traveling on a carriage.

He had received a promise from Eutenia that she would return the villagers to him.

One day, when he was hiding and crouching in the cult.

He had received a warm meal from Roan, which he didn't understand.

One day, when the rainstorm was raging in the dark sky.

He had to watch Eutenia's mood, who was having fun with the thieves of the bandit group.

One day, when he climbed up to the holy land to help Perin.

He had received a fruit of Yggdrasil from Perin as a gift and tasted it.

"I don't know either..."

Before he knew it, the cult had embedded itself in him like a thorn.

They were not brilliant enough to be beautified as memories.

They were all evil memories stained with blood and tainted by time.

He had followed a twisted justice.

I knew it was wrong, but I couldn't help it.

It was as if all those things were chains that bound Peter's body, forcing him to act irrationally.

"Regardless of one's status, there are duties that one must fulfill as a hero."

Arien spoke of heroes, as if he didn't understand Peter's words.

Heroes have a mission that they must accomplish, even if it means death.

That's obvious.

But even that obvious thing was too hard for him.

He had spent too much time with the cult.

Even if he tried to reclaim his true self now, there was nothing left but an empty village.

"Shut up! What does it matter if I'm a hero or not!"

Peter shouted like a scream.

His voice, tainted by evil, echoed loudly.

His white holy sword shone and repelled Arien's magic.

Kwaang!

With a loud noise, fragments of magic scattered in all directions.

The traces of miracles that reflected and sparkled in the light.

Among them, Peter's eyes glared at Arien.

"What can I do among these monsters!"

At first, Peter wanted to be saved too.

He wished a hero would come.

Or anyone else, as long as they could rescue him from the apostle of the evil god.

He had such thoughts once.

But there was no salvation for him.

The choice between two options was a cruel fate that demanded no right answer.

“I never wanted any of this! I never wished for anything like heroism, faith, or being a great being!”

For a young man who was farming in a remote village, it was a harsh choice.

He never wanted to be a hero.

He never wanted to follow evil.

He just wanted to live a normal life.

He hoped to grow old peacefully while farming in the flow of time, watching the village change with the seasons.

But even that simple wish was not granted to him.

“I was content with just farming in the countryside! No one... No one came to save me.”

Everything collapsed.

The only path left for him was a steep road full of trials and hardships.

He was swept away by the current of fate to a faraway place.

It was a cruel fate.

It was obvious that the gods in the sky were playing with him.

“That’s what it means to be a hero. You have to overcome all the challenges with your own strength.”

Peter didn’t hear Arien’s words in his ears.

He only saw the sword in his hand.

It was something he thought he would never have anything to do with in his life.

But before he knew it, it was in his hand, and now he was even pretending to be a knight.

“When I come to my senses, I’m just being dragged around by my weak self... And in the meantime, I’m doing this kind of thing with those damned villains as if we’re friends...”

“Come back to the holy land. It’s not too late.”

“It’s too late.”

“Do you think you can keep your hero status after violating the rules?”

Could I still remain a hero after going against the will of the goddess?

I don’t know.

I never thought that far.

Of course, it wouldn’t matter to Peter himself if he lost his hero status.

He never wanted to be a hero in the first place.

“Hero, warrior, whatever... I don’t need any of that.”

A brilliant light spread from the holy sword he was holding.

It was so dazzling that he couldn't believe it was his own.

It was something that should not have been allowed to a rustic like him from the borderlands.

But at this moment, it shone as if he was its master.

“Do not defy your destiny. You must become a hero.”

“Destiny... What is destiny anyway?”

“The righteous future that the goddess guides you to... That is the destiny given to you.”

“You should have led me to the right path sooner.”

What a joke.

The world does not always go according to providence.

No matter how much time you pour in, there are grains that do not bear proper fruits.

There are seeds that do not sprout leaves even if you bring them helpful things.

He had seen countless scenes like that while farming with his own hands.

He tried to live a righteous life, but he ended up falling into a wrong path.

And the name he called at the end was also the name of an evil god.

“Whether it's an evil god or a great one... I don't care about names. You're probably looking down on us from above anyway.”

“...”

“So, there's only one thing I want to say.”

Huff.

Peter took a deep breath and looked up at the sky.

He felt the pressure of his lungs filled with air.

He raised his voice as loud as he could, making it echo throughout the world.

“Right here, right now! Your apostle is dying! Don’t just watch and do something!”

He might hear a blasphemy from Eutenia, who had recovered.

Maybe he would receive a divine punishment from the evil god in the sky.

But still, Peter vented out everything that had been piled up inside him.

It would be better than staying still, no matter what the outcome was.

“If you brought people here and played with them, take responsibility——!”

He shouted the name of the god with his throat torn.

He was not a follower of the evil god. Nor was he an apostle chosen by the god.

He was just a mere human.

Even so, he yearned for a miracle from the god.

In a life where there was no definite answer, he gambled everything on a once-in-a-lifetime chance.

“It’s meaningless. Even if he hears you, he won’t listen to your story, hero...”

Bang.

A sword stabbed in front of Peter.

The sword was emitting a terrifying malice.

A demonic sword.

That was the only name that could describe the thing that existed before Peter's eyes.

"See... He was listening..."

It was a wicked thing, even at a glance. Maybe it was because it was given by the evil god.

Thump. Thump.

Peter walked toward the sword in front of him.

A short word came out of Arein's mouth with a sneer as he faced the sword.

"An apostle selection, huh."

An apostle selection.

The evil god's temptation that gave a world-shaking power to a mere human.

Even Arein couldn't help but be surprised by the miracle that the evil god bestowed.

Peter stood in front of the sword that was leaking black energy.

It was completely opposite to the white holy sword that he held in his hand.

"Don't touch it. The moment you do, there's no turning back."

Arein tried to persuade Peter as if it wasn't too late.

But Peter knew that Arein was wrong.

It was too late now.

He had already stepped into the wrong path.

He had no choice but to struggle endlessly toward the ruin that the heavenly god foresaw.

“I’ve gone too far to go back.”

“Hero...”

Peter’s left hand grabbed the handle of the divine weapon.

If the future that the goddess decided was destiny, what should he call the ruin that the evil god decided?

Was this also destiny?

If not———.

“Shut up. It’s Apostle Peter’s era now.”

Peter pulled out the black sword and aimed it at Arein.

In one hand, he had a black sword that spewed out sinister energy.

And in the other hand, he had a white sword that spewed out clear energy.

It was a contradictory sight.

Peter knew that this sight was a path that only he was allowed to take.

“How could a hero fall, how could this happen...”

Arein made a holy circle with his trembling hand as he saw Peter holding the sword.

His hollow eyes looked at Peter with contempt.

He was his enemy.

He was the apostle who had to face Arein Crost in front of him.

“The evil god’s...”

As Peter lifted his sword toward Arein, many memories flashed through his mind.

He had spent a long time.

He had spent countless hours cowering among the monstrous beings.

And in the end, he became the apostle of the evil god.

Peter twisted his lips into a forced smile and tried to make a vile expression as he shouted.

“The evil god’s... The evil god’s apostle is here! The evil god’s apostle who will bring the world to ruin is here!”

Peter’s eyes reddened as he held the sword.

He knew it.

This was his destiny.

He was never allowed to have a normal life from the beginning.

This was a sin and a punishment.

And it was a wicked path that deviated from the human way.

“My name is Peter Enklov! The sixth apostle, Peter Enklov!”

Peter added the name of his lost hometown after his name and declared war on Arein.

From this moment on, he was Peter Enklov.

The sixth apostle.

The agent of evil who descended on the earth.

And also, Arein Crost's enemy.

Arein, who drew the holy circle, glared at Peter with a fierce light in his eyes.

A prayer to the goddess flowed out of his mouth.

“O goddess, guide me to the right path.”

Peter didn't intend to just watch either.

He smiled with a wet face and followed Arein's prayer.

“O evil god. Please guide me too.”

Was it blasphemous?

Some might see it as such.

Well, what did they want him to do?

He was an apostle of evil.

He didn't want to live like a bumpkin in a corner anymore.

“Apostle of the evil god. From this moment on, the holy land will not tolerate you.”

“So be it.”

The holy sword and the demonic sword.

The hero of the wicked path who held two swords looked at his enemy in front of him.

He was not afraid of Arein anymore.

He was not afraid of Eutenia, who was lying next to him either.

He was now the sixth apostle, Peter Enklov.

“Dainsleif.”

Peter’s eyes sparkled as he uttered the name of the divine weapon.

He was a hero, but he became an apostle.

Two great words were combined, so he was undoubtedly a great being.

At least, Peter believed so.

So he was not afraid of anything now.

Except for the great being who was looking down on him from the high sky.

Chapter 137: Fall of a Hero (6)

Fall of a Hero (6)

I don't remember ever wanting to be a hero.

I don't remember ever wanting to be an apostle either.

But still, what Peter Englov had to do was clear.

He had to become an apostle like a hero.

That was the only path given to him.

“How arrogant and foolish.”

As he poured his strength into his sword, he saw a dark boundary filled with shadows.

He felt omnipotent as the power of the uninitiated flowed through his body.

He felt a sense of fulfillment as if he was connected to the heavenly god.

He was no longer alone.

He didn't want to admit it, but the evil god he feared so much was behind him.

The god's power would protect him wherever he was.

“Do you think you can be my opponent just because you became an apostle?”

Crackle.

A lightning bolt shot out from Arein's hand.

It was a different level of magic from the thunderbolt he had fired before.

Arein's hand, covered with lightning, aimed at him.

It was the magic that the mage who defeated Eutenia used with full force.

If it were normal, he would have run away as soon as he saw that magic.

But he didn't feel like running away this time.

"I don't know that either."

Peter understood why Eutenia didn't back down and fought against Arein.

Behind him was a great being that supported him.

A being that was overwhelming and awe-inspiring, impossible to comprehend with the shallow knowledge of a mere human.

So it was natural for her to make a reckless attempt.

Even Peter himself didn't know what to do with the omnipotence that overflowed from his body.

"The price of ignorance is always death."

"..."

Peter's eyes, filled with light, checked the boundary drawn between him and Arein.

Peter quickly understood the meaning of the boundary line that reflected in his eyes.

The domain of the sword.

The dark boundary line drawn in the air indicated the space that Dainsleif dominated.

He was not a master of swordsmanship.

But at this moment, Peter had the confidence to overwhelm everyone in the domain.

“—Dainsleif.”

The name of the divine weapon came out of Peter’s mouth.

And right after that.

Peter’s blurred figure popped out right in front of Arein.

Dainsleif, imbued with red light, aimed at Arein’s neck and flew out.

Bang!

The shield that blocked Arein’s front exploded with a loud noise.

Arein, who faced Peter, opened his eyes and mouth wide.

“Blink.”

Ziiiiing—.

With the sound of space tearing, Arein appeared far away.

It was the teleportation magic he had shown when he fought with Eutenia.

Peter’s eyes turned to the tip of Dainsleif that conveyed a regretful sensation.

He felt something breaking, but unfortunately, he failed to take Arein’s neck.

Arein’s eyes, who jumped into space and appeared, glared at Peter.

“You bastard...”

“You almost died by someone who just became an apostle.”

Peter smirked at Arein as he retrieved his sword.

He was there as soon as he realized it.

That was Dainsleif’s ability.

It was possible to fire a super-fast attack that even Arein barely avoided.

Even someone who didn’t know the sword became a master of swordsmanship in an instant.

The convenience of the power borrowed from the evil god made it possible.

“...Lightning Burst.”

Arein’s fingertips, soaked in annoyance, stretched out a magic of thunderbolt.

Peter lifted up his white holy sword to counter Arein’s magic.

Just like he had blocked the magic that aimed at Eutenia, he intended to block Arein’s magic this time as well.

Paat—!

The holy sword emitted light and Arein’s magic that approached him began to blur.

As Peter ignored Arein’s magic weakened by the holy sword and tried to pass by,

The blurred magic became clear again.

“Could it be, this is...!”

“Burst.”

As Arein’s voice echoed, the twisted thunderbolt burst out.

Boom!

A huge explosion threw Peter’s body backward.

Thud. Crack.

Peter, pushed back by the aftermath of the explosion, stabbed his sword into the ground to brake.

“Ugh...!”

Rumble.

The ground that touched the stabbed sword cracked, and two straight lines were engraved on the surface.

Peter’s body, which kept being pushed back, stopped after pushing back some rocks.

Peter, who barely stopped, looked at Arein with blood dripping from his lips.

He felt a hot sensation from his forehead that was torn by the explosion.

“Spit—. As expected, the same method won’t work all the time.”

Peter pulled out his sword from the dusty smoke.

The white holy sword he had had the power to weaken magic.

But even with that power of the holy sword, it was impossible to erase Arein’s magic completely.

Arein seemed to have prepared a countermeasure for the holy sword.

Peter loosened his stiff wrist from braking.

He felt a slight pain from his body that was caught in the explosion.

As Peter took a breath with his sword raised, Arein opened his mouth looking at Peter's holy sword.

"That thing you have is Crossbridge's property."

"So what?"

"It means that the research on the white holy sword was finished decades ago. You'd better give up on stopping me with the holy relic."

The research on the holy sword was done long ago.

In other words, Arein knew how to destroy the holy sword.

The power of the holy sword was strong but not omnipotent.

In the end, it meant that he couldn't rely on the power of the holy sword when fighting Arein.

Of course, Peter didn't intend to rely on the white holy sword alone.

The white holy sword was ultimately a defensive weapon.

He had a better offensive weapon than that.

"Yeah? But you haven't finished researching this yet, have you?"

Peter lifted up Dainsleif that he dusted off.

From the moment he was hit by Arein's magic, Dainsleif's red aura had grown stronger.

As if to prove that it was a divine weapon of an evil god, this crazy magic sword welcomed its master's injury.

But he didn't feel too bad about it.

As much as Peter was hurt and wounded, Dainsleif gave him more power.

“You're obsessed with power.”

“Of course. It's finally time for Apostle Peter's era.”

“What are you...”

“The time to hide in the corner of a carriage is over!”

As he finished speaking, Peter swung his sword and leaped forward.

His figure spread out and then converged right in front of Arein.

Arein looked flustered again at the sight of Peter who approached him in an instant.

There was a translucent shield between Arein and Peter.

Whoosh!

Peter swung Dainsleif, filled with red aura, and shouted the name of the evil god.

“O evil god—!

“Absolute Shield!”

“O goddess—!”

Peter hastily switched to the holy sword and yelled loudly.

There were six goddesses who ruled the heavens, and he didn't know who was who, but he just shouted anyway.

There was no particular reason for that.

He felt like he shouldn't shout the name of the evil god while using the holy sword.

“Bastard apostle! Don't insult the goddess!”

But as Peter unleashed the light of the holy sword, Arein burst out in rage and unleashed his magic.

Even Arein couldn't stand the blasphemy.

Boom!

The magic released from Arein's hand pushed Peter's body back with a strong pressure.

It was a magic of density comparable to the magic that Peter, an apostle, was scattering.

Peter used the power of the divine weapon as soon as he faced the storm of magic that hit him in the air.

“—Dainsleif!”

Peter's figure spread out and converged to another location dominated by Dainsleif.

Peter, who escaped from the storm of magic, checked the boundary line around him.

Arein's body had retreated to the front of the boundary line.

He could fight evenly with Arein in the domain of the sword, but that didn't mean he was equal to him outside the boundary line.

If Arein left the domain of the sword, Peter had no way to deal with him.

Peter started to move his steps, measuring the distance between him and Arein.

‘I have to drag him into the domain.’

Arein also seemed to be calculating Peter’s movement, as he watched him from the boundary line.

Crackle. Crackle.

Peter slowly raised his sword at the sight of thunderbolts rising from Arein’s hands.

He was going to move forward and attack Arein as soon as he fired his magic.

“Come on, mage!”

As Peter aimed his sword and glared at Arein,

Arein suddenly frowned and started to act strangely.

“This is... a bit troublesome.”

Arein raised his hand with a frown.

And right after that, thunderbolts rained down from the sky towards Arein.

Clang! Clang!

Boom!

A huge thunderclap tore through the atmosphere and echoed repeatedly.

The thunderbolts shattered against the thick shield.

“Could this be...”

Peter, who watched the falling thunderbolts, soon understood who dropped them.

The evil god.

The great being who gave him Dainsleif was helping him this time.

Clang! Clang!

Every time a thunderbolt stabbed into the shield, a clear crack appeared on Arein's shield.

Arein seemed unable to hold on any longer, as he frowned and used his magic.

“Blink.”

Ziiiiing.

Arein's figure suddenly disappeared with the sound of space twisting.

The thunderbolt that lost its target pierced the empty ground.

Arein reappeared in the middle of the domain of the sword where Peter was standing.

Peter didn't miss Arein who escaped his attack by teleporting.

He aimed Dainsleif at Arein and ran forward again.

“—Dainsleif!”

Now Peter had the evil god he feared so much with him.

He had nothing to fear as he fought with the god.

He could fight recklessly now without any problem.

As Peter activated the power of the divine weapon, his figure flashed and spread out.

The afterimage of Peter brushed past Arein and went by.

Clang!

With a sharp sound, Dainsleif's blade scraped off Arein's shield.

“Absolute Shield!”

Arein raised his hands in a hurry and restored his shield.

But the god of heaven didn't just watch him do that.

Peter's only ally dropped another sharp lightning bolt.

Boom! Boom!

The thunderclaps overlapped and created an unpleasant harmony.

Arein's face twisted as he saw his shield cracking and used his magic again.

“Blink!”

“—Dainsleif!”

Peter swung his sword and chased after Arein who teleported.

Clang! Clang! Clang!

The trajectory that stretched out with afterimages delivered three attacks in an instant.

No matter how powerful Arein was, he couldn't keep up with Peter's speed in the domain of the sword.

Arein, who was quickly caught up by Peter, pulled up his magic again.

“...Blink!”

“—Dainsleif!”

“Bli...nk!”

“—Dainsleif!”

Arein used his magic to avoid Peter and teleported to another place within the boundary line.

But Peter wouldn't let go of his prey in the domain.

Peter's sword, faster than before, created illusions and hit Arein's shield.

Clang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!

The six illusions that spread out broke Arein's shield with their attacks.

Arein's face became more fierce as he saw Peter hitting his shield with dizzying eyes.

“Absolute Shield!”

Beyond the restored shield, lightning fell from the sky.

Boom! Boom!

The falling lightning bolts scattered as they collided with the shield, spreading fragments of light everywhere.

Through the dazzling lights, Peter's sword lunged at Arein.

As the white holy sword shone and touched Arein's shield,

Arein's figure was wrapped in a stronger light and teleported.

“Blink!”

“Dain—!”

Oops.

Peter's body stopped as he tried to chase after Arein like before.

Arein's body had teleported out of the domain using Blink.

While Peter hesitated at the distance that had widened, many magic circles appeared around Arein.

He had been preparing his magic while running away from the attack.

Peter felt that he had been outsmarted by Arein, who was breathing heavily.

“Haa, ha...”

‘Did he prepare his magic in that gap...!’

A stronger magic would unfold than before.

Maybe the powerful magic that had aimed at Eutenia would pour down on Peter this time.

Could he avoid it by moving to another location in the domain?

As Peter calculated that,

Arein, who had widened the distance, restored his shield and opened his mouth.

What came out of Arein’s mouth was unexpected for Peter.

“I don’t have the confidence to hold on against the evil god any longer. I’ve taken care of one apostle, so I’ll retreat for today.”

“...What?”

Peter looked at Arein with a puzzled expression as he scattered light and said that, having left the domain.

Boom!

Arein raised his hand and blocked the lightning bolt that struck him.

Even though the light created by the collision scattered, Arein’s eyes were still fixed on one place.

Only then did Peter realize what Arein was looking at.

Arein's gaze was directed at Eutenia, who had fallen.

“Could it be...”

Peter's eyes slowly turned to Eutenia.

What he saw was Eutenia's face, pale and breathless.

Blood was still flowing from Eutenia's wound.

There was no time for first aid.

There was no reason for Arein to leave him alone.

“Could it be, in the meantime...”

He had spent too much time on the battle.

Even as he fought against Arein, Eutenia's wound was getting worse.

It was too late to save her now.

Unless a miracle happened, there was no way to bring her back to life.

“Pray to the god. Maybe that will help your friend in her last moments.”

“...”

A wave of magic spread around.

It was a sign of a powerful magic being unleashed.

As Peter looked at Eutenia's fallen figure, he reflexively lifted his white holy sword high in the sky.

The white holy sword emitted a pure white light and tried to scatter the surrounding magic.

But Arein bid him a short farewell.

“See you next time. Traitor.”

“...White one.”

“It’s useless, unfortunately.”

With that, Arein’s body turned into light and scattered.

Peter’s eyes followed Arein’s figure for a moment, then turned back to Eutenia.

Eutenia’s eyes were closed and she wasn’t breathing.

Her face was pale and lifeless, with no trace of blood.

What he saw was nothing but a cold shell of Eutenia.

“Don’t lie to me...”

His enemy was dead.

The one she hated so much, the human of the temple, met his end.

The enemy who killed the villagers was dead.

The apostle of the evil god who trampled on his family, his village, and even his dream was dead.

But Peter felt no relief in his heart.

Only a bitter resentment that had nowhere to go remained in his chest.

“Don’t die like this– You should have died by my hand–!”

Peter’s scream echoed in the barren mountain.

He couldn’t understand it.

Who tricked him into walking the path of an apostle?

He had gained a great power and escaped from his lowly farmer status.

But the damn apostle of the evil god who made him an apostle, returned to the embrace of the evil god he longed for.

“Do you want to play with me till the end...”

Peter’s hand that held the sword slowly lost its strength.

The weight of Dainsleif in his right hand suddenly felt heavy.

Peter didn’t resist the overwhelming weight that reached his fingertips.

Thud.

Dainsleif stabbed into the ground.

“O evil god... show me... the way...”

Peter dropped his sword and called out the name of the evil god.

Maybe there was a god in the high sky who would look down on him.

Maybe he would revive Eutenia and let him finish her with his own hands.

That was what he thought when he did it.

But his voice was weak and stuttering, as he lost his strength.

“Show me... the way...”

The white holy sword fell from Peter’s grip as he uttered a faint voice.

Thud.

The white holy sword stabbed into the ground on the opposite side of Dainsleif.

Peter's eyes looked at the two swords stabbed into the ground.

“...”

The sixth apostle, Peter Enklov.

He felt like he had fallen into an eternal swamp with no end.

Chapter 138: The Contract of Regression (1)

Chapter 138: The Contract of Regression (1)

I was taking care of my characters in the game when I found a message.

It was a long time after I started the game.

A familiar type of message popped up in the message box at the bottom of the screen.

It was a message with a content that I never expected.

-[First Apostle: Eutenia Hyrost] has suffered a fatal damage.

The first thought that came to my mind when I saw the message.

It was that there might be some error in the game.

That was understandable, because Eutenia was one of the most powerful characters among the ones I had.

She had suffered a fatal damage.

It was hard for me to accept that.

“What does this mean...?”

I blinked several times, wondering if my eyes were wrong.

But no matter how much I closed and opened my eyes, the message on the screen remained the same.

Eutenia had suffered a fatal damage.

The message stayed there, waiting for my action.

“Eutenia is in danger?”

My finger that was scrolling down trembled slightly.

I didn’t want to believe it, but it was real.

My first apostle, Eutenia, seemed to be on the verge of death.

If the message was true, I had to save her right away.

After a brief hesitation, I quickly moved my finger and searched for Eutenia.

“What happened? Did a boss appear?”

My finger touched the screen and moved busily.

Swish. Swish.

As I flipped the screen with my finger, many terrains passed by my eyes.

I crossed the mountains and lakes, and reached the canyon in the eastern part of the barren continent.

And when I found Eutenia in one corner of it, my finger finally stopped on the screen.

-“...”

On the screen, I saw Eutenia lying in a pool of blood.

And in front of her, Peter, the horseman, was standing with his sword.

He was trying to protect Eutenia with his sword alone.

On the opposite side, I saw a mage preparing his magic.

Peter shouted at the mage as he faced him.

-“What are you doing here? Your apostle is dying! Don’t just watch and do something!”

Eutenia was bleeding to death.

She was the best character I had created with a lot of time and effort.

I needed another character to help her.

Without realizing it, my finger moved to the <Apostle Selection> skill icon.

It was a desperate thought.

I had to do something, so I chose him as an apostle, and as a result, Peter became the sixth apostle.

-Peter] is selected as an apostle.

-You spend 6400 karma to create a new divine weapon for the apostle.

-[Divine Weapon: Dainsleif] is bound to [Peter].

-[The Sixth Apostle: Peter Enklov] becomes your apostle.

-By the effect of <Apostle Selection>, you share your magic with the selected apostles.

-By the effect of <Apostle Selection>, you can send separate messages to the selected apostles.

I felt strange.

It was a conflicting action.

Choosing him as an apostle.

Spending most of my remaining karma.

I threw the divine weapon to him, who became an apostle.

And then——.

-“The apostle of the evil god is here!”

I don’t remember much after that.

I just wanted to kill the mage who did that to Eutenia.

It wasn’t fun.

I didn’t enjoy playing the game at all.

I was shooting magic mechanically, following the movements of my character, while a surge of annoyance rose from the depths of my chest.

“...What is this?”

Thud. Thud.

I kept tapping the screen repeatedly.

As if to relieve the rising irritation, I tapped the screen with force several times.

But then I finally found a strange message, and stopped my finger that was pressing the screen.

It was because I faced something I didn’t want to face.

-[First Apostle: Eutenia Hyrost]’s apostle contract has been suspended.

I could understand what the new message meant without thinking deeply.

Eutenia was dead.

The character who had been with me for months had suddenly met her end.

A feeling of emptiness settled in my chest.

My finger that had lost its place slowly circled around the edge of the smartphone.

“No... This is a joke, right?”

As soon as I confirmed Eutenia’s death, a hollow laugh escaped from my lips.

All the effort I had poured in was wasted in an instant.

The character I had grown attached to died while looking elsewhere.

Where was such a futile ending?

I was so dumbfounded that I couldn’t even get angry properly.

“Ah, really... This is ridiculous.”

I stared blankly at the screen with dull eyes.

What kind of game was this that I spent so much money and time on?

I resented my past self for doing so.

“Really... This is so ridiculous...”

The memories of Eutenia that I had experienced flashed through my mind.

I watched her grow day by day as I gave her bread.

I was happy to see her become stronger day by day.

How much money did I spend to nurture her?

But now what I was facing was Eutenia's fallen figure.

-[The Contract of Regression] is activated.

-The contract details are adjusted.

I leaned on the bed and stared blankly at the screen.

New messages kept popping up in the message box.

Something was still going on even after Eutenia's death.

But I didn't feel like focusing on the game right now.

For a while, I didn't even want to log in to the game.

"What now..."

I ruffled my messy hair and reached for the power button.

I wanted to turn off the screen and forget about it.

And I wanted to stay away from the game for a while.

I would decide later whether to get a refund or quit the game completely.

As I watched the messages on the screen, a large message box appeared in front of me.

It was a choice window that I could encounter when I used a certain skill.

-You used [The Contract of Regression] to adjust the contract.

-You can make a contract for regression under the following conditions.

-Premise: Revival of [First Apostle: Eutenia Hyrost]

Contract terms:

-No interference with the hero for 30 days

-Deactivation of <The Eye of the Observer> within the range including the hero for 30 days

-Increase of causality adjustment by <The Karma of Heaven> by 5%

-Do you accept the contract?

-Yes / No

I had to stop my finger that was heading to the power button at the content of the message that appeared in front of me.

There were unfamiliar items under the name of a familiar item, filling my eyes.

Of course, the most noticeable thing among them was the line with the word ‘revival’.

It was a concept that I had never encountered before on the screen.

“The Contract of Regression?”

It seemed that there was a way to revive Eutenia.

The Holy Land, Crossbridge.

In the training ground located in the Temple of Abundance, there was Gilford who wielded the divine weapon Ascalon.

He had been recognized as the hero of abundance and entered Crossbridge, and whenever he had time, he came to the training ground and swung his sword.

He wanted to erase his past self who had lost his comrades because of his weakness.

Whoosh.

Gilford, who was swinging Ascalon and creating shockwaves, stopped his sword at the voice that reached his ears.

-“It seems that we have bought enough time.”

The voice that reached Gilford’s ears, who stopped his sword, was from his divine weapon Ascalon.

Gilford looked at Ascalon with a puzzled look as he heard its story.

From his forehead, thick sweat drops flowed down.

Gilford asked Ascalon, who brought up an incomprehensible story.

“What are you talking about?”

-“The evil god made a new contract with heaven as a price for using his power.”

“A contract?”

Contract.

It was a word that Gilford knew well.

But the story that the evil god made a contract with heaven was hard to understand.

When Gilford asked him more details, Ascalon spoke with a faint light.

-“The god of regression defied the order. He paid a huge price in causality and became unable to interfere with the hero for a month.”

“Then...”

-“The power of the divine weapon has been unleashed to the next level. From now on, it will be hard for any weapon to even scratch you.”

The power of the divine weapon was unleashed.

And the new power he gained from it was more shocking than Gilford had expected.

He obtained a toughness that made him immune to any ordinary weapon.

This would be a huge advantage in a battle with many enemies.

Gilford, who was looking at Ascalon that was glowing with light, muttered as he tapped his skin.

“...Amazing.”

-“There will be no one who can match you as time goes by.”

“If time goes by, that is.”

Thump. Thump.

As Gilford tapped his skin with the blade of Ascalon, a person flashed through his mind.

A girl with ash-colored hair.

She called herself an apostle of the church, and controlled countless shadows.

And she was also the one who killed Gaph, Gilford’s most trustworthy friend.

“Eutenia... Maybe someday I’ll be able to kill that woman with my own hands.”

Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost.

As Gilford recalled the image of the apostle that flickered in his mind, he bit his lips.

After Gaph died, he gave up everything and entered the holy land.

For him, Eutenia was a sworn enemy that he had to kill someday.

As Gilford, who held Ascalon, reminisced about his enemy, a presence came from the door that was connected to the training ground.

Ascalon also felt him and spoke to Gilford.

-“She’s here.”

Creak.

The door opened and a girl in a nun’s dress with jewels appeared.

Gilford turned his head and looked at the unwelcome visitor who came to him.

Serena Ederlent. The one who had the highest authority in the Temple of Abundance looked at Gilford with a troubled face.

“You were in the training ground again today.”

“It’s none of your business.”

“It’s none of my business... I’m the saintess of the temple, you know.”

At Gilford’s words, Serena showed a bit of displeasure, but soon gave up and sighed.

Serena now was not the confident and bright saintess that Gilford had first met.

She was broken somewhere, just like Gilford, after losing her escort knight Lian Crost.

Of course, what Serena saw in Gilford was probably not much different.

They both knew that they could not go back to their old selves.

“So, saintess, what brought you to the training ground?”

Gilford faced Serena and stabbed Ascalon into the ground.

Ascalon stopped emitting light as it stabbed into the ground.

Serena glanced at Ascalon for a moment, then turned her gaze back to Gilford's face.

And then she told him her purpose.

"I have something to tell you."

"I don't care about small talk. Just tell me the important part briefly."

Hoo.

Serena sighed again at Gilford's words.

But she seemed to dislike being with him for long as well, so she crossed her arms and told him her purpose with a troubled face.

"The apostle of the church, Eutenia, was defeated by the dispatched heretic inquisitors."

"Eutenia was defeated?"

"Yes. I thought I had to tell you this story only to you."

The first apostle of the church was defeated.

Gilford sorted out his thoughts for a moment after hearing Serena's story.

But no matter how much he thought about it, there was only one conclusion that came down in his mind.

There was no way Eutenia would die by a mere expedition force of heretic inquisitors.

Even if there was a hidden story behind it, his thought was the same.

“There’s no way she would die so easily.”

“Gilford...”

Serena looked at him with a stiff expression, but Gilford’s thought remained the same.

The first apostle of the church, Eutenia Hyrost, was not dead yet.

Even if she was dead, she was the kind of person who could come back from the underworld.

Gilford could not fully trust the judgment of the church.

“More than anything, she has to die by my hand.”

But if she really died by the hands of the heretic inquisitors.

Then he had to drag out even her corpse and punish her.

She had to meet her end by Gilford’s hand only.

Otherwise———.

“If she fell into hell, I’ll chase her to the end of hell and kill her.”

Gilford Plowd would not be able to let go of the countless emotions that were stuck in his chest.

Far behind where she stood, there was a girl with a unique aura.

The girl, dressed in black from head to toe, opened her mouth and looked at Eutenia.

“Are you Eutenia?”

Her clear voice echoed in Eutenia’s ears.

The girl had such a strange atmosphere that Eutenia couldn't feel her as human at all.

Eutenia's eyes slowly took in the girl's appearance.

Her calm eyes seemed to hold darkness.

Her jet-black hair flowed down to her waist.

The girl exuded a dignity that only a transcendent being beyond human could have.

She was sitting at a table, resting her chin on her hand, and smiling at Eutenia.

“Could you be... the Great One I'm chasing?”

The first thing that Eutenia asked the girl was that question.

She had a feeling that it wasn't the case, but she wanted to confirm the identity of the other party just in case.

The girl tilted her head as if amused by Eutenia's question, then shook her head and denied it.

Phew.

A short sigh of relief escaped from Eutenia's mouth.

It would have been the most disrespectful thing if she had failed to recognize her master.

The girl looked at Eutenia, who sighed, and spoke.

“I'm just his agent.”

“Oh... I see.”

Fortunately, the answer from the girl was that she was the agent of the Great One.

She didn't seem human at all, so she must have been a being who helped the great being closely.

That also explained the atmosphere she felt from her.

Eutenia felt a sense of relief, along with a hint of envy in her heart.

She also wanted to help the great being directly like the girl in front of her.

Maybe someday she would have that chance.

“Are you jealous? That I know him?”

“Yes, I'm jealous.”

“You have a good disciple with you.”

The girl nodded lightly and praised Eutenia.

Eutenia felt proud of the compliment directed at her.

If the girl, who was the agent of the great being, said so, then the great being would also acknowledge Eutenia.

As Eutenia looked forward to meeting him, Estelle tapped the table with her finger and said.

“I'll tell you something special, just for you. You can ask me anything you're curious about.”

Apparently, the girl wanted to satisfy some of Eutenia's curiosity.

Eutenia didn't hesitate and asked her the most necessary questions.

The first one was about how to address the girl in front of her.

“Who are you?”

“Are you curious about my name?”

“I’d love to hear everything, but if that’s too hard, I’d be fine with just your name.”

The girl tilted her body for a moment, then smiled warmly and gestured to Eutenia.

Eutenia stepped on the clouds that covered the floor and approached her.

She felt a soft and cool sensation every time she took a step.

The girl spoke to Eutenia, who came close to her, in a quiet voice.

“Okay. I’ll tell you. My name is Estelle. But you can’t tell anyone what you heard here today.”

“I guess I have no choice if that’s the condition.”

“Any other questions?”

“Where is this place?”

Hmm.

After a brief thought, Estelle looked at Eutenia again.

Her eyes reflected the scenery of paradise.

“Divine Realm.”

“Divine Realm...?”

“It’s the dwelling that the heavenly god created for himself.”

Divine Realm.

Eutenia repeated the word she had just heard and smiled.

A space created by god.

It felt different when she heard that.

It was a lucky thing for Eutenia to be invited to such a place.

“So this is the place for him?”

“Well, I guess that’s partly true.”

“Is that so? It’s an amazing place. I’ve never seen such a beautiful place before.”

Estelle looked happy to hear Eutenia’s words.

“You have a good eye.”

“Anyone would think so.”

“Really?”

“But Estelle... where is the Great One?”

Eutenia asked, eager to meet her master as soon as possible.

But this time, Estelle made a troubled expression.

She shook her head and denied Eutenia’s words.

“I’m sorry, but you can’t meet him right now.”

“Why not...?”

“He’s still preparing for the meeting.”

Eutenia felt disappointed.

She wanted to face the great being directly, but it seemed that she was not allowed yet.

Estelle said that and got up from her seat.

Eutenia's eyes followed Estelle as she rose.

“Is that all you want to ask?”

“It's a pity. I had many more questions.”

“You'll have plenty of time and opportunities to learn the truth of the world later.”

“The truth of the world...”

Estelle moved through the clouds and put her hand on Eutenia's head.

A cluster of light poured out from Estelle's hand on Eutenia's head.

Eutenia closed her eyes at the dazzling light that burst out above her.

Then, Estelle's voice flowed into her ears.

“The Great One you revere has given you a gift. He paid a huge price for it.”

“A gift...?”

“You're going back to the earth. You still have a lot of things to do.”

Ah.

A short sigh came out of Eutenia's mouth.

She had vaguely guessed that she was dead.

But she never thought that she could come back to life.

Going back to the earth.

Eutenia's face darkened as she recalled the sight of the earth.

"I see."

It was a regrettable thing to leave without seeing the great being.

But if it was his command, Eutenia had no reason not to obey.

She still had a lot of things to do.

Estelle's words were true, and they would be in the future.

She nodded her head and Estelle tapped her head lightly and continued.

"And besides that, I'll give you one more personal gift."

"A gift...?"

Chapter 139: The Contract of Regression (2)

Chapter 139: Contract of Regression (2)

When Eutenia opened her eyes, the first thing she saw was a dazzling white space.

The floor was made of clouds, and on it were countless plants.

Birds chirped and welcomed Eutenia from above.

The only thought that came to Eutenia's mind as she faced the dreamlike scenery around her was one word.

Divine Realm

It was a place that anyone would call heaven if they saw it for the first time.

“Ah...”

Eutenia let out a small sigh of admiration as she engraved the sights in her eyes one by one.

She had seen many unique landscapes while going through the trials of shadows, but the place where she stood was much more amazing than that.

Eutenia's heart was filled with gratitude as she admired the surroundings.

She had finally returned to His embrace after fighting for Him.

That was the thought that filled Eutenia's mind.

“O Great One...”

As Eutenia was about to kneel down and pray with emotion, she felt a presence behind her and turned around.

“You have a good eye.”

“Anyone would think so.”

“Really?”

“But Estelle... where is the Great One?”

Eutenia asked, eager to meet her master as soon as possible.

But this time, Estelle made a troubled expression.

She shook her head and denied Eutenia’s words.

“I’m sorry, but you can’t meet him right now.”

“Why not...?”

“He’s still preparing for the meeting.”

Eutenia felt disappointed.

She wanted to face the great being directly, but it seemed that she was not allowed yet.

Estelle said that and got up from her seat.

Eutenia’s eyes followed Estelle as she rose.

“Is that all you want to ask?”

“It’s a pity. I had many more questions.”

“You’ll have plenty of time and opportunities to learn the truth of the world later.”

“The truth of the world...”

Estelle moved through the clouds and put her hand on Eutenia’s head.

A cluster of light poured out from Estelle’s hand on Eutenia’s head.

Eutenia closed her eyes at the dazzling light that burst out above her.

Then, Estelle’s voice flowed into her ears.

“The Great One you revere has given you a gift. He paid a huge price for it.”

“A gift...?”

“You’re going back to the earth. You still have a lot of things to do.”

Ah.

A short sigh came out of Eutenia’s mouth.

She had vaguely guessed that she was dead.

But she never thought that she could come back to life.

Going back to the earth.

Eutenia’s face darkened as she recalled the sight of the earth.

“I see.”

It was a regrettable thing to leave without seeing the great being.

But if it was his command, Eutenia had no reason not to obey.

She still had a lot of things to do.

Estelle's words were true, and they would be in the future.

She nodded her head and Estelle tapped her head lightly and continued.

"And besides that, I'll give you one more personal gift."

"A gift...?"

"This is my gift to you."

Eutenia opened her eyes and looked at Estelle, who said that.

She found a black cloak in her hand.

The cloak felt extraordinary in her touch.

"What is this...?"

"It's a rare item. I was going to use a different method, but I think it's fine for now."

"It's a good item. Thank you."

Estelle's hand stroked Eutenia's hair, who thanked her.

It was a strange feeling.

The girl, who looked shorter than her, was patting her head.

But she didn't mind it.

Estelle advised Eutenia, who stroked her head.

"You have to keep moving. The Great One you love trusts you the most."

"..."

"You have to dedicate the whole world to the one you love the most. Then, the great god will descend on the earth. You can do it, right?"

“The whole world...”

Eutenia had already decided to give everything to the great being.

People.

The world.

And anything beyond that, they didn't matter to Eutenia.

But she had to think a little about whether it was possible for her.

“I'll try my best.”

“Of course, you can do anything.”

Nod.

Eutenia nodded in agreement.

And right after that, her fingers that reflected in Eutenia's eyes began to blur.

Eutenia was startled by the sudden change, and Estelle's eyes looked at Eutenia, who was slowly disappearing.

“It looks like time is almost up.”

“What do you mean by time is up...?”

“It's time to go back to where you came from.”

It meant that she didn't have much time left to talk with Estelle.

It was time to wake up from the dream and return to the original reality.

Eutenia, who was fading away with the cloak, asked Estelle one more question.

“Estelle... can I ask you one last question?”

“If it’s only one, it’s okay.”

“What does he think of you?”

I felt my consciousness fading away.

But I wanted to hear Estelle’s answer to this question.

Estelle looked at me with the same curious eyes as before.

She spoke slowly, choosing her words carefully.

“Me? I’m probably...”

“Probably...?”

“An unwelcome guest who’s not unpleasant.”

That was our last conversation.

Thud.

My consciousness went dark.

* * * * *

“.....”

I returned to the ground with my floating consciousness.

When I opened my eyes, I didn’t see the paradise above the clouds that I had seen before.

Instead, I saw Peter, who was holding a sword stuck in the ground and bowing his head.

My eyes scanned his figure slowly.

He was holding a blood-red sword and sleeping with a weary face.

My hand gently stroked his cheek as I looked at him.

“You became an apostle.”

Our relationship would never be the same.

I couldn't play cruel jokes on him like I used to, since he was now an apostle like me.

I felt a bit of regret.

But I also had some idea of what was going on.

I couldn't stay like this forever.

If Peter had refused to become a great being until the end, I would have had to deal with him myself.

“It's a bit wicked that you lied about being a hero.”

I smirked and got up from my seat, looking at the sleeping Peter.

The pain in my shoulder and abdomen was gone.

Through the hole in my robe, I could see the healed wound.

As Estelle said, I had returned to the ground.

I received the grace of the great being and was granted a second life.

I was enjoying a glory that ordinary humans couldn't even imagine.

“Still, thank you.”

Flap.

I put on the black cloak that Estelle gave me and looked around the rocky mountain.

Arein Crost, who fought me here, was gone.

The great being intervened after Peter became an apostle, so it wasn't strange that Arein retreated.

Knights and magicians were not omnipotent.

No matter how strong they were, they couldn't defeat a god.

"I also thank you, great one. You always watch over me, give me my daily bread, and help me overcome any adversity..."

I looked up at the sky.

The sun had already set and a bright moon was rising in the sky.

A lot of time had passed since I collapsed.

The blazing sun had disappeared beyond the horizon, and now only countless twinkling stars remained in the sky.

Under the beautiful night sky, I reached out to the sky.

".....Thank you always."

Chasing the shining stars in the distant sky, I was here.

To dedicate everything in this world to him.

To devote myself to the greatest cause.

For that alone, I decided to bear all the evil in the world.

I stained my hands with blood.

And I would stain them more with blood in the future.

“Life...”

A short prayer escaped from my lips as I looked at the sky.

I reached out higher to the vast night sky.

I wanted to touch something higher, even if I had to stand on tiptoe.

I reached out higher for someone I revered.

“——Life. Build a staircase.”

Beyond my outstretched hand, I saw the bright North Star shining in my eyes.

I longed for the sky.

To reach someone beyond it, I had to keep getting stronger.

To never repeat today's disgrace.

Chapter 140: The Contract of Regression (3)

Chapter 140: The Contract of Regression (3)

“Ugh...”

I threw the water bottle in frustration, making it bounce on the floor of my small studio apartment.

I sighed in relief as I looked at Eutenia on the screen.

Eutenia had come back.

She had disappeared like the other characters, but she had returned to the screen with the help of an item.

The [Contract of Regression] that was stuck in a corner of my inventory had returned Eutenia to me, along with a causality penalty.

“I’m so glad... I almost quit the game.”

If I hadn’t had any resurrection items left in my inventory, I would have quit the game right away.

And for a while, I probably wouldn’t have launched this game again.

Eutenia was the main character that I had spent most of my playtime on.

If she had gone for good, I wouldn’t have had the confidence to play the game anymore.

It would have been like playing a game that had lost most of its content, leaving only ruins behind.

In fact, I had quit other games in the middle of playing them when my enhanced items were destroyed.

“Who would have thought that spending 2 million won back then would pay off like this...”

It was thanks to the [Contract of Regression] that I had drawn that I could get Eutenia back.

What I had thought was a misfortune turned out to be a blessing in disguise.

Besides, I had won the lottery and recovered most of the money I had spent.

It was an experience that I could now cherish as a good memory.

As I watched Eutenia praying on the screen, I felt satisfied and leaned back on my bed, touching my forehead.

“When I think about it, this is really a trash game.”

Suddenly, the top boss appeared and knocked down Eutenia and ran away.

What kind of game designs its balance like this?

It was not an event that could be understood by common sense.

But then again, this game was one that showed nothing but actions that defied common sense.

It was stupid to expect common sense from this game.

Of course, I was the most stupid one for playing a game that was beyond common sense.

“But I’m an idiot for getting attached to the game and not being able to quit.”

But now it was too late to quit the game. I had come too far.

I had to see the end of it, one way or another.

I had been through many hardships, but I really loved this game.

It was a game that I liked.

I didn't want to quit the game for some weird and unreasonable reason.

Eutenia, Evan, Estasia who did strange things, and now those who suddenly disappeared. They were all characters that would hurt my heart if they were gone.

This must have been a scheme by the game company.

They wanted to make me attached to the characters and prevent me from quitting the game. That was their scheme.

“But what can I do when I'm already attached...”

Things that were impossible to replace tended to have strong fandoms, even if they were small in scale.

I had already become a fan of this trash game.

Yes.

A fan.

The Life of a Passionate Gamer Who Checks His Karma Every Day

I was living the life of a passionate gamer who logged into the game every day and checked his karma number.

It had become a part of my daily routine that was deeply ingrained in my life.

“I can't take it anymore. I need to do a gacha to clear my mind.”

To soothe my restless mind, I decided to take a drastic measure.

Gacha was the best thing to do when I felt uneasy.

As I stared at the items that emitted light, I forgot all the thoughts that came to my mind.

Tap.

I touched the <Paid Currency Shop> button on the top of the screen and logged into the game.

As I entered the shop, a message greeted me as usual.

-Welcome to the <Paid Currency Shop>.

-The <Paid Currency Shop> sells various items for a smooth gameplay.

I looked at the 10-pull gacha button that had become too expensive for me.

The button that shone brightly tempted me to press it right away.

I put aside the thought of resisting the temptation and moved my finger towards the provocative gacha button.

Press.

As soon as I pressed the button, a text message came and took away a hefty amount of money from me.

“Please, give me one more contract.”

It was an item with a penalty, but it was the best item to ensure the safety of the characters.

I wished that the gacha would give me one more contract for insurance.

The gacha screen started to emit a brilliant light along with my wish.

The items that were printed one by one passed by my eyes in a blur.

-[Demon Doll]

-[Demon Doll]

-[Demon Doll]

The first ones were [Demon Dolls] in a pile.

It was a trash game after all.

-[Demon Doll]

-[Demon Doll]

-[Demon Doll]

“Ah... trash game.”

The next ones were also [Demon Dolls].

It felt like this was not a gacha but a doll machine.

-[Demon Doll]

-[Demon Doll]

-[Demon Doll]

“Bro.”

The next ones were still [Demon Dolls].

I didn't hope for a contract anymore, but I wished they would at least give me one magic book.

And at least be fair and disclose the gacha rates.

As I flipped the last item with a nervous heart, a strong light burst out of the screen.

-[Magic Book: Voice]

The last item that came out was a magic book.

The name of the item was [Magic Book: Voice].

It was an item that was hard to guess what it was by its name alone.

I flipped the item confirmation window with a mix of regret and relief.

I was a bit disappointed that I didn't get a contract, but getting a magic book wasn't such a bad thing either.

“Voice... what kind of magic is that?”

After finishing the gacha, I stroked my beard and looked at the screen.

It was time to check the contents of the magic book I had drawn.

Tap.

I touched the screen to zoom in on the details.

And then I started to read the contents slowly from the top.

My eyes stopped in the middle of the description as I read the details of [Magic Book: Voice].

“Wait, is this...?”

I smirked at the unexpected content as I checked the skill description.

A familiar figure came to my mind.

The new translator.

The amazing guy who changed my sentences into elegant tones whenever I entered them.

A small village in the northern part of the continent.

A boy holding a divine device leaned against the wall, facing the fallen Cloud investigators.

The hero of order, Philrun.

He was a hero who had received the name of a hero, but he moved alone without joining the holy land.

There was one reason why he didn't join the holy land and wandered alone in the northern part of the empire.

It was because the mission given to Philrun was not accepted by the holy land.

The investigators who fell to the ground were those who chased after Philrun and met their death by his hand.

“Do you mean I don't have to worry about being attacked by the followers of the evil god for a while?”

Philrun, who leaned against the wall, looked at his divine device, Clawsolas, and asked.

It was because of what he had just heard from Clawsolas.

Clawsolas dimmed his light and emitted a faint vibration as he heard Philrun's story.

Right after that, Clawsolas's voice flowed into Philrun's ears.

-“The evil god made a contract with Heaven. For a while, his followers won't be able to touch you.”

“Is that so? Then wouldn’t it be easier for me to go and kill them?”

If the followers of the evil god couldn’t touch Philrun, he could use that to kill them.

Philrun’s story came from that thought.

But the answer he heard from Clawsolas was somewhat different from what he had in mind.

-“They are stuck in the church for a while and won’t come out. You’ll only waste time trying to find them.”

“But isn’t it worth it if I find them?”

-“And our important task is not to find those guys from the church. It will be annoying if we mess up with the holy land or Cloud by making trouble.”

Philrun clicked his tongue as he looked at the investigators who were bouncing on the ground.

The Cloud investigators were a nuisance to him as well.

Just today, he had been attacked while eating and had to deal with a difficult situation.

He had to put down the bread he was tearing and face the Cloud investigators.

The bread he found after the battle was hard and covered with dust.

“Surely... it’s troublesome when the Cloud bastards come in droves.”

Philrun said as he recalled the bread that flew away in vain during the battle.

He was not invincible just because he was a hero.

Besides, Philrun was in a situation where he had not been a hero for long.

It was obvious that he would be in trouble if other heroes or Cloud's high-ranking officers came looking for him.

"I might lose if I fight them."

He might even end up being dragged away by them after losing miserably.

He still needed to train himself continuously.

And for Philrun, his mission was a great help for his training.

The experience of killing something was quite important for those who wielded swords.

Especially if they were those who resisted with their weapons until they died.

"I should learn how to handle the sword better by killing some more."

- "Be careful not to attract too much attention."

"I'm careful. That's why I set the number of kills per day to one."

Thud. Thud.

Philrun punched the wall he was leaning on and talked.

Even though there was a loud noise from behind the wall, no one came out of the house.

That was natural.

All the residents in this village had been dealt with by Philrun himself.

"And I can't go around killing people in several villages in one day."

But no matter how much Philrun was a hero, it was impossible for him to move around and fight in several villages in one day.

He had tied the horses that the Cloud guys had ridden to a pole, but he was not yet skilled at riding them.

Philrun expressed his regret and tapped the back of Clawsolas's blade with his hand.

The blade shook and made a clear sound around him.

"If you were a little more useful, it would have been possible."

Did Philrun's words not please him?

Clawsolas vibrated his blade and spoke to Philrun.

- "If you harvest more lives, it will be solved."

"That's the problem? I have to be stronger to kill more, right?"

- "There is an order to everything. Don't go against the natural law."

"You're so picky for something that the goddess of order gave me."

Bang.

Philrun slammed the handle of Clawsolas that he was holding against the wall.

He didn't like Clawsolas complaining to him.

Philrun grinned and spoke to Clawsolas as he stuck his divine device to the wall.

"I'm an apostle of the goddess of order, what's wrong with breaking some order?"

- "Stop talking nonsense. There is only one being in this world that can withstand going against the natural law."

But Clawsolas gave him a serious answer regardless of Philrun's words.

It was a boring answer. It was not what he had expected either.

Philrun looked at Clawsolas with a dissatisfied face and asked him.

He was the only hero chosen by the goddess of order.

Who else could get away with breaking order?

It was a hard story to accept for him.

“Who is that?”

-“The god of regression. A god whose existence itself is contradictory.”

“The god of regression? I’ve never heard of it. Is there such a god in this world?”

Philrun recited the names of the six gods in his head.

Honor. Knowledge. Order. Hunting. Abundance. Harmony.

There was no being called the god of regression.

From the start, his name seemed far from the world’s providence.

When Philrun asked again without fully understanding Clawsolas’s words, Clawsolas turned off his light and spoke.

-“You wouldn’t know. She is the being that human history books call an evil god.”

Chapter 141: Harvest (1)

Chapter 141: Harvest (1)

I stood in front of the chapel on the first floor of the Ketterland branch of the Order, located in the west of the continent.

I hesitated for a moment before opening the door.

Behind the door was the angel, the representative of the branch.

Normally, I would have greeted her briefly and told her what I came for.

But today, I felt reluctant to open the door.

Was it okay to tell her this story?

I had many doubts in my mind.

“Hmm...”

In my opinion, she was a wonderful angel.

Everyone in the Order liked her, and Estasia always prayed for everyone.

But when I thought about the work of the Order, I couldn't expect a positive effect from her.

She was more of a hindrance than a help.

If anything, her help only delayed things more.

“Hmmm...”

But I couldn't avoid reporting to her what everyone knew.

I was the one who handled the practical matters, but nominally, Estasia was the highest authority.

With a sigh, I grabbed the handle and entered the chapel.

Squeak.

As I opened the door and entered the chapel, I saw Estasia holding a doll in her arms.

“Good morning, angel.”

“Yawn... Hi.”

Estasia rested her chin on the white horse-shaped doll and greeted me.

She looked like she was still half asleep, with her eyes barely open.

Next to her, Aronia was sweeping the chapel with a broom.

It was Estasia's order to make the cursed angel repent.

I nodded briefly at Aronia and walked straight to Estasia.

“You came early today.”

“I have some work to report to you in advance, angel.”

“Hmm. What is it?”

“Well...”

I glanced at Aronia, who was next to me.

She was moving her broom busily, but her body was getting closer to Estasia.

She was stepping forward, but leaning backward.

Her ears twitched as she approached with acrobatic movements.

She seemed very curious about what I was going to report to the angel.

I ignored Aronia's antics and opened my mouth to Estasia.

"Angel. The harvest festival is coming soon."

"The harvest festival?"

Estasia tilted her head when she heard the word harvest festival.

It was understandable.

The angel I knew had stayed in heaven and knew nothing of the world below.

The harvest festival was an event that the villages held every time the harvest season came.

It was a celebration of gratitude and joy, where people prayed and shared fruits and bread.

It was also something that happened every year in any place that cultivated crops.

"It's a day to thank the sky for the harvest and share the happiness with others."

"I see."

"This time, we plan to hold a harvest festival for the believers, along with an altar for the Great One."

I said that and looked at Estasia's reaction.

Originally, it was a ritual to offer an altar to the goddess of abundance.

But now, we knew our true master, the Great One.

The altar would be dedicated to the right one in this harvest festival, but I was wary of bringing up the past sins.

“Harvest festival... Okay, I got it.”

Fortunately, Estasia nodded and let it go quietly.

Phew. I sighed with relief in my mind.

I had a feeling that this harvest festival would go smoothly.

Estasia didn't seem to have much interest in it either, so there wouldn't be much trouble.

It was a quiet festival for the angel and the believers, so we just had to enjoy it peacefully.

“Then, let's proceed as planned...”

“Okay. I'll invite someone.”

Just when I thought it was over.

Estasia gave me a meaningful answer.

I couldn't help but be surprised by the sudden answer of the angel.

It was a quiet festival that we held among ourselves in the branch.

Who was she going to invite?

I asked Estasia back in confusion.

“What?”

“I'll invite someone.”

But Estasia's answer was still consistent.

Blink. Blink.

As I opened and closed my eyes, I looked at Estasia and finally nodded.

I didn't know who or what she was inviting, but I thought it wouldn't hurt to accept it for now.

After all, the angel rarely went out of the Order's building.

"I don't know what it is, but okay."

I thought she would just hand out some handwritten invitations to the believers at most.

I agreed with Estasia's words and exchanged a few more words before turning around and leaving the chapel.

Thud. Thud.

My slow footsteps echoed in the silent chapel.

As I closed the door behind me, I heard the voices of the angels in my ears.

"Estasia. Who are you going to invite to the harvest festival?"

"Shh. If you're an angel, you have to finish your own work first."

"Eh... Estasia..."

"If you're lazy, you'll get scolded by the master."

Squeak. Bang.

I closed the door of the chapel and walked towards my office.

The angels' business was for the angel to handle.

As a bishop, I just had to focus on the Order's work quietly.

"I hope everyone enjoys the harvest festival."

I saw the busy believers of the Order in my eyes.

I felt like I would be busy preparing for the harvest festival for a while.

* * * * *

A dark conference room.

With the table in the middle in front of me, I looked at the other attendees.

Was it because I was chosen by the evil god and became an apostle?

Today, I felt more relaxed than usual.

There was still some tension from the regular meeting, but less pressure than last time.

"Daniel, I heard you became a new apostle. Congratulations."

Roan, who was across from me, was the first to congratulate me.

I always felt uneasy when talking about strength, but now I didn't have to lie anymore.

I was now an apostle chosen by the evil god.

I nodded with a cold expression and accepted Roan's congratulations.

"Thank you."

"Of course, it's only natural that the Great One would take interest in 'the Silent Butcher'."

But I still felt uncomfortable when I heard the familiar name.

Was it because of the ridiculous misunderstandings that had accumulated over time?

I felt sick when I heard my nickname that came out of nowhere.

I thought I could get over it without any problem, but it was unexpectedly stressful.

I clenched my hands and feet and pretended to be calm.

“I guess so.”

I felt like I could endure it if I put some strength in my fingertips.

I wanted to exchange greetings and move on to the main topic.

But Roan seemed to have no intention of doing that, and he continued to talk about me.

He told me about the heretic inquisitors that his disciples had caught by chance after learning how to slaughter.

“And I heard that many of your disciples are already capable of dealing with heretic inquisitors...”

– “Heretic inquisitors... They’ve become excellent assassins.”

“Yes. You’ve trained your disciples to handle heretic inquisitors so quickly. Daniel, you must have a great talent as an instructor.”

Roan praised Daniel as he brought up the story of the heretic inquisitors.

For some reason, Arcrosis also nodded slightly and joined in.

Of course, Daniel felt like dying as he listened to the story.

He knew nothing about assassination.

All he taught was slaughter.

If they ever visited the farm, they might find out the truth.

It was a story that made his heart race with anxiety.

“Daniel? Is something wrong?”

As Daniel stood stiffly with sweat running down his back, Roan asked him with a worried tone.

No matter how much he became an apostle, he couldn't reveal that everything was a lie now.

Daniel racked his brain for a way to make Roan stop talking about him.

There was only one conclusion that came out of Daniel's mouth.

“Roan, Archbishop. An assassin's achievements should not be known outside.”

“Oh... I made a big mistake. I'll be careful from now on.”

– “You're wise and prudent.”

“Killing enemies without anyone knowing. That's the pride of assassins.”

Fortunately, Daniel's words worked, and Roan didn't continue to talk about him anymore.

Phew.

I sighed with relief in my mind.

Becoming an apostle didn't mean I could completely relax.

As the story about me ended, Roan turned to the young man who had just joined the meeting and opened his mouth.

“Peter, congratulations on becoming an apostle. You have received the grace of the Great One.”

“Well... It’s complicated, but that’s how it turned out.”

I also looked at the young man called Peter.

It was his first time attending the meeting, and he was wearing a shabby outfit.

He looked rather poor compared to the other apostles.

I shouldn’t judge people by their appearance, but he looked more like a country bumpkin than an apostle.

As I thought that, Estasia stood up from her seat and pointed at Peter with her finger and shouted.

“Groom...!”

“Who are you calling a groom? I’m Apostle Peter.”

“Groom... became an apostle...”

“No, I’m not a groom...”

Estasia called him a groom, and Peter snapped at her.

As I listened to their conversation, I finally realized who Peter was.

He looked a bit shabby, probably because he used to be a groom.

No wonder he wore different clothes than the robe-wearing believers of the Order.

‘He was a groom before. He must have been lucky to become an apostle recently.’

I came to a conclusion in my mind and nodded to myself.

I also became an apostle by chance, so there was no rule that a groom couldn’t become one.

As I felt sympathy for Peter from my empathy, Evan stepped in this time.

The second apostle, Evan Allemier, looked at Peter, who had become an apostle, and spoke.

“Anyway, congratulations on becoming an apostle. Peter.”

“Thank you... sir.”

Peter gave him an awkward answer to his question.

It seemed that he was struggling with honorifics.

He didn't let go of his respect for Evan after all.

Evan and the others congratulated Peter one by one.

Most of them seemed to know Peter well.

When it was Estasia's turn, she got up and approached Peter.

“I'll give you a special gift for becoming an apostle.”

And she gently stroked Peter's head as she spoke.

Peter looked at Estasia's hand that was stroking him with a puzzled look.

He didn't know what she was talking about.

“Gift...?”

“Yeah. I'll invite you to the harvest festival.”

She said she would give him a gift, but it turned out to be an invitation to the harvest festival.

Peter's expression started to get weird.

He looked at Estasia with a questioning expression.

He had a piece of bread in his hand that he had picked up from the table.

“You’re inviting me to the harvest festival?”

“It’s Estasia’s gift. Of course, I’ll also invite some other people specially.”

It was almost time for the harvest festival.

It was the season when the villagers who had finished harvesting gathered and enjoyed a modest party.

Estasia must have had that in mind when she brought up the harvest festival.

It wasn’t a bad idea to hold a big harvest festival and invite guests.

But the guests who were invited were all extraordinary.

In Daniel’s mind, skeletons, fairies, and vampires lined up in the harvest festival scene.

“And you can bring Cuebaerg too.”

As she said that, Estasia had a white Cuebaerg doll in her hand.

A huge lump was added to Daniel’s mind.

Ugh.

Daniel sighed as he looked at the doll.

Chapter 142: Harvest (2)

Chapter 142: Harvest (2)

<Regular Meeting>.

A skill that temporarily summons designated targets to a predetermined meeting room.

It was also a skill for holding the periodic executive meetings of the cult.

It had been a long time since the cooldown of the <Regular Meeting> skill came back, and there were many things to report in the game.

That's why I decided to use the <Regular Meeting> skill.

It was the first regular meeting since Peter and Daniel became apostles.

-“Daniel, I heard you became an apostle. Congratulations.”

The first thing that came up after the meeting started was congratulating Daniel on his selection as an apostle.

Maybe it was because the news of the new apostle had already spread throughout the cult.

Roan was quick to offer his congratulations to Daniel as soon as he saw him.

Perhaps it was because everyone knew Daniel's fearsome nickname, the Silent Butcher, that all the executives who attended the meeting nodded in agreement.

Of course, I agreed too.

Daniel was an amazing character who didn't fall behind any other executive in both faith and combat ability.

“The problem is that there's a boss that looks hard to catch even with such a character...”

The image of the boss I faced last time came to my mind as I looked at the characters.

An unidentified mage who freely moved through space and used magic.

He was the culprit who made me use [Contract of Regression], and also the one who had a great impact on this meeting.

I had to select Peter as an apostle to stop him from defeating Eutenea.

“We'll have to be careful not to let the apostles meet him for a while.”

The most important reason for this meeting was also because of [Contract of Regression] that I used to revive Eutenea.

It was to inform the executives who attended the meeting about the penalty imposed by using [Contract of Regression].

I had to announce the penalty that I had to bear for 30 days, and adjust the activity plan accordingly.

Of course, there was also a meaning of warning about the new boss character.

As I was thinking about various things while looking at the meeting room, I saw Estasia do something unexpected while greeting others.

“I'll give you a special gift for becoming an apostle.”

She got up from her seat in the middle of the conversation and went over to Peter, who was sitting calmly, and hit him on the head.

And then she said she would give Peter a gift.

I looked at Estasia, who was hugging a [demon doll], with a puzzled face.

The Estasia I knew was not the type to give gifts to others.

She was the angel who ate a whole basket of strawberries by herself in front of Aronia.

I couldn't easily imagine that Estasia would give something to someone else.

-“I'll invite you to the harvest festival.”

“Well, that's it.”

As expected, it was not much different from what I thought.

The gift Estasia was talking about was an event called the harvest festival.

Most of the events that took place in the branch were handled by the bishop in charge of the Catterun branch.

It was fair to say that Estasia had nothing to do with them.

I looked at Estasia, who was confidently inviting the executives, with a smile.

“But still... isn't it nice for the characters to get together once in a while, even if it's not a meeting?”

I thought it would be fun to hang out with other executives.

If I used Uto, I could travel quickly to the Catterun branch.

It wasn't bad to refresh my mood that had been shaken by Eutenea's death.

Besides, there were many people among the cult's executives who didn't have a proper acquaintance yet.

Inviting them to the event was not a bad idea.

If it weren't for Estasia's last remark.

-“By the way, you can bring Cuebaerg too.”

-“?”

A word that Estasia uttered while shrugging her shoulders as she looked around at the other executives.

As I heard that word, countless questions flashed through my mind.

The image of Cuebaerg joining the festive atmosphere devoured the festival in my head.

I couldn't understand why she said that and reached a situation where I couldn't understand.

“What is she inviting him for?”

I muttered out loud, thinking of the giant rice cake.

[Abyssal Demon: Cuebaerg].

Now that he had shed his skin into a rice cake-like appearance, he was roaming the sea.

The giant rice cake that had become a marine creature floated in the sea as big as a whale, swallowing up all the fish he saw.

Although his size was much smaller than his heyday, it was still not something to laugh at.

“Is that a festival for him too?”

I imagined the giant rice cake standing next to the cult's branch in my head.

No matter how I thought about it, it seemed hard to fill his stomach with human food.

It would be lucky if he didn't eat people, let alone grab food.

The executives also had question marks over their heads and pondered.

Maybe it was because they couldn't stand the frozen atmosphere of the meeting room.

Roan, who had been watching him, quickly tried to sort out the situation.

-“We have received your invitation to the harvest festival. We will consider whether to attend or not, and now let's talk about the main topic of today's meeting.”

Fortunately, thanks to Roan's intervention, Estasia's strange conversation didn't last long.

It was Roan's skillfulness that shone, who attended more meetings than anyone else.

Of course, there were other issues to discuss in the cult besides the harvest festival.

The most prominent one was the new boss that appeared.

-“Arien Crost. The main character of this incident...”

-“By the trust of the great one, some guidelines have been given to the cult...”

-“For the time being, we will reduce the external activities of the cult...”

The problem that happened to Eutenea and the emergence of a new formidable enemy.

And the penalty that the cult had to bear because of [Contract of Regression].

Various topics kept pouring out of Roan's mouth.

Of course, the most important thing was to reduce the activities of the cult.

This was what I ordered Eutenea to avoid contact with the heroes.

-“Above all, please be careful not to confront the heroes.”

-“If you have to contact them, try to escape as quickly as possible...”

Avoiding contact with the heroes.

That was the way to cope with the penalty of ‘not interfering with the heroes’.

According to the penalty, for a while, I was likely to be blocked from sight even without special patterns like <Sanctuary Proclamation>.

So I wanted to reduce the scope of the cult's activities and prevent meeting with the bosses called heroes.

For a while, the total amount of karma I acquired would decrease, but one month in game time was not a long time for me.

-“Is there anything else you are curious about?”

That's how the meeting proceeded quickly under Roan's leadership.

Many things were delivered unilaterally, and no one objected to Roan's words.

It was the same for the additional items that Roan added.

Estasia dozed off for a while during the meeting, but as soon as Peter took away [demon doll], she woke up and snatched it back.

-“That's it for this meeting.”

The regular meeting that took place after a long time ended quickly.

As Roan declared the end of the meeting after talking about all the items, Estasia, who held onto the doll, yawned.

After that, they just chatted with each other.

Of course, since <Regular Meeting> skill had a duration limit, they would all go back to normal if left alone.

“I’m sleepy. Should I go to bed?”

I put down my smartphone after watching the meeting until the end.

I felt sleepy after staring blankly at the meeting for a long time.

I thought I could understand Estasia’s feelings a little bit.

Yawn.

I suppressed a yawn that burst out of my mouth and went to bed.

I lay down there right away.

Sleep poured out of my tightly closed eyelids.

The east of the empire.

There is a blue sea there.

There was a huge creature swimming in the sea.

Its name was Cuebaerg, a giant creature that floated in the sea with a round shape.

He used to be one of the lords who ruled the abyss, but now he was nothing more than a marine animal.

Of course, his size was enough to disrupt the surrounding ecosystem.

-“...”

Bobbing. Bobbing.

Cuebaerg's body swayed along with the waves.

But soon he returned to normal and stared at the deep sea.

He saw the fish moving diligently under the blue surface.

The schools of fish were swimming against the sea following their leader.

Cuebaerg gazed blankly at the fish and then opened his mouth wide.

-Gwoooooooo.

As soon as Cuebaerg's huge mouth opened, a massive amount of seawater rushed into his mouth.

The fish swimming in the sea were no exception.

They couldn't resist the huge current and were sucked into Cuebaerg's mouth in an instant.

Crunch.

Cuebaerg closed his mouth after sucking in countless fish and filling it with seawater.

He just had to open his mouth and the prey would come in by themselves.

This was the secret of how Cuebaerg quickly grew his size in the sea.

-“This time, I didn't catch as many as I thought.”

Cuebaerg swallowed the fish and spat out a jet of water into the sky.

A huge fountain sprang up and a rainbow rose in the sky.

He spat out the unnecessary seawater, leaving only the fish in his mouth.

This way, he only had pure meat in his mouth.

Sometimes trash or seaweed came in, but he spat them out diligently.

He was a fervent carnivore.

-“Ahem...”

As Cuebaerg enjoyed his leisurely meal, he felt a huge magic from the sky.

Crackle. Crackle.

A huge thundercloud rose in the sky, and black lightning wrapped around it.

The thundercloud that Cuebaerg saw was clearly that of a familiar friend.

Evan Alemier.

It was the energy of the second apostle of his master.

He seemed to be trying to fall on top of him, and Cuebaerg wondered if he should welcome him for a moment.

It was quite stinging when lightning fell on his head.

-“Long time no see, Evan.”

But soon he put aside such worries and took Evan’s lightning on his head.

Boom!

The dark red lightning burst out and struck Cuebaerg’s head.

And below that, Evan’s figure appeared, wrapped in lightning.

Crackle. Crackle.

Evan scattered the black lightning around his body and greeted Cuebaerg.

“Nice to see you again, Cuebaerg.”

-“Do I look bigger?”

“Definitely. I’d believe it if you said you were an island now.”

Evan sat on top of Cuebaerg and stroked his smooth surface with his finger as he spoke.

He was right.

He was now big enough to compare with a mediocre rock, let alone an island.

Although he wasn’t as powerful as he used to be, he had regained a considerable level of strength by now.

Thanks to the nature of the sea, which had many creatures and was similar to the abyss, he had received a lot of help.

Cuebaerg caught a squid and threw it to him as a gift, and asked Evan who sat on his head.

-“What brings you here this time? Isn’t it time to stop protecting me?”

He used to be protected by Evan because he had lost a lot of power, but now that time was completely over.

Evan nodded his head and agreed with Cuebaerg’s question.

“That’s true. I came here to tell you two pieces of news.”

-“Two pieces of news?”

“The first is what he said himself. Be careful not to meet the heroes.”

Heroes.

That word echoed in Cuebaerg's mind as he recalled the crusaders of the holy land he had met before.

They were a troublesome opponent for him, each wielding a special weapon.

And the core power of those crusaders were the ones called heroes.

Cuebaerg spat out the seawater that remained in his mouth, remembering the nightmare of the past.

-“I don't think I'll meet them on the sea, but... I'll be careful as much as possible.”

“Right. It's better to be careful. One of the apostles has already been defeated.”

-“An apostle was defeated?”

“Thanks to his intervention, she's fine now.”

It was clear that they were a formidable enemy if they could even defeat an apostle.

It was best to avoid them as much as possible.

Cuebaerg's power was still lacking, after all.

He needed time.

Time to devour countless lives and dominate the entire sea.

“And there's another thing...”

-“What's the other thing?”

Evan, who had brought up the warning about the heroes, hesitated to mention the next thing.

Cuebaerg urged him to tell him the next thing, guessing that it would be a serious matter, considering the importance of the previous one.

Under Cuebaerg's constant pressure, Evan opened his mouth with an awkward expression.

"I think this is a stupid question, but do you have any plans to attend the harvest festival?"

- "...?"

Cuebaerg tilted his head.

Evan's body also shook on top of Cuebaerg's head.

Evan tried to balance himself on Cuebaerg's swaying head and muttered with a displeased face.

"I guess I asked for nothing..."

Chapter 143: Harvest (3)

Chapter 143: Harvest (3)

Caterant Branch.

The day of the harvest festival.

The bishop stepped out of his office with a nervous heart.

Today was the first time he would preside over the harvest festival since he became a bishop.

He had been worried about how to please the Great One with a satisfactory festival.

What if the Great One was displeased with the offerings?

What if there was not enough bread for the believers?

He had prepared for the festival with much care, and he was confident that it would be a success.

“Besides, it seems like the angel has been quiet this time...”

He had been keeping an eye on Estasia’s movements for a few days, but she had not left the church.

Of course, he had not received the invitation he had hoped for, either.

But as long as he had checked all the potential risks, today’s event would go smoothly.

The bishop opened the door of the church building with high expectations.

As if they had been waiting for him, the church members greeted him as they decorated the place for the festival.

“Bishop, you’re here!”

“We’re almost done with the preparations for the festival.”

The church members also looked excited about the festival. They smiled at the corners of their mouths.

This festival was for both the Great One and the church.

Everyone could laugh and celebrate the autumn harvest.

The bishop nodded with a satisfied face as he looked at the church yard.

Then, he suddenly thought of Estasia and quietly asked one of the nearby church members.

“Where is the angel?”

“The angel is over there, drinking strawberry juice.”

The bishop’s eyes followed the church member’s finger.

As he said, Estasia was sitting on the chair he had set up, drinking strawberry juice.

Next to her, Aronia was plucking the stems off the strawberries from the fruit basket with a sullen face.

Fortunately, Estasia was behaving herself and eating strawberries.

The bishop tapped the back of a church member and signaled him to go inside.

“Finish what you were doing. You can enjoy yourself later.”

“Yes, bishop.”

After encouraging the church member, the bishop headed straight to Estasia.

Thump. Thump.

The bishop’s footsteps echoed in the noisy yard, and Estasia’s gaze moved to him.

Estasia waved her hand at the bishop as she drank her strawberry juice.

The bishop stopped right in front of Aronia, who was removing the strawberry stems, and looked at Estasia, who was lying quietly on the chair.

“Angel, did you sleep well?”

“Yes.”

“Hehe... You must be looking forward to this harvest festival.”

“Yes. I invited a lot of people to help.”

Estasia answered with an expression that seemed to ask for praise.

The bishop’s head was filled with many questions as he saw Estasia speaking proudly with her chest out.

He was sure he had not seen Estasia go outside recently.

She had just been cooped up in the chapel every day, spending time with Aronia.

But it was important to remember that Estasia was not the type to lie, even if he dismissed her words as false.

She was a clear angel, even though she caused a lot of trouble.

She was a being who lived completely apart from lies.

“Really? Who did you invite...”

The bishop’s face darkened in an instant as he asked Estasia.

Then, Estasia raised her finger and pointed at the sky.

The bishop’s eyes also followed Estasia’s finger and looked at the sky.

Flash.

Something was shining in the distant sky.

Estasia pointed at the light source with her finger and told the bishop.

“They’re coming down now.”

“Who’s coming...”

“The invited guests.”

As soon as Estasia finished speaking,

Something strange happened in the sky.

Crackle. Crackle.

Black lightning spread all over, and a thundercloud filled with lightning stopped above the church.

The bishop’s eyes naturally widened as he looked at the sky.

“What is this...”

Boom!

A loud thunderclap sounded, and lightning fell from the sky.

The lightning that fell to the ground left a clear mark right next to Estasia.

Screech—.

A faint smoke rose from the grass on the ground, and soon a man appeared from within it.

The man's eyes, which had a restrained aura, were directed at the bishop.

"I am Evan Allemier, the second apostle. I heard that you invited me to this harvest festival."

The man who landed on the ground reached out his hand and spoke to the bishop.

Apostle, Evan Allemier.

The bishop was startled by his identity and shook his hand with trembling fingers.

"A, apostle... Huh..."

What was an apostle?

They were the messengers of God who represented the heavenly affairs.

They were in a higher position than even the bishop.

But such a being suddenly appeared in front of the bishop.

And he said that the bishop had invited him.

The bishop was startled by the unexpected guest, but he tried to calm his heart and let go of his hand.

"Thank you for your invitation, bishop."

"Y-you're welcome. I hope you have a good time."

The bishop tried to welcome him and ordered a church member to bring a chair quickly.

He couldn't make an apostle appointed by God sit on the bare ground.

As the bishop greeted the apostle who came down from the sky, the church members behind him whispered loudly.

They revered the apostle as a worthy object.

“The bishop invited an apostle!”

“He brought God’s apostle to the harvest festival... He’s truly our bishop.”

The bishop clenched his teeth as he heard the church members praising him.

He thought there would be no trouble, but in the end, the angel caused a huge accident.

He was sure that he would have to watch the apostle’s mood and conduct the harvest festival for today.

As he thought that and sighed, he saw a huge shadow falling from the sky.

“W-what is that...”

The bishop looked at the sky, still not fully calm, and saw the huge shadow of a dragon flap its wings.

That was clearly a dragon.

The bishop’s mouth gaped open as he faced the dragon.

And then, the dragon changed its direction and started to fall to the ground.

-Krrrrrrrrr.

The huge body of the dragon was flying to the ground.

It was a monstrous size that could be seen at a glance.

If he collided with the falling dragon, his bones would crumble and he would meet his fate.

The bishop raised his arms and tried to protect his face desperately as he saw the falling dragon.

“...!”

“Good job, Alpha.”

But what he heard in his ears as he raised his arms was a gentle voice of a girl.

Swoosh.

The dragon that pierced the ground turned into a shadow and disappeared, leaving only a girl in a black cloak behind.

The girl who appeared from within was familiar to the bishop.

The first apostle. Eutenia Hyrost.

She appeared in front of the bishop.

“It’s been a while. Thank you for inviting me.”

“Huh...!”

The bishop was shocked to see Eutenia.

But his hand was politely accepting Eutenia’s handshake.

He shook Eutenia’s hand with trembling fingers.

He had not invited anyone, but already two apostles had come.

Eutenia saw the startled bishop and asked him.

“Are you surprised?”

“A-a little. The dragon was so huge...”

“It’s a grace from Him.”

“He is truly great. Please take a seat.”

The bishop tried to calm his startled heart and gestured to another church member next to him.

He meant to bring a chair for Eutenia quickly.

A church member ran into the church quickly to get a chair.

As he saw the church member going to get a chair, the church members who were preparing for the event looked at the bishop with admiration.

“Our bishop... He invited two apostles.”

“This harvest festival is quite meaningful.”

The bishop felt that his robe was somehow very damp on his back.

He calmed his trembling heart and looked at Estasia, who was eating strawberries.

Thanks to the angel who left an unexpected invitation, he had to host two guests and conduct the harvest festival.

It was practically impossible to enjoy the harvest festival comfortably.

“W-well... It’s an honor to have two apostles...”

“Undead! Undead are coming!”

Just as the bishop was about to greet Evan and Eutenia, who he had seated.

A church member pointed at the forest and shouted.

The bishop frowned and looked at the forest.

There must have been a dark mage hiding nearby.

How dare they send undead on such an auspicious day.

If the apostles hadn't come here, he would have driven them away with lightning.

“How dare you! Who released the undead near the church!”

The bishop yelled as he turned his eyes to where the undead were.

He thought they would be just a bunch of skeletons.

But something was wrong.

There were no skeletons, only a huge phantom horse floating in the sky.

And on top of the phantom horse, there was an undead wearing a robe upside down.

He had a dreadful aura, clearly one of the top-tier undead.

-“Sorry to interrupt. I heard you invited me.”

Thud.

The undead who stopped the phantom horse in front of the bishop dropped to the ground.

And then he greeted the bishop right away.

The undead greeted him calmly, and the bishop asked him with a doubtful mind.

“Wh-who are you...”

-“I am Arcrosis, the king of the dead. I serve the Great One.”

“Huh... Huhhhhh...!”

The bishop felt like he was going to die when he heard Arcrosis's identity.

His heart was pounding in his chest, which he held with his hand.

He had heard that he invited someone, but he had no idea who it was.

And he had just yelled at the king of the dead in front of him.

As the bishop held his chest with a pale face, the church members behind him clapped and cheered.

“The bishop made even the devil submit!”

“By the grace of the Great One, he made even the devil see the light of faith!”

“Our bishop is amazing! There’s nothing he can’t do!”

“I, Alfred, am deeply moved by your faith, bishop!”

They all exclaimed at the bishop’s action of inviting the devil.

And Alfred, as if he had gone mad, was spouting nonsense in a loud voice.

The bishop felt dizzy as he faced the parade of guests who came one after another.

His heart was not calming down at all.

As he shivered from the pressure on his chest, Eutenia’s voice reached his ears.

“Ah... Daniel said he couldn’t make it, so there will be three more coming.”

“What?”

The bishop thought he had heard wrong.

Three more apostles?

He couldn't understand it no matter how he thought about it.

But Eutenia told him the truth again in a clear tone, as if to wake him up from reality.

“The other apostles said they would bring gifts.”

“Ah...”

Five apostles. One monster.

And two angels eating fruit.

The bishop felt a headache as he hosted eight guests for the festival.

How did this happen?

The harvest festival he had planned was supposed to be a family-like celebration among the church members.

“Ahhh... Great One.”

He saw that reality had grown far away from his expected harvest festival.

Now he had to conduct the festival while watching eight people's faces.

He uttered God's name as he sighed and looked at the sky.

Evan, who was watching him from behind, chimed in.

“Hmm... The bishop has a deep faith.”

“Yes. I'm glad I invited them. They look happy.”

Chapter 144: Harvest (4)

Chapter 144: Harvest (4)

“It’s been a while since we gathered somewhere other than the conference room.”

It was noon on a day when a chilly wind started to blow through the window.

I leaned against the wall and looked at the characters beyond my smartphone.

The Catterant branch of the Church was crowded with many characters today.

Estasia had invited the other apostles to the regular meeting, and they had accepted and came to the Catterant branch themselves.

Perin and Yuto had helped the apostles move quickly.

When Yuto first descended from the sky, the Church’s believers were so surprised that they almost ran away.

Of course, by now they had adapted somewhat, and they were having a good time eating the prepared food.

“It’s peaceful. This isn’t so bad, is it?”

I uttered a short impression as I watched the apostles eating.

I used to be interested only in hunting and expansion every day, but seeing them spend peaceful time like this made me feel not bad at all.

I felt time passing quickly as I stared blankly at the laughing and chatting characters.

And at the center of it all was none other than Estasia.

She was a troublesome character who always caused strange things, but her surroundings were always peaceful and quiet.

“The number of strawberries seems a bit low, though.”

My gaze shifted from the harvest festival to Estasia, who was eating strawberries.

As usual, she had emptied the basket full of strawberries.

Next to her, Aronia was making a sad face at the empty basket.

I couldn't help but smile at the sight.

-“Estasia! Did you eat them all by yourself again!”

-“It's because Aronia was slow to remove the strawberry stems.”

-“Estasiaaaaaa……!”

It was the same scenery as always.

Estasia caused some trouble, and Aronia complained about it.

If I looked closely, she was the only character who had a different genre of game.

Estasia showed a face that would fit in a healing game.

Naturally, Estasia's own influence was the biggest reason why her surroundings changed like that.

Estasia's outrageous actions always brought positive results.

“What about the others…….”

This time, I turned my head to look at the other apostles.

The next thing that caught my eye was Peter, who was picking bread in the corner.

Peter, who had become an apostle this time, was having a meal with the bishop.

-“Hmm... The bread is really delicious.”

-“Hehe... Thank you.”

-“I think I could eat this bread all day long.”

Was it because Peter had risen to the position of an apostle?

The bishop looked a bit uncomfortable as he faced Peter.

Well, it was natural, since there was a hierarchy in the Church.

As I watched Peter eating bread, Estasia shouted at him from nearby.

-“Servant. Come here and help Aronia with the strawberries.”

Peter seemed annoyed by the word servant, and he shouted back at Estasia.

-“I’m not a servant!”

-“Non-servant person. Help Aronia with the strawberries.”

-“Call me Apostle Peter!”

Of course, there was no normal conversation between them.

I wondered if there was anyone who could have a normal conversation with Estasia.

I looked away from Peter, who was yelling at Estasia, and moved my gaze to the other apostles.

There was a fire pit in front of me, where skewers of meat were being grilled.

Eutenia and Perin were waiting for their skewers and chatting.

-“Don’t fairies avoid meat?”

-“We eat meat too.”

-“Hmm... That’s interesting.”

They were talking about whether fairies were vegetarians or not.

Perin didn’t seem to care much, as he grabbed a skewer that was browned nicely.

Yum yum.

Eutenia quickly accepted his example and picked up her own skewer.

The skewer had chicken and green onions alternately. It looked quite tasty from the outside.

-“It would have been nice if Daniel was here too.”

-“Why didn’t Daniel come?”

-“He said he would spend the harvest festival quietly with the believers who are learning assassination skills from him.”

I finally learned why Daniel didn’t come from Eutenia’s story.

I wondered why I didn’t see Daniel, but he must have been taking care of his subordinates quietly.

It was a fitting behavior for an assassin.

I admired Daniel's thoughtful gesture and turned my head to see Arcrosis drinking beer next to him.

Arcrosis was facing Pluto and Evan, and they were enjoying their beer glasses together.

"Why is a skeleton eating food?"

I asked as I watched the beer dripping from Arcrosis's bottom.

They were similar races, but Pluto and Arcrosis had completely different outcomes.

Pluto had a slightly flushed face from being drunk, and Arcrosis kept soaking his chair with beer.

Looking at the silent table atmosphere, they seemed to enjoy the mood itself.

- "Would you like some bread too?"

- "I'll take it gratefully."

When one of the believers next to him offered him a piece of bread, Arcrosis quickly put it in his mouth.

Of course, the bread that went into his mouth also fell on his chair.

The food waste accumulated on Arcrosis's chair was increasing in quantity.

I sighed as I saw the bread soaked in beer.

"He's just throwing bread and beer on the street."

At the same time, I saw the remains of a cup noodle rolling on my table.

It contrasted with the food piled up on Arcrosis's chair.

Well, I didn't mind that much.

That's what gamers are like.

Even if I eat a little less now, I want to give something more to the characters beyond the small screen.

I get excited over a tiny piece of data that I can't even see properly.

"It's good for me if I starve a little and my characters eat well and do well."

I laid down my body on the floor that was leaning against the wall precariously.

The cold touch of the floor was transmitted to my back.

With one hand raised obliquely, I saw the characters laughing and chatting beyond the screen.

I lifted the corners of my mouth slightly as I watched the scene.

It felt like I was full just by watching.

"Let's go together until the end."

Beyond the old film that I didn't know when I attached, countless pixels were shining densely.

There was a world beyond the small LCD screen.

There was a small world that would collapse if I didn't touch it.

The Holy Land, Crossbridge.

In the magic training room located underground of the Temple of Knowledge, Hus's eyes looked at Arein in front of him.

Hus's eyes were full of determination as he looked at the hero of the previous era.

On the other hand, Arein's eyes were dull as he watched Hus.

Arein put down the book he was holding and asked him.

"Do you want to learn magic from me?"

"That's exactly what I said."

Hus nodded and agreed as he faced Arein.

It had been quite some time since Arein Crost came back to life.

And during that time, Hus had been researching about Arein.

Hus had only one conclusion after searching through countless documents about Arein.

The hero of knowledge from the previous era, Arein Crost.

Arein was a true magician of a different caliber than Hus himself.

"Maybe you can... teach me something that will help me surpass my brother."

Hus said that and clenched his device in his hand.

The device of knowledge, Hieroglyph, gave him a powerful ability.

With it, Hus could reproduce any magic he saw once with his eyes.

But even with such power, Hus couldn't beat his brother Evan.

Hus Allemier had experienced it firsthand in the last battle.

He realized that he was nothing but a novice who relied on the power of the device.

"Did you say your brother is an apostle of the evil god?"

Arein opened his mouth as he leaned against the wall of the training room, listening to Hus's story.

He seemed to remember the short conversation they had before.

"The second apostle, Evan Allemier... That's the name of my nemesis that I have to defeat."

"Brothers who became an apostle and a hero... What a strange fate."

A strange fate.

There was no better word to describe Hus's destiny.

His admired brother became an apostle of the evil god that he hated so much.

With the signpost that pointed his way gone, Hus was left alone to grope his way on a path that left no traces.

Hus bit his lower lip as he thought of Evan's appearance as an apostle.

"He wasn't like that. He was more faithful than anyone..."

"The higher you are, the stronger the shock when you fall."

"..."

"When those who had noble faith fall, they tend to show stronger hostility towards the goddess than others."

Arein's eyes were filled with complex emotions as he said that.

Hus watched him and quickly realized something and asked him.

"Is that something you experienced...?"

"It's the story of the people I dealt with by my own hands. Among them was someone who was my old friend."

“...”

“That’s what war is. A time when you kill many people and lose even more things. Brothers are no exception.”

Brothers are no exception.

Arein’s words pierced Hus’s heart deeply.

After saying that, Arein turned his gaze to the opposite side of Hus.

His eyes were directed at the symbol of the temple engraved on the wall.

It was the same symbol as the one engraved on Hus’s arm, the mark of a hero.

The magician who looked at the symbol on the wall asked him a question.

“So, do you have the confidence to fight your brother?”

The question Arein asked.

It was a thought that had been haunting Hus’s mind for a long time.

Could he kill Evan, who had become an apostle, with his own hands?

He didn’t want to do it. But it was something he had to do.

It was because he had a clear answer that Hus could finally come to Arein.

“I have to stop him with my own hands. Otherwise... I won’t be able to protect what’s left.”

“Is that your answer?”

“...”

Silence fell over the training room where only two people remained.

Arien looked like he was pondering something in his head, as seen by Hus's eyes.

Thud. Thump.

Arien's fingers tapped the wall briefly.

He lifted his head again after a long time of thinking, five minutes after Hus's last answer.

"Fine. I'll teach you the combat methods of a mage."

"Really?"

"I have no reason to refuse to train a disciple."

Arien's gaze turned back to Hus.

He picked up the leather gloves he had taken off the floor and started to put them on his hands.

He didn't forget to give advice to Hus as he did so.

"First of all, put down that hieroglyph."

"Aren't you going to teach me magic? Why do I have to put down the hieroglyph, what the hell..."

"I'll teach you from the basics again."

That was Arien's first instruction after deciding to teach Hus.

To put down the hieroglyph he was holding in his hand.

It was a bewildering request for Hus, who had learned countless magic through the hieroglyph.

Using the hieroglyph was essential to learn new magic.

He thought Arien would teach him a more powerful way to use the hieroglyph.

But he told him to put down the hieroglyph he was holding first.

It was a hard story to accept for Hus.

“Let me tell you in advance. You have only one goal. To prepare and manifest magic at the same time as the hieroglyph.”

“Is that possible?”

“The artifact should only be a tool to assist you. First, become a great mage yourself.”

Arien flicked his finger.

Bang.

The hieroglyph in Hus’s hand flew away and hit the wall.

Hus looked at Arien with a hollow expression, having lost the hieroglyph in his hand in an instant.

“It won’t be easy to defeat the apostles of the evil god unless you do that much.”

A clear lightning was contained in Arien’s hand as he spoke.

Chapter 145: The Voice of God (1)

Chapter 145: The Voice of God (1)

“Well, I guess it wouldn’t hurt to learn it anyway.”

In a dark room, only the screen of my smartphone emitted light as the rest of the lights were turned off.

I was staring intently at the smartphone screen.

At the end of my gaze, a magic book that I had acquired last time was shining.

It was a magic book that contained a skill that was different from the ones I had obtained so far.

-Do you want to acquire the <Voice> skill?

-The magic book will disappear when you acquire it.

-Yes / No

[Magic Book: Voice].

It was an item that I had decided to use after hesitating whether to give it to Eutenia.

Of course, the background for that decision was that Eutenia already had a similar type of magic.

Although I couldn’t get any nourishment from her because she didn’t have a magic book, Eutenia was already in a situation where she could use magic

with a similar effect.

As soon as I realized that fact, I decided to use this magic book.

-You have acquired <Voice (Lv.MAX)>.

-You can now use the voice magic by consuming mana.

Once I decided to learn the magic, there was no need to hesitate any longer.

I touched the 'Yes' button without hesitation and acquired the skill.

Soon, a message informing me of the skill acquisition appeared at the bottom of the screen.

I touched the skill icon of the newly appeared <Voice> skill and checked the detailed description of the skill again.

There were some information that I could only confirm after acquiring the skill.

“There’s not much difference from before... Is it just simply transmitting my voice through a machine?”

Unfortunately, the detailed description of the <Voice> skill that I acquired was not very different either.

It was a skill that allowed me to deliver any message I wanted.

That was the feeling of the skill description.

If I could only communicate with other characters through apostles before, this skill seemed to be able to deliver messages widely even without a device.

“Well, I’ll find out when I use it.”

Seeing is believing, as they say.

The best way to find out more details was to try it out for myself.

I touched the skill icon of the <Voice> skill and activated it.

Click.

As soon as I pressed the icon, a new type of message window appeared in front of me and greeted me.

-Please say the message you want to send. (Maximum 10 seconds)

A recording window that allowed me to enter up to 10 seconds of message appeared.

10 seconds was not a short length.

It was enough to deliver a sentence without abbreviation.

The important point was how the content I entered here would be censored.

I moved my gaze towards Roan, who was attending a meeting in his office, and cleared my throat once while rubbing my neck.

“Ahem.”

I cleared my throat lightly and pressed the record button to send a message to Roan.

Of course, I tried to deliver it in a dignified tone, like the divine translator.

I had to see how it would be delivered first, before I could make a proper comparison.

The first thing I said was a word of encouragement for Roan.

“Archbishop Roan. Keep up the good work.”

-Input completed.

“Hmm... Why do I feel so embarrassed doing this alone?”

I felt awkward talking to a game character with my own voice.

But it seemed like the input went well.

As I waited for Roan’s reaction while looking at the message window, a man’s voice started to flow from my smartphone.

As expected, the divine translator didn’t deliver my words exactly.

The voice that came out of the smartphone speaker was exaggeratedly praising Roan.

-“The one who walks his own path will face the light.”

-“Could this voice be! Has the great one finally given me a direct revelation!”

Roan’s reaction was intense after hearing the translated words.

He covered his face with an ecstatic expression and looked up at the sky.

Then he knelt down and bowed his head.

Tears streamed down his face as he bowed.

He kept bowing to the desk, and didn’t forget to say thank you with his mouth.

-“I can’t believe I finally heard the revelation of the great one. I, Roan Hebris, have no regrets even if I die now. But to help the great one’s work, I have no choice but...”

“What a... strong reaction.”

-“O great one. Please let the church overcome all these hardships and trials and establish your kingdom on earth...”

“This is why he’s a fanatic.”

I felt awkward watching Roan’s endless gratitude.

I just wanted to try and cheer him up a bit, but he was living up to his name as a fanatic and giving me an extreme thank you.

It felt like I had to leave him alone for a while.

I left Roan to his admiration and moved the screen to find other characters somewhere.

Swoosh. Swoosh.

The scenery around me changed as I swiped the screen with my finger.

What I found was Estasia, who was riding on Uto with curiosity.

-“Aronia, look. The ground is flying in the sky...”

-“Estasia... You can fly too, you know.”

She was admiring the ground below with Aronia.

I felt like trying out my skill on her, who was standing on Uto with her wings spread.

Estasia, who was not an apostle, couldn’t exchange messages with me personally.

If I used the <Voice> skill to deliver a message to her, it would be the first time we had a conversation.

“Let’s try something weird this time.”

I already checked that it would be delivered similarly if I said something appropriate.

Then what would happen if I said something nonsense?

It was time to check that out.

I clicked on the skill icon of <Voice> and muttered nonsense to Estasia.

“Peter has five butts.”

It was obviously a joke that anyone could see.

I spat out whatever words I could think of and used them near Estasia’s ear in a small size.

Maybe it didn’t like the nonsense I casually said.

The divine translator started to deliver a message that was completely incomprehensible.

-“The sixth apostle will rise above the five branches of darkness.”

-“.....!”

There was no trace of the original meaning left in the content.

As the translated message flowed out, Estasia’s halo flashed brightly when she heard the voice.

Right after that, Estasia shook her wings and turned her head to the side.

Estasia looked at Aronia, who was touching [Fake Divine Tree: Yggdrasil], and opened her mouth.

-“Aronia... The master just gave me a revelation.”

Maybe it was because the voice that was delivered had profound content.

Estasia claimed that she had received a revelation from Aronia.

Indeed, it was a content that anyone would misunderstand if they heard it.

It wasn’t strange that Estasia took it as a revelation either.

At Estasia's words that she had received a revelation, Aronia ran over to her with wide eyes.

-“Oh, did the evil god give you a revelation? What is it?”

-“Mabu has six butts.”

-“The sixth apostle...? That's so unfortunate.”

-“Yeah.”

I watched the two angels' conversation and laughed mockingly at the screen.

I did say nonsense while looking at my smartphone, but it was definitely delivered as a strange content by the divine translator.

But what came out of Estasia's mouth was even more absurd than that.

I expressed my short impression as I watched Estasia spouting nonsense.

“.....That's not what you heard, is it?”

It was clear that——.

Estasia had a translator of the divine level built into her.

A small cabin in the Alterias region, located in the north of the empire.

There lived a squint-eyed man in a thick fur coat.

His name was John.

He was a famous hunter in the Alterias region, and he was also known by the nickname of Red Arrow John by the people around him.

The nickname of Red Arrow came from a story where he shot a wolf with a blood-soaked arrow from his crossbow.

“The weather is especially bad today.”

John straightened his crooked hat and looked at the blizzard outside the window.

The Alterias region was notorious for its harsh cold and blizzards.

It was hard to move around in the snow-covered mountains, even for a skilled hunter.

It was so bad that sometimes outsiders would come and get lost and freeze to death.

Of course, Red Arrow John was familiar enough to go anywhere with his eyes closed.

“I’d better not go hunting today.”

But even for John, today’s weather looked ominous.

He would be in trouble if he went out in this weather.

And even if he somehow managed to get around without any major problems, it was hard to find prey in the strong blizzard.

It was wise to stay at home and light a fire on a day like this.

“Hmm……?”

As he decided that and approached the burning fire.

John felt a slight uneasiness that was different from usual and stopped.

He felt like he heard a strange voice in his ear.

John stopped his steps at the suspicious sign and slowly looked around with a tense expression.

He wanted to check if there was any intruder who had come in.

“.....”

Clank.

John loaded his crossbow and looked around nervously, but he couldn't find any traces that could be attributed to an intruder.

It was the same when he listened to the wall where the blizzard was raging.

He couldn't feel anything like a human presence behind the wall.

“Maybe I was mistaken.....”

He couldn't see any signs of an intruder no matter how many times he looked around.

It seemed certain that John had heard wrong.

He quickly made a judgment after looking around and tried to put down his crossbow.

At that moment, a strange voice started to ring clearly in his ear.

-Kheheheheh.

“What, what is it!”

It was an eerie and desolate voice that came to John's ear.

John felt his hair stand on end when he heard the voice.

It was right after he had confirmed that there was no one around.

Despite that, John heard an unidentified voice.

“Who are you? Show yourself!”

It sounded like a human laughter.

John aimed his crossbow in all directions and shouted in the empty cabin.

His fierce voice echoed in the cramped space.

But John couldn't find anyone to shoot at.

He was still the only one in the house.

“What the hell is going on…….”

-Kheheheheh.

“Wha, what! Where are you? Where are you hiding!”

The clear laughter rang in his ears again.

John quickly pressed himself against the wall and screamed as he fired his crossbow into the air.

Up, down, left, right. He searched everywhere, but he couldn't see the enemy.

But he was sure that someone was there from the voice.

-Kheheh.

-Kheheheheheh.

-Kheheheheh.

The chilling laughter continued to torment his ears.

There was an enemy. But he couldn't see him.

John felt like he was going crazy in this situation.

He had no way to take down an invisible enemy.

His terrified mind quickly came to a conclusion.

“It’s a demon! It must be a demon!”

John reached that conclusion and immediately opened the door and ran outside.

There was no doubt that a demon had descended on his narrow cabin.

Otherwise, there was no reason why he would hear a voice when he was alone.

His survival instinct as a hunter was ringing an alarm.

John started to run with all his might to get away from the mocking demon.

“Help, help me! It’s a demon! A demon has appeared!”

He couldn’t win against an invisible demon.

The best he could do as a mere hunter was to run away.

John kept moving his legs for survival.

He had to avoid the demon’s touch and ask for help from the people of the temple somewhere.

-Kheheheheh.

As he ran, the demon’s voice kept following him.

John swung his arms roughly to shake off the pursuing demon.

Whish. Whish.

His arms cut through the blizzard and hit the air.

“Aaaah! Don’t follow me!”

-Kheheheheh.

“Aaaah! Don’t come near meeeeeee!”

-Kheheheh.

—

[illegible]

The laughter grew louder and louder, and John's pace quickened.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

The rough pounding from his heart told him that it was about to burst.

Facing the fear of impending death, John threw away his crossbow and sprinted.

He moved through the snow as if he were swimming, with a skill that could rival a seasoned sailor's.

Except for the fact that he failed to avoid a rock along the way.

“Aaah! Aaaah!”

He tripped over a rock buried in the snow and lost his balance. His body rolled roughly on the ground.

It seemed that he had stepped on his toe wrong, because he felt a sharp pain in his toe as well.

He looked up at the sky with a grimace as his back felt a chill of pain.

The coldness of the fierce blizzard hit his cheek.

He had no way to escape anymore.

As he lay on the ground and sensed that, he gave up trying to resist.

At that moment,

-Khehehehehheehee

-Khehehehheehee

-Kheeheehee

-Kheeeeeee

A deafening laughter erupted one after another.

It was a noise of a different intensity than before. It shook John's hearing directly.

He covered his ears with both hands to block out the sound.

But when it didn't stop, John's face turned pale and he screamed loudly.

“Aaaaaaaaah!”

-Kheheh

As he writhed in pain, John lost consciousness.

It was thirty minutes after he started hearing the laughter.

Chapter 146: The Voice of God (2)

Chapter 146: The Voice of God (2)

The skill <Voice> that I tried for a day was not bad at all.

It consumed a lot of mana, but it had no cooldown, so I could use it continuously.

Also, the filtering of the divine translator did not apply in many cases, depending on the situation.

For example, when the target was not my follower.

When I used it on any character last night, laughter sounds passed through easily.

“The characters’ reactions were more fun than I thought.”

I could also use it as a TTS that played specific sounds depending on the situation.

It was an experience that I gained by playing only laughter sounds for more than 10 minutes against one character.

Of course, the character who heard the laughter ran away in fear and fainted.

How could he make such a fuss over hearing laughter for a while?

It was fun to watch the characters’ reactions as they were intense.

“Maybe there are more useful places than just communication.”

Depending on how I used it, there might be other uses besides communicating with the characters.

Of course, in most cases, I would use it simply for communication.

For now, I wanted to watch and test the skill's performance a few more times.

I moved the screen around to find a target for further experiments with the <Voice> skill.

Swish.

As I moved the screen with my finger, I saw a farmer cleaning up the straw.

“Hmm...”

I decided to target the farmer and cleared my throat.

I wanted to smooth my throat a little before recording my voice.

I tried to speak as close as possible to the output of the translator every time I used the <Voice> skill.

I didn't know if my efforts were paying off, but the frequency of changing the content was gradually decreasing.

“Run away.”

After clearing my throat completely, I pressed the button to record my voice.

Click.

As soon as I pressed the button, the recorded file started to be converted by the divine translator.

I set the target next to the farmer and played the sound towards him.

The farmer looked up at the sky as a voice came out of the speaker.

– “Run away.”

– “Aaaah!”

He was startled by the sound that echoed while he was cleaning up the straw, and threw away his pitchfork.

He looked around, trembling.

The farmer’s eyes were filled with fear as he clung to the wall.

I gave him a word.

“Doom... is coming...”

– “A storm is approaching.”

“What storm all of a sudden?”

I was puzzled by the strange content, but I faithfully followed what the translator said.

Squeak.

I pressed the skill icon and activated <Weather Control: Storm>.

As soon as the skill was activated, a storm came and it started to rain.

– You used <Weather Control: Storm>.

– The effect of <Weather Control> lasts for one day.

– “Ah, aah! The storm... The storm is really coming!”

The farmer looked outside in panic as the wind blew.

Crash!

A lightning bolt struck down with a creepy thunder.

The farmer leaned against the wall, shaking, as lightning fell in front of his eyes.

He had a hard time regaining his senses as the storm raged with the voice.

– “What... What is this!”

There was a faint moisture in the eyes of the frightened farmer.

He felt like he would run outside at any moment if I teased him a little more.

I gave him one last word that would nail him down.

“Run if you want to live.”

– “Run. Until death can’t find you.”

– “Sa, save me! Aaaah!”

As soon as my last word was translated, the farmer ran away with straw on his body.

It was a funny sight to see him running for his life with a terrified face.

I had no intention of harming him even if he didn’t run away.

I watched him go and decided to find one more target for the last time.

It was boring to just run away, so I wanted to change my repertoire this time.

“Then... Is there any character that looks expensive?”

I started to look for the next character to play with by quickly flipping through the screen.

This time, I hoped for someone higher than a farmer.

As I flipped through the screen with that thought, there was a big castle nearby.

The majestic and huge castle was the first place I encountered in this game.

As I passed the walls and entered the inside of the castle, I saw the splendidly built inner castle.

“This must be a lord’s castle... Then he must be a noble.”

In the courtyard of the inner castle, there was a character walking alone.

He looked like a noble at first glance.

But his face also had a somewhat shabby feel to it.

It was funny to say this to an NPC, but he still looked very noble.

– “How boring.”

Thud.

The young man who was training with his sword threw it to the ground.

I was also bored at that time, so I decided to give him some excitement in his ear.

Squeak.

I moved my finger and clicked on the <Voice> skill icon, and recorded what I wanted to say to the character in front of me.

Of course, I just picked any words that looked cool and spat them out.

“Fight.”

– “Defy your fate.”

I frowned at the amazing translation quality, and used the skill right next to the young man.

He swung his sword around as he heard the voice ringing towards him.

He seemed to be looking for me who spoke to him.

– “Who are you? Show yourself.”

Of course, nothing would come out even if he swung his sword around.

I made up a plausible sentence while expecting his next reaction.

It was also a plausible nonsense that I heard somewhere.

“You have to find your true self.”

– “Face the truth.”

– “This voice... Is it a god? Or a devil? Who am I talking to?”

The young man still spoke with a hostile attitude.

He was very noble indeed.

I ignored his attitude and continued to say anything.

“Grow.”

– “Surpass yourself.”

“Go out and win.”

– “Seize victory.”

– “Victory? What do you mean by victory? Fate? Or...”

It was the divine translator that gave me more nonsense with an amazing translation.

Now I needed one last sentence to end this conversation.

A single sentence that would be more shocking than all the nonsense I said so far.

I opened my mouth and said something that seemed to be the most dangerous in the continent.

I thought the translator would fix it if there was any problem.

“I will make you an emperor.”

— “I will make you an emperor.”

And, as the last word came out of my mouth.

The translator stopped translating my words.

* * * * *

Zedo.

The heart of the empire, located in the center, and the hub of all the departments and technologies of the empire.

In the noble district of Zedo, there was a mansion built with a lavish scale.

A building that could be called a small palace without exaggeration, where the exiled emperor resided.

The second prince. Aicliffe Rogasion.

Also known as, the troublemaker Aicliffe.

That was the name that the world called the second prince Aicliffe.

“Damn them...”

He was already famous for being a troublemaker, and also notorious for being cruel with his hands.

He was so out of favor with the emperor that he was kicked out of the palace and lived in a mansion owned by the royal family.

He had been living with some restraint since he was confined to the mansion, but Aicliffe was not happy with his situation.

Aicliffe had a high succession rank that did not match his power.

He thought he would try to prolong his life by pretending to be insane, but that was now a hopeless story.

He had fallen out of favor with the emperor, after all.

“What’s the point of training this sword every day? I can’t even use it right away.”

Tsk.

Aicliffe threw away the wooden sword he was holding.

It was something that a knight who trained him gave him, and he kept holding it even after the knight left, saying he would loosen up his body.

But now his body was more irritated than relaxed.

Thump. Roll roll.

Aicliffe left the wooden sword bouncing on the floor and looked for his guard knight who was nowhere to be seen.

He didn’t know what kind of trick he had played, but now even the royal guard knight was slacking off.

“...Renglos.”

Aicliffe’s mouth uttered his brother’s name.

The third prince, Renglos Rogasion.

The son of the current empress and a clever person who was rumored to be smart.

He must have been behind this.

He seemed to intend to keep draining Aicliffe's power for a while.

Even if he didn't use this method, Aicliffe was far from the emperor's throne.

If he continued like this, he would not even be tolerated alive, and they would try to kill him who would become a hindrance.

“...”

It was a situation where a person born with the royal bloodline lived a worse life than a beast and died.

Aicliffe bit his lips as he lamented his fate.

As Aicliffe clenched his fist in meditation, a strange voice came to his ear.

It was a strange man's voice that came to Aicliffe's ear.

— “Defy your fate.”

A short but powerful word.

Aicliffe quickly picked up his wooden sword as he heard it.

It was a voice he had never heard before as Aicliffe.

There must have been an unfamiliar intruder in the courtyard of the mansion.

He wondered if they had already sent an assassin.

Aicliffe admired Renglos' bold move and looked for the assassin hiding somewhere.

“...Who are you? Show yourself.”

He slowly moved the tip of his wooden sword and tried to sense the enemy's presence.

Of course, Aicliffe had a low chance of winning against a skilled assassin.

But he chose to resist until the end because his life was too precious to die like this.

He had to face the end that suited the royal bloodline even if it was his last moment.

He couldn't end his life in a miserable way by hiding from the assassin's dagger and running away.

‘Is it in the bushes? Or behind the pillar?’

Aicliffe scanned the roof and the pillars with his eyes.

But he still couldn't see the assassin.

As he tensed up at the sight of the invisible enemy, a strange voice rang out again.

– “Face the truth.”

‘Face the truth?’

He stopped his hand at the words of the unfamiliar voice.

All the words that had been conveyed so far were extraordinary.

Defy your fate. And face the truth.

It was an ambiguous expression.

There was a possibility of interpreting it dangerously either way.

It was an expression that would offend either the temple or the palace.

It was not something that an assassin who came to kill him would say.

“Are you a god? Or a devil? Who... am I talking to?”

Aicliffe thought of two possibilities for the being whose name he didn't even know.

A god who pitied him.

Or a devil who came to tempt him.

Either way, it was not a normal situation.

He was on edge as he heard the next words from the other side.

– “Surpass yourself.”

– “Seize victory.”

The other side kept urging him to do something.

Struggle. Grow. And win.

Who should he win against?

For what?

Aicliffe's mind spun furiously.

But he couldn't even guess what it meant.

“Victory? What do you mean by victory? Fate? Or...”

He needed a clearer word.

The being who was neither an assassin nor his enemy had to explain all the words so far.

And fortunately, the other side explained everything easily.

With just one word.

It was enough for Aicliffe to accept all the words so far with this one word.

The most dangerous word in the world echoed in Aicliffe's ear.

– “I will make you an emperor.”

Everything made sense with that word.

Who he had to face.

What he had to fight against.

Where he had to win.

All those things were summed up in one sweet word.

“Emperor...”

A familiar but strange word.

A word he had realized and given up in his childhood.

Emperor.

Aicliffe uttered the sweet word from his lips.

It was an attractive word no matter how many times he repeated it.

And that's why, finally, Aicliffe succumbed to the power of that word.

“Ah, aah... I understand.”

A magical word that would make even a rat crawling in the back alley open his eyes wide.

That word was waiting for him.

Enemy. Who was Aicliffe's enemy?

He had to fight against those who controlled the heart of the empire.

But he was not afraid to fight them now.

"I don't care who you are. Please make me an emperor..."

The troublemaker of the imperial family, Aicliffe Rogasion.

He wanted to be an emperor.

Chapter 147: The Voice of God (3)

Chapter 147: The Voice of God (3)

On the other side of the smartphone screen.

I couldn't help but be stunned by the sight of the guy who stuck his wooden sword into the ground and made a strange expression.

I had only spouted some nonsense a few times, but he was looking up at the sky with impressed eyes.

He looked like he was sincerely fascinated by something.

He was a character who showed a reaction that was five times more intense than I expected.

“What’s wrong with you? Why are you acting like this all of a sudden?”

The noble character who looked up at the sky with moist eyes.

He kept mumbling something to me, as if he was the tragic protagonist of some drama who had a twisted fate.

Whether I was a god or a devil, or something worse than that. The story he had been guessing my identity on his own did not continue.

Instead, he just set the mood with a meaningful expression.

A speech bubble popped up over his head, who was looking at the sky and pondering.

-“Ah, ah... I understand.”

“What did you figure out?”

I didn't know what it was, but he was someone who managed to figure out something on his own.

I didn't know what he had guessed, but he didn't seem like a normal character either.

That's because I had also figured out something I didn't know on my own.

As I made an awkward expression while looking at him talking nonsense, his determined words continued.

-“I don't care if you are a god or a devil, or something more than that.”

“...”

-“Please make me an emperor...”

He wanted to be an emperor.

That single-mindedness was conveyed to me through his eyes.

And as if to put a period on his story so far, he added one more word to me with a significant meaning.

-“I will dedicate this whole country to you.”

Right after his last words ended.

Ding.

A new message appeared at the bottom of the screen.

The message displayed in the message box informed me of the birth of a new fanatic.

-[Aicliffe Rogasion] has become a fanatic.

Aiccliffe Rogasion.

That was the name of the character who had become a new fanatic.

I looked at him for a moment, who had stuck his sword into the ground.

The character who fluttered his golden hair was a typical noble-like appearance.

“...”

The story I had just told him was nothing more than a joke to mess with him.

It was not my concern if an ambitious character jumped in like a moth and burned himself alone.

However, it was a different story if such a character became a fanatic.

I was not a cruel person who would push away a character who clung to me.

Especially if the target was someone who could benefit me.

“An emperor...”

I recalled the continent that I had seen many times in my head.

This game was based on the relationships that were formed by the interactions between the characters.

Depending on my intervention, I could also change the relationships between the characters.

Then, would it be possible to make one character an emperor in this game?

I couldn't easily come to a conclusion on this new dilemma.

“How strong is an emperor?”

I had no memory of meeting an emperor before.

The ones I had hunted were either affiliated with a place called Cloud, or belonged to the temple and opposed the cult.

But most of them had performance that suited their roles.

The character who was called an emperor would not be much different from that category.

Either the emperor himself was a very powerful character, or he had a pattern of summoning other characters under the pretext of escorting him.

Then, could I capture the emperor character and make this guy an emperor?

“Is he in the area that I can enter? Or else...”

I didn’t know.

It was still hard to make a decision.

Even in the game, the area where I could move the screen was limited.

Most of them were influenced by the <Eye of the Observer> skill, and even if the level increased, there were many cases where the area did not expand in a certain direction.

No matter how much the <Eye of the Observer> grew, the screen did not move beyond the border of the empire.

To find out more, I had to send apostles to do the work.

“Well, he’s probably in a place that I can’t access.”

I wouldn’t know for sure until I checked it myself, but it was likely that the space where the emperor was also could not be directly observed.

In the end, it was a matter that would keep the apostles busy.

It would take quite a long time to make Aicliffe, who was in front of me, an emperor.

I had to invest the cult's manpower and resources for that, and spend time continuously.

-“Please make me an emperor.”

But there was a certain charm in the word emperor.

Wouldn't it be fun?

A story of an unknown force that secretly rules the empire.

To weave a story with my own hands among the characters who live ordinary lives.

Princess Maker... no, King God Emperor Maker.

“Let's try to make one. An emperor.”

I felt a surge of interest in my chest as I watched Aicliffe.

A future where all the characters of the empire become believers and offer karma.

How strong would the cult be then?

My lips curled up slightly as I imagined a golden future in my head.

-I used <Lightning Arrow>.

Crash!

A lightning bolt struck and electrocuted a suspicious character who was hiding on the roof.

I knocked down the character who was aiming his bow at Aicliffe, and turned my gaze back to him.

I had found a toy to make into an emperor.

I couldn't just leave him to die by some unknown assassin.

"I have to tell Roan first, though."

The emperor-making led by the cult.

Of course, Roan would be the one who would spearhead this operation.

Now that I had <Voice> magic, I didn't need to go through Utenia to deliver the message.

I decided to try to make an emperor and started to move the screen to find Roan in the cult.

"...I never thought I'd meet you like this."

A back alley of a deserted island.

There, Van Krite, who wore a hood over his head, opened his mouth.

He had made a name for himself as a special investigator of Cloud, but now he had withdrawn his hand from the hunt for black magicians even within Cloud.

His behavior was due to the experience he had during the Abyss hunt.

The abyss.

A space of nothingness where only monsters that greedily devour everything like jaws exist.

Van had lost his heart while fighting a demon who called himself Arcrosis in the abyss.

"I thought I'd never see you again in my life."

Now he had forgotten even the sound of his heart beating, and he was just living day by day waiting for his death.

But that's what he thought.

Arcrosis, who seemed to ignore him, finally gave Van an order.

To meet the man in front of him and help him.

And the man in front of Van now was a very familiar face to him.

“Long time no see. The Second Apostle, Evan Allemier.”

The Second Apostle. Evan Allemier.

He was the one who had blocked the hunting party in the Kueberg hunt.

He had shown a sight of stalling for time alone against the heroes.

Of course, he didn't seem to have the ability to take down three heroes by himself, but he was at a level that could easily handle one hero.

Van scanned Evan's appearance, who wore a hood like himself.

“What business do you have with a loser who was defeated by you?”

He had come to the island wearing a hood, so he must have had something to do with the island.

What were those evil cult bastards trying to do on the island?

As Van looked at Evan with a crooked gaze, Evan took out a cigarette and put it in his mouth.

Tick. A black lightning bolt sprang from his gauntlet and lit the cigarette.

With a cigarette in his mouth, emitting smoke, Evan slowly opened his mouth to Van.

“Today, I’m going to deal with the empire’s business.”

“Are you trying to tell me to drop the investigation related to the cult?”

“I’ve already given up on the investigation of the black magicians. I don’t expect anything more.”

Hoo. Thick cigarette smoke spewed from Evan’s mouth.

Van clicked his tongue at the sight of Evan smoking a cigarette.

Lighting a cigarette with lightning from his gauntlet.

It was a very strange sight to see.

“Then what do you want?”

“There’s someone in the empire who needs you.”

“Needs me?”

“To be precise, not just you, but all the promising talents in the empire.”

It was hard for Van to understand what Evan was saying.

Why would they need people like him?

Unless they were planning to commit a crime in the empire, why would they need such manpower?

As Van was pondering over this, Evan, who was staring at the back of the alley, added another word.

“The guest will be here soon.”

“A guest? What are you talking about?”

“You’ll see. He’s someone you know better than me, who stayed in the borderlands.”

As soon as Evan's words ended, half of his cigarette burned, something started to feel in the back alley.

Thud. Thud.

Van's eyes turned to where the sound of footsteps echoed in the alley.

A burly young man appeared in front of them, casting a dark shadow.

He also wore a hood deep over his head like the two of them.

"You finally arrived."

"I was a bit late because I had to avoid annoying eyes. Who's that?"

Evan greeted the 'guest' who had come to them.

But the guest's eyes were on Van.

Evan briefly introduced him to the guest who was watching Van.

It was a short story that didn't need any more simple introductions.

"He works for Cloud. He might be helpful to you in the future."

"So, nice to meet you. I'm Aicliffe Rogasion."

Swish.

The guest who had lifted his hood extended his hand to Van and spoke.

Behind the hood that was pushed back, golden hair fluttered.

Aicliffe Rogasion.

Van chewed on his name as he saw the guest introduce himself.

Rogasion. Rogasion. It was a word that felt strangely familiar.

"Rogasion...!"

Van realized the identity of that familiarity belatedly and knelt down.

Rogasion was a surname that only the noble bloodline that led the empire could have.

The fact that he had Rogasion as his surname meant one thing.

Aicliffe Rogasion was the prince of the empire.

The notorious troublemaker prince of the island was standing in front of Van's eyes.

"Special investigator Van Krite. It's an honor to meet you, Your Highness."

As Van bowed to the prince, Aicliffe made a troubled expression and waved his hand.

It was a gesture to stop the conspicuous courtesy.

At Aicliffe's appearance, Van slowly got up.

Aicliffe, who had approached Van, patted his shoulder and said.

"Since we came out quietly, there's no need to be so formal."

"As you wish, Your Highness. But what brings you here..."

"All great causes start in a quiet place."

"...Ah."

Van guessed the meaning of Aicliffe's words.

The Second Prince Aicliffe had joined the cult.

And he had promised to receive full support from the apostle.

If the emperor found out that the prince had joined the cult of the evil god, it would be a matter of great anger.

“Forgive me for asking, but are you with him?”

If he knew the emperor, it wouldn't be strange if he cut off the prince's neck.

That's why Van asked Aicliffe a difficult question.

Evan smiled faintly at Van's question and nodded slightly.

His answer was not what Van expected.

“The great one has chosen me as the new emperor.”

“Is that so...”

“So I decided to follow his will and become an emperor.”

It was a seditious story that would make the royal knights furious.

There was no mercy for a traitor, even if he was a prince.

But Aicliffe calmly told such a story as if nothing was wrong.

He had clearly made up his mind already.

And on top of that, he confidently laid out his plan.

“Listen. I will build the largest altar in this country. And I will make them praise him gloriously every day.”

“Is that your will, Your Highness?”

“So, Van Krite. I hope you can help me with my great undertaking.”

Emperor.

A glorious position that everyone looked up to.

The prince who was intoxicated by his longing for it had lost his rational judgment.

The temple would turn him into an enemy. The emperor would be angry and point his sword at him.

Aicliffe's decision was that dangerous.

Of course, Van's answer to the prince's proposal was already decided from the beginning.

"I will follow your will, Your Highness."

Van could only answer positively.

He had no choice since he had lost his heart's beat.

Chapter 148: Domain of the Evil God (1)

Domain of the Evil God (1)

It was the season of high skies and fat horses.

Under the clear autumn sky, my bank account was drying up without a trace.

It was no wonder, since I had been spending a lot lately.

In the corner of my room, there were stacks of ramen boxes and bundles of bottled water.

Along with them, there were also rows of canned goods that were quite pricey.

They were the items I bought because of the news that created tension over the situation in Africa.

Of course, the fact that the online mall was having a huge discount was also one of the reasons for my impulsive consumption.

“Well... I’ll eat them all someday.”

Maybe it was just a short-lived fuss by the people and it would end soon.

If that was the case, these items would slowly go into my stomach.

They were food items, so I could use them somehow if I needed to.

As long as there was no sudden big expense, I thought I could survive for a while without any problem.

The overdraft account that I opened without much thought also had a lot left until the sign changed, so to speak.

“If it doesn’t work out, I’ll just eat ramen like last month.”

I leaned back on the soft mattress and picked up my smartphone.

I had finished sorting out the deliveries, so now I was thinking of playing some games.

Tap.

As I touched the loading screen and moved to the game screen, the messages that piled up last night came into my view first.

There were a lot of messages in the message box today.

“What? I leveled up again.”

Maybe it was because I used a karma double coupon once and collected a lot of karma in the meantime.

Before I knew it, my player level had gone up.

Unfortunately, because I had consecutively selected apostles, I didn’t have much karma left.

I scrolled down and checked the changes that occurred as my level increased.

-You have reached level 12.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.11)> has grown.

-<Eye of the Observer (Lv.12)> has been achieved. You can observe the continent with a clearer vision than before.

As my player level increased, <Eye of the Observer> reached level 12.

Despite the growth of <Eye of the Observer>, there was no noticeable big change.

It happened sometimes, so I shrugged it off and scrolled down further.

-Warning: Excessively biased karma in one direction may trigger <Causality Adjustment>.

-<Balance of Karma> has tilted.

-<Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Ascalon] has been liberated by one stage.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Hieroglyph] has been liberated by one stage.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Clausolas] has been liberated by one stage.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Astra] has been liberated by one stage.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: ■■■■] has been liberated by one stage.

-Due to <Hero Selection>, [Artifact: Dainsleif] has been liberated by one stage.

-Causality Adjustment Progress: 25%

Next, there was information about <Causality Adjustment>.

Before I knew it, causality adjustment had reached 25%.

I had collected a lot of karma in a short time, and on top of that, I used [Contract of Regression].

It would have been strange if the causality adjustment rate didn't increase.

Of course, as a result, more bosses had grown than before.

“Today's messages are long.”

Among the messages that said artifacts had been liberated, there were two that caught my eye.

One was an artifact with a broken name.

I couldn't tell whose artifact it was, as the name was not properly displayed.

And below that, there was an artifact with a familiar name.

“Why are you getting stronger with them?”

The liberation of [Artifact: Dainsleif] according to <Hero Selection>.

In other words, it meant that Peter had also grown stronger as the enemies did.

I didn't have any skills with the same name, so it was right to think that Peter was actually one of the boss monsters.

Did I tame a boss monster then?

The appearance of Peter, who had been riding a horse, suddenly looked different.

“You're more impressive than I thought.”

He was a hero who hid his identity and rode a horse.

He was not an ordinary horseman, but a high-class one.

Anyway, it was fortunate that he joined our side.

I thought I should be less harsh on him next time I see him.

As I changed my perception of Peter and scrolled down a bit more, I saw a message with an unexpected content.

-You have acquired <Sanctuary Declaration: Lograshion>.

-<Sanctuary Declaration: Lograshion> is a skill that creates a sanctuary that temporarily strengthens your influence.

-<Sanctuary Declaration: Lograshion> has a 3-day cooldown.

<Sanctuary Declaration: Lograshion>.

It was a message that said I had acquired a new type of skill.

As if to prove the content of the message, a new icon appeared at the bottom of the screen.

It seemed to be a reward for leveling up.

I tapped the case of my smartphone and wondered about the name of the new skill.

“Sanctuary Declaration...”

I was somewhat familiar with the name itself.

It was no wonder, since it was a phrase that the guys who spammed me with sight-obstruction patterns often used.

The guys who blocked my sight would say ‘sanctuary declaration’ every time they activated the pattern.

Then this skill might be similar to the pattern they used.

“Let’s check it out once.”

Would it have the same effect as theirs, blocking the sight?

I had to see it for myself to know the details.

I touched the skill icon of the new skill and opened the detailed description page.

And I started to read slowly from the top of the description of the new skill.

-<Sanctuary Declaration: Lograshion (Lv.MAX)>

-Within the range of <Sanctuary>, long-distance teleportation magic is blocked due to coordinate distortion.

-Within the range of <Sanctuary>, divine power output is reduced by 50%.

-Within the range of <Sanctuary>, magic output is reduced by 25%.

-Within the range of <Sanctuary>, mana consumption is increased by 100%.

-Within the range of <Sanctuary>, some effects of holy relics are blocked.

-Within the range of <Sanctuary>, recovery ability is reduced by 50%.

-Within the range of <Sanctuary>, physical and regenerative abilities of demons are increased by 50%.

-<Eye of the Observer> is not nullified within the range of <Sanctuary>.

The detailed description of the newly acquired Sanctuary Declaration was much longer than the skills I had before.

It was the length that I would only see in equipment items with complex restrictions.

But <Sanctuary Declaration: Lograshion> filled most of that length with valid effects.

The more I looked, the more absurd the effects were.

As I continued to read the description, I understood why the bosses used Sanctuary Declaration whenever they had a chance.

“What is this... What the hell is this?”

I read the skill description again from the top.

But no matter how many times I read it, the text on the screen did not change.

I touched the icon of <Sanctuary Declaration: Lograshion> with a blank face.

Teleportation magic block.

Divine power penalty.

Magic penalty.

Mana consumption increase.

Holy relic block.

Recovery ability decrease.

Demon ability increase.

They were all effects that could give the bosses a shitty experience.

On the other hand, they were effects that had almost no negative impact on the apostles.

“This is really... unbelievable...”

To raise the player’s level, I had to accept the growth of the enemies.

That's why I thought <Paid Currency Shop> was the most efficient way to grow.

I thought I could catch up with them to some extent with the items I got from the gacha, even though <Apostle Selection> had a great merit.

But today, my thoughts changed completely.

It was because of the skill I got this time.

“...”

Sanctuary, Lograshion.

I was a god within the sanctuary.

In one corner of Crossbridge, there is a temple dedicated to the goddess of harmony.

Harmony. It was the most important and most difficult concept for humans.

What kind of life could say that it practiced the teachings of harmony?

The priests who belonged to the temple of harmony always lived with such a question in their hearts.

The priest, Lexion, who was facing the intruders in the temple, was also someone who always kept that question in his heart.

“Why is there still no contact from the temple?”

And now, as he faced the elder who was interrogating him about the hero, Lexion had a few more questions in his mind.

What did the goddess of harmony want from him by giving him this trial?

Could it be that this imbalance was also part of her desired harmony?

He felt a blasphemous doubt rising in his chest as he thought.

Of course, those were all locked in his heart, and he could not utter them out loud.

He just swallowed his complaints and did his role steadfastly.

“Don’t you know? The hero of this era has not received any artifact yet...”

“He hasn’t received any artifact yet? What can a hero do without an artifact?”

The elder sneered at Lexion’s words.

It was an annoying story.

But it was also a hard one to refute.

The hero of harmony had not received any artifact for months.

The hero seemed to not care about that fact, but it was a hard situation for those who belonged to the temple.

Especially every time he went to report this to the council of elders, Lexion felt his blood drying up.

How could he confidently say that the hero had no artifact?

Ever since the saintess brought the hero to the temple, the elders had been constantly criticizing the temple of harmony.

“But, this hero is special...”

“I’ve heard that this hero is special. But that doesn’t mean he has an excuse for not having an artifact.”

“No, that’s...”

“Shouldn’t you at least get a divine trust and report it?”

Sigh.

A sigh escaped from Lexion's mouth.

It was a well-known fact that the temple had not received any divine trust for a long time.

And they were picking on him for that.

The more he looked, the more nauseous he felt.

Lexion repeated the words he had said many times and clenched his fist hidden by his robe.

“Why are you doing this? The lack of divine trust has been reported several times at the council...”

“Isn't that because of the saintess's lack of faith?”

“What did you just say? Do you want to fight with our temple?”

“Are you saying that the goddess of harmony deliberately withheld the divine trust if it's not because of the saintess's lack of faith? That's really an irreverent way of thinking.”

“Enough! Even if you're an elder, there's a limit!”

The voices of the elder and Lexion rose at the front of the temple.

The other priests who were working in the temple frowned and looked at them.

The elder ignored the priests' eyes and continued to spew unpleasant words.

As a sharp tension was about to arise between the elder and the temple.

The elder's face changed as he spat out insulting words at Lexion.

“Co, cough...!”

“El, elder...?”

“Cough... Sa, save me...”

The elder grabbed his throat and shouted with a pale face.

He couldn't breathe, and his face turned pale.

The subordinate who was behind him quickly approached him and tried to use divine power.

But even as he grabbed his throat, the elder's eyes were looking somewhere in the corner.

Thud. Thud.

At the same time as the rough sound of shoes echoed, a girl in elegant clothes appeared from the corner of the temple.

“Do you think an artifact is necessary for a hero? I don't think so.”

Her navy hair fluttered in the wind.

A white line of hair parted her side bangs.

She was a presence that captivated everyone's attention with her slow steps.

Lexion took in the unfamiliar appearance of the girl he had faced many times.

She brushed her flying hair with her slender fingers, and watched the elder who was choking and struggling.

A strong killing intent poured out of her golden eyes as she glared at the elder.

The dense killing intent stiffened the air around her, and even disrupted the breathing of those who looked at her.

“Nai... ah... sa, save me...”

“If you’re just a being swayed by a single weapon, you’re nothing without it, right?”

The girl spoke in a different tone from within her domain.

The hero of harmony, Naias.

She was a dragon.

Chapter 149: Domain of the Evil God (2)

Chapter 149: Domain of the Evil God (2)

“Hmm.”

The Duke of Colt lifted his wine glass and muttered in a dissatisfied voice.

His gaze was directed at Aicliffe, who was conversing with people far away.

The second prince, Aicliffe Rogasion.

He was notorious for being a troublemaker in the Empire.

He knew his place, so he always acted as if he didn't want anyone to bother him.

He showed that he was completely different from the first or the third prince.

‘But things have changed a lot lately.’

But recently, Aicliffe had been more active than before.

He had a separate seat with the Duke of Nineglow, who had visited the Empire, and he participated in every major event in the Empire.

He even gathered promising young men from the Empire and held private meetings at his mansion.

The purpose of the meeting led by Aicliffe was clear to anyone.

He wanted to build his own power base and take over the whole Empire later.

‘Has he started to show interest in the throne?’

It was a behavior that could only be seen if he had an interest in the throne.

He had clearly chosen a dangerous path for himself.

It would have been better for him to side with the third prince if he wanted to beg for his life.

The Duke of Colt couldn’t understand why he was risking his life for a reckless challenge.

It was a hopeless fight to start now.

The big shots like the Duke of Colt had already made their bets.

“This is not good.”

That was the situation right now.

For the other princes as well.

And for the Duke of Colt, who supported the third prince, Renglos.

A troublesome variable had emerged, which meant that he had to recalculate the situation again.

Aicliffe himself would not win, but he could act as something that would disrupt the balance among the princes.

As he sipped his wine glass, the Earl of Eifeld, who was behind him, spoke to him.

“Lately, Prince Aicliffe seems to be very busy.”

“Is that so?”

“He meets with promising young people from the Empire and asks for their teachings. His Majesty must be very pleased.”

“There will be no more rumors of him being a troublemaker.”

The duke put down his wine glass and looked at the earl with a smile.

The earl liked to chatter about trivial things by himself.

Normally, the duke would have ignored him, but today he was interested in Prince Aicliffe.

The duke listened to the earl’s words and waited for his next story.

As if he understood the duke’s thoughts, the earl continued to talk about the prince.

“The past is just the past. It’s time for the prince’s reputation to change now.”

“Hmm.”

“Recently, he even said that he had a teacher who he followed around to learn from.”

“He has a teacher?”

The duke turned his gaze to the earl at the unexpected story.

Aicliffe was known for rejecting studies and causing trouble.

And now he had a teacher who he followed around and asked for guidance.

He didn’t know what prompted him, but he had definitely changed.

“Yes. These days, he goes everywhere with his teacher.”

“That’s quite interesting.”

“He must have attended this place today. Ah... there he is. The woman with the black hood.”

The earl pointed his finger at a woman in a corner of the hall.

A woman with a deep hood was quietly eating cake in a corner.

She didn't seem to be a famous person in the Empire, judging by her hidden face.

Such a person was the prince's teacher.

The duke smiled faintly at the earl's story.

“I wonder what kind of person she is that the prince asks for her teachings.”

“Unfortunately, there is not much known about that teacher.”

“She wouldn't be hiding in the corner like that if she was a reputable person...”

“But there must be something outstanding about her if the prince asks for her teachings...”

The duke stroked his beard with a relaxed hand at the earl's words that implied there was something to learn from her.

The duke had a different opinion from the earl.

The position of someone's teacher had a strong influence on the learner in some way.

That's why the royal family had their own verification process when they brought a teacher for a prince who was not of age.

But the prince had chosen someone who looked inexperienced as his teacher.

It was as if he had something disguised as a teacher.

“Do you think so, earl?”

“For now, yes.”

“If the earl, who knows the Empire well, thinks so, then I should think so too.”

“Haha, thank you.”

The earl lifted his wine glass with a smile at the duke’s words that seemed to acknowledge him.

Of course, that was just what he said out loud.

In the duke’s mind, there was another calculation going on.

Aicliffe, who had no foundation, had a low chance of moving like that for no reason.

Someone had put a wind in the prince’s ear.

And the one who put the wind in his ear was, probably...

‘That writer who calls herself a teacher.’

There were forces that wanted to benefit from the prince’s movement.

And the one who connected those forces and the prince was that person who called herself a teacher.

Finding out the identity of the force hiding behind the teacher would be the biggest weapon to decide the next emperor.

The duke came to a conclusion in his mind and got up from his seat.

Clank.

The earl asked the duke as he put down his wine glass.

“Are you leaving already? Was my story boring...?”

“No, your story was helpful, earl. I’m just feeling a bit tired today. I think I should go ahead.”

“I see. I hope to see you again when you’re in a good mood.”

The duke exchanged a brief farewell with the earl and started to leave the banquet hall.

As he stepped out of the hall’s door, his eyes were still fixed on the woman with the hood.

The duke’s mansion in the Empire.

There, the duke was looking at a paper with a thoughtful face.

The paper in the duke’s hand was the trend of Prince Aicliffe that he had bought from the information guild.

Snicker.

The duke lifted his lips as he read the information on the paper.

The information provided by the information guild contained things that the duke had never expected.

“You seem to have some fun, sir.”

The knight, Scollaus, who was polishing his sword in front of the duke, spoke with a witty smile.

Scollaus was that kind of person.

He listened to the duke’s orders faithfully, but he was also very annoying.

But the duke still valued him.

It was enough for him to have a dog that listened to his words well.

“I did have some fun.”

“What was it?”

“It seems that Aicliffe wants to be the emperor.”

Scollaus stopped polishing his sword and showed curiosity when he heard the duke’s story.

The story of Aicliffe, the troublemaker, was quite famous in the Empire.

Scollaus was not ignorant of Aicliffe’s story.

“Are you talking about that troublemaker? That’s indeed interesting.”

“It’s amusing. I wonder how he changed so much when he knew his place.”

“Well, he’s still a troublemaker anyway. He won’t become the next emperor.”

The duke agreed with that story.

Aicliffe could never be the emperor.

But Aicliffe’s actions shouldn’t interfere with Renglos becoming the emperor.

He needed to get rid of anything that could cause trouble in advance.

“That’s obvious. But I have to clear away any obstacles first.”

“Are you going to do as Prince Renglos says?”

“Well. His plan is not a very good one either.”

The third prince, Renglos, was a person who insisted on killing Aicliffe whenever he had a chance.

But that was only possible when the time and situation were right.

It was not something he could do in the middle of the Empire.

It would be stupid to send an assassin to Aicliffe as Renglos suggested, but the situation was different for the writer who called herself Aicliffe's teacher.

It wouldn't matter much if something happened to her.

"Scollaus. Send someone suitable."

"Someone..."

"Aicliffe has a writer who is his teacher. We have to find out who she is."

Scollaus nodded when the duke gave him a hint.

Bring the woman who was Aicliffe's teacher to him.

That was the duke's order.

I was determined to find out who was behind the woman and what their motives were.

"I hope you can bring her quietly."

"Then we can use the Shadow Knights."

"The Shadow Knights, huh. They are a decent option, but isn't there a more proper way according to the law?"

As the conversation continued, Scollaus started to move his hand that was polishing his sword.

The blood that had been stuck on it was long gone by now.

All he had to do was apply some oil to the blade.

Scollaus moved the cloth with a relaxed gesture and answered the duke.

“Is that so? Then I’ll look for some suitable bounty hunters from the law.”

“Well, I’m sure you’ll handle it well.”

The duke gave a short reply and tapped his desk slowly with his finger.

Tap. Tap.

Every time the duke’s hand hit the desk, the flame on the candlestick flickered faintly.

Under the dim candlelight, a shadow was cast on the paper.

Who was trying to interfere with the great undertaking of the royal family?

The duke’s eyes, filled with worry, reflected Scollaus’s figure overlapped with the candlelight.

* * * * *

“A letter has arrived for Your Majesty.”

In his mansion bathed in sunlight, Aicliffie took the letter from the maid.

He then gestured to her and dismissed her from his room.

The maid obeyed Aicliffie’s order and closed the door as she left.

Squeak.

After confirming that the maid was gone, Aicliffie opened the letter with a knife.

Inside the luxurious envelope, there was an invitation for him.

“The Earl of Eifeld has invited me. He wants to host me at a modest party.”

“The Earl of Eifeld?”

The emperor’s gaze naturally turned to the girl behind him after reading the letter.

She was the teacher that the church had assigned to help me.

She always wore a black hood over her head, hiding her face.

I wondered what someone who looked younger than me could teach me, but I had no choice but to keep her by my side since she was vouched by the archbishop.

She nodded briefly after hearing Aicliffie’s words and gave him an answer.

“That sounds fine to me.”

“Then I’ll send a reply accepting the invitation.”

Since she had made up her mind, Aicliffie had no reason to refuse.

Her decisions were mostly rational, regardless of her age.

With her approval, Aicliffie took out a letter and prepared to write a response.

He wanted to convey his willingness to attend the party of the Earl of Eifeld.

“I feel tired lately because I’m so busy.”

“Well, you need to prepare for the big event.”

“Can’t you at least adjust your schedule a bit?”

She smiled faintly at his joking remark.

She chuckled and watched him, then gave him a positive answer.

“I’ll decide on that after seeing what the emperor does.”

Aicliffée’s pen moved busily as he vented his small complaint.

His handwriting was elegant, unlike his nickname of troublemaker.

She continued to talk to Aicliffée as he wrote down his words.

“You write well, though.”

“I rarely have a chance to show it off... This was the only thing I could polish.”

“That’s quite different from the rumor of being a troublemaker.”

“I needed that kind of infamy to survive. But I’ve given it all up now.”

It was a ridiculous time to be called wandering.

I was just trying to stay alive by any means.

Maybe half of it was to vent out the stress that had piled up.

When Aicliffée finished the letter and put down his pen, the teacher lifted the teacup on the saucer and said.

“It’s good to keep that mindset.”

“.....”

“Someday, you might stain your palm with your family’s blood.”

Gulp.

The teacher’s eyes, enjoying the hot tea, were not on the letter but on Aicliffée.

His ash-colored eyes, full of emotions, met with Aicliffée’s who had put down his pen.

The depth of her eyes was in stark contrast with her girlish appearance.

“This country called the empire is like that, right?”

Chapter 150: Domain of the Evil God

Chapter 150: Domain of the Evil God (3)

“Boss.”

Henggloss, a mercenary guild that hid behind the scenes of the island.

They were famous for taking on all kinds of dirty jobs on the island, and doing whatever they were asked as long as they were paid.

Of course, even Henggloss had some jobs that they preferred to avoid.

Anything related to the high nobility or the royal family was one of them.

As I listened to the boss report on the operation, I, Effe, an assassin of Henggloss, opened my mouth.

“Kidnap the prince? Are you crazy, boss?”

“Shh. It’s not the prince, it’s a woman he’s carrying around.”

“So what? That’s okay?”

It was wise not to meddle in anything involving the royal family.

Henggloss had survived until now by following that simple principle.

But today, the boss seemed to be stepping on the thin line.

I felt a chill of uneasiness as I quietly heard about the plan.

The boss seemed to understand my anxiety and added some more explanation to the other members.

“The second prince is weaker than the other princes.”

“I know he’s a fool, but still...”

“Besides, it’s not even the prince himself, but some unknown woman he’s carrying around. It won’t be easy for them to move around in the palace.”

Huff.

A deep sigh escaped from Effe’s mouth.

The success rate of this operation was not the important thing.

No matter how he thought about it, getting involved with the palace was a crazy thing to do.

The wise thing to do was to quickly drop the matter and bow down low if it had anything to do with the palace.

“And if we pull this off successfully... we’ll get a hefty amount of money.”

But the captain in front of him didn’t seem to have any intention of giving up.

It was never a good thing to be greedy.

The captain always said that, but for some reason, he looked different today.

Effe tried to say one more thing to the captain.

“Captain, I think we should reconsider this.”

“Effe. Don’t talk nonsense.”

“Captain...”

The captain had already been blinded by gold and didn't seem to have any interest in listening.

“Do you know how much money is on the line for this?”

“Money is not the important thing.”

“No. Money is the most important thing for mercenaries. Even if we take the risk, there's no other job that pays this well. We're going ahead with this operation no matter what.”

“Captain...”

“Effe. If you don't want to join this operation, you can leave.”

The eyes of the organization members all turned to Effe.

He could only scratch his head with a troubled expression.

It was a foolish act, no matter how I looked at it.

But I didn't feel like leaving the captain alone and moving on, when he was drunk on gold.

And I had a reason for that. The captain in front of me was like half of my life.

“How can I leave the captain and go by myself?”

“Right. Effe, I knew you would say that.”

“I can't stop the captain from going ahead with this, but let's be careful as much as possible.”

“I don't need you to tell me that.”

I looked at the captain with a satisfied face, as he continued to explain the plan.

It would be a happy ending for everyone if we succeeded in the operation without any problems.

But if something went wrong.

If that situation came, I had to save the captain at all costs.

Effe's eyes were filled with firm determination.

* * * * *

The noble district of the deserted island.

Effe and the members of Henggloss' organization were following behind the prince who was returning to his mansion.

The prince looked happy, as if he had drunk a lot of alcohol.

Next to him were a knight with a sword and the target, who was walking with a hood over her head.

Thud. Thud.

The captain, who was watching the prince walk with his footsteps echoing, opened his mouth in a low voice.

“Slowly. Follow them quietly. Five of you, go around and approach them from behind.”

Nod.

Some of the members who received the captain's order started to move towards the target.

Effe watched their movement and turned his eyes to the front again.

The prince's group, who had been walking towards the mansion, had stopped in their place.

Effe felt his hair stand on end at the sight of the prince who suddenly stopped.

“What’s wrong?”

The prince turned his head to the girl who wore her robe backwards.

As the prince stopped walking, the escort knight also stopped in his place.

Did the prince notice their presence?

As Effe worried about that, the girl who followed behind the prince answered him.

“You can go back first today.”

“Suddenly?”

“Yes. I have something to do.”

The prince looked puzzled at her answer.

Effe, who was eavesdropping on their conversation, felt the same way.

“Isn’t it too dangerous to move alone at night?”

“It’s okay. Nothing will happen today, even if I move by myself.”

“If you say so... I guess I have no choice.”

“Yes. So please go ahead and rest.”

The girl kept trying to send him away, and the prince reluctantly agreed.

As the prince started to go back, the escort knight followed him.

The girl was left alone as the two left.

More importantly, the escort knight, who could have been the biggest obstacle to the plan, was gone.

It was easier for Henggloss.

Effe felt a surge of joy in his heart as he looked at the girl who was left alone.

‘Maybe I can handle this quietly.’

The opponent was just a woman without a weapon.

On the other hand, they had brought famous mercenaries and a mage.

Anyone could see that Henggloss had the advantage.

But the girl seemed to have no idea what would happen to her, and she started to walk towards the alley where they were hiding.

She was walking right into the mouth of the beasts that were waiting for her.

“Hide.”

The captain ordered his men as he saw the girl approaching with her footsteps.

As soon as the captain’s gesture fell, they all hid in the cracks of the alley.

Except for Effe, who was watching everything from the roof.

Effe drew his sharp dagger and waited for the girl to come closer.

‘It was a request to bring her alive, so it would be bad if I killed her... But it should be fine as long as she doesn’t die.’

The order from the client was only to capture and imprison the girl.

He had to aim only for non-lethal spots when he swung his dagger.

“.....”

In the situation where everyone was hiding in the alley, the girl's calm footsteps reached deep into the alley.

Four steps. Three steps. Two steps.

The girl's footsteps steadily approached where the captain was hiding.

As she took the last step towards the captain.

The captain jumped out of the alley and pointed his knife at her neck.

“Don't move or you'll die.”

“.....”

“You'll die if you try anything stupid.”

The captain was known among the mercenaries in the back alley for his skill with the sword.

The girl had no chance to react to his sudden attack.

Even with a sharp knife pointed at her, she remained calm.

Her face was hidden by a black hood, and I couldn't tell what expression she was making.

“Are you the ones who have been following us?”

“Yes. If you want to live, you better come with me.”

The finely sharpened blade moved closer to her neck.

It was a situation where the knife could pierce her skin if he pushed it a little further.

She should have been scared by the sharpness of the knife, but she didn't show any reaction.

Instead, she kept a calm attitude and said something strange.

“It might be a good idea to try it for the first time.”

The captain made a disgusted face at her weird answer.

It was an incomprehensible story.

What did she mean by trying something in this place? What was she going to try?

As they wondered about that, she brought her hands together neatly.

Clap.

Two white palms met in the air.

At the same time, she seemed to be talking to someone.

“——Revere. Worship. Bow down.”

“Who are you talking to...”

But the captain's words, mixed with doubt, were cut off.

The moment he came to his senses, an unfathomable darkness engulfed them.

A huge darkness.

In the world of shadows, she moved her hand leisurely.

The captain swung his sword in a hurry at her suspicious movement.

“What are you doing!”

Clang!

The captain's sword, swung fiercely, stopped in midair.

The sword, glowing with light, was held by her hand.

It was an attack that would have cut off her hand if she had faced it barehanded.

But she grabbed his sword with her hand wrapped in shadows.

"You blocked this attack..."

The captain put more strength into his grip, but the sword that stopped in midair didn't budge.

She calmly held the sword and raised her other hand in the air.

The world of shadows that filled the surroundings swayed with her movement.

At this moment, it was clear who was ruling this world.

In the darkness that covered the world, Effe jumped down with his dagger aimed at her.

"Captain..."

He had a bad feeling.

Effe's intuition was ringing an alarm.

The girl in front of him was a monster without a doubt.

He had to deal with her before something bigger happened.

He cast a magic on his dagger that he held in his hand to imbue it with poison.

‘Enchant.’

While the captain was hesitating with his sword, her other hand kept rising up.

She raised her hand high and straightened one finger between her clenched fist.

She pointed at them with her thin finger tip.

Right after that, a gentle voice echoed from under her hood.

“Sanctuary Declaration—— Logration.”

Sanctuary Declaration.

It was a story they would never hear in their lives as they roamed the back alley.

It was the same for Effe, who was recognized as a skilled assassin.

He felt his magic that wrapped around his sword scatter.

The magic that would kill the opponent he stabbed was being dispersed by something.

Thud.

Effe, who was about to jump down at her, kicked the wall and retreated a step back.

“W-what is this...”

His magic scattered faster than it gathered.

I could still use magic somehow, but I would have to pour out more than twice as much as usual.

And even then, the magic wouldn’t be perfect.

But that wasn't the only problem.

A huge sense of exhaustion lingered in my body, and I felt my strength slowly draining away.

Effe's face hardened as he looked at the girl in front of him.

A way to suppress someone else's magic.

Effe knew a lot about all kinds of vile methods, but he had never heard of such a thing.

"You're lucky. You would have died if you had come a little closer."

Between Effe and the girl who sat down, there was a black thorn sticking out.

She was right.

If Effe had been a little slower to react, he would have been skewered by the shadow's thorn.

Effe straightened his posture and raised his dagger, ready for battle.

From his mouth, a question about the girl flowed out.

"Who are you...?"

"Are you curious?"

The girl reached out and pulled back her hood at Effe's question.

Beyond the black hood that fell, her ash-colored hair spread out in all directions.

She stood alone in the world of blackness, like a witch from a legend.

She smiled at them and opened her mouth.

“It’s a secret.”

Chapter 151: Domain of the Evil God (4)

Chapter 151: Domain of the Evil God (4)

A world of black and white, where only light and shadow existed.

In the center of it all, a girl stood, surrounded by tense mercenaries.

There was only one enemy in front of them.

But that one enemy had caused a change that affected everyone in this place.

The first ones to notice the anomaly were the magicians.

“Magicians! Hurry up and cast your magic to support the captain!”

“That’s not magic... It’s not working properly.”

“What are you talking about...?”

In the domain of the ash-colored girl, even magic power could not be used properly.

The magicians of the organization realized that as well, and they looked at each other with stiff faces.

Fizzle-.

The flames that had risen in their palms quickly died down, leaving only smoke behind.

The magic that they had honed for their entire lives had dispersed in a flash.

At this moment, this place was like hell for the magicians.

“What do you mean magic doesn’t work? I’ve never heard of such a thing!”

“Mon... Monster! That’s a monster...!”

The magicians were thrown into confusion by the sight of their powerless magic.

Magicians who could not use magic were useless on the battlefield.

One of the magicians who had been staring at the girl clenched his teeth and drew a dagger with his trembling hand.

He had chosen to fight with a dagger instead of his magic, which he had trained for his whole life.

A world of black and white, where only light and shadow existed.

In the center of it all, a girl stood, surrounded by tense mercenaries.

There was only one enemy in front of them.

But that one enemy had caused a change that affected everyone in this place.

The captain clenched his teeth and gripped his sword with more strength.

Creak. Creak.

The cracks on his sword grew bigger, and the veins on his hand holding the hilt also thickened.

“Ugh...”

His face was distorted with rage.

At that moment, his sword slowly bent in half.

He dropped his sword and drew a dagger from his thigh, aiming at the girl.

The dagger he thrust with his other hand was so fast that even a famous knight would have trouble blocking it.

“Damn you, bitch! You killed Max... Die!”

He stabbed his dagger at the target with a fierce slash.

Whoosh!

The dagger pierced something deep with a speed like a ray of light.

He felt a sensation in his fingertips that was unmistakably the feeling of cutting through flesh.

But at the same time, he also felt a burning sensation in his chest.

He looked down at the source of the pain, unable to understand what was happening.

In his lowered eyes, he saw a dagger piercing through his own chest.

“Captain!”

“Ah...”

The trajectory of the shadow’s hand was bent towards his own chest.

That was all there was to it.

He felt the cold touch of blood from his pierced chest, and blood spewed out of his mouth.

Everyone shivered at the sight of the captain who met his end by his own weapon.

An incomprehensible phenomenon was unfolding before their eyes.

“Ha... Captain...”

Effe, who was watching the captain fall, let out a short sigh.

What he saw in front of him was a monster beyond measure.

It was not hard for everyone in this place to realize the gap between them and her.

Even if they all wielded their weapons and advanced forward, they had no chance of winning.

“Captain...”

“The captain is dead! Effe! What are we going to do now!”

“Effe, we’ll all die if we keep this up!”

But there was no way to escape now.

They were surrounded by darkness.

Their entire vision was filled with dense shadows.

It was a dreamlike scene in the deep night.

If only it wasn’t the place where they would meet their doom.

They knew it was a foolish thing to look for an escape in the darkness, even without Effe telling them.

“Please, I didn’t do anything wrong! Spare me!”

“You bastard... Are you trying to betray us!”

The mercenaries of Henggloss had two choices.

They could beg for mercy on their knees.

Or they could face death and move forward.

Some of them chose to plead for their lives, but their fate was not kind.

The mercenaries who couldn't stand their comrades' betrayal swung their weapons at those who had dropped their swords.

"We'll all die if we go on like this! We can't die like this!"

"I haven't spent all the money I saved up!"

"Shut up! Death is the only thing for traitors!"

Clang!

A man's back was slashed by a mercenary's sword.

He rolled on the floor with a large wound on his back, screaming.

His scream echoed in the world of shadows, reaching everyone in this place.

"Aaah! Why are you cutting your comrades...!"

"Someone who decided to betray us is not a comrade! Die!"

"Michael! How can you cut your comrades...!"

"If you stop me, I'll kill you too! Effe! Hurry up and deal with that girl!"

The situation turned into a hellish chaos by the mercenary's attack.

The mercenaries who had aimed at the girl pointed their swords at each other, wary of anyone approaching them.

Those who had laid down their swords quickly picked them up and guarded themselves.

The mercenary who had swung his sword first didn't hesitate to keep swinging.

The girl who had trapped them watched the situation with a smile.

“How fun.”

As the wounded screamed and the river of shadows was stained with blood, the girl enjoyed it all.

Effe felt a chill run down his spine as he looked at the girl.

Some of them were begging the girl for salvation in the midst of the carnage.

A mercenary who was bleeding from his back shouted at the girl with a hoarse voice.

“We surrendered! Save us!”

He wanted her to save him because he had surrendered.

That was his logic.

It was ridiculous that he even asked her to stop his comrades' attacks.

But the girl's answer was clear.

“Why should I?”

“Why? Because we surrendered! Spare us!”

“We're still your enemies, aren't we?”

Effe had a vague idea of what the predator in front of him was thinking.

She wouldn't listen to anything he said.

She didn't care how many of them bled or how many of them submitted to her.

It would be the same even if they all stopped fighting and surrendered to her.

She would never spare them.

“It doesn't matter to me how you treat each other.”

After all, she was a monster.

The northern continent.

The Alterias region.

Philrun advanced forward with his sword in the blizzard.

What Philrun was holding out in front of him was a divine artifact given to the hero of order – Clawsolas.

He was now walking through the blizzard, using the light of Clawsolas as a lantern.

Of course, Clawsolas didn't seem to like being used as a lantern.

Philrun smiled and opened his mouth to the bright light.

“Why are you so quiet?”

-“I don't like how you're using me.”

“Don't you say we don't have much time left? Then we have to find it this way, right?”

-“...”

Clawsolas closed his mouth at Philrun's words.

Everyone in this place knew the truth.

As Philrun said, they didn't have much time left.

The thirty days that the evil god had given him to protect him were almost over, and soon he would have to fight to defend himself.

What he was doing now was preparation for that time.

He understood that this work was necessary, so Clawsolas cooperated with Philrun without complaining.

"By the way, is that true?"

Philrun wiped off the snowflakes on his cheek and brought up a topic to change the mood.

For Philrun, who had grown up as a loner, Clawsolas was something he could call a friend.

Especially when he was doing such a boring job.

It would be very dull if he kept his mouth shut until they reached their destination.

Philrun shook his sword to shake off the snow piled up on it, and Clawsolas spoke with a stronger light.

- "Are you talking about the effect of the holy relic?"

"Yeah. You said you can summon a sanctuary."

- "Yes. The candlestick of Englerd creates a temporary effect similar to a sanctuary in the surrounding area. You can create a sanctuary yourself even without a saintess."

A candlestick that creates a sanctuary.

Philrun imagined it in his head and shook his head with an awkward expression.

Thud.

The snow on his head fell to the snowfield.

Some of the snow that fell from Philrun's head stuck to his chest.

"Sanctuary. I can't imagine it."

For Philrun, the hero of order, sanctuary was not a familiar concept.

He knew that sanctuary was something amazing, but he didn't know what it was exactly.

He just thought that the goddess would do something great for him.

Clawsolas blinked his light and answered Philrun's words.

- "Sanctuary enhances the power of priests and heroes who enter it."

"Sanctuary sounds good."

- "But more importantly, it blocks the eyes of the evil god for a moment."

"It blocks the eyes of the evil god?"

Philrun looked up at the sky.

God was a being who looked down on the earth from heaven.

To block the eyes of such a god.

It was a presumptuous expression.

Anyone would have thought so if it wasn't for the evil god.

As he looked at the sky, Philrun turned his eyes back to Clawsolas, who continued to explain to him.

-“The eyes of the observer lose most of their power in the sanctuary. That’s why the existence of the saintess is considered important in facing the evil god.”

“I see. Then I have to find her, right?”

-“That’s why we’re doing this now.”

“Okay, okay. Don’t worry too much. I’ll find that holy relic for you.”

If the hidden holy relic was that important, Philrun could just find it and take it himself.

He nodded his head and hastened his steps.

He didn’t know if it was the candlestick of Gelard or Englerd, but he had to find it and take it before the evil god or other heroes did.

Whoosh. Thud.

Philrun kept walking forward in the thick blizzard.

His feet dug into the snow with every step, but he never stopped walking.

Chapter 152: Turbulence (1)

Chapter 152: Turbulence (1)

Everyone has their own goals when they play games.

Clearing all the endings.

Speedrunning faster than anyone else.

Unlocking achievements with bizarre playstyles.

Defeating boss monsters on hard difficulty.

They all set their own objectives and play the game to achieve them.

And for me, clearing the quest for the <Descent> skill was the goal of this game that I was facing right now.

“A new quest has opened.”

I muttered as I checked the newly appeared quest on the screen.

<Descent>.

It was a skill that could be acquired by clearing five quests that it required.

I didn't know what effect it had, but the quests to unlock this skill were so vicious that they could be considered as the ultimate goal of the game.

Like collecting a million karma without using any.

Or retrieving an item while avoiding a ruthless boss monster.

And now, there was one more quest added that was hard to understand its meaning.

-Every time you meet the following conditions, the progress of <Descent> will increase by one step.

-Usable karma: 1328 / 999999 (Incomplete)

-[Sacred artifact: Ergus's stake]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

-[Philosopher's stone]: 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-???: 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-Making a holy body for Descent (Incomplete)

Making a holy body for Descent.

It was not a kind of quest that I could comprehend at a glance.

However, judging by the sentence that said “making”, it seemed clear that the quest was about crafting something that I could use.

I still had doubts about the holy body, though.

“A holy body...”

I didn't know what the <Descent> skill was for.

I vaguely guessed that it might be a task to create a character that I could control myself.

But that was just a leap of logic based on the content of the quest.

I wouldn't know the exact information unless I checked it myself.

After spending so much time on this, I might be disappointed when I finally got the skill.

“But still... maybe it will be a clue to get closer to the ending as I progress?”

Nevertheless, I moved with this quest as my goal, because it was the only objective that was given to me right now.

I felt a deep interest and moved to find Yuto somewhere on the map.

The newly added quest was aimed at making something.

If I had to make something unknown, it would be better to leave it to ‘that guy’ who was studying the [Philosopher’s stone] diligently.

No one else would have any expertise in crafting.

Swoosh.

Using the familiar screen swipe, I cut across the continent and soon found Yuto flying in the air.

-“Mr. Elbon, what are you doing?”

On top of Yuto, Perin was talking to a character named Elbon.

Of course, Elbon looked annoyed by Perin.

Perin peeked at Elbon with his pointed ears twitching, and Elbon waved his arm in the air and put a speech bubble over his head.

-“Don’t bother me when I’m busy.”

-“Yes...”

-“It’s a possibility. If I use this, maybe I can make a philosopher’s stone with other sacred artifacts...”

Elbon was surprisingly diligent in carrying out the task given to him.

Unfortunately, he didn’t produce any results yet.

But according to Eutenia who brought him along, he was competent, so maybe he would someday produce something decent.

“That’s impressive.”

Well, if he ran away from there, he would only free fall from the sky.

I had also considered the possibility that the AI might bug out and drop him.

It was also impressive that he didn’t run away.

I watched Perin petting Yuto with a relaxed expression and Yuto snorting for a while, and then I moved my finger to the <Voice> skill to talk to Elbon.

There was no need to go through Perin to talk since I had the <Voice> skill.

“Ah, listen.”

-“Mortal, listen.”

-“This voice is...”

As the voice played by the <Voice> skill, Elbon stopped his hand in surprise, immersed in his research.

He looked around for a moment, then looked up at the sky with a blank face.

He seemed to have figured out who was talking to him in an instant.

He understood that I was talking to him, so he would listen to my commands using <Voice>.

Now all I had to do was tell him about the quest.

“Ahem...”

Elbon’s job was to create a holy body.

I didn't know much about the holy body either, but I had a kind of trick in mind for that.

It was a method of using a new translator that matched the words to the context.

I used the <Voice> skill to say a story that would convey the minimum meaning.

I believed that the new translator would paraphrase it appropriately.

“A holy body for Descent? You make it.”

-“Prepare the holy body. Weave the clothes that suit your master.”

-“Is that... telling me to make a homunculus for you?”

Did my intention work well?

It looked like a plausible conversation between Elbon and the new translator.

The most noticeable word among them was homunculus.

Homunculus was a term for artificial humans made by alchemy.

Judging by Elbon's conversation, the holy body he was talking about seemed to refer to the avatar of the character.

As I listened to his story, I became more confident in my guess.

It seemed obvious that the <Descent> skill was a skill to control the character made in the game.

“That's right. Make it a cheat character by stuffing only good things.”

-“Create the most strong, sturdy, and powerful flesh in the world. When the time of destiny comes, a worthy being will dwell there.”

Then the character I would control had to be a cheat.

It would have a more direct and intuitive impact on the relationships of the characters.

Not to mention, it would be no different from a god descending for the cultists.

Such a character couldn't be weak.

At my words telling him to make a cheat character, Elbon stroked his beard and pondered for a while, then put up a speech bubble.

-“The most powerful flesh... The only material that suits it is dragon blood.”

“Dragon blood? Well, do you have dragons?”

I want to raise a cool dragon.

Even as that thought crossed my mind, Elbon kept mumbling.

-“But getting dragon blood is not an easy task.”

-“Dragons live in places where people can't see them, and they are wary and powerful.”

-“Not to mention, making a homunculus is risky and experimental.”

So is it possible?

Or is it impossible?

He should just say yes if I tell him to do it, but Elbon seemed to have a lot to say.

I got annoyed and wondered if I should just punch him.

Then Perin spoke for me and looked at him.

-“Mr. Elbon, do you not want to follow the command of the great one?”

-“Hmph.”

Perin spoke with a confident face and crossed his arms, and Yuto below him put up a speech bubble and agreed with her.

Elbon looked flustered by Perin’s unexpected remark.

Even if she was rolling around in the sanctuary all day, Perin was still an apostle.

She was not in a position to be careful in front of Elbon.

-“No, no, that’s not it, I just...”

-“Then just do it!”

-“...”

-“The apostles will help you with the hard part anyway!”

Perin’s positive threat made Elbon nod slowly with a drained expression.

It was an order from God himself.

It was hard to refuse it in front of the apostles.

Elbon gave up on refusing and put down the herbs he was holding.

Then he looked up at the sky instead of him and asked me one more question.

-“If all the tasks are successfully completed, what will happen to me and... my disciple?”

He was worried about the fate that would befall them when everything was over.

Elbon's fate after the work was done.

If it were Eutenia instead of me, she would have disposed of him without hesitation.

Blasphemous, lacking faith.

She would have said such things and thrown Elbon as a sacrifice on the altar.

But now Elbon was asking me and the new translator.

He clearly wanted a different answer than Eutenia.

“...”

What would I say if I were the new translator?

I looked at him as I pondered that.

If I were a god, a being with such dignity, what would I say to him?

After thinking for a while, I opened my mouth with one hand on my chin.

Well. I don't know for sure, but if I were a god, I think I would say something like this.

“Those who perform great deeds will enjoy glory.”

-“Those who perform great deeds will enjoy glory.”

The reception room of the Colt Duke's residence, where the guest had left.

There, the Duke of Colt looked at Scollaus in front of him with a sneer.

He was trying to look a bit more serious than usual.

It was the look that Scollaus always had when he failed the task he was given.

The Duke snapped his fingers and waited for his answer, and Scollaus reported to him with a troubled expression.

“.....I failed. The mercenaries who took the mission seem to have been annihilated.”

It was a failure report on the kidnapping mission that the Duke had entrusted to Scollaus.

The mercenaries hired by Scollaus had failed to bring the emperor’s teacher.

The failure of the mission also meant that there were consequences to follow.

The advance payment to the mercenaries was completely gone, and the alertness of the emperor would have increased.

It was a possibility that the Duke had anticipated to some extent.

“I see. They had some means of their own.”

It seemed that the forces that joined Aycliffe had secretly guarded the teacher.

He had sent the mercenaries with that possibility in mind from the beginning.

Even if the hired mercenaries failed, he could gauge the level of the opponent.

Besides, it was not hard to cut off the tail.

The mercenaries in the back alleys would do anything dirty.

It was a pity that the mercenaries who brought the information were wiped out.

“Yes. Should we move the Shadow Knights?”

“Leave them alone. We’d better stay quiet for a while.”

Scollaus looked regretful as he mentioned the Shadow Knights, but the Duke shook his head and denied him.

Unlike the mercenaries, the Shadow Knights were not disposable trash.

They were made by pouring a lot of gold from the training process.

There were many ways to deny the relationship with the Duke’s family, but it was too wasteful to throw them away just to gauge the opponent.

Eventually, they would face the reality of the opponent as they stayed in the system.

Now it was wise to just wait for the right time.

“What are your intentions, Your Grace? When do you plan to return to your domain?”

“I intend to stay in the system for a while.”

“I see...”

“My son will take care of the domain even if I’m not there. He doesn’t deserve to inherit my place if he can’t do that much.”

The Duke’s domain would be well protected by his successor, Ribore.

The Duke planned to stay in the system for a while.

The succession education was already well underway.

Even if something happened to him in case of emergency, Ribore would become the next Duke without any problem.

It would be burdensome for him to face the emperor for the succession ceremony, though.

“Come on, doesn’t the whole empire know how capable your son is?”

“I raised him as a lion cub, of course he is.”

“A lion... A fitting animal for your son.”

“You know that too.”

The Duke smiled and lifted his lips at Scollaus.

The Colt Duke’s family always had to be lions.

They had to be fierce lions that could play with any prey in front of them.

That was what the successor education was for.

And that was the only way for the Duke’s family to survive in this chaotic era.

Chapter 153: Turbulence (2)

Chapter 153: Turbulence (2)

When I opened my eyes, I was surrounded by darkness.

Black wisps of light scattered and crumbled, creating a space of endless darkness.

I was the only one standing in that space, looking into the deep darkness.

Even as I stared blankly at the darkness, I felt a dull sensation throughout my body.

I tried to recall what had happened.

What was it?

As I searched my memory, the events of today at work flashed through my mind.

“Ah, today was tough.”

Today was more exhausting than usual.

I had a lot of work, a lot of nagging, and my body was drained when I got home.

And then, as soon as I got home, I dropped my stuff and collapsed on the bed.

The next thing I knew, I was facing this darkness.

I reached out slowly to the darkness that was swaying in front of me.

“Is this just a dream?”

The wisps of light moved along with my hand, leaving clear traces.

It felt like I was carving the darkness with my will.

It was an interesting sight.

The world that had nothing but darkness was moving with my touch.

“I feel like a god.”

It felt like I was the god of this whole space.

I was swinging the darkness in front of me alone for a while.

Then, suddenly, I felt a sensation of tilting.

The ground that I thought was there in the empty darkness collapsed.

As the world tilted, I felt a huge force of gravity pulling me from the side of my body.

“Are you having fun?”

At the same time as the black hair fluttered in front of my eyes, a familiar female voice echoed in my ears.

It was a very familiar voice.

It was the voice of the person who always met me at this time.

I slowly lifted my head and looked at the owner of the voice.

What I saw in the direction of my gaze was Estelle, wearing a black dress and looking down at me.

She stared at me with a blank expression.

“Estelle...?”

“Yeah. Long time no see.”

The fact that Estelle appeared meant one thing.

It was the same lucid dream as usual.

Except for one thing that was different from usual.

“What? Was it that kind of dream again?”

“That was the setting. Probably.”

“Then, why am I lying down like this?”

Estelle’s eyes met mine over my head.

I felt a soft sensation from the head that was resting on something.

It was not hard to figure out my posture from the direction of gravity.

I was lying on Estelle’s lap.

She looked at me calmly as I faced her.

“I’m thinking of letting you rest a bit. You looked tired today.”

“You said I looked tired?”

“Yeah. Weren’t you tired?”

Estelle’s slender finger stroked my forehead.

Beyond the split hair, I saw her intense black eyes.

My reflection was in her black eyes, lying on the bed.

Except for the fact that my body was weary and drowsy, I looked just like usual.

I didn't look tired at all in the dream.

“Well, I am tired.”

“Then that's good.”

“Yeah. It's just a dream anyway, so if I'm tired, you must be tired too.”

That was my conclusion.

Estelle was a creation of my subconscious, wasn't she?

It wasn't strange that she could read my current state.

It seemed that my subconscious wanted some comfort from someone.

That's why I was having this conversation with Estelle in the dream.

Instead of playing games as usual, I was talking to her like this.

“Well, not really...”

Of course, Estelle shook her head and denied what I said.

It looked like I was the only one who was tired.

It was funny when I thought about it. I was tired even in the dream because of my exhausted body.

My worn-out body couldn't relax even in the dream.

“What if you're not tired? It wouldn't be bad to rest like this instead of playing games today.”

“Do you like talking?”

“I don’t hate it. As long as the other person is not a dream entity.”

Maybe it was because she heard me deny her existence.

Estelle twisted my bangs slowly and asked me why.

“Why? Do you hate talking to a dream entity?”

“It’s weird, isn’t it? If I’m talking to my subconscious, it’s the same as talking to myself, right?”

That’s true.

Talking to the latent consciousness inside me was no different from answering my own questions.

Not that I never talked to myself before.

Estelle pondered for a moment, then stretched her finger toward my sideburns and said.

“What if I’m not a dream entity?”

“What?”

“What if I’m not a dream entity, would you still think this is all useless talk?”

What if Estelle was not a dream entity?

How would I treat her then?

That was the question that Estelle posed to me.

Of course, if that was the case, I wouldn’t be able to look at her so calmly like this.

But this was ultimately a pointless question.

Who would believe that a dream entity was not a dream?

“Usually, fools say they are not fools.”

Thump.

Estelle’s finger tapped my forehead lightly.

Even though her finger had some force behind it, it didn’t hurt at all.

Rather, only a cold sensation remained faintly on my forehead.

Estelle, who tapped my forehead, looked down at me and asked.

“What about you? Are you a fool or not?”

“I’m... not a fool, but rather a genius who lost his potential.”

“Really?”

“If I had studied properly, I would have surpassed Einstein. Instead of you, Pythagoras would be sitting here and doing this.”

As I muttered nonsense while looking at her, Estelle raised one hand and covered her mouth.

Pfft.

She let out a short laugh and pushed back my bangs again.

The parting that was skewed to the left was now neatly split in half.

“Do you prefer having a world-renowned scholar doing this instead of me?”

“No. You’re better than those people.”

“That’s good then. Because you can beat those people.”

It felt like giving my bangs to the world-renowned scholars.

It was a chilling imagination just to think about it.

I quickly shook my head and blew away that thought from my mind.

And then, instead of that, I told her what I wanted to say when I met her.

“I actually had something to tell you.”

“What is it?”

“The first prize lottery number that I asked you last time. You told me the winning number for the last draw.”

“Really? Too bad you didn’t win the first prize.”

Estelle gave me a brief and formal answer with a calm expression.

Too bad?

It sounded like she was mocking me.

But I didn’t feel too bad since I won the third prize.

I also tried to edit and translate your text into English as a web novel editor.
Here is my result:

“Next time, tell me the first prize number for this draw.”

“There won’t be a next time. That was our deal, remember?”

“You still remember that, huh?”

“Some people can remember all the lottery numbers.”

I chuckled at Estelle’s retort.

I thought anyone would memorize the lottery numbers.

It could change your life with one number, who would forget that?

Of course, Estelle seemed to have a different opinion than me.

“I had something I wanted to say too. Do you want to hear it?”

As we were exchanging jokes, Estelle suddenly became serious and spoke to me.

I looked at her with curiosity, seeing her changed expression.

Estelle, who told me something without any conditions.

That was unlike the Estelle I knew.

“You had something to say? Didn’t you usually ask me to win a game first?”

“I have some time left today, so I’ll just tell you something special.”

“If you say so... I’m lucky today. I get to hear your story for free.”

Estelle usually demanded a game for even a trivial talk.

And now I was listening to her story without playing a game.

It was a trivial thing, but it felt like a huge gain.

I nodded and accepted her offer, and Estelle came close to my ear and whispered.

“A storm is coming. You have to be careful.”

A storm is coming.

That one sentence made me shiver.

Above the sanctuary that was flying over the church.

There, Perin looked at Pluto who was polishing his magic.

Fairies and vampires.

They were different races that were almost opposite, but Perin didn't have a bad relationship with Pluto.

Rather, they were two apostles who could say they got along better than the others.

Maybe it was because Perin was not human, Pluto treated her comfortably.

“Pluto. I think we have to go north this time.”

Perin was quite close to Pluto anyway.

She even delivered the mission that the church gave to Pluto through her.

Perin handed Pluto a fresh apple along with his mission, and Pluto put down her apple and asked her.

“Me? Personally? To the Alterias region?”

Alterias.

It was the first region that came to mind when thinking of the northern part of the empire.

Pluto shivered slightly as if he felt the cold already, after hearing Perin's words.

Perin didn't like the cold of the Alterias region either.

She had moved there a few times to carry the apostles, but fairies and cold weather were not compatible beings.

Seeing Pluto's reluctant expression, Perin tilted her head and asked him.

“Do vampires have trouble with the cold?”

“Not really, but...”

“Then it’s fine!”

“...”

Nod. Nod.

Perin nodded up and down, affirming him, and Pluto looked at her with a darkened face.

He had a complicated face that showed many emotions.

Maybe he was upset by something she did wrong.

That thought crossed Perin’s mind for a moment.

“Did I make any mistakes?”

“No, it’s nothing. I’ll go to Alterias.”

“That’s good!”

Thankfully, Pluto agreed willingly.

Perin cheered and picked up an apple to give him again.

Of course, Pluto put the apple down again.

And then he waved his hand at Perin, who was handing him the apple, and said.

“It’s okay. Vampires can live on blood alone.”

“Is that so? But you drank alcohol last time, didn’t you?”

“That was just... a preference.”

Pluto picked up the cloth that he had put on the ground with one word.

Deathscythe. His magic weapon that had a bluish aura was always a beautiful sight.

Pluto carefully wiped off the dirt from his magic weapon with the cloth.

“Perin.”

“Yes!”

“Why do I have to go to Alterias?”

Pluto asked her about the purpose of this mission while polishing his magic weapon.

He seemed curious about why she was sent to Alterias.

I also tried to edit and translate your text into English as a web novel editor. Here is my result:

Perin remembered the conversation that Archbishop Roan and Elbon had.

This mission started from the story that Elbon brought up.

They needed the blood of the dragonkin to create the flesh of the great being, and according to the documents, there might be some dragonkin left in the northern part of the empire.

“There was a rumor that there might be some dragonkin living in Alterias. Our goal for this operation is to find and bring them back.”

“Dragonkin... You mean those old lizards?”

Usually, they looked like reptiles as Pluto said.

But nature had its exceptions.

Some of the old dragonkin could change their appearance from their natural form.

The dragonkin used the expression of gaining spirituality to honor those kin.

“Dragons with spirituality can disguise themselves as humans. It’s an information I found from an old document, so maybe they blended in with people!”

That was the story that some of the old dragonkin might have mingled with people.

Of course, they wouldn’t give up their lair easily, as they called it.

Pluto pondered over Perin’s story and asked.

“You mean they might look like humans?”

“That’s right.”

“Are those lizards strong?”

“They must be very strong if they have spirituality. After all, even the dragons in the legends look very powerful!”

The story of the dragons’ strength caught Pluto’s interest.

He snapped his fingers and tapped the blade of his Deathscythe.

Clang.

A clear sound came from the blade of his Deathscythe.

A blue aura swirled around his Deathscythe and revealed itself.

He had polished his magic weapon completely and got up from his seat. He slung his magic weapon over his shoulder and said.

“A fight with dragons... That sounds fun.”

Whoosh.

A cold wind blew towards them from beyond the sanctuary where the barrier was lifted.

The wind was full of chill as winter was approaching.

Brrr. Brrr.

Pluto shivered slightly as the cold wind wrapped around him.

“If only the weather was nice...”

Chapter 154: Turbulence (3)

Chapter 154: Turbulence (3)

“It’s getting cold at night.”

I muttered as I closed the wide-open window.

It was late at night, and the stars were twinkling.

The weather seemed to be getting chilly as winter approached.

It was a good way to catch a cold if I left the window open thinking of autumn.

Creak.

I sat down and picked up my smartphone after closing the window completely.

“Ah, I’m tired.”

My body started to feel sluggish as it got late.

I was so exhausted last night that I felt like passing out, but luckily, I felt less tired today after a night’s sleep.

Maybe the time I spent chatting with Estelle wasn’t meaningless.

I felt like I had a good sleep last night.

“But what’s the point of dreaming?”

After all, it was nothing more than a dream for one night.

Thump.

I stretched briefly and leaned on the mattress, looking at the smartphone screen.

On the smartphone screen, I saw Aicliffe and Eutenia talking in the office.

-“Do you have anyone in mind that you want to recruit?”

-“Hmm... well, about that.”

Eutenia was acting as Aicliffe’s adviser on Roan’s recommendation.

Well, strictly speaking, she was more like a guard and a watcher.

Aicliffe himself didn’t seem to know Eutenia’s abilities yet.

He seemed to understand that Eutenia was watching him.

“It would be nice if Count Felton joined us.”

As I watched the two of them, Aicliffe said to Eutenia with a troubled look.

Count Felton.

I had heard that name before.

I was sure I had seen them meet at a banquet.

They said he was a staunch imperialist.

-“Count Felton? He’s a stubborn man who won’t be swayed by any means.”

-“He’s not a genius, but... he would be a trustworthy ally.”

-“It’s foolish to waste time on impossible things. You should try to recruit someone else.”

Aicliffe seemed to want to bring Count Felton under his command.

Eutenia didn't think Count Felton would come to our side.

A funny thought came to my mind as I listened to their conversation.

After all, I was the god they believed in and followed.

I thought it wouldn't hurt to help them out once in a while for their sake.

"Let's see. You say Count Felton won't listen to you."

Count Felton was a character who was clearly an imperialist.

But he didn't follow the new emperor I chose.

That made him more of a rebel than an imperialist.

Well, whatever.

I had to intervene once and make him see sense.

For the sake of the characters I cared about.

"Don't worry and wait. I'll bring you Count Felton in a few days."

Of course, I didn't mean to chop him up into days.

That would only cost me one karma.

I needed to show him a proper example.

Besides, if he was an imperialist, he might be interested in the next emperor with a little correction.

Today, I was going to use the <Voice> magic to modify his mind thoroughly.

"Count Felton, Count Felton..."

First, I had to find his house.

I searched the noble district for a place where he might stay.

The hint that helped me find his house was the conversation of the characters.

I inferred the owner of the house from the context of the conversation and entered it.

I widened my eyes and looked for the people who were talking about Count Felton.

After spending about 10 minutes monitoring the conversation, I caught a speech bubble in the surveillance network of the bio big brother.

-“The count is still not coming out of his office today.”

-“He must have a lot of worries.”

In front of a moderately shabby noble mansion.

There, two servants were walking and talking.

The word Felton was not visible, but I was sure that the owner of this mansion was Count Felton.

It was close to the gamer’s intuition that I had played for a long time.

I searched Count Felton’s mansion thoroughly and found a space that looked like an office.

-“...”

An office with a fireplace burning logs.

There, a character with a neatly trimmed mustache was reading a book.

He had a steaming tea in front of him, and he was leisurely stroking his mustache.

He looked proud of his mustache in his own way.

The man who looked like the owner of the office was undoubtedly Count Felton.

At least that's what I remembered.

“Ahem, ah... Voice test.”

I cleared my throat as I looked at the man who was presumed to be Count Felton.

It was to prevent any mistakes while using <Voice>.

After loosening my throat with a professional announcer-like technique, I moved my finger to the skill icon of <Voice> in the corner.

I had already decided what to say to Count Felton.

Press.

I used the <Voice> skill and recorded what I had thought in advance on my smartphone.

“Follow the second prince.”

-“Follow the second prince.”

Crack. Crack.

After a brief noise mixed in my smartphone, the voice started playing next to Count Felton.

The voice that played was the same as always, a thick male voice TTS.

I was surprised that it conveyed exactly what I had said.

I blew the recorded voice into Count Felton's ear, and he looked up at the sky for a moment.

-“Hmm.”

Then he went back to the bookshelf.

He kept reading the book as if nothing had happened.

I wondered if he had a problem with his ears.

He was so calm.

I narrowed my eyes and looked at Count Felton, then used the skill again on his ear.

“I am the goddess of order.”

-“I am the goddess of order.”

The TTS was still a male voice.

Maybe it was because he hated the content.

Count Felton threw the book and got up from his seat.

He looked up at the sky and shouted in a large and bold speech bubble.

-“You bastard! Don't mock me with a man's voice!”

“What, he can hear.”

I thought he might have a hearing problem, but it seemed like I didn't have to worry about that.

I thought I could see some effect if I kept using <Voice>.

If not, I could mix in some more aggressive methods.

I decided and used the <Voice> skill on Count Felton right away.

“Follow the second prince.”

-“Shut up, you spawn of evil!”

“Follow the second prince.”

-“You bastard! Shut up...”

“Follow the second prince.”

-“Do you think I’ll listen to you!”

He was a character with a surprisingly strong will.

Count Felton didn’t give in easily.

But I couldn’t give up like this.

The people of this world showed resistance when they heard the words of evil.

What about the words of a goddess?

I decided to continue with the goddess concept I had before.

“I am the goddess of order.”

-“Don’t lie! The goddess wouldn’t have such a voice!”

“Cough, cough... I actually have a bad cold.”

-“What do you mean the goddess has a cold! Stop talking nonsense!”

Geez. A goddess could have a cold too.

He had no flexibility at all.

Now that it came to this, I had no choice but to use my hidden trump card.

I put down my smartphone on the table and raised my left hand that was holding it.

I put one finger on the icon of the <Voice> skill and the other on Count Felton's head.

I finished my preparation and started tapping Count Felton's head with my finger while using the <Voice> skill.

“second prince.”

Thump.

-“Cough!”

“second prince.”

Thump.

-“Ugh... Stop!”

“second prince.”

Thump.

-“Aaargh!”

“You must follow the second prince.”

Thump.

-“The se... Cough! No, no, stop it!”

As I tapped his head while instilling the right ideology, Count Felton screamed and writhed.

Maybe it was thanks to the effect of stimulating his brain.

Count Felton was adapting to the truth faster than before.

But he was not yet at a satisfactory level.

I had to keep awakening him to the truth until he showed a satisfying reaction.

“You must follow the second prince.”

Thump.

-“Aaaaah! Stop...!”

“I am the goddess of order.”

Thump.

-“You are no goddess! Stop! Go away, demon!”

“You must follow the second prince.”

Thump.

-“Follow the second... Ah! Nooo!”

“second prince.”

Thump.

-“Second... No! Go away! Go away, you evil... Aaaaah!”

After that, I had a fun time with Count Felton for a while.

Of course, I had to adjust the frequency so that he wouldn't die.

After some progress, I didn't even need to stroke him anymore.

We only exchanged the same conversation.

The simple fact that the goddess told me to follow the second prince.

How long had it been since I started the injection education that was proven effective worldwide?

It took me quite a long time to face Count Felton with his eyes relaxed.

He had become a great person unlike before I started teaching him.

He was so great that my lips curled up when I watched him.

-“You must follow the second prince.”

-“second prince! Long live! I will follow you!”

-“There is no one but the second prince!”

The truth always wins.

Count Felton completely surrendered to the truth I taught him.

I nodded in satisfaction as I saw Count Felton, who became a fervent follower of Aicliffe.

He looked like he would become Aicliffe’s strong right arm if I taught him a little more.

“Hmm. Good response.”

The <Voice> skill was definitely a terrifying skill.

It turned a character who was going down the wrong path into a fine one.

Count Felton, who was properly educated, repeated the lessons he received from me.

As I felt proud of him, the office door suddenly opened.

Clang.

The one who opened the door and came in was a young man with a noble aura.

He was a character who could be recognized as a noble at a glance.

-“Father. I came to report on what you told me last time.

Thud. Thud.

A young man approached Count Felton, who had his eyes unfocused, and handed him a paper.

Judging by his attitude, he seemed to be Count Felton’s son.

I watched closely how Count Felton interacted with the young man.

Count Felton took the paper from the young man and looked at it as he spoke.

-“The second prince...”

The second prince.

The young man was startled by the words that came out of Count Felton’s mouth.

He was also impressed by the results I had achieved in a short time.

He asked Count Felton about what he had just said, as if he doubted his own ears.

-“What? Father, what did you just say...”

-“You must follow the second prince.”

-“What do you mean? Didn’t our family decide to remain neutral on the succession issue?”

Maybe it was because he knew Count Felton well.

The young man immediately denied Count Felton's words.

According to Aicliffe, he was a person who was famous for his loyalty to the emperor.

It was hard for him to believe that he would follow the second prince.

But Count Felton's will was firm after receiving my teachings.

He didn't care about the young man's words and kept expressing his opinion.

-“You must follow the second prince.”

-“Father!”

Bang.

The young man slammed the desk and leaned closer to Count Felton.

Count Felton lifted his head and looked at the young man with half-clouded eyes.

He opened his mouth again and said to the young man.

-“I am the goddess of order.”

-“...What?”

10 seconds.

Silence fell on the office for 10 seconds.

Count Felton.

The young man who was looking at him.

And even me, who was watching them both, closed my mouth and remained silent.

My mind stopped for a moment at the words that Count Felton uttered.

The silence that lasted for 10 seconds was broken by Count Felton's next words.

-“You must follow the second prince.”

-“No, father, if the inquisitors hear what you just said, they will accuse you of blasphemy.”

-“It doesn't matter. You must follow the second prince.”

-“I, I understand. But please, just stop saying those weird things... Please, just stop...”

The young man's attitude changed completely from being harsh to Count Felton before.

He lowered his hand and showed a sorry look to Count Felton.

He was willing to accept even the words of following the second prince for now.

As the young man nodded and tried to move on somehow, Count Felton opened his mouth and added one more thing.

-“Is that so. I am the goddess of order...”

-“Father!”

It was a sight that made my head dizzy as I kept watching.

A mad count who claimed to be the goddess of order.

A young man who was flustered in front of him.

And me, the culprit of this situation, who was watching it all.

A word slipped out of my mouth as I leaned on the bed and stared blankly at it.

“The AI must have gone crazy.”

I rubbed my neck as I looked at the weird guy who had become the goddess of order.

It was a strange feeling.

Chapter 155: The Beings of the Ancient Era (1)

Chapter 155: The Beings of the Ancient Era (1)

The Holy Land, Crossbridge.

That was the name derived from the six bridges that connected each temple to the center of the Holy Palace.

Anyone who visited the Holy Land for the first time would be amazed by the sight of these gigantic bridges.

And in the middle of those connected bridges,

On the bridge that linked the Holy Palace and the Temple of Hunting, Hus, a hero of knowledge, was walking towards the Holy Palace with another hero, Sion.

“The weather is still nice.”

Sion, who had his divine bow Astra on his shoulder, said as he looked at the scenery beyond the bridge.

The race of heroes were all eccentric in their personalities, but among them, Sion Arius was one of the few who could be considered mild-mannered.

That was also the reason why Hus had frequent encounters with Sion.

He had gone to the Temple of Hunting early in the morning to ask for a duel, but he was summoned by the Holy Palace and had to move with him.

Since he had left right after finishing the duel, Hus also had a hieroglyph in his hand.

“Isn’t it? Hus?”

Ting.

Sion pulled the string of Astra as if to make Hus listen, and smiled.

The clear sound that echoed was like playing an old-fashioned string instrument.

As I walked side by side with Sion on the bridge, I looked at him and opened my mouth.

“Sion. We don’t have much time left.”

“Huh? What do you mean?”

Sion asked me with an innocent attitude, as if he didn’t know anything.

Did he really not know?

Or was he just teasing me?

I sighed and swung the hieroglyph I was holding.

Sion quickly stepped back and dodged my attack, which was aimed at the side of the thick book.

Whoosh.

I bit my tongue at the sight of the hieroglyph cutting through the air.

“Tsk. I mean we only have one day of leisure left.”

“One day?”

“Until the gods’ contract that protects us disappears.”

The gods' contract.

It was the grace period given to them by the evil god, who exercised his power.

After one more day, it would be over.

We couldn't ignore the threat of the evil god outside the holy land anymore.

Of course, if the saintess used 'Sanctuary Declaration', we could escape his sight for a while, but that was only a temporary measure.

We couldn't be free from the evil god's gaze forever.

"Well, there's nothing we can do about the contract ending. It's not like we'll face the apostles right away."

Sion shrugged and replied to Hus's words.

He didn't seem to care about the contract ending.

He was either thoughtless or optimistic, I couldn't tell.

Either way, it suited Sion, the hero of hunting, well.

"Have you grown a lot since then?"

"I don't know. Maybe I won't lose my prey like I did in Cuebaerg?"

"..."

Hus closed his mouth quietly at the mention of the Cuebaerg expedition.

He remembered his shameful self when he brought up the past.

It was a famous story in the holy land that Hus was smashed into a swamp by Evan's attack.

He was a mage who lost a firepower duel to a former paladin.

It didn't matter that Evan had received the evil god's power, it was still humiliating for a mage.

"What's wrong, Hus? You're suddenly quiet?"

"...It's nothing."

"Are you blaming yourself again for what happened? Don't worry about it too much."

Bang.

Sion's palm, which was making a smug laugh, hit Hus's back.

Hus frowned at the sensation from his back.

The hieroglyph, which reacted to the user's emotion, also moved right away.

Chrrrrrrr.

The pages of the hieroglyph turned and the magic that was stored in it unfolded.

"Sion."

A crimson circle grabbed Sion's arm and began to twist it slowly.

Sion's eyes widened at the sight of his arm being tied up by the magic.

He twisted his body along with his arm and clung to Hus.

A loud scream came out of Sion's mouth as he looked at Hus.

"Ugh! I surrender! I surrender!"

"I'm not the same as I was before. A month was enough time to change a person."

“Hus! It hurts! It hurts!”

“I’ve buried my naive past with my blood and flesh.”

He had learned magic from Arien Crost during that time.

He became the second user of space magic, and Hus learned how to deal with close combat.

He also prepared his mind to face Evan every day.

Evan Allemier was Hus’s brother, but he was also a huge wall that he had to overcome.

Now it was his turn to reach something beyond him.

“So now... I won’t lose miserably like before.”

“Just untie this first and then talk! Aaah! I’m dying! Is this how a hero dies in the holy land?”

Crack.

Hus clenched his fist with a firm will.

He had to end the second apostle, Evan Allemier, with his own hands.

It was all for that purpose.

The next battlefield where he would face Evan would be the place to prove it.

It was the fate given to heroes and apostles.

Whooosh-.

As he watched the blizzard raging with the fierce wind, Philrun enjoyed the warm bonfire in the cave.

How much time had he spent outside looking for the holy relics?

His ear was completely numb from the cold wind.

The bright light of Clawsolas also faded.

Clawsolas ignored Philrun's attitude and continued his words.

-“The goddess has recovered a lot of causality. Of course, you deserve some credit for that.”

“So my actions helped the goddess, right? Then, what happens next?”

-“If you face any danger, the goddess will give you a little help.”

Direct help.

That was an unexpected story for Philrun, who had only received help through the divine device.

It was a great meaning for a hero that the goddess could intervene directly.

“Will all six goddesses be able to come forward from now on? Like the evil god did until now?”

Did his actions help all the goddesses find their freedom?

When Philrun asked that question with such a thought, Clawsolas vibrated his blade briefly.

It meant no.

-“No. Only the goddess of harmony and the goddess of order can move right now.”

“What? Only two goddesses?”

-“Even then, they can’t pour out their power endlessly like the evil god. The balance of causality is not properly adjusted yet.”

“So you’re saying that the goddess of order is the most amazing right now? Well, it would have been hard without hero Philrun.”

Philrun shrugged with Clawsolas on his shoulder.

It was thanks to him that the villagers were slaughtered and the plan was expedited.

He deserved to be proud of his achievement.

When Philrun boasted of his glory, Clawsolas reluctantly agreed with him.

— “You were a great help.”

“Right? That’s right, right?”

— “Yes.”

“Isn’t this becoming more and more like a heroic tale? It would be perfect if there was a cute saintess by my side.”

The image of the saintess flashed through Philrun’s mind as he bragged about his feat.

There was always a saintess who helped the hero by his side.

And sometimes, love blossomed between the hero and the saintess.

Who would be the saintess chosen by the goddess of order?

Clawsolas added one last word to Philrun, who was dreaming of heroism.

— “...When the time comes, the saintess will find you too.”

* * * * *

Pluto Austria.

She was called the progenitor of vampires, but she was not used to the cold.

Of course, that didn't mean she was strong against the heat either.

That's why Pluto was wrapped in warm clothes to protect herself from the cold.

She made her clothes as thick as possible without hindering her movement.

Perin tied a thick scarf around Pluto's neck.

"There, it's done!"

He let go of his hands and smiled at Pluto.

Pluto looked around her head, wearing the scarf.

Under the blue scarf, she wore a thick coat that the Order had prepared for her.

She felt the pressure of the tight coat as she moved her arms.

With this outfit, she wouldn't be bothered by the blizzard in Alterias.

"Hmm... I feel a bit suffocated."

"But it's not too uncomfortable to move, right?"

"Fortunately, it doesn't seem to be a problem."

Whoosh.

Pluto swung her Death Scythe in the air.

There was a possibility of an unexpected battle while exploring Alterias.

In that case, the mobility of her outfit was important.

Pluto put away her weapon after checking its condition, and Perin brought her a large bag.

Pluto's eyes were filled with questions at the sudden appearance of the bag.

“Pluto, take this with you too!”

“Perin... What is this?”

“It's emergency food that I prepared for you. And this is a secret... I also put a demon doll in it.”

Pluto looked blank as she looked at Perin's bag.

Emergency food? Did he put blood in a bottle?

But as far as she knew, fairies didn't like to see blood.

In that sense, the emergency food that Perin prepared for her was unexpected.

“Emergency food...”

Pluto opened the bag with anticipation, and found it full of fruits.

There was no sign of the blood bottle that she had hoped for.

There was nothing that could be called emergency food.

His eyes, which had grown bigger than before, looked at Perin.

“Have one if you get hungry!”

“Perin. Vampires only drink blood. If I'm hungry, I can just hunt some animals with my Death Scythe...”

“But what if there are no animals?”

It didn't matter if there were no animals.

She wasn't so weak that she would faint if she didn't drink blood for a few days.

She was the progenitor of vampires, a being far from the inherent weaknesses of her race.

But Perin seemed to have a different idea.

He grabbed Pluto's hand and spoke with sparkling eyes.

"You have to eat them all!"

Pluto couldn't easily answer his words.

She didn't mind drinking wine, but she felt uncomfortable eating fruits often.

She tried to avoid Perin's gaze and mumbled an answer.

But Perin didn't give up and asked her again.

"You got it? Don't leave any!"

"...Yeah."

Pluto had no choice but to nod at Perin's shining eyes.

She didn't like fruits, let alone wine.

Especially this many fruits. She didn't have the confidence to eat them all.

But for some reason, she felt like she would become a vegetarian vampire on this journey.

Sigh. Pluto looked at the contents of the bag again with a sigh.

Beyond the fruits rolling in the bag, a Cuebaerg doll was raising one arm.

Chapter 156: Beings of the Ancient Era (2)

Chapter 156

Beings of the Ancient Era (2)

Dragon.

It was a subject of long worship and one of the ancient legends that came from the primordial.

Its massive body was like a mountain, and its scales were hard as armor.

Humans had written many praises for the dragons over the ages.

Fear and awe.

And countless stories that followed.

Ultimately, they regarded it as a sleeping disaster and were wary and afraid of it.

The records of humans that Pluto had verified all contained such contents.

They were endlessly cautious of the beings they did not know.

“Beings that time flows slowest for... How interesting.”

They were as old as human history.

From the human perspective, they must have been afraid of what the dragons had accumulated over many years.

Just as they had feared the progenitor of vampires who did not receive death.

Then, would the old dragons know much about Pluto?

For Pluto, that was also one of her interests in dragons.

“Even if they lived long, they would be weaker than me who received his power.”

Thump. Thump.

Pluto’s steps cut through the snow-covered mountain path.

Every time she took a step, her feet dug deep into the snow.

Walking was not a difficult task, but the occasional coldness made her shiver.

She looked around carefully and kept moving forward.

“Hoo...”

Pluto’s mouth let out a regular stream of white breath as she moved forward.

Even though her blue muffler covered her mouth, the breath did not seem to diminish.

The harsh environment of Alterius was hard for Pluto to get used to.

It was so bad that she admired the Arcrosis and the black mages who lived in the northern part of the continent.

“...”

Pluto's mind was filled with a longing for warm blood that she had just drawn.

She thought it would feel very good to warm her body while drinking blood.

She preferred human blood over beasts or fairies, if possible.

She regretted that the blood would cool quickly even if she drew it here.

"I wish I could have a cup of warm blood."

As Pluto expressed her thirst for blood, she heard a rustling sound nearby.

Pluto's eyes moved to find the source of the sound.

Could it be that she had already encountered a dragon?

With that thought, she chased after the enemy's appearance, and saw a small white furball in Pluto's eyes.

Pluto tilted her head slightly at the sight of the furball in front of her.

"...?"

Thud. Thud. Thud. Thud.

The small furball disappeared across the snowfield.

She thought it was a dragon, but it turned out to be an animal.

Pluto shrugged off the trivial situation and turned her head to continue on her way.

Then, suddenly, her bloodlust for warm blood revived.

If she caught that thing now, she could eat warm blood even if it tasted bad.

That's how far her thoughts went.

“...It seems warm.”

Gulp.

Without realizing it, I swallowed my saliva and moved my steps forward.

My legs started to chase after the animal that ran away, breaking through the thick snow.

Was it because the nameless furball had evolved to survive in the cold?

It moved on the snow without leaving any footprints.

I moved my legs to follow the furball that ran around.

“...”

If I was serious, I could catch it in an instant, but I didn't bother to hurry or move fast.

I just followed the fleeing furball with a leisurely pace.

It was the steps of a predator chasing its prey.

Feeling anxious by my movement, the furball showed a faster speed than before.

-“Snow.”

Every time I took a step, the distance between me and the furball decreased significantly.

I was the progenitor of vampires, who had outstanding physical and magical abilities among them.

It was not difficult for me to catch up with the beast that wandered in the blizzard.

After chasing the furball for a few minutes, it soon stopped in its place as if it was exhausted.

The creature that ran hard shivered as it stopped.

-“Snow snow snow...”

“See? I told you. It’s better to roast them, right?”

And beyond the furball, there was a narrow cave that barely fit one person.

There was a boy in fur clothes who was roasting meat on a skewer.

He seemed to have cooked something with a lot of fur, as he had spread fur all over the place.

My steps stopped when I saw the boy.

At the same time, the boy also stopped his action of eating meat while talking to himself.

“What is that...”

“...”

I stared at the boy in front of me without a word.

There was some smell coming from him.

One sweet smell.

And one horrible smell.

The sweet smell was the blood of humans that had accumulated for a long time.

And the horrible smell was—

“Clawsolas. Could she be the saint I’ve been waiting for?”

The horrible smell from him was the kind I hated most in the world.

The fragrance that rose from the dense divine power.

It was a smell that only came from those who had the strongest divine power among humans.

Like the beings called heroes.

Pluto made her decision and pulled out Death Scythe from the air.

A blue aura flickered and wrapped around Pluto's body, holding the divine weapon.

"...You're a hero."

Pluto spoke as she held Death Scythe, and the boy was startled and raised his weapon.

Woo woo woo woo—

The sword he held shone and shook.

It didn't look like an ordinary weapon, judging by the energy it felt.

It was undoubtedly a divine weapon that heroes possessed.

"What...? You're not a saintess, but an apostle? Then you're not my saintess?"

The one in front of him was a hero.

A weak hero who had not fully awakened his power.

He looked like a novice, full of flaws, from Pluto's perspective.

It was certain that she could easily overpower him in a battle.

Pluto lifted Death Scythe with a relaxed hand.

The boy was still looking at his sword and talking to himself.

“If you’re an apostle, you’re an enemy that should fall to a hero. Then I should kill you here, right? No need to be careful...”

No, it wasn’t a monologue, maybe he was talking to someone else.

But the main characters of this place were only the two who held weapons.

She didn’t want to watch him make stupid faces and talk to himself forever.

Pluto scattered the mists around her and spoke to the boy in front of her.

“Third Apostle. Pluto Astria.”

“Third Apostle? I’m Philrun, the Hero of Order. You should be honored to fall by my hand.”

Hero of Order.

He introduced himself as such, and he smelled of human blood.

It was a bloodline that could not fly without killing countless people.

He was doing something that suited a vampire like me, but he was a human hero.

He was arrogant and stupid.

“You think I’ll fall? That’s a funny story.”

The progenitor is not a weak being.

Even though I had lost many memories of myself, I still had pride in being a vampire in my heart.

Even without the title of an apostle, I was strong.

Blood magic was transmitted through blood, and only those I chose had received his permission.

My body was also a perfect being as a progenitor.

That's why the countless 'defects' below me had submitted and sworn loyalty to me.

Philrun, who faced me, spoke with confidence.

"No. You can't beat me. Heroes always find the right thing for them."

"What an arrogant talk."

"It's called confidence. I've invested a lot of time for it."

Swish.

He finished his words and took out a candlestick from his pocket.

The candlestick looked like it was made of gold, and it emitted an extraordinary energy that anyone could see.

He brought the candlestick close to his sword.

I couldn't help but utter a voice when I saw the candlestick.

"That is..."

"Even if you call yourselves apostles, you're nothing without the help of the evil god, right?"

"...?"

"This means that you're no match for me anyway!"

Clang!

The tip of the candlestick collided with Philrun's divine weapon.

A fierce flame burst out and quickly spread to the candlestick.

The candlestick burned without a single wick, holding a golden flame.

A faint golden wave spread out.

It was a miraculous sight that anyone would marvel at.

“Open your eyes and see!”

Crackle. Crackle.

Colorful waves of light overlapped from the candlestick he held.

The colors that spread from the vivid gold created many harmonies.

The light made stars, and the gold poured out more light.

The glittering lights around them looked holy as if they had received God’s blessing.

“What are you trying to do?”

“Sanctuary Declaration – Auras Saint!”

Under the scattered light, Philrun lifted up the golden flame and shouted.

The lights dispersed and formed a sanctuary.

The smell of the dense divine power made Pluto frown without knowing it.

In the piercing scent of divine power, Philrun declared the goddess’s sanctuary.

As the sanctuary descended on the snowfield, Pluto felt a huge power drain from her body.

“Sanctuary...”

The divine power that filled the surroundings pressed down on Pluto's body.

It was a kind of power that did not affect the apostle's power that she manifested.

But it had a strong influence on her aspect as a vampire.

Divine power was the opposite of vampire's power.

It was so dense that even the progenitor would feel uncomfortable.

"How do you like it? The power of the sanctuary declaration that you taste for the first time?"

"It makes me feel quite unpleasant. The ones with thin blood would have a hard time moving."

"With this, the help of the evil god is over. Now it's time to fight fair and square, apostle of the evil god."

Philrun held out his sword with his free hand.

A golden light glowed in one of his eyes.

Behind him, three pairs of light wings were spread out.

He smiled darkly as he held the shining divine weapon.

He looked like he was imitating the appearance of an angel from mythology.

Of course, if he looked at himself, he had a rather distant appearance from an angel.

"Fair and square..."

The energy he felt from Philrun grew bigger and bigger.

It was a different kind of thing from the divine weapons that apostles used.

Of course, she had no intention of avoiding a frontal fight.

She was Pluto Astria, the great progenitor of vampires.

“You don’t suit that look.”

Pluto’s Death Scythe slowly rose up.

She gripped the divine weapon with both hands and twisted her waist to swing the scythe.

A faint shadow appeared behind Pluto who held the scythe.

Squeak.

The reaper who showed up behind Pluto chuckled and laughed.

“Still, I think it’s better to teach a lesson to a kid who doesn’t know his place.”

Chapter 157: Beings of the Ancient Era (3)

Chapter 157: Beings of the Ancient Era (3)

“—Death Scythe.”

The signal for the start of the battle was Pluto’s death scythe.

The scythe of the reaper swung with a heavy shockwave, charging with a force that seemed to cut through anything.

Kwaang!

The blue mist that wrapped around the scythe spread out, and a huge scar was created above the cave where Philrun was standing.

A straight line that crossed the entrance of the cave.

A massive amount of soil poured down from below, and dust settled everywhere.

‘I couldn’t cut through it.’

Thud thud thud.

Even as the soil that supported the cave fell down, Pluto was able to guess the enemy’s life or death.

The sensation that came through the death scythe told him the enemy’s condition.

He didn't manage to inflict any wounds with this attack.

The death scythe was still starving for human blood.

“Haah, ha...”

Beyond the thick dust, a human figure faintly appeared.

Thump. Thump.

Behind the footsteps of the enemy, a pair of wings shone brightly.

The wings, which had one less than before, emitted light neatly and scattered the dust.

A rough coughing sound reached Pluto's ears, who was holding the scythe.

“Cough, cough... You're too much, all of a sudden.”

The one who came out of the dust that Pluto had created was Philrun, who was frowning and coughing.

The divine tool that Philrun was holding, Clawsolas, was emitting a stronger light than before.

Pluto felt more and more uncomfortable as the light from the divine tool grew stronger.

It was an energy that was hard to get used to, no matter how many times he faced it.

Pluto covered his nose with his fingertips and spoke to Philrun.

“You're tougher than I thought.”

“I've become quite sturdy since I became a hero.”

“I see.”

Heroes were those who were chosen from among humans as the peak of their kind.

It would have been ridiculous if they had fallen to such an attack.

Whirr.

This time, Pluto thrust his death scythe forward.

The density of the mist that surrounded him became thicker than before.

“—Clawsolas.”

Philrun also had no intention of sitting still, so he lifted his divine tool and aimed at Pluto.

Ziiing.

A brilliant light gathered at the tip of Clawsolas, and soon produced a beam of light with a threatening size.

It was Clawsolas' ability to compress and release the overflowing divine power.

It was a blow that would purify any corrupted being in an instant.

“Hmm...”

“Take this, apostle.”

Philrun released the divine power that he had condensed and aimed at Pluto.

Kwaaaang!

A clear trail of light drew across Pluto's position and passed by.

The holy trail that contained heat and light burned and judged everything below it.

Except for one of the oldest vampires who was standing there.

“...”

Philrun's Clawsolas strike ended, and smoke rose from the aftermath of the attack.

Even then, Pluto was walking towards Philrun in a fine condition.

Pluto, who had returned to his original state without any impact, slowly stretched out his death scythe and approached him.

Pluto's relaxed walk made Philrun look at him with a puzzled expression.

“What...?”

“It seems like it didn't work. Too bad.”

Squeak.

Pluto's body, which had been scattered like mist, returned to normal as he released his mistification.

Mistification.

It was a privilege granted to vampires who inherited the blood of their progenitor deeply.

And Pluto's mistification was incomparable to those of his descendants.

Pluto Astria's mistification could easily pass through low-level attacks without any resistance.

Pluto returned to his place without any shock and walked towards Philrun while measuring the distance between them.

Philrun realized the situation and his expression became more serious.

“How can you be fine without dodging that attack?”

“Low-level attacks don’t work on me.”

“Are you saying I’m low-level after seeing me, a hero of order? Don’t talk nonsense! Clawsolas!”

Kwaaaang!

Philrun’s divine tool once again emitted light and shot an attack at Pluto.

But Pluto still moved his steps leisurely as before.

The flash that passed by Pluto melted all the snow on its path and exposed the soil underneath.

Pluto’s footsteps also walked on the road made by Philrun’s attack.

That way, the distance between them narrowed quickly.

When they reached a distance where it was not easy to project power, Philrun swung his sword wildly at Pluto.

“Don’t come near me!”

“Are you scared? You’re a hero?”

“I told you! I’ll kill you if you come closer!”

Philrun’s face darkened as he looked at Pluto who was approaching him.

His face contrasted with the thick smell of blood that surrounded him.

It was a sight that did not match at all.

He had taken many lives himself. But he had not grown himself.

He had been fighting against those who were weaker than him until now.

He had never fought a battle where he risked his life.

“How pathetic, you coward.”

Pluto looked at Philrun’s frightened face and started to run towards him.

Tadadadak.

A light step crossed the snowfield, closing the distance to Philrun.

Philrun gripped his sword and took a stance as the gap narrowed quickly.

A bright burst of light erupted from the clumsy Clawsolas he held.

“Shut up! I’m a hero!”

The sword, imbued with pure white light, swung swiftly at Pluto.

The strength from his enhanced body made even a simple attack look extraordinary.

Pluto’s eyes, starting to glow red, measured the distance between her and the incoming sword.

Three steps ahead.

The slanted sword strike was aimed at her.

It was a sloppy move for a hero’s sword.

“You’re the lowest level among the heroes.”

Just before the sword touched her body, Pluto dispersed into black mist and passed by Philrun’s sword.

Whoosh!

The sword that sliced through the air missed its target and stabbed into the ground.

Bang!

The Clawsolas that hit the snowfield scattered snow in all directions.

Philrun tried to follow Pluto's figure in the dizzying snow.

"Damn it...!"

Pluto, who had passed by Philrun in an instant, reformed behind him.

She had already returned to her original form and moved a beat faster than Philrun.

Spin.

Pluto's Death Scythe, after spinning half a circle, aimed to cut off Philrun's head.

Beyond the five dazzling wings.

Blue sparks converged in a parabola toward Philrun's head.

The moment the swung strike hit Philrun's head directly.

"Ugh...! Clawsolas! Protect me!"

Boom!

A clear light burst out and one of Philrun's wings on his back disappeared.

Something intervened forcibly and blocked Pluto's attack.

It was not a feeling of being pushed back by the collision of forces.

She had anticipated the possibility of being blocked from the beginning, so Pluto continued her attack.

'One more time.'

Just before landing, Pluto's Death Scythe swung behind the enemy again.

This time, she aimed for his abdomen instead of his head.

Pluto's Death Scythe pierced through Philrun's abdomen.

Unfortunately, this attack was not very satisfying either.

Boom! Crack.

Something blocked her approach and protected Philrun.

Then one of Philrun's wings fell apart without light.

“Whew, ha... What, what is this? I've already died three times?”

Philrun stepped back a few steps and muttered as he looked at his wings.

He had only three wings left out of the six he had at first.

Pluto understood the situation as she looked at Philrun's half-gone wings.

One of his wings disappeared every time her attack hit him.

Even though they were both apostles, it was something that would have killed him if he had taken it directly.

There was no doubt that those wings on his back were contributing to protecting him.

Something would definitely change after all six wings fell off.

“Don't worry. I'll take off the remaining wings soon.”

She declared that and pointed her Death Scythe at him.

Her eyes, reddened by boiling blood, fiercely chased his movements.

Even with the power of miracles, Philrun's movements were still clumsy.

If only the unknown force that protected him disappeared, it would be Pluto's victory in no time.

She could use blood magic to incapacitate him with just a small wound on her scythe.

"That won't do! Clawsolas!"

"What a pathetic struggle."

"I'm talking... talking right now! Clawsolas! If this goes on, hero Philrun will die...!"

With Pluto in front of him, Philrun showed his last desperate attempt in a frantic voice.

He hoped that something would come down to save him.

He didn't seem to have any intention of accepting his inevitable end gracefully like a hero.

He was trash that wasn't even worth remembering his name.

Pluto gripped her Death Scythe and approached him.

Philrun repeated his meaningless plea for salvation even as Pluto swung her scythe at him.

"Who will protect Lady Order if I die-!"

"Farewell. Pitiful hero."

Swoosh.

The scythe I tilted emitted a cold aura as it traced its trajectory.

I was sure that this attack would kill Philrun.

I would knock off two more wings with consecutive attacks and then finish him off by cutting his throat.

No one would think that Philrun had any way to survive this situation.

With that thought, I was about to continue my final strike when I sensed something and hastily dispersed into mist.

“...!”

Something was falling from high above, aiming at me.

It smelled of intense divine power.

I continued my attack while in mist form.

Chapter 158: Beings of the Ancient Era (4)

Chapter 158: Beings of the Ancient Era (4)

Pluto looked at the divine strike that pierced the ground in front of him with a wary expression.

The goddess had returned.

The goddess of order, who had been absent from the world for a while, had come back.

The fact that she was back would have a huge impact on the world.

Philrun was a hero who deserved his name, but Pluto could not ignore the goddess behind him either.

“The goddess of order...”

Order.

The goddess who was in charge of the natural laws and rules of this world.

The laws that she established were the proper norms for everyone, and the immutable principles of the world.

The goddess of order would judge and condemn anyone who violated the order that she had set.

And Pluto would also be a target of her judgment.

Pluto was an immortal who defied the logic of mortals, and an apostle of the evil god who opposed the six goddesses.

Philrun, who had the support of the goddess on his back, was more confident than ever as he aimed his divine weapon at Pluto.

“Why don’t you surrender now? I’ll let you die without pain.”

“...”

No matter how powerful Pluto was, he could not win against the goddess.

He was nothing but a creature who lived under the logic of the gods.

Pluto Astria’s name was eternal, but his memory was not.

But the being called a goddess was beyond the logic of such creatures.

Pluto and her had different lengths of time and history that they had accumulated and remembered.

That’s why humans called them gods and worshiped and revered them.

“But still...”

Pluto’s red eyes, filled with determination, stared at Philrun who stood beyond him.

His attack could not reach the god.

But the hero in front of him was a different story.

He could do it.

He could pierce through the divine punishment that the goddess unleashed and kill Philrun.

It was a possibility that only he, not any other apostle, had.

Pluto firmly believed in that possibility.

“If you retreat now, you will disgrace the honor of your lord.”

With that judgment, Pluto gripped Deathscythe and started to move forward.

His flesh, soaked in darkness, scattered and turned into black mist. Pluto’s body charged toward Philrun.

Was it because he had already lost two pairs of wings?

Philrun was wary of Pluto and held his sword while stepping back.

“—Deathscythe.”

Ziiiiing.

The divine weapon resonated and the shadow of the reaper appeared behind Pluto.

He aimed for a strike that would cross the distance.

With one hit, or two at most, he was confident that he could bring down Philrun.

Kwang!

As Pluto’s body kicked the snow and approached, Philrun swung his light beam and opened his mouth.

From the snow that scattered in all directions, Philrun and the goddess’s voices echoed at the same time.

“Oh goddess!”

-“Do not touch my child.”

A golden curtain spread in the air and blocked Pluto’s strike.

Kagagagak!

The reaper's scythe, glowing blue, slid along the curtain and moved toward the ground.

There was no doubt that the goddess of order had spread the curtain to protect Philrun.

The curtain, made of dense divine power, was not the kind that could be passed through by mistification.

Pluto, who had turned into mist, quickly changed his strategy and tried to bypass the curtain with his fast mobility.

‘Again.’

His body, which had dispersed like a mirage, slowly coalesced beyond the curtain.

The darkness began to intersect.

The darkness that began to take on a human shape revealed its true form at that moment. Countless beams of light poured down around him.

A foul smell that twisted his nose assaulted Pluto's sense of smell.

Pluto frowned and hastily restored his body to its original state.

“Huuh...!”

Kwang! Kang! Kaang!

Pluto swung his scythe and fended off the holy light that poured down to the ground.

The arrows of light that collided with Pluto's scythe twisted their trajectories and embedded themselves in the floor.

Crack.

The arrows that he deflected turned into fragments of divine power and scattered.

The beams of light that the goddess shot all conveyed a heavy sensation.

Indeed, it felt like a huge wall to reach her fully with his power.

‘A little faster.’

Faster. And stronger.

Pluto put more strength into his scythe.

Kwang! Kagagagak!

With one swing of his scythe, three beams of light crumbled.

Kwang! Kang!

With two swings of his scythe, Pluto’s footsteps advanced one step forward.

One step. And another step.

As Pluto stepped forward, Philrun shot a beam of light from Clawsolas at him.

“—Clawsolas!”

Chiiiiik.

The beam of light bent by Deathscythe stabbed the ground.

Pluto’s eyes followed Philrun’s movement, who was consumed by fear.

A frightened prey was in front of him.

A human hero who had always offered blood to his kin, trembling with fear at the name of his great race, was in front of him.

He could not retreat from such a human without disgracing his ancestor's honor.

He had to kill him.

He had to kill the hero and rule over him as the ancestor who came before him.

'Faster. Stronger.'

A forgotten sensation revived through his hand.

The ancestor he knew had to excel at everything.

Art. Culture. Ruling. Fighting.

Everything he had forgotten was a qualification of a great lord.

Faster. And stronger.

The proud ancestor did not bow to the threat in front of him.

Even after losing all her people, she had to stay here and avenge them.

-"Proclaim it."

She heard a voice calling her in Pluto's ear as he swung his scythe to reach the past.

The lord of darkness was calling her.

She knew what he wanted, what he wished for.

If he wanted it, she could reach it.

That's why she had only one thing to do.

'If you wish for it.'

She had to proclaim it with her own mouth.

She had to announce who this battlefield belonged to.

She had to say who owned the snow that covered the earth, the bushes that grew abundantly, the clouds that flowed in the sky.

She had to declare who the day and night of this world were for.

“Sanctuary proclamation—.”

If her lord wished for it, she had to work for him.

That was the new mission given to her who had lost everything.

The third apostle, Pluto Astria.

This was a right granted only to herself as an apostle.

Her bloodstained eyes looked beyond the logic.

“Wait... Sanctuary proclamation?”

Philrun’s voice, soaked in confusion, echoed.

But a mere mortal’s question was lighter than a crow’s feather.

This was a declaration carried out under the great command.

She raised her left hand slowly with an elegant gesture.

And, with a lofty voice, she spoke to all the beings in this place.

“—Logracion.”

The moment the agent of evil god declared the age of darkness.

The golden world collapsed.

The darkness of night.

Under the city's night sky where no stars twinkled, only the screen of the smartphone in his hand emitted light.

He could see the faint starlight of Polaris here, but he was captivated by a more brilliant sparkle.

The countless colors created by electricity and signals.

A yawn escaped from his mouth as he looked at the smartphone that shone instead of the stars.

“Huuh...”

I had just noticed Pluto's anomaly while yawning.

I was browsing through the screens to check on the apostles' situations, when I found a place where the screen was not visible.

After [The Contract of Regression] lost its effect, there was only one thing that could block my sight.

The sight-obstruction pattern unique to the boss monsters who used 'Sanctuary proclamation'.

If not, the only explanation for this phenomenon was a smartphone malfunction.

“It can't be broken.”

Chijik. Chik. Chiik—.

The screen that was blurred by noise returned to normal.

What appeared on the restored screen was a strange character facing Pluto.

An unidentified character with wings of light.

Considering his skill pattern and appearance, he was definitely a boss monster of the kind called heroes.

He was looking at Pluto with a light sword in his hand, with a bewildered face.

-“Wha, Sanctuary proclamation... Clawsolas said that the evil god couldn’t interfere...”

-“Your faith in the goddess of order and running away will end here, Philrun.”

Pluto, who used <Sanctuary proclamation: Logracion>, aimed Deathscythe at the boss and spoke.

There were countless numbers of light stuck near Pluto.

Someone had shot magic at Pluto for sure.

As I watched their conversation, I couldn’t help but doubt a certain word.

It was a word that was familiar to me, but also a bit strange.

“The goddess of order? Is this boss from her side?”

The goddess of order was one of the six goddesses who were called so in the continent.

According to the game’s setting, she was also the one behind the boss monsters called heroes who attacked the cult.

Judging from their conversation, the boss in front of me was surely a hero made by the goddess of order.

As if to prove it, the hero called Philrun raised a short prayer to the sky with his sword in his hand.

It was a short prayer that the boss monsters who faced me often uttered.

-“Oh goddess! Guide me!”

“What kind of navigation is the goddess? They always look for a fake goddess.”

Of course, that didn’t mean that the goddess would pop out.

If the goddess came out every time they called her, Ebeni wouldn’t have become my apostle.

At least that’s how it was according to my experience.

With that thought in mind, I started to think about what skill to use to kick Philrun’s ass.

-“Oh goddess! Guide me!”

“Call her a hundred times. Your goddess won’t come out.”

<Lightning>. <Lightning Arrow>. <Giga Lightning>.

As I was pondering over various choices and moving my finger between the skill icons.

A strange voice from the speaker pierced my ears.

My eyes, which were looking at the icons, automatically turned to Pluto.

-“You are arrogant, child.”

At the same time as the woman’s voice flowed from the speaker, a light arrow flew toward Pluto.

Kwang!

Pluto, who was holding his scythe, swung it and ran toward Philrun.

I couldn’t help but be surprised by the scene.

The one who shot the arrow at Pluto was definitely not the guy called Philrun.

“...This is really happening.”

The goddess, whom I had only heard of, appeared in front of me.

Pluto was blocking the arrows that the goddess shot and advancing forward.

Seeing that, I moved my finger to the <Voice> skill that was heading toward the attack magic.

A hero character who attacked the apostle with the goddess.

Was this a special pattern that manifested by causality correction?

I realized then why the messages had been warning me of causality correction until now.

-Warning: Excessively biased karma in one direction may cause <Causality Correction>.

“Yeah, this is fun. Let’s fight together, huh?”

Pluto had held his own against the boss monster even when his sight was blocked.

If I helped her, there was no reason why we couldn’t defeat the enemy in front of us.

Causality correction or whatever, it would be over if Pluto and I overcame it.

Tuk.

I touched the <Voice> skill and used it to talk to Pluto’s ear.

There was only one command I had to give her with my voice.

“Pluto. You take down that guy. I’ll back you up.”

-“Move forward. I’ll guide you.”

-“If that’s your will, I’ll do anything.”

Pluto could take down the boss for sure.

Because I would help her myself.

Tadadadak—.

Pluto, who gripped his scythe, ran toward Philrun while scattering snow.

In front of Pluto who was advancing, arrows filled with light revealed themselves.

-“Submit to the proper order.”

Countless arrows emitted light and flew toward her.

I created a <Barrier> in the air and blocked the arrows that were shot at Pluto.

My countless <Barriers> overlapped and collided with the arrows that flew at me.

Kwang! Zhezhezhek.

The <Barriers> that were hit by the arrows crumbled, but I created new ones beyond them.

-You used <Barrier>.

-You used <Barrier>.

-You used <Barrier>.

My skill control, which I had honed for a long time, was not bad at all.

The spectacle of <Barriers> that the human macro poured out was enough to block the enemy's attack.

As I blocked the pattern that was made to pressure Pluto by myself, a smile burst out from my lips that were using skills.

I laughed as I thought of the goddess who was spouting nonsense.

“Shut up. I am the order.”

Tuduk. Tuk. Tuk. Tuk.

I tapped the skill icons and blocked the goddess's attacks one after another.

Crack. The fragments of the broken <Barriers> scattered star dust beyond the screen.

Before I knew it, I had accidentally pressed the <Voice> skill along with it, and a mechanical voice flowed from the speaker.

-“I am the order.”

-“That's a good word for you, my lord.”

Pluto smiled and accelerated even more than before.

Logracion was the stage that I had prepared for her.

The brightest thing in this stage had to be my apostles.

Otherwise, everything I had poured out until now would lose its meaning.

I gave wings to Pluto's back as he moved forward.

My trailing touch became a shield to protect her, and my pressing sparkle became a blade to trap the enemy.

-“—Deathscythe.”

Kwang!

Darkness shot out from behind Pluto who was accelerating.

A crack opened in front of the spreading darkness, and the crack swallowed Philrun.

Philrun, who was mixed with Logracion's ash, shivered and pushed away the crack.

Zhezhezhezek.

One of his wings made of light burst and a huge speech bubble popped out and covered the screen.

-“Oh goddess!!! Save me!!!”

He shook his pitiful outer wing and widened his eyes.

It was the biggest speech bubble I had ever seen.

It was so big that even though I only saw it with my eyes, I could feel his intense emotion.

Of course, I had no intention of watching his pathetic struggle until the end.

Pluto, who cut through the darkness and moved forward, was already in front of him.

-“Hello.”

Deathscythe tilted greatly and throbbed once.

Kieek.

The reaper who appeared behind her laughed at him.

It was a sight I had never seen before.

The reaper who appeared as the effect of [Divine Weapon: Deathscythe] was mocking the enemy.

-“Guide me!!!”

-“—Deathscythe.”

His arm, fully tilted, swung at Philrun from a close distance.

Kwaaaaang!

A loud explosion and countless beams of light burst out from there.

Under the scattered light, Pluto and Philrun’s faces froze at the same time.

A black and white world where only shadows existed.

As red blood splashed, a new message appeared at the bottom of the screen.

-[Divine Weapon: Clawsolas] has been destroyed.

-[Divine Weapon: Deathscythe] has grown.

Chapter 159: Beings of the Ancient Era (5)

Chapter 159: Beings of the Ancient Era (5)

The Third Apostle, Pluto Austria.

She looked at the scene before her eyes with a hint of defeat.

She had tried to cut down Philrun, the hero of order, in one strike.

That was what she had intended to do.

But for some reason, her scythe was bound by a chain of light, and it stopped in front of Philrun's arm.

Pluto quickly turned her eyes to the direction where the chain came from.

“——O Goddess, guide me on the path.”

There was a girl in a priestess's robe, looking down at Pluto.

She had one eye hidden by her neatly cut hair, and the other eye was staring at Pluto.

The chain that tied Pluto's Death Scythe was attached to the girl's right hand.

A dense aura of divine power was swirling around the girl who recited a prayer.

The girl who blocked Pluto's attack glanced at her for a moment, then turned her gaze to Philrun.

“Cl, Clawsolas! No! The legendary weapon given to the hero……!”

Philrun was bleeding from his right arm, holding the hilt of Clawsolas that had disappeared.

Clawsolas, shattered by Pluto, had lost its light and left only its traces.

He looked at the hilt in his hand with a blank expression.

Although she failed to deal with Philrun due to the girl's interference, she succeeded in destroying all six wings that Philrun had.

The unidentified girl opened her mouth to Philrun, who was mumbling while looking at the broken divine artifact.

“You're so noisy. I came here to save you myself, so stop whining.”

With that, the girl's eyes turned back to Pluto.

The tightly pulled chain of light was trying to hold Pluto's movement.

But the advantage of strength was clearly on Pluto's side.

Pluto maintained a standoff with her Death Scythe and spoke to the girl.

“……Who are you?”

The density of divine power coming from the girl was thicker than that of Philrun in front of her.

Anyone could tell that she was related to the temple.

As Pluto slowly pulled her Death Scythe, the girl frowned and answered.

“The Saintess of Order, Eileen Asnoff.”

“The Saintess of Order?”

“So you are one of the apostles of the evil god, huh? You look like a vampire, not a human.”

The Saintess of Order.

She was supposed to be in the holy land, but she had arrived at the northern part of the empire.

It was a surprise for Pluto as well that the saintess Eileen had stepped forward.

Was it because he heard the word saintess from her mouth?

Philrun shouted at Eileen with a desperate voice.

“You said you are the Saintess of Order? You can fix my broken divine artifact, right? Can’t you?”

“What are you talking about? I can’t fix a broken divine artifact either.”

“What……?”

But what came back from Eileen was a negative answer.

Thud.

Philrun’s hand lost its strength and he dropped Clawsolas.

As the hilt of Clawsolas dug into the snow, Eileen’s voice echoed on the battlefield.

“I can’t hold out for long against an apostle either. You should be glad that you can escape alive.”

“Then, what should I do now……?”

“Isn’t it your duty as a hero to defeat the apostle? What do you expect from me when you can’t even do your own job?”

Pluto, who was watching their conversation, twisted her hand holding Death Scythe with more force.

Crack. Thud.

The chain that bound Death Scythe cracked and its restraining power gradually loosened.

Eileen, who was holding the chain, furrowed her brow even more.

She calmly declared that she would run away from the apostle.

Unfortunately for her, Pluto had no intention of letting the two people in front of her go.

“Do you think I’ll let you go?”

“We have to make it happen somehow.”

Crack.

The chain that bound Death Scythe broke, and particles of divine power scattered around.

Beyond the scattering light, Pluto and Eileen’s eyes met in midair.

As their eyes clashed, Eileen raised her left hand in the air.

She clasped her hands and took a stance, then began to pray in a low voice.

“——Life. Follow the natural order.”

“I won’t miss either of you.”

“——One order. One rule. Obey the great providence.”

As the prayer continued, light spread and pillars of light began to pierce the ground.

Eileen was clearly up to something to stop Pluto.

Pluto swung Death Scythe quickly at the falling pillars of light.

Clang! Clang!

She smashed several of the dense pillars of light, then ran towards Eileen.

She decided that it was more important to deal with Eileen first than Philrun, who had lost his divine artifact.

“——One order. One law. Obey the great principle.”

Thud thud thud.

As Pluto tore through the snow and tried to close in on Eileen.

Eileen joined her two hands together.

Her palms touched and a cube of light began to form around Pluto.

The dense divine power was not something that Pluto could penetrate with her mist form.

Seeing the cube that was meant to trap her, Pluto twisted her body and swung her scythe.

Clack! Clack clack clack!

Pluto's scythe scraped the side of the cube and stopped in place.

“Let's run away while we have this chance.”

While Pluto was swinging her scythe in the cube that trapped her, Eileen reached out with a chain of light and wrapped it around Philrun.

Swoosh.

Philrun, who was quickly entangled by the chain, blinked his eyes with a bewildered expression.

Eileen's action was not a normal way to rescue him.

Philrun, who was bound by the chain, stuttered and struggled.

“Wh, what, wait, what are you doing…….”

“We don't have time for chit-chat. Come with me.”

“What?”

“Divine power doesn't last long in the sanctuary of the evil god!”

Eileen was trying to run away with Philrun in tow.

As Eileen jumped over the trees busily, Philrun's body was dragged along by the chain.

Clang! Clatter!

Pluto, who was trapped in the cube and swinging her scythe, watched them and gritted her teeth.

The cube cracked every time she swung her scythe, but at this rate, she would lose sight of her enemies.

The barrier that her master created also shattered under the goddess's attack.

“……I can't let them get away like this.”

Snap.

Pluto raised her left hand and flicked her finger in the air.

The bloodstains on the ground resonated and traced the signs of life.

Blood magic. The power of bloodline granted to vampires was taking effect.

Pluto's blood magic was targeting Philrun, who was bleeding from his right arm.

The blood that came out of his skin was under Pluto's influence.

“Why are you doing this? I wish you would stop squirming.”

“Wa, wait, my arm is weird…….”

Boom!

The blood exploded by blood magic and Philrun's right arm blew off.

The golden candlestick that created the sanctuary also fell far away and buried in the snow.

With a loud noise, Philrun's right arm disappeared and he twisted his body and screamed.

His hoarse voice echoed over the snow stained with blood.

“Aaaah! Aaaaaah!”

“Ugh…….”

The smell of blood was spreading clearly with the wind.

If she followed the smell of blood, she could chase after the fleeing ones.

Pluto, who was looking at Philrun screaming, swung her scythe again.

Clang! Clang!

Every time Pluto swung her scythe, cracks appeared on the sturdy cube.

‘Just a little more.’

The cracks widened around the area where the scythe hit.

She felt that the cube would collapse if she swung a little more.

And when the cube broke, the fleeing prey would be chased by Pluto again.

“My arm, my arm……!”

In the snowstorm of Alterias forest, Eileen frowned at Philrun who was shrieking.

She didn’t like him from the first time she met him until now.

She was annoyed by his whining against the apostle as a hero, and by his complaining after breaking his divine artifact.

But what made her feel worse was his screaming while running away.

Screaming while running away was a stupid thing to do that was no different from telling the enemy their location.

“Be quiet. The trap has been activated, so we should be fine for a while.”

As much as she had to carry the stupid hero who revealed their location, Eileen set up traps along the way as she ran away.

The traps were designed to trap the enemy with divine power when they approached.

Of course, since they were hastily made, they couldn’t hold them for long, but they could buy some time.

Using the timing of the activation, Eileen tried to gauge the distance between her and the enemy.

“My, my arm……!”

“Really… I feel like leaving you somewhere and going away.”

While Eileen was racking her brain and planning, Philrun was flailing and screaming mindlessly.

Eileen dragged him along and complained.

There was a limit to the body enhanced by divine power.

And because she had to drag the injured Philrun, Eileen’s speed was slowing down.

It seemed impossible to shake off Pluto who was running at full speed with her mist form.

“Sister… my arm, my arm hurts…….”

“We’re almost out of the evil god’s sanctuary… we can’t go on like this.”

The enemy was a vampire who could ignore most of the physical laws in her mist form.

It was hard to gain the upper hand in speed on the snow-covered ground that hindered her movement.

She needed to buy some time properly in this situation.

She had an unused sanctuary proclamation left.

The apostle of the evil god was blindly chasing after them, so she had to take advantage of this and gain a huge benefit.

“I have to suppress her once in the sanctuary and buy some time before I go.”

“Ugh…….”

“If the goddess helps us, we can buy some time to some extent.”

She couldn't trust the hero, but she could trust the goddess.

She was a priestess who served the god.

If the goddess of order struck a powerful blow, the vampire wouldn't be able to move properly for a while.

Even if she was an apostle, she didn't have resistance to divine punishment.

A vampire who was sensitive to divine power would be more affected by divine punishment.

She wanted to widen the distance as much as possible with that time.

“Of all people, the hero who has to buy time is like this... I'm in this mess too.”

Eileen decided and swung the chain to bury Philrun in the snow.

Thud.

Philrun, who was buried in the snow, screamed and stretched his remaining arm to the sky.

Eileen moved her steps towards him.

“Aah!”

And then she started to sprinkle snow on top of him.

She wanted to bury him with snow.

Philrun's eyes widened as the snow touched his bleeding wound.

Eileen's palm also sprinkled snowflakes on Philrun's face that widened his eyes.

A large snowball rolled down the slope and fell next to Philrun.

Eileen muttered something she wouldn't have said if she was in the temple as she watched Philrun being buried by snow.

“To be honest, I wish he would just die like this. I wish we could pick another hero if possible.”

“Sister, it hurts, okay? Why are you burying a hurt person in snow……!”

“It seems like you'll die if your blood explodes again. I'm trying to save you, so be grateful.”

Eileen was sincere.

She saw him explode his blood from afar, and if she faced him up close, he might die.

It would be a big loss for Eileen too if blood splashed on her.

She sincerely buried Philrun and dusted off her reddened palm.

Her palm felt cold because she touched the snow with her bare hand.

“O goddess. Guide me on the way.”

She looked at the snow pile that barely left his breath and recited a short prayer.

She had already prepared a trap to hold the apostle in place for a while.

Now she had to complete the prayer for the proclamation of the sanctuary before the apostle arrived.

Eileen clasped her hands and began to recite the prayer.

She felt a cold sensation from her joined hands.

“——Guide me on the way. Let your lamb find the right path.”

The foundation of divine power was faith and prayer.

To proclaim the great god's sanctuary, she had to pray beforehand.

This was her preparation for the apostle who was coming to her.

Prayer caught the god's attention, and faith turned the god's heart.

Golden light gradually bloomed around Eileen, who appealed to the god.

“——Do not stray from the path even in hard trials.”

Eileen looked ahead with her eyes slightly open as she recited the prayer.

She felt a presence approaching from far away, heading towards where she was.

She saw the apostle who was confronting her.

The apostle, wrapped in black mist, was coming at a speed beyond human.

Pluto was fine even after passing several of Eileen's traps.

She couldn't hurt her with traps that were hastily made.

“There you are.”

As the distance got closer, Pluto's voice became clearer.

The apostle seemed angry at their escape, and ran without calming down.

Eileen's eyes narrowed as she watched Pluto's distance.

She was coming straight to where the trap was.

Unlike other traps, this one was made with some effort.

She was confident that she could hold her for a while if she entered the trap.

Enough time for the great goddess to stab divine punishment into the evil apostle.

“You’re already here.”

“……The saint of order.”

Eileen greeted Pluto briefly as she approached and opened her mouth with her hands clasped.

The moment the apostle of the evil god stepped into the range of the sanctuary.

It was the prayer she had prepared for that one moment.

When Pluto entered the range that Eileen had expected, Eileen proclaimed to the creatures on the ground.

She proclaimed the sanctuary of the goddess of order here.

“Sanctuary Proclamation—— Eustia Saint.”

The golden domain spread and everything around it was dyed in gold.

The great domain of light governed by the goddess of order.

The power of the evil god wouldn’t work properly here.

The vampire in front of her had entered deeply in excitement, but the evil god had already proclaimed the sanctuary not long ago.

She needed time to proclaim the sanctuary again.

“You made another sanctuary……?”

Clang.

Pluto’s foot stepped on the trap engraved on the bottom of the sanctuary.

As Pluto's foot touched the trap, the divine power around it intertwined and created a huge cage.

It was a cage to block the apostle's movement for a moment.

Pluto was trapped in the middle of the cage that was formed in an instant.

Eileen smiled at Pluto who stepped on the trap.

She only needed a very short time until divine punishment fell.

"There, it's a trap."

"Ah....."

A huge spear of light fell on Pluto's head in the cage.

The god's strike that was condensed with immense divine power.

Anyone who was hit by that attack wouldn't survive.

Pluto tried to block the attack, swinging her divine artifact in her hand.

But the chain of light that came out of the cage predicted Pluto's movement as well.

"You can't avoid this, can you?"

".....!"

She needed at least some time to cut off the chain of light.

A huge spear of light pierced Pluto's head who was restrained by her hand.

It was impossible for the bound apostle to avoid divine punishment.

Kwaaaaaang——!

A huge amount of light burst out in front of Eileen with a roar that shook the heavens and earth.

The wind swirled around the spear that touched the ground, shaking her bangs.

Eileen cheered as she watched the light spread.

“Thank you. Merciful goddess.”

She felt like she heard the apostle’s scream from the vibration in her ears.

Kugugugung.

The trembling earth slowly settled down with the light.

The blinding storm of divine power also gradually subsided with the vibration.

Eileen looked at Pluto’s figure beyond the fading light.

Pluto’s appearance in the cage was greatly different from before.

The red blood streak flowing down her forehead was the first proof of that.

“.....This is troublesome.”

Pluto glared at her with fierce eyes, soaked in blood.

The wounded vampire was staggering and bleeding, as if she had lost her strength.

Divine power was almost opposite to the cold energy.

The divine punishment of the goddess, which contained the most intense divine power. The vampire who was hit by it couldn’t be fine.

It wouldn’t be strange if she fainted if she was hit by divine punishment again.

It was a misfortune that happened because she chased after Philrun and herself recklessly.

Eileen looked at Pluto, who smelled of blood, and spoke confidently.

“You should have just let us go.”

“It’s hard to control myself when I’m like this…”

“What are you saying?”

Eileen doubted her ears at the words that came out of Pluto’s mouth.

Pluto looked like she would collapse at any moment.

But she said it was hard to control herself in this state.

What did she mean by that?

Eileen tilted her head at the incomprehensible words, and Pluto sent her a slanted gaze.

She felt a creepy aura from her red eyes soaked in blood.

“I lose my reason when I bleed too much.”

“You lose your reason…?”

Right after the short question came out of her mouth.

The blood that flowed down Pluto’s head began to coagulate in the air.

It stuck together and formed a crown shape above Pluto’s head.

A thorny crown made of hardened blood.

Pluto’s red eyes stared at Eileen as she wore the crown of blood on her head.

Blood kept pouring out of Pluto's wound, who wore the crown upside down.

Eileen felt a different and alien atmosphere from her than before.

"I don't even remember myself well when I'm like this."

The world was dyed in blood.

In it, she had dark red wings of blood on her back.

A red monster that radiated a sinister light in the blood-red world.

A thick bloodlust spread throughout the space.

The person in front of her was essentially different from a weak human.

She was a king.

She was a royal bloodline that existed to be at the top of everything from birth.

"What, what is this……."

"I didn't want to show you this, your highness."

The thick smell of blood.

The spreading scent of blood.

The snowfield dyed with blood was stuck in Eileen's mind.

She felt like her stomach would turn over from the endless smell of blood.

Everything she had swallowed for a day was stirring to reflux.

No matter how much she smelled it, she felt like she would never get used to it.

“Ugh, ugh…….”

Then Eileen realized.

For the ancient monster, the evil god’s assistance was nothing more than a nice thing to have.

The apostle in front of her didn’t follow her into the sanctuary because she was lured by excitement.

She followed her because she was there.

She had the confidence to tear and kill the wounded prey with her own hands, breaking through the goddess’s restraint in the sanctuary.

Chapter 160: Beings of the Ancient Era (6)

Beings of the Ancient Era (6)

-“I didn’t want to show you…….”

-“This side of me…….”

The voice that echoed in her ears faded away.

The dizzying scenery and the shaking voice.

They were both hard to face with a clear mind.

Her bloodshot eyes barely captured Pluto’s change in her sight.

“Ugh…….”

The monster with spread wings looked at her.

Eileen, who was watching him, reflexively brought her hand to her eyes.

Something seemed wrong with her eyes that were looking at Pluto.

Her hand that stroked her eyelids with blood tears stopped in place.

She quickly changed her mind at the blood drops that flowed down her hand.

-“…….”

The problem was in her head.

There was a gap between perception and sensation.

Her head that feared something couldn't draw the scenery that reflected in her eyes properly.

“What am I seeing?”

The distorted law twisted her perception.

What she saw and what she heard were different.

What she heard and what she saw were different.

In the contradictory senses, the shadow of the black monster overlapped.

-“You are…….”

Everything that reflected in her eyes blinked with red light.

It was an incomprehensible sight.

And it was a sight that shouldn't be understood.

The dazzling golden sanctuary was dominated by a being from the opposite heaven.

On the carpet of blood that thickly covered, the king of vampires stared at her.

-“Are you afraid?”

Crack——.

The golden wave that spread out cleared the gap in her perception for a moment.

On the red carpet drawn by the progenitor's blood.

There were countless blood ghosts marching there.

The traces of their dried and twisted flesh told them that they had never been given rest for a long time.

They were foolish and ignorant ones who sold their souls for the eternal covenant.

-“Squeeeeeeeak.”

They bowed to their king and sang praises with their torn throats.

A bizarre scream echoed everywhere.

The vampires who had lost their flesh long ago played a march with their own necks as instruments.

The nauseating and strange march resounded over the fading sanctuary.

-“Bow to the great Astria.”

-“Bow to the great Astria.”

-“Bow to the great Astria.”

-“Bow to the great Astria.”

-“Bow to the great Astria.”

The ghosts crawling on the ground prostrated themselves and bowed to their king.

The souls that lost their light were never free even in death.

Their king was always one and only.

The ancient being who wore the crown of blood upside down.

The supreme predator who had existed since before human history ruled over them.

-“Are you afraid?”

“.....”

The progenitor of vampires does not die.

The heroes of the past knew that, so they sealed her.

Yes. The heroes sealed her.

After realizing that they couldn't kill her with their own hands.

Now it was Eileen's turn to realize that fact.

It was impossible for even the great heroes and powerful divine artifacts to give eternal rest to the progenitor.

-“Are you afraid?”

Pluto Astria never dies.

When her thin life lost its meaning, she just stopped there for a moment.

As long as time passed, the progenitor of vampires would return to her throne again and again.

The end was a concept that was not allowed for the cursed being.

-“Are you afraid because you can't kill me?”

The face that lost its color asked Eileen.

She could hear his voice even without opening his mouth.

His whisper was stuck in her mind endlessly.

She closed her eyes tightly, covered her ears with her hands, and told herself to run away from the sight in front of her.

She was denying the reality that was full of negativity.

“I am…….”

Was she afraid of the sight in front of her?

Of course, it would be a lie if she wasn’t.

It was disgusting. It made her nauseous. She wanted to look away.

The ghosts who swallowed divine punishment with their mouths open were more than grotesque, they gave her goosebumps.

But she knew that as soon as she spat it out, everything would be over.

She needed a lie to deceive herself right now.

“……I’m not afraid.”

Eileen answered his question with a trembling voice.

Eileen Asnoff.

She was a saint chosen by the goddess of order.

Even if she was afraid of the sight in front of her, she couldn’t turn her eyes away from it.

She had to face it and fight it head-on.

Even if her body rejected it, her soul had to remain pure and illuminate the darkness.

“——O goddess, guide me on the way.”

As her perception was being overwritten, Eileen clasped her hands and knelt down.

It was time to pray.

The only thing she could do now was to pray.

From the beginning to the end. Even in the last moment, she had to pray with faith.

That was the only duty given to the saint.

“——Let your lamb find the right path.”

She opened her small lips and cried out for salvation to the sky.

She tied herself under the huge pillar of faith, not to be shaken.

The firm faith in the goddess was the only support that had kept Eileen until now.

“——Do not stray from the path even in hard trials.”

A golden wave spread from her clasped hands.

The great grace that swept over her body warmly embraced her.

As she felt the warmth from the depths of her chest, she was about to close her eyes.

A red shadow loomed behind her who was praying.

The progenitor of vampires who had approached close grabbed her shoulder.

-“Ah.”

Crunch.

She felt a sharp pain in her neck.

The progenitor's fangs had dug into her neck.

Hot blood gushed and flowed down her neck.

The progenitor slowly sucked Eileen's blood that flowed out.

Eileen prayed while trying not to lose her calm as she was being drained.

“——Overcome hardship and trial.”

-“Are you afraid of not seeing the light?”

It was a ridiculous question.

She was not afraid of not seeing the light.

The brightest light was always in her heart.

“——Let the holy light drive away the darkness.”

-“Are you afraid of not facing the sun?”

She was not afraid of the sun hiding its face.

Someday, the brilliant sun would rise and chase away the darkness.

The night was long but not eternal.

“——Make me obey under the great order.”

-“Are you afraid of death?”

Death couldn't stop her faith.

The ones who sacrificed for faith would be given the most sublime rest.

They had to be given.

It was given——.

No, it had to be given.

It had, to, be given——.

“Ah…….”

Something was wrong.

Her train of thought was broken somewhere.

She felt a sense of discomfort and realized that her prayer had stopped.

No more prayers came out of her blankly opened mouth.

-“Are you afraid?”

She saw a finger soaked in red blood in front of her eyes.

The blood drops that fell from the thin finger smelled sweet for some reason.

Eileen’s lips trembled as she looked at the blood drops.

She wanted to drink. She wanted to quench her thirst.

An impulsive thought shook Eileen’s mind.

-“It’s okay if you run away.”

The red blood drop on the finger was undoubtedly the progenitor’s.

The one who bled in front of her eyes was none other than the progenitor who was hit by divine punishment.

What would happen if she drank the progenitor’s blood?

The result was proven by the ghosts crawling on the floor.

It was a stupid thing to eat the blood.

Both flesh and soul would be forever enslaved under the progenitor's rule.

"I have to pray."

Pray. She had to pray.

To purify her tainted thoughts, she had to pray to the goddess.

She clasped her hands and opened her mouth.

She had to pray and prove her faith for the goddess.

"I have to pray, but……."

But no more prayers came out of her mouth.

She had to pray, but she couldn't remember the prayers.

She couldn't recall any of the scriptures she had read for a long time.

She had fallen into a worse state than she had expected.

"Ugh……."

If she had known this, she would have brought a holy relic for mental defense.

But there was no way to turn back time, even if she regretted it later.

The power of the progenitor was too great to resist with her own strength.

"It looks delicious……"

She saw the blood drops falling in her narrowing sight.

The sweet smell shook her nose.

She had long forgotten about praying.

She wanted to drink. She wanted to quench her thirst.

Only a strong impulse remained in Eileen's mind.

Eileen slowly opened her lips as she looked at the blood drops.

-“It's okay if you run away.”

Eileen opened her trembling mouth and brought her tongue close to the finger soaked in blood.

The moment Eileen's tongue touched Pluto's blood drop.

Boom—.

The golden sanctuary collapsed completely.

The holy land, Crossbridge.

On the top floor of the knight order building next to the holy palace, there was a room for the knight commander only.

A place that encompassed all the dangers and possibilities of the continent.

The jewels that shone in various colors indicated whether each danger was managed properly.

The knight commander, Abelz, looked at them every day and checked the upcoming dangers.

“.....”

Today was no different.

He finished his training and entered his room as usual and checked each jewel on the wall.

And he noticed that two of the jewels he had inspected had changed.

The jewels at the top of the map.

Two jewels that would normally shine with a brilliant golden light had changed.

Abelz's face darkened in an instant as he knew the meaning of the jewels.

“The hero of order is dead……?”

The jewels at the top symbolized two people who were the pillars of each temple.

The golden jewels reflected in Abelz's eyes were both lost their light.

One of the jewels that lost their light was still intact in appearance, and the other one was completely shattered.

There was only one thing that the broken jewel meant.

The hero of order was dead.

And that was for those who belonged to the order.

“He never came to the temple until the end, and ended up like this.”

The hero of order didn't come to the holy land even though he received the mark.

The temple of order also gave up on finding him long ago after receiving the trust.

It was inevitable that the hero of order died in a battle somewhere Abelz didn't know.

But he couldn't understand what happened to the saint of order.

“And what is happening to the saint of order…?”

There was no possibility that something went wrong with the saint of order in the holy land.

Crossbridge was a place wrapped in a sacred barrier that even evil gods couldn't peek into.

And now, even Arien Crost was staying in the holy land.

If an intruder had entered in such a situation, a report would have come up sooner or later.

So it was more likely that something happened outside the holy land.

“She must not have died. But somehow the connection was blocked. Considering Eileen Asnoff's personality, the possibility of betrayal was low, but…….”

Abelz bit his lips and opened the drawer.

He wanted to check the suspicious part himself.

The permission to leave the holy land for the main figures of the sanctuary had to be stamped by the knight commander, Abelz, in the end.

As far as Abelz Ederunt knew, he had no memory of stamping the document for the saint's departure.

Had there been a time when the saint's departure was approved without reporting to him recently?

Abelz put the documents in the drawer on the desk and started to flip through them one by one.

“The blue holy sword. The divine artifact Astria. The black holy sword. The divine artifact Astria. And…….”

Rustle.

The sound of turning paper echoed in the quiet office.

Abelz carefully turned the pages and checked the contents of the documents.

And when Abelz turned the last paper of the pile of documents he had stacked.

He found something and made a disappointed expression.

“This is crazy.”

A permission to leave with only the saint’s name written on it, without any accompanying escort.

There were the stamps of the knight commander and the holy emperor on it.

Chapter 161: Kidnapping the Saintess (1)

Chapter 161: Kidnapping the Saintess (1)

I had just finished a boss battle with Pluto, who was dispatched to the north with me.

It was a smooth victory, except for a few times when I almost let the bosses escape because of my poor control.

But in the end, Pluto managed to use her abilities and solve the problem.

She lived up to her name as the progenitor of vampires.

I didn't know how she did it, but I could tell that she was on a different level than the other characters.

“Having one well-raised OP character is really important.”

After clearing the boss battle with Pluto, I was preparing to cook some ramen.

I wanted to go to bed early today, but my heart was still racing from the fight.

Since I wasn't sleepy and hungry, I decided to make some ramen for a late-night snack.

Zzip.

I tore open the ramen package and took out the noodles and soup powder. Then I looked for a pot to boil some water.

“Pot, pot... I put it here.”

I had been eating cup noodles more than bag noodles lately, so I had stored the pot under the cabinet. I found it and placed it on the sink.

Thud.

As I put down the pot and turned my head, I saw a pile of ramen boxes in the corner. I had a lot of ramen left from the last time I bought them, so I could survive on ramen for a while.

“I feel like I’ve been eating ramen a lot these days.”

I had increased my ramen consumption recently.

Especially since I started playing a mobile game.

I often chose to spend money on the game rather than on food.

Of course, I had always been lazy and skipped meals with ramen before.

Ramen was an essential item for someone like me.

“Well, who cares about food? Our second daughter is full enough.”

Second daughter.

That was the nickname I gave to Pluto, who single-handedly defeated two boss monsters this time.

We gained a lot from this battle, thanks to her.

Of course, the first daughter was Eutenia.

Pluto brought us a lot of benefits this time, but the glorious first place was always Eutenia’s.

As I muttered nonsense to myself and tried to fill the pot with water, I suddenly encountered a serious problem that made me panic.

“I should eat ramen and watch TV... Huh?”

Click. Click.

No water came out of the sink when I turned on the faucet.

I tried moving the lever a few more times, just in case, but there was no sign of water flowing from the sink.

I frowned at the suddenly cut-off water.

It was a frustrating situation when I wanted to cook ramen but the water stopped.

“Why is there no water all of a sudden? Is the water broken?”

I was hungry but there was no water.

Annoyed, I recalled a wise saying I heard from the sages in the past.

If there is a problem with the device, hit it once.

It was a famous quote from Thomas Edison, the great inventor who invented the light bulb.

I followed Edison’s advice and slammed the faucet with my palm.

Thump.

When I hit the faucet with my hand, water finally burst out of it.

“Edison bro is awesome.”

Swoosh.

I caught the gushing water in the pot and turned on the gas stove to put the pot on it.

Now all I had to do was wait for the water to boil.

It was a boring fight with patience for a while.

“Maybe I’ll watch TV for a bit.”

As I started to boil the water, I turned my head to look at the TV screen.

The TV was on, showing the news. I must have left it on the news channel last time.

As I watched the news, a map of Africa appeared on the screen with the anchor.

It was another news about Africa, which I had seen a lot lately on TV.

-“South Africa continues to appeal for international support in its situation.”

“Another Africa problem. I guess they still haven’t solved it.”

It had been quite a while since the problem was first reported.

Usually, by this time, there should have been some progress, but there was hardly any hopeful news from Africa.

Instead, they were spewing out negative reports every day.

As if they were waiting for the African countries to collapse.

There were so many reports on the media that sometimes they mixed up the order of the stories.

-“In Congo Republic, a 15-kilometer-long column of refugees is trying to cross the border...”

-“In Somalia, ships are being attacked daily...”

-“Egypt decides to block the Suez Canal...”

They were all headache-inducing stories.

They were not easy to solve, that was for sure.

The window of opportunity for a quick resolution had passed long ago.

I sighed involuntarily as I watched the news.

“How did it get like this...”

On the other side of the world, countless people were dying every day.

Of course, I didn’t feel it as real that people were dying on the other side of the world.

But I knew that fact, and it made me feel sad in my heart.

That was all.

The only thing I could do for them was to offer them a short consolation that would never reach them.

“...”

Sssssssssssssssssssssssssssssss—

I was lost in thought for a moment with the sound of fire in my ears.

People die somewhere even when you don’t know.

Even when you sit at home and watch TV.

Even when you lie in bed and play games.

Unaware, countless people were dying.

Maybe even when you know——.

“——They are fleeting lives.”

Sssssssssssssssssssssssssssssss.

I came to my senses with the sound of boiling water.

I looked at the pot I had filled with water, and saw bubbles rising.

“Ah...”

The water had boiled enough to put in the noodles.

I must have been too engrossed in the TV.

I had been thinking about something I wouldn't normally think about.

“The water is boiling. I should put in the soup first.”

Eating was more important than worrying.

Splash.

I tore open the soup packet and poured it into the pot.

The holy land of the Order.

On top of Uto, floating in the air, Pluto looked ahead with a troubled face.

Next to Pluto, there was a girl who didn't belong here.

The Saintess of Order, Eileen Asnoff.

She was at odds with the Order, and she blinked her red eyes as she stood by Pluto's side.

Eileen's eyes were full of complex emotions as she looked at Pluto.

“Pluto.”

Eileen stood up with a humble posture and opened her mouth to Pluto, who was sitting down.

She was polite as if she was hosting a guest, which was unimaginable a few days ago.

But Pluto's expression was sour as he listened to her.

Pluto's gaze didn't leave the wine glass that Eileen had brought.

The glass filled with red blood was Eileen's own blood that she had prepared.

"It's not to your liking."

"...Is that so. I'm sorry."

"Of course, it's not your fault. It's the vessel that the goddess prepared herself, so it's natural that it has a hard-to-bear smell."

Pluto said that, but he still looked at the wine glass with regret.

Right after the battle ended, Pluto had to face a new kin that he had unknowingly created.

She had fed her blood to Eileen, who was a saintess, and turned her into a vampire.

She was the first vampire she had made by feeding her blood since she woke up from the call of the great being.

And it was something that happened while she was unconscious, so it was a shocking event for Pluto.

After that, Pluto learned the details of what had happened from Eileen, who had become a vampire.

"..."

Pluto, who had lost consciousness and gone berserk, sank her fangs into Eileen.

And then she tempted her to drink her blood.

That was the whole story that Eileen told him.

She had bitten the saintess, the crystallization of divine power.

It was almost laughable to hear.

“I’m really sorry.”

Pluto felt nauseous whenever she got close to divine power.

But she had pierced her fangs and sucked blood from that overwhelming divine power in front of him.

It was not something she could do in her right mind.

She tried to drink Eileen’s blood out of curiosity, but it was as bad as she had expected.

Even after she became a vampire, the bitter smell that flowed through her blood did not disappear completely.

The more she thought about it, the more ashamed she felt of herself for enjoying such a grotesque feast.

“...I told you it’s not something you need to apologize for.”

Pluto raised her hand to stop Eileen from apologizing again, and threw the wine glass to the ground, spilling the blood.

Rumble.

For some reason, she felt the ground shake a little where the blood was sprinkled.

She ignored it and moved on, when Eileen, who was standing next to her, squeezed her shoulder and spoke.

“Pluto is merciful.”

“Do you really think so?”

“I wouldn’t have known in the past, but I think I can understand now.”

Glance.

Pluto glanced at Eileen, who was squeezing his shoulder.

Many of those who received thick blood from their kin could not bear the power and went mad, but Eileen showed no signs of that yet.

Rather, she seemed to have adapted too well, and was showing an overly familiar attitude towards Pluto.

The instinct that flowed with the blood affected Eileen’s reason as well.

The kin always loved their progenitor, devoted themselves to her, and swore loyalty to her.

Eileen, who had become a vampire, could not escape from that rule either.

“Hey, Eileen.”

“Yes.”

“You said you were a saintess of the temple, right?”

“I was serving as a saintess in the Temple of Order.”

But becoming a vampire did not erase all the memories and experiences they had accumulated in their lives.

Only their nature had changed.

And that was something that Pluto could use to her advantage.

Eileen's memories that did not disappear.

There must be countless treasures hidden in them.

"Then will you tell me?"

"What do you want to know?"

"The important stories that the temple hid. Can you tell me all of them?"

The countless secrets of the temple that only the saintess knew.

It was time to dig them up.

"If it's Pluto's request, I have no choice but to comply."

Chapter 162: Kidnapping the Saintess (2)

Chapter 162: Kidnapping the Saintess (2)

At the Temple of Harmony, located in Crossbridge, Naias was looking at the saintess with her eyes closed.

The Saintess of Harmony, Laiteria.

She was praying to the sky with her eyes tightly shut.

The Saintess of Harmony was famous for not showing her eyes behind her eyelids.

She kept her eyes closed at all times, not just when she prayed.

She was a blind person with a congenital vision impairment.

“...”

But everyone in the Temple of Harmony respected Laiteria.

She was more blind because she couldn't see.

She revered and praised the god more deeply and strongly than anyone else.

Laiteria's strong faith made her worthy of being the Saintess of Harmony.

Laiteria, who became a saintess, also had a power that suited her position.

The sight that saw the future's convenience.

And the Divine Grace that told the flow of the world.

All those things made Laiteria's position solid.

"Naias."

"Yes, Laiteria."

Laiteria lowered her hands and called Naias' name after a long prayer.

Naias responded to her call and got up from his seat and walked closer to her.

Thump. Thump.

Every time she took a step, a heavy sound that didn't match her appearance echoed.

Naias quickly moved to Laiteria and bowed in front of her.

The saintess in front of him was a person who deserved respect in Naias' eyes.

When Naias stood right in front of Laiteria, she finally raised her hand and stroked his cheek.

It was an act to understand and recognize the other's shape and existence.

She stroked Naias's cheek and told him the reason for her long prayer.

"I received a Divine Grace from the goddess."

"A Divine Grace?"

Divine Grace.

It was a revelation that only the chosen saintesses could receive, but Laiteria's Divine Grace was different from the others.

Naias tensed up as he heard the important news.

He had to engrave the following stories in his ears.

He listened to her words, and Laiteria slowly continued with the content of the Divine Grace.

“A storm is coming.”

“A storm?”

“The goddess of order made a dangerous decision. I think the world will be very noisy soon.”

Naias looked at Laiteria with a puzzled face as he heard about the Divine Grace.

The goddesses often gave incomprehensible Divine Graces.

But what Laiteria was saying now was very surprising to Naias.

The goddess of order made a dangerous decision.

It was a story that might be protested as blasphemy if he heard it from the temple of order.

“...That’s a sensitive story.”

“That’s why I’m telling you only. It’s not something I can tell anyone else.”

The holy land was composed of six temples, but the influence that one temple could have on another was not very great.

At best, only the temple of abundance could exert some minor pressure by flaunting its wealth.

In such a situation, he couldn’t bring up this story to another temple.

The saintess’s choice to tell only Naias was wise in its own way.

“Alright. It’s better if I’m the only one who hears it.”

“Thank you, Naias.”

“Don’t mention it.”

It was only the Temple of Harmony that would suffer from this mess.

The elders already hated the Temple of Harmony, and it was not good to have a problem.

Naias nodded his head and waited for Laiteria’s next story, and she rubbed his cheek with her thumb and said.

“We also need to prepare for the coming storm. First of all, we have to get back the kidnapped saintess.”

“The kidnapped saintess?”

Naias’s eyes narrowed.

The kidnapped saintess.

It was the first time Naias had heard of it.

“On the day the hero of order died, the apostle of the evil god took the saintess of order.”

“That happened?”

“Yes. So I’m going to trade with them and get back the saintess first.”

“The saintess of order is important, but... do you need to get her back through a trade?”

It was shocking to hear that the saintess had been taken by the Cult.

And it was even more shocking to hear that she would get back the saintess through a trade with the Cult.

No matter how important the saintess was, it was hard to see why she had to bring her back right away with an unreasonable trade.

It was doubtful whether the ones who took the saintess would return her willingly.

They would surely make impossible demands.

Something seemed very wrong to Naias.

Laiteria was talking as if it was obvious, even though he couldn't understand it.

"I need to. The saintesses know a lot of things that others don't."

"I don't know if the Cult will want to trade."

"They will. They must want to trade too."

She seemed strangely confident.

He didn't know what he had to give up to get back the saintess, but Laiteria was sure that the trade would go through.

Was she seeing the future that had not come yet?

Or did she have some weakness of the enemies?

With an expression that could not be seen by her closed eyes, Naias asked Laiteria.

"What kind of trade is it?"

"I'm going to give them dragon blood."

"What?"

"I have to collect some of your blood and deliver it to the Cult. As a price for taking back the kidnapped saintess."

The thing that Laiteria wanted to trade with the Cult was none other than Naias's own blood.

The blood of a dragon had a great life force unlike other creatures.

But if he asked her if it had a tremendous effect by itself, she didn't think so.

Why would the Cult want his dragon blood so much that they would give up the saintess?

It was not an easy story to accept.

The more he talked with Laiteria, the more complicated his head felt.

"You want me to draw my blood and give it to the Cult?"

"Yes. It's not a big loss for us, right?"

"I don't understand. It's just blood, and you're talking about a trade that hasn't even been discussed yet..."

"Naias. Our thoughts are not important."

Laiteria put her palm over Naias's head, who was expressing his displeasure.

And then she started to stroke his head with a relaxed touch, as if to soothe him.

Laiteria gently caressed Naias's hair.

Her kind touch brushed over his navy blue hair several times, and the saintess's voice whispered in Naias's ear.

"It's all the goddess's will. Isn't it?"

"But..."

“We just have to follow it.”

The goddess’s will.

It was a good sound. It was enough to make him forget all the thoughts that came to his mind.

It was also a magic word that could rationalize everything.

To follow the goddess’s will and act on her behalf.

That was the only mission given to them.

Hoo-.

Naias sighed deeply and gave a positive answer to the task he didn’t want to do.

“I understand. If that’s what the Divine Grace says, I have no choice.”

“I’m sorry for asking you to do something dangerous.”

“It’s okay. You can’t do it yourself, Laiteria.”

Naias got up from his seat and brushed off the hair that had fallen on his clothes.

He didn’t want to do it, but he had to.

As Laiteria said, this was a Divine Grace.

To deny the Divine Grace that the saintess of the temple conveyed was tantamount to denying the foundation of the temple.

So he had to figure out how to draw blood without hurting himself first.

“But I’m a little worried about drawing blood.”

“What is this document?”

The knight commander, Ebelz Ederlent, glared at Highpright II with an angry face.

In his hand was a document that authorized the saintess’s solo outing.

At the bottom of the document were the seals of the emperor and the knight commander.

Highpright II looked at Ebelz with an excited face, who was looking at him.

The emperor’s gaze was very calm as he looked at Ebelz who brought the document.

“Sir Ebelz.”

Tap. Tap.

The emperor’s finger tapped on the desk as he called Ebelz’s name.

A slow and heavy rhythm echoed in the emperor’s office.

“I can’t understand this no matter how I think about it. Let alone my seal...”

“A Divine Grace has come down.”

Ebelz stopped his hand that was holding the document when he heard the word Divine Grace.

Highpright II was the emperor elected from the Temple of Order.

The reason why he had approved the saintess of order to go out alone.

If it was because of the Divine Grace that had come down to the saintess, it was not a completely incomprehensible story.

For the clergy, a revelation was above any rule.

“...Did you say a Divine Grace?”

“The saintess of order received several Divine Graces. The permission for the outing was just one of those Divine Graces.”

“No matter what, this is...”

“Sir Ebelz. The real problem is the content of another Divine Grace.”

He had to accept it even though he couldn't agree.

It was the god's will.

Ebelz put down the document he was holding on the table.

The paper slid down the desk with a fluttering sound.

“This is... not a trivial matter. What is the content of the other Divine Grace that makes you say this?”

He couldn't solve the problem that had passed.

It was more constructive to solve another problem than to argue about the responsibility.

Ebelz asked the emperor about the content of the problematic Divine Grace.

He picked up the document on the desk and said.

“The Temple of Harmony betrayed us.”

“...”

“They traded with the Cult to bring to the holy land...”

“Wait, what are you talking about?”

As soon as he heard the emperor's words, Ebelz felt his head freeze for a moment.

He came to his senses and looked at the emperor, who was still sitting calmly.

It was not a joke or a lie.

The emperor was sincerely saying such things.

“Literally, the Temple of Harmony betrayed us.”

“Are you sure? Even if you say that...”

“Didn’t I say it was a Divine Grace? You must think I’m someone who would joke about this kind of thing.”

It was absurd to say that the Temple of Harmony betrayed them.

It was something that should not be uttered even as a joke.

But if that absurd assumption was true.

Then this was not a situation to have a conversation like this.

He had to come up with a plan as soon as possible.

“If what you say is true, we have to convene an elders’ meeting right away.”

“I won’t hold a meeting.”

“What do you mean!”

But the emperor who brought up this story still maintained a quiet attitude.

Ebelz, who couldn’t stand it anymore, urged him, and the emperor looked at Ebelz with a serious tone and said.

“Do you want to call a meeting now and say that the goddess of harmony has abandoned us?”

“That’s...”

“Or do you want the story of us meddling with the temples to spread from the imperial palace?”

“...”

Ebelz shut his mouth at Highpright II’s rebuke.

The friction between the temples was a problem that would be troublesome if it was exposed.

Whether the Divine Grace was true or not, there would be a complex current in the holy land for a while.

The emperor seemed to want to suppress the problem as much as possible.

“I’ll take care of the matter related to the Temple of Harmony, so just watch quietly for a while.”

There was nothing Ebelz could do if that was the emperor’s will.

The knight order was a sword that protected the holy land, not a sword that tore it apart.

Especially if it was a matter of cleaning up the inside.

“I see...”

“Don’t dirty your hands with internal affairs, Sir Ebelz. Prepare for the coming storm.”

The emperor said that and picked up the document he had pushed aside.

Whoosh.

The document touched by the powerful divine flame turned into ashes and scattered.

Beyond the spreading ashes, the emperor waved his hand.

The ashes scattered along the emperor's touch, and a gust of wind brushed past Ebelz's cheek.

“When the storm comes, there will be bloodshed.”

Chapter 163: Kidnapping the Saintess (3)

Chapter 163: Kidnapping the Saintess (3)

In a mansion located in the noble district of the island.

The second prince of the empire, Aicliffe Rogasion, was doing his work as usual today.

He had no official duties from the Imperial Family, but for Aicliffe, managing his own faction was also an important task.

Behind Aicliffe, there was Eutenia.

Eutenia was reading the scriptures and occasionally glancing at Aicliffe's letters.

Under Eutenia's surveillance, Aicliffe checked the letters and soon found something and spoke to Eutenia.

“The Colt duke has sent me a message that he wants to meet me separately.”

“The Colt duke? That's an unexpected proposal.”

The Colt ducal family was a family that ruled most of the Alterias region.

The soldiers of the ducal family, who grew up in the harsh environment of the north, were famous as strong soldiers in the empire.

In addition, the magic stone mine located in Alterias contributed greatly to the ducal family's finances, and the current duke boasted a huge network of connections based on that.

Although the duke's base was in the north, his influence in the island was not light.

He was one of the most respectful people among the nobles, along with the Obtos duke.

"As you all know, the Colt duke supports that Renglus guy."

The only problem was that he already supported the third prince, Renglus.

The Colt duke was Renglus's biggest supporter.

Renglus's rise as a powerful heir to the throne was not without the influence of his maternal grandfather, the Colt duke.

And he suddenly invited Aicliffe, which was undoubtedly a suspicious situation.

He might not have set a trap for an official invitation, but he knew that there would be no pleasant conversation between them.

Eutenia, who heard Aicliffe's story, looked thoughtful for a moment and then closed the scriptures she had opened and said.

"What do you think, Your Highness?"

"I'd rather not meet him if possible..."

"Is that so?"

Aicliffe's attitude of avoiding the Colt duke was natural.

Meeting the duke would be a burden for him.

But Eutenia had a different thought from looking at Aicliffe.

She recalled what she had reported from the sect a few days ago.

‘Maybe this could be an opportunity.’

The sect could not openly participate in the imperial succession war.

Participating in the succession war, Aicliffe himself had to be the main pillar.

The sect had to reveal its power only minimally in the unseen places.

And by chance, Eutenia had a good idea.

It was a way to weaken the princes’ factions and take away the power of the holy land at the same time.

“Then, how about you send an invitation yourself this time, Your Highness?”

That’s why Eutenia suggested to Aicliffe to invite the duke.

At the suggestion of inviting the duke in reverse, Aicliffe looked at her with a puzzled expression.

He wondered if he had heard her wrong.

“Are you telling me to send an invitation to the Colt duke?”

“Yes. It would be difficult to call him right now, but how about inviting him to a party that we’ll have in a month or so...”

She was thinking of bringing the duke as Aicliffe said.

If possible, she wanted to throw a grand party at this mansion.

As Eutenia was about to tell Aicliffe her plan, she closed her mouth at the voice in her ear.

She looked up at the sky reflexively with the scriptures in her hand.

-“The false agent of God will seek you out.”

The voice that came to her ear was always the one that gave her revelations.

The great being clearly wanted to command her.

Eutenia completely shook off the thoughts in her head and focused on the next revelation from God.

-“The child of the dragon will offer himself as a sacrifice.”

-“Accept the sacrifice.”

-“Make him accompany the false saintess.”

The child of the dragon. And the false saintess.

The last command of the great being passed through Eutenia’s mind as she listened to the revelation.

Make a vessel worthy of him.

To make a splendid vessel that suited the great being, nothing was more necessary than pure dragon blood.

The revelation that came down this time seemed to be God’s arrangement for that.

As for the false saintess, it must have been the saintess of order that Pluto had secured this time.

“...I understand.”

If the great being had given her a revelation, Eutenia simply followed it.

Eutenia answered the call from heaven and leaned the scriptures against the window.

Maybe it was because Eutenia's attitude suddenly changed as they were talking.

Aicliffe looked at her with a bewildered look and said to Eutenia.

“What's wrong? Did something happen that I don't know about?”

“I have something urgent to do, so I'll have to leave for a while.”

“Something?”

“I received a command from the great one.”

He received a command from the great one.

It was not something that Aicliffe couldn't understand.

He was also here because he heard God's voice.

Aicliffe just nodded slowly at the news that God's command had fallen.

“Don't worry. Even if I leave for a while, nothing will disappear that I've done so far.”

“That's what you need as an emperor. If even that is hard, it would be difficult to become an emperor.”

“Hmm, so I just have to invite the duke in a month?”

A month.

It was a long or short time depending on who you asked.

Some people couldn't even cross half of the empire in that time, but for Eutenia who borrowed Perin's power, it was a time when she could do many things.

A month would be enough for her to finish all the groundwork she wanted.

Eutenia finished calculating in her head and gave an answer back to Aicliffe.

“Let’s do that. By then, many things will be ready.”

It would be enough to cause a bloodbath in the empire.

“Yawn...”

On top of a floating island.

I was looking at the three characters reflected on the screen of my smartphone and yawning.

Pluto and Perin. And Eileen, who had recently joined the cult.

The three of them were chatting in a noisy manner.

The one who was causing the commotion was mostly Eileen.

-“Pluto! I’m sorry! Don’t send me away!”

Eileen was clinging to Pluto’s leg and crying and begging.

There was one reason why she was pleading so desperately.

It was because I had decided to send her away for a while because of the hidden quest that came a while ago.

The hidden quest that came this time gave [Dragon Blood] as a reward.

It was an opportunity to get the essential material for the top-tier character I was going to control.

“I didn’t want to send you away either... but the time of farewell will come someday.”

I recited a line that seemed like something I had seen in a drama, and stroked Eileen's head with my finger.

Looking back, Eileen had given me a lot of benefits while she was staying here.

She organized the information about the holy land into documents that were easy for Roan to see, and also told me about the holy relic that was hidden in some secluded valley.

Thanks to that, I got another holy relic that I could use for making [Philosopher's Stone].

But each character had their own role.

In this world, Eileen's role was the exchange material for dragon blood.

It hurt my heart, but I couldn't help it.

-“Don't abandon me! I'm loyal to you, ancestor!”

Maybe she realized that she was being discarded.

Eileen was fiercely clinging to Pluto's leg.

Pluto looked at her with an awkward expression.

He raised one hand hesitantly, then reached out and stroked Eileen's head and said.

-“...I'm just pretending to send you away.”

-“Don't even pretend!”

“...”

-“I'm sorry! Can I be a good vampire? Okay?”

No matter what Pluto said, Eileen was stubborn.

She showed that she didn't want to leave this place.

Did her AI get messed up when she became a vampire?

She was a character who was obsessed with Pluto to an extreme degree.

As I watched Eileen spout nonsense, Perin, who was sitting on a tree, opened his mouth.

-“Good... vampire?”

Perin had an expression of disbelief.

He felt that the word vampire and the word good could never go together.

He knew that vampire was a negative word, but he wondered if it was enough to elicit such a reaction.

In reality, wouldn't it be like a good mosquito?

A good mosquito. If it was a good mosquito, surely—.

“Does that make sense?”

It was a ridiculous story.

I decided to agree with Perin's statement neatly.

The people who heard the story were different, though.

Pluto and Eileen glared at Perin with fierce eyes.

At some point, Pluto had Deathscythe in his hand.

-“Pluto is nice...”

Seeing the blue light of Deathscythe, Perin quickly corrected his answer.

Pluto nodded his head with a satisfied face.

-“As expected, Perin knows well.”

-“Yes.”

Was it because their conversation was over?

Eileen clung to Pluto again.

The size of the speech bubble above Eileen’s head was even bigger than before.

-“Pluto! Please don’t send me away!”

-“Eileen...”

-“I’ll do anything for you, Pluto! Cleaning, laundry, cooking, anything! So please don’t abandon me!”

-“Vampires don’t eat things like cooking...”

I smiled faintly as I watched the two characters have a funny conversation.

They were all characters I liked, no matter what they said.

The ancestor of vampires, the lazy angel, and the white rice cake floating in the sea with a stupid posture. All of them.

They were the driving force that made me enjoy this game.

If it weren’t for them, I wouldn’t have been spending money on the game every day.

Maybe I would have quit the game after a month of lightning strikes.

“I guess there are a lot of good kids. Just think of Eutenia...”

As I was about to talk about Eutenia, the first daughter of the sect.

The image of Eutenia sacrificing a whole village and holding a ritual of starvation passed through my mind.

From my point of view, she was a great character who gave me experience points, but I didn't know what it would be like from other characters' perspectives.

In the eyes of other characters, she might look like a crazy demon lord who walks around with shadows.

Maybe from the AI's perspective, she would be described as an incomprehensible horror.

From that point of view, I might need to reconsider the expression of being good.

"Maybe not good? But whatever, as long as they're nice to me."

But what does that matter?

It wasn't important to me whether she killed thousands or tens of thousands of characters or ruled over them.

To me, Eutenia was always the first apostle.

And she was always the first character who was faithful to her purpose.

Because of my meeting with Eutenia, our story continues.

I didn't care what the game characters thought.

"Hopefully they're all happy."

Chapter 164: Critical Point (1)

Chapter 164: Critical Point (1)

It was a day, two weeks after the Saintess of Harmony received her revelation.

Naias was traveling through the Centurion region in the south of the empire, carrying a glass bottle filled with her own blood.

She was going to trade with the Apostle of the Evil God, who had kidnapped the Saintess of Order using dragon blood.

Normally, she would not have been allowed to leave alone, but this time, thanks to the efforts of Laiteria, the Saintess herself, she was able to get out without any trouble.

If they had known Naias's purpose, they would have stopped her from leaving the holy land.

In fact, Naias herself felt frustrated as she embarked on this journey.

"I really don't want to do this."

She was a dragon and a hero.

It was natural for her to feel repulsed by the idea of trading with the cult that was disrupting the world.

If it wasn't for the trust that the Saintess had received, she wouldn't have had to draw her blood and go out like this.

Why did the Goddess of Harmony choose to trade with the cult?

And why did the Evil God agree to accept this unreasonable deal?

The more she thought about it, the more questions she had.

“...”

Of course, having doubts didn't change anything about the situation.

It was a matter that had been agreed upon between the Goddess of Harmony and the Evil God.

Even if the Apostle of the Evil God appeared here, he was nothing more than an agent who received orders from the Evil God.

Their opinions didn't matter at all in this trade.

Hoo.

Naias sighed to relieve the frustration that was rising in her chest, when she felt a presence in the noisy forest where trees were lined up.

She saw a strange man at the place where she had received the revelation.

“You're later than I expected.”

The man also noticed Naias and started walking towards her.

Thud. Thud.

The sound of his footsteps echoed in the dense forest.

A cloaked man approached me with a relaxed attitude, showing no signs of nervousness. He was followed by a girl in a nun's dress, who looked pale and sick.

“Are you the Apostle who agreed to meet me today?”

As the distance between us narrowed, I scanned his figure and weapons with my dragon eyes.

He had two swords on his waist, one much heavier than the other.

They looked difficult to wield with both hands, but he was an Apostle, so he could use any kind of weapon skill.

I prepared myself to subdue him if he drew his swords, and measured the gap between us with my eyes.

“Well, yes. I’m Peter Enklov, the Sixth Apostle.”

He introduced himself casually as he came closer.

Peter Enklov, the Sixth Apostle.

He was supposed to be a hero of honor, but he betrayed the holy land and joined the cult as an Apostle.

And now he was the top priority target for elimination by the holy land.

I barely kept my expression from crumpling as I faced the Apostle and introduced myself.

“I’m Naias, here on behalf of the Temple of Harmony.”

“Naias, huh? Nice name. By the way, this is... what was your name again?”

“...Eileen Asnoff.”

“Did you hear that? She’s the Saintess you’ve been looking for.”

Peter pointed his finger at the Saintess of Order behind him.

My eyes followed his gesture and met hers.

Had she been tortured horribly by the cult?

She looked so blue that she couldn’t even look at me properly.

My heart sank at the sight of Eileen’s pale face.

‘What kind of torture did she endure...’

I was opposed to rescuing her, but seeing her in person made me feel pity for her.

I would have agreed to save her if someone suggested it now.

I looked away from Eileen and turned my gaze back to Peter.

Then I casually mentioned the hidden presence of another Apostle.

“It seems like there’s one more hiding somewhere.”

“You have a good sense for a dragon. He’s an insurance for emergencies.”

“Is that so? I don’t think it matters if one more comes out.”

There was one Apostle who showed himself.

And another one who was watching us from behind the trees.

Even if something went wrong, I could escape by myself.

It was a different matter whether I could rescue the Saintess or not.

“You’re pretty confident in your skills.”

“I’m different from mediocre humans. I can easily overpower you.”

With a half-serious provocation, I looked at the Apostle who was hiding in the forest.

I wanted to see how he would react to my taunt.

But my taunt didn’t elicit any reaction from the hidden Apostle.

Instead, Peter, who was right in front of me, showed an unexpected response.

“Uh... yeah... I can overpower you.”

He said with a serious face, as if he was pondering my words.

I felt embarrassed for provoking him.

He looked back and forth between his swords on his waist and me.

He didn't seem arrogant at all.

The situation was getting weird.

I shook my head and changed the topic.

“Enough with the idle talk. Let's talk about the trade first.”

“Anyway, did you bring what I need for the trade?”

Peter took his eyes off his swords and went straight to the point.

He was talking about the dragon blood that I had drawn from myself.

The item that he would exchange for the Saintess who was held by the cult.

I reached into my bag and took out a glass bottle filled with blood.

The dragon blood glowed in my hand, radiating a strong life force.

“Is this what you mean?”

“Good. You brought it properly.”

Peter smiled as he saw the dragon blood in the bottle.

I was sure then.

Just like I had heard from the trust, they really wanted my dragon blood.

There were many legends about dragon blood in the human world since ancient times.

But they were mostly symbolic, not practical.

Dragon blood itself couldn't do anything amazing.

Yet the cult wanted my dragon blood.

It was a suspicious situation.

“There's no benefit to dragon blood. Why does the cult want it?”

I asked him directly.

Why did the cult want dragon blood?

I thought they might tell me the answer since they got what they wanted.

But Peter snorted at my question.

“That's none of your concern.”

He stepped closer to me and raised his right hand in front of my eyes.

Snap.

He snapped his fingers and looked down at me.

“Hand it over.”

The northern part of the empire, Alterius region.

The duke's mansion of Colt, which boasted an ironclad security.

In the darkness where only candles faintly lit up the surroundings, Daniel, the Fifth Apostle, stood shrouded in shadows.

Three knights lay fallen around Daniel.

They were the ones who guarded the entrance to the prince's office, where he was working.

They didn't even know who had come, and collapsed on the floor with pale faces.

"..."

Daniel watched them and swung Laitimeria in the air, drawing a line.

A dark crack opened in the air, splitting the darkness.

Beyond the crack, a huge eye stared at them. It was the eye of the reaper, who led the dead souls to a place of no return.

Daniel shook off the blood on his weapon and ordered the reaper's eye.

"——Devour them."

Sssss—.

The knights around Daniel turned to ash and scattered in the air.

They were sacrificed for a great being, who had been hit by Laitimeria.

The knights who entered the reaper's eye disappeared without a trace in an instant.

The reaper's eye also closed the crack and vanished after consuming all the offerings.

There was no sign of anything happening around Daniel, as if nothing had happened.

'Now there's only one left.'

Daniel's eyes fixed on the closed door of the office, after dealing with the knights.

He was originally a farmer who raised cows in Everlint region, but he was now in the north for a certain mission.

Eutenia, who was planning to plunge the empire into chaos, had given him a mission personally.

It was a mission that suited Daniel, who specialized in moving secretly.

And his mission was one thing.

To play a 'cruel prank' on the prince who was inside the office.

'It's hard to understand this order, no matter how I think about it.'

Daniel remembered the ridiculous content of his mission and grabbed the handle of the office door.

Clank. Squeak.

The tightly closed door of the office made a noise, announcing the intruder's arrival.

He would have found a way to make no sound at all, if there were any threats left.

But he had already taken care of them all.

As he opened the door and entered, Daniel's eyes met with the prince's.

"Sir Beodor?"

The prince raised his head, thinking that it was one of the knights who guarded outside.

He called out the name of the knight.

But it was Daniel who faced him, wrapped in darkness.

The prince realized that something was wrong and frowned.

He grabbed a dagger that was on his desk.

They both held daggers, but they felt different distances from each other.

“Who are you? Where is Sir Beodor?”

“——Laitimeria.”

Daniel’s cold voice echoed in the silent office.

Right after that, a storm of coldness swept through the room.

It was a cold storm that slowed down everything in Daniel’s area.

Frost began to settle on the floor of the office where the prince and Daniel faced each other.

“What, what is this...!”

Sizzle.

The prince’s limbs began to freeze as he cried out in panic.

His body was getting colder as the coldness settled in.

He felt something was wrong and tried to move his body to resist the coldness.

But his hand that held the dagger was frozen and couldn’t swing it easily.

“...Pray.”

“Wha, what are you talking about! Is there anyone there!”

“I won’t kill you. But pray.”

Daniel approached the prince who was immobilized and took out something from his pocket.

A small glass bottle filled with red blood.

It was something he had received from Eutenia as an important item.

He knew well what the blood inside was.

The blood of a vampire bound to the ancestor.

It was something that was hard to obtain unless you were in the cult.

“What are you trying to do to me...!”

“It’s a blood contract.”

“What did you say...!”

Thud.

Daniel pulled out the cork that sealed the bottle.

A thick scent of blood rose from the bottle.

The prince’s eyes trembled as he saw the tilting bottle.

“Pray. Pray that you can survive after drinking this.”

Daniel dropped the blood into the prince’s mouth.

Plop.

The red blood fell on his red tongue.

The prince’s eyes were filled with horror as he drank the vampire’s blood.

Chapter 165: Critical Point (2)

Chapter 165: Critical Point (2)

On the way back to the holy land after finishing the deal with the cult.

Inside the carriage that she was riding with Eileen, Naias had a dissatisfied expression on her face.

She had no choice but to hand over her blood to the cult that threatened her with the saintess.

Moreover, she had to give Peter some strands of her hair along with her blood under the pretext of data.

Despite gaining a great advantage, Naias's complexion was not bright after completing the humiliating deal.

“Ugh...”

The distance of the sword.

The sense of energy.

The agility of movement.

The level of the apostle named Peter that she examined with her dragon eye was really nothing special.

Before he could show any ability through his magic, Naias was confident that she could kill him.

She felt that she could easily knock him down even if he used his full power and she used the power of the dragon.

However, she had to endure one-sided threats from such an apostle.

It was because Peter, the apostle, pressured her by showing an attitude that he didn't care if the deal fell apart.

And in the end, she had to let him go without even touching him.

“If we meet again... I will definitely...”

In the end, Naias was the one who had her information stolen.

It was a humiliating time.

But this time, it couldn't be helped.

The life of the saintess Eileen was in the hands of the hidden apostle.

She had to follow Peter's words to save Eileen.

But next time, it would be different.

“I will surely bring down that man with my own hands.”

Then, she would surely punish the apostles of the evil god with her own hands.

With that determination, Naias grabbed Eileen's hand that she was facing.

Eileen looked surprised as her cold hand like an icehouse was grabbed.

Naias expressed her doubt at Eileen's cold hand, but she didn't forget to offer her a word of consolation.

“You've been through a lot.”

“Huh? Yes.”

“I don’t know what kind of punishment the temple will give you... but I think you can rest for a while.”

Eileen’s health had deteriorated a lot after being tortured severely.

Now, recovering her broken health by resting in the holy land was a priority.

Hearing Naias’s words, Eileen spoke to her in a subdued voice.

“Are you... going straight to the holy land?”

“That would be best. Or do you have any place you want to go?”

Maybe there was a place she wanted to visit before returning to the holy land.

Thinking that, Naias asked her, but Eileen just lowered her head quietly.

Their relationship was awkward, so they still couldn’t talk properly.

Or maybe she had heard some bad rumors about Naias.

As she watched over Eileen with concern, Naias sensed something strange in the air.

‘This is...’

I felt a powerful surge of energy beyond the carriage with my dragon eye.

Something threatening was flying towards us at a fast speed.

As soon as I sensed it, I quickly picked up Eileen.

I opened the carriage door and jumped out with her in my arms.

“Na, Naias...?”

“Shh.”

Right after I got out of the carriage in a hurry.

A light arrow pierced the spot where the carriage was.

Kwagwagwagwang!

A storm of light swept over the place where the carriage was.

Kwajik! The carriage exploded and fragments scattered.

The flying wooden shards showed how dangerous Eileen's situation was.

“Naias! The carriage...!”

Eileen screamed in shock at the sight of the shattered carriage.

The light arrow that flew out of nowhere had completely destroyed the carriage we were riding.

It was strange not to be surprised by the urgent situation.

Among the scattered fragments, my dragon eye looked at someone beyond them.

I saw a group of people coming towards us from a distant place.

‘The cult? No, the attack just now was clearly...’

My eyes, covered with scales on one hand, followed the hooded man who was approaching.

The man who climbed over the trees had a bow that was very familiar to me.

A graceful bow that emitted a blue light.

The magic weapon Astra, which was only given to the hero of hunting, was in his hand.

There was only one thing that meant.

‘Did Sion Gong attack us?’

Sion Arius, the hero of hunting.

He had targeted us and launched an attack.

And even now, as he moved with the hooded people, he was aiming his bow at me.

I quickly raised my arm at the sight of Astra vibrating with light.

“—Astra!”

Kwaang!

The light arrow that burst out with explosive power was caught by my hand.

My hand that caught the flying arrow trembled violently.

The weight of the arrow shot by the hero of hunting with murderous intent was not light at all.

Pajik.

My hand, which raised its magic power, broke the light arrow completely.

“Everyone! You were here!”

Sion’s voice came closer enough to hear.

Bang!

Another light arrow flew and stuck right in front of Eileen.

Eileen stepped back without knowing it at the sight of the arrow stuck in front of her eyes.

I hugged her and shouted at Sion with a sharp voice.

“Sion Gong!”

“Long time no see, Naias!”

Sion greeted me with a cheerful voice.

But contrary to his attitude, he pulled the string of Astra again as soon as he finished his words.

A light arrow flew towards me.

Kwajik! Kwaang!

I moved my hand to deflect the light arrow.

My face was filled with murderous intent as I looked at Sion.

“Sion Gong... what are you doing?”

“This? Sorry, but I had orders to capture you.”

I couldn't understand what Sion meant by saying he moved by orders.

I was the hero of harmony, and Eileen next to me was the saintess of order.

Who on earth ordered him to capture us?

It didn't make sense considering our positions.

“Orders? Who gave you such orders?”

“Who else? There's only one.”

“Don't tell me...”

Someone's face flashed in my mind.

The holy emperor, Highfright II.

The supreme ruler of Crossbridge and the one who controlled the movements of the six temples.

He was the only one who could give direct orders to Sion, the hero of hunting.

Sion opened his mouth and confirmed my guess.

“The emperor himself ordered me. He said you joined hands with the cult.”

It seemed that he found out about the blood trade.

It was just a deal to get back the saintess, but the emperor must have judged that I betrayed the holy land.

He misunderstood that I colluded with the cult.

I moved according to the trust to save the saintess, and I never sided with the cult.

“You’re mistaken! The temple of harmony didn’t join hands with the cult...”

“You’re going to say it was a simple trade?”

“That was... necessary to save Eileen! Someone had to save her!”

“What are you going to do with a vampire in the holy land? I might be fine, but what about others?”

Vampire.

I felt like my mind stopped at that word.

I was born as a dragon and lived a long life, but I had no memory of ever facing a vampire.

The progenitor of vampires was sealed by the heroes.

It was a long time ago, so I had no chance to meet him.

But Eileen, whom I was protecting, was a vampire?

My blank eyes looked at Eileen in my arms.

“Vampire...?”

“That guy, he’s being controlled by the progenitor of vampires. Don’t tell me you really didn’t know?”

Eileen’s body temperature was abnormally low for sure.

Her complexion was too pale for a human.

But I didn’t think she could be a vampire.

There was only one vampire in existence on the ground right now.

The strength left my arm that was holding Eileen.

“Eileen is a vampire...”

“Is it because you’re an ignorant race that you never thought of that possibility?”

Sion pointed at Eileen, who was sitting on the ground, with his finger as he looked at me.

Eileen avoided his gaze as she met his eyes.

“Anyway, that’s why Eileen Asnoff is exiled.”

“She’s exiled?”

“Yes. It was decided by the approval of the elders’ council and the imperial court, so there’s no turning back. And you should know that it’s useless to argue with me about it.”

I staggered up from my seat, feeling drained.

The scales that covered one of my arms had already hidden inside.

I felt empty.

The saintess I rescued with the revelation was a vampire.

Why did the goddess of harmony give me such a revelation?

I looked at Sion Arius, who was wearing a hood, with a blank stare.

“What did I do this for...”

“I wonder that too.”

He smiled and put one hand in his pocket.

Flap.

A round disc came out of his cloak.

An unidentified energy flowed from the disc he was holding.

“So... did you come to execute me and Eileen?”

“Well, that’s not my mission. It would take a long time for us to take down Naias, right?”

Squeeze.

He clenched the disc hard.

At that moment, light burst out from the disc and started to form a cage around Eileen and me.

I looked around with a bewildered eye at the light pillars that rose up in an instant.

The light that stretched to the sky was making a cage to trap us.

I asked Sion about his identity as I felt a strong divine power restraining me.

“What is this...?”

“Belzer’s Dream Labyrinth. A holy relic that creates trials that repeat between dreams and reality.”

There were many holy relics in Crossbridge that were managed by the imperial court.

It seemed that Sion had obtained permission to take one of them out.

The imperial court had approved the use of the holy relic to bind me.

Crack.

I gritted my teeth at the sight of the imperial court using a holy relic to lock me up.

“It won’t work on heroes who have magic weapons, but you don’t have one, so I can hold you for about a month. You’re a dragon, so you won’t die from starving for a month, right?”

He was right.

Dragons who gained spirit could survive without eating for a long time.

Eileen would also be able to endure without food for a long time if she was a vampire.

The emperor’s goal seemed to be to keep Eileen and me here for a while.

“You’re going to keep me here?”

“It seems that His Majesty is preparing something important, so it would be better if you stay here for a while.”

“Do you think the temple of harmony will stay still?”

“Unfortunately, Laiteria is also imprisoned right now. I hope everyone can settle this peacefully.”

I looked at the sky.

The cage that surrounded us was completed by now.

The barrier made by the power of the holy relic was not easy to destroy even for a dragon.

It would take at least a month to break it.

Sion waved his hand at me in the cage and said,

“Talk to His Majesty after the trial is over.”

Sion’s figure split into two in my eyes.

As he turned around and waved his hand, I lost consciousness with his last sight.

Chapter 166: Critical Point (3)

Critical Point (3)

Lithua-Centrius.

A dark space underground of the lordship ruled by the Meyer Count.

There, many convicts dragged from the city were tied up.

The convicts had their eyes completely covered and thick gags in their mouths.

And under them, there was a huge magic circle drawn with the blood of beasts.

It was a precious thing that the convicts were not allowed to see, made with a thick smell of blood.

“Whew... I’m nervous.”

The convicts and the magic circle.

They were all prepared materials to create the philosopher’s stone.

As if to prove it, there was a holy relic emitting a sinister aura in the middle of the magic circle.

It was the core of the process of creating the philosopher’s stone.

Enia lifted a jeweled staff in front of the glowing holy relic.

She was Enia Claude, the disciple of Elbon Claude, and the one in charge of this ritual.

“Anyway, it’s my first time doing something like this...”

Elbon was currently making a vessel of God in the sanctuary.

So this ritual was entirely up to Enia.

Fortunately, Elbon had verified it once before the ritual.

Now all that was left was for Enia to activate the magic circle and create the philosopher’s stone herself.

It was a fairly simple task compared to the preparation of the ritual.

“But for our safety... we have no choice.”

Enia calmed her mind and glared at the sacrifices in front of her.

She aimed her staff at the holy relic and thought of her master who was trapped in the sanctuary.

It was her first time to use living beings as a medium to create the philosopher’s stone.

But even if it was her first time, she couldn’t mess up the ritual.

If she failed, there was a high chance that something would happen to her and Elbon Claude’s lives.

She had to finish this ritual successfully no matter what.

She poured magic into the magic circle that surrounded her and began to adjust the magic in the surrounding space.

“—Life, build a staircase.”

The first thing that came out of Enia's mouth was a prayer for the offering ritual to the heavenly God.

This ritual used a holy relic and combined offering ritual and alchemy's shaping magic.

It was to make a handful of soul into an entity and then condense it into a crystal.

It was truly an extreme of alchemy that was not shameful to call it so.

Enia had witnessed the cult's offering ritual several times to finish this ritual successfully.

Now it was time to see the result with her own eyes.

“—One path leads to glory.”

With a solemn voice, the staff and the magic circle emitted a resonant light.

The red bloodstains were covered with light and the magic circle vibrated violently.

The holy relic in the center of the magic circle created a brilliant pillar of light.

It was such a bright light that it would have exposed the ritual site if it wasn't for the barrier that swallowed the light.

“—One path leads to death.”

The light of death spewed out and covered the bodies of the convicts who were to be sacrificed.

The convicts who had gags in their mouths screamed in agony as they collapsed.

But Enia ignored them and proceeded with the ritual.

They were convicts who deserved to die anyway.

The cult must have cared for Enia in their own way, but for her, it was a story that could ease her guilt a little bit.

“—Reverse. Coalesce.”

The twisted prayer interfered with the ongoing ritual.

The bodies of the convicts faded and the waves of souls spread throughout the underground space.

A thick life force was transmitted through the staff she held.

The life force she felt at her fingertips was very powerful.

She swung her staff and soon led it to the center of the magic circle.

“—Life, reject the cycle.”

The holy relic that handled life gathered the human life force that was scattered.

The dispersed entities coalesced and formed something.

The magic circle was creating the philosopher’s stone around the holy relic.

The reason why the holy relic was essential for the ritual of creating the philosopher’s stone.

It was because something was needed to hold on to the dispersing life force.

It was impossible to capture the essence of life completely with a simple magical device.

Something that matched its caliber was needed.

“—Despair. Wail.”

Enia sweated and put more strength into her hand holding the staff.

The ritual that reached its end was revealing its result now.

Cracks appeared on the holy relic that was creating the philosopher's stone, and the convicts who were tied to the altar were faintly changing.

All she had to do now was to stabilize the philosopher's stone that revealed its appearance.

She swung her staff with a bright light and glared at the philosopher's stone with a clear gaze.

There was only one word left for the prayer.

“—Play the requiem of death.”

As soon as the last word came out of Enia's mouth.

Paaah!

The whole altar was engulfed in a dazzling light.

Blinded by the intense light, Enia raised her arm to cover her eyes.

The colorful light wrapped around the altar for a while.

After she counted dozens in her mind, only holy relics and jewels remained on the altar where the light subsided, and all the convicts were gone.

Clatter.

On top of the shattered holy relic, there was a philosopher's stone emitting a rainbow light.

Enia gasped as she looked at the philosopher's stone.

“Ah...”

The jewel that shone brightly was the result of countless hours of work by Enia and her master.

It was the existence of an item that was only considered a legend by alchemists.

The ritual was over, and Enia's heart pounded at the sight of it.

For the magicians who pursued the truth, handling life was a taboo.

But even so, the light of the jewel in front of her was so dazzling.

It was enough to blind the eyes of an alchemist with just a brief glance.

“Finally...! I finally completed the philosopher's stone!”

Enia's trembling hand grabbed the philosopher's stone.

Thump. Thump.

She felt a pleasant pulse from her fingers touching the stone.

At that moment when she touched the item she had longed for, Enia realized.

Even if she chased the light and followed the truth, she was still nothing but an alchemist.

At least for today, she felt that her passion would not subside easily.

“Is the research on creating a character almost done?”

A silent room where only the TV made noise.

I was looking at my smartphone there.

Beyond the screen that reflected in my sight, I could see Elbon handling blood.

He was diligently shaping a human form under Utenia's watch.

Compared to him, it was only about the size of a child.

-“It's my first time dealing with blood.”

Maybe it was because he had prepared for a long time.

Elbon started working quickly after clearing the hidden quest and getting the blood.

From his state, it seemed that his outline would appear soon if it was only about his appearance.

-“You have to make a handsome face that suits His Majesty.”

Next to him, Utenia was nagging Elbon as she watched him.

Of course, I could sympathize with Utenia's words as well.

My character had to be good-looking.

He had to have a dignified appearance as a god.

That way, he could walk around the town proudly with shining items on him.

“Yeah. The face is the completion of the outfit.”

Was it not the first time that he was bothered by the same thing from Utenia?

Elbon looked at Utenia with a bored face.

His palm that handled blood was trembling slightly.

Elbon looked at Utenia with an uneasy expression and said.

-“.....You don’t have to repeat it. I’ll take care of it myself.”

-“If you make a mistake... you might end up being sacrificed.”

-“If you keep pushing me, I might make a mistake because of my shaking hands.”

I felt a chill when I heard that.

It was someone’s character creation, but it would be very troublesome if something went wrong.

My gaze naturally moved to the icon above Utenia’s head as I looked at the screen.

As he said, it might be a mistake if he interfered too much.

I wondered if I should have a conversation with Utenia now that things had turned out this way.

“Let’s chat through the device instead of <Voice> for a change.”

It wouldn’t be bad to have an intimate conversation with her after a long time.

As I decided to press the button.

Messages started popping up at the bottom of the screen.

I naturally looked at the message box at the sudden messages.

“What’s going on?”

The scroll that was pushed up to the top contained overwhelming information.

What had happened that so many messages were printed?

I cautiously scrolled down and started checking the contents of the messages.

The first thing I saw was a familiar item name.

-You acquired [Philosopher's Stone].

-The progress of <Descent> is updated.

[Philosopher's Stone].

It was the material needed for the quest of <Descent> skill.

It seemed that I had finally cleared it after waiting for a long time with Elbon.

I heard that he was almost done with the preparation, but I didn't expect it to be today.

“So [Philosopher's Stone] quest is finally over.”

As I scrolled down a little more, the list of ongoing quests was also displayed.

Maybe it was because I had received the quest for a long time.

By now, the progress of <Descent> quest showed a big difference from before.

-Every time you meet one of the following conditions, the progress of <Descent> increases by one step.

-Available Karma: 4014 / 999999 (Incomplete)

-[Holy Relic: Ergus' Stake]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

-[Philosopher's Stone]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

-???: 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

-Making a body for Descent (Incomplete)

I secured [Holy Relic: Ergus' Stake] when Pluto joined, and now I even got [Philosopher's Stone].

And the quest to create a character was also close to completion.

Except for the quests that were not unlocked yet and those that were difficult to clear right away, I had practically cleared almost all the possible quests.

Now all I had to do was wait for Elbon to finish making the character and unlock the last quest.

"I'm almost done."

I remembered how I was shocked when I first found this quest.

Back then, I was worried about how to get a million karma and felt helpless.

But now it's different.

If I use the double karma coupon and wage a full-scale war, it seemed possible to achieve it somehow.

"A million karma..."

A lot of time had passed since I started the game.

A lot of things had changed since then.

The cult that started in a rural area had grown to threaten the continent and surpass the empire.

I felt like something would reach my hand if I moved forward a little more.

"Well, I guess I need to spend a little more money to clear it."

Of course, it wasn't possible to clear it right now, so it was half-joking.

The rest of the tasks were problems that money and time could solve.

I was only faithful to the goal given in front of me.

Swoosh.

I put away my funny thoughts in my head and scrolled down further.

At the bottom of the scroll that still had some room left, there was a message that I was familiar with by now.

-Warning: Excessively biased karma in one direction may trigger
<Causality Adjustment>.

-<Karma's Balance> has tilted.

-<Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

The causality adjustment message by <Karma's Balance>.

It was a warning message that came to me whenever I forgot.

Even as I stayed still, the causality rate kept rising.

Now it was blatantly increasing the difficulty as if it was urging me to spend money.

Naturally, the content below was a message that informed me of the boss's growth.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Ascalon] has been freed by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Hieroglyph] has been freed by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Astra] has been freed by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: S■■■] has been freed by one level.

-Due to <Hero Selection>, [Artifact: Dainsleif] has been freed by one level.

-Causality Adjustment Progress: 30%

Ascalon and Hieroglyph.

They were the weapons of the heroes that I had seen many times.

Below them, there was still Peter's artifact that was out of place.

But among them, there was also something that bothered me, an artifact whose name was partially hidden.

Unlike before, this time one letter was revealed.

"S... What is this? Snowman?"

I tried to guess the empty letters, but there was no plausible word in my mind.

All the words that came to mind were ones that I couldn't understand why they were called artifacts.

As I pondered over various words in my head, something happened to the screen I was focusing on.

"Huh...?"

Crackle. Crackle.

The screen distorted with noise.

The letters and images shook and blurred, then turned into something unrecognizable and scattered.

But that was only for a moment.

The screen that seemed to have a problem stopped shaking and returned to normal.

After the screen returned to normal, I looked at it again where the problem had occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Astra] has been freed by one level.

-Due to <Hero Selection>, [Artifact: Dainsleif] has been freed by one level.

-Causality Adjustment Progress: 30%

The message that had broken letters was completely gone from the screen that returned.

Yet the game's message box displayed information as if nothing had happened.

A sense of strangeness rose in my mind as I looked at the screen.

For some reason, I felt like I was facing a familiar scene.

"I think it was like this back then too."

I recalled a similar moment from my vague memory.

When was that?

I remembered it as the time when I unknowingly bought an item worth 2 million won.

Back then, an unidentified magic sword disappeared and I acquired [Contract of Regression] that could revive my character.

The name of the magic sword I faced then was also broken like this.

I thought it was just a bug when I got [Contract of Regression], but I felt uneasy as I encountered it often like this.

“It’s too weird to dismiss it as a simple bug.”

Right after I doubted the game.

Crackle. Crackle.

The screen started shaking again.

The whole view that I was looking at distorted and a sharp pain came from my eyes.

I felt my consciousness sinking as my head shook.

“This is...”

I remembered.

It was the same as now, when I suddenly lost consciousness...

“What is... this...!”

I tried to resist the sudden sleepiness that came over me.

I opened my eyes wide and put strength into my fingers.

I tried my best to feel the sensation from the end of my body clearly.

But the sensation from my fingertips was gradually fading away.

A severe headache spread in my head in the distorted view.

“Ugh...!”

-“The karma needed for interference has increased too much.”

Thud.

My body lost its balance and collapsed to one side.

The sleepiness swept over me and swallowed my clear consciousness in an instant.

My eyes were closing gradually.

An irresistible urge pressed me down.

I reached out my hand toward the screen and unconsciously called out the name of the character I saw in my eyes.

“Eute...”

-“In a little more time... it will be hard to maintain interference like this.”

The strength left my hand that was reaching out for something.

The last thing I saw in my blurry sight was black hair that reached down to her waist.

-“Sweet dreams.”

Chapter 167: Critical Point (4)

Chapter 167: Critical Point (4)

The knight commander's office in Crossbridge.

There, Serena, the saintess of abundance, faced Commander Ebelz.

He looked at her with a complicated gaze that was different from before.

The atmosphere was so bleak that it was hard to believe they were mother and daughter.

The subtle distance between them had started since the day she was chosen as a saintess.

It wasn't this quiet back then, but she felt they had grown further apart after the death of Lian Crost, the white holy sword.

"Saintess."

"...Yes."

Serena could sense many thoughts in Ebelz's voice.

He seemed to be troubled by many problems.

It was an attitude that did not suit his always strong appearance.

Ebelz looked at Serena and hesitated for a moment, then sighed and told her his story.

"I called you here today to tell you something important."

“I thought so.”

Lately, she had met Ebelz mostly for official reasons.

Today wouldn't be much different.

Serena nodded and answered, and Ebelz spoke as if he had been waiting.

“Next month, His Holiness will open the Heavenly Gate himself.”

“What...?”

“He will open the Heavenly Gate that connects to the Divine Realm of Order, and summon many angels to the earth.”

Serena doubted her ears when she heard Ebelz's story.

He would open the passage to the Divine Realm.

He would summon angels to the earth.

It sounded like something that would help a lot in the war.

But the reality was not so.

There was always a fair price for a miracle.

Especially if it was a huge event that affected the entire continent, the price would not be light.

“If he does that, the causality rate will...”

The causality rate related to the Goddess of Order would collapse.

The collapsed causality rate would have a negative impact on the entire Temple of Order.

Opening the Heavenly Gate was nothing but a temporary solution.

It was also close to a last resort that would completely disable one temple.

The best way for Crossbridge was to win the war with the power of heroes.

But Ebelz still maintained his attitude despite that.

“His Holiness knows that well.”

“Then why...”

“For a while, all priests of the Temple of Order outside the holy land will lose their power.”

Ebelz was right.

All functions related to the Temple of Order would stop in all temples outside the holy land.

This also applied to the heretic inquisitors who were expelled from the Temple of Order.

Then, the influence of the Temple of Order would be greatly reduced for a while.

That was a factor that hindered the reconstruction of the continent even after the subjugation of the apostles.

“And yet he’s doing that?”

“He has received a divine mandate for war.”

“War...?”

War.

Serena’s expression changed at the heavy word.

The weight of war discussed by the knight commander was much heavier than that of others.

Ebelz looked down at Serena and told her about the divine mandate.

“Soon, the fire of war will engulf the whole continent.”

“But there’s also the empire, right? The empire will fight for humanity with us.”

“The empire will split into several factions and wage civil war, and in the north, death’s army will stir.”

“That’s...”

“We can’t rely on the empire in this war. We have to face the church with only Crossbridge’s power.”

It was not a light thing that meant they could not get help from the empire, which was the epitome of human civilization, in the upcoming war.

It wasn’t a crusade. It was a bloody war where they fought each other for their own reasons.

Humanity could not unite properly.

The Holy Emperor had already made that judgment.

As if to prove it, cold reality continued to flow out of Ebelz’s mouth.

“The hero of order lost to an apostle of the church, and the hero of honor betrayed us long ago.”

“...”

“The Temple of Harmony also betrayed us, and even the white holy sword was taken away by the church. That’s why His Holiness made his decision.”

Serena felt many emotions from Ebelz’s black eyes.

It was a weak side that he could never face in his life.

The black holy sword, Ebelz Edelrant, was always a strong being.

But now he looked like he was afraid of something.

“Do you know why I’m telling you this?”

“...I don’t know.”

Why did he act like this? She couldn’t understand his attitude at all.

As she tried to ask him about her doubt,

Squeeze

Ebelz suddenly hugged her tightly

“Serena. I wish you hadn’t become a saintess.”

“Ah...”

“But... fate is so cruel. You became a saintess even though you hated the temple more than anyone.”

He pulled her back with a strong force.

She lifted her head and looked at Ebelz as she felt his warmth in her hand.

She felt a strange sadness in his dark emotions.

He looked very sad even though he wasn’t crying.

“Why are you doing this? I don’t understand at all.”

“I think Ascalon and your existence are the only hope for us.”

“Well, of course, Ascalon is powerful...”

“Heroes are beings that burn themselves to light the way. The fate of a saintess is not much different from them.”

He hugged her tighter.

His attitude also made Serena feel uneasy.

What was he afraid of?

He was emotional in a way that didn't suit his large stature.

“When the end of the cruel war comes, you will have to think about your own end.”

“That's natural, isn't it? Everyone is fighting against the heretics with their lives. Everyone admires and follows those heroes.”

The beings that burned themselves at the forefront.

That's why the world called them heroes.

There were some who fell off the path and became corrupted, but most of the heroes were pure-hearted.

She admired their stories.

And she became a saintess to help them.

But Ebelz didn't seem to like that fact.

“The last flame of Ascalon is completed by the sacrifice of the saintess of abundance.”

“What...?”

“It means that you will have to face a moment when you have to choose for the future of humanity.”

She had to die for Ascalon to be completed.

It was like a death sentence from Ebelz.

She laughed bitterly.

She had guessed it for a long time.

There was no happy ending for the heroes of the story.

They knew it, yet they moved forward for their faith.

But what Ebelz really wanted was not for her to do it.

He had his own reason for bringing up this story.

“What do you want me to do, my knight commander?”

“Don’t die. Serena Ederunt.”

“Is that so...?”

The force that embraced Serena became stronger.

He used to treat her like a saint, but now he showed a more parental side.

Phew.

A short sigh escaped from Serena’s lips.

Ebelz’s voice echoed in her ears as she exhaled.

“Survive, no matter what you have to sacrifice.”

Serena’s hand, which was hanging in the air, moved towards Ebelz’s back.

She gently stroked his back with her clumsy touch.

It was the first time she comforted him like this, except for when she was young.

The words that came out of his mouth were too foolish.

“But that’s too disrespectful, isn’t it?”

“...Serena.”

“I’m not a child anymore.”

She said that and leaned her cheek on his shoulder.

She was a saint, no matter what anyone said.

She had long ago made up her mind to burn herself for him.

As long as he kept looking at her, even if the whole world disappeared, it was enough.

That was the only reason she lived.

Her dream was the sky’s dream.

And the future that the sky spoke of was her destiny.

“I wonder how much longer I have to wait until I can face you.”

She drew an uncertain future from the cold touch of the glass in her hand.

A world that obeys under the name of God.

Everyone shouts his name, worships him, and reveres him.

Everyone who faces him cheers and applauds.

Behind him, the six apostles of the church will follow him.

Of course, the one closest to him should always be herself.

She was his first apostle, after all.

“Please let me be a part of your great story.”

Swoosh.

Her ash-colored eyes engraved the image of the vessel on her retina.

A small stone temple in the middle of Uto.

There, Eutenia watched the figure of a person in a glass tube.

Black hair. Eyes hidden by eyelids.

It was a vessel of God that was waiting for completion, still in the shape of a young boy.

It was what Elbon had stored with an accelerator and Eutenia quietly came in alone to face it.

Eutenia smiled contentedly as she looked at the vessel of God in front of her.

“The moment I face you, the great one... I’m really looking forward to it.”

It was a flesh that was made by the church itself after receiving a revelation from the great being.

When the flesh was completed, her master would soon manifest himself on earth in this form.

At that moment, she would be able to see the appearance of God that she had longed for so much.

Eutenia reached out and caressed the surface of the glass tube as she imagined the future to come.

“There were so many things that happened until now.”

The events that had happened so far flashed through Eutenia’s mind as she looked at the vessel of God.

After her father was dragged away with a false charge and bandits raided her village that day,

Eutenia had changed as she went through many things.

She received grace from the great being and saved her life, and also became chosen by him to carry out his great will.

Since becoming an apostle, she never forgot to thank him for choosing her.

“From being an outcast, I met you and kept running for you.”

The great being always looked down at her.

Under his warm care, Eutenia did not hesitate to stain her hands with blood for him.

Even if everything in the world disappeared, as long as he kept looking at her, it was enough.

That was what drove her to live now.

Her dream was the sky’s dream.

And the future that the sky spoke of was her destiny.

“I will continue to go on for you.”

Years. Decades. Centuries.

Maybe until her life ran out.

Eutenia Hyrost would always serve him faithfully for his sake.

That was the path of faith she chose.

Since their first meeting, Eutenia owed him a debt that she could never repay.

She wanted to remain his apostle until she paid off all that debt.

“How much longer do I have to wait until I can face you?”

She drew an uncertain future from the cold touch of the glass in her hand.

A world that obeys under the name of God.

Everyone shouts his name, worships him, and reveres him.

Everyone who faces him cheers and applauds.

Behind him, the six apostles of the church will follow him.

Of course, the one closest to him should always be herself.

She was his first apostle, after all.

“Please let me be a part of your great story.”

Swoosh.

Her ash-colored eyes engraved the image of the vessel on her retina.

A small stone temple in the middle of Uto.

There, a god and an apostle were, with their eyes closed.

Chapter 168: Daydream (1)

Chapter 168: Daydream (1)

The mansion of the Duke of Colt was located on an island.

The duke was sitting in his office, looking at his servant with an annoyed expression.

He was displeased by the story that came out of the servant's mouth.

Tap. Tap.

He drummed his fingers on the table and glared at the servant.

“Say it again. Who came here?”

“The Earl of Kelters came from the duchy. He said he was following the order of Prince Ribore.”

“Why is the Earl of Kelters here?”

The Earl of Kelters.

The duke frowned at the name that was too familiar to be pleasant.

The Earl of Kelters was a busy man who barely had enough time to handle his own affairs in the duchy.

It was a joke that the duchy would not function properly without him.

And yet, he came here under Ribore's order.

What did he do with his duties in the duchy?

The duke was irritated by both the son who sent him and the earl who obediently came here.

The servant, who met the duke's eyes, answered him with a helpless expression.

"That is... I don't know either."

"Never mind. Bring the earl to me. I'll ask him myself."

"Yes, sir."

The servant bowed and left to fetch the earl.

As soon as the servant left, Scollaus, who was standing next to him, turned his gaze to the duke.

He looked at the duke with his usual frivolous expression and said,

"It's surprising. The prince sent someone himself."

"It's a stupid thing to do. Why on earth did he send the Earl of Kelters here?"

"Doesn't that mean he trusts the Earl of Kelters very much?"

"I don't understand the earl either. He's not the kind of person who would abandon his work and leave the duchy obediently."

The Earl of Kelters was one of the nobles that the duke sincerely trusted.

No matter how powerful Ribore was, he couldn't openly threaten the Earl of Kelters.

But the earl had come here following the heir's order.

The duke saw many suspicious aspects in this situation.

As they were talking about the earl, they heard the servant's voice from outside the door.

"The earl is here."

"Let him in."

At the duke's command, the servant opened the door and ushered him in.

Creak.

The face of the Earl of Kelters who entered with the door opening was very pale.

He looked so unhealthy that no one would say he was well.

The Earl of Kelters greeted the duke as soon as he entered the room.

"It's been a long time since I saw you."

The duke stroked his beard with a troubled expression at the sight of the Earl of Kelters, who looked worse than he expected.

He watched him for a while and then offered him a short consolation.

"I see. Are you feeling unwell? You look very pale."

"I think I had a bad case of diarrhea from something I ate yesterday."

"Tsk. Take care of your health. If you're sick, it'll be a big problem for the duchy."

The Earl of Kelters was a talent of the duke's family.

It would be troublesome if he ruined his health and had to recuperate for a long time.

Maybe he felt the duke's concern.

The Earl of Kelters looked at him with a touched expression and praised his greatness.

“As expected, only the Duke of Colt recognizes me. Ever since we first met...”

“Ahem. Enough with the embarrassing stories.”

“Yes.”

Of course, his words were cut short by the duke’s order.

The duke, who stopped the earl’s talk, got up from his seat.

The brief greetings were over and it was time to get to the point.

Thud. Thud.

The duke rose from his seat and walked up to the Earl of Kelters.

He stopped in front of the earl and looked at his pale face.

Then he asked him the purpose of his visit.

“I heard Ribore sent you, but what are you here for?”

“My lord, this is a rather important matter...”

“Well, it must be important if you came yourself.”

“The prince entrusted me with this. Can we talk alone?”

When he inquired about his reason for coming, the Earl of Kelters unexpectedly requested a private conversation.

It was unlike his usual self.

The duke’s eyes turned to the servant and Scollaus.

He couldn't send Scollaus away, who was guarding him.

The duke gestured to the servant after some thought.

Go outside for a while, he ordered.

"I'll go down then."

The servant bowed and left at the duke's command.

The duke's eyes returned to the Earl of Kelters.

But he still looked uneasy.

"My lord... It would be better if we talked just the two of us."

"Are you asking me to send Scollaus away too?"

"If possible..."

It was a strange attitude.

The Earl of Kelters wouldn't normally care so much about Scollaus.

He couldn't think of any reason to exclude Scollaus from this meeting.

The duke shook his head and refused the earl's request.

"Don't worry. He's tight-lipped. You don't need to be concerned."

Heh.

Scollaus smirked as he watched the earl's demand.

It was a mockery of the earl who tried to get rid of him.

The duke ignored Scollaus and took another step toward the earl.

The earl, who looked displeased, lowered his head and opened his mouth.

“My lord.”

“Answer me. What business do you have on the island?”

“Now you don’t trust me. I’m disappointed.”

“What did you say...?”

The duke was bewildered by the earl’s incomprehensible words.

At that moment,

Swoosh!

The earl’s hand, with sharp claws sprouting out, lunged at him.

The duke stared at it with wide eyes as the earl suddenly attacked him.

The hand that came at an unreactable speed aimed for the duke’s throat.

“Die—!”

The duke felt death approaching from the claws that were close to him.

If he died like this, there would be no more futile life than his.

As he was about to close his eyes at his end, Scollaus’s swift sword strike cut off the earl’s arm.

Slash!

As the hand that was charging at him fell off, the earl’s blood splashed on the duke’s face.

“Aaaargh...!”

“Ke, Earl of Kelters! What the hell are you doing!”

Thump. Roll roll.

The jaws that were targeting him disappeared with the blood that scattered.

It was a situation where he might have died if Scollaus hadn't reacted quickly.

Whew.

With a sigh of relief, the duke reflexively touched his neck as the earl's arm accelerated forward again.

“Ugh... Aaaah!”

“Guh...!”

The severed end was jammed into the duke's mouth, and something unknown flowed into his body.

The Earl of Kelters, who had lost his arm, had attempted a surprise attack on the duke, ready to die.

Ignoring the pain, he shoved the end into the duke's mouth, his eyes overflowing with madness.

He gave a nasty laugh and shouted in a loud voice.

“For the great ancestor!”

“You bastard!”

Of course, Scollaus wasn't just watching.

As soon as the Earl of Kelters stuck his arm into the duke's mouth,

Slash!

Scollaus's swift sword strike cut off the earl's head.

The duke pushed away the headless body in a hurry as he saw the head rolling on the floor.

He barely escaped from the Earl of Kelters and collapsed, gasping for breath.

“Puah! Ha, ha...”

“My lord! Are you all right?”

Scollaus, who had cut off the earl, came over to support the duke.

He looked at the duke’s condition with a worried face.

The duke slowly checked his own body as he sat on the floor.

His arms and legs. Even his neck that had been directly targeted.

He couldn’t find any wounds on his skin.

“Ha...”

He was just startled by the sudden attack.

Thanks to Scollaus’s quick response, he seemed to be fine.

The duke opened his mouth to tell Scollaus his condition.

“Ha... Don’t worry. It’s nothing...”

Thump.

He frowned at the throbbing that spread through his heart.

His mouth didn’t move easily as he tried to say he was fine.

Thump. Thump.

The irregular beating was signaling a bad change.

“...”

“My lord?”

Something was wrong with his body.

It felt like it wasn't his own flesh.

In this dire situation, the duke forced his lips open and spat out his words.

“There's... a problem.”

The gloomy sky with no sunlight.

I looked at the depressing weather today and let out a short yawn to chase away my sleepiness.

I leaned on the railing with my smartphone in my hand, playing a game.

The screen of my smartphone showed the same idle game as always.

Lately, I felt like I only played this game.

When did I stop playing other games?

I couldn't remember a clear point in time.

“Well, I must have gotten bored of them.”

It was natural to neglect games that lost their interest.

When I thought about it, it wasn't something I needed to worry about deeply.

Yawn. I turned my eyes to the screen of my smartphone.

I could see the apostles looking at the glass tube on the other side of the screen.

Led by Elbon, who was standing in front of the huge tube, Eutenia, Evan, Pluto, and Perrin were watching the character.

“He’s grown a lot since then.”

The character in the tube had also grown considerably over time.

He used to look like a young child, but now he was closer to a boy.

He felt like he would become an adult soon.

As the apostles expressed their impressions of the developing character, Elbon, who was operating the tube under many eyes, raised a speech bubble above his head.

“All I have to do is activate this magic circle and my work is done.”

He was almost finished with making the character.

“What happens next?”

“Next, we just wait for the avatar to grow.”

Elbon finished his words and infused light into the magic circle.

Whirring.

Light rose from the base that wrapped around the tube, and a brilliant light covered the whole tube.

The character closed his eyes as he was enveloped in light. He looked pious to anyone who saw him.

I uttered a short admiration as I watched the shining character beyond the screen.

“It’s magnificent.”

I remembered the character jumping around the village wrapped in light.

He looked cool even without the flashy outfit he wore when he roamed the city.

It made my heart swell just thinking about it.

That was surely the end content of this game.

“I’m done with my work.”

As I imagined a bright future while watching the glowing character, Elbon stepped back from the magic circle.

He wiped the sweat off his forehead with his sleeve. He must have worked hard.

The tube was emitting light on its own without Elbon’s touch.

Evan thanked Elbon as he looked at him finishing his work.

“Good job. Elbon Claude.”

“...If you really think so, I’d appreciate it if you returned Enia first.”

“I’ll summon my disciple to the sanctuary soon.”

Thud.

Elbon nodded at Evan’s words and sat down on a chair that was placed in a corner of the temple.

It had been a long time since he brought Elbon here.

He had been living on food alone for a while due to the lack of materials, but now he was no different from an honorary disciple of the cult.

He felt like giving him some reward for his hard work.

“Should I give you one of the dolls in my inventory?”

The first thing that came to his mind was a doll.

[Eutenia] had eaten all the [cakes], so he thought he might as well give him one of the remaining [beast dolls].

As I smiled contentedly at Elbon's finished work, messages started to appear on the bottom of the screen.

My eyes naturally moved from Elbon to the message box below.

-The body for <Descent> is ready.

-The progress of <Descent> is updated. The progress of <Descent> has reached stage 3.

-<Divine Power (Lv.1)> is unlocked.

The last quest of the <Descent> skill was cleared with Elbon's work done.

And with that, a message popped up saying that I had acquired a new skill.

The name of the new skill was <Divine Power>.

I couldn't help but wonder as I looked at the new skill I had obtained.

“...Huh?”

Chapter 169: Daydream (2)

Chapter 169: Daydream (2)

The detailed description of the <Divine Power> skill was hard to understand.

It wasn't that the skill text itself was made of difficult words.

It was just that I couldn't accept the reason why those sentences were written there.

I tilted my head as I looked at the explanation of something that didn't seem like a skill.

-<Divine Power (Lv.1)>

-You become divine for 60 seconds.

-Your physical body is temporarily deactivated while you are divine.

-<Divine Power> can only be used by the user who has contracted with the apostles and the completed body.

-There is a 30-day cooldown after use.

You become divine for 60 seconds.

The first line of the skill text was very abstract.

I could understand the word 'divine' in the text because of the skill name.

But that was it.

There was no clear indication of what effect the skill had.

And what I couldn't understand even more was the next line.

“Your physical body is deactivated? What does that mean?”

Your physical body is temporarily deactivated.

If I took the sentence literally, it meant that he would put my body in a dormant state for a while.

This part was hard to accept no matter how I thought about it.

“How can it deactivate my body?”

Human civilization had advanced rapidly, but there were still technical limitations.

Even with modern virtual reality technology, all you could do was wear a large display device and move around.

Not to mention the devices in my smartphone, which were impossible to do even if I died and came back to life.

“Did they implant a chip in my head without me knowing?”

It was impossible unless they had implanted a chip in my head.

It was definitely impossible with modern technology.

I chuckled at the absurd text and wondered, then another possibility came to my mind.

“Or maybe, it's a metaphorical expression? Don't tell me they call it deactivation because I'm focused on the game?”

It was a game that had a lot of bizarre situations.

The screen suddenly cut off, or the item name was broken and unreadable.

The item evaporated by itself and was replaced by another item.

I woke up and found out that I had paid 2 million won.

It was so strange that even I, who played the game, had fallen asleep several times during play.

It seemed a bit understandable if I thought that the skill text was a result of being immersed in the concept.

“They really put their lives on keeping the concept.”

‘Divine’ indeed. The text looked like I had actually become a god.

But I wasn’t really a god just because I was worshiped by high-performance AIs.

I was just a human who ate ramen in a studio apartment.

How could I have omnipotent power?

Whew.

I looked at my smartphone with a hollow laugh, and my eyes naturally went to the skill icon that was added at the bottom of the screen.

The icon with a human figure covered in light was a symbol of <Divine Power> for anyone who saw it.

“Let’s try it once.”

Seeing is believing, as they say.

It would be better to experience it myself by using the skill than trying to understand the difficult sentences.

I couldn’t just leave the skill I had obtained unused.

There was no need to hesitate once I made up my mind.

I moved my finger toward the <Divine Power> skill icon.

-Please select a target for <Divine Power>.

As soon as I touched the skill icon, a marker for selecting a target appeared on the screen.

On the screen, the possible targets for the skill were shining.

Evan, Eutenia, Pluto, Perrin.

And the character beyond the glass tube in front of them.

I had five choices for the target.

“It would be a waste if I didn’t use it on the character I made.”

I had already decided which character to use the skill on.

I brought the marker to the character in the glass tube without hesitation.

The boy with a mysterious aura still had his eyes closed.

The boy’s body glowed with colorful light as the marker was placed on him.

“Let’s see how amazing it is.”

I touched the marker again to activate the skill after placing it on the boy.

Flash.

A bright light burst out as I used the skill.

And a message was added at the bottom of the screen.

-You use <Divine Power>.

-Your physical body is deactivated for 60 seconds.

Thud.

The smartphone I was holding fell to the floor with a dull sound.

The first thing I felt was floating.

I felt like I was hovering in midair, wrapped in something warm.

My feet didn't touch the ground.

I couldn't feel the ground in my body that was drifting underwater.

“...”

The next thing I felt was omnipotence.

I felt a fullness in my chest, as if I could do anything.

It was an emotion that I had never felt before.

A strange satisfaction spread throughout my body with every heartbeat.

“Ah...”

The last thing that came to me was a sense of dissonance.

It was a dissonance that came from the mismatch between the last situation I remembered and the information that my body sent me.

A wave of information that suddenly hit me started to crush my brain.

The flow of the wind. The rising bubbles. The stopped breathing.

The overwhelming density of information made my head overheat.

‘...What's going on?’

I couldn't understand the situation, so I lifted my heavy eyelids.

The darkness that covered my eyes faded away, and a huge light entered my sight.

What I saw when I opened my eyes was a small temple made of stone.

It wasn't the narrow studio apartment where I had been standing until a moment ago.

I saw the scenery of the temple for the first time.

'Is this... not my home?'

My mind was confused by the unfamiliar scenery.

I was playing a game in my room until just now.

It was a game that I always played, a neglect-type game.

I had just acquired a new skill in the game.

I pressed the skill icon myself to test the new skill.

And then I opened my eyes here.

'What the hell is this?'

My memory didn't connect properly.

There was a huge gap between my memory and reality that I couldn't understand.

I had no recollection of coming to this temple.

Nor did I have any reason to come here.

At least, it wasn't by my own will that I came here.

Then what kind of situation is this?

Is it kidnapping? Or maybe——.

“Ah——.”

A faint female voice rang in my ears as I tried to figure out the situation.

My eyes, filled with confusion, naturally turned to where the voice came from.

Beyond the translucent liquid that wrapped around my body,

There was a girl in a black cloak looking at me.

She looked stunned as she met my eyes, and stood there with her mouth open.

The girl in front of me had an exotic appearance that matched her exotic outfit.

For a moment, I looked at her and felt a familiar feeling from her.

‘Did she kidnap me? Why do I feel like I know her?’

I slowly scanned the girl who was staring blankly at me.

Ash-colored hair that reached her waist.

Large eyes filled with surprise.

A black cloak that fluttered with a tinge of black.

It reminded me of Eutenia, who I always played with in the game.

‘Wait, Eutenia?’

Yes. Eutenia looked like that for sure.

I was confused by the girl who resembled Eutenia.

Why did the girl in front of me look like Eutenia?

It was an incomprehensible situation.

‘Could it be, someone else too?’

I looked at the others with a doubtful gaze.

Next to the girl who looked like Eutenia, there was a young man wearing a gauntlet.

His face, which had a complicated expression, looked somehow like Evan.

“The body opened his eyes...”

He muttered with a shocked face as he looked at me.

He was the same.

After Eutenia, Evan was in front of me.

An impossible possibility rose in my mind.

I moved my eyes to the side with an uneasy feeling.

‘...’

There was another familiar face next to Evan.

The third apostle, Pluto Astraia.

She had a pale complexion that was characteristic of vampires, and she opened her mouth as she looked at me.

Her red-tinted hair was too intense to be human.

There was someone who looked like Pluto here, after Eutenia and Evan.

At this point, I didn’t have to think about who was next.

‘Eutenia. Evan. Pluto. And next to them...’

Perrin Steit.

She had pointed ears that were typical of fairies, and she sparkled her eyes as she looked at me.

I felt like I had hit my head hard as I saw Perrin’s blonde hair flying.

The last skill description I saw flashed through my mind.

This was what the skill description I had encountered said.

-You become divine for 60 seconds.

Divine.

A word that meant a god descending into a human body.

And the target I had chosen for the divine power was also a character who was submerged in a liquid, just like me.

Just like me right now.

If the content of the skill text was true, then maybe I could understand why I was here.

I had descended into the game world with the effect of the <Divine Power> skill.

‘What... This is crazy. No matter how I think about it, this doesn’t make sense.’

No. I can’t understand it.

The scene in front of me couldn’t be made by a smartphone screen or anything like that.

It doesn’t make sense. It was impossible to explain logically.

It was a phenomenon that couldn't be explained by common sense.

'Is this supposed to be reality?'

The apostles from the game world were in front of me.

And they were looking at me with complicated eyes.

It was an absurd scene.

How could the characters from the game exist in reality?

It was a story that anyone would laugh at if I told them.

'This is an illusion.'

What I see in front of me is surely an illusion.

It's not real. It's an illusion.

It had to be. Because it was a scene that was impossible even with the current human technology.

And it was a scene that should never be possible.

My tired mind must have been dreaming up this daydream by itself.

"O great one..."

I ignored Eutenia's voice in my ear and kept repeating to myself in my mind.

This was a fragment of a dream that touched the impossible.

It shouldn't be possible.

It shouldn't be real.

No matter what happened, it shouldn't exist in reality.

‘This is a dream.’

This is not reality.

Not even a game.

This is all just a simple illusion.

It’s nothing but a fleeting dream of my twisted mind.

It had to be that way.

No matter what happened, this had to be a dream.

‘If not... then I...’

If not.

If this was all reality.

If everything I faced was real.

Then what have I been doing all this time?

‘...’

Under the pretext of entertainment for a moment, I had destroyed so many things.

With this light finger, I had crushed countless lives.

So this had to be a lie.

There shouldn’t be any tragedy beyond the play that I didn’t know about.

If not, I couldn’t bear it.

I,

couldn’t bear it.

“It feels like I’m dreaming.”

In the moment of my dream, Eutenia smiled at me.

Right after her voice ended,

My vision blurred and my consciousness began to sink.

Beyond the fading sight, I kept looking at Eutenia’s face.

-The duration of <Divine Power> has expired.

-<Divine Power> is terminated.

Chapter 170: Daydream (3)

Daydream (3)

“Haah, ha...”

My mind cleared up.

I saw my fingers stretched out clearly in front of me.

The floating sensation that covered my whole body, the omnipotence that filled my chest, they were all gone.

I was still standing in my studio apartment.

Just like before I pressed the button, I was blankly staring at the floor.

“What the hell... is this...”

It was a familiar scene.

The small room I chose for commuting after getting a job.

I had slept and woken up in that room countless times.

I was still alone in the room.

The only difference from usual was that the smartphone I was holding in my hand had fallen to the floor.

‘I was definitely... playing a game.’

My eyes, which were breathing heavily, turned to the smartphone on the floor.

The game was still on on the smartphone that was bouncing on the floor.

The idle game I always played.

Beyond the small screen, the game characters were having a conversation.

That too, in the stone temple where I had just faced the apostles.

-“You closed your eyes again.”

-“Did the great one not fully descend?”

-“It seems... we still have things to prepare.”

I saw the conversation that the characters were having beyond the screen.

And that content was connected to my previous memory.

The conversation that the apostles had in the temple came to my mind vividly.

Their voices, which I heard for the first time, were very lively.

The story continued from the short fragment of memory.

The next content would probably be similar to what I see now.

The result of the event that I dismissed as a dream was existing in front of me.

“It wasn’t a dream?”

That couldn’t be.

There was no way that everything I created with my own hands actually existed.

I reached out with a trembling hand and picked up my phone.

I saw Eutenia stroking a glass tube beyond the shaking screen.

Eutenia smiled faintly and said, looking at the glass tube.

-“I hope that when you come back next time, the whole world will be under your feet.”

Thud.

Something in my head felt like it snapped.

It felt like I heard something I shouldn't have heard.

I opened my mouth, looking at Eutenia beyond the screen.

“What are you talking about...”

-“If it's for you, we can sacrifice the empire and the holy land.”

There are moments when you end up admitting something even if you don't want to admit it.

Even if it's something you really want to deny.

There are moments when you give in and accept it.

For me, this was one of those moments.

I found myself affirming what I had denied beyond denial.

“Stop...”

This is not a dream.

I know the truth, even if I want to deny it.

This can't be a lie.

Yes.

The world on the screen in front of me is real.

-“I’ll work hard from now on.”

I...

I killed people.

I created a monster that kills people.

And I was happy to see them die.

I felt ecstasy as I watched countless people die with a flick of my hand.

“Stop...”

Now the cult that I created is killing people for me.

The ones I ruined with my own hands are doing evil for me.

There is no excuse.

There is no possibility of escaping responsibility.

They will kill as many people as they can for me.

For me.

For that one reason alone, Eutenia Hyrost will keep killing people from now on.

“...”

How many did I kill?

Hundreds? Thousands? Millions?

How many numbers did I sacrifice?

For my mere entertainment, how many people have died so far?

How many more have to die, to end this situation?

“I...”

I don’t know.

I can’t even estimate the numbers that keep floating in my head.

I killed too many lives.

For nothing.

Because I was unhappy.

Because I was depressed.

Because I wanted karma.

I kept killing people.

For something worthless, countless lives were destroyed.

A killing machine disguised as a game was always in my hand.

-“I’ll do my best until the day I die.”

Eutenia’s words keep reaching me as I look at the screen with trembling hands.

The black letters on the white background were engraved in my brain more than anything else.

Even if I cover my eyes, or avoid my gaze.

In the end, I was only looking at Eutenia’s words.

I would only face her who was working hard for my pointless amusement.

“Stop it already.”

-“Only for you.”

“Don’t work hard for something like that–!”

Crash!

The smartphone I threw fell to the floor.

My head was burning.

My heated brain hindered my thoughts, and my breath became rough.

With trembling lips, I exhaled my ragged breath and desperately covered my mouth as nausea surged.

“Ugh...”

The thoughts I had suppressed all came back at once.

Everything I saw disgusted me.

I was disgusted by myself, who felt ecstasy while killing people.

I was disgusted by that tiny device that mimicked a game and turned me into a monster.

I was disgusted by someone who made such a thing as a game and watched me enjoy it.

Everything inside me stirred to vomit.

“Ugh...”

Everything I put in my stomach felt like human flesh.

Every scent that came in through my breath smelled like human blood.

The floor I was stepping on felt like a corpse mound.

My past self, who laughed while killing people, felt like a hellish demon.

The rising nausea was no longer bearable.

“Ugh... Ugh...”

I felt like I would die of suffocation if I didn’t vomit everything right now.

So I ran to the bathroom in a hurry.

And then I grabbed the empty toilet and threw up everything that was piled up in my chest.

My hand that struggled to vomit something clenched with force.

“_____.”

What did I eat today?

I don’t remember.

I think I ate ramen.

It didn’t feel good to vomit what I had accumulated.

“_____.”

How many lives did I trample to be here?

I don’t remember.

I think I killed countless people.

My heart was heavy as I recalled what I had forgotten.

“Haah... Hoo, ha...”

I felt nauseous.

My lips stopped spitting out the emotions that had been flowing back.

I felt relieved after vomiting for a long time.

It was dirty. And ugly.

Swoosh.

I turned on the water in the sink and rinsed my dirty mouth.

“Ha...”

I saw myself rinsing my mouth in the mirror.

There was a man with a pale face in the mirror.

He had a scruffy beard and a shaggy hair, looking at the mirror.

He was not the usual me.

He looked like a miserable man who had been broken somewhere.

“What is this...”

Crack.

My hand that exerted too much force stopped the faucet.

The sound of water that echoed in my ears stopped.

Only my voice echoed quietly in the silent bathroom.

“Is this... me...?”

The man in the mirror was ruined.

It wasn't because I faced the truth now.

The image of myself that was reflected in front of me looked like it had started to go wrong long before that.

Half a year.

Or a year.

Maybe even more.

I looked like I had aged so much.

“What a ridiculous sight.”

Click.

The distorted image in the mirror changed back to my normal self.

The monstrous appearance that suited a murderer was gone.

It was just me, as I used to be.

“Hoo...”

I was losing my mind, seeing things that weren't there.

It was a ludicrous story.

A shoddy idle game that I played alone at home was actually a reality somewhere else.

Anyone who heard it would laugh at it.

It wouldn't matter if I told my friends, or my coworkers, or anyone else.

They would never give me a positive answer.

“Is this a god? Is this pathetic thing a god?”

I snorted with a hollow laugh.

After the nausea subsided, I felt a terrible exhaustion.

Just by touching my smartphone, they called me a god and looked at me.

The more I thought about it, the more absurd it was.

“Is this... an evil god...?”

The evil that killed people was mine.

The machine only conveyed my will.

The deeper I thought, the more I despised myself.

Creak.

I opened the bathroom door and walked out. There was a thick front door in front of me.

“Anyone can see... this is impossible...”

I wanted to run away.

I wanted to escape from this suffocating feeling in my chest.

For a moment, that thought filled my mind.

I didn't resist the huge impulse that moved me.

I didn't feel the need to do so.

“Feeling guilty for a game... how stupid.”

Clang.

I opened the heavy door and went outside.

I slowly walked out of the building in my slippers.

The cold autumn wind that grazed my cheek made me feel more depressed.

“Yeah. It was just a game.”

Thud. Thud.

My staggering steps walked along the empty street.

There were no people. No cars.

I was walking alone on the silent road where everything had disappeared.

“If I had known it was real, I wouldn’t have killed them.”

What came out of my mouth was a prickly excuse.

I needed words.

I needed a word that could deceive myself.

Just like he had lied to me, I wanted to lie to myself too.

“It’s his fault... he tricked me.”

My advancing steps reached the crosswalk where there were no cars.

A red light. I saw the dimly glowing traffic light.

There were no cars.

I ignored the signal that blocked me and stepped forward.

I wanted to run away somewhere as soon as possible.

“It’s not my fault... right?”

Thud.

As I took a slow step, I heard a loud engine sound.

A car was coming.

I lifted my head as I realized it.

“...”

My eyes crossed the road and looked to the right.

I saw a car coming from the far lane towards me.

The car didn't slow down even though it saw me.

It would crash if it kept going like this.

Even though I sensed it, my stiff legs couldn't move easily.

"It's not my fault."

Vroom!

A noisy horn sounded towards me.

The sharp sound that made my eardrums tremble warned me of the danger.

But that was all.

The car that was coming towards me didn't slow down.

Facing the bright headlights, I closed my eyes with no strength left.

-[Demon Sword: Causal Killer] is activated.

-<Reversal>: Regenerates the body by ignoring causality.

-All negative effects are removed.

-Crack. Crack.

When I opened my eyes again, I faced a quiet world dyed in dull light.

There was no trace of the intense headlights or the speeding car.

All I saw in front of me was a broken car that had stopped right in front of me.

The car with shattered windows was covered with dust.

I couldn't see any people behind the broken glass.

The car looked abandoned for a long time and I doubted if it could even drive.

“What is this.”

The first thing that came out of my mouth was a word full of panic.

Was I scared of the damaged car with no driver and closed my eyes?

My mind couldn't keep up with the sudden change.

I was sure I had seen the headlights, but the car in front of me had no lights on.

I started to scan the surroundings with confusion.

“...”

The asphalt with cracks.

The cars that were all broken and left alone.

The bonnets that were so dirty that I couldn't tell when they were washed last.

The traffic lights that had lost their light and were silent.

And beyond that, the buildings with broken windows and no lights.

“What is this...”

Everything I saw was ruined.

I couldn't feel any signs of people.

The whole neighborhood was still as if it had stopped breathing.

I was the only one in this abandoned world.

“...”

I walked forward unconsciously in a space where I felt no signs of life.

Thud. Thud.

Every time I stepped on the dark crosswalk, I saw a convenience store with broken windows.

I slowly scanned the approaching convenience store.

“Why does it look like a war broke out...”

Behind the shattered windows of the convenience store, I saw shelves that had fallen to the floor.

Snacks and ramen were all gone, and maggots were writhing on rotten sandwiches.

It looked like it had been left alone for a long time.

I felt like I would vomit if I looked closely.

I felt hollow in my empty stomach.

I tried to ignore the scenery of the convenience store and changed my direction to check other places.

“Ah...”

As I wandered around the dead street, I felt something caught on my shoe.

Screech.

A newspaper that had been stepped on was torn in half.

My eyes naturally moved to the newspaper on the ground.

The ragged newspaper looked like it had been abandoned for a long time.

The headline was written in large letters on the faded newspaper.

“Explosive spread... City lockdown order...”

As I looked at the headline of the newspaper, I lifted my head and looked around.

The ruined city was clearly visible.

It was a city that had been neglected for a long time, where I felt no human presence.

City lockdown order.

And a city that was deserted with no one left.

The only thing that moved in the silence was myself, muttering to myself.

“Did I get abandoned...?”

My eyes that stared at the ash-covered landscape looked at the direction where my house was.

It was unbelievable.

The last time I checked, my room looked the same as always.

The autumn scenery that shone through the window.

The children’s voices that came in from the open window.

Everything was as usual, just staying there.

“Let’s go home.”

I had to check.

I had to go back to the house I just left and see what happened to my home.

I felt like I could accept this situation if I did that.

I hurried my slow steps and started to go back to my house.

It was a day full of impossible things.

I hoped this was all a dream, that's how much.

“Please...”

My quickened steps crossed the crosswalk and returned to the narrow alley I always passed by.

As I passed the familiar street and took a shortcut, I saw the building where I lived.

My face hardened as I faced the shabby building.

The exterior of the building with broken windows had a very ominous atmosphere.

It didn't look like a place where people could live.

“Ah, ah...”

Everything was strange.

It wouldn't make sense if it wasn't a nightmare.

That the character in the game was real, that the world had turned into ruins overnight.

They were all terribly realistic nightmares that couldn't be possible otherwise.

“A dream, right?”

As I stared blankly at the unreal scene, I moved my trembling legs and went up to find my room.

I passed the dusty stairs and went up to the floor where my room was and looked for the locked door of my room.

Ignoring the dirty stairs and reaching the door, I saw the front door that wasn't closed properly.

It looked like I didn't close the door properly when I left the house.

Clang.

I grabbed the doorknob and pulled it open, then took a step inside.

“...”

As I entered the room, I looked around first.

The faded lottery paper.

The black feathers piled up on the torn chicken box.

The ramen box covered with dust that I didn't know when I brought it.

The green soju bottle that was empty and rolling on the floor.

And among all those things, Estelle was standing there.

“Estelle?”

“I'm glad you're safe.”

Estelle greeted me as always as she faced me.

Estelle was standing among the unreal scenes.

I sighed with relief as I faced Estelle.

There was only one thing that Estelle being here meant.

This was a nightmare.

It wasn't the reality that changed without me knowing, but one of the common nightmares that I met Estelle irregularly.

"I'm glad... It was all a dream."

I entered the room with relief as Estelle proved it was a dream.

It was a terrible nightmare.

One that I didn't want to have again.

That I was left alone in a broken world in an instant.

It was a worse nightmare than the ones with weird monsters because it felt more real.

"It can't be anything but a dream, right?"

"What?"

But Estelle's words that followed stopped my thoughts.

What did Estelle just say to me?

My blank eyes recalled her words and looked at her.

The black girl who faced me in black looked very serious.

I couldn't help but ask Estelle who denied my words.

"Estelle, what are you talking about...?"

Estelle smiled at me.

She still stood proudly in the ruined world.

Estelle's arrogant eyes reflected my pitiful appearance.

I looked like the one I saw in the mirror, strangely similar.

She looked at me slowly as I crumbled and said in a calm but clear voice:

“The dream is already over.”

Chapter 171: Daydream (4)

Chapter 171: Daydream (4)

When Estelle told me this was not a dream, I felt like I couldn't breathe.

Not a dream?

If this was not a dream, then what was?

My eyes, which had been staring at Estelle, shifted to the lottery ticket on the floor.

It was the same ticket that I had cashed in a few days ago, and it was still rolling around on the ground.

"Is this all... not a dream?"

Estelle was still smiling at me, but I didn't understand what she meant.

I asked her in a half-defeated voice, almost like a complaint.

"If this is not a dream, then what is...?"

"You already know, don't you?"

Estelle's gaze, holding an umbrella, moved to the smartphone that had fallen on the floor.

The smartphone that I had thrown away was still there, showing the game screen.

It was as if it was proving that the story I had experienced in the game was not a lie.

The game screen was still showing the story of Euteneia and the apostles.

As I watched it, a faint possibility crossed my mind.

A possibility that I didn't want to believe.

I whispered it quietly.

“Could it be... that everything I've lived so far was a dream?”

“Did you enjoy the dream?”

Estelle nodded as if to agree.

It was an absurd story.

That my peaceful life until now was all a lie.

And that this broken world was the only truth given to me.

Who could do such a thing?

God? Devil?

Or was the whole world around me a play to mock me?

I couldn't accept it. I denied Estelle's words right away.

“Stop lying. This can't be real.”

“Is that what you really think?”

“You... you're just a figment of my imagination in the dream.”

“Hmm.”

She spun the umbrella in her hand.

She looked at me with her unfathomable eyes, wearing a meaningless umbrella in the darkness.

Her dark eyes, unlike a human's, shone on me again.

Tap. Tap.

She tapped the handle of the umbrella with her finger and asked me a question.

“Do you remember? How did you start playing the game?”

Of course I remembered.

I couldn't forget how I started playing this game.

Someone recommended this game to me.

She told me it was our secret and showed me this game——.

“Do you remember? Why were you having a hard time that day?”

Of course I remembered.

I had trouble with human relationships.

That's why I drank too much.

Even though I knew I was far beyond my limit, I kept pouring alcohol into my empty stomach.

I felt like I couldn't bear it otherwise.

I wanted to escape from the pain for a moment by borrowing the terrible drunkenness.

And in my drunken state, I started the game——.

“Why couldn't you get out of the pain?”

Of course, I remembered.

It wasn't that I couldn't get out of the pain.

I got in touch with this game and interacted with the characters in it, and forgot about the wounds in my heart.

This game, which had penetrated deep into my life before I knew it, was ———.

“Why were you always alone?”

Of course, I remembered.

Remember? What?

It was a strange question.

I was never alone.

I always went to work and came home,

And played the game alone in my room——.

“Why were you locked up alone in a small room?”

Of course, I remembered——.

Vaguely, I remembered.

I was alone.

I was always playing the game alone in my room.

I didn't know why.

But I felt like I knew the reason.

“Why did you keep the TV on with the same broadcasts?”

That was because I was lonely.

To kill the silence of the room…….

Why was I lonely?

An unexpected question crossed my mind.

The moment I knew the answer, everything would change.

A question that dug into my heart.

“Why did you keep playing a game that you didn’t even know who made it?”

“That’s…….”

I didn’t know.

But I did know.

There was a memory that I didn’t want to know inside me.

The truth that I had buried deep in my heart for a long time, avoiding reality.

That comfort was trying to raise its head inside me.

“The reason is obvious, isn’t it? That was the only thing you could do after burying all your colleagues.”

“Stop it.”

I shouldn’t wake up.

This memory.

This emotion.

They had to stay asleep forever inside me.

It was a memory that had been buried deep for that purpose.

But Estelle's words kept digging deep into my heart.

A truth that I shouldn't know was trying to break through and rise up.

"The only thing you could do as someone who came back after burying all your colleagues was to play the game that I told you to, right?"

"Stop it! Estelle!"

A loud scream shook the narrow room.

Estelle didn't stop telling her story.

She smiled even brighter, watching me suffer.

Thump.

My heart pounded painfully.

I couldn't reveal my shame any longer.

But Estelle finally spoke the truth with her mouth.

"It wasn't because of human relationships that you were struggling, but because there were no humans, right?"

A memory buried in the darkness came back to life.

The trigger was a mobile game.

I didn't remember the exact genre, but I think it was introduced as an idle game.

The game itself was nothing special.

Small human figures walked around, and I just watched their movements.

“Stop it, please...”

The characters moved diligently and did their own tasks, as if the AI was finely crafted.

Sometimes they did something unusual out of the rules.

It felt like raising ants in a transparent gel.

I also remembered the tiny sea monkeys I raised in a fish tank.

“Stop it.”

I felt healed just by looking at the characters quietly.

I spent two or three hours a day watching them like that.

Until I came home drunk after a frustrating day.

“I don’t want to remember.”

No, it wasn’t a frustrating day.

It was a sad day.

I buried my colleagues with my own hands.

I couldn’t bear it sober, so I drank the alcohol that I had stashed in the corner.

And when I got drunk, the sadness inside me turned into another emotion.

“I don’t want to remember.”

I hated this world that had become like this.

I hated the horrible scene that the oil disaster that started in Africa had created.

I felt like I was alone after losing everything.

I felt like everyone in the world had left me behind and gone somewhere far away.

“...”

So.

So I moved my finger and killed the characters beyond the screen.

I needed something to vent my anger on.

I felt like venting my anger somewhere.

That’s how those things became a game, and a source of life for me.

“That was.”

That was a bitter and heartbreaking memory.

Heartbreaking.

A very heartbreaking memory.

A memory that I wanted to keep buried in my heart forever.

“I didn’t want to remember that.”

My head throbbed from the memories that came back.

The fragments of the hidden memories spilled out, shaking my thoughts and emotions violently.

I held my head in pain and glared at Estelle.

I gazed at her, demanding an answer, but she opened her mouth to me as our eyes met.

“I’m sorry for breaking our promise, but it’s time for you to know now.”

Promise?

Another incomprehensible story was added.

I doubted Estelle’s words.

What promise did we have between us?

The only promise we made was the rules of our conversation.

“If you want to stay a good kid forever, you can’t move forward anymore.”

But Estelle kept spouting meaningless stories.

I didn’t know.

I couldn’t guess her purpose, reason, or even identity.

Beyond the thick fog that obscured my sight, she was the only one facing the truth.

“Estelle, what do you want?”

I didn’t understand.

What did she want?

What did she want from me, who erased my memories, showed me a calm life, and locked myself in a room?

I couldn’t understand what Estelle wanted, not even a speck.

“Forgetting reality, forgetting the world where no one exists——.”

“Putting on the mask of the game and committing massacres... what did you want me to become after that?”

Tap. Tap.

Estelle’s finger tapped the handle of the umbrella again.

Hmm.

After a short time of thinking, she folded her finger.

And then she stepped forward and said to me.

“It seems like there’s a misunderstanding between us. Those things were what you wanted from the beginning, weren’t they?”

“I wanted this?”

It was impossible.

I never wanted those things.

I never wanted to kill people calmly and soberly, and pretend to live a normal life in a place where no one existed.

I was not that kind of person.

“Didn’t you want to forget everything in the broken world and just play the game in this room?”

Even if I wanted that, I wouldn’t have told it to someone I didn’t know in a dream.

But Estelle calmly affirmed it.

It was an incomprehensible attitude.

And an unacceptable answer.

“Why would I want that? Why would I want to kill people with this tiny smartphone in this room?”

“Do you remember? Who gave you the smartphone?”

I searched through the foggy memory.

Who gave me this thing?

It was the black-haired girl I met for the first time during the search operation.

I didn't know her name, and only her face vaguely remained in my memory —.

Estelle.

The girl in front of me introduced me to this game.

She said it was our secret and recommended the game to me, who had nothing.

“...”

“You remembered, didn't you?”

Estelle recommended the game to me.

In this room that only we knew, she handed me the smartphone, the only game left.

The smartphone that was still charged in the ruined world.

She gave it to me and urged me to play.

It was one of the few entertainments left in the broken world.

It would have been strange if I wasn't interested.

I thought it was just a game and brought down divine punishment on countless lives.

“It seems like you finally understood the truth.”

Blink. Blink.

I looked at the smartphone that was shining brightly even without charging.

Even when everything collapsed, this smartphone kept working.

I finally realized what I had.

And who she was.

“...The Goddess of Harmony.”

“Yes.”

“I was your apostle?”

-<Causality Adjustment> occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Tool: Ascalon] was liberated by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Tool: Hieroglyph] was liberated by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Tool: Astra] was liberated by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Tool: Smartphone] was liberated by one level.

-Due to <Hero Selection>, [Divine Tool: Dainsleif] was liberated by one level.

Crackle. Crackle——.

The world began to regain its light.

The light bulb in my dark room shone brightly, and the broken TV played the faint news that remained in my old memory.

The world I longed for after losing everything.

In it, only Estelle and I faced each other.

“Welcome back to the divine realm. My little god.”

Beyond the small smartphone screen.

There was a world there.

And there, I was, who had watched over it.

Chapter 172: How to Make a God (1)

How to Make a God (1)

The world was destroyed.

No, it was being destroyed.

It was slowly rotting from the inside, due to the oil disaster that started in Africa.

Most of the people who filled the streets became restless dead.

They couldn't eat or die, and they only wandered around looking for other victims.

The dead became more dead, and the new dead made others dead.

Seven months since the disaster began.

Now, our group was the only people left in this city.

"Yuseong. Why don't you do as I say?"

Of course, if we searched thoroughly, we might find some other survivor groups somewhere.

But as far as I knew, the people I saw in front of me were all that was left of humanity.

I looked at the man who was leading them.

The man with a sturdy physique was the most conspicuous person in our group.

He moved around with a shovel on his shoulder, and he spoke to me with a regretful face.

“It’s not that hard, is it?”

“No, why do you want me to pretend to be a company employee now?”

“That was my dream, okay? Becoming a company president.”

The man who spoke to me was Shin Donghyun.

He was the undisputed leader of our group.

He was the oldest by age, and he also took on the tough and dangerous tasks.

He was a respected person by all the members of the group.

But he had one goal that he couldn’t let go of.

His longtime dream was to start his own business and hear people call him president.

He had worked hard and saved money for his business, but the world had gone to hell right before he could start it.

“Remember we found a fish cake shop last time? Let’s take that and sell fish cakes in front of the company.”

I gave him a constructive idea and advised him.

He suggested making fish cakes with the machine we found on our last exploration.

I didn’t know if he could make them, or if we had any ingredients left.

But if we pretended to do something similar, maybe others would also pretend to buy them.

There wasn't much left to entertain ourselves in this ruined world.

"No, I want to hear you call me president. That's my dream, you know?"

"...Do you like being a president that much?"

"That's the best. That's why our group name is that. Company."

He was the one who gave us that name after he rescued me from the isolated company.

No one objected to him now.

That's why we also called our base camp the company.

It was a funny story, if you think about it.

A company in a destroyed world.

If you weren't someone who would plant an apple tree the day before the end, you wouldn't like that kind of story.

"What's the point of being a president in a useless world where money doesn't matter?"

It didn't take long for things like bank balances and overdrafts to turn into data scraps.

They had no value now.

Cash could be used as fuel, but money stuck in accounts was impossible.

Everything I had accumulated in my life was gone in vain.

The numbers that lost their meaning had no more worth than a toy gun from a stationery store.

Even though I realized that, there were still many people who collected bills as a hobby.

The self-proclaimed president in front of me was one of them.

“You know I’ve been collecting money from the stores I searched, right? What if the rescue team comes looking for us?”

“Let’s just burn it for fuel, okay? If they were coming, they would have come by now.”

But he still seemed attached to money.

Donghyun shook his head firmly and gave me a hint.

The other members who watched him also chuckled.

He seemed determined today.

Since there was nothing else to do but joke around, I decided to play along.

“Anyway, call me. President.”

“...Yes, yes. President.”

I reluctantly answered as he wanted.

He seemed a bit happier then, and he patted my shoulder and said.

“That’s right, Cheon Director. The weather is nice today.”

“I’m a director?”

“You can do that much, right?”

“How much does a director make in our company?”

I asked him with a sarcastic laugh.

Snicker.

The self-proclaimed president, who was in a good mood, stretched out his palm and said.

“500 million won.”

“Wouldn’t the company go bankrupt if you pay that much?”

“I’m willing to take the risk. So stick with me.”

“...Yes, yes. President. Please pay me on time.”

As we exchanged this tedious conversation, we soon arrived at the edge of the safe zone where the barricade was set up.

The barricade that blocked the road was erected to drive away the dead.

It was the result of what we called the pioneering work among us.

Of course, what we had to do today was not pioneering work, but exploration work in the secured area.

The company employee play was over now.

He arrived at his destination and started to scatter people according to the plan he had set up beforehand.

“Alright, everyone, be careful today!”

The purpose of the exploration work was diverse.

Searching for survivors who were missed.

Searching for luxury goods or necessities.

Searching for preserved food.

Especially, finding things like alcohol, cigarettes, or food was the main goal.

In the case of ramen, even the last product produced had reached the borderline of expiration date, so we needed to find it as soon as possible to eat it without any problem.

He divided the people into two-person teams and didn't forget to warn them.

“Keep your radio on. Contact me if there's any problem.”

“Aye, aye.”

“We cleaned it up once, but be careful in case any monsters pop out.”

“Hey, we're not kids, don't worry and go with Yuseong.”

Naturally, I was in the same team as Donghyun.

We were familiar with each other, and we both preferred each other.

He delivered all the precautions and started to walk with me to the deserted street.

Thud. Thud.

The sound of our footsteps echoed on the withered street.

Maybe it was because our colleagues who were next to us disappeared.

The atmosphere became silent in an instant.

“It's suddenly quiet.”

“What are you talking about? We were always the loudest.”

“Really? I think I was pretty quiet.”

“Yuseong. You’re becoming more and more conscienceless as I see it.”

I shrugged my shoulders quietly at his insincere remark.

It was a usual conversation for us.

“Let’s check this place today.”

He stopped in front of a building after walking for a while and scanned its exterior.

We stopped at a place that looked like it could collapse at any moment, a precarious two-story building.

It was not a metaphorical expression, but a building that was literally in a dangerous situation.

The spire of the church next to it was broken and hit the upper part of the building, and cracks were spread on the walls and the roof.

It was a place that anyone would understand if it collapsed at any time.

“The building looks pretty bad, doesn’t it?”

As I commented on the state of the building, Donghyun pointed at the crumbling building with a smile.

And then he gave me a half-reasonable and half-bullshit explanation.

“That’s why we have to check it out now. If it collapses, everything inside will be gone.”

“Well, that’s true.”

“Of course, if it feels too dangerous, we have to get out right away.”

He finished his words and grabbed the doorknob.

Creak.

As the glass door opened, the dusty scenery of the building came into my eyes.

The first floor had a shopping mall vibe with shops lined up, and there was a staircase leading to the second floor in the corner.

Cough, cough.

I coughed involuntarily as I breathed in the dust.

“Yuseong. I’ll look around the first floor, so you check out the second floor.”

Donghyun, who was looking around the mall, told me he would take care of the first floor.

Since we had cleared out the dead once, there wasn’t much chance of trouble.

The problem was rather the condition of this building.

I nodded obediently and accepted his suggestion.

It seemed better to look for things one by one than to search the same space together.

“Let’s do that.”

“Then I’ll leave it to you. Contact me if there’s any problem.”

“You’ll hear me if I just scream, what are you talking about?”

We finished our short conversation and I started to climb up the stairs to the second floor.

Of course, I didn’t forget to mutter to myself with anticipation for the future.

The biggest wish in my heart right now was ramen.

And not just any ramen, but mild ramen that I hadn't tasted for a while.

"I wish I could find some ramen."

I blurted out my inner voice as I climbed up the stairs to the second floor.

It wasn't a bad habit to talk to myself when there were no dead around.

In fact, until I met the self-proclaimed president on the first floor, I had endured by talking to myself while isolated in the company.

At that time, I felt like I would go crazy if I didn't do that.

Now it has become one of the habits that are hard to fix.

It was a habit that I acquired after the disaster happened.

"It wouldn't be bad if we had some decent beer..."

"..."

As I was looking around the second floor, I suddenly felt a presence and stopped walking.

Somewhere on the second floor, a faint humming sound was coming out.

I wondered if there were any dead around, so I tightened my grip on the shovel, but I soon realized that it was not the case.

The humming sound in my ears was unmistakably human.

And it was close to a woman's voice.

"Could it be?"

Could it be that there were survivors who we missed last time.

That thought crossed my mind.

I followed the faint sound in my ears and slowly looked around the hallway.

I headed for the direction where the humming was coming from.

And when I found the glass door, I saw the person behind it.

“...A survivor?”

There was someone reading a book in a store that looked like a comic cafe.

There was a black-haired girl wearing a T-shirt that didn't fit her body.

She was sitting in a corner of the cafe, humming and reading a book.

I watched her for a while, and then opened the glass door and entered the comic cafe.

The first thing that stepped on my foot when I entered the store was a torn page of a comic book.

The dust and paper scattered on the floor proved what had happened here.

“It looks like someone came in.”

And as she looked at me, the girl who was reading the book opened her mouth.

There was something strange about the girl who had black hair down to her waist.

I looked at her for a moment, then turned my head and looked around the half-ruined store.

Except for the torn comic books, there didn't seem to be any big problems.

Thud.

I put down the shovel on my shoulder and asked her a question disguised as a greeting.

“I didn’t expect to find any survivors. Are you hurt anywhere?”

But there was no answer from the girl who was asked.

I didn’t know if she was shy or didn’t want to answer.

But no matter what she said, there was only one thing I had to do now.

I took out the radio that I had hung on my waist.

And I tried to inform my colleagues who were elsewhere about the survivor I found.

“Donghyun hyung, I think I...”

“Shh.”

But as I was about to press the transmit button on the radio, I stopped my hand when I saw what the girl did.

The girl who didn’t say anything suddenly raised her hand.

She put her finger on her mouth and made a gesture to be quiet.

She didn’t seem to like me reporting to others.

I didn’t know if she was worried about meeting strangers or didn’t want to reveal that she was here.

But it seemed clear that she didn’t want me to call anyone else right now.

I tried to reassure her by telling her about our survivor group.

“You don’t have to worry. It may sound funny, but our company, no, group doesn’t have any bad people...”

“One is fine, but it’s hard to show mercy when there are too many people.”

“Mercy...”

“It means it’s hard to let them go peacefully.”

I couldn’t understand what she meant at all.

Except for the fact that she avoided meeting people.

She seemed reluctant to introduce me to other people right now.

But I couldn’t ignore it and move on as if nothing happened either.

I needed some compromise.

I looked at the girl with an odd atmosphere for a while, and then made a short conclusion and told her.

“Well, you seem to be very shy... You don’t have to force yourself to call anyone else.”

I decided to postpone reporting for now.

Chapter 173: How to Make a God (2)

How to Make a God (2)

I had no choice but to go down to the first floor without gaining anything from the girl I was talking to.

It was because we couldn't have a normal conversation.

She remained silent for most of my questions, and showed a negative attitude towards any attempt to call someone else.

She acted as if I didn't exist.

I couldn't force her to come with me if she hated it, so I just checked the shops on the second floor and left.

As I finished searching and went downstairs, I saw Donghyun with a box of ramen and some miscellaneous utensils.

"Yuseong, what did you find on the second floor?"

Donghyun asked me nervously about the upstairs information.

By principle, I should have told him about the girl hiding on the second floor, but it seemed better not to mention it for now.

Given the leader's personality in front of me, he wouldn't just ignore a lone survivor.

There was a high chance that he would only resent me if I pushed him too hard.

Maybe it would be better for me to persuade her and take her to the company later.

It would be troublesome if the survivor I brought caused trouble in the group.

So I calmly lied to him.

“No, there was nothing much.”

“Really? Well, we’ve searched around here a lot, so it’s not surprising that there’s nothing left.”

“They took everything away. There was nothing left.”

When I told him casually that there was nothing, Donghyun nodded his head and agreed.

He didn’t doubt my words much.

It was probably thanks to the trust we had built between us.

He trusted me more than the other members of the group.

I felt the same way.

I felt sorry for hiding the truth, but I had no bad intentions.

I believed he would understand me later.

“Well, don’t worry too much. I found something good on the first floor.”

Thump. Thump.

Donghyun tapped on the box of ramen with a slightly excited voice.

Ramen was a big harvest for us.

If we ate sparingly, we could survive for a few days with this amount.

As I looked at the ramen that Donghyun was holding, I remembered the girl I met on the second floor.

I asked Donghyun, who was satisfied with the box of ramen, about the harvest we found last time.

“Ramen is good. But do you have any chocolate left, hyung?”

“Chocolate? Why? Do you want some?”

“I’m craving some sugar.”

A while ago, we found a large amount of chocolate nearby and distributed it among the group members.

Donghyun’s personality would have made him save the chocolate instead of eating it.

As if to prove my guess, he opened his fanny pack and took out some chocolate.

The chocolate that had been piled up with dust came out of Donghyun’s bag.

He handed it to me right away and said,

“.....This is really what I saved, but I’m giving it to you because you’re my brother.”

Swoosh.

I nodded my head as I took the chocolate without hesitation.

This kind of delicacy was not easy to find in the ruined world.

I wondered if I could talk to the quiet guy on the second floor with this.

Of course, thanking Donghyun for giving me the chocolate was a bonus.

“Hyung. No, boss. I’ll die for the company.”

“Yeah, yeah. Trust me and follow me, Director Cheon.”

Donghyun received my gratitude with dignity.

Looking at Donghyun, who was leading the group, I felt like he would have taken good care of his subordinates even if he had run a business.

Whether his business would have succeeded or not was another story.

I put the chocolate in my pocket while acting out a sudden scenario.

The self-proclaimed boss looked at me curiously and asked me as he packed up the harvest he found on the first floor.

“Weren’t you going to eat it now?”

“I realized how precious chocolate is. I’m going to save it and eat it slowly.”

“Is that so? Next time I find some more, I’ll give you my share too.”

“That would be nice for me.”

I also shared the harvest that Donghyun had prepared and talked to him.

Maybe it was because he had been busy searching by himself while I was spending time on the second floor.

He was getting ready to leave this building soon.

“We searched pretty hard and got some decent harvest... Shall we look for another place?”

It wasn't strange that he had finished searching the first floor since I had wasted a lot of time on the second floor.

Besides, we had a huge harvest of ramen boxes.

It seemed okay to move on to the next building as it was.

I wanted to get out of this building as soon as possible, thinking of the huge burden hiding on the second floor.

"They'll love this today."

"Yeah. Even those who complained about ramen before are now waiting for the day we find some more."

"Here, I'll carry this. Let's go outside."

I lifted the box with the utensils and headed out of the building with a shovel.

The musty smell of the old box tickled my nose.

I felt a pang of regret that I couldn't smell the new boxes anymore.

Donghyun, who followed me with the dusty box of ramen, looked at the cracked exterior of the building and said,

"It's a good thing we finished searching before it collapsed."

"Didn't I tell you it was dangerous from the start?"

"But it's good to look around when we have a chance. We're in a situation where we can't afford to waste a single box of ramen."

I nodded slightly, remembering the girl who was left in the building.

It seemed risky to leave her alone in there.

It would be better to go back and advise her to move when I had a chance.

As I was lost in thought, fiddling with the box, Donghyun nudged my shoulder and said,

“Yuseong, let’s check out a few more places and then go check on the barricade.”

“Yes.”

We still had plenty of time.

Those who were lazy during the day would suffer at night.

It was time to continue searching other buildings.

“You’re back.”

After finishing the search work, I sneaked out of the group under the pretext of taking a walk and was greeted by the girl’s cold answer.

She still didn’t show any emotion in her reply.

I guess it was strange to have a friendly conversation with a stranger.

I would have just left like before, but now I had a secret weapon.

I sat down next to the girl who was reading a book.

“Ah. It’s a nice day for chocolate.”

And then I took out the chocolate I had kept in my pocket.

Crack.

As I tore off the paper wrapper, the chocolate wrapped in foil appeared.

Even without peeling off the foil, I could already smell the sweetness of the chocolate.

As I started to unwrap the chocolate, the girl next to me looked at it and asked me.

“What are you doing?”

“Redistributing wealth.”

I tore off half of the unwrapped chocolate and handed it to the girl.

Thud.

The cross-section of the chocolate was revealed beyond the torn foil.

She stared blankly at the chocolate I gave her, then took it with one hand.

Maybe she couldn't resist chocolate even if it was from a stranger.

She peeled off the foil slightly and nibbled on the chocolate.

“It's sweet and nice. I haven't had this kind of snack for a long time.”

I also peeled off the foil and bit into the chocolate, feeling the melting sweetness and talking to her.

When did I stop eating chocolate?

I think it was since I started preferring beer over soda.

When I was young, I loved these simple treats.

But after society collapsed, I don't even have to go to work, and I cheer for these simple snacks.

The ruined world was turning me into a child.

“This reminds me of the old days. By the way, how old are you?”

“.....”

Maybe it was because of the sugar in her stomach.

I asked her lightly.

But she still focused on her book, chewing on the chocolate.

She seemed reluctant to answer my question.

I took another bite of the chocolate and muttered in a half-annoyed voice.

“I don’t know if you’re shy or just don’t want to answer.”

“.....”

I often talked to myself, but I didn’t like talking to myself in front of someone else.

That wasn’t why I came here.

If I couldn’t get an easy answer, I had to try a hard way.

If I left her here and the building collapsed, I would have nightmares for a while.

I decided to get up and look around.

I saw board games scattered around the comic cafe.

“They have board games here too.”

There were various kinds of games on the shelves, from famous ones to ones with unfamiliar names.

I picked up the one that I thought was the most popular.

Dust rose from the chessboard as I lifted it up.

Cough, cough.

Dust from the chessboard made me cough repeatedly.

“Ah, the dust... cough, it’s too bad.”

The chessboard was covered with dust from being neglected for a long time.

I took out a handkerchief and wiped it all off, then shook the handkerchief in the air to clean up the dust again.

Chess was a game that I thought she would know the rules of.

Of course, if she didn’t know how to play chess, I could teach her myself.

Chess rules were simple among board games.

“Whew... this should do.”

I took the dust-free chessboard and went back to her.

Then I held out the chessboard to her and tapped it with my finger.

Tok. Tok.

A light thud echoed from the tip of my finger.

Maybe it was because I suddenly pushed a chessboard in front of her.

The girl looked at me with a puzzled face and tilted her head.

“Let’s play a game.”

“A game...?”

“You have to pay for the precious chocolate you ate in these times.”

Achoo.

I sneezed again, maybe there was still some dust left.

I sneezed in the direction where no one was and continued the conversation with the girl.

“Just playing a game is boring... How about the loser answers the winner’s question?”

There was nothing better than entertainment to form a relationship with a stranger.

Playing a game could make you enemies or friends, depending on how it went.

Especially in this world where most of the entertainment was gone.

As I pushed the chessboard hard and said that, the girl who pushed it away with one hand seemed to hesitate a bit.

“A bet?”

“One question per game. The winner of the game asks the loser a question. As long as it’s not a question you have to avoid, you have to answer it.”

“What do you gain from doing that?”

She was surprisingly responsive.

It seemed easier than I thought to drag her into the game.

I refused to answer her question and pointed at the chessboard with my finger instead.

“The rules have to be fair for everyone, so why don’t you try to win the game if you’re curious?”

“Hmm...”

“Well, if you’re not confident, don’t do it.”

“If that’s the condition... Maybe I can play along a little.”

The cheap provocation worked well, and the duel was quickly settled.

I brought a table from nearby and made a space between me and the girl.

And I put our pieces on the chessboard.

“Do you know how to play chess?”

“...”

She didn’t ask me about the rules of the game, so I guessed she knew them.

She just picked up a piece and started the game first.

She didn’t move her pieces out of the rules.

And the outcome of the chess game was decided faster than I thought.

“I won.”

“Ah...”

I lost.

She crushed me in the first game.

I didn’t think she would be that good, but she surprised me with her skills.

She wiped out my pieces without breaking a sweat.

“Can I ask you a question now?”

“What do you want to know? The thing you asked before?”

“No. Something else.”

She threw me a simple question after winning the game.

It was something anyone could answer.

“Your name.”

“Cheon Yuseong.”

“That’s a dull name.”

That was all she said about my name.

She was better at chess than I expected.

She outmatched me in every move.

But I couldn’t just accept defeat.

I had to win at least one game, for my pride as a man.

“One more game.”

“Do you have to?”

“Are you trying to run away now?”

“Fine...”

The second game was also tough.

She had the upper hand from start to finish.

Maybe it helped that I had some experience playing board games with my group members.

I barely managed to beat her and claim the first place.

“Whew... That was close.”

It was half luck that I won.

If she hadn’t made a mistake at the crucial moment, I would have never won.

The last move she made with a loss of concentration changed the course of the game.

Now that I had won one game, it was my turn to ask her a question.

Name and age.

Which one should I ask?

As I was weighing the priorities in my head, she watched me and asked.

“What do you want to ask?”

“Just a sec.”

For someone who didn't know their name or age, asking about their identity was very important.

But right now, there was something else I needed to ask her more urgently.

My top priority was to get her out of this place.

So I decided to ask her a different kind of question.

A question about why she was here.

“Why are you staying in this place? It's falling apart already.”

“I need this place for my plan.”

“Plan? What kind of plan do you need this place for?”

“World domination.”

“What...?”

“I'm creating a god. Everything else is just a necessary step for that.”

World domination.

Creating a god.

I stared blankly at her eyes as I heard that.

Her dark eyes were still looking at me with a clear gaze.

She was serious about what she said.

That's when I realized who she really was.

The girl I was facing was actually—.

“Ah...”

My head hurt for sure.

Chapter 174: How to Create a God (3)

Chapter 174: How to Create a God (3)

It had been almost two hours since I started playing games with the girl.

Unfortunately, time didn't narrow the gap between our skills.

I lost every game that followed, and I had to answer all her questions.

Her questions were mostly simple and meaningless.

How I felt right now, what I thought of my group members.

And what food I wanted to eat.

“Hey.”

“I'm listening.”

Of course, losing the games didn't mean I gained nothing.

We became quite friendly as we played several games.

We used to have trouble talking, but now we could have a decent conversation.

There was nothing like a game to break the ice.

After a round of competition, most of the barriers between us crumbled.

“Don’t you get bored being alone?”

“Well. I never thought about that.”

Now we could even have this kind of conversation.

I had many losses in between, but I could convince myself that I didn’t do my best.

And the girl’s safety was more important than the outcome of the games.

The reason I came here was to get her out of here somehow.

So I casually suggested something to the girl sitting across from me.

I didn’t think she would accept it right away, but it was the best question I could think of to figure out what she wanted.

“Why don’t you come with me to the company... I mean, the camp? If you do some dishes or laundry, they’ll feed you.”

I didn’t think the girl would be helpful for pioneering or exploring work.

Even if she joined the group, I would have to take care of her for a while.

At least I wouldn’t make her do anything too hard.

As I was waiting for her answer and cleaning up the pieces, the girl who was looking at me opened her mouth.

“I don’t think that’s a good idea.”

“Do you have a reason to avoid groups?”

“I’m fine with facing one person like this, but I don’t like places with too many people.”

“Why?”

“Because the more people there are, the more eyes there are.”

That made sense.

Yeah, the more people there are, the more eyes there are.

Was it a matter of shyness?

Or a matter of social anxiety?

I couldn't tell which one was the cause.

“Is that so? I can't force someone who doesn't want to join, so I'll give up on that idea.”

She clearly expressed her refusal.

I couldn't pressure her any more about joining the group.

When I gave up on persuading her, she tilted her head and asked me in surprise.

“You're giving up so easily.”

“I came here to make another offer if that didn't work.”

I had considered the possibility that she wouldn't join the group.

But even if she didn't join the group, I wanted her to get out of this place.

So I brought up the next thing to her.

Plan B.

It was a suggestion to get out of this dangerous place that could collapse at any moment.

“How about moving to a different place? It looked pretty risky from the outside.”

“Risky?”

“Yeah, risky. It wouldn’t be surprising if it collapsed anytime.”

It might not collapse today.

Or tomorrow, or the day after.

The building might still stand and hold its ground.

But the fact that it could collapse at any time was what mattered.

By the time I was sure that the building would fall, it would be too late.

“Really? Then where do you think I should go?”

Did she sense my feelings?

She put down the piece in her hand and asked me after hearing my words.

Thud.

The piece she inserted into the chessboard made a dull sound around us.

“Are you asking me to recommend a place?”

“If you know any. Preferably somewhere where I don’t have to meet people.”

She had an unexpected attitude when I suggested a place to stay.

She was cold to me until just a moment ago.

It was not an easy thing to do, to ask someone like that for a recommendation.

She was still a strange one.

Her words, actions, and thoughts were all different.

She seemed far from the normal trust relationship of people.

“If you have nowhere else to go...”

I thought hard about a place where she could stay.

A place to stay.

I would have recommended the company, but that was not an option for her.

Then where should I suggest?

As I was pondering in front of the girl, the image of my old studio apartment flashed in my mind.

‘I have a studio apartment.’

I didn’t go there often because I stayed at the company, but I cleaned it once in a while.

It was my secret base, so to speak.

There wasn’t much inside, though.

I had moved most of my food and necessities to the company, so the only things left were bulky items.

But it was still a place where I could find some peace of mind when I visited.

I decided to recommend my studio apartment to the girl in front of me.

“I have a place I used to live in, why don’t you go there?”

“You don’t live there anymore?”

“I’m staying with other people at the company. It’s better than being alone.”

I had some personal space at the company, and I could deal with any problems quickly.

And the food storage and distribution were all done by the company.

I ate at the company, so I had no reason to go home.

Unless I wanted a quiet place, I rarely went to my studio apartment.

Maybe she liked my plan more than I thought.

She nodded and accepted my suggestion.

“That might be less risky.”

“Nobody else will go there except me. I cleared the area around it, so there’s no chance of any undead getting into the studio apartment.”

“Then I’ll follow your opinion this time.”

Swoosh.

She pushed away the table with the chessboard and got up from her seat.

I got up too, following her.

Thud.

She threw the book she was holding on the floor and gestured to me.

“Lead the way. I’ll follow you.”

“Are you sure you’re okay with following a stranger?”

“I don’t care. It won’t be a big problem even if something happens.”

Was she cautious or weird?

I felt like I would never understand her personality no matter how much time passed.

“This is the place I told you about.”

Creak.

I opened the locked door and revealed the dark interior.

I looked at the studio apartment I hadn't visited for a long time and felt nostalgic.

It was the place I lived in when I got my first job and commuted to work.

I didn't come here often because I stayed at the company, but it was still a place I visited once in a while.

“I left it empty for a long time, but I cleaned it occasionally, so there shouldn't be much dust.”

“It's smaller than I thought.”

The girl who followed me into the studio apartment looked around the lifeless space and commented.

She wasn't wrong.

It was a space suitable for living alone, as it was a studio apartment.

It was much smaller than the house I lived in with my family.

“Well... It's not that big.”

The girl walked past me and started to examine the things around her.

The TV that was silent with the power off.

The light that didn't turn on because of the blackout.

The sink that didn't have water because of the water cut.

The things that stopped working after the apocalypse were piled up here like a mountain.

She looked around the quiet room for a while and then smiled and said to me.

"It's a peaceful place."

"It used to be noisy with kids playing outside, but lately it's been pretty quiet."

"..."

"It's not a bad place, even if it's small. Most of the people who lived here liked it."

It was a decent place for the price.

And it was also a place where I had many memories.

Inviting friends over and drinking together.

Dragging my exhausted body home and waking up with a headache the next day.

Cheering for sports games together in the small room.

Sometimes, lying on the bed and immersing myself in my smartphone.

I spent those times here.

"Do you like it too?"

As I recalled those short memories and looked at the empty space, she asked me that question.

Did I like this place in the past?

I think I did.

I was a happy person back then.

“It was a place I liked. Maybe I still like it now.”

“Is it precious to you?”

“I don’t know. Was it precious to me?”

Snort.

A hollow laugh escaped from my mouth as I looked around the room.

As I arrived here and remembered the past, I felt strangely unsettled.

“I hated going to work back then... But now I miss waking up here and going to work.”

They were moments that I thought I would never miss.

But now, even the moments that I thought were hard were left as happy memories.

Getting up from my seat, taking a shower, going to work, and coming home exhausted at night.

I realized how precious my daily life was, the one I thought would never change.

I only appreciated it after I lost it.

What a foolish thing to say.

“You’re deep in thought.”

The girl who was watching me said.

Her dark eyes were clear even in the darkness.

They were not human eyes.

I nodded at her, without denying it.

I felt like the walls in my heart were crumbling as I faced her.

“It helps me sometimes.”

“I see... It does seem helpful to some extent.”

“Yeah? Do I look like I’m getting help?”

“I won’t die in vain for a while.”

Was she talking about herself?

Or was she talking about me?

I didn’t know which one it was.

But I felt like I could understand her message a little bit.

I looked at the direction where the company was and opened my mouth.

“I wish we could all make it to the end.”

Beyond the endless hardship.

I hoped for a happy ending where we were all together.

I prayed for everyone’s happiness in my heart.

Chapter 175: How to Create a God

(4)

How to Create a God (4)

Even in a world where nothing was left, time still passed quickly.

Every day, I woke up, ate the breakfast that was distributed to me, and went outside with a shovel in my hand.

The obligations and rules that oppressed me were long gone, but the only thing that kept me going was the prosperity of the past that had already disappeared.

Everyone was busy looking for their own roles, hoping that the glorious days would return.

It was a paradoxical scene of leisure and bustle.

This was the camp scenery that I liked.

“Yuseong, you’ve been going for walks a lot lately, haven’t you?”

As I stood by the window, sipping my coffee and looking outside, Donghyun approached me and started a conversation.

He also had a paper cup with mixed coffee in his hand, reflected on the glass window.

I took another sip of my coffee and turned to him.

“Yeah?”

“Yeah. You didn’t go out this often before... Do you have any worries?”

I smiled faintly at his question.

It had been almost two weeks since I met the mysterious girl.

During that time, I had taken some time to visit her with the food that was given to me.

Most of what we did when I went to see her was playing games.

We played board games that I brought from the comic cafe and had trivial conversations.

Sometimes we shared simple snacks that I found somewhere.

As our meetings became more frequent, Donghyun seemed to sense something suspicious.

“I’ve been thinking a lot lately.”

I couldn’t tell Donghyun the truth, not yet.

It was clear that this was not the right time.

I tried to brush him off with a vague answer and a sheepish smile.

He looked at me with a complicated expression as I shook my coffee and laughed.

“If you have any worries, you can always talk to me.”

“You know I always come to you first when I have any worries.”

“Lately, you seem to be keeping things to yourself, like you used to.”

“It’s not that kind of worry, it’s just... I miss the days when I was happy even though I was busy at work. You know, those silly thoughts.”

At first, I went to see her to persuade her, but now I didn't mind playing games with her quietly.

I even enjoyed it.

Someday, I would have to tell everyone the truth and bring her to the camp, but for now, it was better to keep our secret and have our strange conversations.

I didn't care about her nonsense about the truth of the world and how to create a god.

It felt like I was going back to the past when we played games and chatted in my room.

"You're not hiding a pack of cigarettes somewhere and smoking them by yourself, are you?"

"I don't smoke that often, do I? Do you want to smell me?"

"Get away from me. What do I care about your smell?"

He backed away a few steps, hitting his hand as I tried to dispel his suspicion with a witty attitude.

One of the group members behind him chuckled and laughed.

Donghyun glared at him for a moment, then sighed and rummaged through his pocket.

"You're more likely to take more chocolate than cigarettes. Let me know if you find any cigarettes."

"Oh... chocolate?"

"Eat it secretly when you go for a walk."

I held the chocolate that came out of his pocket in my hand.

It was not as big as before, but a small piece of chocolate fit in my palm.

I nodded and put it in my pocket.

It was a good thing to give to the guy who was waiting for me to play games in my room.

As I tapped the chocolate in my pocket with satisfaction, one of the group members who was watching me teased me.

“Hey, boss. Why are you only giving presents to Yuseong? That’s unfair.”

“Come on. You’re not kids. Why are you acting like that? I’ll give you a cigarette if you follow me.”

“Oh, you’re the best, boss.”

Donghyun winked and left with the group member.

I sighed with relief as I watched him leave the building.

I knew it was all for the sake of the group, but I couldn’t help feeling a pressure in my chest.

It was the weight of the secret.

It felt heavy just to keep words in my heart.

“I need to find a cigarette.”

Through the blurry window, I saw his broad back.

He was always devoted to the group members.

I owed him a lot too.

I didn’t know when I would be able to repay him.

It had been three weeks since I met the girl with the strange personality.

By now, even my walks were accepted as part of my routine by the group members.

As usual, I went to my room under the pretext of a walk and found something that made me gasp.

The girl was sitting on the bed, leaning against it, with a familiar object in her hand.

It was a familiar but special object that shouldn't work normally in this world.

“What is that...?”

Blink. Blink.

I opened and closed my eyes several times, not believing what I saw.

No matter how many times I closed and opened my eyes, the scene before me remained unchanged.

A girl was holding a smartphone in front of me.

A smartphone with its screen on.

“An important item.”

“What? The smartphone still has battery left?”

I widened my eyes as I looked at the smartphone in her hand.

Even though the power had been cut off for a long time, the girl's smartphone was still working perfectly.

A smartphone with its screen on. It was something I hadn't seen in a long time.

The relics of the old era had all fallen asleep without any battery left.

I couldn't even remember the last time I used a smartphone.

"Do you find it amazing?"

"What else would be amazing if not this?"

There was a time when using a smartphone was normal.

But now, a smartphone with battery was not a common thing at all.

Everyone wanted it, but it was hard to find one.

I took off my shoes and walked towards the girl who was holding the smartphone.

I sat next to her and stared intently at the smartphone in her hand.

"Where did you get it? Did you pick it up from outside?"

"I made it."

"What?"

"I made it myself because I needed it."

The girl answered calmly to my question about the origin of the smartphone.

She always gave me strange answers.

And today's answer was more annoying than any of her previous ones.

I grabbed the back of my neck and looked at her.

"You made this? You did?"

"Yes. Do you like it?"

“Oh, sure...”

It was nonsense.

How could she make a smartphone by hand?

Maybe she could assemble one, but she couldn't produce a normal one without a factory.

But she gave me such a brazen answer that I had no choice but to accept it.

I nodded quietly and looked at the smartphone in her hand.

I saw pixelated characters moving busily on the screen.

“You were playing a game, huh? Well, I guess you can't watch videos or anything since there's no internet.”

“Do you like games?”

The girl who was holding a smartphone in her hand asked me as she shook it slightly.

Do I like games?

Not many people would say they hate games when asked such a question.

Unless they say they don't enjoy them much.

And I was the same in that regard.

“Games... I don't hate them. But I wasn't so passionate that I would put everything else aside to play them.”

I was also one of those who liked games, if I had to be honest.

Even after work, I would sometimes play some mobile games.

Well, that was a long time ago, though.

Now, it had been so long since the battery died that I couldn't remember the last time I played.

As I followed the game screen in her hand with fascination, she opened her mouth with a faint smile.

“Do you want to try playing this?”

She offered me the smartphone she was holding.

As she held out the smartphone to me, I reflexively took it.

My eyes moved along with the smartphone and examined the game she was playing.

I saw dots densely filling the smartphone she handed me.

The characters expressed in dots were moving busily and interacting with each other.

“A pixel game, huh? This kind of nostalgia is nice.”

I liked both pixels and 3D graphics.

It might depend on personal taste, but I felt like I could enjoy any game right now.

As I fiddled with the smartphone she gave me and looked at it, she made a light comment on the pixel graphics.

“It's because it hasn't grown properly yet.”

“What hasn't grown? Is your character level too low?”

“That thing you're holding.”

She said, pointing at the smartphone in my hand, not the game.

I looked at her again, sitting next to me.

What did she mean by the smartphone growing? It wasn't a Tamagotchi or anything.

Even the famous Tamagotchi couldn't evolve the device itself.

I was puzzled by her absurd remark and tried to mess up her hair.

“Hey, how can a smartphone grow, logically... huh...?”

But my hand that was reaching for her stopped in mid-air and stayed still.

Something I couldn't identify was holding me back.

It felt like my hand was trapped in space and couldn't move forward.

I opened my mouth wide as I looked at my hand hanging in the air.

-“Forget it.”

“...”

And I quickly forgot.

Why did I raise my hand?

I couldn't remember it well.

I lowered my hand awkwardly and focused on the screen of the smartphone in my hand.

The small characters were still moving on the smartphone screen.

“They're cute. But I can't understand a word they're saying.”

They were having some incomprehensible interactions with speech bubbles above their heads.

I watched the characters in the game more closely.

It looked like the characters had some roles assigned to them as I watched them quietly.

They seemed to have their own society.

“Is it fun?”

“This game is not bad.”

The characters moved diligently and did their tasks, as if the AI was finely crafted.

Sometimes, they would deviate from the rules that governed them and show some peculiar behaviors.

It felt like I was raising ants in a transparent gel.

I also remembered the tiny sea monkeys I used to keep in a fish tank when I was young.

It was soothing to just watch them without any thoughts.

“You might feel healed if you just stare at them.”

I knew this feeling wouldn't last long, but it wasn't too bad for now.

As I gazed at the screen with the smartphone in my hand, the girl pointed at a character on the screen and said,

“Something will change if you tap it.”

“Really?”

She said I could interact with the characters.

I followed her advice and moved my finger towards a character on the screen.

Tap.

A number -1 appeared above the character's head as I touched it.

It seemed like the character took damage.

The gauge at the top of the screen also decreased significantly.

“Hmm... I guess I can hit the characters by touching them.”

“Don't you find it fun? Why don't you keep doing it?”

She asked me if I enjoyed hitting the characters, but I shook my head after some thought.

I didn't feel like doing it right now.

I didn't know how their society worked, or even what the purpose of the game was.

I didn't like to cause trouble without any reason.

“Well, I'm having fun just watching them for now.”

I gave her a vague answer and continued to look at the smartphone blankly.

The game I played after a long time was enjoyable without any complicated controls.

Chapter 176: How to Create a God (5)

How to Create a God (5)

The sun was high in the sky.

Donghyun was staring blankly out the window from inside the building when he spotted a familiar face and sipped his coffee.

Beyond the glass window he was facing, he saw Yuseong holding a shovel.

Cheon Yuseong.

He was the first companion Donghyun had made after the disaster that started in Africa reached Korea.

He had been trapped in the company surrounded by monsters until Donghyun rescued him.

That's when their relationship began.

Since then, they had been relying on each other for a long time.

‘But something is off about him lately.’

Donghyun felt a strong sense of discomfort from Yuseong recently.

When did he start feeling this way?

He remembered that it was about a month ago when Yuseong began to show some strange behaviors.

He started to leave his seat more often, using walks as an excuse.

Maybe he had found some valuable resources and hidden them somewhere.

He briefly entertained that suspicion, but he dismissed it as he thought about Yuseong's personality.

As far as he knew, Yuseong was not stingy or selfish when it came to sharing.

He also tended to avoid causing harm to others as much as possible.

It didn't make sense that Yuseong would hoard food or necessities and keep them secret.

‘What is he hiding?’

His eyes narrowed as he watched Yuseong leave the company.

Yuseong always attracted trouble wherever he went.

He had always solved the problems in the group with his intuition, but Donghyun doubted that he could handle everything on his own.

As he recalled the past that had gone by, a vague anxiety crept into Donghyun's chest.

The thick and sticky anxiety quickly eroded Donghyun's heart.

“...”

He was uneasy.

He felt uneasy about his friend who was going outside.

It wasn't that he didn't trust Yuseong, who had been with him for so long.

Donghyun was sure that Yuseong had a good reason for whatever decision he made.

But there was an inexplicable uneasiness flowing from Yuseong's appearance as he went outside.

“...”

This won't do.

As his doubt and anxiety grew in his chest, Donghyun grabbed a steel pipe.

He couldn't just sit and watch like this.

He had to see for himself.

I had to find out what was causing this uneasy feeling in my chest.

As Donghyun went down the stairs with a steel pipe, one of the group members who was wandering in the hallway saw him and asked.

“Where are you going, bro?”

“I have something to check.”

Donghyun gave a brief answer to the group member and started to follow Yuseong, who was on his way.

He had a bad feeling about this.

It was the same intuition that had helped him survive until now.

He had to chase after Yuseong.

He had to find out why he was lying about taking a walk and going outside.

“I'm looking forward to today.”

Donghyun kept a distance from Yuseong and followed him from a barely visible range.

Yuseong walked calmly with a shovel, unaware of anyone behind him.

He crossed the crosswalk with a shovel on his shoulder and passed a narrow alley.

Then he went through a few more buildings and headed somewhere unknown.

He seemed very familiar with this place, as if he had been here many times before.

‘Where is he going?’

The place Yuseong was passing by was definitely an area that the group had explored early on.

But it wasn’t a road that the group members often used.

Since the exploration work was done long ago, there were hardly any resources left in the buildings.

In other words, they were buildings with nothing to gain.

Donghyun continued to follow Yuseong, who was heading somewhere.

“I never thought I could play games in these times.”

‘Games...?’

Yuseong muttered something incomprehensible as he moved his feet busily.

It was clearly about games, judging from what came out of his mouth.

But after the world was destroyed, the only games that could be played were card games or board games at best.

It was impossible to play games using PCs or smartphones anymore.

Despite that, Yuseong was calmly mumbling about a game.

‘A game... What the hell...?’

Considering Yuseong's habit of talking to himself, his words must have some basis.

To find out the truth behind his incomprehensible story, I had to follow his trail to the end.

That's why I chased after Yuseong more carefully than before.

“...”

As I kept following Yuseong, I finally found something.

He stopped in the middle of a street where buildings of moderate height were densely packed.

He looked around as I quickly hid myself. He seemed to be cautious.

“I thought I heard something. Is anyone there?”

But that was only for a moment.

He decided that no one was there and opened the door of a building and went inside.

Creak.

The glass door that he had opened closed back as soon as he went in.

I heard the sound of friction as the glass door shut. I sighed in relief then.

“Whew...”

I barely breathed a sigh of relief as I confirmed that Yuseong had gone inside the building.

There was no way he could hear me sighing now that he was inside.

I calmed down my pounding heart and approached the building with quiet steps.

It was a close call.

I almost got caught by Yuseong.

‘Sometimes he’s brilliant... But he’s clueless when it comes to this.’

Was he dull or trusting?

Maybe it was both.

I gave a brief evaluation of Yuseong and looked closely at the building he had entered with a steel pipe in my hand.

I touched the stone that decorated the exterior of the building and dust came off, reflecting the passage of time.

‘He must have gone upstairs.’

My eyes followed the dust and landed on the hallway where Yuseong had disappeared.

Through the windows of the same size, I could see the residential facilities where people used to live.

I didn’t know how long it had been since the owners had left, after the day of destruction.

It was obvious that the place was meant for people to live in, no matter how I looked at it.

‘Is that his old home?’

I had heard him talk about it before.

It was the studio apartment he had rented when he got his first job at the company.

He had moved away from there naturally as he and the other survivors gathered at the company.

He said he only visited there occasionally to clean up.

But it seemed like he had been sneaking there more often, using walks as an excuse.

“I don’t like this feeling...”

I muttered something without realizing it as I looked at the building.

I startled myself and looked around.

But I meant what I said.

I felt uneasy as I watched the building where Yuseong had gone in.

My sharp intuition was ringing a loud alarm.

‘Maybe I should go in when he comes out.’

It was a sense I couldn’t explain.

But I knew that my intuition had never betrayed me before.

It was always my intuition that saved me in dangerous situations.

When the dead came in through an unknown passage.

When a fire spread unexpectedly.

I always trusted my intuition and solved the problems.

‘Why am I so anxious?’

My intuition, which had always saved me, was sending me a stronger anxiety than ever.

Sweat dripped from my hand that held the steel pipe as I felt the anxiety.

I moved my right hand that was slippery with sweat.

I adjusted my grip on the steel pipe and leaned against the wall.

My heart was pounding hard in my chest, sending loud thumps to my ears.

“Huff...”

I listened to the thumping of my heart and took a deep breath to calm it down.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

The sound of my heart was more clear than ever.

As I tried to quiet it down, a thin female voice echoed in my ears.

“Curiosity killed the cat.”

My body froze at the unfamiliar voice.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

My heart beat faster than before.

My hand that held the steel pipe trembled with the raging blood flow.

I pressed my shaking hand with the other hand and turned my head toward the direction of the voice.

Creak.

I slowly turned my head and saw a girl with jet-black hair fluttering in the wind.

“Ah...”

“You made a foolish choice, it seems.”

It was over.

I knew it as soon as I faced the girl.

I didn't know why.

But just by looking into her eyes, I felt that my life was over.

My intuition told me that this was the end.

The camp, the group, everything was over.

My dream of becoming a boss was gone like a bubble.

“Pl-please...”

I begged for my life instinctively, without knowing why.

But the girl's expression was still cold as ice.

She didn't seem to care about whether I lived or died.

She waved her hand as if to shoo away an annoyance and spoke to me.

“I don't care who survives anymore. Can you go back to where you came from?”

“...”

That was the last conversation I had with her.

Thud. Thud.

I walked back the way I came with a blank look in my eyes.

My role was over.

Donghyun's eyes were dark as he headed back to the company.

“You finally woke up.”

I regained my faint consciousness and got up from my seat.

The first thing that caught my eye was the dark studio apartment.

The TV and the lights were off, and the silence was oppressive.

The room still reflected the world after the destruction.

Yawn.

I let out a short yawn and looked at the girl with sleepy eyes.

She was sitting in the same spot as before, and next to her was a smartphone that was turned on.

“Did you fall asleep while playing a game?”

“You looked happy in your sleep.”

It seemed like I had borrowed the smartphone from the girl and dozed off while playing a game.

I was staring blankly at the screen, so it wasn't strange that I fell asleep suddenly.

It wasn't a bad feeling to sleep while playing a game.

The problem was that I had fallen asleep without any plan.

“This is bad. I told the others I was going for a walk.”

I lifted my head and looked out the window. It was already evening.

I had been gone for too long for a walk.

Maybe I was too relieved to be in my old room, but I had slept quite heavily.

It wasn't something I could excuse with my usual lies.

And knowing Donghyun's personality, he might be searching for me outside by now.

I had to go back soon to avoid worrying them more.

“Hey.”

I stretched my stiff body from sleeping and looked at the girl who was still sitting in the same place.

She didn't show any interest in the smartphone that was rolling on the floor.

I called her to say goodbye.

I had to go back to the company before everyone got worried.

“Are you listening?”

“I have to go now.”

Blink. Blink.

The girl closed her eyes as she heard me.

She thought for a moment, then smiled faintly and said to me.

“You're leaving?”

“Yeah, I should go. At least I have some excuse.”

I said that and looked at the liquor box in the corner.

The liquor I had found by chance was still intact, except for a few bottles.

It was a lucky find from this area a while ago.

Some people in the group didn't like alcohol, but there were more who wanted to get drunk.

They would be happy if I brought this back. It was obvious.

“I have some liquor I found last time to bring to the group. I think they’ll like it.”

“There are still many people who like that kind of thing.”

“It’s not that few. I don’t really like it, though.”

I walked over to the crate in the corner and put the shovel I had brought on top of it.

Then I grabbed the crate firmly with both hands and lifted it up.

The weight in my hands told me how full the contents were.

I thought the company might smell of alcohol for a while.

“Anyway, I have to go now. See you next time.”

“...”

I said a simple goodbye to the girl and opened the door and left.

The weight of the shovel that hung from the crate to my shoulder and the weight of the liquor in my hands felt together.

The bottles were heavy, but so was the liquid inside them.

It was not a weight that I could easily run with.

But my mind was light as I carried the crate.

“I hope they like it.”

How many times had I come and gone here in a month?

My steps were familiar and skillful as they found their way forward.

I had made dozens of excuses to go out for a walk and escape from the group.

My steps were agile enough to get used to the phrase “knowing the streets”.

“Donghyun hyung... He’ll get really drunk today.”

I thought of Donghyun, the leader of the group, as I passed through the narrow alley.

He was a big man who drank like a fish, as if it suited his size.

He hadn’t had a proper drinking party lately because of the lack of alcohol, but he still drank so much that it made anyone who saw him dizzy.

He would love the crate I brought today more than anyone else.

“Maybe he’ll be less angry if I bring some liquor.”

I hoped he wouldn’t nag too much today.

I moved my steps while thinking of the apology I would give to my colleagues who were worried about me being late and the reaction of the group members who would see the crate.

“Huff...”

Traffic lights. Crosswalks. Corners of alleys.

And then a large crosswalk again.

I followed the flow that I had repeated as usual.

When I passed by the buildings and streets that I always passed by, I soon found the building where the company was located.

“There’s already one person out.”

A building standing tall in the middle of the shopping district.

It was hard to call it big, no matter how you looked at it.

There was a silhouette of a group member standing there, waiting for me.

He looked impatiently waiting for me, who had been late without any news.

I guessed his identity from his silhouette in the distance and shouted at him with a loud voice.

“Seongcheol hyung!”

I shouted with joy at him.

My voice echoed loudly in the silent street at night.

Did my voice reach him?

The silhouette that was far away started to come closer to me quickly.

He seemed to be running to meet me sooner.

“You’re quick! Hyung, do you know what I brought today?”

— ...

I tried to talk to him in a cheeky tone as he approached me.

But there was no answer from him.

As I waited for his answer, the silhouette in the dark grew bigger and bigger.

As the size of the silhouette grew gradually, we were soon close enough to touch each other.

That’s when I realized his condition.

“What is this...”

What I faced at the entrance of the company was a group member who was staggering with his eyes open wide.

He used to prank me all the time, but now he had a grotesque expression on his face as he came toward me.

It didn't take long for me to realize what had happened.

He was dead.

The old colleague in front of me had become a nameless corpse.

Thud.

I dropped the crate I was holding and asked him with a half-locked voice.

“Hyung... right...?”

Meteor showers were falling behind the dark building.

Chapter 177: How to Create a God (6)

Chapter 177: How to Create a God (6)

When I returned to the company, all of my colleagues had turned into corpses.

Friends and coworkers, they had all become monsters, and I was the only one left as a human.

I didn't know the cause.

Maybe some corpse had infiltrated and spread the infection inside the group.

Or maybe we could turn into monsters without even touching them beyond the barricade.

Either way, none of the group members I had lived with were spared.

“...”

It was only half a day.

Everything had collapsed in that short time.

The group that we had run under the name of Company had lost all of its members and completely collapsed.

I was the only one left in the group.

Donghyun, who had led the group, and the others who had followed him, were only moving their dead flesh without any reason.

“...”

There was only one thing that the survivors in this ruined world had to do.

To give eternal rest to the immortal monsters.

It didn't matter if they were my former colleagues.

Rather, because I knew their faces, I had a promise to keep.

I had to give them peace with my own hands.

‘Yuseong. If I ever become one of those monsters, then you have to kill me yourself.’

That was the promise.

We had promised to bury each other with our own hands if we became monsters.

We had to keep the promise we had made to each other.

I swore to them.

No matter what happened, I would keep my promise.

So I tried to keep it.

“...”

I took down one by one those who had lost their sanity and ran wild.

I killed with my own hands the colleague I had talked to this morning.

I killed with my own hands the colleague who had promised to be my friend because we were the same age.

I killed with my own hands the great leader who had always been respected by everyone and took on the hard tasks.

I stopped their breathing and silenced them.

I decorated their last moments with my own hands.

Their cold bodies stopped moving.

The noisy voices that filled the building would never reach my ears again.

“Donghyun hyung...”

In front of Donghyun, whom I had destroyed with my own hands, I leaned on the shovel and looked at him.

The great leader who had stood in front of everyone was gone from here.

Only a cold sword remained of the man.

I stared at Donghyun without a word, then slumped to the floor, leaning on the shovel.

My hands were soaked with blood and shaking violently.

“Am I... alone here now...?”

There was no answer to my question.

The diligent leader was dead.

What I saw in front of me was nothing but a trace he had left behind.

But my eyes still followed his trace.

“I asked you...”

My voice faded away.

The thick smell of blood stung my nose.

The blood that oozed out was nauseating.

Once, when I first met Donghyun.

I was desperate to survive then.

“Answer me...”

And now,

I was desperate to die.

* * * * *

“Ugh...”

The liquor bottles rolled on the grassy field.

There, I stabbed the shovel into the ground and vomited repeatedly.

The alcohol I had gulped down without thinking was coming back up and shaking me.

Huff.

I held onto the shovel in the ground and tried to remember how much I had drunk.

‘Five bottles? Or six...?’

I couldn’t remember clearly.

But I knew I had gone way beyond my limit.

There was only one reason why I had drunk so much after cleaning up the company.

To bury my colleagues who had met a miserable death.

To keep the promise I had made with them, I had to drink all the liquor I had brought.

“Ugh...”

I couldn't do it sober.

That's why I filled my empty stomach with liquor.

I felt like I would go crazy if I didn't borrow some drunkenness.

It was such an act to bury my mutilated colleagues in the ground.

Every time I faced them, the past memories came back to life.

As I looked at the scenery beyond the shovel, I felt a dizzy sensation for a moment.

“Ugh...”

My stomach that I had barely calmed down surged up.

Everything in the world was unpleasant, and the whole view started to shake.

In that discomfort, I tried to calm myself down and kept moving the shovel in my hand.

I had to dig the ground to bury them.

I had too much to do to stop my hand already.

“Hah, ha...”

Huff.

I shrugged off my stiff body and moved the shovel little by little.

Despite the cold wind that brushed my cheek, the drunkenness that weighed me down didn't go away.

My stomach turned every time I saw a dead colleague, and my consciousness faded every time I moved the shovel.

In the chaotic world, only my hand was quietly doing its job.

Everything was mixed up and I was out of my mind.

“Ugh... ugh...”

I closed my eyes, opened them, and entrusted everything to my fading consciousness.

The hole grew bigger every time I opened and closed my eyes.

When I felt a bit of satisfaction in the growing hole,

I felt my body holding the shovel tilt.

“Ah...”

As I blinked several times at the dizzying sight,

Thud.

I blacked out.

* * * * *

As if a switch had been turned back on, my blurry consciousness came back to life.

When I opened my eyes again, I was in my studio apartment.

A girl was sitting on the bed in front of me, and in my hand was a bottle of liquor.

I glanced at the empty bottle for a moment, then opened my mouth to the girl on the bed.

“I killed them all.”

The girl looked at me with clear eyes, then tilted her head and curled her lips.

I felt like she was smiling.

Maybe it was because I was too drunk.

I closed my eyes and opened them again, and the girl asked me with a serious expression.

“Who did you kill?”

Who?

It was obvious.

I had killed my colleagues today.

I had finished off those who were dead even though they were alive, and came here with blood-stained hands.

“My colleagues.”

“What did you do next?”

“I buried them all with my own hands.”

“Okay. You did well.”

She spoke to me without any emotion.

It wasn't a consolation.

She didn't seem to have any intention of comforting me.

She was calm, unlike me.

“With my own hands...”

I extended my trembling hand into the air.

I didn’t know how much blood I had smeared on it.

Even after I had scrubbed it hard, I still felt the smell of blood.

No matter how much I held my breath or covered my mouth, the smell of blood never went away.

“I... with my own hands...”

The image of Donghyun bleeding and falling flashed in my mind.

I owed him a lot.

I had accumulated a huge debt that I could never repay.

He had given me hope to live in this harsh world.

I felt like I could overcome any ordeal as long as I was with him.

But I had to bury him with my own hands.

“I had to... kill them all.”

My meaningless confession echoed in the air.

It wouldn’t bring back those who were already dead.

I was still alive, and they were already gone.

There was a huge gap between us that would never be closed.

I lifted my drooping head and looked at my hand again.

The empty bottle in my hand came into view.

“What did I do wrong—!”

I impulsively threw the bottle at the TV that was turned off.

Crash!

A large hole appeared on the TV with a heavy impact.

It was a useless thing that didn't work properly because there was no electricity.

My reflection was distorted on the broken TV screen.

“What did I do wrong, what did I do to deserve this...!”

I longed for a normal life.

That was all.

I wanted to repeat the same routine every day, and move forward one step from yesterday.

That small wish seemed to be a big greed.

“Why does this world, make me so lonely...?”

I wished we could all be happy together.

I hoped that someday a rescue team would come for us.

I hoped that somewhere in this world, there was a city that survived and would save us.

But those hopes were all futile.

In the end, I was the only one left.

“Who is it... who made those monsters... who keeps tormenting me...?”

And now, I was not happy.

No one had a happy ending.

As I stared at myself covered in dirt with blank eyes, Estelle opened her mouth while watching me.

“You’re not alone.”

The terrible smell of alcohol shook my head.

The scent of alcohol spread every time I breathed, clouding my reason.

Still, I listened to her.

I waited for the next words she would tell me.

“Then what am I... if I’m not alone...?”

“Don’t worry. I’ll be with you forever.”

The girl raised her pinky finger on the broken screen.

It was a vow.

We intertwined our pinkies, a ritual to convey our trust to each other.

She stretched out her thin finger and said to me.

“I’m the one who made you like this, and I’ll take responsibility and stay with you forever.”

“...”

“It’s a promise.”

Click. Click—

My consciousness was cut off with the noise.

* * * * *

“...”

My consciousness surged back with the smell of alcohol.

When I regained my consciousness from the broken memory, I was still in my dark studio apartment.

The broken TV. The liquor bottles rolling on the floor.

And the small studio apartment where only me and the girl were left.

There, I lay on the bed with a small smartphone in my hand.

On the screen that came into view, there was a game that had leveled up somehow.

“Do you like it?”

I looked up at the voice in my ear, and saw the girl looking down at me.

Her finger was stroking my hair.

I looked at her, then turned my eyes back to the smartphone in my hand.

A game of unknown identity and name.

My finger was tapping on the character in the game.

“I guess I was playing a game.”

“Yeah. You said you wanted to forget by playing a game, right?”

Did I say that?

I felt like I did.

I also felt like I didn't.

I couldn't remember clearly because of the blackout.

"Did I say that?"

"You sure did."

"I guess so."

I stared blankly at the character on the smartphone.

Tap.

Every time I touched it, the character popped up a meaningless speech bubble.

It took a lot of taps, but I could kill the characters if I kept hitting them.

"This is fun."

"Isn't it?"

"I think I can do this all day."

With a few gestures of my hand, the characters on the other side of the screen disappeared.

Just like the humans who had fallen irrationally in this world, the characters also met a whimsical fate by my touch.

As I tapped on the characters on the screen, I felt like I had become an omnipotent being.

I remembered the other game I had played hard to level up as I saw the numbers go up.

"It's okay to do this all day."

"I guess so. I don't have to go to work now, and no one will say anything even if I play all day."

“Have I become the freest person in the world now?”

The freest person in the world.

Maybe that was true.

There was no fierce competition in society, and no past self who worked like a part of the company.

No one forced me to do anything.

At this moment, I was in the most free situation than anyone else.

“But I liked it better when I wasn’t free.”

But now, I was not happy.

I had nothing to ignite my passion, and no huge wall to challenge myself.

Back then, I always looked at the future.

I lived longing for the future that never came.

But there was no future left in this world.

Along with my decaying mind, I was slowly rotting from within.

“I want to go back to the past.”

As I killed the characters on the smartphone one by one, I spoke to the girl who was listening to my story.

It was a futile wish.

It was an impossible hope.

But still, I felt like venting to someone now.

The girl who heard my story stroked my hair and asked me.

“What kind of life do you wish for?”

“I just want to get up from here, go to work, and come back to play games without thinking.”

“That’s a greedy wish.”

For a survivor living in a ruined world, there was no more luxurious wish than that.

I know that.

But I still wish for it.

Maybe because it’s impossible, I long for it more than anything.

Maybe because it’s impossible, I don’t even know why I want it so much.

“If possible, I want to go back to when there was nothing.”

“I see.”

“When the work is over, I want to buy some beer, drink it, and spend a satisfying day playing games by myself.”

But if this were possible.

If I could erase all the unpleasant memories of the past and make them a nightmare in an instant.

I wouldn’t care what or who I had to sacrifice.

A month. A week. Even a short time would be fine.

No, even just one day would be fine.

If only someone showed me a happy dream—.

“I’ll grant it for you.”

A clear voice brought me back from the smartphone.

The girl who was stroking my head said she would grant my wish.

It was an impossible wish.

It was not a wish that could be fulfilled by a mere human's hand.

I couldn't help but ask the girl who said she would grant such a wish.

“You'll grant it? My wish?”

“Yes. I'll grant your wish.”

Snort.

A hollow laugh escaped my mouth.

It was a ridiculous story.

What did she think of herself?

I gave her an answer full of emptiness.

“Wow, really...”

“Do you believe me?”

“Before that, why don't you tell me who you are?”

Even though we had spent a long time together, I still didn't know her name.

The only thing I knew was one thing.

That she was here now.

That was all I knew about her.

I complained and asked her identity, and she looked at me with serious eyes unlike usual.

– “I am the god of harmony–.”

– “No, from now on, you can call me Estelle, the god of retrogression.”

I doubted my ears at the name I heard for the first time.

But Estelle didn’t give me time to sink into thought.

Estelle’s clear voice engraved in my brain.

It was not a sound or a letter, but something else.

“Estelle...?”

Estelle.

The goddess of retrogression, Estelle.

I repeated the name that was delivered to me through the will that pierced my head.

There was an incomprehensible holiness in the name that flowed out of my mouth.

– “From today, you are the eternal rival of the new evil god that the continent will face.”

The room that was dark lit up with colors.

The light that had been asleep for a long time started to shine brightly.

The broken TV played the faint news that remained in my old memory.

Outside the window, I heard the cries of birds and the laughter of children running around.

The world that I had lost once was spread out in the small room.

And in the middle of that miracle, Estelle smiled.

“I hope you have a happy dream. My little god.”

Estelle’s last farewell echoed in my ears in the miracle.

Chapter 178: Cherubim: Estasia (1)

Chapter 178: Cerubim: Estasia (1)

All my memories came back vividly.

The cruel reality that I had been ignoring was still there.

I couldn't make it disappear by turning away and avoiding it.

I was nothing but her toy, standing here.

“Estelle...”

I had lost too many things.

I couldn't deny my weakness that failed to protect anything.

But the one who pushed me to the limit was undoubtedly Estelle in front of me.

She wanted something.

I couldn't guess what it was.

So I had to hear it now.

“What is your purpose?”

“Are you curious?”

“Tell me.”

I glared at her, who was still smiling, and she spun her parasol leisurely.

Round.

Our eyes met across the spinning parasol.

I was sure of it.

She wouldn't avoid my question now.

Just like she had told me everything when I didn't know anything.

“Fine. I'll tell you everything. I'm creating a new god.”

“How to create a god...”

“More precisely, a god who will be my counterpart on the zenith of karma.”

“Is that why you destroyed this world?”

“Partly, yes. I had to destroy this world to give birth to a god. I needed a massive amount of karma. But you see—.”

Her mysterious eyes shone with a lofty atmosphere.

Her eyes always seemed to be far above me, and they still looked down on me from afar.

“Don't you think it's fun to destroy a sandcastle that someone built with difficulty with your own hands?”

“What...?”

“What kind of expression would the mortals have when they see their sandcastle crumble in front of them?”

It was a dangerous look.

It was the eye of someone who wouldn't hesitate to kill or ruin people over and over again.

But what was more dangerous was that the target was not limited to humans.

“And what kind of expression would the gods have when they face that situation themselves?”

“You, don't tell me—.”

Estelle's goal was to make me a god.

She wanted to create someone who would be her counterpart in a godless Earth.

But that was not all.

She also wanted to put the world beyond the smartphone in her palm.

“The zenith of karma is the most effective way for gods to exert their influence in lower dimensions outside their realm. But there is a mechanism called causality rate that limits the excessive intervention of gods.”

“Causality rate adjustment...”

“So the six goddesses created a new god who would play the role of a counterpart. Estelle, the god of retrogression. A fake divinity that they could easily control.”

I remembered the girl who had told me her name for the first time in Estelle's story.

The god of retrogression, Estelle.

It was the name that the girl in front of me had introduced to me first.

And it was also the name that she had been claiming herself as the goddess of harmony.

“But now I’m Estelle. You can understand what that means, right?”

“Don’t tell me, you betrayed the goddesses.”

“Yes, I did. It was all my doing, to induce an imbalance of causality rate among the six goddesses, and to take away the evil god’s divinity that he used to abuse every time he killed.”

I finally understood.

I could explain all the strange phenomena that I had experienced so far.

The game on the smartphone was very unfriendly, but the game flow was strangely kind to me.

It was because there was someone who had always been watching me from beyond.

“That’s why you helped me by using the game framework...”

“Yes. I did. I was planning to use you to bring down the other gods.”

There were many hints from the beginning.

That Estasia and Aronia knew each other.

And that Aronia had received a trust from the goddess of harmony for that reason.

It was the same for what the heroes said about the different situation from before.

In the confrontation between the evil god and the goddesses that had been repeated until now, neither side was sincere.

“That’s why the goddess of order was very angry. She showed actions that she wouldn’t normally do.”

“So from start to finish, everything was playing in your palm.”

“I guess so. It was a fun puppet show.”

As Estelle spoke without losing her smile, I unknowingly gritted my teeth.

Crunch.

I felt Estelle’s emotion in my distorted sense.

I could never understand her way of thinking.

“What do you think of people...?”

“Do you really need to be so angry?”

“You killed all my precious people, and made me a murderer without knowing anything... And now you tell me not to even get angry?”

My rage reached its limit, but it only made me laugh.

I laughed because the situation was absurd.

It was a series of ridiculous stories.

And beyond all those stories, there was a being that I would never understand in my life.

“I decided to be with you. Not the other goddesses who are hiding like cowards.”

“You...”

“Don’t be sad. I’ll always be with you.”

One step. And another step.

The distance between Estelle and me, who had been apart, got closer.

As the distance between the two got closer, the gap between the emotions that were tied to each other grew bigger.

The capricious god approached me without any hesitation.

And she smiled brighter than ever as she spoke to me.

“Shall we do something bad together?”

As she said that, Estelle handed me the smartphone she was holding.

It was the smartphone that Estelle had given me as a gift when I had lost everything.

A new message popped up on the smartphone that Estelle handed me.

It was a message that showed the updated quest conditions for the <Descent> skill.

It was also the last offer that she gave me, who had controlled everything until now.

– Every time you meet one of the following conditions, the progress of <Descent> will increase by one level.

– Available karma: 1628 / 999999 (Incomplete)

– [Sacred Relic: Ergus’s Stake]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

– [Philosopher’s Stone]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

– [Heart of Origin]: 0 / 1 (Incomplete)

– Make a body for Descent (Complete)

The minimum number of kills is 500,000.

It’s a number that can never be filled unless it’s a war.

Estelle still wanted me to kill countless lives with this small device.

She wanted me to decide for myself, not by the sweet dream she showed me.

It was an absurd proposal.

I couldn't accept such a proposal even if I knew everything.

"Do you think... I'll accept this?"

"Don't you like it?"

"You've killed millions, tens of millions... no, billions with your hand so far."

The number of people who died by Estelle's hand was beyond count.

And she wanted me to kill hundreds of thousands more with my own hand.

It was an insane proposal.

"How can you ask me to kill more people now!"

I shouted, letting out the air that filled my lungs.

It was like a scream that echoed in the room.

It was a clear refusal.

But Estelle didn't hesitate and reached out to me.

She handed me the smartphone she was holding and gently caressed my cheek with her gloved hand.

I felt the soft touch of the fabric on my cheek.

"You know you can't refuse, right?"

"You..."

“I prepared a gift for you, since you achieved your goal. It would be a shame if you didn’t accept it.”

A gift.

My mind stopped when I heard that.

The words on the smartphone in my hand lingered in my head.

I had a feeling I knew what her gift was.

“A gift...?”

“You don’t want to be alone forever, do you? So I’ll help you to be with those kids.”

That was why I kept seeing those inexplicable quests.

And that was why I kept trying to complete those impossible quests.

All my actions were leading to one truth.

“<Descent>... You don’t mean...”

“Yes. It’s my gift to you. To create a paradise for you and the ones you love.”

Estelle had one thing to tell me.

She would give me the chance I had always wanted.

She would give me the opportunity to escape from this ruined world.

Not to the Earth that had become a wasteland, but to the world beyond the crystal where the apostles were waiting.

“Me, there...”

“I know you won’t refuse. You know better than anyone what will happen to the apostles who were abandoned by the god.”

What followed was a threat.

A cruel threat that everything I had left might disappear.

My hand that was holding the smartphone with the screen on started to tremble.

Should I kill people or abandon them?

I had a cruel choice in my hand.

“So I hope you keep up the good work. Until we drive away the evil five goddesses with our evil god’s hand.”

Estelle, who had forced me to make a cruel choice, turned around.

Only her black parasol entered my sight.

Click. Click.

She walked away with a relaxed step, but soon turned her head as if she had forgotten something.

The girl with the jet-black hair that fluttered in the wind spoke to me one last time.

“Oh. And since you might have some trouble while you’re alone, I’ll attach a kid who won’t cause any problems to the plan even if he leaves the order as your escort.”

Right after Estelle’s last words.

My sight went dark.

* * * * *

When I opened my eyes again, I was lying on a bed with someone's lap as a pillow.

In the studio room with the light on, there was a TV in good condition.

The realm of god.

It was the scenery of the world that I had longed for many times.

A false space created by my longing for the past.

“Are you awake?”

As I regained my senses and tried to figure out the situation, I heard a stranger's voice in my ear.

I slowly turned my eyes to the owner of the voice, and there was a girl with silver hair that flowed down.

Above the girl's head, there was a halo shining brightly.

White wings and a glowing halo.

The identity of the girl who looked like an angel was obvious to anyone.

“Estasia...”

“Yes.”

Estasia.

The lazy angel that I had created using <Creature Maker>.

She was in my studio room.

It wasn't strange that a game character popped out after I had faced a dream character just before.

I asked Estasia with a hollow voice.

“So you’re here now?”

“I came here because you called me, master.”

That reminded me of what Estelle had told me last.

She had said that she would attach someone who wouldn’t cause any problems to the quest even if he left the order as my escort.

It seemed that Estasia was the one she had chosen.

Estasia would be fine even if she left the order, since she could still perform the war.

Aronia would hold the branch of the order anyway.

“Who is your master among the two of us?”

But there was something I had to make sure of.

She had come here by Estelle’s will.

It was Estelle who had paid the karma to bring Estasia, and who had brought her directly to my studio room.

So I had to ask Estasia.

Whose side was she on in this place?

“I don’t know. What do you mean?”

“Estasia. Who is your master, me or Estelle?”

Who was the one who gave orders to her, Estelle or me, who was holding the smartphone?

When I asked her that, Estasia tilted her head at my question.

She looked at me with a puzzled expression, as if she couldn't understand my question.

“Who is Estelle?”

“The goddess of harmony.”

“But my master whom I made a contract with is not a goddess.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes.”

I felt relieved when I heard Estasia's answer.

Even though the smartphone I received was a miracle from Estelle, it seemed that all the contracts made inside it were connected to me.

Considering Estasia's personality, she was unlikely to lie calmly.

I could trust her words as the truth.

“I hope you stay on my side no matter what.”

“I won't do anything even if you say that.”

“Well, that's you.”

I chuckled at Estasia's answer.

My mood, which had sunk to the bottom, improved a little.

The angel in front of me was someone who brightened up the surroundings wherever she was.

Estelle must have brought her here for that reason.

“I can't give up as I please now.”

I reached out and picked up the smartphone that was on the bedside table.

There was a time when I was with Estelle in the evening.

I smiled as I looked at the characters beyond the smartphone.

I was happy just by staring at the screen back then.

But not anymore.

Every time I looked at the screen, I felt uncomfortable emotions mixed together, as if I was walking through a swampy swamp.

“Is that so?”

“It must be.”

The game that Estelle created always forced me to choose.

It was the same this time.

Should I lose everything and remain noble?

Should I gain everything and survive vilely?

I had an inevitable choice in front of me.

“Should I stay good or evil? It’s time for me to decide.”

If I stained my dirty hand with more blood of hundreds of thousands, I could have a happy future in the place where the apostles were.

If I followed my will and stopped the slaughter, I would lose the apostles and be left alone in the ruined world.

It was a cowardly proposal.

It was a choice that forced me to choose evil with my own hand.

As I looked at the smartphone and recalled the choice given to me, Estasia asked me a question.

“So, which side do you want to stand on, master?”

“Me? I am...”

I had to choose a side.

I had to decide what I wanted to be.

It was a very difficult question.

But it was also a question that had an answer from the start.

“I am...”

I had been playing the game for a long time.

During that time, I had created many apostles and harvested many lives.

The story that we had built together was not something that I could discard now, even if I wanted to.

I could not abandon my apostles.

Estelle was right.

From the day I first stained my hands with blood, the answer was already set.

“I am, perhaps...”

I had been pretending not to know, but now I had to admit it.

From the day I was drunk and numb.

From the day I lost my comrades and cried out in misery.

And from the day I handed over my smartphone to Estelle completely.

From that day on, I became—

“A god of evil.”

I had become a god of evil beyond the smartphone.

Chapter 179: Cherubim: Estasia (2)

Chapter 179: Cherubim: Estasia (2)

When I opened my eyes in the morning, the first thing I saw was Estasia's face, sleeping soundly.

She was holding a stuffed animal in her arms, drooling on it.

I didn't know how the toy came along with us, but it suited her better than I expected.

I left Estasia alone and got out of the bed.

“...”

As I got out of the bed, avoiding Estasia, I saw some feathers on the floor.

The white feathers that were rolling on the floor belonged to Estasia, without a doubt.

I remembered hearing that if you have a dog, you'll find dog hair all over the house.

It seemed that if you have an angel, you'll find feathers flying around the house.

I quietly looked at Estasia's feathers and then picked one up.

“Feathers, huh...”

I examined the feather in my hand closely.

But there was nothing special about it, even though it was an angel's feather.

It looked no different from the ordinary feathers I had seen before.

I picked up a cigarette and a smartphone that were lying in the corner, along with Estasia's feather.

The cigarette was something I had kept to give to the leader of the group who was now dead.

I took everything and carefully opened the door and went outside.

A cold wind brushed past my cheek as I stepped into the hallway.

"It's still quiet."

The scenery I faced in the hallway was the opposite of what I saw in the room.

Unlike the temple that was wrapped in dreams and illusions, everything that met my eyes was faded and rusty.

This world was already ruined beyond repair.

I looked at the ruined cityscape as I put a cigarette in my mouth.

It was something I didn't smoke often.

But for some reason, I felt like smoking right now.

Click.

I lit it with a lighter and then saw the leader who liked cigarettes flash through my mind.

"I couldn't give him anything after all."

The alcohol and cigarettes that I had kept to repay him for the chocolate were still in my hands.

I looked at the cityscape with a hollow feeling.

It didn't take long for a lively city to fall apart.

It was over as soon as an unidentified virus swept through the city.

“Hoo...”

The gray smoke drifted away with the wind.

Even though the fog that hid the truth had disappeared, my mind didn't feel any easier.

Rather, there were things that I couldn't avoid anymore because I knew the truth.

My own mistakes too.

And even my future that was given to me.

They were things that I couldn't turn away from or pretend not to see anymore.

“Whether or not I get along with Estelle, I'll have to keep you with me for a while. That won't change.”

That's why I spoke to the smartphone in my hand.

But there was no answer from the screen that was turned off.

I urged him as if to hurry him up, and called his name again.

The name of the familiar existence who had delivered my voice instead of me for a long time.

“Right? [Miracle: Smartphone].”

New translator.

No, [Miracle: Smartphone].

The name of the guy who was always erased from the warning message about causality correction.

I said his name out loud for once.

Then, light flowed from the screen and his voice reached my ears.

-“You already had a hunch about me.”

“Estelle wouldn’t do something like that herself, so there must have been someone who acted on her behalf and conveyed my intentions.”

-“...”

“It’s a reasonable deduction, isn’t it?”

There was someone who pretended to be God instead of me.

That was what I thought when I heard from Estelle that a smartphone was a miracle.

In this world where there seemed to be no living humans, there was only one thing that could act on my behalf.

-“I see.”

The smartphone accepted my deduction without any hesitation.

He probably had no reason to deny it.

He kept silent for a while, then blinked his screen and spoke to me again.

-“So, why did you call me?”

The reason why I called him.

That was because there was something I wanted to ask him right now.

I tilted the smartphone slightly and looked at the screen full of noise.

And then I spoke to him who would be staring at me from this small device.

“There’s something I want to hear from you.”

-“What are you curious about?”

“Do you think I look like a god too?”

Estelle said that everything that had happened so far was a work to make me a god.

And that this small space behind this old door was a temple made for me.

If what Estelle said was true, then I would be something different from an ordinary human.

For example, I might have some hidden divine power that I didn’t know about.

The question I asked the smartphone was to check that.

-“Yes.”

The smartphone answered my question without a hint of hesitation.

At least to him, I was no different from a god.

The important thing was what he said next.

I asked him about his identity.

“So, what kind of god do you think I am? A god of justice? Or a god of slaughter?”

Just like the six goddesses had their own names, if I was a god, I would have a fitting name too.

Then, what was the name given to me?

I asked the smartphone that, but this time he gave me a negative answer.

-“I don’t know what kind of being you are.”

“You don’t know either?”

-“I’m just a mere creation. I can’t answer anything beyond what I know.”

Unfortunately, he didn’t know anything about my identity either.

I had no choice but to look at the smartphone with a sour taste in my mouth.

It was too frustrating to end the question like this.

“...Is that so.”

-“But I can tell you about your fate that I’ve been watching so far.”

But the next thing he said made me listen to the smartphone again.

He seemed to have one more thing to tell me.

Fate.

I didn’t know if it would be helpful for me now.

But it didn’t seem like a bad idea to hear it once.

“Okay, tell me. What is my fate?”

-“You... were born with the fate of destruction.”

“Destruction...?”

And what he said about my fate was not very pleasant.

The fate of destruction.

It was a repulsive story just by hearing it.

I gestured to the smartphone to continue, and he went on.

-“Those who catch your eye will bring death upon themselves, and those who receive your grace will run towards ruin.”

-“That fate eventually drove both himself and the world into destruction.”

As I listened to his story, the characters I had faced beyond the screen of the smartphone flashed through my mind.

Sometimes for me.

Sometimes they brought death upon themselves.

Countless lives had met their futile end.

It was a fitting outcome for those who were watched by the evil god.

“Destruction...”

-“You are destruction.”

In a way, it wasn't completely wrong.

Everything around me had been falling apart from the beginning to the end.

The people I cherished had all left me, and even myself who remained here was heading towards ruin.

It wouldn't be strange if it was all a joke of fate.

But that didn't mean I could accept it completely.

“So, you're saying I'm going to become a god of destruction?”

-“I don’t know that either.”

“I see. You’re just a useless piece of metal after all.”

-“...”

I chuckled bitterly and stubbed out the cigarette butt on the railing.

The cigarette butt that had lost its heat crumbled.

I threw it towards the empty street, and looked at the smartphone again.

The screen still showed some incomprehensible stuff with noise.

“I didn’t call you just to hear that kind of story... Well, whatever.”

There was nothing that could really help me in the end.

I licked my tongue and put the smartphone on the railing.

And then I grabbed it with both hands and swiped the screen with my finger.

But nothing changed on the screen, no matter how much I swiped it with my finger.

So I had no choice but to give him an order.

“Stop showing me weird stuff and show me the gacha screen.”

War was inevitable.

No matter what decision I made, I had to prepare for war anyway.

The simplest way to do that was gacha.

The gacha of <Paid Currency Shop> was the only way to increase my specs without causality correction.

“I’m going to make the cult stronger with this.”

Of course, the cost for 10 pulls was not small at all.

In the past, I would have trembled and hesitated to pay that amount.

It was an amount that I couldn’t afford with an ordinary salaryman’s monthly income.

But now it was different.

I could use all the money I had saved in my bank account for gacha.

Estelle knew that too, so she asked me to wage war.

“I have about 30 million won left in my account... Maybe I can pull 3,000 times.”

I never thought I would spend this much money on a game.

It was ironic that I could only use money as I pleased after the world was destroyed.

I smiled bitterly and lifted my finger towards the shiny gacha button in front of me.

And then I touched it with my fingertip.

-You can get various items that will help you play the game by using 10 pulls.

Squeak.

As soon as I gave the command, items started to appear on the screen.

It was the same gacha that I always faced.

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

.

.

.

-You have acquired [Hard Black Bread].

And the familiar results appeared before my eyes.

Chapter 180: Cherubim: Estasia

(3)

Chapter 180: Cherubim: Estasia (3)

- You have acquired [Magic Sword: Kerios].
- You have acquired [Holy Relic: Ezier's Pendulum].
- You have acquired [Spellbook: Meteor Strike].
- You have acquired [Spellbook: Tempest].
- You have acquired [Spellbook: Lightning Storm].

I didn't know how much time had passed since I started the 10 gacha.

In front of the numerous trials, probability was not a big threat.

As the accumulated gacha count exceeded 1,000, decent items started to come out continuously.

Of course, it was not very fun to just keep pressing the gacha button.

If I still thought it was a simple game, maybe. But now I knew what these items were for.

It was hard to enjoy gacha with a pure heart even though I knew everything.

"I've pressed a lot, but I still haven't used up all the money."

My finger started to hurt from tapping the screen repeatedly.

Pressing the gacha button was not a big problem, but the problem was pressing the screen continuously to skip the animation.

I felt like I would get stressed if I kept looking at the screen, so I decided to stop gacha for now.

Besides, Estasia had woken up from her sleep and came out of the room.

“Master...?”

Estasia rubbed her eyes and came out of the room.

She saw me holding a smartphone and spoke.

Estasia, who had been living on strawberries from the cult, had no chance of knowing about the modern gadget called smartphone.

She had no clue what I was doing from her perspective.

I put the smartphone in my pocket and walked towards Estasia who came out of the entrance.

“It’s cold, let’s go inside. And take off your shoes when you come in.”

“Is that so?”

“That’s the rule here.”

“Yes.”

Estasia flapped her wings slightly and turned back to the room.

She didn’t forget to take off her slippers as she entered the entrance.

I followed her and entered the room where the light was on.

The scenery that greeted me was completely different from what I saw in the hallway.

“It feels a bit different.”

When I went out to the hallway and came back to the sanctuary, I felt strangely energetic.

Some unknown power was infusing my body with strong vitality.

It might have something to do with the power of god that Estel told me about.

I stretched out my hand and shook it in the air. I felt something indescribable brushing past my fingers.

I didn't think I could unleash an amazing ability right now, but I needed to keep studying it over time.

“Master.”

Estasia, who had been watching me from a distance while I was lost in thought about the sanctuary, lifted her head.

She looked at me with an expression that seemed to have something to say.

Considering that she was waiting for me in the hallway earlier, she probably had something urgent to tell me.

I couldn't ignore it if it was something important.

I walked towards Estasia and asked her what she wanted.

“What is it? Do you have something important to say?”

“I'm hungry.”

Gurgle.

A sound came from Estasia's stomach as she finished speaking.

I looked at her blankly for a moment and then remembered that it had been quite a long time since we had our last meal.

I was also quite hungry as I looked at Estasia.

Eating was definitely a major issue for us.

“It’s about time we get hungry.”

I naturally headed towards the ramen boxes in the corner.

There were stacks of ramen boxes that looked new in the corner of the room.

Unlike the broken boxes that I saw before the sanctuary was activated, the ramen boxes in front of me looked like freshly produced products.

Squeak.

I opened a box and took out a ramen package.

The expiration date on the package still had some time left.

“The expiration date is still valid... Is this also the power of the sanctuary?”

It was impossible for any product with a valid expiration date to exist in this world logically.

Something must have overwritten the letters on the outside with some kind of power.

I took out a ramen package with a valid expiration date and looked at Estasia.

“Estasia. The expiration date is still valid, so let’s boil this for now...”

“...”

“Oh.”

As I tried to hand her the package and tell her to boil the ramen, I realized something and stopped my hand.

There was no way Estasia knew how to boil ramen.

It was impossible to order her to cook for me.

I looked at Estasia who was standing still and made a awkward face. Then I went out to the hallway with the ramen package in my hand.

“I guess you can’t help... me.”

Maybe I could teach her how to use the faucet and the gas stove, and then ask her to cook for me.

I thought about it for a moment, but then shook my head and dismissed it from my mind.

It didn’t seem possible no matter how much I thought about it.

It would be better for me to do it myself.

I gave up on the idea of having her do the housework and looked at the ramen package that I brought outside of the sanctuary.

“Hmm...”

As soon as I brought the ramen package outside of the sanctuary, its condition changed in an instant.

The package in my hand was covered with dust and the expiration date on it had changed.

The ramen package that was fine turned into something that suited the ruined world.

I examined the package in my hand and then brought it back to the sanctuary.

“Maybe it will change back when I go inside?”

The TV and the lights that had lost their function also worked normally inside the sanctuary.

Even if they were broken outside, they might change back to their original function when they entered the sanctuary.

That’s why I thought of bringing back the items that I had taken out of the sanctuary.

As I stepped inside the sanctuary, another change occurred on the ramen package.

“What is this...”

The ramen package turned back into a smooth one, just like before it was taken out of the sanctuary.

The expiration date at the bottom also didn’t differ much from before.

This meant one thing.

If you bring rotten processed food into the sanctuary, it will turn into an edible state.

Various foods that were found in the city could perform their roles here.

It was a very helpful information for us who needed food.

“...Estasia.”

After finding out that things from outside would revert back to their original state when brought into the sanctuary, I immediately called Estasia’s name.

Estasia, who was wandering around barefoot in her room, lifted her head and looked at me when she heard my call.

“Yes.”

“Let’s go outside for a bit.”

I thought I could find some food for the two of us if I searched the city.

Maybe I would even stumble upon something that could serve as a dessert.

Of course, there might be some unpleasant things along the way, but that was the price of exploration.

Besides, it was not a difficult task to move some stuff around. It did not require any special skills.

Even Estasia, who had no knowledge of the modern world, could be of some help.

With that in mind, I ordered Estasia to follow me. She looked at me with a blank expression and said,

“I don’t want to...”

She gave me a sharp answer.

It was a clear refusal.

Well, figures.

She was not the type to work diligently.

I stared at her for a moment, then spoke in a cold voice.

“Then starve.”

“I’m hungry.”

“Starve.”

“Angels die if they don’t eat.”

“People die if they starve too.”

“...”

“I’ll go outside.”

She finally gave in when I was firm.

I then started to look for a decent coat to wear.

The weather outside was chilly.

It would be better to dress warmly to avoid catching a cold.

“Achoo!”

“...”

Maybe I should also find a coat for her.

Probably.

In a splendid mansion on the island,

the Count Colt frowned as he looked at the invitation he received.

The invitation in his hand had the name of the second prince, Aicliffe, and a polite message inviting him to a party.

It was Aicliffe’s way of confirming the Count’s acceptance that he had sent a few weeks ago.

But there was a big difference between the Count then and the Count now.

After his son was attacked by bandits on his way to his bride’s house, the Count’s body had undergone a drastic change.

“Are you alright?”

“Cough...”

His skin turned red as soon as it touched the sunlight.

And the reddened skin caused him severe itching.

He would have gone out for his schedule if it were normal, but now it was impossible for him to walk around outside.

It was too much of a burden for him to move under the sun.

“Wouldn’t it be better to decline the invitation for your health’s sake?”

Scorlaus asked as he watched the Count groan in pain.

It was an invitation from Aicliffe, who was almost an enemy of the Count.

If it were an ordinary situation, no one would gossip if the Count rejected his proposal.

But the Count shook his head and denied Scorlaus’s suggestion.

He thought that this was the time when he had to show up at the party.

“I will attend the party.”

“But...!”

“I have been staying at home for over a week. If I miss this party too, people will surely doubt my health.”

He couldn’t afford to skip the party he had promised to attend after being confined to his mansion for so long.

He was a great lord of the north.

He could not show any weakness to his enemies who were sharpening their fangs to tear him apart.

“Besides, the timing is not bad.”

The Count Colt said as he looked at the date written on the invitation.

The party would start when the sun was setting.

They wouldn't make a fuss over him being a little late.

And if he entered the party hall after the sun had set, there would be no major problem with his body.

It was a good place to show his well-being to the island.

“Alright. I will follow your wishes and order the servants accordingly.”

The butler bowed his head and said in response to the Count's decision to attend the party.

Nod.

The Count nodded to the butler and sat down on a chair, sighing.

“Phew...”

The butler. And the escort knight.

These two were the only ones who knew the Count's condition in the mansion.

He only showed his frailty in front of these two.

The Count groaned in pain as his body stiffened, and asked Scorlaus, who was standing behind him.

“Scorlaus, how is the thing I ordered you earlier?”

“I have sent out the shadow knights to look for renowned doctors, but it seems that we need more time.”

“I see...”

He had tried to find doctors who could diagnose his illness through Scorlaus, but that was not easy either.

Scorlaus offered him some words of consolation as he saw the Count's disappointed expression.

“Don't worry. I will find out the cause no matter what.”

“You better. You have to.”

“Yes, my lord.”

“Otherwise, this damned body will hold me back...”

He couldn't afford to stay idle for too long.

He had to find a cure for his symptoms and return as soon as possible.

The wild wolves were never merciful.

They wouldn't wait for their wounded prey to recover.

The nobles on the island were no different.

The moment the Count's weakness was exposed, they would rush to tear his flesh apart.

Chapter 181: Cherubim: Estasia

(4)

Chapter 181: Cherubim: Estasia (4)

A convenience store that had become a ruin with no sign of human presence.

In a creepy place where it seemed like a corpse could pop out at any moment, I was looking around the inside with Estasia.

Maybe it was because a lot of time had passed since the disaster.

Most of the food that was easy to preserve or had a long shelf life was gone.

The company's scavenging activities must have contributed to the disappearance of the convenience store's goods.

Of course, it wasn't a big problem for us, since we were looking for rotten and spoiled food.

“Triangle kimbap. Chicken breast. Pig's feet.”

Rather, my stomach was more of an issue.

I tried not to look at the shape of the collapsed food as much as possible, and put one food item after another into the plastic bag I brought.

It was harder than I thought to collect rotten food.

The smell was bad enough, but the appearance was also quite unpleasant.

The only good thing was that Estasia, who used purification magic, was more helpful than I expected.

“Fi-five... Ugh...”

“...”

Thud.

The food that Estasia put in went into the plastic bag.

She had a subtle expression on her face, but she kept moving the food.

It must have been hard for her too, as an angel in front of me.

I asked Estasia, who was struggling.

“Estasia. Are you okay?”

“Yes I’m not okay I want to go home I can’t take it anymore.”

As expected, Estasia answered me right away.

I nodded to her with a calm face.

I believed she would answer like that.

But I had no intention of sending her home.

“You’re so hardworking that you want to do everything by yourself, even my share. You really have an angelic heart.”

“Huh?”

“Can’t leave such a kind angel alone to suffer. I’ll help you at least as far as I can reach.”

Estasia’s face turned pale as she heard my words.

She seemed to be shocked by what I said earlier.

Estasia quickly shook her head and said to me in a desperate voice.

“I didn’t say that.”

“Yeah. I know. Your devotion to serving God is really admirable.”

“You’re a liar.”

“Indeed, the faith that can serve God deeply is not given to anyone.”

I denied everything she said and spouted nonsense that had nothing to do with reality.

As I kept teasing her, Estasia soon started to blink her halo.

The flickering halo that lit up the convenience store reminded me of a faulty light bulb.

Estasia, who was fluttering her wings, stuffed the food she was holding in her other hand into a bag.

Then she added a word with a dissatisfied expression.

“You are an evil god.”

“Yeah, I am...”

My hand that was reaching for the shampoo stopped in mid-air.

An evil god.

It was not something I could deny at this point.

I had lost count of how many people had died by my will.

But the one who spoke rudely to her master deserved a punishment.

“I am an evil god, of course.”

I swung the shampoo bottle that I held upside down lightly on Estasia’s head.

Estasia created a shield of light to block the incoming shampoo bottle.

But the shampoo bottle I swung ignored it completely and flew towards its target.

Thud.

It hit Estasia’s crown lightly, and she fell to her knees, holding her head.

“Ouch.”

“It’s the wrath of the evil god.”

I put the shampoo bottle that hit its mark accurately into a plastic bag.

I was running out of shampoo at home.

I thought it would be fine to take one home with me.

As I looked around with the plastic bag containing the shampoo, I saw something reflected in the glass window.

It was something that others had not taken for a long time because of its overly complicated storage method.

“Ice cream...”

I could see the piles of ice cream behind the glass of the ice cream freezer.

It was a snack that cooled me down in the summer.

The ice cream bars were in a shape that was hard to pick up.

So my eyes naturally moved to the pint ice cream next to them.

It was a lot of food and easy to eat.

“Maybe I should take some ice cream too.”

Of course, I didn’t expect the contents to be intact just because it was a pint.

But it seemed to work somewhat when I took it to the divine realm, so I planned to take it back with the other groceries.

I thought the angel who was kneeling in front of me, holding her head, would like some ice cream too.

I opened the freezer and put three pints of ice cream into a bag.

Then I spoke to Estasia, who was still kneeling.

“Estasia. Let’s get out of here.”

“...Are we going home now?”

Estasia looked up at me with teary eyes and asked.

That was her question, whether we were going home right away.

She seemed to want to go home very badly.

But it wasn’t time to go back yet.

Unfortunately, there was one more place we had to visit before we could go back.

Because I had left all my food and regrets in that place.

“Not yet.”

“...?”

“There’s a place we have to go before we go home.”

I turned my head and looked in a certain direction.

It was the place that felt most familiar to me in this ruined world.

The company.

The old headquarters of our group that had disappeared, leaving only traces behind.

I had to go there and say goodbye to my past self.

“It’s time to quit my job.”

It was time to part ways with my past self.

The southern part of the empire.

In a forest in the Centurion region.

There, Pluto looked at the front with a displeased face.

In front of Pluto’s eyes, there was a cage made of light.

The cage made of divine power was a nauseating sight just by looking at it.

It was very annoying for Pluto, who was a vampire.

“What a troublesome kid.”

Beyond the cage, he could see two people who were trapped.

One of them was Eileen, the saintess of order who Pluto had subjugated himself.

She was crawling on the floor with a pale face.

And from the other one, he smelled something that was not human.

He guessed it was probably a dragonkin who had gained spiritual power.

“Could it be a dragon?”

Pluto, who was looking at the back of the fallen dragon, shook his head and stepped back slightly.

He only wanted to save Eileen anyway.

It didn't matter much who or what the other one was.

Besides, the discomfort that the holy relic emitted was not small when he observed it too closely.

He felt like he would vomit if he endured it any longer.

“...Is it because it's a holy relic? It looks really poisonous.”

Pluto spat out his complaint, covering his mouth with one hand.

The mediocre divine power did not have much influence on Pluto.

But the cage made by the power of the holy relic was not something he could take lightly.

The holy relics scattered around the continent were objects that possessed transcendent power.

Even Pluto could not ignore and overcome the cage made by a holy relic.

Pluto, who had stepped back a few steps, waved his hand in the air.

“Death Scythe.”

Swoosh.

The divine weapon, Death Scythe, popped out of thin air and landed in Pluto's hand.

Pluto's eyes looked at the blue aura that swirled around Death Scythe.

Maybe it was because he was affected by the cage, but Death Scythe's aura was also shaking slightly.

“...”.

Normally, he would have cut down anyone with this Death Scythe, but unfortunately, the cage in front of him was not included in that list.

However, the divine weapon served as a link between him and his god.

It acted as the most suitable medium for borrowing the power of god.

As Pluto aimed his Death Scythe at the cage.

Eileen, who had woken up from a deep sleep, lifted her body from her seat with half-closed eyes.

“Uh, um...”

Blink. Blink.

Eileen slowly blinked her eyes and looked at Pluto.

Was it because she still had some drowsiness left?

She rubbed her eyes while staggering, and then widened her eyes as she looked at Pluto.

Eileen, who was soaked in surprise, asked Pluto with a doubtful voice.

“Ma... Master...?”

“Eileen.”

“Master! Did you come to save me!”

She understood why Pluto had come and approached the cage with joy.

She had felt very sorry when Pluto said he would hand her over to the hero for a deal.

So it was natural that she was happy that Pluto had come to get her himself.

“Yes, I came to save you.”

“I knew it, Master wouldn’t abandon me.”

“...Yeah.”

Pluto watched Eileen, who was excited for a moment, and then moved his eyes to the dragonkin who was lying on the floor.

Swoosh.

He pointed at it with his Death Scythe, which had an aura flowing around it, and asked.

“Eileen. Is this person the hero?”

“Yes! He’s Naias, the hero of harmony. According to the rumors I heard, he’s a dragon who gained spiritual power.”

“I see. So that’s what it was.”

As Pluto had guessed, the identity of the doll that was lying down was a dragon.

But it was surprising that a dragon had been given the title of a hero.

Since he had handed over Eileen to the hero for a trade, Eileen’s words that the dragon in front of him was a hero seemed to be true.

The hero of harmony, Naias.

Pluto repeated the name of the hero who was lying in front of him and lifted his scythe.

“He seems to have been abandoned by the holy land from what I heard from the hero of hunting.”

“What happened?”

“It seems that there was a friction between the holy land and the temple of harmony.”

“Trouble between temples... That’s an interesting story.”

Snicker.

Pluto smiled briefly and put more strength into his hand that aimed his Death Scythe.

Whirr——.

The aura that wrapped around Death Scythe rose more intensely.

With a blue aura covering him, Pluto flashed his eyes and said to Eileen.

“I’ll get you out now. Wait.”

It was interesting that there was a conflict between the temples belonging to the holy land, and that the hero had been abandoned by the holy land.

But he had to peel off this cage first if he wanted to hear more details.

He reassured Eileen and grabbed the thread of Death Scythe that connected him and his god.

“Master... I believed in you.”

“Yeah.”

Holy relic, Belzer’s Dream Labyrinth.

It was a holy relic that was difficult to deal with for non-human races, but it was not a hard task for Pluto, who had the power of an apostle.

All holy relics would lose their power under the influence of a great being.

Hoo. Pluto exhaled a short breath and declared to the world.

“Holy Sanctuary.”

It started with darkness.

The area around Pluto began to be engulfed in darkness.

Then it was the turn of thick shadows.

Countless shadows spread on the ground and eroded the earth.

Pluto’s scythe slashed down on the cage in the dark area where the light disappeared.

“——Logration.”

Light and darkness.

And more shadows than both.

The shadow of the god that Pluto called in the scattered darkness descended on the world.

A larger darkness revealed itself in the oxidizing light.

When the domain of shadows that Pluto continued was completely settled in reality.

“...!”

Crack. Bang—!

The cage that wrapped around the two people collapsed completely.

Chapter 182: Cherubim: Estasia

(5)

Chapter 182: Cherubim: Estasia (5)

The last place I ended up visiting was the company building where blood was splattered.

The building that had faded with time still had clear traces of that day.

They were all traces that I had made with my own hands.

I felt like bad memories would come to mind if I kept facing the traces I had made.

“...”

“Master?”

Maybe it was because my feelings were clearly shown on my face.

Estasia, who was watching me, lifted her head with a worried expression and asked me.

I shouldn't be like this.

I didn't come here to be bound by the shackles of the past.

I had to face all my mistakes and memories that I wanted to forget properly.

If not, I wouldn't be able to move forward.

“I’m fine.”

“Master is a liar.”

“Maybe you’re right.”

I pretended to be okay and took a step forward.

Thud.

Every time I took a step, I felt a twisting sensation in my chest.

I couldn’t breathe.

The things I had done came back vividly in my head.

“But I have to go.”

Then, happy memories flashed through my mind.

When we were all together, it was fun just to see each other’s faces.

It was happiness just to have a meal together.

Back then, I believed that such happiness would last forever.

Those were the things that I could now call memories.

“Memories...?”

Estasia asked me with a curious tone as I packed the food into the bag.

I nodded and smiled faintly.

“Yeah. Memories of the past.”

I remembered the days when we were all together, working hard to survive in this ruined world.

We were a group of people who had nothing in common except our will to live.

We shared our joys and sorrows, our hopes and fears, our dreams and regrets.

We were like a family.

But now, they were all gone.

They had died one by one, by my hand or by others'.

And I was the only one left alive.

The last survivor of the group that had once been called the Cherubim.

“Do you want to hear about them?”

I asked Estasia, who was looking at me with interest.

She nodded eagerly and said.

“Yes, please. I want to know more about you, Master.”

I chuckled and handed her the bag full of food.

“Then let’s go somewhere else. This place is too depressing.”

I said as I walked out of the storage room.

There was one more place I wanted to visit before I left this building for good.

The place where it all began and ended.

The place where I had met them for the first time, and where I had killed them for the last time.

The place where I had to say goodbye to my past self.

The conference room.

I'm sure there were hard times and painful memories, but now only good feelings remained in my heart.

In the end, the only thing that stays in time is the most memorable impression.

The afterglow of happiness still breathed somewhere in my chest.

“When I lived here, we used to gather food together.”

There were things I didn't want to lose.

There were people I didn't want to forget.

There was a moment when I didn't want to let go of the happiness in my hand.

There was a memory of not giving up even in a desperate situation.

“What happened to everyone?”

“They died. They all turned into monsters, and I had to kill them with my own hands.”

But Estelle forced me to remember something that denied all of that.

She forced me to remember the tragedy of having to kill all of them who became monsters with my own hands.

In the tragedy, I lost many things.

After everything was over, the only thing left in this place was my pathetic self.

“...”

Thud.

In the silence, only my hand moved busily.

Things piled up one by one in my backpack.

Estasia, who was listening to my story, stared at the box in her hand with a blank look.

She hesitated for a moment, then put it in a plastic bag and said,

“Are there no other gods here now?”

“I’ve been alone in this city for a long time.”

“...Were you alone, master?”

Estasia looked at me with pity in her eyes.

I never thought I would tell this story to a lazy angel who always loafed around.

It was unexpected for me too.

But I kept telling her my story.

Maybe I secretly hoped that someone would listen to my story.

“She, the goddess of harmony, destroyed them all.”

“The goddess of harmony...”

Sad memories. Heartbreaking memories.

Maybe I wanted to feel better by confiding in someone.

Maybe I, who always thought of myself as an adult, was living like a child more than anyone else.

“The people I loved, the people I would love, they all died by her hand. And now she tells me to leave this place and gives me a chance.”

Estasia kept listening to my story.

Without complaining or closing her ears, she silently and calmly listened to me.

She looked more mature than anyone else at that moment.

“She said she would get me out of this hell, and asked me to hear her terms.”

“A deal, huh.”

“Yeah. A very unfair deal.”

She was not the cheeky angel I always saw on the other side of the screen, but a merciful angel who listened to my confession in front of me.

It was a sight that I couldn’t see through the small screen.

“So, I think I’ll have to kill another 500,000 people.”

So, I didn’t stop showing her my weak self.

Just a little more.

I wanted to give myself up to the illusion that was in front of me.

After we finished cleaning up the food warehouse.

Estasia and I went to the president’s office on the top floor of the company.

If it were before, the reliable leader of the group would have been sitting here, but now it was just an empty seat without any warmth.

I passed by the door of the office and went straight to the desk that had lost its owner.

The desk that had not been cleaned for a long time and was covered with dust came into my view.

“There’s a lot of dust.”

Swipe.

I reached out and swept the desk, and pale dust stuck to my finger.

It had been almost a year since then.

In a place where all kinds of equipment had stopped, it would have been stranger if there was no dust left.

As I looked at the dusty desk leisurely, various papers scattered on the desk caught my eye.

“Is this what you wrote...?”

I could easily tell whose handwriting it was without thinking too hard.

As I read the contents of the paper slowly, a smile came out of my mouth.

Some possible ways to continue are:

-He liked to write something on paper whenever he had time.

-Just like this paper that I was holding in my hand.

“I didn’t know before, but you were more thoughtful than I thought.”

-There was even a part where my name was written.

-Cheon Yuseong. I looked at the four characters written on the top of the paper and pushed it aside.

It was a gift he had prepared for me.

“Ha.”

He was really an admirable person.

I would never be able to become like him in my lifetime.

He left me with a debt I could never repay until the end.

I stared at the chocolate in front of me with a hollow feeling.

He had made a small promise to get me some chocolate when he could.

I had no trouble guessing who this chocolate was for.

“Estasia.”

As I was lost in my own thoughts, following the traces of the past, Estasia called me from behind.

“Huh. I’m listening.”

“Is this the place you said you would go to?”

She seemed to have a vague idea of why I came here.

I nodded at her.

This was why I decided to come to this company.

To break the thick shackles that bound me.

I had a plan to look through the food warehouse, but I think I wanted to sort out the things that were left in my head more.

“Yeah, this is it.”

No matter how much I turned away and ran away, the past would not disappear.

But I couldn’t stay still in sorrow forever.

People always had to be ready to take a step forward.

For themselves. And for the people who were with them.

My future was not just mine alone.

“The last... time?”

“Yeah, the last time.”

So, this was the last time I came here.

I didn't plan to come here again.

I came here today to say goodbye to my past self.

“I'll stop living in the past and ignoring reality today.”

I counted the things on the desk with my fingertips as I answered Estasia's question.

As if estimating the number, I counted the things on the desk and saw a chocolate that had melted and changed its shape.

It was twisted and dusty, but it was undoubtedly a new chocolate that hadn't been unwrapped.

“This is...”

I didn't notice it at the time because I was too busy, but I found it now.

A faint memory of his promise passed through my mind.

This chocolate was for someone.

I smiled bitterly as I picked up the chocolate and handed it to Estasia.

“Here, take this. It's yours now.”

She looked at me with surprise and confusion in her eyes.

“Mine? Why?”

“Because you’re the only one who can enjoy it. And because you’re the only one who can make me smile.”

I said that without hesitation or regret.

It was true. She was the only one who could make me smile in this broken world.

She was the only one who could give me hope and courage to face reality.

She was the only one who could stay by my side until the end.

“I’ve had enough of being pushed around by a capricious god.”

All the things I had built up until then turned into one emotion inside me.

That was the only fuel that would make me move forward.

I wouldn’t give up on either side.

The cult and apostles who trusted and followed me, and the world that was ruined by Estel.

I had to reclaim them with my own power.

“Is that so?”

“Yeah. I won’t run away anymore.”

The past me who tried to escape from reality without knowing anything was gone.

Now it was time to face reality.

It was time to prepare for a war to restore the broken world.

It wasn't just the cult and apostles who stood on the battlefield.

I also had to take my place on the battlefield prepared for me.

"I won't turn a blind eye with the excuse of a game, or shirk responsibility with the pretext of ignorance."

I had to take responsibility for what I had done.

I couldn't face everyone if I resigned and surrendered to the fate that was set for me.

The fate of destruction.

What did it think it was, trying to block my way?

If I was going to break and bend to something like fate, I wouldn't have been ready to stand here.

"So, from now on, I'll—."

The ones who decide the fate of others with their own hands.

The world calls them gods.

"I'll be your god."

My hand reached out and touched Estasia's cheek.

Her eyes sparkled like jewels, which I couldn't see beyond the screen.

There were things that I couldn't see on the small screen.

There were also things that I could only realize by facing them with my own eyes.

"Then..."

She looked at my hand on her cheek and opened her mouth.

There was no hesitation in her pure eyes.

She spoke with her will, more innocent than anyone I had seen.

Her voice was still languid and listless, but it wasn't hard to understand what emotion was in it.

“Then I'll stay with you until the end.”

“Is that so?”

“Yes.”

I lowered my hand that was reaching out to Estasia.

I felt strangely reassured by just a short word.

I never thought I would rely on this lazy angel.

I must have been quite lacking myself.

Of course, being such a person, there were things I could say as well.

“Thank you for being with me.”

“I still won't do any work, though.”

“You never change, even in this situation.”

“I'll hide all the snacks if you keep bothering me.”

The heavy atmosphere quickly crumbled.

As expected, no matter what we talked about, she was Estasia.

She was like that now, and she would always be like that.

That was the Estasia I knew.

“Well, I like that you're consistent.”

My gaze shifted from Estasia to a corner of the desk.

The chocolate on the desk was still there, covered with dust.

I reached out and grabbed the chocolate that was lying on the desk.

And with a bitter smile, I crumpled it and stuffed it into my pocket.

“I’ll take this as my severance pay.”

I said goodbye to my naive past.

As I left my mark on a place that I would never return to.

Chapter 183: The Cathedral (1)

Chapter 183: The Cathedral (1)

Archbishop Roan Hebriss.

He tried to calm his trembling hands, feeling the pressure he hadn't felt in a long time.

He let out a short sigh.

It had been several years since he received the command of the great being and founded the order.

In a short time, the order had expanded endlessly, and now its influence could swallow up several cities.

But even for Roan, who had led such an order, this command was not easy.

“The Heart of Origin...”

The Heart of Origin.

It was an object that was presumed to be stored in the center of Crossbridge.

Of course, it was nothing more than a conjecture of the black mages, and no one knew if it really existed there.

But the great being he served ordered Roan to find the Heart of Origin.

There was only one thing that meant.

“War is inevitable.”

He had to wage a full-scale war with the Holy Land.

He had poured everything into growing the order for his own future, but now he had to face the Holy Land, which he feared the most.

There would surely be countless casualties.

The monsters that were stuck in Crossbridge were not easy opponents.

And the heroes who had grown up would not be as easy to deal with as before.

“Archbishop Roan. Are you afraid of war?”

“Wouldn’t it be a lie if I said I wasn’t?”

Roan said as he looked at Evan, who had asked him a question.

He couldn’t help but be afraid.

Crossbridge was a nightmare for black mages.

He had to give the order to attack that place with his own mouth.

Any black mage would be afraid of that.

“But I have to do it. Because I’m the archbishop. And because it’s the command of the great one.”

But he couldn’t back down.

Roan had already received too many things from his master.

He had received a magic sword that absorbed magic, and the position of archbishop that made everyone respect him.

He had also received a miracle that allowed him to control fire and wind with his hand.

The guardian beast of the order that was hidden in his arm would do most of what Roan asked.

‘And now... this has happened.’

And now, Roan had a relic that would protect his life tied to his arm.

He had received too much grace from the great one.

He had to complete the impossible mission no matter what.

Evan nodded at Roan’s answer and said.

“That’s a good attitude.”

“What about you, Apostle? You’ll have to fight your blood who became a hero, won’t you?”

“Are you talking about Hus?”

Evan looked troubled by Roan’s question.

Hus Alemir, the hero of knowledge.

Evan Alemir’s brother would be waiting for them in the Holy Land.

If the war started, the two would have to cross swords with each other.

Evan moved his gauntlet and said after a moment of hesitation.

“I don’t know yet.”

“Are you still not ready?”

“Don’t worry. I won’t avoid fighting.”

He still looked troubled.

Roan saw Evan’s magic sword tied to his waist as he looked at him.

It was a new weapon that the great one had bestowed on Evan, who used a gauntlet.

He heard that it was a magic sword that increased the power of lightning by almost half.

They couldn't help but show their loyalty to the great one who loved them so much.

It was a decision they made the moment they stepped under the name of the order.

“Of course. That's what it means to be an apostle of the order.”

It didn't matter what the being they served wanted.

Even if he was a huge darkness that was scorned by the world.

Or even if he was a huge hypocrisy that wore the mask of darkness.

They had to fulfill the will of the great one in the end.

“Archbishop Roan. It seems like time is up. Let's go up.”

Evan, who had briefly looked up at the sun's position, said.

He was right.

The overwhelming presence that came from beyond the tent was felt even where he was.

They were the ones that Roan had summoned to announce the will of the great one.

“Is it already that time?”

It was time for Roan to stand in front of them himself.

What they had been fighting for until now.

And what they would be fighting for from now on.

He had to tell them himself with his own mouth.

“Archbishop Roan.”

“It seems like you still have something to say, Apostle.”

“I believe that Archbishop Roan will somehow make it happen.”

As Roan grabbed the tent to go outside after making up his mind, Evan looked at him with a faint smile and said.

It was a smile that didn't suit his stiff face.

Roan also smiled back at Evan and replied.

“Is that so?”

“It's because of the power of the great one and Archbishop Roan that the order has come this far from nothing.”

The image of himself pouring his blood and sweat for years passed through Roan's head.

It had been hard days, he thought.

And it had been happy days, too.

It was a better life than rotting as a mere black mage, or being pointed at as a heretic by the paladins.

Roan stopped in front of the tent and shook his head to deny Evan's words.

“No. You're wrong, Apostle.”

“Did I say something wrong?”

“All this is done by the great one.”

Evan looked surprised for a moment.

But soon he couldn't hold back his laughter and said.

"I still have a long way to go to follow the archbishop."

"You'll catch up if you work hard slowly."

"I guess so. That's how I can go along with Archbishop Roan."

Swish.

Roan pushed aside the tent and said his last words to Evan.

"Of course. We are the ones who serve the great one."

Roan's footsteps headed to the podium after finishing his last conversation with Evan.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

As Roan's footsteps climbed up the stairs to the podium, more and more people appeared in his eyes.

There were too many people there for something that started from a bandit's hideout.

The order's humble hideout had turned into several magnificent temples in no time.

The influence of the great one was evident everywhere in the order, despite the short time.

"Archbishop Roan is entering!"

A follower of Roan shouted at his subordinates as he watched him climb up the podium.

As soon as they saw Roan, the archbishop, the people who had been waiting below started to buzz.

The crowd was making noises of all kinds, creating a noisy scene.

Thud. Thud.

Roan reached the end of the podium after receiving the salutes of the officers.

He then flicked his sleeve and raised his hand to the sky.

“Listen to me!”

Roan’s voice echoed loudly, silencing the noisy crowd.

All eyes were on Roan.

Even a grand duke would not feel such a gaze easily.

Roan faced the endless followers with a serious face and opened his mouth.

“The great one has commanded.”

Roan always had one thing to tell them.

The will of God.

He only conveyed what the great one wanted to the humans on earth.

And what the great one wanted now was one thing.

“Prepare for the holy war. We will raise the order’s flag in Crossbridge.”

A huge war.

Their master craved for the greatest war.

The Holy Land, Crossbridge.

On the bridge that connected the imperial palace and the temple, Hus looked at the crowd that was moving hastily.

Ever since the emperor passed a dangerous bill in the council of elders, all the clerics in the temple of order had started to move busily.

There was one reason why they were so busy.

They were preparing for the ritual to open the gate of heaven.

“Isn’t it amazing that they’re going to open the gate of heaven?”

Next to Hus, who was walking side by side, Sion’s face was full of curiosity.

He always moved with interest, but this time he seemed more excited than usual.

Sigh.

Hus let out a short sigh and looked at Sion.

“Sion, there’s going to be a war. It’s not a time to be happy.”

“But it’s not easy to see angels coming down, right?”

Sion was not wrong.

Even they, who were called heroes, had never seen an angel’s face directly.

An ordinary person would never see an angel in their lifetime.

But as Hus listened to Sion’s words, he felt that he needed to correct some part of them.

Hus pushed away Sion, who was smiling smugly in front of him, and said.

“The angels are coming down on the empire’s side. More precisely, near the islands.”

“What? So we can’t see angels here?”

“We might be lucky enough to meet some. But there won’t be any spectacle like you expect.”

The angels’ purpose was not to defend the Holy Land.

Rather, they were beings used to attract the attention of the order and the apostles.

While they were reducing their power a little bit, Hus and his fellow heroes had to defeat other apostles.

That’s why they were trying to open the gate at the expense of the temple of order.

As Hus thought about his future, Sion, who still had a playful expression on his face, said to him.

“That’s too bad. I thought I could see angels.”

“Didn’t the saintess tell you?”

“I don’t really know much. Maybe it’s because I’m still young?”

Hus thought of the huntress of the saintess who followed Sion every day.

To be honest, she was too young for the position of a saintess.

The huntress of the saintess liked chasing Sion more than doing her duty at the temple.

But it was an inevitable fate once she was chosen as a saintess.

Hus chuckled as he thought of the huntress of the saintess who chased Sion.

“Someone might say that’s an insult to the saintess.”

“She wouldn’t care about that, would she?”

“That’s irresponsible of her.”

“I’ve always lived like this, you know? If I had to act like a hero, I’d suffocate and die right away.”

Sion was right.

He always did what he felt like doing.

He often defied the orders of the temple or the imperial palace.

But he usually obeyed them anyway.

“Well, that might be true.”

“Rather than me, you should be more worried about yourself, Hus.”

“What are you talking about?”

Sion’s finger pointed to the direction of the temple of honor.

It was where Hus’s brother Evan belonged.

Sion pointed to the temple of honor with his finger and said to Hus.

“You’ll have to fight your family when the war breaks out.”

“...”

“If you don’t harden your heart, you’ll have trouble on the battlefield.”

Hus frowned at Sion’s words.

Someone had to fight Evan when the war broke out.

He knew that from the beginning.

He had engraved his mindset in his heart many times for that.

Hus answered Sion with an indifferent voice.

“Don’t worry about it. It’s my problem to solve.”

“If you say you’re feeling burdened, I could fight for you instead...
Ugh...!”

Crack.

Hus twisted Sion’s neck and brought his face close to him.

Hus’s eyes had changed to a murderous look as he looked at Sion.

He said with fierce eyes as he lifted him up.

“I’m the one who will kill Evan Alemir.”

“Hus...!”

He had to be the only one to fight Evan.

He had trained for that until now, and he would continue to do so.

So Evan had to remain Hus’s nemesis.

He had to end Evan’s life with his own hands.

Otherwise, his whole life would be unfair by someone else’s hand.

“No matter who you are, if you interfere with my business, I won’t let you go.”

Hus declared to Sion with a vicious look.

A killing intent that seemed to kill anything in sight filled the surroundings.

Sion looked at Hus with a panicked expression and then gave up resisting and slumped his arms and legs.

Chapter 184: The Cathedral (2)

Chapter 184: The Cathedral (2)

One afternoon, when the sun was high in the sky.

When I came back home after wandering outside, the first thing I saw was Estasia eating ice cream.

Estasia had quickly adapted to the studio apartment, where she had been staying for almost a week.

The most obvious thing was the blanket that wrapped her body.

She hid under the blanket, only poking her head out, and ate ice cream while watching a documentary about penguins.

“Estasia...”

I sighed as I looked at Estasia hiding under the blanket.

I could tolerate her not doing any work.

But I couldn't stand her eating ice cream on the blanket.

As soon as I took off my shoes and entered the room, I said to Estasia who was eating ice cream.

“Don't eat ice cream on the blanket.”

“It's cold...”

But Estasia only gave a short answer and wrapped herself more tightly with the blanket.

Seeing that, I felt like I couldn't stand her not doing any work anymore.

She needed some punishment.

Thud. Thud.

I walked straight to Estasia, who only showed her head.

And then I grabbed the halo that was floating above her head with both hands.

“Don't eat ice cream under the blanket!”

“Don't pull my halo!”

As I pulled her halo, Estasia's body also came out of the blanket.

She grabbed my hand that held her halo and struggled to get out of the blanket.

When I finally dragged her out of the blanket, Estasia flopped on the floor.

Flap. Flap.

Her wings fluttered weakly, scattering a few feathers.

I gave Estasia a stern warning as she lay on the floor.

“I told you not to eat like that last time.”

“It's cold.”

“Why don't you wrap yourself with your wings and eat?”

“My wings are cold.”

“...”

But Estasia didn't listen to my warning.

I was speechless as I listened to her excuses.

She looked dejected as she lay on the floor. Then she rolled over and lifted her head.

She looked at me calmly and said.

“Master.”

“What.”

“This is angel abuse.”

She must have picked up some strange words from watching TV for a few days.

Angel abuse.

It felt like words that should never meet had met.

There was no such word in the world.

Even if there was, I had no reason to accept it.

There was only one thing I could do to Estasia who claimed angel abuse.

I bent down and looked her in the eye.

“Don't expect such standards from a demon.”

“Ugh...!”

Thump.

I hit Estasia's forehead hard.

She grabbed her forehead and flailed.

I ignored her and went to the side. I leaned against the bed and sat on the floor.

I had a smartphone in my hand.

I left Estasia alone and looked at the world inside my smartphone.

“Pick up the feathers on the floor yourself.”

“...”

“If you don’t, you’ll have no ice cream next time.”

“O-okay.”

Thankfully, the threat of ice cream worked well.

Estasia got up quickly and started picking up the feathers that fell while she was rolling around.

Of course, she wasn’t very fast.

She kept whining at me as she cleaned up the feathers.

“Master is a wicked demon.”

“I know.”

“It’s wrong to make an angel work.”

“There’s a strawberry cake in the plastic bag I brought today. Don’t forget to put it in the fridge when you’re done cleaning.”

“Master is a kind god.”

I had to be firm with her sometimes, since she wouldn’t do any work otherwise.

After assigning her some chores, I looked at the smartphone in my hand.

The screen of the smartphone showed the same thing as always.

It looked like a game to anyone who held the smartphone, with various buttons and a game-like interface.

“I don’t have many items left... Maybe I should think about the plan some more.”

It had been a while since I found out that the world inside the smartphone was real.

And yet, I decided to move the cult and start a war.

The cult followed my orders and prepared for the war.

But there wasn’t much I could do to control the war.

I had acquired some powerful skills like <Meteor Strike> and <Lightning Storm>, but they had some problems to use them right now.

The biggest problem was <Karma’s Judgment>.

“I’ve distributed most of the items I’ve drawn, but I can’t really help them right now.”

I would have plenty of opportunities to intervene when the war started.

But not right now.

Too much intervention would inevitably bring about causality correction.

I had no reason to balance causality with my own hands for something of little utility.

If possible, I wanted to delay the awakening of the heroes as much as possible.

Considering that, I ordered the cult leaders to stop fasting for a while.

“Are you worried about the war?”

“Yeah. There’s no point in using the double coupon and slaughtering them recklessly.”

Estasia asked me with six feathers in her palm as she cleaned them up. .

I nodded at her and answered.

I couldn’t worry enough about the war.

The details would be filled by Roan, the archbishop, but I needed to make a big framework that would set the direction.

For example, who would face which enemy.

“The most troublesome enemies would be the heroes. I haven’t touched them for a while, and their causality correction has increased a lot.”

“But you said you’ve become stronger too.”

“That’s the problem. They become stronger as I become stronger.”

I explained the mechanism of the smartphone to Estasia again, who already knew everything from me.

The [Divine Tool: Smartphone] that I had was something I got from the Goddess of Harmony.

Every time karma’s balance collapsed and causality correction occurred, I also received the effect of causality correction and gained more functions.

What I called leveling up until now was actually that concept.

My actions resolved the karma imbalance between the six gods and demons, and that made the power of the Goddess of Harmony stronger.

The more I tried to gain an advantage, the stronger my enemies became.

It was a strange situation.

“So I have to postpone karma acquisition as much as possible and deal with those annoying ones first.”

“Like that mage named Merona Frost.”

“Of course, Arien Crost. He’ll be the toughest opponent. I have to use <Holy Blast: Logration> on him even if I use it.”

My eyes naturally went to the icon of <Holy Blast: Logration> at the bottom of the screen.

Using <Holy Blast> would give a wide-area penalty to the enemy for a certain period of time.

And most of those effects were fatal for paladins and mages.

I had to use <Holy Blast> on that Arien guy no matter what.

He was the strongest and most threatening among all enemies, including heroes. He could easily escape from the battlefield with his unique mobility.

“And he also pushed back Eutenia... It won’t be easy for anyone who goes out. If I have to find someone who can fight him, maybe...”

He was also the one who had a one-sided advantage over Eutenia.

No matter who faced him, any apostle would likely feel embarrassed.

So I had to prepare as thoroughly as possible.

I had to move an apostle who could gain an advantage over a mage in a space that endangered mages.

For example, like that guy Mabu on the screen right now.

-“Swing harder. Don’t let any distractions get into your sword.”

-“No, I swing with both hands like Evan, so I can’t do that kind of skill...”

-“Don’t make excuses for yourself. Training is never enough no matter how much you do it.”

Mabu, who was learning from Evan, was shown on the other side of the screen.

They were training themselves by swinging their swords in a corner of the cult.

I looked at the weapons in Peter’s hands with a troubled expression.

The [Divine Tool: Dainsleif] that Peter had was a divine tool that allowed him to move at an incredible speed in a narrow area.

And the weapon he held in his other hand, I didn’t know its name, but it had the effect of weakening magic.

He was a nemesis of mages who was optimized for fighting at high speed in a narrow sanctuary.

“Will Mabu fight Merona?”

“...I guess so. I think that’s the best option if possible.”

He was someone who no one expected until he barely protected Eutenia.

And now that I think about it, he was also someone who I did a lot of terrible things to.

The sixth apostle, Peter Enklof.

Both Eutenia and I owed him a lot.

I wasn’t sure if I could pay him back even after this war ended.

But if it was possible, I wanted to give him a happy ending as my apostle.

“He’s an apostle of God... I don’t think that’s a fitting title for him, but I should give him a gift since he’s taking on the most important task.”

I touched the screen to open my inventory.

Pop.

As soon as I opened my inventory, an item at the top came into my sight.

A cloak with a sinister design and a jet-black color.

It was a holy relic that I obtained from a draw that burned all my assets.

It was an item that had a radical effect unlike any other items I had so far.

-[Holy Relic: Sephida’s Cloak]

-Reduces damage from magic by 50%.

-Protects from negative status effects caused by magic.

Sephida’s Cloak.

It was an item with a simple but powerful effect.

Simple effects were usually powerful.

And it was also an item that suited Peter, who was becoming a counter to mages.

This would be a great help in the fight against Arien.

I decided to give this holy relic to Peter and moved my hand to the <Voice> skill at the bottom of the screen.

“Hmm, hmm.”

“...”

“Pick up the feathers first, Estasia.”

I brushed off Estasia’s blank stare and looked at Peter on the screen.

And then I opened my mouth to speak to him.

I spoke with the voice of God, but this time I didn’t need the help of a divine translator.

I was already their master since I decided to become their god.

-I tell the sixth apostle.”

-“I tell the sixth apostle.”

Peter, who heard my trust, lifted his head and looked up at the sky.

In his hands were a white sword and a black sword, one each.

Their colors seemed to prove Peter’s twisted fate.

“Prove yourself even in the darkness.”

-“Prove yourself even in the darkness.”

He was a hero.

He was born with the destiny of a hero, and he was destined to be admired by everyone.

It was none other than me who led him to the path of an apostle.

At the end of the destiny that I forced upon Peter, I had to give him a future that he wanted.

That was the role given to a demon who decided the fate of humans and the world.

“Don’t give up hope even in hardship.”

-“Don’t give up hope even in hardship.”

Flap.

A black cloak landed on Peter’s shoulders.

The holy relic that contained darkness proved my will by putting a ring on Peter’s chest.

In front of the hero who fluttered his cloak, I gave him my last trust.

“Then, I will be your god.”

-“Then, I will be your god.”

Peter was not the only one who had to prove himself.

So did I.

Proving that I deserved to remain as a god who suited them.

And correcting the mistakes that I had made as much as possible.

That was the burden of someone who called himself a god.

Chapter 185: The Cathedral (3)

Chapter 185: The Cathedral (3)

A mansion located in the center of the system.

There, Count Colt stepped out, gazing at the setting sun.

Today was the day of the banquet led by the second prince of the empire, Aicliffe Rogasion.

At first, Count Colt had accepted the invitation with the intention of mocking him, but now it had become a necessary task to prove his well-being.

Behind Count Colt, who was heading to the mansion where Aicliffe was, his escort knight, Scollaus, followed him in a refined outfit.

A little further away from Scollaus, the shadow knights who always followed Count Colt were watching over them.

Count Colt spoke to Scollaus, who was following him.

“Scollaus. Don’t intervene today, no matter what happens.”

He was already suspected of having some health problems.

If Scollaus showed an overprotective attitude towards him, such rumors would spread faster.

It was important for Count Colt to not show any suspicious behavior that would undermine his firmness in front of others.

That's why he warned him not to step in to protect himself unless someone tried to assassinate him.

"I understand."

"I'll handle any problems myself. Even if the second prince is rude to me, stay calm."

Count Colt firmly instructed Scollaus and moved his steps towards the banquet hall.

Thud. Thud.

The eyes of other nobles turned to Count Colt, who was walking ahead.

He was one of the famous grand dukes in the empire.

And since he had been staying in his mansion lately and not coming out, it was natural that people's attention was drawn to him.

Among them was Count Eifeld, who was known for liking to gossip at banquets.

"Count! I was very worried about you since you haven't been seen lately, but it seems like it was needless worry."

"Count Eifeld. Thank you for your concern."

Count Colt replied to Count Eifeld, who greeted him, and headed to the entrance of the banquet hall.

As Count Colt approached, the soldiers guarding the entrance also tensed up.

When Count Colt, accompanied by his escort knight, winked at the soldiers at the entrance, they immediately opened the door and bowed their heads to him.

The voice of the herald announced Count Colt's visit to the banquet hall.

“The guardian of the north, Lord Ordo Colt, has entered!”

The reaction inside the banquet hall was not much different from that of the nobles outside.

The whole banquet hall began to stir with the voice of the herald.

The nobles whispered to each other in surprised voices about Count Colt.

Some of them spoke so loudly that Count Colt could hear them clearly.

“Count Colt is here?”

“He avoided parties for a while... Was there something wrong?”

“I don’t like the feeling of him attending only the second prince’s banquet.”

Count Colt frowned at the murmurs of the nobles.

They probably thought he couldn’t hear them, but with his current abilities, he could easily catch their words.

Did they finally realize the situation when they saw his scowling face?

Some of the quick-witted nobles immediately shut their mouths.

But there were still some foolish ones who kept talking loudly.

“Tsk.”

It seemed that many of them had forgotten who he was while he was out of sight for a while.

Just as Count Colt was about to say something out of irritation,

someone approached him with a friendly voice, as if to save him.

“Count Colt! It’s been a long time since I’ve seen you!”

“second prince Aicliffe.”

The one who came to him was none other than Aicliffe.

He came up to him with a bright smile and took Count Colt’s hand.

He looked like he had forgotten who Count Colt was supporting, just like the ones who were gossiping before.

When Aicliffe, the host of the banquet, came to him, the attention of the others was once again focused on Count Colt.

Count Colt suppressed his displeasure and greeted the second prince politely.

“It’s been a long time, Your Majesty.”

“I was very worried about the bad rumors about you, but it seems like you’re still fine.”

“Is that so? It looks like exercising every day paid off.”

Squeeze.

Aicliffe’s grip on Count Colt’s hand tightened slightly.

It was a far cry from his usual courteous handshake.

Was it because more people were supporting the second prince lately?

Or was it because most of the nobles in the banquet hall were his followers?

He looked very arrogant and confident, unlike before.

“But are you really okay? You seem to have unusually cold hands today...”

Aicliffe, who was holding Count Colt’s hand with force, blurted out a word.

Count Colt’s nerves tensed up when he heard Aicliffe’s words.

Ever since he was fed blood by his assailant, Count Colt's body temperature had become abnormally low.

It seemed that Aicliffe had noticed that part when he held his hand.

Count Colt tried to act calm and counter Aicliffe's words.

"Haha, maybe it's because of the cold weather. I tried my best, but it seems like I can't fool my age."

"Aren't you the pillar of Alterias? You should take more care of your health."

"Thank you for your wisdom, Your Majesty. When I go back to the north, I'll have to boil some wolf meat and regain some energy."

Count Colt wanted to get out of the conversation with the second prince as soon as possible.

But this was a banquet hosted by Aicliffe.

The flow of the banquet was in Aicliffe's hands.

And Aicliffe didn't seem to want to end the formal talk easily.

Aicliffe, who was talking to him, turned around and ordered a servant something.

"Hey! Bring that here!"

"Yes, Your Majesty!"

The servant bowed his head and moved somewhere.

It looked like he was going to bring something that Aicliffe had prepared.

Count Colt had no idea what it was.

He asked Aicliffe, who was in front of him.

“What is that? What are you talking about?”

“I have a special gift for you, since I heard that your health is not good.”

“What is that...”

No matter how he thought about it, Aicliffe and Count Colt were not in a relationship to exchange gifts with smiles.

Of course, since it was an official occasion, Aicliffe wouldn't give him anything strange.

“It's coming right there. I'll show it to you myself.”

As Aicliffe said, the servant who brought the gift came back quickly.

He had prepared something nearby, knowing that Count Colt would come.

A servant returned in an instant and handed a box to Aicliffe politely.

“Here it is, Your Majesty.”

“Good, go back to your place. This is the gift I want to give to the count.”

Aicliffe opened the box and showed him what was inside.

It was a bracelet made of silver.

It was worth less than gold of the same weight, but it looked like it was not something to be ignored by its size.

Count Colt looked at the silver bracelet that Aicliffe showed him and asked him with a bitter tone.

“Is this the gift you're giving me, Your Majesty?”

“Silver is a metal that drives away evil energy and heals people. It's a gift I prepared for Count Colt.”

“Haha, I appreciate your kindness, but I can’t accept this...”

It was a ridiculous gift from Aicliffe.

Count Colt had no reason to take such a thing.

Then Aicliffe grabbed Count Colt’s hand firmly and said.

“You don’t need to refuse. I’ll put it on you myself.”

Aicliffe took out the silver bracelet and put it on the hand that he was holding with Count Colt.

It was a reckless behavior that he wouldn’t have shown before.

Count Colt was momentarily startled by the second prince’s sudden action.

Soon, he felt a strong pain in his hand that touched the silver bracelet.

“Aaaargh...!”

“Co, count? What’s going on?”

Squeak!

Flames burst out from Count Colt’s hand that touched Aicliffe’s silver bracelet.

Count Colt widened his eyes and looked at his burning hand.

It was his hand that was fine until a moment ago.

But as soon as Aicliffe’s silver bracelet touched it, it caught fire.

It was obvious that Aicliffe had done something to it.

“Ugh... Ai, Aicliffe...! How dare you do this to me—!”

“Count! Be careful!”

Swoosh.

Scollaus, who was waiting behind Count Colt, drew his sword.

Count Colt also staggered back slowly.

He attacked him in the banquet hall of all places.

Aicliffe must have gone mad for sure.

Many eyes in the banquet hall saw this scene, so Aicliffe couldn't make any excuses anymore.

“Count! Are you okay! I'll pour water on the fire!”

But Aicliffe didn't care and picked up a silver cup nearby.

The cup that Aicliffe picked up was full of clear water.

He poured it on Count Colt's wrist, which was burning.

Whoosh!

The fire on Count Colt's wrist, which was dying down, flared up even more.

Count Colt bit his lip hard as his arm burned.

“Khh... Ugh... Aaah...!”

“Count! I only poured water from the silver cup on the fire, how can it blaze up like this? What the hell is going on?”

“Aicliffe...! Khh... You bastard...!”

He hated Aicliffe's face, who was standing calmly after setting his body on fire.

He felt like killing the second prince in front of him right now.

Scollaus blocked the second prince's front with his sword, and Count Colt kept shivering and backing away.

And Aicliffe, who was watching him, opened his mouth again.

“Both the silver bracelet and the silver cup... Could it be that you are... a vampire?”

Vampire.

Count Colt's stomach turned at the word that came out of Aicliffe's mouth out of nowhere.

Why was he talking about vampires all of a sudden?

They had been exterminated by the heroes and disappeared from the continent hundreds of years ago.

No one here would take him seriously if he started talking about vampires now.

“I've heard that. Vampires' skin burns when they touch silver.”

“Who told you such nonsense...!”

But someone in the banquet hall agreed with Aicliffe's words and stepped forward.

Count Colt looked at the owner of the voice with blurred eyes.

The one who sided with Aicliffe and came forward was a young man with black hair and a sharp impression.

Van Krite. The young genius of Cloud.

He was a special investigator from Cloud, who had not been in the empire for long.

“I never thought Count Colt would be a vampire. Damn vampires, they’ve crawled into the heart of the empire.”

Van glared at Count Colt with a fierce look and advanced forward.

He was famous for being one of the best in Cloud.

It was a situation where Scollaus couldn’t guarantee to win even if he stepped in.

But what was more problematic was Aicliffe, who was standing behind Van with an embarrassed face.

“I’m sorry, count. I didn’t know you were a vampire...”

“You don’t need to apologize, Your Majesty. It seems that this evil vampire didn’t know his place and came here.”

“But still, he’s Count Colt. How can I do this to him...”

Van Krite blocked Aicliffe, who was pretending to be sorry.

He stopped the second prince and picked up a knife nearby.

The knife in Van’s hand was also made of silver.

“You should be careful. It seems that the count is a vampire, and there is a high possibility that the whole Colt family is too.”

“How can that be! Are you saying that the Colt family, who were the loyal guardians of the empire, were actually the den of vampires?”

“Yes. It looks like vampires are rampant in Alterias as well. Recently, some of Cloud’s investigators lost contact in the north, and it seems that it was the work of vampires.”

It was a ridiculous story.

Count Colt had never clashed with Cloud’s investigators.

The same was true for the Colt family and the shadow knights.

Van's claim that he was involved in the disappearance of Cloud's investigators in the north was a blatant lie.

But it was clear who the people here would believe.

The twisted count shouted at his enemies in front of him.

“Yo, you bastards... How dare you talk nonsense in front of...!”

His anger rose to his head, and he felt like he forgot the pain in his arm.

His blood rushed to his head and his vision turned red.

As if to mock Count Colt's anger, Aicliffe stepped forward again.

“This can't be. I have to tell His Majesty. If Alterias has fallen into the hands of vampires, we have to respond at the royal level.”

“We have to form a proper extermination force. There are many undeads in the north, including vampires.”

“Were those undeads also under Count Colt's command? Count Colt, you were really a terrifying person after all.”

“We have to drive out the vampires who are devouring the empire. No matter who they are.”

The two exchanged ridiculous conversations and pressured Count Colt.

It was a play full of holes.

Their exaggerated words and actions were something that even a third-rate troupe wouldn't do.

But despite their stupid play, the nobles around them were agitated.

Some soldiers drew their swords with wary faces.

“Ugh... Ugh...!”

Crunch.

Count Colt gritted his teeth and looked at Scollaus.

There was only one decision he could make in this situation.

He knew that he couldn't turn back if he didn't explain himself here, but all the eyes around him were forcing him to act against his favor.

He made up his mind and shouted at Scollaus with a metallic voice.

“Scollaus! Move the shadow knights!”

“Count! The shadow knights are...!”

“Move now! Make an escape route for me!”

This whole space was Aicliffe's trap.

He had to get out of here.

Right now.

Chapter 186: The Cathedral (4)

Chapter 186: The Cathedral (4)

In the office of the duke, located in the Obtos duchy.

There sat the Obtos duke, who had a splendid beard.

He was one of the few great nobles in the empire, along with the Colt duke, but lately he had been having a lot of trouble maintaining his dignity.

The attack of the cult at the auction house, the loss of troops, and the decline of his credit that made some nobles say they would not put up any goods for the next auction.

If it weren't for the Obtos duke's reputation, he would have grabbed the necks of those others right away.

But for the Obtos duke, the report that came in this time was something he could laugh happily about for the first time in a long time.

The Obtos duke looked at his subordinate who had brought up the report with a satisfied smile.

"Is that true? The Second Prince Aicliffe revealed the identity of the Colt duke?"

"Yes. According to the report, the Colt duke's identity was actually a vampire."

"Haha, I knew he had a sinister side all along, but he was indeed a vampire! This is a great feat by the second prince!"

The hearty laughter of the Obtos duke echoed in the office.

He had been displeased by the Colt duke's movements to expand his influence in the central region lately, but that Colt duke's position had plummeted in an instant.

If it was spread that the Colt duke's identity was actually a monster, the holy land would react in some way.

And the royal family also had to show active movements in this situation.

"Damn! He's a cold-blooded one who eats people! No wonder! He's a vampire after all!"

Soon, an expedition force would be organized to send to the Alterias region.

There was a high possibility that Cloud and the heresy inquisitors would move together.

The face of the Colt duke who would panic when he faced the expedition force flashed through the Obtos duke's mind.

He felt full just by imagining the embarrassed face of the Colt duke.

"So, where is the Colt duke now?"

"He seems to be returning to Alterias quickly under the escort of the Shadow Knights."

The Obtos duke stroked his beard with his hand as he heard his subordinate's report.

He felt a good idea sprouting every time he flipped his beard.

He pondered for a moment while intoxicated by the satisfying report content, and then opened his mouth to his subordinate.

"He's going back to his duchy... We can't let him go easily."

“Are you thinking of moving troops?”

“Pick out some elite soldiers and prepare them. We have to lend a hand to the expedition, don’t we?”

The downfall of the Colt duke meant a lot.

It meant that the power of Renglos, whom he had supported wholeheartedly, was weakened.

And it also meant that the balance was strongly tilted to the side of the first emperor, whom Obtos duke supported.

He had to cut off his breath when he had a chance.

It was obvious what would happen if he let go of a vicious beast with a bad temper.

“Yes. I will prepare knights and elite soldiers.”

“As soon as you are ready, chase after him. Tell them I’ll give 500 gold coins to whoever cuts off his neck.”

“Everyone will do their best to uphold your command.”

The subordinate who received orders from Obtos duke bowed his head and left out of office.

He would prepare troops as quickly as possible since he had been told strongly.

It was an honorable battle that brought political benefits.

It was a very satisfying situation for him.

The Obtos duke watched his subordinate leave and muttered with a satisfied face.

“I can’t let those vicious undead run wild. That’s for sure.”

The Abyss, the stronghold of the black mages.

A person came to see Arcrosis, who was drawing a huge magic circle there.

The person who came to him was Kerington, the leader of the Abyss and a black mage.

Kerington had grown at an astonishing speed since he made a contract with Arcrosis.

It was certain that he would become one of the strongest in the empire in a little more time.

Arcrosis also had some expectations for Kerington's future.

"O ruler of death. A message from the great one has come down through the cult."

Kerington spoke to him with a polite attitude as soon as he came to Arcrosis.

Arcrosis stopped his hand that was carving a magic circle on the ground as he heard Kerington's words.

The contact from the cult was likely to be about the trust.

Arcrosis asked Kerington, who had come to him, as he stopped his hand.

- "What is it?"

"They say that human troops will come to the north."

- "Is it our role to crush them?"

"Yes. To trample on the empire's expedition force and make our existence known in the north. That is the command that the great one has delivered through the cult."

Click.

A jewel ring on his finger came into Arcrosis's sight as he moved his finger.

It was something he had gotten when he was invited to the gathering of those who served the great being.

Arcrosis turned his body and looked at Kerington as he stared at the ring on his finger.

His eyes filled with darkness turned to Kerington this time.

-“Is it your wish to destroy the empire and build a kingdom of black mages?”

“You seem to remember. Our goal is to repay the insults we received from the damned empire and create a world for black mages.”

-“I see.”

Arcrosis remembered the conversation he had with Roan as he listened to Kerington's words.

He argued that they needed to suppress the empire's troops if a war broke out with the holy land.

The imperial army coming to Alterias region would also be part of that plan.

Arcrosis, who had been standing still for a while, raised darkness in his palm and spoke.

-“I'll give you some more power.”

“What do you mean by power?”

-“I'll lend ten thousand undead to all those who have contracted with me.”

They needed to raise the level of black mages a little more before facing the war.

It was Arcrosis's decision for that.

Ten thousand was a number that a single necromancer could not reach even if he gathered them for his whole life.

Moreover, the undead of Arcrosis, the lord of the dead, were of unquestionable quality.

Kerington's mouth curled up as if it would tear as he heard Arcrosis's words.

“O ruler of death!”

-“Lead the army of death and face the enemies that are coming.”

Not only Kerington, but all the officers of the Abyss were happy with the news.

Arcrosis, who had entrusted them with the army of the undead, turned his body and looked at the magic circle again.

It was not an easy decision for Arcrosis, who was called the lord of the dead, to give ten thousand undead to each of the officers.

But now Arcrosis was confident that he wouldn't care even if he lost all the undead he had lent them.

After he went down to the abyss and came back, the primordial demon had gained a new enlightenment.

Now, for Arcrosis, human death was infinitely light.

“We will work hard not to disappoint the great one!”

-“The great being will watch over your loyalty.”

“Hehe... Under the name of the Abyss, all humans will bow their heads.”

Kerington left with a sinister smile as he received Arcrosis's confirmation.

Kerington's footsteps looked infinitely lighter than usual as he left.

Arcrosis left Kerington alone and continued to draw the magic circle with magic.

The most important thing for him now was the magic circle he was engraving in a deep cave.

-“I have to prepare to welcome the guests.”

The magic circle that Arcrosis was drawing was a thing that connected the surface and the abyss.

It opened a temporary passage between the two places, to bring out the monsters of the abyss to the surface.

The monsters living in the abyss boasted a strength that could not be compared with the life forms on the surface.

The moment those monsters showed their appearance on the surface, humans would run away in fear.

The only thing a mere prey could do in front of a true predator was to run away.

-“Maybe I'll be able to bring out a lord-level monster.”

Crack.

The ground cracked and the magic circle continued.

The humans outside would not know what was happening in the deep cave hidden in the cold.

Until the monsters that were crouching in the abyss came out to the surface.

“It looks delicious.”

In her usual studio apartment, Estasia bit into a rice cake and said.

At the end of Estasia's gaze, there was a white rice cake on her smartphone screen.

Cuebaerg, the abyssal beast.

He was the one that the smartphone called the lord of the abyss.

I glanced at the rice cake that Estasia was holding, and then opened my mouth to Cuebaerg, who was beyond the smartphone screen.

"Well, he does look similar. But I don't know if he's tasty."

"Have you never tried him?"

"...Why would I eat that."

Peek.

Estasia, who was looking at me from the side, quickly stuffed the rice cake into my mouth.

I coughed in surprise as the rice cake suddenly entered my mouth.

"I shared it with you."

Cough, cough.

As the powder of the rice cake stimulated my throat and made me cough, Estasia got up from her seat and spoke with her wings fluttering.

A few feathers fell along with her fluttering wings.

"Cough, cough..."

"Praise is fine with strawberry juice and ice cream."

The one who created that situation had a proud face and a chest out.

He clearly thought he deserved praise.

I wondered for a moment if I should throw out the white trash in front of me, but I decided to just let it go this time.

I had too much work left to do to care about Estasia.

“Do you want to kill me...”

“Please give me strawberry juice and ice cream before I die.”

“...”

I nodded with a blank eye and turned my gaze back to the smartphone screen.

Cuebaerg on the screen was talking with Evan.

There was only one thing that Evan could say to Cuebaerg in this situation.

Of course, it was about the war.

-“Therefore, the cult is preparing for a full-scale war with the holy land.”

-Kuoooh.

-“You must have recovered some of the power you lost by now. You will be a great help on the battlefield.”

As time passed, Cuebaerg had regained a considerable amount of power.

The cult, which was preparing for war, seemed to want to use Cuebaerg for combat as well.

I didn’t know how much help a rice cake floating on the sea would be on the ground.

But it seemed clear that he would have some influence on the coast or the port.

“Cuebaerg has grown a lot.”

He was Cuebaerg, who had contributed a lot to the karma supply.

Of course, it was hard to expect the same amount of karma supply as before, but he still had some performance to show, as the saying goes, better than nothing.

As I watched Cuebaerg with that thought, he stretched out one arm toward Evan.

And then he opened his mouth and spoke to him.

-Kuoooh. Kuoooh.

-“I’ll fight in the sea. If I can only exert my power in an environment similar to the abyss, it might be better to do so.”

-Kuoooh.

-“I’ll find out the sea route to the holy land myself. It would be better to do that if I get a chance.”

I don’t know if it’s a problem of power or a limit of magic.

But Cuebaerg and Evan seemed to have a normal conversation.

Evan wanted to use Cuebaerg strategically, who was floating on the sea, and Cuebaerg also seemed to accept him.

It was better to use any available power in any way.

A million karma was not a light number.

“He seems to understand the conversation somehow. It’s not bad to have a lot of guys who can do well in various ways.”

As I watched them for a while, this time Buoyto, who brought Evan here, came close to the screen.

Buoyto, who had grown as big as a castle by now, cast a huge shadow over their heads.

It looked very intimidating even on the screen.

Buoyto, who made even the huge Cuebaerg look small, covered the screen and popped up a speech bubble.

-Sniffle.

Under the huge speech bubble that rose up, Evan's speech bubble popped up, now hidden from view.

Evan looked at Buoyto floating above his head and said.

-“...He seems to have something to say.”

-Kuoooh.

-“I can't know what the spirit is thinking. It would be better to talk to each other instead.”

It seemed that Buoyto had something to say to Cuebaerg.

Maybe there was something in common between the giant creatures.

Evan waited gladly for them to talk.

And right after that, huge speech bubbles poured out and covered the screen.

-Sniffle.

-Kuoooh.

-Sniffle sniffle.

-Kuoooh kuoooh kuoooh.

-Sniff. Sniffle sniffle sniffle sniffle sniffle.

-Kuoooh kuoooh kuoooh kuoooh kuoooh kuoooh kuoooh.

I couldn't understand the conversation that was going on at all.

I watched the conversation of the two giant life forms with blank eyes.

What kind of conversation were they having?

No matter how hard I thought about it, I couldn't guess what it was about.

“What are they saying?”

“He says he wants strawberries and ice cream.”

“...”

The one who answered my question was Estasia, who was next to me.

I put down my smartphone on the table and snatched away Estasia's stuffed animal that was talking nonsense.

After that, Estasia struggled for a while to get back her stuffed animal that was taken away from me, but that was irrelevant.

Chapter 187: The Beginning of Heaven and Earth (1)

The Beginning of Heaven and Earth (1)

When one stands alone in a world where there is nothing, they wither away day by day.

That was proven by the reflection of myself in the mirror.

My unkempt hair.

And my rough beard.

As if to testify to the years I lived in ruin, my reflection in the mirror remained pitiful.

The fruits of the past that I had built up after losing everything showed the passage of time clearly.

“Well... I decided to stop turning away from reality.”

I looked at myself reflected in the mirror for a moment, then grabbed a razor in my right hand and lifted it up.

If it were my past self, I would still be wallowing in misery and struggling in the swamp.

But I am different now.

I have faced the lives of many people, and I have made a vow with Estasia.

I could not stay bound by the past forever.

“I can’t help it. It was such a promise.”

I received courage from others to take a step further.

To repay them for that step, I had to become a person worthy of them.

The first thing that had to change was myself.

I decided to start by trimming this rough beard.

Squeak.

I squeezed out some shaving cream and applied it to my beard, then started to erase the traces of time with the razor.

“Hmm...”

This is a story that started from a human’s foolishness.

I didn’t even know what kind of ending my story would have.

I had gone too far to pretend to be good, and my hands were already stained with blood.

My deeds were worthy of being called evil.

Yet I wanted to give a happy ending to the apostles who trusted and followed me.

“...”

It didn’t matter how many or how much more I killed.

I was prepared to kill even a god if necessary.

All my sins and mistakes would be gone if I turned them around.

So there were only two things I wanted.

“Master. Your face has changed.”

“...Is that so.”

“You look like a grandfather.”

To give a happy ending to all the apostles.

And to make Estelle pay for what she did to me.

My life was driven by nothing but that.

It was a step for that alone.

“Have I become a little more presentable now?”

Swish. Thud.

I put down the razor that had scraped off the foam and turned on the water to wash my face.

The cold water touched my rough skin and flowed down.

I felt a bit refreshed after shaving off my messy beard.

I tied my long hair back with a rubber band.

It wasn't a completely neat look, but it was much better than before.

After shaving, I wiped my face and asked Estasia.

“Are you almost ready for the expedition?”

“Yes. I think we'll start soon.”

The order had been preparing for the expedition for a long time.

And today was the day they moved their troops.

I nodded at the news of the expedition and asked her another question.

There was more than one thing I had asked Estasia to do.

“How did the information gathering from Aronia go?”

“Aronia said it would take some time.”

Blink. Blink.

Estasia spoke with a halo shining above her head.

Ever since I learned that the angel’s halo had a communication function, I had asked Estasia for a few favors.

One of them was information gathering through Aronia.

“We need a lot of information to fight Estelle, so don’t forget to tell me every time you come in.”

“Yes.”

Estasia and Aronia were both under the goddess of harmony, so I calculated that they would be somewhat helpful in collecting information.

In fact, communicating through the halo was much more efficient than chatting with a smartphone.

I had already received some information from Aronia.

If you ask me if I can use that information right now, that part would be a bit difficult to answer.

“Especially, collect as much information as possible related to the myths.”

“I told him as you ordered, master.”

“Good job, Estasia.”

I knew less about the gods than Estelle did.

So I had to collect information somehow and narrow the gap.

Information gathering through Aronia would be a preliminary battle for the upcoming fight with Estelle.

Six goddesses. And the evil god Estelle.

There were still many enemies to face.

“Can I eat ice cream?”

“...Just one.”

“I’ll eat two.”

Estasia flew to the refrigerator as soon as she was praised.

I left her alone and sat on the bed with my smartphone on the table.

As Estasia said, the order’s believers were gathered in one place and preparing for the expedition.

Many troops were on the floating island to fight on the ground.

-“Is this the sanctuary of the order...”

-“The power of the great one is endless indeed.”

One unit was composed of those who could borrow my skills through <Divine Response Device>.

Another unit was made up of assassins trained by Daniel, the silent butcher.

And there was a dark knight order created by Evan’s guidance.

Of course, I didn’t know why they were called dark knights.

I heard that Evan named them.

“Really... A lot of time has passed.”

It was incomparable to the past order that started poorly.

I didn't know what was going on then.

Actually, I still don't know how things work now, but it felt more systematic than before because of the scale.

It was a spectacle to see many troops on board a floating island as big as a castle.

Perin, who was on top of the fake divine tree, seemed restless from the pressure of the crowd.

-“Yu, Yuto... What if we sink because it's too heavy?”

-Sniff.

-“Do you mean we should abandon all the people...?”

YYuto and Perin were still having a friendly conversation.

I watched their conversation for a while, then checked the other apostles on Yuto one by one.

Daniel, the silent butcher, was polishing his dagger that had been enhanced by eating the magic sword, and Peter was yawning while leaning on Yggdrasil.

Eutenia was moving her shadows to estimate the number of troops on board.

She was always busy and diligent.

“You're my first apostle. You always make me proud.”

As I looked at Eutenia, I felt a subtle emotion as I remembered the past when I threw away my smartphone.

Did I tell her not to work hard for such a thing?

Even though I knew how she felt about preparing for the war, I said that to her in the past.

She kept running towards me, only looking at me.

“I’m proud too.”

“...Of course you are.”

I moved my gaze from Eutenia and looked at Roan who was left on the ground.

He had no intention of leaving the order after loading most of the troops on Yuto.

Someone had to protect the order that the apostles had left, and Roan was one of the valuable forces, so it was an understandable decision.

Roan, who stayed on the ground, continued to help with the shipment of supplies and the movement of troops.

The work seemed to be nearing its end, as the believers who were working under Yuto were decreasing.

-“Archbishop Roan. Is the work done?”

-“We have prepared enough food, but it would be better to finish it as soon as possible.”

-“We won’t give up the advantage of surprise. We’ll finish it as quickly as possible.”

-“We must secure the heart of the origin... and succeed in bringing down the great one.”

Roan, who was talking to Evan, lowered his hand in the air.

The believers who had finished their roles began to step back.

It was time to launch Yuto.

As the believers who had done their roles stepped back, Eutenia retracted the shadow stairs that had stretched to the ground.

The huge shadow hid its appearance in the darkness and Yuto regained its original shape.

-“Didn’t you have something to say before we leave?”

Evan, who had finished preparing, spoke to Roan below.

Nod.

Roan nodded his head and reached into his chest to pull out a dagger.

The magic sword that devoured magic had become more than a simple weapon; it had become the symbol of the order.

He lifted it high in the sky and swung it several times towards the ground.

-“...”

Crash! Clang!

The believers’ attention was drawn to Roan with the fierce thunder.

Roan opened his mouth to them as he received their attention.

Large and majestic speech bubbles rose above Archbishop Roan’s head in sequence.

-“The great one has commanded us.”

-“The time has come to judge those who have false faith.”

-“Those who lie will be buried in the earth and return to a handful of dust, and those who follow the truth will receive eternal glory in his name.”

Was it true that a dog who went to school for three years could recite a bumper crop?

As if his skill in writing scriptures had not gone anywhere, Roan raised the morale of the believers with his plausible story.

And when all the stories he had prepared came to an end.

He added one last word and declared the start of the war.

-“Begin the holy war.”

Holy war.

Everyone shouted at the heavy word, and Perin moved Yuto to depart from the headquarters of the order.

Yuto, floating in the air, gradually moved away from the order.

It was now the beginning of the final battle with the holy land that had been in conflict for a long time.

And as Yuto and the order m grew farther apart until they were far away.

I looked at the messages that began to appear at the bottom of the screen with a stiff face.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Ascalon] has been released by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Hieroglyph] has been released by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Astra] has been released by one level.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Artifact: Smartphone] has been released by one level.

-Due to <Hero Selection>, [Artifact: Dainsleif] has been released by one level.

The sudden message of <Causality Adjustment>.

But this message was not all that came up.

As if waiting for me to start a war, the most intense messages I had ever seen came up.

-<Karma's Judgment> has approved the connection with <Divine Realm: Asterix>.

-<Divine Realm: Asterix> is temporarily opened.

-The connection with the divine realm has a negative effect on all living beings on the ground.

-The connection with the divine realm greatly amplifies the power of divine power manifested on the ground.

-After the connection with <Divine Realm: Asterix> ends, all entities in all areas except <Holy Land: Crossbridge> will not be affected by <Divine Realm: Asterix>.

I looked at Yuto advancing towards the enemy with troubled eyes.

Chapter 188: The Beginning of Heaven and Earth (2)

The Beginning of Heaven and Earth (2)

To Serena Ederunt, this winter in Crossbridge was unusually cold.

She could see her breath as she stood still, and white snowflakes that looked very cold poured down on the ground.

It was a cold that would make anyone stay inside the temple.

She felt the cold seep into her bones even as she stood in her place.

“Hoo...”

But today, no one could make that choice.

The elders who were hard to see even their faces came out, and there was a huge altar in front of the imperial palace.

It was an altar fit for a ceremony in the name of the emperor.

Many priests stood in front of the altar with their hands clasped.

The crowd gathered in front of the altar looked like they were telling of a great change that would come soon.

“What kind of ceremony is it that the emperor himself comes out?”

“I don’t know. I haven’t heard anything beforehand...”

“It seems that there is still no news from the temple of hunting.”

The priests who didn't know the truth that would happen today murmured in their voices.

Most of them were low-ranking priests who had nothing to do with this ceremony.

Serena watched them and brought her cold hands together and blew her breath into them.

She felt a little better as her frozen hands warmed up by her breath.

If it were the old days, her escort Lian would have given her his coat, but now she was watching the ceremony with nameless escorts.

She didn't know if this winter was so cold because Lian was not by her side.

“The representative of the six goddesses and the holy land, Emperor Highright II, enters.”

“The emperor is coming!”

As Serena warmed her hands with her breath, a voice announced the arrival of the emperor that everyone had been waiting for.

Emperor Highright II.

He was the most noble and respected priest who ruled over the holy land and was recognized by the leaders of the six temples.

Everyone looked up at the altar as he appeared.

Serena also watched him climb up the altar with a trembling body.

“...”

Thud. Thud.

Highpright II walked up the high altar with his own feet.

He moved with restraint that did not match his old age.

When he reached the top of the altar and stood in his place, everyone on the ground bowed their heads to him.

At that moment, the emperor was no different from the spokesperson of the goddesses for the ceremony.

“Listen to me.”

The voice of the emperor on the altar echoed.

Highpright II was different from his usual tone.

There was no respect for the priests in his voice on the altar.

He looked down at the priests who were burning with zeal with a domineering gaze.

His eyes were so fierce and fierce that everyone forgot his age.

“This is...”

That’s why Serena realized his intention quickly.

He had given up many things to stand there.

And he would give up many more things in the future.

What came out of Highpright II’s mouth from now on was a unilateral declaration.

It would be the most grand and magnificent ceremony that he would perform with the authority of the goddess of order.

“Pray. Close your eyes and pray.”

At the emperor's command, the priests at the front knelt down and prayed.

The content of their prayer was as they had been instructed by the imperial palace beforehand.

With those priests under his feet, the emperor held a rod-shaped sacred relic that only he was allowed to use and spoke.

"I will now perform the ceremony to open the gate of heaven."

"What does opening the gate mean..."

"I will begin the ceremony."

Bang!

The emperor's staff slammed down on the altar.

The priest who was about to protest also shut his mouth.

The meaning of opening the gate was not light, but the atmosphere here was even heavier.

The emperor, who silenced everyone, lifted his staff and opened his mouth.

"——Life. Follow the natural order."

The emperor's heavy voice echoed below the altar.

Serena closed her eyes as she heard his voice in her ears.

It was the first time she saw the emperor perform the ceremony himself.

She was too young to discuss the order of the world, and Highpright II had left behind a lot more time than he could compare with.

That's why it was the first time Serena saw the emperor's ceremony.

"——One order. One rule."

She saw a light in front of her closed eyes.

The small light grew bigger with the emperor's voice.

She knew what the light that she could see even with her eyes covered was.

Divine power.

It was the light of hope that connected all the priests and the goddesses' power.

“——Obey before the great providence.”

As his solemn voice rang out, a heavier weight pressed down on her.

A wave of powerful divine power burst out from the center of the altar.

The overwhelming density of divine power that matched the weight of the emperor was conveyed to everyone here.

Serena engraved the prayer in her mind and tried to withstand the pressure of divine power that came to her.

“——One order. One law.”

Arrogant. But great.

The phrase of praise that descended on the ground was very insulting.

But under the logic of the great goddess, it was natural.

The gods were always beings that ruled over the laws of all things.

Under that mercy, humans were living by holding their breath.

“——Obey before the great logic.”

The light spread out.

Beyond the pressure that crushed her body, a warm ray of light wrapped around her.

She felt like she wanted to kneel before the goddess of heaven.

But she somehow endured and resisted it.

She was nothing but a human in front of the huge power that transcended cognition.

“——Everything will live in accordance with the order and the great law.”

Bang. Bang. Bang.

The sound of the emperor’s staff hitting the altar echoed.

Thump. Thump. Thump. Thump.

Serena’s heartbeat also rang out loudly with it.

Everyone recited the prayer under the huge order.

And the last thing that adorned it was the last line that was common to all scriptures.

“——Goddess, guide us.”

“——Goddess, guide us.”

“——Goddess, guide us.”

“——Goddess, guide us.”

“——Goddess, guide us.”

At the moment when the emperor’s voice ended with everyone’s prayer.

Boom—!

Serena's consciousness was awakened by the light that burst out over her eyelids.

A flash of light for a moment covered the holy land, and then Serena lifted her heavy eyelids.

When Serena opened her eyes again after closing them for a while.

All the priests who were in the front had disappeared from their seats, leaving only a mass of light.

A splendid mansion located in the island.

There, Prince Aicliffe raised his head with a tense face.

He would have gone to his office and checked his schedule for the future, but for some reason he felt like he couldn't do that today.

It was because a chilly feeling passed through his spine as he stood in the mansion.

It was too strange to blame it on the cold winter weather.

So Aicliffe had no choice but to raise his head and check the direction where he felt uneasy.

“Ah...”

The sky that was reflected in Aicliffe's raised eyes was different from usual.

What was different was, first of all, its appearance.

It felt like the light around a certain point was distorted.

It was something that could not be explained without magic.

Something was happening in the sky.

Something unknown was causing a change in the island's sky.

“What on earth is going on?”

Aicliffe was well-versed in most of the sciences, thanks to being born as an emperor and receiving education from the palace.

Even to him, the change in the sky that was happening now was hard to understand.

Something was distorting the sky.

Was it a tower located on the island? If not, was it a prank by a malicious archmage?

If not that, did it mean that someone who could cause such distortion existed on the island?

As he watched the sky with all kinds of worries, a strong light burst out from the center of the refracted sky.

“...”

It started with a strong light in the center.

A huge line was drawn in the sky from the point where the light burst out.

The trail of flash made of bright light.

The light that split the huge sky was a sign of the change that would happen.

Aicliffe's trembling voice flowed out of his mouth at the sight of the change in front of him.

“The sky... is torn?”

The trail that split the sky began to crack with a sound.

Creak. Creak. Creak.

Aicliffe's pupils grew bigger along with the growing crack.

It was an unbelievable sight.

A miracle that even an archmage could not do was unfolding in the sky.

The peak of its strangeness was the scenery that shone beyond the crack.

“...”

The opening.

Beyond the torn sky, the realm of God revealed itself.

A heavenly paradise with lush plants.

There, countless angels appeared with their wings spread.

The angels with pure white wings emitted a radiance that would captivate anyone's eyes.

Among them, the angel in the front had wings that were larger than any creature's wings in the world.

The fluttering wings' shadow covered the ground and hid the shining sun.

“Tell the foolish humans.”

“An, angel...!”

The angel who cast a shadow on the ground opened his mouth himself.

A powerful will that stuck in his mind shook Aicliffe's head.

The spreading wings shook his sight dizzyingly.

She looked down at all the humans living on the ground and declared to them with a heavy voice.

“Obey the great order.”

“Those who oppose the order will be punished.”

It was a warning to humanity.

It was a declaration of war to those who abandoned the rules made by God and reached out to the darkness.

Aicliffe’s hand trembled as he looked at the warning angel.

The angel’s eyes were not looking at him, but he felt their gaze on him.

No human could be rude to the messengers of God in front of him.

“Only the right order will be the light that protects your paradise.”

His legs that supported his flesh were trembling too.

He felt like he would collapse on the floor any moment.

The pressure from the messengers of God was incomparable to anyone he had ever faced.

“From now on, we will punish the evil spirits that roam on the ground.”

“Those who have sinned repent, and those who follow the light pray.”

After leaving a brief warning to the humans on the island,

The angel who blocked the sun began to fly somewhere.

Starting with the giant-winged angel who started flying first, many angels followed her.

With the angels moving toward their destination in his sight, Aicliffe slowly raised his trembling hand.

“Huh...!”

The angels stayed here for only a moment.

But Aicliffe felt like it was hours.

Aicliffe moved his shaky hand and touched his neck.

His fingers felt his neck still intact.

On top of Uto heading to the holy land, Pluto sensed a sinister aura and got up.

Something huge and disgusting was coming from afar.

It was divine power of an unbelievable density.

And its destination was none other than the sect they had left behind.

“Perin. Don’t mind me and keep going.”

“Pluto? What’s going on?”

Perin asked with a question at Pluto’s sudden remark.

But Pluto didn’t care and lifted Deathside up.

She thought she was the only one who could stop it here and now.

And others had a mission to carry out the command of a great being.

“You just have to keep going toward your destination. I’ll go stop those unwelcome guests myself.”

So Pluto had only one decision to make.

She took her stance and jumped off Uto.

The powerful barrier that surrounded Uto let Pluto go quietly.

As Pluto fell toward the ground, Perin's voice came to her ears again.

“Pluto...!”

“Let's meet again when this is over.”

Whoosh—!

As she faced the wind that brushed her cheek, Pluto greeted her as she fell.

Chapter 189: The Beginning of Heaven and Earth (3)

Chapter 189: The Beginning of Heaven and Earth (3)

Centurias Region.

The Order's Headquarters.

Pluto, who had landed in the middle of the Order, looked at the angels who were approaching from afar.

They were countless angels who were flying to attack the Order.

Their number was so immense that it was impossible to estimate with the eye or the hand.

A staggering number of angels were flying towards the Order with their sights set.

The angel who led the front flapped his huge pure white wings and shouted in a loud voice.

-“Punish the ones who disturb the order!”

Crackle. Sparkle.

A white flash of light emanated from the angel's hand.

The flash that the angel unleashed exploded with a blast and flew towards the Order.

Boom!

With a loud noise, the upper part of the warehouse flew away and was reflected in Pluto's sight.

A thick smoke spewed out, and numerous fragments scattered and poured onto the ground.

The Order's believers who remained under the collapsing debris screamed.

“Kyaaak!”

“O, O great one! Please protect us!”

The screams of the believers echoed all around.

Leaving them behind, Pluto looked at the Deathscythe in her hand.

The Deathscythe that had a blue haze was now gripped in her hand.

With a faint sigh, Pluto glared at the enemies in front of her.

What she saw in her sight were undoubtedly angels.

“...”

The messengers of God.

They were the ones who wrapped themselves in a nauseating divine power and tried to invade this place where she stood.

Even though they were not enemies that remained in Pluto's memory, for some reason, intense emotions boiled in her chest.

She did not know what those emotions that tickled her heart were.

But she vaguely understood that they were traces of what she had lost so far.

-“Annihilate the humans who have fallen into evil!”

Following the angel who gave the order at the front, the voices of countless angels rang in Pluto’s ears.

The windows of light flew in and stabbed into the buildings of the Order one by one.

Pluto swung her Deathscythe to fend them off, but there were too many angels for her to block completely.

Bang! Bang!

Screams and explosions resounded everywhere.

In the dizzying haze, a desperate cry for help shook Pluto’s ears.

“Master! Please save us!”

“O great one!”

Sharp voices that tore my ears.

Among them, I recalled my name.

Pluto Astraia.

Long ago, I engraved that name in my heart, one letter at a time, as countless people cried out for me.

I drew in my mind the past self who was satisfied with hearing the name that praised me.

“...”

Someone called my name a great one.

Another one called it a cursed name.

Either way, it was a name that showed how great Pluto Astraia was.

I lived through many eras and led many people.

Even though I don't remember anything now, there were many documents that recorded how amazing the progenitor of vampires was.

“...Angels.”

And there were common descriptions in those documents.

The vampires who followed me were slaughtered by the angels who descended from heaven and the human forces who followed God.

And even Pluto, who lost the war, was sealed by a stake that suppressed her life.

The heavenly gods always hated me and my bloodline.

It was the same even now.

I don't know why they hate vampires forever.

The reason would not remain in the memories that disappeared in time.

“You really...”

Maybe it was because I was a cursed life that was not allowed to die.

Maybe it was because my clan was too strong unlike the weak races.

Or maybe——.

“Always the same...”

I erased the countless thoughts that came to my mind.

The reason was not important.

They always claimed to follow God's will.

The priests who drove stakes into the hearts of vampires always acted on behalf of the God they served.

“They are trying to destroy what I love.”

Vampires always earned the hatred of the gods.

Those who could not look up at the sun directly, they suffered from the curse of the gods and spent the night curled up.

And in the end, their lives were taken away by God's minions.

She, who was born as a loner, became a loner again after many times had passed.

Now they were trying to destroy another home that was given to her.

“I still don't know why——.”

I couldn't tolerate it.

I couldn't let them have their way anymore.

So, Pluto Astraia decided to reveal her fangs.

She decided to show herself fully to the world, instead of hiding herself from the eyes of others.

At this moment, it was her mission from her master to protect those who were here.

-“How much do you want to take away?”

She stabbed her nails into her chest, leaving her Deathscythe on the ground.

Swoosh.

A drop of blood fell to the ground with a creepy sound.

Thud. Thump.

The falling blood drop reflected the image of the progenitor who put her hand into her heart.

She looked sad in the red blood drop.

Even though she had no memories of losing something completely in her head, she looked sad for some reason.

-“Don’t ruin what I love.”

The blue earth was covered with blood.

The red blood that spread on the ground scattered around and started to create a carpet of blood that suited the great progenitor.

A red crown of thorns settled on her head, and a strange howl like a beast roaring echoed everywhere.

In the crimson world, red wings sprouted on Pluto’s shoulders.

She revealed her lordly face to the world that she didn’t want anyone to see.

-“Bow to the great Astraia.”

-“Bow to the great Astraia.”

-“Bow to the great Astraia.”

-“Bow to the great Astraia.”

Her people, who had disappeared in a single line in the long history, shouted the name of their king.

The screams that came out of the red blood were the history that she had lost long ago.

They had lost their flesh and their souls, and until the end, they called out the name of their king and waited for her return.

Hearing the voices calling for her, Pluto stepped on the red carpet and moved forward.

-“Bow to the great Astraia.”

It was the same in the past and now.

Someone called out her name and waited for her to step up.

Someone turned to ashes in front of her eyes, and another one bled and screamed in front of her.

She was Pluto Astraia then and now.

Pluto Astraia, the noble and great one that everyone on the continent feared.

-“She’s the progenitor of vampires! Take her down first!”

The angel who saw Pluto coming forward shouted.

It was a loud voice.

Pluto looked at the angel who spoke with her eyes filled with bloodlust.

They dared to look down on her from heaven, without knowing their own place.

-“I won’t let you do that.”

The world that was reflected in her burning eyes was disgusting.

It was ugly, vile, and nauseating, and she wanted to destroy everything without leaving anything behind.

In that world, Pluto Astraia spread her wings of blood.

The progenitor who did not tolerate anyone looking down on her, gave up her nobility and soared to the sky.

“Kwaaak——!”

And then, she tore the neck of her prey like a blood-soaked beast.

Crunch.

The thin life was cut off.

In front of the predator who did not know death, life was very insignificant.

The Hero of Harmony, Naias, opened her eyes in the midst of a deafening explosion.

As she got up from the bed, still half-asleep, the first thing she saw was a burning building.

The ceiling that had blocked the rain was torn away, revealing a desolate sky. And in the darkened sky, a storm was raging.

Crash!

A lightning bolt fell from the sky and shot down something unknown in heaps.

In the chaotic situation, Naias smelled the blood that stung her nose.

“...Ah.”

She threw off the blanket and got out of bed, walking on her own legs.

She felt a strange distortion in her sight, as if her dreams and reality were mixed for a long time.

Was it a dream? Or was it real?

She was wrapped in a drowsy haze that blurred the boundary.

“You look sleepy.”

In the faint border, someone’s voice whispered in her ear.

Naias shook her head to shake off the drowsiness that weighed on her mind.

But the fatigue that enveloped her did not go away easily.

As she felt another wave of sleepiness, Naias rubbed her eyes and opened her mouth.

“I guess I’m still dreaming.”

The dragon’s sleep was longer and darker than that of humans.

They were born with a long lifespan, but they had to spend it in a boring sleep.

Although Naias had gained spirituality, she could not escape from the influence of the artifact that disturbed her sleep cycle.

Just as she was about to fall asleep again, thinking everything was a dream.

Someone’s voice woke her up from her haze.

“It’s not a dream.”

“...”

“What you see is not a dream at all.”

Naias moved her head towards the direction where the voice came from.

She saw a black-haired girl holding an umbrella in her sight as she turned her head.

The girl smiled brightly and looked at Naias.

Naias asked the girl in front of her.

“Who are you?”

“Well. It’s a bit difficult to tell you my name.”

She was a strange woman.

Her atmosphere and her playful tone were both odd.

And the place where she was now was also an absurd place.

That’s why Naias wanted to ignore what the girl said.

“...I don’t have time to play along with your joke.”

“Hmm... Do you think I’m joking right now?”

“If you’re not joking, then reveal your identity.”

Even though she was abandoned by the holy land, she was still a hero chosen by the goddess of harmony.

She was not someone to be ignored by a mere human.

As Naias took a firm stance and waited for the girl’s answer, the girl stepped forward with a smile on her face.

Click. Clack.

The sound of her shoes echoed in the mysterious space.

“Do you really want to hear it? You might regret it.”

“I don’t care. Whatever your identity is, you won’t be a threat to me.”

“You’re quite confident, aren’t you?”

The girl with a relaxed look came closer to Naias.

The distance between them was gradually shrinking, but Naias did not bother to stop her.

The dragon race boasted a toughness that could not be pierced by any ordinary attack.

That was why the hero of hunting decided to waste time when he came to find her.

“...Are you insulting me right now?”

“I don’t like children who can’t recognize their master.”

“You, who are you...!”

Suddenly, the girl who came close to her touched Naias’s forehead with her finger.

Thud.

Naias’s consciousness was cut off with a sensation that shook her head.

After that, what Naias faced was a dark swamp that had no end.

-<The Heavenly Voice of Karma> converts the activity of [Reverse Dragon: Naias] into your causality rate.

Chapter 190: The Beginning of Heaven and Earth (4)

Chapter 190: The Beginning of Heaven and Earth (4)

-I used <Tempest>.

-My karma increased by 1.

-My karma increased by 1.

-My karma increased by 1.

Beyond the smartphone where a fierce battle was raging, I watched the characters on the screen with clenched lips.

As soon as the angels who came to the cult launched their attack,

I realized that the enemies had ambushed us while the cult was empty, and I tried to intervene in the game and stop their invasion.

Even though most of them had left for the battle, there were still many believers in the cult.

I couldn't lose all the members of the cult here, including Roan.

-“Don't be afraid! The Great One is with us!”

-“——Lightning Storm!”

Of course, I wasn't the only one who joined the battle.

Roan, who shared my magic through <Divine Response Device>, was fighting at the front line and performing miracles.

[Dark Beast: Beta], who had been Roan's long-time companion, also showed his struggle to barely fend off the enemies on the battlefield.

Beta had shown an incredible power against the soldiers, but he had his limits against the angels.

Most of the flying angels were out of Beta's attack range.

“.....Pluto.”

And in the midst of such a battlefield, there was a character who shone more than anyone else.

The Third Apostle, Pluto Astraia.

She had changed into a never-before-seen appearance and was fighting against the angels in the sky.

Pluto, who wore a red crown on her head, let out a rough breath every time she exhaled.

-“Don't ruin what I like.”

It was a splendid sight that suited her name as a progenitor.

Anyone who faced her would be impressed by her beauty and charisma.

Unless they only looked at the grotesque shapes on the floor.

-“No one... will touch what's mine.”

She was showing an incredible achievement that matched her appearance.

Every time Pluto swung her arm, spikes of blood pierced through the angels.

Even the angels who moved quickly to avoid the spikes were caught in Pluto's bloody wings and had their necks snapped.

As she repeated the same words and slaughtered the angels, some of them flinched and backed away.

“Is this the progenitor of vampires?”

I saw Pluto in a way I had never seen before.

Yet, she shone brighter than ever in front of me.

She flew around the battlefield with a desperate face, eliminating the enemies she saw one by one.

One. And another one.

There were countless numbers of angels lined up in the sky, but Pluto never gave up and erased them one by one.

“The apostle is doing so well, there's no way the author who calls himself God is losing.”

I felt a bit moved by Pluto's actions.

Click.

I raised my finger and touched the skill icon, then shot one skill after another at the enemies on the battlefield.

As my finger drew in the air, countless numbers of enemies disappeared.

The feeling of countless lives disappearing at my finger was not something that touched my heart directly, unfortunately.

-I used <Lightning Storm>.

-My karma increased by 1.

-My karma increased by 1.

With a loud noise, the angels fell to the ground.

The angels that collided with the ground turned into ashes and scattered, and the angels that hid their appearance were converted into karma.

In the midst of flames and light, where they killed each other,

I felt something strange when a lot of time had passed since the battle started.

-<Karma's Voice> converts [Reverse Dragon: Naias]'s activity into your causality rate.

Suddenly, a new message popped up at the bottom of my smartphone, and a huge body was revealed as one of the buildings of the cult collapsed.

Crash!

The huge dragon that tore apart the wooden wall showed itself.

The dragon wrapped in darkness flashed its red eyes and glared at the angels.

I couldn't help but be surprised by the dragon that suddenly appeared on the battlefield.

“Reverse Dragon...?”

The characters that belonged to <Karma's Voice> all had one thing in common: they were my subordinates.

The apostle Pluto.

The dark beast Alpha.

The king of the undead Arcrosis.

They were all beings that belonged to me through the game system.

And now, there was someone who belonged to me unintentionally in front of my eyes.

[Reverse Dragon: Naias].

It was the first time I saw the shape of a dragon wrapped in darkness.

“Could it be... Estelle’s doing?”

That was the only thing I could doubt about Naias’s appearance.

Estelle’s intervention.

If she wanted the apostles to turn the holy land upside down, it wouldn’t be strange if she did something to help me.

For example, forcing unwanted support on me.

- ○ “■■■■■■■■! ■■■■■■■■■!”

As if to prove it, the dark dragon spat out incomprehensible words and moved toward the angels.

Kwaaaaa——!

A jet of black light from the dragon’s mouth swept away the angels in the sky.

He didn’t seem to be in a rational state, but his strength against the angels was not something to laugh at.

I tried to guess Estelle’s purpose as I watched Naias fight against the angels.

“Why did she intervene? To prevent the cult from collapsing?”

My power would only weaken if the cult’s headquarters collapsed.

Estelle wouldn't welcome that situation either.

So it was possible that she supported me in this way.

“Or is it to trigger causality adjustment?”

But there was always a backlash to extreme support.

<Karma's Voice> always gave a fair price for the movements in the game.

If Estelle used her power to give me more strength, she would have to pay for it herself.

The fact that my smartphone's power had grown stronger meant that something had changed for me.

I frowned as I felt something unpleasant digging into my head as [Artifact: Smartphone] grew rapidly.

“Did they both aim for this?”

—This is all for creating a new god.

I felt like I could understand Estelle's words a little bit now.

Crossbridge, the Temple of Harmony.

There, Paladin Oren looked at the Saintess of Harmony with a troubled eye.

The Saintess of Harmony in Oren's sight had her eyelids tightly closed.

She was Laiteria, who had lived without her eyes since birth.

It was not strange that Laiteria closed her eyelids even without praying.

“Laiteria.”

“Yes.”

But because of that, Oren was in a situation where he had to doubt the saintess in front of him.

It had been a long time since Highpride II ordered the imprisonment of Laiteria, the Saintess of Harmony.

And during that time, Oren, the blue holy sword, had faithfully performed his duty.

While under Oren’s watch, Laiteria had never shown any suspicious behavior.

Except for what happened yesterday.

“I don’t want to doubt you.”

“Why? Did I do something suspicious?”

Looking at Laiteria who asked calmly with her eyes closed, Oren sighed deeply with mixed emotions.

Yesterday afternoon, Oren had lost sight of the Saintess of Harmony for a moment.

And after that, Laiteria didn’t show up in Oren’s sight for a long time.

She showed herself after some more time passed, but she tried to pass it off as a simple prank.

He couldn’t ask for more details at the time because of his confused mind, but it was not something to be dismissed as a simple prank.

“Do you remember what happened yesterday?”

So Oren decided to ask Laiteria directly.

When Oren asked her about what happened yesterday, Laiteria gave him a playful smile.

It was an expression that didn't match her innocent face.

“Are you still holding on to the prank I did yesterday?”

“I don't think it's possible for a saintess who can't see to do such a cruel prank. Did you get a miracle that made you see?”

“If I got such a miracle, I would have told you first.”

“Would you tell me instead of the hero of harmony?”

Oren belonged to the holy land, but he was not part of the Temple of Harmony.

He didn't think Laiteria would have any favor for him who was watching her.

As Oren looked at her and spoke, Laiteria moved her legs and answered him while sitting on a chair.

“I would like to tell Naias first if possible. But you guys have him captured, don't you?”

“She betrayed the holy land. Of course, so did you.”

“I didn't betray.”

Laiteria lowered her head and denied his words.

“Then why did you help the cult?”

“Because it's God's will. You know what's most important for us clerics, don't you?”

Laiteria had only one reason for her betrayal.

Faith.

In front of the great revelation that only the saintess could receive, it was meaningless for a mere paladin to argue.

So Oren brought up a more essential question.

“Did God betray the holy land?”

It would have been blasphemy to say it out loud normally.

But Oren had some kind of certainty about Laiteria and spoke his mind without hesitation.

Laiteria answered him with a still playful voice after hearing his words.

“That’s a remark that deserves a trial for blasphemy. Do you think a mere human can judge God’s will?”

“If not, how can you explain the betrayal of the hero and the saintess?”

“Oren. If you keep crossing the line, you’ll be in trouble.”

“The one who is doing something dangerous is not me.”

Thump.

Oren approached the saintess and grabbed his holy sword at his waist as he spoke.

Was it because they kept talking about God?

Laiteria couldn’t stay still anymore, and she warned him with a serious face.

“Oren, I warned you. Don’t insult God anymore...”

“You are abandoning humanity.”

“Oren? What are you talking about?”

“Saintess Laiteria. Who was inside you that day?”

Oren glared at Laiteria’s closed eyelids.

He felt like he could see the pupils stained black behind her eyelids.

The dark and deep black eyes that were staring at him even though they couldn’t see.

“Why did you abandon humanity?”

Chapter 191: Allemier (1)

Chapter 191: Allemier (1)

Under the dark clouds that covered the sky,

Revelz Etherunt, the knight commander, looked down from the wall where the soldiers of the holy land were lined up.

The land that reflected in Revelz' eyes was strangely quiet.

On a normal day, he would have heard the cries of beasts, but today, even that was silent.

It was as if someone had cleared out all the animals around them.

'I don't like this feeling.'

Revelz stroked the black holy sword that hung on his waist, pondering.

He had a better intuition than the other knights in the holy land.

That aspect of Revelz had helped him several times on the battlefields he had crossed.

He could roughly guess the possibility of an enemy ambush or the advantage or disadvantage of a situation.

'In this situation... The only ones who would come are those bastards from the cult.'

And his intuition was screaming at him this time.

It was not long ago that they opened the gate of heaven and summoned angels.

It was practically a declaration of war.

That meant it was not surprising if the cult attacked them right now.

Revelz gripped the hilt of his holy sword and ordered the soldiers on the wall.

“Everyone, prepare for battle.”

“Prepare for battle!”

Clang.

As soon as Revelz finished speaking, the soldiers grabbed their weapons and took their positions.

The knights also drew their swords and watched the land below the wall.

Starting with the knight at the front, the prayers of the knights echoed in sequence.

“O Goddess, guide me on the right path.”

“O Goddess, please...”

“Please, guide me on the right path.”

Revelz listened to the prayers of the knights as he looked at the forest in front of the wall.

He could see a faint smoke rising from a distant place.

The smoke from the forest confirmed his intuition.

Revelz quickly drew his black sword.

Swoosh.

With a sharp metallic sound, the dark blade absorbed the light around it.

“It’s an attack. Ring the bell.”

As soon as Revelz opened his mouth, a soldier on the tower rang the bell with all his might.

Ding—. Ding—. Ding—.

The heavy bell sound echoed and a frantic voice came out of the soldier’s mouth.

“It’s an attack! The enemy is invading!”

“It’s an attack!”

The bell sound from the tower spread throughout the city, announcing that the war with the cult of the evil god had begun.

As if responding to the majestic bell sound, the enemy army that had been stirring up dust from afar also revealed themselves.

Revelz was momentarily puzzled by the sight of the approaching enemy army.

The identity of the enemy that came from the forest was quite different from his expectation.

“They’re not the cult’s fanatics.”

The identity of the enemy that broke through the forest and ran towards the gate.

They were countless beasts that were running with madness in their eyes.

Deer. Rabbits. Horses. Wolves.

The beasts that lived in the forest were mixed together regardless of their species and ran towards the gate.

Despite being mixed with predators and prey, the horde of beasts was moving in perfect harmony.

“Beasts are running wild...”

“It seems that the evil god’s minions have done something!”

The knights who watched the scene exclaimed in horror.

Revelz agreed with them.

Numerous beasts were rushing towards the gate.

Only an evil god could create such a spectacle.

“Captain. How should we respond?”

It was obvious that it was a bait sent by the evil god.

But they were too many to ignore.

If they left them alone, they might eventually break through the city’s gate.”

Revelz was about to give an order to his subordinates who were waiting for his instructions.

“We can’t afford to lose soldiers over mere beasts. Shoot them with arrows from the wall...”

“The sky is black! The black sky is here!”

“Did you say the black sky?”

But his words were cut off.

One of the soldiers who was looking at the sky pointed at it with his finger and shouted in a loud voice.

Everyone on the wall followed the soldier's scream and looked up at the sky.

A huge shadow was cast over the already gloomy sky.

As the sun began to be swallowed by the darkness, everyone there remembered the disaster they had faced before.

"The evil god's... black sky..."

The black sky.

The evil god's power was taking away the sun's blessing and spreading darkness over the world.

Under the black sky, plants could not grow properly and those who were unprepared could not even see in front of them.

The people on the wall became tense at the sight of the darkened sky in an instant.

"It seems that the cultists are going all out from the start."

In the darkness where the sun had completely hidden its face, only the torches hanging on the wall brightened their vision.

But even the vision illuminated by the torches was not enough to shoot arrows.

The archers on the wall were all rendered powerless by the evil god's power that covered the sky.

It was certain that the cult had sharpened their blades to destroy the city.

And unfortunately for them, the enemy that came to the wall was not just a horde of beasts.

– “Revere.”

Underneath the black curtain that descended on the ground.

Someone’s voice echoed in the soldiers’ ears.

Revelz felt a tingling sensation in his nerves at the voice of someone he had never heard before.

The voice that echoed in the darkness was filled with immense magic.

– “Worship.”

Crackle. Sparkle.

Every time someone’s voice echoed, black lightning burst out of the darkness that filled the sky.

The black light that illuminated the darkness was a paradoxical sight.

And under that paradoxical sight, the bodies of the soldiers who looked up at the sky slowly stiffened.

– “Obey.”

Boom!

The black world flashed and dropped a bolt of lightning.

All eyes on the wall turned to where the lightning fell.

On top of the tower where the rope holding the bell was torn off.

There, an apostle wrapped in black lightning spread thunder around him.

“——The great one is watching you.”

The apostle of the evil god landed on the ground and folded his wings of lightning as he opened his mouth.

His eyes glowed red.

And his gauntlet sparked repeatedly.

The soldiers who were exposed to the power of lightning fell to the ground in front of the apostle of the evil god who scattered thunder.

Revelz lifted his black sword at the sight of the fallen soldiers.

‘As expected, the beasts at the gate were just a bait.’

Revelz, who was granted the black sword, had only one thing to do as always.

The extermination of the invaders who entered the holy land.

That was the mission given to the last guardian of Crossbridge.

He aimed his black sword at the apostle he saw in front of him.

“Enemy of the six goddesses. Reveal your name.”

With his black sword emitting aura in front of him, the apostle looked at him calmly.

He did not look down on Revelz or show any leisure.

He was just a similar kind to Revelz.

Crackle.

A black spark flew from the apostle’s gauntlet as he stared at Revelz.

“Second Apostle, Evan Allemier.”

The second apostle of the cult. Evan Allemier.

The apostle of the evil god who finished his brief introduction rose from his seat.

* * * * *

The hero of knowledge, Hus Allemier, looked at the sky that was darkened.

Until a moment ago, it was a sky covered with dark clouds, but now only thick darkness replaced it.

The meaning of the disappeared sun was only one thing.

The evil god's power covered the sky and created a black sky.

"A black sky..."

He could not see the sun anymore even if he looked up.

For a while, the sun's light would not be granted to the people on the ground.

Instead, a beam of light filled with enormous magic flew out from beyond the darkness that covered the sky.

Boom—!

The beam of light with a tremendous heat collided with the barrier that covered the holy land.

"It's finally time."

Creak. Crack.

As he looked at the holy land's barrier that began to crack slightly, Hus picked up the hieroglyph he had put down next to him.

The evil god's army began to move seriously to target the holy land.

The apostles who followed the evil god also came here to act on behalf of the evil god's will.

It also meant that he would soon have a meeting with Evan Allemier, whom he had longed for so much.

“Evan Allemier.”

The second apostle, Evan Allemier.

His brother’s name, which he had called out many times, felt awkward in Hus’s mouth.

The name of the noble knight he had always admired now sounded evil and gloomy.

The sturdy back that he had once followed was no longer in front of him.

Now he had to face his lost brother head-on.

He had to face not the blood who had protected and moved forward with him, but the enemy who blocked and must be overcome.

“Evan... Allemier.”

Once again, his blood’s name lingered on his lips.

Bright flames always cast shadows.

Evan Allemier was the shadow of the hero he had become.

Yet Hus wanted to be the brilliant light that would erase even that shadow.

He had to be the one to finish off the apostle of the evil god.

He had to end everything with his own hands, not anyone else’s.

“I’ve missed you for so long.”

That was the only destiny given to the hero.

Hus smiled bitterly and opened the hieroglyph.

Swoosh.

The hero's device bestowed by the god of knowledge turned pages and created a huge light source by its own will in front of Hus.

The sphere of light floating in the air shone brightly on Hus even under the black sky.

The magic that created light was the only guide that would lead Hus in this darkness.

“——Hieroglyph.”

Under the light source that illuminated his vision, the hieroglyph quickly turned to a page engraved with teleportation magic.

It was the magic of Arein Crost, who was called the strongest mage, captured by the power of the device.

Hus had learned many magics under Arein Crost.

Now he was confident that he could defeat Evan even if he was his opponent.

It was time to prove the power he had accumulated over time.

“——Teleport.”

Hus muttered the name of the transfer magic, longing for a reunion with his blood.

Under the blue light that wrapped his whole body, Hus silently prayed to the sky.

Hus Allemier's prayer to the sky was always the same.

—O Goddess, guide me on the right path.

Chapter 192: Allemier (2)

Chapter 192: Allemier (2)

Humanity has always revered someone transcendent.

They prayed to the gods for what they could not achieve with their own power, and longed for the gods' help for what they could not reach with their own hands.

Faith was the pillar that supported people.

It was also the last line of defense that strengthened the weak human heart.

Most people cried out the names of the gods in desperate moments, and sought the help of miracles.

“.....”

Then what are the gods?

What does the world call and cry out as gods?

Why do humans fear what they call evil gods, and worship what they call good gods?

What criteria determine the line of right reason, and label what is on the opposite side as evil?

“■■.....”

It was not an easy story to conclude.

Countless people had their own faiths, and countless faiths claimed their own truths.

I did not know what could be called the most valuable belief.

I could not even properly know who was allowed to tie the knot.

But there was something clearly left that I could understand with my shallow insight.

“Ma... ster.....”

There are people somewhere in the world who cry out my name.

There are those who try to move forward even if they break and fall into the abyss.

Many people live day by day relying on their faith in me.

I do not know if I have the right to bear such faith.

Yet only by repaying their faith, I was given——.

“Master!”

Thud.

I woke up from the thoughts that weighed on my mind at Estasia’s voice.

I gasped for breath and looked around, only to see the darkened sky reflected in the window.

The scenery outside the divine realm was false, but the concept of time was not much different from the outside.

“.....Estasia. How much time has passed?”

I moved my parched throat and opened my mouth toward Estasia.

A weak voice flowed from my cracked throat.

When I asked Estasia about the current time, she pointed at the window with her hand and said.

“Three days have passed.”

“Already three days?”

I rubbed my head that felt like it was going to break and recalled what had happened so far.

As the power of [Device: Smartphone] was released by one level due to causality adjustment, I was able to access <Karma’s Heavenly Voice> for a moment.

And I was swept away by the waves of information and thoughts in there for a while.

I managed to find a clue in the end, but the time I felt was not that long.

The time gap was bigger than I thought.

“Yes.”

“Pluto... Then what happened to Pluto?”

The last situation I faced came back to my mind.

Pluto in my memory was clearly fighting against the angels who approached the ground.

If nearly three days had passed since then, the battle must have reached some conclusion.

I had to check Pluto’s condition right away.

I quickly found my smartphone and looked at Pluto’s appearance on the screen.

— “.....”

Pluto on the smartphone screen was dozing off.

He leaned on a black dragon as a pillow, and there were many feathers flying around him.

Around Pluto, there were also believers who were repairing the collapsed buildings of the cult.

It seemed that he somehow defended against the angels' attack.

His body was covered with thick blood, showing the intensity of the battle.

“Master closed his eyes and fought with the black dragon for a long time.”

“What happened to the angels?”

“They all retreated as if something went wrong.”

“.....That's a relief.”

Pluto's own power was formidable, and the sudden appearance of Naias also helped him to some extent.

I was relieved that the cult's believers did not suffer a complete annihilation.

I sighed with relief and looked at Pluto soaked in blood.

He seemed to be in a deep sleep, as if he was exhausted from the battle.

“I guess it's hard to send him to battle right now.”

It was a fight with an overwhelming difference in numbers.

If it wasn't Pluto who stayed here, but another apostle, I couldn't be sure if he could have done this much.

He had fought too hard, so he needed some time to recover here.

For a while, it was safe to say that Pluto was out of power.

The battle in the holy land was entirely up to the other apostles.

“And I got a message from Aronia.”

As I watched Pluto sleeping soundly, Estasia blinked her halo and said.

It was a message about the information gathering that I had asked Aronia earlier.

I put down the smartphone in my hand and turned my eyes to Estasia.

Pluto’s fight to protect the cult was important, but the information collected by Aronia was also very important.

“What did he say?”

“He found some information about the Temple of Harmony.”

The fight here was entirely up to me, just like the fight in the holy land was up to the other apostles.

I had no one else to rely on like a god.

* * * * *

“.....How terrible.”

The second apostle of the cult, Evan Allemier, opened his mouth as he watched the knights rising from their seats.

He had paralyzed them several times with his lightning, but he failed to completely cut off their breaths because of the interference of Revelz, the knight commander.

The black sword, Revelz Ederunt.

He was as strong as his reputation that he had heard since Evan was a knight.

He had the skill that matched his nickname, the Sword of Crossbridge.

“——O Goddess, guide me on the right path.”

More troublesome than Revelz’s attack was Revelz’s holy power that healed the knights who fell by Evan’s attack.

The knights who were exposed to Astraphe’s lightning were incapacitated, but they soon returned to the front line after receiving treatment from Revelz.

And if there was even one intact knight left, he would immediately heal other knights.

He had to sweep away the enemies at once if possible.

“Do you believe in the path that the goddess guides you?”

Clang.

Evan held his magic sword that his master had bestowed upon him and asked.

Beyond his magic sword that flashed with black lightning, he saw Revelz’s face with an unpleasant expression.

Revelz seemed to dislike Evan’s question and retorted with an angry voice.

“.....What do you know, you traitor of humanity and servant of the evil god.”

“Well. The path that the goddess guided me to is here.”

Evan tilted his magic sword with a smile.

Crackle. Crackle.

The black light grew from his lightning magic sword in his hand.

The magic sword's ability to amplify the power of lightning was not something to be taken lightly.

The power of the lightning that Evan shot with all his strength increased by half compared to before.

As he aimed his sword wrapped in lightning at the enemies in front of him, Revelz twitched his eyebrows and asked him.

“What are you trying to say?”

“Even if I prayed with everything I had, the reality I faced was all there was.”

“You arrogant bastard. It was your choice to abandon the right path.”

Revelz also held his black holy sword and took a stance, preparing to counter Evan's lightning.

The sharp black holy sword absorbed the light under the darkness.

Evan thought that it was a weapon that did not suit the name of a holy sword.

Revelz's black holy sword was a very different weapon from other holy swords.

“Even a light answer did not reach me when I condemned it.”

“It's because your faith in the goddess was lacking. The goddess always gives a proper answer to those who have pure faith.”

He denied all the faith he had built up himself.

Evan's eyes soaked in emptiness looked at Revelz's holy sword.

Some people in the world are chosen directly by the goddess and live a glorious life as heroes.

On the other hand, some others are abandoned by the goddess and resist endless trials until they break and snap.

And the goddess of honor he believed in chose not Evan himself, but a farmer from a rural village.

“Are you saying that my faith was less than Peter’s?”

It was a ridiculous story no matter how he thought about it.

Peter, who was doubtful whether he had prayed properly, was more pure than the knight who had devoted everything to the goddess.

He did not want to resent Peter now.

Nor did he want to agree with the story that denied his past.

“The goddess knows everything.”

“.....Yes. Hearing that from someone who reached the peak of knighthood, I feel like my mind is a little clearer.”

He was someone Evan admired once.

He was still guarding the gate of the holy land as he did in those days Evan admired.

The one who changed was Evan himself.

Evan was no longer a knight who blindly followed the goddess’s guidance.

Crackle.

As the condensed lightning emitted black light, Evan spoke to Revelz in front of him.

“Did I say that I broke because of my lack of faith?”

“It’s nothing but a fool’s step.”

“Then let me say it again.”

There was only one thing that Evan Allemier here had to do.

To cut off the admiration he had built up since childhood with his own hands.

Red sparks flew from Evan’s determined eyes.

Evan swung his magic sword with all his might with his eyes shining brightly.

“I am Evan Allemier, the second apostle.”

The black storm of lightning burst out and covered their sight.

Kwagwagwagwang!

The fierce storm of lightning stretched out toward Revelz and the knights.

Darkness covered the sky once, and then light tore through space.

Revelz also swung his sword to defend against the sharp trajectory that rushed toward him.

“——Light!”

Zap. Zzzzap.

Revelz’s holy sword began to refract space and moved to block Evan’s attack.

The black sword that flowed smoothly without unnecessary movements was sucked into the center of the storm in an instant.

As Revelz's holy sword swung to collide with Evan's magic sword.

Evan swiftly twisted his trajectory as he felt a powerful energy from the side.

“.....!”

A little away from where their swords were about to clash.

There, a massive magic was gathering.

Light and heat. And the immense pressure from the compressed air.

It was a strike that could be fatal if he allowed it in an unprotected state.

‘I'll be in trouble if I let this attack hit me.’

Evan swung his storm of lightning with his desperate hand at the unknown magic.

Crackle.

The lightning burst along the forced curve.

Evan's magic sword moved to block the fire magic that flew toward him.

A blazing flame rose from where the magic appeared and covered the whole space with scorching heat.

“——Fire Storm.”

“Hus Allemier.....!”

Right after the voice of the magic chant and Revelz's shout echoed.

The storm of lightning and the storm of fire collided in the air.

Evan's body was pushed back as he twisted his center in the overlapping storm.

Kwaaaaang——!

Evan's body lost its balance and bounced off the wall.

His sight shook in the air as he held his magic sword.

“Kugh.....!”

It was a difficult situation to respond properly to the strike that came during the collision with Revelz.

Even Evan, who barely dodged the heat, could not ignore the force that pushed him away.

As he was pushed back by the shock wave, Evan pulled up his magic in his hand with a gauntlet.

He tried to stop his body before he got too far from the wall.

“——Astraphe!”

Crackle.

The wings of lightning spread out and offset most of the force that pushed Evan away.

Evan stabbed his magic sword into the ground to withstand the remaining force.

Kagagagak!

The ground where he stabbed his sword was scarred and Evan's body stopped.

“Hah.....”

He was able to stand still a little further from where he spread his wings.

A rough breath burst out of Evan's mouth as he stabbed his sword into the ground.

The sudden magic that he did not detect was more powerful than he expected.

And there were only two people in Crossbridge who could do such a level of attack.

"I missed you. The second apostle, Evan Allemier."

"You are....."

Hero. Or someone equivalent to that.

One of them was Arein Crost, an unrivaled genius.

And the other one was——.

"Let me introduce myself for the first time. The hero of knowledge, Hus Allemier."

Evan Allemier's only brother.

Hus Allemier.

He was standing in front of Evan with his magic.

Chapter 193: Allemier (3)

Chapter 193: Allemier (3)

“...Hus.”

Evan called out Hus’s name as he got up from his seat.

The hero of knowledge. And the second son of the Allemir family.

His younger brother, who had followed him since childhood, was now standing in a different position.

Evan was looking at him with a hostile gaze, standing in the place that he had longed for so much.

“Evan Allemir. I will judge you according to the will of the goddess.”

It was a terrible fate.

A tragic destiny that forced them to point their weapons at each other.

It was a fate that could not be called anything but a joke of the gods.

Yet they did not hesitate to point their weapons at each other.

Because they had already made up their minds long ago.

“The will of the goddess... You have become a devout believer, haven’t you?”

“I don’t think that’s something a fallen paladin should say.”

Clang.

Evan grabbed his magic sword with his gauntleted hand and pointed it at Hus.

A lightning-like energy was spreading from the sharp magic sword.

“——Hieroglyph.”

Hus, who was facing him, was not idle either.

He held his hieroglyph and prepared a magic spell to shoot at Evan.

Their eyes were full of killing intent as they glared at each other.

“I’ve been waiting for this for a long time. Evan.”

Now the only thing that supported them was their irreconcilable faith.

A tremendous amount of magic power burst out from their bodies, chosen by the heavenly god.

Crack.

A black lightning erupted from Evan’s body.

As he watched the clash of their momentum in the air, Rebels, who was standing on the wall, shouted in a loud voice toward Hus.

“Lord Hus, I’ll join you now, so please wait for a moment...!”

“Evan Allemir is mine. No one can interfere in this fight.”

But Hus immediately refused Rebels’ participation.

“...Hus.”

Evan called out Hus’s name as he got up from his seat.

The hero of knowledge. And the second son of the Allemir family.

His younger brother, who had followed him since childhood, was now standing in a different position.

Evan was looking at him with a hostile gaze, standing in the place that he had longed for so much.

“Evan Allemir. I will judge you according to the will of the goddess.”

It was a terrible fate.

A tragic destiny that forced them to point their weapons at each other.

It was a fate that could not be called anything but a joke of the gods.

Yet they did not hesitate to point their weapons at each other.

Because they had already made up their minds long ago.

“The will of the goddess... You have become a devout believer, haven’t you?”

“I don’t think that’s something a fallen paladin should say.”

Clang.

Evan grabbed his magic sword with his gauntleted hand and pointed it at Hus.

A lightning-like energy was spreading from the sharp magic sword.

“——Hieroglyph.”

Hus, who was facing him, was not idle either.

He held his hieroglyph and prepared a magic spell to shoot at Evan.

Their eyes were full of killing intent as they glared at each other.

“I’ve been waiting for this for a long time. Evan.”

Now the only thing that supported them was their irreconcilable faith.

A tremendous amount of magic power burst out from their bodies, chosen by the heavenly god.

Crack.

A black lightning erupted from Evan’s body.

As he watched the clash of their momentum in the air, Rebels, who was standing on the wall, shouted in a loud voice toward Hus.

“Lord Hus, I’ll join you now, so please wait for a moment...!”

“Evan Allemir is mine. No one can interfere in this fight.”

But Hus immediately refused Rebels’ participation.

He wanted to defeat Evan with his own strength, without Rebels’ help.

Rebels’ voice echoed in the air, flustered by his resolute answer.

“Hus Allemir! What are you talking about!”

“Rebels Ederlant. You should be dealing with the cult’s army that is descending on the ground, not with me.”

“What did you say...?”

As soon as Hus finished speaking, a man with a dagger fell from above Rebels’ head.

The man’s presence was so stealthy that even Rebels, the knight commander, could barely sense him before the collision.

Clang!

The black holy sword and the assassin's dagger clashed, and a metallic friction sound rang in the air.

“Ugh...!”

It was a sharp strike that Rebels had not expected at all.

Rebels, who barely fended off the assassin's attack, swung his holy sword to counterattack.

But Rebels' sword only grazed the spot where the assassin had disappeared.

The assassin had completely hidden himself while Rebels was swinging his sword.

Seeing the trail of his holy sword passing through the air, Rebels shouted in a hurry to his surroundings.

“An assassin has infiltrated! Everyone, be on guard!”

The enemy was a skilled assassin.

And now, the ground was covered by the evil god's power.

Even a skilled paladin could fall victim to an ambush.

But the battlefield did not give Rebels any respite, as loud voices began to erupt from all sides.

“Commander! The gate is in danger!”

“Edward! Hera! You go down and prepare for the gate being breached!”

“Commander! We received news that the Holy Palace was attacked...!”

“Don't panic! The Holy One is in the Holy Palace!”

The beasts that kept charging at the gate.

The cult that broke through the gate by some means and wreaked havoc inside the Crossbridge.

And the assassin who hid in the darkness that covered the ground and launched a surprise attack.

The paladins who defended the wall had no room for leisure.

In the end, Rebels was crushed by the pressure of the battlefield and turned his eyes away from Hus's matter.

“Hus Allemir! I will hold you accountable for your unilateral action later!”

“I will take responsibility here with my own hands.”

He stepped forward.

Hus clenched his magic with flames and took a step forward.

“Second Apostle, it is my responsibility to kill Evan Allemir.”

Hus smiled faintly as he moved away from Rebels' sight.

Evan also moved his feet as he faced him.

He did not want to settle things with Hus Allemir either.

The two heroes who met eyes in the air moved toward each other.

“——Astraphe.”

“——Fire Storm.”

Evan ran with his magic sword of lightning and wondered at Hus who was closing the distance like him.

Hus seemed to not avoid the collision with him, as he raised his magic power and ran toward Evan.

It was a different sight from the usual tactics of a mage.

It looked like he had no reason to avoid close combat with Evan, who could not use aura or holy power.

‘He must be looking down on me.’

Zap.

The lightning with a long tail moved to swallow everything in its trajectory.

The light refracted in the space where the sword moved, and the black sword shot at the enemy in front of him.

The dazzling bombardment of light and darkness reached the mage in front of him.

Hus curled his lips and uttered a chant.

“——Teleport.”

Boom!

The lightning that lost its target stabbed into the empty ground.

Evan’s magic sword that hit the ground scattered black lightning around.

Rumble.

The trees in the forest that were caught in Evan’s attack broke from their roots and collapsed.

But Evan’s sword only hit the wrong place, and Hus had already left there after that.

“He dodged the attack...?”

“I’m not who I was back then.”

Hus, who had taken his place behind Evan, raised his hand.

Whoosh!

Hus's hand still held a dense fire magic power.

He did not hesitate to release the magic condensed in his hand.

The fire magic power that was compressed to the extreme aimed at Evan's empty back and shot out.

“...!”

He couldn't block it with his magic sword in his hand.

In the end, all he could do was to twist his body as much as possible.

He pulled out the power of lightning to the limit, and twisted his body to avoid the center of the firestorm.

Boom!

A loud explosion sounded as his body flew away like before.

“As... traphe...!”

Zap.

Lightning flowed from his gauntlet, and he moved to protect his flying body as much as possible.

Clang! Crash!

The gauntlet that was stabbed into the ground and scraped away raised flames and dust, trying to deflect the impact somehow.

Of course, Hus wouldn't let him fend off the impact easily.

Hus's next attack flew toward him as he was pushed back by the dust.

“——Inferno.”

A trail of light and flames was drawn in the air, and a red flash began to stretch toward him.

The burning flash was so intense that it would burn his whole body at the touch.

Sizzle.

The light that flowed from his wings of lightning pushed his body away.

He twisted his direction with the power of lightning and collided with a tree, stopping his body. A sharp pain ran through his body.

“Ugh...”

He clenched his teeth and quickly got up from his place.

He felt a thick taste of blood in his tightly closed mouth.

His left arm that was grazed by Hus’s magic also looked not so good.

But he didn’t have the luxury of groaning in pain from being hit.

Every moment on the battlefield was connected to death.

“You’re lucky to dodge that.”

Hus’s hand that floated in the air pointed at him again.

Whip.

He also gripped his magic sword and pulled out the power of lightning.

“——Astraphe.”

“——Hieroglyph.”

He moved in sync with the power of lightning, and Hus also pulled out the power of flames.

Zap. Whoosh.

The two fierce energies aimed at each other and flew out.

Flames and lightning. And light and heat.

The red and black colors that collided in the air tangled to gain the upper hand.

“——Ice Strike.”

Boom!

The colliding magic power exploded and scattered.

Beyond the broken magic light that lit up the surroundings, the two men started to move again to prepare for the next attack.

Hus's hand that crossed the space had a cold ice magic power, and Evan's sword that spread its wings had a lightning magic power on it.

“——Astraphe.”

The first one to move was Evan's attack again.

The light of lightning stretched out its trajectory, and Hus dodged it with a space movement magic. Then, a sharp ice flew toward Evan.

But Evan escaped from his place with the mobility of Astraphe.

He was faster to prepare for the next attack than Hus.

“——Astraphe...!”

The strike of lightning flew out, and Hus dodged it by crossing the space again.

Then, just like before, Hus crossed the space and shot out his magic.

It was the same movement as before.

Boom!

Evan blocked the attack that flew at him with his sword of lightning.

“——Hieroglyph.”

“——Astraphe.”

“——Fire Storm.”

“——As, traphe...!”

The battle afterwards repeated a similar pattern for a while.

Block, dodge, and attack again.

A monotonous stalemate where neither gave each other any space.

As the two had infinite magic power, the battle did not tilt to one side quickly.

“What a pointless struggle.”

Ten minutes. Twenty minutes.

And an hour.

The light that swallowed everything around did not stop.

As the battle continued, the forest near Crossbridge changed its shape repeatedly.

If the two had infinite stamina as well, it seemed like the battle would never end.

“...Hus.”

“Evan Allemir. You will never leave this place alive.”

But the two were not equal.

Evan's body was damaged from the beginning of the battle by Hus's attacks, and Hus did not look tired yet.

It was because Evan did not judge Hus's changed tactics properly.

The longer the battle lasted, the more disadvantageous it was for Evan.

The wound on his shoulder widened, and his hand holding the sword trembled slightly.

“I will kill you.”

Hus understood that as well.

Time was not on Evan's side.

It was his own fault for getting injured, so he could not blame anyone else.

Even if he somehow defeated Hus, there was no guarantee that he could fight well in the next battle.

‘I guess I'll get scolded by Eutenia after this battle.’

Evan smirked and lifted his sword with his shaky hand.

He thought he could defeat the hero and stay on the battlefield.

But that was also Evan's mistake.

He saw his younger brother who always followed him, but still, his enemy in front of him was a true hero.

He was not a leisurely opponent who would let him save his cards and defeat him later.

Fighting other heroes was the job of other apostles.

“...What are you thinking?”

Hus, who was preparing his magic in the air, asked Evan with a sudden smile.

He still saw his immature brother in Hus's face.

Suddenly, a memory from the past flashed through Evan's mind.

He had admired the heroes of old stories since he knew nothing.

“I remember my childhood. I thought I could be a hero back then.”

“That's too bad. The goddess chose me instead of you.”

“No, now that I think about it, it was a good thing. I wasn't fit for the hero's seat.”

His longing for heroes did not fade even after he became a paladin.

He believed that someday the goddess would look at him if he had the strongest faith in his heart.

Faith. Longing. And heroes.

All those things were the driving force that supported Evan Allemir in the past.

“So you finally realized your place.”

“Yes. I finally understood my place now.”

But there was no place for Evan in the old hero tales.

He was not a hero now.

He was a paladin abandoned by the goddess, and the second apostle chosen by the evil god.

Hus in front of him was not his brother who always lagged behind him, but his enemy who aimed his weapon at him to kill him.

What he had to defeat was not his blood relative Hus Allemir.

It was the hero of knowledge who ruled over the seat he longed for.

“Hero of knowledge, Hus Allemir. I will defeat you with all my power now.”

Evan’s eyes glowed with a different color than before.

The light of faith that burned Evan had gone out long ago.

But what he had to do was not much different from before.

Like a paladin who devoted everything to follow the goddess once, he now had to become an apostle who burned everything to chase faith.

Evan made up his mind and recited a prayer as he glared at Hus.

“——O great one, let your will be done.”

Since he gave up the light of faith, what Evan wanted most was a ray of miracle.

And his master always gave him miracles.

Once a day.

The most brilliant miracle in the world that could only be used at the most needed moment.

Chapter 194: Allemier (4)

Chapter 194: Allemier (4)

There was only one thing that a person who took on the priest's duty could do, whether it was then or now.

To believe in God and move forward.

Even if the target was called an evil god by the world, Evan Allemier's role was always fixed.

To burn everything and follow God's will.

He opened his mouth as he held the magic sword that he received from the heavenly God with both hands.

“——Astrape.”

Crackle.

Red sparks flew and scattered light in the air.

A fierce storm raged around Evan, who held the magic sword with both hands.

Boom!

A streak of lightning fell and drew a line in the dark space.

Evan tilted his sword beyond the beam of light that echoed with thunder.

“——Lightning Storm.”

The divine artifact of lightning that enabled him to use all kinds of magic in the thunder system emitted light.

Right after God's wrath descended on the ground through Evan's sword.

A huge amount of thunder energy swept and shook the ground with thunder and lightning.

The roar of the thunder dragon that tore the silence burst the air and reverberated loudly.

“——Barrier!”

The storm of lightning struck without sparing anyone.

As a priest, there was only one thing I could do, in the past and in the present.

To trust God and follow His path.

Even if the world called Him an evil god, my role as Evan Allemier never changed.

To burn everything in His name and carry out His will.

I gripped the magic sword with both hands, a gift from the heavenly God, and spoke a word.

“——Astrape.”

A crackle of red sparks lit up the air.

A fierce windstorm surrounded me, holding the magic sword tightly.

Boom!

A bolt of lightning struck down, cutting through the darkness.

I swung my sword across the beam of light that resounded with thunder.

“——Lightning Storm.”

The divine artifact of lightning glowed, granting me access to all kinds of thunder magic.

As soon as God’s wrath hit the earth through my sword,

A massive surge of thunder swept across the land, shaking it with thunderbolts and flashes.

The thunder dragon’s roar shattered the silence, exploding in the air and echoing loudly.

“——Barrier!”

It seemed that he wanted to get out of the aftermath, and Hus, who was watching Evan, used barrier magic.

The flow of magic that took shape stayed near Hus and formed a barrier of light.

It was barrier magic used by one of the magicians who reached the peak.

It was certain that he would not even scratch it with a decent attack.

“...Hero of knowledge, Hus Allemier.”

Evan walked forward with his sword in his hand in the thunderstorm that blurred his sight.

Boom!

Every time the fallen knight took a step, a sound like thunder echoed.

Crackle!

Every time the apostle of the evil god got closer to the hero, the light of thunder spread and sparks flew in all directions.

In the shrinking distance, Evan Allemier's sword was aiming at his only brother.

The eyes buried in the flashing thunderlight emitted a fierce aura.

“Don't put my name in your dirty mouth!”

Hus snapped at Evan, who was approaching him, and shot him with sharp thunder magic.

But the spear of lightning that Hus shot did not reach him.

The spear of lightning that left Hus's hand was swallowed up by the swirling thunder and became part of it.

After the spear of thunder that flew away with a faint spark disappeared, the thunderstorm that became stronger than before advanced while wrapping Evan.

“What made you a hero who trapped me is nothing but the karma that I created in the past.”

“Shut up your nonsense! I only, until now to kill you...!”

“So I don't intend to avoid taking responsibility for it.”

Evan still moved his battered steps toward Hus with a bitter smile on his mouth.

The hero of knowledge in front of his eyes was a mirror reflecting his past self.

He was chasing the brightest place.

He was chasing the brilliant glory that made everyone in his family look up to him.

What made his younger brother admire him, what made him walk this path that he despises so much now, was all Evan's karma.

So he intended to take responsibility for it from now on.

“——The heroic tale that you wrote down in an immature way is over now.”

Evan’s footsteps ran forward as he finished speaking.

Thud thud thud—.

A huge wing of thunder spread behind Evan’s back as he sprinted forward.

The thunderstorm that wrapped Evan became a strong wind that pushed the wings, and the lightning that struck him made the wings of light grow bigger.

Evan’s body accelerated toward Hus Allemier, scattering currents.

‘A little faster.’

Crackle.

The thunderlight that burned his soul accelerated Evan’s body even more.

The swaying darkness was dyed with light, and the rising light faded into darkness again.

The black lightning created by the great being drew a contradictory tail of light and pushed the apostle’s body forward.

‘A little more.’

The apostle of the evil god was still in the center of the storm that swept around.

His footsteps that ran on the ground were floating in the air, and only the thunder that he had piled up several times burst the air and moved forward.

The burning light led Evan forward.

Evan Allemier continued to advance in the heat that burned everything.

‘Just a little more——.’

Kwaaaaang—!

The thunder wings that had grown too big could not bear their size and burst out.

Evan felt like his ears would go deaf from the deafening explosion.

Even so, he did not stop and accelerated one more step toward the front.

“——Astrape……!”

“——Hieroglyph!”

A black flash drew a trail in the air in the collision of light and darkness.

The target of the light of darkness was only one.

It was Hus Allemier who was standing with a barrier at the end of the trail.

Facing the apostle of the evil god who was approaching at a destructive speed, Hus was holding a divine artifact in one hand.

‘Not yet… not yet.’

In the distance that had narrowed so much that it seemed to touch if he swung his sword, Evan hesitated to swing his magic sword in his hand.

The hero in front of him could jump over space as much as he wanted.

If he missed his target with his sword swinging in the air, and Hus used the prepared magic in that gap, it was impossible to catch him.

So the opponent who swung his sword was not Hus Allemier in front of him.

He had to swing this sword attack at Hus Allemier who would get out of here and prepare magic for him in the future.

“——Teleport!”

As if to prove his expectation, Hus, who had Evan in front of him, used transference magic and hid his appearance from his eyes.

It was to deflect Evan’s attack and inflict effective damage on him.

As soon as Hus hid his appearance from his eyes, Evan immediately swung his sword and fired a prepared attack.

Evan’s magic sword swung quickly and mercilessly scraped and passed through the air.

“——Fire Storm!”

‘Now.’

The sword that swung like that was not aiming at nothing in the air.

Whip.

The sword that spun around in the air soon completely left Evan’s grip.

The target of the magic sword that left its owner’s hand was Hus Allemier floating in the air.

“A sword from your hand… this……!”

At the sight of the magic sword flying towards him while spinning, Hus Allemier panicked and activated magic again.

There was only one magic he could use to avoid the sword.

Using the power of the divine artifact that could create multiple illusions, he chose to jump over space again. assistant Here is the edited text:

I was still at the eye of the storm, an apostle of the evil god.

My feet left the ground as I ran, propelled by nothing but layers of thunder that exploded around me.

A blazing light guided me forward.

I pressed on through the inferno that consumed everything.

‘Almost there——.’

Boom!

My thunder wings burst apart, unable to contain their enormity.

A blast rocked my ears, making me feel deaf.

But I didn’t stop. I sped up even more towards my target.

“——Astrape……!”

“——Hieroglyph!”

A black flash carved a trail in midair, where light and darkness clashed.

There was only one thing I wanted to hit with my dark light.

Hus Allemier, standing behind a barrier at the end of my path.

He held a divine artifact in one hand, facing me as I closed in with devastating speed.

‘Not yet… not yet.’

I hesitated to swing my magic sword as I reached him. He could easily warp through space and dodge me. If I missed him and he used his prepared spell in that gap, I would never catch him again.

So I wasn’t aiming for Hus Allemier right in front of me.

I had to strike at Hus Allemier who would escape from here and ready his magic against me.

“——Teleport!”

As if confirming my guess, Hus vanished from my sight with a transference spell.

He wanted to avoid my attack and hurt me back.

But I was faster. I swung my sword and unleashed my own spell.

My magic sword sliced through the air with ruthless force.

“——Fire Storm!”

‘Now.’

My sword wasn’t swinging at empty air.

Whip.

It spun out of my hand and flew towards its target.

Hus Allemier, hovering in the air.

“A sword from your hand… this……!”

He saw the magic sword coming at him and panicked. He cast another spell to evade it.

There was only one option for him.

He used the divine artifact that could create multiple illusions and tried to jump through space once more.

Hus hid his figure from the trajectory of the spinning magic sword, and right after that, he showed himself again in a different location.

“——Te, teleport!”

“——Tempest.”

The moment Hus showed himself floating in the air after transferring.

Evan activated the magic he had prepared beforehand as if he had been waiting.

Tempest. An ice magic that freezes the air around.

The miracle that was reproduced by borrowing the power of God revealed itself to the world and collided with the flame power that was clenched in Hus's hand.

In Evan's calculation that was rushing with thunder, Hus's figure avoiding the sword was also drawn.

Hus's voice echoed in the air at Evan's unexpected magic.

“Suddenly tempest… what……!”

“——Astrape.”

“Keeuk……!”

But all Hus could do without magic ready was to spit out a doubtful voice while looking at the mixed power.

Kwaaang—!

The ice power and the flame power collided in the air, and a large crack was made in the barrier that protected Hus.

He didn't get hurt because he had wrapped the barrier beforehand, but his body that didn't touch the ground could never be free from that influence.

“Euk… te, tele……!”

Hus's body bounced off in one direction in the collision of cold and heat.

And behind him was Evan who was still running with thunder.

Evan reached out his hand with a gauntlet to Hus who was flying towards him.

Kwaduk.

The curved barrier was firmly caught by the gauntlet that had nothing in it.

"I've been waiting for you, Hus."

Evan's eyes stained with thunder looked at Hus in front of him.

Hero. The second of Allemier family. Cloud's second-class investigator.
Dull magician.

The memories of his blood relatives that he had faced so far passed through Evan's head.

Evan fixed Hus Allemier who was caught in his hand with thunder power.

This was the only responsibility he chose for his family.

"What are you going to do... aak.....!"

Evan's hand stuck Hus to the ground with a barrier.

Evan's wings that still didn't slow down were running through the storm.

Hus's barrier that was pushed forward towards the front rubbed against the ground as it touched it.

Kwaddddddduduk!

Light and heat spread from his hand and a flash of light cut through and passed the ground.

“——Astrape.”

Zzak. Zzajak.

Hus’s barrier that ran through the dirt and rocks began to crack.

The huge crack that was created by the collision of two magics had grown to an irreparable size.

Yet Evan, who had caught him, was still running at a speed beyond his senses.

Evan shouted at Hus in the shock wave that shook his ears.

“Pray, Hus Allemier……!”

Evan’s voice was buried in the tearing atmosphere and not properly delivered.

But Hus Allemier who was caught in his hand understood his intention exactly.

There was no time to prepare a new magic for transference.

At this moment, the barrier that protected him was slowly collapsing.

There was no longer a way for the hero of knowledge to overcome this situation.

“Lift your head and revere the sky. And——!”

Zzak! Kwadddddddduk—!

The friction sound of the barrier that flowed through the air in the splitting air was conveyed to Evan as a pleasant sound at this moment.

Hus’s distorted face appeared in his sight beyond the collapsing barrier.

The hero in the old story was now screaming in his grip with a powerless look.

Writing a story was not only allowed to those who qualified as heroes.

It was not because he became a hero that he performed feats.

Everyone showed him respect for his feats.

-“Accept your fate.”

Accept your fate.

Evan laughed at the familiar voice of the evil god.

A predetermined fate.

What is the fate given to him?

The power began to drain from Evan’s hand that clenched Hus.

“I am…….”

He had lived glorious days.

But there was no glory at the end of that road.

In the end of that long ordeal, what he chose was a path that denied everything.

He was not a knight now.

He was not an inquisitor now.

And he was now——

“I am… Evan Allemier, the second apostle!”

Kwaaang—!

The light of faith collapsed.

-[Divine Artifact: Hieroglyph] has been destroyed.

-[Divine Artifact: Astrape] has grown.

Chapter 195: The Contrast of Black and White (1)

Chapter 195: The Contrast of Black and White (1)

In the northern part of the continent, in the Alterias region.

In a gloomy cave near the Colt Duchy, the King of the Undead, Arcrosis, raised his massive body.

Creak. Creak—.

Arcrosis's body, filled with sharp bones, moved with a creepy friction sound.

Underneath Arcrosis, who stood up in the cave, was the black mage Kerington, who had made a contract with him.

Kerington looked up at Arcrosis, who was checking the completed magic circle, and opened his mouth.

“I have already sent all the other mages out of the cave.”

As he said that, there was no sign of anyone else around Kerington.

According to the grand plan that Arcrosis had designed, he had taken measures to prevent the black mages of the Abyss from getting involved.

Nod.

Arcrosis nodded at him and lifted his staff.

The staff, carved out of bone, had a cruel and old-fashioned atmosphere.

-“How is the human army?”

“A vanguard composed of Cloud’s branch and the soldiers of the Obtos Duchy has arrived near here.”

-“They are faster than expected.”

Even though he had left them alone until the human army came close, there was one reason why Arcrosis had made the black mages of the Abyss move away from the cave.

The magic that Arcrosis was about to use from now on was quite dangerous for living beings.

If they were caught in this magic, there was a possibility that his toys would scream and die without any meaning.

That’s why Arcrosis deliberately dropped them out of the cave.

He still had many regrets about breaking his toys with his own hands.

-“I should prepare for the ritual soon.”

Arcrosis lifted his staff and checked the magic circle he had engraved once more.

He was one of the ancient demons called the King of the Undead, but he had never handled magic other than necromancy to the extreme.

So this plan was a somewhat experimental challenge for Arcrosis.

As Arcrosis lifted his staff to use magic, Kerington, who was below him, asked him politely.

“Lord of Undeath... what should I do?”

-“Stay in my space until the ritual is over.”

Thud.

As Arcrosis swung his staff toward the air, a dark and unpleasant space revealed itself.

It was the passage to Arcrosis's space where he stored his undead.

Kerington frowned at the sight of Arcrosis's space, which conveyed a gloomy aura.

But that was only for a moment.

He soon greeted Arcrosis and stepped into his space.

"...I understand. Thank you for giving me the opportunity to face a new realm."

-“You are allowed to stay there until the plan is over.”

As soon as Kerington entered his space completely, the open space shrank and closed as a two-dimensional door.

After Kerington, who was next to him, went to a safe place.

Arcrosis then sprinkled the blood of the sacrifice on top of the magic circle.

Thud. Splash.

The blood sprinkled on the floor made the color of the magic circle red.

The red blood that started to circulate with Arcrosis's power created a dizzying spectacle for anyone to see.

-“About twenty?”

Arcrosis sprinkled all the blood he had piled up on the floor and moved toward the center of the magic circle.

Then he stuck his staff in the middle of the magic circle and stroked the skull-shaped head on top of his staff with his hand.

Screech—!

The skull attached to his staff screamed with a rough voice.

It was a human voice that Arcrosis used to make noise for the ritual, not being able to convey anything but his will.

-“By the name of Arcrosis, the third child of the Nameless King, I call upon heaven.”

“By the name of Arcrosis, the third child of the Nameless King, I call upon heaven.”

Thud. Thud. Thud.

Along with the sound of his staff hitting the ground, a human spell with a torn throat echoed in the cave.

In an empty cave with no one else, a chant like a scream echoed and made the blood magic circle emit a strong red light.

-“I offer twenty.”

“I offer twenty.”

-“I wish for ten.”

“I wish for ten.”

The mismatched numbers resonated in the cave.

He lifted his staff high and shouted.

-“Approve.”

“Approve.”

Right after the ghastly voice of the skull ended.

The red blood that filled the magic circle dried up in an instant.

The life that Arcrosis had offered by his name was converted into karma and existed there.

Arcrosis blew the karma he had transformed through the ritual back into the magic circle.

The demon's magic that dealt with the essence of life was about to begin.

-“I’ve been waiting for a long time. Come out now.”

The entire magic circle was covered with a flickering light, and then it began to crack and open slowly.

What Arcrosis did with the karma he had sacrificed was one thing.

He created a passage that connected the abyss and the surface for a moment.

And beyond the passage that Arcrosis created, there were countless undead that he had captured and shaped in the abyss.

Evil spirits that only chased their prey in front of them without any sense of reason.

That was the nature of the monsters that lived in the abyss.

-Roar.

-Gurgle. Gurgles—?

-Screech—!

All kinds of monsters raised their bodies from beyond the crack.

The size of one monster was enough to overwhelm the entire cave.

Rumble.

The monsters' bodies came out of the crack one by one, and the cave where the magic circle was engraved began to collapse slowly.

The cave was too narrow to accommodate the huge monsters of the abyss.

-“You can run wild as much as you want from now on.”

Arcrosis said that as he watched the monsters coming out.

The monsters also conveyed Arcrosis's will and roared.

There was no one who could recognize his expression without any skin on this place.

Hus Allemier opened his eyes from the beginning of the ritual.

Blink. Blink.

As if trying to regain his sight that had not returned yet, Hus blinked several times and tried to look ahead.

His blurred vision gradually took shape as he did so.

In the darkness where nothing could be seen clearly, the first thing that Hus saw when he opened his eyes was a small bonfire and his brother Evan Allemier.

“You finally came to your senses.”

In front of Hus's eyes, Evan, who was covered in blood, was wiping his gauntlet and looking at him.

The divine artifact that Evan, an apostle of the evil god, had received, Astrape.

The gauntlet, stained with blood and dirt, was hardly a sight to behold.

Hus looked away from Evan, who was cleaning the gauntlet, and searched for his own artifact.

Not far from the cave wall where Hus was leaning.

There were fragments of broken hieroglyphs rolling on the floor.

“This is...”

“Your hero’s weapon. It’s been ruined miserably, but it’s a cheap price for your life.”

Evan gave him a brief comment as he looked at Hus, who was murmuring at the shattered hieroglyphs.

The value of his life that was still attached.

It was the most miserable thing to say from the loser’s perspective.

Hus stared at the broken hieroglyphs for a moment, then shifted his gaze back to Evan.

His face was mixed with complex emotions as he looked at Evan.

“Why...”

A feeling of emptiness and futility.

And beyond that, a sticky something mixed with resentment and longing.

The things that he had been suppressing in his chest all this time began to surge up as he faced Evan.

Hus swallowed the emotions that were pouring out one by one, and asked Evan with a doubtful voice.

“Why... did you spare me?”

Hus Allemier was the hero of knowledge.

And he was the enemy of Evan Allemier, who had become the apostle of the evil god.

So there was no reason for Evan to spare him.

If Hus himself had won the battle, he would not have thought of sparing the apostle of the evil god.

Evan gave him a short answer with a serious face.

“The hero of knowledge died just now.”

The hero of knowledge was already dead.

It was a story that told him that it was hard for him to remain as the hero of knowledge, since the hieroglyphs bestowed by the goddess were completely destroyed.

Hus Allemier before becoming a hero was not a great person.

He knew very well how pitiful and miserable it was to lose an artifact, as he had watched Naias, the hero of harmony.

No, rather Naias would have been much better than him.

She was originally a dragonkin who had a powerful power, and Hus before becoming the hero of knowledge was just an ordinary mage from the frontier.

Hus without hieroglyphs was a human who had to spend several months to handle high-level fire magic accurately.

“Then what about me...”

That’s why he felt more miserable.

He was nothing without being a hero.

Since he received the mark of a hero from the goddess of knowledge, he had always been supported by one thing: being a hero.

He was able to prepare himself to fight against Evan, because he was a hero. He was able to pledge to protect humanity from the evil god, because he was a hero.

Then what should Hus Allemier do without being a hero?

He couldn't fight against Evan in front of him, and he couldn't handle the infinite magic that came through the artifact anymore.

“What will happen to me here!”

Envy and jealousy. Arrogance and anger.

And beyond that, a deep doubt about his weak self that would have been there.

The emotions that he had been forcing himself to pick up began to leak out one by one.

His self that he hated so much was being stripped off and exposed in front of him.

Showing his weakness that he wanted to hide in front of his brother whom he longed for, Hus Allemier vented his anger with a distorted voice.

“I'm not a hero, nor a great mage, nor even recognized by my superior brother. I'm abandoned... How am I supposed to live now!”

Evan Allemier and Hus Allemier were different.

Evan was always ahead of him, and Hus was always behind him, lacking.

Now there was no longer a pedestal called a hero to support him.

Evan's eyes were still watching Hus, who had let go of his hand in the distance that he could never catch up with in his life.

Evan spoke to Hus, who was spitting out his voice mixed with anger.

“You are Hus Allemier.”

“Such worthless consolation...”

Hus, who tried to avoid Evan’s voice toward him, closed his mouth when he found something in Evan’s eyes in front of him.

Evan’s eyes in front of him were not pitying him.

They didn’t feel sorry for him either. Nor did they despise him.

They just watched him with a serious look as before.

“Don’t rely on the name of a hero. Don’t be trapped by the ghosts of my past.”

“If I’m not a hero... I have nothing left.”

He had been unfair to Evan in the past.

There was only one time when Hus went ahead of Evan on his way.

It was when he was chosen as a hero and entered the holy land.

Yet Evan told him to put down the weight of a hero.

“If you’re not a hero, are you not Hus Allemier?”

“But I’ve been living... never once recognized by you...”

“Don’t bet your life for me.”

Clang.

Evan, who had wiped off the blood, put on the gauntlet and got up from his seat.

Evan's figure, seen beyond the flickering flames, looked somewhat dazzling.

He showed a relaxed attitude as if he was carrying the heaviest thing in the world, but lighter than anyone else.

“Even if I don't recognize you, you are the proud second son of the Allemier family.”

Evan's eyes, who got up from his seat, headed to the city wall far away from the cave.

There was a fierce fire rising from the wall.

The fire of war was growing bigger than imagined.

Evan watched the burning holy land and took out a cigarette from his pocket.

The cigarette that Evan had was the same kind that Hus burned.

He glared at it for a moment, then threw the cigarette into the bonfire.

“When the war is over, call me brother again.”

Crackle. Crackle.

A terrible smoke rose from the bonfire where the cigarette burned.

Chapter 196: Contrast of Black and White (2)

Chapter 196: Contrast of Black and White (2)

In a small studio apartment, moonlight streamed through the window.

I lay next to Estasia, who was sound asleep, and stared at the screen of my smartphone.

New messages kept popping up on the phone I held in my hand.

Most of them were notifications of karma acquisition.

-Your karma increased by 2.

-Your karma increased by 16.

-Your karma increased by 4.

Ever since I ordered the war to begin for the cult's followers,

I had been receiving a huge amount of karma, thanks to the 2x karma coupon I used.

It wasn't fast enough to fill up a million karma in an instant, but it was still more than I ever dreamed of.

As I watched the countless messages of acquisition on the phone's message box, I felt like I could understand why the war between the evil god and the six goddesses had been recurring periodically.

There was no better way to get a lot of karma than war.

“War...”

According to Aronia’s story, the confrontation between the six goddesses and the evil god had been going on endlessly even before I took over the role of the evil god.

And the god of regression was not a personality god who had a will from the start.

But there was a reason why both sides kept waging war.

As I looked at the screen, several reasons came to mind.

“It must have been to solve the problem of the ceiling.”

One was to make their opposition recognized by <The Ceiling of Karma>.

<The Ceiling of Karma> prevented any specific god from interfering too much with the world.

The gods, who were supposed to be the most perfect beings, were ironically unable to be complete on their own.

A god without an opposite point could not rule as a god.

“They also needed a way to get a large amount of karma steadily.”

Another was that the purpose was to increase the karma through war.

The anxiety and chaos that arose from the war would have increased the dependence of the believers on their faith, and as a result, the amount of karma that the goddesses received would have increased more than usual.

Moreover, as the war progressed, the growing cycle of life would have brought them a huge benefit of karma.

No matter how I thought about it, there seemed to be no reason for the goddesses not to wage war periodically.

“The goddess of harmony must be trying to put me in her place.”

In that situation, the goddess of harmony decided to pull down all the other goddesses.

The huge benefit that would result from the confrontation of the two gods, she and I, who had become gods by obtaining the divinity of the evil god, would share it.

And from there, she took one step further and tried to rule as a god on Earth, where I lived.

She was trying to push me into the abyss of war that would never end.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> occurred.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> occurred.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> occurred.

It was not a good story for me.

The only reason I was still alive was because Estelle chose me, and I, who was nothing but a human, was gaining divinity thanks to her.

From the perspective of profit or loss, it was a story that had nothing bad for me.

If I turned my eyes away from the stories of the people who died in front of me and the people I killed with my own hands, I could end everything with that.

“But... I don’t like being pushed around.”

Still, I didn’t want to compromise with the comfort in front of me.

From the moment I declared to fight against Estasia, I decided not to run away anymore.

So if I had to choose, it had to be a way that I could hit Estelle hard.

That was why I asked Aronia to investigate the goddess of harmony.

“How would a goddess who was born high up know the mind of a humble human?”

And in the process, I found one hint that could reach her.

The vessel that the heavenly goddess chose to contain herself.

The weapon that the heavenly goddess forged with the help of a great power.

At the moment when these two things miraculously fit together, my plan would shine.

Ever since I touched <The Ceiling of Karma>, I had been studying nothing but that.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Weapon: Ascalon] was released by one level.

How to kill a divinity.

More precisely, how to detach the connection of divinity from <The Ceiling of Karma>.

Until now, I had been sharpening a sharp blade for that purpose alone.

So, the conclusion I came to after going through all that was only one.

“I’ll kill the goddess of harmony as soon as she descends.”

I borrow the power of a god to reach a god.

From now on, I was going to start an underdog's rebellion that would topple the one at the peak.

Arien Crost.

The hero of knowledge of the past and the unparalleled genius born by the continent looked up at the sky.

Beyond the darkened sky, the army of the evil god was approaching.

And leading them was a fortress wrapped in a thick shield.

Arien raised his hand at the sight of its enormous size, which looked extraordinary even to the naked eye.

“I’m not sure if it’s possible to shoot it down.”

The size of the fortress detected by Arien’s senses was comparable to the legendary aerial garden used by the queen of the fairy race.

It would not be easy to knock it off its orbit with any ordinary attack.

To shoot down such a thing, he had to fire an attack with an incredible power.

But unfortunately, it was impossible for Arien now.

If he had been the hero of knowledge, he would have drawn out infinite magic and tried to attack, but Arien Crost now was nothing but a ghost who had lost his hero’s power.

“But I can’t let it roam around freely.”

He couldn’t let such a fortress fly over the holy land freely either.

Even if he couldn't shoot down the fortress, he could at least reduce some of the evil god's army in it.

Arien began to prepare a magic to make a small hole in the fortress's shield.

If he added this to an attack magic with increased penetration power, those who were drifting in the air would feel threatened and show some reaction.

“——Blaze.”

Many magic circles began to rise around Arien, who started to raise his magic.

The light magic circles engraved in the air reacted with other magic circles, and soon they mixed together and created a large magic circle.

Behind the flames, new flames were added.

In front of those flames, a hot flame magic condensed to pierce through the path.

As several magics overlapped and created a new magic, something was detected by Arien's senses, who was preparing magic.

“What is this...”

“Arien Crost!”

Someone began to show up from beyond the darkened sky.

Arien's eyes, which adjusted his vision with magic, confirmed the identity of the target.

There was a man with an ordinary appearance, wearing a black cloak fluttering in the air, descending toward the ground.

The man had two swords of contrasting colors hanging on his waist.

A white holy sword. And a divine weapon of evil god.

Arien could easily guess who he was.

“A fallen hero.”

Apostle Peter.

He was an apostle of the cult who had fallen to the evil god’s temptation.

Seeing the apostle in front of him, Arien twisted the trajectory of his magic.

Ziiiiing.

The magic aimed at Peter began to spread condensed flames.

“——Blaze.”

Kwaang!

The magic that left Arien’s hand exploded with a huge shockwave and went on.

It was a fire magic that had several layers overlapped and shot at Peter.

No matter how much he was an apostle, he wouldn’t be fine if he was hit directly by that magic.

Peter, who was descending toward the ground, drew out a white holy sword as soon as he saw the flying magic.

“——O Goddess!”

Paaat—!

A light burst out from the white holy sword that Peter drew, and soon the flames of the magic that Arien had fired subsided.

The white holy sword that weakened the magic showed its power.

Using the holy sword to weaken the magic, Peter blocked the flying magic with his cloak.

Bang!

The magic that Arien fired showed much weaker output than expected and exploded in the air.

Arien frowned as he saw Peter, who was landing on the ground with smoke on his head, and prepared to greet him.

“.....You still insult the goddess.”

“Arien Crost! The apostle of the evil god is here.....!”

Peter, who shouted at him with a confident voice, still did not hesitate to blaspheme against the goddess.

It was an attitude that often seen by heretics who had not grown up with proper education.

After all, it was foolish to hope for a proper mind from someone who had rejected the glorious position of a hero.

Flap.

Peter turned back his fluttering cloak and landed on the ground with the power of the evil god.

His hair, which had descended through the darkness and landed on the ground, was severely tangled.

“You wicked servant of the evil god. Do you have no intelligence?”

Arien opened his mouth as he looked at Peter who had landed in front of him.

He was a bastard who brazenly called out the name of the goddess while serving the evil god.

He had already faced him once before, but it was a very horrible feeling to see the traitor who had abandoned his hero's position again.

It would have been over at that place if the evil god had not intervened.

If that had happened, he wouldn't have to face this unlucky face again.

“.....”

“Seeing that you're keeping your mouth shut, you seem to understand your place somewhat.”

Despite being insulted in front of him, Peter was just quietly pointing his sword at him.

I expected him to rush at me in excitement, but surprisingly, Peter looked very calm.

He seemed to be aware of his own shortcomings, no matter how incompetent he was.

As I was about to say one more thing to Peter, who was quietly standing there, he opened his mouth first.

“No. A man speaks with his sword.”

With that, Peter drew his sword from his waist.

Clank.

The dark sword that came out of the scabbard was gripped by Peter's empty hand.

A white holy sword. And a black evil sword.

The apostle of the evil god, who held two swords that did not harmonize with each other, pointed his sword at me.

“.....”

A man speaks with his sword.

It was an old saying that was passed down among the mercenaries.

I quietly repeated Peter's words in my head and looked at my hand.

There was no sword in the hand of a magician like me.

On the other hand, Peter had two swords in his hands.

His intention was clear through that.

“What are you doing standing there? I told you a man speaks with his sword. Or are you not a man?”

Snickers.

I clenched the air quietly as Peter sneered at me.

Chapter 197: Contrast of Black and White (3)

Chapter 197: Contrast of Black and White (3)

Under the magic of Arien, who illuminated the darkness, the sharp eyes of the two people met each other.

In the silence, only their rough heartbeats echoed in their ears.

They had exchanged provocations once, but they both understood that it had no great meaning.

From the moment they faced each other here, they must have realized that they did not like each other.

The important thing was not words, but actions.

“——Blaze.”

Whoosh.

A hot flame magic wrapped around Arien's hand.

It was a magic that showed strong power among the ones that could be activated quickly.

The opponent was a swordsman who used a white holy sword.

Persistent magic was meaningless when he had a white holy sword in front of him.

That's why Arien was preparing a single-shot magic that had strong power compared to the amount of magic he put in.

"I was waiting for you to move first."

".....What?"

As Arien prepared to fire his magic, Peter, who was facing him, opened his mouth with a smile.

Arien couldn't help but show a puzzled expression at Peter's appearance.

He looked like he was waiting for a prey caught in a trap, showing a confident attitude to Arien.

He must have had some hidden trick.

As if to answer Arien's curious face, Peter stabbed his black sword into the ground and opened his mouth.

"Sanctuary Declaration—— Logration."

Sanctuary Declaration.

The power of the gods to proclaim their domain on the ground.

As Peter, who borrowed power from an evil god, declared his sanctuary, the light sphere that Arien had set up began to lose its light.

Zap. Zzzap.

Beyond the crumbling light sphere, a huge shadow area surged in like a wave.

".....Sanctuary Declaration?"

Arien looked around with a sigh as he faced the evil god's sanctuary for the first time in his life.

The shadow that rose so deep that the ground was not visible was already at a level where it could cover his knees.

The light sphere that he had made to secure his vision also faded away.

To create a new light sphere, he had to push in more magic than before to face the result.

The area of darkness that settled around me was interfering with my magic.

“This is... the evil god’s sanctuary.”

The evil god’s sanctuary that I, Arien Crost, was facing was a very fatal space for a mage.

Any mage would have to pay a price in this place.

No matter how great I was, it was impossible to ignore the influence of the evil god’s sanctuary.

There was only one way to overcome this situation.

To get out of the sanctuary where the evil god’s power was spread.

“Arien Crost. This is a gift I prepared for you.”

“——Teleport.”

As Peter looked at me with a confident voice, I felt a sense of crisis and prepared a long-distance transfer magic.

No matter how I thought about it, the fight in the sanctuary was disadvantageous for me.

Besides, it was impossible to intervene in the outside battlefield from here.

So I decided to avoid the sanctuary for now and fight again somewhere else.

The moment I quickly prepared the teleport magic and tried to use it.

Zap.

The space twisted and the magic lost its power.

“What is this...!”

The use of transfer magic was difficult due to the effect of the sanctuary.

The coordinates inside the sanctuary were distorted every moment and interfered with my teleport.

If I forced myself to use it, I could jump over a short distance, but long-distance transfer to the outside of the sanctuary was completely impossible.

It meant that the means to escape from the sanctuary by myself were completely blocked.

Peter, who had pulled out the divine device that he had stabbed into the ground, spoke to me, who was biting my lips.

“You seem to like the gift very much.”

“You, bastard...!”

Peter, who created the sanctuary with the power of the evil god, was still smiling with a relaxed face.

He was a fool who didn't know the greatness of magic, and he was satisfied with somehow hindering me.

Gnash.

I clenched my teeth and raised my magic power, glaring at Peter.

In the end, there was only one choice left for me.

I had to put off intervening in other battlefields and finish the fight with Apostle Peter first, while carrying a penalty.

“——Dainsleif.”

Among the two people facing each other, Peter moved first toward his opponent.

The dark purple magic sword in Peter’s hand roared and expanded its territory.

My eyes, enhanced by magic, calculated the area of Dainsleif that spread out.

Even if I used teleport as far as possible, it seemed difficult to get out of Dainsleif’s area completely.

I had to fight in the space and way that the enemy wanted.

“——Teleport.”

I, Arien Crost, was a great mage who could skillfully fight in an unprepared battlefield.

But I was not someone who didn’t know what it meant to have an area prepared by a swordsman.

I had to end this fight as quickly as possible.

Only then could I move on to the next battlefield with minimal loss.

Therefore, I decided to pour out all my power from the beginning and finish it off.

“——Dainsleif.”

“——Teleport. Blaze. Fire Storm.”

From within Peter’s spreading afterimage, my magic spewed fire.

I pushed myself beyond space with several times more magic power, and gathered powerful flames in my hand several times over.

Flames and heat. A raging storm of fire.

And beyond that, a hidden, intense and majestic explosion.

Arien, who had cast five spells at the same time, revealed himself on the opposite side of Peter.

“——Explosion.”

Peter’s spreading figure converged to where Arien had been, and behind him, Arien’s hand released the power of the blazing flame.

Boom! Bwaaang!

The dazzling flames and the deafening blast shook the air.

The explosions that went off in sequence pressed Peter’s position alternately.

Even if he used his afterimage to avoid Arien’s magic, it was an attack that made the chain explosions from all sides wrap his clone in flames.

“——Dain... sleif! Oh, goddess...!”

Peter, who faced the flames, tried to quickly get out of its range, but Arien’s magic did not let him go.

Even while moving, the flames that he had overlapped kept exploding again.

Whoosh! Bwaaang!

A fierce fire that momentarily drove away the darkness rose up, and right after that, another explosion shook the whole space.

It was the ultimate combination that did not give any chance to escape even to a fast swordsman.

Arien, who had poured out his magic on Peter with all his might, breathed roughly.

“Huff, huff... That should do it.”

Even if the white holy sword weakened his magic, it was an attack that focused on firepower to ignore the durability of the armor even in a weakened state.

The result would not be much different even if the opponent was an apostle of the evil god.

Arien, who had used his magic recklessly, stared beyond the rising smoke, and heard a rustling sound from there.

Splash. Scraaaape.

The sound that felt like scraping the floor was unmistakably a sign of a person.

“Ugh...!”

“He’s still alive...?”

Arien’s eyes looked at the person’s silhouette wavering beyond the smoke.

Beyond the thick smoke.

There was Peter’s figure wearing a black cloak upside down.

He had suffered minor injuries from the explosion, but he still looked like he was not badly hurt.

He only had some burns on his face.

“It’s impossible! How did he...?”

I exclaimed in shock as I saw Peter's unscathed appearance, surpassing my expectations.

It was an attack that I had calculated to be reduced by a quarter of its power by the white holy sword.

But it was unbelievable that he didn't even suffer a proper injury.

My shocked voice echoed loudly in the sanctuary, and Peter emerged through the smoke, smirking and advancing again.

He still looked down on me.

Peter flapped his black cloak and opened his mouth toward me, who was in front of him.

"You must be curious how I came out unharmed?"

"It was an attack that would inflict a great damage even to a dragon. But how can you stand there so fine?"

It was impossible according to my common sense.

When I asked Peter for the reason, he lifted his two swords with a relaxed expression.

I didn't feel any fear from Peter's appearance as he stepped forward.

Peter's mouth smoothly spilled the reason.

"The white holy sword greatly reduces the output and duration of magic."

"I already know that. But no matter how white the holy sword is..."

"Besides, the cloak I'm wearing has an effect of lowering the output of weakened magic by almost half."

Flap.

My head quickly calculated the numbers as I looked at his fluttering cloak.

Single-shot magic would be reduced by 25 percent by the white holy sword.

If what Peter said was true, then I was only delivering 12.5 percent of the power.

“Half again...”

“And the sanctuary you’re standing on has an effect of lowering the output of consumed magic by half and reducing the power of magic by a quarter.”

And if you cut it in half and then cut it by a quarter again, the output of my magic would be only 4.6 percent of my full power.

4.6 percent.

It was an absurd number for me, a mage.

To produce the original power, I needed a level of magic amplification that exceeded 20 times.

I knew best how impossible it was to implement that in reality.

“I can only deliver... 4 percent of my original power...?”

“That’s the difference between you and me in this sanctuary.”

Peter took a short breath and ran fast toward me.

Bang!

The apostle’s puppet that flew in the air shattered by the power of the divine device.

Peter’s target was obvious to anyone as he moved too fast for my eyes to follow.

Arien Crost.

His heart that was standing still after pouring out his full power.

“——Dainsleif!”

“——Teleport. Blaze.”

It was an unreasonable area of death.

In it, I tried to fend off Peter who was coming at me.

But the situation now was completely different from before.

“——Dainsleif...!”

“——Tel... eport. Blaze.”

Even the magic that I poured out with all my power only remained 4 percent in this space of death.

I didn't have to think deeply to know how poor the power of my attack was.

Peter, who borrowed the power of the divine device, ignored my attack and charged at me, and it was hard for me to repel him who ran at me without defense.

Peter ignored my check with teleportation and continued to attack me aggressively.

“——Teleport.”

“——Dainsleif!”

It didn't take long for the fight between the two people with extreme compatibility to end.

The moment I lost my balance due to severe exhaustion, Peter's sword mercilessly chased after me.

The flames burst.

And the white sword that cut through the flames.

The dark purple magic sword that ignored all attacks and approached me shone brightly.

Before I knew it, a blade flashed in front of my eyes, and only one name flowed from my mouth, Arien Crost.

“...Aurora.”

The saint of knowledge, Aurora.

As I muttered the name of my long-time lover, red blood splashed in my sight.

The blood that spurted. The dream that scattered. The truth that I couldn't reach.

And beyond that, the fleeting oath that promised eternity that I sought.

In the collapsing dream, my eyes reflected the image of my lover shrouded in darkness.

“...I love you. Forever.”

Splash—.

I, engulfed in shadows, slowly closed my eyes.

It was a second life that I had obtained by chance, but the end was a futile one that didn't suit me.

Chapter 198: Contrast of Black and White (4)

Chapter 198: Contrast of Black and White (4)

The Temple of Abundance, located in Crossbridge.

There, the saint Serena Ederlunt was looking at her trembling hands.

Boom! Bwaaang!

Outside, the blasts were ringing one after another, but that was a trivial matter for Serena now.

The reason why the story she had received a few minutes ago was still haunting her mind.

‘They have to kill the saint?’

A few minutes ago.

An apostle of the evil god had invaded the temple and delivered something to her and left.

It was shocking that he had broken through the barrier that was spread outside the temple, but what was more surprising was the content that the apostle had delivered to Serena.

The evil god wanted to tell her something through his apostle.

To be precise, not to Serena, but to the Goddess of Abundance who was watching over her.

And she, who represented the eyes of the goddess, had no choice but to face that content.

‘Why do they have to kill the saint of harmony in the Temple of Abundance?’

The content that the evil god wanted to deliver to the goddess through her.

It was that Laiteria, the saint of harmony, had to be killed by the Goddess of Abundance.

It was understandable that the evil god wanted to kill the saint.

But it didn’t make sense that the one who asked for it was not the apostle of the evil god, but the Goddess of Abundance whom Serena served.

Why did the Goddess of Abundance have to harm another goddess’s saint with her own hands?

Especially when that target was the saint of harmony who was considered to have helped the evil god.

No matter how she thought about it, she couldn’t understand the evil god’s intention.

‘The saint of harmony was imprisoned, but that was because she betrayed the church. But why do they have to kill the saint of harmony who helped the church...?’

There must have been some dark purpose hidden.

The saint of harmony had fallen for the evil god’s trick, or so they said, trying to sow discord between the Temple of Abundance and the Temple of Harmony.

Maybe the saint of harmony was a victim too.

There was no reason for the evil god’s minions, who had killed Rian Crost, the vice-leader, to show any goodwill to the Temple of Abundance now.

It was reasonable to be wary of the power of Ascalon, which was known to be able to kill even gods.

“O Goddess, guide us on our path——.”

Deep in thought, Serena knelt down and clasped her trembling hands.

When her heart was heavy, the best thing to do was to clear her mind and pray.

After all, the great flow of the world was not something that Serena could resist by herself.

It was the goddess’s will that always led them on the right path.

The brilliant light that illuminated the way forward even in the thick darkness.

That was what Serena Ederlunt had been following until now.

“Give us courage to move forward even in hardship and adversity.”

As Serena closed her eyes and prayed, a warm light flowed around her.

In the flickering light, Serena felt a cozy sensation.

The holy light that the goddess bestowed always protected her.

While praying, she felt like she was in the arms of a merciful mother.

As she prayed, Serena heard the familiar voice of the goddess in her ear.

-“Darkness will cover the world, and a corrupted god will descend by taking a human body.”

-“Evil will stir in the land of harmony.”

Trust.

It was a trust that Serena Ederlunt had received from the goddess after a long time.

And the content of that trust was deeper and darker than the previous ones.

“...The descent of the evil god.”

The evil god would come down to the earth.

That was what her master was telling her.

There was not much that humans could do in the face of the unprecedented disaster of evil's descent.

But it was something that they could not give up on.

-”Prepare for the final battle, chosen hero.”

The place where the evil god would descend was the Temple of Harmony.

And what was needed there was the hero of abundance who had Ascalon.

Serena, who had received the trust from the goddess, opened her eyes that were filled with golden light.

The revelation had fallen, and now there was only one thing that Serena had to do.

She had to find the hero who was out on the battlefield.

“...Gilford Proud.”

The hero of abundance, Gilford Proud.

She had to take him to the Temple of Harmony where the final battle would take place.

The northern part of the continent.

The Alterias region.

The Count Colt, who was sitting in his office in the ducal palace, looked around with a frown.

Ever since it was revealed that Count Colt was a vampire, the imperial army had been besieging the castle for a long time.

He had closed the gates and held on, but the supplies in the castle were slowly running out.

Besides, considering that most of the Alterias region was land where farming was impossible, it was impossible to stay inside the gate forever.

“How... How did this happen to the Colt family!”

Bang!

Count Colt slammed his desk hard and looked around with bloodshot eyes.

In his office, there were nobles who had already become vampires, bowing their heads.

While he was away from his domain, his son, Revoir Colt, had turned all the nobles into vampires.

From the inside, the Colt domain looked like nothing but a den of vampires.

Now it was not something that would end with someone dying.

“The food is running out, and our position in the empire is shrinking day by day. How did you manage the domain while I was gone that it came to this...!”

As Count Colt raged under pressure, one of the nobles who had been listening to his roar with their heads down opened their mouth.

“...Your Grace. I happen to have a solution for the food problem.”

“What did you just say? You can solve the food problem in the castle?”

The Count Colt stopped his rage and looked at the noble who brought up the food problem.

He was already troubled by many complex issues.

He was willing to listen to any solution that could solve at least one problem.

As Count Colt looked at him with a face that asked him to speak, the noble bowed his head and laid out his prepared proposal to the duke.

“Vampires don’t eat bread, they drink blood, right?”

“...”

“If food is the problem... why don’t we turn them all into vampires...”

“Cut off that bastard’s head right now!”

It was a blood-boiling suggestion.

He couldn’t believe that he had put such a person in a high position.

As Count Colt was about to execute the noble, a loud noise came from outside the office window.

Boom! Boom!

Everyone’s eyes turned to the window as they heard the huge sound in their ears.

“What’s that noise?”

The imperial army had been pounding on the gate for days.

So it was not usual for them to look out the window for any level of noise.

But the sound they heard this time was something essentially different from those noises.

Count Colt looked at the scenery beyond the window, and saw smoke rising from a distant place.

It was a completely different direction from the gate that the imperial army had been hitting every day.

“That means the imperial army must have bypassed some of their troops...”

“Yo, Your Grace, over there...”

One of the nobles who was looking out the window shouted in a loud voice.

At the same time, Count Colt’s eyes also spotted something coming from beyond the wall.

What appeared beyond the wall was a huge mass of flesh.

A huge body that rivaled the wall was moving toward us.

“What the hell is that!”

It looked like something that would happen if you twisted and mashed living creatures together.

It was a monster with a shape that made me wonder if the Creator had made a mistake, and it was advancing forward while breaking the wall.

Boom! Boom!

The monster’s advance made the surroundings vibrate.

The monster that broke the wall kept spreading the vibration and approached the ducal palace.

“How can such a monster come out of the mountains!”

“Did the imperial army release that thing...”

“Even the empire can’t create something like that! Do you think humans can control a monster that big!”

Boom. Thud. Boom. Thud.

The heavy footsteps shook Count Colt’s ears.

It was a horrible sound that made goosebumps rise on my back just by hearing it.

What we saw in front of us was a monster that shouldn’t exist in this world.

We couldn’t even guarantee that we could stop it before it reached the palace.

“Your Grace! Something is following behind that thing!”

“There’s more than one monster...”

And behind the massive body that moved forward, there was something of a similar size forming a line and advancing.

Monsters of enormous size were moving in a group.

There was more than one monster in sight.

There were at least ten of them by their numbers.

Monsters that far exceeded human size marched in a line and advanced together.

The sight of the monsters’ army was not something that human soldiers could stop.

“...”

Silence fell on Count Colt's office in an instant.

In front of the overwhelming size of the monsters advancing toward the palace, all their struggles so far became futile.

Outside the gate, the imperial army was waiting for Count Colt's neck.

And from the mountains, monsters that they had never faced before were coming to trample them.

They were in a situation where they could neither move forward nor retreat.

"How did this happen..."

Boom!

The houses lined up on the track collapsed like dominoes.

Crash!

The spire and the forge all fell down, and screams filled the streets.

Even if the imperial army didn't set foot here, the Colt domain was over today.

There would be no residents who wanted to live in the ruined land.

Everyone here sensed that this land, where the history of the Colt family remained, would be abandoned.

"How did this happen... How did the Colt family end up like this."

"Your Grace, you must get away right now."

"Get away... Get away? Yes, I have to flee from here as soon as possible."

"If you give me an order, I will lead the soldiers to the main gate..."

Huh.

Count Colt let out a hollow laugh.

It had been a series of incomprehensible events since when.

He felt too old and weak to keep up with them.

That's why Count Colt decided to let go of everything he had in his hands.

“Open the gate. I surrender.”

Right after Count Colt's last order was delivered to the nobles.

Crash!

The inner wall that was firmly built collapsed.

-You gained 8 karma.

-You gained 24 karma.

-You gained 6 karma.

-You gained 2 karma.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> occurred.

Chapter 199: Fallen Angel: Estasia (1)

Fallen Angel: Estasia (1)

A world where only two people remain.

But it seemed too big to call it that.

When I leaned on the railing of the rooftop with no people, I faced the face I didn't want to face.

The goddess of harmony.

And the goddess of retrogression.

Meeting Estel, who had two faces, was entirely up to her will.

“Are you getting along well with that kid?”

Four days had passed in game time since the battle began.

The situation had been overwhelmingly in our favor.

And the time I spent with Estasia, who came to Earth, was much longer than that.

Since I started living with Estasia from the day I first learned the truth of this world.

So it wasn't strange that Estel asked me if I was doing well.

“Don’t you already know without asking?”

“It takes a lot of effort to interfere with the divine realm.”

It would have been different if Estel and I had a rather tricky relationship.

The goddess in front of me seemed to have no sympathy for human thoughts.

But it was also true that there was no need to provoke her right now.

I would reveal the hidden blade when I was sure I could deal with the target.

It wasn’t time to show the blade yet.

“It seems like there’s something even a great goddess can’t do.”

“I’m no longer harmony here.”

The god of retrogression, Estel.

That was her name here.

She could be anything in the world beyond the smartphone, but what she carried here was nothing but the karma of an evil god.

The name of Estel in front of me confirmed that speculation.

“Did you say the name was important? Then Estel’s name means she’s a god of retrogression.”

“Name... Yeah. Name is important. It’s the only thing that can show who I am now.”

“So the only thing that can show yourself is your name... Is that so?”

Listening to Estel’s story made me feel complicated in my head.

God. World. And fate.

Only two people were left in this world — or so it seemed.

The world was too vast for such a name.

As I leaned on the empty rooftop railing, I came face-to-face with someone I wished to avoid.

The Goddess of Harmony.

And the Goddess of Retrogression.

It was her choice to confront me, Estel, who bore two faces.

“How is that child doing?”

Four days had gone by in game time since the battle started.

We had been dominating the fight ever since.

And I had spent even more time with Estasia, who had arrived on Earth.

I had been living with her since the day I discovered the truth about this world.

So it wasn't surprising that Estel asked me how we were getting along.

“You know the answer without asking, don't you?”

“It's not easy to meddle with the divine realm.”

If only Estel and I didn't have such a complicated relationship.

The goddess before me didn't seem to understand human logic.

But there was no point in antagonizing her now.

I would only unsheathe my blade when I was certain I could finish her off.

It wasn't time for that yet.

"You're a great goddess, but you have your limits too."

"I'm not Harmony here anymore."

She was Estel, the God of Retrogression.

That was her name in this place.

She could be anything she wanted in the world beyond my smartphone, but here she carried the burden of an evil god's fate.

Her name confirmed my suspicions.

"Did you say names were important? Then does Estel mean you're a god of retrogression?"

"Name... Yes. Name matters. It's the only thing that shows who I am now."

"So your name is all you have to define yourself... Is that so?"

Her words made my mind swirl with thoughts.

God. World. Fate.

Big and complicated things were pressing down on my weak self before I knew it.

In the dizzying choices full of irrationality, I was forced to make a choice.

I just wanted a peaceful life.

There were too many things that I sacrificed for a moment of peace.

"That's what it means."

"Yeah. Those great gods live so complicatedly."

Clear sky. The sun shone brightly on the rooftop below.

I sighed with mixed feelings and looked at the black girl next to me.

She was standing there as always.

The only thing that faded in my memory was my miserable self.

Estel smiled with her black eyes shining across the parasol.

“It’s okay. Special things stand out in a complicated world.”

“Seeing that you’re still alive, I guess I was special?”

“In some ways, you’re too ordinary, but in other ways, you can be seen as special.”

She was a capricious goddess.

The wind blowing over the railing shook her and my hair.

Beyond the swaying hair, I looked into Estel’s eyes that resembled black obsidian and asked.

“Why do you want to make me a god if I’m ordinary?”

“Because only you can do it here. The only thing I want from you is that.”

“What do you want?”

“When everything is over, I hope you make this world prosperous. You’re making a world where nothing is left the way you want it.”

It was all up to her from beginning to end.

She said she would give me a chance to escape, but it turned out that it wasn’t everything.

I could tell by the way she brought up the idea of rebuilding the left world.

There would be some consideration for me in there, and her intention to become a god of two worlds would also have a strong influence.

But there was one thing I realized as I listened to this story.

“Let’s make one rule between us.”

At least the descent was not irreversible.

It seemed possible for me to stay there or stay here if I wanted to.

It was her plan to make me rule over two worlds like her.

They would endlessly repeat the cycle of birth and death, depending on each other.

Gods who live together forever.

Not a bad proposal.

In the world beyond the smartphone, she advocated evil, and in the ruined earth, she advocated good.

“You bring light and prosperity to this world, and I destroy this world. That’s how we keep our own world forever.”

If she had made such an offer to me someday, I might have accepted Estel’s offer reluctantly.

If I wasn’t an evil god.

But since Estel made me walk the wrong way for the first time, I had been twisted and broken for a long time.

It was too late to pretend to be good now.

Dyed with emotions that seeped into my bones, I stayed here as I faded away.

“Do whatever you want. It was never my choice from the beginning.”

“Good. You’re a good kid.”

“Just grant me one wish.”

“What wish? If it’s not unreasonable, I can grant you one.”

So I lied.

With a look that had no sincerity left, suppressing the emotions burning in my chest.

I lied to deceive the god in front of me.

“Restore this world to its original state.”

“That’s difficult. I used too much karma. Even if I try, half is all I can do.”

“...”

“Of course, I don’t want to grant such a wish either. But if it’s a simple wish, it’s okay. Don’t you have any other wishes?”

I didn’t think she would grant it from the beginning.

It wasn’t what Estel wanted.

I turned my head away from Estel, who expressed her refusal, and looked at the distant mountains.

But I said something else to deceive her.

“...Then send Aronia here.”

“One angel wasn’t enough for you, huh? Fine. But it will take me a few days even if I start now.”

The sky was clear and blue without a cloud in sight.

But I had a feeling it would rain soon.

That was my intuition speaking.

I sensed a downpour looming under the darkening sky.

“I hope he gets here before the war ends.”

Of course, my intuition wasn't very reliable most of the time.

The First Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost.

She felt exhausted from fighting for days on end, but she pushed through the fatigue and kept moving.

This was a war for her one and only god.

She couldn't afford to fail her duty here and ruin his grand plan.

She couldn't bear to lose sight of him whom she had longed for so long.

“...”

Clack. Clack.

Her footsteps echoed under the silent stairs.

The stairs led to the underground chamber of the Temple of Knowledge. It was a narrow and dark place.

Not everyone was allowed to enter there, as it housed the vital relics that sustained the holy land.

Only a few chosen ones could access this place in the holy land.

“So, the intruders have finally reached here.”

As Eutenia arrived at the end of the corridor after descending the long stairs, a voice greeted her.

It belonged to a woman.

A very old woman in her twilight years.

Her dim eyes that betrayed her age met Eutenia's.

The elderly nun standing before Eutenia had no weapons in her hands.

She only held a thick scripture with both hands.

“Who are you...?”

“I am Aurora, the Holy Maiden of Knowledge who guards this place.”

She looked similar to Eutenia, who clutched the miracle bestowed by the great one, the Grimoire.

The only difference between them was that their faith had different endings.

Eutenia nodded coldly as Aurora introduced herself.

It was no trouble to grant her a chance to fulfill her role, as she wished to do her best until the last moment.

“Is that so.”

“Then may I ask for your name?”

“...The first servant of the great one, Eutenia Hyrost.”

“Eutenia. A fine name.”

Eutenia thought so too.

Her father must have gone through a lot of trouble to name her.

She used to hear that story often when she was young.

But now she had strayed too far to listen to such a story.

For her, who was stained with blood, the social life of a noble lady was a fleeting dream.

“It’s been a long time since I heard such a story.”

“I had a time like you too... but now too much time has passed.”

Aurora said that and gave a faint smile, looking at the empty glass tube.

It was a smile that seemed bitter and yet nostalgic for the glorious past.

The Holy Maiden of Knowledge gripped the scripture tighter in her hands.

A ring with a missing jewel was stuck between her thin fingers.

“Did you use the forbidden method?”

“...Everyone in the holy land agreed. We had no other way.”

“You called them worshippers of the evil god and despised them, but in the end you were no different.”

“I wanted to dream a little.”

There was a price to pay for going against reason.

It was even more so for opening the sky.

They were calmly using a method that only the cult that despised evil would use.

Clack—.

Eutenia left the hypocritical saintess behind and headed for the primal heart behind her.

“There’s no use in me stopping you here. This old woman has no strength left.”

The glorious era dedicated to the six goddesses was slowly coming to an end.

The faith of everyone hiding in the continent would not disappear in an instant, but as time passed, the old faith would gradually crumble.

The saintess of the old era facing Eutenia would also disappear in the fading history.

The only thing that history recorded was the story of the winner.

The flames that burned in the midst of conflicting beliefs would fade away, except for the most intense one.

“The great one is different from the fakes you serve. I’ve been working hard to see him.”

“...It would have been nice if someone like you became the next saintess of knowledge. It’s a pity.”

“It’s the right thing. He was the only one who reached out to me at that moment.”

The shadow that spread on the floor followed the sound of footsteps.

The shadow of the apostle that covered the ground soon took over the whole space.

Eutenia’s footsteps passed Aurora and stopped in front of the primal heart.

The huge jewel that contained light was more beautiful than any jewel in the world.

Eutenia reached out to the primal heart and asked Aurora behind her.

“Is the story over?”

“Goddess, guide us——.”

“Well, goodbye.”

At the moment when Eutenia’s last greeting to Aurora ended.

Thud, thump—!

Sharp spikes of shadow pierced Aurora’s abdomen.

Blood drops fell in the swaying darkness, and a heavy something fell with a thud.

Chapter 200: Fallen Angel: Estasia (2)

Fallen Angel: Estasia (2)

The Imperial Palace, located in the center of Crossbridge.

There, Peter looked at his enemy in front of him with a troubled eye.

He thought the fight would be easy after he dealt with Arien Crost, the strongest in the holy land, but contrary to his expectations, there were many strong enemies left in the holy land.

One of them was the old man of Varna who was in front of Peter right now.

The old man's body, which tore his shirt and exposed his upper body, looked sturdy unlike his age.

“Evil heretics cannot step on the threshold of the Imperial Palace.”

Emperor, Highpright II.

He flexed his impressive muscles and unleashed a massive amount of divine power.

Peter had thought he was a frail old man when he first encountered him.

But when the emperor revealed his full strength, he turned out to be nothing like what Peter had imagined.

Highpright II seemed to defy age itself. He possessed a physical prowess that even the knights of the holy land could not match.

Peter had no idea how much training it would take to reach that level.

“...This is absurd.”

Peter wiped the blood from his lips and glared at Highright II.

He had assumed that the emperor was a powerful cleric who wielded miracles from afar with a staff. He had charged at him without hesitation.

That assumption was shattered when he received several blows from Highright II's fists.

He was a martial artist who fought with his bare hands.

His aged appearance concealed a mysterious skill that seemed beyond his years.

“Foolish heretics. Do not rely on your miracles and act arrogantly.”

“...”

To make matters worse, the old man's waist was adorned with various holy relics.

The combined force of his fists and holy relics was too much for Peter's white sword and cloak to handle.

He could suppress some of the power of the holy relics by invoking a sanctuary. But right now, another apostle was maintaining the sanctuary instead of Peter.

He had to rely on pure speed using Dainsleif. But Highright II was also superior in reaction speed and combat sense compared to Arien, who was a mage.

If he carelessly closed the gap, he would only get punched and flee.

“The history of Crossbridge is not so light that it can be destroyed by the corrupted ones.”

“I don’t know about that...”

Peter straightened his body and spoke again.

Unlike the Imperial Palace in the center of Crossbridge, the six temples that made up the holy land were not in good condition.

Two bridges leading to two temples had been destroyed, one hero had been disabled, and there was also a saintess who had lost her life.

And they had also secured the item they were aiming for.

The reinforcements from the kingdom had departed, but it would not be easy to approach the holy land with the black sky spread out.

“You know, if you take off all those things on your waist and fight me, you might lose to me.”

“What...?”

“If you’re confident, take them off and come at me.”

If this boring fight continued, it meant that the cult would win in the end.

Knowing that, Peter continued to fight.

As time passed, Dainsleif’s power grew stronger, and Peter, who experienced the battle with his body, also grew more.

Time was on Peter and Dainsleif’s side.

“You’re not confident? All the great clerics think alike.”

“...Foolish heretics.”

“I’m not going to let go of the things I’m holding in my hand.”

Clang.

Peter tilted his twin swords and took his stance.

There was a faint smile on Peter's lips as he pointed his swords at him.

He was no longer afraid of how strong his opponent was.

He was not the weak country boy he used to be since he held the two swords.

“Goddess, guide us——.”

“Evil god! Guide me too! And make me faster than that guy!”

It was now the era of Apostle Peter.

A warm and cozy feeling.

But I felt a strange tickle in my nose, and I felt my consciousness floating.

Blink. Blink.

When I woke up from a sleep I didn't know when I fell into, I saw a white wing covering me.

I could tell whose wing it was without looking at his face.

It was a white wing with thick feathers.

Next to me, I saw Estasia lying on the bed and watching TV.

“Strawberry ice cream... It looks delicious.”

Flap.

Estasia's wings trembled slightly as she watched the ice cream ad.

I looked at her wings and then gently bit one of them.

Chomp.

With a bit of force in my teeth, Estasia screamed and flew high into the sky.

“Eek...!”

Thud.

Estasia hit her head on the ceiling and fell on the bed.

She had flown once and came back. She started to curl up and hold her head.

She must have hit her head pretty hard on the ceiling.

I saw Estasia curling up on the bed and a smile formed on my lips.

“Not bad for a blanket.”

“...You’re a bad person, master.”

Estasia buried her head in the blanket and muttered a small complaint to me.

A bad person.

She had changed her word from last time.

Maybe she had adapted to the human-centered perspective by watching TV, or maybe she had blurted out something in panic.

She still had an amusing reaction.

“Then I’ll confiscate your ice cream for a while.”

“Actually, Estasia was a bad angel who lied.”

“Yeah? Then it’s not my fault.”

“That’s right. Master did nothing wrong.”

It was hard to imagine this when I faced Estasia through my smartphone.

She was so quick-witted that she blocked most of my pranks back then.

But now Estasia was burying her head in the blanket next to me.

I ruffled her hair a little and picked up my smartphone from the corner of the bed.

“Estasia. How long have I been sleeping?”

“I don’t know. I found you sleeping on the roof and brought you to this room.”

“Collapsed on the roof... Oh, was it because of Estelle?”

I was spending time alone on the roof when I met Estelle and talked to her.

She must have left me asleep after we finished talking.

The time on my smartphone wasn’t much different from when I was on the roof.

It was proof that Estelle’s influence on me was decreasing as time passed.

Maybe it had something to do with me becoming closer to a complete god.

“You’re still a vile character.”

He was hard to like no matter how I thought about it.

He was adept at playing with people like toys.

He didn’t treat his fellow gods much differently either. It didn’t seem like it would end well even if he was with Estelle.

Of course, I wouldn’t make such a choice by my own will.

I snorted and teased Estelle for a while, then pressed the button on my smartphone to turn on the screen.

“Are you checking the war first?”

“I have to. It looks like it’s getting closer to a stalemate, but I still have to hold out in the holy land for a while.”

Swoosh.

As soon as I started the game, the progress of the <Descent> quest came into my sight first.

It was written as a quest, but it was actually a requirement that Estelle wanted from me.

The progress of the quest that I could see at a glance was very different from before the war.

-The progress of <Descent> will increase by one step for each of the following conditions met:

Available karma: 882331 / 999999 (Incomplete)

-[Holy Relic: Ergus’s Stake]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

-[Philosopher’s Stone]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

-[Origin Heart]: 1 / 1 (Complete)

-Create a body for Descent (Complete)

The quest to obtain the [Origin Heart] was completed.

Eutenia had managed to access the place where the [Origin Heart] was kept and obtained the target.

The temples were far apart from each other, and it was nearly impossible to defend them all with the holy land’s forces.

That's why it was only natural that we got the [Origin Heart] sooner than the end of the war.

There were also many casualties among the believers in the process of taking over the temples.

"...I wish I could have intervened more."

In this war, I only intervened when it was absolutely necessary.

It was because my power was quickly drained by the apostles using magic simultaneously.

My power recovered a bit every hour, but the apostles also consumed a lot as they continued to fight.

If I used too much power, I might leave the other apostles vulnerable.

So I only acted when I thought my intervention was needed.

It was unavoidable that I saw the faces of the believers who couldn't be saved.

"The karma supply is also much faster. It doesn't seem like there's much left until we reach a million."

The accumulated karma was also rapidly approaching a million.

Most of the huge karma supply came from the war that was raging in the empire.

From Centrius, where the cult's headquarters was located, to the northern part of the continent where Arcrosis was, the flames of war were spreading everywhere.

At the center of such an empire, Emperor Aicliff was stirring up the war.

A large amount of karma was coming in because of the civil war that erupted in all directions.

“...A million karma. It seemed like a number that would never be within my reach.”

It was a huge amount of karma, regardless of my growth level.

It was not easy to estimate how long it would take to collect that much karma.

Yet, I was close to achieving my goal.

At this pace, I would reach a million karma in no time.

“What happens when you collect all the karma?”

“Well, I don’t know either.”

What situation would I face when I reached a million karma?

I had no clue about that.

But I knew clearly what I had to do after that.

I had prepared many things for that purpose.

“I’ll have to make a grand spectacle. I made that promise with her.”

The message I sent to the goddess of abundance without Estelle knowing.

The contract we made under the sky of karma was still valid.

Since my biggest goal was to stop Estelle’s plan, there would be some deviations from my original goal.

But I was sure that Estelle’s reaction to the gift I prepared would be intense.

“Shall we start the countdown?”

I got up from my seat and spoke to Estasia, who was wrapped in a blanket.

I couldn't miss the preparations for a good day.

Alcohol and food. And a cannon for a monument.

I decided to prepare what might be the last supper for me and Estasia here.

“Let's make egg fried rice today. It's a special day.”

“We had egg fried rice yesterday too.”

“That was golden fried rice.”

“...”

Chapter 201: Fallen Angel: Estasia

(3)

Chapter 201: Fallen Angel: Estasia (3)

As he watched the crumbling castle, Aicliffe had a complicated expression on his face.

He wanted to be the emperor.

And now, he had only a few enemies left in front of him.

The Duke of Colt, who supported the third prince, had already fallen, and the Duke of Obtos, who backed the first prince, was also losing his power.

Moreover, the royal forces were also dwindling due to the simultaneous rebellions.

“What a pity.”

The emperor’s throne that he had longed for was no longer far away.

The noble factions that were like iron walls collapsed in an instant.

The emperor’s authority that seemed eternal was gradually eroding.

To the divine will, human power was nothing but a castle on the sand.

In the end, for the gods, the human empire was worth only that much.

“It turns out that the glorious empire I dreamed of was an illusion.”

He only had to move forward a little more to reach the emperor's seat.

The world had been moving to make him the emperor.

And the empire he faced at the end would not be the old empire he had admired.

The future empire would be the same.

He would someday become the emperor of a ruined empire.

Because the god he made a contract with allowed it.

“Did I have nothing I could do with my own power?”

But he wondered if he was really necessary for that process.

Anyone who stood in this position could have become the emperor.

Even a street rat from a back alley, or a farmer from a rural village, could become the emperor by being here.

In the end, for the great being, he was just a part that was there.

And the contract with the god would follow him for his whole life.

“I'll have to change the state religion when I become the emperor.”

Everything stemmed from Aicliffe's own choice.

He promised his future to a great being.

He also vowed to offer anything as a price.

He obtained the empire that way, and even that it played on the palm of the god, it was all Aicliffe's choice.

The Temple of Abundance, located in Crossbridge.

For days, he fought in the endless battle, his face covered with blood and burns.

Drip.

He dragged his sword, Ascalon, along the ground and looked at its tip.

The divine artifact, bestowed by the heavenly goddess, never dulled no matter how many enemies he cut down.

It was something he could never dream of when he was a mercenary.

“Kill the hero!”

“Prepare the miracle!”

In front of him, the heretics were keeping their distance from Ascalon.

He had killed countless heretics with his own hands, but there were still many of them left.

The apostle of the enemy he had defeated before must have healed by now.

He had wanted to fight against the cult, but he never wished for the battle with these pests to drag on so long.

His desired opponents were the evil god and his apostles.

Not these annoying heretics who threw their lives away.

“——Ascalon.”

He called the name of the artifact and swung his sword vertically, sending a huge wave of magic that shook his legs.

Boom!

With a loud noise, some of the heretics blocking his sight fell down.

The remaining heretics were regrouping and approaching him.

Tsk. He clicked his tongue and lifted Ascalon, waiting for the enemies to come closer.

“——O goddess, guide me.”

Fwoosh—.

A familiar prayer sounded from behind him, and a warm light wrapped around his body.

The holy power that enveloped his whole body slowly healed his wounds.

The sacred light infused his weary body with strong vitality.

He felt his mind clear up and turned his head to glance behind him.

“Didn’t I tell you it’s dangerous?”

The saintess of abundance was standing behind him, having come closer without him noticing.

Gilford spoke in a grumpy voice to Serena, who had appeared before him.

They had never gotten along well, neither in the past nor in the present.

They were only working together out of necessity.

Serena approached him and whispered in his ear as he heard his voice.

“We should get ready to move soon. Finish off the heretics as quickly as possible.”

She told him that they had to deal with the heretics fast.

It was the first time Serena had taken the initiative to talk about the strategy.

Gilford asked her in a puzzled voice, wondering what she was talking about.

“What are you saying?”

“The evil god is descending.”

“...”

He closed his mouth as he heard that.

It was the most shocking news he had ever heard.

It meant that the heroes who had defended the holy land had failed, and that the cult of the evil god had achieved their goal.

The evil god who had ruled over the world from the sky.

No one could predict what would happen if he descended to the earth.

“You’re the only hero who can stop the evil god. You don’t want to miss this opportunity, do you?”

Serena added more explanation to the stunned Gilford.

She said that he was their only hope.

Gilford’s face became even more grim than before.

“You’re saying I can kill the evil god with my own hands...?”

“The evil god will have trouble controlling his power right after his descent. Maybe you can reach him with the power of Ascalon, the divine artifact.”

Gilford had heard that before.

He had heard that Ascalon could even kill a god.

He also remembered that Ascalon had confirmed that.

And now, the saintess behind him was telling him the same thing.

“I don’t know if it’s a complete death. But it’s a sure way to keep them from setting foot in this world for a while.”

What kind of being was the evil god?

He was the one who had killed Gilford’s precious comrades through his apostles.

His dream of remaining a mercenary had also been shattered by the evil god.

He still vividly remembered the sight of Gaph, who had died in a miserable state, bleeding.

And now, he finally had a chance to face the evil god himself.

“A way to kill the evil god...”

He didn’t know if he could reach the evil god.

The operation could fail, and he could lose his life with his sword broken.

They were heroes who had failed to defend the holy land.

If his opponent was the evil god, it would be an absurd probability.

But still, Gilford decided to stake everything on that faint possibility.

“We don’t have time. We have to move fast.”

“...Fine. Let’s go.”

Gilford smiled.

He was a hero.

Before he swung his sword in vengeance, he was a hero who had a mission to protect the world.

After having a quiet meal with Estasia, I was drinking beer in my room.

I knew that I didn't have much time left to enjoy like this, so I was spending a miserable time with beer.

Estasia, on the other hand, had piled up ice cream like a mountain.

I had allowed her all the snacks, thinking that it might be our last time together.

She had taken out all the ice cream from the freezer and opened the lids.

It was like a last supper for those who were waiting for destruction.

“Strawberry, vanilla... This time, vanilla...”

As I watched Estasia eat the ice cream one spoonful at a time, I remembered our first meeting.

She was summoned by an item whose name I couldn't even remember properly.

She was so lazy that she went into a cave as soon as she came down to the ground, and only came out the next day.

She was the opposite of Kueberg, who worked hard from the first day.

Well, that personality was also part of what made Estasia who she was now.

“The goddesses must be in trouble. They only have useless angels to exploit.”

I said that to Estasia as I took a sip of beer, and she shook her head with a spoon in her mouth.

She was trying to deny what I said somehow.

She swallowed all the ice cream in her mouth and spoke with a troubled expression.

“Most angels are diligent.”

“Not the one I know.”

“I guess I shouldn’t have been born as an angel.”

She said that and scooped up more ice cream and stuffed it in her mouth.

Estasia, who was not an angel.

It was not an easy image to imagine in my head.

No matter what she looked like when she was born, Estasia would find a way to be lazy.

In the end, all the images converged to the Estasia in front of me.

“Isn’t there anything good about being an angel?”

“Angels have to pray every day and do their best in their given roles.”

“Don’t you just have to do what you’re given?”

“There’s no ice cream and strawberries are hard to get. Especially Aronia, she didn’t want to give me any strawberries.”

After all, no angel would want to share snacks with a lazy and gluttonous angel.

For Estasia, living here with minimal work and freedom would be a better life than being an angel.

She suited that kind of life well.

As long as this situation continued, I had no intention of interfering with her.

But I wondered how long this world would tolerate that.

-Available karma: 991247 / 999999 (Incomplete)

I looked at the screen of my smartphone, which I had tilted slightly.

As if to prove the fierce situation of the continent, the karma numbers displayed on the screen kept rising.

People were dying at an excessively fast pace for a war.

Most of it was karma caused by the massacre that Arcrosis was committing.

In a little more time, the accumulated karma would reach a million.

“Well, that’s the way of life you chose.”

“So I’m happiest now.”

Snicker.

I couldn’t help but smile.

She was always fun to meet.

Except for the fact that she annoyed everyone around her.

“Is it almost time?”

The numbers on the smartphone screen started to rise quickly.

The numbers were too close to count down.

I repeated the numbers on the screen in my head irregularly.

One. And then another one.

The moment the numbers I was slowly counting in my head all aligned to the same digit.

-Available karma: 999999 / 999999 (Complete)

-You have met all the conditions for the <Descent> skill.

I was able to face the message I had been waiting for so long.

Chapter 202: Fallen Angel: Estasia

(4)

Fallen Angel: Estasia (4)

-Every time you meet the following conditions, the progress of <Descent> increases by one step.

-Available Karma: 999999 / 999999 (Completed)

-[Sacred Relic: Ergus's Stake]: 1 / 1 (Completed)

-[Philosopher's Stone]: 1 / 1 (Completed)

-[Origin of Heart]: 1 / 1 (Completed)

-Making a body for Descent (Completed)

One million karma.

The moment that Life Up reached that special number I had been waiting for.

Guidance messages from the smartphone burst out one after another.

They were like a huge wave, constantly popping up repeating messages without stopping.

They were a salute announcing the birth of a great god.

-You have reached the maximum level.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Device: Smartphone] has been freed by one step.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Device: Smartphone] has been freed by one step.

As soon as the accumulated karma reached one million, I jumped up from my seat.

The connection with <Karma's Sky> was getting stronger.

There was no more time to spend leisurely.

Estasia, who was on the opposite side, also put down her ice cream and got up from her seat.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Device: Smartphone] has been freed by one step.

-A high level of <Causality Adjustment> has occurred.

-Due to <Causality Adjustment>, [Divine Device: Smartphone] has been freed by one step.

As the power of the smartphone was released by causality adjustment, I felt that I was different from my previous self.

God. Apostle. Hero. Saintess.

Numerous concepts turned my head upside down.

In the midst of the brilliant waves of knowledge, I had to hold on to my center to the limit.

<Karma's Sky> acknowledged the new god.

It recognized that I, who had been isolated on Earth alone, was not a mere human, but a new god of this world.

“...”

The pillow of truth.

The impossible knowledge that only great beings are allowed to enter my head.

I couldn't spit it out with my mouth, and I couldn't understand it even if I heard it with my ears.

I understand it.

I can't understand it.

And I understand it again.

The human shell that accepts the fragmented truth splits and splits.

“Ha...”

I die just by understanding it.

The pillow of truth.

The impossible knowledge that only great beings were allowed to enter my head.

Information about everything flowed in. I couldn't spit it out with my mouth, nor could I understand it even if I heard it with my ears.

I understood.

I couldn't understand.

And I understood again.

The human shell that accepted the fragmented truth split and split.

“Ha...”

I gasped in agony as I died just by understanding.

There was knowledge that mortals could never reach, even if they stretched their hands for a lifetime.

Everyone who chased knowledge wanted to know it. And there were also those who devoted their lives to reach it.

But no one ever touched the truth.

That’s what the truth was.

It eluded those who were alive. And it trapped those who had death.

The great principle was composed of one clear story.

But it was simple. So simple that it screened out those who were unworthy of being its owner.

‘Did Estelle show me this?’

There was a qualification for the soul.

There was an unknown realm that humans could not access, no matter how many times they died and were reborn.

Someone would call it a qualification.

The qualification to rule over everything.

The qualification not to be challenged by any creature.

Under the absolute concept, the gods’ power ruled over the creation.

I was no exception.

My life started under someone's concept. And it was also built on someone's understanding.

And in the end, I acquired a qualification that was forbidden for a short life.

A concept that existed for God.

The castle of understanding, built on top of all kinds of misunderstandings, was waiting for its owner high up.

'Did I live for this kind of thing?'

There was a concept that followed God.

I had a concept that represented my entire short life.

Destruction.

I was destruction.

Just by looking at me, they dropped their lives into hell.

And just by loving me, they made their fates collapse.

I was born with the fate of destruction.

And everything I loved collapsed under their own fate.

I was the god of destruction.

"...Yeah, that's what you're saying."

It was a cruel joke of fate.

From beginning to end, she played a terrible prank on me.

Estelle knew what kind of god I would become.

She also knew what fate I would face, and what expression I would make when I faced the truth.

She must have already understood what kind of ending would come when I rebuilt this world, followed by destruction.

“Fine. Let’s play along as you wish.”

But even at this moment, I realized that there was a new possibility.

A loyal dog does not bite its master.

In the same way, this concept of destruction was nothing more than a principle that followed the god.

It destroyed even the fate of destruction.

I had to be the one who ruled over that fate.

“Let’s see what happens if we go all the way.”

I thought of Estelle, who would be smiling in her head.

Then I shook my head and looked around the narrow room.

There were truths that I could only face after reaching the pillow of truth.

Why did God send his lion?

There was only one reason. Because it was more efficient than doing it himself.

For them, the land where humans lived was something of another dimension that could not be interfered with without tools.

And Karma’s Sky was a tool of interference that existed for those gods.

‘God. And angels.’

In that sense, angels were the closest tools to God.

They were born for God, and their only mission was to convey God's will.

The only way for me, who had nothing, to interfere most strongly in this world was also one.

I needed my own angel.

An angel who could move and fight for me, who had become an evil god.

An angel who had to exist if I didn't have one.

'And the angel who would help me...'

It was Estelle, of course.

I grabbed the angel's shoulder, who was hesitating, even harder.

The pure white wings fluttered and the white feathers flew.

The bright halo took away my eyesight.

It was the last day for her as an angel to call miracles.

From now on, her prayers would be songs that bring destruction.

There was no reason to suffer anymore even if I didn't do anything soaked in laziness.

"It's the command of your god."

"..."

"Let's go to hell together. Estasia."

"..."

"I'll be with you until the bottom of hell."

No matter what was at the end.

We would be together at the moment of arrival.

So I decided.

I would fall to the bottom of this world with her.

What was below the abyss?

I was going to check it out from now on.

“So—”

Fall, Estasia.

As soon as I spat out that word, I kissed Estasia.

Her halo turned black and the light that lit up the room faded away.

Under the dying light, the white wings turned black.

Black feathers spread out with the fluttering wings, and Estasia, who met my eyes under them, was there.

“...!”

Estasia’s breath burst out as she had been holding back, and the angel dyed in black light looked at me.

A small crown made of darkness was placed on Estasia’s head.

The white wings turned black and the tainted halo emitted a sinister aura.

Only the bright silver hair was the only trace that could find her original appearance.

In the rough breath, I opened my mouth to Estasia.

It was a story about the promise we made.

“That was the promise, right? I’ll be with you until the last moment.”

“That... was a promise.”

Under the moonlight coming through the window, the black angel touched her lips with a blank face.

She looked at me with a dazed eye, stroked her halo once, and looked at me again with a blank eye.

Flutter.

The black wings fluttered and sprinkled feathers that absorbed light around them.

Now I smiled faintly at Estasia, who was scattering black trash.

“So keep your promise.”

“You’re a bad person, master.”

“I know. But it’s okay now that you don’t have to live like an angel anymore.”

Estasia’s slender fingers picked up one of the feathers that flew around.

The black feather sparkled in the moonlight.

She looked at me with a dissatisfied eye while holding the feather.

“The fallen angel will eat five ice creams a day.”

“I don’t care.”

It was already what I was doing.

“The fallen angel won’t care if feathers fall on the bed.”

“It’s okay.”

I had been cleaning up half of the feathers from the beginning.

“The fallen angel will also eat snacks on the bed.”

“As much as you want.”

Estasia was always eating something on the bed when I came back from going out.

“The fallen angel won’t do any cleaning.”

“I’ll forgive you for that too.”

She mostly pretended to clean when I told her to do so.

“Sometimes I might accidentally break things that you like and make you angry.”

“Well, there might be days like that once in a while.”

There were also days that were hard to see as simple pranks. I had let them pass by several times.

“If I can’t eat strawberries, I might nag you all day long.”

“If that’s how you live, there’s nothing I can do about it.”

Thud.

She stepped closer to me and looked into my eyes.

My seventh apostle on Earth was an angel who shone brightly even in the dark.

“But you’re a bad person, master.”

This time, she hugged my neck.

Our lips met again as our eyes locked.

What followed was the sweet trace of ice cream that filled my mouth.

Chapter 203: Descent of the Evil God (1)

Chapter 203: Descent of the Evil God (1)

Crossbridge, the Temple of Harmony.

In the space where the saintess tied to a pillar and the fallen knight were, Eutenia's shadow spat out something on the ground.

What came out of the swaying shadow was a transparent glass tube that showed a boy with his eyes closed.

Eutenia placed the glass tube in the center of the temple and looked around.

She saw the figure of Laiteria, who was tied to a pillar, in her sight as she turned her head.

"It's okay to start the ritual now."

Laiteria, the saintess of harmony, gave her advice with a pure smile.

Even though the knight who was guarding her in front of her eyes fell, she was still calm.

She even tried to help Eutenia, who was starting the ritual.

Eutenia, who had completely taken over the temple of harmony, could not easily understand Laiteria's behavior.

"I don't understand."

This temple was an unpleasant place for Eutenia, an apostle.

If her master hadn't wanted her to perform the ritual in this place, Eutenia wouldn't have come here.

It was a risky act to perform a ritual near the battlefield.

But it was after the great being had already given the order for the ritual.

It was also part of that order that she didn't kill Laiteria and subdued her.

"Why do you, a saintess of harmony, want to help me?"

"It's much more fun that way."

"..."

"The ritual of God's descent is not something you can do often. If you fail, you'll be in trouble too, won't you?"

It was still an incomprehensible answer.

It was natural for an apostle who served the goddess of harmony to be hostile to the cult.

Just like Eutenia didn't like the six temples.

"——Desire. Crave."

"——Praise by tearing your throat under the great name."

The light that seeped through the stained glass of the temple split and drew shapes.

The faint glimmer became a line, and a streak of line became a pillar of light.

Under the pillar of light that connected the sky and the earth, Eutenia smiled brightly.

All things in heaven and earth were singing with joy at the appearance of the god.

“——Pray. Worship.”

“——Praise until your flesh rots away.”

Crackle. Fizzle.

From the pillar of light that pierced the glass tube, countless sparks flew up.

The transcendent's flesh, wrapped in a massive light, began to blur and spread.

A great power that could not be handled by a mere human's flesh was descending to the earth.

Even an ignorant person could guess what would come at the end of this ritual.

“——Revere. Adore. Obey.”

The end was approaching for the long ritual as well.

Before long, the grimoire that had turned to the last page shook weakly.

The unknown light that had enveloped Eutenia, the apostle, also faded slowly.

With the turning page in front of her, Eutenia recited the last phrase for the descent.

“——The great one has returned.”

At the moment when Eutenia's last prayer ended quietly.

The pillar of light that connected the heaven and earth became a line and disappeared.

Clatter. Clatter—.

The stained glass that covered the ceiling of the temple shattered and collapsed, and the temple that was filled with dazzling light also darkened.

Eutenia felt cozy in the darkness that descended to the earth.

The overwhelming presence that filled the space was the root of her power that had split off.

“...”

“Finally...”

The black-haired boy who had closed his eyes for a long time opened them in the darkness.

Even in the terrible darkness, his black eyes revealed his menacing presence.

Eutenia realized that she was facing a great dignity that seemed unreachable.

“Finally... have you come?”

After overcoming countless hardships and adversities.

She finally realized that her master had come to this world.

Darkness.

Under the huge darkness that dazzled my eyes, I looked down and saw my hand.

It was smaller than my original self.

The discomfort I felt in my neck was also different from my usual self.

It felt awkward as if it was not mine, even though it was my flesh.

“...”

And what followed was a sense of omnipotence that filled my whole body.

A feeling that I could do anything.

The god's sight that looked down on all living creatures on the ground was unfolding before my eyes.

There was only one reason why such a sensation came from my body.

Descent.

It was because the moment that Estelle had designated as the end of the journey had finally arrived.

“Finally... have you come?”

The girl who met my eyes for the first time also appeared in my awkward sight.

She felt familiar yet strange, and she pierced through the thick darkness that settled around and approached me.

Her steps were a bit fast, but also a bit light, and they quickly narrowed the distance between us.

The girl who came to me in no time showed me one action.

“My god... I really wanted to see you for a long time.”

Squeeze.

The girl grabbed my hand tightly and smiled brightly.

There were glistening tears in her eyes as she smiled brightly.

The First Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost.

The apostle that I had created for the first time in this world kissed the back of my hand politely.

“...Eutenia.”

She showed respect to the awe-inspiring god as much as possible.

I reached out to her head.

Now it was not beyond the small screen of a smartphone, but a clear sensation that touched my hand directly.

Swoosh.

The first touch that reached her head made the memories of the past flash through my mind.

“My apostle is still loyal.”

The memory of knocking down the bandits who chased Eutenia.

The memory of giving her a cake along with an artifact.

The memory of her working hard to create a cult after becoming an apostle.

The memory of watching her do her best for any mission I gave her.

The memory of smiling at her eating bread in the conference room.

Countless memories of the two that could not be expressed in words bloomed in the silence as many thoughts.

“I really... really wanted to see you.”

Thud. Thump.

A few drops of tears fell on my hand that was holding Eutenia's.

Her emotions flowed into me through our clasped hands.

Even though she was with the cult, Eutenia always lived in loneliness.

The only thing she truly relied on and opened her heart to was the great heavenly being that she believed and followed.

“...”

My lips trembled as I faced Eutenia.

What should I say to her?

What should I tell the apostle who had waited for me for so long?

I had to think hard as I faced the meeting I had longed for.

Even though I had become a god who could manipulate the fate of humans, I could not utter a single word freely.

“I only have... the great one now...”

How ironic.

I wanted the power to fight against Estelle, but I had to struggle to find something to say to the apostle in front of me.

The great being became even weaker in front of the apostle.

Maybe it was because I had become a great being that I had to worry more.

I always had to be a stern god in front of her.

I did not want to show my weak and pathetic self to the apostles.

-“Lift your head.”

I had to be a perfect god in front of the apostles.

They had to look up to me, worship me, rely on me, and depend on me.

I did not want to disappoint the apostles who believed and followed me.

So, I decided to keep pretending to be a god.

I decided to become the most great being that she had admired.

“Great one...”

-“Your god promises you.”

My story from long ago was spread to the world through a divine translator.

That was because I did not have the dignity that suited a god at that time.

And now, I was telling Eutenia my story with my own mouth.

As we looked into each other’s eyes, I told her my sincere story.

-“I will be with you.”

-“I will save you in times of hardship, and guide you in times of adversity.”

I did not need a translator to imitate a god for me anymore.

From now on, my story was enough to be delivered by my own mouth.

Whoosh.

The darkness that filled the space moved and lifted Eutenia’s body into the air.

“Ah...?”

Eutenia, who was floating in the air, reached out her hand in confusion.

I firmly grabbed her hand and looked at her seriously as she looked down at me.

I was not sure if I could keep my promise.

But I still hoped that my promise would last forever.

-“I will be your god. Forever.”

As I told Eutenia my story with a flushed face,

Flash—!

The ruby ring on her ring finger emitted light.

Beyond the ring that emitted bright light, someone’s figure leaning on a pillar was faintly visible.

“...You should think a little about the people who are watching.”

Hoo.

A short sigh and a familiar voice echoed in my ears.

Chapter 204: The Descent of the Evil God (2)

Chapter 204: The Descent of the Evil God (2)

I didn't need to wonder who the owner of the voice was.

There was only one being who could walk around with such leisure in the temple of Harmony that had been occupied by the cult.

The goddess of Harmony.

She had descended into the body of the saintess who served her and was watching us.

I pulled Eutenia, who was floating in the air, into my arms and greeted the goddess of Harmony, who had cut off the rope and came out.

-“I didn't expect to see you here.”

“What a nice way of speaking. You're quite different from usual.”

The smartphone with the power of the divine was only for the being in front of me.

It wasn't strange that she could use it freely.

She had revealed herself to me through a temporary divine manifestation.

The goddess of Harmony, who appeared by cutting through the darkness, smiled at me and Eutenia.

Of course, there was no way that a physical restraint could have a lasting effect on a god.

-“It depends on who I’m dealing with.”

“That makes me a little sad.”

I suppressed my inner feelings as I looked at the goddess of Harmony who appeared in front of me.

She was here according to my calculations.

I had performed the ritual in this place from the beginning for that purpose.

The important thing was from now on.

The descent was just the first step for the future plan.

“How do you like your new body? I helped you out a bit.”

-“It’s not bad, considering.”

“Couldn’t you praise me a little more? The child you cherish must have worked hard too.”

As I responded appropriately to the conversation that came from the being in front of me, I began to feel the gap between my body and mind.

The body that was here now was created to share and control the senses.

Somewhere in my consciousness, there must have been my original body that was facing Estasia.

Thanks to the fragment of truth that I gained by becoming a god, I had some clues.

I followed those clues and moved on, holding Eutenia’s head tightly in my arms.

-“You did well. Eutenia.”

“Yes...”

I continued to move my consciousness busily to find a point somewhere.

Estelle had two divine statuses and was active freely in two worlds.

I didn't think it would be impossible for me to do the same.

In an instant, I found the root of my consciousness that was splitting apart in my thoughts.

A huge stem of information and ideas was connected to something.

“I'll say it again, but I'd appreciate it if you paid a little attention to the eyes in front of you.”

I understood what the heteromorphic passage meant without difficulty.

It was a line that connected this body and my soul.

I climbed up along that stem and connected my thoughts to my body on Earth.

The deliberately divided thoughts reached beyond the end of my flesh and touched my original flesh.

Zzzz—.

My shaky vision split and now two senses coexisted in my head.

-“Master...?”

“O great one...”

Eutenia. And Estasia.

The two of them, standing in different worlds, appeared in my sight at the same time.

It was quite confusing to process the sensations from two perspectives at once.

Nevertheless, thanks to the many growths I had experienced so far, it didn't take long for me to adapt to the split vision.

I calmed down my divided consciousness and spoke to Eutenia.

-“It's thanks to you and the apostles that I'm here now. And among them, the one who suffered the most was, of course, my first apostle.”

“...”

-“I will reward those who participated in this great event accordingly.”

The second preparation for the plan was completed.

Now it was time to move on to the next step.

Many conditions had to be met at the same time for the goal I was aiming for.

If I thought about the contract I made with that woman, the heroes would be coming here by now.

I had to use that fact to somehow move the goddess of Harmony.

“You might not have time to spend so leisurely like that.”

Just then, the goddess of Harmony looked at me and uttered a sigh.

It seemed that the heroes were coming here as planned.

I pretended not to know anything and asked her why.

-“What do you mean?”

“There are many people in this world who are afraid of our god. They seem to be coming here.”

That was natural.

It was right to come when he was weakest if he wanted to stop a god who had descended on Earth.

Besides, if they were given a chance themselves, there would be no reason not to come.

-“This is a bit troublesome. I’m not used to moving this body yet.”

“Then——.”

The goddess of Harmony, who heard my words, made a playful face.

It was a familiar face that I had faced once.

To be exact, it was the face that Estelle showed when she played with people.

“Should I protect our god?”

She said as if she was doing me a favor by protecting me.

At the moment when I was about to agree to her offer.

Eutenia, who was in my arms, raised her head and spoke.

“I’ll, I’ll protect the great one...!”

-“This is not your place to step in.”

I was grateful, but this was not the time for Eutenia to step in.

The whole story so far was a trap to catch a god.

I drove a wedge into the conversation and spoke to the goddess of Harmony.

-“Just this once, I’ll owe you a favor.”

Whirl.

As if to show her excited mood, the parasol in her hand spun in the air.

A battlefield where screams and shouts were rampant.

There, the divine weapon Ascalon slammed into the ground.

Kwaang!

With a loud explosion, the cultists were split in half.

The hero Gilford, who cut through the cultists with one stroke, ran forward while bleeding.

“Gilford Proud...”

The saintess of abundance, Serena Ederunt.

She saw the cultists being pushed back by the hero in front of her.

Every time Ascalon swung, the cultists screamed, and every time it hit the ground, cracks spread around.

Gilford’s appearance, leading the front line and opening the way, was worthy of being called a hero.

A few knights followed behind him to assist him.

Because there were fewer cultists guarding the bridge than expected, it seemed that they would soon arrive at the temple of Harmony.

“——Ascalon!”

But Serena’s heart was not comfortable watching Gilford’s figure.

She was a saintess who had to support the divine weapon Ascalon and the hero of abundance with all her might.

And the evil god who descended on Earth was much stronger than any enemy they had faced so far.

In other words, she had to unleash the power of Ascalon to its limit.

The problem was how to unleash the full power of Ascalon.

‘Will I have to die now?’

There was only one way to draw out the hidden power of Ascalon.

The death of Serena, the saintess of abundance.

Ascalon would be completely liberated by that.

Just like the old saintesses who had met their death by the side of the great hero long ago.

That was the only way to reverse this unfavorable situation.

‘I’ve known it for a long time... but it still doesn’t make me feel any better.’

I knew it from the beginning.

That someday this moment might come.

That this fight was nothing like the stories I had seen in the myths.

Even so, I chose not to run away.

If it was the destiny given to the saintess of abundance, someone had to play that role.

“——Ascalon!”

“——O goddess, guide us!”

‘My father must still be fighting.’

But I couldn’t help but think of the face of Knight Commander Revelz, who would be sad when I died.

He wished that I wouldn’t become a saintess, and that I wouldn’t lose my life like this.

How many parents in the world would wish for their own child to die?

Yet Revelz had to send me to the battlefield.

He was the knight commander of the holy land, and I was a saintess belonging to the temple of abundance.

The two of us had a mission that we had to accomplish.

“——Ascalon...!”

Kwaang!

The holy light that stretched out sharply tore apart the cultists completely.

Serena woke up from her trance at the loud noise that shook her ears.

Before she knew it, most of the cultists who had blocked the bridge had fallen.

The way to the temple of Harmony was opened.

Gilford, who had defeated the enemies in front of him, gasped and said.

“Haa, ha... The way is... all clear...”

“This is really the end.”

“...Yes.”

Gilford said that and walked on the bridge filled with blood and smoke.

The suicide squad members who followed Gilford also followed him and Serena with torches in their hands.

Thud. Thud.

The footsteps of the suicide squad members who bravely moved forward echoed on the bridge.

They crossed the sea of corpses and blood and soon reached the door of the temple.

When Gilford and the knights stood in front of the temple door, the knights who followed Gilford grabbed the door and said.

“We’ll open the door.”

Nod.

Gilford nodded and they immediately opened the door.

Serena looked nervously at the temple door that began to open.

It was the moment when they would face their long-awaited enemy directly.

Creak. Thud.

The temple door opened with a creepy sound.

And at the same time, someone’s voice rang in Serena’s ears.

“You’re finally here.”

Serena moved her eyes to where the familiar yet unfamiliar voice came from.

There was a girl who was covered in black from head to toe.

She looked somewhat like Laiteria, the saintess of Harmony, but her hair color and atmosphere were completely opposite to Laiteria's.

Behind her were two more people.

“...”

One was Eutenia Hyrost, the first apostle.

She was an apostle who had defeated Lian Crost, who had been her escort long ago.

And the other was a boy who had an overwhelming presence that no one in this place could match.

Serena was sure that he was probably the evil god who had descended on Earth.

Otherwise, there was no way a human could have such an aura.

“Who are you?”

Clang.

Gilford, who held Ascalon firmly, asked the girl who spoke to them.

Gilford's eyes were filled with a dreadful glint as he glared at her.

But she answered Gilford with a playful voice.

“Well. Who am I?”

“...Laiteria.”

When she heard her voice again, Serena was sure who she was.

Laiteria, the saintess of Harmony.

It was her voice that she had heard several times before.

But Laiteria wasn't moving by her own will now.

Of course not, because Laiteria she knew was a blind person who couldn't even see properly in front of her eyes.

"Too bad. Close but wrong."

"...Are you the evil god?"

This time Gilford stepped forward in front of Serena and asked her.

But she shook her head and denied Gilford's words.

"The evil god you're looking for is right next to me."

"No way..."

"You don't have to worry. You'll know who he is."

Following her gaze towards the unidentified boy, Gilford's fierce eyes turned to him in the corner.

The boy held Eutenia, the apostle, in his arms.

The fact that the boy who held the apostle was the evil god was confirmed.

Instead of denying her words, the boy who was named as the evil god spoke to her with an indifferent expression.

-“You haven't forgotten the promise we made earlier, have you?”

“Of course not. It's a promise with our god, after all.”

She took a step forward.

She smiled brightly and raised her hand slowly and opened her mouth.

Her hand stretched out in the air and flowed gently like a conductor.

The voice that came out of her mouth spread beautifully like a short song.

“Sanctuary Declaration—— Harmonia Saint.”

As soon as the amazing voice uttered a word.

A bright light and hymns filled the air.

Chapter 205: The Descent of the Evil God (3)

The Descent of the Evil God (3)

A dreamlike harmony filled the space, echoing in my ears.

A bright light that illuminated the darkness poured down from the sky, bringing a pleasant warmth and coziness with it.

A miniature space where various colors of light blended beautifully.

In this area where everything was arranged harmoniously, Serena felt anxious and clutched the rosary around her neck.

It was a space that anyone would praise as beautiful, but Serena Ederlant, the saintess, knew where this place was.

‘This is, the sanctuary.’

The Sanctuary of Harmony.

It was the domain of God that only Laiteria, the Saintess of Harmony, could summon to the surface.

In this harmony that seemed impossible to imitate with human power, Serena finally deduced the identity of the girl in front of her.

The girl who had familiar features to her was undoubtedly the Saintess of Harmony.

Otherwise, there was no way to explain the scenery that she saw before her eyes.

‘Does that mean... The Goddess of Harmony betrayed Crossbridge?’

She couldn’t understand.

She couldn’t understand why the Temple of Harmony, which had been giving mercy to humans until now, suddenly betrayed them.

She couldn’t accept why the Saintess of Harmony was trying to protect the evil god.

But she could understand why the Holy Emperor had tried to imprison the Saintess and the Hero of Harmony by any means.

Highpright II knew everything from the beginning.

It meant that the era of the Goddess of Harmony caring for the humans of the holy land with mercy had come to an end.

“Welcome to the sanctuary. I hope you like it here.”

The Goddess of Harmony, who had spread out a splendid sanctuary, spoke to Gilford and Serena with a bright voice.

She looked relaxed, facing the unwelcome guests who had entered her domain.

Her head was spinning.

The more she tried to understand the situation, the deeper her worries became.

‘I don’t have time to think anymore.’

But she couldn’t keep worrying while facing a fight.

Instead of confronting the Goddess of Harmony, who was testing the humans, Serena clasped her hands together and muttered a prayer.

“O Goddess, guide me on the right path.”

A huge storm was in front of her eyes.

A storm that none of the heroes before her had ever faced.

When this storm passed, the holy land would be stained with blood and sacrifice.

But Serena decided to do what she had to do quietly.

-‘Gilford Proud.’

Using the holy relic she was equipped with, she sent a message to Gilford in front of her and drew a dagger from an angle that no one else could see.

Swish. The dagger slid out of its sheath with a soft friction sound.

The short and thin blade looked like it would not be easy to inflict a fatal wound unless it hit the exact spot.

The dagger in Serena’s hand was something she had received from Rebels once.

To be precise, it was a holy relic that could take someone’s life without pain.

It was something that Rebels had gotten for her so that she could have a peaceful end when she had to fulfill her duty as a saintess someday.

“What is this...”

-‘Don’t panic and listen to me. I can read your thoughts while using the holy relic.’

Gilford was startled by Serena's voice, but soon composed himself and glared at the evil god, following Serena's instructions.

They both knew that this was their last chance.

They were not in a situation to waste time on foolish worries.

Serena aimed her dagger at her chest and conveyed her will to Gilford in front of her.

- 'Don't ever look back.'

- 'What's going on?'

- 'I have a way to draw out more power from Ascalon.'

- 'A way to draw out more power from Ascalon...?'

Ascalon's power was enough to reach God for a brief moment.

But it was not easy to hit the evil god with an attack in that short moment.

That's why they needed a final way to bring out Ascalon's power.

If Ascalon's light could touch God for a moment, they could drive the evil god out of the continent.

- 'Of course, it won't last for long, but it might be possible to break through the interference and land a hit on the evil god.'

It didn't take long.

All she had to do was stab her own heart with this dagger.

It wouldn't take long for the blood to flow and her breath to stop.

With that, the hero of abundance could get his last hope to challenge the evil god.

Gilford didn't hesitate to reply to Serena after hearing her plan.

-‘Then use that method right now. I’ll buy you enough time somehow.’

-‘Okay. From now on, focus on the enemy in front of you, not me.’

-‘Don’t worry about me. I’ll survive and defeat the evil god and his apostles.’

Clang.

Gilford took a step forward, holding Ascalon firmly.

He still looked determined.

He was Gilford, who had trained every day for the sake of his comrades’ revenge.

Serena had also lived for revenge.

She still remembered vividly how Lian had fought to make her retreat.

She had harbored hatred for the evil god in the depths of her heart for a long time.

-‘Hero of abundance, Gilford Proud.’

-‘...’

-‘You have to slay the evil god with your own hands.’

———No matter what.

Serena sighed with resolve.

Hoo. Her trembling breath was distorted by the warm sunlight.

The blade that flashed in front of her eyes looked like the fangs of a beast waiting to devour her.

She gripped the dagger tightly.

‘Guide me on the right path.’

Squawk.

Serena stabbed the dagger into her chest with a trembling hand.

As the blade of the holy relic touched her body, a bright light burst out from her eyes and the dagger flew away.

Serena watched the dagger spin in the air and fly away.

“Ah...?”

The holy power that suddenly surged from her body blocked the dagger.

She had failed to end her life with her own hand.

She looked at Gilford, who was in front of her, as the dagger moved away.

Gilford, who was holding Ascalon, looked different somehow.

His whole body was radiating holy power, and his eyes were glowing with a dark aura.

“_____.”

‘Ascalon’s awakening? No... Something’s different...’

What she had heard about awakening was not like this.

It was a state where Ascalon’s power was drawn out to the limit and became one with the divine weapon.

But Gilford’s appearance now looked far from the heroes of legend.

His eyes looked lost, gazing at somewhere far away.

As if he was being controlled by something.

“It’s time. Fulfill the contract.”

The evil god spoke, watching Gilford.

Right after that.

Gilford, who had lost his mind, met the evil god’s eyes and they both uttered a chant at the same time.

What came out of their mouths was a declaration that proclaimed the holy domain of God on the ground.

-“Sanctuary Proclamation – Logration.”

-“Sanctuary Proclamation – Aurus Saint.”

Gilford and the evil god’s voices overlapped and echoed in the Sanctuary of Harmony.

A dazzling light burst out from Gilford’s body, and a deep darkness descended around the evil god.

Brilliant light and dreadful darkness.

Two incompatible energies began to clash in the air.

Three sanctuaries of God that ruled the ground overlapped.

Serena’s mouth opened wide at the unprecedented sight that was not recorded in any history.

But she was not the only one who was surprised by that sight.

Someone else’s voice rang out along with them, watching them with the sanctuary spread out.

“Wait a minute, what are you doing right now...!”

A sticky darkness that flowed from the evil god's shadow grabbed a girl with black hair.

She was once called Laiteria, and now someone else was moving in her place.

The darkness that held the girl was unstable, as if it would break at any moment.

Because of the girl's struggle, it looked like it would collapse in about 20 seconds.

-“Stop thrashing and stay still. I'll finish this soon.”

-“I will fulfill the contract.”

Clang.

And then Gilford – who used to be the hero of abundance – ran towards the girl with Ascalon in his hand.

A blessing-like radiance burst out from Ascalon in his hand, and a trail of light fluttered from his cloak.

Kwaaaaang!

Gilford's sword thrust forward, scattering light.

The trajectory of light drawn in the air extended towards the girl without any hesitation.

“Huuk...!”

Pook!

The sound of piercing flesh resounded in the sanctuary.

Gilford's strike pierced through the girl's abdomen.

Paaah—!

Ascalon's light flashed and a gruesome scream erupted.

The girl, who had screamed once, looked at the evil god and spoke with a trembling voice.

“You, you... what are you doing...!”

Tears of blood flowed from the girl's eyes as she looked at the evil god.

Crackle. Crackle.

Every time the divine weapon tore through the human flesh, ash smoke rose and the girl's body faded away.

A few drops of faint blood fell from the girl's mouth, which was filled with panic.

-“I've been waiting for this.”

“Why, why are you doing this... why are you doing this to me...!”

-“I just fulfilled the contract we made with Karma's decree in front of us.”

Karma's decree. And the contract.

All those words were familiar to Serena, who had lost everything.

And those who were talking were the ones who should have been fighting against Gilford, who had awakened his full power by now.

Instead of joining forces to take down the girl, the two beings were baring their teeth and fighting each other.

A possibility crossed Serena's mind as she watched the conversation going on in front of her eyes.

“Are you kidding me? We promised to be together forever...!”

-“I heard that too.”

“Then why are you doing this... why are you doing this to me?”

The enemies’ conversation, blaming each other.

Gilford, who looked like a stranger, as if he had become someone else.

The light of the sanctuary that felt strangely cozy.

The brief message from the evil god that she had faced with her own eyes once.

Serena smirked as she put all those pieces together.

‘O Goddess...’

Serena felt a sudden urge to pray.

She clasped her hands neatly and decided to pray to her master, whom she had served all her life.

The Goddess of Abundance.

The heavenly and magnificent goddess that Serena had always longed for.

‘O Goddess, guide me...’

But when she saw Gilford holding Ascalon, her polite hands dropped down for some reason.

The prayer that had always crossed her mind was buried in the darkness and faded away.

Serena Ederant smiled without saying a word as she saw the scene before her eyes.

It was a smile of realizing that she had no reason to fear death anymore.

It was a bitter and painful smile that left a deep ache in her mouth.

Her silent laughter continued until Gilford Proud, who had lost his light, fell pierced by the thorns of the shadow.

Chapter 206: The Descent of the Evil God (4)

Chapter 206: The Descent of the Evil God (4)

The divine weapon that pierced through her abdomen.

The Goddess of Harmony who screamed.

And myself, standing in front of her.

I recalled all these things vividly in my mind as I looked at the Goddess of Harmony, who was shedding tears of blood in front of me.

“You, you... what are you doing...!”

The Goddess of Harmony looked at me with eyes mixed with confusion and resentment.

It didn’t suit her, who always looked down on me from above.

Of course it didn’t.

She didn’t know how much time I had spent for this moment.

She didn’t know how careful I had been to prevent any information from leaking to Estelle.

-“I’ve been waiting for this.”

It was almost impossible to kill a complete god.

They could reduce their influence in this world drastically, but it was difficult to destroy them by moving the humans on the ground.

Besides, I was an immature god who had just gained divinity and ascended to the throne of god.

So I had to make a plan.

A plan that seemed worthless, but I had to prove that it could reach her.

To kill the god who ruled the heavens.

To sever the connection between the divine and this world, and make it impossible for them to interfere with the ground as gods.

My goal was to erase the Goddess of Harmony from this world completely.

“Why, why are you doing this... why are you doing this to me...!”

For that, I chose the Goddess of Abundance as my partner.

Estelle had carried out many schemes to reduce the influence of the goddesses on the ground.

And now, the situation on the ground was favorable for the Order.

That’s why I chose to trade with the Goddess of Abundance.

She would finish off the Goddess of Harmony with Ascalon while I held her down.

-“I just fulfilled the contract we made with Karma’s decree in front of us.”

The power of Ascalon, the divine weapon, could reach even God.

That was not an exaggeration.

If a god who had incarnated into a human body in the divine sanctuary that had elevated its dimension, it was possible to sever the connection with

Karma's decree.

And the Goddess of Harmony was not only a threat to me.

Her schemes had twisted the causality of all the goddesses to a dangerous level.

It was impossible for Crossbridge to overwhelm the Order without the intervention of the goddesses in such a state of twisted causality.

As the Goddess of Abundance, she had no reason to refuse my offer.

The divine weapon that pierced through her abdomen.

The Goddess of Harmony who screamed.

And myself, standing in front of her.

I recalled all these things vividly in my mind as I looked at the Goddess of Harmony, who was shedding tears of blood in front of me.

“You, you... what are you doing...!”

The Goddess of Harmony looked at me with eyes mixed with confusion and resentment.

It didn't suit her, who always looked down on me from above.

Of course it didn't.

She didn't know how much time I had spent for this moment.

She didn't know how careful I had been to prevent any information from leaking to Estelle.

-“I've been waiting for this.”

Killing a complete god was almost impossible.

They could reduce their influence in this world drastically, but it was difficult to destroy them by moving the humans on the ground.

Besides, I was an immature god who had just gained divinity and ascended to the throne of god.

So I had to make a plan.

A plan that seemed worthless, but I had to prove that it could reach her.

To kill the god who ruled the heavens.

To sever the connection between the divine and this world, and make it impossible for them to interfere with the ground as gods.

My goal was to erase the Goddess of Harmony from this world completely.

“Why, why are you doing this... why are you doing this to me...!”

For that, I chose the Goddess of Abundance as my partner.

Estelle had carried out many schemes to reduce the influence of the goddesses on the ground.

And now, the situation on the ground was favorable for the Order.

That’s why I chose to trade with the Goddess of Abundance.

She would finish off the Goddess of Harmony with Ascalon while I held her down.

-“I just fulfilled the contract we made with Karma’s decree in front of us.”

Ascalon, the divine weapon, could reach even God.

That was not an exaggeration.

If a god who had incarnated into a human body in the divine sanctuary that had elevated its dimension, it was possible to sever the connection with

Karma's decree.

And the Goddess of Harmony was not only a threat to me.

Her schemes had twisted the causality of all the goddesses to a dangerous level.

It was impossible for Crossbridge to overwhelm the Order without the intervention of the goddesses in such a state of twisted causality.

As the Goddess of Abundance, she had no reason to refuse my offer.

The only condition for the new contract between me and the Goddess of Abundance was one thing.

To guarantee the safety of all clerics except for the hero of abundance after fulfilling the contract.

It meant that she promised to send out all those who could pose a threat to me from the holy land without any battle or plunder.

This contract would last for 100 years, and peace would continue for 100 years as long as the clerics did not attack first.

Of course, I was careful not to expose any part of the process to Estelle until the contract was made.

I even used Aronia and Estasia's halo connection to relay my orders to the apostle, and then communicated my intentions to the Goddess of Abundance through him again.

"What are you doing... why are you doing this to me...!"

I smiled as I realized that fact too late, looking at the Goddess of Harmony who resented me.

It was an expression that I would never see otherwise.

It was an expression that a god, a great being, could only show when they were cornered at the edge of a cliff.

I approached closer to the Goddess of Harmony, who was bound by my shadow.

And then I whispered in her ear with a small voice that only she could hear.

-“Because it’s more fun that way.”

“What...?”

She looked at me with blank eyes.

What a foolish face she had.

It was funny that she had hidden such a face all this time, even though she knew how to make it.

-“Isn’t it more enjoyable to take revenge at a crucial moment than to follow orders stupidly?”

“You, now, how do you see me...”

She looked at me with eyes filled with malice.

Hatred. Malice. And resentment.

All those things were what I used to look at her with in the past.

I stepped back from the Goddess of Harmony, who began to disappear scattering particles of light.

The Goddess of Harmony would no longer interfere with the ground.

The six temples in Crossbridge would also be replaced by towering buildings of the Order from now on.

-“This will be the last time I see you here.”

I smiled and said goodbye to her as she faded away.

Pah—!

The last ray of light squeezed out by Ascalon severed the connection between the Goddess of Harmony and Karma's decree.

The bright cluster of light scattered and the Sanctuary of Harmony collapsed miserably.

The stained glass that decorated the temple of Harmony shattered into pieces, and the only thing left here was the broken trace of faith.

-“Let's meet again soon. Estelle.”

There was no longer a being called the Goddess of Harmony in the world beyond my smartphone.

There was no place for her, and her followers would disappear in the flow of time.

Even the glory of her past would fade away completely someday, leaving no trace behind.

The era of Harmony had come to an end.

Because of the god of destruction who had descended here.

-“Eutenia.”

I turned my gaze to Eutenia as soon as I defeated Estelle.

She was looking at Estelle, who was scattering, with a nervous gaze, and then she lifted her head when she heard my voice.

“Yes, your greatness.”

-“Take care of that guy and then withdraw the troops from the temple of abundance.”

I pointed at the hero of abundance, who was fading away as his light dimmed, and Eutenia asked me with a question.

“What do you mean...?”

-“It’s a mercy that I bestow as a winner’s magnanimity.”

“I understand. If that’s your command...!”

Eutenia nodded as if she finally accepted my words.

There would be nothing more to worry about once I dealt with the hero of abundance here.

“...”

I saw the hero, who was leaning as his divinity faded.

The hero of abundance, Gilford Proud.

He was a miserable hero who had been used until the end.

But I had no choice but to kill him.

We were incompatible beings.

-“A worthless life.”

I was a god of evil here.

And he was a hero.

My blurred vision returned, and this time I saw Estasia standing on the roof of my studio apartment.

I started to move my body on Earth by controlling my consciousness that was split into two.

Even though I had severed the divinity of the Goddess of Harmony from Karma's decree, Estelle, who had the divinity of retrogression, was still on Earth.

Our fight was not over yet.

Estasia asked me with a worried face as I staggered up from my seat.

“Are you okay now?”

“I'm fine. It was nothing.”

I looked at the smartphone in my hand, touching my forehead.

The smartphone that had been showing Eutenia until a moment ago had its screen turned off.

It was natural.

The reason why I had been interfering with another world until now was because of this divine device that I had received from the Goddess of Harmony.

Since the divinity of Harmony had been completely cut off from Karma's decree, her divine device would no longer work properly.

“Don't do anything too dangerous.”

“Maybe this will be the last dangerous thing I do.”

“...Is that so?”

It was not a definite answer.

I didn't know everything about the future either.

But fighting against gods would be the last time for a while.

It had been a very long time.

I had killed my comrades with my own hands, deceived by Estelle, and stained myself with countless blood to get here.

All that was left in the long time was a tattered heart and a degraded mind.

If I were to describe a person's life as a flame, I was nothing but a candle with little wick left.

“Revenge should be done at once.”

“Is that your way, master?”

But I couldn't stop here yet.

The opportunity that I had grasped was not something that I had built up alone.

I had come here after passing through many sacrifices and screams.

Not as a human who had been chased and hidden in a ruined world, but as a god who had been created by human history.

“So stay with me until the end, Estasia.”

I reached out my hand to Estasia, who still looked worried.

Swoosh.

Estasia grabbed my hand and knelt down politely, kissing the back of my hand.

It was the utmost reverence that a lost angel showed to her god.

I blessed Estasia and looked at the scenery beyond the rusted railing.

It was a sight of restless souls wandering the streets in a savage landscape.

“If that's what you want, master.”

Years ago.

It was the world's landscape that had been created by an unprecedented disaster that started in Africa.

It was the destruction of humanity that Estelle, the god of retrogression, had created.

She had destroyed this world and reduced my life to a mere amusement.

The favor of the evil god was like a dreadful swamp with no bottom.

“...”

I had been Estelle's toy until now.

I had been hurt, fallen, and broken many times according to her intentions.

But the story that would start from now on would be completely different from before.

The one who would move the pieces on the huge game board was not Estelle, but myself.

“I'll pray for you.”

Estasia lifted her lips from the back of my hand and clasped her hands together.

Flap.

Her black wings spread out beautifully, scattering black feathers around.

As she fluttered the feathers that glowed faintly, Estasia closed her eyes and began to pray.

Ah——.

A beautiful voice that only the heavenly angels could have filled the air and spread around.

“What a pleasant sound. Is this the song of an angel?”

An angel who prayed with all her heart could create a miracle.

A pure white angel could heal people, calm their minds, and bring them the light of hope.

But the black angel in front of me was an apostle of destruction who had made a contract with the god of destruction.

Her prayer would no longer heal people.

Instead, her song would drive the world to destruction.

“Ah ah ah——.”

I walked to the front of the rusted railing, listening to the angel’s song in my ears.

Clang.

I grabbed the railing that looked like it would collapse at any moment, and looked at the world that had already faced destruction once.

It was pitiful and worthless.

I was going to break the world that I saw in front of me.

It started with Estasia’s prelude of destruction.

The world that began to crumble under the influence of the power of destruction would create a causality correction by Karma’s decree.

A huge distortion that would not allow any freedom to the two evil gods who existed in the world.

Estelle, who faced the distortion caused by causality correction, would face a choice of either-or filled with pain.

“...To hide this and call it a passive game. What a wicked hobby.”

I clenched my smartphone tightly in the midst of the voice spreading on the roof.

Through this small smartphone screen, I had witnessed many stories of people.

I had faced the stories of heroes who fell.

I had watched the stories of evil that stirred.

They each shouted their own justice, and burned their bodies in their beliefs.

They deceived themselves that they could be anything, and moved forward.

They became moths that burned brightly, and ran towards the other side of the line where there was no retreat.

-“I will be your god.”

The fleeting stories that burned like flames——

I couldn't leave them as mere amusement for a moment.

-“Please let me be a part of your great story.”

The prayer that Eutenia had offered to me sometime ago echoed in my ears.

A great story.

It was a story that didn't suit someone like me at all.

But I had to find the right story with my own hands.

“A great story...”

There was a story that suited a hero for a hero.

And there was a story that suited an apostle for an apostle.

I had to give them all the right endings with my own hands.

Destiny or something like that should never block their way.

“...Since you said so much, I guess I have to live up to it now.”

That must have been the role left for a being called god.

I made up my mind and looked at the ghosts crawling on the ground.

Hoo.

The air that filled my lungs brought me a pleasant pressure.

I spat out my voice that I had pressed to the limit, and told my story to the world where I had been wandering alone.

“Everyone, listen——”

The voice of god spread everywhere.

There was no longer me who had chased salvation in a narrow room.

I was no longer the pathetic loner who lived in hiding.

The cruel fate that had bound me had collapsed and crumbled by itself.

I would destroy the world.

The god who was about to be born had to destroy the world.

“Right here, right now.”

The ghosts looked up at me as my voice vibrated.

The eyes of those who couldn't die and lived on gathered on me.

Sorrow. Pain. Anger. Sadness.

Many emotions flowed and intertwined.

And beyond that, I faced the moment of light that I had to chase.

The fleeting flame that had moved the hearts of the great ones ignited my chest.

I was not afraid.

The fate that had tied me had long burned to ashes.

“Your god has descended——.”

It was time.

It was time to reclaim what I had lost once.

Chapter 207: The Descent of the Evil God (5)

[END] Chapter 207: The Descent of the Evil God (5)

A beautiful voice that pierced the silence.

A huge darkness swept over the world with the hymn of destruction.

The insects that sensed the crisis crawled out and ran in all directions, and all kinds of birds flapped their wings and flew away from death.

Crack.

As the ground cracked and the buildings collapsed, Estasia continued to sing calmly.

“...”

It was not common to see the world being destroyed.

In that sense, the world that I saw in front of me was definitely an amazing sight.

The whole landscape that I could see to the horizon shook and crumbled.

The concrete fortress that seemed to never fall followed my gesture and collapsed, spewing smoke.

The world that collapsed like dominoes was very splendid.

“What a spectacle.”

Everything was ruined and destroyed.

In the area of destruction where screams and noises ran rampant, the cursed ones staggered and fell to their places.

The only rest they were given was their own share.

For them, death was salvation.

I gave them a fair death, who had lost their reason and even their names.

I no longer needed a smartphone to perform such miracles.

I was now a being who could do anything I wanted without clinging to a small smartphone.

“It’s a pity if the invited guest doesn’t show up when I’ve set up such a splendid stage.”

At the same time, I felt an inexplicable pressure that tried to suppress me.

It was the sanction of <Karma’s decree> for the unilateral and extensive exercise of power.

If my smartphone had been fine, it would have surely displayed a message like this.

Karma that was excessively biased in one direction had a high possibility of causing ‘causality correction’.

Of course, that was what I wanted right now.

There was no way to restrain the evil god who ran wild without a high-intensity sanction.

“Isn’t that right, Estelle?”

As I turned my head with a smile, I saw Estelle’s figure that had appeared on the roof somehow.

Estelle's expression, holding a black umbrella as always, showed no sign of leisure.

It was natural.

I was choking her breath right now.

People were not beings who lived satisfied with the fact that they had their breath.

How much more so for a god who looked down on humans from a high position.

She would not want to live a life that had all possibilities blocked.

For Estelle that I knew, the current situation was no different from dying.

“You... do you know what you're doing?”

“You look very angry, my goddess.”

Estelle looked at me with a distorted face and showed clear hatred.

It was a thick killing intent that made my skin tingle.

But I just smiled brightly at her.

It was clear who was on top at this moment.

Estelle, who had lost her potential in the world beyond the smartphone, had little to do here.

Especially when the opponent was the last survivor who had lost everything and only had his breath left.

“You, really...!”

Crack.

The sound of grinding teeth echoed on the roof.

She would be angry.

She would be annoyed.

She would feel like going crazy with rage that she couldn't express anywhere.

It was natural.

That was all the emotion that I had felt back then.

It was the memory of the time when I was tormented and suffocated by the unknown god in front of me.

I opened my mouth, recalling the memories of the two of us, to the suffering Estelle.

“Estelle. Do you remember what you said to me once?”

Estelle had said this to me once.

There was nothing more enjoyable than destroying a sandcastle that someone had built with difficulty.

But I thought Estelle was wrong.

It was troublesome to feel joy by just destroying a sandcastle.

It would be more enjoyable to destroy something bigger than that.

“Isn't it fun? To smash someone's plan right before they succeed with my own hands.”

“You...”

“Of course, this world is more suitable than a sandcastle.”

Crack.

The outer wall of the cracked building began to float in the air under the influence of gravity.

Concrete with exposed rebar.

Lampposts that were separated from the ground and tangled.

Everything in this world was in chaos and disorder.

And at the center of that world were Estelle and I, looking at each other.

“Stop it...! There’s nothing to change by doing this!”

Estelle’s appearance, shouting at me to stop, was funny.

She had never bothered to think when I shouted at her to stop, but now she hoped that I would stop in front of me.

Estelle was afraid.

Of the punishment that the tilting decree would bring.

Of the price that would come if she broke the balance that she had barely adjusted to the limit.

Estelle, who had destroyed the world once, could not have avoided such karma.

Even the karma of life that she was carrying now was enough to burden her.

At least in my eyes, who had become a god like her, I could see it clearly.

Estelle’s appearance, who was afraid of losing more than me.

“There’s nothing more to lose. You’ve already destroyed everything with your own hands.”

There was only one rule that the decree imposed on a world where the balance of good and evil was broken.

There is no god in disorder.

Only immortal demons rotting in hell where no one takes the side of life remain.

Can a being who can only live without exercising any power be called a god?

Well, I didn't think so.

"It was all for you. You knew that..."

Estelle spoke to me with a trembling hand holding an umbrella.

The falling goddess seemed to have a lot to lose.

Unlike the time when she was more noble than anyone else, she looked so ugly now.

Of course, if she called the love of an evil god destruction, her words were not wrong at all.

I was loved by her greatly.

Enough. Beyond satisfaction, to the point of shedding tears.

"Yeah, I guess so. I thought you would say that."

"So, right now——!"

"We'll be together forever, Estelle."

So I was going to pay her back for what I had received.

It started with a choice of either-or that Estelle could never avoid.

A forced choice full of irrationality and contradiction.

To lose or to let go of what she had.

She had to make a choice in a situation where there was no compromise.

I was the stake in this irrational gamble.

“You were the one who wanted to be with me forever, right?”

The roof that began to float in the air shone the scenery of the world that was being destroyed.

The destruction that the song of the end created had reached the roof of the building where we were standing.

Estelle, who faced such destruction, bit her lips with trembling eyes.

“...”

“So this is the decision that your apostle made.”

I threw the smartphone in my hand to the ground with force.

Crash!

The screen of the smartphone shattered and the fragments scattered around.

It was something I no longer needed.

Too much time had passed for me to depend on everything on this small device.

I had grown up losing countless things.

It was time for me to step into this world with my own power, not the power of tuning.

“Uh...”

Estelle was so confused that she couldn't even say a proper word.

It was natural.

The karma of the decree that bound the two divine beings to the earth was tilted extremely.

Although it was a choice of either-or, there was only one way that Estelle could choose.

“Why are you like that? Don't tell me there's no proper role for the goddess of retrogression in a destroyed world?”

Tilting the decree to the other side.

It was nothing but spitting out everything she had done and going back to the way it was.

What she hated so much——

Going back to the boring and dull world.

“Ugh...!”

A moan mixed with countless emotions escaped from her mouth.

She looked extremely miserable.

She had to let go of everything she held in her hands.

I was ready to fall to the bottom of the abyss, but sadly, Estelle was not.

“But you're lucky, you know.”

“Stop...”

“I'm different from anyone else, I'm kind. I can tell you what you have to do.”

Fortunately, even I, who had just ascended to the throne of god, had something to tell her.

No, maybe it was a story that I could only tell her because I had become a god now.

Because I had just realized it and it was still vivid in me.

“...”

The moment I followed Estelle’s plan and collected a million karma and got the fragment of truth.

I finally understood.

What was a god.

And what was the right order of the world.

Rules and regulations, they had no meaning at all now.

Well, wasn’t a god a being that established its own rules on top of those regulations?

“From now on, I’m the evil god.”

I raised my finger at Estelle, who was speechless.

I folded my thumb that pointed at myself, and then pointed at Estelle in front of me.

This finger meant one thing.

“So you have to save the world.”

I overturn the order of this world.

I create a new order.

Under the order where everything converges to destruction, she has to go against the only order.

That was the only miracle allowed to the ‘god of retrogression’.

That was the only miracle that Estelle could make at this moment.

“You...”

“Go back. That’s what you’re good at, right?”

Thud—.

Estelle dropped the umbrella she was holding with a trembling hand on the floor.

She covered her face with her shaking hand, soaked in anxiety and impatience.

Her lips that showed through her hidden face spat out a trembling voice.

“You... are crazy.”

Did she finally make up her mind?

With Estelle’s short word as a signal, an overwhelming density of power spread throughout the world.

Estelle’s power, with a huge amount of karma, suppressed my power and tried to interfere more strongly with the world.

As the power of retrogression activated, the world began to go against the flow of causality.

The minimum line to maintain balance was half.

I take back half of the world from her.

That was the return I was aiming for, betting my whole life on it.

“Estasia. Stop now.”

“Yes.”

Once Estelle’s power that defied order began to move, it was meaningless for me to use my power anymore.

I stopped Estasia, who was praying, and looked at the world that began to go back.

“Is the world going back to normal?”

The collapsed buildings started to merge as if rewinding the video.

The lampposts that were pulled out returned to the ground naturally.

The broken things went back to their original state against causality.

The power of retrogression that I faced for the first time was very amazing and mysterious.

“Yeah. It’s a nice view.”

“That’s right. Just like you said, master.”

The world was going back.

Even if it wasn’t the perfect world that I longed for, the whole world was returning to the lively world where people lived and breathed.

The scenery of the world that I had buried in my old memories came back to my mind.

The world before destruction was very boring and dull.

Someone had to get up in the morning and go to work.

Someone else had to suffer from their boss’s nagging.

Another someone had to come home with a tired body and drink beer and play games.

“It’s a view that you would believe if someone told you it was a game.”

The same day repeated every day.

A tedious day that didn’t show any change.

The painful times that I lived under pressure and responsibility.

Yet I loved it very much.

“Really.”

That time, that moment.

More than the game that I liked very much.

Epilogue

A year had passed since the fight with Estelle, the god of retrogression.

There were many things that happened in the continent during the last year.

The Temple of Abundance moved south from the holy land, and the Order became the state religion of the empire.

The priests of the six temples who survived also fled outside the empire’s influence.

In Crossbridge, a new temple of the Order was built magnificently instead of the six temples, and the organizational structure of the Order was also greatly reformed, led by Roan, who became popular.

According to the reformed organizational structure of the Order, the church tax also grew significantly.

Many believers came to the holy land every day to face the god who descended to the ground.

Of course, it was my duty to look after them from above.

They were the ones who came from the empire to see me.

I would have to punish them if they showed rude behavior, but it wasn't hard to greet them who wouldn't hesitate to give their lives for me.

Today, too, I wore a suit that matched my body to meet the believers, and Eutenia, who chose my suit, spoke with a smile.

She had been in charge of these events since I descended to the ground.

It was not only because she was the first apostle, but also because her wish that she asked me was one of the reasons.

"It's thanks to you choosing a good suit for me."

When I answered her question with a solemn tone, Eutenia's expression brightened up more.

She was very weak to this kind of reaction.

She would be happy all day with just one compliment from me, and when she received a gift from me, she would walk around the holy land all day and brag about it to other apostles.

It was a scene where I could understand why she had the trait of a fanatic.

Of course, it changed completely in a different direction after I came down to the ground.

Now her appearance looked like a blind love rather than fanaticism.

"Any suit suits you well, great one."

"That might be true."

I nodded and looked at my reflection in the mirror.

I might sound narcissistic, but I looked pretty handsome in the mirror.

I was handsome enough in the first place.

Sometimes when I saw a mirror, I would see a celebrity's face overlapping with mine for a second.

But the way I looked now was a little more handsome than that.

At least, I had an appearance that gave off an old-fashioned vibe that didn't match my visible age.

As I looked at myself in the mirror with satisfaction, Eutenia came close and draped a cloak over my shoulder.

"I'm sincere."

"Yeah. You always are."

"So, I wish you would say something sincere to me too."

Eutenia leaned her head on my shoulder in the mirror.

Seeing her like that, I remembered the wish she had asked me.

The day when I had not been on the ground for long.

When I asked the apostles about their wishes, only Eutenia had asked for a peculiar one.

Her wish was very crude but special.

"I love you, Eutenia."

But it was not easy for me to grant her wish.

How could I calmly utter such a word that would ruin my dignity as a god?

But Eutenia was stubborn.

So I had no choice but to say it, even if I was embarrassed.

“Please tell me more. That’s my wish.”

“I love you more than anyone else in this world.”

It was a word without any lie.

Eutenia Hyrost.

She was a very special being to me.

She closed her eyes with satisfaction and opened her mouth with a languid voice.

“I like it. It feels like being loved by you, great one.”

As I watched Eutenia’s happy face, I recalled the memory of that day.

Once, when she asked me for a wish.

I swore in my heart as I looked at her then.

I would spend the rest of my life in this world for her sake.

That must have been the only thing that was truly valuable to my first apostle.

I still believed that.

In the middle of the sea where the intense sun shone down.

There, the abyssal beast Cuebaerg was moving with a parasol stuck on his head.

It was not his own will, but according to the strong request of the tenants sitting on his head.

The vampires sitting on Cuebaerg's head hated sunlight very much.

Cuebaerg conveyed his will to Pluto, who was sitting on his head, with a relaxed voice.

-“Are you still not satisfied?”

“This place is not suitable for vampires.”

Pluto's voice echoed from under the parasol that blocked the sunlight.

She looked at the isolated island floating in the middle of the sea and shook her head.

On Pluto's right, there was Eileen, who was faithfully assisting her.

She had forgotten the fact that she was once a saint, and she was very obedient to Pluto.

Of course, that was also why she could follow Pluto's side until now.

-“What's the problem?”

“It's hard to find blood, and more importantly, the sunlight is too strong. It would be better to go into a jungle somewhere.”

At Pluto's words, Cuebaerg spat out a fountain.

Thud. Splash.

Some of the seawater that he had sucked in fell on the parasol.

Cuebaerg, who played a light water prank, showed a short dissatisfaction to the tenants on his back.

-“You're picky.”

“Weren’t there any beasts in the abyss that cared about the environment?”

-“The abyss was all the worst environment. There was no room to choose a place to live.”

“...”

At Cuebaerg’s words, Pluto showed a moment of hesitation.

But soon she neatly folded her worries and shook her head.

What they were looking for now was a land suitable for building a country of vampires.

It was not right to build a country in a place where the sunlight was strong, no matter how they thought about it.

“I guess this won’t work.”

At the words that compromise was impossible, Cuebaerg stopped for a moment.

But soon he stopped spitting out the fountain and answered her.

-“Is that so.”

“Sorry, but keep moving. Let’s look for a darker place.”

Pluto finished talking to Cuebaerg and tapped his head with her palm several times.

Thump. Thump.

The sound of tapping his soft skin echoed.

Cuebaerg showed a fountain full of dissatisfaction and then started to move forward again.

Eileen, who saw Cuebaerg hitting the fountain, poked his head with her finger and said.

“I won’t forgive you if you disobey master’s words, even if you’re a monster.”

-“All vampires are rude.”

With two tenants on board, Cuebaerg cut through the sea and set out for an unknown land.

Until they find a suitable land to build a country of vampires,

The journey of the three monsters would never end.

The holy land, Crossbridge.

In the place that had become the holy land of the Order, Peter looked at his left with bored eyes.

On Peter’s left, there was Perin sitting on the railing.

She was sitting on the railing and biting an apple full.

Her face eating the apple looked somehow happy.

“Is that good?”

“It’s good. Do you want a bite too, master?”

At Peter’s question, Perin offered him an apple with a bite taken out of it.

Peter looked at the apple that Perin offered him for a moment, then snorted and shook his head.

Even though Estasia had been gone for a long time from the meeting, Perin’s name for her still hadn’t changed.

“.....Forget it.”

Sigh.

Peter let out a short sigh and turned his head to look at the other side.

On the right side of the railing where Peter was standing, Evan was sitting in light armor.

He was still looking at the crowded streets of the holy city with a heavy face.

Peter asked Evan, who was looking down at the ground, about Daniel, who had been missing since earlier.

“Where did Daniel go?”

“He went to prepare the meat for the feast for the great one.”

Evan’s answer was a familiar pattern that he had heard many times.

It was a well-known story that he, who claimed to be a farmer, usually hid his identity.

Daniel was an assassin by profession, but his slaughtering skills were impeccable.

He had clearly learned the assassination techniques to kill people silently by using animals.

Now he was using those skills to process the meat that came to the holy city.

“Come on, who doesn’t know that’s just a cover-up job?”

“Well. He says he’s satisfied with just preparing the meat for the great one.”

An assassin who had terrorized the world was content with killing pigs and cows.

Peter couldn't understand that at all.

If he had the same power as Daniel, he would never have settled for that level.

Rather, he would have had ambition and tried to spread his name across the world.

Of course, that would have made him a covert assassin, contrary to Peter's thoughts.

"By the way, did your wish come true from the great one?"

Peter, who was leaning on the railing and having a pointless thought, was asked by Evan first this time.

The wish he had asked from the great being.

It was the story of the wish he had promised to the apostles after all his deeds were done.

Of course, Peter wished for his lost family to be returned.

His master gave him a three-year grace period for that wish.

There were still two years left until Peter's family came back.

"I still have two years left."

"Didn't he say he would grant it if you waited three years?"

"He promised that."

"It's already been a year, so the remaining time will pass quickly."

Peter stroked his chin with his finger at Evan's calm words.

Daniel and Evan in front of him, they all looked like transcendent beings.

They had modest dreams even when the great being asked them for their wishes.

The wish Evan had asked for that day was the prosperity of the Alemir family.

It was a stark contrast to ‘that woman’ who had boldly asked for a crazy wish.

“Evan, you’re amazing. Sometimes you seem to have no ambition.”

“Do I look like that?”

“Yes. If you think about it, even that crazy woman who asked the great one to say he loves her once a day... Uh-uh...”

Evan’s thick gauntlet blocked Peter’s mouth as he calmly talked about Eutenia.

Peter looked puzzled at Evan, who suddenly covered his mouth.

He had brought up the topic when there were only three of them, but he didn’t understand why he reacted that way.

Then Evan warned him with a serious face.

“Eutenia can hear the stories that flow throughout Crossbridge. You should be careful if you can...”

-“I already heard everything.”

Before Evan finished his sentence, a hand stretched out from the shadows and grabbed Peter’s back.

The hand that pulled his back hard slammed Peter into a pillar of the building.

Koong!

Peter screamed as he opened his eyes wide with a dull shock.

He felt a sensation of nausea from the pain that spread throughout his body.

“Kuaak……!”

“I should have advised you earlier, but it was too late.”

Evan smiled as he looked at Peter, who was stuck to the pillar, and reached out his hand to him.

Above Evan’s head, who reached out his hand to the fallen Peter, the sun shone brightly.

After Estelle reversed the flow of causality.

The earth was able to recover to a considerable level after a long time.

Although half of the population disappeared and a significant number of infrastructure was destroyed, humanity was strong enough to overcome those wounds and move forward.

The TV in the sanctuary, which used to repeat the same content every day, started to show new content.

The internet, which had been silent and stopped, also had new information uploaded every day.

It was moving in a completely different direction from the broken world where only old memories existed.

My sanctuary was still located in a place where there were few people, but that was unavoidable for the safety of the world.

Of course, sometimes I went out to shop, but that was only occasionally.

The basic premise was to suppress the transcendent beings here.

“Estasia. Clean up the feathers you dropped.”

One fallen angel with the power of destruction.

One overly diligent angel.

And two beings with divine power existed in this space.

It was right to keep them away from the residential area for the peace of the world.

“No.”

Unfortunately, my roommate – no, my cohabiting angel – was very unfriendly.

She was watching TV while eating ice cream, and ignored the feathers on the floor.

She refused my request with a very firm attitude as she stuffed her mouth with ice cream.

I couldn’t help but sigh at the sight.

I felt the need to be more assertive with Estasia.

Even if she was lazy, wouldn’t she listen if it was God’s command?

“Really? Then it’s an order. Let’s clean up.”

“Estasia doesn’t listen to master’s order either.”

“.....Why?”

“Because she’s a fallen angel.”

She said that and took another bite of ice cream.

Nom.

I had no choice but to stare at Estasia with a blank face as she ate a mouthful of ice cream and mumbled.

I couldn't figure out what to say when she said that bluntly.

It was undeniable that I made Estasia a fallen angel.

“.....Estasia. It would be nice if you cleaned up a bit.”

Aronia intervened with a word for Estasia from beside me.

She spread her wings wide and spoke confidently to Estasia.

But Estasia's answer was very cold.

“Aronia will do everything anyway.”

“.....”

“I don't want to do it.”

Squeak.

Aronia's head turned toward me with a strange sound as she heard Estasia's answer.

Her eyes were full of expectation as she looked at me.

She seemed to think that I would side with her, who was saying the right thing.

“Maybe you should clean up your own feathers...”

“Cheer up, Aronia.”

“Master!”

But I only cheered her on.

It was hard to refute the logic of the invincible fallen angel with my current logic.

I put my newly purchased smartphone in my pocket after giving Aronia a brief encouragement.

And then I prepared to leave this space where Estasia and Aronia were.

Being a god was more work than I thought.

“I think I have to go up to the roof.”

“Please don’t abandon a hardworking angel!”

Aronia grabbed my leg that was heading to the roof and sprawled out.

But unfortunately, I was a cruel god with a cold heart.

I mercilessly left Aronia behind and got out of the room.

As I left the room, I didn’t forget to firmly remind Aronia and Estasia.

“Clean up all the feathers until I come back. And eat ice cream moderately.”

“Have a good trip.”

Thud.

As I closed the door with Aronia’s sobbing and Estasia’s farewell, I started to see the scenery of the city that was being rebuilt.

The cityscape that was moving with noisy sounds was very lively.

Cars with headlights on were running on the road, and countless workers were restoring the ruined city.

It was a contrast to the cityscape that was dead with the lights off until recently.

“What a beautiful sight.”

I felt a proud emotion in my chest every time I saw the people who came back.

I couldn't get back all the people I lost, but the half I got was very precious.

Is this how the gods feel about the humans on earth?

Even if they don't know about me, I will love them as much as I can.

I have vivid memories of countless nights when I missed them so much.

“I hope they're all happy.”

Snicker.

I muttered to myself and walked up the empty stairs.

The stairs that I had walked up many times were cleaner than before.

It was thanks to Aronia who cleaned diligently.

At the top of the stairs, there was a large cage with an ominous aura.

Of course, what existed beyond the cage was a familiar face of a girl.

“You've been visiting more often lately.”

“I'm worried that the goddess here might run away. It would be a disaster if the world is destroyed again, right?”

The god of retrogression, Estelle.

I was suppressing Estelle, who had weakened after exhausting most of her power, here.

Estelle, who was trapped in the cage, was reading a book in her hand leisurely.

It was something I had Aronia get for her.

I leaned on the cage that was holding Estelle and glanced at her reading the book.

Estelle was reading a book with an old-fashioned title that suited her well.

“Did you have a good day yesterday?”

“How could I? Someone is locking me up like this.”

“Isn’t it God’s duty to watch over you so that the seal doesn’t break?”

As I said that, I checked the sturdiness of the cage that locked Estelle up.

The strong energy that came from my fingertips told me that it was intact.

It meant that the cage could still do its job.

Estelle’s power had not recovered enough yet.

“You know this cage will collapse someday, right?”

“Well, that day will come too.”

“Do you think I’ll stay still when that happens?”

Estelle, who was watching me check the cage, warned me in a sharp voice.

She was right.

It might be impossible for me to suppress Estelle forever with my power.

Someday, she might break this cage with her own power and escape.

I couldn’t predict whether that would happen in 100 years or 1000 years.

But even then, my actions wouldn’t change much.

“Then I’ll have to stop you again.”

“Do you think you can do that?”

“I don’t know yet. Maybe by then I’ll have grown into a great god.”

I would stand in Estelle’s way many times in the future.

I wouldn’t let her ruin this world ever again.

That was the role given to a being called a god.

I would destroy this world many times, and save it many times.

That was the only duty I could bear as the one named Destruction.

“Well. I don’t know.”

“I thought you would answer like that.”

I left Estelle behind me with her cold answers, and took out the smartphone I had in my pocket.

The smartphone I bought new in the city was shining clean as if to prove its newness.

I reached out my finger to the screen of the smartphone and unlocked it.

Swish.

On the spot where my finger passed, I saw the pictures of the apostles and believers.

It was an image I had taken from the other side of the world and set as the wallpaper of my smartphone.

“You have a bad hobby. You put pictures on your smartphone even after being treated like that?”

“It’s what I like best.”

“That’s very sincere of you.”

As I listened to Estelle’s words, I looked over the faces of the apostles in the picture one by one.

Eutenia. Evan. Pluto. Perin. Daniel. Peter.

And Roan, the Holy King, standing in the middle of them.

They were precious memories that would never be forgotten even as time passed.

“It’s better to keep them like this, right? They are things I don’t want to forget even when time passes.”

“...”

Thud.

As I watched the apostles on the screen, I tilted it to show it to Estelle.

Estelle’s blunt eyes looked at the screen of the smartphone.

She looked at the faces of the apostles with an indifferent face.

I also smiled brightly and looked at the screen of the smartphone with her.

Even under the darkened sky, the screen of the smartphone was shining brightly.

“It’s nice to be able to be together always.”

Beyond the small screen of the smartphone.

There was a world there.

There was a precious story that I could never forget.

And there was me.

The Evil God Beyond The Smartphone 完.

Fin ~

Chapter 208: Epilogue

Chapter 208: Epilogue

A year had passed since the battle with Estelle, the god of retrogression.

Many things had happened on the continent during the past year.

The temple of abundance had moved south of the holy land, and the order had become the state religion of the empire.

The surviving priests of the six temples had also fled outside the empire's sphere of influence.

A magnificent temple of the order had been built in Crossbridge, replacing the six temples, and the order's organizational structure had also been greatly reformed, led by the successful Roan.

Following the reformed structure of the order, the order's influence had also grown significantly.

Countless believers came to the holy land every day to face the god who had descended to the ground.

"Today, you look really amazing."

Of course, it was my duty to look down on them from above.

They were the ones who came from the empire to the holy land to meet me.

I had to punish them if they showed rude behavior, but it was not difficult to greet them who would not hesitate to give their lives for me.

Today, as I wore a suit that suited my body, Eutenia, who had chosen my clothes, spoke with a smile.

Since I descended to the ground, this kind of event had always been Eutenia's responsibility.

She had the symbolism of being the first apostle, and the wish she had asked me was also one of the reasons.

"It's thanks to you for choosing the clothes that suit me well."

As I imitated a stern tone and answered Eutenia's question, Eutenia's expression brightened even more.

She was very weak to this kind of reaction.

She would be happy all day with just one compliment from me, and when she received a gift from me, she would walk around the holy land all day and brag to the apostles.

It was a moment when I could understand why Eutenia had the trait of a fanatic.

Of course, it had changed completely in a different direction since I came down to the ground.

Now, her appearance looked like a blind love for me.

"The great one looks good in any clothes."

"I suppose so."

I nodded and looked at my reflection in the mirror.

I might seem narcissistic, but my reflection in the mirror was quite handsome.

The original me was also handsome enough.

Sometimes when I saw a mirror, I saw a celebrity's face overlapping for a second.

But the appearance I saw now was a little more handsome than that.

At least, it was a look that had an old-fashioned atmosphere that did not suit the age visible to the naked eye.

As I looked at my reflection with satisfaction, Eutenia came close and draped a cloak over my shoulder.

"I'm sincere."

"I know. You always are."

"So, I wish you would say a sincere word to me. That's my wish."

Eutenia leaned her head on my shoulder in the mirror.

As I saw her, the wish she had asked me flashed through my mind.

It was not long after I had descended to the ground.

The day I asked the apostles for their wishes, only Eutenia had asked for a peculiar wish.

Her wish was very crude but special.

"I love you, Eutenia."

But for me who fulfilled that wish, it was not an easy thing to say.

How could I say such a thing that would ruin the dignity of a god?

But Eutenia was stubborn.

So I had no choice but to say it, even if I was embarrassed.

"Please tell me more. That's my wish."

“I love you the most in this world.”

It was a word without any lie.

Eutenia Hyrost.

She was a very special existence for me.

She was satisfied with that and closed her eyes, opening her mouth with a languid voice.

“I like it. I feel loved by the great one.”

As I watched Eutenia’s happy face, I recalled the memory of that day.

Someday, the day she asked me for a wish.

I looked at Eutenia then and swore in my heart.

I would spend the rest of my life in this world for her.

Surely, that was the only thing that was truly valuable for my first apostle.

I still believed that.

In the middle of the sea where the sun was shining brightly.

There, the abyssal beast Cuebaerg was moving with a parasol on his head.

It was not Cuebaerg’s own will, but the result of the strong request of the tenants who were sitting on his head.

The vampires who were sitting on Cuebaerg’s head hated the sunlight very much.

Cuebaerg conveyed his will to Pluto, who was sitting on his head, with a relaxed voice.

-“Are you still not satisfied?”

“This place is not suitable for vampires to live.”

Pluto’s voice echoed from under the parasol that blocked the sunlight.

She looked at the isolated island floating in the middle of the sea and shook her head.

On Pluto’s right, there was Eileen, who was faithfully serving her.

She had forgotten the fact that she was once a saint, and Eileen was very obedient to Pluto.

Of course, that was also the reason why she could follow Pluto’s side until now.

-“What’s the problem?”

“It’s hard to get blood, and above all, the sunlight is too strong. I’d rather go to a jungle and live there.”

At Pluto’s words, Cuebaerg spat out a fountain.

Thud. Thud.

Some of the seawater that he had sucked in hard fell on the parasol.

Cuebaerg, who played a light water prank, showed a short displeasure to the tenants on his back.

-“You’re picky.”

“Weren’t there any beasts in the abyss that were picky about the environment?”

-“The abyss was all the worst environment. There was no room to choose a place to live.”

“...”

At Cuebaerg's words, Pluto showed a moment of hesitation.

But soon she neatly folded her thoughts and shook her head.

What they were looking for now was a land suitable for building a vampire nation.

No matter how she thought, it was not right to build a nation in a place where the sunlight was strong.

“I guess this won't work.”

At the words that compromise was impossible, Cuebaerg stopped for a moment.

But soon he retracted the fountain he had shot and answered her.

-“Is that so.”

“Sorry, but keep moving. Let's find a darker place.”

Pluto finished talking to Cuebaerg and tapped his head several times with her palm.

Thump. Thump.

The sound of tapping the soft flesh echoed.

Cuebaerg showed a fountain full of displeasure, and then started to move forward again.

Eileen, who was watching Cuebaerg's fountain, poked his head with her finger and spoke.

“Even if you are monsters, you will not be forgiven if you disobey the words of the ancestor.”

-“Vampires are all rude.”

With those words, Cuebaerg took off with his two tenants, cutting through the sea and heading for an unknown land.

Until they found a suitable land to build their vampire kingdom,

The journey of the three monsters would never end.

The Holy Land, Crossbridge.

In the place that had become the stronghold of the Order, Peter looked at his left with bored eyes.

On Peter’s left, he saw the figure of Perin sitting on the railing.

She was sitting on the railing, biting a big bite of an apple.

Her face, as she ate the apple, looked somehow happy.

“Is that good?”

“It’s delicious. Do you want a bite, Master?”

Perin answered, holding out the half-eaten apple, to Peter’s question.

Peter glanced at the apple Perin offered, then snorted and shook his head.

Even though it had been a while since Estasia disappeared from the meeting, Perin’s way of addressing him had not changed.

“...Never mind.”

Hoo.

Peter sighed briefly and turned his head to look at the other side.

On the right side of the railing where Peter was standing, there was Evan in light armor.

He was still looking at the crowded streets of the Holy Land with a heavy face.

Peter asked Evan, who was looking down at the ground, about Daniel, who had not been seen for a while.

“Where did Daniel go?”

“He went to prepare the meat for the feast for the Great One.”

The answer that came out of Evan’s mouth was a familiar pattern that he had heard many times.

It was a well-known story that he, who called himself a farmer, usually hid his identity.

Daniel was an assassin by profession, but his butchering skills were impeccable.

He had clearly learned the assassination skills to kill people silently by using animals.

Now he was using those skills to process the meat that came to the Holy Land.

“Really, who doesn’t know that’s a cover job?”

“Well. He says he’s satisfied with just preparing the meat for the Great One.”

It was unbelievable that the assassin who had terrified the world was satisfied with killing pigs and cows.

Peter could not understand that at all.

If he had the same power as Daniel, he would never have been content with that level.

Rather, he would have had ambition and tried to spread his name across the world.

Of course, that would have made him a covert assassin, contrary to Peter's thoughts.

"By the way, did the wish you asked the Great One come true?"

Peter, who was leaning on the railing and having pointless thoughts, was asked by Evan first this time.

The wish he had asked the Great One.

It was the story of the wish he had promised to the apostles after all the great deeds were done.

Of course, Peter wished for his lost family to be returned.

His master gave him a three-year grace period for that wish.

It meant that there were still two years left until Peter's family came back.

"There are still two years left."

"Didn't the Great One say he would grant it if you waited three years?"

"He promised that."

"It's been a year already, so the remaining time will pass quickly."

Evan said that calmly, and Peter stroked his chin with his finger.

Daniel and Evan in front of him, they all looked like transcendent beings.

They were so modest when the Great One asked them for their wishes.

The wish Evan asked for that day was the prosperity of the Alemir family.

It was a completely different sight from ‘that woman’ who boldly asked for a crazy wish.

“Evan, you are amazing. Sometimes you seem to have no greed.”

“Do I look like that?”

“Yes. Think about it, the crazy woman who asked the Great One to say he loves her once a day...”

Peter’s mouth, which was casually talking about Eutenia, was blocked by Evan’s thick gauntlet.

Peter looked puzzled at Evan, who suddenly blocked his mouth.

He had brought up the topic when there were only three of them, but he didn’t understand why he reacted like that.

Then Evan warned him with a serious face.

“Eutenia can hear the stories that flow throughout Crossbridge. It’s better to be careful if you can...”

-“I already heard it.”

Before Evan’s words were over, a hand stretched out from the shadows and grabbed Peter’s back.

The hand that grabbed his back forcefully slammed Peter into a pillar of the building.

Kwoong!

With a dull impact, Peter opened his eyes wide and screamed.

He felt a sensation of nausea from the pain that spread throughout his body.

“Aaaah!”

“I should have advised you earlier, but it was too late.”

Evan smiled as he looked at Peter, who was slammed into the pillar, and reached out to him.

Above Evan’s head, who reached out to the fallen Peter, the sun shone brightly.

After Estel reversed the flow of causality.

It took a long time, but the earth was able to recover to a considerable extent.

Although half of the population had disappeared and a significant number of infrastructure had been destroyed, humanity was resilient enough to overcome those wounds and move forward.

The TV in the sanctuary, which had been repeating the same content every day, began to show new content.

The internet, which had been silent and stopped, also had new information uploaded every day.

It was going in a completely different direction from the broken world where only old memories existed.

My sanctuary was still located in a place where there were few people, but that was unavoidable for the safety of the world.

“Estasia. Clean up the feathers you dropped.”

A fallen angel with the power of destruction.

An overly diligent angel.

And two beings with divine power.

It was a space where such beings existed.

For the peace of the world, it was the right answer to keep them away from the residential area.

Of course, sometimes they went out to shop, but that was only occasionally.

The basic premise was that they were holding down the transcendent beings here.

“No.”

Unfortunately, the roommate who lived with me – no, the cohabiting angel was very unfriendly.

She was watching TV while eating ice cream, and ignored the feathers on the floor.

She refused my request with a very firm attitude, putting a full scoop of ice cream in her mouth.

It was a sight that made me sigh involuntarily.

I felt the need to be a little more stern with Estasia.

No matter how lazy she was, she wouldn't listen to God's command? That's what I thought.

“Is that so? Then it's an order. Clean up a bit.”

“Estasia doesn't listen to master's orders.”

“...Why?”

“Because she's a fallen angel.”

She said that and took a bite of ice cream.

Munch.

I had no choice but to stare at Estasia with a blank face as she stuffed her mouth full of ice cream.

I couldn't think of what to say in response to her blatant statement.

It was hard to deny since I was the one who turned Estasia into a fallen angel.

"...Estasia. It would be better if you did some cleaning."

Aronia, who couldn't stand it, chimed in from the side.

She spread her wings and spoke to Estasia with a confident voice.

But Estasia's answer was very cold.

"Aronia will do everything anyway."

"..."

"I don't want to do it."

Creak.

Aronia's head turned to me with a strange sound after hearing Estasia's answer.

Her eyes were full of expectation as she looked at me.

She seemed to think that I would side with her since she was right.

"Well, you should clean up your own feathers..."

"Cheer up, Aronia."

"Master!"

But I only cheered her on.

It was hard to refute the logic of the invincible fallen angel with my current reasoning.

I put the new smartphone I bought in my pocket after giving Aronia a brief encouragement.

And I prepared to leave the room where Estasia and Aronia were.

Being a god was more work than I thought.

“I think I have to go up to the roof now.”

“Please don’t abandon the hard-working angel!”

Aronia grabbed my leg and clung to me as I tried to go to the roof.

But unfortunately, I was a cruel god with a cold heart.

I mercilessly left Aronia behind and got out of the room.

I didn’t forget to firmly remind Estasia and Aronia as I left.

“Clean up all the feathers before I come back. And eat ice cream moderately.”

“Have a safe trip.”

Thud.

I closed the door with Aronia’s wailing and Estasia’s farewell.

The city that was being rebuilt came into view from afar.

The city was bustling with noise and movement.

Cars with headlights on were driving on the roads, and countless workers were restoring the ruined city.

It was a contrast to the city that was dead and dark until recently.

“What a nice view.”

I felt a sense of pride in my chest every time I saw the people who came back.

I couldn't recover all the people I lost, but the half I got was very precious.

Was this the feeling of the gods who watched over the humans on the ground?

Even if they didn't know about me, I would love them anyway.

I had many nights when I stayed up longing for them, and they were vividly in my memory.

“I hope they're all happy.”

Snicker.

I muttered to myself as I walked up the empty stairs.

The stairs that I had climbed many times were cleaner than before.

It was thanks to Aronia who cleaned diligently.

At the top of the stairs, there was a large cage with a sinister aura.

Of course, the one behind the cage was a familiar girl.

“You've been visiting more often lately.”

“I'm worried that the goddess here might run away. It would be a disaster if the world was destroyed again, right?”

The god of regression, Estel.

I was holding down Estel, who had weakened after exhausting most of her power, here.

Estel, who was trapped in the cage, was leisurely reading a book in her hand.

It was something I had Aronia bring to her.

I leaned against the cage that held Estel and glanced at her reading the book.

Estel was reading a book with an old-fashioned title that suited her.

“Did you have a good day yesterday?”

“Of course not. Someone is keeping me locked up here.”

“Isn’t it the duty of a god to monitor the seal so that it doesn’t break?”

I said that and checked the sturdiness of the cage that locked Estel up.

A strong energy came from my fingertips, telling me that it was intact.

It meant that the cage could still do its job.

Estel’s power had not recovered enough.

“You know this cage will collapse someday, right?”

“Well, that day will come eventually.”

“Do you think I’ll stay still when that happens?”

Estel, who was watching me inspect the cage, warned me with a sharp voice.

She was right.

It might be impossible for me to hold Estel down forever with my power.

Someday, she might break the cage with her own power and escape.

I couldn't tell if that would happen in 100 years or 1000 years.

But even then, my actions wouldn't change much.

"Then I'll have to stop you again."

"Do you think you can do that?"

"I don't know yet. Maybe by then I'll have grown into a great god?"

I would stand in front of Estel many times in the future.

I wouldn't let her ruin this world again.

That was the role given to me as a god.

I would destroy and save this world over and over again.

That was the only duty I could bear as the god of destruction.

"I don't know about that."

"I knew you would say that."

I left Estel's cold answer behind and took out the smartphone I had in my pocket.

The new smartphone I bought in the city was shining brightly as if to prove its newness.

I unlocked the screen of the smartphone with my finger.

Swipe.

The pictures of the apostles and the believers appeared where my finger passed.

They were the images I took from the other world and set as the wallpaper of my smartphone.

“You have a bad hobby. You still put their pictures on your smartphone after all that?”

“They’re my favorite.”

“It’s quite a devotion.”

I scanned the faces of the apostles in the photo as I listened to Estel’s words.

Eutenia. Evan. Pluto. Perin. Daniel. Peter.

And the holy emperor Roan standing among them.

They were precious memories that would never fade away, even as time passed.

“I like keeping them like this. They’re the things I don’t want to forget, even if time passes.”

“...”

Thump.

As I watched the apostles on the screen, I tilted the phone and showed it to Estel.

Estel’s cold eyes looked at the screen of the smartphone.

She glanced at the faces of the apostles with an indifferent expression.

I also smiled brightly and looked at the screen with her.

Even under the dark sky, the screen of the smartphone shone brightly.

“It’s nice to know that we can always be together.”

Beyond the small screen of the smartphone.

There was a world.

There was a precious story that I could never forget.

And there was me.

Chapter ss1: [END] Side Story 1 - Divine Power (1)

Side Story: Divine Power (1)

Hell reeked of blood.

That was the impression of the knight commander, Rebels Etherland, as he gazed at the scene before his eyes.

Countless clergy were bleeding and dying in front of him.

Innumerable heretics were trampling on their holy land with swords in their hands.

The holy land, Crossbridge, was being destroyed by the war between the six temples and the heretics.

It was a displeasing and turbulent sight that should never be tolerated, and it filled his vision.

“Order Temple is requesting salvation!”

“Where is the Hero of Hunting?”

“Commander! The Holy Palace is on fire!”

Urgent voices echoed from all directions.

Those who were attacked by the cult of the evil god were sending their pleas for salvation.

The Holy Palace, located in the center, was engulfed by a huge flame that could be seen from the bridge.

Rebels, who held a black holy sword, was also swinging his sword continuously.

The fanatics were rushing at him with the intent to kill him, even at the cost of their lives.

It was a very difficult task to face the fanatics who disregarded their own lives.

“Goddess...”

Chwak!

Rebels cut down a heretic with his sword and uttered the name of the goddess.

Even as he recited a short prayer, he could hear the desperate voices of the clergy from all sides.

But Rebels had no power to save them all.

Even though all the clergy of Crossbridge were in crisis, there was only one Rebels Etherland.

All he could do was to hold his sword and move forward, and that was a trivial thing for him.

“Guide me, please!”

As soon as the short prayer ended, Rebels’ body was wrapped in a brilliant light.

The countless wounds that were bleeding also hid their appearance in the holy radiance.

—Miracle.

The great goddess bestowed a miracle upon him.

Just by praying, his body was healed, and just by regaining his mind, his fatigue faded away.

He would never fall unless he faced a complete death.

That was the power of the paladins, who were called the indomitable.

“Goddess!”

In the isolated battlefield, where he was swinging his sword alone, the memory of the first time he awakened his divine power flashed through Rebels’ mind.

What was divine power?

It was their will to pursue the god.

It was the product of their faith in the god, and their will to move forward.

—You must deliver the brightest light to the future.

That was what the paladin who taught him the sword for the first time said to him.

That’s why they fought countless heretics with the resolve to die, until now.

“Guide me!”

He cut down countless heretics.

He knocked down countless monsters.

He slashed the ones who claimed to be evil, and gave faith to the ones who longed for the light.

The path he had walked until now was pride itself for Rebels Etherland.

It was a pride that he could not exchange for anything.

He believed that he would fall with his brilliant pride until the last moment.

“Please, guide me!”

Chwak!

Every time he swung his sword, the light flashed.

The sword that he had swung for his whole life drew countless sword lights in the air.

The black holy sword that did not allow even a ray of light, shed light along the path he swung his sword.

This was the once-in-a-lifetime light that he emitted.

It was a flame that would never have come out if it were not for the holy land that was stuck in the bottom of the abyss.

“Kill him! Show him the will of the great one!”

“Let’s move forward! Destroy the temples of the false gods!”

The heretics who blocked Rebels shouted angrily and glared at him.

They were nothing but fanatics.

They ran at Rebels to inflict wounds on him, even ignoring their own lives.

Even the wounds that were made healed in an instant by the divine power, but the fanatics did not stop running.

“The goddess... is watching over you.”

Kwaduduk!

The sword that absorbed the light swung roughly and crushed the enemies that blocked him.

As Rebels, who blocked the bridge alone, became isolated, the radiance that wrapped the holy sword became brighter.

Even if his body was broken and died, the holy land would not collapse.

That was the oath he made when he became the commander.

That was what it meant to be the commander of the paladin order.

He had to protect the holy land by giving his all, no matter what.

“Commander! There is a suspicious movement from the direction of the Harmony Temple!”

“Apostle! The enemy’s apostle has appeared!”

Rebels’ eyes turned to the direction of the Harmony Temple, where the enemy’s apostle appeared.

There was a considerable distance from the bridge where he stood to the Harmony Temple.

Moreover, the number of heretics who filled the gap between them was not small.

Rebels looked back and forth between the bridge where he stood and the bridge that led to the Harmony Temple with a worried gaze.

‘An apostle of the evil god...’

He had to deal with the apostles of the evil god first, or the fight would not end.

But the moment Rebels left his place, the balance of the bridge he was on would collapse in an instant.

He was seriously considering whether he should move to the direction where the apostle appeared.

At that moment, he saw a group of soldiers running toward him from the Holy Palace.

“Rebels Commander! We will stop them here! The direction of the Harmony Temple is in danger right now!”

“Chris!”

The soldiers who ran toward Rebels were a few paladins, including the heretic inquisitor Chris.

Rebels smiled faintly at the sight of the paladins who ran toward him.

He thought they could trust and entrust the heretics who crossed the bridge.

If Chris and the knights stopped the heretics, Rebels could break through and head to the Harmony Temple.

“The Hero of Abundance also headed to the direction of the Harmony Temple! While we hold this place, please go and stop the apostle, Commander!”

Chris also seemed to aim for that situation, and urged Rebels to go and stop the apostle.

The heretics who rushed to the Holy Palace were also a problem, but the bigger problem was the apostles who descended on the holy land.

Every time they joined the battle, one front line was pushed back.

Besides, they could not leave the apostles alone, who might have some tricks up their sleeves.

Rebels nodded and accepted Chris’s encouragement.

“That sounds good. I’ll leave the defense of this place to you.”

“Don’t worry! We will stake our lives and stop them!”

“Just... survive somehow.”

“Of course. We will also show you that we can protect this place.”

Chris smiled confidently and began to push back the heretics.

Rebels looked at Chris’s firm determination and turned his body to the direction of the Harmony Temple with his sword.

The Harmony Temple had been showing suspicious movements from the beginning.

It was not hard to guess that something had gone wrong with the intervention of the apostles.

Kwak!

Rebels Etherland, the knight commander who held a holy sword, put more strength into his hand.

He had to stop the apostles and the cult’s plan somehow.

“Hold on as much as you can. I’ll come back when this is over.”

“Don’t worry about us and go quickly!”

Rebels started to move toward the Harmony Temple, raising his divine power explosively.

He poured out his divine power as efficiently as possible, within the limit of what he had left, excluding the power to fight the apostles.

At the end of his sight, where he swung his holy sword toward the Harmony Temple, he could see the temple with a faint pillar of light connected to it.

The Harmony Saintess, who had been imprisoned, seemed to have used her divine power.

He didn't know what was going on, but if the saintesses and the heroes were still there, there was still some leeway.

If Rebels joined them, the situation would likely tilt to the holy land's side in an instant.

He decided that and tried to move his steps faster at that moment.

“!”

Paat!

He witnessed a fierce darkness bursting out from the direction of the Harmony Temple.

The thing that scattered the blackness as dark as pitch was a blasphemous figure with a radiance like light.

Rebels, who was running with his holy sword, stopped his steps urgently at the strange sight.

“That is, no way...”

Rebels' voice sank as he witnessed the darkness that came out of the temple.

A black pillar that stretched out from the sky was connected to the Harmony Temple.

He could feel the huge pressure that came with the trembling atmosphere.

He felt suffocated as if his whole body was being crushed.

Even though he knew something had happened, he couldn't shake off the immense fear that pierced his chest.

“Co, Commander! The Harmony Temple is...!”

“Is there a problem with the Harmony Temple...!”

Rebels' anxious eyes looked at the black pillar that pierced the Harmony Temple for a moment.

The pillar of light that was stained black stretched out to swallow everything, and then converged and disappeared completely.

But even after the light disappeared, the huge anxiety that settled in Rebels' chest continued to grow.

It was not a situation to be relieved just because the pillar of darkness was gone.

As Rebels now, he couldn't accurately grasp what had happened.

He had to check what had happened.

As Rebels' voice echoed in the battlefield with horror, shortly after.

As if to respond to his fear, a strange voice resonated throughout the battlefield.

-“—Lograshion.”

The world lost its color and collapsed.

The evil god's domain began to spread, and Crossbridge lost its hue.

In the world that was dyed gray, Rebels raised his black holy sword.

Something went wrong.

The temple was going in a completely different direction from their expectations.

The apostles of the evil god had definitely done something.

“What the hell is...”

“...”

Thud.

Someone made a sound of footsteps and came out of the darkness that covered the Harmony Temple.

The one who came out of the temple's darkness was a boy who still had a young appearance.

Despite his immature appearance, an overwhelming density of divine power was rising from around the boy.

Rebels understood the relationship between him and the boy just by looking at him.

The intimidation of the predator that could manifest the legendary dragon or the beast was flowing from him.

The boy's aura overwhelmed the countless people of Crossbridge.

-“Ah—.”

A syllable that flowed out as if clearing his throat.

With that alone, all the clergy shivered and looked at him.

The heretics who seemed to have sensed something early knelt down and looked up at him.

There was no need to wonder who he was.

The only one that the evil heretics followed.

The ruler of the countless darkness on the continent.

And, the loser of the earth that all humanity feared.

“Ah, it's the evil god...!”

“The evil god... the evil god has descended!”

“Did no one... stop the evil god’s descent in the end?”

Evil God (悪神).

A god had descended on the earth.

All the clergy screamed with a cry like a scream as they realized that.

In an instant, all the forces of the holy land fell into chaos and lost control.

As if to answer him, the boy raised a finger.

Leisurely. With a relaxed look.

He spoke as if he was sentencing everyone here.

-“The light has fallen.”

A single word that flowed out faintly from the boy’s mouth.

Right after that, the sun collapsed.

Chapter ss2: [END]Side Story 2 - Divine Power (2)

Side Story 2: Divine Power (2)

Since ancient times, humans have worshipped gods.

They were always beings beyond the reach of human cognition, incomprehensible and unfathomable.

The allies of omnipotence and omniscience.

Under their endless power, the great names always received the prayers and praises of humans.

There was only one reason why countless humans always called out the names of gods.

They hoped that the great beings who existed in the heavens would give them the greatest answer.

“...”

And now, that answer was mine.

I slowly scanned the fierce battlefield of Crossbridge, stained with blood.

The god who brought darkness to the continent had fallen, and those who claimed to be the light had hidden in the darkness.

What remained after they disappeared was a land of steel and fire, with a thick smell of blood.

The god of retrogression and coordination who had led everything was gone, but even so, there were still many people left on the battlefield.

Each of the priests burned themselves to the last moment and resisted.

“O Goddess, guide us!”

“Light——!”

They were those who faced the enemy calmly even in the face of death.

They were those who would not bend their faith even if they were broken, snapped, and collapsed.

There were always such people everywhere.

A ray of hope like light.

And the fools who burned brightly by betting everything on that hope.

What they needed was not light.

It was the only darkness that would reign over everything.

-“Ah——.”

With a body that had not yet fully grown, I opened my mouth lightly.

A short syllable echoed in the fierce battlefield.

As soon as my voice was heard, everyone who was wielding swords on the battlefield looked at me.

The emotions that reflected in their eyes were one of two.

Fear. Or awe.

It didn't matter which one.

Essentially, they were not much different.

“Ah, it’s the evil god...!”

“The evil god... the evil god has descended!”

“Did no one... no one stop the descent of the evil god in the end?”

The priests of the six temples who were surprised to see me opened their eyes wide and uttered a scream-like sigh.

People are afraid of what they cannot understand.

And my appearance in the eyes of humans would be the same.

A god was a being that could not be understood.

And a being that should not be understood.

In that logic, I was able to reign over everyone who was in this place.

-“The light has fallen.”

I opened my mouth and declared the reality.

Divine word.

The divinity in human flesh uttered a short word.

It was the proclamation of the law.

The divine territory that covered the entire Crossbridge changed its appearance and realized the law of the anomaly.

“The sky has changed!”

“What the hell is this...!”

Zzzz-.

The sun collapsed and darkness descended.

The deep shadows that reached up to the waist covered the bodies of the priests.

The weak lives that were breathing roughly also sank under the thick shadows.

-Lograshion.

The sanctuary where the power of destruction spread was the most familiar and free place for my flesh now.

“Eric! Snap out of it!”

“O, O Goddess! Guide us!”

“Holy maiden! Where are you...!”

In the deep shadows covered with black, each voice echoed.

They were all confused and looking around.

Most humans would never encounter in their lives, a miracle that was beyond cognition.

All humans who faced the changing law stared at the unknown spectacle with despair.

I declared the second law to the sighing humans.

-“A black sun will rise.”

As soon as the next word echoed, a black light bloomed in the place where the sun had collapsed.

It was a contradictory shape that was dark and yet shining brightly.

The humans who faced the black sun in the sky raised their heads and uttered a short prayer.

On the blood-stained land soaked in darkness, people were chasing their own light.

Even in the situation where they faced an unbelievable sight, they opened their mouths and shouted the name of God.

“O Goddess... guide us... guide us...”

“Even if darkness descends, the light will rise someday...”

“O Goddess, why do you give us this trial!”

The Goddess did not answer them.

This place was entirely a divine realm that I ruled.

The goddesses who were watching this place from the heavens could no longer interfere with me.

However, even so.

There were always people who tried to take a step forward in the chaos that surrounded them.

-“O Goddess, guide us.”

Clang.

A knight in black armor raised a dark sword and recited a quiet prayer.

He was the knight commander of Crossbridge who survived the battle with the sect.

He pulled out his sword roughly and pointed it at me.

“I am the knight commander, Revels Ederant. I am a servant of the Goddess and a holy knight chosen by the black holy sword.”

-“...”

“On behalf of all the priests of Crossbridge, I will cut down the fallen god.”

Revels Ederant.

The leader of the surviving holy knights spoke to me with his sword pointed at me.

The hero they had hoped for was long gone.

Now he seemed to stand in place of the hero.

A heavy divine word struck Revels.

-“The price of ignorance is not light.”

“If I don’t stand up, no one will.”

He said that and ran towards me with a black sword in his hand.

The sword tilted diagonally pointed at me, and the footsteps that stepped forward pushed away the shadows that rose from the ground.

The sword that advanced through the gray atmosphere.

He tried to stab me with his sword without any hesitation.

“Evil god who disturbs the continent! I will bring you down even if I have to sacrifice my life!”

A word full of determination burst out from Revels’ chest.

However, there was one thing he overlooked.

The fact that I was a different being from him.

Rebelz's wish was impossible from the start.

“...!”

“Re, Rebelz...!”

Thud-.

Rebelz's wrist, which was stabbing towards me, was twisted.

The black holy sword, which was cutting through the air with a sharp trajectory, also turned into ashes and collapsed.

Without his sword, Rebelz fell to the ground with his wrist broken.

Splash.

Rebelz, who fell into the sea of shadows, looked up at me with a blank face.

“Why, why...”

It was a simple reason.

This place was my sanctuary.

Only the heroes who received the blessing of the gods were allowed to wield their swords against the owner of the sanctuary.

And Rebelz was not a hero.

He was not even properly given the right to challenge me.

-“The price of ignorance is not light.”

I looked at Rebelz, who was lying on the ground, and spoke to him.

Right after that, many priests who were around grabbed their throats.

They were choking themselves with painful faces.

The ones who were corrupted by the overflowing divinity killed themselves with their own hands.

Some of them, who escaped from the corruption, tore their own throats and sang praises with all their might.

Logration moved by itself and made the priests around sing the ashen hymn.

“For the great... one... for him...!”

“For the great... one... for him...!”

“For the great... one... for him...!”

Many voices spread out, and a wave of fanaticism that disturbed the ears surged.

Some cried and shouted for the god, and some others screamed in fear of the approaching death.

Rebelz, whose wrist was broken, bit his lips with tears of blood.

As time passed, the ones who choked their throats died one by one.

In the sea of shadows where the priests died, Rebelz screamed in agony.

“Aaaa... Aaaaaaaah——!”

His broken throat let out a loud scream.

Rebelz’s scream, mixed with the sound of metal, flowed out as if he was venting his anger.

But even then, the priests who choked their throats died one by one.

The inquisitor who walked towards Rebelz also died right in front of him.

“Da, captain... please... cough...!”

“Chris...!”

Thump.

The shadow waves spread around the fallen inquisitor.

Rebelz’s eyes trembled violently under the realm of death where many priests met their end.

He must have realized the difference in rank from the spectacle just now.

There was a huge gap between the creatures and the beings beyond that could never be reached.

Rebelz, who saw the fallen priests, let out a rough cry.

“Why... why did it turn out like this...!”

I looked at Rebelz, who was full of despair, and raised one hand slightly.

It was not enough.

I had to engrave my existence into everyone in this place.

To make them never look up at the sky again.

Until the six gods they serve never come to their minds again.

I had to prove the authority of the god to them.

That’s why I decided to revive the ones who killed themselves by choking their necks.

-“Rejoice. I am your order.”

Logic collapses and laws perish.

Logration, which filled the surroundings, was the realm of destruction.

The life and death of all living beings that fell under the power of destruction depended on me.

Without my permission, they could not die or escape from this place as they pleased.

Tick-.

As I flicked my finger briefly, the ones who were lying down revived from death in an instant.

“Puhaa...”

“Huek... hoo...!”

“Wha, what, what just happened...!”

The priests who returned from the brink of death gasped for breath.

They looked at each other with disbelief.

The handprints that tightly squeezed their throats were no longer there.

But the punishment I imposed on them was not over.

I flicked my finger again.

-“Marvel. I am your knowledge.”

The pressure of unbearable information swallowed up many priests.

A massive amount of information that exceeded the human processing limit.

It was obvious what would happen to the humans who received it all at once.

Puke-!

The priests who were standing vomited blood.

Blood streams continued to flow from their eyes and noses.

-“Praise. I am your abundance.”

Once again, I flicked my finger.

Along with my declaration, sprouts sprang up from the bodies of the ones who shed tears of blood.

The stems of plants that grew from human bodies expanded at a fast speed.

At the same time, the priests who were rooted by the plants screamed.

The screams that were mixed without balance created a gloomy atmosphere.

-“Honor. I am your glory.”

Again, I flicked my finger in the air.

Now, the priests who grew plants started to fight each other.

Their swords cut each other's flesh, and their hands grabbed each other's throats.

Blood splashed and screams ran rampant in the battlefield where a huge fear spread.

Rebelz's face, who saw the priests killing each other, became more vicious than before.

The honor that the knights longed for was no longer in this place.

-“Admire. I will control you from now on.”

When I flicked my finger for the last time, watching all this spectacle.

Everything returned to normal.

But the eyes of the priests who looked at me were very different from before.

They looked at me with a deeper fear.

There was no longer any resistance in their hearts.

They had already understood.

The huge doctrine that the god's flesh, who descended into the world, created.

-“Behold.”

I just enlightened them with that doctrine one by one.

From now on, I am the rule.

I am the flow.

I am the order.

And I am the——.

-“I am your god.”

The god of destruction who controls the fate of people and the world.

Chapter ss3: [END]Side Story 3 - A Thousand and One Nights

Side Story 3: A Thousand and One Nights

After the priests who had surrendered to the evil god who descended to the earth left, the holy war ended and the world became peaceful.

However, even then, the sixth apostle Peter Englov was always busy.

There were still many people who acted foolishly even though the god had come down to the earth.

Peter's job was to exterminate them.

“The apostle of God has arrived—!”

Peter, who had descended from the moving sanctuary using a featherfall, swept away all the rebels in an instant.

The rebels could not resist properly against him, who wielded both the holy sword and the demon sword.

There were hardly any people on the continent who could keep up with Peter's speed, which was enhanced by Dainsleif.

Peter had reached a level where he could proudly boast about his strength.

He had completely forgotten the days when he was treated as a horse by Estasia.

As Peter quickly annihilated the rebels and looked at the scene, the fourth apostle—Perin Shtait, who had led the sanctuary down from the sky, handed him a handkerchief with her pointed ears twitching.

“Good job! Demon Peter!”

“It’s nothing to me now.”

Peter took the handkerchief and wiped his sweat, then looked at the fallen rebels.

They were very foolish.

He, who had received the mark of the hero, had given up everything and submitted to him.

But how could they, who were neither heroes nor apostles, stand against him?

It was a stupid thing to do, no matter how he thought about it.

“Peter has become cool now!”

“Hmm.”

Peter lowered his hand in embarrassment at Perin’s praise and returned to the sanctuary.

After the work was over, he had to go back and pray to the great being.

Three years of constant prayer.

And constant dedication for the church.

That was the price of the wish that the great being had promised to Peter Englov.

“Are you going to pray now?”

As Peter was about to enter the shrine in the sanctuary to pray, Perin, who had been watching him, asked him.

Nod.

Peter agreed with Perin's words and answered her.

"Yeah. I have to pray to the great one."

"Peter, how many days have passed today?"

"41 days."

It had been 41 days since he started praying along with dealing with the rebels who defied the great being.

There was still a lot of time left until the three years he had promised with the great being were over.

He had to pray to the sky whenever he had a chance.

That way, the great being, who was moved by his sincerity, might perform a miracle faster than the promise.

"Good luck today!"

"I have to. Thank you."

Peter, who had a short conversation with Perin, entered the inside of the shrine and closed the door.

And then he immediately prayed to the sky.

The content of his prayer was always the same.

It was about how loyal he was to the great being and how much he missed his family.

“O great one. Today, I have executed those who disobeyed your will for you.”

“O great one. Please kindly restore my family, my village...”

“O great one...”

It was a sincere prayer, with every word.

As he listened to his own prayer sound ringing in his ears, Peter quietly closed his eyes.

The apostle’s prayer continued until the sun set.

Even after time passed, Peter’s day did not change much from before.

He executed those who defied the great being, and prayed to the great being whenever he had time.

That was most of the way he spent his day.

Of course, there were times when he had a conversation with Perin, who transported him, but the proportion of that in Peter’s day was not very long.

He usually finished the conversation within an hour.

“Demon Peter! How many days have passed today?”

“95 days.”

“It seems like there’s still a lot left!”

Peter nodded quietly as he listened to Perin’s story.

There would be at least a thousand days left.

He had no idea how long it would take for the time agreed with the great being to pass.

Sometimes he wondered if this was the punishment that the great being imposed on him.

“Peter, you must have a lot of stories to tell when the villagers come back, right?”

As Peter was having a disrespectful thought while leaning on Yggdrasil, Perin, who was sitting on a branch, asked him a different question.

Did he have any stories he wanted to tell the villagers?

That was the question that came to Peter.

“Stories I want to tell?”

“You have had a lot of experiences, haven’t you?”

“I have a lot to say.”

Peter recalled his experiences and answered.

He, who was nothing more than a rookie in a corner of the village, became an apostle of God and fought bloody battles with heroes.

If he told the villagers who knew him in the past, no one would believe him.

He felt like he could talk all night with the villagers on that topic.

Maybe they would all marvel at his changed appearance.

“They will be fascinated by my stories. I have a lot of interesting stories.”

“You must have a lot of stories!”

“I can’t tell them enough in a day. I have so many feats.”

As Perin listened to Peter's words and agreed, she suddenly seemed to remember something and rummaged through the branches.

After rummaging through the branches for a while, she took out a thick book.

Peter looked at her with a puzzled expression as he saw the thick book in Perin's hand.

"What is that?"

"Demon Peter! How about writing a diary?"

"A diary...?"

"It's where you write down the details of what happened every day! To tell your precious people vivid stories someday!"

Peter looked up at Perin with his mouth wide open at the word diary.

He had learned some writing when he was with Utenia.

But he had never thought of writing such content as a diary.

Peter looked at the thick diary in Perin's hand for a long time and said.

"A diary... Can I write well?"

"It's okay if you write a little badly, right? It's only for you to see!"

"Is that so?"

Snicker.

Peter snickered and reached out to the sky.

And then he gestured to Perin to hand him the diary.

"Alright. Let's give it a try."

“Writing a diary will help you pass the time better.”

“Fine. Fine. Just stop with that...”

“If you help me weed Yuto’s sanctuary, I’ll give it to you!”

But the diary was not free of charge.

A louder voice came out of Peter’s mouth, who was flustered.

“You’re not just giving it to me?”

“Nothing is free in this world.”

“...”

He had to clear the weeds of the sanctuary.

Peter leaned against Yggdrasil and looked at the vast sanctuary.

It didn’t seem like a quick job.

“What are you going to do, Peter?”

“I have nothing else to do, so I might as well pull some weeds.”

Peter said that and got up from his seat.

Thud-.

A heavy sound echoed from Peter’s joints as he stretched his body.

The same morning as always.

Peter got up from his seat and went out of the shrine to face the morning of the sanctuary.

The first thing he saw as soon as he woke up was, of course, Perrin, who was twitching his pointed ears.

“Good morning, Peter!”

“Good morning.”

“Master Peter! How many days have passed?”

As soon as he woke up in the morning, Peter recalled the date he wrote in his diary yesterday, in response to Perrin’s question.

He had not lost track of the days left for him since he learned the habit of writing a diary from Perrin.

The date he wrote yesterday was 273.

It would soon be a year.

“273.”

“It’s been almost a year!”

“Yeah, I guess so.”

It had been a long time since he started praying.

But even then, there was still more time left than that.

Peter’s diary was the same.

There were more pages to fill in the future than the ones he had filled so far.

As Peter pondered over the diary he wrote last night, Perrin pointed down with his hand and said.

“Today, I brought you to a place you would want to see.”

“A place I would want to see?”

“Lady Utenia said you would like it if she brought you here!”

At Perrin’s words, Peter stepped out to the edge of the sanctuary and looked down.

Before he knew it, a familiar scenery appeared below the lowered sanctuary.

The place where he first met Utenia.

The small rural village where he had been farming since he was a child.

He felt a complicated feeling in his chest as he faced the familiar sight after a long time.

“Utenia said I would like it if she showed me this place?”

“Yes. Don’t you like it?”

“She still has a bad taste. That person.”

Peter sat down at the end of the sanctuary and looked at the village below his legs.

There was no trace of people in his hometown anymore.

Only the sight of broken houses and neglected fields remained instead of him.

As Peter looked down from the end of the sanctuary, Perrin, who was watching him, also sat next to him.

And he looked down at the village on the ground with Peter.

“Is that where your hometown used to be?”

“It’s been ruined a lot... but it’s a place I miss.”

“It’s a miserable sight.”

As he saw his hometown, memories of the past came back to him.

He wanted to leave the small rural village when he was young.

He wanted to go out and wield a sword and write heroic tales rather than farming.

That's how he became an apostle of God, who everyone looked up to.

"It's because of me."

But Peter realized something new only after he rose to a high position.

He didn't know the value of what he had in his hand when it was precious.

He only regretted and lamented after losing it, and traced its traces.

Just like his small rural village that he couldn't face now.

He kept chasing the traces of his family with the sin he exchanged for his dream.

"I wanted to go to the city back then."

"Did you like the city?"

"I wanted to be a hero. But I thought I couldn't achieve anything living as a bumpkin in a rural village."

It was a foolish thought.

He was a young fool who didn't know that the simple happiness was something that couldn't be exchanged for anything.

In the end, he let a monster into his village.

The result was the ruin that Peter was facing with his eyes now.

“But no matter how great I become... there’s no one left to be happy for me now.”

What he longed for was still in his grasp.

What remained became the longing he had to hold on to.

In the reversed order, the path he had to take was decided.

He had to walk a journey of going towards the smallest thing, using the biggest thing as a stepping stone.

It was a trial that the being he served and the followers who followed him gave him.

“So I won’t give up until I get it back.”

“...”

“I won’t lose it again after I get it back.”

There was still two years left.

And during those two years, he would continue to build his story.

Someday, when the diary he wrote reached its last page.

He was going to tell the villagers his heroic tale with confidence.

It was a story that he had built up for several years.

It was not a story that would end in one night.

“Peter is amazing.”

“Uh, um...”

“I’ll cheer for you too!”

Perrin took out a branch and moved it to tap Peter's head.

Peter felt his head clear up for some reason at that sight.

One evening, after finishing all his tasks and returning to the sanctuary, Peter encountered Perrin, who was waiting for him in front of the shrine.

Perrin had a trace of moisture on her lips, as if she had just eaten some fruit.

She waved her hand and asked a question to Peter, who was holding a diary and heading to the shrine.

“Peter! How many days have passed?”

“471 days.”

“That’s a lot!”

“I guess so.”

Perrin was right.

Compared to the beginning, when it was not even 100 days, a lot of time had passed.

Now, he did not need much time to reach the halfway point of the agreed period.

The content of the diary he had been writing was also thicker than before.

Since he started his ordeal, many things had changed.

“In a little while, Peter’s dream will come true!”

“Perrin, there’s still a lot left.”

She spoke with a hopeful voice to him.

But Peter scoffed and waved his hand at Perrin's words.

Even though a lot of time had passed, the time of hardship he had to face was still longer.

It was not an easy situation for him to accept it positively like her.

"Peter. Are you going to write your diary again today?"

"You taught me that. And I thought it would be okay to tell everyone the story."

"Is that so!"

Perrin, who was worried, threw an apple to Peter.

Thud-.

Peter caught the apple that Perrin threw lightly and looked at the apple in his hand.

The apple in his hand was something that the artificial divine tree Yggdrasil sometimes produced.

Perrin gave him one last word as he received the apple.

"Peter! Cheer up today! I'll keep cheering for you!"

"Sure."

Peter greeted Perrin with a drained voice and stepped into the shrine where no one was.

Perrin, who he saw, was always a positive person.

No, a positive fairy.

He could not tell if that was the average personality of the fairy race.

Perrin was the only fairy he knew.

“I miss them all...”

Peter entered the empty shrine and opened his diary and sat at the desk.

Rustle.

As he turned the pages of the diary, he saw many letters filled up.

The diary, which was already filled up by a third, looked dense and oppressive just by looking at it.

It was a completely different atmosphere from when he received a blank paper from Perrin.

“There’s a lot of content I’ve written so far.”

What was contained in the letters that were densely packed was the content that Peter had experienced since he started his ordeal.

He repelled the bandits who attacked the village.

He repelled the remnants of the six temples who tried to cross the Crossbridge border.

He answered the call of the great being and went to face the leaders of other countries.

They were all things that could be called nonsense.

“.....They would be happy if I told them these stories.”

It was a hard story to hear in a small village in the corner.

There were hardly any professional storytellers passing through the village, so it was practically a story that could only be heard occasionally in the city.

If he told these stories to his family and villagers, they would be interested and listen with pleasure.

Of course, there would be some who would not believe that it was his own experience.

It would be very strange to them that Peter, who always claimed to want to leave the village, had grown so much.

“.....”

Peter, who had been looking through the diary he had written, looked at the empty page of the diary.

It was the page where he would write today's diary.

Click.

Peter lifted his pen and lightly stabbed it into the ink.

And then he started to write down what he had experienced today on the empty diary.

“Today's weather was... clear. The wind was also refreshing. It felt good to go up the hill and look down at the village on a day like this.”

Scratch. Scratch.

The pen in Peter's hand moved busily and wrote letters.

Maybe it was because he had a lot of words in his chest.

The empty page of the diary was filled up in an instant.

Peter turned the diary to the next page and continued to write down the remaining contents.

“Sometimes I would go up the mountain with Bill and skip work, and then pick apples from Jay's tree and share them...”

Now that he thought about it, it was not such a bad day.

He farmed, and watched the trees and grains grow day by day.

And some days he ran away to the mountain with his friends and had a little escapade.

And then he met a snake, and was scared and went back.

“Well... I guess I had... more than I thought...”

He had a fun day on a day when the weather was good.

He had a happy day on a day when everyone was noisy.

He had a lovely day on a day when Emma from next door came out dressed up.

He had an exciting day on a day when a wandering knight came to the village and told his nonsense.

“I shouldn’t have said I wanted to go to the city... I shouldn’t have thought I wanted to get out of this boring corner.”

Snap-.

The pen he was writing with broke.

Peter looked at the broken pen, and then sighed and bowed his head.

He felt unusually heavy in his head today.

Following the weight of his head that he could not bear, a drop of hot water fell.

“Ah, why all of a sudden...”

Tears flowed from his eyes as he wrote his diary.

His childhood self, who tried not to cry because tears were a sign of weakness, flashed through his mind.

Since then, he had tried to hold back his tears no matter how hard it was.

He was able to be calm in his own way while he was with the Order, thanks to that.

But now it felt strange.

“Why... won’t the tears stop...”

The tears that ran down his cheeks did not stop.

No matter what he did, he could not stop the tears.

The tears that fell on the diary blurred the letters.

The diary that recorded his day was ruined.

Peter desperately reached out his hand to his face and tried to wipe away the tears.

“I’m, actually, not feeling anything...”

He wiped the tears in his eyes with his sleeve.

But the tears did not stop and kept flowing.

As if to express his honest feelings that he could not spit out.

They continued to soak Peter’s diary.

“Ah, aah—”

A sigh burst out of his mouth.

He felt his emotions that he should not reveal trying to leak out.

Peter hurriedly tried to suppress his feelings.

And instead of letting out his true feelings, he clasped his hands and began to pray to the great being.

“O great one...”

Instead of the stories he could not tell, Peter spoke of what he really had to say.

His long wish.

His earnestness.

His only hope.

The huge and heavy price he had to pay for the dream he had in his foolish days.

“I, I... did wrong.”

And above all, his deep regret for his foolish self of some day.

Bang.

Peter bit his lip and slammed his head on the desk.

As if to vent his anger at himself.

Once. Again.

He kept hitting his head on the desk.

Twenty times in total.

When the act of hitting his head on the desk ended with the blood flowing down, the last thing that came out of Peter’s mouth was a desperate plea.

“Please... give me back my precious people...”

The huge sanctuary floating in the high sky.

The fortress that moved by the giant spirit called Buuto was protected by the fourth apostle Perrin.

So the first thing Peter saw when he opened his eyes after staying in the sanctuary for a long time was Perrin, who was guarding the sanctuary.

“Peter! It’s a good morning today!”

Day 871.

Peter looked at Perrin after adding one to the number he had written in his diary last night.

The fairy in front of him was waving his hand with a bright face since early morning.

She looked lively as always.

It was a completely different situation from Peter, who was half asleep from the fatigue that weighed on his body.

“Yawn... Yeah, good morning.”

“Did you sleep well yesterday?”

“Well. I don’t think I slept well.”

Peter loosened his stiff body and answered Perrin.

He did not sleep well yesterday.

He was immersed in a strange sentiment as he wrote his diary, just like some night.

Of course, the end of his day was the same as usual.

Praying to the great being who watched over him.

That was how Peter decorated the end of his day.

“Was there a problem?”

“Don’t worry. It’s just something that happens sometimes.”

Perrin asked with concern at Peter’s words that he did not sleep well, but Peter shook his head with a light smile.

It was not something he could easily tell to others.

It was also a story related to Peter’s own scars.

He thought he had grown up, but his heart still had a weak side.

He sometimes got lost in his feelings while writing his diary alone.

“Peter! By the way, how many days are left today?”

Nod.

Perrin agreed with Peter’s words and then asked how many days it was today.

He had calculated it beforehand, so Peter could easily answer Perrin’s question.

“871 days.”

“There’s not much left now!”

“I guess so.”

Perrin was right.

It was already over 800 days.

Compared to the time when it was not even 100 days, there was not much time left.

Only relatively not much.

But in Peter's mind, it was still a long time.

"Master Peter! Today, there is a command from the great one!"

As Peter counted the remaining days and worried, Perrin clapped his hands and spoke.

The command of the great one.

It was about the mission that Peter performed every day.

Sometimes there was no such mission, but today it seemed that there was a mission.

"What is the command?"

"It's to wipe out the bandits in the northern part of the empire!"

Bandit extermination.

It was one of the longest tasks.

He had to search around all day without a set time.

But Peter did not complain and spoke to Perrin.

"Okay. Then I'll leave the north to you."

"Yes!"

After finishing the conversation with Perrin, Peter went back to the shrine to get his sword.

It seemed that he would be busy today as well.

The last day from the promised three years.

Peter came out of the shrine with a determined expression.

He had worked hard to fulfill the mission of the great one.

Now, if one more day passed, the day he had been looking forward to would come.

The moment he returned to the village he had been abandoned for a long time, he would be able to see the result of his faith.

“Now... it’s the last day.”

Peter came out of the shrine and immediately began to loosen his body that had been stiff while sleeping.

It was the most important thing for a warrior to check his physical condition.

It was what his swordsmanship master Evan Allemier had taught him.

As Peter followed Evan’s teachings and loosened his body, Perrin’s voice suddenly rang out from the edge of the sanctuary.

“Peter, Peter!”

“What is it, Perrin?”

“It’s a disaster! The bandits are attacking the village!”

Perrin’s eyes were fixed on the scene below. It seemed that one of the nearby villages was under siege by a horde of bandits.

Saving the villages from the bandits was one of the tasks that Peter had been assigned as an apostle of the great one. He wanted to return to his

hometown as soon as possible, but he couldn't ignore a problem if he saw one.

Peter followed Perrin's gaze and looked down. He was curious to see which village was in trouble.

"That's..."

And what he saw in his eyes was the sight of the village he had been longing for.

His hometown.

The place where his heart belonged.

The place that he had lost once, but now was bustling with life and people.

Of course, he also saw the bandits that were surrounding the village, as Perrin had said.

"The village is being attacked! We have to hurry..."

"Thank you, Perrin."

Peter thanked Perrin sincerely after confirming the sight of his returned hometown.

Perrin tilted his head in confusion, not understanding Peter's words.

"Peter? What do you mean..."

"You've been a great help. I couldn't have made it this far without you."

"..."

"I mean every word I say. You know I can't lie to you, right?"

Swoosh-

Two swords emerged from Peter's scabbard: Dainsleif, the black magic sword, and the white holy sword.

The black and white swords.

The symbols of Peter's identity.

He held them in his hands.

He heard Perrin's faint voice in his ear.

"Master Peter..."

"So, if you ever need anything, just call me. I'll help you as much as I can."

He felt that he could end his diary of a thousand and one nights today.

From now on, he could tell his stories to the people he cared about.

That's why he drew his swords and jumped to the ground.

Using Featherfall to soften his landing, he didn't forget to shout at the bandits that were surrounding the village.

"The apostle of the evil god is here!"

It was a phrase that he had spat out in anger once.

And it was a phrase that he uttered with hope today.

Kaboom!

With a loud impact, he landed on the ground and flapped his cloak.

He saw the faces of the villagers and the bandits looking at him.

"What, what is that..."

"Could it be... Peter...?"

Peter smiled brightly at the people who were looking at him.

Tears of joy streamed down his eyes.

His lips were twitching involuntarily as he smiled.

But he tried to keep his smile as steady as possible.

He had to smile brightly, for he had grasped happiness in his hands.

“The sixth apostle, Peter Enklov, has returned to this place!”

The sixth apostle, Peter Enklov.

He raised his black and white swords and shouted at the bandits.

It had been a long time.

He had worked hard for a long time to show his grown-up self to the villagers.

He wanted to show off his swordsmanship to everyone.

He wanted to boast his dignity to his family.

He wanted to tell his tales of valor to the villagers.

That was the only hope that Peter had been chasing.

Even in the dark, a ray of bright future had guided his way.

“Peter... Enklov?”

“Who the hell is Enklov?”

“What are you babbling about while crying? What a weirdo!”

He didn’t care about the bandits who were mocking him.

He had nothing to fear now.

Neither the dark hardships nor the heavy trials and tribulations.

Nothing could stop Peter, the apostle of the great one.

“Let me say it again, I am the sixth apostle of the great one.”

He smiled as brightly as he could, even as he shed tears.

It was a brilliant smile that burned away all the sorrows he had accumulated.

He smiled and unleashed the power of Dainsleif.

And he shouted with all his might, so that the whole world could hear him.

“So get lost, you weaklings! This is the era of the apostle Peter!”

The young man who had been engulfed in the bloody battle became an apostle of the great one.

But still, the story of Peter Enklov was just beginning.

After this battle, he would gather the villagers and tell them everything he had achieved.

Even if the sun set and the bonfire in the middle of the village burned out.

His story would never end.

Just like the diary he had written for a thousand and one nights.

Chapter ss4: [END]Side Story 4 - My Son-in-Law Was a God, Altear Hyrost.

Side Story 4: My Son-in-Law Was a God, Altear Hyrost.

He was a baron who ruled over a small fiefdom in the empire's borderlands.

He had a personality that could not stand injustice, and he was hated by many nobles because of it.

The reason why he was now imprisoned in the Cloud's underground dungeon was also because of his bad relationship with the nobility.

The nobles who had always regarded him as a thorn in their eyes had framed him and dragged him to the capital.

“...”

But even after spending several years in prison, Altear's mind had not changed much.

He was a person who would not bend his beliefs even if he suffered disadvantages.

The only thing that bothered him now was his daughter Eutenia, who was left alone. He wondered if she was doing well.

‘She must be doing fine, but...’

Altear knew Eutenia as a smart and upright daughter.

She would have managed the territory well even without Altear.

Maybe by now she had gained the trust of the people and had more authority than Altear.

Either way, he did not doubt that Eutenia was doing her role well.

As Altear was pondering in his prison cell, he heard someone's footsteps from beyond the bars.

His eyes quickly turned to the source of the sound.

“Baron Hyrost.”

Thud. Thud.

The one who came down to the underground dungeon with his footsteps echoing was a Cloud's investigator.

He had been facing Altear for a long time, and he had a complicated expression on his face.

Altear looked at the investigator who confronted him and asked.

“What is it?”

“Release.”

“...?”

The Cloud's investigator did not give Altear any time to be lost in thought.

He immediately unlocked the padlock that locked the prison cell.

Clang.

The prison door that confined Altear opened, and the jailer who guarded him stepped back.

“Hurry up and get out. The crown prince is waiting for you.”

“Th-the crown prince...?”

The words that came out of the investigator’s mouth, who glared at Altear as if urging him, were more shocking than anything else.

The crown prince.

The one who was next in line to the emperor of the empire was waiting for him.

Altear was flustered more than ever by the crown prince’s request to meet the knight of the borderlands.

“What are you doing? Do you intend to make His Highness wait?”

“I-I’ll follow you right away!”

But he did not have much time to delay.

The other party was none other than the crown prince of the empire.

Altear shook his head once and quickly got up from his seat.

The meeting with the crown prince.

It was an unexpected event for Altear, but it might also be an opportunity.

Altear, who was released from the Cloud’s underground dungeon, was helped by the maids who came from the palace and quickly finished his bath and grooming.

He could not go to meet the crown prince in a dirty state, so Altear accepted the maids’ hands without any refusal.

After he finished dressing up and went to the reception room, someone opened the door and came in.

It was the crown prince who had invited Altear to the palace himself.

“Nice to meet you, Baron. I am Eicliffe Rogasion.”

“Ah, I am Altear Hyrost...”

Altear quickly got up and bowed as much as he could at the sight of the crown prince who entered the door.

It had been a long time since he had formalized, so Altear’s greeting was a bit awkward.

But Eicliffe did not mind him and took a seat opposite Altear.

He gestured for Altear to sit down and spoke in a relaxed voice, as if he was meeting an old friend.

“Baron Hyrost.”

“Yes, Your Highness.”

“How long has it been since you came out?”

“I asked some people, and it seems that it has been about four years.”

Altear did not count the time while he was in prison.

At first, he tried to calculate the time, but at some point he realized that it was meaningless.

Instead, he tried to remember the day he first came in.

He asked the palace servants for the date, too, to calculate how long he had been in prison.

Eicliffe nodded his head and lifted the teacup in front of him.

“I ordered a reinvestigation of the baron in Cloud. It turned out that you were falsely accused.”

“Your Highness...!”

“I heard that you had a hard time. The empire will compensate you enough for that.”

Eicliffe smiled kindly at him and said, and Altear felt like he was going to shed tears of gratitude.

He had been reinvestigated and released from prison by the authority of the crown prince.

There was nothing better than that for him.

The crown prince also mentioned compensation, but Altear declined it with a humble expression.

It would be a little money at best, and he was satisfied enough with the fact that he had been helped by the crown prince to get out of prison.

“Your Highness. Compensation, that is an unworthy word...”

“His Majesty has decided to give you the Colt Duchy, which was confiscated from the traitor Duke Colt.”

“Yes, yes...?”

But Altear felt like he had been hit hard on the back of his head by the next words of Eicliffe.

The traitor Duke Colt.

And the Colt Duchy.

He could not understand the words that he heard in his ears, even though he knew them.

‘What? Did I hear it wrong?’

He must have heard it wrong.

Otherwise, there was no way that he would suddenly give a duchy to a baron of the borderlands.

As Altear waited for the next words of the crown prince, thinking that way.

Eicliffe’s mouth uttered an even more shocking story.

“Also, His Majesty wants to grant you the title of Duke Hyrost and entrust you with the important role of guarding the northern part of the empire.”

“Ah, ah, no, you mean me as a duke...?”

Duke Hyrost.

In other words, he was going to elevate the baron’s family to a ducal family.

It was an unprecedented and unheard-of event in the history of the empire.

And it was a ridiculous story, no matter how he thought about it.

Just because he had been unjustly imprisoned, he would give him a duchy and a ducal title.

It was a decision that the royal family would not make unless they went crazy.

Altear rudely expressed his honest opinion to the crown prince, who was flustered.

“Are you saying that the hardships I endured in prison are enough to make me a duke? No matter how you look at it, this is...”

Well, the main reason why you were appointed as a duke was the First Apostle’s will, rather than your hardships.”

“First Apostle...?”

“First Apostle, Eutenia Hyrost. She has chosen you as the guardian of the north.”

Hearing Altear’s question, Eicliffe told him about the First Apostle Eutenia’s involvement.

Altear’s eyes widened at the mention of his daughter’s name.

He quickly grabbed the table and stood up, facing Eicliffe.

“Eutenia... First Apostle...? Your Majesty, where is my daughter Eutenia, where is Eutenia now?”

“Calm down. You will meet her naturally when the time comes.”

“But, Your Majesty...”

“You should rest in the palace for a while and wait for your appointment as a duke.”

Eicliffe said that and sipped his tea.

The crown prince’s lips still had a kind smile.

The sudden conversation with the crown prince.

The incomprehensible promotion to a duke.

And the story of his daughter who had become the First Apostle.

All of these stories felt like a joke to Altear Hyrost.

It was as if the whole world was trying to deceive him.

After the meeting with the crown prince, Altear’s time passed very quickly.

He heard stories about the responsibilities of a grand duke every day, and received reports on the changing situation of the Colt duchy.

He also met some excellent talents introduced by the crown prince.

Sometimes he was invited by the nobles to attend the splendid parties of the empire, which was a strange experience for him.

“Dad!”

“Eutenia!”

“Dad... I don’t know how long it’s been since we last met...”

Another day, he unexpectedly met Eutenia.

Eutenia, whom he hadn’t seen for a long time, looked much more mature than the last time he saw her.

She was wearing a very elegant dress and had a noble aura around her.

Altear’s attitude towards Eutenia was so polite that it was even respectful to his own flesh and blood.

“Me too. But Eutenia, I heard that I became a duke, do you know anything about that?”

“The elevation of the Highrost family? It was all approved by the great one.”

“The great... one?”

“The only divine seat who descended to the earth. He understood my merit and your hardship, and bestowed grace upon our Highrost family.”

Eutenia’s face turned slightly red as she talked about the great being.

Altear looked at her and then collapsed on the chair with his legs losing strength.

No matter how hard he thought, his head couldn't keep up with the situation.

What was the First Apostle and who was the great one?

But Eutenia, who faced him, only told him incomprehensible stories.

“So, we can't help but go to thank the great one.”

“Thank... prayer?”

“Then let's go to the temple of the church together.”

Altear had no chance to object to the bewildering story.

He was led by Eutenia's hand to an unknown place, and met unknown people there.

And he received a lavish treatment from them.

It was a treatment that he couldn't understand the reason for.

“Your Grace. The meal is ready.”

“This is the scripture that we, the church, present to you as a gift.”

“Wear this necklace and call the name of the great one ten times a day.”

They devoted their time and effort to Altear as if they had met a great person.

And at the end of those incomprehensible things, there was an incomprehensible result.

At some point, he was kneeling in front of everyone who was praying.

“Highrost Duke. I appoint you as the honorary bishop of the church.”

“Yes...?”

“Yes. You were born to serve under the great one.”

“...?”

“From now on, you and your subjects will pray and dedicate to the great one. Then the great one will promise eternal prosperity to the Highrost duchy.”

Honorary bishop of the church.

With that incomprehensible title, a splendid badge was added to Altear’s shoulder.

After that, he received the same treatment as before and spent a few days with Eutenia.

He regained his senses after a few days in confusion and returned to the palace.

“Your Grace. I will take you to the castle.”

Altear looked at the servant who bowed his head with a blank eye.

It had been a month since he escaped from the damp underground prison of Cloud.

When he came to his senses, he was in front of a servant who greeted him politely in the cold land of the north.

It was the servant of the castle who came to meet the new duke, Altear.

He showed respect to Altear and praised him.

“I heard that you have done a great deed on your way here, Your Grace.”

“Deed...?”

“When you enter the castle, the knights who know your feat will salute you all at once.”

“...?”

Tap. Tap.

On the saddle of the slowly moving horse, Altear thought.

What did I do?

No matter how hard he thought, he couldn't guess.

He just woke up and became a duke.

‘What deed did I do?’

Altear looked at the servant who moved in front of him with a doubtful gaze.

But the servant didn't care about Altear's gaze and just did his job quietly.

Creak-.

As the door of the castle opened and Altear and the servant entered.

The servant shouted in a loud voice that could be heard throughout the castle.

“The lawful ruler of Alterius! The divine seat who descended to the earth and the faithful honorary bishop recognized by the church! And the great knight who is the guardian of all the northern people! The Highrost Duke has arrived!”

“Woaaaaah!”

As soon as the servant's words ended, the knights who were lined up slammed their swords on the ground.

The stewards of the ducal family behind the knights cheered.

With the thunderous applause and the bursting cheers.

In the midst of the cheers that echoed everywhere, Altear thought.

‘Really, what is this?’

Altear Hyrost.

The new duke of the empire still couldn’t believe the sight in front of him.

Chapter ss5: [END]Side Story 5 - Estasia TV

Side Story 5: Estasia TV

It had been quite a long time since I started living with two angels.

During that time, Aronia and Estasia, the two angels, seemed to have adapted to the modern life in their own way.

Of course, they were careful not to expose their halos and wings outside, but they were now well-versed in the benefits of civilization and the life beyond the network.

For example, Estasia's hobby had changed to gaming.

She spent 80 percent of her waking hours playing video games or online games.

Just like she was doing right now, using a controller to play a fighting game.

“...”

Thud. Thwack.

Every time Estasia's fingers moved the controller, a merciless combo followed.

The opponent's character, who had allowed Estasia's character to combo, was in a critical state.

Estasia, who was busy moving her fingers, soon knocked down the opponent's character.

On Estasia's screen, the word 'WIN' was prominently displayed.

She had won the match against her opponent.

Estasia made a V sign with her fingers and said to me.

"Master. I won again."

She smiled and boasted of her victory.

I nodded my head with a half-hearted smile and replied.

I didn't feel like teasing her when she was happy with her win.

Besides, Estasia's matching rank was also close to the top.

I gave her a short compliment that was not sincere.

"...Well. You're amazing."

"I'll keep defeating your enemies."

I couldn't help but wonder about Estasia's words that followed.

Why were Estasia's opponents my enemies?

They were just Estasia's opponents.

I asked her directly to clear up the doubt in my mind.

"Why are they my enemies?"

"Anyone who blocks Estasia is your enemy."

"...?"

"Estasia is the most excellent angel on earth."

Was it because of Estasia's words?

Aronia, who was watching us, stopped the broom she was holding.

She looked at Estasia, who was engrossed in the game, and made a sharp remark.

"Estasia... If you're such an excellent angel, why don't you clean up your feathers?"

"It's okay. Aronia will take care of everything."

"Estasia is always like that. What are you going to do without me?"

"Let's live together forever. Aronia."

But in the end, she couldn't refute Estasia's logic and bowed her head and continued cleaning.

I felt a bit sorry for her.

I was the one who made them have a master-servant relationship at first, but now Aronia couldn't get away from Estasia's grasp.

Even if I gave her freedom now, she wouldn't be able to leave Estasia.

I chuckled and watched them.

Then, Estasia, who was holding a controller, picked up another one and said to me.

"Master. Let's play together."

"Okay. One round won't hurt."

I gladly accepted Estasia's offer.

I wasn't very good at fighting games, but it wasn't bad to play with her sometimes.

Especially since Estasia wanted to play with me.

I didn't hesitate and grabbed the controller.

I chose a character that was considered a cheat character by the players.

Estasia picked a difficult character that required precise control.

A cheat character and a high-difficulty character.

It was clear which one had the advantage.

“This time, I defeated you, master.”

And the game was over soon.

The result was my defeat.

Estasia's brilliant hand skills made my character lose without any resistance.

But I didn't accept the result cleanly.

I gave Estasia a suspicious look.

I had noticed something strange about her during the game.

“Estasia. What did you do just now?”

I saw Estasia's eyes turn golden while playing the game.

And at the same time, her hand movements became faster.

They were different from before.

Estasia looked at me with her eyes turning golden again.

She reproduced the phenomenon that had happened before.

“I used holy magic.”

“Holy magic...?”

“It’s a magic that only high-ranking angels can use. It makes your thinking speed 10 times faster...”

“That’s cheating.”

I moved my finger and slapped Estasia’s forehead.

She had used cheat in front of me.

I gave her a stinging punishment with my finger.

Estasia covered her forehead and made a crying face.

“Huek.”

“Estasia. One more round.”

After punishing her, I forbade her from using magic and asked for a rematch.

The next match was my victory.

It wasn’t because my skills had suddenly improved, or because Estasia’s skills were lacking without cheat.

Estasia was good at games even without magic.

It was just that I used my power this time.

The reason was simple.

I just wanted to win the game.

I used my power to knock down Estasia and said with a smug look.

“You still lack skill. You need to work harder.”

It was a very evil thing to do, even by my standards.

Estasia, who played games every day, started to buy electronic devices one day.

She bought things like computers, cameras, and microphones online.

She used to only order strawberries and ice cream with the money I gave her, so I was very surprised by her behavior.

I asked her why she was doing this.

She showed me the controller and said.

“Someone called me a coward.”

“In the game?”

“They said they could win the whole round in 10 seconds without the program. But Estasia doesn’t use any program.”

Of course.

Estasia used magic instead.

I didn’t see much difference, but she seemed reluctant to admit it.

So her solution was to start a personal broadcast and prove her innocence.

I gave up on trying to stop her, and told Estasia to do whatever she wanted.

“Fine, just do as you please.”

“Okay.”

“I’ll make sure your wings and halo don’t show up on the camera.”

For the next few days, Aronia, who learned about the broadcast settings through the internet, helped her.

She was a capable and clear-minded angel, quick to learn and accurate in her actions.

With Aronia's skilled touch, Estasia's studio was completed in no time.

As soon as the studio was ready and the broadcast settings were done, Estasia turned on the camera and started the broadcast.

More people than expected came to watch Estasia's broadcast, where she claimed to prove her innocence.

I had no idea how they found out the broadcast address and came so eagerly.

But it seemed that her account and play had been controversial on the internet from the beginning.

"Yup. Today I'm going to show you my game and prove it."

"Right. My nickname is ezez1111."

"I don't use any programs or anything."

Estasia showed her play to the people who came, proving herself with the camera.

She showed a scene where she shot down the opponent's character with long-range attacks in a duel between the top-ranked players.

Of course, there were cases where the opponent's character came out of the range of the long-range attack, but as soon as they did, they fell to Estasia's cheat combo.

After a few attempts, the opponent realized that approaching was meaningless and gave up resisting, choosing to die while only allowing long-range attacks.

As long as she proved her play by herself with the controller while the camera was on, the accusation of using a program was no longer valid.

-eksldpf donated 100 coins.

-eksldpf: Wow... this was not a program?

-ekslapf: This was real skill?

Right after Estasia finished the duel with another player with a one-sided victory.

The viewers who were watching her match poured out chats and donations.

The suspicion of program abuse towards her was cleared, and instead, many compliments began to flow.

-vmffnxh donated 1000 coins.

-doqjs donated 10000 coins.

-vmffnxh: I'm sorry for doubting you... I donated as an apology.

-dkfhslkd: I saw you for the first time today, but you're good at games and cute as a streamer... I donated for your success.

Some of them were even ridiculously large amounts of donations.

It was enough to make me gasp for a moment as I watched the broadcast.

Estasia seemed to be happy with the compliments, and she shrugged her shoulders with a V sign while looking at the camera.

Maybe someone didn't like Estasia's behavior.

One viewer expressed a short complaint towards Estasia through the chat.

-vlxj: What's with her? She got a million won and didn't even say a proper thank you or reaction?

It was a suggestion that there should be something corresponding to the large amount of donations.

It was a hard thing to ignore for a professional broadcaster.

But Estasia showed a sullen look at the viewer's chat.

Rather, she tilted her head and asked him a question.

“Do I have to be thankful if you give me money?”

-vlxj: Isn't that obvious? If you get a million or two million won, you should have some reaction.

“I'm annoyed... I don't want to say thank you.”

Estasia said that and kicked out the viewer who protested to her.

After that, she started to read the chats that the viewers posted one by one.

Most of them were compliments to her.

Of course, some chats were not properly delivered to her.

“You look like an angel, but you play like a devil...? Estasia doesn't like devils.”

Estasia shook her head and read the next chat.

She didn't understand the meaning of the chat.

Rather, she preferred more direct expressions.

For example, like the chat of the donor who gave her a large amount of money.

-dpqks: I donated, but there's no reaction and no fun.

-dpqks: I won't donate anymore.

“You still have to send me money. I have to order strawberries and ice cream.”

Estasia argued her opinion without hesitation to the high-value donor.

Regardless of Estasia’s attitude, the viewers had to pay her money, according to her theory.

-dptmxpf: Look at her conscience. She’ll ask for all my assets at this rate.

“Yup. I’ll like it if you give me all your assets.”

It soon evolved into a more advanced theory, that the viewers had to dedicate their assets to Estasia.

She liked the theory that she came up with herself.

Estasia repeatedly preached to the viewers that they had to dedicate their assets to her.

The reason was that she had to buy strawberries and ice cream.

“I think it’s better to give all your money to Estasia as a gift than to give it little by little.”

-dptmxpf: What do I eat and live on if I give you everything?

“You don’t have to worry. It’s not a shameful thing to donate to a great angel.”

It reminded me of a cult’s recruitment scene.

Estasia added a spoonful of sugar and packaged her story as a package product.

She started to justify her donations.

The donation product with added options soon changed into a form of indulgence.

Estasia, who abused her position as an angel, propagated her proposal through the microphone.

“If you donate a lot, I’ll ask the master to let you go to heaven.”

“Heaven is a place where strawberries and ice cream come out five baskets a dayyyyyyyyy...!”

I couldn’t stand it anymore and dragged Estasia out of the camera and ended the broadcast.

That was Estasia’s first and last broadcast.

After that, Estasia never turned on the broadcast on the internet again.

Sometimes there were posts on the internet asking about her whereabouts, but there was never a proper answer about Estasia’s whereabouts.

And there will never be.

As long as I keep my eyes open and watch her closely.

Chapter ss6: [END]Side Story 6 - The King of Assassins

Side Story 6: The King of Assassins

The Holy Land, Crossbridge.

There was a person who was called the king in this place, which was known as the headquarters of the Order.

The Holy Land was ruled by the great divinity and the Holy Emperor, but everyone in the Holy Land praised him as the king.

It was not only the people of the Order who belonged to the Holy Land.

Today, another outsider came to the Holy Land and knelt before the king.

“...What do you want?”

The Fifth Apostle, Daniel Hesrof.

A young man knelt before the apostle of the Order, who was known as the ‘King of Assassins’ by everyone in the world.

Daniel stopped his steps and looked at the unfamiliar young man.

The young man was covered in dirt and had a haggard face as he looked up at Daniel.

It was obvious that he had gone through a long journey to reach the Holy Land.

The young man, who looked at Daniel with a shabby hat, soon opened his mouth with a desperate voice.

“Please... please teach me!”

“What do you want me to teach you?”

“I want to learn from you, Daniel, who is called the King of Assassins! Please bestow your teachings upon me!”

Seeing the young man who asked for his teachings, Daniel sighed deeply and looked at him.

Daniel had been away from the fight for a long time since the Order took over the Holy Land.

Now, he even left the training of the newcomers to others, and he was only taking care of the animals and processing the meat.

Especially, most of the meat that went to the great beings or the apostles were superior products that passed through Daniel's hands.

Daniel was satisfied with his life now.

He didn't want to act like an assassin anymore.

“I am now nothing but a farmer.”

That was why Daniel recently called himself a farmer.

He thought that he had no reason to fight himself anymore.

He had given up everything and returned to the life of a farmer who raised livestock.

There were many people who asked for his teachings like the young man in front of him, but he didn't want to take any more disciples.

When Daniel told the young man his identity with sincerity, the young man started to say something that Daniel didn't expect at all.

“I know very well that you are a farmer who sows blood instead of seeds, and harvests human heads instead of grains!”

“What the hell...?”

“Ultimately, for you, Daniel, who is the King of Assassins, human heads are nothing more than grains.”

Daniel looked at the young man in front of him with half-crazed eyes.

He just said he was a farmer, but what the hell was a farmer who harvested human heads?

The title of ‘King of Assassins’, which became dangerous in a different sense from the Silent Butcher, made Daniel unable to think.

If this goes on, he might end up being branded as a human butcher without any resistance.

Daniel decided to make up a plausible story and send the young man away.

“What does it mean for an assassin whose identity is revealed? The ‘King of Assassins’ is nothing but a hollow story.”

“Ah... so that's why you call yourself a farmer...”

“Yes. I am now nothing but a farmer.”

Did his sincerity finally reach the young man?

The young man nodded his head as if he understood something.

It seemed like he finally understood what he was saying.

When Daniel tried to send the young man away, the young man who was nodding his head alone raised his head and spoke to Daniel.

“Hide the face of an assassin in a background that no one would expect... That’s a brilliant idea.”

“...”

“Some fools even brag about being assassins with their own mouths... But we should hide in the shadows created by the light.”

What did he understand from the previous conversation?

The young man’s appearance in Daniel’s eyes became even more dangerous than before.

He seemed to not listen to what people said.

Even if Daniel talked a hundred times, the young man would twist it as he pleased.

It might be better to show him once with his eyes than to talk a hundred times.

Daniel made a suggestion to the young man who was kneeling.

“...Follow me for today.”

“Daniel...!”

“And judge for yourself with your own eyes. What kind of being I am now.”

He would realize it if he followed Daniel all day.

That he was not doing the work of an assassin now.

And that he was more sincere than anyone else in the work of a farmer.

He would make the young man understand by showing him everything.

That was Daniel’s plan for today.

Daniel Hesrof's first task.

It was to feed the livestock in the farm.

"This is the barn where the meat that is consumed in the Holy Land is procured and processed."

There were countless livestock gathered in Daniel's farm, which was located in Crossbridge.

He had received permission to raise livestock in one of the places where the six temples used to be.

The bigger the farm for raising livestock, the better it was for Daniel.

He was very satisfied with it.

It felt like a blasphemy to run a farm in the place where the temple used to be, but Daniel decided not to care much about it since he had a god who came down to the earth behind him.

"You can think of the whole area around here as a farm."

"This place is so wide and it's all yours... No one would think that there is an assassin hiding in this place."

"There is no assassin in this place."

The disciples who followed Daniel had already grown up and left long ago.

He only taught them two things: how to cut off the breath in one strike and how to move quietly.

But still, his disciples came to thank him for his teachings.

They also achieved remarkable results in their own ways.

Now, they were independent and running their own training centers for assassins.

“...Is that so?”

“Yes. There is no longer an assassin here.”

Daniel threw hay into the cages of the livestock and spoke to the young man.

The only ones left in the farm now were Daniel, the farmer, his wife, and a few believers who helped him.

There was no one among them who could be called an assassin.

They only cleaned or helped with the operation of the farm, the meat that Daniel raised and slaughtered.

They were all people who were not much different from Daniel now.

“Do you want to try feeding them hay?”

Daniel asked the young man as he handed him the hay he was holding.

The young man nodded and took Daniel’s hay.

He fed the hay to the cows that filled the barn, just as Daniel had done.

Moo. Moo.

The young man marveled at the sight of the cows eating the hay.

He seemed to have no experience of feeding the cows in front of Daniel’s eyes.

“They eat well.”

“I feed them every day to fill their stomachs, and when the time comes, I send them to where they belong. That’s my job.”

“That’s a very thought-provoking statement.”

The young man, who was feeding the hay to the cows, seemed to recall something and stood still in his place, lost in thought.

Daniel watched him for a while, then moved his steps again and started to spread the hay.

There were many livestock in the farm besides the cows.

It took a long time to feed them all.

Even if the nameless young man followed him, he had to take care of the livestock in the farm as always.

No matter what anyone said, Daniel Hesrof was a farmer.

‘He will realize it when everything is done.’

Even if the cumbersome name of ‘King of Assassins’ followed him, his essence did not change from being a farmer.

And his purpose today was to make the young man realize that fact.

Daniel’s second task.

It was to slaughter the livestock and get the meat.

A considerable amount of meat was consumed every day in Crossbridge.

And it was Daniel’s job in the Holy Land to get the meat that would go to them.

“Before slaughtering, you have to clean your body.”

“Is that so?”

“Also, you have to be careful not to get any dust on the meat. It’s a tribute to the great being, so you can’t neglect any work.”

The best quality meat that Daniel slaughtered was the one that went to the great being and the apostles.

A tribute to the god who manifested on the earth.

It was a thing that was offered to the most noble being than any other, so Daniel was careful about the slaughtering process.

Especially, the hygiene of the equipment he used was something that he could never overlook.

“Indeed... Not leaving any trace is one of the basic skills of an assassin.”

“...”

“I will follow your teachings and do it as cleanly as possible.”

Even if he came to learn, he couldn't enter the slaughterhouse with a dirty outfit.

The young man took the clothes that Daniel gave him and washed his face and bathed, getting rid of his shabby appearance.

He looked like a completely different person with a neat appearance.

Daniel took the young man who had changed his clothes and entered the slaughterhouse.

There was a pig that he had prepared in advance waiting for him.

“This is today's tribute.”

“Are you going to kill it yourself?”

“I think it's the greatest respect I can give them to send them off comfortably without knowing their own death.”

As he said that, Daniel took out a slaughtering knife from his waist.

The sharp knife reflected the sunlight and flashed once in the air.

Thud. Thud.

Daniel's steps with the slaughtering knife moved toward the pig that was tied up.

He looked at the tribute that would go to the great being and spoke to the young man who followed him.

"I don't kill humans anymore. I just slaughter animals."

What Daniel said to the young man was the truth without a trace of lie.

Right after that, Daniel's knife moved.

Swoosh!

With a short recoil, Daniel's knife went deep into the pig.

The pig that was hit by his knife collapsed without even screaming properly.

The young man clapped his hands and said, admiring Daniel's skill.

"That was a very elegant and beautiful technique."

"By now, you should have understood the meaning of my words."

"Of course. As expected... You only choose to execute those who are less than animals. There are countless people in the world who are worse than the pig that just died."

"..."

"But even if you make slaughter your business, you can't let go of the weight of life. That's a great statement. I have more things to think about this time."

Daniel couldn't understand what the young man was saying.

He felt like the conversation was getting deeper into the maze.

Instead of answering the young man's words, Daniel started to drain the blood from the pig.

He had to prepare the meat by the set time, regardless of the young man's learning.

"I think I know why you are called the 'King of Assassins'."

Daniel sighed inwardly and left the young man alone, looking at the dead pig.

Was it the right choice to allow the young man to learn?

It was a story that the fifth apostle couldn't easily conclude in his head.

Even after the slaughter, Daniel's tasks continued.

He offered the meat to the great being.

He met the first apostle and talked about the situation of the great being.

He met the archbishop, who had now risen to the position of the Holy Emperor who ruled the whole Holy Land, and prayed.

As always, there were many tasks that waited for Daniel.

And behind those many tasks, there was a young man who came to learn from Daniel.

"Are you having any trouble?"

"It's fine. I'm grateful enough to be able to follow and learn from you, Mr. Daniel."

The last thing that marked their day of work was the same as the first: feeding the livestock.

Daniel returned to the barn and fed the animals, while observing the young man who had spent the day with him.

He was still watching Daniel's actions with a serious expression.

He held the feed for the animals in one hand.

The young man had helped Daniel with his work as much as possible while following him.

He did not do anything sloppily, even when he was assisting Daniel.

If it weren't for the young man's habit of adding a comment every time he saw what Daniel did, Daniel would have been satisfied with the day.

"We have some meat left from the slaughter today. How about we have dinner together when we finish?"

"It looked like a delicious meat. I won't refuse, then."

Daniel decided to treat the young man with some of the leftover meat.

They finished feeding the animals quickly, and then Daniel prepared the meat skewers himself.

He planned to grill the meat over a fire, after putting various vegetables and meat alternately on the skewers.

Thanks to the young man's help, the skewers were ready soon, and they sat facing each other on a hill at the corner of the farm.

From the farm located at one corner of Crossbridge, they could see the splendid night view across the bridge every night.

The scenery around the Imperial Palace, where the Emperor and the Divine Seat resided, was always dazzling.

“It’s a nice view.”

Crackle. Thud.

The young man said, looking at the sight of the holy land shining beyond the burning fire.

After the great being descended to the earth, the holy land had transformed into a very beautiful sight.

The night view of the Imperial Palace was also one of those sights.

“Yeah. It’s a nice view. My wife likes this scenery too.”

“Your marriage is famous in the holy land.”

“It’s embarrassing to say it myself.”

As Daniel and the young man looked at the night view of the holy land, a savory smell reached their noses.

Daniel took one skewer for himself and one for the young man, and handed one to him.

“It’s probably cooked by now. It’s better to eat it.”

“It smells delicious. I’m looking forward to it.”

Daniel nodded and bit a piece of the skewer.

As he ate a piece, the rich juice and the meat flavor filled his mouth.

The meat was in a very good condition.

The young man seemed to think so too, as he looked at Daniel and said something similar.

“This is a really great meat. It’s hard to find this level of meat in our country.”

“That’s too much praise.”

The young man, who praised the meat used for the skewers, soon ate the skewers at a fast pace.

He finished all the skewers and quickly picked up another one.

He seemed to be quite hungry.

Daniel watched him eat the skewers, and asked him a question that came to his mind.

“Do you still think I’m the ‘King of Assassins’?”

“Of course not. You are not the ‘King of Assassins’, Mr. Daniel.”

It was a different story from what the young man had said so far.

It was the first time he said something negative.

Daniel smiled faintly at his words and replied.

“.....You must have felt something.”

“You should be the ‘Emperor of Assassins’, Mr. Daniel. Unlike the assassins who became arrogant with their achievements, you still adhere to the most important principle.”

“.....”

“I was sure that the rumors about you didn’t even capture half of the truth today.”

He thought the young man had finally accepted it, but it was all Daniel’s misunderstanding.

Rather, the young man seemed to be more impressed than before.

Hoo-.

Daniel sighed briefly and looked at the young man, asking his name.

“What’s your name?”

“I’m the heir of the assassin family of Hegros Kingdom, the Plaid House. I’m Reckon Plaid the Fourth.”

“.....Assassin family?”

“I learned a great lesson from the one who reached the peak in a short time.”

The young man threw the skewer he had eaten into the air.

The skewer, thrown at a fast speed, pierced deeply into a nearby tree.

It was a skill that could not be shown unless one was well-versed in assassination.

Even Daniel couldn’t do such a feat.

The young man, who showed an impossible skill, bowed politely to Daniel and said.

“I will never forget the lesson you taught me today.”

“.....”

“King of Assassins, Daniel Hesrof. I hope to be a worthy disciple of you someday.”

Daniel looked at the skewer stuck in the tree and sighed again, looking at the sky.

A short day with the heir of the assassin family.

Daniel also felt that he would never forget today’s events.

Chapter ss7: [END]Side Story 7 - The Proof of Faith Evan Allemier.

[END]Side Story 7: The Proof of Faith Evan Allemier.

The second apostle of the Order had always admired heroes since his childhood.

He was fascinated by the countless stories of noble heroes who faced evil foes in epic battles and rose to greatness through trials and tribulations.

He was inspired by the stories of heroes that had been passed down for a long time, leaving a faint spark in his heart.

It was a flame.

A small ember that had not yet burned brightly.

But if someone added fuel to it, it could blaze up with a small possibility.

Evan, who was filled with dreams and aspirations in his childhood, fed that ember with his own fuel.

“Evan Allemier. You are appointed as an apprentice knight.”

Evan’s dormant aspiration became a firm faith, and the belief in his hand became a sword that would protect him.

Evan continued to follow the path that his conviction pointed to.

At some point, he became the most promising member of his family.

The family was satisfied with his brilliant achievements.

But they despised a pathetic member who did not suit him.

Hus Allemier.

An incompetent mage who inherited the blood of Allemier.

And the only brother of Evan Allemier.

Evan's evaluation of the weak and dull mage was one.

“He does not suit a hero.”

Evan Allemier's ideal of a hero did not match the person.

The family hoped that he would lead the frail Hus Allemier.

Evan felt the same way.

Evan wanted Hus to be a companion of the heroic tale that he would someday create.

The talk of not fitting the family was just an excuse to hide his intention.

He sincerely hoped that his blood would become stronger.

Strong enough to stand side by side with him.

“I decided to follow your will and join the Cloud.”

So when Hus joined the Cloud, the execution agency of the empire, it was a very welcome news for Evan.

If he worked in the Cloud that caught criminals, Hus's weak personality would surely be fixed.

If he received recognition for his merit and advanced to a high position in the headquarters, the family might also see Hus differently.

So he sent his only brother on a harsh journey.

Hoping that Hus, who would someday face him on the battlefield, would be a reliable ally.

“Brother... why...”

Years later.

The two brothers finally met under the heroic tale.

The first thing that broke was Evan’s own faith.

The mansion of the Allemier family.

There, Evan, who was drinking with Hus, looked at his brother.

Evan, who had not drunk a sip of alcohol since he was appointed as a knight, was now sharing a strong drink with Hus.

Evan looked at Hus, who was dressed neatly, and opened his mouth.

“It was a ridiculous story when I think about it now.”

“What story are you talking about?”

“That you were more suited to be a hero than me, and I didn’t even notice that and kept harassing you.”

Evan said that and recalled the battle with Hus.

Apostle and hero.

The brothers who carried different fates met several times on the battlefield.

And what was left at the end of such a battle was countless scars engraved on each other.

The heroic tale was nothing more than a worthless story, and he realized that fact after spending a lot of time.

“There is no need for that. It was the result of my stupidity.”

“...”

“I knew from the beginning that I was not good enough.”

But Hus’s aspiration was different from his.

What he wanted to chase after was not the hero in the story that Evan admired.

Hus Allemier wanted to stand by Evan’s side.

He had followed Evan from the beginning with only that desire.

It was a completely different logic from Evan Allemier, who abandoned his faith and joined the Order.

“That’s why I always longed to be like you.”

Evan looked at Hus’s face for a long time, and tilted the glass in his hand, swallowing the liquor.

With the burning heat, Hus’s face became clearer.

The war left a lot to the two.

The broken spirit, the scars in the chest, they would never disappear.

But even so, Evan thought that he had learned a lot from the past.

About family.

About faith.

About the countless magic and the divine seats that dominate them.

Those many things were the factors that influenced Evan's decision.

So Evan Allemier was able to say without hesitation.

"What I'm going to tell you now is the result of a meeting within the family."

"What is it that you are talking about?"

"Hus Allemier. You will soon become the head of the Allemier family."

Evan's words made Hus open his eyes wide and look at Evan.

It seemed that Evan's words were quite shocking.

"I... will become the head?"

"Yes. You are the new head of the Allemier family. The succession ceremony will take place soon."

"Why me... Wouldn't it be better for you to be the head?"

Hus shook his head as if he did not want to be the head.

He had no more power of a hero after his magic was destroyed.

So he meant that he had no qualification to take charge of the head, but Evan's thought was quite different from Hus.

Evan himself was already a clergyman who followed the god.

And he was an apostle who devoted his entire destiny to the god.

After the succession ceremony, he would completely withdraw his will from the family's event, and he did not intend to interfere with the family's affairs anymore.

"I am an apostle who follows the great one."

“Brother...”

“So I don’t suit the position of the head of the family. The only person who can be the head now is you.”

There was a silence between Evan and Hus.

There was a complex emotion in the eyes of the two who faced each other.

They knew that it was not something that could be solved with just a word.

But even so, Evan decided to say the best word he could say now.

“I believe that you can lead the family properly.”

Faith and action.

That was the basis of the clergy.

The succession ceremony of the Allemier family was held less than a month after the conversation between the two men.

The guests who came to the ceremony were also more splendid than usual.

Among them were the crown prince of the empire, Aicliff Rogasion, and the apostles Peter and Perrin, who attended to grace the ceremony.

And what was most noticeable was that the divine being who ruled the holy land came in person to congratulate the Allemier family on their succession.

He was the one who rarely left the holy land in most situations.

Therefore, it was very natural that the eyes of the many nobles who participated in the ceremony were unknowingly drawn to him.

“Why did the great one come to this succession ceremony?”

As most of the nobles looked at the divine being who descended to the ground with their mouths open in admiration, Peter, who was watching the scene, asked Evan the reason.

But Evan knew that it was a futile question.

What was the point of trying to fathom the will of God as a mere human?

In the end, their job was to make things flow as the great one wished.

“As an Allemier, I am just grateful for the great one’s visit.”

“...You also didn’t know anything about the great one.”

“It’s impossible to fully understand the will of the divine throne even if you are an apostle.”

Evan said so and turned his eyes to the scene where the succession ceremony was taking place.

Even though most of the nobles were looking at the great one, Evan had to keep watching Hus’s appearance.

That was the role given to Evan Allemier today.

Among the crowd of people who surrounded the succession ceremony, Hus was heading towards the platform where the crown prince Aicliff was waiting.

Thump. Thump-

The sound of Hus’s footsteps echoed as he walked along the carpeted road.

He seemed to have made a firm determination for a month, and he was moving towards the crown prince without any hesitation.

As Hus knelt down in front of the crown prince, Aicliff, who was holding the imperial decree, looked down at Hus and opened his mouth.

“I, Aicliff Rogasion, came to confirm the loyalty of Hus Allemier and the Allemier family on behalf of the great sun of the empire.”

“Hus Allemier greets the representative of the great emperor.”

“I ask you on behalf of His Majesty, you, Hus Allemier, do you swear to be loyal to the empire and the sun forever?”

The oath of loyalty.

It was a ritual that every successor of a noble family had to go through.

Originally, the lord would go to the temple after the succession ceremony and perform the same ritual again, but today, the crown prince Aicliff came in person to accommodate him.

Hus swore eternal loyalty to the royal family and the empire to Aicliff, who was looking down at him.

“I, Hus Allemier and all the members of the Allemier family, swear to be loyal to the great sun and the prosperity of the empire.”

“Then you take this decree.”

“I accept His Majesty’s command.”

“I appoint Hus Allemier as the next lord of the Allemier family under the glorious name of Rogasion.”

Swoosh-

Aicliff drew his sword from his waist and tapped Hus’s shoulder with it.

By tapping Hus’s shoulder with the sword, representing the emperor, the succession ceremony of the family was completely finished.

As Aicliff was about to put his sword back in, all the participants of the succession ceremony realized that there was one more procedure left.

-“I will ask.”

Under the dark sky.

Behind Aicliff, a throne suddenly rose.

And sitting on it was a boy with hair as black as pitch.

The boy on the throne was looking at Hus, who had finished the succession.

Hus bowed his head and assumed a respectful posture in front of the intense pressure he felt.

-“Do Allemier and his vassals wish to be under my protection?”

The great one.

The only divine being who descended to the ground offered his protection to the Allemier family.

It was an attractive offer that no one in the world could refuse.

And under that oppressive offer, Hus instinctively found the answer he had to give.

This was in the form of an offer, but it was not something that could be rejected.

What he needed now was a submission that would satisfy the great one.

“I swear eternal loyalty to you.”

-“What I want is not loyalty.”

“I will prepare the sacrifices and rituals that suit the great one. The descendants of Allemier will offer sacrifices to the sky every year and swear to offer grateful offerings for your grace.”

After the oath of faith flowed out of Hus’s mouth.

The boy who was sitting on the throne stood up.

And he solemnly declared to Hus, who was kneeling and bowing his head.

-“As long as you do not lose that faith, you and your descendants will prosper forever.”

As soon as the declaration from the divine being ended.

The throne and the boy disappeared together.

Hus was then able to understand that everything was over.

Hus, who had completed the perfect succession ceremony, stood up and straightened his posture.

And he faced the baptism of applause from all sides.

“Congratulations. The great one himself blessed you.”

In the midst of the applause, Hus Allemier looked back at the scene he had faced.

The memory of the unbelievable past flashed through his head.

Evan Allemier and Hus Allemier.

The minds of the two men were still filled with thoughts of the capricious god.

Chapter ss8: [END]Side Story 8 - The Holy Emperor, Roan Hebriss

[END]Side Story 8: The Holy Emperor, Roan Hebriss

The Holy Emperor, Roan Hebriss.

Ever since the war in the holy land ended and the throne of God descended to the earth, his position as the archbishop of the church had been expanding day by day.

The kings of various countries treated Roan with courtesy at the conference hall, and all kinds of precious food were served to him at mealtime.

He also acquired expensive clothes and jewelry that he could not have dreamed of before.

Although he could no longer continue his research on black magic, he still had countless things in his life that he could not have had before.

“Wasn’t the great one really amazing today?”

“...”

Roan’s first task of the day was to get ready in the morning and go to meet the great one.

Every time he went to meet the great one, the first apostle, Eutenia, was always there, and she would come to him every day after the first task was over and tell him her impressions.

Most of them were words of praise for the great one.

If it were someone else, he would have thought that they had a deep faith, but to Roan's eyes, Eutenia's current appearance seemed somewhat distant from faith.

No, rather, it seemed closer to love.

Love for the throne was in some ways disrespectful and irreverent, but the great one was somewhat tolerant of Eutenia's behavior.

It must have been because of the wish she had made to the great one.

"I think it would be nice to erect another statue of the great one in front of the holy palace."

"...A statue, you say?"

"I think the number of statues we have now is not enough to express the greatness of the great one."

Sometimes, Eutenia's enthusiasm would go too far like this.

There were already statues of the great one in every chapel, but she still wanted to erect more statues.

It was a very irreverent thing to guess the will of God, but to Roan, the holy emperor, their master did not seem to welcome the carving of his image.

It might have been because his image was not perfect, or because the avatar that descended to the earth was only temporary.

But Eutenia did not care about that fact, and that was a well-known story.

She already had countless statues in her room.

"Why don't you take out the ones in your room and move them here?"

"They are too small to be of any use."

The statues that were the size of an arm were already placed on every piece of furniture in Eutenia's quarters.

There were so many of them that one day, the great one who visited her room burned half of them.

Even so, the fact that there was still one on every piece of furniture was amazing enough.

There were many radical believers in the church, but there were not many who had such an obsessive attachment to statues as Eutenia.

“And... the more artworks that capture the image of the great one, the better.”

“Is that so...?”

“Isn't it obvious that the artworks that capture the image of the throne are the most beautiful and perfect?”

As she said that, Eutenia sipped her tea with a satisfied expression, and Roan sighed inwardly.

It was good for an apostle to show a devout side, but he wished that she would say those things in front of the great one.

Moreover, he wished that she would stop coming to the holy palace every day at the time when the cake arrived.

Today, too, the cake that was placed in front of him disappeared into Eutenia's stomach.

As Roan stared blankly at the empty cake plate, Eutenia put down her teacup.

“I enjoyed it. Please seriously consider my suggestion.”

“...”

“I’ll come back tomorrow at this time.”

After eating all the cake for today, Eutenia bowed politely to Roan.

It was the minimum etiquette for Roan, who had ascended to the position of the holy emperor.

As soon as she got up from her seat and left the office, Roan raised his middle finger at the door where Eutenia had disappeared.

It was his revenge for the empty cake plate.

He also did not forget to mutter his complaints in a small voice.

“I wish she wouldn’t come tomorrow.”

Squirm.

As the shadow under his feet moved, Roan lowered his hand politely.

One of Roan’s tasks as the holy emperor.

It was to deal with the countless documents that came to him.

Most of them were about the establishment of temples, the enactment of laws, the appointment and promotion of clergy, and so on.

There was a higher throne in the holy palace than Roan, but it was not something that he could pass on to the great one, so most of it was Roan’s responsibility.

“They want to keep the old church headquarters as a holy land...”

Among them, there were some tricky problems that he had to think about for a long time.

There were many aspects that were affected by the church's prestige or financial situation.

Moreover, there were some documents that Roan had to review again at the end, because there were not a few people who had taken important positions without having a good head.

As Roan racked his brains while looking at the documents, a priest outside the office told him something.

"The second apostle, Evan Allemier, wishes to see you, your holiness."

"Evan, you say...?"

Evan Allemier.

The second apostle of the church had come to see him without any notice.

He must have had something to say to Roan in person.

After a moment of hesitation, Roan ordered the priest to open the door.

"Let Evan in."

Creak-.

As the door opened at Roan's command, Evan, who was wearing armor, entered the office.

He greeted Roan briefly and then dragged a chair to the opposite side of Roan.

In Evan's hand, which faced Roan, there was a document.

"Your holiness, Roan. I have something to ask you."

"What is the problem?"

“I was notified unilaterally by the holy knight order that part of the defense budget of the holy land has been cut. I want to hear the whole story of how this happened.”

Evan said that and handed the document to Roan.

Roan felt that this would be a tiring conversation as he faced the document.

Every department in the holy land needed funds for their own reasons, but the finances of the holy land were not enough to handle all of them.

The church, which had newly occupied the holy land, did not receive as much donation income as the six temples combined.

That was why there were complex money problems all over the holy land.

Roan saw that the reason why Evan came today was also one of those problems.

“I always say this to other people, but that kind of problem is not mine, but the lower level’s...”

“I heard that you can’t ignore the documents with your seal on them. I thought it would be faster to talk to you directly.”

“...”

Roan felt a sense of crisis and tried to turn the conversation to another priest, but unfortunately, it seemed that there was already a priest who had sold him out.

It was hard for the other priests to face Evan, who was an apostle chosen by the god himself.

It looked difficult to avoid the situation now that Evan was talking like this.

Roan had no choice but to listen to Evan’s complaints that followed.

“As you know, Your Majesty, the defense of the holy land is a serious matter.”

“...Yes.”

“Even the six temples that were holding the Crossbridge were careless enough to allow the invasion of the cult.”

“...Hmm.”

He had a lot of things to say about that, but Roan nodded obediently under Evan’s menacing gaze.

He could not suppress the apostles who were directly selected by the god with the authority of the holy emperor.

They showed respect to Roan, but he knew very well that it was not because of Roan’s authority.

So the only thing Roan could do now was to listen to Evan’s dissatisfaction.

“No matter how great the one who resides in the holy land is, we cannot rely on his existence alone for the defense of this place.”

“That, that’s true.”

“Besides, even if we repelled the invaders, it would be a problem if we failed to defend completely and the holy land suffered a great damage.”

“Evan is right. The defense of the holy land is an important matter.”

He would give a plausible reason, but in the end, all these words converged to one point.

Increase the budget.

Since most of the documents that Roan stamped were related to the execution of the budget, the conflict over the finances was inevitable.

But the fact that the holy land's finances had a limit was a fact that he swore to the great one.

“But how can you reduce the budget of the holy knights, who are the mainstay of the holy land's defense?”

“Hmm...”

In the end, Roan was inevitably destined to be scolded by Evan.

How could he make Evan's dissatisfaction subside a little?

Roan listened to Evan's nagging and sighed deeply in his heart.

When the sun began to set, most of the official schedules of the holy emperor were over.

After that, he would eat dinner and drink wine, or read a book and spend time alone. That was Roan's daily life.

As he was moving to eat dinner after a day's work, he met a familiar apostle who waved his hand with joy.

“Roan! Long time no see!”

The one who came to him was the sixth apostle of the cult, Peter Enklov.

Peter spent most of his time outside the cult, so he had relatively fewer meetings with Roan than the other apostles.

Peter, who met him after a long time, was holding something in his hand and walking towards Roan.

Roan greeted him with a forced smile, hiding his fatigue.

“It's been a while, apostle.”

“You can call me Peter, you know.”

“I can’t do that to an apostle who was chosen by the great one. You seem to have been to a faraway place this time.”

The clothes that Peter wore in front of Roan were quite exotic.

As Roan guessed, Peter nodded and pointed to the sky.

He was pointing to the sanctuary that would be floating high above them.

“I went with Perin, and it was a very unique country.”

“It must have been a good experience.”

“The food was not to my taste, but apart from that, it was a pretty good time.”

Peter said that and handed something to Roan.

It was something similar to a scarf that Peter was holding.

It looked like a clothing that was common in that country.

As Roan looked at the scarf that Peter handed him, Peter smiled brightly and put it in Roan’s hand.

“It’s a gift. I can’t pay off all the debt I owe you with just this, though.”

“Peter, apostle...”

As he said that, the memories of the apostles he met today flashed through Roan’s mind.

In the morning, Eutenia came and stole all of Roan’s cake.

While he was working, Evan came and demanded an increase in the budget.

While he was touring the holy land, Daniel came and urged him to secure additional manpower for the farm.

And finally, at the end of the day, he met the first apostle who gave him a gift for himself.

It was a trivial gift, but it felt different to Roan who received it.

“You don’t owe me anything, apostle.”

“Come on.”

“No. I swear by the name of the great one, you don’t owe me anything.”

At this moment, it was rather Roan who felt a slight debt in his heart.

He smiled brightly and put the scarf that Peter gave him around his neck.

It was a thing that did not match the holy emperor’s formal attire, but it was not a situation that he needed to care about now that the schedule was over.

Roan pointed to the lit-up restaurant and said.

“I would like to have dinner with you, Peter. It’s been a long time.”

“Dinner with you... That sounds good.”

“Let’s go together. There will be delicious meat prepared.”

In the evening, the red sunset was cast on the sky.

The footsteps of Peter and Roan echoed side by side in the holy palace.

Chapter ss9: [END]Side Story 9 - The Last Wish

[END]Side Story 9: The Last Wish

After the battle with Estelle, I granted each of the apostles one wish.

The six apostles told me their wishes.

Some of them wished for something very small.

Others wished for something very grand.

And finally, someone wished for something very troublesome.

“I still have some quota left today.”

The first apostle, Eutenia Hyrost.

Her wish was of that kind.

It was a rather audacious request, to say the least.

She wished for me, the god she served, to tell her that I loved her once a day.

Even a fanatic would not dare to ask for such a wish.

-“When do you want to hear it?”

“I think it would be better to save it for today.”

-“If that’s your wish.”

Of course, if she were an ordinary person, she might have tried to make such a wish.

The problem was that I was a god who had to maintain dignity in front of her.

I could show some emotions from time to time, but if I seemed too frivolous, it would be troublesome.

Faith and prayer come from authority and dignity.

If I did not even keep the minimum decorum as a god, I would have difficulties of my own.

At least in the holy land, I had to try to keep my dignity as much as possible.

“You are always so majestic, sir.”

My confession to Eutenia was also not out of the rigid form.

Eutenia seemed to like even that kind of confession.

Yesterday’s confession would have elicited the same reaction from her.

If she were the usual Eutenia.

-“You seem to be disappointed.”

“I would be lying if I said I wasn’t, but I’m satisfied enough that you granted my whim.”

But today’s Eutenia was different from usual.

Her attitude had become colder than before.

Maybe she got tired of hearing the same cold confession every day, no matter how much she liked me.

Eutenia had a forced smile on her face, full of thoughts and worries.

-“That’s a lie.”

“...”

-“You can tell me the truth. I’ll allow it.”

I couldn’t just let it go, knowing that she had a complaint.

Especially if the cause was me.

So I asked her to tell me the truth.

“I tried to tie you down with my wish, knowing that you would hate it.”

-“...”

“But now I wonder if it wasn’t a disrespectful and selfish thought.”

-“You were thinking that?”

“So I was wondering, what if today’s wish was the last one, if you were uncomfortable.”

In other words, she was saying that she would give up her wish from today if I was having a hard time.

It was her own way of caring for the object of her faith.

I looked at her with mixed feelings and asked her.

-“Are you okay with that?”

“Your will is my wish.”

If I asked her if her wish was troublesome for me, I couldn't completely deny it.

But if I asked her if her wish was unpleasant for me, that wasn't true.

I could face her true feelings from her wish.

It wasn't a bad thing to see a precious being longing for love.

Besides, after repeating the same words over and over, I even felt something like affection for her lately.

-“It seems like you have a big misunderstanding.”

“Misunderstanding... was it?”

-“Yes. A misunderstanding.”

I said that and picked up the letter I received from Acliff in the island.

The letter from Acliff, the crown prince of the empire, said that the founding day festival would start from today in the island.

The festival that transformed the whole island into a lively place was held under the support of the royal palace and the tower.

And the last of the festival would end with a ceremony for me, along with fireworks.

“Get ready, Eutenia. We have to go to the island right away.”

But what I paid attention to in Acliff's words was, none other than the fact that the festival started from today.

The word festival had magic.

The magic that made people's hearts flutter.

It wouldn't be hard to untangle the complicated feelings of the two people in such a place.

"The island...?"

"Today, we'll spend some time alone there."

"...Yes?"

That was the hasty plan I prepared to appease Eutenia.

A one-day date in the island.

The island, called the heart of the empire, had countless shops and people.

And today, especially since it was the time of the festival, the crowd was unusually busy.

I was walking along the street with Eutenia, just the two of us.

And that was with Eutenia, who had completely let go of the divine artifact I gave her.

"I've never seen you dressed up like this, Eutenia."

"It's a bit... awkward without the divine artifact."

Eutenia was holding a parasol, dressed in a splendid outfit.

She was showing the opposite of her usual appearance in the holy land.

And I was also wearing a suitably refined outfit to match Eutenia's appearance.

If the people of the island saw us, they would think we were a gentleman and a lady who came to enjoy the festival.

“You look good, don’t worry.”

“Is, is that so?”

“Yes. It wouldn’t be bad to walk around the city with this outfit sometimes.”

Eutenia still looked awkward, but I grabbed her hand and led her to the festival site.

This was not the holy land, but the middle of the island.

It would be a waste not to enjoy it, since we came this far.

Today, for one day, we could have fun and eat, without being bound by the roles of god and apostle.

-“If there is anything you want to see, feel free to tell me. It’s not hard for me to take you there.”

“...”

-“It would be a waste if you don’t enjoy yourself at the festival.”

Eutenia’s eyes followed me for a long time, feeling uneasy.

She had not enjoyed a proper social life for a long time.

For her, who had only been to battlefields and temples, all these sights must have been very unfamiliar.

But I still hoped that she could enjoy all these sights as much as she wanted today.

That would be the best date I could give her.

“Ah, there...!”

About ten minutes after we started walking around the island, Eutenia suddenly stopped in her tracks, having found something.

She seemed to have discovered something that caught her eye as she looked around the festival.

I also stopped and looked in the direction of her finger.

I wanted to see what had captivated Eutenia's attention.

-“...”

“Look, they are erecting a statue of the Great One!”

I was shocked when I saw what Eutenia was pointing at.

There was a statue being erected in my likeness.

It was a very large statue.

The clothes were pious robes, but if you looked closely at the face, you would recognize it.

I tried to hide my flustered expression and pulled my hat down deeper.

I did not forget to distort the perception of the people around me.

-“That's what Eicliffe was talking about. It's so big that it catches your eye...”

“I like it because it's big. It must mean that the prince's faith in the Great One is as huge as that.”

How does that make sense?

I was bewildered by her overly leap of logic, and when I looked at her, Eutenia had a faint smile on her lips.

I tried to say something to her, but then I smiled back and held her hand again.

The festival had just begun.

There were still plenty of things to see on the island, even without that statue.

“Uh, uh...?”

-“There are still many things to see today, princess.”

“Wait a minute...!”

I didn’t have time to waste on a statue.

At least not in my opinion.

It was very unpleasant to see a huge statue of myself being erected.

I didn’t think it was a fitting attitude for a god.

I led Eutenia around the festival and showed her various attractions.

We admired the crudely made sculptures, or watched the knights marching on the streets.

There were also people who made chickens fight, and drunkards who drank beer while watching them.

There were also magicians who showed magic to the people and attracted everyone’s attention.

On the outskirts of the shopping district, there was an old woman who tried to lure passers-by by offering to tell their fortunes.

“You two are a match made in heaven.”

The woman who took us to the front of the god's throne blasphemed about fate.

Of course, she did not receive any divine punishment.

What she faced was not a god and an apostle, but a couple who came to enjoy the festival.

But Eutenia's face was redder than before after the fortune-telling.

-“Let's go eat some skewers this time.”

-“Let's do that.”

We also ordered some skewers from a stall when we felt hungry after seeing the sights.

The skewers we bought from the stall were sold by a man named Melson, who said they were made by his mother with great care for the festival.

He praised his mother's skewers until his mouth was sore.

I didn't know if he was sincere or just trying to sell, but the skewers were decent.

They tasted good and filled our stomachs.

-“I heard from Perin that there is a famous cake shop on the island.”

After we finished the skewers, we went to eat some cake together, which Eutenia liked.

It was a cake shop that was famous on the island.

Perin's words were not empty, as the shop we were introduced to had quite a lot of nobles.

Eutenia and I were able to enjoy the cake and tea that came to the table after a long wait.

The combination of sweet cake and bitter tea was not bad.

“Hehe...”

Maybe it was because of the taste that matched the fame.

Eutenia’s expression was quite a sight as she ate the cake.

She savored the sweetness of the cake, then looked embarrassed for a moment, and then ate the cake again while looking at me.

She seemed to really like the cake.

-“Don’t mind me and eat as much as you want.”

-“...Yes.”

I ordered more for Eutenia without hesitation.

Eutenia also accepted my offer without refusing.

That was understandable, since there were six plates of cake stacked up when we left the shop.

Of course, I only ate one piece, so Eutenia ate almost all of the six pieces by herself.

“It’s delicious.”

I wondered what made her a cake monster.

When I looked back at the past, the first thing that came to my mind was the cake I gave her for the first time.

Maybe the culprit was me in the past.

When we left the shop after enjoying the cake with Eutenia, the sun was almost setting.

The darkening sky was filled with shining stars, one by one.

The end of our date was approaching, as if to tell us that.

The sunset was disappearing beyond the horizon.

The people who crowded around the fountain also disappeared almost all of them.

It was getting close to dinner time, so they all seemed to be going to eat.

-“It’s quieter than before.”

“I like it. It feels like a place for just the two of us.”

Eutenia, who was sitting on the edge of the fountain, said that with a bright smile.

She seemed to like today’s date.

Maybe even this moment was being engraved in her heart.

The fountain we were sitting on would always be there, but today was only once for us.

The same day would not have the same excitement as today, even if we repeated it.

-“Are you feeling better?”

“I’ve been feeling fine from the beginning.”

-“...”

“Just a little worry, that’s all.”

Euteneia said with a face that looked somewhat refreshed.

She looked like she had found the answer to her dilemma in her own heart.

Euteneia smiled and got up from her seat, looking at me.

Behind her, faintly shining constellations were drawn in the night sky.

“I think it’s okay to ask for one last wish from the great one now.”

Under the sky where billions of stars were spread.

The apostle with ash-colored hair fluttering looked at me.

Her eyes were full of firm determination.

Euteneia, who had finished her own resolution, told me her wish.

“Please tell me that you love me for the last time.”

-“Euteneia.”

“That’s enough for now.”

She was always doing whatever she wanted, except for me.

And today, she was acting like a spoiled child to me.

She was here not as the guardian of the cult and the first apostle of Euteneia, but as a noble girl who longed for a fleeting romance.

She seemed to want to show me that this was her true self.

-“But before that, let me ask you one thing.”

So I had to listen to her now.

What she thought when she harbored such feelings.

Why she had such longing.

I had to hear her sincere thoughts about me.

“Of course, you can ask me anything.”

-“Do you think that the feeling you have is love?”

Euteneia made a subtle expression when she heard my question.

There are things that you have to hear even if you know.

And there are things that you have to hear because you don't know.

What Euteneia was about to tell me was all of that.

Euteneia clasped her hands on her chest and opened her mouth to me.

“Do you remember the day when the great one extended his hand of salvation to me?”

I couldn't forget.

The small story that started from the other side of the small smartphone screen.

I moved my finger for a moment of amusement and saved her from danger.

Without even knowing what it meant to her.

“I think there are many people in the world who are like me that day.”

Yeah. It was just a moment of entertainment.

It was the satisfaction that came from the thought that I was superior to the existence beyond the screen.

“A situation where you can't see even an inch ahead, and you can't find any hope at all.”

“And even in that situation, you can’t do anything, you are incompetent and weak.”

“The sense of loss that nothing is left to you in the last moment.”

But it had more value than that.

What Euteneia showed me that day was her past self.

The time when she was deceived by someone and fell to the bottom of the abyss.

The loneliness of living alone in a world where no one was.

And above all, the powerlessness that came from the fact that she had no power to overcome all those situations.

“As I hated the world that had dropped me to the bottom of the abyss, I only hoped for a blind salvation, and I felt so pathetic.”

Maybe it was natural that I was drawn to her.

What Euteneia, who was broken, showed me was her self that had already collapsed.

She was the one who fell into a momentary dream by being deceived by Estelle, and had to kill her own people with her own hands while drunk.

“I was just so scared and desperate, and I waited for the last moment to come to me, feeling frustrated.”

“Then you showed me mercy, the great one.”

The cheap price of salvation was blind faith.

Faith.

It was a faith that was strong enough to be scorned by the name of fanaticism, but twisted.

Euteneia had been giving me sincere faith ever since that day.

“So I decided from then on.”

“It doesn’t matter to me why the great one saved me.”

It was just a moment of fun.

That was the whole reason.

“I decided not to wonder why you made me, who was weak, your first apostle.”

It was just a coincidence that she had a chance.

There was no deep reason for that order.

“I don’t care if the whole world points fingers at the great one and criticizes him as an evil god.”

Still, she gave me blind faith.

Even if it was a being that demanded blood and flesh from humans, and ruled over them with fear under the name of the evil god.

Even if everyone condemned her as a witch, and criticized her soaked in blood.

Her faith never wavered.

Eutenia chose to be with me of her own will.

She decided to stand by my side, no matter how much blood stained her hands.

“Because... you are the only salvation for me.”

She was always on my side, even without threatening her with magic and power.

Eutenia always moved for my sake, even without tempting her with gold and glory.

That was the way of life she chose.

That was the absolute rule that reigned over everything she loved.

Eutenia made her choice with her own will.

There was nothing I had to pay for that choice.

“What do you call this feeling?”

Eutenia Hyrost.

She looked at me with a faint smile on her face.

She was the one who asked the question now.

She handed me a question that was simple and difficult, more than anything in the world.

“Is it longing? Is it awe? Or is it love?”

“I’m still immature, so I don’t know.”

Bang!

A cannon sounded behind her, announcing the end of the festival.

The magic created by the mages of the tower turned into a splendid fireworks that decorated the sky.

Eutenia reached out her hand to the sky in the deafening roar.

Her figure became a picture under the blooming flowers of light.

“But I think you must know, since you are so great.”

It was longing.

It was also awe for the celestial being.

She still had the sky she looked up to in her weak days in her heart.

“So, what do you think is the answer, my lord?”

-“I love you, Eutenia.”

But the answer that came out of my mouth was the opposite.

She still had one wish left.

What I had to tell her now was a dry confession.

Eutenia knew that too, so she smiled bitterly and spoke to me.

“What a pity. This is the end of the last wish.”

Under the dark sky where countless fireworks burst out.

I looked at my apostle who shone more than anyone else.

She stained her hands with the blood of many, and wore the stigma that everyone shunned.

My first apostle was still shining brightly.

More than the fleeting fireworks behind her.

And more than the countless stars that adorned the night sky above her.

-“I still love you, Eutenia.”

“.....Yes?”

-“I’m sure it will be the same tomorrow.”

“.....”

Even after the last wish was over, I still smiled and looked at her.

Eutenia Hyrost.

She had her own radiance.

A radiance that could steal the heart of even a god who lived forever.

Chapter ss10: [END]Side Story 10 - The Evil God Beyond the Smartphone_Illustrated

[END]Side Story 10: The Evil God Beyond the Smartphone_Illustrated

Every story has an end.

And everyone knows that.

The same goes for the human journey.

Starting from a historical moment called birth, they go through their own journeys and reach some kind of destination.

Great heroes, terrible villains, wealthy tycoons, poor people, everyone has a predetermined end.

But there are beings in the world whose ends are far away.

People call them gods.

-“It’s been a long time since we had a meeting.”

I was one of the only two gods existing in the modern world.

A fallen god who was trapped in a cage and yearned for freedom, and myself who watched over him.

But the believers who served me existed in a completely different world from me.

Beyond the screen of the smartphone in my hand.

In a world connected by a tiny mechanical device, I was worshiped by countless people.

-“It really has been a long time.”

-“Well, we haven’t had a meeting for a while.”

What I saw beyond the screen were the apostles, who stood at the top of those believers.

A gathering of followers who served the great throne that ruled over the heavens.

It still felt a bit vague to me that they were a gathering of those who served me.

I sat on the throne by chance.

I didn’t want to sit here.

But I felt a vague sense of responsibility for those who served me.

It must have been the weight given to the being called god.

-“By the way, it’s been a long time since I saw the angel.”

-“Yeah. It’s been a long time.”

-“I heard you were with the great one, but how is it where you are?”

The apostles in the meeting room beyond the screen talked to each other.

Roan, who had risen to the position of the holy one and had some dignity, asked Estasia, who was taking the bread in front of him.

There was virtually no way for Estasia on Earth to meet them except for the [regular meeting].

That's why Estasia's existence was of interest to the others as well.

-“The master's refrigerator is full of strawberry pastries and strawberry ice cream.”

-“Refrigerator? What is that?”

-“A refrigerator is a place where you put ice cream and strawberries.”

The other apostles looked at Estasia, who was talking about her life on Earth.

It must have been a very unfamiliar story to them.

Of course, what Estasia said about the existence and function of the refrigerator was all wrong.

Pluto, who heard the story of the refrigerator, admired her and said.

-“It's definitely a place worthy of the great one. It's a place you can call heaven.”

-“Yeah. The refrigerator is heaven.”

-“I like blood more than strawberries. Is there any delicious blood there?”

-“I saw a place full of packaged blood on TV a while ago.”

-“Hmm... Heaven is really different. It's full of things everyone likes.”

I smirked at the misunderstanding that spread through Estasia's story.

The fallen angel with black wings always produces unpredictable results.

This meeting was no exception.

But that was also something that could be called Estasia's charm.

The place where Estasia was always had a bright atmosphere.

It was also her personality that saved me from the deep darkness.

-“How is the great one doing there?”

As Estasia and Pluto watched their conversation, Eutenia, who was watching them, asked.

Eutenia, who spent every day with me in the holy land, was also curious about Estasia and my life.

The environment of Earth and the continent was different, so their curiosity was natural.

But if they asked me about my life here, to be honest, I had nothing to tell them.

I was practically a bum.

Even though I was watching the movements of the fallen god and the angels trapped in the cage, I was in a situation where I had no income.

The only thing that kept my life going was my own power.

-“I go out often, but I don’t know.”

-“You go out often?”

-“Yeah. But sometimes I take Estasia with me and go out together...”

But I took Estasia or Aronia out with me whenever I had time.

If they were stuck in the room, even the angels would get stressed.

And I couldn’t let them wander around alone, so the best thing was to hide their halos and wings with my power and go with them.

Of course, when I went out with Estasia, the end was always with a dish that had strawberries in it.

I learned for the first time that there were so many dishes with strawberries in them as I went with her.

-“I see. Estasia must have had fun with the great one.”

-“Estasia is the best angel, so it’s natural that she gets the master’s favor.”

Eutenia smiled and picked up the bread as she heard Estasia’s simple story.

What followed was Eutenia’s story to Estasia.

-“Ahem, ahem. Actually, I went sightseeing with the great one in the capital of the empire a while ago.”

-“Estasia had strawberry ade with the master at the movie theater a while ago.”

-“I walked around the night holy land with the great one a while ago.”

-“Estasia had strawberry cake with the master at the cafe a while ago.”

-“I don’t know how many times the great one told me he loved me last night.”

-“Estasia secretly bought two boxes of strawberry ice cream with the master’s card yesterday.”

“What?”

The two’s conversation followed one after another.

Eutenia and Estasia detailed their lives without being asked by each other.

The atmosphere heated up as they watched, and the expressions of the apostles who watched them changed subtly.

Among them, Peter was the one who reacted the most strongly.

He couldn't stand the conversation between the two and spoke to Roan, who was leading the meeting.

-“Excuse me, Mr. Roan... What are those two doing?”

-“Mabu, be quiet.”

-“...”

But he soon shut his mouth at Estasia's sharp remark.

I watched him and burst into laughter.

It was a sight that made me laugh involuntarily.

They each laid out their own arguments and influenced each other.

The countless discordant sounds that flowed between them proved that they were alive.

They were not NPCs in a game, but living and breathing people.

“What a pleasant sight to see anytime.”

Just watching them made me feel relaxed.

The world in my hand was a very beautiful place.

No matter what I did.

No matter what happened.

I couldn't let go of anything that was lovely.

The world where my loved ones lived was valuable enough in itself.

“As I keep watching, I feel like I'm falling in love with this world more and more.”

Everything has a fixed lifespan.

Bound by the shackles of being a god, I would spend more time than those beyond the screen.

Someday, everything I loved would scatter in time and become something else.

But even so, this world was still a lovely place.

Even if the time I loved passed by, and everything changed completely.

I would surely look at the changed world and love it again.

“...Even though I know it will all disappear someday.”

That’s what a god was.

Living close to eternity, but ultimately being captivated by a momentary sparkle.

Every living being that lived for a moment had its own sparkle.

It sometimes shone brightly, and sometimes faded away.

It was a beautiful sparkle because it was not eternal.

Even those who called themselves gods were blinded by the dazzling light.

-“Estasia played the game with the master too.”

-“I’ve been with the great one since he was in the glass tube.”

-“Perin. It’s time for you to step up...”

-“Mabu.”

-“...”

The sparkling lights wrote their own stories.

Some would write a story of a hero.

Some would write a story filled with evil.

Some one's story would be full of happiness.

Some other's story would be full of hardship and adversity.

But even so, some would not lose hope.

They would move forward to find some possibility in the faint sparkle in their hands.

They would not give up and work hard to overcome their given fate.

They would long for the beautiful future that I once failed to grasp.

“...”

And granting them the right fate was surely the duty given to the being called a god.

Helping those who moved forward on their own.

Showing hope to those who sought possibility.

Making them face the future they desired against their given fate.

That was what I had to do from now on.

-“...By the way, Estasia brought something from the great one this time.”

-“What is it?”

-“It's a thing called a camera. You can use it to take pictures of other people.”

As Estasia finished the short argument and took out the camera, I also engraved their faces in my pupils.

The apostles who had been watching Estasia and Eutenia were now smiling at each other.

It was a sight that looked happy to anyone.

The smile that spread from the fallen angel was still lingering on everyone's lips.

– “How do you take a picture?”

– “Ahem. First, you all have to stand in front of the camera.”

– “So we just stand in front of the camera?”

Estasia, who was holding and shaking the camera.

Perin, who was showing curiosity at her.

Pluto, who was dragging a skull with an unreadable expression.

Evan, who was shaking his head with a snort.

They were all having a happy time in their own ways.

– “Oops. I pressed it wrong.”

– “Something is coming out from the top. Is this a picture?”

A picture was printed out from Estasia's hand, who was flustered.

Perin, who was below, caught the picture that was fluttering down.

The eyes of the apostles all turned to the picture in Perin's hand.

Some frowned at their own stupid expressions, while others marveled at the existence of the picture.

Click-.

Along with the capture sound from the smartphone, that moment was saved in the device.

It was a precious memory that would never disappear from within them, even as time passed.

– “Estasia... I think I look a bit weird.”

– “Mabu, you were always weird.”

I smiled as I looked at the memory that remained in a single picture.

Someday, I will look back on this moment again.

There might be a time when I will remember everyone who is shining in my hand.

Even so, I know that this moment is the happiest time of all.

Happiness is not a grand thing.

It is only after realizing that the small thing in your hand is happiness that people truly know happiness.

“I hope you all are happy.”

There is an end to the story.

And everyone knows that.

Yet, I know that the story of the apostles in front of me will not end here.

They will continue to write their own stories.

Stories that are more splendid and brilliant than anyone else in the world.

And the ending will surely be a happy ending filled with happiness.

Please, let everyone be happy.

Dominus meus et Deus meus———.

— The End —